

伪像报告

须尾俱全



虚伪聚钱®

伪像报告

Contents

- Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies
- Chapter 2: Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?
- Chapter 3: The Sweet Illusion in Mai Minghe's Hospital Ward
- Chapter 4: Mai Minghe Seizes a Second Life
- Chapter 5 — Sydney Ginn, the Hunter Plagued by a Stalker
- Chapter 6: Sydney Ginn's Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion
- Chapter 7 – Sydney Ginn: The Hunter's Life Is No Easy Living
- Chapter 8: Sydney Ginn's Blackmoor City Transportation and Tourism Map
- Chapter 9 — Goodbye, Sydney Ginn
- Chapter 10: A Gathering of Heroes at Mai Minghe
- Chapter 11: Mai Minghe's Rock-Paper-Scissors
- Chapter 12: Mai Minghe's Comedy Horror
- Chapter 13 — Mai Minghe: The Way Things Tend to Go
- Chapter 14 — Chase, Where the Sea Meets the Sky
- Chapter 15: Chase, Hunter Among Men
- Chapter 16 — Chase and the Artifact Submerged in the Metropolis
- Chapter 17 — Chase: The Hunted Hunter
- Chapter 18: Mai Minghe's Fourth Person
- Chapter 19: Mai Minghe's Reproductive Unit
- Chapter 20 — Mai Minghe and the Jonah Who Begged for Help

Chapter 21 — How Can You Tell If I'm Making Excuses?

Chapter 22: Sydney Ginn, After Life and Death

Chapter 23 – Sydney Ginn: If the Mountain Won't Come to You

Chapter 24 — Sydney Ginn's Altered History

Chapter 25 — Sydney Ginn, Latest Version, Present Day

Chapter 26 — Sydney Ginn's Choice at the Crossroads

Chapter 27: What?! I've been an ungrateful wreck since April 23rd?

Chapter 28 — Hello everyone, your Southern Airlines Ambassador here

Chapter 29: The Attack Pattern of the Sydney Ginn Resident

Chapter 30: The Way Sydney Ginn Fights Back, and Establishing True Identity

Chapter 31: All Those Chapters Before Sydney Ginn Are Gone

Chapter 32: Chase's Underground Pursuit

Chapter 33: The Form of Chase's Artifact

Chapter 34: Chase's Logical Story

Chapter 35 — Folks, Grandmas, I'm Home

Chapter 36 — Chase Searches for the Passage Artifact

Chapter 37: The Thing Chase Hates Most

Chapter 38: Chase's Second Memory

Chapter 39 — The First Resident Chase Ever Saw

Chapter 40: Chase Is Very, Very, Very Simple

Chapter 41: Chase, Did You Think the Rumor Had Stopped Spreading?

Chapter 42: The Root of the Chase-Sydney Enigma

Chapter 43: Sydney Ginn's Original Plan for the Artifact

Chapter 44: Sydney Ginn Buys Things and Of Course She Pays for Them

Chapter 45: Sydney Ginn Pays Taxes and Launderers Money

Chapter 46: Sydney Ginn's Grape Soda

Chapter 47: The Strange Detail Sydney Ginn Had Overlooked

Chapter 48 — It's on the shelves, and here I am perched on them with a few words to say

Chapter 49: The Secret Behind a Qidian Author's Fake Gathering-Money-and-Being-Unfilial Act for Over a Month

Chapter 50 — Some Q&A on the World-Building Behind the Artifact Reports

Chapter 51: Mai Minghe Has No Home to Return To

Chapter 52: Mai Minghe Cannot Be Found by the Morgan House Faction

Chapter 53: Mai Minghe Between a Rock and a Hard Place

Chapter 54: The Correct Response of a Vagrant Named Mai Minghe

Chapter 55: Mai Minghe and Taylor Ford's Interrogation

Chapter 56 — Taylor Ford and the Morgan House Faction Contract

Chapter 57: What Taylor Ford and Wellesley Know

Chapter 58: Taylor Ford Isn't the Only One Lying in Wait

Chapter 59 — Taylor Ford's Stakeout for Two

Chapter 60: Taylor Ford, This Matter, and Its Connection to Key House Faction

Chapter 61: Taylor Ford's Key Is Remarkably Straightforward

Chapter 62: Taylor Ford — Amber Alert?

Chapter 63: Taylor Ford, a perfectly ordinary retired Hunter

Chapter 64: The One Thing Taylor Ford Wants Most

Chapter 65: Mai Minghe Trapped With No Way Out?

Chapter 66: Mai Minghe Re-Enters the Nest

Chapter 67: Mai Minghe's Starting Point

Chapter 68: The Conditions for Mai Minghe's Departure

Chapter 69: Mai Minghe's Face as She Responds to the Nest's Themed Event

Chapter 70: The Rules, Clues, and Hints of Mai Minghe's Restaurant

Chapter 71: Everything Mai Minghe Sees Seems Like Nonsense

Chapter 72: Mai Minghe, Cowboy Hill Chase Company

Chapter 73: Mai Minghe's First Face

Chapter 74: Mai Minghe's Harvest in the First Hour

Chapter 75: Mai Minghe — Bomb or Hint?

Chapter 76: Mai Minghe's Brush with Death and Snatching Chestnuts from the Fire

Chapter 77: Mai Minghe's Sixth Piece of Face

Chapter 78: Mai Minghe on the Importance of Taking a Nap

Chapter 79: Chase and a Resident in the Same Car?

Chapter 80: The Reason for Chase's Arrest

Chapter 81: Two Ways to Handle the Chase Situation

Chapter 82 — Chase, Just Over a Minute

Chapter 83: Chase Switches Mobile Carriers

Chapter 84: The Police Station That Reached Chase

Chapter 85: It Would Be Nice If Sydney Ginn Were a Resident

Chapter 86: Sydney Ginn's Way Out

Chapter 87: The Shape of Sydney Ginn's Rules

Chapter 88: Sydney Ginn Realizes the Order of Two Things

Chapter 89: Sydney Ginn, Who Squeezes Through Every Crack

Chapter 90: Sydney Ginn Has Not a Single Simple Character

Chapter 91 — Sydney Ginn: Just a Few Words Between Two People

Chapter 92: Sydney Ginn's Special Talent Is Getting Dragged Into Things

Chapter 93: Sydney Ginn's Unexpected Trap

Chapter 94: Sydney Ginn Was Blind to What Was Right Under Her Nose, Time and Again

Chapter 95: Sydney Ginn — An Offer She Can't Refuse

Chapter 96: Sydney Ginn's Choice

Chapter 97 — Chase: The End of the Nest Communication Network

Chapter 98: Chase's Supreme Luck and the Failed Snipe

Chapter 99: The Trouble Chase's Good Luck Brought

Chapter 100: Chase Hides a Door Here

Chapter 101: Chase Breaks Through, and Flying Bullets

Chapter 102: Chase Steals a Moment from a Sky Full of Bullets

Chapter 103: Brushing Past Brianna

Chapter 104: Why Chase Was Followed, and the Phone Alert

Chapter 105: Chase, the Fourth Contestant

Chapter 106: The Second Favor Mai Minghe Extorted

Chapter 107: Mai Minghe's Experiences in the Nest?

Chapter 108: Mai Minghe's Post-Rationalization

Chapter 109: The Truth of Mai Minghe's First Hundred Chapters Revealed!

Chapter 110: Mai Minghe's First Day as a Resident?

Chapter 111: The First Hour with Reed Hydes as Guide

Chapter 112: Reed Hydes's Lucid Dream

Chapter 113: Reed Hydes and Mai Minghe's Resident-ification Progress Report

Chapter 114: Reed Hydes Finishes the Form?

Chapter 115: Reed Hydes and Schrödinger's Mai Minghe

Chapter 116 — Dual-POV: A Resident Who Doesn't Bite the Hand That Feeds Is No Resident at All

Chapter 117: Reed Hydes Leads Mai Minghe Astray

Chapter 118: Reed Hydes and Taylor Ford's Proposal

Chapter 119: The Shifting Situation That Taylor Ford Set in Motion

Chapter 120: Double-Pendulum Mai Minghe and Hunter Taylor Ford

Chapter 121: Mai Minghe's Car Really Does Have a Lot of Screentime

Chapter 122 — Mai Minghe: Her Decision

Chapter 123 — Sydney Ginn Is Not the One Unraveling the Truth

Chapter 124 — Sydney Ginn: A Partnership of Mutual Hidden Agendas

Chapter 125: The Fantastical Life of Sydney Ginn

Chapter 126 – Sydney Ginn, for One, Is Not an Empty Coffin

Chapter 127: Sydney Ginn's Party of Three, Some Casual Chat

Chapter 128 — Sydney Ginn Moves a Resident Out of Its Coffin

Chapter 129 — Sydney Ginn Thinks Back: This Is the Second Time She's Encountered a Vulture

Chapter 130 — Sydney Ginn and the Lightning Vision

Chapter 131: Sydney Ginn's Assault on the Vulture

Chapter 132 — June: Can the Vulture Read Minds?

Chapter 133: June's Chickens and Rabbits?

Chapter 134: June's Whack-a-Mole, 2026 Edition

Chapter 135: June and Chase's Orders

Chapter 136: June's Corpse Isn't All That Easy to Use

Chapter 137: Key House Video Records (I)

Chapter 138: Key House Visual Record (II)

Chapter 139: Key House Video Record (III)

Chapter 140 — The Key House Footage Chase Saw (Part Four)

Chapter 141 — Chase Watched That Recording

Chapter 142 — Chase Arrived Before Him

Chapter 143 — Chase: The Person Who Died on the 18th

Chapter 144 — Taylor Ford, and Meanwhile, He's Out Here Feeding a Cat?

Chapter 145 — Lying in Wait Is a Skill in Itself for Taylor Ford

Chapter 146 — Taylor Ford Apartment, Second Floor

Chapter 147: It Wouldn't Be So Bad if Taylor Ford Crossed Over Too?

Chapter 148: Taylor Ford Wouldn't Be Moved

Chapter 149 — The Only Home Taylor Ford Had Ever Known

Chapter 150: Taylor Ford's Brief Ten Minutes

Chapter 151 — Taylor Ford, the Mantis Stalking the Cicada on the Third Floor

Chapter 152: Mai Minghe — Fortunately, Reed Hydes Was Someone She Could Trust and Work With

Chapter 153: Mai Minghe — Any Object Might Explode

Chapter 154: Mai Minghe — The Fisherman Who Came Back Empty-Handed

Chapter 155 — Mai Minghe Catches Someone Red-Handed

Chapter 156: Hunter Positions One Minute After Taylor Ford

Chapter 157: Taylor Ford's Pleading Cat Head

Chapter 158: When Taylor Ford Exploded, a Glimmer of Breakthrough Appeared

Chapter 159: Taylor Ford and Mai Minghe's Judgment

Chapter 160: Mai Minghe — Hidden Threads, Still with Cards to Play

Chapter 161: Mai Minghe, A Person About to Die

Chapter 162 — Taylor Ford Still Refuses to Be Abandoned by Life

Chapter 163: Mai Minghe — Entropy, Loss of Control, and Reluctance

Chapter 164: The Trap Taylor Ford Set from the Very Beginning

Chapter 165: Mai Minghe, the Elderly, and a Romantic Comedy?

Chapter 166: A Nest Where Mai Minghe Gets Off Easy?

Chapter 167 — These memories of Mai Minghe's—they shouldn't all be implanted ones, right?

Chapter 168: The Footstool in Taylor Ford's Home

Chapter 169: Taylor Ford's Key of Uncertain Origin

Chapter 170: Has Taylor Ford Told Too Many Lies Before?

Chapter 171: Taylor Ford's One-Line Trap and the Way Out

Chapter 172: Has Taylor Ford's Key Actually Been Counting Down All Along?

Chapter 173: Dual-Perspective View — Casualties Already Decided?

Chapter 174: Taylor Ford's True Key and a Father-Son Moment

Chapter 175: Sydney Ginn and June Act Together

Chapter 176: Sydney Ginn's Path of Love

Chapter 177: Sydney Ginn Meets an Old Acquaintance Far from Home

Chapter 178: Sydney Ginn's Life on Earth—Creative Ways to Court Death

Chapter 179: Sydney Ginn Sails a Ghost Ship into the Harbor

Chapter 180: Sydney Ginn, the Genius Troublemaker

Chapter 181: Sydney Ginn — A Key House Loyalist on Outsourced Contract?

Chapter 182: Sydney Ginn's Allegiances Shift by the Second

Chapter 183: The Moment Sydney Ginn Has Been Waiting For

Chapter 184: Sydney Ginn Always Keeps Thinking About the Same Person's Artifact Report

Chapter 185: The Reason Behind Mai Minghe's Rules

Chapter 186: A Ping-Pong Ball Between Mai Minghe's Four Walls

Chapter 187: Mai Minghe's Precious Contest Candidate

Chapter 188: Mai Minghe's Answer Beneath a Glittering Starry Night

Chapter 189: Mai Minghe — Hurricane Makes Landfall in Florida

Chapter 190: Mai Minghe, This Is Way Too Real

Chapter 191: Mai Minghe Accidentally Corners the Doctor

Chapter 192: Mai Minghe Officially Steps into the Hunter World

Chapter 193: Mai Minghe's Lipstick

Chapter 194: Mai Minghe's Emergency Supplemental Report

Chapter 195: Chase the Good Hound Never Lets Go

Chapter 196 — Chase: A Good Leader Knows How to Put the Right People in the Right Place

Chapter 197 – The Person Chase Narrowly Missed

Chapter 198: The Error That Fate Corrected for Brianna

Chapter 199: The Person Command Brianna Accidentally Entered

Chapter 200 — Sydney Ginn: Everyone Is Keeping Very Calm

Chapter 201: Chase the Traitor, Chase

Chapter 202 — Chase's Karma Comes Fast

Chapter 203: What Chase Does Best

Chapter 204: Chase Runs His Mouth, Chase Monroe

Chapter 205: Chase's Brief Flight

Chapter 206 — Chase: How Can One Small Alley Hold So Many People

Chapter 207 — Chase and a Thoroughly Anticlimactic Gunfight

Chapter 208 – Chase Pursues the Blank

Chapter 209: Zebra-POV Escape and Hiding Place

Chapter 210: Chase Follows the Trail

Chapter 211: Switching Perspectives — A History That Was Once Set in Motion

Chapter 212: Shift in Perspective — Dressage

Chapter 213 — Chase: Villains Don't Die from Talking Too Much

Chapter 214: Brianna and Her Connection to the Past

Chapter 215: Brianna's Connection to the Present

Chapter 216: Mai Minghe's Nest Debt Has Been Paid

Chapter 217: Mai Minghe's Action Point and the Mayor

Chapter 218: Why Does Mai Minghe Always Come Back to Making Money?

Chapter 219: Mai Minghe's Thirty Subjects of the Nest and Over-Packaging

Chapter 220: Sydney Ginn, Sydney Ginn's Shell, and the Lipstick Without Its Shell

Chapter 221 — Sydney Ginn's Daydreams and "Who Even Is This Guy"

Chapter 222: A World Sydney Ginn Doesn't Quite Understand

Chapter 223: Sydney Ginn Turned Away at the Door — and Those Who Got In

Chapter 224: The Troubles of Mai Minghe's Grandniece

Chapter 225: Mai Minghe, Alone

Chapter 226: Before Mai Minghe's Departure

Chapter 227 — Mai Minghe, No One Opens the Door

Chapter 228: Taylor Ford's Prayer

Chapter 229: Taylor Ford, Perfectly Reasonable

Chapter 230: The Chains Taylor Ford Cannot Hear

Chapter 231: The Han Ford Brotherhood Club

Chapter 232: Taylor Ford's Exchange Game

Chapter 233: Mai Minghe's First Trial

Chapter 234 — Mai Minghe Mai Minghe Mai Minghe

Chapter 235: The Conditions for Mai Minghe's Rebirth

Chapter 236: Mai Minghe and So Many Things

Chapter 237: The Most Obvious Thing to Mai Minghe

Chapter 238: Mai Minghe, Road Signs, Wooden Man, Hide-and-Seek

Chapter 239: The Poster Nobody Noticed

Chapter 240: Mai Minghe's Roaming — The Tourist Information Center

Chapter 241 — In Every Tourist Information Center Along Mai Minghe's Street

Chapter 242: Mai Minghe Now Has Two Targets

Chapter 243: Mai Minghe Splits the Rules Poster

Chapter 244: Mai Minghe Follows the Map to Find the Nest's Secrets

Chapter 245: The Nest That Mai Minghe Loves

Chapter 246 — A Sliver of Hope Amid the Chaos of Mai Minghe

Chapter 247: Mai Minghe's Last Few Seconds

Chapter 248: The People at the Mai Minghe Rendezvous Point

Chapter 249: Mai Minghe's Real Trial

Chapter 250: Chase Osmosis

Chapter 251: The Consequences of Chase's Choice

Chapter 252: Mai Minghe, and Mai Minghe in the Mirror

Chapter 253: The Lead Mai Minghe Cannot Escape

Chapter 254: Where Is Miss Jones?

Chapter 255: Mai Minghe Searches for the Jones Level

Chapter 256: Mai Minghe and Jones's Hiding Scheme

Chapter 257: Mai Minghe Found You, Jones

Chapter 258: Mai Minghe, the Mirror Corridor, and the Wooden-Door Mirror

Chapter 259: Mai Minghe's Cement Waterfall

Chapter 260: The Four Forms of Mai Minghe and the Infinite Floors

Chapter 261: The Blind Spot in Mai Minghe's Clearance

Chapter 262: Mai Minghe's Braid

Chapter 263 — Mai Minghe, 2019

Chapter 264: Mai Minghe's Rescue Arrives Beyond All Expectation

Chapter 265: Mai Minghe's Colorful Reality and the Undercover Snake

Chapter 266: Mai Minghe and the 'Three Lizard-Skin Quacks' Discovery

Chapter 267: Mai Minghe's Long-Overdue Message

Chapter 268: Mai Minghe's Fleeting Glimpse of Home

Chapter 269: Mai Minghe — Between the Nest and the World of the Living

Chapter 270: Mai Minghe's One-Way Communication

Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies

When Mai Minghe woke, the room was dim and dark, and the light seeping in beneath the curtains was still the light of night.

She was a light sleeper, waking several times each night, but tonight the reason was different. A small, hard sound had pulled her from sleep, rising out of the steady "whooo—whooo" of the background noise that filled the room.

What was making that noise?

She was groggy with sleep, her mind slow to catch up.

The metallic scraping and clinking went on, until finally there came a sharp snap—the lock tumbled—and the door was pushed open with a long, creaking "squeeeak." The hinges had gone years without oiling; stiff and dry as an old person's joints, they sliced a sharp wound through the silent night.

Oh. Someone had broken in.

If her mother ever found out, there was no telling what kind of scolding was in store—a young woman living alone, and she couldn't even think to prop a chair against the door at night?

Her mother had always been uneasy about the world: checking the gas four or five times before leaving the house, peering into the back seat before getting into a car, never once letting her return a stranger's nod or smile.

Mai Minghe had always thought her mother was a bit too anxious—but here she was, someone actually breaking through her front door tonight.

The sounds that followed were hard to make out, but vaguely, a figure moved inside. Through the crack under the door, a beam of light swept back and forth—a flashlight.

Unfamiliar footsteps padded softly around the living room, occasionally drawing out a creak, and Mai Minghe knew: that was the wooden floorboard just outside the kitchen. A pipe had burst one year, and the boards there had warped from the soaking, ever since voicing their shrill complaints underfoot.

Having a burglar was actually a rather unusual thing.

She closed her eyes again and listened carefully to the burglar's movements.

He opened the door to the next room first—a very small, narrow room that had never really been used. It had once been painted as a nursery, then briefly served as a study, then been converted into a wardrobe room, yet not one of those purposes had ever truly been fulfilled; now it was simply a dusty storage room piled with clutter.

One glance would be enough to see that the room was heaped with nothing but junk, not worth rifling through—and sure enough, the footsteps retreated almost immediately, and the door was shut with a dull thud.

Honestly, if you searched the whole building, you'd probably struggle to find anything of real value.

Things did go missing often enough in this low-rent apartment building; once, when Mai Minghe hadn't latched her door properly, she came home to find a pair of ankle boots gone from the shoe rack by the entrance—it had infuriated her enough to knock on every neighbor's door, but nothing came of it. Still, lost things were one matter; it was rare for an outside burglar to actually pick a lock and go to all this trouble over people with so little to their name.

How funny—such a trivial thing, and she remembered it so clearly. Those boots had been calfskin, a smooth, polished brown, sharp-looking; she had never managed to find a pair she liked as well after that.

Whatever he wanted to take, let him take it—she didn't have anything worth making a fuss over anyway.

The burglar made his way to the bedroom doorway, pushed the door open, and the flashlight swept in, finding Mai Minghe at once.

The harsh white light pressed through her eyelids and lit up her face, yet she remained perfectly still, keeping her eyes shut, feigning sleep.

An unfamiliar voice let out a surprised "Huh?" as though actually taken aback.

Mai Minghe held herself still and kept quiet.

The burglar's footsteps thumped into the room; he circled around the bedroom, didn't even open the nightstand drawer, and went back out again.

Stealing things so carelessly—what could he possibly hope to find? Mai Minghe almost felt anxious on his behalf. You had to have a little patience in whatever you did, a willingness to see things through properly.

A minute or two passed, and he came back in, stopping at the side of Mai Minghe's bed; the warm, living breath of another person hovered in the air just above her.

"Hey," a man's voice said, and a hand gave Mai Minghe's bony shoulder a nudge. "Hey, wake up."

There didn't seem to be much point pretending to sleep any longer.

Why wake her up? If he was looking for something valuable, couldn't he just look for himself? Not only was he stealing things, he was being lazy about it too—people these days, honestly.

Mai Minghe opened her eyes. A dark silhouette was hunched over her at the bedside, looming above her head.

The flashlight was angled down along the edge of the bed, so the burglar's face was lost in shadow; at the rim of the light, she could just make out a pale throat, the Adam's apple rising and falling with each word.

"Don't be afraid, I just want to ask you something. Is there someone here by the name of Mai Minghe?"

"...That's me. Do we know each other?"

The man drew a breath and straightened up, taking in the shape beneath the covers.

"You—you're her?" He seemed unwilling to believe it, and raised the flashlight to sweep it over Mai Minghe's face several more times, without any ceremony.

She hadn't looked in a mirror for a long time and had no idea what she looked like now—certainly nothing good.

"What is it?" she asked quietly.

The man stood there with his mouth half open, as though still digesting something.

He didn't want her to be Mai Minghe—that much she could see; because he immediately asked again, as if she might not have heard him clearly: "Mai—the 'mai' in wild wheat. Mai—Ming—He."

"It's me," Mai Minghe said with a faint smile. "There's no one else."

The man stared at her.

After a few seconds, he asked: "Old lady, how old are you?"

How old was she? Even Mai Minghe had to stop and think.

She couldn't remember, from some year onward, how old she was—sometimes she even mistook herself for a young girl.

A year per year of age: it didn't sound like much, yet those years were like snowflakes falling thick and countless, each one an infinitesimal moment; without her noticing, they had accumulated into a lifetime.

Scoop up a handful of snow, and you don't know when it fell. A passage of life rises to the surface, and she has forgotten how long ago it came from.

The social worker had said that at her age—eighty-six—Mai Minghe's mind was still fairly clear, unlike some elderly people...

"Eighty-six?" Mai Minghe asked the social worker in her memory. "You must be mistaken. I'm not nearly that old."

The room fell quiet again, and the steady "whooo—whooo" of background noise rose once more.

The burglar seemed to notice it only now. He pointed at the small plastic tube inserted in Mai Minghe's nose and asked, "Is that... are you on oxygen?"

"Hm?" Mai Minghe sometimes forgot. "Oh, yes. It's quite a nuisance."

The burglar let out a sigh. He set the flashlight down on the edge of the bed, its beam casting a circle of light on the opposite wall, splitting the room—cutting out a bright ring of warmth, and leaving the rest to dim, heavy darkness.

"Look at me, I forgot to ask. Would you like some tea?" said Mai Minghe. It had been so long since anyone had visited that she had quite forgotten to be a host. "It's hard for me to get up... there's tea and biscuits in the kitchen, please help yourself."

The burglar shifted uncomfortably, as though he hadn't expected this turn of events.

"No, I'm fine," he said, hesitating a moment before adding: "But... would you like some? I can bring it to you."

Mai Minghe declined and thanked him; host and burglar exchanged polite pleasantries for a little while.

The burglar clasped his hands together and stared at the television in the corner of the room for a long moment before asking it: "Your health isn't good?"

"I'm quite all right—I can still get out of bed and walk on my own."

"...What about meals? Does a son or daughter come to bring you food?"

"I don't have any children," she said with a small smile. "And I don't eat much—anything simple will do... the social worker brings me vegetables and eggs now and then."

"A social worker? Do you have no family in Blackmoor City?"

"I'm used to it," Mai Minghe said. "I never had many relatives or friends to begin with, and they've all died before me. Dear, would you like to watch television?"

The burglar seemed to find the question absurd. He was silent for a moment, then suddenly took out his phone and glanced at it, and walked quickly out of the room.

"Hello?"

So he was taking a call.

"Yes, I've found her... no, I haven't done it yet." The burglar paused here, faltering. "The thing is—did you know she's an old woman? Eighty-six years old. That wasn't in the file."

The reply from the other end was brief, because the burglar spoke again almost immediately.

"Yes," the burglar said, not bothering to lower his voice—perhaps he felt there was no need. "But... does it have to be hers? She's not the only one with a passage. And besides, we don't even know what her passage is like... taking it would be hard on a young person—what about her? What if she can't hold on and dies?"

The person on the phone was very displeased; even Mai Minghe seemed to catch the faint sound of a raised voice.

The burglar bore it in silence for a time, and at last, like a student admitting a mistake, said: "No... I understand. I'm sorry. I'll get it."

Mai Minghe sometimes startled herself at the sight of her own hands.

Thick, wrinkled skin, layer upon layer draped over each bone, blue veins and blood vessels standing out in ridges, almost cold to the touch—nothing like the hands she remembered as her own. They belonged to two different people.

With that hand that seemed not to belong to her, she fumbled beneath the covers for a moment and found the pendant resting on her chest, closing her fingers tightly around it.

This time, the burglar came in and spoke at once: "I'm sorry, old lady. I need to take something from you."

She could just make him out now—he had a bright, regular sort of face, somewhere in his twenties or thirties, still young; if you didn't know, you'd never think him capable of harm.

"What would you like?" Mai Minghe asked. "I don't have much use for things anymore—take them. There's a silver brooch in the drawer..."

"No, I don't want valuables," the burglar interrupted. "I need to take something from your body."

"Is it an organ?" Mai Minghe asked, curious. Her organs hardly seemed worth taking.

"No, no, stop asking. You wouldn't understand even if I explained."

"Then... will I die?" Mai Minghe asked. "You said so just now."

The burglar was caught off guard; he went still for two seconds before saying, "I don't know... possibly."

Mai Minghe quietly studied the cracks in the ceiling for a while.

"If you need to take it, take it," she said softly. "It's just... before you do, could you grant me one wish?"

At some point the burglar had come to stand beside her.

"What wish?"

"I used to work at a library. The pay was very little, but I loved the library—I was happy there... Once, when my shift ended, one of the librarians told me there was an old book they were retiring; it hadn't sold at the clearance price, so they gave it to me to take home and read."

The burglar rested a hand on her pillow.

At his feet was a dark, bulky shape—some kind of machine—that seemed to have been brought in at some point without her noticing; Mai Minghe was only seeing it now.

"I looked, and it was a poetry anthology; I flipped through it idly when I got home," Mai Minghe murmured. "I read a little, put the book down, and later even lost track of where it went. But somehow... these past few years, I keep thinking back to one poem that was in it."

"Which poem?"

"You young people—don't you all have those... smart telephones?"

"Smartphones," the burglar corrected.

If she had a grandchild, she might have been corrected just like this.

"They say you can find anything on them?"

"...More or less."

"Could you look up that poem for me?" Mai Minghe asked. "I want to hear it one more time."

The burglar looked down at her, and something in his expression shifted—a sudden unease. He pulled a tissue from the nightstand box and pressed it into her hand. While Mai Minghe stared at it blankly, not understanding, he said: "All right, stop crying. I'll find it for you. Do you remember the title?"

She was crying?

So even at this age, she could not accept death.

Or perhaps it was that, even at this age, she had not yet had the chance to truly live.

"It's called... something with Daisy in the title." Mai Minghe deliberately left out half the title.

Smartphones held a great deal, but searching for a poem was no easy matter—and daisy was such a common image in poetry—so it took a good while, as she expected.

After finding several poems that weren't right one after another, the burglar finally lost patience: "Old lady, if you don't remember the name, that's not my fault. I still have to get back and hand in the job—you—"

"I've remembered," Mai Minghe said quickly.

This young man who had come to take something from her—he was likely the last person in her life who could let her hear a poem one more time.

Even if she could no longer put it off—even if she had to face death—it would still be a good thing to hear a little more poetry first.

"I Shall Pick More Daisies'... I think that's what it's called."

The young man glanced at her, said nothing, and tapped his fingers across the screen a few times.

This time, he quickly found the poem that Mai Minghe had kept returning to.

"I found a read-aloud video for you," he said, setting the phone on the edge of the bed.

In the quiet room thick with the smell of medicine and decay, the advertisement before the video burst cheerfully to life, announcing a deal at Little Caesars Pizza.

"The ad's almost done—you just listen. You listen while I work."

He bent down and pulled a tube from the dark, squat machine.

...If I had my life to live over,

I would try to make more mistakes.

I would relax.

I would be more limber.

I would be sillier than I have been this trip.

Mai Minghe felt the side of her face grow damp.

She had spent her whole life in anxious calculation, just as her parents had. During wartime inflation, she painstakingly rationed every meal; in peacetime, she kept a household ledger every week. When she was a child, her family ran a small shop, and no matter how desperately she wanted to, she never once dared to steal a single candy from the shelves.

As she grew older she came to many crossroads thick with wildflowers, but she never set foot in them.

People are strange—everyone knows they only have this one life, yet every single day is lived as though there is infinite time left, as though it can all be done again.

The thief lifted the blanket and pressed a cool tube against Mai Minghe's chest, and she dimly realized that the thing looked rather like an old-fashioned vacuum cleaner.

"What's this?" The thief picked up the pendant at her chest, glanced at it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to answer, pushed it aside from the mouth of the tube. Young people generally didn't recognize it—had no idea what the thing was for.

Lucky for her that he didn't.

Amid the poem, he pressed the mouth of the tube against Mai Minghe's bony chest. He switched on the machine, and a low hum unlike anything she had ever heard slowly spiraled through the room.

...If I had my life to live over, I would travel lighter than I have. I would start barefoot earlier in the spring and stay that way later in the fall.

If I had my life to live over, I would go barefoot through the long springs and autumns.

I would play hooky more.

I wouldn't make such good grades, except by accident.

I would ride on more merry-go-rounds.

I would pick more daisies.

In the final instant that the darkness of death closed over Mai Minghe, she faintly heard the front door of the apartment burst open, and hurried footsteps and voices came rushing in together.

Carried to term for years, and at last delivered a homely child...

"I Shall Pick More Daisies" is a real poem. The poet wrote it when she was eighty-five—one year younger than my daughter. The inspiration wasn't actually the poem itself; it was only after I'd started writing that I suddenly remembered it and thought it fit perfectly.

My, it's been so long since I've updated or rambled on like this—I'm almost embarrassed, and I'm not quite sure what to say.

Thank you for coming back.

Chapter 2: Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?

"You live alone,"

the social worker unfolded a small brochure to show her and said, "If you fall, no one would know—it's too dangerous. Best to get one you can wear around your neck; it won't get in the way. What do you think?"

That was many years ago now.

Mai Minghe still remembered that brochure. The product's name was blunt and to the point: "Life Alert."

The image showed a white-haired woman collapsed on the floor, with two lines of small text: "Help! I've fallen and I can't get up!"

Her older cousin had shattered her pelvis in her eighties and never got out of bed again; once you're bedridden, your days are numbered.

What year had she passed? Mai Minghe couldn't remember anymore.

The legs that had once carried her leaping onto rooftops and running wild—in the blink of an eye, even getting out of bed now required guarding against their betrayal.

The body that had followed her all her life had slowly become something foreign; she was like a stiff wheel turning slower and slower with each revolution, powerless to stop it.

"The Emergency Response System is available twenty-four hours a day, every day of the year," the social worker explained, worried she couldn't make out the text on the brochure. "No matter what the emergency, one press and someone will come... let me see—oh, they promise a maximum response time of thirty minutes, and there are participating hospitals nearby."

Mai Minghe took the brochure and studied the pictures for a moment.

She had scraped and saved every penny her whole life, but now money had suddenly lost its weight; prices were nothing but curved little symbols.

"I'll take this one," she said, pointing to the third model. "This one's the nicest-looking. Like a pendant on a necklace."

The social worker let out a laugh. "Great—it'll look lovely on you, I'm sure."

Though it looked nothing like a necklace, she wore it like one anyway; she'd been wearing it that way for years, and the first time she ever pressed the Life Alert was the night the thief walked into her living room to make a phone call.

The thief probably hadn't expected that the "necklace" on her chest was an alarm—the young and the old live in two worlds that are nearly sealed off from each other; unless you have regular reason to deal with elderly people, few know what their lives look like, let alone what things they see and use day to day.

Starting from when she'd made the thief hunt for the poem... she'd tried every trick she could think of, and had bought herself more than ten minutes by now.

No one had come yet, and she was on the verge of losing consciousness.

For some reason, the cold tube defied gravity—it stood straight upright on her chest with no one holding it. The machine hummed steadily, the sound of the poem grew more and more distant, and she sank into wave after wave of dizzy darkness, going deeper and deeper.

From the depths of that darkness, fragments of hallucination floated up like the shards of a dream.

Strange—they say that when a person is dying, they see the memories of their whole life; but all Mai Minghe saw was another version of herself, a tube connected to her chest just the same, walking step by step toward the television, then suddenly lunging forward and crashing into the screen.

She was startled by her own actions, and dimly heard a dull, wet sound from somewhere inside her chest.

With eyes half-open and half-closed, hallucination and reality overlapped; her hallucinated self slammed into the old television in the corner of the room again and again, and the screen erupted into spider-web cracks each time.

The hallucination was finally shattered by a sharp shout—an unfamiliar, low, rough voice called out: "What are you doing? Who are you?"

Mai Minghe jolted, and her eyes opened slightly.

Through her blurred vision, she saw an ink-black, lustrous tube standing upright on her chest—it seemed more alive than she was, pressing down on her with a heavy weight and pinning her to the bed.

The next moment, the tube vanished.

The thief snatched the tube behind his back, and despite his panic, kept his wits about him; he turned the question on the two people who had just burst into the bedroom: "Who are you? Why are you suddenly barging into my grandmother's house?"

Two people strode briskly in through the doorway, switched on the lights, and drove out the night; the room blazed white and bright, revealing a bedroom filled with decay, the smell of medicine, cracks in the walls, and the steady whoosh of an oxygen machine.

They were both wearing blue-and-white uniforms—nurse aides.

"Your grandmother?"

The male nurse aide looked at Mai Minghe, then turned a skeptical eye on the thief. "Her? She's your grandmother?"

"I'm two generations mixed—it doesn't show." The thief seemed to realize the difference in their skin tones and ethnicity, and reacted quickly. "Look, I have dark hair. Who are you people?"

"We're emergency-response nurse aides; we came because we received an alert signal—we thought she had an emergency." The other, a woman's voice, explained. "According to our records, she lives alone."

The thief had already composed himself completely.

"Yes," he said, giving Mai Minghe's arm a gentle pat as if to reassure her, and then addressed the nurse aides: "You responded very quickly—thank you for coming so fast. But there's been a small misunderstanding. I'm in Blackmoor City on a business trip and I'm staying with my grandmother for the time being. She's getting on in years, her mind isn't always clear, and she forgot I was coming—she probably thought I was a stranger and triggered the alert. She's fine."

The female nurse aide walked to the bedside, lifted Mai Minghe's eyelids, examined her, and asked softly, "Ma'am, are you all right?"

Mai Minghe opened her mouth to say something, but only the faintest breath passed between her lips. The female nurse aide had seen this many times before and was not surprised that she couldn't speak; she began listening to her heartbeat.

"Would you mind showing me some identification?" the male nurse aide asked the thief, still a little uncertain.

"Of course," the thief said, and right in front of the nurse aides, coolly and openly kicked the black machine with the tube attached to it under Mai Minghe's bed, muttering as he did so: "Why is the vacuum cleaner sitting there...? One moment—I'll go to the next room for my wallet. My driver's license is in it."

The bed she was lying on now was a hospital-style care bed with four wheels; the space underneath was empty and just right for storing things.

"Oh, my phone—" the thief had only taken a couple of steps before he turned back, smiled at the female nurse aide who was still examining Mai Minghe, and said: "I almost forgot. My grandmother sometimes gets frightened for no reason; I have to play poetry or music for her to calm her down."

The female nurse aide's gaze crossed over Mai Minghe to sweep over the phone screen, and her expression relaxed another degree.

Mai Minghe thought: a thief who breaks in and plays poetry for the homeowner—who would believe that if you told them? It looked far more like a devoted grandchild.

Since she was still alive, that meant the thief hadn't yet managed to take whatever was inside her, right?

Right—otherwise he wouldn't still be here playing the dutiful grandson.

Though if the nurse aides had come a few minutes later, he would have succeeded.

No one knew that death had just been sitting right beside her, leaning over and gazing down at her; she had never been this close to death before, and this was the first time she had ever had a dying hallucination...

That's right—the television!

Even Mai Minghe herself hadn't expected it, but the moment she thought of the hallucination just now, a sudden urge arose out of nowhere: she wanted to roll out of bed and go touch the television.

She had to get over there—had to get over there and look, quickly...

Driven by wave after wave of urgency crashing through her, Mai Minghe was so anxious she nearly cried out.

The dark, black television screen had become the only thing in the world with any weight to it—it pressed heavily into her field of vision and drew her toward it; the room, the nurse aides, and the thief were about as substantial as sheets of paper, and seemed on the verge of floating away.

Mai Minghe strained to lift her hand toward the television.

"Ma'am, what's the matter? What do you need?" The female nurse aide followed the direction of her raised hand, turned to look, and asked, "Do you want to watch TV?"

The door to the storage room next door opened and closed again, as if the thief had actually gone in to retrieve something. He had just returned as the female nurse aide spoke, handing his ID to the male nurse aide; the latter looked it over, and when he spoke again, both his tone and his posture had eased.

Mai Minghe let out a sound from her nose—a syllable of negation—but kept her hand pointing at the television.

"I'll turn it on for you," the female nurse aide said; though puzzled, she was kind about it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to respond, switched the television on.

The television was replaying a daytime news commentary program; the host was going over and over the sudden death of Blackmoor City magnate Wellesley from the day before, recounting his business triumphs and charitable works.

"No... no." Mai Minghe finally found her voice again, which was a quiet relief—good, she could speak; her strength was coming back.

The thief quickly swept his gaze over her.

He immediately turned back to the male nurse aide, picking up the thread of what he'd been saying: "...My grandmother is getting on in years—the more confused her mind gets, the more stubborn she becomes. There's no family in Blackmoor City who can look after her..."

Such a young age, and already spinning one lie after another.

Telling them this person wasn't her grandson would probably do no good. An ordinary thief wouldn't stay on the scene to negotiate; from the nurse aides' perspective, between him being a thief and her being a senile old woman, she was the more likely candidate.

Never mind that—the television was more important and more urgent than him right now.

"Help me... help me over there." Mai Minghe pointed at the television and said quietly to the female nurse aide: "Please."

The thief glanced at her again, then looked at the television.

Before he could get a word in, the male nurse aide's question pulled away his attention: "When we arrived, you were hunched over holding a tube—what were you doing?"

"You don't have to go over there—you can watch it from here." The female nurse aide was a little hesitant.

The thief was explaining: "My grandmother cried out in the middle of the night and woke me up; I came to check on her and found the vacuum cleaner hose had fallen onto the bed."

"Please," Mai Minghe gripped the female nurse aide's hand tightly, fixed her eyes on those brown eyes, and begged: "Help me over there. Please. I... I just want to sit there for a moment."

She was coming across more and more like a muddled old woman.

"All right, I'll help you." The female nurse aide gave in. "Can you get up?"

"Yes, yes."

The thief glanced at Mai Minghe once more and, seemingly out of concern, came over on his own initiative to support her—also conveniently extricating himself from the male nurse aide's questioning. "Grandma, what do you want to go over there for? You can take a look, but then you have to come back and sleep, all right?"

Mai Minghe ignored him. He seemed like such a decent-looking young man—what on earth was he doing?

With both of them supporting her, she shuffled unsteadily to the television set; her own pale, ghostly half-reflection floated on the screen, then disappeared as the broadcast cut to footage of the Wellesley Family Estate.

She understood now.

So there really had been a reason for the hallucination after all, Mai Minghe thought.

No wonder she had felt such urgency to come over—well, she should have thought of it sooner; at her age, her mind really wasn't what it used to be.

"I'll get a chair," the female nurse aide said, and let go of Mai Minghe.

That left only the thief holding her. He held her thin, dried-up arm in a loose, light grip, as if he didn't dare exert any force.

"If everything's all right, then we'll be on our way." The male nurse aide stood in the doorway and asked the thief, "Can you get her back to bed on your own in a bit?"

The thief exhaled in relief. He nodded repeatedly and said, "Of course—sorry for making you come all the way out here..."

While he was speaking, Mai Minghe suddenly pulled her arm free, let her body fall backward, and toppled toward the television screen.

She should have thought of it sooner—her hallucination had been telling her how to save herself.

If she fell against the television right in front of the nurse aides, they would have no choice but to send her to the hospital—no matter what the thief claimed to be, right? At the hospital, with plenty of people around, she would be safe.

From the corner of her eye she saw the thief's head snap toward her, but he was a beat too slow and couldn't make it in time; Mai Minghe heard the dull, heavy crack of her skull against the television, and then the room erupted with startled cries and the sound of rushing footsteps.

The female social worker seemed to call out something from very far away, but Mai Minghe couldn't make out the words—

"Where did she go?"

Posted yesterday

but I didn't expect to actually start the book

It's only two chapters—no rush to collect on that debt yet, let's wait and see; what if the later chapters aren't good? Qidian doesn't do refunds on tips, you know.

The same goes for 95, 秋水不染尘, 相声福晋, 绾瑾, 颖佑, 西下有木名栗, 039追女娲? , 卡夫卡, and everyone else—are you all angel investors? I'm flattered and terrified...

Full disclosure: the book launches on the 12th, and I have to leave town on the 14th... My stockpile of advance chapters definitely won't survive the combination of travel chaos and bonus-chapter donations—looks like I'll be pecking away at the keyboard on the plane again.

PS: I saw some readers asking why this is posted on the male-frequency channel when it's a strong-female-lead feature. The editors have their reasons, actually—a large portion of male-frequency readers are women who don't visit the female-frequency side, so a strong-female-lead feature on the male channel is meant to draw them in; think of it as poaching readers for the female channel's benefit (?).

Chapter 3: The Sweet Illusion in Mai Minghe's Hospital Ward

As the world spun around her, Mai Minghe instinctively grabbed at a white shape nearby, but still couldn't steady herself—she stumbled and sat down hard on the ice-cold tile floor, letting out a hoarse groan.

This is bad. Could she have broken a bone?

The pain blurred her vision completely, and she couldn't even tell which bone it was that might be the death of her—one single fall was all it took to shatter her, scatter her into pieces across the floor.

After a fall like this, the nurse aide should have taken her to the hospital no matter what; yet as she caught her breath, the nurse aide who should have come rushing never appeared, and no one asked if she was all right.

What was going on?

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes and looked carefully, and couldn't help but freeze.

...This wasn't her room.

The room was dim and murky; by the thin sliver of white light seeping in under the door, she could vaguely make out that it was a very large space. In front of her and behind her stood an empty narrow bed on either side, and what she had grabbed turned out to be a corner of a bed sheet.

She let go of the sheet and looked left and right.

A row of wheeled care beds, each with a small bedside cabinet, each with a curtain divider—this was clearly a hospital ward. She had been hospitalized several times before and could recognize one at a glance.

How strange.

How had she ended up in a hospital ward? The nurse aides must have brought her here, right?

But how could she have completely forgotten the whole process of being sent to the hospital? It was as if it had never happened—as if a black hole had opened up in her memory.

Mai Minghe suppressed her panic and pain, and no matter how hard she tried to think, the last moment she could recall was still slamming into the television; she remembered the world tilting in the midst of searing pain, and then the next second, she had fallen onto the hospital ward floor.

It was as though she had fallen straight from her home into the hospital—but that was impossible.

Had she lost consciousness at the time and forgotten because of that?

"Is anyone there?" Mai Minghe called out in a hoarse voice. "Nurse? I've fallen..."

In the cold, silent ward, her cry for help was like a chip of broken ice slowly sinking into a cold river, as if it had never existed.

Whether from pain or cold, she trembled uncontrollably in waves. If this went on, something would surely go wrong—she had to call the nurse quickly. Right, there was usually a call bell at the head of the hospital bed.

Mai Minghe struggled to push herself upright, trying to stand, but the pain in her leg bones wouldn't allow it; her hands and feet went limp and weightless, and she slipped, nearly falling again.

There was nothing else for it—she had no choice but to crawl inch by inch toward the bedside cabinet, prop herself against its edge, stretch her arm out as hard as she could, and just barely graze the call bell button with her fingertips.

"If I were you, I wouldn't press that."

The man's voice came out of nowhere and sent a jolt through Mai Minghe's chest; her blood rushed up as though it might burst her brain.

She steadied herself through the dizziness and turned her head toward the sound, only then noticing that there was another bed behind her.

The bed curtain was drawn, but not all the way—a pair of feet belonging to the patient in the adjacent bed were visible.

Those feet were bare, nothing on them at all, snow-white as if dusted with heavy powder, the toes curled ever so slightly, not moving at all.

Mai Minghe couldn't help but feel a rush of relief—thank goodness, there was someone else in the room.

"Are you—are you also a patient here?" she asked, still breathless as she spoke; even as she spoke, she reached toward the call bell again.

"You really want to call the nurse?" the patient behind the curtain asked in return.

"Yes... I've fallen and I have no choice but to call."

For something minor, she wouldn't bother the nurses in the middle of the night if she could help it—Mai Minghe actually understood the adjacent patient's concern.

She pressed the call bell, and not a single sound rang out in the room.

"There, you went and pressed it anyway."

The patient in the adjacent bed knew all the same, and laughed—a stiff, flat laugh, as though each contraction of the diaphragm were deliberate and conscious, every segment precisely equal in length.

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and slowly slid down to sit on the floor, her entire body sinking into exhausted helplessness; but she quietly stole a glance at the curtain from the corner of her eye.

"Won't listen to advice... people really do get more stubborn as they get older. I was saying it for your own good."

"What... do you mean?"

The other person laughed again, two stiff and measured bursts, but gave no answer.

Something felt off, though she couldn't say exactly why.

Mai Minghe was still hesitating over whether to ask again when a deafeningly loud broadcast suddenly tore through the dead-silent corridor outside—an electronic female voice blared and echoed, reverberating through the ward door: "Room three, bed 03, calling nurse. Room three, bed 03, calling nurse!"

The broadcast gave her a fright, and a terrible jolt burst through her chest; she pressed one hand tightly over her heart—relieved that someone was coming, yet unable to stop a creeping unease from rising.

...Strange—normally, after pressing the call bell, would a broadcast go off? This loud, in the middle of the night—weren't they afraid of disturbing people's rest?

Could this be some new rule at hospitals these days?

The broadcast stopped.

In the silent room, for a moment there was nothing but Mai Minghe's trembling breaths.

"Please be advised," the broadcast suddenly blared again at the same staggering volume, startling her once more: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at Room Three within five seconds. Countdown: five—four—three—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She must have been going deaf and blind, mishearing things—otherwise why would she think the broadcast had said "a figure disguised as a nurse"?

The patient in the adjacent bed began to chuckle again, the laughter chopped into segments.

"What the broadcast just said..."

Before Mai Minghe could finish the question, there came a sudden bang—the ward door was slammed hard into the wall, the ear-splitting crash making her chest tighten with a deep, dull ache.

As the ward door flew open, white light from the corridor poured in; standing in that white light was a thin, elongated, extremely tall dark shape, its head cut off by the doorframe above.

The shadow rotated its right shoulder, stepped forward with its right foot—as though its joints were misaligned and stiff—and lurched crookedly one step through the doorway, its head still left outside.

That could not possibly be a nurse.

The thought sharpened the radiating pain pulsing outward from her left chest in waves, her entire left arm as though someone had seized the tendons and was pulling them free; soon she felt herself unable to breathe.

"Oh? It's one of those?"

The patient in the adjacent bed began to laugh with rhythmic contractions of the chest, the snow-white feet beyond the curtain still utterly motionless.

"Say you're unlucky, and yet what came isn't a Resident; say you're lucky, and yet... at this exact moment, you've gone and had a heart attack—so you still won't make it out alive."

The shadow rotated its left shoulder, stepped forward with its left foot, its head swaying and scraping along the wall as it entered; angling its body, it took another step toward bed three.

From far beyond the wide-open door, someone bellowed in fury: "Who's closest?... Get to Room Three now and cut them off! Don't let whoever pressed that bell escape—the nerve, stealing our things!"

...What was happening?

Would she survive this day?

The shadow was backlit, and no matter how much Mai Minghe squinted, she couldn't make out its face. It walked with both arms and legs on the same side swinging together, and though it seemed to take only two or three steps, it had already reached the foot of the bed, trapping her between the two beds.

She wanted to ask who it was, but she could no longer speak.

Someone was sprinting down the corridor toward her, the pounding footsteps growing louder and louder until she could almost feel the floor shaking; the shadow paid no heed to the noise outside and swayed steadily closer until it loomed directly before Mai Minghe.

Was this... a person? she wondered dimly, at the edge of death. That couldn't be, could it?

Before she could understand, this life of hers was about to reach its end.

The shadow slowly bent down toward her.

Though her consciousness was fading, Mai Minghe finally saw clearly the first face she had encountered since entering this hospital.

Beneath a mass of wild dark hair, what extended from the neck was an oval, smooth, hard mirror-surface. Below the mirror, there was nothing but darkness.

It was not a person wearing a mirror over their face.

Where a face should have been, there was not the slightest contour of features or bone—only a mirror in its place, grown out from the surrounding flesh, angled directly at Mai Minghe.

Her aged, withered face was reflected in the mirror, and in that moment, it was as though the one bending down toward her was Mai Minghe herself.

Was she inside a dream right now? A mirror for a face, a heart attack—it was all a dream, surely.

Before dying, she had actually seen something so... extraordinary.

Dream or reality, this was at least the first time in her life she had glimpsed something beyond the ordinary—and it would be the last.

Mai Minghe made no expression, yet the old face in the mirror smiled faintly, the way a person smiles when they have reached a point of helplessness and have no other choice.

The reflection of her opened its mouth, lips parting and closing, speaking soundlessly to the Mai Minghe outside the mirror.

If I could live again...

I would ride the merry-go-round to my heart's content,

I would go everywhere, try everything,

...I would pick more daisies.

Mai Minghe could not move at all—whether her mind had been stilled by some outside force, or whether her old, exhausted heart, on the verge of sleep, could simply no longer be roused.

The lips in the mirror grew more and more indistinct, harder and harder to read; the shadow continued drawing slowly closer, and finally enveloped her completely.

...If you were given the chance to begin again, what would you do with it to make this new life worthwhile?

The thick, tangled, coarse black hair pressed against Mai Minghe's forehead; she was submerged in dense darkness, unable to see anything. Two arms, grotesquely long, wound around her body again and again, pulling tighter and tighter, until it felt as though the bones inside her would be snapped one by one—

"Let go of me,"

Just as the breath in her chest was about to be cut off, Mai Minghe finally struggled and shoved with both hands—but she met no resistance as she had expected, and her hands pushed

through empty air.

She quickly steadied herself and scrambled up from the floor, only then realizing that there was nothing before her at all—the shadow had vanished.

Wait...

It dawned on Mai Minghe belatedly.

She had just jumped to her feet—easily, cleanly, without any difficulty at all?

Mai Minghe raised a hand and pressed it to her chest; the pain was as though it had never existed, and from deep within, there came a steady, familiar rhythm.

Her hands... seemed a little different.

Mai Minghe raised both hands and found that the skin was full and smooth, the nails clear and lustrous, without a single fold of excess wrinkled skin. She lowered her head and stared blankly at what showed below the hem of her pajama pants—a pair of legs, evenly fleshed, fair and strong.

She had to have gone mad.

Youth, it turned out, was a sweet illusion—fierce and full to bursting, so overwhelming it left one at a loss.

For a moment she forgot everything, and frantically explored her own body: her fingers plunged into thick, abundant hair; her arms and thighs had the firm muscles she had long been without; her back had straightened, her height risen... Mai Minghe let out a breathless "ha" of a laugh, her voice trembling.

A clear, young voice she hadn't heard in at least several decades flowed into the cold air of the ward.

From the other side of decay, darkness, and ash, she had somehow been released—born into the world a second time—but wait, was any of this real?

"In here!"

A sharp shout rang out at the doorway, and Mai Minghe jolted upright, lifting her head.

Her vision was no longer clouded and grey; even in the dim light, she could clearly see a man burst in through the door, his face filled with deep wariness.

"There's a woman in here, but I don't see the Artifact."

The man fixed his eyes on Mai Minghe and called out to his companions behind him, then snapped at her: "Which House are you a Hunter for? You've got the item on you, don't you? You have the nerve to steal the Artifact Mr. Wellesley wants?"

"What?" Mai Minghe asked blankly, her mind a tangled mess of confusion—the man's question, rambling as nonsense, had to seep through the cracks of that tangle before even a little of it could reach her.

The man was about to step inside when his eyes swept to something beside her and he stopped dead in his tracks.

"Get in here, all of you," he called to those outside the door. "There's a Resident in Room Three!"

A Resident? What was he talking about?

From that brief glance just now, it seemed like there was something in the room—not far from her at all.

Mai Minghe turned his gaze in a daze and found that the originally empty Bed No. 3 beside her had its curtain drawn at some point.

The curtain wasn't fully closed, revealing a pair of feet so snow-white they looked as though they'd been dusted with powder; the toes were splayed out to either side, frozen still, not moving at all.

...Huh? Wasn't he on the bed next to her just now?

When had he moved over to Bed No. 3?

"Calling you 'old lady' wouldn't be right anymore," the patient behind the curtain said with a laugh. "I should be calling you 'young lady' now. Young lady, what you just got your hands on is a rare and wonderful thing. How about letting me take a look?"

I'm boarding a flight today—the pressure to update has kicked in, so I'll have to write on the plane. I just hope whoever sits next to me isn't one of those screen-peekers. One time I was writing an apocalypse story on a plane, and the guy one seat over suddenly grew five centimeters of neck, like a crane, and twisted it all the way over to ask me: "You writing a novel? What's it about?"

Makes you wonder if nearsightedness really isn't widespread enough.

(Why do I keep catching flights and going on long trips—truly an unsolvable mystery...)

Chapter 4: Mai Minghe Seizes a Second Life

By any reasonable logic, three to five tall, built, hostile strangers pouring in through the door should have been the most alarming threat, right?

No matter how you looked at it, they were still more dangerous than a patient lying in a hospital bed.

And yet, somehow, Mai Minghe couldn't help but fix her gaze on the pair of white feet peeking out from behind the curtain. Her heartbeat thundered in her ears like rolling drums; her palms were cold and clammy—and she couldn't spare so much as a glance for the strangers.

She was wedged between the Bed 03 patient and Bed 02, with the bedside cabinet and wall at her back. The path ahead was blocked by the intruders, and there was no way out.

She stole another glance at the patient in the next bed.

Compared to when she had first seen them, the feet looked slightly different now—she couldn't say exactly how—but looking at them now triggered something instinctive, something biological, a revulsion so deep she almost wanted to open her mouth and heave out everything: the sight before her eyes, the air she'd breathed that had touched those feet, along with every organ in her body.

Looking up again, she could tell the strangers might be feeling the same way: for all their ferocious swagger when they'd barged in, their eyes were now drifting upward, not one of them willing to lower their gaze to the feet on the bed—at a glance, they looked exactly like a group of blind men who had all just taken off their dark glasses at the same moment.

Mai Minghe wiped her nose.

Perhaps terror and tension had wound too tight, and her nervous system was seeking release; perhaps the return of youth carried an intoxicating, surging magic that even fear couldn't dispel; or perhaps it was simply that the people across from her looked too comical—whatever the reason, she suddenly couldn't hold it in, and burst out laughing.

"How did you manage that?"

She stifled her laughter, not wanting those people to think she belonged in a psychiatric ward. She turned to the patient in the next bed and said: "I don't know why, but one look at you and my

guts start churning. You'd make a great side job here at the hospital—stomach-pumping."

The red-haired man who seemed to be the leader didn't say a word, but the expression on his face said everything about what he thought of Mai Minghe—not quite right in the head.

"Miss,"

the male voice from behind the curtain was like a bag of stones clogged with thick phlegm—hearing it was indescribably unpleasant. "This is your first time in the Nest, isn't it?"

Since just moments ago, Mai Minghe had heard a string of incomprehensible terms: a figure disguised as a nurse, Hunters, Artifacts... and now another one had been added—the Nest.

"This isn't a hospital?" Mai Minghe asked.

Though it was a question, she already had the answer clear as a mirror in her mind: of course this wasn't a hospital.

She had somehow ended up in this place called the "Nest"; and that "somehow," it seemed, had a great deal to do with her falling onto the television set.

"But it is a hospital—why wouldn't it be?" the patient behind the curtain answered, in a tone that was almost friendly. "A hospital inside the Nest is still a hospital."

Mai Minghe stalled for time, thinking as she spoke: "You say this is the Nest, but you don't look much like a chicken to me."

The red-haired man let out a sound through his nose—something he'd tried and failed to suppress—and covered it with a cough.

"Doesn't even know what the Nest is," one of the people by the door muttered to a companion in a low voice. "Really is her first time in. No wonder she's still in her pajamas."

"But if it's her first time here, how could she have gotten hold of an Artifact?" another murmured.

"Wait and see," the red-haired man instructed. "Be ready—if she can't hold on, we'll have to take it from the Resident."

As they spoke, they treated Mai Minghe as though she barely existed—or rather, as though she were something that was about to cease to exist very soon.

In the span of just a minute or two, far too many incomprehensible things had happened; right now, Mai Minghe could only hold tightly to two facts.

First, after entering the Nest, she had regained her youth. Second, the thing that had restored her youth seemed to be the objective both parties were after.

Even knowing nothing else, she knew that she was like a child carrying a fortune through a busy marketplace—more like a ghost market—and that was not a good position to be in.

Behind the curtain, there was dead silence; two bare feet, pale-blue and white, rested with their toes hooked over the footrail of the bed.

"What do you want?" Mai Minghe stared at the feet behind the curtain and asked, knowing full well the answer. "How about this—you tell me what's going on, and I'll give you whatever you want. Nice and peaceful, wouldn't that be better?"

The patient behind the curtain considered for two seconds.

"Feel around on your body," his voice had calmed somewhat—less painful to listen to than before—though he still refused to explain further, only saying: "You should be able to feel something. Take it off and give it to me."

Mai Minghe reached her hand inside her pajamas and felt along her back and lower abdomen; the moment she touched it, she flinched.

Slightly raised, ice-cold, band-like things wound around her torso in layer after layer—to the touch, it was exactly like a great snake coiled around her body.

Right—that dark shadowy arm from earlier had seemed to wrap around her just like this, in ring after ring.

"Found it, haven't you," the patient in the next bed suddenly hissed, mucus churning in his throat. "Give it to me."

Mai Minghe traced the edge of the "snake-band" and felt that it seemed deeply reluctant to separate from her skin; she would have to use some force to wedge her fingertips between the band and her flesh.

"Alright, alright, I know, I'll give it to you." It could indeed be removed—she lifted her hand, and had already peeled the "snake-band" up slightly.

She thought of another question.

"I had a heart attack just now, and it only stopped after this thing appeared. Once I take it off, will the attack come back?"

"For someone your age, your mind works fast. I don't think so. What it reversed was aging, not illness—the illness disappearing was merely a side effect, and doesn't necessarily come back along with the aging."

The patient in the next bed's voice was thick and viscous. "Of course, I could be wrong—but besides being optimistic, you have no other choice. Now then, take it off."

As he said, she had no other choice.

"Fortunately, I've always been an optimist." Mai Minghe let out a breath, first peeling the "snake-band" away from her lower abdomen, then following it all the way around to her back, working it off her body bit by bit.

The tail of the pitch-black "snake-band" slipped softly out from her pajamas and hung suspended in the air, swaying gently back and forth, as though it were alive.

"Wait—don't give it to him," the red-haired man suddenly barked, stepping forward and spreading both hands wide. "Give it to me—if it comes for me, it'll leave you alone!"

He used the pronoun "it"?

The thought flashed through Mai Minghe's mind; she had no time to dwell on it, but she had already realized this was a lifeline—in this brief sliver of an opening, she might be able to escape the ward and get out alive. Mai Minghe seized the moment and immediately shouted to the red-haired man: "Catch!"

She swung her arm and pulled a dark shape from behind her back, hurling it toward his raised hands.

It may have been her imagination, but Mai Minghe could have sworn that for one fleeting instant, the patient behind the curtain in the next bed was also drawn away for a split second of distraction.

With a smack, the dark shape landed in the red-haired man's hands at the very same moment Mai Minghe seized her chance: she rolled across Bed 02 and dropped to the ground on the other side—the body of a young person was truly so strong, agile, and balanced; the movement was smooth and effortless, so exhilarating that for one brief instant she nearly forgot she was fleeing for her life.

The dark shape, soft and puffed-up, was nestled between two hands, surrounded by a ring of faces staring intently at it.

"A pillow?"

The red-haired man blinked in surprise once he saw what it was, then flung the pillow—which Mai Minghe had taken from Bed 02—onto the floor, and snapped: "Do you want to die at a Resident's hands?"

Mai Minghe had no time to reply; she had only just found her footing when she turned her head and found that the patient had followed—the curtain around Bed 02 had been drawn shut.

But not fully.

The curtain seemed to have been pulled a little wider; at some point, a pair of lower legs had extended out from it, the two knees pressed tightly together, bending over the edge of the bed and hanging down.

The patient in the next bed was lying flat, with only their legs lowered—that in itself was not strange; what was strange was that those bare feet, pale-blue and bloodless, planted flat on the floor, had rotated a full turn at the ankle and were now facing directly toward Mai Minghe.

This felt too much like an absurd dream; if she were to open her eyes in the next moment and wake up in a hospital bed, Mai Minghe would not have been at all surprised.

"Get back,"

the red-haired man said, his face taut, retreating further from Bed 02 along with the others behind him.

It was as though even the air was slowly tightening, thinning out; as though they were wild animals long accustomed to these surroundings, and had sensed the danger one step before Mai Minghe, who understood nothing.

She thought for a moment, then asked the patient in the next bed: "Did you come into the hospital for a broken ankle?"

As she spoke, Mai Minghe had a vague sense of something pulling at her waist.

"Or... you really aren't human?" She called out to the red-haired man: "Hey, young man—if it's not human, what is it? Really a chicken?"

Everything was so unbelievable that she found she'd lost her capacity for shock, and simply wanted to understand what was happening—after all, no one can keep startling themselves too frequently.

The red-haired man didn't answer her.

He and the others behind him were all staring at the lower legs dangling from beside Bed 02 and at the floor, as though Mai Minghe had already been erased from the situation—she just didn't know it yet.

The curtain rustled with a soft shushing sound; someone was slowly drawing it open.

Mai Minghe did not want to see what lay behind the curtain—it couldn't be anything good.

She quickly lowered her head again; when her gaze fell on the pair of feet before her, she noticed that the patient in the next bed's left foot had, at some point, stepped forward.

Though she herself hadn't moved at all, her own left foot had also stepped forward.

Like two old acquaintances reuniting, walking toward each other.

No wonder it felt like something was pulling at her waist...

Strange—why was it that simply seeing the other's feet caused her own feet to move beyond her control, mirroring the other's movements—no, this was not the time for puzzling and reflection.

Even with her head lowered, she could sense from the corner of her eye that the curtain had been drawn open.

On Bed 02 beside her, a long human-shaped shadow lay dimly on the mattress.

Mai Minghe drew a deep breath.

If this had been the Mai Minghe of before, she might have chosen to keep the peace and put self-preservation first, handing the "snake-band" over to it; the first time you're alive, you're always afraid that one wrong move will lead to irreversible, unbearable consequences and make this life a miserable one.

Later, when she had grown old, she found that her decades of life had been filled with nothing but loneliness, regret, and wishes long past their expiry date—not much of a good life after all. Opportunities no longer came calling, and she had run out of strength.

This "snake-band" could be the last great adventure in her eighty-six years of life; but it could also be the first choice of her life yet to come.

She wanted to try.

Mai Minghe knew that pressing the call button would not break the dead silence in the room with any sound.

"Ward Three, Bed 01 is calling for a nurse!"

The broadcast's sharp, almost piercing female voice shattered the room's silence without warning.

Before anyone had time to react, Mai Minghe pressed the call button several more times in quick succession.

The intercom, as if galvanized, announced down the corridor in increasingly urgent tones: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds—a second figure disguised as a nurse is about to arrive—a third figure disguised as a nurse—a fourth figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds!"

Amid the announcements, each more urgent than the last, Mai Minghe thought she dimly heard the red-haired man curse "Are you insane!"; immediately after, a flurry of retreating footsteps receded rapidly, as though the group, seeing things had gone south, had fled the ward ahead of everyone else.

She had not lifted her head the entire time.

Mai Minghe felt the dark shape beside her rising up joint by joint: thighs lifting off the mattress, hips suspended halfway in the air, upper body still flat on the bed.

In the dim residual light, that head turned toward Mai Minghe, and spoke in a voice utterly unlike any human sound: "For an old lady, you've got quite the nerve."

At that very moment, something heavy was suddenly hurled across the room and slammed down hard between her and the patient in the next bed—landing with a thunderous thud, the nightstand instantly smashed to pieces—the shadow tumbled to the floor, and when it scrambled up against the wall, it turned out to be the red-haired man; finding himself wedged squarely between the patient and Mai Minghe, he swore under his breath.

Mai Minghe didn't look at him.

She kept her gaze fixed on the doorway of the ward, and said quietly: "Look again. I'm not an old lady anymore."

Not now. Not tomorrow either.

She would seize this second life—truly seize it—for herself.

By the time you see this chapter, I should already be on the plane—this chapter was set on a timer—having a backlog really gives you confidence! You can even schedule posts! Back when I was writing the apocalypse story, it was feast or famine!

Unfortunately, the backlog, all told, is barely enough to last a little over a week... hopefully I can manage to write at least one chapter on the plane, so once I land I can start bonus updates to pay off my debt.

Speaking of debt—dear readers, aren't you being a little too swift and decisive? The Artifact Report just came into the world and you're already stuffing in red envelopes—what if the child grows up to be the Hunchback of Notre Dame?

It feels like every time I blink, another debt appears...

Aiya, boarding time is almost here, there's a super long line at the gate, and here I am sitting cross-legged typing away—just wait until I've landed, and then we'll properly tally up how much more I owe.

So what if I'm a pack mule—I've been in this business for a hundred years! I'll gather coins with my donkey tail!

Chapter 5 — Sydney Ginn, the Hunter Plagued by a Stalker

Sydney Ginn stood before her own memorial portrait, ears ringing.

A funeral wreath was blocking her front door; open it, and the first thing you'd see was her own smiling, blurred face. The black-and-white portrait photo was crooked-nailed to the center of the wreath, and a line of savage crimson letters — "BITCH" — tore across her smile.

It was the first time in her life she had seen, in person, the kind of wreath used at Asian funerals; and even as fury and shock surged through her, some small part of Sydney found herself marveling at how authentic it looked — identical to the ones on TV — wondering where on earth someone would even get one made.

As for who had left it there, she wasn't curious, because she already knew.

Sydney kicked the wreath over, slammed the door, and walked toward the elevator, pulling out her phone as she went.

"Get up here right now and take a look at what's been left in front of my door."

She had lived in this building for three years, and today was the first time she had ever raised her voice at the building manager like this — before now, she had always been too afraid to be rude.

"What gives you the right to charge such high rent and management fees? This is supposed to be the most expensive address in Blackmoor City? Your security staff — did you borrow them as mummies from the National Museum next door? Are they all dead? I told you, didn't I, that there's been a creep following me lately — why wasn't security tightened? How did he even get the chance to reach my front door?"

When Sydney had first moved into this building, she had been deeply insecure about it.

By any normal trajectory, someone like her — born to an ordinary immigrant family, with no impressive credentials and an equally unremarkable job — could spend a lifetime saving for rent and still never pass the application screening, never gain entry into this century-old landmark, already designated a historic site.

The layered barriers of class and social networks made it difficult even for many newly minted tech millionaires to lease a unit here, let alone buy one.

Not long after she moved in, she had once encountered a woman in the elevator who struck up a very friendly conversation with her, which quietly pleased her; just before the elevator reached the lobby, the woman smiled and asked, "Who do you work for? We happen to be interviewing for household staff at the moment."

It took her several seconds to realize the woman had mistaken her for a maid.

Even dressed in much the same way, something — she couldn't say what — still allowed others to see at a glance that she didn't belong to this class. The building manager on the phone was one of them.

"Miss Ginn,"

the manager explained in a tone that bordered on sympathetic condescension, "I also feel very sorry about this. But you may not be aware that we generally prefer not to interfere in our residents' personal affairs — that has always been our policy.

"The people our residents typically associate with are all respectable individuals of standing, so this sort of thing is happening for the very first time. According to security, he said he wanted to give you a surprise, and he was carrying flowers, so we couldn't quite tell — it seemed like perhaps you and your boyfriend had some kind of romantic dispute..."

"It's not a romantic dispute, it's stalking and harassment!" Sydney snapped, too furious to even register the implication buried in the word "respectable." "And he's not my boyfriend — what he was carrying was a funeral wreath!"

The man had been on a few dates with her and had indeed visited before, having been granted entry each time; it was precisely after seeing her home and her lifestyle that he had begun repeatedly demanding money and gifts from her, and only when she could no longer bear it had she decided to cut off all contact.

She had never imagined that a simple "no" could ignite such an unhinged, consuming hatred.

"Of course, of course, I'll have someone remove the wreath right away. Security isn't like you — they wouldn't recognize that kind of wreath, which is understandable, and I hope you can appreciate that." The building manager continued, "That said, Miss Ginn, I'd also like to ask you to try to communicate with him and calm the situation down. After all, our residents here tend to prefer things quiet and low-key; they don't care for this sort of disturbance..."

"So I'm the one who should be apologizing to you?"

Sydney was too furious to catch anything else the manager said, hung up the call, and kicked the elevator door hard.

When she left the building, she didn't ask the doorman to call a car for her, and walked absentmindedly out into the Blackmoor City streets, where the morning sun was blazing.

Sydney could file a police report, apply for a restraining order — but neither was a sure thing.

For all she knew, the police wouldn't act until she'd already become a victim; and a restraining order might deter a sane person, but how much effect would it have on someone unhinged?

For an ordinary woman, there was little left beyond reporting it to the police, staying on guard, fleeing somewhere far away, and praying — but what that Anthony probably didn't know was that what Sydney could actually do went far beyond any of that.

She wandered for a while, made up her mind, and flagged down a taxi.

The timing worked out perfectly; when she reached the Buluan district, "Between the Backlight" had just opened its doors.

The bar's entrance was hidden behind a short staircase that descended from the sidewalk into the ground, and people walking past could hardly see its sign light; though in Sydney's memory, the sign light had never actually been on — so it hardly mattered whether any passerby could see it.

She pushed open the faded wooden door, and to the dry creaking of the door's hinges, stepped into a cramped, dim basement.

In the murky darkness, chairs sat upside down on tabletops, and cardboard boxes were stacked in the booths. The air was stale and cool, drifting with dust, the smell of alcohol, and a faint trace of vomit.

"You're here this early?"

The back door was pushed open, and a man peered in, then walked behind the bar. He had the face of a Shar-Pei, all drooping brows and downcast eyes, and yet, like a dog, his expression was somehow warm.

He switched the television on for Sydney and gestured toward the bar. "Sit down, I'm still tidying up."

The television mounted in one corner of the bar's ceiling lit up with the midday news. A baby elephant had been born at the Blackmoor City Center Island Zoo, and the female anchor was beaming.

"Any news?" Sydney sat down and asked. "I'm planning to head over in the next couple of days."

"There's a team that's temporarily short-handed and wants to hire an experienced Hunter with no House Faction ties. I thought — isn't that you?"

The bartender's Shar-Pei face remained buried behind the bar counter; he seemed to be scrubbing the cabinet door on his knees, and said over the shushing sound of the cloth: "Not much money — three thousand dollars, departing next week. And of course, whatever comes out of it at the end has nothing to do with you."

A few years ago, three thousand dollars would have lit her eyes up like flashlights; but now, it wasn't nearly enough to make it worth her while.

"I can't work with a group right now — I've got some personal business this time. Are there any other commissions?"

"Then there's nothing—"

He'd barely gotten the words out when the television suddenly rang out with a sharp, urgent chime, making Sydney glance up at the screen — breaking news.

"We have just learned," the female anchor said, her expression grave, "that Wellesley, founder, shareholder, and CEO of the Qunmu Consortium, was found dead this morning at his upstate estate, at the age of fifty-nine. The cause of death is currently suspected to be sudden cardiac arrest, and police have opened an investigation... Mr. Wellesley was also a state senator, a philanthropist..."

Sydney startled. "He's dead?"

The Shar-Pei face emerged from behind the bar, watching the screen. "Did you know him?"

"No, not personally. But I have a client who had some dealings with him... I thought maybe I'd be able to do business with him someday. Pity." Sydney said, and set aside the death of Blackmoor City's richest man. "No other assignments?"

"You could wait a few more days — something might come up." The bartender went back to polishing the beer taps. "When are you planning to go?"

Sydney took out her phone, intending to check the time, but found over twenty text messages on her screen, all from an unknown number; even without opening them, she could tell at a glance they were a mix of pitiful pleading, filth, and threats and curses.

She had already blocked four or five numbers, but it didn't seem to slow the harassment at all.

"I'm going tonight — no assignment, forget it." She put her phone away, her tone cooling. "There's a problem that's not huge but is deeply unpleasant, and I need to go make a trip and bring something back to deal with it."

The bartender nodded and asked, "The usual drink? Or should I pack it to go?"

"Yes," — just mentioning the drink, Sydney was fairly sure the color drained from her face — "I didn't bring a cup, just pour it into a couple of plastic bottles, whatever you've got."

The moment she thought about the drink he prepared for her, even before it was down her throat, her stomach started to heave, as though every organ in her body wanted to empty itself out in advance.

No matter how many times she drank it, Sydney could never get used to the taste of alcohol. She had been forcing herself to drink for the past several years, and she seemed to be turning into Pavlov's dog — sometimes just catching a whiff of alcohol on someone else was enough to make her legs go weak and her head swim with nausea.

"Only the drink you mix has the effect I need. If I drink anything else, my mind goes numb all right, but my limbs get heavy and sluggish, and the moment I close my eyes I fall dead asleep — that's just playing with my life."

A smile flickered across the bartender's face. "But it's still not efficient enough, is it? I'll keep an eye out and see if there's a suitable medication for you."

If she could pop a pill and get the same effect, that would be wonderful. But until she had that pill, she had no choice but to grit her teeth and force the drink down.

If she still wanted to keep living this life.

When night fell, Sydney changed into running shoes and athletic wear and pulled her hair up into a tight bun.

She packed all her usual gear into a bag — not an ordinary backpack, but a half-body-height hiking pack of the kind trekkers used, big enough to stuff a sleeping bag into.

Though she didn't plan to stay long, Sydney didn't dare be careless, and still brought a hunting knife, a ladies' handgun, and a can of bear spray.

What a shame — with real-world laws to contend with, none of these things could be used directly on the stalker; in the end she still had to go the long way around.

The time on her phone ticked over to 9:43 PM.

Harassment messages — each from a different number — kept flooding in without pause, piling up at the bottom of the screen, not a single one swiped open; the unread message count had already reached 129.

Sydney had discovered a few hours ago that the stalker had posted her number on dozens of yellow websites; since then, the messages coming in were not only nauseating but impossible to block fast enough.

She simply shoved the phone to the very bottom of her backpack, out of sight, out of mind.

Night had dyed the entire floor-to-ceiling window black; she sat on the floor before it, as if suspended in midair, adrift among Blackmoor City's skyscrapers and countless lights.

The neon glow, bright as scattered diamonds, would persist through the deep of the night and into the dawn. This city — the largest and most prosperous metropolis on earth — never slept, never rested.

The drink the bartender had prepared for her, she forced down sip by sip, enduring the discomfort, until her consciousness was soon scorched into something light and floating, her blood churning and bubbling; even though the apartment was perfectly quiet, she seemed to hear a hum coming from somewhere.

The primal fear honed by millions of years of evolution was not something that could be habituated to or overcome simply by trying again and again.

If she didn't drink large quantities of alcohol, if she didn't dull her mind into a hazy stupor, Sydney didn't even have the courage to walk to the edge of the balcony — she had always been severely acrophobic; she wouldn't even ride roller coasters at an amusement park.

She gripped the balcony railing with trembling hands, drew a breath, and stepped up onto the chair she had prepared.

The backpack hung heavy from her shoulders, and as she pushed herself up to sit on the railing it caught and scraped against it; the lurch of her body nearly sent both her heart and her stomach sliding up her throat, and it was only with great effort that she steadied her breathing, her palms soaked through with cold sweat.

Even drunk, she still dared not look down, keeping her gaze fixed on the city skyline.

Far away between the buildings, rivers of traffic flowed, countless headlights blurring into bright smears in the fine drifting rain. The cool, thin rain fell in close, slanting lines against her skin, and Sydney felt a vague worry that the cold rain might sober her up, stripping away the blessed numbness.

...Time to go.

She sat on the railing, her back to the neon lights of Blackmoor City, watching her reflection in the glass door and the faint outline of the living room beyond it.

"I'll be right back," Sydney Ginn said softly to the apartment. "Wait for me."

She closed her eyes, leaned back, and fell straight down into the cool early-November night wind.

*I'm back, everyone — first thing I did was eat until I couldn't anymore, god it felt like getting out of jail, I nearly cried over the food — wait, no, what am I saying, the first thing I did was sit my butt down and write, for real!

Hehehe I just posted four chapters and already swapped away from Mai Minghe — sorry about that. The worldbuilding needs multiple perspectives or it'll be confusing for too long, which isn't great. I won't be switching POVs that often going forward.

I should have given a heads-up at the end of the last chapter, but I forgot... donkeys have bad memories, and apparently so do I — you all are hippocampi, I'm a hippo-donkey, the pirated version glitches out, but paying readers will definitely forgive me (right?).

I've always thought one of the big reasons Western fantasy is hard to get into is the names... so I've given all the Western characters in this story names that Chinese readers can actually remember. Take Sydney Ginn — her name is translated as 金雪梨 (Jin Xuěli). If I'd called her 西

妮 · 洁, who would even know who that is, right? I picked up this trick while writing Milady, and it really works — solid 4.8 stars on the reviews.

*Why am I sticking this ramble at the end of the main text? Because the author's note section ran out of space, and I just can't bring myself not to ramble. This chapter is free anyway, so you can't say I'm padding the word count.

Let me see which impatient grannies have made themselves my creditors this time...

Alright, I now honorably owe Tiánxiá one bonus chapter (how does it always end up costing me more than it saves?), owe Magical Grey Feather one big healthy bouncing baby of a bonus chapter (didn't I just say don't be in such a rush?! I actually feel bad), and owe Yīngyòu one big healthy baby (I'd be better off going to stake out the maternity ward at People's Hospital — faster that way)... what are you all doing, you're already here, you didn't have to bring gifts too (lol.

Thank you Tángmián Yè, Shí Zhī Yōulíng, Please Call Me A-Qī, and 锦o (maybe I'll scrape together one kid for the four of you — go home and split it into four pieces, my stockpile is already shivering with cold sweat)

Thank you Péng Xiǎoxī, Pūpū Hāhā, Mí Miēmiē, Mò Yuān (pronounced Black Bird), Fēitiān Dàdào Zéi, Déyún Fūjìn, Kafka, A-Shí qwq, Sān Xī Yī, Yūki Akinana, Qīngqīng Jiǔ, Me and Honeydew Are Mortal Enemies (Melon!!), Jiāng Lù Jīng Lúfù, and Today I Had a Roasted Sweet Potato — what's the rush, grannies, isn't it nicer to let this relationship flow gently like a stream? What if it turns out not good, I'm already second-guessing myself.

Counting the grannies from before, how many bonus chapters do I owe now? Five?

...Five?????

.....????????

Time flows like a river — and by "time," does that mean my stockpile?!

Chapter 6: Sydney Ginn's Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion

She had lost count of how many times she'd fallen from a great height.

Sooner or later, between the alcohol and the repeated falls, her heart would slam against her sternum one final time—and then Sydney Ginn would cease to exist.

But at least this time, she was still alive; even as the blood her heart was furiously pumping surged in waves through her skull, sending wave after wave of dizziness crashing through her.

The hot alcohol turned to sweat and burst from her pores, and the needle-sharp burning across her back faded into a cool, damp chill.

Sydney Ginn would perhaps never stop fearing the fall; but after so many jumps, she had at least learned to land without screaming—there was only her breathing now, ragged and heavy, nearly a whimper; fear like a centipede, crawling and scratching inside her chest and throat.

She had landed in the same old place again.

The room was adrift with the smell of stale dust, the kind that called to mind old cardboard boxes; dim and cool and dark, but not a deep darkness—more like a half-drawn curtain that you could push aside with one hand and find someone hiding behind it.

Sydney Ginn didn't move.

The alcohol still rolled through her like waves born inside her body, rocking and pushing at her.

Something must have been watching over her, because no matter what position she jumped from, she always landed on her feet, like a cat blessed by the heavens.

She crouched in place for a few seconds, then reached out her right hand into the darkness to feel for the wall. Every time she landed, the alcohol left her unsteady on her feet, and she would brace herself against the wall on her right—if someone shone a flashlight on it, they'd probably see the wallpaper gleaming where it had been soaked through with the oils from her hand.

The moment her hand touched something smooth, flat, and square—a plastic panel—she yanked it back as if electrocuted, cursed under her breath, and felt a cold wave of belated terror prickle across her skin.

...Impossible to guard against everything, she thought. Last time she was here, the light switch definitely hadn't been on this wall.

Fortunately, her hand hadn't had enough weight behind it to press down that eager, impatient light switch.

Sydney Ginn moved slowly into the corner and felt her way to the same spot where the faucet always was, then turned it on. She cupped her hands and drank several large mouthfuls; the faucet squeaked and squeaked as it turned two full rotations, then fell silent again.

Unlike food, water in the Nest was generally safe.

Sydney Ginn pulled a flattened fried doughnut and a can of coffee from her bag.

Drink before the jump to numb the fear with alcohol to its limit; after landing, wash the alcohol out with fried food and coffee as best she could—every single time Sydney Ginn entered the Nest, she had to go through the same routine.

She leaned against the corner of the wall and, though she had no appetite at all, forced herself to finish eating, then carefully packed the empty can and paper bag back into her backpack.

Never leave personal belongings behind in the Nest—not even if it's trash. That was a Hunter's first lesson. When she had learned it, Sydney Ginn couldn't remember anymore.

On the far side of the sink, there was a locked storage cabinet.

She fumbled in the dark for several tries before finally fitting the key into the lock; from behind the silently swinging cabinet door, she felt out a radio—cool, heavy, square, and solid.

The static crackle of electricity rose from the depths of the darkness and settled beside her; as she turned the dial searching for the channel, the static slowly resolved into a man's voice.

"Welcome to Nest Radio 173," the man's voice said quietly, as if he were about to begin telling a story. "This is the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion. I am your host."

No name—only "your host."

His—or perhaps its, since no human could live in the Nest—entire identity seemed to exist solely in relation to the radio station.

No matter when Sydney Ginn turned on the radio, the first words she heard were always "Welcome to Nest Radio 173"—as if the host were waiting at all times, and a listener turning on

the receiver was what switched him on.

"Today is Monday, November 16th, 2026."

Time in the Nest moved at the same pace as in the outside world; Sydney Ginn glanced at her phone and confirmed it once more.

On the phone screen, over a hundred ugly unread messages were frozen in place; no signal, no new texts coming in.

"First, let's bring you the Nest news."

In the darkness, Sydney Ginn listened while she waited for the coffee and food to take effect. This hideout should be known only to her, so there was no need to worry about anyone barging in.

In the Nest, where a single moment of distraction could mean the difference between life and death, she sat perfectly still listening to the radio—when she thought about it, she found it a little funny herself.

She was a solo Hunter, without the backing of a House Faction, and the Artifacts she'd managed to get her hands on in the past had all been bottom-tier; by rights, she had no room to be choosy—she should take any Artifact she could get, sell any Artifact she had.

But this one radio—this, she would never sell to anyone. It was her lifeline.

"...We trust that all Residents who truly love the Nest will be very pleased? A great threat to the Nest had only just begun to take root, yet it was swiftly stamped out through the combined efforts of all parties. We hope everyone will share this good news with friends and family—if you haven't already made them into dinner."

Sydney Ginn listened with only half her attention. Honestly, she hadn't understood it; and she had no idea what "great threat" referred to.

The broadcast wasn't made for humans; the host's audience was the Residents of the Nest, so out of every ten sentences, there were about eight that she couldn't follow.

As long as it seemed to have nothing much to do with her, Sydney Ginn couldn't be bothered to puzzle it out; the curiosity she'd felt when she first got the radio had, after nearly dying once, long since vanished completely.

She understood barely half of it, yet she listened anyway.

"A Toyota with the license plate MKA-388 has been parked at the entrance of the Buluan District Public Library for more than seven days. The owner is requested to move the vehicle as soon as possible, or it will be added to the library's vengeance list."

The license plate sounded like a real Blackmoor City plate... could a Hunter really have driven a car in here?

If it had been sitting there that long, the owner was probably dead.

The thought passed through her mind and left no mark.

Being an Artifact Hunter meant racing against the darkness; the Hunters who had been swept under by its black waves and sunk forever into the depths of the Nest were beyond counting by now.

Sooner or later, she would sink down too; she just didn't know what form her grave would take when it finally appeared before her.

"...Next, we'll bring you traffic conditions and map information."

Sydney Ginn snapped to attention, the effects of the alcohol fading considerably, her mind sharpening. She quickly pulled out a pen and a brand-new Blackmoor City tourist map, clamped her phone between her teeth, and used the faint glow of its screen to spread the map out on the concrete floor.

"First," the host said, as though even he understood the importance of this information, slowing his pace, "streets from Fifth to One Hundred and Ninetieth remain unchanged and are accessible as normal today."

She let out a breath of relief.

Whether it was a good thing or a bad thing was unclear, but the Nest seemed to have a life of its own—always slowly mutating.

Before she got the radio, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had to brace herself mentally—even a location she'd explored more than a hundred times, the next time you pushed open the door, you might still step into a room you'd never seen before.

The Nest resembled Blackmoor City's layout, but in a distorted, off-kilter kind of way—as if the Nest were a slanted, warped mirror image, twisted by light and shadow, breeding from the

gaps and crevices of shade things that did not belong to this world.

Was this a crack in the universe, a legendary hell, or the delusion inside the mind of a madman?

Sydney Ginn had come here more times than she could count, and still didn't know the answer.

After listening to enough broadcasts, she had worked out the patterns.

"Currently undergoing construction/renovation/repair"—this meant the area was in the process of changing.

"Attracting a large number of visitors / a great weekend destination"—absolutely do not go near it; you had to give even the surrounding area a wide berth.

"Unchanged, accessible as normal"—exactly as it sounded: as long as you had previously scouted the terrain and assessed the risks, you could still trust your last experience.

The thing Sydney Ginn had prepared to deal with her stalker was hidden on 99th Street, which happened to fall within an area showing no unusual changes; if everything went smoothly, the journey from her landing spot to 99th Street would take only two days, and she could retrieve the item and return to Blackmoor City.

Two days... she couldn't help letting out a self-deprecating laugh.

By distance alone, it was at most fifteen kilometers between the two points; but in the Nest, covering fifteen kilometers in two days counted as remarkably smooth going.

By the time the traffic and map report was finished, Sydney Ginn's map was covered in circles of all sizes, along with annotations like "DANGER!" "GO STRAIGHT" and "Bus available, but don't talk to the driver."

Based on the experience she had bought with her life over and over again, the broadcasts could be trusted.

If she ever decided to retire, this radio could probably fetch her at least a million dollars.

But Sydney Ginn knew she could never retire—even with a million waiting for her, she couldn't bear to stop being a Hunter—there were too many things in this world worth trying, her desires ran too deep, and a million was far from enough.

"I'm doing him too much of a favor," Sydney Ginn thought, growing more irritated the more she dwelled on it. "What kind of rat crawls out of the gutter thinking he deserves me to bring back an Artifact just to deal with him..."

She put the map and pen away and was just about to pick up the radio from the floor—which was currently playing "Nest's Hottest New Songs Chart No. 1," a track that wasn't actually too bad, sounding like a howling wind through a forest with faint, drawn-out human shrieks woven through it—when the "music" suddenly paused and stopped.

Then again, with something like drawn-out human shrieks, who could ever tell which one was the last?

"What a soothing and melodious song," the host murmured. "I just received a listener call-in, so I'll be adding a special emergency broadcast segment."

Sydney Ginn's breath caught.

A "special emergency broadcast"—since she'd gotten the radio, she had only heard it twice.

The first time, the special emergency broadcast had helped her find a fixed, hidden, and private landing spot—the very small room she was in right now.

She hadn't even known before that, that a human could bind a landing point within the Nest.

In the past, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had appeared in a public landing point like everyone else—City Hall, the Contre-Jour Garden, St. Louis Hospital, and so on—surrounded by Hunters, Residents, and countless other unknowns, she hadn't even dared stay in one place long enough to finish a coffee.

The second time, the Artifact she obtained through the special emergency broadcast had bought her that apartment in Blackmoor City—the kind of place an ordinary person couldn't get close to in a lifetime. Beyond the payment, the buyer had also signed an open-ended contract: for as long as Sydney Ginn lived, she would have permanent right of residence in that apartment.

Now the third time had finally come.

In that moment, Sydney Ginn's entire field of vision narrowed to the radio on the floor; she forgot to breathe, every ounce of her focus sharpening into a hook, clamped tight around every single word coming through.

"...After entering through Door D of the Museum of Modern Art, take the elevator on the left down to basement level one."

The host's voice flowed slowly from the radio, as if projecting the interior layout of the building inside her mind. "Remember—you must take the first elevator on the left. If the doors of any other elevator open, do not get in, do not look, and no matter what happens, pretend you don't notice."

Although the broadcast audience seemed to be Nest Residents, there were always these small details that made Sydney Ginn feel as though the host was issuing instructions to her specifically—or rather, to whatever Hunter happened to be listening.

"The 'Candlefall' in the first basement exhibition hall is something you'll want to keep in mind. From what I know, it only recently became an Artifact—and some might say it is one of the most powerful Artifacts the Nest has ever produced."

The host paused, as if he could sense the thudding of Sydney Ginn's heartbeat.

"To anyone thinking of going to take a look—take my advice. Human fate is as thin and fragile as a cotton cloth. The floods of this world are too many, too unpredictable—they surge and crash without mercy. A person can only be torn apart and swallowed up in the churning currents, flung by forces far greater than themselves toward a future they cannot see clearly.

"And an Artifact... is a mountain torrent and a tidal wave, a storm and a towering wall of water. It is the genie that grants your wishes, and the god that heeds no pleas..."

He got this far, and then, as if what came next was too difficult to say, he trailed off involuntarily.

The darkened room fell silent for a moment; the host had no breath—Sydney Ginn had realized that long ago.

In the room there were only four or five breathing sounds, including her own, rising and falling together in the dark.

"Dear listeners, that's all for today's broadcast. Please stay safe, everyone—until next time."

Sydney Ginn stood there in a daze for a few seconds, then grabbed the radio and stowed it away again. Feeling her way to the door handle, she cracked the door open and slipped out.

The Museum of Modern Art was in the direction she was already heading.

Go to the museum first to see the Artifact the broadcast mentioned, then head to 99th Street to get what she needed to deal with Anthony...

A day or two's delay was no big deal.

Sydney Ginn only has one chapter, there's nothing in the drafts.

I've seen people asking what Mai Minghe's English name is—Mai Minghe is actually ethnically Chinese, so her Chinese name is just Mai Minghe; but of course she does have an English name, and it's one I'm quite proud of, so pretty that I regret giving it to her—River Rye.

I kind of want to take it back for myself lol.

What's wrong with that? A daughter giving her mother a little tribute is only right, isn't it.

For minor supporting characters like that nuisance Anthony, I'm not going to bother Sinicizing the names—if you can't remember them, you can't remember them; coming up with names that sound both good and distinctive is such a headache.

Writing on an iPad while away from home is such a pain, ugh, it's really affecting my output.

Now I want an e-ink tablet again lol.

Chapter 7 – Sydney Ginn: The Hunter's Life Is No Easy Living

Night in Blackmoor City is also night in the Nest.

Wind tumbled down through the cracks between heaven and earth, tossing her bangs astray. If she squinted and peered out through the shadow of her lashes, Sydney Ginn could barely tell whether she was in the Nest or in Blackmoor City.

A Blackmoor City abandoned and desolate, its shadows twisting, every detail more unsettling the deeper you looked—at the intersection ahead, the green light on the traffic signal had gone dark, replaced by a purple one, blinking on and off; the surface of the empty road was seized by the purple light, then released, seized, then released.

Only sound was truly honest: she couldn't hear car engines, rolling tires, or honking horns; no voices in conversation, no dogs barking, no video blogger narrating into a selfie camera. At this moment, the only sound Sydney Ginn could hear was a steady footstep, one after another.

A soft "tap"—her left foot meeting the ground; before she could even lift her right foot, she heard another "tap."

The footsteps behind her had been following her for several minutes now.

Whoever it was didn't seem much like a Hunter; Hunters who crossed paths in the Nest tended to keep their distance, sizing each other up with cautious wariness—the ever-present threat of extreme danger kept everyone's nerves wound tight, and nobody wanted to invite extra trouble.

If it wasn't a Hunter, then it was a Resident.

Should she pretend not to notice?

Sydney Ginn opened her phone's camera, held it flat against her chest, angled it slightly up over her shoulder, and snapped a photo—quick and discreet.

She quickened her pace to put some distance between them, then darted a glance at the screen.

In the photo, a warped, grinning version of Sydney Ginn's own face was staring back at her.

The teeth were white and enormous, packed so densely they could barely fit inside the mouth, the lips nearly insufficient to contain them. The figure looked to be resting its cheek on someone's

shoulder, flashing a "yeah" hand sign.

Sydney Ginn recognized it at once—that shoulder was her own.

What rotten luck.

"Get lost!" Sydney Ginn hissed without turning around, slashing her hunting knife backward to drive the thing back a few steps. "Who do you think you're dealing with? You think I'm not long for this world?"

Silence from behind. A few seconds of stillness, then she heard her own voice let out a low, tittering "heh heh."

...So it wasn't going to leave on its own.

Annoying as it was, her luck wasn't entirely bad—whatever had latched onto her wasn't especially dangerous.

This type of Resident was common in the Nest. When they set their sights on someone, they would wrench their face into that person's likeness, though the result was always slightly off—an extra eyeball in the right eye socket, a single black hole in place of nostrils, or, as now, a mouth so crammed with teeth it could barely close.

They simply followed their target wearing the target's face, and while deeply unsettling, they posed no immediate threat.

Only after a target met with danger and died would this type of Resident pounce, coiling and writhing and feeding upon the corpse, until when it finally raised its face, it had become an exact, flawless replica of the original. Some said it was perhaps because they longed to return to the human world that they wished to impersonate humans and slip back into Blackmoor City in the original's place—though that was just hearsay, not worth taking seriously.

In other words, they were like vultures over a desert, perpetually circling above animals on the verge of death.

This particular Resident had probably caught the smell of alcohol on Sydney Ginn, noticed the faint sway still in her step, and decided she wouldn't last much longer.

Its technique wasn't up to par with its kind, though—ordinarily, a "Vulture" trailing someone wouldn't let the Hunters notice at all; this one was stomping along quite audibly.

Still, harmless as it might be, knowing that thing's face was hovering just over her shoulder was irritating enough.

She listened carefully, gauging the distance between footfalls with her attention, calculating whether she could create an opportunity to shake it—when a thought suddenly broke through: something's wrong.

Sydney Ginn's whole body jerked. She stopped dead in her tracks, and before she'd even gotten a clear look at the ground ahead, she threw herself sideways off the path, her back hitting the railing with a loud clang.

That noise—who knew whether it would draw other Residents now...

But this wasn't the time to worry about what came next—she'd almost fallen for the Vulture Resident's trick.

"Sydney Ginn" was still standing just a step or two away, watching her, the lower half of its face all smiles and teeth. But the eyes grew deeper and deeper, darker and darker, until they resembled a pair of holes poked by a child's finger into dough.

Sydney Ginn did her best not to look at it, and swept a glance at the ground she had almost stepped onto.

A long chalk-drawn hopscotch grid stretched out ahead, extending far beyond what she could see, covering the entire width of the sidewalk.

The chalk had faded, submerged in the dim yellow glow of the streetlights and the shadows cast by the trees along the roadside; if you didn't look carefully, it was nearly impossible to notice.

The first row had four squares. The first three were blank; only the last one, at the edge, had writing: "Right foot."

"Damn it all, waiting here for me, were you."

Sydney Ginn wiped the cold sweat from her neck with her sleeve, and hissed at her other self: "No wonder your footsteps were so clear, deliberately falling in the gaps between mine, just to make sure I heard you..."

It had been deliberate.

It had wanted Sydney Ginn to fix all her attention on what was behind her, her mind occupied with the question of "how to shake the Vulture"—and there were only so many ways to

shake someone following close behind, and whichever method she chose, she would have ended up breaking into a run and stepping straight into the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid.

If she hadn't stepped into the square marked "Right foot" with her right foot, she would have been in serious trouble.

"November 17th, the Nest, Colorado Avenue. A chalk-drawn Hopscotch has appeared here."

Sydney Ginn opened her voice memo app and briefly described what had just happened, then said, "Although the 'Vulture' did not directly harm anyone, it has shown signs of luring targets into a trap... This is a new behavioral pattern, worth noting."

She had never joined a Hunter House Faction, so when it came to gathering and updating intelligence on the Nest, she naturally couldn't match the systematic, organized approach of House Faction Hunters.

But she had her own way of surviving: she would bring whatever valuable information she'd collected to the bar called "Against the Light," where the owner—whose face looked like a Shar-Pei—would exchange a different set of information in return. He was like a human information exchange board, or a primitive version of LinkedIn.

She put her phone away and looked around, almost wanting to sigh.

To the right was a row of stone-brick townhouses; short flights of steps climbed up to each front door. Between the staircases, clusters of trees separated one from the next, and the railing she'd just slammed into stood just outside the tree line.

Never mind that she was trying to get to the Museum of Modern Art—even if she weren't, she absolutely could not just wander into a Nest building.

To the left, the road was empty; all she had to do was step off the sidewalk and walk along the street to go around the chalk house—under normal circumstances, that would have worked, but not now, because the traffic light was still purple.

"If it weren't for all this garbage, why would fifteen kilometers take two whole days to walk..."

Sydney Ginn muttered under her breath, tucked away her knife and phone, adjusted her trail pack, cinched it tight around her waist, and stepped her right foot into the square.

She stood in the square on one leg like a crane, the alcohol not yet entirely faded, rolling and pushing against her ankle in waves; Sydney Ginn broke into a cold sweat all over, swaying unsteadily, one hand gripping the railing.

The square said right foot only, so she absolutely could not add a left foot.

The smile on "Sydney Ginn's" face froze rigid, then, starting from the cheekbones, began slowly contorting. One cheekbone jutted further and further out, while the other gradually slid downward.

Was it about to give up, seeing that she hadn't taken the bait?

As a rule, when a Vulture saw that "replacing" its target was hopeless, it would abandon the target's likeness—either shifting into someone else's face, or retreating into the shadows and vanishing.

Watching your own features, your own face, warp and melt off another face the way ice cream melts on a summer day—other Hunters had said it was an unexpectedly unpleasant thing to witness.

"Get lost now, and I won't kill you."

Sydney Ginn threw out a hollow threat, turned back, switched to her left foot, and hopped to the middle square of the next row; the moment her single foot landed, the trail pack dragged heavily downward, as if someone had jumped onto her back.

Her hands spun around like a windmill several times before she finally steadied herself, and in her mind she had killed the harassing lunatic Anthony back and forth ten times over—naturally, everything bad was his fault.

But if something good came of this trip, like getting her hands on a rare Artifact, that would obviously be entirely thanks to herself.

She just had to wait for the purple light to go out, and then find a moment to jump off the sidewalk.

The first four or five rows of squares were still reasonable: though hopping forward one foot at a time with a pack weighing more than ten kilograms on her back and alcohol still in her system was exhausting work, at least it wasn't impossible.

At some point—she lost track of which square—the writing inside the squares was no longer just "left foot" or "right foot."

"Left hand," read one square.

The squares on either side of it listed penalties—"Lose consciousness," "Lose all red blood cells produced in the past year," "Visit No. 87 Colorado Avenue."

Fortunately, there was a utility pole right beside that square.

With great difficulty, Sydney Ginn hugged her pack with one arm, braced her feet against the pole, and tipped herself upside down, pressing her left hand into the square—she felt like a circus acrobat, stretching one leg out far behind her, her whole body a trembling, lopsided "Y," barely managing to land on the next square.

"Exchange food for the right to stand," said another square.

That was nothing; Sydney Ginn had no shortage of food in her pack, and good food at that.

She stood on the spot she had purchased with a beef sausage, rested her trembling limbs for a moment, then looked up—and stopped cold.

Every single square within sight ahead was covered in the same three words, packed in densely.

Copied copied copied copied copied copied copied copied

...All penalties?

Copied? What would happen if she stepped on one—

A chill shot through Sydney Ginn. She slowly turned her head, and there on her shoulder she saw a chubby-cheeked profile, flush and round.

Somehow, at some point, it had crept back up without a sound.

She was only about a hundred meters from the traffic light now, yet the purple glow kept blinking on and off, as if it had absolutely no intention of leaving.

The road to the Museum of Modern Art had barely begun, and already she was at a standstill.

Sydney Ginn thought of "The Nest's Current No. 1 Hit Song."

Truly, no exaggeration—the only "song" that could express and carry what she felt in this moment was one of long, drawn-out human howling.

Only six days in and I've already slipped up—can't keep the 10:15 update time anymore...
Whatever, I posted today! Deal with it!

Typed the whole thing with my head drooping, and now my neck is killing me (at home my computer sits on a stand at eye level, so my neck doesn't get tired).

I don't have much neck to begin with—what happens if I lose what's left.

Feeling a bit dizzy and awful, let me go eat something first, then I'll organize everyone's names from the patron list...

(Let me know when you think would be a good time to tell my mom she's suddenly got a lot of new moms.)

Chapter 8: Sydney Ginn's Blackmoor City Transportation and Tourism

Map

"What I'm about to say may be hard to believe. I find it hard to believe myself.

"I'm still standing inside the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid, and I have nowhere to go. I can't go back—I've tried. Behind me, two rows away, there's a square with 'left hand' written in it. When I came through, I could use a utility pole to do a one-handed handstand, but going back, I can't reach that pole anymore."

Carrying a heavy backpack while doing a one-handed handstand on her weaker left side—Sydney Ginn couldn't manage it. Hunters had a passage and could enter the Nest, but that didn't transform them or grant them supernatural strength.

What's more, the Resident's breathing floated constantly at her ear; in the corner of her eye, her own face lingered, vaguely distorted, like a reflection sunk deep underwater, watching her.

She had been gripping the hunting knife again for quite some time now.

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes, then opened them. On the road to her left, the silence continued to be split open—sliced through again and again by flashes of violet light, like wet viscera exposed under an X-ray.

"It seems like Hopscotch and the 'Vulture' Residents have developed a kind of... cooperative relationship."

Sydney Ginn murmured into her phone's voice memo: "I can't think of a better explanation than that they're working together."

The Vultures had tried to drive her into the hopscotch grid, and the grid had returned the favor—once she'd gone deep enough that she couldn't turn back, it had written "Copied" as the penalty in the squares ahead of her...

If she had actually stepped on one, the Resident following behind her would probably become a second Sydney Ginn.

And what would happen to her then?

The original hadn't even died yet, and a Vulture had already become the target itself—she had never heard of such a thing.

"Maybe I'm overthinking it... The traffic light on the road hasn't changed color for nearly ten minutes now. It's been purple the whole time, keeping me trapped on the sidewalk. Could it also be part of this trap? It's hard to imagine... Unlike Residents, other things don't have intelligence. How would they work together?"

The information recorded in the voice memo served more than one purpose, beyond being exchanged as intelligence later.

If she could never leave the Nest and ultimately died here, she could at least imagine that someday her phone would be picked up by some Hunter.

Who she was, where she died, the last moments of her life—none of it would sink with her into the depths of the Nest.

Perhaps somewhere in this world, another person would hear the last few words of her life and know that a Sydney Ginn had once existed. Even if in the very next moment, like wind scattering smoke, her name dissolved with a single turn of that person's thoughts.

Sometimes when she thought about it, she found it strange: someone like her, bursting with desires and devoted to pleasure, was ready to die at any moment, anywhere.

Perhaps without that readiness, you couldn't make it as an Artifact Hunter.

She put away her phone and looked at the traffic light again.

She didn't really need to look up to know the purple light was still on; but what else could she do besides staring at the traffic light over and over?

The buzz of the alcohol had mostly worn off, but her energy and stamina seemed to have evaporated along with it, seeping out through her pores, leaving behind a body that felt loose and heavy; the muscles in her legs trembled, as if they couldn't hold on to the bones.

The square read "trade food for the right to stand"—it said nothing about sitting, so Sydney Ginn didn't dare sit down; the backpack, weighing some ten-odd kilograms, she kept on top of her feet, not daring to let it touch the chalk drawings.

"Just you wait," she said quietly to the Resident beside her. "I don't believe that purple light can stay on for seven days straight."

The Resident didn't respond. It probably knew, too, that Sydney Ginn was just bluffing—even with food and water, standing for seven days straight without sleep was enough to kill a person.

Well, this was exactly why most Hunters, after a few solo runs into the Nest, would put in applications to the major Hunter House Factions... Even someone like Sydney Ginn, who hated taking orders and couldn't stand being managed by others, found herself sighing: it would be nice to have a partner watching her back right now.

She stood in one square of the chalk hopscotch grid as the night wind grew increasingly cool; the longer she stood, the more foolish she felt—what was she even doing here?

She'd survived a fall from a great height, only to stand here like a human post?

After racking her brain for a while, running through every option including climbing a tree and walking a tightrope, only to have each one shot down by reality, Sydney Ginn had even screwed up her courage and, with a what-have-I-got-to-lose attitude, shouted "someone help!" twice—whether it was good luck or bad, nothing came out of that row of stone-brick Western-style houses in response.

She'd tried several plans and was back to her old standby of being a human post.

It would've been nice if the broadcast had given a heads-up—had she known, she never would have taken this wretched road.

That said, Sydney Ginn also knew it was far too much to ask.

If the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion were to introduce the road conditions on every single street in the Nest, by the time it finished broadcasting, she'd have already gone back to Blackmoor City and there would be nothing left to do.

Thinking of the broadcast made her think of her own map, covered in annotations—wait, what if those annotations could actually be useful?

Sydney Ginn glanced over at "Sydney Ginn."

It was still standing two steps away, but it was looking more and more repulsive—when she'd turned her head just now, it had mimicked her, rolling its dark irises to the right so the whites showed, and then staying like that for a long time, unable to roll them back.

That was her own face. She'd have nightmare material for a week.

Sydney Ginn slid the hunting knife back into its sheath at her waist, took the map out of her backpack, shook it open, and studied the annotations carefully by the flickering violet light and the murky yellow glow of a streetlamp.

A few minutes later, she looked up from the map and snapped a sharp curse at the Resident beside her: "Son of a bitch!"

"Sydney Ginn," unaware it had been cursed at, stared at Sydney Ginn with rapt, entranced attention, and its lower lip suddenly drooped crookedly, as if it were trying to mimic the shape of her mouth.

"Get over here!" Sydney Ginn had found nothing useful on the map, and her anger was surging. "They all say Residents can't be killed—so you won't mind if I stab you a few times, will you? Get over here!"

"Sydney Ginn" simply would not come over.

The more she thought about it, the more furious she got. She pressed her lips tightly shut, worked her tongue around for a moment, gathered up a mouthful of spit, and "ptoo!"—spat it all out onto the chalk square at "Sydney Ginn's" feet. Not that whatever penalty the square handed out was any of her concern.

Unfortunately, the square wasn't about to be washed away by spit—though it would have been wonderful if it could—that patch of foamy wet stain dried in the blink of an eye, as if absorbed by the floor tiles, leaving the chalk drawing completely unchanged beneath.

As a result, "Sydney Ginn" mimicked her: pressed its lips tightly shut, and its tongue seemed to stir as well.

"Oh, you've got to be kidding me,"

Sydney Ginn finally panicked a little, and quickly raised her backpack, ready to use it as a shield against the Resident's spit—but thankfully the Resident seemed to be physiologically different on the inside, and when it opened its mouth, it was just a dark, dry hollow. Nothing came out.

The interlude was over, and she was still at a complete loss.

Sydney Ginn stared at the words "Blackmoor City Tourism and Transportation Map" and had no idea what to do. Her eyes lingered on the map, but her thoughts had drifted away, wandering blankly to some unknown place.

By the time she came back to herself, she realized she had been staring at several rows of small print in the lower right corner of the map's reverse side for several minutes already.

Sydney Ginn slowly narrowed her eyes.

The tourism and transportation map included a great deal of additional information—emergency numbers, police numbers, tourism website URLs, travel insurance details... Among all those rows of small print, her gaze snagged on one thing in particular.

The taxi service hotline for Blackmoor City.

Of course, this was a phone number from the real world.

She was currently inside a delusion-like, nightmare-like mirror world, where there wasn't even a phone signal...

A mirror world...

The yellow taxi—one of Blackmoor City's iconic symbols, the yellow taxi that appeared in countless films and television shows—would it also cast its mirror image inside the Nest?

The thought was like a hand placed at the back of her mind, nearly impossible to ignore.

Sydney Ginn was inwardly laughing at herself for having an overactive imagination, for being driven by desperation into wishful thinking, and yet she once again reached for her phone without meaning to—and of course, the upper right corner showed "No Signal."

She hesitated, but in the end entered the service hotline number digit by digit and pressed call.

There was no harm in trying; even if it didn't work, was she really afraid of being laughed at by "Sydney Ginn" standing next to her?

In her taut, tense anticipation, from beneath the night sky sliced into black and violet, came the sound of a dial tone—"beep—beep—beep—"

"Hello," a woman's voice came on. "Do you need a taxi?"

She stood there with her mouth half open, dumbstruck and silent. Was this a hallucination?

"Do you need one, or not?" The woman's voice wasn't impatient—it asked the question matter-of-factly, like a machine.

"I—I do!" The words were out of Sydney Ginn's mouth before a new wave of anxiety hit her. "Wait—are there any conditions for calling a taxi? What do you pay with? I do have to pay, right?"

"Of course. Please note the following Passenger Rules," the woman's voice said flatly. "One, tell the driver the address you wish to go to. Two, do not look at the driver. Three, sit in the back seat. Four, lower your head and lean it between the driver's seat and the passenger seat. Five, recall a recent experience in your mind. Six, do not panic when the driver collects payment."

"...Recall?" Even with all her Nest experience, Sydney Ginn was sometimes still thrown by its strangeness.

"Yes. Please note the following fare requirements. One, the recalled experience must be from within the past month. Two, the scenes and events in the recollection must be continuous. Three, the experience being recalled must have lasted at least three minutes when it originally occurred. Four, the driver only accepts the first experience that comes to mind automatically—deliberately screened or selected recollections are not accepted."

"Is that all? Just a memory—nothing else? I'll arrive safely at my destination and get out safely?" Afraid the other party might play word games, she went through every loophole she could think of and plugged them one by one.

"Correct."

"That works perfectly," Sydney Ginn let out a long breath. "Send a car right away!"

Never mind the past month—even going back ten years, there wasn't a single memory she'd rather die than give up; and besides, it was only three minutes.

"I'm on Colorado Avenue," she gave her address, then suddenly remembered something and quickly asked: "Can you have the driver open the car door for me when he stops?"

She looked at the square beneath her feet, then at the road beside it, and measured the distance with her eyes. That gap—she could lunge across it.

It was just that "landing" would be considerably more difficult than a normal landing; she couldn't land on the sidewalk, and she couldn't land on the road either—she'd figure out the specifics once the car arrived.

Almost too smoothly to be real, the woman's voice replied, "Yes."

Sydney Ginn's sudden rescue made her heart leap with joy; she hung up the phone, and the screen reflected half of a face pressed right up against hers.

The duck was about to fly right out of reach—it must be getting anxious too, right?

"Back off,"

Sydney Ginn used the same method as before, swinging the hunting knife in wide circles to force the Resident back a few steps—and when she came back to her senses, she was sitting in the back seat of a taxi.

...Huh?

The taxi, gradually picking up speed, glided smoothly through the purple traffic light, the numbers on the meter perfectly still. A human-shaped silhouette sat in the driver's seat, a leather glove on the hand resting on the steering wheel.

"...Where are we going?"

The question was barely out of her mouth before she realized she was breathing hard, her heart pounding—as if she had just been through a burst of intense physical exertion.

"The Museum of Modern Art," the voice seemed to be the driver answering, but no matter how she listened, it sounded like it was coming from beneath her feet.

Sydney Ginn decided not to look down.

Though she couldn't remember how she'd gotten into the cab, a little reverse reasoning made it easy enough to figure out—the first memory that surfaced in her mind was apparently something that had just happened when she boarded: the process of giving the driver the address and having her memory taken had already been handed over as the fare.

Well, that worked out; she'd turned misfortune into a stroke of luck, and could ride all the way to the Museum of Modern Art in one go.

She turned and glanced back at the other "Sydney Ginn" she was steadily leaving behind.

Even from a distance, she could tell the Resident was furious: it flailed its arms like one of those long inflatable tube men outside car dealerships, thrashing wildly, and every so often it threw its head back and let out a long howl—yet another new behavior.

Hopscotch, the Resident, the taxi... everything she'd encountered tonight was brand-new intelligence.

The Nest seemed to be changing; she just didn't know whether the changes were still within normal range.

But Sydney Ginn couldn't summon the energy to write any of it down just yet—she slumped in her seat and let out a long, slow breath.

Before the next crisis came along to torment her, all she wanted was to rest properly for a moment.

I'm dying—suddenly going back to cranking out daily word counts is a bit much... after all, my one-week stockpile of chapters took three months to write.

My update pace is probably a really bad fit for the male-demographic channels—is there a disabled-friendly channel somewhere? Maybe I should go there.

Chapter 9 — Goodbye, Sydney Ginn

"Thank you for riding,"

The driver's silhouette didn't move an inch—the one absolutely motionless object in the moving cab from start to finish. "You have arrived at your destination."

Sydney Ginn stood on the street beside the Museum of Modern Art; with a "thud," the car door closed behind her.

When she instinctively turned to look, she caught a glimpse of the yellow taxi's red taillights gliding into the fog that rose from the depths of the night and the white steam curling up from the drain grates, blurring into the distance.

...She seemed to have forgotten something.

Sydney Ginn stood in the street and watched the taillights until they vanished into the dark night, the foggy blue, and the smoky white—though she couldn't say why she kept staring after them.

She knew, of course, that a stretch of her memory had been collected as the fare, and no amount of trying would ever bring it back.

But Sydney felt that what she'd forgotten lay beyond that taken memory—as if there was something she should have noticed but hadn't. It was like the feeling she sometimes got before leaving the house, a vague suspicion that she'd left something behind; like a layer of cloud covering part of her mind, impossible to brush aside, the moon nowhere to be seen.

At times like these, no amount of thinking ever helped; you had to wait until you were already out the door and the moment actually came, and then you'd slap your thigh and suddenly understand.

Oh well—she'd gotten off the car with all her limbs intact and her head still on her shoulders, so whatever she'd forgotten clearly wasn't a matter of life and death. She'd remember it sooner or later.

She pressed herself against the glass door of Entrance D, peered inside first, then carefully pushed it open little by little.

Unlike Blackmoor City, buildings and facilities inside the Nest were almost never locked. If you came across a door that wouldn't open, it usually meant there was a Hunter inside—the faint comfort of a lock seemed to be something people who ventured into these strange and treacherous depths clung to all the more tightly.

After all, people can't survive without at least a little illusion of safety. If everyone knew exactly what was happening in the world at every moment, would anyone dare step out their front door?

Sydney held the door open with one hand but didn't go in. She waited a few seconds, and when silence held on the other side, she stepped inside as soundlessly as she could, placing her foot on the floor.

Even deep into the night, the museum had half its lights on, and the hallways, galleries, and elevator lobbies were all soaked in a white light that looked like it had been sterilized.

Perhaps because it was a museum of modern art, the lighting design and architectural style always left one with a sense of vast emptiness and coldness. Walking between the still white walls and white light, she felt almost too "alive"—too warm, too much, entirely out of place.

Following the signs, she quickly found the elevator lobby.

The broadcast had given three main instructions: one, "take the first elevator on the left"; two, "do not look at the other elevators"; three, "go to the basement level"—none of them complicated. Fortunately, the fare she'd paid getting into the cab hadn't been this particular memory, or she'd really have been in trouble.

Sydney pressed the button, planted herself in front of the first elevator on the left, and stared straight ahead at nothing.

This wretched place—sometimes it wasn't surprising in the least; when a clear "ding" shattered the still air, sure enough, the elevator that arrived first was the one on the right.

A dead silence held for a breath, then, like a zipper being slowly undone, the elevator doors parted.

Sydney didn't look, but every hair on her body stood up like a tiny antenna. Her eyes were locked rigidly on the closed elevator doors in front of her, and she had a vague sense that the elevator on the right wasn't empty—there was something in there.

Let it come, she'd made up her mind long ago—never mind a Resident, even if a flood of cash poured out of that right-side elevator, she would not turn her eyes so much as a fraction.

"How wonderful, there's someone out here..."

A woman's voice threaded out of the elevator like a strand of silk, drawn by some invisible hand, trembling in the air. "Listen to me—I came down from the third floor. Something very serious happened up there..."

Don't talk to me, Sydney told herself silently. I'm deaf and blind.

The display above the first elevator on the left glowed with a blood-red "28"; this building had only three floors above ground.

"Don't be afraid,"

The woman's voice, which had started out thin as a thread, was gradually thickening, as if voices, too, had roots. Or perhaps the woman herself was crawling out of the elevator inch by inch, and the source of the sound was drawing closer to Sydney.

"I'm a Hunter from Blackmoor City too—I came in to retrieve an Artifact I'd hidden... but after I got in, I lost track of time... What's today's date? The day I came in, Reagan was giving his victory speech."

I'm blind and deaf, I'm deaf and blind—Sydney repeated it to herself like a chant.

She shifted a step to the side as if by accident—but not too far, in case the elevator doors opened and she couldn't dart in at the first moment.

"Whatever you do, don't get on that elevator,"

Now that the voice was closer, it no longer sounded like silk thread—it had become sewage gurgling up from the mouth of a dark pit. "I never should have listened to the host... The first two times I got what I wanted and that made me overconfident; the third time it led me straight to my death. Lucky I reacted fast enough..."

The moment the words "the host" reached her ears, Sydney almost couldn't suppress the urge to turn her head. She still kept her eyes fixed on the elevator, but her heart lurched as if it had been jabbed, beating nearly out of her control, the sound of it hammering over and over in her ears.

Her gaze was propped in midair, too afraid to drop; yet a dark shadow had slowly risen from the floor and stilled at chest height beside her, as if it were listening with its head tilted.

...Did a racing heartbeat count as a response to the woman?

Sydney didn't dare make any reaction at all. Her breathing and the dark shadow at her chest held each other in a frozen standoff for a few seconds in the cool, silent elevator lobby—until another elevator arrival "ding" finally broke the stagnant air.

The door of the first elevator on the left opened.

Wait—the woman was stopped right in front of her; to get past, she'd have to go around it. But if she went around it, could that still count as ignoring it?

But if she didn't go around it, she couldn't very well walk right through it either.

Sydney watched the door part little by little, revealing an empty elevator car; just as she couldn't make up her mind, she felt the dark shadow at her chest suddenly flinch to one side and pull back.

"Annoying..." the woman seemed to mutter.

Sydney never stopped to wonder why good things happened to her when they did, because good things were fragile, and they couldn't withstand being examined too closely.

The moment the shadow stepped aside, she immediately strode into the elevator and slapped the door-close button over and over—"thwack thwack thwack"—as if she meant to punch through the panel; the whole time, her gaze stayed turned to one side, never once looking toward the doors outside.

But even without looking, she could feel it in the corner of her peripheral vision—a shadow on the floor, its limbs swaying against the ground like some enormous lizard, slowly crawling away into the distance.

Only when the elevator doors finally shut completely, grumbling as they carried her down into the basement level, did Sydney let out the breath she'd been holding clenched inside her chest.

So far, she'd followed the broadcast's instructions to the letter—nothing should go wrong again—

"...The first two times I got what I wanted," the woman's voice suddenly echoed back in her mind, "and the third time led me straight to my death."

Sydney rubbed the corners of her eyes and decided to push that nagging, distracting thought aside for the moment.

The Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion was meant to be heard by the Nest's Residents—it was no surprise at all that the woman knew about the host.

Compared to the lizard-like Resident in the elevator lobby, she still trusted the broadcast host a little more; that "trust," of course, carried within it three parts doubt, three parts wariness, and three parts scrutiny.

Yet the next few minutes seemed to prove that the broadcast host hadn't said a single false word. In the dimly lit basement gallery, she found the exhibit named "Candlefall" with almost no effort—honestly, it would have been harder to miss it.

Sydney stood before the exhibit and stared, dumbfounded.

Because the exhibit named "Candlefall" was a colossal white candle—roughly her height in diameter and easily tens of meters long—lying horizontally on the floor.

If not for its unmistakably waxy, milky-white surface, smooth and faintly lustrous, and the black wick the length of an arm drooping from one end, it would have looked more like a giant's roof beam. The candle rested on a series of iron frames specially built for it, beneath which ran a row of metal troughs whose purpose she couldn't make out.

"This thing is an Artifact?"

The candle was so enormous that Sydney walked around it for a while and still hadn't made it all the way. "Hard to say how powerful it is, but the size alone is really something..."

This big—how was she supposed to bring it back on her own? Would cutting off a piece work?

She couldn't even tell what this Artifact did, let alone whether cutting a piece off would work.

Ordinary art exhibits always came with a brief introduction to the piece and its creator; from experience, if there was detailed information about an Artifact, it was likely in the write-up.

Sure enough, when Sydney walked around to the other side of the candle, she found that the introduction for "Candlefall" covered half a wall of text.

"Some say time is like flowing water; some say time is speed. But artist Judy Picault believes time is wax... The time we are living through is a candle slowly melting away, giving us the

illusion that its form is still within our grasp; yet the moment it passes, it becomes hardened candle tears, fixed forever in the shape of history.

"...The artist's interpretation of time ultimately gave form to the exhibit 'Candlefall.' The colossal candle visitors see before them represents a long, primordial span of time.

"It is an interactive artwork. Visitors may build a fire beneath the iron frames to heat the candle, watching it gradually deform and shed its candle tears."

Among the neat rows of printed black text, there were lines of handwriting scrawled in—crooked, lurching strokes, as if whoever had originally printed the introduction for "Candlefall" had deliberately alternated one passage of orderly reason with one passage of wild, crumbling madness.

"It's an Artifact okay Artifact Artifact an Artifact that melts time"

"Melt time and you free history from its chains! Go look at your own history don't accidentally kill your past self put me inside, what do you say, put me right beside your past self"

The next passage returned to normal.

"Once the candle grows transparent from the heat, visitors will notice the contents the artist has embedded within the wax. They represent historical events that occurred within the span of primordial time. By re-melting the hot wax and reshaping it—altering the contents inside—visitors can change 'what originally happened.' The artist believes..."

Reading this far, Sydney could no longer hold back; she turned to look at the enormous milky-white candle behind her, and for a moment simply didn't know how to process the shock.

You could melt and reshape this candle to alter time—no, to alter history?

Was she understanding this correctly?

If she was, then being called "one of the most powerful Artifacts in existence" was a title it had well and truly earned.

She would need to study the specific instructions more carefully, and ideally try it herself once. She'd also need to figure out what effect it might have on the future.

She had to form a basic understanding first before she could think about next steps. Cutting off a piece to take away probably wasn't going to work; even with other Hunters to help carry it, it

couldn't be moved, since everyone's passage was different and they couldn't go back together. It seemed the only option for now was to hide it somewhere...

That was the last thought passing through Sydney Ginn's mind before she turned around and a hunting knife was driven into her throat.

After half a year off, everything else aside, my typing speed has practically gone in reverse... I've realized there's a kind of resolute beauty in all of you—I clearly have no resemblance to a donkey that cranks out twenty thousand characters a day and pays off a debt in a month, and yet when you all pledged your support, you were so decisive about it that I, a trembling donkey, was left humbled and awed.

For example, Wanjin... if you won't feel sorry for me, who will? Can't we let our bond flow on gently, like a slow stream? Alright, that's a sixth big fat baby owed. And then there's 95 — she really isn't my alt account, and I have no idea what potential she saw in me, sending people and money and effort and support my way. Alright, that's another big fat baby...

Buwenhuakaijiv, Grandma, don't you already know what I'm like — and then there's Changgoagao's Fish, Always on the Side of the Egg, Linze, Shimodege — you're all Grandma's readers, and we can really take it slow. Can't keep shearing the same flock of sheep forever, can I?

I also want to thank Haiyan Qifeng, Love Letter W0ZV, nestea, Fengyin (you two seem like new readers? or just the quiet type?), Dongxie (somehow you all feel like a matching set?), Banxia Jiejie, Jianbing Fujin (please for the love of god stop), Kafka, Qiti, Junmi xi, Xuanfeng Feiwanr, Qiwu, Weba de Qingjiatiao (did you flip it backwards?) and everyone else for all your support and encouragement... The word "thank you" in Chinese feels like I've worn it down to a nub from overuse! I haven't written anything that good either — it's really not worth all this!

Seven — seven chapter update AAAAAAAA

Maybe I should just go catch all seven Calabash Brothers instead

PS: This one definitely won't take as long to write as Doomsday! Even an eighteen-year-old values her life! Two or three years, I say with the reckless confidence of youth.

Chapter 10: A Gathering of Heroes at Mai Minghe

Mai Minghe had never heard of the Nest, and had no idea what a "Resident" was or how dangerous one might be.

But she figured that no matter how strange things appeared on the surface, nothing could ever violate the internal logic governing it.

The hospital inside the Nest seemed to operate by the same principles as a real hospital: press the call button, and a "nurse" would come—or rather, someone "disguised as a nurse" would come—and that someone's target would be whoever had pressed the button.

The only difference was that nurses in a real hospital came to take care of patients; what the "nurses" here intended to do... she didn't let herself think any further.

If she couldn't escape the ward, she was about to find out firsthand anyway—why waste the energy thinking about it?

To get out, she needed to create a few evenly matched rivals for the patient in the next bed.

There was one truth that held both inside and outside the Nest: only when multiple blades clashed against one another would gaps appear; a single blade would pass through her without any distraction.

The real question was: could she slip through the narrow gap between those blades?

Clearly, the red-haired man had figured out the thinking behind her pressing the button.

The moment he steadied himself, he drove his foot hard into Bed No. 2—its locked wheels grinding harshly across the floor—sending the patient and the whole bed crashing into the cabinet and beds behind him; amid the impact, he shouted without looking back: "Even if you wanted to draw the Artifacts out, you didn't have to press the damn button four times!"

He had a point; to be honest, Mai Minghe was feeling a little regretful herself right now.

She had just rolled off the bed again, hoping to use the moment the red-haired man was blocking her to drop down on the other side of Bed No. 1 and make a run for the door; but before Mai Minghe could even swing her leg across the mattress, she stopped dead.

On the other side of Bed No. 1, a nurse was already standing there.

What filled her field of vision was the hem of a light-colored nurse's uniform.

She froze on the bed, staring at that patch of fabric, and realized that in just a few seconds the room had filled with people.

One human-shaped shadow after another, like trees sprouting from the floor, far more than four of them, stood silent and still in the dim ward.

In her peripheral vision she couldn't make out their faces—only the vague impression of round, oversized heads, all exactly alike, every single one turned to face the corner of the room where two living, breathing people remained.

How had so many of them come?

"...Everyone's so kind. I'm actually feeling much better," she said flatly. "Why don't a few of you head back?"

As the "nurse" beside the bed slowly tilted its neck down toward her, Mai Minghe closed her mouth.

A flurry of fragmented, terrifying guesses raced through her mind; but she hadn't expected that when the figure lowered its head, she would find herself looking at a perfectly normal, healthy face.

"Where does it hurt?"

It was a young, soft round face. It—or should she say "she"?—spoke with a slightly drawn-out southern accent, as if she hadn't been on the job long enough to lose it.

If she looked only at the nurse's large eyes with their slightly drooping outer corners and ignored the round heads one after another in her peripheral vision, ignored the slender black silhouette several meters tall rising from behind the red-haired man, Mai Minghe might truly have believed everything just now was an illusion, a dream she'd been having while lying in a hospital bed.

"Get away from that nurse!" the red-haired man suddenly shouted.

Mai Minghe startled and instinctively glanced toward him—somehow the red-haired man had managed to half-climb the wall, like a knockoff Spider-Man who hadn't quite mastered his powers and looked a bit awkward about it.

The moment he climbed up, what had been behind him was exposed: the slender black silhouette with its head pressed against the ceiling was walking toward Mai Minghe, one step at a time.

On the left and right of the bed, Residents; the only way out was at the foot—

As if heaven had heard her thoughts and set out to grant her wish, Mai Minghe suddenly felt a tightening around her ankle, as though something had seized it and gave a sharp yank; she was pulled helplessly down onto the bed, the nurse's face and the ceiling sweeping past her eyes as she was dragged straight toward the foot of the bed.

Cold and hot sweat broke out all at once; Mai Minghe frantically reached out both hands and grabbed the edge of the bed, but all that accomplished was leaving her palms burning raw—it did nothing to slow her at all.

Whatever was gripping both her feet from beneath the bed and dragging her toward the foot possessed a strength no human could match—never mind Mai Minghe, even a Marine would be no match for it; in her desperation, she called out: "My ankle!"

The little nurse tilted its head.

"My ankle hurts!"

Even as those few words left her mouth, most of her body had already been hauled off the bed, her feet nearly touching the floor.

The slender shadow that had come down from the neighboring bed was standing at the foot of the bed, waiting for her.

It was nothing like what she had planned—the thing wasn't interested in where Mai Minghe was about to be dragged at all: because as she was being pulled off the bed, her pajamas had ridden up, exposing her lower abdomen—and the coils of "snake bandage" wound around it.

The slender shadow reached its hand toward her stomach.

"Oh?" The girl's southern drawl stretched long and warm: "If the ankle's gone, it won't hurt anymore."

Every word she had ever been told a proper young lady shouldn't say made a lap through Mai Minghe's mind.

At the same moment, the slender shadow made contact with her abdomen.

The instant those ice-cold fingertips touched her skin, Mai Minghe nearly lost consciousness.

It was as though the fibers of her skin, her blood vessels, her fascia—all of it seized and twisted together at that icy touch, tying itself into knot after knot; her mind could not endure the agony of her nerve endings knotting up, and darkness was already rising before her eyes.

The little nurse wasn't stopping the slender shadow, her ankle looked like it was about to be lost, and all the while she was still sliding down toward the floor beneath the bed...

Just as Mai Minghe thought all hope was gone, in a flash she heard a screech erupt from beneath the bed.

The emotions that screech stirred in the human ear were almost impossible to describe: the closest comparison would be discovering that your jackpot lottery ticket had fallen into the toilet—watching a winning ticket spiral away with the waste, that gut-wrenching feeling was more or less what it felt like to hear the screech from under the bed.

But regardless, her feet were finally released.

The little nurse let out a small "Hmm?" It had been standing by the side of the bed just a moment ago, yet somehow had already moved to the foot of the bed as well, crouching down to examine Mai Minghe's ankle.

"There's something on your ankle," the little nurse said. "I didn't get through it just now—let me try again."

As it spoke, it raised its hand—and it was the first time Mai Minghe got a clear look at that hand: extending from the wrist was not a hand at all, but a dense cluster of thick, silver-bright steel needles.

In that instant, she thought she understood.

The nurse had jabbed its needles at her ankle, but a pair of hands was gripping that ankle, so the needles had naturally gone straight into those hands instead...

Mai Minghe understood now, but with her elbows propped on the bed and her feet on the floor, even without anything restraining her, she could barely hold herself up enough to keep from sitting down on the ground—she couldn't move at all—because the slender patient was standing right in front of her, body half-folded down, long fingers slowly peeling away the "snake bandage."

Every time they touched, that agony of knotted blood vessels and nerves left her unable even to breathe, let alone walk or run.

"My stomach," she stared at the countless densely packed needle-tips, forcing the words out: "my stomach hurts now... stick it in my stomach..."

The little nurse seemed unable to see the other Residents, or if it could, it paid them no mind; it glanced down at Mai Minghe's abdomen, raised the needle-cluster high, and jabbed downward.

The slender patient finally stopped peeling away the "snake bandage," and suddenly flung its arm in a sweeping swipe at the little nurse—its arm unfolding joint by joint through the air as if it had an unknowable number of joints hidden within it—it sounds slow described like this, yet in the blink of an eye, a curtain was pulled from nowhere, and the little nurse and its steel needles were blocked behind it.

What kind of strange trick was that?

Mai Minghe certainly wasn't going to sit there and wait to see if the little nurse could get out from behind the curtain.

She seized the opportunity, leapt up, darted past the slender patient, and sprinted for the ward door—from the moment she had first spotted the little nurse to now, only a few seconds had passed, and already she felt like half her life had been used up.

"Keep it up," a round-headed figure said from the darkness.

Do I need your encouragement?

"Duck," said another round-headed figure, still in place, in a flat tone.

Who would duck at a time like—

Mai Minghe slammed to a halt and dropped into a crouch. She immediately felt something whip past just above her head—and something went thud against the doorframe of the ward.

She was only five or six steps from the door now, yet she had no choice but to turn back; unwilling to give up, she shot a quick glance—there seemed to be a pale white hand embedded in the doorframe, attached to an impossibly long arm.

A spiderweb of cracks spread across the wall around the doorframe.

If she hadn't ducked, that hand would have landed squarely on the back of her head and smashed her against the doorframe like a fly.

Well. She really did need the round-heads' encouragement after all.

"Hey!" Mai Minghe ran toward the cluster of motionless round-headed figures and called out: "What's the deal with all these big heads?"

From behind one of the round-headed figures, a shadow suddenly stirred—Mai Minghe had barely startled before she heard it suck in a sharp breath, as if fighting through pain, and answer: "I've never seen this kind of Resident before. I don't know either."

Apparently the red-haired man had come down from the wall at some point and seemed to have been injured in the process; probably to avoid the slender patient, he had also moved close to this cluster of round-headed figures in the center of the room, separated from her by several shadowy forms.

Mai Minghe badly wanted to keep asking him what Residents he had seen, and what Residents even were, but this was clearly not the time—the slender patient had already turned its head in this direction, and the sound of its crown scraping against the ceiling made a soft, rasping hiss.

As if terrified of the slender patient getting close, the red-haired man quickly threaded himself between the round-headed figures; his face was ashen, slicked with sweat, as he edged sideways in small steps through the crowd toward the door, not daring to brush against any of the round heads.

Mai Minghe followed his lead and quickly stepped into the forest of round heads as well.

The moment she got a clear look, it felt as though every organ inside her had lost its support and dropped deep into her gut.

The reason they had all looked identical was that in the dimness, every head appeared swollen and round and enormously large; but up close, the round-heads were actually of all kinds—men and women, old and young, their features all different.

Yet what should have been normal human skulls had every bone separated—the facial bones, the cranium, all of it—and some gas-like substance beneath had inflated the skin outward, forcing the shattered bones and human skin together into a perfect sphere: the fragments of bone shattered beneath the skin were still recognizable by their shapes, calling to mind the continental plates drifting on the surface of the earth.

The eyes, one on each side, were set separately into either side of the skull, like two blisters risen from the flesh, swiveling to follow Mai Minghe's footsteps; the nasal bone had been split cleanly in two down the middle, pulling two crooked, elongated nostrils open across the "face."

The mouth, at least, was normal; beside the corners of the mouth, across every face, long lines of deep-purple sunken grooves ran everywhere—the marks left by skin stretched until its fibers had torn.

A guess suddenly surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind. "Could these originally have been people?"

The red-haired man rounded the last round-headed figure, stepped clear of the cluster, and strode toward the door. "Sorry—you're the Resident's target, and there's nothing I can do about that. If I ever get the chance to see your body again, I'll bring it back to Blackmoor City for you."

He truly wasn't the target; he was nearly at the door of the ward already, and the slender patient paid him no attention whatsoever.

At this point the nurse was still standing blankly behind the curtain, only its shoes visible below; the two hands reaching out from under the bed were also motionless.

Only the thin, elongated patient drifted slowly back and forth before that cluster of round-headed silhouettes, as though waiting for an opportunity to strike at Mai Minghe.

"It can't get in," said one of the round-headed figures standing to Mai Minghe's left, almost as if to reassure her.

The one on the right said, "We'll all surround you,"

A round-headed figure behind her finished the thought: "and walk together toward the door — you'll be able to get out."

Ugly as these things looked, they had a surprisingly good heart, and their idea wasn't bad either — Mai Minghe lowered her head, staring at the floor, and a thought that had surfaced not long ago flickered through her mind again.

No matter how bizarre the surface appeared, nothing could ever violate the inner logic by which it operated.

She snapped her head up and called out, "Hey, young man — stop right there, don't you dare step outside!"

Honestly, I was perfectly comfortable in the women's fiction side of things, and it was never my intention to come stir up the men's fiction scene... The numbers on the women's side aren't great, sure, but it's a nice little space for a small community to enjoy themselves. The mood is calm — everyone's numbers are more or less the same, there's no real difference between first place and tenth, and it's all very harmonious.

Men's fiction is a different story. The vibe feels anxious and high-pressure, like everyone's grinding out ten-thousand-character daily updates trying to blow up and dethrone the kings, chasing votes, chasing tips, rushing the plot, fast-forwarding to the power fantasy moments... I don't have that kind of firepower. Looking at all the rankings and charts and votes, I don't know how to put it — it feels like being swept into a roaring current, and it wouldn't be surprising to sink to the bottom any moment.

I still hope to work slowly and carefully, and write as well as I can. I also hope everyone will feel free to ask me to take days off — I'll absolutely say yes, every time.

Chapter 11: Mai Minghe's Rock-Paper-Scissors

In truth, Mai Minghe didn't really expect that the red-haired man, upon hearing her shout, would immediately pull back his foot and not step outside.

With an escape route right in front of him, who would hold back from taking that one step?

So what happened next truly exceeded her expectations by a wide margin: the red-haired man urgently pulled back the foot he'd been about to step into the corridor with, the motion so sharp he nearly lost his balance; he pressed one hand against the wall, hopped back two steps on one foot, and stopped in the doorway between himself and the round-headed figures, letting out a curse.

"How did you know?" His gaze passed over the round-headed figures one by one and landed on Mai Minghe.

The room was packed with "Residents" ready to move against them, yet at this moment there was a hairline gap between the knife's edges—a rare opportunity to exchange a few words.

Mai Minghe answered immediately: "I don't know what's going on exactly—I only know we can't go out there. What did you see? You didn't stay in just because some elder told you to, did you?"

"Don't talk down to me like you're my elder." The red-haired man rubbed his face irritably and said, "There's a Resident at the doorway."

The ward door stood wide open, revealing a hollow, brightly lit corridor; in the corridor's light, there was not even a shadow on the floor tiles.

"Really? Well, that's something—don't tell me it knows how to turn invisible?" Mai Minghe said, surprised, and couldn't help marveling, "Have they actually made that work? I remember back in '75 or '79, some scientist said they could use electromagnetic waves or something..."

"Stop rambling about nonsense," the red-haired man cut her off, his expression darkening further. "How did you know we couldn't go out?"

Mai Minghe first glanced at the tall, thin patient.

In her youth she'd stood five foot eight, yet even then she could only have seen the tall, thin patient's navel; the hospital gown was far too short, hanging at chest level, and there was a dark,

gaping hole in its stomach—she didn't dare look long, and quickly averted her eyes.

Mai Minghe hadn't forgotten that inexplicable step she'd taken outside.

The tall, thin patient still seemed unwilling to give up, but just as the round-headed ones had demonstrated, as long as she was surrounded by them, it appeared to lack the nerve to come inside.

She had a moment to catch her breath, though she had no idea how long it would last.

"These things came here to harm people, didn't they?" Mai Minghe explained. "They're so eager to help me get out—that means we definitely can't go out."

The red-haired man paused, as though Mai Minghe's words were a handkerchief stuffed into his mouth. "...That's it?"

"There are two other reasons, actually," Mai Minghe said, a little sheepish. "I don't know if you'll agree. You seem familiar with the Nest—take a look: are there a lot of lines on the faces of these round-headed ones?"

The red-haired man gave a nod—only half his attention was on Mai Minghe; the other half kept shifting back and forth among the round-headed figures, the tall, thin patient, and the empty doorway, staying alert.

"Same principle as stretch marks," he said in a low voice, "except they've grown on their faces."

For someone who didn't look like a married man, he knew a fair bit about that sort of thing; Mai Minghe couldn't help thinking that in the old days, if a man knew too much about women's bodies, it was somehow considered shameful.

Young people nowadays seemed different—though she wasn't sure how much things had really changed.

"Right. Their heads have been stretched as full as a nine-month belly, so it's no wonder they've developed those marks—but marks like that only appear when the fibers of living human skin are pulled apart and torn.

"It occurred to me: the bird-like Residents inside the Nest aren't human at all, so why would they bother growing stretch marks? If the round-headed ones were once living people... what on earth turned them into this?"

A bubble-like eyeball swiveled around and looked at her.

The red-haired man kept his gaze on the doorway, nodded, and said, "Makes sense. It means whatever turns people into Residents like this hasn't shown itself yet—it's lurking somewhere."

Even though it was invisible, the thing was right there in the doorway; thinking about it that way, no wonder the round-headed ones were all gathered in the center of the room, leaving the door clear instead of blocking it.

If Mai Minghe hadn't pressed the call button four times, if the thing hiding in the doorway were the only Resident she'd summoned, she would surely have woven past the figures in the room and made straight for the exit—and in that situation, she would almost certainly have walked straight into its hands.

From below the ceiling came the tall, thin patient's voice: "Had enough of the deduction game?"

The voice slid into her ears with a sticky, slithering quality, and Mai Minghe was hit by another wave of dizziness—nauseated to the point of retching—the biological instinct to expel invading pathogens and toxins from the body.

The tall, thin patient slowly bent at the waist; its face was about to emerge from the darkness and into the light of the doorway.

The red-haired man suddenly cried, "Don't look at it!"—Mai Minghe instantly turned her gaze away, retreating behind one of the round-headed figures, her heart hammering again. She noticed her mouth had gone dry and bitter; she didn't know how long it had been.

"Give it to me,"

The tall, thin patient was bent over, its skull hovering above Mai Minghe, its voice echoing and dripping down, so that one almost had the illusion that the sound itself carried slime and shreds of flesh.

Its hand circled above the crowd several times as though trying to grab Mai Minghe, yet it never reached down; it only howled: "Give it to me! Give it to me give it to me give it to me give it to me!!!"

Mai Minghe hunched over, her stomach acid surging up without control, spattering onto the floor.

Dizzy and weak-legged, she reached out and grabbed one of the round-headed figures by the arm; the round-headed figure immediately began to moan softly, murmuring, "It hurts... it hurts so much..."

Your skull is splitting open and you don't call that pain, yet me grabbing your arm for support is?

Mai Minghe steadied herself, straightened up, and let go; the round-headed figure fell silent.

"Damn it, this thing is dead set on getting the Artifact." The red-haired man stood against the wall, staring at the tall, thin patient. "Residents inside the Nest who want Artifacts are actually pretty rare—and of all things, you ran into a troublesome one."

Even without looking at it or going near it, the mere sound of the tall, thin patient's ceaseless howling was unbearable; if Mai Minghe kept vomiting, she would be dehydrated and unconscious before long, left as helpless as a fish on a chopping block.

The red-haired man had more than just experience—he probably had a way to deal with this too. She was about to ask him what to do when she heard him speak again: "...Rock, paper, scissors."

What?

A rustling sound came from below the ceiling, and even the elongated patient seemed to turn its head toward him.

"Are you casting a spell?" Mai Minghe asked with a wry smile.

"No, I just suddenly thought of that game." The red-haired man pressed his back against the wall, standing in a spot far from Mai Minghe and all the Residents, and said, "Think about it—why does the tall thin one want to grab you, but won't actually reach out and do it?"

"It's... wary of something?"

"Right, it doesn't dare touch the round-heads. The round-heads said it themselves—they counter it. So it won't make a move on the Residents by the door either, because the moment it turns around, the round-heads behind it can pounce." The red-haired man continued, "As for exactly why, I don't know either. And then the tall thin one counters you—no question about that —"

Hearing this, Mai Minghe understood.

"Like rock, paper, scissors, where each one beats another in a cycle," she said, cautiously reaching out toward one of the round-heads. "So next would be... I counter the round-heads?"

The moment she touched its arm, the round-head immediately began buzzing and moaning, its legs even starting to tremble and shake.

"I don't understand why they're afraid of you either," the red-haired man said.

"It's not fear, though..."

The elongated patient laughed in halting, staggered bursts, as if it had realized it could torment Mai Minghe with its own voice—and it had to be said, it had found the right approach.

"These humans—after being caught by the thing at the door, it pumps its own bodily fluids into them, turning them into flesh tentacles, each one standing upright from the ground, used specifically to deal with other Residents."

Mai Minghe wanted to hear more information; she just wasn't sure whether her insides would hold out.

As the elongated patient spoke, she stood half-bent over, feeling as though some great beast were churning deep in her abdomen, trying to force its way up her throat; all she could do was curl like a shrimp, wracked with spasms—she was completely helpless.

"A person has to be alive to serve as a flesh tentacle. When stimulated by another living person, the anesthetic effect of the bodily fluid diminishes, and the flesh tentacle risks regaining consciousness, separating from the host, and dying." The elongated patient explained with almost patient deliberateness. "When you touch them, it's the same as waking them back up—dragging them into unimaginable pain."

"Shut up," said one of the round-heads at the front, in a flat tone.

Mai Minghe was of the same mind—please, shut up.

"So that's how it is—the situation's at a stalemate." The red-haired man let out a small sigh of relief and said, "If the flesh tentacles attack the tall thin one, they have to move, and the moment they move, they expose you. If the tall thin one seizes the chance to grab you, it can use you to make the tentacles wake and detach, and in the end the two of them destroy each other. But that has nothing to do with me—getting dragged into this is a real injustice."

No one, human or Resident, paid him any attention.

...He had probably already made his plan—to use the moment the Residents came for him as a chance to escape.

Mai Minghe was furious, nauseated, and envious all at once, wishing desperately she could trade places with him.

"We can take a page from the human spirit of negotiation. Give me the person," the elongated patient said, not the least bit concerned about whether Mai Minghe would vomit up her stomach, "and give me the Artifact."

That was bad.

"How do we give her?" one of the round-heads asked.

"You have the flesh tentacles part," said the elongated patient. "I take the Artifact off her, then toss her to the door—toss her right into your mouth."

"And you guarantee it?"

"Of course. I have no interest in her."

The round-head was silent for a moment, then answered: "Agreed."

Mai Minghe felt very much not agreed.

But cold sweat was already breaking out across her back, and she had no idea how to stop this. Even if she could counter the round-heads, so what? Could she actually bring herself to wipe out her only line of defense?

Sure enough, the round-heads began to part in front of her, and all she could do in that moment was follow along behind them—wherever they retreated, she retreated too. For a moment, it was almost like playing a deadly game of duck-duck-goose.

"If you'd just given me the Artifact at the start, I might have let you live out your days as a little old lady," the elongated patient said, utterly unbothered by her stalling and resistance, laughing in a flat, measured way. "But you had to be clever, and in the end you'll only bring about your own ruin..."

It hadn't even finished speaking when Mai Minghe involuntarily doubled over again in another round of dry heaving. She had already emptied everything there was to empty; her consciousness was swimming and dim, and she could feel the round-heads hurrying away from her side.

No good—she had to stay with them—

She had no time to straighten up before the elongated patient reached down one hand and closed it tightly around her calf.

1. A stockpile of saved chapters is like snow under the summer sun—every glance shows there's less of it, and sooner or later it runs out completely... Last chapter I saw how enthusiastically everyone was asking me to take a day off. In male-oriented fiction where even one chapter a day can get you cursed out, isn't that something of a revolutionary force? It'll happen, it'll happen—I'll make sure everyone goes home happy, welcomed in like guests, cozy and chatting away.

2. I'm getting on a plane again on the 23rd—this year's theme is just one long haul after another. By my count, over the next few weeks I'll have spent thirty or forty hours in total curled up on planes. Every airline would find life a little emptier without me.

3. The world of the Artifact Report has a lot of settings and details to cover from every angle, plus the shifting POV format—I'm not sure how you all are finding it so far? Does the worldbuilding need to be laid out more plainly? Even though it's a modern Western setting, it doesn't feel like too much to swallow, does it? I stuck with Western-style translated names for the locations—otherwise Sydney Ginn getting into trouble on Red Flag First Street would feel like a completely different show.

4. I just love rambling. After all, a mouth is a mouth—when I'm bored it's either eating or talking, and talking nonsense doesn't put on any weight.

Chapter 12: Mai Minghe's Comedy Horror

In the instant the world tilted, Mai Minghe remembered only two things.

The first was sharp and overwhelming, driving away all capacity for thought and conjuring a warped hallucination before her eyes—for some reason, she found herself thinking of a time more than forty years ago, when she had gone on an outing in the countryside and seen a large tree.

It was the ugliest tree she had ever seen in her life: infected by some fungus or virus, the entire trunk was covered in gnarled, knotted burls, one piled on top of another, galls and warts crisscrossing every which way, so that at first glance it looked almost nothing like a tree—more like one great mass of brown, misshapen, overgrown flesh.

In cold sweat, trembling, and pain, she looked down at where her right calf should have been, and had the illusion that she was looking at that tree from forty years ago again—she hadn't even noticed when her head had struck the floor.

Thin, sickly fingers wound around her calf, joint by joint, long and slow.

The second thing was not really a feeling at all—it was a dull thud she heard, as though some heavy object had struck something, not far from her.

When she first heard it, Mai Minghe's mind had been wiped blank by the onslaught of pain, and she had not thought at all about what the sound might be; but something—whether it was the slick floor beneath her palm, or a flicker at the edge of her vision—struck her like a bolt of lightning through her hazy consciousness, and her mind suddenly lit up.

...So that was it.

Because the Slender Patient had been deliberately tormenting her, she had barely done anything since this all began—she had been doubled over retching amid the circle of Round Heads, unable to do much else; but no one in the ward had anticipated that this torment would bring with it another entirely unexpected consequence.

Which was that the ceramic tile floor of the ward was now smeared everywhere with slick, sticky patches of vomit and stomach acid.

In the "eagle catches the chicks" game just now, five or six pairs of feet had tramped back and forth through this slippery filth, spreading it all over the place—which meant that anything

walking on two legs faced a very real risk of slipping and going down hard enough to knock its teeth out.

No matter how strange a flesh-tentacle thing might be, if it walks upright on two legs, it still has to eat dirt when it slips—right?

The moment that thought came to her, strength surged from Mai Minghe's battered body; and as the Slender Patient's shadow loomed over her, she wrenched herself around with all her might and saw it.

Not far away, one of the Round Heads had indeed just fallen to the floor and was flailing, feet skidding, trying to get back up.

In that moment, if Mai Minghe could have laughed, she would have laughed out loud—think you can run?

No matter how bizarre the surface might be, the underlying logic could not escape; it seemed that the basic laws of physics applied to the strange things inside the Nest just as well.

In that moment, Mai Minghe forgot the Slender Patient entirely, lunged forward, stretched out her arm, and grabbed that Round Head by the ankle.

At the same moment, the Slender Patient's hand touched her abdomen again.

It would not have been strange at all if she had lost consciousness; what was strange was that she didn't.

The Slender Patient's shadow loomed high above her, and she still did not dare look at its face—her eyes fixed only on the ankle gripped in her left hand, staking everything on it.

Through the pain that blurred her mind, through the growing emptiness and dread as the "Snake Band" was peeled away from her body inch by inch, Mai Minghe held on to that Round Head's ankle without loosening her grip one bit—and then a pained groan that did not belong to her shuddered through the room.

"Tell it... tell it to get lost..." she wheezed, her words barely intelligible. "Otherwise I won't... I'll never..."

She didn't finish the sentence, but it didn't matter—the Resident at the door understood perfectly well.

Within a few seconds, one of the distant Round Heads said aloud, "Let her go!"

The Slender Patient appeared not to hear, still peeling the "Snake Band" away little by little, its movements slow and careful, almost gentle—yet no matter how delicate its touch, the pain it inflicted was still enough to blacken her vision.

"Hurry up,"

all the Round Heads urged in unison, striding toward the Slender Patient in perfectly synchronized steps. "A mature flesh-tentacle can't be lost—make her let go, or—"

"I know," said the Slender Patient, which was indeed wary of the Round Heads; seeing them all advance together, it finally released the hand gripping Mai Minghe's calf—its other hand still held the "Snake Band," and it clearly was not willing to let go of the Artifact.

The moment it let go, blood began to return to her calf, and what had been a knotted, tumor-covered tree slowly became a flesh-and-blood limb again.

But it was too late for that to help her.

Mai Minghe watched as a long, ghastly pale hand drifted through the air above her, its fingers unfurling joint by joint—how many joints were there?—and swung down toward her arm; never mind how much it would hurt when it connected, she had no confidence whatsoever that she could withstand that sweeping blow without having her hand knocked away.

If her hand was knocked away, wouldn't all her effort be wasted?

Before it could reach her, Mai Minghe shoved off the floor, barely managed to twist her body, and shot her right hand out toward the Round Head's ankle—if one hand wasn't enough to hold on, would two do?

She knew this idea was perhaps naive. She knew she had been driven into a corner that an ordinary human could not fight their way out of.

The world seemed to run its wheel over a person again and again, all just to make you bow your head, make peace with it, and swallow your resentment; she didn't know how she had lived through eighty-six years of it. The days that had felt endless at the time, like she could never endure them to the end—they had all passed in a flash.

If she had pushed back a little more often, resisted a little longer here and there, perhaps she wouldn't be carrying so much regret today—too much to bring herself to think about.

Compared to all the tangled suffering that people in this world had made for one another, these strange creatures were refreshingly simple and direct—almost endearing in their straightforwardness.

All she had to do was reach out one more hand. She could do it.

She could definitely—

The thought hadn't finished forming when a brief darkness swallowed Mai Minghe's mind and she knew nothing at all.

When the shapes around her came back into focus, she found herself lying on her side, both hands slack and empty against the floor.

The Round Head had long since scrambled up and retreated; the Slender Patient was peeling the last section of the "Snake Band" from her back—just one more coil and it would be gone from her entirely.

...She had failed?

Even two hands hadn't been enough to keep hold of the Round Head.

Mai Minghe lay on the floor smeared with her own stomach acid, her body seeming to have gotten a head start on returning to her eighty-six years, all weak softness and heavy weight.

The Slender Patient extended two fingers—long enough to skewer a person clean through—and flipped Mai Minghe over like a lump of dead meat, laying her flat on her back, then continued to peel away the final stretch of "Snake Band."

Being flipped like that, Mai Minghe's right hand flopped softly onto her own chest.

...Hm?

Her fingertips were wet—she didn't know if it was blood or filth; her nail beds especially were thick with it, a heavy, uncomfortable layer.

Wait.

...Blood?

The thought that surfaced in her mind sent a shudder through her whole body; as though driven by pure survival instinct, without thinking, she raked her hand down at the Slender Patient's arm.

Every time she had touched the Slender Patient before, the pain had been unbearable—so the Slender Patient had probably never imagined that Mai Minghe would willingly reach out and touch it. But there was something else it had imagined even less.

The instant Mai Minghe's fingernails made contact with the Slender Patient, it burst suddenly into a great churning mass of billowing shadow.

It was as though her touch had been an agony beyond all measure—so painful that the Slender Patient hurled the Artifact away, its long body writhing and shuddering, like a plume of grey-white, startled mist rising in the dim air.

...Just as she had thought.

Mai Minghe did not dare waste a moment; she immediately pushed off the floor and hauled herself upright, and the "Snake Band," as if alive, wound itself around her body again in coil after coil.

Once she was on her feet, she quickly stretched out her hand and flicked the liquid from her fingertips hard toward the Slender Patient—and as she flicked, she thought it over, and couldn't help but start laughing between gasps, the sound like broken glass, halting and sharp and bright.

It wasn't that she had a strange personality, laughing in circumstances like these—it was that the scene was actually funny: a spindly shadow with its head pressed against the ceiling, writhing and rolling, arms and legs flailing; and next to it, a woman flinging her hand at it in tremors so violent they looked like a stroke—one person, one ghastly thing, both looking like they'd grabbed a live wire.

Anyone who saw it would have to agree: even if you'd blundered into a horror film, this was a comedy horror.

"What's happening?" the red-haired man asked blankly from the other end of the ward. "Did it take the wrong medication? Did you?"

He was standing beside a hospital bed, pushing it toward the door, and at the sight of the Slender Patient's condition he had stopped moving altogether.

The moment Mai Minghe saw him, she understood immediately what he was doing, and called out at once: "Wait—take me with you!"

Even as the words left her mouth, she had already skirted around the Slender Patient and sprinted toward the bed; before the red-haired man could react, she leaped onto it and rolled on,

crying urgently: "Go, go, go—it's not dead yet!"

The red-haired man looked like he wanted to curse, then seemed to realize he had no time for it.

"You've got a nerve, hitching a ride—"

He bit off his complaint halfway, gripped the bed rails, and broke into a run, pushing the bed at full stride; just before they reached the doorway, the red-haired man grabbed the side rail, shoved off with one foot, and jumped onto the bed—and with the momentum already built up, the bed went rattling and rolling straight out the door, carrying both of them with it into the corridor.

"Don't touch the floor," the red-haired man shouted, kicking off against the wall to send the bed sliding farther down the corridor. "That Resident is underneath the floor!"

"It really is under the floor?" Mai Minghe gripped the bed tightly and said, "I told you not to go out the door because I'd noticed what looked like lots of fine lines drawn on the floor tiles between the Round Heads—I knew something was off about that. Thank goodness it wasn't invisibility."

"Invisibility has nothing to do with it!"

As the bed slid past the doorway, the floor tiles seemed to sense something; blood-red threads suddenly seeped up through them, like the countless red veins that appear in an eye filled with urgent fury—but both of them were seated on the bed, not touching the floor, and the "eye" could only watch helplessly as they glided away down the corridor, bed and all.

"What made that tall skinny one suddenly go berserk?" the red-haired man asked, pushing off the wall to move forward, not forgetting to ask.

The explanation was actually quite simple: when Mai Minghe had made that grab for the Round Head just now, she hadn't caught it, but her right hand had scraped open the skin of its ankle.

Before falling into the Nest, she had been a bedridden old woman whose fingernails had gone uncut for a long time and had certainly never been filed smooth—that desperate, clawing grab had dug deep enough to break the skin, and her nails had come away coated in the Round Head's blood.

"...Doesn't the Round Head counter it?"

Mai Minghe gave the wall a kick as well; the bed advanced through the corridor in a Z-pattern, and with each lurch as it struck one wall, it jolted whoever was speaking mid-syllable.

"Then whatever's inside a Round Head's body must counter it too—right? So I smeared that bit of blood on its hand. I really didn't expect it to have such a big effect."

The red-haired man couldn't help but smile. "And this is really your first time in the Nest? Well done."

"Are they going to catch up?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Very likely," the red-haired man glanced back down the corridor—still empty for now. "Get ready—we'll slide a bit farther, then we'll have to jump off and run."

As they spoke, the bed carrying the two of them glided past the window of one of the rooms.

In the glass, Mai Minghe caught a fleeting glimpse of her own reflection: hair in disarray, face pale, one side smeared with filth...

But a smile played at the corner of her mouth, and she looked the very picture of someone in the prime of their life.

Tomorrow I have to leave for the airport at five in the morning, and there's another flight the day after landing — absolutely exhausting. Watching the last little bit of my stockpiled chapters about to run dry, I feel like a wastrel who's squandered his inheritance: my ancestors left me a thousand taels of silver and ten thousand acres of farmland, and I've gambled it all away. It's over!

Before I board the plane, let me take a moment to sincerely thank the following new patrons:

Thank you Haynes for feeding me McDonald's (I already know exactly what I'll spend it on) — your support will surely be converted into body fat, keeping me company on my person, possibly for the rest of my life...

Thank you Ironclad Baitang for the several cups of coffee you gifted (you're back for the new book! Coffee is the only thing in the world keeping me from turning into a zombie) — if you ever catch a whiff of coffee in a chapter from now on, part of it is thanks to your support;

Thank you Weibaodeweimaor for the Minoxidil gift; why, you ask — seeing your username gave me quite the illusion that I'm Sun Wukong, as if plucking a hair and blowing on it would summon an enthusiastic reader to support me. What a bargain that would be. I want to grow more fur.

I also want to thank vitang for the sweets (my life ambitions really aren't all that grand), and to thank Kankankǎn Sherlock, Miemie's Little Fatty Soap, and the whirlwind Feiwán who treats gifting like checking in daily — thank you all for the encouragement. See you after I land!

Chapter 13 — Mai Minghe: The Way Things Tend to Go

"We've been through life and death together — I saved you, and you saved me."

The red-haired man was covered head to toe beneath a white sheet, and his voice came out muffled when he spoke.

In the room thick with the smell of disinfectant, an old incandescent bulb began to hum the moment it was switched on; Mai Minghe opened her eyes, only to find a white cloth draped over her face, her whole field of vision a murky, dim white.

"With that in mind, I won't go after the Artifact on you — for now. But if you run into any of my other Hunters, and they come for you, I certainly won't stop them. This is our mission, after all, and my people risk their lives to enter the Nest — I have no right to ask them to give that up."

"...That part I can live with,"

Mai Minghe spoke from beneath the white sheet, a warm, damp breath of air trapped between her and the fabric. "What I want to know is why we're lying in the morgue pretending to be corpses."

A few minutes earlier, the two of them had decided they were far enough from the Residents below, and had leapt off the hospital beds and bolted, desperate to put as much distance between themselves and the ward as possible and shake the Residents for good.

But as Mai Minghe ran, she had glanced back in a hurry, and in the distance she caught a dark shape flashing across the doorway of the ward — it looked like a Resident had given chase. The red-haired man noticed too, and hissed under his breath: "Running isn't going to work. We need to hide — follow me!"

The Spindly Patient was three or four meters tall and could stretch its body further still; if that was the one chasing them, there was truly no outrunning it.

What Mai Minghe hadn't expected, though, was that the red-haired man would lead her straight into a stairwell, clatter down to level B1, and then push open a door marked "Morgue" as if he'd done it a hundred times before.

When she hesitated in the doorway, he turned and shot her a glare. "Get in here — what are you standing around for? Do you want the Residents to catch up?"

Easy for him to say — who sees the word "Morgue" and feels any urge to rush inside?

Still, when she saw that her only living companion in this godforsaken place had already stridden in, it became clear that staying outside wasn't really an option either.

The moment she stepped through the door, an involuntary shudder ran through her; the temperature inside the morgue was at least three or four degrees colder than out in the hall.

"Find an empty bed," the red-haired man said, switching on the morgue light. He lifted a white sheet off one of the beds, lay down on it, and pulled the sheet back over himself. "Do what I'm doing — cover yourself head to toe, and don't move. If a bed already has someone in it, leave it alone; it'll be fine."

Mai Minghe stared at the gurney in the corner of the room — the white sheet draped over it rose and fell in the shape of a human body. The light flickered on and off, and she couldn't make out whether the figure beneath it was breathing, let alone whether it was a person, a corpse, or a Resident.

At any rate, whatever lay under that sheet hadn't exploded upright to greet them when they walked in, which was probably a good sign.

"Um..." She pointed at the gurney, only managing two words before the red-haired man, already flat on his back and fully covered, prompted her from beneath the sheet: "Hurry up."

In the span of a moment, the entire morgue had come down to one living person still standing — Mai Minghe — and two figures shrouded in white.

As she climbed onto the gurney and pulled the sheet over herself, a faint sense of unreality washed over her: an eighty-six-year-old woman, first admitted to a hospital ward and then ending up in the hospital morgue — it really was very much in keeping with the way things tended to go.

The whole night felt like a metaphor; for what exactly, she wasn't wise enough to say.

The red-haired man let out a sigh beneath his white sheet.

"First-timers in the Nest are nothing but trouble — they don't know anything," he said, dropping his voice. "Training new recruits is one of my least favorite parts of the job."

"It's not as though I wanted to lie in a morgue either," Mai Minghe replied. "You can't get through life without doing things you'd rather not do."

Including playing dead.

"Don't be so put out — the morgue is the 'door of life' in this hospital. Sounds ridiculous, right? How can a place for dead people be a door of life?"

Mai Minghe made a sound of agreement right away.

"The Nest contains countless locations, and each one has its own distinct terrain, dangers, and opportunities. St. Louis Hospital is a location my House Faction knows fairly well — this is my third time here. In St. Louis Hospital—"

"Wait, this is St. Louis Hospital?" Mai Minghe couldn't help cutting in. "You said this was the Nest — but St. Louis Hospital isn't far from my home at all."

She had been to St. Louis Hospital a few times before, and she'd never seen anything like this.

"No — the one you're thinking of is St. Louis Hospital in Blackmoor City. What we're in right now is the St. Louis Hospital that exists within the Nest.

"The Nest exists entirely outside the human world."

The red-haired man was quiet for a few seconds, as if giving those words time to truly sink into Mai Minghe's understanding.

"Perhaps the universe cracked somewhere, and the shadow that Blackmoor City cast into that crack became this Nest — a place full of danger and strangeness, an otherworld that only a handful of people can enter. Any place name you know from Blackmoor City, you can find here in the Nest as well, though it will almost always be a twisted, darkened version of itself."

As if afraid she might interrupt again, the red-haired man pressed on: "Long story short — we've found that when a person encounters a danger they can't shake inside St. Louis Hospital, say, when a Resident has set its sights on us, the morgue acts as a kind of 'reset' point."

"Reset?" Mai Minghe was working hard to absorb what he was telling her, and whatever she couldn't absorb, she fixed firmly in her memory.

She wasn't always up on the words young people used; smartphones — or was it "smart phones"? — had taken her quite a while to figure out too.

"Right. Simply put: you come to the morgue, pull the sheet over your face, lie still for a bit, and in the eyes of St. Louis Hospital, you've 'died.' The person the Residents were chasing is dead, so naturally they stop chasing. When you walk back out, you're a brand-new living person — nothing's after you anymore. It sounds absurd at first, but think it through and it actually makes

sense, doesn't it? Someone who's ended up in a hospital morgue — of course the hospital forgets about them quickly enough."

"It's the same in ordinary life," Mai Minghe murmured. "It's not only hospitals that forget you."

"Which is exactly why I brought you here," the red-haired man concluded. "Count yourself lucky — if you were a Hunter from any other House Faction, I would never have brought you along so easily."

"Why not?"

"Rivals don't do each other favors."

Mai Minghe understood, more or less. These people called themselves Hunters, and the Hunters were apparently divided into many House Factions; they had no way of knowing whether other factions had discovered that the morgue was a reset point, and if they hadn't, there was naturally no reason to give away something so valuable.

"But why do you all come to the Nest in the first place...?"

"Come on," the red-haired man gave a short laugh. "Feel the Artifact on your stomach and think about why. The effects Artifacts can produce are endless — from raising your IQ by five points to overturning fate itself, nothing is beyond them; they can even bring the most impossible human fantasies to life. But Artifacts only exist in the Nest. Back in Blackmoor City, there's no shortage of powerful people in politics and business willing to pay a fortune for them. Where there's demand, there's supply — economics is what leads us all into the Nest."

He paused, then said: "That's why we're called Artifact Hunters."

Artifact Hunters...

In the very city where she had lived her whole life, there was apparently a whole world of people chasing and trading in things as fantastical as something out of a dream...

And now, through her own carelessness, she had stumbled into a world beyond the world, and been given a second life.

Mai Minghe lay on the gurney, her heart thudding.

What surprised her was that she felt no fear right now, no urge to flee back home; instead she felt rather like a child who had wandered into an amusement park in the dead of night — the

darkness was its own domain, and the unfamiliar, eerie silhouettes of the park in the dark were as irresistible as they were vast and wondrous.

The Nest... in the deep blackness of a shadow-filled night, a fairground where she could climb onto a spinning carousel horse and ride toward the extraordinary.

"I never imagined... that I would ever fall into a place like this," she said softly.

Set against tonight, all the years before seemed to have suddenly shriveled and gone dull.

"It's understandable that you didn't know the Nest existed before now. Without someone experienced to guide you, finding your passage by sheer luck and stumbling into the Nest on your own is not something that happens often—"

"Passage?" Mai Minghe seized on the word, nearly bolting upright like a corpse reanimated. "After I ran into the television screen, I fell straight into the ward. Does that mean the television screen is my 'passage'?"

The red-haired man considered this and gave a low "hm."

"So that's how you got in... You've never run into a television screen before, have you?"

Of course not — nobody goes around headbutting televisions for no reason.

"Every Hunter's passage is different." The red-haired man gave a quiet laugh and said: "Of all humanity, only one percent are born with a passage that can lead them into the Nest. The conditions vary from person to person, and most of them are pretty strange and demanding. So even within that one percent, who knows how many people live out their entire lives without ever opening their passage — never even knowing the Nest exists..."

Wasn't that exactly her situation? Eighty-six years, right up until the night a thief broke through her front door—

Mai Minghe gave a start.

...Right. That thief was an Artifact Hunter too.

"Some people have relatively ordinary passages," the red-haired man went on. "I've heard of someone who could enter the Nest simply by sitting down in a full bathtub. Not that his luck was anything to envy, mind you — the first time you take a bath, you're small and young and bare and you haven't brought anything with you. What are the odds you make it back out of the Nest alive?"

"Then there are people whose passages are more troublesome — standing in the toilet bowl while flushing, opening a door in an abandoned building, and so on and so forth, the list goes on. The conditions for simply opening a passage are already so exacting that a huge number of people are eliminated right there; and on top of that, there's one more important requirement for entering the Nest."

"What requirement?"

"Your passage can only be opened in a city with a population of over ten million. We don't fully understand why, but..."

The red-haired man lowered his voice. "The general belief among Hunters is that the Nest is a byproduct born once human civilization reaches a certain scale. So the most densely populated places are the ones connected to the Nest."

Mai Minghe lay quietly for a moment.

Every word he had just said was like a piece of a puzzle, slowly assembling in her mind into a deep world she had never imagined existed; she very much wanted to reach up and press her fingertips to her temple — the spot swollen from hitting the television screen — just to confirm she wasn't dreaming.

"All right,"

There was a rustling of fabric nearby, the sound of the red-haired man lifting the sheet and sitting up. "That should be enough time — the reset ought to be complete. If you want to hold on to that Artifact, you'd best not let any of my companions see you."

The young man did have a decent streak in him after all.

"The Artifact I'm carrying — are you planning to hand it over to Wellesley?" Mai Minghe asked.

"That's right, he's the one who hired us," the red-haired man said, startled, turning to look at her. "You know about that too?"

"He's already dead — he can't buy the Artifact anymore." Mai Minghe thought back to the news that had been running nonstop on television for the past two days and asked, "Haven't you heard yet? When did you all enter the Nest?"

The red-haired man gave her a skeptical sideways glance, then looked away.

He clearly didn't believe her.

The Artifact Wellesley wanted had happened to land in her hands, and the moment it did, she was already saying Wellesley was dead and couldn't buy it anymore — it was a little too convenient a coincidence, no wonder he didn't buy it.

"Ha — he's not about to die. Those Artifacts he has on him are so powerful that—" The red-haired man stopped himself mid-sentence, rubbed his nose, and let the thought drop. "Dead or alive, I've already said I won't make a move on you. My advice is to get back to Blackmoor City as fast as you can."

"How do I get back?"

Though the Nest was both terrifying and captivating, Mai Minghe's best move right now was to get out while she could—for the Artifact's sake.

"Haah, this is really..." The red-haired man let his shoulders drop, looking a little deflated. "In for a penny, in for a pound—I'll take you to the exit. But let's get one thing straight: the moment a House Faction Hunter spots us, I'll have no choice but to join them in taking the Artifact from you."

Hello, friends—what you're seeing now is yet another message from on high; I have ascended the throne, so doesn't that practically count as a divine decree?

Day after day it's nothing but power struggles—one minute crowning myself, the next getting knocked off the pedestal.

I have a question rattling around in my stomach (sorry, it's not a baby): I've seen readers mention that Qidian now puts a lot of weight on something called "chasing-read" numbers—what's that? Does it literally just mean the number of people following the updates? What happens if it's too low? What counts as enough? Can I count myself as one... Writing a novel has me on edge every single day.

Chapter 14 — Chase, Where the Sea Meets the Sky

"...AED defibrillator, cardiac stimulant, epinephrine,"

The brilliant neon lights on the distant shore fell into the water and were jostled by the waves, gradually dissolving into patches of dim amber and murky green ripples that rocked along with the hull atop the pitch-black swells.

"Last one — broad-spectrum antibiotics, in case we need to be out here for a while."

Once each item had been introduced, a silver-white medical case snapped shut with a sharp clap; a large hand with long fingers reached under the seat and pulled out a black cylinder.

"This is a cauterizing gun. It can seal large wounds, sear through blood vessels and nerves, and keep a person from bleeding to death — very handy."

Accompanied by a cheerful voice, that large hand gave a hearty slap on the shoulder of the man in the white coat sitting beside him.

"Let me introduce you — Dr. Nate, a decent man. Not only has he supplied me with everything, he's also willing to come in person to handle any unexpected situation... For instance, after I cut off your limbs, he can guarantee you'll neither die nor lose consciousness."

Dr. Nate didn't say a single word. His lips were pressed tightly together, his face contorted, a sickly pallor washing over him — he looked like a wisp of fog floating in the night.

The cauterizing gun was set down, and a pair of hands clapped together loudly. "Come now, say thank you to Dr. Nate."

What answered him was a muffled, incoherent cry — a man with his limbs bound behind his back, wrapped from head to toe in tape so tightly that only his eyes and nostrils were exposed, thrashing desperately, rocking the small boat back and forth and stirring up soft lapping waves.

"I'll speak for Dr. Nate — you're welcome, it's the least I could do."

The man in the expensive suit, tall and broad, his smile never wavering, leaned in and gave the bound figure a friendly pat.

His black hair was combed back, sleek and neat, catching faint glimmers of light in the night above the sea.

"Don't be impatient — I haven't finished making introductions."

He spread his pale hands wide, and with a flip and a grab of his right hand, effortlessly pulled a heavy weight plate from under the seat. "Each arm and leg, once severed, will be tied to a twenty-five-kilogram plate. You'll be able to watch your own limbs go plunk — sinking to the bottom of the sea..."

He let out a low whistle, his fingers swaying nimbly from high to low, like fish gliding down into the depths.

"...Just like that."

The man mummified in tape let out another garbled, heavy groan, like a wild animal trapped in a bag and unable to break free.

The suited man leaned back in his chair, studying his captive with an air of leisurely amusement.

"Ready to start talking?"

The bound man twisted and writhed furiously: "Mmph, mmph!"

The suited man flicked open a knife, gauged roughly where the mouth was, and drove the blade in a deep slash across the tape — blood and a shriek of pain erupted together into the night.

Slender fingers worked into the blood-slicked slit in the tape and pulled out a large wad of medical cotton.

The moment it left his mouth, panting and retching poured out of the man in broken spurts: "You — who are you? What do you want..."

The suited man leaned in close, fixing his gaze on his prey, his eyes so dark they reflected not a single glimmer of light.

"I'll cooperate with whatever you want — there's no need to be this brutal..." As the bound man spoke, the wound on his lips tore wider, and the pain twisted his face; in the darkness his face was slick and wet. "I'm nobody — I'm nothing to anyone..."

"That's the wrong thing to say."

The suited man raised one index finger and cut him off. "A nobody who's nothing to anyone — like an extra in a movie, they die and they die, and no one cares. If you want me to let you go, you first need to make me care about you. Isn't that right?"

The bound man was taken aback.

"You're probably wondering — how do I get you to start caring about me? Well, I'd have to understand you first, empathize with you as a person."

The suited man laced his long fingers together, forming something like a pale bridge in the dark of the night. The face of his watch caught a faint, thin arc of light in the darkness.

"Come then — tell me. Who are you?"

"I... my name is Ivan. I'm twenty-nine years old, I'm originally from—"

"No, I don't want a résumé — that's boring." The suited man cut him off, his tone encouraging. "I want to know: what hopes do you carry in your life? What has left you disappointed? What are your dreams?"

Ivan stared, his face streaked with blood and tears. "My... my dreams...?"

"Yes. Surely you don't plan to be Wellesley's bodyguard for the rest of your life?"

Ivan gave a start, and a flash of sudden comprehension lit up his eyes.

"Could this have something to do with Mr. Wellesley—"

"Furthermore," the suited man continued, deaf to the remark, "Wellesley died a violent death yesterday, and today you can barely save yourself — you weren't much of a bodyguard. No great loss giving it up."

"I don't know anything..."

"Don't waste your energy." The suited man's thin lips curved into a smile like a knife's edge. "A character who can't move me is just a sack of skin — I don't care how many pieces of it end up on the ocean floor."

Silence fell over the boat for a few seconds.

"Speak."

It probably never crossed Ivan's mind, not even in his wildest dreams, that he would find himself in a situation like this, baring his innermost thoughts.

"I... I understand. My dream is to become someone like Mr. Wellesley..."

"The wealthiest man in the city? A state senator? Recipient of the Distinguished Contribution Award on Climate Issues?" The suited man asked with a smile: "...Or the true power behind

Blackmoor City?"

Ivan only nodded without speaking. He stared vacantly at Blackmoor City in the distance — at the neon advertisements on shore, the skyscrapers. Across the central bay lit up by countless lights, dark waves gently lapped and rocked the small boat.

"Good." The suited man nodded. "What have you done to pursue that dream?"

"I haven't done anything," Ivan snapped back to attention and said quickly, "Mr. Wellesley's death has absolutely nothing to do with me..."

"Wrong direction." The pale hand waved through the darkness with the air of a director giving notes to an actor. "I didn't say you had anything to do with his death — but after he died, you took no action at all?"

"I don't understand..."

"With nothing but ambition and no action to back it up, a character that spineless is impossible to empathize with." The suited man seemed nearly exasperated. "If you won't even help yourself, why on earth should I let you off the hook?"

Ivan's bleeding mouth hung open. After a moment's hesitation, he finally ventured: "After Mr. Wellesley died... I didn't leave. I stayed. Does that count?"

"Oh?"

"Mr. Wellesley had dismissed me the night before," Ivan said quickly. "I was supposed to leave, but I didn't want to go, so I didn't tell anyone."

"Why did he dismiss you?"

"It was just bad luck." Ivan's wet, glistening lips went still. After a moment, he said quietly: "I hadn't done anything seriously wrong... I only tried on a pair of trousers..."

The suited man raised one eyebrow and the corner of his mouth. "Trousers?"

"Yes, yes... once you hear it, you'll understand." He paused, then said suddenly: "Do you know that Mr. Wellesley had a very soft voice? When I first started working for him, I was surprised — a man of such importance, I'd imagined he would speak loudly."

Ivan's teeth were stained blood-red, but he seemed to have forgotten his wound; once he started talking, he couldn't stop.

"Later I came to understand: because his voice was soft, everyone else had to give him their full attention when he spoke. When he opened his mouth, he wasn't concerned about whether others could hear him — that was the listener's problem to worry about.

"You see, even the way his voice rose and fell had its purpose, had its wisdom... So in my free time, I gradually began to carry myself the way Mr. Wellesley did, to dress the way he dressed. I even wore a cologne with a similar scent, and I felt like people looked at me differently when I went out."

The suited man held out a cigarette to Ivan.

He took a drag; in the murky darkness above the sea, the tip of the cigarette flared red; pain made his cheek twitch again, but his tone and composure steadied considerably.

"During this period, Mr. Wellesley and a number of us staff had all been staying at the estate in the Upper District. The night before last, he went to attend a banquet, while I was off duty and didn't go with him. When he came back unexpectedly early, I happened to be in his room putting on a pair of trousers, and he caught me right in the act.

"He probably thought I was having an affair in there... his face turned purple. But how could I possibly be doing something like that? He didn't believe me — he shoved me aside and went through the bathroom and dressing room from top to bottom before he was finally convinced I'd really been alone..."

Ivan gave a bitter laugh: "Then he noticed I was wearing his trousers. I only wanted to know what it felt like to wear them... but he flew into a rage and fired me on the spot, told me to pack my things and leave the next morning."

The suited man threw his head back and laughed, the sound deep and resonant, crashing against the night.

"Amusing — but that's all." His large hand patted the cauterizing gun. "You want to reach the pinnacle of wealth and power, and the action you took was secretly trying on someone's trousers? With that, what could you ever amount to?"

"It's not that simple, obviously,"

Ivan was stung into a flash of anger, and blood sprayed as he argued back.

"Dressing and carrying myself like him was only one part of it — I never let slip an opportunity for action either. The moment I heard yesterday that Mr. Wellesley had died in his

study, I immediately realized: word of my dismissal hadn't spread yet. Only Mr. Wellesley and I knew, and with him dead, as long as I said nothing, it was as if I'd never been dismissed — no one would ever know.

"So I rushed to the study door at the first chance. On the surface I was pretending to guard the scene while waiting for the police, but in reality I was secretly—"

Ivan suddenly stopped.

In the darkness, there was nothing left but the sound of waves and his own heavy, ragged breathing.

The suited man fixed his eyes on Ivan, slowly leaning his body forward, like a great python lowering itself inch by inch from a branch.

"So... you went inside the study." He said quietly.

Ivan seemed to realize it then — that when an interrogator conceals their true purpose, the person being interrogated ends up committing mistakes they didn't even know they shouldn't commit.

"...And what happened after you went in?"

Seeing that Ivan refused to answer, the suited man raised both hands. In the darkness between sky and sea, they looked like two vague, enormous white fans — each one large enough to cover an adult man's entire head and face.

"Strange, isn't it? I introduced you to all the first-aid supplies, yet I never showed you what I'll use to sever your arms and legs. That's because I only remembered when I got on the boat — I forgot to bring the electric saw. Fortunately, I have some confidence in the strength of my hands... nick an opening in the skin, and I can peel you apart layer by layer. The bones are easy enough — wedge them against the side of the boat and one stomp will snap them."

In the darkness, the suited man broke into a silent grin, his white teeth bared in even, gleaming rows.

"Why did you go into the study?"

This time Ivan answered quickly. "I — I just wanted to see if there was anything worth taking... in case there was something valuable. I saw a watch..."

"Why did you go into the study?" The suited man's hand came to rest lightly on Ivan's arm.

Ivan swallowed a mixture of blood and saliva.

"You likely know as well — what went missing from Wellesley's study does not belong to this world. Those who had no business touching it yet touched it anyway will only end up as you are now: swept under and swallowed by the fate it carries. An endless sea with nowhere to turn."

The suited man closed his eyes, drew a long, slow breath through his nose, pulling in the salt-smell of the sea, the petrol fumes from the boat's engine, and Ivan's fear — all of it drawn deep into his lungs.

When he spoke again, his voice had gone hoarse.

"The Artifact from the study — where have you hidden it?"

The mega-ordeal begins today... Yesterday, the moment I landed, I got a text saying my connecting flight had been cancelled, so I scrambled to refund and rebook—only to find no flights available, leaving me no choice but to travel to Guangzhou today to catch a flight out. A huge detour added for no reason, and a huge chunk of time lost.

The days ahead are going to be stressful, chaotic, and miserable. Adjust for jet lag? What a luxury that would be—a blink counts as sleep at this point.

Ugh.

All I want is to go home and hole up for a solid year, ideally with a new e-ink tablet in my arms.

Chapter 15: Chase, Hunter Among Men

Chase drew a silver comb from his suit pocket and slowly combed a loose strand of hair back behind his head.

The comb was small, its inlaid emeralds casting a deep, crystalline light that sank into the black hair and shattered between the strands.

Luxurious and precious things exist in this world to be used. Chase would never lock a comb away in a jewelry cabinet just because it was a valuable antique.

"I stripped his clothes off with my own hands."

Chase leaned back in his chair and said, "I don't mind finding a new use for the cauterizing gun, but Dr. Nate was afraid I'd be too rough and puncture his intestines, so he handled the search himself. I watched the whole time—I can confirm there was nothing on that bodyguard."

Rolan Key, sitting across from him, made a low sound of acknowledgment.

He was past sixty, his hair faded to iron gray, like the heavy fog of a cloudy morning. Wrinkles carved out a hard face with few expressions, and his pair of pale blue eyes always seemed to be watching people from a great distance, as if peering through deep mist.

In his presence, Chase sometimes still felt like a small child.

"What about his home?"

"I only got back from his place this morning—there isn't a single unbroken tile left." Chase thought for a few seconds and continued, "I searched the car too. Nothing. I also checked the driving records and surveillance footage—after he left the estate, he drove straight home and didn't go out again before I found him. Aside from a pizza delivery driver, he hadn't met with anyone. If he hid the Artifacts at the estate—"

"Not a single one left at the estate," Rolan Key said quietly. "The newly arrived Hunters have already scanned it."

Chase nodded, his thick dark brows knitting together.

"Out of the four Artifacts that went missing from Wellesley's study, the bodyguard didn't take a single one?" Rolan Key asked.

Chase stared at the ceiling and thought for a moment.

"No," he murmured, "he got one... he got at least one."

"How do you know?"

Chase straightened up, a hint of irritation in his movement, his two large pale hands clasped tightly together, tendons rising on the backs. A thin line of dark reddish-black stain still lingered in the creases of his fingernails—he hadn't yet had the chance to clean them.

"I searched every place I could think of to hide something, and there were no Artifacts anywhere. The man couldn't take pressure—all it took was one broken left arm and he was already begging me to search his home, his car. He didn't even wait for me to ask before giving me the address of his sister's place outside the city."

He pulled out a few banknotes, folded them into two stacks, rolled them up, and used their sharp corners to slowly clean out the stains from his fingernails.

"My search was thorough—I'm confident I missed nothing. But as I watched him on the boat, a feeling gradually took hold of me... I can't explain it, but I just knew." Chase stared at the dark reddish-black on the corner of the banknote and said, "He got an Artifact."

Ivan had been terrified and in agony, willing to do anything to escape the small boat and escape Chase—and yet there was something... something indescribable, like bone itself, that held up the man who was weeping and convulsing and howling, and made him grit his teeth and keep the secret.

Someone who had seen another world seemed to gain a certain distance from the reality before their eyes. Even bodily pain, at first, felt as though it were filtered through a layer of cotton.

This was a feeling Chase had encountered before, in Hunters who had just returned from the Nest.

Ivan was not a Hunter; he had only come into contact with another reality through an Artifact, and so carried only a faint, vague trace of that same quality.

But on his own, he wouldn't have been able to hold out for much longer.

The moment Chase thought of this, his hands wrenched together with a sharp, restless twist.

No matter how precious an Artifact, it could not be worth more than life and limb; even a rare Artifact capable of granting someone supreme wealth and status would not be worth

becoming a human torso.

In the deep of the previous night, Ivan had sat naked in a pool of blood, shaking violently in the cold sea wind, his arm snapped in several places and dislocated at the shoulder where a bloody hole had torn open, hanging a full length longer than his right arm.

Looking at him, Chase had known that even without resorting to real measures, the man was not far from his breaking point.

By any standard, Ivan was not a man of iron will.

A few more minutes, and he would have talked—but it was exactly at that moment that a light suddenly pierced the pitch-black curtain of night over the distant sea; the roar of a large speedboat's engine carved through the waves, pushing its light steadily into Chase's field of vision.

Dr. Nate snapped his head up and said under his breath, "Is that the—the Coast Guard?"

From what Chase knew, the Coast Guard didn't usually appear in this location at this hour, but out of caution he still dropped the bloodstained dumbbell plate he was holding; it landed with a heavy thud, making the hull shudder faintly.

"Get down," he ordered the bodyguard, then said, "Doctor, hand me the cover cloth under the seat."

The cloth normally used to cover the boat was thrown over Ivan hood-first, concealing pale flesh and dark crimson blood all at once.

Chase stepped over the trembling, rustling cloth in one stride, took a can of beer from the liquor cabinet, tossed it to Dr. Nate, and said, "Drink."

The crisp crack of the pull-tab was swallowed up by the engine sound growing ever closer; Chase could already make out, faintly, that the approaching vessel was a large speedboat very much resembling standard Coast Guard craft—by the look of it, within a few minutes it would come crashing through the waves and pass right in front of them.

"Great, the taxes I pay, coming to get in my way."

Chase muttered as he sat down and picked up a fishing rod from the boat, not even casting the line into the water.

That night the clouds were thick and formless, with no stars or moon to be seen, and visibility on the sea was extremely poor—a few meters out and one's gaze seemed to tumble into a black

void.

If the other vessel didn't shine a searchlight on them, they wouldn't be able to tell how many people were on the boat, let alone spot a fishing line; the cloth, the beer, and the fishing rod were prepared purely as a precaution.

Boats out night-fishing at two or three in the morning were rare enough, but the central bay was never short of private pleasure craft, and the Coast Guard seemed to have a different target altogether—it plowed straight past them without the slightest interest in Chase's small boat, not even slowing down.

The large speedboat racing past threw up wave after wave, tossing the small boat up and flinging it back down, again and again—and in the midst of the rocking, Chase suddenly cursed under his breath, leapt to his feet, and lunged toward the cover cloth.

He lost his footing and slammed into the railing from the pitching of the boat, but he seemed to feel nothing of it; he swept out an arm, and a large hand with long fingers closed around the cloth.

"What's wrong?"

Amid Dr. Nate's startled cry and the crash of waves against the hull, Chase pressed down on the cloth that was heaving and shifting beneath him, and closed his fist around it—Chase was confident in his grip; if he locked his hand around someone, they couldn't get free unless they pulled a gecko and shed a limb.

And yet Ivan had slipped away all the same.

At the time the whole thing happened so quickly that it was only afterward, thinking it over, that Chase was able to piece together how Ivan had escaped.

Taking advantage of the boat's pitching in the waves, Ivan had crawled from under the cloth toward the railing, trying to jump overboard while Chase was distracted; Chase had noticed in time, lunged over, and grabbed him, yanking him back—but in the rocking of the waves, with the cloth between them, Chase hadn't anticipated that what he'd grabbed was the very arm he himself had broken and torn open.

As the bodyguard's shoulder was wrenched by that pull, the wound that had just been cauterized and sealed tore open again, deeply; a long cry of agony rang out from beside the railing, piercing sharply into the night.

Along with that cry, a gush of fresh blood poured from the body.

The pain was unbearable, but it was precisely the flood of blood that acted as lubrication—and so Ivan finally managed, in a sway of the waves, to wrench out his broken arm by sheer force and roll overboard off the small boat. All of this happened in the span of two or three seconds; but by the time Chase rushed to the railing and swept his gaze around, the bodyguard had already sunk below the surface and was nowhere to be seen.

The night was dark and the sea was vast; even with a flashlight, one could only see a few meters of churning water.

Though the bodyguard was dragging an injured arm, if he held his breath and swam underwater for a while, moving beyond Chase's range of visibility was not difficult.

"He thought he could swim back to Blackmoor City with an injured, bleeding arm?"

Chase tried to smile, but found the muscles of his face too heavy to move. "He most likely died in the central bay long ago—who knows where the current will carry him. I'll keep an eye out over the next few days for any reports of a body being found."

"You're going to wait for news of a dead man before you know how to proceed?" Rolan Key smiled slightly and asked.

"No... of course not, Uncle Key."

Chase couldn't help it—even his voice dropped lower. "I'm planning to go find his sister, and the pizza delivery clerk."

Rolan Key, however, seemed to have no interest in his next steps. He took a sip of black coffee and said, "Anything left in plain sight for you to see isn't where something is hidden."

Chase made himself swallow those words.

He had nothing to say to that.

Before Ivan had jumped off the boat, Chase had already gotten hold of his keys, phone, documents, and even important passwords—all that had escaped was a bare body. In principle, even if the bodyguard had gotten away, as long as he'd hidden things somewhere he'd been, Chase should sooner or later be able to find a lead.

But Chase had searched every inch of every hiding place he could think of, and had still come up empty.

Just where had he missed?

Chase's hands had been unconsciously twisting and grinding against each other all this while; only now did he notice that the banknotes he'd used to clean his fingernails had been reduced to a scatter of fine shreds, drifting down into the carpet—he felt a sudden flush of embarrassment.

"Uncle Key, let me get the vacuum. Is the handheld one still in the usual spot?"

He had barely risen to his feet when Rolan Key said, "No rush. Sit down."

Though puzzled, Chase sat back down.

"Force cuts both ways," Rolan Key said slowly. "The full weight of a punch thrown at someone else inevitably reverberates back into one's own bones and heart. That's why interrogators who use violence either start out numb and dull, or gradually become numb and dull through violence."

A warm, tingling sensation spread from his palms to his chest.

"I'll be careful, Uncle Key," Chase said, with genuine gratitude. "It's just blood. I can handle it."

"That's not what I mean."

Chase's heart suddenly sank. He waited for what Rolan Key would say next, the way one waits for a punch that is about to land in the gut.

"A numb, brutal enforcer is the most worthless thing in this business," Rolan Key said. "You grew up at my side. I thought you would conduct yourself with more intelligence than this."

It was only after a brief moment that Chase's breathing returned to normal.

"For a Hunter House Faction to grow, the Nest is merely the foundation. What truly matters is how we establish ourselves and act in the human world—how we build influence. A truly powerful Hunter House Faction holds dominion over the 'reality' that every one of us must live within."

Rolan Key gave a low, slow chuckle from the back of his throat.

"...And yet dominating 'reality' cannot be achieved through violence and bloodshed alone. Don't tell me that's the only card you have."

Chase hadn't known his own head could feel so heavy; for a moment he wanted nothing more than to drop it into his hands—and it wasn't because he hadn't slept all night.

He knew that Rolan Key had not grown angry, but he would have preferred the man to lose his temper—to question him, scold him for failing to get things done.

Chase stood a full head taller than Rolan Key now, trained and formidable, a man even Hunters were wary of. And yet when Rolan Key was disappointed in him, Chase still felt that drowning sensation of sinking into ice water—because he could not stop being disappointed in himself.

He stared at his own hands; faint white scars ran across the backs, extending until they disappeared behind his watch and cuffs.

In his youth, trying to locate his own passage, Chase had run many experiments on himself and left all manner of scars and hidden injuries on his body.

Only 1% of humanity possessed a "passage"—a channel through which they could enter the Nest; but no one knew what their own passage was until they tried every method one by one. He had tried every known method of opening a passage, yet still stood in the mortal world, unable to see the Nest.

Now he was thirty years old, and he still could not forget the moment when Uncle Key finally accepted the truth that he had no passage—the way he had lowered his eyelids and said nothing.

Like watching a work of art shatter on the ground, revealing the foam padding inside.

The scar on the back of his hand was not from the experiments. It was from after the experiments—Chase had cut it himself with a hunting knife, and he didn't know why; perhaps he had believed, in that moment, that he could cut open a passage that way.

"I understand." Chase said it, then noticed his voice had gone hoarse, and cleared his throat. "Uncle Key, I made you a promise—everything on this side of the world, I will deliver to you."

He could not enter the Nest, but he could become a Hunter in the mortal world, seizing every scrap of power and wealth that could be taken and bringing it into the Key family's hands.

Because what Uncle Key truly wanted, he could never give him.

Chapter 16 — Chase and the Artifact Submerged in the Metropolis

"According to the surveillance footage we obtained,"

Chase said as he drove, "Ivan left the gates of the Wellesley Family Estate at 7:21 a.m. on November 16th, and never looked back."

The bodyguard naturally had no intention of going back; the moment he'd stolen the Artifact, he put his job out of his mind without a word to anyone and headed straight for Blackmoor City.

"What about his movements after leaving the estate? How do you pin those down?" The young woman in the passenger seat wore her hair in long, thick dreadlocks dyed a deep violet, and when they fell over her shoulders, they looked like a great cascade of flowing lavender.

"His GPS records are in my hands. The route we're driving right now is the same one he took on the 16th."

The young woman paused at that and glanced over at him.

"I know," Chase said, his expression unchanged. "The fact that a route is logged in his GPS doesn't mean he actually drove it."

"Right — I've heard you'd need to pull the route data from the manufacturer to know exactly where he went," the dreadlocked woman replied. "That'd be hard to manage without police resources, wouldn't it?"

Generally speaking, that was true.

But Chase had always had good luck.

He quickly discovered that a grocery store sat across from Ivan's apartment building — since people lived on the second floor, the owner had installed a smart security camera out front that recorded all comings and goings.

Posing as a police officer, he smoothly pulled up the time window he needed: at 10:47 a.m., Ivan's car had turned onto the street, circled for a bit, and snagged a parking spot.

That day was a Saturday, with no rush-hour traffic. Ivan had taken 3 hours and 26 minutes to get from the Upstate District to Blackmoor City — only thirteen minutes more than the GPS

estimate. Given the overcast, rainy weather, a discrepancy of a few minutes was not significant at all and fell entirely within the normal range.

"If he'd taken a different route, the timing wouldn't have lined up so neatly."

Every other GPS route would have added at least twenty minutes, making the timeline impossible; and besides, Ivan had been fleeing with the Artifact — by all logic, he'd want to move as fast as possible and wouldn't take the long way around.

This meant the possibility that Ivan had made a detour en route — to his sister's place, for instance, or a rented storage unit — and handed the Artifact off to someone else for safekeeping was virtually nonexistent, because a few minutes' discrepancy simply wasn't enough time for any of that.

But what if Ivan had called ahead and asked his sister to wait for him somewhere?

As he drove past, all it would take was passing a package through the window — a delay so small it would never show up in the driving record.

That theory, however, was quickly dismantled by Chase himself.

He had everything of Ivan's in his possession, and he easily pulled the call records from the carrier, finding that Ivan hadn't made a single outgoing call that morning, and hadn't been in contact with his sister in the days before or after, either — in fact, Ivan's entire call log for the 16th contained only two entries: the first was a call from the head of the bodyguard team, demanding to know why he had quit without authorization; the second was a call that afternoon to a pizza place, ordering one large pepperoni pizza.

Surely no one would hand over a priceless Artifact to a complete stranger making a delivery.

If the two knew each other, that would be one thing; but according to the Hunter sent to investigate, the delivery driver had no connection to Ivan whatsoever.

It was possible he had used someone else's phone — there was just no evidence to support that at the moment — and Ivan didn't seem like the kind of man capable of thinking that far ahead.

Regardless, Chase still had to exhaust every possibility.

He had to bring back what Uncle Kai wanted for the House Faction; before that single objective, no obstacle could be allowed to remain one.

"Mr. Monroe, I have a question—" the young dreadlocked woman began.

"Just call me Chase," he cut her off. "When other Hunters call me Mr. Monroe, it means they know they're in trouble."

Kingsley had not been with the House Faction long — she'd previously been an unremarkable Hunter of no particular renown — but recently her reputation had suddenly soared and she'd become a sought-after talent. Since she'd been recruited into the Key household, today was the first time Chase had actually met her in person.

As far as Chase knew, this kind of transformation in a Hunter wasn't all that unusual.

The Nest took on a thousand forms, strange and fantastical beyond all imagination; aside from the Artifacts that could be brought back into the world, Hunters might encounter creatures, rules, domains, or things that defied all definition — their interactions with such things produced no telling how many kinds of consequences and effects. Not all of them, of course, were good.

The vast majority were not good.

But occasionally, a lucky soul like Kingsley would draw the winning lot — returning from the Nest one day in possession of abilities she'd never had before.

"Chase," she corrected herself, then said: "I swept the Wellesley Family Estate. I can confirm there isn't a single Artifact left inside or outside the grounds. All along the road we drove in on, I didn't sense any Artifact presence either. That supports the idea that the bodyguard took the Artifact and carried it straight to Blackmoor City without stopping — that part is still easy enough to follow.

"But why did he lock himself in his apartment after he got home? If he went to the trouble of stealing an Artifact, he must have understood what it meant and what it was worth — he'd know people would track him down. If it were me, I'd go home, grab what I needed, and run — actually, I might not even go home at all. I'd leave everything behind."

Before answering, Chase lifted his chin toward the window.

Outside, a heavy, overcast sky hung there grey and sullen, brooding with the constant threat of rain; beneath it, a dull, dark-green blur of trees streamed steadily past.

"Well? Are you getting anything?"

Kingsley furrowed her brow, paused for two seconds, then said, "It overlaps quite a bit with my last detection range... still no Artifact."

Chase glanced at the time and said nothing.

He had no idea what method Kingsley used to sense things.

For a Hunter, the ability to "detect Artifacts" was fundamental and invaluable — but the problem was that Kingsley's detection precision was truly terrible.

He had been driving at fifty kilometers an hour for several minutes, and they still hadn't left the range of Kingsley's last sweep.

By rough calculation, her Artifact detection range was about a five-kilometer radius — as for exactly where within that five-kilometer radius an Artifact might be hiding, only heaven knew.

With a sensing method this vague, was she really a prize worth poaching for a Hunter House Faction?

Chase had never set eyes on the Nest himself, so he didn't know the answer to that question.

"That Ivan — he had a bit of cunning about him."

He pulled his thoughts back to the present, fixed his gaze on the road ahead, and said: "He knew people would track the Artifacts that went missing from the study, so he gambled against fate — he bet he could slip through the cracks."

"Slip through the cracks?"

"If Wellesley's former bodyguard fled the moment he died, everyone would have known immediately that something was wrong with him. Never mind that no one even knows yet whether Wellesley's death was natural or not. If it was murder, running would tie Ivan to it as well.

"If Wellesley was murdered, a fleeing Ivan would draw the attention of three different parties.

"First, the police investigating the cause of death; second, whoever killed Wellesley, who wouldn't want any loose ends discovered; and third, the various Hunter House Factions suspecting he'd stolen the Artifacts."

Kingsley nodded. "That makes sense... he'd be better off acting like he didn't know anything. Even if he planned to run, he should at least lay low through the first few days and not attract attention."

"Exactly. He couldn't stay at the estate, because the estate would be the first place anyone searched for Artifacts. Wellesley had fired Ivan before he died — as long as he used that as his excuse, he had a reason to leave. And since four Artifacts went missing, and he'd likely only taken one, if he kept a low profile, there was no guarantee anyone would come looking for him specifically."

"So how did you find him?" Kingsley asked with genuine interest.

"...I got lucky."

"Lucky? I don't believe in luck," Kingsley said, looking at the road ahead with a smile.

"Everything I have, I earned for myself."

What a young thing to say.

The Nest was not a primary school teacher; the Nest did not reward sheer effort — but Chase kept those words to himself.

"Is that so? Then I suppose you wouldn't care about what the other Hunters say about me."

"What do they say?"

"That the reason I have such good luck is that I draw the good luck away from the people around me."

Kingsley probably thought he was joking and started to laugh, glancing over at Chase as she did — then, like a cloud shadow passing overhead, her smile dimmed and faded quickly, leaving her quiet.

Anyone who became a Hunter had sharper instincts than the average person, to some degree or another.

Following the GPS route, Chase exited the highway and entered Blackmoor City proper.

A forest of modern towers built from glass and steel, classical buildings that had stood and settled over centuries past, neon advertisements layering light and shadow over one another, office workers striding briskly down the streets, tourists perched atop red double-decker sightseeing buses with their phones held aloft — like pieces of a puzzle, it all gradually assembled before his eyes into the most prosperous, vibrant, and diverse metropolis in the world.

Chase had lived in Blackmoor City for thirty years, yet everything he'd learned about it probably didn't amount to the tip of the iceberg; accompanying its vast and endlessly varied

population was an unknowable quality — the sense that no one could predict what the next moment might bring. Chase had never wanted to leave Blackmoor City, and beyond his ties to the Key household, it was because he needed that unknowability, the way he needed air.

If every day of his life were the same as the last, he would be as good as dead already, just waiting to be buried.

To minimize distractions, Kingsley closed her eyes and rolled down the window, as though listening to the pulse of the city.

"Nothing... nothing... up ahead is Buluan 5th Street?... nothing there either."

"Are you sure?"

Kingsley's eyes snapped open. "Wait!"

Chase lifted his foot off the accelerator. The moment the car slowed, a wave of irritated honking erupted from the line of vehicles behind them.

Blackmoor City residents were not known for their patience or their courtesy.

"Got one!" Kingsley's eyes went wide as she twisted her head left and right, scanning around — yet a shadow of puzzlement wouldn't leave her face. "Hold on, let me just—"

"Where?"

Kingsley seemed not to hear him. She craned her head out the window, held still for a few blank seconds, then dropped back into her seat with a thud.

"It's gone," she said quietly. "I thought there was an Artifact nearby... but it's strange — the feeling flashed past, and by the time I focused and tried to sense it again, it had vanished. I swear my instincts are usually spot-on; I've never run into anything like this before..."

Flashed past?

The car crawled along, and the honking and shouting from behind had been completely shut out of Chase's mind.

His attention spread outward like a searchlight sweeping in all directions: the road, the streets, the buildings, the pedestrians, the signs — scenes he had passed by countless times before all registered in his mind one by one, sharp and vivid, as though he were seeing them for the very first time.

An Artifact that "flashed past" within a range this large — a full five-kilometer radius...

His eyelids gave a sudden twitch, and his gaze landed on a round sign in the distance bearing the letter "D."

A thought occurred to Chase.

He looked over at the oncoming lane, waited for a gap with no approaching cars, then gave the steering wheel a sharp turn, cut across half the road, and swung onto the other lane.

Amid the shriek of brakes, blaring horns, and furious curses, he pressed down on the center of the steering wheel and leaned on it without letting up, while the car had already mounted the sidewalk; the pedestrians who scattered to either side in fright were like waves the car had thrown up in its wake.

Kingsley gripped the overhead handle with both hands and cried out, "What are you doing? Where are you going? You're going to hit someone!"

With one set of tires on the curb and the other on the road, the car tilted forward at an angle; they tore past a row of storefronts, startling a customer who had just stepped out and sending coffee splashing all over him.

The chaos and commotion outside the car meant nothing to Chase.

He kept his eyes fixed ahead and said, "I know where the Artifact is."

Friends, yesterday I got up early in the morning and headed out to take care of some things — I even sent the chapter from the car. Chapter numbers, author's notes, none of that was on my mind; I just needed to get the food on the table first, and if I remember the cutlery later I'll bring that too. For now just eat with your hands, we've been at this long enough, we make do.

As for what I'm doing today — as I write this, I'm once again on my way to the airport. If you went to the headquarters of every major airline right now, you'd find my portrait hanging there. Seriously, go look if you don't believe me.

As for writing author's notes, I have mixed feelings — I can't bring myself to leave out all this pointless rambling, but whenever I do write them, I always end up seeing comments saying the notes are better than the actual chapters, and honestly I don't know whether to be happy about that. Maybe after the novel goes on the paid roster I'll just post nonsense — sound about right?

Chapter 17 — Chase: The Hunted Hunter

Ivan was either a genius or an idiot.

No, Chase thought, perhaps he was a mixture of both; they say that when an idiot has a flash of brilliance, even the smart ones can't compete.

"Are you trying to get yourself killed? Don't drag me into it!" Kingsley forgot to be polite to her superior in her panic and cried out, "This isn't the Nest — this is the real world! There are consequences for driving like this. You hit someone, you go to prison — do you not hear the sirens behind us?"

It had only been a few minutes since he'd blown through a string of traffic laws before he heard the sirens.

The wail of sirens carved through the sky behind them like circling knife-tips, slicing again and again; sometimes growing more distant, making Chase think he'd shaken the last patrol car, only for them to close in again as new ones joined the chase from other directions.

But the patrol cars never managed to cut him off, because they couldn't do what Chase did — tear across sidewalks, drive the wrong way through red lights, and blast through intersections as if the road were empty.

Along the way, he lost count of how many pedestrians he saw throwing themselves to the side of the road in frantic panic, and lost count of how many times he heard the sharp screech of tires grinding against asphalt.

Wherever the car went, chaos followed — running, honking, screaming; and by some miracle, by the time Chase finally straightened out and roared down the open road, he had only knocked a side mirror askew and caved in one headlight, without causing any truly irreversible damage.

"Hold on," he said, glancing back at the vast sweep of flashing red and blue lights behind them. "I'm going to accelerate."

"More? You—"

Kingsley didn't get to finish — the car surged forward and the force of inertia drove her back into her seat.

Chase spun the wheel; the car twisted around the vehicle ahead, then cut sharply in front of it, drawing a chorus of furious honks. "The search I had you run earlier — you still have it open, right?"

Kingsley let out a sigh and brushed her lavender hair back from her face.

"It's open," she said, holding her phone up into the edge of Chase's vision; the screen was indeed lit up with a map app. "Fine — it's not like I'm the one driving. Where exactly are we going?"

"Buluan Community College," Chase answered briefly, blasting between two more cars.

"...Why?"

"When you sensed the Artifact flash by, I caught a glimpse of the subway sign for 'Fullington Station' on Line D. Buluan Community College is the terminal station for Line D in that direction."

Kingsley absorbed this, blinking several times in quick succession.

"Wait — you're saying you think that bodyguard hid the Artifact at Buluan Community College Station?"

"No," Chase said. "I think he hid the Artifact on the subway."

Kingsley's jaw dropped. Two seconds passed before she pulled it back up. "The subway? Blackmoor City's subway? You — he — is he out of his mind?"

Somehow, she had the feeling that what she'd originally meant to say was something more like "are you serious."

Blackmoor City's subway could be called world-famous — just not for being busy or crowded.

Beyond ordinary commuters and tourists, the cars were always filled with cult members recruiting followers, vendors selling fake newspapers, people announcing the deaths of public figures who were still very much alive, prophets warning of the coming apocalypse, performers changing clothes in public to beg for money — an endless parade of strange and colorful characters.

People often said that to tell whether someone was a true Blackmoor City native, all you had to do was watch them on the subway — if they could sit there, completely unfazed, from the moment they boarded to the moment they got off, then they were the real thing.

Anyone's first instinct, if they needed to hide something, would not be to hide it in a place like that.

And besides — once the subway pulled away, how would Ivan ever retrieve it?

"There's a lot I don't understand," Kingsley said, thinking it through. "Ivan stopped the car on his way into Blackmoor City, went into the subway station, and came back out quickly — that part makes sense, and he would have had time for it. But how do you know he hid it on the subway?"

"You said the Artifact 'flashed by,' right? If your detection method is really as reliable as you say, then it means that at the moment you sensed it, it was at the very edge of your detection range, moving forward at high speed, and left your range an instant later.

"In other words, before you began detecting, it had already been traveling through your detection range at a certain speed for some period of time — that's exactly why, at the moment you started detecting, it happened to be right at the edge of your range, and ultimately 'flashed by' like that."

Her detection range was enormous. Pedestrians, bicycles, even cars moving at city speed limits — if they weren't moving fast enough, they couldn't leave her detection range in any short span of time.

Based on the picture they'd pieced together so far, Ivan had not been in contact with anyone; and within the city, what could travel continuously at high speed without being restricted by traffic, carrying the Artifact out of Kingsley's detection range?

When Chase's gaze had landed on the "D" sign, it came back to him: Fullington Station was right nearby.

While they'd been searching without finding anything, deep beneath their feet, a subway train had been thundering off into the distance — with the Artifact on board.

The possibility that another Artifact had simply happened to appear along Ivan's route was something neither of them had stopped to consider — "possibility" and "probability" are two entirely different concepts. Even with any number of Hunters tirelessly trying to carry Artifacts out into the world, the total number of Artifacts in existence remained very small.

Kingsley glanced back at the cluster of patrol cars refusing to give up the chase, and resigned herself to her fate. She gripped the overhead handle and said, "No wonder you cut across the

streets and didn't hesitate to drive against traffic and over the speed limit — you're racing the subway, and just taking a regular shortcut probably wouldn't be enough. Though this is actually terrifying. If I don't die in the Nest but end up dying in a car crash, that would really be too ironic."

Chase didn't respond to that. He glanced at the time and said, "When you detected the Artifact, it was around 10:03."

He had an obsessive habit — no matter the situation, he had to know the time, and it had to be precise to the minute.

The habit had held for over twenty years; now, even without checking his watch, his internal clock was nearly flawless. Before he'd even looked, he already knew it was 10:13 — he had been speeding through the pursuit and blockades of patrol cars for nearly ten minutes.

Ahead of him, there were still any number of red lights waiting. Every one of them was a choice: stop and get caught by the police? Run it, and get split in two by oncoming traffic?

He needed to think of something — how to carve an empty road out of Blackmoor City's sea of traffic?

Chase asked, "What's the current interval between trains on Line D?"

Kingsley glanced at the map app on her phone. "Seven minutes," she answered.

"Check your navigation — how many minutes until the next train departs from Fullington Station? And how long does it take to reach the terminal?"

"The next train departs in two minutes. It takes thirty-five minutes to reach the terminal."

As Kingsley said this, she caught on as well, her eyes gradually lighting up. "Ah — the train with the Artifact on it will reach the terminal station at 10:36! We just need to get to the platform before 36 minutes past."

People who could treat "entering the Nest to hunt" as a career rather than a final hobby before death were never slow on the uptake.

If the next train departed at 10:15, then the ones before it had left at 10:08 and 10:01 respectively. When Kingsley had started detecting at 10:03, the subway that had left at 10:01 was just about to leave her detection range; by the time it traveled from Fullington Station to the terminal, it would be exactly 10:36.

"But I still have one question," Kingsley said, frowning. "How do you know that subway was heading toward Buluan Community College Station and not going the other direction?"

"I don't," Chase said.

Kingsley's head snapped toward him and she stared.

"I only know one thing," Chase said — he was more patient with Hunters from his own House Faction than with anyone else, and he explained: "When you go down into Fullington Station, the platform on the first underground level is the one heading toward Buluan Community College Station. The second underground level is the one going in the opposite direction."

"Oh," Kingsley's frown relaxed and she nodded. "So you're betting that the bodyguard just got on the nearest available train. That tracks — he only took thirteen minutes more than the GPS-estimated route; factor in the time to park, get out of the car, and wait for the train, and it means he didn't linger in the station at all. He was in and out."

Ivan only needed to ride one stop — once he'd hidden the Artifact, he could get off at the next station and, without even waiting, cross the platform and catch the subway going the other way.

"Still, to know a random subway station has two platform levels," Kingsley remarked, "you must have been born in Blackmoor City. You know this place so well."

Chase didn't answer. He simply said, "Make a call. Report it to the police."

Kingsley blinked twice, unable to help glancing back at the patrol cars behind them. One had gotten very close; the spinning flicker of its lights cast blue and red across the rear window glass.

"We're not short on police," she pointed out.

"Don't waste time." Chase kept his foot steady on the gas, continuing toward the intersection ahead where the light was red. "Call it in — tell them you're on a speeding car, and have them seal off the area from Columbia Avenue and East 106th Street to Cherry Street within ten minutes."

"You're the boss either way." She muttered as she opened the dialer.

Kingsley had barely finished pressing the three digits when her eyes yanked away from the screen — from the road on their right, a large truck had just crossed through the intersection and was now rumbling toward them, on a direct collision course to slam into the black Mercedes broadside.

"The truck—"

Chase didn't brake — he accelerated, flooring the gas pedal level with the floor, and the engine let out what sounded almost like a cry of desperation as the car shot straight ahead at breakneck speed.

Kingsley's involuntary scream filled and echoed through the cabin, then was swallowed by the thunderous crash that struck the rear of the car — though only the corner of the tail end was clipped, the impact wrenched the entire vehicle hard to one side, nearly spinning it to a sideways stop in the middle of the intersection.

Two large hands wrenched the steering wheel hard over, and amid the shuddering groan of metal and engine, the car broke free of the intersection and pulled out onto the road ahead; behind them, the truck slammed on its brakes and skidded diagonally across the road, and a chain of rear-ending cars piled up in an instant into a steel serpent, blocking the pursuing patrol cars on the other side.

"I joined the Hunter House Faction for more security," Kingsley cried out, still reeling from the shock. "Not to put my life on the line at work! This isn't the Nest—"

"911," a woman's voice came from below the seat. "What is your emergency?"

"Hurry," Chase kept his foot on the gas, snapping his fingers in front of Kingsley. "We might not be so lucky at the next intersection."

"Hello — hello!" Kingsley scrambled to pick up her phone. "I'm in the car that's been barreling through the Buluan District!"

She rattled off Chase's instructions at speed, then paused, glanced at him, and said, "...You want to know who I am? Well, I've been — been kidnapped into this car. He's pointing a gun at me and making me make this call. He says if they don't block off the road... he'll throw a bomb into the traffic."

Chase shot her a sideways glance and broke into a grin, a flash of white teeth.

"I'd say it's been a pleasure working with you," he said quietly, after Kingsley hung up, "but our work together has only just begun."

My stockpile of chapters is almost gone after tomorrow, aaaaaahhh

And I've been running around like crazy these past few days and haven't had time to check who the new sponsors are — the bonus chapter debt is still at 7. Well, as long as I don't look, it stays at 7... No, I mean, I will definitely write those bonus chapters. I promise.

Today is packed again — Qidian in the morning, errands in the afternoon, and then some unexpected last-minute event tonight that I absolutely cannot skip... I had no idea this thing was happening, and my suitcase only has jeans, sneakers, and T-shirts, so they might not even let me in the door — hey, if they don't let me in, doesn't that mean I get to come back and write? See, I'm such a responsible, work-minded person.

PS: Prices are going to be the death of me... Especially to my friends in Shanghai — how do you people survive? I was absolutely floored by the prices. I paced back and forth in front of a single bottle of mouthwash four times, like I was working up the nerve to propose to it. The store clerk was already staring at me before I finally steeled myself and grabbed it. A small bottle of mouthwash is like under ten yuan anywhere else, right?! What is Shanghai mouthwash made of — can you drink it after rinsing for beauty and wellness benefits or something?!

Chapter 18: Mai Minghe's Fourth Person

The exit of St. Louis Hospital (Nest version), according to the redhead, was inside the guardhouse outside the hospital building.

To get there, they had to go up to the first floor, cross the lobby, and walk out the main entrance—and the whole way, they'd have to avoid not only Residents, but also the redhead's companions; without someone to lead the way, it was a actually thorny problem.

Mai Minghe was grateful.

"Young man, what's your name?"

She smoothed the white sheet back into place—a habit she had kept for seventy or eighty years; even after climbing down from a mortuary slab, she still had to leave it neat—and sighed: "What a shame we don't know each other back in Blackmoor City. Otherwise, no matter what, I'd have knitted you a sweater and sent it over. Look at you—you didn't dress warmly enough today. It's November and you're still wearing short sleeves."

The redhead glanced at her as though she were the strangest thing in the entire Nest.

"...It's not like you're my great-aunt," he finally muttered after a long pause. "My name's Jonah. But I'd advise you, once you're back, to keep pretending we don't know each other. Don't let my House Faction find out about you."

She still had countless questions and very much hoped she could ask Jonah in a safe environment—but he was right; none of those questions were as important as the Artifact.

Questions about the Nest she could slowly tease out, bit by bit, in time.

"Let's go," Jonah said. "We reset, but it's still safer not to take the same route back."

As the two of them left, Mai Minghe switched off the light on her way out. In the instant before the light died, the body lying beneath the white sheet in the corner of the morgue swept across the edge of her vision one last time—and then was swallowed by the darkness.

The morgue door was heavy; left unbraced, it swung shut on its own, closing behind them with a heavy thud.

Mai Minghe followed behind Jonah, turning down the other end of the corridor, and for reasons she couldn't quite name, her mind felt hazy and unsettled.

Her thoughts kept drifting back to that silent, sheet-covered shape in the morgue—it struck her as a truly genuine corpse: no reaction when Jonah turned on the light, no reaction while the two of them talked, and no reaction when they left.

"Do they actually use the morgue to store real corpses?" Mai Minghe asked. "The moment I think about how we might have been lying right next to an actual dead body just now, my heart just—it gives me the creeps..."

"Hm?" Jonah answered absently. "Just now? A dead body?"

She swallowed back a sentence that had nearly slipped out, and raised her eyes to look at his back.

Jonah's red hair was cut very short; below the neat line of his hairline at the back, there was still a faint dusting of light-orange fuzz that hadn't been shaved clean, hovering like a mist across the nape of his neck.

Something stirred and settled uneasily in her chest, and she could hardly have said what she was thinking—she said vaguely: "Right... just now."

Jonah was quiet for a second or two.

In the rhythm of their footsteps, he said, "I don't know—maybe someone would do that. It is a morgue, after all."

Mai Minghe gave a low "mm" to show she'd heard.

She turned to look behind her; at her back stretched a straight corridor, leading to the staircase they had come down earlier.

If she turned and ran from here, she had nowhere to change direction—fleeing in a straight line, it would be very hard to shake off a pursuer... No, no, maybe she wouldn't need to run at all?

Maybe she was overthinking it?

Right—don't rush, think it through first, Mai Minghe told herself.

1. The morgue was a "reset" location: a person went in, lay down, and played dead; after enough time had passed, the hospital Residents would forget them.

2. Before they entered, someone was already lying in the morgue—or at least something person-shaped.

3. After they came out, Jonah had clearly forgotten that someone was still lying in the morgue.

Goosebumps rose in waves across the skin of Mai Minghe's thighs, every pore seeping cold.

Reasoning from these three known facts, there was only one conclusion to draw: Jonah was a Resident.

But that conclusion was absurd—he was plainly a flesh-and-blood living person, and he had saved her. She must have missed something; she needed to think it over again.

Jonah's pace was fast, and after following him at a brisk stride for a while, Mai Minghe found they had climbed up a staircase on the other side of the hospital and emerged onto the first floor, not far from the emergency room.

The hospital corridors and waiting areas were all brightly lit, but the nurses' station was completely empty.

Aside from the all-round emptiness, this place was an exact replica of the real human world. On the surface of the nurses' reception desk, there was even a paper cup—only without anyone to drink from it, as though the apocalypse had arrived without warning and humanity had abandoned the place.

Along the corridor they were in, there were several examination rooms; some doors were shut tight, others stood half-open, revealing a sliver of impenetrable dim darkness.

The whole way, there was nothing to be heard but their own footsteps and breathing. Jonah had chosen a very good route—not a single Resident encountered, every danger avoided.

"There's often something in the emergency room," Jonah crouched behind a wall, carefully peered out, surveyed the space for a moment, then said to Mai Minghe: "When we pass through, we have to stay absolutely silent."

Mai Minghe nodded, but a thought forced its way into her mind.

...But when they were playing dead, they hadn't needed to stay silent?

She actually knew nothing about the Nest or about "life gates," but thinking about it logically, she felt that when a person was pretending to be a corpse, they shouldn't be chatting and

laughing back and forth the way the two of them had just been doing.

A corpse—shouldn't it be like the figure lying in the corner... motionless, utterly silent, no matter what happened?

What if the person in the corner was a Hunter who was truly in the middle of resetting...

Then had she actually reset successfully?

Mai Minghe looked down at her fingertips.

As for how to verify whether Jonah was a Resident or a living person—when she thought carefully, she actually did have a way.

Although she had wiped most of the blood off onto the lanky patient earlier, a thin line of dark blood still remained deep under her fingernails, not entirely cleaned away.

Mai Minghe used the nail of another finger to work out a little of the dark red residue and held it between her fingertips. When Jonah stood up and said quietly, "Let's go," she immediately reached out and grabbed his arm, calling out: "Wait."

Fortunately, he was wearing short sleeves; the dark red blood on her fingers transferred cleanly onto Jonah's skin.

Nothing like the writhing and thrashing the lanky patient had shown happened at all.

"What is it?" Jonah half-bent, stepping back behind the wall. "Did you spot something?"

He looked a bit pale—but who could look rosy-cheeked in a situation like this; Mai Minghe suspected her own complexion was worse—yet apart from that, he seemed completely normal, no pain, no reaction, not even noticing that the round-headed one's blood had gotten on his arm.

It seemed he wasn't a Resident after all. Mai Minghe quietly breathed a sigh of relief.

There was probably some other explanation for what had happened in the morgue, even if she couldn't think of it at the moment—but she wasn't God; how could she possibly account for every single thing without a gap?

From now on, she'd just have to stay a little more careful and watchful.

"Say something."

"Mm... I was thinking," Mai Minghe, under his stare, needed an excuse, and hemmed and hawed: "Once we get out of here, isn't it going to be pretty dangerous? We should find some useful

weapons before we head out."

Jonah frowned, thinking it over. "We don't have much time. Who knows how long this corridor will stay safe? As long as we're fast enough—rush to the exit before danger closes in—weapons aren't strictly necessary."

It had only been meant as an excuse, but now that he put it that way, Mai Minghe actually felt that finding a weapon was necessary. In this life, no matter what you're doing, being prepared does no harm; a youngster like Jonah, brimming with confidence, was perfectly normal—but she couldn't just go along with his overconfidence.

"How about this—when we pass the nurses' station, I'll duck in and take a quick look around. It won't waste any time."

To leave the building they had to pass the nurses' reception desk anyway; if she went in one end and came out the other, it would only take a few glances.

Jonah wasn't thrilled, but he didn't argue.

"Then I'll come in with you," he tilted his chin in indication. "If there's nothing strange inside the nurses' station, it's actually safer than being out in the open—gives us some cover."

Decision made, the two immediately crouched low, moved lightly on their feet, and slipped out from behind the wall.

Scanning left and right as they went, they hurried toward the nurses' station—like two frantic beetles, four legs rustling and scraping across the floor—and slipped behind the partition of the nurses' station.

The nurses' reception desk was rectangular, with entrances on either side directly facing each other. Mai Minghe was perpetually afraid that the moment she looked up, a face would appear at the opposite entrance; so, almost compulsively, every few seconds she had to sweep a glance over before she felt at ease.

On the side facing the lobby were three nurses' workstations, fitted with computers, office chairs, telephones, and various odds and ends like folders and forms—if not for what she had just experienced, she could hardly believe this wasn't the real St. Louis Hospital.

How could there be phones and computers in the Nest? Who had brought all this in?

The letters on the keyboard had worn white, as though someone had actually typed on it for years; a small cactus—real or fake, she couldn't tell—sat grey and dusty in the corner of the desk.

For a moment she almost forgot her objective entirely, caught in the strange wonder of a TV viewer first setting foot on a film set—even the most mundane, unremarkable things, the duty roster and the ballpoint pen, seemed to take on a fresh novelty that made them worth a second look—but unfortunately, she couldn't find anything that might serve as a weapon.

Mai Minghe had just stretched out her hand, wanting to listen for a dial tone on the phone, when Jonah immediately stopped her.

"Don't touch anything that could make contact," he warned her in a breath. "There's no telling what it might attract."

He had probably been traumatized by her pressing the call bell four times in a row—his whole face read: "Have you learned nothing?"

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and thought for a few seconds.

"There's nothing here," Jonah crouched behind the workstation; that way, no one looking in from outside the nurses' station would see anyone inside. He pointed to the entrance on the other side and said, still in a whisper: "Let's go, don't waste any more time."

"Okay."

When Jonah crouched low and moved to the front of the entrance, he suddenly stopped and looked back at Mai Minghe. "What are you just standing there for? Come on."

Mai Minghe pulled out an office chair; the four wheels rolled and rumbled, breaking the quiet, and stopped in front of her.

She bent slightly forward, both hands pressed on the back of the chair, looking at the face across from her.

Jonah looked no older than thirty—as a grown adult, he had barely begun his journey in life. His eyes were a little red, his lips dry, his body carrying a faint shimmer of warm sweat—very human.

She didn't know the truth of it, but she couldn't help feeling sad. Like a conditioned reflex, she felt sad for a child so young, and sad for the mother who had raised him little by little.

"You go ahead," Mai Minghe said, her voice a little hoarse. "I'm not going with you."

Jonah furrowed his brow, stared at her for a moment, as if he thought she was talking nonsense.

But after two seconds, his brow relaxed.

"...You noticed something?" He no longer seemed to care about being seen—he straightened up beside the nurses' station entrance and flashed Mai Minghe a bright smile. "Tell me about it."

"Not counting the lanky patient who was already in the room,"

Mai Minghe said quietly: "After I pressed the bell four times, a nurse came—plus the pair of hands under the bed and the underground Resident controlling the round-headed one... that's three 'figures disguised as nurses' in total. The fourth one to enter the room was you."

Truth be told, I thought that after posting the Mai Minghe and Sydney Ginn sections, someone would definitely spot the foreshadowing about "the fourth person" and "the exit" — but nope! (In Sydney Ginn's section, it was mentioned that returning to Blackmoor City also goes through the passage.) So this round goes to me — anyone who goes back to leave a comment about it now doesn't count!

I suppose my dear readers took pity on me and let me have this one win — after all, I've had such a rough time lately, running around exhausted and stressed and irritable every single day... Ugh, I won't get into the unpleasant stuff.

My backlog is gone. Starting tomorrow I'll have to live by my wits and perform for you all on the spot (not really) — I opened the Artifact Report page and took one look: variety arts, miscellaneous rambling, stand-up comedy (not actually).

First I lured everyone in with a novel, and now that the stockpile's dry, I'm putting on a ballet called **Swan Lake: Wielding a Broadsword** to pay back what I owe my dear readers — is that okay? Quite the innovative scam operation we've got here.

Chapter 19: Mai Minghe's Reproductive Unit

Looking back on it now, Jonah had kept quite a close watch on her.

He would turn his head every so often to check whether Mai Minghe was keeping up, and whenever she hesitated or slowed down, he would urge her to keep moving. Even for someone actually warm-hearted, his concern for her safety seemed almost excessive—not only was he willing to forgo the Artifact, he was even ready to abandon his companions for her sake.

Of course, all of this reflection on Mai Minghe's part was hindsight.

"You're that sure about it?"

Jonah still kept his voice low—no longer a whisper exactly, but as though he didn't want anything else to hear him either.

"This is your first time in the Nest. How can you be so certain that ringing the bell would definitely bring a Resident out? What if one of them didn't go, or went but found they couldn't outcompete the others and simply didn't enter the room?"

"If I really am just a Hunter who got caught while trying to escape and was thrown into the ward, yet you're this suspicious of me, wouldn't you just be throwing away a valuable ally for nothing?"

"...So are you?" Mai Minghe asked quietly.

Jonah licked his dry lips, thought for a moment, and smiled.

"...No."

The word had barely left his mouth before Mai Minghe had already kicked a chair, sending it flying straight at him.

She didn't wait to see whether it connected—she spun around and ran immediately. A clang rang out, as though the chair had struck something hard, sending a heart-stopping echo through the empty, silent waiting hall.

It didn't sound like it had hit a human body, but Mai Minghe had no time to look back and find out. She burst out of the nurses' station, sprinted across the hall, and charged toward the

corridor she had come from—she remembered there were several examination rooms along it, their doors left ajar, and if she could dash into one and lock it, she might be able to hold Jonah off.

A sharp whistle pierced the air behind her, followed immediately by Jonah's voice: "Come!"

What was he calling?

Mai Minghe forced herself to pump her legs even faster, twisted around a corner, and plunged into the quiet corridor—strangely, not a single footstep sounded on the floor behind her, as though Jonah hadn't given chase at all.

She couldn't suppress her curiosity and shot a quick glance back over her shoulder.

The corridor was empty, pale light soaking into the desolate silence.

Jonah really hadn't come after her.

Never mind why he hadn't; she'd already run this far—even if he started chasing now, he probably couldn't catch up, could he?

Should she still duck into an examination room?

The question flashed through her mind, and she made her decision at once: yes.

She knew nothing about this St. Louis Hospital inside the Nest, and running around blindly might land her in any number of dangers. She had at least glanced into the examination rooms as she passed—they weren't entirely unfamiliar territory.

The door of the first examination room was firmly locked; she tried the handle and found it wouldn't turn, so she immediately ran toward the next room, whose door stood half-open—it was a heavy sliding door sheathed in a steel panel. The moment she got a clear look at it, she cursed under her breath and kept running.

Fortunately, the next examination room wasn't far, and its door hadn't been shut all the way either, leaving a gap; she gave it a quick push, only to find it wouldn't budge more than a fist's width, as though something was jamming it.

"Why didn't you go into that last room?" Jonah's voice asked.

Mai Minghe's heart skipped a beat.

She slowly raised her head and followed the sound, and there, wedged in the angle where the ceiling met the wall, she saw a human face hanging upside down.

Of course—Jonah had climbed the walls before. He had crawled along them to get here; no wonder she hadn't heard any footsteps.

Jonah's abdomen faced the ceiling, his hands and feet clinging firmly to the plastered wall like some enormous insect. She had no idea when he had gotten above her, nor how he was managing not to fall.

His neck bent downward, his eyeballs drooping, fixed on Mai Minghe with a wide expanse of white showing—Jonah at this moment reminded her of a certain kind of doll whose eyes open and close with gravity, the kind that always made her feel, whenever she held one, as though she were holding a living thing pretending to be lifeless.

She also understood now why the door wouldn't open.

One of Jonah's hands wasn't gripping the ceiling at all—it was thrust into the gap in the door, clamped firmly around one corner of the panel so she could neither push nor pull it.

"Don't be in such a hurry—just wait a little longer,"

Just as the question surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind, Jonah opened his mouth; his upper teeth, upside-down, flickered in and out between his lips. "My child is almost here. Reaching full maturity still depends on you."

What child?

Mai Minghe stepped back sharply from Jonah, then quickly cast a glance down the depth of the corridor.

What came around from behind the corner was a very small shadow. Had it not been crawling toward her with a faint rustling sound, Mai Minghe might never have thought it was alive.

At first glance it looked like a ball, or a crumpled plastic bag; but within a few seconds she could see it clearly—it was roughly the size of two fists, a wrinkled mass of pinkish flesh, and along both its sides, numerous slender legs were moving in rapid alternation, blurring into a smear of shadow.

What on earth was that thing?

The thought had barely crossed her mind when she felt a sudden chill on both her cheeks; two hands dropped down from the ceiling, fingers like iron claws, locking around her skull.

Mai Minghe jolted in fright and struggled with everything she had, fists pounding up against those arms again and again, each blow landing with a dull thud against hard muscle—but it didn't loosen the grip by a fraction. The two male hands pressed deep into her cheeks, seized her jaw, and forced her mouth open.

The wrinkled pink ball of flesh seemed to grow suddenly excited, crawling faster, several tentacle-like legs climbing up along her pajama pants.

Never before had she wished so badly to have a weapon in her hands—anything at all, even a length of pipe would do; but she had spent the first half of this night as a bedridden old woman, and aside from the clothes on her body, she was completely empty-handed.

"Don't be afraid," Jonah's voice soothed. "Look—am I not perfectly fine right now? As long as memory endures, a person isn't really dead. After I entered Jonah, his memories as 'Jonah' are still continuing, which means 'Jonah' is still alive... there's simply one more symbiote, that's all."

No wonder the round-headed one's blood had been useless against him—because the blood had been smeared on Jonah's body, not on the Resident's true self.

Mai Minghe flailed and swept her hands frantically across herself, trying to knock the thing off, but the flesh-ball moved like a nimble cockroach—its legs scuttling lightly and swiftly, darting away from her palms again and again, pressing ever forward toward her head.

"You could try covering your mouth the way Jonah did at the time," said the Jonah above her head.

What kind of advice was that—utterly insincere?

Now that he had said it, she honestly didn't know whether she should cover her mouth or not—or was that precisely the effect he was going for?

Mai Minghe truly regretted pressing the bell four times; since falling out of the hospital bed, she had lurched from one danger to the next, each situation more unpleasant than the last.

In that moment of hesitation, the thing had already crawled up to her chest, and up close it looked more and more like some hybrid of a brain and an insect—a raw, icy smell rose from her chest, five or six thin legs stepped across her collarbone, and an ugly, slick, wrinkled thing, its folds of skin layered over one another, appeared in Mai Minghe's field of vision.

Mai Minghe suppressed the instinct to raise her hands, twisting her head desperately to dodge, and rapidly pulled off her outer robe—the older you got the colder you felt, and she was no

exception; she slept in several layers, and the outermost one had its buttons undone, so she could yank it off in one go.

Two long, slender legs had already crept into her mouth—revolting, and maddeningly itchy.

Mai Minghe forced her gaze upward, fixed on her target, swung her arm, and with a sharp crack lashed her robe across Jonah's eyes with all her strength.

If he was using a human body, surely he couldn't escape the limitations of human physiology?

Who could stay perfectly still and composed after taking a hit straight to the eyeball?

Sure enough, Jonah let out an involuntary cry of pain, and the hands gripping Mai Minghe loosened slightly.

The moment she felt the hold slacken, she immediately bent low, pulling her head free from Jonah's reach; at the same time, Mai Minghe wrapped her hand in the robe and grabbed the thing that had been crawling into her mouth, pulling it out.

Thank goodness the skeletal patient had already wrung her dry of anything to vomit, because if she hadn't been, the sight of that squirming ball of flesh thrashing its limbs right in front of her face would have made her retch all over again.

Mai Minghe wrapped it in the robe, gripped it in her hand despite the revulsion, and ran.

She couldn't afford to be choosy this time; when she realized she had run back to the steel-paneled sliding door, Mai Minghe suddenly had an idea. She charged inside, immediately spun around by the door, and sure enough saw Jonah on the ceiling, eyes half-narrowed and blood-red, crawling rapidly toward her with his face twisted in fury.

"You slippery old woman—"

Mai Minghe kept her face expressionless and pulled the door with one hand.

These Residents.

"I told you, I'm not an old woman," she said quietly, and tossed the ball of flesh to the ground, landing it right on the sliding track. She pulled hard on the door, and it pressed down onto the flesh-ball.

Jonah's scream sounded as though it might tear his throat apart: "No, wait!"

The heavy sliding door, made of lead sheathed in steel plate, came crashing down on the wrinkled flesh-ball just as it hit the floor, before it could steady itself. Without so much as a cry, it was crushed and burst open, blood and shredded flesh spattering in all directions—in an instant, all that remained between the door and the wall was the largest fragment, a flat piece of flesh, its thin legs still twitching.

Before she could kick the remains aside and shut the door all the way, a hand covered in bulging veins slammed against the door frame with a crack.

Through the gap in the door, half of Jonah's face barely looked human anymore; his nostrils flared open and snapped shut like a pair of bellows that had opened on his face.

"My child!" he shrieked.

Mai Minghe braced against the door with all her strength, not daring to let him wrench it open and come through, while at the same time she swept a quick glance around the dim interior, then couldn't help letting out a quiet, resigned sigh.

Just as she had expected, this room was a medical imaging room.

Rooms for X-ray scanning required radiation shielding on the doors and walls, and few hospitals would install windows in an X-ray room—not because special shielded windows didn't exist, but because they were expensive and not cost-effective—which meant that once you were chased into an X-ray room, you were a turtle in a jar with no way out.

That was also why Mai Minghe had passed this door without entering the first time: if she went into an ordinary examination room and locked the door, she could still escape through a window, but in an X-ray room that would be impossible.

"Does something like you really need to pass on offspring?" Mai Minghe said through gritted teeth, still straining against the door. "This is the Nest—you don't need to go in for ecological reproduction here, do you?"

"Once I've killed you," Jonah's words came out in a wet, rasping hiss, as though each syllable was sticking to the next. "Your corpse will dissolve in the Nest, and from your constituent units, I will rebuild my child..."

"You mean, using my flesh and blood to rebuild your child?"

Mai Minghe leaned against the wall with her whole body braced against the door, muscles trembling, still unable to force it completely shut. She scanned the room for anything that might

serve as a weapon while buying time with conversation: "My flesh and blood probably aren't disgusting enough to make one."

Jonah suddenly burst out laughing.

"Flesh and blood? I don't want your withered old flesh and blood at all! As long as you have ever given thought to the matter of 'reproduction,' your mind and body have already been marked. The you who once considered 'reproduction' is still a part of who you are today, and as long as I can obtain that part—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She hadn't expected that, here and now, she would be pulled back into memories from years ago: the anxiety over her day-by-day declining fertility, the confusion over what choice to make, the unease about the prospect of old age...

Without realizing it, her grip loosened slightly.

Jonah caught it.

The sliding door was shoved open with a sudden, forceful push—she had barely startled when a red-haired head poked through the gap.

Digging a saved draft chapter out of my iPad, I've scraped by another day—it feels just like finding a thousand yuan in the pocket of a winter coat!

Chapter 20 — Mai Minghe and the Jonah Who Begged for Help

The shock hit Mai Minghe like a thousand volts crackling through her body all at once; she threw every ounce of strength she had into pushing the door forward—and she was fast enough that the sliding door clamped tight around Jonah's neck just before he could squeeze himself through.

If she could simply choke him out that way, things would have been simple.

Unfortunately, the door was pressing against the side of his neck, over the carotid artery—enough to flush his face deep red and make his breathing labored, but not enough to crush his windpipe fatally; as long as he could still breathe, he still had strength, and one hand hooked around the door's edge as he shoved hard back toward Mai Minghe.

The man could even talk.

"Did you know?"

His breath was ragged, but his words came out clear and complete: "...Anyone who lingers in the Nest for more than seven days, or who dies within it, is not merely broken down in body—their mind, their memories, their emotions, their experiences, even a single passing thought, are all dismantled piece by piece and transformed into other forms, becoming part of the Nest. You've lived a long life, haven't you? Quite a few experiences. And no shortage of wicked thoughts too, I'd wager. When you die here, I wonder what extraordinary things will emerge... People who die in the Nest at seventy or eighty years old are very rare indeed."

She half understood, and half did not.

After death, emotions, memories, and experiences would all become part of the Nest? What did "part of it" mean—would her own memories each become a Resident?

As if he had heard her thoughts, Jonah laughed, his breath hoarse: "What things will come walking out from eighty-six years of a life... I'm so looking forward to it."

Was this speech of Jonah's meant to shake her again, the way it had before?

Mai Minghe braced against the door with everything she had, teeth clenched, thinking: then he had miscalculated.

"Is it because Jonah always has to train new people that you can't help trying to enlighten me too?"

Even as her muscles trembled and her whole body shook, she still had no trouble finding words; she said, her voice quivering: "You live inside someone's body like a roundworm in an intestine—you have no experience of human life. What person makes it through this life without setbacks and hardship? But the thing is, life always finds a moment you least expect to offer you a little light and warmth.

"Even if you kill me here today and use me as raw material to produce a Resident, I won't be in pain, and I won't be angry. I didn't have many days left to begin with—lying in bed day after day, like a dried-up husk. The best of it has been gone forever. But before my life ended, I got to be young again, to live again, and to die in the image of myself as I was in my memories—who could be lucky enough for that? This is the gentleness Heaven has given me. I'm quite happy about it."

"Shut up!" Jonah couldn't get a word in, and he let out a hoarse shout: "Shut up!"

"When a person gets older, they can't help rambling a bit—once they start talking, they just can't stop."

Jonah seemed actually furious; he led by example and shut his own mouth first, pressing his lips into a tight line; a person and a disembodied head then engaged in a silent reverse tug-of-war for a while, accompanied only by each other's heavy, labored breathing.

Mai Minghe, true to form, could not hold herself back, and spoke again.

"You've burrowed into Jonah's body—doesn't that mean he has no independent will left at all? Hey, young man, are you still in there? Get a handle on that brain-worm of yours—this can't go on."

Jonah's face had long since burst into patches of broken capillaries from the pressure, covered in large, vivid blood spots all across his skin, like a swollen purple grape—yet he seemed entirely unbothered, showing no reaction to Mai Minghe's words at all, and kept pulling at the door.

People were dangerous when they went down a dead end, but it turned out that something that wasn't a person, going down a dead end, was just as hard to deal with...

Mai Minghe knew her own physical strength was no match for Jonah's.

Even if she had recovered her youth and regained a strong body, that was only in comparison to her eighty-six-year-old self; Jonah was powerfully built and had routinely walked the line

between life and death, and the two of them had never been on the same level to begin with—and what was more, the elderly had poor appetites, and in the day before she fell into the Nest she had eaten only a few crackers and a little egg, all of which she had vomited back up, and now, looking at the mutilated remains of the "child" on the floor, she was actually beginning to feel a faint twinge of hunger.

That she had managed to hold on this long was purely due to the advantage of her position; if the stalemate continued, she was bound to lose sooner or later.

Mai Minghe glanced once more at the remains of the "child" on the floor and suddenly sucked a sharp breath through her teeth: "Hm?"

The flicker of startled suspicion was enough to involuntarily slacken her grip.

Jonah reacted at once, and sure enough followed her gaze, glancing downward—Mai Minghe had been waiting for exactly this moment; she immediately seized the chance, threw her full body weight behind the door, and slammed it forward with all she had; a dry, cracked screech tore out from between the door and the wall, as if a frail, crumbling rubber tube had been caught in the gap.

"A child's trick, and it actually got you to look down," Mai Minghe said—though inside, she cursed under her breath.

She had hoped that while Jonah looked down, she would have a chance to slam the door shut completely.

Now, of course, the situation was hardly any different from before, and there was no telling how much longer the stalemate would drag on.

Air passed in and out of Jonah's throat in fitful, broken intervals, as though each breath was harder than the last.

Had it caught on his windpipe?

Because he had turned his head, she couldn't quite tell from her angle.

"I... I..." Jonah's face was to the wall, and his voice came out muffled and hoarse—less like speech, more like a balloon slowly leaking air. "I'm... a Hunter with Morgan House Faction..."

Now of all times, he was still bothering to introduce himself?

The doubt had barely formed in Mai Minghe's mind before a sense that something was different came over her; she kept listening.

"My name is Jonah Janko... This is already my fifth day in the Nest..." he said with great difficulty. "I beg you... go to Morgan House... ask for rescue..."

A layer of goosebumps prickled softly across Mai Minghe's skin.

Whether it was because the door had caught something critical and temporarily severed the Resident's control, she couldn't say—but the one speaking to her now was not the Nest's Resident bent on killing her, but Jonah, a Hunter from Blackmoor City, begging for his life.

"Where are your companions?" Speaking was a strain for Mai Minghe too at this moment. "Can't you call them here? You can see my situation—I can barely keep myself alive."

Her limbs had long since begun going weak in waves; all she could do was keep telling herself "one more second," and when that second passed, "one more second," and that was how she had held on until now.

"Get out of the Nest... get out now..." Jonah was still speaking in broken fragments.

"I can't get out," Mai Minghe cut him off. "Can you keep control of your body and stop the Resident from coming after me? From here to the exit of the Nest is still a long way—"

"No, no... it lied to you."

Mai Minghe snapped her mouth shut, and her teeth clicked together with the force of it.

"However the passage brought you here... is how you go back..." Two rattling clicks came from Jonah's throat, and then silence.

Just as Mai Minghe's heart clenched and she thought the Resident had wrested back control, he spoke again without warning: "Fell in through the television... the television... go back that way. You've already passed through the passage once, so when you see it again, you'll feel it..."

"But the moment I let go, the Resident will regain control of you, won't it?" Mai Minghe couldn't fully conceal her agitation. "Never mind that I might not even make it out—even if I could run, I don't know if I'd find the tele— before it catches me—"

The word "vision" lodged itself in her throat, unfinished.

Her gaze came to rest on the far end of the room.

After a few seconds, Mai Minghe asked in a low voice: "When I see the passage, I'll know that's what it is—is that what you mean?"

Jonah's throat hissed faintly, as though he could no longer answer her.

Mai Minghe couldn't help swallowing, her heartbeat loud enough to hear inside her own ears.

In the dimness, she could just barely make out, at the far end of the room, a small door.

Although the medical imaging room had no outward-facing windows, a small room had been partitioned off inside it, and that door led to the small room; beside the door was a glass window facing directly toward the X-ray machine.

When she had been searching for a weapon, she had only looked at what was close at hand, so she had noticed the small door and the glass window without thinking anything of them; but now she suddenly realized something—when she used to go for X-rays, the doctor would always sit in that little room.

Why sit in there?

Because the doctor had to operate the equipment and view the images.

From the edge of the window, she could now make out the shadow of half a computer screen; with no light, everything was blurry and indistinct, and if one hadn't specifically looked for it, one might not have registered it as a screen at all.

The screen was used for viewing medical images and was quite large—and the feeling she'd had back then, lying in the bed and desperate to get to the television, suddenly ignited inside Mai Minghe like a wildfire, burning brighter and brighter.

Could it be that her passage was not a television set, but simply a "screen"?

But then—when she had passed the nurses' station and seen the computer screen on the counter, why had she felt nothing?

That question didn't matter right now, and this was not the time to think about it.

"Hey, Jonah?" Mai Minghe called out. She wanted to confirm her guess with him, but from Jonah's throat came only a low, wet gurgling.

"How am I supposed to find Morgan House Faction? Do you have... do you have their phone number?"

You wouldn't find a Hunter faction in the Yellow Pages, would you—oh, right, there were no Yellow Pages anymore. People in the old days had worried about no one being able to find them, so they'd list their home numbers in the public phone directory; people nowadays were exactly the opposite, as if what they feared most was something called "a privacy breach."

The world had changed.

How was she supposed to find "Morgan House Faction"? Would it be on a smartphone? She couldn't let a perfectly good young man be done in by some rotten worm.

But Mai Minghe called out to him a few more times, and Jonah gave no response whatsoever.

She looked at the screen in the small room, and inside her chest the wildfire burned.

If her guess was wrong and she made a dash for the small room only to find she couldn't return to Blackmoor City, that would certainly mean death; but if the stalemate dragged on indefinitely, death was just as inevitable.

Since danger lay on either path, she might as well act.

Mai Minghe took a long, deep breath, and lowered the foot she had been bracing against the door.

She let go; the moment the pressure on the door eased, the Resident snapped awake. At the very instant Jonah's shoulder forced the sliding door open, Mai Minghe took a step and broke into a run toward the small room.

Today is another day I find myself on a plane; by my estimate I'll have to fly at least three more times in the next two weeks—all the major airlines are popping champagne right now, except for China Eastern.

Just seeing the words "China Eastern" when I'm booking tickets is enough to make me feel unwell—I have to scroll past it immediately. There's a saying that people won't remember what you said or what you did, but they'll always remember the way you made them feel. That's exactly how it is with China Eastern and me—I've long since forgotten what it was that disgusted me in the first place, but that disgust has weathered the passage of time and stands unyielding to this day. The mere thought of China Eastern can make me motion-sick sitting on the toilet, so I'd rather take a Southern Airlines flight that doesn't arrive until eleven at night than give a single cent to an afternoon China Eastern flight.

Chapter 21 — How Can You Tell If I'm Making Excuses?

Friends, grandmas, extraterrestrials — honestly, I don't know myself whether this counts as a fake excuse note or not.

Grandma, put the shoe down first, let me explain for a moment, and then see if you can hold back from swatting me like a cockroach.

I was originally supposed to fly out yesterday. I checked the weather in the morning, Shanghai was clear and sunny, I was pretty happy about it — trotted off to Pudong Airport, figured I could sneak in some writing in a quiet corner while waiting to board. Had it all planned out; I was even willing to buy a lounge pass just to get some updates done.

After all that hassle getting there, I took out my phone and looked — well, would you believe it, the flight was cancelled.

Apparently all of Guangdong was under an orange weather alert — thunderstorms — which just goes to show how warmly my home province welcomes me back.

But I couldn't just strand myself in Shanghai forever, I still had to leave — so I immediately applied to rebook. The rebooking alone took a goddamn two hours, during which there were all sorts of phone calls, checking flight information... After two hours, I successfully got rebooked onto a 9:30 PM flight that same night — except it departed from Hongqiao Airport.

Fine. Off to Hongqiao.

Every DiDi driver in Shanghai must have me enshrined on their dashboard or something.

I got to Hongqiao Airport and looked at the departures board — there was an extra line of text. Above "Scheduled departure 21:35," a new line had appeared: "Estimated departure 23:35" — I ask you, is that how human beings communicate? What is this, a competition to see who knows the most synonyms? I already had a bad feeling at that point. After all, Guangdong's rainstorms don't play favorites. What was I supposed to do — I couldn't just sit in the airport waiting to see when the plane might eventually decide to fly. I'd better book a hotel.

It's not like I'm staying overnight anyway, cheapest one will do, maybe in a few hours I'll be on my way. I thought naively.

So I dragged my luggage into a cab and got ferried to a place that looked less like Shanghai and more like a county town. Got out of the car. It really was close to the airport — a jumbo jet thundered so low over my head it nearly blew my wig off (going so hard on the writing that I started losing hair at eighteen). I took a few pictures of the planes while I was at it. Couldn't come all this way for nothing.

Checked in, walked into the room, walked right back out — why? To go buy disposable toilet seat covers. That toilet seat was yellowed like old braised stock — one look and you knew it had been marinating in ancient piss for years.

Right. This is the hotel that still costs over three hundred yuan at the cheapest. I am indeed in Shanghai.

Well, would you believe it — the universe heard me say "not staying overnight." The second flight was delayed too. Delayed until five in the morning.

Even owls can't pull an all-nighter like that!!!

I rebooked a second time, to eleven o'clock this morning.

And then I just stood there in that hotel room, holding my bag, trapped and miserable, realizing I really was going to have to spend the night here. If I'd known it would come to this, why didn't I book somewhere decent? The heavens are out to get me. First I put the door chain on (I never normally bother with that), then I pulled back the duvet and inspected the sheets — the sheets were okay, at least they looked white.

By this point I'd been through the wringer and it was already evening. Having typed not a single word but feeling utterly drained in body and soul, I reached down to feel the mattress.

...Where is my mattress?

These individual springs, poking me one by one — what are they made of, diamonds? Don't mattresses usually have some kind of padding on top? Where's the padding?? I could feel every single spring through the sheet, like I was taking its pulse — WHERE IS MY PADDING?!?!?

I honestly felt like crying right then. You want to know how I slept that night? I spread the duvet back out flat and used it as a mattress. Lying on top of the duvet, the sensation was exactly like lying on a sidewalk.

Then I pulled one end of the duvet out, wrapped it around myself from the side, and made myself into a stuffed flatbread. That way I had both a mattress and a blanket at once — one item,

two functions — and only then could I actually sleep.

By this point I had typed all of three hundred words and was completely spent. I closed my eyes somewhere after nine. Going to bed that early was a form of disrespect toward the neighbors next door.

So around past ten o'clock, I heard it. You might think the sounds in a hotel are more or less the same few things. You'd be wrong.

I heard a pair of high heels going click-clack-click-clack down the hallway — at least twenty laps of it (no carpet) — then the door slammed, one loud bang, and whoever it was went inside. After that, someone began moving furniture.

Half-asleep, I was lying there thinking even in my dreams: how are you moving the furniture? The tables and beds in hotels are all bolted to the goddamn floor — so what on earth is that heavy thing scraping across the floor???

And why did it go on for half an hour?! Are you renovating the hotel??

What is everyone in this place here for???

Anyway, long story short, I made it through the night. Once I post this little account of the situation, I'll have to pack up all my bags again and head to the airport. I'm exhausted, worn out, and half-convinced I smell terrible (didn't dare shower here)··· Estimated landing time is around two in the afternoon. If the flight actually lands on time, there might be an update tonight. If there's another delay, I'm going to go jump in the Huangpu River.

After everything I went through on this trip to Shanghai — you think I'm done once I get home?

No. Business isn't finished. I have to come back again on the 8th, after the holiday.

Wonderful. I'm clearly here to build character and experience life to the fullest.

Chapter 22: Sydney Ginn, After Life and Death

They say that at the moment of death, a lifetime of memories passes before your eyes like a revolving lantern; Sydney Ginn now knew that this was neither entirely right nor entirely wrong.

She lay on the cold floor of the exhibition hall, and yet she felt like a small boat adrift—the ropes that had bound her to the world of the living had come loose, and she was slowly drifting out onto a river thick with fog.

Sometimes the fog thinned and parted, revealing the scene of her first arrival in Blackmoor City; back then she had split the rent on a semi-basement apartment, and looking out the living room window at the street, all she could see were passing shoes and trouser hems.

Sometimes she saw the client from her very first transaction, turning an Artifact over and over under a desk lamp, the light falling into their eyes and rendering both their pupils and their suspicion half-transparent.

The experiences closest to her—opening the passage, attracting a stalker, being killed—felt more like things that had happened to someone else, flat and bleached-out descriptions that the fog swallowed whole. The distant, long-ago moments were more vivid: carrying out the scallion-and-meat pie her mother had baked, going over to a classmate's house every week in seventh grade... open the door, walk inside, and she could go home.

Drawn along by those faraway memories, Sydney Ginn drifted further away; the faint, desperate rattling in her injured throat grew harder and harder to hear.

Her head lay submerged in a pool of blood, which spread out around her like a river of the dead.

"Go ahead and die," a voice floated from somewhere above, whispering in a hissing, leaking sort of way.

And yet it was this send-off that called Sydney Ginn partway back.

...How did it come to this?

She had called the taxi, paid the fare, followed every instruction to the letter without daring to step out of line, and had a stiff neck to show for it by the time she got off.

She had pretended not to see the female Resident crawling out of the elevator on her right, fought her way into the ground-floor exhibition hall with great difficulty, and held her breath in tense, coiled readiness the entire time...

She had done everything, done it all, and still ended up like this. How could she not be furious.

A dark figure stooped down, apparently kneeling on the floor, studying her face.

Sydney Ginn could no longer make out details; all she saw were blurry silhouettes: a rounder shape was a skull, connected below it was a neck, and jutting out from that neck was another dark shape—the hunting knife she had driven into the other's throat.

As the figure opened its mouth to speak, the knife buried deep in its neck trembled gently up and down with each word. The blade had cut through its windpipe, and between syllables it leaked air with a hiss: "...I really should thank you—you've reminded me what it was I forgot. It was the hiking backpack."

Even though Sydney Ginn still had thoughts, none of them showed on her face. Blood had stained her neck a black-red, as though her throat had been erased; her body had gone still, utterly motionless.

When she had leapt onto the first taxi, she must have accidentally stepped on the "Copied" square.

She still remembered the moment she lifted her foot—someone had given the hiking pack on her back a sudden violent yank, nearly sending her tumbling backwards; when Sydney Ginn caught herself and turned around, she was looking at her own face—no distortion of any kind, the features smooth and fine, like looking in a mirror.

She had frozen.

"When did you copy yourself into me?" that other "Sydney Ginn" demanded, glaring at her and getting in the first word. It seemed to want to shove her, but wasn't quite brave enough to make contact, and snapped: "Get away from me!"

So the square labeled "Copied" really just meant she would be copied, and nothing else?

That actually made sense—copying something didn't necessarily mean the original would be damaged...

Apart from the existence of a copy, Sydney Ginn felt, going over herself from head to toe, that nothing was wrong; if there was one thing that made her most uneasy, it was this—"Sydney Ginn" seemed to have inherited both her body and her mind simultaneously, and was now utterly convinced that it was the real one.

...Then how could she be certain, one hundred percent, that she wasn't the Resident? She, too, was absolutely sure she was the real Sydney Ginn.

No—no, that was impossible; the one in front of her was the Resident, and it was about to take her place and go to the Museum of Modern Art.

There was one key piece of evidence that proved she was the real Sydney Ginn—the backpack, the hunting knife, and her phone were all still on her, none of them copied into a second set; the other one had nothing on her, not a single thing.

"At the time, my mind was entirely on how to jump onto the taxi, so I forgot to take the hiking backpack. I was standing in the square the whole time—it was too heavy to keep on my back, so I'd set it down on top of my feet..."

The dark figure hovering before her, shaped like a human face, went on leaking air: "What happened afterward that made me fail to pick up the backpack—that I forgot, because I handed that stretch of memory over to the driver."

Even at this point, "Sydney Ginn" apparently still did not believe it was the Resident.

It paused there, as though something had occurred to it: "I'd actually meant to ask you—Passenger Rule number four: can you lift your head once the fare is paid? But you're a Resident; you don't follow the Passenger Rules, so what could the consequences possibly be... never mind, it doesn't matter. I made it off the taxi just fine either way. I didn't expect you to bring my things to me, though."

...How could she not be furious.

At the time she had not dared to keep fighting with "Sydney Ginn," afraid of stepping into some punishment square; so she had called another taxi, paid the fare with memories, rode the whole way with her head bowed, following behind "Sydney Ginn," and got off at the Museum of Modern Art.

Whatever it did, she did the same, until she finally followed it into the underground exhibition hall, seized her moment, and drove the hunting knife deep into its throat.

Sydney Ginn had heard that Residents couldn't be killed. Even if they died for a moment, they could regenerate somewhere else.

But Residents were bound by rules that went beyond life and death, so an attack could still have some kind of effect—what she hadn't anticipated was that driving a knife into a Resident's throat would only result in a leaking windpipe.

She had let go of the knife handle in a daze, staring at "Sydney Ginn."

When it tried to spit, nothing came out of its mouth, which gaped like a dried-up black hole; now with the knife buried in its neck, it only hissed and leaked air, unable to bleed.

The other stood motionless, its eyes rolling down to look at the hunting knife, then lifting back up to look at her.

For a second or two, neither of them moved.

"Sydney Ginn" slowly spread her familiar teeth at her in a grin. She had brushed every single one of them countless times, studied their color and shape in the mirror until she knew them at a glance—and yet here they were, in someone else's mouth.

...Disgusting.

"My neck has been stabbed with a knife," the Resident said, matter-of-factly, after that second or two. "Since you copied yourself into my likeness, your neck should be pierced as well."

The moment those words were spoken, Sydney Ginn's neck opened its mouth.

...Why? How could this be?

So this was how cold the outside world was; when the blood vessels and muscle were torn open in one stroke, it was like ice water being poured in along the wound—and the pain came only belatedly, trailing behind.

The sudden cold at her throat was instantly swamped by the scalding spatter of blood that splashed across the face of her "self" opposite her—Sydney Ginn pressed one hand hard against her gaping throat, instinctively trying to clamp the wound shut again, but blood kept bubbling up through her fingers.

With her consciousness shattering at the edge of death, she crumpled to the ground.

Her eyelids froze half-open, half-closed, and her soul drifted into the deep, dense fog.

Sydney Ginn forced down the crawling dread that raised every hair on her body, pressed one hand tight against her neck, and seized the hunting knife's handle with the other.

Her palms were slick with cold sweat; her legs had gone so weak she couldn't stand, and she could only slowly slide down until she was sitting on the floor. A few steps away, the corpse that looked exactly like her lay on the ground, its eyelids half-open, the pupils beneath already clouded over like a dead fish's.

"Sydney Ginn" hadn't driven the blade deep enough, and had missed the critical structures—perhaps the one small mercy in all of this.

She knew very well that when a blade penetrated the body, pulling it out would only deepen the wound and cause heavy bleeding; the first rule of first aid was "do not remove anything from a wound." Sometimes a blade lodged in the body could temporarily act as a plug, sealing the wound and reducing blood loss.

The reason "Sydney Ginn" had died from the same injury while she herself was still alive was almost certainly due to that one crucial difference—the hunting knife stanching the bleeding. So Residents weren't unkillable after all, at least not the "Vulture" kind.

The logic of killing it was just a bit convoluted: you had to let it copy itself into a second version of you first, then, after you received a fatal wound, remind it to copy the fatal wound onto itself—only then would it die.

Even a wound that merely looked fatal would do.

Even though she knew she wasn't going to die, having a knife lodged in her throat was a torment to every nerve in her body; and besides, she couldn't call an ambulance in the Nest, couldn't go to an emergency room, and certainly couldn't climb all the way to the top of a high-rise and jump off with a knife in her neck just to get back to Blackmoor City for medical treatment...

She would have to handle it herself.

She dug a spare T-shirt out of her backpack and wrapped it tightly around her neck and the knife, winding it so tight she kept seeing stars and gasping for breath. She felt along the skin for the knife tip, located it with her fingertips, and got ready—the moment the knife was pulled out, she would press down on the wound immediately; she couldn't risk a major hemorrhage.

Sydney Ginn knew the Nest was dangerous, and had no doubt given herself first aid more than a few times; but even with her self-taught basic first aid knowledge and her well-stocked pack, this kind of injury was truly beyond anything she had imagined.

Even she herself didn't know how she had managed to stop the hemorrhage and then clumsily sutured the knife wound closed—it was nothing short of a miracle.

Despite the successful "surgery," Sydney Ginn couldn't hold on any longer and lost consciousness for a while.

When she came to, the underground exhibition hall was still perfectly silent; she and the stiffened corpse of her dead self lay slumped on either side of the enormous candle, and if she cocked her ear to listen, the place felt like a tomb.

Sydney Ginn rested for a long while before she slowly climbed to her feet.

The serious injury, the lingering fear, and the exhaustion made her want nothing more than to go home, to curl up under her covers, breathing in the familiar scent of jasmine laundry detergent, and sink into a long, deep sleep.

But it wasn't time yet.

Sydney Ginn was also quietly astonished; she hadn't expected that, faced with an Artifact, she would show a toughness that seemed beyond ordinary human limits. With a knife wound to the throat, how could an ordinary person survive?

She walked step by step to the candle, hesitated for a moment, and placed her hand against its surface.

A small line of text immediately floated up beside her palm: 2009.4.22.

...So the history encoded at this position corresponded to April 22nd, 2009?

She was currently standing several meters below the top of the candle. Why did this particular spot represent April 22nd, 2009?

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment, walked to the very top of the candle, and reached out to touch it—and sure enough, she saw her own birthday: 1998.9.29.

So that was it... her gaze followed the length of the candle downward.

That meant the flow of time encapsulated within the candle ran from the day she was born all the way to the present day while she was still alive; the candle held no future.

Because the future was chaos, unfixed—and therefore could not be foreseen?

Though her greedy hope of glimpsing the future had come to nothing, which was a little disappointing, looking at it from another angle it was a strange kind of comfort: since fate was not already written, she could still choose what to do and where to go. A person wasn't a small insect sealed inside a transparent cage, every possible path already defined.

In this bewildering, disorienting world, a person still had this small measure of control over themselves.

Of course, Sydney Ginn wasn't arrogant enough to think the Nest had custom-built this Artifact especially for her—whoever touched the candle, it should show history beginning from that person's date of birth.

She walked on a little further and, judging the distance by feel, placed her hand on the candle again to search.

2026.5.2. She found without difficulty the moment she had first encountered the stalker Anthony.

Sydney Ginn had an idea.

She crouched down and found an ignition switch beneath the metal trough. With a *click*, flames ignited beneath the candle's base.

She wanted to try—to snuff this whole thing out before it could begin.

All the sleep debt I'd racked up from the exhausting scramble of recent days came knocking the moment I finally got back... No matter how much coffee I drank, I was drowsy from the moment I opened my eyes in the morning until I fell into bed at night... By eight o'clock I simply couldn't take it anymore and had to sleep...

Chapter 23 – Sydney Ginn: If the Mountain Won't Come to You

The exhibition hall was as dead-still as a cave, broken only by the soft crackling of the flame.

Sydney Ginn's nerves were strung as tight as a bowstring; every little crack of the flame was like a finger plucking that string.

She had read through the long description of the Artifact "Candlefall" in full, and stood there turning it over in her mind for a good while before she could consider it even halfway digested.

She walked another circuit around the underground exhibition hall, making sure nothing lurked in the corners and shadows ready to launch a second attack—being attacked by herself once was already more than enough.

When she passed the corpse, she quickened her pace to move past, then suddenly stopped and turned back.

The corpse of her dead self always made Sydney Ginn feel deeply unsettled.

She had no wish to look at it, and even less to be looked at by it, so she simply covered its face with a towel, smothering that accusatory, scrutinizing gaze her own eyes had fixed on her, and only then returned to the candle.

Using a small flame to heat such an enormous candle naturally took a good deal of effort.

She had completed a full circuit of the exhibition hall before the candle had at last melted enough to proceed to the next step: the section of wax representing early May 2026 was beginning to soften and slacken from the bottom up, drooping heavily toward the floor like a belly swollen with child—except that the "belly" was gradually turning translucent, dark shapes drifting and shifting slowly within it, as though it were pregnant with a womb full of ghosts.

Sydney Ginn hurried over in a few quick strides, bent down, and peered at the past world showing through the melted wax.

The first thing she saw was herself.

According to the Artifact's description, because she was the one who had touched the candle, what the wax revealed was primarily her own personal history—the reason for "primarily" being that no person can survive apart from their broader environment, so significant events in the world around her that had shaped her would also surface within the wax.

The exact words in the description were as follows:

"...In today's highly integrated world, the historical turning points that carry decisive influence are more often than not caused by a handful of people. The mass movements that occasionally succeeded in the past are now almost impossible to replicate.

"Yet the decisions of a small number of oligarchs can influence and reshape the fate of all humanity. By the same token, when applied to personal history, the candle will faithfully render the key figures and key events that influenced and reshaped the individual's immediate environment."

This passage had seemed somewhat obscure at first reading, but after watching the history in the wax for a while, Sydney Ginn understood.

For instance—why had she come to meet the harasser Anthony in early May?

The most direct cause was that a female friend had invited her out to a bar that night.

Amber was not a Hunter and had no passage, but she worked in finance for the Morgan House Faction and had crossed paths with Sydney Ginn a few times before; the two of them got along well enough. It was that very night, at the bar, that Sydney Ginn had met Anthony—all gilded surface and nothing beneath.

But thinking one step deeper: why had Sydney Ginn, who hated the smell of alcohol most of all, agreed to go to the bar with Amber that day?

Because at the end of April, a regional war that had dragged on for years—exhausting the entire world with inflation and wearing everyone to the bone—had finally ground to a halt after immeasurable bloodshed, ending in what amounted to a farce.

The outcome of the war was far from satisfying to anyone with a sense of justice—no matter which side their sense of justice supported—but after years of tragedies that had repeated themselves until people were nearly numb, the whole world had collectively let out a breath; on the day the war was declared over, there were no shortage of celebratory parades and spontaneous public festivities, and even the news anchors seemed somehow lighter.

Artifact Hunters had one foot in the Nest and one foot in the human world, and their outlook always kept them a few paces removed from worldly affairs; Sydney Ginn was no exception.

But even she had felt those days as if sunlight were falling warm on her skin, her mood as brimming and expansive as the approaching summer—when Amber suggested going out for

drinks to celebrate, Sydney Ginn thought she could always have fruit juice, and agreed without a second thought.

If the war had not ended, Amber would not have invited her to celebrate; without going to the bar, she would never have met Anthony; without him becoming her stalker and harasser, Sydney Ginn would never have entered the Nest, would never have had a knife driven into her throat, would never have been standing beside her own corpse—and would certainly never have found this giant candle.

Everything she had endured today, traced back to its root, had come about because of some bald old man on the other side of the world who had started a war... so how could the people and events closer to her—those that had shaped her—possibly not be enfolded into the candle?

"When you are reshaping what lies within Candlefall, you will find that the greater the physical distance between you and your target, the harder it becomes to alter their past."

Immediately following this, the description for "Candlefall" contained this passage:

"Someone standing right beside you can have their past changed with the utmost ease—simply reach into Candlefall and nudge or mold the wax itself, and you can shift their position, experiences, and actions; the past will change naturally as a result.

"Someone on the other side of the city can still be changed, albeit with difficulty—but you will find that the portion of Candlefall encasing them is somewhat stiff and uncooperative when you try to mold it. Fine details are hard to adjust; at most you can alter a rough outline—and as for how much of a difference that change will actually produce, that is even harder to say.

"And what of someone on the other side of the world? Regrettably, even if such a person appears within your candle, you cannot exert any influence over their past experiences."

That hardly mattered, Sydney Ginn thought, gazing at the still-slightly-hazy scene within the candle. What she wanted to change was about to come out through the bar's back door and step right up beside her.

The wax had turned transparent and become a pool of liquid that hung suspended just above the floor, as though it were a glimmering basin of water floating in midair. She reached out and touched it gently, and found it was not hot.

Reflected in that pool was a night in Blackmoor City blazing with countless lights; leaning closer, Sydney Ginn could even catch the distinct smell of the bar—alcohol, tobacco, and perfume

mingled together.

Within the pool formed by Candlefall, tall buildings, the bar, shops, and streets all looked like tiny miniature models. A figure the size of a fingertip—herself—stood at the bar's back door, gazing up at the starless night sky over Blackmoor City.

Right there.

There was no need to stir the wax and search for the right moment; she only had to wait—in this regard, working with Candlefall was a little like scrubbing through a video's progress bar: she could drag it backward or forward, or let it play forward naturally in time.

She remembered that before meeting Anthony, a motorcade of several black Mercedes SUVs had driven past nearby—every window reinforced against blast—and she had stared long enough to catch herself; shortly after the motorcade passed, the back door of the bar, painted dark red, had—

There it was.

The moment the bar's small back door was pushed open the tiniest crack, Sydney Ginn immediately extended her little finger and pressed its tip firmly against the door from within the Candlefall.

The shortest finger, and yet it was nearly as large as the bar door itself—pressed there against it, the sight was actually strange.

Through the door, Anthony shoved again and again, his force no more than a small insect kicking its legs against her fingertip; but how could someone so tiny within the Candlefall ever push open her enormous fingertip?

She leaned close to the wax and heard, muffled beneath the raucous music behind the door, a curse: "...This damn door—what is wrong with it?"

The tiny Sydney Ginn who had stepped outside the back door for some air paid no attention whatsoever to the enormous finger stretching across the air beside her.

When she heard the cursing from behind the door, she only glanced back briefly, then stepped a few paces away—a competent Blackmoor City resident always kept a certain wariness and cool distance from strangers, let alone a stranger who was cursing.

The would-be harasser behind the door shoved furiously a few more times, then finally gave up, and seemed to turn and walk away; quiet returned behind the door.

That should do it, Sydney Ginn thought, not quite daring to pull her hand back yet, still holding the door shut.

As long as they never met in the first place, none of what followed would ever happen.

The rage and indignation she had originally felt toward Anthony seemed, after witnessing "her own" death, to have been soaked through by a cold shiver, and was no longer as fierce; her first priority now was simply to use the candle to run the experiment—revenge had fallen to second place.

As for what effect changing history would have on the "present," the Artifact's description had offered a detailed explanation:

"...After the point where a change occurs, history will continue to develop naturally according to its own internal logic, and the person's 'present' will shift accordingly.

"There is a time-travel paradox that asks whether a person can go back and kill their own grandfather. Because if the grandfather dies, the person would not exist—but then no one would have gone back to kill the grandfather in the first place... and so a paradox is formed."

When it came to traveling through time and changing the past, it seemed there was always a great deal to explain—whether in film and fiction, or with Nest Artifacts.

"'Candlefall' will not fall into any such paradox. The candle constitutes a fixed segment of time—beginning from the birth of the person who touches it, and ending at the very moment they touch it. Therefore you cannot change the past before your own birth.

"However, changing history through 'Candlefall' will still affect the present. For example: if you melt open the wax for a month ago and crush your past self within it—at the instant of that crushing, you will also vanish from before the candle, and the candle will return to its original state.

"That is an extreme case. If you caused yourself to break your leg a month ago, then naturally, a month later, you would not have met a potential client on the ski slopes—correct? As stated above, history will always move forward according to its own internal logic and produce the consequences that naturally follow."

In other words, if she prevented herself from meeting Anthony that night, Sydney Ginn would also vanish from beside the candle—with no harasser, she would have no reason to enter the Nest; and having never entered the Nest, she would of course not be here now.

"However, to preserve the continuity of the timeline, memories of using 'Candlefall' and altering history will still be retained in full—they will not be lost because you have made changes to history."

In other words... if Sydney Ginn prevented herself from meeting Anthony, she would not be in the Nest today; and yet she would still remember that in the "previous version of history," she had met Anthony, entered the Nest, and altered history.

Retaining the user's memories was enough to preserve the continuity of the timeline? But why?

Sydney Ginn turned it over for a while, arrived at no answer, and let it go. Being able to retain her memories was a great boon; great boons don't hold up to scrutiny, so it was best to simply accept it without question.

Only by keeping her memories could she come back and find "Candlefall" again—and compared to such a precious Artifact, what did the nauseating memories Anthony had brought matter at all?

Within the Candlefall, the tiny Sydney Ginn stamped her feet, turned around, and seemed to be heading back inside the bar.

Sydney Ginn moved her little finger aside and watched that tiny version of herself pull open the door and disappear into the flickering lights and music on the other side.

Good—it was all done. She could extinguish the flame and let the candle solidify once more.

Only when Candlefall had solidified again would it set into the shape of a new time and a new history.

The pool of transparent liquid wax suspended in midair slowly turned white, grew cloudy, rose back up little by little, was drawn back into the body of the candle, and once again became smooth and unblemished—no matter how one looked at it, it was as though it had never melted at all.

Sydney Ginn took one last look at the shrouded corpse not far away, closed her eyes, and waited quietly for the brand-new "this moment" that would come after changing history.

After a little while, she opened her eyes.

She had not returned to Blackmoor City; she was still inside the Nest.

The pool of blood beneath the shrouded corpse had nearly dried to a dark, purplish-black; the candle stretched long and unbroken into the distance; the exhibition hall was utterly silent.

In her mind, the string of memories—being stalked and harassed by Anthony, entering the Nest, being copied by a Resident, melting the candle—were all there, clear and complete, exactly as the Candlefall's description had said: none of them had disappeared.

There was only one difference.

The place where she and Anthony had first met had changed from the back door of the bar to the front door.

These past two days have been absolutely exhausting... I overdid it a while back and still haven't recovered. We're 18 now, not 17 anymore—not as young as we were—and I'm really starting to feel the toll on my body. Sigh.

When you're this tired you can't tell if you're sleepy or just hungry, and you spend the whole day thinking about food, but the moment you eat anything you pass out right after—which only makes things worse... These past two days have really been... rough...

Chapter 24 — Sydney Ginn's Altered History

The wound on her neck had stopped hurting much. Her toughness and resilience truly surpassed her own expectations.

But Sydney Ginn's irritation only grew thicker, like a heart overrun with weeds that couldn't be pulled no matter how hard you tried.

Who would have thought history had such resilience — changing one small detail still couldn't alter the course of events. People always say that sometimes missing one turn can change your entire fate. What a lie.

A stalker, putting on the airs of destiny and fate — just thinking about it was nauseating.

Sydney Ginn glanced at the corpse.

She had killed a Resident for the first time — supposedly one that couldn't be killed — and she'd managed it only by talking her way through it, so she couldn't help feeling uneasy. She was afraid that in the blink of an eye it would stagger back up from the floor again, so every now and then she had to take another look.

But she was worrying too much. Death had already soaked through that body like cold water, fixing it completely in place.

After watching the corpse for a while, she finally relaxed a little and opened the fire trough again.

Time to try once more. This time, Sydney Ginn intended to cut off any possibility of the two meeting right at the root.

She melted the candle for the same window of time, watching the transparent Candle Tears fall and pool mid-air into a lake once more.

In the lake-like Candle Tears, a tiny Sydney Ginn and a tiny Amber stepped out of a miniature taxi together, laughing and talking as they walked into the bar — Sydney Ginn watched them enter through the front door, then shifted her gaze back out to the street, sweeping it up and down.

She clearly remembered that on that night, when the stalker Anthony had approached her, he'd said: "You must have arrived at the bar before me. Otherwise, when a girl like you walked

through that door, there's no way I would have failed to notice."

She couldn't take a pickup line at face value, but thinking back on it afterward, it did seem like Anthony had arrived a step later than she had.

Sydney Ginn pushed down the restlessness in her heart and kept her eyes locked on the bar's front entrance, not daring to look away for a second.

There had been a lot of people going to the bar that night, and in the span of just twenty or thirty minutes, four or five groups of strangers stepped out of several cars in succession — she had never seen so many miniature living people, clustered together in twos and threes, walking through the night under the lights, which made them even harder to make out; she stared until her eyes nearly blurred, and at last she spotted Anthony rounding the corner from down the street.

According to the description, "suicide" via the Candle Tears seemed to be possible — but it said nothing about whether it could kill someone else.

Sydney Ginn decided to try.

What could be more final than turning him into a dead man outright?

She had never been willing to kill lightly. In fact, ever since she had become a Hunter, although she had seen no shortage of dead people, not a single one had actually died by her hand.

But tonight, it was as if something inside her had cracked open, and something not quite the same as before was trying to push its way out.

Come to think of it, she had already killed "herself"; trying to kill someone from the past — a stalker, at that — what was the big deal?

If she couldn't kill him, she would think of something else — whatever the outcome, at least it would count as learning more about what the Candle Tears could do.

Sydney Ginn's finger hovered above Anthony's head, like a massive celestial body about to come crashing down on the earth and crush the dinosaurs.

He was still completely oblivious, hands shoved in his pockets, tall and loose-limbed, looking every bit like a decent man.

...Crushing him to death still meant washing her hands afterward.

Sydney Ginn curled her knuckles and brought them down hard on that carefully styled head.

She had expected the sensation to be something like squashing a large bug, but instead it was like pressing down on a slippery ball; the stalker stumbled, and her forceful strike had only shoved him half a step to the side — he quickly steadied himself, and not only was he still alive, he didn't even seem to feel any pain.

Anthony looked down, muttered a curse, and kicked a pebble away.

...Could it be that she couldn't reach in and kill someone else directly? That the only one she could kill was herself?

That was truly funny.

Despite her frustration, two more attempts seemed to bear out the theory: she tried pushing the miniature Anthony into the road, but an oncoming car swerved in time, leaving him with nothing worse than a few curses from the driver; she managed with great effort to knock a sign light loose, timed it carefully, but it bent in mid-air and crashed to the ground right in front of Anthony's nose.

The stalker was apparently no ordinary person — he brushed past danger several times in a row without anything happening to him, and walked into the bar as if nothing had occurred.

"One of the most powerful Artifacts" — the broadcast was full of hot air. It couldn't kill a person, couldn't prevent a meeting; what was the point of this broken candle containing the past at all?

In the end, wasn't everything exactly as it had been? Nothing had changed at all?

Suppressing her frustration, Sydney Ginn swept through the Candle Tears, searching for herself.

She had already grown quite practiced at working the Candle Tears, and quickly found the moment the two had met: a tiny Anthony pushed open the dark red back door, spotted a tiny Sydney Ginn, walked over to her, and struck up a conversation.

"I didn't have the courage to ask for your number at first — I'm not the type who goes around talking to girls," Anthony said with what seemed like genuine feeling. "But do you know what? On my way here just now, a sign light suddenly crashed right in front of me — this close... if I'd been half a step faster, I would have died. Thinking about how full of surprises life is, I couldn't bear to let this pass..."

She had actually helped him upgrade his material?

Sydney Ginn had played a computer game called The Sims as a child, and now, watching the two of them talk in the Candle Tears, a strange, hazy sense of familiarity came over her, leaving her somewhere between the urge to laugh and the urge to cry.

But this was not a computer game.

Sydney Ginn watched that tiny, oblivious version of herself exchange numbers with Anthony just as she'd expected, and could only sigh inwardly with weary irritation as she closed the fire trough — she needed to let the Candle Tears cool and solidify first, to let this chapter of history "set," and then melt it again before she could change it once more.

The tiny Sydney Ginn — she had lost count of how many times now — pushed open the back door and stepped out of the room thick with tangled music and the smell of alcohol, standing outside to get some air.

A convoy of all-black Mercedes SUVs rose silently out of the night; each vehicle, fitted with anti-terrorism and armored modifications, maintained an equal distance from the others as they passed in succession before the bar's back entrance.

As the last vehicle was about to drive past, Sydney Ginn reached out and flicked it toward the back door — the matchbox-sized SUV was caught by the force, lurched involuntarily, veered off the road, and with a shriek of tires slammed its nose squarely into the bar's back entrance.

The bar's back door, which had not been fully shut to begin with, now had its panel caved in and its hinges twisted by the impact, hanging crookedly at an angle — anyone could see at a glance that it would never close again.

The tiny Sydney Ginn stared at the SUV only two paces away, her face drained of color.

Oh — she had forgotten to protect her past self... Never mind, she hadn't been hit by the car, and alive was good enough.

It wasn't as if she had wanted to get so tangled up with a stalker in the first place — so why was she putting herself through all this trouble? Letting her past self get a good scare was no less than she deserved.

Sydney Ginn watched with a faintly disgusted indifference as that tiny version of herself hurriedly backed away a few steps and called out to no one in particular: "Someone help! There's been a crash!"

If the bar had to temporarily shut down because of this, it might scatter the two before they could meet —

Before Sydney Ginn had even finished the thought, the driver's door of the SUV was shoved open, and a man in a black suit half-tumbled out and quickly swung around behind the wide-open door, dropping into a half-crouch; his left temple had been split open by the impact, and blood, curls, and an over-ear earpiece were all tangled together in a matted mess.

But what stood out most was the 9mm pistol held between his two hands.

Nearby, the tiny Sydney Ginn's gaze landed on that black pistol, and her lips pressed together instantly.

After the vehicle was struck and disabled, his first move was to leap out — so he wouldn't be a sitting duck; he sheltered behind the car door to use it as cover against any potential sniper; even though he had clearly taken a significant blow, that 9mm was still held steadily in a position ready to return fire at any moment, his slightly bent elbow not trembling in the slightest...

Both the Sydney Ginn inside the Candle Tears and the one outside it could see it: this was a personal bodyguard with highly specialized professional training.

Then the other vehicles —

Sydney Ginn turned at once, and sure enough found that the convoy had not wasted a single moment — the other four SUVs had already split off in separate directions, each changing lanes and altering course in an instant before accelerating away, disappearing into the night and lights in every direction.

The level of professionalism here was very high, she thought.

At the exact moment the rear vehicle was struck and lost control, the convoy had immediately abandoned it and broken formation, each turning onto a different route and rapidly increasing the distance between them... this was clearly a contingency plan prepared well in advance.

Such a plan generally has only one purpose: to protect whichever vehicle in the convoy carries an important figure, so potential enemies cannot tell which car that person is actually riding in.

"...No, at present we cannot confirm what was done to the vehicle. Yes, no attacks so far."

The man in the black suit crouched behind the car door, speaking in a low voice into his earpiece: "The situation with the car is strange, but I've detected no signs of Artifact use in the

vicinity... Yes, there's a bar here, and there are witnesses nearby — they've probably already called the police."

Artifact? Had he just said Artifact?

Sydney Ginn's interest sparked immediately, and she leaned in closer — fortunately, the man in the black suit was nothing more than a tiny figure within the Candle Tears, unable to see that floating between heaven and earth above the car was a gigantic human ear, listening to every word he said.

"...Understood," the man in the black suit replied quietly after a few seconds. "In the negotiations and handling that follow, I will not mention Mr. Wellesley's name."

Mr. Wellesley?

Sydney Ginn froze.

An important figure, and surnamed Wellesley... could it be that the person so carefully protected by this convoy was Wellesley himself — Blackmoor City's foremost figure in both wealth and standing?

Wellesley was indeed a person of great status, but he wasn't a head of government; that his security should be this tight clearly meant he knew he was in danger...

Could it be that his death, not long from now, was not from natural causes but something deliberately brought about?

Had he noticed, months in advance, that someone wanted to assassinate him — and that was why he had taken such thorough and careful security measures?

Curious as she was, Sydney Ginn hadn't forgotten her original purpose, and glanced back at the back door.

The crash had drawn all the bar patrons outside — some were watching the spectacle, some were on their phones, and some were taking photos and posting on Twitter; the man in the black suit had a sharp read on the situation and, to avoid causing a scene, had already holstered the 9mm back beneath his jacket — though one hand remained pressed over it, ready to draw at any moment.

Among the crowd of onlookers, the tiny Sydney Ginn and Amber were speaking in low voices; a few steps away, the tiny Anthony was glancing toward them again and again.

Within seconds, he walked over and greeted the tiny Sydney Ginn with a smile.

Unbelievable — was there truly no way to keep herself from running into Anthony?

Sydney Ginn cursed under her breath, but after a brief consideration, she decided to set the stalker matter aside for now.

Wellesley appearing in her Candle Tears history meant that he and her fate were bound together in some way... and that was exactly what made it interesting: what possible connection could the soon-to-be-dead richest man in Blackmoor City have with her?

She set little Sydney Ginn and the stalker aside, and working backward along the timeline of when Wellesley's motorcade had appeared, she traced the thread until she had a rough location, then lit a new wax channel.

If she could keep an eye on Wellesley's history, she was sure to dig up quite a bit of information...

The more you wait for something, the slower it comes.

Sydney Ginn fidgeted restlessly—touching the melting candle one moment, adjusting the flame the next—impatient and anxious, her thoughts scattered; her gaze wandered here and there, yet it was only after quite some time that she suddenly realized two things.

First, the stretch of Candlefall from when she and Anthony had met due to the car accident had solidified again, setting into the latest version of history.

Second, the corpse on the exhibition hall floor had vanished at some point without her noticing.

I finally managed to recover a little today! But then I looked at the date—it's already the 5th, and in the blink of an eye I'm going back to Shanghai again...

Following those seven Calabash Brothers from a while back, I don't even know how many Minions I owe everyone now—let me check...

Okay, I'm back after checking, and I owe way too many—can't fit it all in the author's note, so I'll open a separate chapter tonight and thank everyone properly first (。

Thank you all for your enthusiastic support, darlings—I've already bought property in the OB/GYN department of Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, and I'll be living there from now on; everyone is welcome to visit bearing cakes and gifts.

Why is it always Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, you ask—because that's where I was born, and we like to keep things full circle.

Chapter 25 — Sydney Ginn, Latest Version, Present Day

Although the beginning of the story had been rewritten several times, the moment Sydney Ginn met Anthony had never changed:

On the eve of summer's arrival, in a soft and restless night, she ran into a handsome-looking venomous thing.

Of course, her eyes could not see through Anthony's smooth, attractive skin and hair to the dark, twisted liquid writhing deep inside his mind—and when a person feels they are getting everything they want, one by one, they are perfectly capable of being gentle and generous, attentive and considerate.

Especially at the very beginning.

"...That scared the life out of me just now," Sydney murmured to her friend. "He suddenly lost control—the car came straight at me. Lucky I've been keeping fit; my reflexes were fast enough that I threw myself out of the way in time... otherwise I'd be a human pancake sandwiched between his bumper and the wall by now."

Amber drew a sharp breath. "That dangerous? Thank goodness you always go to—"

She stopped herself, glanced over at Anthony, and corrected course: "Thank goodness you always go to the gym."

Amber wore her hair short, had a round little face, and a pair of ears that stuck out sharply from her straight hair like an elf's; her personality matched her looks—quick-witted and perceptive.

Sydney often told her it would be wonderful if she had a passage too, so the two of them could go adventuring together in the Nest—though she also knew that if Amber had a passage, she would be a Hunter for the Morgan House Faction, making the two of them potential rivals.

"You had a real brush with death there. Keeping up with exercise is never a bad idea."

Anthony suspected nothing; he fussed over Sydney with worried concern, the lingering fear on his face so vivid that it looked as though he himself had nearly lost his life just now.

In the space of a minute or two, his emotional range proved quite comprehensive—moving from worry to relief and gradually into righteous indignation, covering the full spectrum: "What

kind of driving was that? Was he drunk? Standing off to the side all sneaky like that, not even coming over to apologize! When the police come to take the statement, you have to spell out exactly what happened."

What would later feel false was, at the time, quite welcome. Sydney flashed him a smile and lowered her voice: "He wasn't drunk... he's probably a private bodyguard. I caught a glimpse of his sidearm just now."

"A bodyguard?" Amber slid a glance sideways and immediately let out an "Oh," her voice dropping. "No wonder he's been keeping one hand under his jacket the whole time... There's no one else in the car—did whoever he was guarding leave already?"

"Already gone," Sydney answered. "He had a whole motorcade ahead of him; the moment his car hit trouble, they all scattered immediately. No idea what went wrong with his car—why it would crash into the door like that."

The moment he heard the word "gun," Anthony's face tightened slightly. He hesitated, then reached out and pulled both women behind the bar's back door, saying repeatedly, "Better safe than sorry... what if he's not a bodyguard but some kind of lunatic? Should we go inside?"

At the time, Sydney thought he seemed quite steady and careful.

"I'd rather stand here a bit longer," Amber said, stealing several glances toward the black-suited figure behind the SUV. "I just love watching the drama unfold—you two don't mind, do you?"

Anthony glanced at her, then at Sydney.

Amber wasn't there for the drama—Sydney knew that perfectly well.

Compared to the everyday dealings of a Hunter's house faction, a car crashing into a door wasn't even interesting enough to bother mentioning.

Moreover, the look in Amber's eyes was nothing like someone watching for entertainment: a bright, focused light had settled in them, moving from the car to the figure beside it, as if that one point of light had already seized on something amid all the noise and confusion.

With a major Hunter house faction behind her, Amber had access to a remarkable amount of information. The Matthew Effect applied here as well: the more a person knows, the better they know where to look for more, and the better they know what actually counts as real "information."

Unfortunately, Sydney couldn't ask her directly what she had spotted—Anthony was right there beside them.

"Then I'll keep you company," she said.

Anthony showed no sign of reluctance.

"The public order in Blackmoor City really is getting worse and worse—I suppose even the wealthy are starting to feel the water heating up." He leaned against the wall and chatted idly with Sydney: "Ordinary people like us can't afford bodyguards; we can only look after ourselves... especially a young, attractive woman like you—you're more likely to become a target."

With his warm gaze fixed on her face, Sydney instinctively smoothed her hair and said with a smile, "I'm not particularly worried."

"Having a boyfriend is a lot safer," Anthony said. "Didn't your boyfriend come with you tonight?"

"I'm single."

Because she had a good impression of him, Sydney didn't bother taking offense at such an obvious fishing attempt; she thought for a moment, then added: "I can take care of my own safety perfectly well. Not to mention anything else—I have a small ladies' pistol at home, and a hunting knife I bought specially from Europe."

Anthony froze.

Something seemed to rise to his throat, then he held it there in his mouth without speaking, rolling the words around on his tongue. While he was sifting and weighing them, Amber gave Sydney a light tug and murmured, "His colleague just arrived."

Sydney's gaze cut through the crowd, and sure enough she spotted a car that had just pulled up; the driver who stepped out was dressed in the same black suit and strode over quickly to meet the bodyguard who had caused the crash.

Whatever had caused that bodyguard to crash earlier, the danger had long since drained away from the scene, replaced by curious bar patrons, the deeply frowning manager, and the emergency responders who had just arrived... The bodyguard had finally relaxed as well, and was now sitting in the driver's seat with the car door hanging wide open, answering questions from two police officers while letting the paramedics check his pupils.

"Dylan," the newly arrived black suit called out.

"Ivan?"

The crash-causing bodyguard looked up at the sound, startled to see who it was, and lowered the cotton pad he had been pressing against the wound on his temple. "Why are you the one who came?"

The second bodyguard, named Ivan, seemed to be lower in both rank and experience, and his manner was respectfully proper: "Something went wrong here, and the boss got a bit uneasy having to go pick something up in the middle of it, so they brought in quite a few extra people on short notice. Sister Mi was worried it would be hard for you to manage on your own, so she sent me over to lend a hand."

For some reason, his voice was pitched a notch lower than most people's. Sydney was quite certain that Amber, just like her, had been straining her ears and edging several steps forward just to catch the general gist of it.

Dylan showed little warmth or gratitude toward this reinforcement.

"Got it," he said, pressing the cloth back against his wound, looking like a man who had nothing more to say and wanted Ivan to stop talking as well—perhaps because there were police officers right beside them.

"We're still open for business as usual," a bartender called out loudly from the back door, apparently trying to remind the patrons to hurry back inside and keep spending money. "Don't worry, everyone—nothing's been affected!"

"Shall we?" Anthony tilted his head down and spoke to Sydney very gently: "Let's go back in and have a proper chat—let me buy you a drink."

Running into Anthony tonight had been a complete surprise; she found herself torn on the spot between "bodyguard crash" and "attractive man"—and it was Amber who smiled at her, tipped her chin toward the bar's back door, and said: "You go ahead. If anything interesting turns up, I'll tell you about it later."

Sydney had no choice but to remind her, "Come find me inside in a bit then"—and after Amber promised she would, Sydney went into the bar with Anthony.

As she settled into her seat, her thoughts flickered briefly to Ivan. He had said something about the boss "picking something up," hadn't he? Picking up what? And was it at all connected to

whatever had caught Amber's interest in the matter?

But she didn't let herself think too deeply about it. Because Anthony had settled in beside her, a lock of hair slipping down over his face, the light in his eyes rippling faintly beneath the shadow of his hair; as if she were some rare treasure the rest of the world had somehow inexplicably overlooked.

Later, Sydney reflected that no matter what the quarry is, a person who can be a Hunter needs a certain instinct—for instance, she hadn't felt there was anything particularly distinctive about her own appearance or dress, yet Anthony had still picked her out from among the crowd of bar patrons at a glance.

In the Nest, she was a Hunter. Back in the human world, she was the prey.

"What would you like to drink?" he asked.

"I absolutely hate alcohol," Sydney said—and hearing herself say it out loud inside a bar, she couldn't help laughing.

Using "not drinking" as a topic of conversation, she began her chat and first date with Anthony.

Over two or three months, they went from seeing each other occasionally to growing closer and closer; after Anthony visited her home for the first time, he became very nearly the most perfect boyfriend in the world—though that illusion didn't last very long.

At some point along the way—she couldn't remember which meeting it was—the two of them were talking and the conversation drifted to the black SUV that had crashed into the bar's back door in early May; it was only then that Sydney remembered she'd never gotten around to asking Amber what she had actually discovered that night—perhaps the whole thing had turned out to be not worth mentioning after all, which was why Amber had never thought to bring it up.

"By the way, I remember you said that night that you had a hunting knife you'd bought specially from Europe." Anthony's interest suddenly sparked, and he asked: "You can get hunting knives here too—what makes a European one special? Let me take a look?"

Sydney immediately leapt up from the sofa, retrieved the hunting knife, and launched into its brand, craftsmanship, and value; the more animated she became about it, the more Anthony's desire was kindled.

"I'm not trying to take it from you," he said, still performing a degree of embarrassment back then: "Could I borrow it for a while? I have a friend who specifically collects knives—I'd like to show it to him."

Sydney thought it over and figured she probably wouldn't need to enter the Nest again for the next two or three months. And even if she did, she had other weapons and tools. "Fine—just bring it back when I need it."

...She slowly opened her eyes, unable for a moment to tell whether the stiff, cold thing was her own body or the exhibition hall floor—the two had nearly fused into one.

Anthony never returned the hunting knife.

Sydney looked at the two threads of memory running through her mind, feeling both lost and bewildered, and suddenly, blindingly clear.

She turned her head without a sound, her gaze traveling across the floor and far into the distance, where it came to rest on the enormous candle lying across the exhibition hall—

And on her own back, seated before it.

So that was it.

In the second version of history—the one that had been altered for unknown reasons—Anthony had borrowed the hunting knife and never returned it; Sydney had entered the Nest without the knife, and had naturally been unable to drive it into the Resident's throat.

And so the Resident had not caused the same wound to appear on its own throat—

And so she had survived.

Today the May Day holiday ended and I went back to my usual chaos—spent most of the day running around outside, so the chapter's a bit late... I'm exhausted every single day, all I want is to go home and sleep properly...

This author's note is being typed on an e-ink screen! I keep buying them and returning them, buying and returning—I'm already on my third one. Will this one survive the 7-day no-questions-asked return window? Stay tuned... The first two I returned the moment they arrived.

(Okay, I can't break the em-dash rule, are you trying to finish me off—)

Chapter 26 — Sydney Ginn's Choice at the Crossroads

For the first few seconds, Sydney Ginn stared at the distant silhouette of herself crouched over a fire, her mind reduced to something like a battlefield after a nuclear detonation. Fragmented thoughts drifted like radioactive fallout—scattered, impossible to form into anything coherent.

Why did she have two separate lines of memory?

In the first memory line, the night she had encountered her stalker Anthony, there had been no car crash behind the bar; she had never mentioned owning a hunting knife, so Anthony had never "borrowed" it from her.

She had entered the Nest intending to retrieve something that could take care of Anthony, only for things to go sideways—at the Hopscotch grid, a Resident had copied her appearance and taken on her identity.

That Resident was utterly convinced that it was the real "Sydney Ginn."

Even the fact that it had no backpack, no phone, and no hunting knife had been explained away: a scuffle between the two of them just before they boarded the taxi had made it rush onto the cab, leaving her things behind.

The truly troubling part was this—if the Resident was so certain that it was the real Sydney Ginn, then by the same logic she could no longer rule out the possibility that she herself was the Resident. Sydney had originally thought that having her phone and hunting knife on her person was proof enough that she was the real one; but what if she had simply forgotten the moment when she had taken those things from the original?

After boarding the taxi, hadn't a stretch of her memory been taken away? If that missing memory happened to cover the moment when she, having become Sydney Ginn, had seized her things from the real one, then she had absolutely no evidence left to comfort herself with.

Between the Sydney lying on the floor and the one sitting before the candle—which one was truly the Resident?

No... that question was a bottomless rabbit hole; fall in and you'd never climb back out. She could set it aside for now. Better to treat herself as the real Sydney Ginn and trace the timeline from the beginning.

After the Resident left, she had called a second cab, carefully followed the Passenger Rules, and trailed the Resident all the way to the Museum of Modern Art. On the basement level, Sydney had found her moment and driven her knife into the Resident's neck.

Not one thing she had hoped for came to pass.

The Resident had stood where it was, both hands pressed over the wound; she had barely glanced at it and couldn't tell whether it bled at all—and she'd had no chance to look more carefully—because in no time at all the Resident had looked at her and smiled, baring a mouth full of teeth she knew too well.

"Since you copied my form, your neck should split open just the same."

The first memory line ended with her own throat suddenly splitting wide, blood spraying outward, her body crashing to the ground like a shattered stone statue.

Sydney Ginn knew she had died.

And yet death was not her ending; after death, she entered the second memory line.

On the night she had encountered Anthony, a black SUV had come barreling straight at her; she had barely dodged it before it slammed into the back door. Starting with the fact that the driver was a bodyguard, she had mentioned to Anthony that she owned a hunting knife—and not long after, he had taken it from her.

When she entered the Nest, Sydney had muttered a quiet curse—being down one weapon always left her feeling a little exposed.

From there, the second memory line was no different from the first: she heard the broadcast, stepped onto the Hopscotch grid, called a cab, and was copied by the Resident... The only difference, at the very end, was that when the second memory line terminated, she opened her eyes on the floor.

Staring at the silhouette before the candle, Sydney Ginn climbed to her feet as silently as she could manage. The floor tiles were smooth and cold, unstained by a single drop of blood.

The second memory line had overwritten the first, becoming the true, most recent version of history—so she had never stabbed the Resident, and had never had her throat cut by a single sentence.

She didn't dare stand up straight for fear the Resident would notice her, and crept on all fours back behind a pillar, holding her breath so rigidly that her chest began to ache—she had to keep it under control, because she actually feared she might start sobbing without meaning to.

...How could a single sentence cut someone's throat?

Compared to a mouth opening in her neck, she couldn't even say for a moment which frightened her more: being killed again without rhyme or reason, or discovering that she wasn't a real human being at all and would spend the rest of her existence wandering the Nest as a Resident.

If she wasn't a Resident, why had her neck so faithfully reproduced the wound on the other one?

Not a single one of these questions did Sydney Ginn have an answer for.

Her back pressed against the pillar, she squeezed her eyes shut and covered her mouth, wishing she could draw herself inward into a ball so tight the Nest would never find her again.

No—calm down first, think it through...

There were several pieces of circumstantial evidence pointing to the other one being the Resident: first, it had no phone, no hunting knife, and no backpack; second, according to what she had witnessed in the first memory line, it had boarded the taxi without following the Passenger Rules and had still gotten off without incident.

Third—and most compelling—the neck's skin was only a thin layer wrapping arteries, nerves, blood vessels, the trachea, and the esophagus; could a living person really perform first aid on a stab wound to the neck and carry on as though nothing had happened?

Sydney Ginn calmed herself a little and quietly peeked out.

The Resident was still seated before the candle, repeatedly adjusting the heat of the flame tray, looking visibly impatient for the candle to melt. The candle, growing gradually soft and drooping, had formed a pool of nearly transparent Candle Tears in midair; from this distance, Sydney could just barely make out what sounded like a voice inside the Candle Tears calling out "Mr. Wellesley."

The candle was surely the key—the reason she had come back from the dead and formed two separate memory lines.

The broadcast had said it was an immensely powerful Artifact, and that was clearly no exaggeration—something that could drag a person back from death was formidable by any measure.

But why was the Resident so keenly interested in it?

Sydney looked around and noticed that the far wall of the exhibition hall was covered in a dense block of exhibit text—Artifacts in the Nest were almost always accompanied by some form of "item description," and this had to be it.

The only problem was that the exhibit text was on the other side of the hall, and to reach it she would have to pass directly behind the Resident.

No matter how she thought about it, she had to deal with the Resident first.

Regardless of whether she was truly the real Sydney Ginn, once the "Sydney Ginn" beside that candle was dead, she would naturally become the "real Sydney Ginn" by default—right?

When survival was on the line, it seemed that even something fundamental, something principled, could be glossed over... Before today, Sydney Ginn had never imagined she would find herself thinking this way.

But if the Resident could kill her with a single sentence, how was she supposed to kill a Resident?

Sydney's gaze swept the room and landed on her hiking backpack slumped on the floor not far away, its mouth hanging open and lopsided, exposing a wadded hand towel and various odds and ends inside.

"Where did it go—"

In the distance, the Resident was still fixed on the Candle Tears, muttering under its breath, looking thoroughly impatient. "It seemed like he said something really important just now... didn't it? Where was it said..."

Taking advantage of its attention being entirely on the candle, Sydney quickly slipped off her shoes and padded toward the backpack in her sock feet, step by careful step—sure enough, she made no sound.

As she passed the backpack, she reached in and hooked out a long towel, then retreated quickly to the far end of the hall—she didn't dare stand out in the open of the sparse exhibition

space with her head tilted back reading the exhibit text, and instead slipped behind another exhibit at the far end of the hall; that piece was far enough from the candle, and was made of bundles of long wooden poles fanning outward in a spiral, which was lovely to look at even if she couldn't tell what it was supposed to be, but at least it was just barely enough to hide a woman crouching behind it.

The Resident would eventually notice that she had disappeared from the floor.

Even if its attention was fixed on the candle for now, it would soon enough discover that its neck was completely unharmed and that the wound had been erased. This was the only window she had to strike first—but how should she use it?

Should she use this chance to read the candle's description first, or make her move against the Resident first?

If she struck first, could the candle become the Resident's trump card to turn the tables on her? When she had her throat cut by a single sentence earlier—had that been connected to the candle?

Unfortunately, when Sydney had followed the Resident down here in the first timeline, she hadn't had a chance to read the candle's description carefully.

At every fork in the road, it's impossible to foresee the chain of dominoes that will follow one after another; just as Sydney herself had never imagined that entering the Nest to deal with Anthony would lead to news of an Artifact, and that searching for the Artifact would lead to being copied by a Resident.

Which path should she choose?

After a moment's hesitation, Sydney couldn't quite say what moved her to do it, but she took out her phone, silenced the shutter sound, aimed it at the exhibit text on the distant wall, zoomed in, and took several photos in quick succession.

Before she could even enlarge the photos to read the description, the Resident suddenly stood up—she contracted all over, seeming to shrink to half her size, and stared tensely at its silhouette through the gaps between the wooden poles.

It hadn't noticed anything was wrong yet. It seemed dissatisfied with the candle in front of it; it placed a hand on the candle, took a few steps as if searching for something, then crouched back down, and with a click snapped the flame tray open.

The flame swayed like underwater grass in the stirred air, casting light on the features that were hers.

Sydney let out a small breath of relief and enlarged the first photo, reading quickly.

The text in the first photo was the closest to her, and though the writing was blurry it was still legible enough to get the gist. By the time she finished reading it, her mouth had gone dry: no wonder she had been pulled out of the fatal ending of the first timeline—it turned out the Resident had accidentally altered history. She had never once imagined there could be something so inconceivable in the Nest.

If she could bring it back to Blackmoor City...

She tapped open the second photo, but the angle and distance were far less ideal than the first, making the specific text actually difficult to make out.

It didn't matter—the most important thing was already clear: though the candle was powerful enough to reverse history, it could not be used as a weapon.

Then she would proceed with the original plan.

Sydney Ginn made her decision, pressed her two fingers down, and locked her phone screen.

In the screen as it went dark, a second face looked back at her.

Lately it really feels like all my stats are kuacha kuacha dropping across the board... I guess this is the price you pay for writing niche stuff (not really lol)

Gotta get on another plane tomorrow ahhhhhh

When on earth am I going to be able to go home and just lie down in peace ahhhhhh

Chapter 27: What?! I've been an ungrateful wreck since April 23rd?

Time flies, the years rush by, and in the blink of an eye, those seven Calabash Brothers I owed you all have...

Never grown up, because I still haven't given birth to them...

I always felt like my last thank-you post to you all was just recently — but I just checked, and the last one was April 23rd?? So I've been heartless, shameless, and utterly without conscience ever since??

I'm so sorry, everyone. You've been supporting me and cheering me on nonstop, while I've been nonstop ungrateful... Let me take stock of the family ties and count how many of those original seven Calabash Brothers have turned into little Minions by now. Don't go flipping past this just because it's a thank-you chapter — what if your name gets called?!

I've been running around nonstop lately, and I figure I can't properly pay my debts until I'm back home. Fortunately, this stretch of running around looks like it's finally entering its last leg — Shanghai is the last stop. Once I'm home, I truly never want to leave again for the rest of the year. I love writing, writing loves me, and nothing can tear us apart.

(Unless someone warmly invites me to New York to gather material for an Artifact report.) (I could leave right now, seriously.) (What do you mean a side project — shouldn't I be working even harder on this one?)

The crowd waiting outside the OB-GYN department of SZ City Second People's Hospital to collect their babies has grown quite a bit:

Well, well — Bohemian Xiang (I dare not look too hard at that username) has shown up to offer their support. I figure quite a few of you still remember this legend... I've completely lost count of how many babies I owe you... Can we just call it one for now...?

A new legend has arrived: Gunsmith Rousseau. You alone added two spots to the baby quota, and I'll be honest, my knees are shaking a little... The username feels vaguely familiar, but I don't dare claim to know you. Are you a new reader who got lured in by the Artifact report? Or are you a blessing from my ancestors delivered via apocalypse (?)

姥姥 b111111111, I refuse to believe you got the number of 1s right the first time you typed that username! I figure you can't tell whether I've written too many or too few either (jk), but either way the baby debt is on the books (.)

Thank you to Yaoyao and Linlin for the KFC (yes, I've abandoned McDonald's — the Golden Arches have let me down, and did you know they've switched away from Heinz ketchup?), to Tie Jiǎ Bái Táng for the dessert (desserts are so expensive now — I nearly fainted seeing egg tarts going for 20-something yuan), and thank you to Chū Shí Qíng Zì Chán, Mò Yuān (pronounced "Black Bird"), and Yǐng Yòu — each of you snuck me a cup of milk tea (the flavors these days are so wild, who even comes up with them?). Haynes even treated me to dinner. You guys basically covered my entire day!

How many babies does that make — oh, I owe another five — so what!

Too many persimmons and your mouth won't pucker!

Thank you to Èr Shí Sì's QD for getting me a DQ (DQ is actually so good, and it was such a lucky buy), to vitang (you've already bought me two bottles of mouthwash — Shanghai ones, no less), to Fēng Yīn (did I still owe you from last time?), and to Joiiiiii for sending an opening flower arrangement...

And also to Lǐ Bāo Bāo de Bāo Bāo (oh my, I actually don't know the story behind that name — really, tell everyone), Zhǎng Gāo Gāo de Yú (this fish is truly very tall — I've been eating it since the last book), Jūn Mǐ Xī (all longtime readers~), Dōng Xiē (oh come on, you're too kind, hehe), and Ā Ā Ā Zěnmē Fēi Shì (how even)

And also Murakami's Kafka (no Consort to sit next to you this time), Sān Xī Yī (I think I saw your comment), Cīlè Mò (what did you say again — I'm just plucking a few sheep here), and Shí Wàn Fú Tè (were you the one who recommended the Northeast bathhouse?)

Thank you to Chén Chéng Yè (new reader?), Xiǎo Sūn Dài Nǚ Fēi (not a new reader), Liú Jǐn Qí (know you all too well), Parsons Yùbèi Shēng, Emmy 酱, whhit, MARGINAL Yú, Yǎ Er (nice to see you again), 书友20240202130643416 (I nearly died typing all those digits), 书友20230109114807508 (please, I'm begging you both to go change your names)

Let me catch my breath and keep going:

Sān Jiǔ's Exclusive Bandage (fine, you don't have to shower), Méi Tóu Nǎo Diū Diū, Xuán Fēng Fēi Wán who tips like it's a daily check-in, Yuè Zhuó Xǐ Huān Mào xiǎn Gù shì, Mǐ A Áo, Lín

Sān Jiǔ's Dog (?), Yú Xiā Xiè Wú Chù Bù Zài, Nǐ Yǒngyuǎn Shì Qiàn Tàiyáng De, mocaozy, yoleen Yú...

And to everyone who's sent monthly votes — I can basically see all of you, I just actually can't fit everyone in. I'm so grateful that you're willing to cast your monthly votes on a story this niche. I've actually started worrying a bit about the numbers lately, and seeing the monthly votes and readthrough stats is actually reassuring.

I've noticed that saving up all the tips and thanking everyone at once makes it look like business is booming (jk)... It's only 12 babies, right? Come on — let's run through all twelve zodiac signs (.

Chapter 28 — Hello everyone, your Southern Airlines Ambassador here

Welcome to the Southern Airlines Passenger First-Hand Experience Channel, where you can feel the full boarding experience in real time — no Wi-Fi, no social distancing, two hours of upright seatbacks with nothing to eat — all without leaving your home.

That said, I'm actually pretty content: the two girls sitting next to me smell nice, not a hint of anything unpleasant (if anyone smells, it's probably me — I've been running around all day), and the flight isn't even delayed!

What an honor!

Right now the seatback is digging into the back of my skull, the seatbelt buckle is jabbing my butt, my bag is crushing my feet, and the screen in front of me is showing a podcast called "Why We Love the Song Dynasty," while a faint whiff of something drifts over from up ahead (someone let one go a little too early).

I haven't even lifted my head since I sat down — racing against the clock to bring you this live flight report. Why, you ask?

Because

a wandering soul like me won't touch down until seven-thirty

and who knows

when this broken, rootless

update

will

go live in China time.

(continued)

A little poem, just for you — thank you all for tuning in.

Finished the poem and realized I have a tiny bit of time left, so let me ramble for another two cents' worth: the new chapter is five hundred words in! Still featuring the big-eared monkey (?) Sydney Ginn!

If the heavens would grant me two — no, three hours, I'd definitely get an update out today.

But who knows what time I'll reach the hotel... I'm landing at Hongqiao but staying over in Pudong... My biggest hobby in life is donating money to airlines and DiDi drivers as an act of charity.

Why do I always stay in Pudong? Because that's where the starting point of the Nest is.

I'm about to venture deep into their lair again!

(Can my editor see this? I am absolutely not calling you a Resident.)

What? What if it's too late by the time I get to the hotel?

Eat first, eat first — come on, fill up your cups, let's all eat and chat after, eat and chat after.

Chapter 29: The Attack Pattern of the Sydney Ginn Resident

The moment Sydney Ginn caught the first words spoken behind her, amid her terror, a faint flicker of relief managed to surface—

"I knew long ago that you came back to life,"

her own voice, thick as a miasma, drifted up slowly from somewhere above and behind her head. "You're so easy to fool—nothing like me at all."

Good, Sydney Ginn thought, pivoting on her knee and twisting her body around in the same instant, thank goodness its first words were a waste of breath.

So what if it had noticed early? Either way, the two of them were always going to end up fighting for their lives.

She had long since steeled herself for this—yet the moment "Sydney Ginn" flashed into view, she couldn't help but catch her breath, as though someone had shoved her from the front.

Compared to the "Sydney Ginn" she had seen in her memory, the Resident now looked somehow more vivid, more real: a forehead faintly glittering with beads of sweat in the firelight, a strand of golden-brown hair stuck to a temple; the fine down on a cheek, warm breath spilling from parted lips...

Those eyes, blazing bright as if nothing else remained.

This was Sydney Ginn—this was herself—and yet she herself was standing outside her own body, one arm raised high, bringing a dark shape crashing down toward her face.

At the last possible moment Sydney Ginn finally lurched sideways in time; a thunderous crash exploded beside her ear as the exhibit was bitten deep, gouging out a huge chunk; amid the shower of splinters, she squinted and rolled outward across the floor as fast as she could—her face and the backs of her hands already bristling with who knew how many wooden slivers.

"Just die already—there can only be one Sydney Ginn in this world!"

Her own voice, strange yet unmistakably hers, rolled in waves through the exhibition hall; "Sydney Ginn" strained and wrenched a fire axe free from deep within the exhibit of wooden strips.

When had...?

Before she could even finish the thought, Sydney Ginn sprang to her feet and bolted—but in her panic she had forgotten that she'd taken her shoes off earlier, and with nothing but socks on her feet, she had almost no traction at all on the smooth exhibition hall floor.

At the instant she was about to pitch face-first onto the ground, she flung herself forward in a diving posture instead—since she had opened her eyes again, she seemed to have spent more time sprawling and rolling on the floor than standing upright.

The fire axe struck the tile with a dull thud, biting deep—only one step behind her.

Sydney Ginn had never stripped off a sock so fast in her life.

While the fire axe was still stuck in the floor, she tore the sock off and hurled it straight at her other self's face, aiming for the eyes; just like any normal person, the Resident had no desire to let a sock hit its eyeballs, and jerked its head to one side.

Sydney Ginn would have loved to press her advantage, but she had no chance to pull off the other sock and throw it—the Resident had already closed the distance in one stride, raising the axe high above her.

Almost on pure instinct, she kicked hard at the Resident's ankle.

Once the Resident had copied Sydney Ginn, it was nothing more than an ordinary human body; kicked in the shin with full force, it stumbled back two steps in pain. Sydney Ginn seized the opening, scrambled to her feet, and ran forward—one foot steady, one foot slipping.

But as she ran, she found herself involuntarily replaying the sensation of that kick landing on the Resident's ankle.

She had never thought about it before: what shoes was the Resident wearing?

She already knew that when a Resident copied someone, it couldn't replicate their bag, phone, and other belongings. But what about clothes? What about shoes?

In that brief glimpse during the life-or-death moment just now...

"Wait!"

Sydney Ginn knew full well that with one bare foot she couldn't possibly outrun the Resident; and the more chances she gave it to talk, the more dangerous things became—she wheeled around and called out urgently: "What are you wearing on your feet?"

The other "Sydney Ginn," teeth clenched, bearing down hard behind her, startled at the question but wasn't distracted—it brought the axe down first; only after Sydney Ginn barely dodged did it laugh breathlessly: "Trying to say something useless to buy time?"

"A Resident can't copy a backpack, and it can't copy clothing either!"

Terrified it would catch up again, Sydney Ginn hurried on: "You copied my appearance, but the shoes you're wearing are still your own. You must have the memory of what I was wearing when I entered the Nest today, right? Look down, then think—do the clothes and shoes you remember match what's actually on your body?"

"Sydney Ginn" froze for a moment, and actually looked down at her clothes.

Even a Resident in the Nest couldn't go around naked—there was generally something on it.

This particular one, perhaps because it was a Vulture—always ready to become someone else at a moment's notice—was wearing plain, highly versatile black trousers and black shoes. One couldn't really blame Sydney Ginn for never having noticed its clothing; when a face identical to your own rises out of the darkness, you're not very likely to pay attention to what shoes it has on.

"That's exactly right," it said when it raised its head again, enunciating clearly. "When I enter the Nest at night, I always wear black from head to toe so as not to draw attention. If you think you can trick me with that, it's really quite laughable."

It hefted the fire axe in one hand and gave a small kick with the tip of its shoe.

"I can even tell you—I bought these shoes at Bloomingdale's during a sale, because I thought: anything I wear into the Nest just needs to be good quality; there's no point paying full price for something fashionable."

Now it was Sydney Ginn's turn to freeze. That line of thinking was unmistakably her own; she could even recall several pieces of clothing she had bought for exactly the same reason.

"And you?" The Resident smiled at her, a strand of hair sticking to its lips, framing its teeth. "If you truly have my memories, you'll find that it's your clothes that don't add up."

Sydney Ginn couldn't help but look down, her gaze dropping to the khaki joggers.

She remembered pulling on these exact pants before climbing out the window... but where had they come from?

Most people can recall, at least vaguely, where they bought their clothes—yet these joggers felt as though someone had pulled them onto her body mere seconds ago, so unfamiliar that her mind went blank.

Why was there no memory of buying these pants?

"It seems that after a Resident copies its original, it smooths over and lubricates the memories—patching up details that don't match reality, filling in the gaps... which is why you're so firmly convinced that you're the real me."

While she stood with her head bowed, staring blankly at the pants, the other "Sydney Ginn" had been slowly closing in; its voice, its breath, its smell, and its feet in their black shoes were gradually encroaching on her existence.

"Residents can't be killed—I've heard that."

It said quietly, "Still, I'd feel better once I've taken away your ability to move... I imagine there's a time limit on how long you can hold a human form? When the time runs out and you haven't returned to Blackmoor City to replace me, you should revert to your Resident form, right?"

Wait—what was it saying?

As though something had quietly pricked a point deep inside her mind, a grain-of-rice-sized point of light slipped through—but it flared for only an instant before heavier, more pressing shadows closed over it and blotted it out.

She neither heard nor saw anything—it was something beyond the five senses, some pure instinct, that made Sydney Ginn suddenly duck low and lunge forward the moment the fire axe swung down toward her forehead, wrapping her arms around the Resident and driving it off its feet.

The Resident's arm, tensed and swinging with full force, came crashing down hard against her ear and the side of her head; but the fire axe itself—the truly lethal part—finally glanced off her shoulder, slipped free, and clattered onto the tile a short distance away.

The two of them went down together, and the back of the Resident's head struck the floor with a sound that made every organ in the body clench.

"You copied my form," it still managed to speak with difficulty, "so you also—"

Before it could finish the sentence, Sydney Ginn had already pulled the towel she'd tucked into the back of her waistband and shoved it over its mouth.

The Resident twisted its head from side to side to avoid it, and though the towel didn't go in cleanly, it stopped the Resident from finishing what it was saying.

Sydney Ginn didn't dare let go; gritting her teeth, she endured the blows the Resident kept landing on her body, holding the long towel taut with both hands, and seizing the moment when the Resident's lips parted, she pressed it deep into the Resident's mouth—the towel ran like a rope across her other self's cheek, driving its tongue to the back of its throat, leaving it capable of nothing but muffled groaning, unable to form a single clear word.

"I... I think I understand..." she murmured, staring at the face distorted beneath the towel. "I think I've figured out your attack pattern. You really are the Resident."

Yesterday I arrived at the hotel, had dinner, typed for a while longer, and simply couldn't hold on—fell asleep... Woke up early this morning and kept going, otherwise I'd feel guilty.

This time the hotel stay was thanks to some perks from Qidian—you know they had that promotional event for the Joy of Life drama production, right? I'm not connected to that, but I tagged along and piggy-backed on it, sort of like sneaking in through a side door... How to put it—I keep having this guilty feeling like someone will audit the accounts afterward and make me pay for the room. Someone from Qidian told me Maoni was also staying there. Round it up and down, and you and Maoni are basically the same tier.

That's some seriously wide rounding—one step would carry you from the Huangpu River all the way to Tokyo...

Chapter 30: The Way Sydney Ginn Fights Back, and Establishing True Identity

Looking back now, it was probably because she had the "Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion" that Sydney Ginn had almost never truly gone head-to-head with a Resident—let alone fought one in a life-or-death struggle.

It was only after she was released from death once more that she finally arrived at a conjecture.

She knew that every Resident had its own distinct way of surviving and attacking.

But "attacking" alone was far too vague and broad a term: punching someone was an attack; splitting someone's throat with a single sentence was also an attack—and so, crowding out your existence bit by bit was an attack as well.

"You said it yourself—Residents alter memory details and fill in gaps and holes, which is why a Resident is absolutely, unshakably convinced that it is the real person."

Sydney Ginn was already struggling to keep the towel pressed down; if the strength the Resident beneath her was now using to thrash was actually her own, then all those years of keeping herself in shape had paid off quite well—well enough that her teeth were clenched and her arms were trembling, and she could be thrown off at any moment.

But not a single word of what needed to be said could be left out.

There could truly only be one Sydney Ginn in the world—the Resident was not wrong about that.

"When I think back, I find that I'm not like that. Ever since I discovered there was another 'Sydney Ginn,' I haven't been able to shake the self-doubt—especially after I came back from the dead... I can't explain why I would copy your wound onto myself, or why I can't remember where I bought those pants. If I were the Resident, I should have had a smooth answer to all of these questions long ago."

The "Sydney Ginn" beneath her had the towel shoved deep into her mouth; her lips were pressed into two long, thin, taut lines, teeth half-hidden and half-bared, saliva and drool and

retching sounds and her tongue all churning and struggling in the depths of her throat as though she still wanted to speak—her own face looking like that was almost unbearable to witness.

Sydney Ginn knew what it wanted to say.

"You want to say that precisely because I am the Resident, when I face questions I cannot answer, I take that as proof that I'm the real one—is that it?"

A muffled whine rose from its throat, something that sounded like an angry "Yes."

"Impressive... no matter what argument I raise, you can turn it into doubt I cast upon myself."

The Resident drove a fist into her side, and for an instant it was as if it had knocked the air and the light clean out of the room.

Sydney Ginn's vision went dark in waves; she bore the pain and kept pressing it down with all her strength, managing only to twist her body to the side and curl her legs up, using her thighs as a bulwark to absorb its pounding fists—her other knee still had to pin down its other arm, and the muscles were screaming.

"This is your attack pattern, isn't it?"

She had to say it out loud; only by saying it out loud could there be any chance of survival. "Between the two of us, you are the one with absolute, unshakable certainty, and I am the one filled with fear and doubt. It's that little seed of doubt in my heart that gives your words their power to wound—that's what turns them into reality."

The reason a single sentence had split her throat open was not because she was a Resident; it was because of that tiny sliver of doubt within her.

A Resident's weapon was "language"—but its method of attack was like a syringe filled with poison: it had to pierce the skin before the poison could take effect.

And that tiny grain of self-doubt was the entry point on the skin—without an entry point, a Resident's verbal attack would have no effect.

If the Resident had said that same sentence to Anthony, his throat would certainly never have split open, because his sense of self was perfectly clear and had nothing whatsoever to do with "Residents."

"...Your instinct is to crowd out my existence. So you keep reminding me, pointing out all sorts of problems and inconsistencies, trying to make me believe that I am the Resident. 'Sydney Ginn' is a seat—if I die, or disappear, the seat is vacated, and only then can you sit in it forever, and truly become Sydney Ginn.

"To that end, you split my throat open with a single sentence, and then you told me that a Resident's 'copying' has a time limit—even if no such thing is actually true, because you've said it out loud, after a while I'll gradually start turning into a Resident, won't I?"

The tiny sliver of doubt she had felt about herself just now had already served as an entry point, letting that sentence seep inside; the time left to Sydney Ginn was running short.

If she still hadn't dealt with the Resident before her in a little while, she was afraid she would begin to take its place and become the Resident herself...

Even though she felt she had worked everything out, the moment that thought arose, a small voice still surfaced from somewhere deep inside her: Was that really true?

When the time came, would she be "replacing" it as the Resident—or "reverting" to what she had been as the Resident all along?

...No, now was not the time to think about this; she was already struggling to keep "Sydney Ginn" pinned down.

Sydney Ginn shook off that voice from the depths of her mind and picked up her pace, wanting to pour out everything she had to say before the moment slipped away.

"When you said the 'Resident' has a time limit, that was actually what began to reveal the truth to me. Because the real 'Sydney Ginn' would have no knowledge of that piece of information whatsoever—I even doubt whether that information actually exists, or whether you invented it on the spot, just to make me take your place as the Resident."

The final syllable was stretched into a broken note.

With one violent lunge from the Resident that gave it more room to move, it slammed its fist into Sydney Ginn's temple; amid the clanging bells and white stars, by the time her vision cleared again, she found that at some point she had been thrown to the ground.

"Sydney Ginn" was climbing to its feet, dry-coughing as it did. The long towel had been soaked through with saliva, heavy and sodden, lying flat on the floor beside it.

"You're wrong," it said.

Its voice was hoarse, as though its lips and tongue were still numb and sluggish, not quite obeying. "...The real Sydney Ginn does know about that piece of information. Last month, when I was listening to the radio, the host mentioned it in passing as a rumor—I remembered it..."

Fire axe—three words leapt into Sydney Ginn's mind.

She couldn't let it get to the fire axe.

She couldn't stand up; she pressed her limbs to the floor and crawled in an unsteady wobble toward the fire axe. The Resident had clearly spotted her target too, and gave a soft, contemptuous laugh, turning as if to kick at her—just as Sydney Ginn scrambled to dodge and sat back down hard on the floor, the Resident strode toward the fire axe.

It seemed there was only one way left to slow it down.

Even if she could only buy herself a few seconds, just enough to catch her breath.

Staring at the back of another version of herself hurrying toward the fire axe, Sydney Ginn called out in a hoarse voice:

"Then why don't I?"

The other "Sydney Ginn" stopped dead in her tracks. It turned its eyes and looked at Sydney Ginn from beneath its lids.

"You said the real Sydney Ginn knows about that piece of information, right? If you're the original and I copied you, then naturally I should also have that information somewhere in my memory."

Sydney Ginn let out a low, dry laugh at her other self. Her throat felt as if it had just been rolled through sand and coated in a layer of grit.

"...When you brought up that piece of information, I suddenly realized—I don't have it in my head. I'm not the copy. You are."

The Resident stood there blankly, as if momentarily unsure how to react.

"Don't forget—there's one more key point."

Sydney Ginn didn't dare crawl toward the fire axe again; she was afraid of jolting the Resident out of its daze. The more confused it was, the better for her. "...Residents can't be killed,

can they? But I've died once—haven't I?"

The Resident lowered its head and shook it hard several times.

"No—you could be lying to me, knowing full well but pretending you don't. Wouldn't that be simple enough?"

It spoke in a voice that was almost a murmur.

If a voice could have a shape, it would be like a worm drilling endlessly into the darkness, never looking toward the light. "The idea that Residents can't be killed has always been just a rumor—before I killed you today, I'd never actually tried to kill a Resident before... its validity has always been up for debate."

"You see," Sydney Ginn laughed under her breath and said, "a Resident really will find all kinds of excuses and reasons to fill out its own memories and logic, to convince itself that it's the real person."

The words settled, and the hall was silent for a second or two.

She watched herself slowly lift its head toward her.

A person is not very familiar with their own expressions, unless they spend every waking moment looking in a mirror; so Sydney Ginn found it difficult to describe exactly what the look that flashed across that face meant—if she had to describe it, it was as though something that had been suspended high up in "Sydney Ginn's" mind suddenly came crashing down.

The next instant, she understood.

"No matter which of us is actually the Resident," that face—her own face—twisted slightly and said, "as long as I kill you, I'll naturally be the real Sydney Ginn."

Before the words even finished falling, it had already lunged forward, snatched up the fire axe from close by, and swung its gaze back toward Sydney Ginn—Sydney Ginn cursed her luck inwardly, hurriedly yanked off her remaining sock, rolled to her feet, and ran.

Truly worthy of being her copy: faced with the same problem, it had arrived at the same answer.

She had originally thought that once she punctured the Resident's confidence and sowed doubt in it, things would take a turn for the better—but whether the Resident was confident or not, it was still coming to kill her, so hadn't the situation remained fundamentally unchanged?

Worst of all, she couldn't kill a Resident, but a Resident could kill her—was there any way to win this fight?

The exhibition hall was large, but when someone behind you was chasing you with an axe, it suddenly felt far too small.

Sydney Ginn was barefoot and couldn't run toward the area covered in wood splinters and debris—if a splinter lodged in her foot and she couldn't run, she'd be leaving her life here; that left only one direction of escape open to her, which was where the enormous candle stood.

...And the flames dancing at the base of the candle.

The Resident hadn't put the fire out, and it hadn't let the candle solidify—the thought jumped into Sydney Ginn's mind.

When she had been watching from a distance just now, she had noticed that the section it had melted seemed to be not far from the time period when she had first encountered Anthony—in other words, about six months ago.

Wait—if the section from six months ago could be melted, then—

Before Sydney Ginn could finish the thought, her feet had slowed without her realizing it, her mind elsewhere.

A heavy, sharp pain cut through both her train of thought and her shoulder at once.

Friends, I'm sorry—I was completely exhausted yesterday. I am an extreme introvert, and these past couple of days I've unexpectedly turned into a social butterfly who's also been gaining weight (actually gaining weight—I've barely had a proper meal, and I'm already up to 125 jin), and yesterday I basically collapsed dead in bed.

But today I pulled myself together and mustered my motivation—can you guess where I finished writing this chapter...

I opened up a passage, entered the lair of China Literature, and wrote it to completion right there in their headquarters...

How do I put it—the pressure was very real, but you need pressure to get an update written... after all, tomorrow I, well, have to get on a plane again, so a little pressure is necessary...

(Honestly, this trip to Shanghai has completely unfolded into an entirely different storyline—I really never expected to have my cover blown like this. When I have a moment, I'll fill you all in

on the details.)

Chapter 31: All Those Chapters Before Sydney Ginn Are Gone

Two threads of memory were like neighboring rivers—after the banks dissolved, they were slowly beginning to converge. The surface of each reflected the other's ripples, until it was impossible to tell where memory ended and reality began.

Sydney Ginn lay collapsed on the ground, and above her field of vision loomed the belly of a massive candle.

For a moment she couldn't remember why she had fallen: had her left shoulder been cleaved off? Or had her throat been torn open?

All she knew was that she seemed to be losing blood rapidly.

With such grievous injuries, her body had not yet gone into shock, but her consciousness was already teetering on the edge of dissolution.

"I thought it over again, and I still think you're the Resident after all."

Her own voice rang out a few steps away, heavy with labored breathing. "I'm not sure why, but I feel like you weren't lying—maybe because I know myself. You said you had no information in your head about 'Resident copies having a time limit,' and I believe you. But there's one thing you overlooked. Do you know what it is?"

Sydney Ginn heard it, but it felt like there was a layer of something between her and the words—she listened through a fog and couldn't make sense of them.

She lay with eyes half-open, watching the candle not far away, as a transparent lake slowly formed across her body—as though the pool of blood beneath her were merely its reflection.

Perhaps this kind of death was fitting: watching another version of herself living and moving through a different time and place, oblivious and unaware, then slowly deciding when to close her eyes.

"When you got into the taxi, just like me, you gave up a stretch of memory. The memory you gave up was most likely the information about 'Resident copies having a time limit'—that's why you feel like you never knew it. And yet that was precisely what made it so convenient for you to latch onto my words, to treat them as a loophole, as proof that you were the real one..."

Even a dying Sydney Ginn understood that last sentence.

"So you're the Resident after all." Her other self concluded.

If I were the Resident, I wouldn't be dying here.

Sydney Ginn desperately wanted to say those words aloud, but her throat produced only a rattling sound. Her injured left shoulder seemed to have become a black abyss, and her focus, her consciousness, were draining away through it at terrifying speed—so much so that when she strained to turn her head slightly to the left, she didn't even dare glance at her own shoulder.

In her blood-stained field of vision, the other "Sydney Ginn" was bending down to pick up the fire axe.

The axe, still coated with her flesh and splinters of bone, had sunk too deep a moment ago and slipped from the Resident's grip, falling to the ground.

Sydney Ginn dimly recalled that after taking that axe blow, she had stumbled forward a few steps—at that moment, the fact of "shoulder severed" was still distant, not yet registered by her brain; her mind had been fixated on reaching the correct section of the candle.

That was why, when she could no longer hold on and finally crumpled to the ground, more than half her body had fallen beneath the candle.

"...Resident," she said softly, watching the silhouette bend down to lift the axe. "I'm not one."

"Ha."

The Resident didn't look up. It weighed the axe in its hand and let out a single syllable.

"Pants..." Each of her words was nearly weightless, barely even breath. "Taxi... took them."

Truly worthy of being another "Sydney Ginn"—it was like talking to herself; a few words that anyone else would have found incomprehensible made it pause, and it caught on quickly.

"You're saying that the memory the driver took from you in the taxi was actually the experience of buying your pants?"

To convey how absurd it was, it let out a deliberate laugh and said, "Are you delirious because you're about to die? This is the Nest—Hopscotch especially, strange and dangerous as it is. Right after fighting with me, when you got in the taxi and paid the fare, the very first thing that leapt into your mind was where you bought—"

It didn't finish the sentence. It stopped mid-word.

If this Resident hadn't copied Sydney Ginn, it would never have wasted half a second on such a ridiculous claim—it would have walked over, swung the axe, and ended her life.

But precisely because it had become "Sydney Ginn" completely and utterly, it suddenly froze, standing in place with the axe hanging at its side—and after two seconds, it looked down at the pants it was wearing.

A small sound escaped from its nose, like someone jarred awake early in the morning by an unwelcome phone call in the middle of a dream.

They say knowing oneself is the hardest thing in the world; but if a person has lived twenty-eight years without being utterly muddled and dull, they will have gained at least some degree of self-awareness.

Sydney Ginn shared one trait with a puppy not yet a year old—a pigeon flying past would make a puppy swivel its head, and a faint noise in the distance would make it prick its ears; Sydney Ginn was the same.

A neon sign with a letter missing a leg, the white feathers a bird flashed when it flapped its wings—both would intrude upon her attention, briefly stealing her focus away.

One of the Passenger Rules stated that you had to lower your head, hanging it between the driver's seat and the passenger seat.

What would happen after she followed that rule?

Sydney Ginn would find that part of her field of vision was her own thighs and pants.

"You're saying... you lowered your head, saw your pants, and involuntarily thought of the memory of buying them, and that was the memory the driver took?" The Resident stood in place, murmuring.

Sydney Ginn let out half a groan from her throat in answer.

"Absurd," said the Resident, standing still for a moment. "Impossible."

Even having made up its mind to kill Sydney Ginn regardless of who was real and who was false, it couldn't help but fall into thought—perhaps it was some part of Sydney Ginn's personality taking hold, or perhaps it was human nature, simply copied onto its body.

While it was lost in thought, Sydney Ginn had already made out the history unfolding in the Candlefall nearby. A tiny version of herself was giving instructions to a doorman: "...If anyone

suspicious shows up, don't let them ring my doorbell..."

She remembered—that was the day before she received the funeral wreath.

The Candlefall encasing that day was suspended just above her abdomen... the next day—today, the day she entered the Nest—would be right next to it, wouldn't it?

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes and imagined her right hand as a mole searching for its target, creeping along quietly.

Only by pretending it was not part of this body that was losing heat so rapidly could she manage to move it at all—only then could she feel her way forward and gently flip the next switch on the fire groove.

The left half of her body was flooded with a rush of cold wind; but the right half grew faintly, almost illusorily, warm.

She couldn't let the Resident notice what she was doing—otherwise it would know immediately what she intended.

The flame had only just leapt up, and the candle hadn't fully melted yet, but the Resident had already come back to itself, let out a breath, and spoken.

"Look at me, almost getting twisted up in your words. All this true-and-false, back-and-forth—I can't sort it out, and I don't need to. Same as before: kill you, and there's no problem left."

Buying a few seconds had already been difficult, yet it was still nowhere near enough; Sydney Ginn fought desperately against the dizziness, pulling her scattered consciousness together, while searching through the white fog of her mind for the next excuse.

She had to say something to divide the Resident's attention—fortunately, she was not someone who was hard to distract; that flaw had now become the very thing that might save her life.

"Can't..." Two words drifted from her lips, like dust disturbed by a breath.

The Resident walked toward her step by step, still carrying the blood-dripping fire axe, and asked, "Can't what?"

Sydney Ginn's mind was like a fire on the verge of going out; at the edge of losing consciousness, dizzy and faint, she let slip what was in her heart: "...Can't kill me."

The Resident let out a laugh, crouched down, and reached beneath the candle to grab her ankle. "And why not?"

Whether it was its hand or those words, something ignited a few bright red sparks in Sydney Ginn's mind.

She watched the large expanse of white wax on her body shudder and soften, slowly drooping lower, as if it were reaching down to close her eyes and spare her from further suffering.

"If I die... it proves you're the..."

The hand gripping her ankle paused.

The Resident let out a cold laugh from beyond the candle and said, "You want to say that because a Resident can't die, if you die, it proves I'm the Resident?"

She had never imagined that the one person in her life she could communicate with perfectly, without needing many words, would be a Nest Resident that had copied her own form.

Sydney Ginn narrowed her eyes, her trembling gaze settling on the Candlefall; a dark shape was finally beginning to emerge faintly within it, but not clearly enough—she wanted to see tonight's version of herself as soon as possible.

"The last time I killed you, I already understood. You are the Resident, but you don't believe yourself to be a Resident. You believe wholeheartedly that you are 'Sydney Ginn' herself—even the self-doubt you feel has become, in your mind, evidence that you are the real one.

"If we're talking about who believes it more completely, it's actually you, alright?"

"On the premise that you firmly believe you are the real person—if I inflict a fatal wound on your body, you will die from that wound. Haven't you heard of that experiment? A person's eyes are blindfolded, and they're told that a hot iron is about to be pressed against them; after artificially producing the sensation of pain, actual burn marks appear on their arm.

"That is the power of the mind at work. The reason I can kill you operates on exactly the same principle as that experiment."

"Sydney Ginn" spoke while dragging her; but one hand wasn't enough to move her, so she set down the fire axe and used both hands—Sydney Ginn slid across the floor like a heavy, lifeless piece of meat.

Inside the Candlefall, a tiny Sydney Ginn had just stepped out through a doorway. She was walking along Colorado Avenue, her steps still slightly unsteady from the alcohol that hadn't worn off, unaware that a human-shaped shadow had quietly fallen in behind her.

Just a little further—Hopscotch was almost visible.

That frantically struggling thought made bright red sparks flicker in the nearly extinguished fire of her mind; Sydney Ginn had no idea where the strength came from, but as she slid outward once more, she raised her hand and brushed it across the Candlefall.

She had watched the Resident manipulate the Candlefall and already knew how to adjust the timeline. Perhaps the heavens weren't yet willing to let her fall into a dead end here—in her dying struggle, Sydney Ginn adjusted the time to exactly the right moment: from within the Candlefall came her own voice cursing the Resident just before she got into the taxi: "Get lost!"

The sound rang out, and those hands loosened; her feet thudded to the ground.

"What did you do?" The Resident reacted instantly. "You want to keep 'Sydney Ginn' from being copied by 'the Resident'? You'll disappear—you're the Resident!"

It looked like it was about to lunge at her.

Sydney Ginn's right hand felt like an empty sack of skin, with no muscle, no blood, no strength; but she still gritted her teeth and shoved the tiny Sydney Ginn inside the taxi—her enormous fingers became a dividing wall, separating the tiny Sydney Ginn from Hopscotch.

Before Sydney Ginn finally lost consciousness, she saw through blurring vision that the tiny Sydney Ginn inside the Candlefall had not been copied.

The "Vulture" Resident within the Candlefall had not become another version of herself, either.

That meant... the stretch of history in which she had been "copied by the Resident" had been changed, erased, as if it had never happened at all.

Very soon, there would be only one Sydney Ginn waking up in the underground exhibition hall of the Museum of Modern Art.

And only when she looked back at the threads of memory in her mind would she know which Sydney Ginn had been the Resident, and which had been herself.

The flight was delayed again today—wasted my entire day. By the time I got home it was nearly nine at night, and I only just finished writing the update... Sorry for keeping everyone waiting so long.

There's actually a lot I want to share, but it's too late tonight—I'm dead on my feet. I'll save it for next time.

Because Sydney Ginn changed history, the seven or eight chapters before this have all disappeared—it's as if they never happened. Truly, go check if you don't believe me.

Chapter 32: Chase's Underground Pursuit

It was only after hanging up the phone that Kingsley thought of the one critical question—by which point Chase was still tearing through Blackmoor City like a man with a death wish, plowing through everything in his path as if the streets were empty.

Not that Kingsley could be blamed for the slow reaction: after watching a truck come thundering down on you, anyone who could immediately calm down and think clearly existed only in novels.

"Wait—you gave them the whole search area," she snapped upright with a start and said, "so when we reach our destination, won't we be walking straight into a police cordon?"

Chase had given a wide search area on purpose—to scatter the police and keep them from pinning down which direction he was actually heading; but on the whole, Kingsley's understanding was exactly right.

"Watch yourself," he said, wrenching the wheel into a hard turn and forcing the car off the main road into a dim, narrow alley. "You're talking like a criminal."

Kingsley quickly steadied herself and came back to her senses. "Oh, right—I was 'kidnapped' into this car..."

"Exactly. Remember that. In a little while, that's the only truth."

The other side mirror didn't survive either, knocked clean off against the alley wall; the already-dented Mercedes paid no attention to a row of trash cans blocking the way and plowed straight into them—clang—a can tumbled over the windshield, plunging the interior into momentary darkness.

Garbage bags split open; through a shower of flying trash raining down from every direction, the car burst through and came out filthy. The windshield wiper swept off a banana peel, but left a smear of sticky grime across the glass in its wake.

This car was finished anyway.

"What's your plan?" Kingsley asked.

"Open the glove box in front of you," Chase ordered. "There are zip ties inside—take them out and bind your own hands."

Kingsley raised her eyes, stared hopelessly at the sky for a few seconds, and finally resigned herself to it.

She fished out the zip ties, clamped them between her teeth, and with great difficulty managed to loop them halfway around both wrists—but couldn't fasten them, so she had to call on him for help. Chase reached back with one hand while still driving and pulled the zip ties tight.

When he drew his hand back, he couldn't help frowning—the zip ties were slick with saliva; Chase shot her a cold look and, with a firm backhand motion, wiped his hand hard on the shoulder of her denim jacket.

Kingsley let out a small, shameless laugh.

"This goes against every survival principle I've ever held," she muttered, raising her bound hands in front of her face like a bundle of tied flowers.

"You don't need to survive anything here." This wasn't the Nest.

"Fine, so what am I supposed to do in a moment? Stand there with my hands tied while you let yourself get caught, and I get dramatically rescued?"

"Stop talking nonsense."

Chase steered the car back onto a side road; the pursuing police cars were no longer visible behind him—but he knew that was only temporary. This area would already have police vehicles on patrol, ready to appear in his rearview mirror at any moment and lock onto him all over again.

"Almost at the destination," he said, eyes fixed on the road around him. "I'll slow down, but I won't stop. It's almost time—get ready, you may need to detect the Artifact at any moment. Do you want to be lightly injured or seriously injured?"

Kingsley stared at him. "I want to be not injured."

"If you think you can talk the police into letting you go with nothing to show for it—just with your mouth—then suit yourself. If you don't want to get hurt, it all comes down to how fast your reflexes are."

"What do you mean?"

The next moment, Kingsley understood exactly what Chase meant.

The moment the Brooklyn Community College Station sign came into view, Chase immediately slowed the car; he unbuckled his seatbelt, shoved the door open, and leapt out, rolling

off the road surface and springing to his feet in one motion, then broke into a full run toward the subway entrance—the driverless car immediately veered off course on the road, drifting toward the center of the lane.

"You just wait—when I'm back I'm demanding a contract renegotiation!" Kingsley swore and shouted from the car behind him.

A beat later, her voice rang out again: "It's here—it's really here!"

The Artifact had indeed entered Kingsley's detection range—it was on the next train, nearly at the station.

Chase didn't look back, but as he charged down into the subway station two steps at a time, he vaguely heard a dull impact from somewhere far up on the road.

The impact didn't sound serious—better than he had expected. It seemed Kingsley had managed to control the car in time, even with her hands bound.

Chase planted one hand on the subway turnstile and vaulted clear over the barrier, landing like a leopard; for such a tall frame—six-foot-five—his feet made only a soft thud on landing.

A few idle young men nearby who had been whispering to each other, passing something between them, looked up at him and burst out laughing, calling over: "Nice moves, man! But what—even guys in suits can't afford a ticket?"

Chase paid them no mind; within a few breaths he had already charged down to the platform, then immediately slowed his pace, glanced around once, and blended into the crowd of waiting passengers as if nothing had happened.

He checked the time: 10:33.

His suicidal driving had gotten him here three minutes earlier than the subway would have.

There would have been no shortage of witnesses to the moment he jumped out of the car and ran into the station; once the police arrived at the scene, they would immediately realize the suspect had gone into the subway, and the next move would naturally be to seal the exits and send people down to search—now all he could do was wait and see which came first: the train or the police.

He drew a long, slow breath and went over each step of what came next carefully in his mind.

One small slip, and he'd be trapped with no way out.

The first thing to deal with was...

Chase looked up at the security camera mounted in the corner of the platform.

Blackmoor City's subway system had been built and put into service around 1905, and most platforms still retained the look of the early twentieth century; the surveillance equipment installed in recent years always looked slightly out of place against the old station walls.

If he was caught on camera, even if he managed to shake off the pursuit later, it would be trouble down the line.

He reached into his jacket pocket and pulled out a remote control barely the length of a finger.

The remote had a small plastic display screen, currently lit with a single line of text—**【Countdown: 127 days, 21 hours, 36 minutes】** .

Below the screen were two buttons, one labeled "replace" and one labeled "cancel"; aside from looking cheaply made, they gave no indication whatsoever of what they were for.

Chase raised the remote, aimed it at his own throat, lightly pressed "replace," then slipped it back into his trouser pocket.

Not a single person waiting around him looked up; most had their eyes glued to their phone screens, and some had earbuds in, staring blankly at the tracks ahead, and at the platform on the opposite side of the tracks—which was empty, not a soul on it.

Even if someone had been watching Chase the whole time, they wouldn't have understood what he had just done.

The first time Chase had received this small remote from a House Faction Hunter's hands, he hadn't thought much of it.

Strangely enough, Artifacts from the Nest, no matter how unusual their appearance, seemed to follow rules similar to those of the real world: the more exquisite, valuable, and substantial something looked, the greater its power and purpose; if an Artifact felt like it was made of thin plastic, its functions were bound to be limited.

But that Hunter wore a smile of quiet confidence and said, "Try it and you'll see—the functions really are limited, but it's practical."

She took out her phone, opened the camera app in video mode, handed it to Chase, and stood in front of the lens herself.

Chase stared at the phone screen, watching as the Hunter leisurely picked up the remote, aimed it at her own throat, and pressed the "replace" button.

In the next moment on the screen, her entire head had transformed into a massive, snow-white goat's head; the goat's head wore a floor-length black robe, as if it had just stepped out of some medieval horror legend as a demon creature.

But looking at the Hunter herself, outside the screen, she was exactly as before: hair half-wavy and gathered behind her head, wearing outdated skinny jeans and a pair of sneakers—every bit the look of a middle-school kid's mom.

Most astonishing of all, even in the first few seconds of video recorded before she pressed "replace," the Hunter's face and head had already been replaced with the goat.

"Impressive, right?" said the goat's head on the screen, opening its mouth to speak. "Press the button, and your true face will never be recorded—on any device, all anyone sees is a big goat's head. And the effect can even be traced back one minute before you press it—so if you forget to activate it, you've got a full minute to cover yourself! An Artifact this thoughtful is rare in the Nest."

It was exactly what Chase had been looking for.

After a quick round of testing, he made his decision without hesitation: "The House Faction will take it—twenty thousand."

The one unfortunate thing was that this Artifact, once it left the Nest, could only exist for six months—which was also why Chase had valued it at only twenty thousand: by any measure, a six-month lifespan was simply too short.

"No need to feel bad about it," the middle-school mom said with a smile as she prepared to leave. "It's actually a blessing that Artifacts expire and disappear in the human world after leaving the Nest—that's exactly why we Hunters can keep doing this line of work indefinitely."

True enough.

Chase had no idea how many years the Nest had already existed, but the history was surely not short; generation after generation of Hunters had brought countless Artifacts back to the

human world, and if those Artifacts could exist forever, the world would have long since turned into a chaotic science-fiction film.

If someone were to review the surveillance footage afterward, they would find that at 10:33, on the departing-side platform, there had been a goat's head in a long black robe. It stood near the foot of the staircase, occasionally glancing up toward the entrance above, then lowering its head again, propping its face on one large hoof—looking for all the world like a pensive, deeply troubled goat.

That was Chase keeping his ears on the movements inside the subway station—as for the goat hoof, that was him raising his hand to cover his face.

After all, to everyone's naked eye he still looked like himself, so naturally the less he exposed, the better.

At 10:34, a faint stir of commotion drifted down from somewhere inside the station.

Hurried footsteps trod down from above the staircase; someone was asking "what's going on outside?", and someone else was asking, "is the subway still running?"

It seemed the police had arrived.

Chase glanced at the platform display screen: the departing train was also due to arrive at 10:36.

He drew a slow, deep breath—both the departing and returning trains arriving at the same time meant that a one- or two-second difference could mean the difference between his life and death.

10:35.

A group of people suddenly came barreling down the stairs with shouts and yells, landing on the floor and startling the passengers nearby—it was the same group of young men who had been whispering to each other at the subway entrance and had called out to compliment Chase earlier. One of them looked back and swore: "What are all these Blue Bags doing here?"

Chase moved to the far side of the staircase and stopped at the platform edge near the tracks. Blue Bags was slang, named for the blue color of the police uniform; some people also called them simply "bags."

He heard several sets of footsteps bearing down together—all keeping the same trained rhythm, urgent and heavy, mixed with the rustle of bulletproof vests and holsters—converging on the staircase all at once.

At most thirty seconds left until 10:36.

Wait one more second, he gritted his teeth and thought—one more second...

From the distant subway tunnel, a rumbling sound finally rolled back faintly—still far away, almost like an illusion, vibrating at the very edges of nerve and sense.

"Everyone on the platform," a voice suddenly shouted, "stay where you are! We are in pursuit of a dangerous driving suspect!"

Chase smiled.

The moment everyone's attention was drawn to the shouting figure, Chase leaped off the platform, landing lightly beside the rail—like a large cat sliding soundlessly off a rooftop.

By the time a passenger finally noticed and let out a low gasp, he was already sprinting across the subway tracks, lunging toward the platform on the other side—

"Stop!" someone shouted from behind. "Or I'll shoot!"

But the subway gave them no chance to shoot.

The train arriving at 10:36—the one carrying the Artifact—screamed out of the tunnel and hurtled toward Chase; its headlights blazed across half his body and the platform just a few feet ahead of him.

I've discovered that Shanghai has a certain force of gravity, best described as: easy to get in, hard to get out. The flattering comparison would be an American university; the unflattering one would be a cult—

Ugh, I still have to go back someday, so I'd better shut my mouth.

Anyway, I got to the airport at 11:30 last night and sat there until 4:30 in the afternoon before my flight finally took off.

At first I used my points to get into a VIP lounge—thought I'd only be waiting an hour, so sitting in the VIP lounge felt a little indulgent. Well, let me tell you, I have never in my life spent points so well; every single one came back to me threefold.

I sat there complaining to whoever would listen about how terrible the lounge chairs were—lumpy and sunken, like sitting in a torture device. Some VIP treatment. Then I went to the bathroom and realized this actually was a proper VIP lounge—because the toilets had a built-in intestinal cleanse mode. I stood there reading the sign on the wall encouraging everyone to hold it in and conserve water, and for a moment I felt actually lost.

Chapter 33: The Form of Chase's Artifact

When Chase scrambled up onto the platform and rolled frantically clear, the subway train grazed his back and screamed into the station—

The icy cold of the train's metal hull, the hard gust of wind it kicked up, felt as though it might shear every layer of flesh clean off his back; if he had reached up and found the back half of his skull missing, that would not have surprised him in the slightest.

Chase gasped and pushed himself up off the ground; the train had come to a gradual stop, and in the reflection on the carriage window, he was still in one piece.

...He had always been lucky.

The subway from this station rumbled in right on its heels, almost as if it had been arranged that way, blocking the police on the opposite platform; even if they wanted to follow Chase's example and come after him, they would have to take a long detour first, losing a good deal of time.

Through the trains, the shouts from the other platform were muffled, swaying and echoing through the station: "You two, go after him... block the other exit, check every person coming out!"

Chase couldn't help but laugh. He rolled his shoulders and neck, then tilted his head back and let out a breath.

For just one second, he allowed himself to sink into the rush of adrenaline flooding his veins, his whole body burning with the surge of his blood.

When he opened his eyes, all the subway doors were opening, and the arriving passengers were filing off the train onto the platform.

"Hey!" From the front of the train, a man in a driver's uniform stepped down and called out to Chase from a distance: "Are you out of your mind? You almost got yourself killed—"

Before the man could get a clear look at his face, Chase pivoted nimbly and melted into the stream of passengers heading for the exit. The driver muttered a few curses, then turned and walked back onto the train—at which point Chase immediately shoved aside the person next to him and, just before the carriage doors slid shut, bolted inside.

The entire train was empty. Not a single person.

He looked left and right; the carriages ahead and behind seemed to stretch on forever, the same circular handholds and plastic seats repeating endlessly. With just one element missing—people—the train became a narrow, monotonous alien corridor, like the inside of a roundworm's belly. Truly strange.

The train began to move, keeping to a low speed—it was probably heading onto the turnaround track to reverse and take on passengers again. Chase walked toward the rear of the train along the gently swaying floor, stepping into the last carriage.

Ad panels on the carriage walls, handholds, handrails, seats, graffiti, food wrappers, and a drink bottle tossed on the floor... it looked like an ordinary carriage. There were neither too many nor too few places to hide something.

...The part that required the most patience was about to begin.

That was fine.

Whether in the Nest or in the world outside, no matter what he was hunting, a good Hunter needed a great deal of patience—and Chase happened to have an abundance of it.

"If I were a clever idiot," he muttered under his breath, "...where would I hide an Artifact?"

To guess the answer to that question, he first had to know what kind of Artifact he was tracking.

Artifacts came in every conceivable form—countless shapes and manifestations, stretching beyond the limits of human imagination with no end in sight. But fortunately, he didn't need to search blindly and trust to luck; because any Hunter in Blackmoor City worth their salt had heard at least something about Wellesley's Artifacts.

What was more, Roland Key had been a Hunter for decades, with a network of connections in Blackmoor City as deep-rooted and far-reaching as an old tree; almost any intelligence related to Artifacts would inevitably drift past his ears sooner or later.

"I need you to get your hands on the Artifacts in Wellesley's study. Even just one will do."

Roland Key had summoned Chase the moment news of Wellesley's death arrived. Outside the window, the sky had still been a pale duck-egg blue, as though a thin haze hung over it; Chase

later learned that when he sat down at the breakfast table, Wellesley had been dead for exactly three hours.

At that moment, Mrs. Wellesley, alone in Blackmoor City, was still asleep—still unaware that she had become a widow.

And in another hour and twenty-one minutes, Ivan would leave the Wellesley Family Estate carrying the Artifacts he had stolen.

"The first Artifact—he bought it from me back in the day. It's a black cube, about ten centimeters on each side."

Roland Key's tone was flat. It was hard to tell whether he regretted the transaction now.

The Artifacts in Wellesley's hands had laid the foundation for a business empire that stood first in the world; looking at the wealth and influence he had accumulated afterward, it was almost puzzling why anyone had been willing to sell him all four Artifacts in the first place—perhaps that was Wellesley's singular gift: the ability to see a future in something that no one else could.

If anyone had known what they were truly worth, no one would ever have sold those Artifacts to Wellesley.

"The second is a set of tailor's tools."

Roland Key paused, then said: "I've heard this set of tailor's tools is roughly the size of a laptop—whether that's accurate, I can't say for certain. This Artifact is said to be the most precious and most important of the four. Getting your hands on it would be worth trading away an entire House Faction."

In his spare time, Chase had once tried to estimate the value of the Key House Faction.

Hunter House Factions were hard to define—they operated like criminal gangs but were structured like modern corporations, making them something of a hybrid between the two.

By corporate standards, the Key House Faction's valuation was well into the tens of millions—and yet, from the way Roland Key spoke, trading it away sounded like getting the better end of the deal?

"What does it do?" Chase asked.

"If you manage to get your hands on it, you'll know. Before then, the less you know, the better."

Chase nodded. "He has two more. What are they?"

Roland Key let out a sigh and set down his coffee cup.

"The later an Artifact came into his possession, the less complete my information on it... He sealed off a lot of the channels through which things leaked. The third is said to be extremely dangerous; from the time he acquired it, any opponent who couldn't be removed by money, power, law, or market forces would conveniently and neatly disappear from the world—oil merchants as far away as Yemen were no exception."

Beyond "extremely dangerous," he offered no further details—and Chase had not a single word of objection.

He was the person who solved problems for the Key House Faction; incomplete information was part of the problem he had been handed.

"And the fourth?"

Roland Key was silent for a few seconds.

"About that one, I've only ever heard one rumor," he said quietly. "...It is a rumor that creates rumors."

Chase even forgot to chew, letting the egg just sit on his tongue for a moment.

When he finally came back to himself and swallowed, he sought confirmation: "Uncle Key, you mean—the Artifact itself exists as a 'rumor,' its function is 'creating rumors'...and all of this is itself just a rumor you heard?"

Roland Key nodded and said: "Yes. Round and round it goes—enough to make your head spin for a while."

What would Wellesley want with a rumor that created rumors?

And for that matter, how would you even find a rumor?

But then, when it came to the Nest and Artifacts, no matter how strange or bizarre something seemed, you couldn't simply assume it didn't exist.

If the thing you were looking for was a "rumor"—invisible, intangible—it should at least make some sound, shouldn't it?

Since some Hunter had once managed to bring it back into the world, there was no reason Chase couldn't find it.

Standing in the train, he cocked his ear and listened for a while, gradually sorting and filing the ambient noise into categories in his mind: the friction of the wheels on the rail, the sound of air flowing through the vents, the material creaks of the train's moving parts... not a single one was close to a human voice.

Since no faint whispers were drifting over like something haunting the place, did that mean the fourth Artifact wasn't here?

He hadn't expected to find the Artifact right off the bat, anyway...

Chase sighed and, for the first time, found himself cursing his own height.

Like some oversized spider trying to fold up its legs, he lowered himself awkwardly to the floor and swept his gaze beneath the seats, taking in the full length of floor under the entire row at once: a forgotten shopping bag, an earbud, fire-suppression equipment, stains... and even a shoe, its owner presumably having stepped off the train with one bare foot.

It sounded like a lot, but in truth the space under most seats was empty—a single glance told him there was nothing there that could be called an Artifact. That said, even a piece of chewing gum was not something Chase could pass over lightly.

Chase pulled a short, dark baton from behind his back, snapped it open with two sharp clicks, and extended it into an arm-length, heavy rod—a T-shaped cast-iron head at one end, a threaded grip at the other.

Blackmoor State law prohibited citizens from carrying firearms in public, so sometimes being armed actually invited unnecessary trouble—who would have thought that his trusty, portable, never-leave-home-without-it weapon would find an entirely different use today.

Patient as he was, as Chase used his beloved weapon to poke through the assorted rubbish under the seats—nudging aside that foul-smelling shoe, prodding a piece of chewing gum, then straightening up and running his eyes over the carriage's ad panels—he still couldn't help feeling that this was exactly the kind of job that ought to be handed to a low-ranking rookie in the House Faction.

But a different person might not be as swift or thorough as he was; in just a few minutes, he had finished searching one entire carriage.

Chase stopped in his tracks and glanced out the train window.

The subway had not, as he had expected, headed up onto the turnaround track and looped back to the departure platform; instead, it had grown slower and slower until it stopped altogether.

Outside, the tunnel was dim, its yellowish light barely illuminating a wide expanse of ground—beneath a vault as vast as an empty cave, several tracks ran parallel and crossed one another, like a compressed bird's-eye view of a highway interchange.

This was clearly not a place meant for passengers... Where had the train taken him?

As Chase moved on to search the next carriage, he heard footsteps approaching from the other end.

As the person walked, a keychain jangled against them, and they hummed a vague tune—apparently they only knew one phrase, repeating it over and over: "baby please don't go."

Chase straightened up, T-bar in hand, and stood quietly in the center of the carriage, waiting.

A man in a subway employee's uniform walked toward the second carriage and stopped dead—it was the same train driver who had shouted at Chase moments ago.

"When did you get on?" His face immediately went stiff, barely holding down the confusion and faint fear beneath. "What are you doing here? This train is going out of service—you have to get off right now."

Out of service meant it wouldn't be taking any passengers for a while.

At his current pace, another forty minutes would be enough to search the entire train... Not looping back to take on passengers was actually more convenient for Chase; the only thing was, to stay on the train, it would be best to have the man in front of him cooperate.

Chase had a T-bar, and he also had a wallet packed with cash—in today's world of digital payments and credit cards, carrying cash in person served almost only one purpose.

Just as he was weighing which method to use to get the driver's cooperation, the driver looked at his face, then at the T-bar, and suddenly furrowed his brow—a fear he couldn't quite suppress slowly rising to the surface.

"You—you're not..." he said, stumbling back two steps. "I have a family. I have kids... please..."

Who does he think I am?

Chase was taken aback. He was always careful in what he did; outside of Hunter circles, almost no one knew who he was. How had he barely driven through a few streets before apparently having a fearsome reputation?

Wait... "fearsome reputation"?

A current shot through Chase's mind like lightning illuminating a thick bank of clouds; though the picture wasn't entirely clear, he seized on the one thought that mattered most.

The next moment, the driver murmured, "You—you're the subway serial killer from the rumors?"

Chase slowly licked his lips.

...He'd found an Artifact.

Friends, neighbors, I know some of you aren't fond of the shifting-perspective style, but this is my vision for the new story—each character's arc pieces together a larger world, a world where the characters influence and intertwine with one another, and just thinking about that gets me excited. No other approach to this story does that for me.

Compared to the traditional web novel method of following a single character's perspective straight through to the end, I will definitely lose a significant chunk of readers this way—my road just keeps getting narrower, I know, no need to remind me again. Thank you. This is the approach I chose for myself; nobody held a gun to my head. I'm the one who decided to go down this path.

Chapter 34: Chase's Logical Story

Ever since he'd started chasing the subway, Chase had been sitting with one nagging question.

Blackmoor City's subway fleet numbered at least several thousand cars, and cars could be split apart and recombined into new formations; once a train pulled away, it was like a stone sinking into the sea—the odds of encountering that exact same car again were about as good as winning the lottery—and on top of that, the trains were cleaned every single day.

How could Ivan be so certain he could get the Artifact back?

It was only when Chase watched the subway driver backing away step by step and then turning to run that the answer suddenly crystallized, taking shape in his mind.

The target Ivan needed to find again was never one of hundreds of identical, untraceable subway cars; it was a subway employee with a name, a face, and a fixed work schedule—if you couldn't track down a train, wasn't tracking down a person simple enough?

He almost wanted to laugh out loud. He'd thought Ivan was a clever idiot, yet he hadn't quite guessed where the idiocy ended and the genius began.

A priceless Artifact capable of rewriting a person's fate had truly been left by Ivan on a complete stranger—he couldn't decide whether that was stupidity or audacity; perhaps the two had never been all that different.

The truly brilliant part of Ivan's plan was that no one in the world besides Ivan himself could connect him to this fleeing subway driver—because in the vast sea of Blackmoor City's millions, the two of them were distant, randomly chosen strangers; between them, there had never been any connection whatsoever.

It seemed Ivan understood perfectly well that once someone had him in their sights, they would dig up and scrutinize even the delivery driver who'd brought him a pizza—to say nothing of anyone with an actual relationship to him.

A complete stranger, someone with whom he had never shared a single point of contact, was therefore the safest hiding place imaginable.

Once he'd placed the Artifact on the driver, he could move freely, approaching whoever he liked; in fact, the more people he contacted, the more he could mislead anyone tracking him and

drain their time and energy—hadn't Chase himself wasted no small amount of effort on that pizza delivery driver?

It appeared Ivan hadn't anticipated this angle, otherwise he wouldn't have stayed locked inside his room that day.

While he thought all this through, Chase extended one large hand and lightly grabbed the back of the driver's shirt.

When Chase's hand closed on the driver's back and yanked him down to the ground, the man looked as though he hadn't yet understood what had happened—he fell flat on his back, face blank with bewilderment, seemingly unable to figure out when Chase had appeared behind him.

It wasn't until the back of his head hit the floor with a thud that the driver snapped back to his senses; he sucked in sharp hisses of pain, and while scrambling to roll over and get up, cried out, "Please! I'm begging you, don't kill me—I haven't done anything!"

That part was probably true. But Chase had no intention of saying so aloud.

He pressed one large hand flat against the driver's chest, his long pale fingers splayed over the man's sternum like the bars of a cage.

Chase hadn't applied any force, yet the driver didn't dare move; his shadow fell over the driver's face like the canopy of a great tree.

"What—what are you going to do to me?" the driver asked, his voice trembling, propped up on his elbows, unwilling to fully rise and unable to fully lie back down.

He had, at least, asked the right question.

In truth, Chase hadn't expected that he would find the most incomprehensible Artifact of all in a manner quite like this.

He'd gotten the man in his hands—yet what came next, he found himself, unusually, at a complete loss.

To begin with, Ivan hadn't had the time or opportunity that day to fabricate a plausible excuse to trick the driver into taking something; the driver couldn't possibly know he was carrying an Artifact, and didn't look like someone who knew the passage existed or had any familiarity with the world of the Nest.

Besides, Ivan couldn't have entrusted the Artifact to anyone connected to the Nest—after all, it was only when the other party was an ordinary person with no knowledge of the Nest that he could hope to reclaim it.

Ivan must have attached the Artifact to the driver when the man wasn't paying attention.

The moment he thought of it that way, the questions multiplied.

What exactly was an Artifact that existed in the form of a "Rumor"? How did it attach to a person? What did it look like? How did you remove it?

"I—I'm still on duty; if they notice I'm not working in a bit, someone will definitely come to check on me..." the driver said softly, pleading, "Please let me go, I'm begging you. I have face blindness—I won't remember what you look like..."

Since reaching adulthood, Chase had never once met a person who, having seen him once, failed to recognize him the next time.

"No rush," he said quietly, and thought for a moment.

How do you extract the truth from a target who doesn't even know the truth himself?

He had interrogated more than a few people himself, yet he had never encountered a situation quite like this: the target clearly held the key information, yet still knew nothing at all.

Judging by Ivan's route that day, he'd had no time whatsoever for any real interaction; the Artifact must have changed hands in the space of a single passing encounter, and the driver might not even remember him.

The odds weren't good, but Chase decided to try anyway; after briefly describing Ivan's appearance, he was met, as expected, with a blank stare.

"Where did you hear about this 'subway serial killer'?" he thought it over, and decided to approach from an angle the driver might actually be able to speak to.

The driver darted a quick glance at him from the corner of his eye, then fixed his gaze hastily on a handrail in the distance.

He paused, then spoke tentatively, as if addressing the empty air: "...Well, a few nights ago, after the C Line shut down for the evening, wasn't a woman's body found? I remember it made the news."

Chase frowned.

That had indeed happened; but people dying in Blackmoor City was so commonplace that if the driver hadn't brought it up, that news item would have vanished from his memory forever.

"The subway staff thought she'd fallen asleep and forgotten to get off, but no matter how they called out she wouldn't wake up; the moment they nudged her shoulder, she rolled right off the seat onto the floor."

As he spoke, his gaze drifted to the seat beside him, as though he could see the body rolling to the ground right there. "The one who found her happened to be a colleague of mine—we sometimes play a few rounds of poker together... when he described it to me afterward, his face was as white as a sheet."

What did a person's death have to do with an Artifact—especially with "Rumor"? And how had the "subway serial killer" rumor even started?

The driver seemed to read something else into Chase's faint change of expression and hurried to explain: "Of course, the more I think about it, I'm sure I got it all wrong—you're distinguished-looking, tall and impressive, how could you possibly be a serial killer? Ah, I think it's just because I've been on edge lately, and when I'm alone on the subway I get a bit paranoid. The moment I saw you carrying that pole thing, my mind immediately jumped to the wrong place... The woman's body was slumped against the wall, so you couldn't tell anything at first—it was only after she rolled to the floor that my colleague saw the impact wound on her head..."

Some people, when seized by panic, open their mouths and can't stop—talking more and faster, as though trying to build a foundation they can stand on out of pure words; this driver was likely one of them.

Chase decided to stoke the fear higher, to burn a deeper hole in the man's composure.

He lowered his head and looked down at the driver, slowly spreading into a smile.

When Chase smiled, his lips went very thin. His teeth were white—not a bright, lustrous white, but the airless, deadened white of concrete. Teeth without any warmth of the living, packed tightly between those thin lips; when he smiled, they all showed at once, as though the lower half of his face had been unzipped.

"You see," Chase said quietly, "weaving a logically coherent story takes skill. That skill, you don't have."

"Huh? Me?" The driver jolted, as expected. "I'm not lying. That news story is real—look it up if you don't believe me! I saw the news and misunderstood you, it really was rude of me..."

The news story might be real, but it didn't explain his behavior.

"One death hardly makes for a serial killer," Chase said, like a careful editor hunting for inconsistencies. "Or rather—why did you assume the woman who died was killed by a serial killer?"

The driver's mouth fell slightly open, as if he'd been asked a question he'd never thought to ask himself.

A lump pushed up suddenly against one of his cheeks from inside, slid along the surface, and disappeared—as though he'd pressed his tongue against the inside of his cheek.

"I... you're misunderstanding, I haven't gotten to the second part yet. It's because the Brooklyn District has had bad security lately; after the woman's body was found, there was another assault. Someone got off the night shift, came up out of the subway station, and barely stuck their head out before someone hit them with a—I mean, with a club—to the head..."

He swallowed.

"The detectives who came to investigate called in quite a few people from the transit company for questioning. They didn't come out and say it, but from the way they talked, they suspected someone was committing a series of crimes..." The driver pushed his tongue against his cheek again before continuing: "That's how the rumor spread—I'm not lying to you. One of the detectives was quite pretty too, and her partner looked like a perfect match; there was a real air of something between them... All of this circulated together, everyone knows about it."

Chase was silent for a second or two.

Plenty of people talked without any filter when they were nervous, but this sudden spill of gossip still caught him off guard. "...What?"

"Quite an air of something between them,"

Under his fear and anxiety, the driver's words spilled out almost unstoppably, and he answered immediately: "The two of them were constantly trading remarks back and forth, no one else could get a word in edgewise. The man didn't seem to be a police officer—he was a criminology professor brought in from some university as a consultant, heard he'd been divorced once, don't know the details. Anyway..."

Chase released the hand pinning him down and took his phone out of his pocket.

Life was truly a strange and unpredictable thing.

For instance, this morning's version of himself could not have predicted that the midday version would be driving recklessly through Blackmoor City; and the version driving recklessly through Blackmoor City could never have predicted that thirty minutes later, he would be on a subway car, phone in hand, opening the App Store and downloading Netflix.

"What are you doing?" The driver's angle let him see Chase's phone screen, though not clearly enough to make anything out.

"You have an account," Chase said—not a question, but a statement. "...Log in."

"Wh—why?" The driver was thoroughly confused, but clearly didn't dare argue; he rapidly typed in his password and asked, "If I hand you my account, can I go?"

Chase said nothing and took back the phone.

On the home screen, under the "Continue Watching" row, several shows and films were lined up that had been played before; he scrolled through for a few seconds and had already locked onto his target.

He looked at the screen, then looked at the driver.

The man had no idea what he was doing, and still stared up with a blank face—beads of sweat faintly gleaming, mouth half-open, as though a small cavern had been cut into his face.

Unless this subway driver moonlighted as an Oscar-winning actor after his shift, it was obvious he had not the faintest awareness that the story he'd just told—about "a female detective and a male consultant jointly investigating a serial killer case"—was the plot of the first season of a crime detective series on Netflix, even though he had watched it.

Chase could no longer say his story wasn't coherent.

Hey everyone, I'm on a plane again today—not sure if I'll have time to write and post an update once I land, so here's this chapter for you first, eat up, eat up, come back for more if it's not enough. (As for when more dishes will arrive after you order—that I can't say.)

Chase's portion of the plot isn't as complex as Sydney Ginn's, but it ended up taking me the most time to research... Parts that a reader might skim past in a single glance still had to be nailed down when writing: for example, the same train at the same time on the same day—would

it be the same physical car? I searched and searched without finding an answer, and eventually went to Reddit to track down a channel run by a New York subway enthusiast (and somehow that niche hobby exists), posted a question... and finally got my answer: no, it wouldn't be the same car. Once a train pulls away, it's gone like a stone dropped into the sea.

Then there was the layout of the subway station, how spare trains turn around, this and that—plenty of research done, not much of it actually used.

Blackmoor City is fictional, but beyond that I want all the background details to be as true to life as possible—a fuller sense of reality makes for a better experience.

I'm finally heading home! My cat must have forgotten what I look like by now. No telling how many socks she's been stockpiling to ambush me with after this month away.

Chapter 35 — Folks, Grandmas, I'm Home

This whole trip absolutely wiped me out... curled up in my seat with my legs folded like a bird's, couldn't sleep properly, food was terrible, and after layovers, train transfers, subway switches, hauling luggage, and climbing stairs, I finally get home and—

Dust everywhere, like I'd stepped straight into the Sahara.

I normally use pine cat litter at home—clean and practically dustless—but it needs frequent scooping. Whenever I'm about to sit down and write, I make a point of trotting over to check: any droppings? Need scooping? Yes? Perfect, that's another ten minutes of not writing justified.

Since I had someone come over to look after the cats while I was away, I couldn't very well demand they show up three times a day on a strict scooping schedule, so I switched to regular cat litter. Good lord, the dust from that stuff—every single object in the apartment, whatever color it used to be, is now uniformly grey-white. My place looks like it got hit by a sandstorm. It's not fit to host the National People's Congress right now.

Vacuuming, mopping, wiping down the furniture—I was already half-dead—when I discovered a nest of laundry sitting in the washing machine. I'd washed it before I left... and it had been sitting in there, unremoved, this whole time. Use your imagination. Picture that smell. It's enough to cost you your life.

I ended up crouching on the floor dry-heaving out roughly half my soul.

Got everything cleaned up, but the smell wouldn't leave. In the midst of cat-poop fumes hanging over every inch of the apartment, I finally managed to make myself a cup of coffee and sit down (and let's see who can't help themselves from saying "cat poop coffee"), opened my laptop—and guess what, the screen wouldn't turn on.

I kept closing and opening the laptop over and over. Every now and then it would deign to light up for a moment; I'd type in my password, and it'd go black again—like a bashful young maiden.

AAAAAA

AAAAAAA

The beauty of the West Lake, in the month of June

The display screen is dead, so how am I typing right now? Because I have an e-ink external monitor... with extremely low resolution. Extremely blurry. Things like logging into an account and being asked to click on all the images with traffic lights—absolutely out of the question. All I can manage is typing text, where I can just barely tell which blobs are characters and which is the background.

How blurry are we talking? Anything that isn't your native language, you'd have a hard time making it out at all.

On the plane, when I was sitting there like a bird but wasn't completely exhausted yet, I wrote 980 characters. Several hours after getting home, I'm now at 1,020 characters.

Anyway, I'll post this chapter whenever I finish it. Right now my legs are shaking going up and down the stairs, my muscles have the texture of wood grain, and I have no idea why I'm this tired...

Chapter 36 — Chase Searches for the Passage Artifact

When Chase was young, Uncle Key would sometimes take him camping in the mountains.

Deep in the mountains, far from Blackmoor City's endless nocturnal noise, the world was pitch-black and still. Aside from a basin of red-glowing fire, only the stars overhead were visible; he had never seen such a pure night, as though even the forest had dissolved into outer space.

Uncle Key taught him to identify constellations, gently tracing lines between stars scattered across the sky, connecting them into the shape of a water dipper, a great bear... Mountain nights were cold, so Uncle Key always brought extra blankets. Young Chase sat beside him bundled head to toe, his gaze drifting through the universe.

Right now, in this moment, he found himself thinking again about those lines drawn between stars.

It was nowhere near as beautiful as a sky full of stars, but a few points of light seemed to be gradually surfacing on the subway driver in front of him — points that, once connected, would form a shape.

From that vague shape, he had formed a guess.

One: "A woman's body was discovered after the subway stopped running" — a fact, recent news.

Two: "Someone was attacked after finishing a night shift" — Chase wasn't yet certain whether this was true or false; it could easily be one of the hundreds of everyday news items in Blackmoor City.

Three: "A female detective and a male professor team up to investigate a serial case" — a TV drama.

That gave him the three elements that composed the Rumor.

Seen this way... Chase's appearance on the subway was like a sudden bolt of electricity, lighting up something in the driver's mind.

Before he had noticed Chase, the subway driver showed none of the so-called "paranoia" or "fear" he later described; when he was walking alone through the empty subway car, he had even been humming to himself.

Yet the moment he laid eyes on a tall man carrying a weapon, the driver clearly lost, for a brief instant, his ability to distinguish truth from fiction — the three points above were rapidly assembled and combined, and in the span of a single breath, a Rumor was created: "a serial killer has been stalking the subway lately."

What was interesting was that the moment the driver blurted the Rumor out, he himself believed wholeheartedly in what he had just created, and even grew worried for his own life over it.

...So this was how the Rumor Artifact operated?

By recombining and adapting raw information, it caused a finished Rumor to flow out of someone's mouth... but that was only the first step. What came next would probably only become clear once he had the Artifact itself in hand.

No — wait, perhaps it would be more accurate to say this was one of its operating modes.

From all the signs, the subway driver was merely an information bank stocked with enough relevant details, a mouth capable of passing the words along; he had no idea what had influenced him, and no awareness of it whatsoever. It was hard to imagine Wellesley allowing an Artifact to manipulate him rather than the other way around.

There had to be a way to use it actively, to manufacture Rumors on purpose; but that was not the most pressing question right now.

The most important question right now was getting the Artifact into his hands first.

Chase stared at the driver's cheek and watched what looked like something being pushed up by a tongue — a small bulge that slid past and vanished — it had happened several times now.

"Spit out whatever's in your mouth."

The driver stared. "My mouth? There's nothing in there."

Chase looked at him without a word.

"I mean it, there's nothing — I just have a habit of pressing my tongue against the inside of my cheek." Under Chase's gaze, the driver immediately grew flustered and said, in an appeasing tone: "If you don't believe me, I'll open up, take a look —"

Chase directed his gaze, with mild distaste, into that fleshy pink cavity.

He had seen plenty of human insides; he was used to it, yet always found them slick and unpleasant.

The inside of a person's mouth was a strange thing — stare at it long enough and it even brought to mind alien creatures: a red, trembling throat, a hairy tongue, everything perpetually sliding and rolling in a thin sheen of glistening liquid, as though it had a will of its own.

But however unappealing, they were not Artifacts; other than what should be in a person's mouth, there was nothing extra in the driver's.

Of course, Chase had never really expected the Artifact to be spat out that easily, so coming up empty didn't disappoint him — after all, if something was truly being held in the mouth, how could anyone not notice? Ivan couldn't have slipped something into someone's mouth without them knowing.

Although he still had no idea what form the Artifact took, if it was hidden inside the man's body, extracting it would likely mean drawing blood and getting his hands dirty... a subway car serving as a backup vehicle was not an ideal location for that. As the driver had said, someone might be coming soon.

Chase grabbed him by the collar and was just about to haul him up when the driver suddenly seemed to realize something and began struggling and kicking wildly, crying out: "Where are you taking me?"

He was a broad, heavy man, and anyone else might have had real trouble subduing him — but the moment Chase sensed the movement, he had already released his grip; in the same instant, his right foot swung sideways in a heavy kick directly onto the driver's ankle. The driver's cry of pain had barely left his mouth when Chase's T-bar plunged deep into his gut, driving the breath, balance, and strength all out of him at once, and he crumpled to the floor without another sound.

The driver didn't quite make it all the way down — Chase had already caught him by the back of his shirt, holding him like a bag of groceries.

Only this particular bag of groceries was rather large, and his legs were dragging limply along the floor.

"I'm very interested in this thing called Rumor," Chase said, hauling him along, his tone perfectly reasonable: "I just want to have a little chat. Whether that chat happens with all your limbs intact or not is entirely up to you."

The driver couldn't even breathe properly and could produce nothing but intermittent, indistinct groaning; Chase decided to take that as consent.

Not until he had dragged the man a few more steps did he faintly make out a few words from within the groaning — and Chase stopped.

He glanced out the window; the dark, silent subway tunnel showed no sign of anyone arriving any time soon.

"What did you say?" He bent down and prompted, in a tone that was almost gentle: "Say it more clearly."

The driver said it again, his voice thick and garbled.

Even with his imagination working at full stretch, Chase could only make out a few nonsensical syllables — something like "line," "broken," "electric" — which he couldn't assemble into any meaning at all.

He was about to ask the driver to repeat himself when something stirred in his mind.

He knew exactly how much force he had put into his own strikes, which was why he had deliberately held back just now. Besides, a single blow to the gut shouldn't leave someone unable to speak clearly more than ten seconds later.

Thinking about it that way... when the driver spoke just now, had he actually opened his mouth?

The thought seemed to prick him; he swung his arm and flung the man, who tumbled to the floor like a bundle of rags.

The driver's face flashed upward for an instant before he rolled facedown — in that brief moment, Chase had already seen clearly: the driver's face was stretched pale and taut, his lips pressed so tightly together they were barely visible; he looked as though he was fighting against something, jaw clenched hard, a tendon rising along his chin and leaping toward his temple.

His eyes had rolled back in his head, as though some deeply terrifying question was consuming him — the less he could make sense of it, the more frightened he became.

Just moments ago he had been frightened of Chase and couldn't stop talking; but now his lips were sealed tight, and he seemed to be afraid of something new entirely.

The next second, Chase understood where his fear was coming from.

The driver's head struck a handrail — just one knock, but it seemed to jar loose whatever tension he had been holding so rigidly in place.

He had not opened his mouth, yet from between his sealed lips came a human voice again, far clearer than before: "Car... electric light... wire, snapped, falling down..."

Had Chase been even a blink slower to understand, the electrical wire dropping from the ceiling might have run a current straight through his body — as it was, he only managed to throw himself clear at the last possible moment, crashing into the seats to one side, watching a shower of crackling sparks rake across the floor in front of him, the scattered embers drifting into the shape of a serpent.

Was this Artifact trying to protect itself?

The thought flared suddenly through Chase's mind.

The driver instinctively curled up and clutched his head; the wire hit the floor, missed him, bounced back up, and whipped through the air again, swinging straight toward Chase.

The car was not particularly wide, and the spot where the casing had come loose and the wire had fallen happened to be dead center; a live wire crackling and thrashing was already a serious problem — but as Chase swung his arm and drove the T-bar forward to knock the sparking end of the wire back several paces, he heard the voice from the driver's cheek again.

"Want to go home,"

Hearing it now, he realized it was a voice entirely unlike the subway driver's, speaking in rapid, blurred fragments: "Want to go home — passage — the passage through which people can enter the Nest —"

For one instant, Chase thought he had been struck by the wire.

Every pore on his body went numb and tingling; he found himself afraid to move, as though afraid of startling it, afraid it would not be able to keep speaking. The scar on the back of his right hand stirred awake, tightening and contracting the skin in waves.

Chase stood dazed before the seats, one hand still resting on the plastic backrest. Everything in the world seemed to recede from his awareness except for the voice beneath the driver's cheek, and he was back again in that dark, still mountain forest of his childhood. The difference was that in this darkness, there was only one point of starlight he could see.

"...None." The voice beneath the driver's cheek said.

The wire sprang back into the air, a string of electric sparks tracing an arc through the darkness and falling at Chase's feet.

He heard his own heart slam against his ribcage with a dull thud, unable to break free, sliding back down into the depths of the dark.

In the dead silence, he became aware that he had stepped forward, legs stiff, fingers closing around the fabric of the driver's shirt — yet his hand seemed somehow very far away from him.

This meaningless body of his also seemed very far away.

"Resident,"

As the driver was hauled upright by him, feet barely finding the floor, another sound came from between the man's closed lips. "A passage through which one can come into the human world — there is one. One Resident."

The driver's heavy panting, the rush of air from the subway car's ventilation system, the crackling of the wire... it was as though a floodgate had been lifted, and every sound and sensation came pouring back into Chase's awareness at once.

"Make it quiet," Chase said through clenched teeth, forcing four words out in the driver's direction.

After those four words, his peripheral vision told him that up ahead, a pane of black glass was bowing inward toward the car's interior, as though pressed from the outside by something enormous.

I know this might sound like I'm making excuses for myself, but yesterday when I was so exhausted my head was spinning, I actually got stuck at 1,500 words and couldn't push through — the plot felt like it had hit a dead end, and I had no idea who'd written the first 1,500 words or who was supposed to take it from there. Anyway, I couldn't do it, because my brain is a block of wood.

Didn't sleep well today either (cat noise, early morning meeting, not enough sleep), but at least I did sleep, and when I sat back down to write it was different — somehow the images and ideas were there, and somehow I finished it.

And after finishing it I'm actually a little pleased with myself? Especially pleased with the part where Chase is completely let down. (laughs)

Chapter 37: The Thing Chase Hates Most

Time — he needed time.

In the span of just twenty or thirty seconds, one unexpected twist had followed another, each one catching him off guard and defying all comprehension.

But Chase knew that given even a little time, he could connect the dots between each "point of light" and assemble them into a clear, legible picture.

The world might be chaotic and complex, but Chase believed it could always be understood this way: first, seize enough key pieces of information from the chaos and noise, then use each point to illuminate the broader picture, connecting them into a shape that brought the whole framework to the surface.

The only problem was that time was precisely what he had the least of right now.

When Chase turned his head and his gaze landed on that pitch-black pane of glass bulging high into the car's interior, he knew he had made an unavoidable mistake — there was no way he wouldn't look at the window; no one could have resisted. But the moment he looked, his attention had been stolen away.

In that split second of distraction, the wire that had just been torn free crackled and sparked behind him, whipping through the air toward the back of his head.

Even the air seemed twisted and taut with the current; he could almost smell the electric sparks, and the skin on the back of his neck felt as though a flash of blue were scorching across it.

...No matter how skilled a person was, they couldn't move faster than electricity.

Chase closed his eyes.

The moment of waiting for the shock stretched out impossibly long; memories of the electric jolts he had endured years ago in search of a passage rose to the surface, like a preview of the piercing pain about to come.

But after a single breath, Chase opened his eyes again.

The crack of current striking flesh, a pained grunt, the thud of a body hitting the floor — he heard all of it; yet the current itself, he felt nothing of it.

Someone had been electrocuted, but it wasn't him.

Chase snapped his head around, and sure enough, the driver was sprawled on the floor behind him, his complexion ashen and sickly, body curled and convulsing in waves, as though some tendon deep inside him had been seized and yanked taut — he couldn't straighten up, and he couldn't escape. The wire had lost its earlier frenzy and hung limp on the floor nearby, motionless, as if ashamed of what it had done.

Chase glanced at the car window swelling like a balloon, then glanced back at the driver lying a step behind him; for a moment, he almost laughed.

"I forgot to mention," he said, picking the T-bar up from the floor and weighing it in his hand. "I have very good luck, because I tend to drain the luck from everyone around me."

The driver couldn't speak at all; even his consciousness seemed to be fading.

"Just now, you followed my gaze and turned to look at that window too, didn't you? I was distracted at that moment, and I let go of you." Chase wasn't looking for an answer from the driver — he needed to work through everything in front of him himself. He fixed his eyes on the window and said, "You saw the window looking like that, and it terrified you. You stumbled back a step, and in doing so, you took the shock that was meant for me. Am I right?"

A low rumble rolled up from the driver's throat.

So it seemed that the Rumor Artifact couldn't control the physical movements of its host — otherwise the driver wouldn't have stumbled backward onto the wire out of sheer fear.

"I have you to thank, because you took that shock for me, and now I have a little time."

Chase gripped the T-bar and walked step by step toward the window ahead, which looked as though it were nine months pregnant. When he was two paces away, he swung the T-bar high and brought his full weight down — driving it straight into the pitch-black glass. No shattering sound came; instead, the window yielded like a sheet of rubber, caving inward and swallowing all his force without resistance.

Behind the window was most likely a Resident capable of entering the human world — it was only natural that the T-bar would have no effect on it.

"What I'm about to say isn't for you," he continued, "but for whatever is inside your mouth... Rumor, right? That's what I can call you, isn't it?"

The driver lay on the floor, drifting in and out of consciousness; the voice beneath his cheek had gone quiet too, as if in tacit agreement.

"For an Artifact, you possess a certain degree of intelligence — enough to protect yourself. That's remarkably rare. But you don't have true self-awareness, and your intelligence only goes so far; otherwise, you wouldn't be an Artifact at all. You'd be a Resident."

From the window that had swelled like a breath of air, the shape of a human hand emerged; it pressed against the glass from behind, and a five-fingered outline rose to the surface, slowly feeling its way around.

Wherever the hand groped, Chase's gaze followed.

"If your intelligence were high enough, you would have realized earlier that when I threatened the driver and went after him, it wasn't because I wanted to hurt him — it was to get to you. But that chain of cause and effect is too complex for you to grasp. You didn't understand it... you only have raw instinct.

"When the driver you're inhabiting felt his life was threatened and he fell into a state of fear and panic, your survival instinct was triggered too. I don't know what you look like, but you seem to need a person to exist within. If that person dies, you'd be in serious trouble, wouldn't you?"

The driver had stopped convulsing and lay still on the floor; a thread of consciousness still lingered in him, his eyelids half-open and faintly trembling.

From between his barely parted lips, a tiny voice was speaking rapidly: "Help, help!" — as though crying out on the driver's behalf.

Chase turned his gaze back to the window. In the swollen black glass, a distorted reflection of himself stared back; as the corner of his mouth curved up, the reflection showed half a twisted smile in return.

"Who exactly are you calling for help?"

Chase didn't know whether other people's lives were as full of ironic, dark humor as his own — if he weren't the one living it, he could almost laugh out loud.

After all, half the reason the driver was so terrified in the first place was because the Artifact had conjured the rumor of a "subway serial killer," convincing the driver he'd run into one — which also indirectly proved that Rumor didn't have a particularly high level of intelligence.

It hadn't realized that the rumors it created at random could turn around and affect its own host.

"From the 'subway killer' and the 'loose wire,' I can see that you can't conjure things out of thin air — you can't just say something and make it appear.

"Whatever you say has to be grounded in some existing reality. If no one had ever died on the subway, you couldn't have invented the rumor of a 'subway killer'; if there were no wires here, you couldn't have willed an extra wire into existence from nothing.

"The wire couldn't kill me, so you called in a Resident capable of entering the human world... but you don't truly want to return to the Nest — you just sensed that the Nest is somewhere you could hide from me."

A dark tide of ink-black surged up inside Chase, and for an instant he felt a violent urge — to close his hands around the Resident behind the window and wring it into powder and fragments.

Sometimes he wished he could use these same hands to wring his entire life into pieces.

His words fell, and the cabin sank into a brief, dead silence.

The Artifact made no sound; the driver's breathing was faint as a dying thread. The hand behind the window had finally felt its way to where the glass met the window frame, and like someone unpicking stitches, it began slowly tearing the glass downward.

"I don't know how low your intelligence really is. But if you can understand a single word I'm saying, you'd do well to send the Resident back to the Nest right now..."

If this Artifact had truly wanted to go home, it would have had countless opportunities before today.

There were bound to be Hunters around Wellesley, and every Hunter had a passage — it could have hitched a ride back with any of them. And even if it couldn't reach a Hunter, why hadn't it called on this Resident capable of entering the human world long before now?

"Help..."

The Artifact spoke again, this time slowly; after listening to Chase, it seemed to hesitate a little itself, and when it called for help again, there was a question mark at the end: "Help?"

"I'm asking you to send it back for two reasons." Chase's tone was calm. "First, once the Resident comes through, I can protect myself, but I can't guarantee your host's life."

Several grayish-white fingertips had begun to push in through the gap between the glass and the frame. Chase watched them and said quietly, "Second... you have a decent read on things. You're right that I have no passage, and I can't enter the Nest."

For a moment, both the Resident and the Artifact seemed to be waiting for him to continue.

"However, this is not the first time I've encountered a Resident."

Chase watched his own reflection and slowly rolled his shoulders and neck.

"The thing I hate most is a Resident that can enter the human world. Every time I see one, I can't help but lose my temper a little. Fortunately, they're rare, so I don't lose my temper very often.

"But today, you called one right to my door."

Chase let out a quiet sigh.

"If you truly want to protect yourself, I suggest you stop making me angry."

Rushing through it all, I finally managed to get a chapter out before the day ended!

Now that I'm slowly getting back into my regular routine, I should start thinking about bonus updates for everyone... Ugh, if I took a month off starting today but counted all the updates during that month as bonus chapters, would that be a little too sneaky? It'd be written all over my face.

P.S.: Barring anything unexpected, updates will be in the evenings from now on. I've still got my day job, and there's a mountain of work that's piled up.

Chapter 38: Chase's Second Memory

"Chase, Chase, wake up—time to go home."

A hand gently nudged his shoulder, and his dream cracked open at the seam; fragments slid away and drifted off, and Chase opened his eyes.

The horizon had already faded to a pale violet, long clouds dyed deep crimson, as though someone had dragged a finger across the sky and left streaks of rouge behind.

The shadows of palm trees stood tall beneath the sky, and in the evening parking lot, dim amber lights flickered on one by one.

"Sleeping so soundly—what were you dreaming about?"

His mother stood outside the car window; seeing him awake, she pulled her hand back from the half-open window and straightened up. Chase couldn't quite make out her expression, but he heard a trace of guilt in her voice. Her tone was very soft, because guilt is a softening agent.

Chase couldn't remember. The light in the dream had been very bright—far brighter than this western evening in the parking lot; he had been very tall, far taller than he was now.

But whatever he had actually dreamed, he had forgotten it entirely.

"No overtime today?" he asked, watching his mother open the car door and settle into the driver's seat on the other side.

"I begged my manager to let me leave early today." His mother glanced at him, and a hint of a smile surfaced, but it couldn't break through some heavy lid pressing down on it, and faded away. "I didn't even dare tell him you'd been waiting in the car for me all day..."

"Why didn't you dare?"

His mother set a plastic bag on the back seat; the smell of food inside was familiar. She always brought home leftovers from the restaurant for the two of them to eat as dinner. She started the car and said, "It's not exactly something to be proud of. If anyone found out, child protective services might come and take you away."

Chase didn't understand what was wrong with sitting in the car waiting for his mother to get off work—the window was half open, a soft breeze drifted in, his fingers were sticky with chip

crumbs, and the storybook on his knees had slid to the floor while he slept.

"I'm sorry. It won't happen again. When you grow up, don't go complaining to a therapist about me. Buckle your seatbelt."

It would happen again, of course, because the only person willing to watch Chase for next to nothing was a neighbor girl nearby, and she didn't have time every day.

Later, Chase thought that what he had truly wanted to say back then was "I like waiting for you"—but somehow, what actually came out was a complaint: "I want to go home and watch TV."

"Okay," his mother said, pulling out of the parking lot. "Not until after dinner."

By the time they got on the highway, the sky had gone completely dark; bright headlights cut through the night, sweeping past their old car one after another. The highway sat high up, with a mountain cliff on the left; looking out from the road, you could see all the way to the distant horizon.

The vast, sprawling city of Los Angeles lit up beneath the night sky with countless lights, like stars.

This was a road they had traveled countless times, as familiar as their own kitchen. Chase kept watching the L.A. nightscape through the window; his mother was listening to the radio, and the two of them chatted idly.

Everything happened before anyone could react: when a heavy freight truck ahead suddenly lurched sideways and crashed through the right guardrail at an angle, his mother was still mid-laugh.

Her sharp intake of breath made Chase snap his head around, just in time to see that long truck jackknifed across the highway ahead of them.

The shriek of the emergency brakes tore through the entire cabin, but the car still couldn't overcome its own momentum and kept hurtling straight toward the truck—Chase was pinned into his seat by the seatbelt, watching the truck grow larger and larger, like an overwhelming catastrophe bearing down on him, and in that moment he forgot whether he had screamed.

He only remembered turning his head and seeing the driver's seat empty.

The seatbelt was still buckled in its clasp, lying flat across the driver's seat as though it were protecting an empty chair; the steering wheel, freed from the hands that had held it, turned ever so

slightly.

...Huh?

The bewilderment lasted only a flash; by the time Chase came to his senses and lunged for the steering wheel, he slammed into the truck—in that instant, the front of the car crumpled and buckled upward, swallowing most of the window and his field of vision, and a moment later Chase sank into darkness and knew nothing at all.

Ah, right—Chase Monroe died in a car accident when he was five years old.

...He did die, didn't he?

Something felt off, though.

If Chase Monroe had died at age five... then who was the person now recalling this from his perspective, who believed he had died?

A small voice raised a faint objection.

Does it matter who is doing the remembering? And whether he died or not—that doesn't matter either.

What truly mattered was this: if he stopped all this pointless thinking and simply sank down through the warm, amniotic darkness, closed his eyes and drifted off to sleep, then every struggle and confusion would find comfort and answer... nothing to worry about anymore...

Nothing to... worry about...

Absolutely not.

Chase's eyes snapped open.

He was lying on the floor; the nearly blinding white light of the subway car, for just a moment, left him unable to see anything at all.

Some instinct that jolted awake from deep in his bones was the first thing to suppress his reflex to roll over and spring up; he forced himself to stay completely still, listening as a soft rustling on the floor swept past his ear and slowly receded.

His vision cleared quickly, and he found himself lying in front of a window that had lost its glass.

He still remembered how, just moments ago, the glass of that window had bulged outward like a rubber balloon, with several gray-white fingers prying at the gap between the glass and the window frame; now the window was empty, and all that remained were shards of broken glass scattered across the floor and the seats.

The Resident had already crawled in through the window, entering this human world...

But no matter how hard Chase tried, he couldn't remember why he had ended up on the floor.

When he fell, the back of his head must have struck the seat first before hitting the floor; his neck was twisted at an awkward angle now, a dull ache running through it.

He listened as the rustling came to a stop a few steps away, and from the driver's throat came a low, trembling moan—the moan had barely begun when it cut off abruptly, as though it had been strangled.

Dead?

Chase's heart sank. That Artifact—

"...So you are, con—scious," a sticky, glutinous voice said, in a deeply unnatural cadence: "Good then."

It was the Resident.

"So you're conscious—good then." That line was directed at the driver, which meant the driver wasn't dead yet, at least for now...

Chase held his breath and slowly rolled his eyes to the side, making out a blurry gray-white shadow standing not far away on the floor; it was hard to tell clearly, but it seemed as though that shadow had its back to him.

His abdominal muscles tightened inch by inch, and he silently, soundlessly lifted himself off the floor, spotting the T-bar lying by his feet. He didn't reach for it.

From the state of things, it looked as if he had gone down before he'd had the chance to do anything at all...

That hunched, curled-up figure had a very short build, barely reaching Chase's waist. Its entire body was wrapped in a gray-white robe, ragged and torn in many places, shredded into strips.

From beneath the gray-white robe, one gray-white palm—larger than a mop head—lay limp against the floor, facing upward; the other hand was raised in the air, three long fingers extended, one of which was now bending down toward the driver.

"Mem—ories that, can be, died in. Three, places."

Once the cadence went wrong, even the meaning was hard to grasp on first hearing; Chase paused slightly before understanding that it was saying "memories that can be died in—three locations."

Which meant—

Chase understood everything all at once.

He jolted with alarm and, no longer caring about concealing himself, stamped his foot down on the driver's ankle and shouted furiously, "Wake up—don't listen to it, you're not dead!"

He had effectively exposed himself—before the next thought could even form, a face swiveled around on that hunched back, spinning toward him.

The moment his gaze landed on that face, the subway car once again rapidly blurred, dissolved, and slid into darkness; Chase stumbled involuntarily backward onto the seat behind him, the Resident's sticky laughter sounding in his ears.

"Mem—ories that, can be, died in. Thir—ty-nine, places."

So that's how it was...

That faint mixture of indignation, fear, and agitation, as he tumbled back into the memory, dissipated rapidly from the edges of his consciousness like gray smoke.

If the car accident when he was five was the first memory the Resident had found—one in which he could conveniently die while reliving it—then Chase now knew what the second memory it had found was.

The second time his life had been in danger was six days after the car accident.

It was also the day his mother came back from the Nest.

Chapter 39 — The First Resident Chase Ever Saw

At first, the ward was a constant stream of people coming and going.

Unfamiliar faces drifted in and out, their features blurring together until Chase could no longer tell one from another. He remembered traffic officers, nurses, doctors, detectives, social workers... every vague, flesh-colored face would open its mouth and pour an endless torrent of questions over him.

Who is your mother?

Where did you get on the highway?

Did you notice the car door — was it closed? Did she jump out of the moving car?

What about your father? Oh, you've never met him?

Are there any other relatives at home?

Other than being able to answer "My mother's name is Daisy Monroe," Chase couldn't answer a single question.

Chase used to sometimes imagine that he actually had a father — a CIA agent, deep undercover abroad, or a top scientist working on a classified project and therefore unable to meet him. The ordinary fantasies of a child.

But during those days, Chase sat alone on the hospital bed with his arm in a cast, watching one stranger after another walk in and walk out, leaving behind snacks, empty paper coffee cups, cigarette butts, business cards, and an endless stream of questions.

Every naive fantasy he'd once held peeled away before reality, like shedding a skin he had long since outgrown.

"It's just me," he told the police officer. "There's only me left at home now."

That day, he heard a few people talking by the door — whether they were police officers or social workers or something else entirely, a child had no easy way of telling.

"I've worked this job for decades, and I've never seen a mother run off like this," the middle-aged man said, chewing tobacco. "Parents who walk out the door in the morning and never come back — that's common enough... but how did she manage to vanish from a car accident?"

"Strange, isn't it. You can't make out from the scene evidence how she disappeared at all," said another, younger-looking man. "Though it's ironic, when you think about it — if she hadn't suddenly vanished, that kid probably would have ended up with more than just a broken arm."

"Oh, right, you mentioned something about that before. Something about the direction of the front of the car?"

"Right. You've heard how, when drivers face a sudden emergency, they instinctively jerk the wheel to the left, so the passenger side takes the impact? That's not always the case — some drivers steer toward whatever has more clearance. But in this particular accident, that boy's mother had no choice but to steer left—"

Because on the right was a cliff.

That answer surfaced in Chase's mind at the same moment the middle-aged man let out a low "Oh."

"She probably hadn't finished turning the wheel yet — or had only just started — when she vanished from the driver's seat. She let go, the wheel returned to center, right? According to what the boy said, after he realized his mother was gone, he instinctively reached out and grabbed the wheel... In doing so, he nudged the car slightly to the right — but not too far right, just enough that it didn't smash through the guardrail and go over the cliff. Instead, by some perfect coincidence, the boy came away with the lightest possible injuries. It's like a miracle."

"Lucky kid," the middle-aged man said, then stopped himself. "...No, you can't really call him lucky. Five years old, and now he has neither a father nor a mother. What happens next?"

"His mother has a distant aunt living in Blackmoor City who's agreed to come and look after him for a few days," a third person cut in. "Whether she's willing to take on long-term guardianship is another question... If she's not, the boy will have to go to an orphanage or a foster family."

Chase was discharged on the third day, carrying one broken arm in a cast and a medical bill he had no idea what to do with.

His aunt was getting on in years — her glasses were always sliding down to the tip of her nose, and she started dozing off every night at eight o'clock. She and Chase had no idea how to be around each other, and the small apartment that had once been noisy and busy fell as quiet as if no one lived there at all.

On the sixth night after the accident, Chase could not sleep no matter what he tried.

The pain in his arm was one thing; once his aunt fell asleep she snored constantly, and every time he lifted his head, there was a strange, mountain-like silhouette sleeping in his mother's bed.

By midnight, Chase couldn't take the boredom and the misery any longer. He crept out of bed and made his way into the living room. There was nothing in the living room either — he thought he wanted to play with his toys, but he stared at the box for a while and didn't even reach out to open it.

Chase walked to the window and looked down at the familiar street below, empty of people.

If only Mom could come back, he thought. Right now — walking back up the street, wearing the clothes she had on the day she disappeared, carrying the snacks and breakfast she'd bought for him, her keys jangling with every step...

Though he was only five, Chase already understood that his imaginings would not come true.

So when he truly saw his mother walking up the street toward him, step by step, the shock made him lurch forward — thunk — and bang his face against the glass.

"...Mom?" he called softly.

The apartment was on the second floor, still a good distance from his mother, yet she looked up at him as if she'd heard.

In that instant, Chase didn't move, his forehead pressed against the cold glass.

Half of his mother's face was covered in blood.

In the darkness, the blood was blacker than the night itself, making half her face look as though it had been swallowed by nothingness. One eye couldn't open; only the eye sunken in that dark, bloodied ruin was looking at him, its pupil faintly gleaming.

But it was unmistakably his mother.

The moment their eyes met, his mother stretched out her hand and waved at him hard, the way she used to when she came to pick him up from kindergarten; then she kept on limping and stumbling toward the apartment, nearly tripping once in her hurry.

In a moment like this he should have gone and woken his aunt at once, but in that instant Chase didn't even remember there was an aunt in the apartment; he ran straight to the door, threw it open, and clattered down the stairs.

"Mom!"

Chase ran toward her as fast as he could, and if his mother hadn't quickly reached out to steady him, he would have thrown himself — cast and all — right into her arms. "Mom, what happened to you?"

"I tripped and fell," his mother said, gasping, bent half over, managing a small laugh. "It hurts so much. Your arm—"

"Where did you go?"

His mother looked him over for a moment before she said, "A... a very strange place. But it doesn't matter. I'm back now. Don't worry — I'll never go there again..."

At those words, whatever force had been holding her up and carrying her home seemed to give way all at once; she collapsed on the roadside like a stack of building blocks someone had suddenly kicked over.

"Mom?" Chase was startled and rushed to support her.

In truth he couldn't really support her — it was more like he threw his arms around hers and tumbled down to the ground alongside her.

But his mother waved her hand, signaling that she was all right. "I'm just tired... let me rest a moment... is it just you at home?"

"Aunt came from Blackmoor City," Chase answered.

"Go home... have her call an ambulance..."

Chase looked down and found that the front of his body, his arm, and his cast were all stained with blood.

"Go... go on." His mother's voice was faint, as if a breath of wind could scatter it.

Chase nodded hard, over and over. Before he got up, somehow his hand began to tremble, and he reached out and gently touched his mother's side.

Perhaps he wanted to find where she was hurt and how badly, but what he touched was something strange.

"Mom," Chase said, startled. "What is this wrapped around you?"

In that moment, his mother's face went still.

In his entire life, Chase had never seen a face so terrifying — because the person that face belonged to had herself been swallowed whole by bottomless fear.

A fear as dense and suffocating as cement slowly pressed the air flat. For one fleeting instant, Chase had the sudden urge to make himself very small, invisible to everyone — including his mother.

His mother didn't look down at her waist, as if by not looking she could keep her fear from becoming real. That one eye that could still open was locked on Chase, and whether tears had gathered in it or not, it shone with a frightening brightness.

"Wh... what? There's something wrapped around me... what is it?"

Chase didn't realize until now that he had been crying, tears crawling down his face in a steady, itchy stream.

"I... I don't know," he said, not understanding what he was so afraid of, unable even to pull his hand away — it still rested at his mother's waist, trembling. "It... it feels like a thin rope..."

Just then, he felt the rope stir faintly beneath his hand.

As if the other end had been given a tug.

The other end...

Chase dimly realized that the rope around his mother's waist must have another end.

"Don't look,"

he heard his mother say, pleading, "don't look behind you, Chase... go home, run..."

But Chase couldn't hear her. His body seemed to have been taken over by another version of himself; he rose to his feet without meaning to, stepped to the side, and let his gaze fall on the ground behind his mother.

A rope lay slack there, stretching back into the night, disappearing gradually into a darkness no streetlight could reach.

...Strange. Who had tied a rope to his mother?

The rope moved again.

"Chase! Come back!"

Chase startled, and only then realized that he had been walking forward along the rope without knowing it, several steps already. He looked back at his mother, then turned again — and this time, ahead of him was not only darkness, a street, and a long rope.

The massive dark shape holding the other end of the rope was standing before him, and he had no idea when it had appeared.

"Run!" His mother's cry, nearly a shriek, jolted Chase sharply back to himself.

He had no time to make out the shape of that shadow. He spun and ran. He thought he screamed — or maybe he didn't; he thought a neighbor's light came on — or maybe it didn't.

In that moment, the world suddenly dropped the facade of rational order and exposed the dark, murky nightmare churning beneath, and nothing felt real anymore.

He heard the shadow speak.

Its voice stretched across the night, drifting through the air.

At the time he couldn't understand the words, yet every single one was carved deep into his bones; later Chase came to understand what they meant, but by then so much time had passed, everything was too late, and he simply never let himself think about it again.

Only once — while interrogating a traitor — did those words the Resident had spoken leap unbidden into his mind.

By the time Chase came back to himself, someone was holding him around the waist, begging him to stop; the traitor had already been beaten by his fists into a pulp of flesh, barely more human in shape than a heap of mud.

"Thank you so much,"

the Resident had said. "The only way I can enter the human world is to find a dog, tie a rope to it, and have it lead me in. You didn't really think you escaped from me, did you? You really thought you could come back and be reunited with your son? Oh, let me have a taste... I've heard that a human being's shattered hope is the most delicious thing there is."

I thought about it for a while, and in the end I've settled on Daisy for Chase's mother's name.

Chapter 40: Chase Is Very, Very, Very Simple

Had he been wrong?

When five-year-old Chase bolted madly forward a few steps, he suddenly remembered that his injured mother was still lying at the roadside.

In that moment, instinct stopped him cold, and without a second thought he spun around and lunged back toward her, wanting to help her up and run with her—was he not supposed to do that? Had he been wrong?

"I told you to run!"

His mother's shriek in that moment was sharp and piercing, almost nothing like the heavily wounded woman who had been unable to speak just moments before.

"Mom—"

He grabbed his mother's arm and only managed to cry out that single word.

The next second, he watched his own feet dangling in midair, swaying and drifting away from the ground.

His mother tilted up a face half-blackened with blood, frozen for a split second in shock and terror, then suddenly screamed: "Let him go!"

The thing had not gripped Chase, nor had it lifted him by the collar.

He realized, belatedly, that a long black shadow had pierced through his chest and stretched out into the air—like a blade run clean through him—holding him suspended in midair. But Chase felt no pain, and he wasn't bleeding; he had only lost all strength in his body, and his head hung heavy, too weak to lift.

"No rush," the Resident hummed from behind him. "I don't think you've fully grasped the beauty of the situation before you. Let me explain it carefully."

His mother's voice drifted through its words like a whimpering howl.

"The flavor I most love to savor and appreciate is 'irony.' That kind of thing only flourishes in humans—the Nest has none of it.

"The disappointment of a person who buys a lottery ticket and doesn't win is still disappointment, yet it tastes plain and dull, like a cup of instant noodles—it fills you up, but that's all. Your disappointment right now, however, is an exquisite delicacy. Why? Because your hope has been dashed with irony. A losing lottery ticket lacks that particular flavor. I must make you understand this beauty completely, or I'll be driven half-mad with longing."

The Resident jostled Chase up and down a few times and let out a satisfied sigh.

"First of all, your passage simply delights me to no end. Only in a car accident can you enter the Nest—no wonder you're thirty-six years old and only now opening your passage for the first time... But if this car accident had happened a few months earlier, none of tonight would exist. Do you know why?"

His mother's gaze was fixed on Chase, swaying gently with him in the air.

"Because the residential population of your region of Los Angeles only surpassed ten million this year. Look at you—if the accident had happened earlier, it would have just been ordinary bad luck; and if you had moved away this year, the way you'd always planned, you would never have entered the Nest for the rest of your life... Isn't the timing of the accident especially ironic? Especially delicious?"

Chase dimly recalled that his mother had indeed once asked him whether he'd be willing to move back to her hometown.

It was just that at the time, he still couldn't understand what moving or not moving had to do with any of this.

"You thought you escaped, never knowing you became my guide dog and led me into the human world—already quite good. If you had called the police for help the moment you arrived and been sent to a hospital, wouldn't that have been dreadfully dull? I would naturally have left then and gone to find another human.

"But you didn't go to a hospital. Your first thought was to go home and check on your child, to make sure he was safe—and in doing so, you exposed him directly to me... How wonderful.

"If you didn't love him so much, he wouldn't be dying tonight."

Chase knew he was crying, and he also knew he wasn't crying for himself.

His mother's whimpering and wailing from the ground terrified him far more than the black shadow piercing through his chest.

He used to think he had a superpower—whenever his mother was unhappy, he could always make her laugh with just a few words—but tonight, that superpower seemed like the conceited dream of some other five-year-old child.

"Don't bother calling for help—who could save you?"

"Haven't you noticed that the neighbor who just opened their window to look has already closed it again and gone back to sleep? Ordinary humans with no passage and no prior contact with a Resident simply cannot see me... nor can they see the child I've skewered in midair. Right now, you're nothing but a madwoman sitting by the road in the middle of the night, crying."

In the Resident's grasp, Chase was like a piece of meat on a skewer.

With a sudden swoosh, it swung him through the air in a wide arc past his mother's face—as she lunged forward and grabbed at nothing—then hoisted Chase high once more.

"Oh my, the two of you crying together, mother and child—you've even made me sad. Don't be like this; I do have a shred of mercy. How about this: I'll give you a choice."

His mother stared blankly upward, a glimmer of wetness bright in one eye—though it was not the gleam of hope.

"Residents who can cross into the human world are very, very, very rare—not even one in ten years. Far fewer than the humans who have passages. Isn't that unfair?"

The Resident clicked its tongue—if it had a tongue.

"The conditions for crossing over are hard to meet, extremely demanding, and after all that effort, one careless misstep and you fall right back into the Nest. Now, I'm going to tell you how to send me back."

His mother went completely still. She murmured: "Wha... what?"

"Very, very, very simple. You still have a rope around your waist, don't you? It's actually a part of me. All you have to do is cut it, and the passage I used to enter the human world will be severed—I'll naturally return to the Nest. You don't believe me, do you?"

"Well, there's nothing I can do about that. All I can say is that for us Residents who've crossed into the human world, once our passage is cut, we fall right back into the Nest. It's that simple. If you don't believe me, try it."

"The choice," his mother pressed one hand to her waist, breathing hard as she asked: "You said you'd give me... a choice. What is it?"

"Oh, just whether or not to cut the rope."

The moment those words landed, the air went quiet for a second or two in bewilderment. Chase couldn't see clearly, but his mother had certainly furrowed her brow.

"I... why would I... not cut it? You have... a trap..."

"Wrong—there's no trap." The Resident said matter-of-factly: "I am a very, very, very trustworthy person. If I allow you to cut the rope, I will absolutely not stop you. The rope can grow back anyway. But you'd better think carefully before you cut it."

Chase felt himself being lifted, hanging high beside a vast, flat black shadow; the Resident seemed to rub Chase against what served as its face a few times, almost affectionately.

"Your little one, I won't be letting go.

"So your choices are: one, don't cut the rope—I stay, and I kill both you and your child; two, cut the rope—I take your child's corpse back to the Nest with me, and you keep your own life."

Chase felt the flat black shadow that was its face swell outward in a bulge, pushing his body up a little—the Resident was laughing.

"I promise, your child will die tonight without fail. The only difference is whether you want to die alongside him."

That sharp, anguished shriek his mother let out—even after all these years—still lodged in Chase's chest like a blade.

He had died after all, it seemed—no matter what his mother had chosen that night, he had been killed by the Resident without a doubt...

A voice in his mind that did not belong to Chase kept persuading him: that's right, you died that night. Don't you remember? That small body in a cast, hitting the ground with a thud, falling right before your mother's eyes...

Residents who could cross into the human world—were they really so rare?

One had come when he was five. Now another had come.

...He had not, of course, died that night.

Chase refused to die in the moment of the car accident, because if he had died then, he would never be able to see his mother one last time.

He still remembered, to this day, the warmth of his mother's arms around his shoulders that night.

Chase equally refused to die at the Resident's hands, for reasons somewhat more complex: first, the Resident had been badly wounded that night and driven back to the Nest, so the last remnant of reason buried deep in his mind would not allow him to believe the Resident had killed him then; second, if five-year-old him had died that night, he would never have been lifted from a pool of blood by Uncle Key.

He strained to lift his neck, his mind hazy, wanting to turn and look at his mother one last time—but Roland Key's hand covered his eyes.

"Listen... listen to him, go quickly," his mother's last broken words rose from the warm darkness of that palm. "From now on, Mom... is leaving you in his care."

If he had never met Uncle Key, he would never have known what had truly happened to his mother that night, and there would be no place left in the world to hold the remnants of his soul.

Chase's consciousness returned to the subway car—this time, he did not open his eyes.

He sat up soundlessly, and in deep focus, his five senses sharpened and amplified severalfold: he traced the faint rustling sounds, the faint raw-flesh scent from the Resident's body, the subway driver's breathing... and mapped out the layout of the car in his mind.

To drive the Resident back into the Nest—"very, very, very simple."

All he had to do was cut off the path by which it had come.

Lately, after finishing each chapter, I write a few hundred extra words to save up for bonus updates... The idea is good, but the pace is really a bit too slow.

Chapter 41: Chase, Did You Think the Rumor Had Stopped Spreading?

"Hm? Hmm hmm hmm?"

A long, sharp sound of bewilderment rose from the Resident's throat, as though it couldn't fathom why Chase simply refused to die inside a memory and kept dragging himself up off the ground again and again.

"Can die, go to memo, ry thir, ty-eight——"

It had just said "thirty-nine" a moment ago, Chase thought. So it's counting down.

A memory that had already been used once couldn't be used to attack him again, could it?

Good. He was thoroughly sick of that helpless, useless, five-year-old child who could do nothing but wail.

His contempt for weakness far surpassed even what he felt for the Resident.

Chase shut his eyes tight and drew a long, deep breath.

"Hmm hmm hmm hmm hmm?" Seeing him still standing, the Resident seemed deeply displeased; its voice turned far more grating: "Thir, ty-eight——"

"Stop that," Chase said quietly. "As long as I can't see your face, I won't black out. That's how it works."

Every time his gaze landed on its face, he immediately toppled over and sank into a memory. Even a fool could draw a line between cause and effect.

"By any Resident's standard, you're a crude, inferior thing." Chase spoke as he stepped back. "You've hardly any new tricks, but your weaknesses are plentiful——"

Before he could finish, a gust of wind swept toward him head-on.

The soft smack of bare feet against the floor, the faint current of air stirred by countless shredded strips of cloth swaying, and the thick, viscous, bloody smell that grew dense all at once

With his eyes closed, his other senses sharpened.

Chase stepped back again; his shoe crunched onto broken glass with a grating creak, and he knew he had reached the window the Resident had crawled through.

He suddenly dropped into a crouch, reached forward and grabbed — his hand plunged into what felt like a sticky, pestilential fog — and sure enough closed around a fistful of fabric. The nauseating, familiar electric shock of physical contact with a Resident jolted from his palm all the way up to the crown of his head — his chest was seized in return, and the Resident let out a short, triumphant laugh.

Chase knew why it laughed.

It probably assumed Chase would be too overwhelmed to move; most people, during their first few encounters of physical contact with a Resident, were hit so hard by the physiological effects that they couldn't even stay on their feet.

But it didn't know that compared to the Resident from when he was five, it was nothing more than cheap merchandise.

Chase gritted his teeth against the trembling in his muscles, closed all five fingers tight around the Resident's chest robe, swung his arm, and hurled it hard through the broken window beside them.

The Resident only managed a single "Huh?" — the next instant it had already slammed down onto the tracks outside the window with a distant, heavy thud.

Now came the real question — what was the passage this Resident had used to enter the human world?

It had crawled in through "a pitch-black train window," but that surely wasn't the only condition.

Otherwise, there was no shortage of "pitch-black windows" in everyday life — it could have entered the human world long ago. Why would it have waited until now?

Beyond the condition of "a pitch-black train window," at least one other condition must also have been met for it to crawl into the human world — no matter how he turned it over in his mind, Chase could only think of one.

In a flash he had already opened his eyes, broken into a sprint across the carriage, swept his arm down midway to scoop up the T-bar, and skidded to a stop beside the half-unconscious train driver.

"Rumor — send it back."

Chase could already hear rustling from outside the window behind him, as though the Resident was trying to crawl back in. He raised the T-bar high and said, "Otherwise I'll turn your host into pulp right now."

He never made empty threats.

The instant the T-bar bit into the train driver's shoulder, the tiny voice inside the driver's cheek shrieked in rapid succession: "Cancel the invitation to 'Nostalgia Attack'! Cancel the invitation to 'Nostalgia Attack'!"

.....What a terrible name.

Chase exhaled sharply and lifted the T-bar free from the driver's shoulder bone. He stood there and waited a second or two; the carriage was bright with white light, utterly silent.

Slowly, he turned to look at the window the Resident had crawled through.

He had actually braced himself to see a human body hanging half out of the window, to see a face smiling back at him — but the window was empty, with only a few fragments of broken glass still standing in the frame, oblivious to the fact that they had become useless.

Chase carried the T-bar and walked toward the window step by step; he was careful, and didn't look directly with his own eyes — he simply opened his phone camera and swept it across the view outside through the screen.

If the other party was a Resident, it would naturally be fond of playing mind games, and might well be crouching just outside the carriage, both hands pressed over its mouth, snickering and waiting to see him disappointed.

But outside was nothing more than a dim subway tunnel, empty and quiet.

He walked back across the floor of broken glass and the driver's pained groaning, and returned to stand before Rumor.

A single blow to the shoulder had jolted the driver out of near-unconsciousness; now, seeing Chase approach, he was whimpering and trying to inch backward — Chase pressed the tip of the T-bar against his chest and said, "Don't move."

The driver went still, his face all fear and cold sweat. "Jus— just now, that was....."

"A dream," Chase said flatly. "You had a nightmare."

If the expression on the driver's face could be rendered in words, it would be roughly: "Even if you're going to lie to me, you could at least put some effort into it."

But Chase had never liked dealing with loose ends and cleanup, and had no patience for finding reasonable explanations for everything that had just happened. He was considering how to retrieve the Rumor Artifact when the driver spoke again.

"Something in my mouth……what's in my mouth?" the driver said, dazed and disoriented. "You just called it Rumor……why Rumor again……"

Chase's attention snapped upright like a dog's ear catching an unfamiliar sound.

"Again'?" He leaned in, startling a hiccup out of the driver. "Who else said the word 'Rumor'?"

Whether from physical pain or sheer terror, the driver's lower lip was wet and trembling. "A few days ago, someone said they'd lost their glasses and couldn't see clearly, and asked me to read a couple of lines for them……"

Chase froze, and didn't interrupt.

"He asked me whether what was written said 'I have a Rumor to tell you.' I looked at his phone and said no — it said 'I heard a Rumor'……It was a strange thing, and nobody knew who had sent him that nonsensical message, so I remembered it."

"What did he look like?" Chase asked immediately.

"I don't know……" the driver said, trembling. "He was wearing a mask. All I could tell was that he was a man, somewhere in his twenties or thirties."

No wonder the driver had shown no reaction when describing Ivan's appearance earlier — for a moment, Chase almost wanted to burst out laughing.

He understood everything now.

The answer turned out to be this simple; knowing it, and then looking back, it was almost strange that he hadn't thought of it himself.

Since the Artifact in question was a "Rumor," the way to pass it along was of course through "words," wasn't it?

The person who had asked the driver to read a message that day was, without question, Ivan.

Ivan's purpose wasn't merely to have the driver read a message — he had been tricking him into completing a conversation:

"Now say it once: 'I have a Rumor to tell you.'"

Chase watched the small bulge in the driver's cheek, pushed up by a tongue, slide away again. "Once you say that, I'll leave immediately and won't touch you again."

"Rea— really?" The driver blanked for a moment, then latched onto this lifeline. "I— I have a Rumor to tell you!"

Chase drew a long, slow breath.

".....I heard a Rumor," he answered quietly.

The exchange was complete.

The carriage fell into silence. Chase looked at the driver's cheek; his face showed not a flicker of movement.

Chase suddenly felt his own tongue, beyond his control, lick the inside of his mouth — and then settle back into place.

He slowly broke into a grin.

"You.....you said you'd leave....." the driver trembled and propped himself up, inching backward, eyes fixed on Chase. "You can't....."

"Relax."

Chase stood up and pulled a wallet from his inner jacket pocket. He drew out the entire thick stack of bills and tossed them onto the driver. "Consider it my compensation for the undeserved ordeal. When you call the police, mind what you say."

When the driver's eyes fell on the money, Chase turned and left.

He would certainly call the police at the first opportunity — Chase couldn't care less.

"Rumor," Chase murmured as he stepped onto the platform. "How much time do you have left?"

He waited patiently, and sure enough heard a small voice from inside his own cheek:

"'Rumor,' countdown: 3,405 days, 16 hours, 15 minutes."

Chase did a rough calculation. Worthy of being Wellesley's Artifact — first-rate in every respect, with nearly nine years and four months of remaining use — worth noting that many Artifacts, when they first left the Nest, didn't come with nearly that much time.

It must have been in Wellesley's hands for quite a few years already. After Wellesley died, how had it passed from a dead man's mouth into Ivan's?

Chase couldn't work out the answer for the moment.

The officers pursuing him seemed to have assumed he'd long since slipped in among the disembarking passengers and left.

He reached up and roughed up his own hair, letting his bangs fall down to cover his forehead, then stripped off his jacket and dress shirt and discarded them, keeping only the white short-sleeve underneath, and walked out of the subway station more or less openly — there were a few officers stationed to watch the exits, and one called out: "Hey!"

Chase stopped and asked in a mild, cooperative tone: "Officer, what is it?"

The officer looked him up and down.

When he had crossed the tracks earlier, all the officers had caught was a suited figure from behind, and with the dim lighting in the tunnel, Chase was confident they couldn't recognize him. He was tall, but that wasn't uncommon.

"Where are you coming from?"

"Ninth Street."

"When did you get off?"

"Just now. I used the restroom and it took a little while."

The officer thought for a moment, waved a hand, and said, "Understood, thanks for your cooperation. You're free to go."

As Chase was about to leave, he suddenly found himself asking without quite meaning to: ".....I heard there's a serial killer targeting the subway. Is that right?"

The officer paused.

"Oh.....right," he said, as though slowly surfacing from a memory; he glanced at his colleague beside him first, then said: "Yeah, there is that Rumor.....but the person we're after

today isn't him. Or, well — probably not."

"Good luck, Officer." Chase smiled, turned, and walked out of the subway station.

Honestly, I'm pretty pleased with the part about Chase's childhood — let me have a little moment. His arc wraps up in one more chapter!

Chapter 42: The Root of the Chase-Sydney Enigma

Chase sat on a park bench, staring straight ahead with an unfocused gaze.

His elbows rested on his knees, his upper body hunched forward; both hands hung loosely, and a T-bar was tucked into the back of his waistband.

Everyone who passed along the path in front of him made a point of quietly stepping back a few paces and giving him a wide berth; the space within several meters of Chase was completely empty.

A moment ago, two young women had been walking over from a distance, chatting and giggling softly to each other as they glanced his way, but the moment they got close, their expressions changed, their eyes fixed straight ahead, and they hurried past with quickened steps.

When people spotted a madman, their reaction was always more or less the same: they had to sneak sidelong glances to track where the madman was, what he was doing, and how far away he was—yet at the same time had to keep a blank face, look right through him, and put distance between themselves as fast as possible.

In truth, this wasn't the first time in Chase's life that people had taken him for a madman; he'd even been called one to his face more than a few times.

But in the past it had always been because he came across as vicious and brutal, heavy-handed enough to kill—never, not once, for a reason like today's.

Leaving the subway station had been some ten-odd minutes ago.

By rights, his first move should have been to return to Key House Faction, hand the "Rumor" Artifact over to Uncle Key, then contact Kingsley and bring her back from police custody—but before he could even flag down a cab, Chase had been forced to abandon his original plan and duck into a small park first.

...Because the "Rumor" Artifact was using his lips, teeth, and tongue—his own voice—to speak, sentence after sentence, without pause.

He had lost control of his own tongue; no matter how hard he tried to press it down, it kept springing back up, shaping new words inside his mouth.

Whether it was the struggle against the Artifact that had twisted his expression, or whether it was the unstoppable muttering to himself, either way he had drawn stares from everyone along the way, and people were going out of their way to avoid him.

Being stared at by strangers didn't bother Chase.

But the Artifact spoke at a tremendous speed, and whenever a car horn blared on the road or a jackhammer started up at a construction site, he'd miss whatever it had just said—words that came out of his own mouth, yet even Chase had no idea what they would be before he heard them.

He had been so close to handing it over to Uncle Key, yet he was forced to suppress that urgency and sit patiently through every last sentence the Artifact spoke, hoping to understand as much as he could about how it operated and what hidden dangers it might carry.

Because he had to make sure that every Artifact he placed in Uncle Key's hands was, at the very minimum, safe.

"After you create a rumor and spread it, what happens next?" he had asked as he walked out of the subway station.

Who could have guessed that the "Rumor" Artifact would turn out to be such a chatterbox?

A single question seemed to open the floodgates.

The subway driver had certainly never asked his own mouth that question, never activating the Artifact, so he'd had no idea that something like this was even possible: the Artifact lacked the ability to say so much all at once on its own, so it had conscripted Chase's tongue and had been rattling on ever since, with no sign of stopping.

Its intelligence might not be high, but the sheer volume of information it contained was absolutely enormous.

"...This breaks down into four aspects. One, the generation of a rumor; two, the spread of a rumor; three, changes in a rumor's credibility; four, the consequences of a rumor. Each aspect is further subdivided into several sub-categories according to various different situations. I will now begin with the first aspect..."

How to describe this feeling?

It was like someone staring at a PDF that was several hundred pages long and should have been printed as reading material, then reading it aloud to you at a furious speed—using your own

mouth—the sensation was bizarre, the information overwhelming, and the moment your attention slipped for even an instant you lost track of what had been said, with no way to ask for a repeat, because your mouth had been commandeered.

And so Chase sat on the park bench, the upper half of his face blank, the lower half very busy.

"...Under ideal conditions, a rumor constructed from a blend of real information can spread rapidly through an environment and population that suits it. It is worth noting, however, that at this stage a rumor may be circulating without necessarily being believed by everyone, and at this point everyone still knows it is merely a rumor, with the possibility of being disproven.

"The shorter a rumor is, the less distortion it undergoes in the course of transmission. Once it reaches a sufficient number of people in its original form—that is, the first variable—the rumor acquires a certain degree of credibility...We can treat the environment in which a rumor exists as a system; once credibility reaches the second variable, the rumor, as a 'macro-theme' within the system, generates quantum responses with multiple 'butterfly effects.'"

Chase desperately wished he could tell it to speak plainly, but he couldn't say a word himself.

"Let's use an example," the Artifact finally produced from Chase's mouth the words he had been waiting to hear.

"Suppose you release a rumor that reads: 'Nest Elementary's Xiao Ming gets diarrhea after eating people.'

"Assume the real materials composing this rumor are: one, Xiao Ming does indeed exist; two, Residents in the Nest do occasionally eat people; three, Xiao Ming sometimes gets diarrhea."

...Right, note to self: remind the House Faction Hunters to bathe regularly.

"...The rumor is relatively short, and the Nest is an environment conducive to transmission... Let us assume it successfully reaches both the 'number of transmissions' and 'credibility' variables. What happens next?

"Multiple seemingly unrelated factors already present in the Nest will at this point become 'butterfly effects.' What is a 'butterfly effect'? It is precisely the initial condition that causes change in a chaotic system, as in the butterfly effect.

"For example, Xiao Ming has a younger sister, Xiao Mei. Xiao Mei normally eats Xiao Ming every Wednesday evening, but after hearing the rumor, she decides he isn't very clean, so this

Wednesday she does not eat him."

...Never mind the passersby—Chase, listening to the voice coming out of his own mouth, felt very much like he himself had gone mad.

"'Hungry Xiao Mei' becomes the first 'butterfly effect.'

"The second 'butterfly effect': assume there is a Hunter who has been captured. The Hunter suggests to the Resident who caught him that they not kill him, and in exchange, he designs that Resident a battle-royale arena."

Chase's mouth and tongue had gone completely dry, but the Artifact paid no mind.

"After all, this is only an example, so for simplicity's sake, let's keep it to two 'butterfly effects.'

"Hungry Xiao Mei ventures out to find food and eats one of the arena's contestants. To compensate the arena's owner, she hands Xiao Ming over to him.

"The arena owner wants to select the most outstanding children, and inspired by the recent rumor, names the arena 'Nest Elementary'...And so the result of this rumor is that a 'Nest Elementary' truly comes to exist within the Nest."

Chase was taken aback.

He had assumed the rumor's consequence would be that "Xiao Ming gets diarrhea from eating people" would come true—the feeling was like stepping on empty air.

"You see, the part of this rumor that can come true might be 'Xiao Ming gets diarrhea from eating people,' or it might be 'Xiao Ming eats people,' or it might be 'a Nest Elementary exists'... The reason the last outcome appeared is that the 'butterfly effects' in the Nest's environment steered the result toward 'Nest Elementary.'

"If we substituted different 'butterfly effects,' then the part that comes true could be 'Xiao Ming gets diarrhea from eating people.'"

Sure enough, the Artifact then went on at length about another example.

With different "butterfly effects" in play, the result was that Xiao Ming started getting diarrhea when he ate people.

In short, its operating pattern was: create a rumor—people hear the rumor—people believe the rumor—"butterfly effects" (if any) begin to interact with the rumor—and finally, the rumor comes true, or it does not.

...So in order to make a rumor come true in the way you wanted, you had to narrow down the range of possible outcomes it might produce—was that it?

By the time Chase arrived at this conclusion, his own mouth had already finished saying several more sentences.

If, before spreading the rumor, one were to set up appropriate "butterfly effects" in the environment in advance—like planting foreshadowing—it might be possible to steer the rumor toward a desired outcome...

He had only been thinking for a few seconds, but his mouth had already moved on to a different direction, shifting from theoretical function to concrete application. Chase quickly pulled his attention back and kept listening for a while, until he suddenly heard himself say: "...In that case, the rumors previously created by all prior hosts of 'Rumor' can serve as operational references for the new host."

...Wait, did it mean that he could look up the rumors Wellesley had previously created?

"As long as the host does not delete them, every rumor is recorded for later retrieval."

The Artifact paused for the first time at that point, as if waiting for Chase's response.

"Tell me,"

Chase was finally able to speak with his own tongue: "what was the rumor before the 'Subway Serial Killer'?"

Given the command, the Artifact answered quickly—fast enough that he nearly bit his own tongue.

"The 'Vulture' in the Nest can copy a target human and become a second version of that person, then use their passage to enter the human world."

Chase's hands suddenly clenched together, fingers twisting tight.

Another Resident trying to enter the human world...

No, no—that wasn't the point.

The point was: why create this rumor in the first place? Even if it came completely true, what would that accomplish?

"Who created this rumor?" Chase confirmed during another pause from the Artifact.

"Wellesley."

It seemed Wellesley had wanted to conjure a Resident capable of entering the human world out of thin air. What was his purpose?

"And the date it was created?"

The date the Artifact reported was over three months ago.

Considering that each rumor had to run its full course and reach its conclusion before a new one could be created, this was very likely the last rumor Wellesley had created before his death.

A rumor's conclusion could only end one of two ways: either it came true, or it simply faded away into nothing.

"Did this rumor come true?" Chase asked again.

"It came true on November 17th," the Artifact answered.

That was...the day after Wellesley died.

The reason I said earlier that writing this story with an ensemble perspective gets me excited is because I love the feeling of storylines interweaving and influencing each other...

Think about it—if I were writing strictly from Sydney Ginn's single perspective, would discovering the contents of the rumor be anywhere near as interesting? (She'd have a much harder time finding out in the first place—what grounds would a solo operator Hunter have for learning what's inside a Key House Faction Artifact?)

Chapter 43: Sydney Ginn's Original Plan for the Artifact

Of course... of course it was me.

There was never any reason to doubt it—the real Sydney Ginn was me, all along—

The moment that thought surfaced, it was as though something that had been cinched tight around Sydney Ginn suddenly came loose.

She sank to the floor without meaning to, buried her face in both hands, and wept aloud.

It wasn't grief, and it wasn't fear—this crying was closer to release: the unease and suspicion from moments ago, the near-death memory of struggling and fighting, the pain and terror of having her throat torn open and her shoulder hacked through... all of it seemed to flow out of her body, little by little, with each sob, leaving behind nothing but an exhausted, hollowed-out Sydney Ginn.

By the time she stopped, the last echoes faded from the exhibition hall, and silence settled back over everything.

Everything that had happened in those memories left not a single trace now.

No blood on the floor, no fire axe, no gouges bitten into the ground by its blade. The artwork made of long wooden strips still sat exactly where it had been, intact and undamaged, and naturally there were no splinters of it embedded in her face, hands, or feet.

Her trail pack was tossed in a corner of the hall. Sydney Ginn walked over to it, dug out the long towel from inside—dry and soft, never once soaked through by another version of herself's saliva.

In this world, no one but Sydney Ginn herself knew that she had died once tonight.

If the Resident, after killing her, had never gone to melt the candle—had never altered the history of their encounter with Anthony—then she would have remained on the cold floor of the underground exhibition hall forever, slowly becoming part of the Nest.

As though something thick and black seized her bones and gave them a shake, Sydney Ginn shuddered faintly.

She walked toward the candle, step by step, her sneakers making soft, faint sounds against the floor.

Since none of the history the Resident had copied had ever taken place, the candle before her had naturally never been touched—it was cool and firm beneath her fingers; in the shadow it cast, the fire groove stayed silent.

2026.5.19—a row of small characters rose from the surface of the candle.

Sydney Ginn yanked her hand back as though she'd been shocked.

After a pause, she let out a bitter laugh. Those two lines of memory had really done a number on her nerves.

Even though the only reason she was alive today was this very candle, the Resident's reckless melting and rewriting of history had shaken her deeply—after all, the Resident hadn't melted the candle in order to save her; if Sydney Ginn were to rashly thrust her own hand into history, who could say what unintended consequences might follow?

Which meant the candle was something she could neither take away nor use without anxiety...

Sydney Ginn sighed and, after thinking it over for a moment, decided to leave it alone for now.

Honestly, looking at the candle inevitably called to mind the Resident who had copied her form; it was better to let her feelings settle first and figure out what to do with it later.

Besides, a candle that size wasn't going anywhere—if someone truly managed to move a several-dozen-meter-long candle out of a windowless underground exhibition hall with narrow stairs, then Sydney Ginn would simply have to admit defeat.

She picked up her trail pack from the floor, patted the phone in her pocket, and confirmed everything was there except the hunting knife.

In this current timeline, the hunting knife had been in Anthony's hands all along; and after watching it sink into "her own" throat, Sydney Ginn no longer had much desire to take it back.

Anthony...

Only her hatred for him had grown sharper and more solid—she wanted it to become a weapon and drive it straight through his gut. The Resident was already gone; all of Sydney Ginn's

fury now locked onto the stalker.

Before she stepped into the elevator, she glanced back at the enormous candle in the distance.

"...That little detour is over," she murmured to herself.

Now it was back to the original plan—head to Ninety-Ninth Street, get the Artifact there, and then deal with Anthony swiftly and cleanly once she was back. This time, Sydney Ginn was not going to let herself get distracted halfway and wander off course again.

Once she was out of the Museum of Modern Art, she realized that being copied by a Resident hadn't been entirely a loss.

She had originally braced herself for nearly two days of walking before she would reach Ninety-Ninth Street.

That two-day journey was, when you stripped it down, only fifteen kilometers—it was just that the roads in the Nest were treacherous, full of unexpected dangers at every turn, and Hopscotch was a prime example of that.

But now, because she had hitched a ride in the taxi, she had cut a large portion of that distance and avoided the dangers and traps along the way; and with a bit of luck thrown in to balance out the misfortune, Sydney Ginn found herself, half an hour later, already standing at Ninety-Ninth Street.

Standing beneath the street sign, she scanned her surroundings first, then pulled out her phone for a quick check.

November 17th, 2:12 AM.

She had entered the Nest the evening of the 16th, before ten o'clock.

After listening to the full broadcast, she had been stuck on Colorado Avenue by Hopscotch for quite some time—roughly estimating, she must have been copied by the "Vulture" Resident sometime after midnight.

By rights, a Vulture Resident should only be able to take on someone's form after that person had died, yet tonight Hopscotch had seemed to hand it an opportunity on a platter, somehow letting it copy her while she was still alive...

No, no—that was all from the previous memory line. In the current timeline, she had escaped the fate of being copied.

The Vulture Resident had lost its target; for all she knew, it was still wandering Colorado Avenue right now.

Let it go—it was done—Sydney Ginn pushed down the unsettling images rising in her mind and pulled her attention back to the present.

Beneath the dim black sky, a staircase descended without a sound into the earth, swallowed by a pool of darkness.

At the top of the staircase stood a sign printed with the letter "D," marking this as the entrance to a D Line subway station. Looking down from the sidewalk, the darkness below looked like solidified ink—your gaze would simply snap at its surface.

Sydney Ginn remembered how, the first time she had seen this staircase leading down to the subway station, she had hesitated for quite a while before she could bring herself to go down.

She took out her phone, turned on the flashlight, and shone it against the side wall of the staircase first.

Where the name of the station should have been written, there were only large, uneven black characters slanting across the wall: "Go down for a surprise."

Yes—those were still the words.

Good. Those words meant it was safe.

November was an odd-numbered month; in every odd-numbered month, the characters at this subway entrance read "Go down for a surprise," and in every even-numbered month, they changed to "Go down for a hug."

When it said "surprise," you could go down into the station—it was not only safe, but you could also retrieve an Artifact. The Nest could be unexpectedly honest at times. But when it said "hug," you must never go down under any circumstances.

Sydney Ginn still had no idea what would happen if you went down when it said "hug," and she hoped she would never find out.

She held up her flashlight and descended the stairs step by step, passed through the broken and damaged fare gates, and arrived on a platform lit by only a handful of scattered white lights.

Most of the platform was dim and murky—a wall on one side, and a wall on the other.

Sydney Ginn had only ever been to this one subway station inside the Nest, so she didn't know whether all Nest subway stations were like this—no tracks, no trains, both sides of the platform sealed off by walls.

In the middle of the platform, several people turned their heads toward her.

"Hunter," said one of them, a person wearing a baseball cap, before losing interest and looking away again.

"Yes," Sydney Ginn answered, lowering her phone's flashlight slightly so it wouldn't shine in anyone's face. "Why are there so many people here today?"

There were four people in the middle of the platform, all Hunters; judging by the distance between them, they seemed to be in two separate pairs.

Sydney Ginn had come here several times and knew this place wasn't exactly unknown among Hunters—quite a few people made periodic trips here to retrieve Artifacts.

Because of the regular traffic, an order had naturally formed: Hunters typically went by first-come-first-served, took what they came for, and left without interfering with each other. Even so, this was her first time seeing four people gathered here at once.

"Look," said a woman with a gentle face, tilting her chin forward. "Your timing is perfect—you caught the vending machine restocking."

Every transition chapter has to cost me a layer of skin; you wouldn't believe how long this one took me...

I'll say something a little shameless: I feel like the Artifact Report isn't the kind of story you can skim through at speed, because I'm burying information in every single chapter... which is also why I write it so, so slowly.

Chapter 44: Sydney Ginn Buys Things and Of Course She Pays for Them

Beneath a mop of unruly short hair, a smooth expanse of bare skin looked up to meet Sydney Ginn's gaze.

She managed to suppress the urge to suck in a sharp breath just in time.

Slight, smooth hollows beneath the brow seemed to serve as its eye sockets; it had no nostrils and no mouth. As it spoke, beneath the seamless expanse where a nose should have been, a bulge of skin kept pushing outward with each word — always making her worry that it would balloon too high, then snap back and crumple into folds, and from the center of those folds a dark hole would cave inward.

Sydney Ginn sometimes really disliked her own imagination.

"So many customers today," the skin-bulge pulsed rhythmically as it spoke, "no rush, it'll be loaded up in just a moment. Got quite a few new items in today."

As it spoke, it was slotting several cans of drinks into the dim interior of the vending machine.

When the soft-featured female Hunter had said "the vending machine is being restocked," Sydney Ginn hadn't imagined it would be a Resident doing the restocking.

The four of them had formed a semicircle that happened to block from view the Resident crouched on the ground — which was what had startled her. Now that Sydney Ginn stepped closer for a better look, she found the restocking process actually resembled the real thing quite well: several boxes were arranged beside the Resident, some empty, some still half-full; it was loading cans into the vending machine one by one.

Sometimes the Nest really did insist on "realism" in the strangest places — rather than fussing over loading drinks one can at a time, shouldn't it first do something about that face?

The baseball-cap wearer's companion was a girl chewing gum, who at this moment had even struck up a conversation with the Resident: "How often do you restock? How come I've never seen you before?"

"Depends on how well things sell," the Resident answered every question without hesitation. "The last few months' stock wasn't moving, so there was no need to restock, which is why I haven't been here."

The last few months... Sydney Ginn thought about it — she had come by and checked, and the selection really had been mediocre, pretty useless stuff.

Inside the vending machine at this subway station, every so often, Artifacts with different functions would appear — every can of drink, every packet of snacks, was an Artifact with its own distinct function and varying expiration date. Whether you could find something suitable was largely a matter of luck.

"What new stock do you have today?" the soft-featured female Hunter asked.

"Oh, quite a lot," the Resident said warmly. "The supplier changed — more than half are new products! I've put up the new product descriptions too, have a look and you'll know what's what."

The product descriptions it had just posted covered an entire wall.

The five of them exchanged glances; the baseball-cap wearer stepped forward first, announced "we got here first," and walked over to shine a flashlight on the product descriptions, reading carefully.

The gum-chewing girl stood right beside the vending machine, also holding her spot at the front; the other three maintained a few paces' distance from the two of them, as was the custom when buying soda Artifacts.

"All done,"

Under the expectant gaze of all five, the Resident finally closed the vending machine — not only producing a key to lock it, but picking up the empty cardboard boxes from the ground as well. "I'm off."

The gum-chewing girl smiled sweetly and gave it a wave: "Thank you, bye-bye."

Such a cordial exchange between Resident and Hunter — Sydney Ginn hadn't seen one of those in quite a while.

That thought had barely settled when the Resident, halfway out the door, stopped in its tracks, cardboard boxes in hand, and turned to look back at the group.

It was still standing there even after the baseball-cap wearer finished reading the descriptions and the gum-chewing girl took her turn.

When Sydney Ginn couldn't help herself and stole a quick glance at it, the skin on the Resident's face gave a single pulse.

"...Oh, I just remembered — the company is running a promotion, inviting lucky customers to try out new products. You can take a free sample."

Sydney Ginn quickly looked away and shifted one step closer to the soft-featured female Hunter.

The gum-chewing girl seemed to suddenly lose her hearing, studying the product descriptions with complete focus; not one person turned their head toward the Resident.

"Anyone want to come?"

No one moved, no one looked at it, no one spoke.

"No one?"

All five Hunters seemed to hold their breath; the baseball-cap wearer stood before the vending machine, shoulders drawn up tight.

"Really no one? You know, opportunity knocks but once—"

The skin on the Resident's face gave a soft *pop* and bulged outward right next to Sydney Ginn's ear. "—and never knocks twice."

She swallowed back a scream rising in her throat, eyes fixed hard on the floor, with no idea when the Resident had gotten so close.

You cannot respond — any competent Artifact Hunter would realize, in that moment, that responding was absolutely out of the question.

The other four, like Sydney Ginn, had presumably never encountered a "restocking Resident" before and didn't know how to handle it.

But in those brief few exchanges, everyone had clearly reached the same conclusion and taken the same course of action — because Hunters, drawing on experience and instinct, must probe and judge within a split second.

After its first invitation, the five of them falling silent without any prior agreement was itself a "probe."

Wait and watch — in most situations, that is the safest way to probe.

Its next line, "No one?", made it clear that the restocking Resident interpreted no answer as a refusal — and all five Hunters picked up on that immediately.

Conversely, if its next line had been "Everyone's interested?", the five Hunters would have instantly realized it interpreted no answer as consent; in that case, staying silent would of course be out of the question, and an immediate denial would be necessary.

The Nest and its Residents, for all their treachery and unpredictability, still left open a sliver of possibility for analysis, judgment, and action — and it was precisely that sliver which had kept the profession of Artifact Hunter alive for so long.

"Ah, what a pity."

The words seeped out through that expanse of skin and settled deep into the hair at the back of the gum-chewing girl's head.

From Sydney Ginn's angle, she could see the Resident standing right behind her; that featureless face was craning forward, pressing into the girl's hair. She still had no idea when it had moved there.

"Alright then, I really am leaving this time. Anyone want to exchange phone numbers with me?"

Within a single Resident, there is often a consistent internal logic to its behavior.

A Resident that treats silence as a refusal on one question is unlikely to suddenly treat silence as consent on the very next — and in the breathless silence of all five, the restocking Resident seemed to leave with some reluctance, disappearing step by step into the shadows of the subway station entrance.

Several seconds passed before Sydney Ginn finally let out the long breath she had been holding in her chest.

"That scared me,"

The other four relaxed as well; the girl started chewing her gum again and said, "I actually thought it was one of the harmless Residents."

"How long have you been doing this?" the man who had said nothing until now immediately lectured her. "Don't you know Residents can be dangerous at any moment? It only comes down to whether they feel like coming after you or not. You were just chatting away with it!"

"And how long have you been at it? Have you even hit a year?"

The girl walked back from the product descriptions and stood beside her tall, slender companion, looking at him out of the corner of her eye. "Do you know why I thought it was a harmless Resident? Do you know what the characteristics of harmless Residents are? Always eager to teach — is there a school paying you a salary for this?"

"Hold on, no need to argue," the soft-featured female Hunter, seeing the two of them on the verge of a fight, quickly raised both hands to placate them: "It's not a matter of principle, and besides, the danger has passed. Didn't I talk to it too?"

"You did, and you were wrong too." The man wasn't buying his companion's mediation.

"Who died and made you judge?" The girl flicked her hand, and suddenly layers of massive muscle swelled up along her left arm, filling her sleeve to bursting. "Watch your mouth next time."

"M&M Beans?" The man glanced at her arm and let out a cold laugh. "Which House Faction are you from? You think you're the only one who's bought M&M Beans?"

M&M Beans were one of the vending machine's products — the name was an abbreviation, the full name being "Machine Muscle." The purpose was self-evident from the name alone; simple, but effective.

They were popular among Hunters, especially female Hunters, though stock was rarely available. The most inconvenient part was that once taken out of the Nest, they would expire within twenty-four hours.

The fact that the girl had M&M Beans on her indicated at least one thing: she had a place within the Nest to stash belongings — not particularly surprising, as most House Factions had a hiding spot.

"Listen to me,"

Sydney Ginn stepped forward and positioned herself between the two of them, feeling she had no choice but to smooth things over — these two had only clashed over a few words, with no real grudge between them; all they needed was a way to back down gracefully. Actually coming to blows in a place like this would do neither of them any good.

"Actually, neither of you is wrong. I just noticed tonight that the Residents have been acting a bit strange lately."

Everyone looked at her.

The baseball-cap wearer finished choosing, pressed in the product number, and asked, "What do you mean?"

"You all know the 'Vulture' Resident, right? I just ran into it."

She wanted to smooth things over, but that was perhaps just a pretext; what Sydney Ginn truly wanted was to use the Vulture incident to gauge the other Hunters' reactions and see if anyone had additional information to add.

What she wanted most of all was to pour out everything she had been through to companions who were flesh and blood and could understand what she had experienced — but she couldn't expose the existence of the Candlefall Artifact, and she feared drawing suspicion onto herself.

"Impossible,"

The moment Sydney Ginn finished speaking, the man rendered his verdict immediately. "You can't die, so the Vulture can't take your form — that's common knowledge."

"Which is exactly why I said their behavior is abnormal." Sydney Ginn was getting a little irritated too. "If you don't believe me, go check Colorado Avenue and see if there's a chalk-drawn hopscotch grid."

The man said nothing, brow furrowed.

"The changes and anomalies appearing in the Nest recently have been more numerous and more frequent than before."

It was the first time the baseball-cap wearer had said anything that long, and only then did Sydney Ginn suddenly realize that the person was a woman.

She stood at least six feet tall, with broad, level shoulders and a head of short hair; her appearance wasn't easy to read at a glance, and her voice was a full register lower than that of most women.

"I imagine this isn't any of your first times buying from the vending machine."

The baseball-cap wearer gently tossed the soda in her hand into the air and caught it again. "Generally speaking, what do you all think this Artifact is worth?"

"Five hundred dollars?" Sydney Ginn guessed.

Things from the vending machine tended to be like that: you paid for them with real-world money, the price was never cheap, the function was singular, the power modest, and the expiration

date startlingly short.

That was precisely why Artifact Hunters hadn't turned into soda couriers shuttling between Blackmoor City and the Nest.

"That was roughly the price before." The baseball-cap wearer smiled, and a long, narrow dimple sank into the clean lower half of her face. "I just paid by credit card — this one can of soda ran me over nine thousand dollars. But it was worth it."

The moment she finished speaking, the soft-featured female Hunter immediately strode over to the product descriptions; her flashlight swept two circles across the wall, and she drew in a low, sharp breath.

Since getting home, she hadn't slept a single good night, surviving each day purely on coffee and tea. Without caffeine, there would be no way to gather fake money in the world. Caffeine is my father, caffeine is my mother, without caffeine, there would be no ne—

That was a close one, damn.

Oh, speaking of which, there's something I keep forgetting to mention—friends, I've finally figured out what flavor of chips the Puppeteer is! (Yes, the reason I didn't say before is because I didn't think any flavor suited him.)

Want to know? To find out, please call our hotline at 25115222. Free consultation, five yuan per minute. Remember: 25115222.

Chapter 45: Sydney Ginn Pays Taxes and Launderers Money

The two groups who had already finished their purchases still hadn't left, each standing far apart on the dim platform, talking in low voices.

Even without hearing what they were saying, Sydney Ginn could guess the gist of it.

They were all House Faction Hunters; for a House Faction, this product description sheet had completely changed the meaning of the vending machine.

Artifact Hunters risked their lives to enter the Nest — when you stripped it down, it was all for one thing: money.

The vending machine had been overlooked before because its products had weak effects and heavy restrictions, with little potential profit to speak of — take M&M Beans, for instance: they expired twenty-four hours after leaving the Nest, so who would pay a fortune for something essentially disposable? Even selling it at cost price meant you had connections to spare and a circle full of suckers desperate enough to bite.

The vending machine's product restrictions still existed now — if anything, they were even more absurd than before — but even Sydney Ginn, with no House Faction to her name, could see at a glance that the potential returns were in a completely different league.

What a shame, though — that only held true for House Factions.

She swept her flashlight over the product descriptions twice and found the image of a blue plastic-bottle drink.

The soft-featured female Hunter had finished reading the description and, without a word, bought a bottle of water right then and there, immediately smothering it and shoving it into her backpack; it was only Sydney Ginn's sharp eyes that let her track that flash of blue and identify what the woman had bought.

Gatorade sports drink 500ml

Everyone knows that the threshold between life and death is like a door — on this side is the human world / the Nest, and once you step through, you either go up to heaven or down to hell.

(Just kidding — how could humans possibly go to heaven, hahaha)

In real life, people don't always march cleanly through that door between life and death — all kinds of unexpected things can happen that leave a person hovering on the edge. For example, getting hit by a car, a sudden stroke, a gunshot wound... in situations like these, you might find that between life and death, there's actually a precious window of time for emergency treatment.

Think of it as one foot in the door and one foot out — surely you'd want the human-world side to hold on to you just a little longer?

If that window is longer, it gives doctors more time to fight for you, and you might just make it; if it's too short and that window closes, you're destined to end up with lividity spots.

This sports drink is specially suited for those hovering on the edge of life and death — it's like launching an assault on death's door! Remarkable! It can't bring the dead back to life, but it can buy you a little extra emergency time — as long as fluid can still be safely administered, every 1ml consumed adds 3 seconds.

Disclaimer: This product has the effect of extending emergency response time, but does not guarantee that resuscitation will succeed. Please defer to the attending emergency physician or surgeon for specific assessments.

Post-Nest expiry: 4 hours

Price: \$38,000

Flavor: Blue-Green Lividity

Thirty-eight thousand dollars for an Artifact with only a four-hour shelf life — for a solo operator or a small House Faction, it was a guaranteed losing venture. Without the network, intelligence, manpower, and logistical support of a major House Faction, simply finding a client willing to trust you completely was already next to impossible, and beyond that lay an even bigger problem.

How would you even deliver it?

Say a client found themselves in mortal danger, and their representative urgently contacted you at that moment, demanding the Gatorade Artifact within ten minutes.

A solo operator would first have to enter the Nest through their passage, rush to a cache or the vending machine, retrieve the Artifact, then open a passage back to Blackmoor City — by the time they got back, the client would already be in the ground.

But for a major House Faction, it was a different story entirely.

Sydney Ginn didn't know the specific operational procedures and methods; but she had heard bits and pieces that might offer a glimpse of the whole picture — when major House Factions ran into time-critical situations, they dispatched helicopters.

The thought made Sydney Ginn glance back involuntarily at the two shadows still bent in whispered conversation at the far end of the platform. They had bought so decisively — the House Faction behind them must be sizable, with no trouble moving product; the cards they used to pay were almost certainly the House Faction's.

Ah, how nice, she thought, turning back with a glum expression.

Her own credit card didn't even have a limit of thirty-six thousand — though Sydney Ginn had earned decent money from her broadcasts, when it came to this particular problem, she couldn't help but envy the advantages of a House Faction: all her income was under the table, nothing she could put on the books, nothing that could become a personal asset, nothing that did a thing for her credit score.

House Faction Hunters were a different matter, though.

Their income came from the House Faction itself and could be labeled as wages, bonuses, dividends, commissions, allowances, reimbursements — not only completely above board, but they could even pay a token amount of taxes, just enough to keep the IRS off their backs.

And what about the House Faction's income?

"As for me," Amber had explained to Sydney Ginn once, plainly and matter-of-factly, "aside from doing accounting and finance, I also have to handle money laundering for the House Faction."

Sydney Ginn let out another long sigh.

She had spotted what she wanted to buy long ago.

But the reason she hadn't rushed over to buy it yet — standing here like a fool, turning over the problems of money laundering and tax filing in her head — was, apart from her own tendency to zone out and let her thoughts wander, one critical thing: her credit card limit was maxed out.

Sydney Ginn looked left and right, her gaze settling on the soft-featured female Hunter, then, after two seconds, drifting back to the two with the baseball caps, who were sitting on the stairs

talking.

Worth a try, she told herself, steeling her nerves — asking doesn't cost anything. The worst they can say is no, right?

As she walked to the foot of the stairs, one of the baseball caps looked up.

"Something you need?"

Sydney Ginn had a nagging suspicion she might be making a fool of herself right now. "Um... if you don't mind me asking, are you two House Faction Hunters?"

The gum-chewing girl gave a nod and said, "Yeah, why?"

She seemed quite fond of the baseball cap one — now that her left arm had recovered, the two of them were sitting shoulder to shoulder, and they looked considerably closer than the other pair.

"I'm a solo operator, no House Faction." Sydney Ginn cleared her throat and said, "Um... the vending machine — I haven't bought anything yet. I've got my eye on something that would be really useful to me, and I can't afford to wait; I need to get my hands on it right away."

The two looked at her, waiting for her to continue.

Backed into a corner, she steeled herself and pressed on: "But I don't have enough credit left on my card... would you be willing to swipe yours for me? I have money in my debit account, but the card doesn't have a contactless chip — the vending machine can't read it..."

Here they were, deep inside the Nest — a place about as far from reality as you could get — and yet the problem she was describing was about as mundane and petty as it gets. Sydney Ginn had the distinct sense that something about this was off.

Afraid they'd misunderstand, she quickly added: "I do have cash — I'm not flat broke!"

In the shadow of the baseball cap, a long, narrow dimple suddenly appeared on that half-visible face. "You have cash on you?"

Sydney Ginn was overcome with despair. "No, the cash is in Blackmoor City..."

"So you're asking to borrow money?" The baseball cap's grin widened further, a flash of white teeth gleaming in the dimness.

"When you put it that way... yeah, it, it does seem like that..."

The gum-chewing girl stopped chewing, mouth half open as she stared at Sydney Ginn — she had probably never been asked to lend money to a stranger inside the Nest before.

Sydney Ginn felt the situation was getting a bit out of hand, and stammered, "I mean, of course, I could always come back in again, but my passage — ah, that's not convenient to explain..."

The baseball cap suddenly burst into laughter.

When the laughter died down, she lifted off her cap, reached up, and ran her hand through her wavy short hair, tilting her face upward into the dim platform light.

This was the first time Sydney Ginn had gotten a clear look at her face, and she was briefly, momentarily transfixed.

Though she was probably also in her twenties, she had the look of a youth of indeterminate gender; behind the tousled waves of hair were a pair of deep-set, narrow blue eyes — clear as the sky reflected between Arctic icebergs.

The gum-chewing girl glanced at Sydney Ginn, shrugged, and murmured the expression on her face into words: "I knew it."

"What?" Sydney Ginn snapped back to reality, her embarrassment doubled. "Never mind, it's fine — I'll just come back in again. I mean, if it were me, I wouldn't lend money to a stranger so easily either..."

The baseball cap one — she had taken the cap off now, but Sydney Ginn still didn't know her name — stood up and pulled a wallet from her back pocket.

"My driver's license and my card," she said, holding up two cards and addressing Sydney Ginn: "Give me your driver's license, your credit card, and your phone."

"Oh? You need the phone too?"

"Of course. How do I know the ID you're carrying is real?"

The gum-chewing girl nodded vigorously in agreement: "These days, the only things you absolutely have to get back — besides your own kid — is your phone."

The baseball cap's demands were reasonable: the driver's license went without saying, of course she needed to know who she was lending money to. The credit card served as extra

collateral, in case Sydney Ginn didn't pay her back or ended up dead in the Nest; and besides, she was asking for the phone, not the passcode.

Sydney Ginn hesitated for a long moment before she finally handed over her phone as well.

The baseball cap looked down at the phone screen as it lit up, and in the glow of the screen, that clean face paused. She looked at the hundred-odd filthy messages still frozen on the screen, expression blank, said nothing, and slipped the phone into her trouser pocket.

For some reason, Sydney Ginn felt a shame like being stripped of her clothes.

"This is my address and number," she said, seeming to have already forgotten about the messages — she wrote Sydney Ginn a note, then asked, "Is there anything on your phone you need to write down? Like a phone number?"

Anthony's number was already engraved in her memory; Sydney Ginn shook her head.

"Sydney Ginn, right?" The baseball cap looked at the driver's license, then looked at her, and smiled. "Not often you see an ID photo that actually looks as good as the person."

Sydney Ginn thanked the two of them repeatedly for a while, and they exchanged a few necessary details. Throughout the whole process, she felt as though she were drifting through clouds in a daze, unable to believe she had actually borrowed a card from strangers — strangers, in the Nest of all places?

She couldn't bring herself to look at the baseball cap's driver's license the whole time; it wasn't until Sydney Ginn had walked back to the vending machine that she quietly snuck a glance at it.

London Moon — even the name was androgynous.

Sydney Ginn took a deep breath, dragged her attention back to the vending machine, punched in a few numbers, then pressed the credit card against the reader.

A notification flashed on the screen confirming a successful charge of \$12,000; with a thunk, a can of soda tumbled into the dispensing slot below.

Sydney Ginn reached in and picked it up, tucking it into her backpack.

She straightened up and turned her head — and found herself meeting London Moon's gaze.

She hadn't hidden the can of soda, and it was the only purple item; under the light of the vending machine, the purple was vivid and unmistakable. Anyone who had read the product

descriptions would know that the purple soda had only one function.

Killing.

How did I discover Puppeteer Master chips? A coworker in Shenzhen told me there was an imported chip at the Oley supermarket — the best chips she'd ever eaten in her life. Of course I was curious, so she gave me two bags.

They really were good. Whether they're the best is still up for debate, but one of the flavors — when you ate it — actually had the texture of popping candy in your mouth!

I looked it up: it was the "bubbly serrano chilli" flavor. Translated, isn't that basically "bouncy little spicy pepper"?!

I still have the photo on my phone — I'm wondering if I should post it in the comments section of Doomsday...

Chapter 46: Sydney Ginn's Grape Soda

The most precious thing in the world is whatever can pull a life back from the edge of death.

Even if it costs millions, there's never a shortage of people willing to pay; even the slightest increase in the chance of survival draws people rushing over—like that bottle of sports drink.

But erasing a person's life is cheap.

The things that kill people are rarely worth much.

Sydney Ginn glanced once more at the purple can of soda in her hand.

If all she wanted was to kill someone, a knife would do just fine—and if she couldn't do it herself, twelve thousand dollars was more than enough to hire someone who would.

But using methods from the real world meant bearing the real world's risks and consequences, and Blackmoor City was, after all, a society with rules and laws. What if someone traced Anthony's death or disappearance back to her?

Not even the Nest's Residents had managed to catch her—it would be rather too ironic if she ended up in a real-world prison.

She needed to handle this cleanly, without leaving so much as a trace of suspicion on herself—she still had plenty of money and plenty of life left to enjoy.

The true reason this can of soda was so valuable wasn't simply that it could cause a person's death—if she were being honest, she wasn't even certain whether what it caused could really be called death.

But she was certain of one thing: using an Artifact to deal with Anthony would leave her with no loose ends.

As Sydney stared at the soda in a daze, the small print on the bottom ticked from "Countdown: 6 hours 25 minutes" to "Countdown: 6 hours 24 minutes."

It had a total effective window of only eight hours, and she'd already burned through an hour and a half; what annoyed her most was that after those first few calls, she'd spent the rest of the time doing nothing but waiting.

Had Anthony been thrown off, not expecting her to reach out to him on her own?

Just as that thought crossed her mind, the disposable phone she'd bought earlier buzzed to life on the table. Sydney swept a glance at the screen and snatched it up immediately. "Anthony?"

There was a second of silence on the other end.

Then the voice spoke, casual as if nothing were the matter: "Ah, it really is you."

"Of course it's me—didn't I leave you a voicemail?"

"You suddenly said your phone was lost and told me to call this number—that's pretty suspicious." Anthony's speech was unhurried, but his voice and tone carried something like a rodent sniffing the air in the shadows. "...When did you lose it?"

Sydney thought for a moment and named a time before he'd plastered her number all over those adult websites. "Yesterday morning."

Anthony paused.

When he spoke again, his tone had warmed a degree: "What made you suddenly reach out to me? It's been so long..."

"Can we meet in person?" Sydney asked, cutting straight to it. "At the bar where we first met?"

Choosing a public place was to put Anthony at ease about showing up—he'd almost certainly worry she'd brought people along to rough him up.

"Is something the matter?" The harasser was, predictably, fairly cautious.

In that moment, Sydney summoned the spirit of every female lead from every romance film she'd ever seen in her life and mimicked their light, earnest voices: "I... I didn't like how we ended things. I feel like there's still some room between us—it doesn't have to come to this. Whatever you want, we can sit down and talk it over..."

Could there really be women that foolish in this world?

After being bombarded with calls in the dead of night, subjected to endless insults and curses, and threatened with "I'll have you killed," could anyone truly be dim enough to sit down and have a civilized talk with her harasser?

Sydney didn't think so—but Anthony seemed to think otherwise. Or at the very least, he hoped Sydney was.

"Right now?" There was something restless and eager in Anthony's voice that made her skin crawl even through the phone. "I'd need at least an hour before I could get away..."

Sydney said through her teeth, "No problem. I'll wait for you."

She hung up, set the phone and the purple can of soda side by side on the table in front of her, and stared at them for a long moment.

From the table next to hers, a group of men and women drinkers suddenly erupted in loud laughter; they seemed to be colleagues out for a drink after work, and they raised their glasses, clinking them together in midair.

The waitress came over to the table with a smile. "How's it going? Is the person you're waiting for on their way?"

"Still a little while." Sydney pulled a few Franklin-faced bills from her wallet and handed them over along with the purple can of soda. "Just like we discussed—when he gets here, I'll leave it in your hands."

The waitress stared at the cash, clearly startled by the size of the tip, and looked almost like she didn't believe it. "Are you sure?"

Sydney leaned slowly back against her chair and smiled at her.

"...I'm sure."

It was nearing nine o'clock, and the bar was gradually filling up.

The smell of alcohol in the air mingled with perfume and the tobacco smoke that drifted in every time the door opened, diffusing in the haze of the lights.

When the countdown had dwindled to 3 hours and 41 minutes and Sydney was starting to consider whether to fall back on her contingency plan, Anthony finally pushed open the bar door—his gaze swept the room, found his target quickly, but he didn't come over right away.

He stood at the entrance, looking over every customer in the place first, then sauntered over at his own pace and dropped into the seat across from Sydney.

"You look exhausted," he said, opening with what appeared to be concern. "Things not going well lately? I haven't been sleeping either—I think about you all the time."

Sydney considered herself reasonably worldly, but faced with this kind of shamelessness that was completely without self-awareness, she was still too astonished to find any words.

"You know," Anthony said, knocking on the table with one hand, "I called your lost phone before I came."

Before Sydney could react, he had already said with righteous conviction: "Just like I thought—someone picked it up. If you pick up someone else's phone, how can you not return it?"

"Wait—someone answered?" Sydney asked quickly.

"Yeah, a guy," Anthony said.

London Moon's voice was lower than most women's, which had apparently led him to that conclusion. Still, the fact that she'd answered the phone meant that London Moon and the others had made it back to Blackmoor City.

"I told him, 'How much do you want to give my girlfriend's phone back?'"

The feeling Sydney had at that moment was like visiting a socialite's home, taking off her shoes at the door, and discovering she was wearing a sock with a hole in the toe.

"She—he, what did he say?" She scrubbed her face with her hand and asked.

She had come here today to kill someone, and yet right now she wanted nothing more than to hang herself from the ceiling first.

"You wouldn't believe how greedy he was!" Anthony was indignant. "'Twelve thousand, and I'll give it back to her'—can you believe that? I got angry right then and wanted to threaten him a little, scare him..."

"...And then?"

"The guy laughed and hung up." Anthony leaned in as he said it, as if to reassure her: "Don't worry—if you need me to, I'll keep calling to get your phone back."

Sydney lowered her head, paused for a few seconds, then sat up straight again.

Before responding, she raised her hand toward the waitress in a brief signal, then let her gaze settle on Anthony's face.

Like examining some newly discovered insect, she watched him and said quietly, "Right—calling people relentlessly really is your specialty, isn't it."

If Anthony had pushed back or flared up in embarrassed rage, that would at least have shown he had some sense of shame.

He only blinked, then smiled and said, "I knew you'd hold a grudge. I'll admit—I did go too far... because I've never cared this much about anyone before."

The waitress came over carrying a tray and set a glass filled with ice in front of each of them.

With a hiss, she pulled the tab on the soda can and poured half of it into the glass in front of Sydney; thick white foam floated on top of the purple liquid.

Just as she was about to pour some for Anthony as well, he reached out and covered his glass with his hand.

"Your soda?" Anthony looked at the purple can on the tray and gestured for the waitress to set it down. He picked it up and turned it over in his hands a few times, then said to Sydney, "I've never seen this brand before... you always have the strangest things."

Though he was reluctant to admit it, Anthony had a kind of instinct—and it was precisely that instinct that had let him single Sydney out from a whole bar full of people.

"It's imported," Sydney said, not wanting the Artifact in his hands any longer than necessary. She held out her hand and said, "It's quite good—want to try?"

"No thanks, you have it." Anthony pushed the can back toward her, then turned to the waitress. "A gin and tonic for me."

Sydney kept her expression neutral and nudged the can to one side, as if it were nothing important.

When the gin and tonic arrived, Anthony finally spoke again. "You came to find me today..."

"There are a few things I wanted to say to you."

Anthony took a sip of his drink and made no move to ask what she wanted to say. He glanced at the glass of soda and said, "Go ahead and drink—didn't you say you liked it?"

Sydney looked down at the soda and raised the glass to her lips.

Anthony held his own glass, watching her over the rim; she parted her lips and let the cold liquid slide down her throat and into her stomach.

The moment she swallowed, Anthony seemed to relax. He watched the level in the glass drop and smiled. "I'll try some in a bit—haven't seen this brand. What did you want to say?"

Sydney set down the glass and said slowly, "You have a mental disorder."

Anthony's face went cold in an instant.

"I don't know whether it's a genetic defect you were born with, or whether the circumstances you grew up in made you into a deviant. Maybe no one has ever said this to you before—but I'm going to tell you today: you are scum.

"You think the world owes you something—women especially. You think it's unfair, that others have taken what's rightfully yours. Why do I have money when you don't? Why won't I be with you? For someone as narcissistic as you, rejection is the gravest of insults... and so you do everything in your power to harass and retaliate against me—but you're too cowardly and pathetic to do anything more than post my number on some website."

Anthony stiffened, his face flushing red.

Sydney smiled slightly, lifted her glass, and drained the soda in one go. "What you get today is exactly what you deserve."

"What?" he asked blankly.

"I'm leaving," Sydney said, rising and stepping out from her side of the table.

"Wait," Anthony immediately jumped to his feet and reached out to grab her arm. "Finish what you were—"

In the moment he drew close, Sydney gently blew a breath of air into his face.

A rich, heavy scent of grape billowed between them.

"People are watching," she said softly. "What do you think you're doing?"

Anthony let go reluctantly, as expected. His eyes drifted to Sydney's seat and landed on the handbag left there; his cheek muscles twitched into a smile, and he sat back down.

He'd misread the situation—Sydney was only going to the restroom.

She stood by the sink, neither using the toilet nor washing her hands, which drew the eye of a blonde woman nearby. The woman was a little drunk; she looked Sydney over and suddenly asked with a smile, "Why are you wearing rain boots?"

Sydney was in a good mood; she tapped the toes of her boots on the floor a few times like a tap dancer showing off a step, and answered with a smile, "The forecast says rain."

When she judged enough time had passed, she walked back out and returned to her table. The chair beside the table was empty—no one there.

The seat was soaking wet, a large patch of purple liquid dripping, dripping down onto the floor. A puddle had already collected on the ground, as if someone had accidentally knocked over a can of soda—or perhaps two.

Sydney Ginn stepped into the puddle, liquid splashing up onto her shoes. She bent down to pick up her bag, then grabbed the soda can from the table.

On her way out, she waved goodbye to the waitress.

"My friend had to head out early," she said with an apologetic smile. "I accidentally knocked over a drink just now..."

"No worries, don't give it a second thought!" the waitress said cheerfully. "I'll go mop it right up."

The part I was most proud of in yesterday's chapter, besides London Moon's name, was the gate-raid — has anyone figured out who its real-world counterpart is? It's Gatorade!

Ah, I need someone to play straight man to my jokes.

Chapter 47: The Strange Detail Sydney Ginn Had Overlooked

The last time she had seen London Moon was no more than a day ago; Sydney Ginn hadn't expected them to meet again so soon—in fact, it was barely half an hour after Anthony dissolved into soda.

Why?

Because, as the girl named Joy Jo had said, the only things worth ransoming these days were your own children—and your phone.

Sydney Ginn had no children, so all she could say was that without her phone, she felt like she'd truly lost a piece of her soul.

"Oh, you're calling in person this time?" London Moon laughed when the call connected.

There was no need to keep reminding her about the embarrassing thing, whether openly or in passing. Even without anyone reminding her, she could carry every cringeworthy memory for at least ten years—and they always came barging into her mind in the middle of the night, chasing away all sleep.

"I can pay you back now. Are you free tonight?"

London Moon was quiet for a second. "Where?"

Sydney Ginn gave her the address of the Between the Backlights bar, and heard London Moon say, "Not far from me."

She wanted to ask whether the other woman lived nearby, but was afraid she might take it as prying for intelligence on a Hunter, so she held back—and before she could say anything, London Moon added, "Just finished handing off with a client. I'll head over."

How nice—one trip into the Nest and they came back with money; meanwhile she'd done the same and come out twelve thousand in the hole.

Perhaps it was that thought hanging over her head like a storm cloud, occupying most of her attention; or perhaps it was knowing she was back in Blackmoor City and didn't need to stay on high alert anymore—whatever the reason, when she walked into Between the Backlights, she still hadn't realized she'd made a serious mistake.

"Don't move!"

A sharp shout hit her the moment she stepped through the door, jolting Sydney Ginn out of her skin.

She looked up to find that every Hunter in the bar had risen to their feet, every one of them staring at her with drawn, razor-edged tension; a few had even pressed a hand to their hip, clearly ready to draw.

"Wh—what's going on?"

Sydney Ginn froze mid-step, not daring to move, and swept her gaze around the bar in bewilderment. "What's wrong with all of you? What's wrong with me?"

It wasn't entirely true that everyone had stood—there was one person in the whole bar who remained seated at the counter, pulling her cap down low to muffle the soft laughter underneath it.

"What do you think you're doing?" The shar-pei-faced bartender raised a bottle, seemingly ready to hurl it as a weapon at any moment. "You walked in here with an Artifact in an active state. What's that supposed to mean?"

Sydney Ginn looked at the crowd, then looked down at the half-empty soda can in her hand, then looked back at the crowd, and the penny dropped.

"Oh, this—no—"

She panicked, started to put the soda down, and was immediately barked at with another "Don't move," so of course she froze again, and could only explain: "I wasn't going to hurt anyone with it—I did use it—but it has nothing to do with any of you, I wasn't going to use it on anyone here! I just forgot I was holding it. I've been carrying it the whole way."

Even though Artifacts look much like ordinary objects on the surface, when placed in front of experienced Hunters they would stir something like a sixth sense—especially an Artifact in an active state.

Only now did Sydney Ginn realize, belatedly, that what she'd just done probably carried the same energy as charging through an airport with a gun.

"...She's a regular," the bartender said hesitantly, lowering the bottle and addressing the room.

"Someone forgot they were carrying an Artifact?" A middle-aged man looked less than convinced.

London Moon finally saw fit to offer her support.

She slowly swiveled her stool around and said, "It's true. When she was buying the Artifact, she ran out of money and asked a complete stranger standing nearby to lend her some."

"How would you know?" A woman slowly moved her hand away from her hip, still not sitting back down.

"I was that stranger." London Moon gave Sydney Ginn a loose, unhurried wave. "Come on—pay me back."

Under the eyes of an entire bar full of Hunters, Sydney Ginn slunk over to the counter in a few quick, shame-faced steps—but the matter wasn't over yet.

Several Hunters who still weren't satisfied closed in from various distances, studying her and the soda can. "So how does that Artifact work? What does it do?"

It wasn't out of the question that they already knew and were just testing whether she'd tell the truth.

Not that Sydney Ginn had any intention of lying.

"After a few big mouthfuls, while you've got enough grape flavor in your mouth, blow a breath at the target's face as fast as you can."

"And then?"

"The target turns into grape soda." Sydney Ginn answered honestly, sitting down on a barstool. She lifted one rubber-boot-clad foot and pointed at it. "I thought for sure there'd be a huge volume of liquid—I even wore rain boots on purpose, see? Turns out it's only about a can or two worth."

"You just...killed someone?" a stranger Hunter asked.

"Watch what you say." Even in a room full of Hunters, Sydney Ginn wasn't about to admit that out loud. "All I said was I blew breath at the target. I never said anything about killing anyone."

At that, a few of the other Hunters actually seemed to relax somewhat; a few pairs of eyes drifted toward the soda can, with a faint glimmer in them.

"If someone turns into soda, other people would see it happen, wouldn't they?" an old man asked.

Sydney Ginn raised one finger. "No. After the breath is blown, it takes effect the first moment the target isn't being watched by any human eyes. It happens in an instant."

Clothes, shoes, phone—nothing is left behind—but that detail wasn't something she could say outright.

"How much is left?" Someone stepped two paces closer. "What's the expiration?"

"About half left, and the expiration—" Sydney Ginn suddenly realized what was happening. "Are you interested in buying it?"

Everyone present was a professional; even though the purple soda was an Artifact appearing for the first time, it took only about ten minutes to assess its value and function.

Considering the expiration was less than three hours away—the longer she waited, the less it would sell for—Sydney Ginn simply sold the remaining half-can to the first Hunter who made up their mind, and whatever else could be said about it, this trip had at least cut her losses by three or four thousand.

"I never drank from it directly," she said warmly, pocketing the money. "Drink up with confidence! It's pretty good—might be a little flat by now, though."

The Hunter gave her a look, his expression unreadable, and walked out the door quickly with the soda in hand.

"I hope you're not planning to scrape together the rest of what you owe me on the spot," London Moon said beside her.

"Of course not," Sydney Ginn turned around, but couldn't bring herself to meet her eyes, and rummaged in her bag with her head down before producing an envelope. "Twelve thousand. Count it."

The hand that took the envelope had slender, lean fingers with short, round, clear nails.

"...Do you have a strong objection to electronic transfers?" London Moon asked lightly, tapping the envelope.

"I haven't found anyone willing to launder money for me yet, so I keep cash at home." Sydney Ginn watched her seemingly capable hand and said, "If you know someone suitable, introduce

them to me."

For some reason, London Moon was always on the verge of laughing—when they first met, Sydney Ginn had thought she was a woman of few words.

Sydney Ginn had also assumed London Moon was the type to pocket the money without a glance, but to her surprise London Moon upended the bills onto the counter and slowly slipped them back into the envelope one by one.

"What are you doing?"

London Moon, without her cap, suddenly turned those eyes on her—eyes that were a startling blue, like a sky locked in Arctic ice, like a sea burning with polar cold, so clear they seemed as though they had never once fallen to earth.

All earthly things, even gender itself, seemed as though they should have nothing to do with London Moon; and yet there she sat with a banknote held between her fingers.

She looked at it carefully, tucked it away, and only then said, "...Seven. Of course I have to look properly. How would I know you haven't slipped in a counterfeit?"

Where would anyone even get counterfeit bills these days.

Sydney Ginn simply ordered her a drink and let her carry on as a human bill-counter in peace; London Moon smiled and said to the shar-pei-faced bartender, "By the way—it's her. She's the one who had a firsthand encounter with the Vulture."

Huh? The Vulture?

The bartender nodded and turned to Sydney Ginn, whose attention had immediately sharpened. "Just a few hours ago, I got word from a House Faction looking for information about the Vulture. You can call and tell him yourself—whatever compensation you want, that's negotiable too."

He wrote something on a slip of paper and handed it to Sydney Ginn.

"Chase Monroe?" She thought for a moment and said, "Never heard of him. Is he a Hunter? Which House Faction?"

The bartender stared at her for a second or two. "No, he's not a Hunter... You don't know who Chase Monroe is?"

"Should I?" Sydney Ginn was even more blank than he was.

"Never mind—you're not with any House Faction," the bartender volunteered the explanation on her behalf, waving a hand. "No need to know the people inside them. Just make sure you speak properly when the time comes and don't get on his bad side. If Chase Monroe is handling this personally, it must be important—otherwise it's usually Key House Faction Hunters who contact me."

"Key House Faction," London Moon interjected, though her tone gave nothing away. "...Thirty-one."

Important... Sydney Ginn turned that word over in her mind.

The Vulture Resident's behavior had been very abnormal, and it had grown dangerous—but in terms of importance, it didn't quite seem to rise to the level of needing a major figure from a House Faction to personally come asking around, especially given that, by the bartender's implication, this person was the second-in-command of Key House Faction.

What factor had made the Vulture so important?

Sydney Ginn glanced at the time on her phone—those hundred-plus messages had long since been cleared away, vanishing along with any trace of Anthony's existence—it was now November 18th, 10:23 PM.

She had encountered the Vulture Resident in the early hours of yesterday morning, and a House Faction was already asking about it today.

Marveling at just how well-informed a large House Faction could be, she thought: there was definitely more to the Vulture than she knew.

Had something happened recently in Hunter circles?

Sydney Ginn mulled it over for a while, then probed the bartender with a few indirect questions—but everything he could tell her was something she already knew. "Anything recent? Nothing particularly worth mentioning. The biggest thing has been Wellesley dying. The day it made the news, weren't you sitting right here?"

...Wellesley?

Sydney Ginn sat there with both hands wrapped around a plain cola she'd just ordered, mouth half-open, momentarily unable to believe she had managed to overlook something so glaring.

No, no—at that time she had just barely survived the ordeal of the real-and-fake Sydney Ginn crisis, her nerves still raw and her mind still scattered; it was perfectly normal to have missed it...

When she woke up on the museum floor, the Resident had been watching history inside the candle.

More precisely, it had been watching the history inside the candle that pertained to Wellesley.

But after it had copied her form, when it touched the candle, what appeared should have been Sydney Ginn's history—so why had Wellesley appeared?

And it had clearly been important; the Resident had watched with total absorption.

What connection did she have to Wellesley? What could Wellesley possibly have to do with her?

She would have to go back and look at the candle to find out, wouldn't she?

"What's wrong?" London Moon glanced at her. "You suddenly look very defeated."

"I... I might have to go back to the Nest again," Sydney Ginn said, and even just thinking about jumping off a building again, she could hear the blood draining from her face.

Wasn't there any way to do this without going back into the Nest, she thought, pressing her fingers hard against her temples.

The history that Resident had been watching at the time... it seemed to be from May.

Right—she remembered a long section of candle having melted into a lake-like pool of Candlefall; and in that "lake" not far from the Resident, there happened to be a fragment from the night she met Anthony, a clip of a bodyguard ramming a car into the back door of the bar.

That was a new piece of history—one the Resident itself had created—and the only version of events that had truly taken place.

Sydney Ginn jerked her head up.

She grabbed her phone and quickly found Amber in her contacts. After a few rings, Amber picked up on the other end: "Hello, Sydney?"

"The incident in May, when the car crashed into the bar—do you still remember?" Sydney Ginn cut straight to the point. "Did you ever hear anything afterward about that bodyguard

motorcade?"

Amber paused, not answering immediately. "Why are you suddenly asking about this?"

"...You know something," Sydney Ginn realized.

"No—I wouldn't say I know anything." Amber sounded somewhat reluctant. "Well... I wasn't trying to hide it from you forever. I mentioned what happened that night to the House Faction, just briefly—I didn't think it was anything significant myself. But after a while, the Hunter Director from our faction came to find me."

Amber drew a breath and continued: "He told me to keep that night's events confidential and not to speak of it to anyone. Even though I didn't know much and couldn't see any real need for secrecy... but it was the House Faction's wishes, so I had no choice but to comply."

This was the most important reason Sydney Ginn had no desire to join a House Faction: her own actions would be decided by others. On what grounds?

She didn't even know who the Key House Faction's second-in-command was, let alone who the Morgan House Faction's Hunter Director might be, so she simply asked: "Who's your Hunter Director?"

"Taylor Ford," Amber said.

Her tone was completely flat, which for a moment left Sydney Ginn unable to tell whether Amber had simply grown used to it or truly didn't know how illustrious those words—"Taylor Ford"—were in Hunter circles.

...Since when had Taylor Ford joined Morgan House Faction?

While Sydney Ginn was still stunned, Amber seemed to misread her silence and said, "You're not thinking of going to Taylor Ford to ask about this, are you? He won't tell you anything. Besides, our faction is in total chaos today—everyone's rushed off their feet. He'll be leading a team into the Nest very soon..."

"What happened?" Sydney Ginn instinctively asked, following the thread.

"A squad we sent into the Nest last week seems to have been completely wiped out somehow—not a single one has come back. The squad leader, a man named Jonah, is only known to still be alive, but he needs emergency rescue and there's no time to waste... A woman who had just come out of the Nest reported it to us. I forget her name."

Friends, this chapter is going up early today because I need to take my cat to the vet in a bit—she's been losing fur in a strange way lately, which has me worried...

Didn't expect that before I could squeeze out a bonus chapter, it would be time to go paid already—yes, tomorrow, the 29th. I really do drag my feet...

I humbly ask all you dear readers to spread the happy news (?) of the launch! I'm aiming to try my best and get at least 20 first-day subscriptions. Our greatest virtue is not being greedy.

I'll subscribe one myself, rally my editor into subscribing one too, plus family and close friends—hmm, that still leaves 17 people to win over...

Once I get back from the vet (?) later, I'll write a launch post. Oh my, I really do have quite a bit of nonsense I want to ziang about.

Chapter 48 — It's on the shelves, and here I am perched on them with a few words to say

Think about it — it's only been forty-some days since Artifact launched, just over a month.

I truly never expected I'd be riding such a rollercoaster...

Ensemble writing is at least three times harder (I calculated this by repeatedly pouring green liquid back and forth in a lab while wearing a white coat), and the audience is three times smaller (same method — very scientific). I'd mentally prepared myself for all of that.

Or rather, I thought I had mentally prepared myself.

When I first started, I was still carrying the illusions and momentum left over from my last novel, and if I looked out far enough, I could almost still see a garden in full bloom — ghostly as it was.

(I know that one wasn't all that popular either — it's just that, comparatively speaking, it had a much broader appeal.)

Aside from the initial burst of support when I launched — when things were, for a brief moment, actually in full bloom — after that, as the story unfolded, I started facing the cold hard reality: wait, I knew you were niche, but I didn't think **this** niche?

It felt like all my readers had followed me over from the last novel, and were dropping off one by one along the way — my reserves were shrinking fast. Who wouldn't panic? Watching the backend numbers fall lower and lower, I went through a pretty anxious stretch.

See, no matter how resolved you are when you make a decision, you still feel it when you walk headfirst into reality. Hit it hard enough, and you end up in a cast.

Head wrapped in plaster, I watched (don't ask me how — I could see it anyway) my new novel grow quieter and quieter, and I slowly ground my way forward, writing Chase at the time — an unpopular character in an already niche story. But somewhere in that grinding, my mindset suddenly settled.

Hard to explain — it was just this sudden feeling of, **oh, this is actually the state I should be in.**

When I started this book, I came into it with the mindset of writing as if I'd never written anything before — as if this were the first novel of my life. So when the outside world wasn't buzzing, wasn't flying flags, wasn't putting on a show — wasn't that exactly right?

The more niche and obscure a story, the more it needs a niche, quiet environment to be written in — otherwise it's too easy to lose your eye to other things. "Environment" counts here in both senses: internal and external.

So when I said I'd aim for twenty first-day subscribers — yes, it was a joke, but thinking back on it now, if it really were just twenty, that wouldn't be so hard to accept. You go back to where you came from — and that's not saying the road was walked for nothing. It's more like... the mountain is a mountain again, and the water is water again.

I chose a path few others walk, so naturally I should take it step by step in silence, watching the mountain ranges shift through pale smoke and cloud, and every now and then, the veil lifts — and I glimpse the hidden landscape I've been searching for.

All of that to say: thank you, all of you, for being willing to walk this road with me all the way to the end of the dark — because for the record, I didn't bring a flashlight (。

PS: Oh right! My editor reminded me to mention the Wild Deer Convenience Store every so often, in case anyone still doesn't know I've been keeping a short-story side piece (not really). My editor has been incredibly good to me — practically one step away from going out masked to drag people in to read — so I have to shout it out a couple more times: Wild Deer Convenience Store, Wild Deer Convenience Store!

Short reads to go with your meals — with a sweetness that lingers!

After reading Wild Deer Convenience Store, kids' test scores improved, grandma's knees stopped aching — so says citizen Ms. Liu.

"Wild Deer Convenience Store is a shop I'd be happy to visit again and again," — excerpt from a Wall Street Journal review, totally made up for the sake of clout.

Chapter 49: The Secret Behind a Qidian Author's Fake Gathering-Money-and-Being-Unfilial Act for Over a Month

Hello, my dear readers — my leave note got taken down by Qidian, and I'm not sure if it's because I said j* or because I said m*le.

Perfectly normal words, and yet the moment they get turned into **, the evil energy doubles, doesn't it? Truly picking up a rock just to drop it on everyone's feet.

Anyway, it got taken down. My chapters are limited-edition — read them while you can, because poof, they're gone (。

Now the leave note is just a dream in a rearview mirror growing smaller in the distance. But those of you who did see it are blessed — you should run downstairs right now and buy a lottery ticket (click the little tree icon in the bottom right, there's a chestnut tree).

The last time I posted a thank-you chapter was back on May 7th — just five days after the death of the Bronx Brothers.

Going over a month without thanking my dear readers — what an act of filial impiety. What on earth was the reason behind it?

First, because I've been using every scrap of author's-note real estate for my own rambling nonsense; and second, because saving them all up and thanking everyone at once makes for a very long list — which creates the illusion that the Artifact report is wildly popular (。

Though it might well be the same crowd of readers every month, sponsoring me the way you'd hand over allowance money to a kid (。

First up, I'd like to invite to the stage: Your Dad Laughs Openly, Chalk-the-Frame, Nine-Five, Yaoyao and Linlin, Don't Ask How Many Flowers Bloom, and Pangxiaoya — six high-shine readers. Let me lie down on the floor and be your red carpet...

Oh my dear readers, what are you all doing — your tips are truly too generous, it's gotten to the point where I'm too embarrassed to just give you a stage appearance and have no choice but to add extra chapters instead... We know each other so well at this point, so next time save it and just give a m*le vote, okay?

(I'm right there on the edge of violating the rules, what are you gonna do about it)

But honestly, quite a few of you tipped around the time I posted my frustrated rant, and I think you were trying to comfort me — I looked at the dates and nearly teared up. Leave me a message? Extra chapter or a stage appearance, or if you want something else just tell me — I promise I didn't say s*usage, Qidian please don't ban me.

Sure, our reader count isn't huge, but the hearts you all use to support me are real and true, and I do love living off your generosity (。

Next up are the regulars who show up almost every month: Haynes and Iron-Armor Baitang... what can I say, honestly — you might as well leave a secondary card on file with me — no wait, that's not what I meant — it's just, I feel a little bashful.

Into the Artifact Report Field Research Fund, thanks to: BookFriend20190620111919738 (let's get you a real name — you've tipped twice, and I typed out this whole string of numbers both times only to realize it was the same person), Jiuri Little Monster (a new reader perhaps? No? Yes?), and Mòyuān Pronounced as Black Bird (your username has practically brainwashed me to the point where I no longer recognize the characters 墨鸢),

as well as b1111111111 (hold onto your subway ticket — do they have a three-day pass to save money?), Murakami's Kafka (awfully polite of you?), Joiiii (tipping while watching the game — a spirit that moves the heart), and Twenty-Four's QD (I feel like if I keep saving these up I'll be able to sign over my entire self).

Let me add it all up — not counting accommodation, I think this should be enough to keep me alive for three days of field research? I've never actually experienced New York prices myself; I've heard even a breakfast roll costs seven kuai, though luckily I don't eat breakfast.

Next up, first tier of the rolling thank-you list: Does Sanjiu Love Red Bean Cake (yes, the one shaking down first-years for protection money, that's me), Sanjiu's Doggo, Non-Edible Little Cat Gummy (you tip more punctually than I update), Always on the Side of the Egg (I get it), and vitang (oh hey, we meet again).

New line, so everyone's eyes can catch a breath: thanks to Drunk Uproot a Willow (put him down for a sec would you), Jinjiang Qinshui, Emmy-chan, Zookeeper K, Ciel Mò, Ahhhh What Is Happening, Yinglóng Wants Herbal Jelly (eat it), Mia'ao (meow), and Fujin of Mumbai (what are you up to).

Continuing the line: thanks to Wu Ya, Yingyou, I Am Ayun's Puppet Wuwuwuwu (how does that username not get banned?!), Shèjiāng Is Away (I feel like you and Jinjiang Qinshui are part of

the same series), Dongxie (reader, you're in remarkably good health?), and Medea's Little Sheep.

This next row I know every single one of: MARGINAL Fish, Cloud Alliance Little Angel, Fox Baby, Yuèzhuó Likes Adventure Stories (excellent in both comments and tips), Shandong Runaway Excavator (thanks — I'm definitely not telling Lanxiang), A Cup of Daydream No Sugar, and Ten Thousand Volts i — see, this is the advantage of having a small readership: I know every one of you.

Business is booming though, and I still have more to thank: Erikakoo, Little Sun Takes You Flying, DStorm, Spring Jingzhe, Little Wine Cup, Fallen Plum Treading Snow to Come (unfamiliar face — possibly a new reader, don't dare say for sure), A-Qi's Little Girl, Du Ziruò, Jīnwú, _E_Stella_, BookFriend20230503221938575 (see, there's just no getting to know someone by their numbers), and Good Luck Seven Treasures.

Looking at all this, it turned out to be quite a grand sweeping chapter of thanks — anyone who didn't know better might think I'm a top-three tipper myself.

But a person can't live in delusion forever. Going forward I really do need to thank my readers in a timely manner — I can't afford to be this unfilial for so long again.

Chapter 50 — Some Q&A on the World-Building Behind the Artifact Reports

Since I've seen similar questions come up a few times in the VIP chapters at the back, I've decided to open a separate chapter to address them before the paid content begins.

If this makes sense to you, feel free to read on — subscribing will be worth it. (Of course, if the plot turns out to be no good... well, there are no refunds.)

The main question is: why hasn't the government gotten involved in Hunter affairs — or in other words, why isn't there any government oversight?

I'd like to break this question into two parts: first, whether it's possible; and second, whether anyone would want to.

1. Whether It's Possible

The passage is something entirely random, rare, and demanding in its conditions.

Whether a person ever discovers they have a passage comes down entirely to luck — government power has absolutely no role to play here.

Because the government can't very well mobilize the citizens of a major city and have them try jumping off buildings or ramming into televisions one by one... The very nature of the passage fundamentally ensures that no government can form a national team, because it is an intensely personal trait that cannot be controlled by any outside force.

Without a national team, there's no way to enter the Nest; you're shut out at the source. If you have no idea what's being brought into the human world, you have no way to regulate the circulation of Artifacts. (This doesn't rule out the occasional Artifact falling into official hands.)

So what about organizing or overseeing the Hunters who already exist?

First of all, the Artifact Report world draws on the American political environment — any kind of oversight would require a whole chain of steps: introducing a bill in Congress, voting to pass legislation, securing congressional funding, establishing a regulatory body, submitting to public scrutiny...

But 99.9% of humanity has no idea that the Nest, Artifacts, or Hunters exist.

If you were a senator, how would you explain to your constituents why you voted in favor of a proposal that sounds like complete nonsense, and why you spent enormous amounts of tax money on "something that doesn't exist"?

How would you keep your political opponents from using that against you?

You might say that intelligence agencies could quietly move to arrest or surveil Hunters — and technically speaking, yes, that could be done.

But only on the premise that you already know who the Hunters are.

The randomness of passage discovery means that as the regulatory authority, you never know who might become a Hunter tomorrow, and there's never any warning in advance.

Not to mention that Hunters aren't stupid — the moment that kind of operation began, Hunters would go deeper underground to protect themselves, or even fight back using the power of Artifacts. So where's the benefit? (This gets into the question of whether anyone would want to, which I'll cover in part two.)

And from the Hunter's perspective — when you've risked your life to obtain an Artifact and you can sell it for a high price, how likely are you to turn it over to the government, get absorbed into the system, and take home a few thousand dollars a month as a civil servant?

On top of that, the Nest is a realm beyond the reach of any law. Once you're inside, only the people who come out alive know what happened in there. What if a government team went in and never came back?

Government power is ultimately made up of people, and when over 99% of people are shut out from the Nest and Artifacts, that means the government is shut out too.

2. Whether Anyone Would Want To

Short answer: no.

Suppose the government did have the ability to regulate Hunters and the Nest: Party A gets elected, establishes a Bureau of Artifacts, nearly eliminates Artifacts from civilian hands, and consolidates all Artifacts under government control.

Then Party A fails to win re-election, and Party B takes power.

Once Party A becomes the opposition with no access to Artifacts whatsoever — would they feel like they'd shot themselves in the foot? (This kind of competition plays out within parties too.)

What if, at that moment, an Artifact suddenly appeared that could keep the ruling party in power forever — or keep the opposition in opposition forever? Would Party A be willing to exit the stage of history for good?

And given that the political environment this story draws on is the United States, the ultimate goal of dark-money politics still comes down to money.

Would the donors behind those senators want them to pass regulations? Once things are regulated, their own access to Artifacts shrinks and becomes less convenient. Even if the candidate they back is willing to leave the back door open for them, would that candidate's opponents?

As a major donor, would you fund a candidate who, once elected, raises your taxes?

If not, then you certainly wouldn't fund a candidate who, once elected, makes it impossible for you to buy Artifacts.

Would a candidate even bother pushing something this thankless — even just to keep the campaign contributions coming?

Look at the real-world example: American commercial health insurance doesn't just profit off people's misery — it profits by consuming people outright. So why won't either party touch commercial health insurance, even to win votes? Because those companies are major donors.

So, to summarize:

1. The vast majority of people are kept in the dark;
2. Regulation would face enormous obstacles;
3. Hunters are just in it for the money — pay them enough, and you can buy the Artifacts right out of their hands;
4. Letting Hunters come and go from the Nest as they please benefits everyone, including high-ranking government officials themselves;
5. The consequence of regulation might be losing your political donations and doing all the hard work for your opponents.

Something that is basically all hardship and downsides with no benefit to speak of — if you were in power, why would you bother?

Chapter 51: Mai Minghe Has No Home to Return To

Mai Minghe had no home to return to.

She walked barefoot through the streets of Blackmoor City in the small hours of the morning, chilled to the bone—especially her toes, which felt as though they'd been glued on and might drop off at any moment.

At first, she could still feel the layer of grime on the soles of her feet, and whenever she stepped on something suspiciously sticky, she would scrape and slap her feet hard against the ground. But after a while, Mai Minghe gave up caring—the streets of Blackmoor City were hardly clean, and fussing over it was like trying to put out a fire by spitting on it; if she worried about that, she'd never make it home before dawn.

Just before she'd hit the screen, Jonah had grabbed her by the shoulder at the last second, and it still burned and ached; for all that the young man had been taken over by some parasite, his grip was something else.

She had thought that the hardest part of getting home from the Nest would be shaking Jonah off.

She had slammed into the screen just ahead of Jonah's grasp and had indeed made it back to the real world—but the place she'd tumbled out into was not her own home.

All these years lived, and yet here she was, old as she was, still finding new ways to suffer.

Mai Minghe sighed inwardly as she walked, stone-faced, past a cluster of drunks on the roadside who whistled and called out—"Hey, sweetheart! What are you doing walking around in your pajamas? Did your boyfriend kick you out for the night?"

Rationally, she knew that being a young woman alone on the streets of Blackmoor City at this hour was actually dangerous.

But emotionally, Mai Minghe couldn't quite summon the will to be afraid.

"Hey!" One of the drunks actually came after her, reaching out to grab her arm, slurring, "We were calling you... don't go, walking around barefoot must hurt. Come with us... we'll give you money."

Mai Minghe stopped, her gaze drifting past him to the building behind.

"Where's the pharmacy?" she couldn't help asking. "It's been there for decades—when did they tear it down? When did it turn into a real estate agency? I don't even recognize this building..."

The drunk turned around in a daze. "...Huh?"

"The old man who ran that pharmacy, raising his granddaughter on his own—life wasn't easy for them. He's probably long gone by now..." Mai Minghe shook her head and kept walking. "I haven't walked this far in seven or eight years. I've lived here my whole life, and now I can barely recognize the place..."

The drunk stood rooted to the spot, watching her walk away, and didn't follow.

If he had actually followed her, Mai Minghe would have been happy to chat with him—she always felt that talking things out was the only way to sort them through properly, one by one.

For instance, as she walked and reflected, she'd worked out that the rules for entering and leaving the Nest went something like this: she had hit the screen and fallen into the Nest; then, inside the Nest, she had hit the screen again and fallen back into Blackmoor City.

But where she came out wasn't necessarily where she'd gone in, and it didn't have to be through the screen either—just now she had dropped out of nowhere onto the lid of a trash can outside a residential building, and when she'd rolled off and looked around, she was still a kilometer from home.

It seemed the passage wasn't particularly precise; getting you back roughly in the right area was apparently good enough.

During this walk home, she couldn't help wondering—how was that young man named Jonah doing? How could a perfectly good kid be allowed to stay taken over by some parasite?

Besides, a person couldn't stay in the Nest for more than seven days, and Jonah didn't have much time left.

She'd have to find a way to track down the Morgan House Faction... they had that thing now, oh right, the internet—or else she could go to the library and ask the librarian to help her look it up online.

She was deep in thought, walking along, when she caught sight of the run-down apartment building she'd lived in for decades—and came to a sudden stop.

A police car was parked in front of the building, its lights casting alternating flashes of red and blue across the wall.

Late as it was, a small scattering of onlookers had gathered around—some were neighbors from her building, others were idle passersby from the surrounding area.

This neighborhood had poor public safety: a lot of immigrants, a lot of low-income residents. A police car in the middle of the night was nothing unusual. But among the crowd, Mai Minghe immediately spotted one familiar face: the middle-aged woman who lived below her, an incorrigible busybody—though, to her credit, also actually warm-hearted.

"...The two of them climbed down the fire escape in the dead of night, groping around outside the windows—scared me half to death!" Mrs. Smith had latched onto a police officer's arm and refused to let him go. "They said they were looking for someone, but I don't buy it. I know that old woman on the second floor—she hasn't gotten out of bed or left the apartment in years. She doesn't sprout wings and fly away in the middle of the night!"

"What is that supposed to mean?"

The female nurse aide's face had gone white with anger. "We're proper nurses—you think we came here to steal from you? We came because we received an emergency alert, but the old woman suddenly disappeared on her own. How could we not look for her?"

The male nurse aide, for his part, was focused on an entirely different concern.

He had boxed in the officer from the other side and kept repeating his account of the situation: "...This matter is absolutely not a failure on our part—please make sure to note that down carefully, and be sure to make it clear to our hospital as well. At the time, her grandson was watching her; we were already getting ready to leave. In terms of supervision, it was no longer our responsibility. If you find that the old woman actually fell off the building..."

Right—it was only now that Mai Minghe realized something she'd been slow to consider.

The thief was without a doubt an Artifact Hunter, or at the very least, someone connected to the Hunter trade.

He knew she had entered the Nest through her passage; but the other two nurse aides on the scene were ordinary people who knew nothing about the Nest—just as she herself had been until not long ago.

All they knew was that there had been an old woman in the room, and then in the blink of an eye, she was gone. How was anyone supposed to handle a situation like that?

Thinking about it that way, it was actually rather remarkable: so many Artifact Hunters, so many of their clients, and yet they managed to keep the existence of the Nest and its Artifacts sealed tight—not a whisper of it reaching the wider world.

Tens of millions of ordinary people went about their daily lives, toiling away at survival in the real world, entirely unaware that beyond the everyday, there existed a world of dark and fantastical things.

"Alright, alright, Mrs. Smith, is it? Go on back inside—it was all a misunderstanding, nobody's here to steal anything from you."

The officer finally managed to extract himself from the crowd, pulled open the car door, and turned to the male nurse aide: "The family member has already said they won't be pressing any charges against you—see how he gets in touch with you to handle things from here. A living person doesn't just vanish into thin air; my guess is the old woman got confused and wandered off somewhere. We've already filed a report, and more officers will be here shortly to do another sweep of the area... alright, alright, everyone go home."

"Family member"—that would be the thief, then?

Mai Minghe thought of her convenient grandson, craned her neck to look around, but saw no sign of the thief.

She watched the officer get back in his car, and the rest of the crowd gradually dispersed; in no time at all, only Mai Minghe remained on the street.

The police car drove past her, and the officer inside glanced at her briefly—her heart lurched for a moment, as though she were the guilty party—but she watched the officer's gaze shift away almost immediately as he picked up his phone and pressed it to his ear.

Mai Minghe let out a slow breath.

Of course. There was no way they could know that this young woman who looked to be in her twenties was the very old lady they couldn't find no matter how hard they searched...

When she passed Mrs. Smith's door, she moved with careful deliberateness, making no sound, and turned to head up the stairs.

Mai Minghe was focused on one thing: getting home as fast as possible, washing her feet first, then changing her clothes—rescuing Jonah would have to wait until daylight, when she could ask someone to help her find information; at this hour, the library wouldn't even be open.

But her path home came to a halt just a few steps short of her own door.

Her front door, which had been pried open, was now half-ajar, not fully shut.

Through the gap in the door, she heard footsteps moving around inside, occasionally hitting the wooden floorboards in front of the kitchen with a creak; and amid the sound of those footsteps, the thief's voice came through clearly with a low "mm-hm."

Mai Minghe froze where she stood, caught between advancing and retreating.

"They left?"

The thief's voice carried through the door, clear in the quiet of the night. "The nurse aides went home too? What did you tell them?"

Who was he on the phone with?

The room went silent for a few seconds; then the thief let out a breath. "I owe you one for handling this so quickly. Yeah, right—my main concern was those two nurse aides..."

Mai Minghe's curiosity and instinct to investigate surged all at once, and she silently edged one step forward.

Whatever the person on the phone had said put the thief at ease; his voice relaxed somewhat: "You're right. If it hadn't been for that woman downstairs insisting on calling the police, I think those two nurse aides would've preferred to keep it quiet too—they probably wouldn't have dug any deeper. Yeah, your people are really professional at cleaning things up... it was exactly like the real thing. If I weren't the one who'd made the call myself, I'd have been worried."

A wave of goosebumps broke across Mai Minghe's skin, and she suddenly understood who was on the other end of the line—just a moment ago, she had seen that person herself.

"Yes, just send the bill to our House Faction..."

The thief seemed to have heard a tricky question, because he paused before continuing: "Hm? No, I don't know how that old woman could have suddenly discovered her passage out of nowhere either..."

He was lying.

The moment he'd pressed that tube against a person, it let them see the vision of opening their own passage.

Mai Minghe thought back to the scene and felt everything fall into place: the thief had intended to use the vacuum device to take her passage from her, but while the vacuum device was working, it had also let her see, for the first time, how her own passage could be opened.

As if drawn by a summons, she had been called to the television set by her passage, and had tumbled into the Nest.

While she was turning this over in her mind, the thief's next words came half a beat late, breaking through her thoughts and reaching her.

"...Wait, there's someone outside my door."

Mai Minghe jolted with a start and instinctively looked down, seeing in the corridor light that her own shadow fell in a vague, blurry patch—right in front of the door.

She had to move—

But before she could even turn around, the door was already pulled open by the thief; she looked up and found herself face to face with him.

Apart from the faint sound of traffic coming through his phone, there was complete silence between them.

In that split second, Mai Minghe felt as though another version of herself had taken over her reactions: she stared at him blankly for a moment, then seemed to collect herself, and smiled at him.

"I just took out some trash," she said quietly. "Did you move in recently?"

The thief's brow furrowed slightly as his gaze swept across her face twice.

Having said her piece, giving him no chance to think further, Mai Minghe turned and walked on, as if her own apartment were somewhere further down the corridor.

Even though she looked decades younger and had shed her pajama jacket, she still didn't dare let the thief's eyes linger on her any longer than necessary—as she passed her own front door, she could almost tangibly feel his gaze slide over her bare, filth-streaked feet.

Two steps on, and she still hadn't heard the thief go back inside; she glanced back, and sure enough, met those eyes again.

"Something wrong?" She frowned too. "Oh, and your door wasn't shut just now."

"Hm? Oh, thanks."

The thief startled slightly, and seemed to realize that standing in a corridor in the middle of the night staring at a young woman was, indeed, a bit improper; a trace of suspicion remained on his face, but under Mai Minghe's unflinching gaze, he finally drew back—and this time, he closed the door.

The moment it clicked shut, Mai Minghe turned and ran.

She had no thought to spare for whether her footsteps might wake Mrs. Smith—she thundered down the stairs; and just as she reached the landing at the foot of the staircase, she heard a door upstairs slam open with a bang, crashing against the wall.

Immediately after, a second set of footsteps rang out in the hallway.

The thief might not yet realize he had grown young again, but he had certainly noticed enough telltale signs to arouse his suspicion—this home, it seemed, was somewhere he could not return to for the time being.

Mai Minghe burst out through the building's front door, but did not keep running along the street; she ducked sideways and slipped into the narrow alley behind the building, crouching down behind a waist-high trash bin.

After about ten seconds, she heard the footsteps, just as she had expected; peeking carefully from behind the trash bin, she caught the thief's retreating silhouette scanning back and forth along the street, before he picked a direction and walked away.

Several more minutes passed, and the street was empty again.

Not daring to make a single sound, Mai Minghe slowly rose, hunched at the waist, and retreated step by step under the cover of the trash bins. She was afraid the thief might still be close by; once she stepped on a fragment of cracked hard plastic, the pain made her bite down hard on her lip, but she did not make a sound.

Following the alley behind the building, she finally put distance between herself and her home, inch by inch.

When the sky began to lighten to a pale gray, Mai Minghe stood dazed in the street, at a loss for where to go.

As long as she waited patiently, the thief would give up sooner or later—he could hardly move into her home permanently. But in the time before he left, where was she supposed to go?

The goal of finding the Morgan House Faction seemed to have grown even more distant.

The most pressing matter right now seemed to be finding herself a pair of shoes first.

Come to think of it, there was one place that would suit her perfectly: she could not only find shoes there, but also get a piece of clothing and a few slices of bread—near Brooklyn Community College, there was a charity relief station where homeless vagrants often came to collect aid supplies.

Wasn't that exactly what she was right now—a homeless vagrant?

The relief station was not close, but Mai Minghe had no other choice and could only push her bare feet forward.

She had no watch and no way of knowing the time, but by the time she finally drew near the place, daylight had long since broken fully, and the heavy rush-hour traffic had thinned out again and returned to its usual flow.

Mai Minghe did not see the moment the black Mercedes suddenly swung its door open.

By the time she registered that a tall figure had leapt up in the street and was striding in large steps toward the subway station across the road, the black Mercedes, now without its driver, had already lost control—it veered crookedly up onto the sidewalk and, with a thunderous crash, slammed headlong into a tree just a few steps in front of her.

A woman inside the car, her hair in purple dreadlocks, appeared to have taken a hard hit from the impact; struggling to push the door open, she muttered furiously to herself: "...When I get back to the House Faction, I am absolutely renegotiating my contract!"

Today's chapter ran quite long—even I didn't expect to write this much. Consider it a celebration of the official launch!

Truly, I couldn't save a single extra word...

The timelines of the three (current) main characters are finally about to converge!

P.S.: My cat is fine!

The vet asked me whether my cat had fleas. I said, with full confidence, no—she never goes outside. Then the vet took a little comb and ran it through her fur a few times, and the fleas on

that comb outnumbered my confidence by a wide margin...

No wonder my poor girl has been losing fur so badly—turns out she's allergic to fleas!!!

I've got a major project ahead of me when I get home—spray everywhere, strip all the fabric and wash it, mop the floors with a steam mop...

Truly, there's never a shortage of things to keep me busy...

Chapter 52: Mai Minghe Cannot Be Found by the Morgan House Faction

What happened next swept in like a tornado—fast enough to catch everyone off guard.

In the blink of an eye, more than ten police cars came screaming onto the scene and surrounded the crash site; onlookers sprouted up from nowhere like mushrooms after rain, standing at a distance on the nearby streets—and on the upper floors of the buildings alongside, window after window swung open, vague faces peering out.

Did they really have to be this efficient?

Couldn't they have at least left her two minutes to ask the purple-haired woman about the House Factions?

In over eighty years of living, this was the first time Mai Minghe had ever complained that the police arrived too quickly—she watched as the purple-haired woman was already surrounded by officers, unable to ask her anything, yet unwilling to leave; what surprised her was that after a few words exchanged with the purple-haired woman, several of the officers holstered their guns.

"The ambulance is almost here," one of the officers said. "Can you stand?"

Wedge in among the crowd of onlookers, Mai Minghe caught fragments of conversation drifting past her—things like "came barreling through in a car," "kidnapped a woman," "suspect not yet apprehended"...

Kidnapped? How was she kidnapped?

That purple-haired woman seemed to have some connection to Artifact Hunters, and Hunters were supposed to be capable people; and judging by her tone just now, she seemed to know the man who had been driving.

Mai Minghe couldn't make sense of it. She tried several times to strike up a conversation and ask what was going on, but the moment anyone caught a glimpse of how she looked, they all pretended not to see her and casually stepped away.

She couldn't blame them—she really did look quite a sight right now.

Her bare feet were so dirty that the original color of her skin was unrecognizable, and here she was in the middle of the morning, still wearing her pajamas.

Years of being bedridden had left her hair uncut; now that it had grown thick again, it was an even wilder tangle—and when she touched her face, she found a dried layer of vomit still crusted on it.

Mai Minghe picked out a kind-looking woman and, no matter how many steps back the woman took, she kept closing the distance with unwavering persistence—until the woman finally shoved two folded banknotes into her hands and made a hasty escape.

...Well then. She'd discovered a side hustle.

Being someone everyone avoided did have its advantages: working off the single edge that nobody would go near a vagrant, Mai Minghe clutched her two banknotes and made her way smoothly to the very front of the crowd, watching the entire process of the police escorting the purple-haired woman away with perfect clarity.

"Y-yes, he held a gun to me and forced me into the car... The pickup location? Hmm, I can't quite remember, my head hurts so much..."

The purple-haired woman's steps were unsteady and faltering, supported on either side by an officer as they walked toward the ambulance that had just arrived.

Her hands were bound in front of her with zip ties, and she said in a slurred voice, "He tied me up, but then had me read the map for him... Oh, no, he didn't hurt me. But I'm very dizzy, a little nauseous..."

Watching her, Mai Minghe couldn't shake the feeling that the moment the police arrived, the purple-haired woman had suddenly grown considerably weaker, her mind considerably more muddled—when just moments ago she had been shouting curses with a perfectly clear, sharp voice.

Could this somehow be connected to the Nest or to Artifacts as well?

Well, never mind—whatever she and her companion were planning, one thing was perfectly clear: if she wanted information about the Morgan House Faction, the best way was to ask a Hunter.

But the only person in front of Mai Minghe right now who had any connection to Hunters was being helped along and walking away, climbing into the ambulance, which then swung its doors shut with a heavy thud.

She watched the Mercedes get towed away, and then the ambulance drove off in a grand procession accompanied by a fleet of police cars. Mai Minghe looked down at her feet and let out a long sigh.

She was exhausted, hungry, and aching all over; it felt like the soles of her feet had been cut open too.

"I'm sorry for putting you both through this," she said to these hard-won young bare feet of hers. "We've lost our shoes, so we'll have to walk a little further."

In all her years, she had encountered no shortage of uncomfortable, miserable, and unpleasant situations; Mai Minghe had long since developed her own way of absorbing and adapting to them—for instance, she had just given her two feet names in her head: one was called Little Left, and the other Little Right.

To add a touch of fun, she decided that Little Left was the right foot, and Little Right was the left foot.

Mai Minghe had company now; Little Left and Little Right led the way, the three of them setting off together toward the nearest hospital.

When they passed by the charity relief station, Little Left wanted to turn in and get a bite to eat, maybe ask for a pair of shoes; but Little Right had a better grasp of the bigger picture and explained the situation:

The purple-haired woman looked like she had, at most, a mild concussion—and it was quite possibly faked.

She didn't need a large, fully-equipped hospital, so the ambulance would certainly take her to the nearest Clayton Hospital emergency room. Under normal circumstances, the police would also follow to take an immediate statement; so for the next hour or so, the purple-haired woman would be staying at Clayton Hospital.

And since she appeared not to be a suspect and didn't seem to be facing detention, all Mai Minghe had to do was walk over to Clayton Hospital and wait at the entrance for a while—she should be able to catch the purple-haired woman on her way out.

But if Mai Minghe went to the relief station now and lost time over a meal, she had no idea how she would ever find another Hunter in the vast expanse of Blackmoor City.

Compared to a meal and a pair of shoes, one person's life was more important, wasn't it?

Little Left was convinced, and together with Little Right, the two of them dragged the utterly spent Mai Minghe all the way to Clayton Hospital.

The moment she caught sight of the hospital entrance, Mai Minghe nearly crumpled to the ground like a collapsing building—since fleeing her apartment, she had been walking nonstop for at least four or five hours, and on top of that, since the previous night, she had not had a single drop of water nor a single bite of food; even a young person would have been unable to bear it.

"Thank you," she said to Little Left and Little Right. "Rest a while—from here, all we have to do is wait."

Mai Minghe was very patient.

She thought of not long ago, when she had lain in bed day after day. Back then, Mai Minghe had already lost much interest in the news, always feeling it belonged to another world—one she had no part in, one she was about to be left behind by.

She was fonder of a lively reality show about a household of over a dozen people—she would lie in bed, motionless, watching the daylight shift outside the window, waiting amid the murmur of the news for the reality show to begin, her mind drifting in and out of clarity.

Life felt like a pearl necklace, moments that could easily slip away strung one by one along a long, long thread of waiting.

Mai Minghe was too exhausted and nearly missed the purple-haired woman walking out through the main doors.

It wasn't until the woman was already standing at the roadside with her phone, waiting for a ride, that Mai Minghe jolted awake and rushed over, calling out to her: "Hey, hello there."

The purple-haired woman turned around, revealing a face that was pleasant and approachable, yet wore an expression of exhaustion.

Understandably—anyone who had been through what she had that morning would be exhausted.

"Hmm? Oh, hold on," the purple-haired woman patted the pockets of her jacket, "I think I have some change..."

"I'm not asking for money," Mai Minghe clarified.

The purple-haired woman stopped her hand and looked at her.

To look at her, you would never have guessed she was a Hunter—except for the taut muscle on her frame and the practical ease of her clothes.

At this critical moment, Mai Minghe found herself suddenly less certain, but with no other option, she steeled herself and went straight to the point: "Could you tell me how to find the Morgan House Faction?"

"You're asking for directions? Morgan—"

The purple-haired woman glanced off to the side, then suddenly caught herself and fixed her eyes back on Mai Minghe, asking slowly, "...You mean the Morgan House Faction?"

Surely Artifact Hunters wouldn't kill off every person who knew about them just to keep them quiet?

The thought actually startled Mai Minghe herself.

If knowing about them meant danger, then naturally there was only one most reasonable course of action.

"Yes, I'm a Hunter too. But I've always gone into the Nest on my own—I've never joined a House Faction, so I don't know anything about any of this." Mai Minghe said it while silently hoping that there were indeed Hunters in the world who operated without joining a House Faction. "I want to join the Morgan House Faction now... Do you know how to find them?"

The moment the word "Nest" left her mouth, a subtle shift crossed the purple-haired woman's expression; as though "Nest" were a key that unlocked the surface she wore as an ordinary citizen, revealing beneath it something tougher, more removed from the everyday world.

"You... how did you end up like this?" She looked Mai Minghe up and down. "I've never seen a Hunter who's had it this rough. And how did you know I was one too?"

"I was right there when your car crashed," Mai Minghe said, herself a little embarrassed, rubbing her hand vigorously through her hair.

"Oh, you saw Chase. He's pretty hard to miss." The purple-haired woman nodded, seeming satisfied with that explanation.

If "Chase" was the tall silhouette, then Mai Minghe had only ever seen a "Ch"—though she was rather pleased with herself for thinking up that joke, she kept it to herself.

"You can't just join a House Faction whenever you feel like it, you know—there are screening standards you have to meet first..."

The purple-haired woman said it, then looked again at Mai Minghe's sorry state, and something like sympathy stirred in her. "Well, but when you're truly out of options, it's not a bad thing to try... At the very least, they should be able to give you a meal."

"So how should I..."

"You're in luck—I was just recruited into the Key House Faction," the purple-haired woman said with a smile, as though speaking of something she was proud of. "Before I joined, I'd saved contact information for several House Faction HRs. Morgan House Faction's happened to be one of them."

...HR?

Hunter House Factions had a Human Resources department?

It was Human Resources, right? Not some new term the young people were using?

Mai Minghe kept her face carefully blank and watched as the purple-haired woman took out her phone; the woman looked up and met her eyes.

The two of them stared at each other in silence for a few seconds until the purple-haired woman finally spoke: "Why are you staring at me? Get out your phone and take down the number."

Mai Minghe rummaged through her pockets and produced two crumpled banknotes. "Do you have a pen?" she said, with some awkwardness. "This is all I have... I'll write it down on this..."

"You don't have a phone?"

She only had a landline—a single elderly-model phone that she hadn't used in years. But Mai Minghe sensed that this was better left unsaid.

"In the Nest... I lost it." She said haltingly.

The look the purple-haired woman gave Mai Minghe had shifted from sympathy to something closer to the expression one wore at a funeral.

"Ah," she wiped her nose, as though there was something she wanted to say but couldn't quite bring herself to. "Well... I mean, no wonder you want to join a House Faction. You need to

remember going forward—personal belongings must not be left in the Nest. You should always, always try to avoid that."

Her expression all but added: if you have a going forward, that is.

The purple-haired woman really did have a remarkably kind heart.

"Now that I've joined the Key House Faction, it wouldn't be appropriate for me to contact other House Faction HRs anymore. You have to keep up appearances in the workplace. Here's what you do—find a... find a payphone, give them a call, and say Kingsley Roselyn referred you."

She fished a pen from her bag and wrote a phone number on the banknote. "Keep this money—once they give you the address, take a ride over."

If Jonah could truly be saved, at least half of that would be owed to a moment of kindness from Kingsley Roselyn.

Mai Minghe thanked her again and again, and even after Kingsley got into her car, she waved hard several times, watching her go—who said young people today were cold-hearted? Hadn't she just run into a good kid?

But what Mai Minghe hadn't anticipated was that even after she'd managed, just barely, to get the Hunter House Faction's contact information, her next goal would turn out to be even harder to find than the Morgan House Faction itself: a public payphone booth.

Hadn't they been everywhere once upon a time?

But nowadays you could walk for half a day and not spot a single public phone booth; and when you finally did find one, you'd step inside only to find no telephone at all—just the word "WI-FI" written there, with a little umbrella shape drawn beside it in three curved arcs.

What on earth was that even for?

Mai Minghe spent at least thirty minutes wandering the streets before she finally accepted the truth: public phone booths had apparently been rendered obsolete by the times.

She rested for a bit, feeling truly at her wit's end, and with nothing to lose, stepped into a small Chinese restaurant that looked like it had been around for years—sure enough, behind the counter she spotted a familiar old-fashioned telephone.

"Could I borrow your phone for a moment?"

Mai Minghe was almost giddy with relief; she also knew she looked absolutely wretched, and terrified of being thrown out, she hastily added, "I'll order a plate of chow mein too."

"You got money to pay for the chow mein?" The owner eyed her with suspicion. "One dollar a minute."

Thank goodness for Kingsley Roselyn's money... she'd have to find that kid afterward and pay her back, then write a thank-you note.

Mai Minghe pressed her ear to the receiver, listening to the dial tone ring, and felt as though the past day and night had been some strange, shadowy stage play that was slowly drifting toward its final act, the curtain nearly ready to fall.

She reached through her clothes and felt the Serpent Band wrapped around her body.

She had long since grown used to its presence—if she didn't touch it, she could almost forget it was still coiled around her at all.

She had not forgotten, of course, that the Serpent Band was the Morgan House Faction's target.

So Mai Minghe had no intention whatsoever of showing her face; keeping herself out of the Morgan House Faction's sight was the safest option.

"Hello?" A woman's voice came from the other end of the line.

"Hello," Mai Minghe glanced at the owner not far away, turned her back, covered the receiver with her hand, and said quietly: "Is this the Morgan House Faction?"

"Who are you?"

"Someone just gave me some money and asked me to call you, to pass along a message."

The person on the other end immediately grew wary. "Who exactly are you?"

Mai Minghe paid no attention and continued: "She told me she had just come back from a place called the Nest, and that she saw one of your people there—a young man named Jonah... a man named Jonah. She asked me to tell you—are you listening?"

The other end of the line stayed silent; yet somehow Mai Minghe couldn't help feeling that the silence was taut, as though it were smothering a great deal of movement and noise beneath it—unnatural.

"I'm listening," the woman's voice came through, and the background noise surged up along with it; the moment those words were spoken, the line went dead quiet again.

Had Mai Minghe been more experienced with mobile phones, she would have known that the person on the other end had pressed mute.

But she lacked that experience.

"She asked me to tell you—Jonah is at St. Louis Hospital and needs emergency rescue."

Just saying that one line might not be enough; perhaps she should explain a bit more about Jonah's condition... otherwise, what if they brought that worm back with him?

While Mai Minghe was thinking it over, the woman on the other end asked a few more questions—none of them particularly important; Mai Minghe noticed nothing unusual and answered them one by one.

But the woman's next words made every hair on her body stand on end.

"I know where you are now," the woman said, and then—click—she hung up.

Why are both of these chapters so long! If I can keep this up, maybe I have a shot at full attendance after all?

Thank you all for coming out to support me on launch day—even the readers who had been saving it up came out, I'm truly moved! It really did beat 20-something (you all didn't slack off dragging people in off the street, heh heh heh)! The friends who said first-day subscriptions could hit a thousand were being a bit too optimistic, but that's alright—numbers are essentially just noise; what matters is that I write the story the way I want to write it.

As promised, as a thank-you, first-day subscribers get a cat—specifically, the fleas on it. Come on, everyone line up, collect your fleas one by one.

PS: There's a writer who, at the end of a letter to a friend, included an apology that went something like: I'm sorry, I was pressed for time—I didn't manage to write you a short letter, so I could only write a long one.

I actually share that feeling. If I had more time to update, I think I could trim the word count down a bit further...

Chapter 53: Mai Minghe Between a Rock and a Hard Place

And just like that, they'd found out where she was?

Had caller ID gotten so advanced that it could show your address now?

Mai Minghe's heart hammered like a drum, and she fell into a momentary panic: if the Morgan House Faction found her, the only thing standing between the Serpent Band Artifact and their Hunters would be the thin shirt on her back.

Once they realized she was the last person to have had any dealings with Jonah...

No — she had to run.

Unless she was unlucky enough that the Morgan House Faction happened to live right above this Chinese restaurant, they'd need some time to get here. Right — she had to get out before they arrived.

Mai Minghe quickly slammed the receiver down, slapped some bills on the counter, and turned to walk out the door — but to her surprise, her foot didn't move.

Because someone had grabbed her by the back of her collar.

"And where do you think you're going?"

Before she could react, she heard the restaurant owner hollering behind her: "Your fried noodles are already in the wok — you haven't paid yet and now you want to walk out on me? I've had my eye on you this whole time, good thing I stayed sharp!"

She'd completely forgotten about that — her mind had been so wrapped up in Artifacts and Hunters that the fried noodles had slipped it entirely.

Mai Minghe was flustered and annoyed and half-amused all at once, and the collar was digging into her throat hard enough to make her cough twice; she hurried to say: "Let go — I'll pay you, won't I?"

The owner had half his body leaning out over the register, like a bald owl eyeing a mouse, and he didn't trust Mai Minghe one bit.

"Sixteen fifty," he said flatly. "Card or cash?"

"That much? It's just fried noodles!" She was taken aback, and shot a glance at the menu, full of regret. "Prices have gone up that much?"

"Do you even have the money?"

Mai Minghe's scalp was practically crawling: these precious minutes she should have been using to flee before the Morgan House Faction arrived, and here she was scraping together change one bill at a time for a plate of noodles.

She finally managed to pull the money together; the owner took it and still had complaints: "Took you that long to come up with sixteen fifty? Aiya, fine, fine — you want this to go or are you eating here?"

The person on the phone had said they knew her address — for all she knew, they'd be here any minute — what was she thinking, sitting down to eat—

Mai Minghe had just opened her mouth when she paused.

She stared at the owner's bald head for a moment, then changed her answer: "...To go."

The owner had no interest in a person who looked like a vagrant eating in his restaurant anyway; that was probably the first thing she'd said that suited him, and he turned and headed straight back to the kitchen.

Mai Minghe stood by the register, standing there in a daze, lost in thought. The little restaurant was empty and business was dead — just her, the drone of the TV news in the corner, and the dim, greasy smell of years of cooked meals.

...Why had the Morgan House Faction person said "I know your address" before hanging up?

Thinking about it now — this was a matter of life and death, and the Morgan House Faction would never just take some unknown caller's word over the phone and head straight into the Nest to rescue someone. They would have to verify the source first...

If they suspected she had something to do with Jonah's accident and were coming to grab her, they certainly wouldn't warn her ahead of time — that would be the same as telling her to run.

If she were the one from Morgan House Faction, would her first instinct be to suspect the caller of having something to do with Jonah's accident?

Maybe. Maybe not.

"I know your address" was, in itself, a perfectly neutral statement.

The other party hadn't said what they intended to do — only implied that someone was coming to find her.

If Mai Minghe had a guilty conscience and bolted the moment she heard those words, she would be sending the Morgan House Faction an unmistakable signal: I'm involved — come get me.

In her current state, she'd never outrun a House Faction Hunter search party.

But what if she truly was just a vagrant who'd taken someone's money to pass along a message? Would a person like that even take those words to heart?

The other party was testing her — and Mai Minghe had no choice but to play along, even if it meant showing her face to the Morgan House Faction.

She'd only come to realize it this late in life: life was strange — things that came without the slightest risk were rarely worth having; and now it seemed that keeping the Serpent Band Artifact meant taking a risk too.

She had the restaurant owner to thank for that — if he hadn't held her up, she never would have had the chance to think it through, and she'd have already bolted.

Not to mention, if he hadn't stopped her, who knows how much longer she'd have gone hungry, right?

Mai Minghe thought with something close to contentment as she sat on the ground along the outer wall of the Chinese restaurant, shoveling fried noodles into her mouth.

Her appetite had been ruined for years — couldn't chew, couldn't swallow, food had lost all taste; but here, at this moment with the storm about to break, the hot, fragrant, oil-rich noodles in her hands seemed to truly root her in this second youth of hers.

Whatever came next, she had food in her belly right now, and nothing could feel better than that.

That was just the kind of person she was — no matter what happened, she could always find something good in it.

A sleek gray car pulled up in front of the Chinese restaurant while Mai Minghe was picking bean sprouts out of her noodles.

She hated bean sprouts most of all — when she'd been starving a moment ago she'd shoveled everything in without a second thought; but now that her stomach was no longer empty, the bean sprouts were suddenly insufferable, as if they'd taken advantage of her hunger.

Mai Minghe glanced up at the car, steadied her heartbeat, kept her expression as neutral as she could, and looked back down to keep picking.

A man and a woman got out of the car and had just walked up to the entrance when the Chinese restaurant owner poked his head out first. He pointed over at Mai Minghe by the wall, said "that's her," and retreated back behind the door.

Mai Minghe wasn't surprised in the least.

When she'd been wolfing down her noodles a moment ago, she'd heard the phone ring inside the restaurant.

"Was it you who called?" the man asked; his gaze, sure enough, dropped to the pair of dirty bare feet she had deliberately stretched out, and one eyebrow gave a slight twitch.

"Yes," said Mai Minghe, wiping her mouth with the back of her hand — and leaving it dirtier than before. "Which one of you is Morgan?"

Nobody answered — but the woman had already pulled out her phone and called someone, and said into it: "We found her. Stand by where you are for now."

The moment she spoke, Mai Minghe recognized her — she was the one who had answered the phone earlier.

Which meant... besides these two, there were others nearby, weren't there? The Morgan House Faction probably had eyes on every street in the area — if she'd run just now, she wouldn't have gotten far.

The woman hung up and turned to Mai Minghe: "What did the person who asked you to deliver the message look like?"

Her guess had been right — they didn't seem to suspect her.

"Aiya—"

Mai Minghe lowered her head and scratched vigorously at her scalp, as though she had fleas — the man stepped back half a pace. "Talked funny, didn't make much sense, strange... I can't really say how old, somewhere in the twenties or thirties, maybe thirties or forties, not yet fifty.

Wore a hat and glasses, had a scarf wrapped around the whole lower half of the face, couldn't make out much."

The two exchanged a glance.

"How tall?"

"I was sitting on the ground — couldn't tell."

"...What ethnicity?"

"Either a light-skinned person of color, or a very tanned white person."

"Accent?"

"Oh, very standard," Mai Minghe said admiringly, "like someone who could read the news on the radio."

The woman's jaw tightened.

"What else did she say?"

"Strange stuff — see if you can make sense of it." Mai Minghe cleared her throat, set the takeout container down on the pavement, and said: "She said: 'Jonah looks normal on the outside, but a Resident has already gotten inside his body.'"

Both of their expressions shifted ever so slightly.

Good — so they understood... That meant when they went into the Nest to rescue him, they'd also know what to watch out for.

Mai Minghe let out a small, quiet breath of relief.

From the looks of things, the Morgan House Faction seemed like quite a formidable House Faction.

She still didn't know exactly what a House Faction was, but then again there were plenty of new words she didn't understand — it wasn't as if this one made a difference; and if they were truly that formidable, they ought to be able to bring the person back safely, right?

"What are you smiling about?" the man asked, catching her off guard.

Mai Minghe started, and realized she must have let a small smile show.

Being able to help someone — how good did that feel? How could she not smile?

People usually thought the one receiving help should be the happy one, but there was actually a warm, tingling kind of pleasure in being the one who helped — someone had explained it to her once, something about human evolution — but unfortunately, she couldn't say any of that out loud.

"She gave me money and I got to eat," Mai Minghe said, holding up her noodles. "That kind of thing doesn't happen every day."

"Watch her," the woman said to her partner, "I'm going to call Taylor Ford."

She stepped to one side and waited for the other end to pick up. After a few seconds, she said quietly: "Taylor? We found the one who made the call — it's a vagrant who got paid to do it."

Mai Minghe listened to her own fabricated story being gravely repeated back, word for word, from that woman's mouth.

But every word about Jonah's condition was the truth; and as the woman's expression grew more and more serious, Mai Minghe felt her heart rise higher and higher in her chest.

By the time she hung up and came back, even her partner looked somewhat tense, watching her in silence.

"This is serious. He may personally lead a team into the Nest," the woman said to her partner, then gestured toward Mai Minghe with her chin. "But before that, Taylor Ford wants to meet her first."

She crouched down then, as though speaking to a small child, and smiled at Mai Minghe in a pleasant, easy manner: "Our director has some questions for you. Come with us — we'll take good care of you. You can ask for whatever you want."

This time, it was Mai Minghe's turn to be at a loss.

For a vagrant, this was an extraordinary stroke of luck — there was no reason to refuse; but how could she dare go back to the Morgan House Faction with these two?

"Um — I — " She couldn't think of an excuse, and finally blurted out: "It's not that I don't want to — it's just that I have fleas—"

"That's fine," the woman said, her expression not entirely pleasant but entirely firm. "You can come to our — to our company and take a shower."

The man stepped forward, looking thoroughly reluctant, and planted himself right beside Mai Minghe.

He bent down and said: "You getting in yourself, or do you want my help?"

See, this is proof that I write every chapter from scratch with no stockpile — I mentioned fleas just two days ago and now the fleas have shown up with a pretty substantial role...

How about this — those of you who've been tipping, choose between a bonus chapter and an on-screen appearance; a bonus chapter would take a while, but if you appear in the story I'll definitely give the fleas proper treatment...

P.S.: Wrote pretty fast today, but I have a feeling tomorrow I'm going to hit a wall.

Chapter 54: The Correct Response of a Vagrant Named Mai Minghe

The play was already halfway through—it was too late to back out now.

There was no other way but to brazen it out and keep up the "vagrant" act to the end...

Mai Minghe reviewed her words and actions from just now and felt she probably hadn't given herself away.

For one thing, the pitiful, filthy state she was in wasn't something anyone could fake on short notice; and beyond that, she had carefully weighed what to say and what not to say, and was fairly certain she hadn't let anything slip.

Morgan House Faction's people wouldn't suspect a vagrant without reason, would they?

Whatever they asked about anything she hadn't already told them, she would simply answer that she didn't know—it wasn't as if they could read minds.

There was just one thing: they absolutely could not find out she had an Artifact on her.

That was exactly what Mai Minghe was worried about right now.

Sitting in the backseat, she kept fearing that her clothes might bunch up or press against her body and reveal traces of the Serpent Band Artifact; so every now and then she would adjust her posture and tug at her clothes.

The more she fidgeted, the more unsettled the two people in front became.

"Itchy?" The woman glanced at Mai Minghe in the rearview mirror and slid her seat forward a little. "Our company has a shower room—you can go clean up properly when we get there."

It sounded like Taylor Ford was quite an important figure, and the two of them didn't want to bring him a bag of fleas.

A shower was out of the question—at most she could wash her feet; even if someone poured blood over her she still couldn't take off her clothes—but of course Mai Minghe said none of this aloud.

"Why does a company have a shower room?" she asked offhandedly.

The man driving muttered, "...Minding a lot of business, aren't you."

Mai Minghe had assumed they simply didn't want to say "House Faction" and were calling the place a company instead—a manor having a shower room made perfect sense, didn't it?

But she hadn't expected that the car would ultimately pull into the underground parking garage of an actual office building—and not just any office building, but a modern one with full security and complete facilities, where the man and woman had to swipe their keycards before they could press the button for the elevator going up.

When the elevator doors opened, Mai Minghe was led into a bright, clean, cream-white reception area.

Several sofas were scattered across a round rug; in one corner stood a potted plant, its great clusters of glossy dark-green leaves brushing the ceiling. A screen on one wall was playing a promotional advertisement; on the wall behind the reception desk, a company name in clean, simple lettering read—"Morgan & Morgan."

What surprised Mai Minghe most was the line of small text printed beneath the company name: Financial Consulting & Property Management.

What was going on?

Wasn't "Morgan" a Hunter House Faction?

Her own side hustle was begging—theirs was financial consulting?

A young woman sitting at the front desk looked up the moment she saw the group step off the elevator, immediately bent down to pick up a paper bag, and came over in a few quick steps. "Jane, I just went and got everything—it's all here."

The woman addressed as "Jane" didn't even look at the bag and gestured for Mai Minghe to take it, then instructed, "Take her to get cleaned up first."

It was a brown bag printed with "ZARA." Mai Minghe thought she had seen the brand before; she opened it with curiosity and found a set of clothes and a pair of shoes inside.

When they had asked her shoe size earlier, she had already guessed as much—now she couldn't help but think that Morgan House Faction was rather thoughtful. Of course, no matter how thoughtful they were, the Artifact was still not theirs to have.

"That brand name's not one you see every day," she said after thanking them, running a hand over the bag. "Is it expensive? You really didn't have to spend money on my account."

The others glanced at her, and nobody spoke.

"Um, Jane..."

The receptionist didn't move; instead, she gestured to the man and woman and they stepped a few paces to the side with her, where she said something in a low voice—faint and indistinct, though the name "Taylor Ford" seemed to be buried somewhere in it.

Mai Minghe pretended to look at the clothes while her ears were pricked up higher than a satellite dish.

"...What?"

Jane's voice was kept very low too, and only a few words pushed forward by emotion were barely caught by Mai Minghe. "About to... at such a critical time... who gave him..."

...Great—not a single word with any real information.

The receptionist said something quietly, and Jane stopped talking.

After a few seconds, Jane let out a helpless sigh and returned to her normal volume. "Anyway, take her to get cleaned up first. Taylor Ford just said he wants to ask her some questions, but he can't have her show up looking like this... honestly, no wonder he insisted I bring a filthy person over here."

What was going on? What did any of this have to do with her?

Mai Minghe had only caught bits and pieces of it, which made her even more anxious; but she knew that even if she asked, no one would take her seriously, so for now she had no choice but to play dumb and follow the receptionist.

A financial services and property management company that truly had a shower room inside it.

It was a single-occupancy shower room partitioned into two sections—the inner part had a showerhead, and the outer part had a changing area.

Mai Minghe set the bag on the chair in the changing area and pushed open the shower room door—the next second, she lurched back half a step as if she'd been punched.

The sharp smell of sodium hypochlorite disinfectant nearly made her think she'd walked back into a hospital. No—it was even stronger than a hospital.

Standing in the shower room, Mai Minghe understood.

She turned, and it was as though she could see a blood-soaked Hunter walking in, turning on the faucet; mucus, fluid, blood—all the indescribable things brought out of the Nest—rushing down into the drain of the human world.

Morgan truly was a Hunter House Faction.

A Hunter House Faction had no qualms about blood.

Even a fool knew how precious an Artifact that could restore youth was—at the very least, far more precious than the life of a dying old woman.

...If she never walked out of this office building again, there was not a single person in the world who would come looking for her.

Mai Minghe leaned against the tiled wall, both arms wrapped tightly around her abdomen; through her clothes, the Serpent Band raised a slight ridge, pressing against her arms.

This was her lifeline.

The moment she walked out of that shower room, a silent battle to defend that lifeline would begin.

In this battle, her greatest advantage was that Morgan House Faction did not know the person standing before them was their adversary. Which meant she didn't need to strike—she only needed to not make mistakes.

...If I were Taylor Ford—a Hunter House Faction director—what would I ask?

How would I probe the other person and extract information?

Lost in concentrated thought, Mai Minghe washed her hands, feet, face, and neck without noticing. She stuffed her weary, cold, aching feet into the shoes and then pulled the new clothes on directly over her pajamas.

It was an autumn-winter hoodie. Adding another thick layer of cover over the Artifact put her somewhat more at ease.

She also borrowed a comb from the receptionist and carefully combed her hair straight before stepping out—like a warrior fully armed and ready to take the field.

"Oh no, don't bother returning it—"

The receptionist waved both hands frantically, wanting to keep the comb at several arm's lengths away. "Keep it, really—you keep it."

She paused, looking Mai Minghe over. "You actually look quite nice once you're cleaned up. How did you end up on the streets?"

"Bad luck, I guess," Mai Minghe smiled at her and tucked the comb into her pants pocket. "Who am I going to see next?"

"One moment," the receptionist picked up the phone. "Jane? She's done... Yes, yes. Oh? Alright, I'll bring her over now."

It was entirely ordinary content—just a matter of bringing someone to meet a superior—and yet that "Oh?" seemed to carry a hint of surprise that didn't quite fit.

Was it related to their whispering from before?

Mai Minghe licked her lips, steadied herself, and followed the receptionist with as neutral an expression as she could manage, winding through four or five turns before arriving at the door of a private office.

"Mr. Ford?" She knocked.

"Come in," a steady male voice answered.

As Mai Minghe walked in, she happened to see a man standing before the floor-to-ceiling window, turning his head toward her.

She had no idea what an important figure in a Hunter House Faction was supposed to look like, but seeing him now, she felt he was exactly as one should be.

The man wore a sleek, immaculately pressed suit, his face square and austere; though he was already middle-aged, it was still easy to see that this had once been a rather striking face in his youth—only time had won out in the end, his jawline softening and sagging, giving him a slightly weary look. Just slightly—not much.

"Sit," Taylor Ford instructed, taking his own seat on the other side of the desk.

Mai Minghe sat down in the visitor's chair.

This office looked like it was rarely used—almost no personal belongings, as stark as a showroom display—which made sense; a Hunter shouldn't be sitting in an office all day.

The only proof that someone used it was a few small dishes of snacks on the desk—Taylor Ford tilted his chin toward them and said, "Help yourself."

Mai Minghe was full, but she had to keep up the vagrant act properly.

The moment he finished speaking, she immediately popped a grape into her mouth; then, thinking it over, she simply picked up the dish and swept the few pieces of cheese and all the thin crackers into her coat pocket, and the small bunch of grapes that wouldn't fit she grabbed in her hand as well.

Pretty good acting, she commended herself inwardly. It was clear that Taylor Ford was holding back from frowning.

"When did you see that woman?" he asked, getting straight to the point.

"This morning," Mai Minghe had already rehearsed answers to many questions he might ask. "I don't have a watch, so I don't know what time."

"Where?"

Mai Minghe gave a location quite far from the Chinese restaurant.

"I know you said she had her face covered. But think back—was there anything about her you remember?"

"Hmm... well..." Mai Minghe furrowed her brow and pretended to think for a moment. "She was very generous with money."

Taylor Ford stared at her, his expression growing even more severe—clearly he didn't find it funny at all.

"You remember everything she said to you pretty clearly, don't you." He slowly leaned back in his chair, fingers tapping the desk one after another—tap, tap.

"Ah, don't remind me." Mai Minghe had prepared for this. "I didn't know if those strange things she said were some kind of code or what—I didn't catch them the first time. She made me memorize them, repeat them back twice, before she'd give me the money."

"And she just trusted that you'd definitely make the call?"

This was a question Mai Minghe had also thought through how to answer.

"She said it was a matter of life and death. Either way, she paid me and asked me to make the call—she'd done her part. If I didn't call and someone died, that death would be on my hands, and she'd have a clear conscience."

She said this and then tapped a few times on her face and chest, making the sign of the cross. "I'm not about to take on a death debt—God is watching. If I didn't make that call, I'd never get into heaven."

Taylor Ford fell silent, mulling it over, but Mai Minghe still couldn't relax.

The conversation had stayed focused on the "mysterious woman" the whole time, which meant he was suspicious of whoever had provided the information and wanted to know who the source really was.

He kept pressing about a person who didn't exist—even though she'd come prepared, she couldn't afford to let her guard down, terrified of letting something slip somewhere, her palms growing a little damp.

It was truly maddening—they already knew where Jonah was, so why not hurry up and rescue him—if she weren't afraid of blowing her cover, Mai Minghe would have loved to give them a proper talking-to.

"You can sit in our company for a while," Taylor Ford said with a low, flat laugh. "You leave when I say you can leave."

Mai Minghe's heart lurched, but she kept her expression carefully neutral.

"Why?" She scratched her head with one hand and asked, "I want to leave and I can't? That's kidnapping."

"Legally speaking, yes, it is kidnapping. So what?"

Taylor Ford was entirely unbothered. "I can also tell you why—if you'll sit tight and behave, all the better. That place you mentioned should have surveillance cameras nearby. Even if there aren't any, we can find the people in the area.

"A woman bundled up head to toe, standing on a busy street corner talking to a homeless person for that long—that naturally draws attention. All we have to do is pull the security footage, or find a witness, and confirm your story checks out. Then you're free to go. I'll even personally give you money and see you out the door."

Mai Minghe didn't hear that last part at all—she sat frozen in her chair, her mind completely blank.

Right, it seemed like so many places had installed those cameras nowadays...

She simply hadn't thought of that.

It wasn't her fault. For most of her life, "surveillance cameras" hadn't even been a concept to her.

She'd forgotten how old she was when she first heard the term; she only remembered the last time she'd noticed a camera—she'd been in the hospital, her body already in steep decline.

"No problem with that?" Taylor Ford kept his eyes fixed on her as he asked.

What else could she do but nod?

Get through this obstacle first—she could look for a chance to run later.

"Good. I'll have—"

Before Taylor Ford could finish the sentence, someone knocked urgently on the door—deep, rapid thuds. This time, without waiting for him to say anything, the door was pushed straight open, and Jane Lynch strode into the room.

"Mr. Ford, there's an emergency," she said, without sparing a glance at Mai Minghe. She walked up to Taylor Ford and lowered her voice: "Jonah—"

Jonah?

Mai Minghe jolted; but in the instant she looked up toward Jane Lynch, she suddenly realized something.

While Jane Lynch was speaking, Taylor Ford's eyes had remained fixed on her the entire time.

...As if he were waiting to see her reaction.

You see, I've been posting long updates every day lately, and earlier than before—not like the old days when I'd moan and groan with every word I typed...

It's because I truly love ensemble stories, and I love the world of Blackmoor City and the Nest even more, so every day I write with real joy, practically glued to my computer; even when I'm not writing, I'm always thinking about it.

That kind of state makes me happy. Writing (when it's going well) is a actually fascinating, absorbing process.

Honestly, I started writing because I loved it in the first place—I never thought about making a living from it.

Of course, that mindset has its downside too: when I'm not in that happy place, updates can't be guaranteed. No amount of money could drag me to the millstone then.

What can I say—I'm not a professional web novelist. I write for the joy of it.

Chapter 55: Mai Minghe and Taylor Ford's Interrogation

In the space of a heartbeat, Mai Minghe knew she could no longer hide it.

The only option was to keep playing along.

"...Jonah?"

A cold sweat had broken out across her back, and her face felt heavy. Mai Minghe had no idea whether she'd managed to pull off a "curious" expression—but she tried.

"The same Jonah you mentioned when you passed along the message?"

She pretended not to notice Taylor Ford's gaze, keeping her eyes on Jane Lynch. "The one whose life was in danger? What happened to him—he's not hurt, is he?"

Without waiting for either of them to answer, Mai Minghe made the sign of the cross in front of her.

"God bless him," she murmured. "It wasn't because I called too late, was it? God wouldn't blame me for that..."

Jane Lynch glanced at her superior; Taylor Ford furrowed his brow, waved a hand, muttered "she's religious," and at last moved his gaze away from Mai Minghe's face.

Mai Minghe quietly let out a breath of relief.

Of course she'd reacted to the name Jonah—that was perfectly normal, seeing as it was a name she herself had spoken aloud more than once...

So it seemed she'd managed to slip through for now.

"This doesn't concern you," Jane Lynch said to Mai Minghe first, then didn't continue in front of her. She picked up a pen and paper from the desk, quickly wrote something, and handed it to her superior.

The muscles in his face gave a visible twitch.

"Understood."

He rose abruptly from behind the desk, crumpled the note into a ball in one hand, and without sparing Mai Minghe another glance, strode toward the office door. As he left, he threw

back a single line: "I'll handle it. Get her out of here fast—out the back."

What had happened?

What Jane Lynch had come in to say hadn't only been meant as a test—something had truly gone wrong?

Mai Minghe was full of questions, but one thing became clear: because of this sudden development, the Morgan House Faction's attitude had shifted on a dime; she was free to go now.

Whatever the sudden development was, if she could leave, why would she hesitate even half a second?

She shot to her feet and immediately followed Jane Lynch out; they took an entirely different route than the one she'd come by, and she had no idea what was happening at the other end of the company floor.

Jane Lynch was preoccupied, and had not a single thought to spare for Mai Minghe—no matter what Mai Minghe asked, she answered only with "it doesn't concern you."

She led Mai Minghe through two quick turns across the sprawling office floor, then stopped, jutted her chin toward the corridor ahead, and said: "Take the stairs down from over there. Once you're down, have security let you out. Don't wander around—it's not safe. Get out quickly."

With that, she turned and hurried off, nearly breaking into a run.

In just moments, Mai Minghe was alone again.

The short corridor was perfectly quiet; the Morgan House Faction's offices were well-soundproofed, and straining her ears here, she couldn't make out what was happening up ahead.

All right—whatever was going on, she should get out of there fast.

There didn't seem to be a single soul nearby, only the sound of her own footsteps bouncing back and forth off the corridor walls—so when that voice dropped into the air, Mai Minghe gave a small start.

"Hey, big sis?"

Oh, that couldn't be for her; the last time someone called her "big sis," her parents had still been alive.

...Mai Minghe took another step forward before it occurred to her that "big sis" might in fact be meant for her.

She followed the sound and looked. At the far left end of the short corridor, a doorway opened into a bright, tidy break room. The break room was spacious, with a scattering of long tables, chairs, and sofas, and curled up softly on one of the sofas was a kid.

A teenager who looked at most seventeen or eighteen—wasn't that a kid?

The teenager seemed boneless, draped lazily over the sofa back, half his face buried in the crook of his arm.

One hand hung down at his side, a rolled cigarette nestled between his long fingers, thin white smoke curling around them like silk.

His eyelids were half-lowered, and when he spoke, his voice was light and drifting, like a white cloud high in the autumn sky, liable to scatter at the slightest snip. "...Big sis, are you good at chemistry?"

Mai Minghe paused. "What?"

"I don't like chemistry," the teenager said in that same cloud-soft voice, its edges tinged with a smile, languidly indistinct. "Help me look at my homework, will you?"

Sure enough, there were papers and a pen on the table. But this was hardly the moment to help anyone with homework—what kind of Hunter had such nerve, bringing a kid to the office?

"I'm in a hurry, I have to go. Sorry about that," said Mai Minghe, already moving away from the break room doorway.

A moment later, she turned back and poked her head in.

"Um... do you know where the stairs are?" Mai Minghe asked, a little sheepish, lowering her voice. "The person from this company just told me to take the stairs from around here..."

In the few minutes she'd been looking for the stairs, the teenager appeared not to have moved at all; only now did he slowly raise his head, revealing a face with a hazy, unfocused look; through the fog, his lips were red—moist and vivid, like a sunset reflected on still water.

Even having lived through a long lifetime, she rarely encountered a child this beautiful.

In that moment of distraction, Mai Minghe caught a faint yet heavy scent hanging in the room. She glanced at the cigarette in his hand and understood. "Wait—are you smoking—"

"What about it? It's not illegal." The teenager said it carelessly, taking a long drag. The white smoke curled out, hazy, as though blurring the edges of reality.

It was legal now?

The last time Mai Minghe had been in her twenties, hippie culture had been at its height, and she was long past being surprised by such things—yet she was surprised all the same.

But right now, what mattered was getting out of the Morgan House Faction's building.

"Well... I can show you to the stairs."

Seeming to sense her urgency, the teenager rose from the sofa and came toward her. It was as though his body were made only of smoke or cloud—he moved as silently as a cat. "I'm Taylor. What's your name?"

"...Mai Minghe."

Facing him, she felt there was no real need for a false name; real or fake, it was a name no one in this world would recognize either way.

The teenager's eyes were a waterlogged red; if not for the cigarette in his hand, Mai Minghe might have thought he'd been crying. Thinking of how she'd just refused to help him with his homework and yet he was still willing to show her the way, she felt a pang of guilt and said, "Thank you. Don't worry—I won't tell anyone."

"Oh? This?" The teenager seemed only then to remember the cigarette between his fingers. He glanced at it and gave her a smile. "It's fine. No one cares what I do."

This kid, when he grows up, is going to break so many girls' hearts, Mai Minghe thought to herself. The way he'd looked at that cigarette had inexplicably made her feel that even the cigarette had been worth coming into this world for.

"Let's go, then," she said, thinking of leaving as soon as possible. "I'm in a hurry."

"Why? Do you have a date?"

Was this how kids talked these days?

"Something's come up at home," Mai Minghe deflected. "Which direction are the stairs?"

The teenager tilted his head, eyes hazy, baring a small red mole on his neck. He looked at Mai Minghe for a few seconds, and she couldn't tell what he was thinking; just as she was growing

impatient, he smiled again all of a sudden. "Oh, I almost forgot. There's lots of food in the break room, and drinks too, you know?"

"How about you just point me to the stairs and I'll head over myself."

Mai Minghe knew there was no use getting impatient with someone in this state—they were always half a beat behind. "I really am in a hurry."

"Don't be so quick to ditch me," the teenager said with a laugh, and casually took hold of her wrist. "Come on, the stairs are over there—you went past them. You really don't want to look at my homework?"

"I really don't have time," said Mai Minghe.

"Everyone else says they don't have time either." The teenager pouted slightly. "Because Jonah just came back from the Nest with a Resident, and they ended up right here in the building."

Before Mai Minghe could process this—before she had a chance to stop herself—she had already jerked to a halt, her face flooding with shock.

Every mystery from before lit up at once, blindingly clear, solved.

A Resident had gotten in? No wonder Jane Lynch had been in such a panic, and no wonder they'd stopped letting her stay; with that thing in tow, Jonah had—

No. Wait.

This boy...

When she turned her head, she found the teenager looking at her with another soft smile.

Still that hazy, weightless smile—but watching him, Mai Minghe felt a prickling cold sweat rise along her spine.

Even time seemed to have been poured full of mercury, slowly suffocating in the space between them.

Perhaps he'd seen her in the Morgan House Faction's building and assumed she was a Hunter, which was why he'd spoken so freely...

"I'm sorry, big sis."

The teenager lowered his head, one hand still holding hers, the other raising the cigarette for a drag. "I'm someone who lies a lot. Girls tend not to like that about me."

Mai Minghe felt as though she were watching a car crash—powerless to stop it, able only to stare.

"Jonah hasn't come back," he said, as if to reassure her. "I haven't gone to the Nest yet. No one's brought him back, so how would a Resident end up in the building? Don't be afraid—there are no Residents here."

Mai Minghe thought she heard faint footsteps somewhere far beyond the bend in the corridor.

Were they coming for her?

"Big sis, you're not a vagrant at all. You put in a lot of effort to look like one... When you came in, I saw you, and I thought to myself: odds are there's nothing to get out of her."

His voice was indistinct and soft, barely above a murmur.

"So why not just tell us—that you're a Hunter?"

The teenager paused, then gave a quiet laugh.

"My guess is, either you're caught up in what happened to Jonah and afraid the Morgan House Faction will hold you accountable; or you're mixed up with whatever Jonah was chasing when he got into trouble, and afraid you'd be walking into a trap."

Mai Minghe had the strange sensation that the Serpent Band had already left her—she felt the pain of it pulling away, like skin being stripped off.

His fingers lay lightly around her wrist, as though they could be withdrawn at any moment.

But what then, after she pulled away?

In the Morgan House Faction's building, full of Hunters—where would she go? What could she do?

Mai Minghe's voice came out hoarse. "You're..."

"I didn't give you my real name just now. Please don't hold it against me."

The teenager's eyes remained half-lidded, his expression still dreamy and unawakened. "My last name is Ford... My name is Taylor Ford. Hunter Director of the Morgan House Faction."

Heh heh heh heh, heh heh heh heh heh, heh heh heh heh heh heh heh.

rubs hands So, how's everyone doing? Did you all have cake for Children's Day?

Why do I love writing beautiful characters so much? Because I am
the number-one looks-obsessed person of this century.

If the main characters aren't beautiful, writing them is just dull, because what I do is translate
the images in my head into words.

If the people in my head aren't good-looking, what's the point of writing them?

Anyway—beautiful people, regardless of gender, the moment they smile, I lose my soul.

Can you imagine what I'm like when I see Li Xiaoran and Zhang Yuqi?

That feeling—I suddenly understood King You of Zhou completely. King You of Zhou is
back on the job. I'm going to go light the signal fires right now. So what if the lords have to make a
few trips? Let the beauty smile!

Chapter 56 — Taylor Ford and the Morgan House Faction Contract

For most students, school was a place they would avoid whenever possible; for Taylor Ford, it was the closest thing he had to a vacation.

He still lounged lazily in his seat, long after everyone from the previous class had left.

He had no idea where his next classroom was, because he had no idea what his next class even was.

This winter had been unusually long. March was almost here, yet the trees outside — pale or pitch-dark against the sky — still stretched their bare branches into the grey overcast, each one dusted with a thin coat of snow.

He could sit here in perfect silence all morning, watching the desolate colors of the world outside. Even if the next class began, no one would come to hurry him along.

The whole school knew he was nothing more than a spectator on the shore, standing apart from rules, coursework, and ordinary life — that when the bell rang, it might shatter the reflection he'd cast into this still pool.

He was already in eleventh grade, yet he never thought about his GPA, and had never once looked at a single college brochure.

As for attending class — he could take it or leave it. His father had already had a word with the school: whenever Taylor felt like it, he could stand up and walk out, and no one would ask a single question.

Taylor had never asked exactly how that arrangement had been made, and had no interest in knowing.

Even completing enough credits to graduate was something he'd decided to do on a whim; if Taylor chose to stop coming to school altogether, his father would never object in the slightest — if anything, he would be all the more pleased.

How did he put it again?

Oh, right.

"The world has its favorites. Some people are born with gifts that ordinary people couldn't reach in a lifetime of effort," his father had told him more than once. "Tai Lan, you are exactly that kind of lucky soul — no, you are the best of the lucky ones. Your time and energy should be spent on things with the highest returns, so as not to waste your talents."

Taylor couldn't be bothered to sit through the rest of the day's classes, but as if in a kind of protest, he stayed at school through the entire day anyway.

He walked down the front steps with the crowd of students leaving school and, unsurprisingly, spotted that familiar SUV — and quietly sighed to himself.

"Tai Lan, is your dad picking you up again? Why does he worry about you so much?" A girl waved at him with a smile. "Bye — make sure you come to school tomorrow, okay?"

There weren't even three people in the entire school whose names Taylor could recall. But that didn't stop people from noticing him and striking up conversation; all he needed to do was be polite — nod, say "hi" or "bye" — and that was enough.

It wasn't that he was arrogant.

The more time you spent in the Nest, the more the outside world seemed thin and sparse when you returned — even its colors looked grey.

Especially right after coming back: people with no connection to the Nest barely registered any facial features to him, impossible to remember; whatever happened around him felt distant. It was almost wrong to call this place "reality," because everything felt weightless and scattered, without any solidity.

He sometimes thought that the center of gravity in his life was the Nest — and the Nest was a black hole.

Usually, after spending some time back in the outside world, the normal feeling would slowly return.

But even when the feeling came back, the mental habits he'd developed refused to change. Even when he could see colors again and recognize faces, none of it had anything to do with him.

Taylor walked around to the right side of the car, opened the rear door, and tossed in a limp, empty backpack.

"How was your day?" His father turned and smiled at him. "Did you have a good time at school?"

His father had a square, stern face — probably not bad-looking in his youth. But middle age had softened his jawline into a loose, drooping line, giving him an air of flabbiness and weakness, and at last his looks had caught up with his character.

It was a good thing Taylor didn't look much like his father.

"Drive," Taylor said as he got in, too lazy to answer him, tilting his chin toward the front. "Why do you keep coming to pick me up?"

Even before his father answered, he had already guessed.

"Today we got two new offers."

Han Ford drove and explained earnestly: "You haven't entered the Nest in almost half a year. At first I didn't understand why, but I think I get it now. The biggest House Factions in Blackmoor City don't just need talent — they're afraid of someone like you ending up with the competition. They're all fighting over you. Without you, they don't know what to do with themselves.

"The terms look pretty good to me now. How about it — want to pick one you like and take it? If you keep holding out, they might give up, and that would be a huge missed opportunity..."

Taylor pulled out a cigarette and clicked his lighter — snap; he leaned into the flame and drew a long drag.

His father considerately cracked a window, and the cool March air rushed in — he liked cold air, the colder the better.

Taylor waited until that soft, warm current smoothed out the creases in his mind and cleared away his thoughts, then asked, in a drifting, absent tone, "...Who is it this time? What's the contract?"

"One of them is a per-mission contract — Dad knows you like that kind, more freedom."

"Don't talk in half-sentences," Taylor said, his voice going low and soft, draining the words of their edge. "Keep it short. Be clear."

"Ahem, you really are impatient, kid. I read that contract carefully — the per-mission pay isn't bad, but outside the pay, there's nothing else. No cut from the Artifact, no coverage or death benefits — not that Dad thinks anything will happen to you, so that part doesn't matter — and as

for perks, subsidies, equity, don't even think about it. It's basically the same as hiring some ordinary solo operator Hunter."

Han Ford gave the steering wheel a light slap, visibly displeased. "Do they know who they're negotiating with? How rude."

Taylor smiled silently. "How much per trip into the Nest?"

Han Ford hesitated, then admitted it himself: "The price isn't terrible... five hundred thousand per trip."

"How many trips?"

"Four."

"Is there a time limit?"

"...No."

That was the crux of the matter.

A House Faction that contracted Taylor on a per-mission basis would never send him on tasks that an ordinary Hunter could handle.

Only when they received confirmed intelligence on a rare Artifact and lacked the confidence to retrieve it themselves would they deploy Taylor into the Nest — chances to pull chestnuts out of the fire like that were naturally few and far between.

His father understood perfectly: if Taylor took this four-mission contract, he would not enter the Nest even once more before it was fulfilled.

In other words, if the other House Faction took five years to use up all four opportunities, Taylor would bring in not a single yuan beyond two million in the next five years.

"Artifacts keep emerging, it's true — but truly rare, truly powerful ones are very few," said his father,

a man who had never once set foot in the Nest, now explaining the situation to him.

"While you're not going in, those Artifacts could be found and taken by other Hunters. Isn't that a waste of your talents? Letting people with less ability than you carry off the Artifacts — fine, they make the money — but it builds up their names, as if they could compete with you!"

Taylor extended the half-smoked cigarette forward; his father, mid-sentence, reached back to offer an ashtray.

He didn't take it — he just stubbed out the ember inside the ashtray, pressing down again and again so that Han Ford's hand dipped with each press.

"What about the other contract?"

"It's from Morgan House Faction," his father's face visibly brightened in the rearview mirror. "Their terms are truly impressive. Looking across all of Blackmoor City, I can say there has never been a Hunter who received an offer like this. As your agent, I'm actually proud to have negotiated these conditions..."

In truth, this kind of conversation was far from their first.

Taylor had long known where these conversations always ended up, and he found the back-and-forth tiresome — but he simply refused to let Han Ford get what he wanted without a fight. Even when he didn't actually mind entering the Nest, he would still say: "Not signing."

"You haven't even heard their terms—"

"House Factions aren't free."

This time, his father didn't rush to argue back. Instead, he smiled in a rather shrewd way.

"You're wrong — this contract is different. The position they're signing you for is Hunter Director. Aside from reporting to the board, all the House Faction Hunters answer to you. You have final say on how every mission is run. The so-called CEO who handles operations carries no weight in front of the Hunter Director. If that's not freedom, what is?"

He paused, then added: "You're still young. You don't understand yet. Only power brings freedom."

Every so often, his father would say something that gave Taylor pause.

"And you don't even know the annual salary they're offering."

The number his father named next made even Taylor blink — it was so outrageous that for a moment he thought he'd misheard.

"No, that's the right number,"

Han Ford said, in a tone that nearly lifted him out of the driver's seat: "And that's just the base salary — the most basic part. There are also all kinds of incentive structures, profit-sharing, equity, and other terms... After this ten-year contract ends, the two of us can retire!"

Taylor felt like a bucket of cold water had been dumped over him. "How many years?"

"I know — ten years sounds like a long time. But if you don't take this contract and just do ordinary work, ten years from now you could still be running into the Nest over and over."

At that, his father suddenly let out a long sigh.

"Do you think I can just watch my own child walk into that dangerous place again and again with any peace of mind? Every time you're in the Nest, I don't sleep a single night — the agony of it, I wish I could go in your place. Ten years, and then we're done for good. Your mother is gone. In this world, it's just the two of us, father and son. I don't want to be burying my child before I go."

Taylor sat in silence in the back seat for a moment.

"...Their terms are too good. It doesn't make sense."

After a long pause, he said quietly: "I don't have three heads and six arms, and I'm not a superhero. If it's just entering the Nest and finding Artifacts, there isn't a single Hunter in the world worth that price. Morgan House Faction must have other intentions."

"What else did they say — outside the contract?"

Han Ford had looked ready to argue back, but faltered at those last words.

"They did say one thing — if you're interested in accepting the contract, they'd want to speak with you privately, one-on-one. Whatever they'd be discussing would have to be kept confidential, of course... I didn't think much of it at the time. Why don't you go talk to them?"

Even with one's own father, there were certain matters involving Hunters that a House Faction would only disclose to Taylor directly.

Taylor thought it over.

"Set up a time with Carter Morgan," he told his father. "Whatever can't be put in the contract — have him say it to my face."

When the timelines of all four characters converge, that is when the main plot finally surfaces.

Chapter 57: What Taylor Ford and Wellesley Know

Carter Morgan was pushing fifty, his crown of brown curls thinning imperceptibly, yet still combed smooth and neat, coiling against his pink scalp.

Just as Taylor Ford had anticipated, his every move carried the easy unhurried air of a man who had long since turned privilege into habit—and he knew it himself: his standing was different.

Perhaps it was precisely that self-awareness that gave Carter's warmth and charm a slightly unanchored, slippery quality—as though that easy familiarity, when performed by him, fit a little too loosely and yet a little too well at the same time.

"I've heard a great deal about you," he said.

When he first laid eyes on Taylor Ford, he didn't falter the way most people did; rising to his feet, Carter wore only a measured look of appreciation: "I've long wanted to meet the finest Hunter in Blackmoor City today, and now that I have, I'd say the trip was worth it."

Taylor glanced at the extended hand, then lazily sank into the sofa before lifting his own hand toward the empty air between them.

"Say things like that and I'll start believing them. Last time I checked a mirror, I wasn't Superman."

Carter Morgan took no offense; he bent down to shake the half-raised hand and laughed instead: "To an ordinary man like me with no passage, you're close enough."

Taylor gave him a sidelong glance.

Carter was the second generation of the Morgan House Faction—unlike the founder before him, he had no passage.

But he had no desire for one either; he was perfectly content to exist in the human world as a director and major shareholder of a Hunter house faction—Taylor knew full well that behind all the polite words, whether the money flowing into Carter's pockets came from Hunters, financial analysts, or horse and dog racing made very little difference to Carter Morgan.

A passage was valued only because it could generate profit, like everything else in the world.

If you were born already sitting in the rentier class, who in their right mind would open a passage, enter the Nest, and hang their life by a thread in the dark and the blood?

"I've already seen the contract—Han Ford showed it to me."

Taylor curled his legs up on the sofa and said unhurriedly, "I told him the same thing: under normal circumstances, there isn't a Hunter alive worth the price you're offering. I'm curious—once you sign me, what exactly do you intend to use me for?"

"I love talking to someone who gets straight to the point."

Carter Morgan said this while pouring him a glass of whisky. "Your father told me you've already decided to sign, you just need a few things clarified first—is that right?"

At this stage, going back and forth over whether to sign seemed pointless anyway.

Even if he turned down the Morgan House Faction, Han Ford would just bring him the next one—the Roselyn family, the Martin family, the pig-cow-sheep-dog family—forget it, it was only ten years.

Ten years from now, at twenty-seven, he would never have to enter the Nest again.

Taylor looked at the clear amber liquor in his glass and felt a faint urge to laugh.

He was seventeen now, not yet the legal drinking age, yet no one would bat an eye at that, let alone have any opinion about what he smoked or what he did—simply because compared to the average seventeen-year-old, he was worth money.

Money was the unit by which everything was measured.

Even power—the kind that could buy freedom—when people possessed it, they would inevitably trade it for money. How much more so everything else in the world?

Taylor drained the glass in one go, then said: "Right."

Carter Morgan's expression brightened a little.

"Good, then we're on the same side." He took a sip of his drink, worked it slowly around his palate, and then said: "...What I'm about to tell you is known only to you, me, and Wellesley himself."

Taylor tilted his head—he hadn't expected to hear that name. "Wellesley? The one on the wealth rankings? What does he have to do with this?"

Carter turned toward the floor-to-ceiling windows of the high floor, taking in the unobstructed nightscape of Blackmoor City and the distant sea still faintly tinged with a deep crimson, and weighed his words for a moment before finally speaking.

"Wellesley has a piece of critical intelligence in his hands.

"He's kept every Hunter in Blackmoor City in the dark. As for me—I've only sensed that this intelligence exists, but I don't know what it actually contains."

"Then how do you know he has it?"

"A man with motives takes action."

Carter Morgan smiled, showing a row of closely set teeth. "It was precisely his movements growing more and more frequent lately that made me curious, so I looked into it a little...and that's how I arrived at this conclusion."

Taylor turned the words over in his mind and asked, "What did you find out?"

"You know that Wellesley himself has no passage, right?" Carter asked, catching him off guard.

Seeing Taylor nod, he continued: "He and I are the same kind of person—I know perfectly well that neither of us is cut out to be a Hunter. But I've heard that he recently plans to quietly put out an anonymous request into Hunter circles through a proxy—he wants a passage.

"The first time I heard about it, I was taken aback. Isn't a passage something you're born with? Either you have it or you don't. And on top of that, he doesn't want anyone to know that the one asking for a passage is him personally...I actually don't know how to make sense of it."

Carter shook his head and said, "But the fact that Wellesley conceived this idea at all perhaps suggests that acquiring a passage after birth isn't entirely impossible."

"What does he want a passage for?" Taylor asked.

Truthfully, whether the richest man in the city wanted a passage or not had nothing to do with him.

But when facing a future employer, he had to ask a question or two, just to show he was listening.

Carter smiled and said, "I don't know. That alone is strange enough—Wellesley entering the Nest would be walking into his own death, wouldn't it? But beyond that, there's something even

stranger."

Before responding, Taylor first reached into his pocket and pulled out a small plastic resealable bag.

He tapped the curled green leaf wrapped around crystal fragments out of the bag bit by bit onto rolling paper and said, "Don't mind me—I like the rolling process."

Carter nodded and smiled.

"When I was your age, I had to sneak around to smoke. Times were different back then—not like now, with weed shops on every corner. Getting it was a real hassle; you had to ask a friend to find someone, and after paying through the nose, you'd open it and find shredded newspaper mixed in."

Taylor laughed for the first time that day, feeling that Carter actually had something of an ordinary person's quality to him after all.

He lit the rolled cigarette, took a drag, and asked, "...What's the even stranger thing?"

Carter shifted his posture and said, "He recently placed a commission with the Morgan House Faction. Once you're on board, it'll be your job—there's no harm in telling you now in advance..."

"Wellesley has commissioned us to enter the Nest on the 13th of every month and search for an Artifact related to 'time' in St. Louis Hospital, Broom Street, and the area corresponding to Blackmoor University Law Department."

Taylor slowly raised his head and stared at Carter, as though his vision had only now finally come into focus.

"...That's impossible," he said quietly, then paused. "How does he know that?"

"Exactly."

Carter seemed actually pleased to have finally piqued his interest: "You're a Hunter—you know better than anyone that once you enter the Nest, where you go and what Artifacts you encounter is beyond human control or prediction."

"And yet Wellesley behaves as though he knows exactly when and where certain things will appear in the Nest, and he only needs a Hunter to follow the map and bring them back for him."

"He's not a Hunter himself—he once tried to build his own Hunter team, but it didn't go well, and eventually the whole thing fizzled out with nothing to show for it."

"So you've hit on exactly the right question: this intelligence of his—how did he come by it?"

Carter hadn't finished speaking.

"And the commission he placed with the Morgan House Faction isn't the only one. From what I know, he previously placed another commission with someone else as well...but I don't know specifically what that one was for. What on earth does he want these two things for?"

Taylor sat in silence for a moment, thinking.

The information Carter had provided was still very vague—enough only to let one glimpse a rough outline—but even that outline was sufficient to convince anyone that Wellesley truly knew something no one else did.

"Taking a logical approach, I can assume Wellesley has in his possession a certain...let's call it 'intelligence.' Having obtained this intelligence, he formed a goal.

"To achieve that goal, he needs a passage and at least two Artifacts. He has learned through some means when and where these two Artifacts will appear in the Nest...correct?"

"Looking at it that way, the crux of the matter is what a passage and those Artifacts could possibly give him—and that, for now, no one in the world knows except him."

"Talking with you is so easy," Carter said, refilling both their glasses.

"So what do you want me to do?"

"Why, satisfy Mr. Wellesley's wishes, of course," Carter said with a loud laugh.

Then he leaned his body forward and, looking Taylor Ford in the eyes, said slowly: "...And then get whatever his true objective really is into our hands."

This was not something that could be done without the most capable Hunter available.

That was what Carter said while patting him on the shoulder and singing his praises; but Taylor honestly didn't know whether he counted as a capable Hunter, let alone the "most" capable.

It was just that sometimes the world seemed to have been scripted and arranged by some unknowable force—and the role written for him was that of a "star Hunter."

For instance, right now: less than two months after Taylor Ford had taken over the Morgan House Faction's Hunter operations, he hadn't expected the next lead about Wellesley to come from

a finance employee with no passage—and he hadn't even been looking for one.

"Yes, it just happened. I came here with a friend for drinks..."

The finance employee was a young woman named Amber, who, upon meeting Taylor Ford for the first time, likewise couldn't help freezing for a moment. Even with the conversation already started, she seemed unable to believe it and asked again to confirm: "You...you're really the new Hunter Director our house faction just hired?"

"Why would I lie to you? I never lie to girls."

Taylor sat on the street outside the bar, tilted his head back, and smiled up at her. "Do you usually like to drink?"

"Not really," Amber said, still faintly flushed from the alcohol. "We were celebrating...my friend likes drinking even less than I do, so she came outside for some air partway through. In those few minutes, the last SUV in a motorcade suddenly lost control—it was almost like someone had shoved it—and plowed straight into the back door, nearly hitting my friend. Look, the door's still bent out of shape and won't close properly."

Taylor glanced over at the bar's back door.

By the time he arrived at the scene, the car had already been towed away; but judging from the marks left behind, the way it had lost control was indeed very unnatural.

"Who's your friend?"

"Oh, she's not a Hunter from our house faction—she goes into the Nest on her own, picking up small jobs. Her name is Sydney Ginn. She's still inside the bar right now, probably chatting with someone—she ran into a guy who seems to like her."

Women, regardless of age, always seemed unable to stop themselves from saying a few extra words when facing Taylor Ford—though he wasn't sure how useful it might be, he filed away the name "Sydney Ginn."

"The person who got out of the car was a bodyguard."

Amber recounted the motorcade's initial reaction and the details of the bodyguard one by one, then added: "I felt like I'd seen him somewhere before, and after a moment it came to me—he'd come to our company once before, as Wellesley's personal bodyguard."

When Wellesley placed the commission with the Morgan House Faction, he came in person—at the time, Taylor Ford had not yet taken over as Hunter Director, but she was already in the know.

Amber tucked her short hair behind her ear, revealing a pointed, slightly elfin ear.

"I recognized him, but he didn't recognize me—he never noticed me standing nearby watching the commotion. Later, one of his colleagues came to meet him, and I heard that colleague say with my own ears, 'The boss is going to pick something up.' Right then I thought, no wonder that motorcade was so heavily guarded—was Wellesley about to receive an Artifact? If so, maybe I should say something to Jane Lynch..."

Taylor Ford glanced at the time on her phone screen.

According to Amber, the crash had happened twenty minutes ago—fortunately she had a good relationship with Jane Lynch, and Jane Lynch's instincts happened to be sharp enough that she'd notified her in time.

There was still time...

The motorcade, having been given a scare not long ago, would need to verify whether the situation had truly changed; they shouldn't have been able to complete their original plan in such a short window.

"This matter... have you told your friend about it?"

Amber shook her head.

Taylor Ford rose quietly to her feet and gave a slight lift of her chin toward Jane Lynch, who was waiting nearby; she understood immediately, turned at once, and went to bring the car around.

"Sister Amber," he said lazily, giving Amber a smile, his voice low: "Do me a favor, will you?"

The very tips of Amber's ears turned red. "What favor?"

"Just head home tonight—give your friend a chance to chat more with that guy."

Taylor Ford said this, then tilted his head and thought for a moment.

"This matter is a little sensitive where the House Faction is concerned. If your friend asks, just tell her I'm the one who told you not to say anything... and that I came to you for details after you

got to work Monday, and only then told you not to tell anyone else. Say it that way—is that alright?"

Amber glanced toward the bar.

"Since you're the House Faction's Hunter Director, that makes this the House Faction's call... I understand." She nodded and added: "Sydney probably doesn't know yet that this motorcade has anything to do with Wellesley."

Ah, whenever I'm writing there's so much rambling I want to share, but by the time I actually post, I've forgotten it all...

Wait! One piece of rambling just came back to me.

Throughout the writing process, I've been racking my brain trying to keep the "realism" dialed all the way up. It's not that I'm padding the text—I just feel that if a world is too fantastical at every turn, money and banknotes lose their sense of weight...

But money is the main driving force of the Artifact-report world, which means I need to do my best to make everyone feel the magic of cash (as if that's something I even need to remind anyone of).

So here's the problem:

How does a broke person write about a life of extravagance?

I'm hoping we can crowdfund some life experiences for the author, so I don't end up writing a scene where some CEO points at the clothes on a rack and says, "Take down both of these rows for me."

Chapter 58: Taylor Ford Isn't the Only One Lying in Wait

Jane Lynch rested one hand on the steering wheel, and as Taylor Ford got into the car, she gave him a sidelong glance from the corner of her eye.

That faint trace of cool disdain vanished without a trace the moment she lowered her eyelids—she was a consummate professional, and even if she had her doubts and reservations, she wasn't about to let them show on her face in front of a new superior.

Jane Lynch simply leaned forward to peer at the road ahead and said, "Mr. Ford, there are no surveillance cameras in this area. With no cameras, how are we supposed to know which way they went?"

"Don't call me Mr. Ford. I'm not him."

Taylor Ford opened the map on his phone and replied, "Even if there were cameras, by the time we pulled the footage it'd already be too late—we were never counting on that anyway."

"Then may I call you Taylor?" Jane Lynch paused, and in the end couldn't hold back the barb, adding: "...and reserve 'Mr. Ford' for your father?"

An eleventh-grader who had swooped in and landed the Hunter Director position on the strength of a name alone—and on top of that, had come into the House Faction with a father in tow. Taylor Ford was young, not stupid; he knew perfectly well what people said behind his back.

"Call him whatever you like. It doesn't matter."

Every second passing was precious, yet Jane Lynch made no move to drive, instead dropping a question at his feet first: "So where are we going?"

Though not much time had passed since the incident, tracking down Wellesley to intercept the Artifact handoff was still an enormously thorny task—to say nothing else, the moment trouble had erupted, the motorcade had instantly scattered in all directions, precisely to prevent anyone from tailing them.

What's more, beyond knowing that "Wellesley had been on the road twenty minutes ago," they had zero other intelligence. Where would they even begin?

"We don't know his destination, we don't know who he's meeting or when..."

Jane Lynch listed the disadvantages one by one, stopping just short of saying outright that catching up with them was impossible. "I don't understand why we have to follow him to the Artifact pickup at all. If we're discovered, it could seriously offend him."

Carter Morgan's plan was naturally not something to be broadcast throughout the House Faction—what was remarkable was that Jane Lynch, without any knowledge of Carter's intentions, had still managed to tip Taylor Ford off about tonight's events in time.

She was a capable and sharp woman—no wonder she had risen to Hunter HR without being a Hunter herself; and no wonder she had been watching Taylor Ford with such cool scrutiny all along.

Taylor Ford looked at the map.

Jane Lynch wasn't wrong, really; by any ordinary means, there was simply no way to determine which direction Wellesley might have headed.

"Didn't you recently interview a Hunter who can detect Artifacts?" he asked, catching her off guard.

Jane Lynch startled and glanced at him.

"Yes—her name is Kingsley Roselyn. Her detection range is too wide and far too imprecise, so I met with her once but haven't made a decision yet."

"A wide range has its advantages," Taylor Ford closed the map and said. "Call her. Whatever conditions she asks for, it doesn't matter—have her come over right now."

Jane Lynch frowned and didn't move.

"Tay—that is, Taylor, we can't possibly drive her around street by street looking for Artifacts. Without knowing the destination, that's no different from searching for a needle in a haystack."

"Who said anything about going street by street?"

Taylor Ford didn't press her to make the call; instead he picked up his own phone and glanced at a text message that had just come in—it was from Carter Morgan.

"Finding out where Wellesley is— isn't that simple enough?"

"How?" Jane Lynch stared at him fixedly.

Taylor Ford had already pressed the phone to his ear; when the call connected, he flashed Jane Lynch a smile, gesturing for her to listen in.

"...Mr. Green?"

He reclined his seat, half-lying with his legs drawn up, and said into the phone: "This is Taylor Ford, Hunter Director of the Morgan House Faction. Mr. Morgan should have already given you a heads-up just now. Could you transfer me to your employer? I have an urgent situation that requires immediate communication with Mr. Wellesley."

Jane Lynch's eyes went wide—Taylor Ford had put the call on speaker.

"What situation?" The secretary, Green, on the other end of the line sounded somewhat hesitant, but notably did not say he wasn't with Wellesley.

"Tell him it's about 'time,'" Taylor Ford added: "It's urgent."

While waiting for Secretary Green to connect the call, the moment he muted the line, Jane Lynch immediately asked, "What are you planning? Is the approach you're talking about—"

"Exactly—if we don't know where he's going, why not just ask him?" Taylor Ford said, as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

Wellesley had no idea that Carter Morgan was quietly plotting to swoop in from behind.

Jane Lynch stared at him blankly. "That's...completely reckless, isn't it? What information do we even have about a 'time' Artifact?"

She was quite straightforward about it—but sometimes the truth wasn't the most convenient thing to say; making up some so-called urgent intelligence was entirely a matter of letting his imagination run wild, wasn't it?

Wellesley couldn't very well go into the Nest himself to verify it.

If Taylor Ford had any particular talent, he reckoned it was his ability to make something with no basis in reality sound extraordinarily convincing and detailed. Even Wellesley—who was at this very moment on his way to collect an Artifact—couldn't help but be stirred into hesitation after hearing him out: "...Right now? I'm on the road. It's not convenient."

"That's fine,"

Taylor Ford said, with impeccable consideration: "Why don't you give me a location, and I'll wait for you there. As long as Mr. Wellesley can make a brief stop on the way back—just five

minutes—that would be enough for us to confirm our next move."

That last half-sentence, at least, wasn't a lie.

Wellesley proved to be very cautious—even with a House Faction he was working with, he didn't let slip his current location; perhaps the earlier inexplicable attack on one of his escort vehicles had put him on high alert.

Yet even after being rattled once, he was still dead set on completing this transaction tonight—which said everything about how important that Artifact was.

"I'll have Green send you an address. Thirty minutes from now—"

Wellesley got that far before someone nearby seemed to murmur something in a low voice, prompting him to correct himself: "No. One to two hours from now, I'll be there."

Taylor Ford thought the person in the background had said something like "need to verify."

Verify what?

The only thing that would need verifying seemed to be the Artifact he was about to get his hands on.

In other words, he hadn't yet taken possession of the Artifact, so he needed to leave time for the verification—and the time required to verify it would very likely end up being much longer than Wellesley had initially estimated.

Once they had an address, the rest wouldn't be hard.

"With this address as the center and a thirty-minute driving radius, dispatch a helicopter immediately to sweep a few circles around the area—look for his security motorcade, look for heavy security presence. We'll drive over as well."

Taylor Ford's instructions this time were swiftly carried out by Jane Lynch—even though she still had no clear idea why the Hunter Director wanted to tail a client.

"And what about Kingsley Roselyn?" After dispatching the helicopter, Jane Lynch this time proactively picked up her phone and asked, "I'll call her now. How should we arrange things with her?"

"She's only a backup. Just have her come."

As Taylor Ford said this, he had not yet foreseen that he was making a mistake. "Even if we don't need her tonight, the House Faction will need someone like her going forward."

Jane Lynch quickly got through to the call and relayed Taylor Ford's instructions precisely, even taking the trouble to add, "It's our House Faction's Hunter Director—he thinks very highly of you"—as the saying goes, flattery never wears thin.

"Mm? Yes, the terms you named—we can meet all of them...right. We can double it."

At that, Jane Lynch stressed: "But our requirement is that you get here within thirty minutes. There's a situation, and we may need you."

Through the car's speaker, the voice of Kingsley Roselyn—seemingly always cheerful—rang out. "What's the address?"

Jane Lynch glanced at Taylor Ford; he thought for a moment, then nodded.

She gave the location, and two seconds of silence followed before Kingsley spoke up. "Ah, sorry—I can't make it over there."

Jane Lynch immediately frowned—she leaned hard on the horn at the car ahead before turning back to the phone. "Where are you right now? I can send a helicopter to pick you up."

"Ah, I'm sorry, I really can't get away right now," Kingsley paused, sounding actually regretful. "...Does my coming on board have to be tied to tonight specifically?"

Before Jane Lynch could respond, Taylor Ford pressed a hand on her arm.

She turned her head; Taylor Ford shook his and mouthed silently: "Hang up."

"What is it?" Jane Lynch quickly ended the call and asked.

Any Hunter who had survived the Nest had to possess the ability to pick up warnings and hints from the faintest of clues—an ability that, starting from deliberate analysis, had long since been distilled into something closer to instinct; the more skilled the Hunter, the less likely they were to ignore even the slightest hair-thin sense of something being off.

"Someone's with her." Taylor Ford spoke with near certainty.

Jane Lynch paused. "...How do you know?"

That was hard to explain.

A feeling is something elusive and vague—like mist, it scatters the moment you reach for it, and it's difficult to pin down in words and then analyze strand by strand.

It might have been that Kingsley had paused both times before answering; it might have been that she hesitated for a moment instead of stating her location.

It could also have been that Taylor Ford had caught the faint rustle of her collar as she turned her head—as if she were looking at someone—and all such phantom-like clues might have been seized unconsciously, yet the moment he tried to surface them and articulate them, they seemed almost too tenuous to hold.

"...Because I'm very good at lying," he finally offered as his answer. "So I could tell she wasn't telling the truth either."

Whether that persuaded Jane Lynch, he didn't know; but she accepted the explanation for the time being.

"So what do we do next...?"

"Don't worry—keep going."

Taylor Ford still lounged in his seat like a large cat, his voice unhurried and drifting: "Having someone else there doesn't necessarily mean anything. Never mind people in our line of work—anyone living in this world never knows what might be unfolding out there in the wide world, or what might come knocking at the door and turn their life upside down. But it doesn't matter. Deal with soldiers when soldiers come, dam the water when water flows."

Jane Lynch was quiet for a moment, then gave a wry smile. "You...really don't seem like someone your age."

"Is that so?"

Taylor Ford raised his head and smiled at her profile. "They say the brain doesn't fully develop until you're twenty-five—maybe I'm still an idiot right now. Do you want to see what I'm like at twenty-five? If you do, you can't quit on me."

In the nearly two months since she had started, it was the first time he had seen Jane Lynch laugh from the heart.

"You know," she said, eyes on the road as she drove, "I have a passage too."

"Oh?"

Jane Lynch spoke in the easy tone of friends chatting: "But I'm different from you. I took one look at the Nest, and I knew—I couldn't be a Hunter. I feared the Nest, I despised it, and I had no confidence I'd make it back alive the next time. That's why I chose to only work within Blackmoor City.

"...This world is truly strange." She mused: "Something like a passage doesn't necessarily go to someone who matches it."

Taylor Ford couldn't help but think of Wellesley—and the offer he hadn't yet put out, the bounty he'd been considering posting for passages.

Whatever Carter Morgan's plans were, Wellesley remained Morgan House Faction's most important client—and in Blackmoor City, he was the last person anyone should think of provoking.

Even if he located Wellesley, it didn't mean Taylor Ford could move against the deal or cut in on it—the timing was far from right.

But simply finding out what he had purchased, and what that item was for, was not an impossible task.

Getting the answer didn't even require disturbing Wellesley himself.

After all, in any deal, there are two people who know.

"Found him,"

the helicopter pilot's reply reached Taylor Ford's earpiece a little over ten minutes later—fast enough to catch him off guard. "Where Wellesley went is a private dock where his cruise ship is moored."

If not for the fact that tonight's deal had leaked in a way that seemed almost as though someone had given it a push, this meeting spot was actually quite safe and convenient—he'd nearly forgotten: billionaires live in a world of their own.

"No need to follow," Taylor Ford glanced at the time on his phone and said, "His meeting spot should be on the cruise ship. Station a few people on the road outside the dock and see who goes in after him—give me the license plates and vehicle types."

Barring any surprises, the other party to the deal should be the first to leave the cruise ship a little while from now.

That meant that as long as Taylor Ford lay in wait outside the dock, he would be able to see the Hunter who left after completing the deal with Wellesley—and once he confirmed the other party's identity, he could get there ahead of them, to the location Wellesley had arranged, and keep spinning stories for the billionaire to enjoy.

Taylor Ford stepped out of the car, pulled up the hood of his hoodie, the shadow falling across half his face.

He sat on the hood of the engine, gazing across the water at the rolling skyline and city lights of Blackmoor City on the other shore, wisps of white smoke curling from between his fingers and dissolving into the night.

Now it was just a matter of waiting.

But Taylor Ford hadn't expected that the first person to appear would not be the one he was anticipating.

When another black Mercedes slowly pulled to a stop in the middle of the road alongside him, Taylor Ford only turned to glance over—he hadn't even had time to make out the person who had just pushed open the car door—yet something like a physiological instinct of revulsion, like an electric current, made his eyebrow twitch.

A tall figure in a suit straightened up outside the car door and slammed it shut with a bang.

Chase Monroe stood in the darkness, gazing toward the distant dock, not sparing Taylor Ford so much as a glance, and quietly cracked a smile.

Today's chapter went up pretty early, right! That's because I was hunched over writing until midnight last night. I have no idea how people manage daily updates of over ten thousand characters—four thousand is already killing me...

Yesterday's author's note got me some subway fare and milk tea money, and I'm planning to save it all up into an "Artifact Report Field Research Fund," so that by the time the story wraps up, I can actually go out and gather some inspiration (not really).

Chapter 59 — Taylor Ford's Stakeout for Two

Taylor Ford was still sitting on the car hood. He glanced at the newcomer, turned his head back, and didn't get down.

"...Don't tell me the people on that boat are yours?"

"Don't say stupid things."

Chase Monroe seemed entirely unbothered by the fact that his car was parked in the middle of the road—though the stretch leading to the private dock ahead had little traffic to speak of, let alone at this hour of the night. Taylor Ford's fleeting hope that a patrol car might happen to pass and ticket him quietly died.

"If we were the ones dealing with Wellesley, do you think I'd let you sit here?"

"Then where would you have me sit? In Roland Key's chair?"

Taylor Ford shot back with his mouth, but inside he couldn't stop the irritation gnawing at him.

...How on earth did he know?

Wellesley's deal tonight had been kept from the entirety of Blackmoor City.

Taylor Ford himself had only learned of it less than an hour ago through a piece of intel that had fallen into his hands by accident, and had improvised his moves step by step on the fly—he had barely arrived here himself. So where had this man caught the scent, that he came tracking along like a hyena?

He very much wanted to know. But he wanted even less to ask.

He kept his face stiff and sat in silence for a moment before letting out a cold laugh. "...So it was Kingsley Roselyn. Someone was actually willing to board that sinking ship of yours? She'd better not think about switching sides later."

"Oh? Figured that out yourself?" Chase asked. "No tutoring needed?"

There was still one piece he hadn't worked out—such as how, even if Kingsley Roselyn knew their location, Chase would know that Wellesley was dealing with a third party—but no matter what, Taylor Ford could not bring himself to ask.

Anyway, that man was the type to clamp down the moment he got even a single clue and never let go. He'd gone into the wrong line of work entirely—he should've been a snapping turtle.

Taylor Ford only asked one thing: "Still happy being a godfather's dog?"

Chase didn't take the bait. He smiled, a flash of white teeth in the dark.

"Happier than having a dog for a real father."

"...Hunter business has nothing to do with you. You don't understand it. Go home."

"That won't do. Someone has to be the adult when you make a mess of things." Chase fixed him with a look, then dropped his gaze with a small laugh. "...You're used to that by now, aren't you."

Taylor Ford had never paid any attention to the color of Chase's eyes—but right now, in the darkness, Chase's eyes looked like a pair of obsidian stones reflecting a hard sheen, sunk deep beneath his brow, as if swallowing the surrounding night whole.

Compared to humans, he sometimes seemed closer to a Resident—clearly Chase standing in Blackmoor City, yet appearing to cast a long Resident's shadow on the ground.

Perhaps it was that feeling lodged in his chest that made Taylor Ford notice his own body gradually tensing as Chase walked toward him, step by step.

Without consciously deciding to, he had almost imperceptibly shifted his angle, angling as much of his front toward Chase as possible, every muscle coiled and ready to spring at the first touch.

Jane Lynch was behind him on the road, managing personnel deployment and surveillance. He was the only one here.

If a confrontation broke out with Chase here...

"Relax. If I wanted to move on you, your guard wouldn't help." Chase tipped his chin toward Taylor Ford's hands. "Just need a light."

"No light."

Taylor Ford cursed under his breath and looked at the burning paper roll in his hand—go rub two sticks together if you're so determined. "You should get out of here."

"Oh?"

"The person dealing with Wellesley hasn't come off the boat yet,"

Taylor Ford flung the paper roll to the ground. It was, in every sense, a violation of his youthful temperament—he had spent every last reserve of patience he possessed to say: "Your car is sitting in the middle of the road, sticking out like the Loch Ness Monster. What do you need a light for—to send them a flare so they know to stay on board?"

Most Hunters in Blackmoor City knew trouble was coming if they were driving at midnight and their headlights suddenly picked out a Chase standing in the road ahead.

"Worried I'll ruin your plans?" Chase turned to look toward the road leading to the dock. "I'm a very reasonable person."

Taylor Ford swallowed back a retort.

"If I knew what plans I might be ruining, I certainly wouldn't still be standing in the middle of the road."

...As much as he was loath to admit it, Chase Monroe had no passage, yet had risen to his current standing in the Hunter world—not entirely because he was willing to be a foster father's dog.

As Carter Morgan had said, "Where there is desire, there is action"; and once a person acts, they leave traces.

Chase had used every last bit of that snapping-turtle talent of his to catch a scent from the Morgan House Faction's movements tonight that was different from their usual pattern—in other words, his target was not only Wellesley's trading partner, but also the intentions and plans of the Morgan House Faction itself.

Thinking further, he might even have had his eye on the Morgan House Faction for some time now.

He truly would have made a good Hunter.

Which was exactly why he could never have a passage.

"This has nothing to do with the Key House Faction."

Taylor Ford's expression went cold. "Someone's been poaching Morgan House Faction business. We're cleaning up the garbage—it's an internal matter. Think carefully: does the Key House Faction really want to stick its hand in tonight?"

"Nonsense."

Chase looked out toward the distant dock. "When you first saw me just now, didn't you ask whether the people on the boat were from the Key House Faction? That means you don't know who's on the boat either."

There was no way Taylor Ford would be caught on such an obvious slip.

"Is this your first day out here? If someone dares to cross us, there's backing behind them. The moment I followed this lead, you showed up right here." He let out a cold laugh. "Nothing is ever that much of a coincidence. Of course I had to ask."

Chase looked at Taylor Ford with a blank expression—as if even he was now a little uncertain.

"That's a fair point."

Yet Chase thought for a moment, and his next words were: "Too bad—even if you told me you were human, I'd need to see the autopsy report before I believed it."

Taylor Ford immediately jumped down from the hood, walked around Chase, and yanked the driver's door open.

"Then stand there all you like," he said. "I'll see what you manage to accomplish."

The car door slammed shut with a bang, cutting off whatever Chase's response might have been.

Though Chase was now an added variable, tonight's situation remained under the Morgan House Faction's control.

First, with Taylor Ford watching from the side, Chase wouldn't be able to take the trading partner away.

Second, even if the trading partner spotted Chase and turned back, the Hunters and helicopter Taylor Ford had deployed nearby could continue to trail him and identify who he was—more complications, but it would also draw things away from the dock, making it less likely to alert Wellesley.

Even if Wellesley grew suspicious later, everything could be pinned on the Key House Faction...even the trading partner himself would assume it was the Key House Faction chasing him.

So from another angle, Chase's appearance was actually a good thing: he had become the Morgan House Faction's camouflage.

That said, asking a seventeen-year-old to swallow that suffocating frustration quietly was still asking a great deal of Taylor Ford.

He looked out through the half-lowered car window.

Chase had walked back to the middle of the road. His tall silhouette was leaning against the hood of the black Mercedes, arms folded, seemingly resolved to turn the whole night into a scrambled deck of cards.

Whatever he planned to do next, right now both of them could only wait.

The night settled back into silence, the distant lights on the sea glimmering far away.

After a while, Taylor Ford reached instinctively for his trouser pocket, then remembered—the last paper roll, he'd thrown it on the ground just now.

He hesitated, which was rare for him: going out to pick it up felt somewhat like losing face.

But not going—sitting stiffly in the car without moving a muscle, not even able to check his phone—felt actually unbearable. However you looked at it, he was still seventeen. Even knowing that in a short while things would probably come to a head, boredom in the present moment was still boredom.

Taylor Ford leaned forward and peered out the window again.

Did that mean middle-aged people didn't get bored?

If Chase didn't move soon, he was about to wonder whether the man had fallen asleep—and at precisely that moment, Chase stood up, circled to the side of the car, and bent down to reach a hand through the window.

When he straightened back up, he had in his hand what looked like a heavy rod with a T-shaped top. At the same moment, music started playing from inside the black Mercedes.

Chase smiled silently at Taylor Ford—like a wound torn open through the dim nothingness.

Swinging the T-bar loosely in one hand, he walked step by step back to the car hood, treading on the singing voice that spread through the night like mist, and leaned against it once more.

The night paused—then a gust slammed through like a highway wind, hard enough to feel like it could stir someone's bangs.

I've been dreamin' about the West Coast

Where the people take it real slow

Chase's silhouette remained motionless as ever, like a frozen statue—only if you looked carefully would you notice the tip of his shoe tapping along, ever so slightly, in quiet agreement with the beat.

Taylor Ford held back, then didn't—a short huff of laughter escaped through his nose, half mockery, half amusement.

If even the middle-aged were listening to music, what was the harm in picking up a paper roll?

Taylor Ford pushed the car door open and put one foot on the road—and at that exact moment, a car came around the bend ahead, its headlights cutting sharply through the dark.

...Here they come?

Taylor Ford swept a hand across the car roof and grabbed the length of chain he'd placed there earlier. He didn't turn his head—just heard a dull thud, and out of the corner of his eye the tall silhouette leaped up onto a car hood.

The incoming car had barely finished rounding the bend when it lurched violently off to the side as if startled. Amid a piercing shriek of tires that seemed to scrape sparks from the dark, the car veered wildly off the road in a panic—Taylor Ford's mind had just flashed "could it have seen Chase?" when he immediately realized something was wrong.

Too far away—the driver shouldn't have been able to make out Chase clearly, and wouldn't have been frightened enough to bolt like that.

They must have spotted something else—

The thought hadn't finished forming when, from a squat, dark building by the roadside, a deafening cannon-blast tore through it, the night caved in, and a ball of fire bloomed.

The next second, the car was flung into the sky like a toy hurled by a child's hand, riding the fireball and the shockwave high up into the dark above.

All I wanna do is fly

Take me where the sun shines

Sleep has been rough lately—staying up past midnight every night, it's been rough...

I think I finally understand why I write so slowly. I'm just an amateur web novel hobbyist, but somewhere along the way I got the delusion that I'm a film director—I'll be writing along and then absolutely have to pick a background track, spend half an hour scrolling through playlists, finally decide "West Coast" is perfect, and it has to go in the chapter.

The lyrics fit perfectly, there's something nicely ironic about them, and they suit Chase's background. The tempo is a touch fast, but it works—this scene isn't long, just a few shots (lol).

Went to the gym yesterday and saw a familiar-looking ridiculously handsome guy. I barely came up to his shoulder—he must have been at least 2.1 meters? I couldn't help sneaking a few extra glances, got caught, and it was mortifying. I immediately told myself: anyone that good-looking is definitely gay, and just like that my heart was calm, my expression serene, and all the awkwardness was gone.

What's wrong with a girl checking out a fellow cutie, honestly.

Chapter 60: Taylor Ford, This Matter, and Its Connection to Key House Faction

...Should it be said that he was shocked just then?

Yes, startled he certainly was—the person who should by now have fallen into his hands had suddenly gone airborne, car and all, launched high into the sky. Anyone would have been startled.

But Taylor Ford found that alongside his shock, there was also a kind of calm that felt almost unsurprised: the jolt surged up and then crashed back down together with the distant car, and once it had, everything was simply fact.

Because when he thought about it carefully, this was almost destined to happen, wasn't it?

He just hadn't expected it to happen so fast, so violently, so recklessly.

As though whoever had made the decision to kill understood perfectly well that the laws and rules governing Blackmoor City were not meant for him—and he had no intention of letting them constrain him.

The weapon that had flipped the car was something Taylor Ford had witnessed before with his own eyes.

A single kiss from a bazooka rocket launcher, and the car exploded on the spot—like a steel firework blooming in midair; the flames fed on the spilled gasoline, burning half the road a lurid red. After a hit like that, no one inside could have survived. It was already too late.

The person who had fired the rocket from inside the building—limited by the angle of the road and the resulting blind spots—likely hadn't spotted the two cars further back on the street just now.

So the most important thing right now was to evacuate the scene immediately...

He had only just thought that far when, from the small building beneath the night sky, a rapid succession of shots rang out—bang, bang, bang—far sharper and cleaner than the bazooka had been, seemingly from a rifle.

Strange—

In that instant, Taylor Ford suddenly understood.

The moment he spun around and bolted off the road, a dark figure came charging up from behind him at the same time.

"...Is it Wellesley?"

In the blink of an eye, Chase had already closed the gap and was running at his side—despite having been half a block further away just moments ago—and his breathing, by the sound of it, was still completely unhurried.

So this one had figured it out too, Taylor Ford cursed inwardly. A bastard through and through.

A direct hit from a bazooka would turn the car and driver alike into smoldering wreckage—not even the gods could escape that. Yet the sniper had still switched to a rifle and fired several rounds into the darkness, and there was only one explanation for that.

Someone had jumped from the car before the bazooka hit.

Which meant that if he got there right now, he might still find someone alive—or at the very least, a clue to identify the dead—but running toward where the car had crashed and burned also meant running straight into the sniper's scope.

To be safe in case the sniper hadn't yet left, the two of them wordlessly agreed to close the distance crouching low, weaving through whatever cover they could find among the nearby walls, warehouses, and other man-made structures.

Taylor Ford considered his own skills respectable, but Chase's were nearly inhuman—to keep Chase from reaching the spot ahead of him, Taylor Ford had to squeeze out the breath to speak as he ran: "...If it's not him, does that mean it's you?"

"Interesting," Chase returned, nothing more.

He dropped low and waited two seconds behind a short wall; when the small building across the road remained silent, he suddenly sprang up and lunged forward.

Taylor Ford was shorter, with a smaller stride, but running slower had its advantage: as long as he followed in Chase's wake and mirrored his path, he could stay out of the sniper's line of sight across the road. A minute or two later, the two of them arrived one behind the other at the stretch of road burning fiercely ahead.

The night flickered with uneven light; the buildings around the docks were dragged into dim visibility by the firelight one moment and pushed back into darkness the next, as though taking turns watching the spectacle.

Even the air was warped by the heat. Taylor Ford stood behind cover and swept his gaze again and again across the shifting light and shadows, until at last, in the darkness cast by a stretch of eaves, he spotted a pair of legs lying completely limp and motionless. He had barely leapt toward them when he saw Chase lunge forward at the exact same moment.

The person lay face-up on the ground, covered in blood, impossible to tell where exactly the bullets had hit.

One look was really all it took to see that he didn't have much time left, that there was no saving him: his eyes were welling with tears, his mouth half-open, and as the shadows of the two men fell across his face, his throat produced a wet, gurgling sound—blood and air bubbles churning together.

"You just made a deal with Wellesley, didn't you?" Taylor Ford crouched beside the man and said quietly, "The ambulance is on its way. Hold on and answer me."

Chase lifted his eyes and looked at him.

Taylor Ford leaned closer and called to the injured man again: "Hey, listen to my voice—don't close your eyes. Did you just make a deal with Wellesley?"

The man seemed to be barely held to the world by the sound of a voice; from between his half-parted lips, a breath escaped, and it sounded like it could be a single word: "Yeah..."

"What did you sell him?"

Even with Chase right there listening, he had to get this information into his own hands—because the Hunter dying before him was likely the only person in Blackmoor City, apart from Wellesley himself, who knew what had been exchanged tonight.

It wasn't the first time Wellesley had done business with a Hunter, but it was the first time he had killed to silence one afterward.

What Artifact could have driven him to move against a Hunter?

Wellesley had also filed a commission with Morgan House Faction, but he couldn't possibly silence one of Blackmoor City's largest House Factions after the fact—the fallout from that would

be enormous, tantamount to a localized war.

That meant the Artifact traded tonight had one fundamental difference from every other Artifact that had ever been traded or was about to be traded. What was it?

Why was Wellesley unafraid of people knowing he possessed other Artifacts, yet unwilling to let anyone know he possessed this one?

The dying Hunter's mind seemed to have already scattered. Taylor Ford had no way of knowing whether the man had understood him at all.

His eyes, unmoving, rested on Chase's face; from deep within a throat full of blood, he murmured: "Key... Key House..."

Taylor Ford jolted, and immediately shot a glance at Chase.

Unexpectedly, Chase's expression looked as though he had just been slapped—caught completely off guard, he instinctively asked: "What?"

That momentary blankness left Taylor Ford equally stunned.

Chase looked even more astonished than he was, as though he had never anticipated the words "Key House" emerging from the mouth of a dying Hunter.

The world truly was strange—always twisting and turning, one thing threading into another. Originally, Taylor Ford had thought Chase's appearance here tonight was an infuriating complication; if he could turn back time, he would never have made that call to Kingsley Roselyn.

But right now, at this very moment, it was precisely because Chase was here in person that Taylor Ford had caught his first unguarded, unmasked reaction—and turned it into a crucial clue.

"Key... Key House..."

The dying Hunter seemed only to want to release that last word from his chest back into the world; he could not hear their surprise, and had no strength left to explain.

But how could this have anything to do with Key House Faction?

If it did, why was even Chase unaware?

Wait—Key—

Taylor Ford's heart suddenly lurched, and his mind went blazingly clear in an instant. He immediately bit down hard on his lip and dropped his gaze to the dying man on the ground,

careful not to let Chase read anything in his face.

He understood now what the man meant.

What he had said was not "Key House" (Keys), but "key" (key).

It was only because he was at death's door, blood flooding his airway, that his voice had come out slurred and rasping—the two sounded almost indistinguishable.

If Taylor Ford hadn't already known in his own mind that Key House Faction had no business being part of this, he might have been misled as well.

But Chase had not caught onto this—not yet.

As the saying goes, the anxious mind stumbles—he was embedded in Key House Faction, and when he suddenly heard its name spoken by a dying man, it was obvious his thoughts had been led off in the wrong direction. He was pressing forward: "What about Key House? What does it have to do with your deal?"

But the Hunter gave no further answer.

He stared wide-eyed, unseeing of the two men before him, as though he had already looked past them and was gazing into a vast and infinite sky.

Taylor Ford stood up.

He had lingered here long enough. Wellesley's people would be arriving soon to clean up, and he needed to leave this trouble spot as quickly as possible.

But before he left, there was one more thing he had to do: he couldn't let Chase keep thinking, couldn't let him have the chance to work it out.

Because once the answer was unraveled, it was actually quite simple—the only thing he could rely on was a misunderstanding.

So Taylor Ford needed to distract Chase, and at the same time drive that misunderstanding firmly into his mind, so that it would cloud his judgment and take root as a first impression—that way, even if Chase eventually figured it out later, he would already have the advantage.

"Just as I thought... I always knew tonight's business couldn't be untangled from your Key House Faction. What are you surprised about? Don't tell me even you didn't know what was going on behind the scenes? Well, fair enough—after all, you're not his biological son."

He knew he was walking a tightrope right now.

The best way to lower someone's intelligence was to infuriate them. But the person in question was someone who had every physical advantage over him—height, speed, strength...

Taylor Ford tightened his grip on the iron chain in his hand and smiled. "When I keep a dog, I don't go reporting family matters to it either."

From within the blazing red night, Chase's shadow slowly rose, cutting off the wall of fire behind him.

Chase turned his face, and his gaze settled on Taylor Ford.

That gaze had texture—like silt, like a dry and hollow wind, like something filtering through from an old black-and-white photograph, drained of life; it seemed as though neither the one looking nor the one being looked at belonged to this world.

The moment Taylor Ford knew he had successfully enraged Chase, something like a savage beast tore a chunk from his left chest—for an instant, he lost all sensation there, as though a black void had opened just beside his heart.

Had a piece of flesh been ripped away?

The thought flickered through him, but he didn't dare look down, because Chase would never give him the chance to raise his head again.

If Taylor Ford hadn't managed to twist sideways just in time, the place now screaming with pain so sharp it had gone nearly numb—that black void with the cold air pouring through—would have been his heart.

"Han Ford ought to spend less time selling you out and more time teaching you some manners."

Only then did Taylor Ford see clearly: what had just struck him in the chest was the T-bar, which had somehow found its way back into Chase's hand and was hanging loosely at his side.

He should have brought a gun tonight—

Taylor Ford leapt sideways, swinging the iron chain at Chase's midsection in a wide sweep, the links ringing loudly through the air like a rigid, bone-hard whip. Chase neither dodged nor sidestepped; instead he dropped slightly forward, raised his arm to block, and when the chain

landed with a heavy crack across his back and arm, he seized it and twisted his hand back—the chain coiled around him loop by loop, like an obedient snake.

This was bad.

The words had barely formed when Taylor Ford, before he could even let go of the chain, was yanked sideways by Chase and lifted clean off the ground.

"No decent weapon tonight?"

Chase grabbed him by the chest, slammed him to the ground, and looked down at Taylor Ford with a grin splitting his face. "Don't worry—when you're dead, I'll send your dad a little condolence money."

Taylor Ford had hit the back of his head hard on the ground and was seeing stars, but he still managed to prop himself up on his knuckles and swing a fist at Chase's eye; before it could connect, Chase caught him and heaved, tossing Taylor Ford like he was shaking out a folded blanket.

Taylor Ford tumbled out several steps; when he pushed his arms down to get up, his hands met something wet and soft. He looked back and found he had braced himself on top of the corpse.

The moment he realized he shouldn't have looked back, he also understood clearly that unless he rolled over a corpse, there was no avoiding the blow now sweeping in from behind his head.

Taylor Ford's judgment was timely—by the time he was gasping and pushing himself up from the ground, he was soaked in the dead man's blood, but at least none of it was his own; the back of his skull was still intact.

From the distant sky came a vast roar that twisted and coiled through the night, and within a few breaths it had closed in from afar, bearing down over the two of them; sand and gravel flew, and the wind churned wildly.

"When it comes to brute force, I can't match you,"

He kept his eyes on Chase, who stepped over the corpse in a single stride, and smiled as he backed away slowly: "...which is perfectly normal—how could a man possibly beat a gorilla? But look, you don't have time to kill me tonight."

The bright column of light beaming down from the helicopter swept back and forth over the two of them several times; the fuselage door slid open, and someone shouted something indistinct downward through the deafening roar of the rotors.

There was no need to make out exactly what was said, and no need to look at the gun leveled in that person's hands—the tone and sharpness alone were enough to convey the warning. Chase glanced back at the helicopter, then raised one hand and gathered his wind-tossed black hair back behind his head.

"Calling in the adults to take you home already?" he said, almost calmly. "Go on. Next time you head out, don't forget to bring a babysitter."

Chase didn't seem at all worried that whoever was in the helicopter would shoot him in the back as he turned and walked away—though Taylor Ford truly could not suppress the temptation to do exactly that.

But in the end he still didn't give Jane Lynch the order: too many unexpected turns had already occurred tonight, and Wellesley must have spotted this helicopter as well—he couldn't afford to stir up any more trouble.

"I heard the sound of a shell and knew something had gone wrong. Thankfully I didn't arrive too late."

Jane Lynch slid the helicopter door shut again, and as they gained altitude and left the scene, she watched Taylor Ford and asked, "What happened? Are you hurt?"

"Jane, I'm in so much pain I could die."

Taylor Ford pointed at his own chest, his face creased with misery, and said, "Got hit with a rod, smacked my head on the ground, and rolled around in a pile of blood. Still, it's not all bad news."

As he spoke, he pulled a blood-soaked wallet from the pocket of his hoodie.

"Look—that guy who was making deals with Wellesley was pretty thoughtful. He left a wallet on him, just for me."

Chapter 61: Taylor Ford's Key Is Remarkably Straightforward

The deaths of the Bronx Brothers barely stirred a ripple in Blackmoor City, and even within hunter circles, the news faded quickly into silence.

The two of them had been doing well in recent years, their reputations just beginning to rise, but they had never joined a House Faction, and it seemed their families hadn't even known they were Artifact hunters.

With their deaths, no one was left to grow suspicious, and no one would dig deeper or stand outside the police station demanding answers; their family came to Blackmoor City to clear out the apartment and collect their belongings, and the file on this "traffic accident" was closed.

In the end, the only trace they had left behind as Artifact hunters seemed to be a wallet stained black with blood, sitting on Taylor Ford's desk.

He picked it up, tossed it lightly into a drawer, and shut it.

"...As I said, all investigations into the Bronx Brothers within Blackmoor City are to be suspended for now."

Taylor Ford never sat where he was supposed to sit.

He was perched cross-legged on the desk, one hand propping up his chin, eyelids half-lowered, with a clear view of Jane Lynch's head on the other side of the desk.

There were three other people in the office besides him—aside from Jane Lynch, the other two were the core Hunters needed for the upcoming operation.

"Suspended?" Jane Lynch hesitated, then said, "But we still haven't found out the details of their deal with Wellesley..."

Today was May 4th, two days since the deaths of the Bronx Brothers, and the Morgan House Faction's covert investigation had been running for those same two days.

Witnessing them get silenced hadn't been entirely without benefit—Taylor Ford had been among the first to know, and before anyone else had even registered what had happened, he'd already arranged a plan of action; by the time he'd identified the victims and deployed people to investigate, Wellesley's men were still out on the road cleaning up the wreckage.

Looking back on it, he found it almost funny: when he'd met with Wellesley on the night of the incident, both sides had kept their composure on the surface, while in truth one side was mobilizing resources to cover everything up, and the other was already probing the reasons behind the silencing.

The net Taylor Ford had cast that night had pulled up every piece of information that could be gathered within hours of the Bronx Brothers' deaths.

But there were more questions still unanswered, and yet he could not push the investigation further.

"Wellesley's side has taken care of everything that needed to be taken care of, and the deaths of the Bronx Brothers have been officially ruled."

Taylor Ford replied, "There's no way he doesn't know about the helicopter that appeared that night. He's freed up now, which means he can turn his attention to whether anyone in Blackmoor City is suspicious about this 'accident.' At this point in time, he'll be especially alert and sensitive—we can't let Wellesley realize we've been sniffing around him."

Otherwise, it would be no different from calling Wellesley directly to confess.

"But we still don't know what the 'key' is," Jane Lynch reminded him. "If we stop investigating the Bronx Brothers, where do we go from here?"

"Hold on, Jane, I think I understand—"

A female Hunter with lip studs, brow studs, and a nose ring slapped Jane Lynch on the shoulder twice—enough to make her wince—before saying, "Just now, the Director said 'within Blackmoor City?'"

Taylor Ford instinctively rubbed his chest. Where Chase had struck him, a large dark purple bruise had spread, and even the bone underneath ached faintly.

"Right," Taylor Ford said. "It's inconvenient for us to keep digging around in Blackmoor City... but we still have the Nest, don't we?"

Facing three pairs of eyes, he ran a hand through his hair and said, "The Bronx Brothers' 'key' was also obtained from the Nest. The source of the information is in the Nest—so yesterday afternoon, I went to the Nest."

"Where?" Jane Lynch nearly leaped out of her chair. "Alone? Yesterday?"

She wasn't a Hunter, but she'd long been accustomed to managing Hunter affairs within a major House Faction, and seemed to always feel that entering the Nest should be a serious "project": one requiring advance planning, mapped-out routes and division of labor, selection of suitable members, and a full team assembled before setting out—since when did anyone just waltz in on a whim?

The other two Hunters, however, simply nodded, not particularly surprised.

"The Director leading by example, very good, very good—"

The female Hunter, clad head-to-toe in black leather, fishnet, and rivets, clapped her hands together with a smack smack, "Look at that, leading from the front. Didn't even call us—lucky for me, because I actually got to bring a girl home last night."

The flattery she offered was so offhand it bordered on mockery—or perhaps her mind was never really on whether Taylor Ford had entered the Nest at all.

"This is a workplace, keep your private life out of it," Jane Lynch said with a straight face, then turned to Taylor Ford: "You're the Director now. You shouldn't be risking yourself so casually going forward. Did going into the Nest yield any results?"

"It did," Taylor Ford paused, then abruptly turned to the female Hunter: "Remy, why are you so popular? How come nobody ever wants to come home with me?"

Before Remy had a chance to answer, Jane Lynch's eyes had already fixed on her, then shifted pointedly to Taylor Ford with a warning: "He's a minor. Don't say anything reckless."

"When I was his age—"

"You were studying."

Jonah, who had been quietly keeping to himself, couldn't hold it in any longer—a laugh escaped through his nose; he cleared his throat and steered the conversation back on track: "Anyway, what were the results from going into the Nest?"

"Oh right," Taylor Ford touched his nose and said, "I found the key."

The office fell into a moment of sudden silence.

"...What?" Remy stared at him.

Taylor Ford grinned at the group: "Just kidding."

"Director!" Jonah let out a breath in protest. "Something like this—"

"It's not entirely a lie either," Taylor Ford waved a hand and said. "Based on the intelligence we gathered from our investigation, I found the place where the Bronx Brothers used to stay when they went into the Nest. Starting from there, I asked around about their movements..."

Jane Lynch's face was growing paler by the moment. "Asked around? Asked who?"

Who else could it be.

"Residents," Taylor Ford answered.

The word "Residents" seemed to carry a strange closing force, drawing the expressions of everyone present imperceptibly tighter, making them sit up just a little straighter.

Taylor Ford understood perfectly well—it was an intangible fear rooted deep in the bone.

He himself was not immune.

Like other Hunters, in his dealings with Residents, even when there was no physical threat, he would often feel something fundamental to his existence as a person being slowly eroded and contaminated... as if he were sinking into a warped, suffocating submersion he couldn't pull himself out of.

But what set him apart from the average Hunter—if there was indeed a difference—was that Taylor Ford had discovered from a very young age that he seemed able to actively "tune his frequency."

To put it simply, it meant shifting his own "wavelength" closer to that of a Resident—this wasn't actually difficult to do, because every Resident he had ever encountered had a part of them that was "human."

Though that was often the most terrifying part.

"I've long heard that you're extraordinarily skilled at drawing out information from the Nest that ordinary Hunters can't..." Jonah murmured, "I'd really love to go into the Nest with you sometime."

"That's embarrassing," Taylor Ford said, unmoved, "but you probably won't get that chance anytime soon."

"Why not?" Remy asked.

"As it turned out, the Bronx Brothers' movements were very easy to ask about."

Taylor Ford paused to think, then said, "How easy? It was almost like the Nest had been waiting for someone to come and ask—it barely took any effort at all."

...Taylor Ford rarely encountered Residents so eager and cooperative; one had even drawn him a map, apparently worried he wouldn't be able to find the right place.

"It's a hotel on this street called the 'Legend Hotel.' 'Le-gend Ho-tel'—make sure you don't go to the wrong one."

The Resident extended one long finger and pressed it against the map, as if afraid Taylor Ford couldn't read, spelling out every character.

Beneath the translucent skin of its finger, countless tiny, contorted human faces churned and roiled; as they shifted, they pressed outward against the skin in rising and falling contours, so that at first glance, the Resident appeared to be covered from head to toe in sliding tumors.

The Resident spoke with almost painstaking earnestness: "Once you go in, you'll see a front desk. Ask it whether the Bronx who stayed here last time is still around. If the front desk says they've checked out, then ask whatever you need to ask; if it says they're still staying, step back and stop talking for a while—wait about half an hour, then go back and ask again."

When he was leaving, the Resident's apology was entirely sincere: "I really should take you there myself, but the thing is—I'm worried that if we spend too much time together, I won't be able to stop myself from laying eggs in your face."

...How terribly considerate.

It was precisely because the Resident had been so thorough that when Taylor Ford followed the directions and arrived at the Legend Hotel, he had originally assumed it was a trap—after all, who would fully trust a Resident's word?

"Those two Mr. Bronks? They've already checked out."

The front desk was a young man whose upper body was completely indistinguishable from a normal human's, with an ordinary face. As for the lower half of his body, Taylor Ford had no idea—because from the waist down, it was simply a hotel counter, as if the figure had grown out of the countertop as a bust.

"What do you want with them?" the front desk said, sounding rather displeased. "Are you hoping to stay in their room?"

Taylor Ford knew very little about the Legend Hotel and wasn't sure whether he should say he wanted to "stay," let alone what the consequences might be. While he was still thinking it over, the front desk added another sentence: "Do you know those two? They took one of our keys with them—we're still looking to hold someone responsible."

Taylor Ford's reaction at that moment was exactly the same as the three people in the office now—they jolted, and asked: "What key?"

Remy hesitated, then added, "A hotel room key?"

"No, the Legend Hotel doesn't have room keys. Once you've checked in, the room doors can't be locked."

Taylor Ford shifted his posture and said lazily, "It was information I heard for the first time from the front desk. It said the key they lost is the one used to lock the hotel's main door. And it's not just the Legend Hotel—many places in the Nest have a key like that for their main entrance."

"In that respect, it's just like the normal world—doesn't our office building have a key for its main door? Any building of some importance does. The only function of a key in the Nest is to lock and unlock... I asked specifically."

"Generally speaking, the main doors of buildings in the Nest are rarely opened and closed, and the keys are hidden away somewhere, in someone's hands—no one quite knows where. Even if you found one, apart from locking or unlocking that one door, it has no other function whatsoever."

"I think that's partly why Hunters have never paid attention to them—they have no reason to appear on a Hunter's radar, and no value worth a Hunter's pursuit."

"Wait, truly?" Jonah blanked for a moment. "Then that also means—"

"Right. The 'key' really is just a key, not even a one-of-a-kind Artifact. By that logic, once brought back to the human world, it wouldn't even function as a key for locking and unlocking anymore. I can't come up with any reason at all to commission a Hunter to bring a key back."

In a sense, it was no different from going into the Nest to dig up a floor tile and bring it back—what would you even do with it?

Taylor Ford tilted his head back, staring at the ceiling, and after a moment's thought said: "That makes it even stranger... How did Wellesley know that Nest buildings all have a master key? What does he want it for? If there's more than one of these keys and they have no special value, why did he have the Bronx Brothers killed?"

There was only one way he could think of to answer those questions.

"The matter of Wellesley's commission to find the 'time' Artifact—I'll leave that to the two of you," Taylor Ford said. "Jonah, Remy, each of you pick a team and take turns entering the Nest on the 13th of every month. I won't be going in with you, because I need to go get a key and find out exactly what it's all about."

Today's update is late because the plot started getting stuck on me... I know exactly what the next goal is and where it is, but I just can't get there.

I've been stuck so long my head is going bald—I honestly have no idea why I'm putting myself through this...

But look at that—doesn't this prove your wishes came true?

Friends who saw me say I was stuck yesterday—congratulations, you've unlocked superpowers!

The moment the thought "this author seems like she's about to take a day off" flickered through my head, bam, I took a day off.

What kind of power is this?! Everyone's jealous!

Here's what actually happened: deep down, I didn't want to take a day off—but your collective mental energy was so vast and overwhelming that it swayed the forces of fate, and somehow, I don't even know how, I ended up opening the author dashboard...

The more I think about it, the more I'm sure: your power was just too great, your pressure too crushing (do they still say that in the male-readership genre these days?), and it caused your wishes to come true. Truly astonishing. Limitless potential.

(I hear that flattery reduces the number of beatings you take by 35%.)

On a serious note: it's true that I really shouldn't be taking days off this early after launch, but I wrote today's chapter feeling completely at a loss—none of the flavor I had before. I dragged out 1,600 characters and found every single one of them dull.

No joke—the first line of this chapter was "the following section is very boring." For real.

Posting it would be more or less like advertising for the competition. Ha. I'd rather die.

I'll probably end up deleting it tomorrow anyway.

Why? I don't know either. Maybe it's because I'm trapped in Taylor Ford's perspective and can't get out? I've only gotten fifty chapters into the ensemble experience, so why am I already defaulting back to a single-protagonist setup? (not really)

Come to think of it, ensemble really does suit me—now that I think about it again, writing one protagonist from start to finish versus sitting in a cell, what's the difference, right? It's like... hang on, let me rephrase: when I get together with friends and family to talk poetry, I can't just talk about one poet the whole time.

(The leave-of-absence note got flagged by Qidian—no idea which word set off its sensors.)

Even though there's no update today, there is a surprise—truly, and I'm not talking about this leave note, because you've all already seen this one, so how could it be a surprise, right?

Dearest readers, please open this leave note and unfold it.

Oh? What's that tucked inside?

Open it up and take a look.

Why, it's another leave note!

Life's little surprises—one hundred percent delightful!

June 22nd? Or was it the 21st—I'm going to a music festival! (Originally wrote "attending the music festival," which made it sound like I was going onstage to perform.) Both singers I love are going—I'm so excited, it'll be my first time seeing them live!

The only downside is how far it is: three and a half hours by train... For one music festival, I'm going to have to stay for two whole days.

As for the exact date, it's fine—I'll check my tickets closer to the 19th. Life is short, eighteen years old, still plenty of time.

We'll leave the date on the note blank for now—fill it in whenever you like (said with affection). This is what a blank check from a billionaire CEO feels like.

One thing I can promise around here is that you'll always get your money's worth in volume.

Buy-one-get-one leave notes—already pretty generous, right? But wait, there's more: the long-overdue thank-you chapter is available for pickup today. Just 998, take it home today.

The thank-you chapter is in a new format—kind of like a pyramid scheme, but—wait, let me rephrase: readers featured in today's thank-you chapter, feel free to leave a comment telling me whether you'd prefer a bonus chapter or a cameo appearance. After all, bonus chapters are a big undertaking—at the moment the only place they exist is on my lips. Here, mwah.

I've always tried my best to read through the comments, but I might still miss some, so it's better to just tell me directly in the thank-you chapter (◡

Let me think if there's anything else I forgot to mention... Doesn't seem like it. Everything else is in the wine—and the wine is in the store.

Chapter 62: Taylor Ford — Amber Alert?

"Oh dear, it's already gone."

.....Taylor Ford hadn't seen many truly elderly people, but he thought that no matter how old a human face got, it couldn't possibly look like the one in front of him.

He didn't quite dare to look directly at that ancient face; he always had the feeling that his gaze would sink into the wrinkles and get trapped there, unable to pull free, and eventually be crushed into fragments.

If he stared a few seconds longer, even his eyeballs would probably start filling with a dense web of bloodshot veins to match those wrinkles.

"That's right — I'm the one who has always kept that gate key. But since last week, I just can't find it anymore..."

Last week — the same time the Bronx Brothers had taken the key and made their way back to Blackmoor City.

"Ah, when you get old, your memory just isn't what it used to be. Can you promise Grandpa one thing? If you find the key, bring it to me..."

As the Resident spoke, it raised one hand, scooped up the sagging skin of its cheek, and peeled it back a little, revealing the half-mouth that had been hidden beneath.

Deep vertical cracks, one after another, fanned out like rays pointing toward half a black void; from within that void came a voice that seemed to echo from somewhere very far away: "Bring it to me, and put it inside my mouth-hole. Hmm? You're asking what I need it for? I have to replace the key that was lost. Once someone else's key goes missing, it's no longer my responsibility — as long as I can lock the door again, that's all that matters. Find it and bring it to me; you won't regret it, I promise you..."

Could it be that gate keys from different locations were actually interchangeable with one another?

If Taylor Ford could find a key and try it on a different gate, he'd probably get his answer — but that line of thinking was going nowhere.

Because he hadn't found a single key.

Getting entangled by Residents or falling into the Nest's traps were things Taylor Ford was mentally prepared for; what he hadn't anticipated was that starting in May, every single time he entered the Nest, the result was always the same — empty hands, nothing to show for it.

The hotel front desk hadn't lied; keys did seem to be genuinely common things, present in nearly every location.

The problem was that every single place he tracked down, the key had vanished for one reason or another — there was even one caretaker who, by all accounts, had just been sealed inside a concrete room together with the key. No matter where he looked for a key, there simply wasn't one.

It was almost as if the moment the Bronx Brothers found a key and rushed it back to Blackmoor City, the Nest had suddenly woken up, shut the stable door after the horse had bolted, and buried all the remaining keys deep out of reach.

But... how could that be?

The Nest was just a name for this particular space — it had no unified will, let alone any self-awareness.

Whatever was deliberately making the keys disappear from the Nest could only be a portion of the Residents who possessed consciousness and intelligence.

But leaving aside whether they even had the ability to coordinate with one another — why would they do this?

Was the motive driving them to hide the keys the same reason Wellesley wanted the keys?

Taylor Ford had no answers for now.

Entering the Nest at such a high frequency had made his grip on the human world grow ever thinner and more colorless, as if he'd been soaked soft and diluted — like a scrap of paper reduced to nothing but pulp fibers; by September, Jane Lynch had taken the initiative to ask him to rest for at least two or three weeks within Blackmoor City and to stop entering the Nest for the time being.

"Just now, it took you about ten seconds to recognize who I was."

After closing the office door behind her, Jane Lynch lowered her voice and warned him: "I've worked in HR for quite a few years. I know this is a sign of Nest Dissociation Syndrome — it

means your sense of reality is being eroded. The younger a person is, the shallower their roots in the human world, and the more susceptible they are to this kind of influence.

"Once this symptom appears, House Faction rules say you can't enter the Nest anymore — and that applies even if you're the Director. Besides, summer break ended long ago. Shouldn't you at least be going to school?"

Taylor Ford stared blankly for a moment, then slowly pulled "school" out of the haze of pale blankness in his mind, thought about it a little longer, and finally arrived at its meaning — not the schools he'd seen inside the Nest; the one in the human world, the place where you attended classes and talked to classmates.

Although he'd always tried hard to conduct himself like an adult, he still had the nature of a teenager: once he'd set his sights on a goal, it was very hard for him to sit still.

He hadn't expected that a momentary lapse in attention, a few too many trips to the Nest, would leave his mind carrying so much accumulated strain.

"So this is what 'Nest Dissociation Syndrome' is?"

Taylor Ford murmured: "Ever since my first time in the Nest, I've felt it on and off... sometimes worse, sometimes not so bad."

"Right — did Mr. Ford never tell you? Or did he not know either? The reason I cap House Faction Hunters at a maximum of fourteen days in the Nest per month, with anything beyond that not counting toward performance, is precisely because of this." Jane Lynch glanced at him and said: "The memos and emails I sent you — you never read any of them, did you? All of that came from lessons Morgan House Faction learned the hard way."

"...Because they're really boring." Taylor Ford said, perfectly honestly.

A House Faction like Morgan House Faction — with its meticulously developed regulatory systems and operational model that closely resembled a large corporation — had a remarkable talent for taking the most thrilling thing in the world and turning it into the most sleep-inducing employee handbook imaginable.

"That won't do," Jane Lynch pressed the point seriously, "we'll need to call a meeting this afternoon to emphasize it — where do you think you're slinking off to? Get up. You have to come to the meeting too."

She paused, then said: "Besides, you really should start dealing with the time Artifact that Remy's team brought back."

...A time Artifact?

It was something Taylor Ford himself had arranged, yet he still had to think for a few seconds before it clicked — this Artifact was not that Artifact.

When Taylor Ford had drawn up his operational plan, he had split Remy's team and Jonah's team into two alternating waves.

One team would enter the Nest on the first of each month; the other would enter on the thirteenth, rotating in order month by month.

The team going in on the first of each month had no territorial restrictions — they were to search the entire Nest for any Artifact that could make someone think of "time." It didn't need to have any time-related function; it didn't even need to be particularly valuable. As long as it could evoke the idea of time, they were to bring it back.

The team going in on the thirteenth, on the other hand, was to follow Wellesley's instructions and search for time-related Artifacts within the specific fixed areas he had provided.

Remy had extraordinary luck this time around; she led her team into the Nest on September first, and by September third they were already back — and not only that, they'd brought back an Artifact that no one could claim was unrelated to "time": an alarm clock.

Taylor Ford gave a quiet smile.

"That alarm clock? No rush," he said, sprawled lazily in his office chair. "I'll wait another two weeks and deliver the alarm clock to Wellesley myself."

Jane Lynch glanced at him and nodded.

She didn't look confused or surprised — which meant she had already worked out that what the first-of-the-month team found was what Taylor Ford truly intended to hand over to Wellesley: merely a placeholder substitute.

What Wellesley actually wanted was what the thirteenth-of-the-month team would find — and never mind the fact that it hadn't been found yet; even if it were, Taylor Ford would need to take a good hard look at it first, and had no intention of handing it over anytime soon.

"Wellesley will certainly realize the alarm clock isn't what he's looking for." Jane Lynch thought it over and said: "When that happens..."

Exactly — what Taylor Ford wanted was precisely Wellesley's reaction upon seeing the alarm clock.

That was also why he was delivering the alarm clock in person: Wellesley clearly knew far more than he'd let on; and when faced with a mismatched Artifact, would he offer any new information in order to help Morgan House Faction find what he truly wanted more quickly?

Even if he said nothing at all, that in itself would be information.

Taylor Ford needed to see it with his own eyes.

This time, the handoff of the alarm clock Artifact would not take place on Wellesley's cruise ship; the location Wellesley had chosen for tonight was a place where he had done business with Morgan House Faction before — the top floor of the Wellesley Headquarters Tower, an entire level of space that served as Wellesley's private office and reception area.

"...You only just brought this back from the Nest?"

The one who took the alarm clock was not Wellesley, but his secretary — a man named Green.

Green had a fair, refined face and a slender, tall build; he appeared to be no older than thirty, and in his occasional gestures there was a faint, feminine quality — for instance, when he sat on the sofa, leaned forward, and reached out to take the alarm clock from the table, his knees were pressed tightly together.

Perhaps because Wellesley came from the conservative south, there had once been rumors circulating that he deeply despised sexual minorities — but now, looking at his secretary Green, that rumor was most likely nothing more than a rumor.

"Was it retrieved from our designated area?" Green studied the alarm clock for a moment, then looked up and asked.

"Of course," Taylor Ford said with complete sincerity. "After entering the Nest on September thirteenth, we found it in a residential building on Broom Street. The traps in that building were extremely dangerous — our people barely made it out. Is Mr. Wellesley available? Would he like to come take a look in person?"

Green kept his eyes on the alarm clock and said without looking up: "That won't be necessary. Mr. Wellesley has other matters to attend to and can't get away. If the item is correct, I'll bring the alarm clock to his office."

Taylor Ford made a small sound of acknowledgment and glanced at the two bodyguards standing behind Green's sofa.

...In other words, Green knew how to conduct a preliminary verification of Artifacts?

Wellesley was right here on this floor, yet he wouldn't come out?

That was a little strange.

Even stranger was the fact that Wellesley was clearly on his own turf, yet from the lower floors all the way up, the building was layered with bodyguards and security personnel at every turn — as if Wellesley were afraid of something. Surely it couldn't be Taylor Ford he was afraid of?

"It does seem like Mr. Wellesley hasn't been appearing in public much lately," Taylor Ford ventured, probing.

"Have you been keeping tabs on Mr. Wellesley's whereabouts?" Green raised his eyes and asked, his tone flat and cold.

"I just wanted to get a bit more familiar with Mr. Wellesley," Taylor Ford smiled at him, as if completely oblivious to the edge in the question. "Not getting to see him today — quite disappointing, really."

Green paid him no mind; he simply pressed the button on the back of the alarm clock. He seemed to be waiting for something — waited a few seconds, and when nothing came, he gave the clock a gentle twist. Naturally, it didn't open.

"...Not right." Green set the alarm clock down and said: "This isn't what we're looking for."

"How is it not right?"

"This isn't what we're looking for." Green repeated it again, fixing his gaze on Taylor Ford. "Is this how Morgan House Faction operates? The commission has been with you for half a year, the instructions were given in considerable detail — whether or not it's what we want, I'd think you'd know better than I do."

"I don't know. You only said it was related to 'time.'" Taylor Ford spread his hands and said: "Are you telling me an alarm clock has nothing to do with time?"

"It does," Green conceded, "but this isn't it."

"How do you know it isn't?" Taylor Ford was growing quietly anxious. "Do you have more specific information? If you tell me, it'll be easier for us to search going forward."

He was hoping to extract more information from Green, but Green turned out to be like a broken record — beyond that same single response, he refused to utter a single word of value: "This isn't what we're looking for. Please continue searching."

Taylor Ford felt he had never met anyone so single-mindedly stubborn — Green was clearly able to conduct a preliminary verification of the Artifact, which meant he definitely knew something; yet his vocabulary seemed to have been stripped down to a single sentence, and no matter how Taylor Ford tried to probe from different angles, Green answered him again and again with the exact same line.

In the end, the only intelligence he came away with was those few gestures Green had made while verifying the alarm clock.

...Wellesley must also be on guard against House Factions using him to fish for information in reverse.

Well, sparse as it was, a few movements still counted as intelligence.

At the very least, from Green's actions, Taylor could infer two things: first, the "time" Artifact seemed capable of changing its form—which was why, when Green first spotted the alarm clock, he hadn't been certain it was what he was looking for.

Second, secretary Green had very likely once been a Hunter.

"All right," Taylor saw no need to hide his disappointment, letting the emotion show plainly on his face. "Since you're not planning to purchase this alarm clock, I'll take it back with me."

The moment he reached out for the alarm clock, Green happened to push it toward him at the same time.

Their fingers brushed lightly against the alarm clock Artifact in an unexpected touch.

Green withdrew his hand; before Taylor could pick up the alarm clock, a sharp, vibrating, familiar buzzing suddenly erupted from inside his trouser pocket.

"Oh, an Amber Alert," he recovered after only a brief pause, reaching into his trouser pocket for his phone.

Whenever a child abduction occurred, the law enforcement system would send emergency alerts to the public through various channels, including mobile phones; generally, an Amber Alert would list the missing child's information and the suspect's information, turning the general public into the first line of search.

...Wait.

Something wasn't right.

The moment Taylor's fingertips touched his phone, he realized what was off.

This was supposed to be an emergency alert broadcast to the general public—yet at this very moment, the only phone in the room emitting that sharp buzzing was the one on him.

What was going on?

The bodyguards in the room, Jane Lynch beside him, and secretary Green—they all certainly had phones on them, so why weren't their phones going off?

He had rested in Blackmoor City for two or three weeks and his mental state had recovered considerably; there was no way Nest Dissociation Syndrome was making him hear things wrong.

"...Mr. Ford—oh, no. Taylor."

Taylor had only just gripped his phone when he looked up and found that secretary Green had, at some unknown moment, risen from the sofa and taken a step toward him.

Those eyes were fixed on Taylor without a single blink.

"I need to borrow your phone for a moment."

As though a string had been pulled taut, the bodyguards moved in unison, stepping a few paces toward Taylor.

Jane Lynch seemed to sense the sudden shift in atmosphere as well; she rose silently and stood beside Taylor, every muscle in her body tensed.

Green's tone remained perfectly gentle.

"Take out your phone and hand it to me, would you? I'd like you not to look at the screen at all—and absolutely no screenshots. I'll only take a quick look. I'll return it to you right away

afterward... That shouldn't be a problem, should it?"

As for yesterday's thank-you chapter—since the editor is on holiday for Dragon Boat Festival, I'll have to wait until she's back at work before she can reset it to be free of charge...

When I went to her in a panic yesterday, the editor was very experienced and immediately told me to go change the title. What does that tell you? I'm definitely not the first author on this platform to have done something like this...

Also, I set this chapter as a paid chapter of over three thousand characters, and after replacing the content, the charge on the platform won't change, so don't worry—it won't cost you any more whether you came early or late!

Even though I go by the name of a shameless money-grubber, charging for a thank-you chapter really is a bit too much, even for me...

Chapter 63: Taylor Ford, a perfectly ordinary retired Hunter

...No matter how he thought about it, the situation was against him right now.

A large part of it was that tonight's Wellesley was unusually cautious.

Entering the Wellesley Headquarters Tower, Taylor Ford's group had passed through at least three metal detectors—forget a handgun, even a slightly oversized metal hairpin in Jane Lynch's hair had to be removed and examined.

In all of Blackmoor City, Wellesley was probably the only person with the standing and authority to openly check whether his counterparts in a deal were carrying weapons.

But the metal detectors were only the beginning.

As they were led toward the elevator bay, the bodyguard guiding them specifically asked Taylor Ford to hand over the alarm clock Artifact, then had Taylor Ford's group walk across the footbridge over the lobby's koi pond first—beneath the bridge, the water shimmered like jade gauze, and several long, plump shadows in gold, red, white, and yellow drifted slowly past, pulling long, lazy ripples through the gauze.

When that bodyguard carried the alarm clock Artifact across the bridge in turn, Jane Lynch, waiting on the other side to receive the Artifact back, couldn't help but suck in a sharp breath.

"You're actually keeping things from the Nest in here?" Taylor Ford stared fixedly at the koi pond and asked in a low voice.

The bodyguard had no time to answer him just then.

He was gripping the alarm clock tightly, taking small, careful steps along the center of the bridge, every ounce of his attention fixed on the path beneath his feet, not daring to stray even a hair's breadth from the middle.

The water on both sides of the bridge broke apart, and a dense mass of fish mouths rose to the surface.

The pond, which had seemed to hold only five or six koi a moment ago, was now covered wall to wall with fist-wide mouths pressed tightly together. Even the surface of the water had been crowded out of sight—there was nothing but one hollow after another puckering up toward the bodyguard, like openings trying to draw him in. Looking at it, you couldn't tell whether those were

scales, or mouths, or whether some thing composed of countless scales and countless mouths was trying to suck at the edges of the bodyguard's shoes and pull him—along with the Artifact in his hand—down into it.

Countless fish mouths rose and fell, opened and closed at every height, making your scalp crawl at a single glance; by the time the bodyguard finally stepped off the bridge and returned the alarm clock to Jane Lynch, a thin sheen of sweat had risen on his forehead.

The moment he left the bridge, the mass of mouths splashed back down into the water all at once. The koi pond rippled, rings of foam spreading across the surface, and the water held nothing but the same few smooth, rolling fish shadows as before.

"My apologies," the bodyguard said. "We do need to ensure that no one brings an Artifact into Mr. Wellesley's room. After all, an Artifact is far more dangerous than a weapon—we hope you understand."

"This building has people coming and going for work every day, doesn't it?" Taylor Ford asked. "Quite a few people cross the koi pond?"

"As long as no one is carrying an Artifact, it doesn't matter even if someone falls in."

The bodyguard's smile had not yet fully settled—it sat only on the surface of his face. "So asking you to hand over the alarm clock before crossing the bridge was also for your own safety."

That last line was, naturally, a pleasantry that no one would believe.

What was Wellesley so afraid of?

When Taylor Ford had met him back in May, he hadn't been this jumpy, this ready to see danger in every shadow.

Now Wellesley's caution had nearly crossed into paranoia—he even refused to meet in person for the deal. And yet the same rules he imposed on others clearly weren't ones he applied to himself.

The two bodyguards standing across from Taylor Ford both had a hand resting at their waists; through the slightly open fronts of their suit jackets, the faint outline of holsters was visible.

They were not the only firepower in the room. The reception room had two exits—one that Taylor Ford's group had entered through, and another whose door was shut, leading somewhere

unknown, though it was easy enough to imagine that any number of people could come pouring through it at any moment.

"What's wrong with my phone?"

Taylor Ford kept both eyes fixed on Secretary Green as he slowly drew his phone out with one hand—without handing it over.

His phone hung at his side; the Amber Alert had just finished its final chime—if that had truly been an Amber Alert.

"As a business partner, I'm not unwilling to let you look at my phone. But you'd at least have to give me a reason—let me know you mean no harm—otherwise this is a bit much of a slight to Morgan House Faction, wouldn't you say?"

Green shook his head, the way a teacher might face a student who refused to see reason.

"Taylor Ford, I've long heard your name. A Hunter of your caliber—why use that line on me? You know perfectly well: if I could tell you the real reason, I wouldn't have stopped you from looking at your phone screen. You want to pressure me into lying, because a lie is also information, isn't that right?"

Taylor Ford paused. "...Is Green your surname? What's your first name? I don't think I've ever heard of you before."

"George Green. I'm an utterly ordinary retired Hunter—no particular strengths, no distinguished history. It's entirely natural that you've never heard of me."

As Green spoke, he raised one hand. "Come on, hand over the phone—face-down, remember."

...Was there really no way to see the contents of that "Amber Alert" before handing it over?

Taylor Ford had always prided himself on being sharp and quick-witted, but stripped of weapons, with no advance preparation and facing hostile firepower, every idea felt like a bad one.

Even if he was the Hunter Director of the mighty Morgan House Faction, he couldn't afford to gamble—if he and Jane Lynch died here tonight, would Carter Morgan avenge them?

Carter Morgan would make a phone call, express regret, say that this Hunter Director was too young and too reckless, and hope it wouldn't affect future opportunities for cooperation.

If Green truly killed him, as long as Wellesley gave his approval, Green would face virtually no consequences afterward.

That much, Taylor Ford understood clearly—and so did Green himself.

If only Green wore glasses, Taylor Ford thought, nearly in despair—he could at least catch a glimpse of the reflection in the lenses—though in the softly lit reception room, that was probably wishful thinking too.

He let out a quiet sigh.

"All right, I understand."

As he handed over the phone face-down to Green, the two bodyguards across the room had already drawn their guns from their holsters and were holding them loosely at their sides. "I'm very curious, but I really can't think of a way around it."

"Good boy." Green smiled gently, took the phone, and the glow of the screen lit up his strikingly feminine face.

His eyes shifted slightly toward the bottom of the screen—where notifications appear—and he studied it without moving for a moment.

If this were a movie or a science fiction novel, Taylor Ford thought, I could read the text from the reflection in his pupils. What a pity that no one could do that in real life.

Green did not ask him for his passcode; he simply swiped and tapped with his finger to clear the notification.

He was an exceptionally meticulous and careful man.

After clearing the notification, he still located the buttons on both sides of the phone and gave a light press—the phone emitted a clear "click" as it took a screenshot.

The screenshot was to listen for whether Taylor Ford's phone had been silenced—whether he had taken a silent screenshot when he first pulled the phone from his pocket.

But that was not enough: he also tried pressing the action button on the left side of the phone.

This was to confirm that Taylor Ford hadn't set the action button to function as a "silent switch"—after all, Taylor Ford could have silently taken a screenshot first, then un-silenced the phone afterward.

Taylor Ford's phone apparently used only the most basic functions and had not assigned multiple shortcuts to any single button; Green turned it this way and that, testing it twice over, and appeared satisfied.

"That should be fine."

Green smiled as he said this, then seemed to recall something and turned it over privately in his mind for a moment before handing the phone back. "Thank you for cooperating—I'm genuinely grateful. The Morgan House Faction's Director truly knows how to see the bigger picture."

Keeping a straight face at a moment like this was, for a seventeen-year-old, genuinely difficult—and Taylor Ford had no desire to put on the composed mask of an adult. Why should he? He was itching to grab a megaphone, shove it in Green's face, and shout "you're insufferable."

He took the phone back with lowered brows and a thoroughly displeased expression, signaled Jane Lynch to pick up the alarm clock, and let his gaze sweep across Green's face.

"...You received an 'Amber Alert' too, didn't you?" Taylor Ford asked out of nowhere.

Green's eyelids flicked up at him, then dropped again quickly, lashes veiling his pupils.

The words had come out on instinct, but thinking back, he found that many small details had quietly confirmed the fact from the sidelines.

The moment he realized only Taylor Ford's phone had sounded an alert in the room, Green had reacted too quickly—even before Taylor Ford had pulled the phone from his pocket, Green had already signaled the bodyguards to close in.

Taylor Ford had also kept his eyes fixed on Green the entire time he was looking at the notification. Faced with an "Amber Alert" that couldn't possibly be an Amber Alert, Green's expression had remained perfectly composed—he hadn't even taken the time to read it a second time before clearing it, as though he had already known what he would find.

"Most things in this world have nothing to do with me. Why would I go poking my nose into other people's business and come away smelling like trouble?" Green said with a smile. "If I don't know what's happening in other people's lives, can't my own life carry on just as well?"

He personally escorted Taylor Ford's group down the elevator, across the koi pond, and watched them into the car.

Before closing the door for Taylor Ford, he gave a small wave, the gesture light as a young woman's. "I look forward to working together in the future."

The car door closed with a "thud," and the engine hummed low and steady, laying out the road home beneath their feet.

Taylor Ford held his phone—now stripped of any clues—and waited until the Wellesley Headquarters Tower was completely out of sight before speaking, his face set and somber.

He was rarely outmaneuvered like this—especially not in a way that had nothing to do with his own ability or intelligence, but was purely a matter of missing critical information and being kept in the dark at every turn, falling one step behind as a result. That, if anything, made it all the more suffocating.

"Jane Lynch, tomorrow morning, let Remy and Jonah know: starting this month, each of them is to lead a team into the Nest twice."

"Understood. Why?"

"Have them do everything they can to keep searching for a substitute similar to the alarm clock—something time-related."

Even though the notification was gone and couldn't be recovered, he stared at the notification center on his phone and said: "Besides the team entering the Nest on the 13th to continue searching for what Wellesley wants, the other three missions should all be focused on finding a substitute. Bring extra people if needed—do whatever it takes. For the next few months, this is the top priority; all other tasks take a back seat for now."

"Taylor..." Jane Lynch leaned forward from the back seat, and the seatbelt gave a sharp rasp. "What have you figured out?"

Taylor Ford put away his phone and looked at his fingertips, slowly rubbing them together.

"I have a theory I need to verify," he said quietly. "To verify it, I'd have to repeat tonight's transaction process one more time...which means we'd need to bring Green another Artifact."

The thank-you chapter I accidentally set as paid last time has been moved by the editor into the afterword volume—readers who tipped can flip to the very beginning (it's free now), and if you leave me a comment there, I can still see it!

Because I've been saving it up for so long, I've surely left some people out, and those of you who've been voting monthly tickets for me couldn't all fit in, so I wasn't able to list everyone...but my grateful, humbled thanks are sincere.

Same as always: with a niche taste like mine, gaining even one more kindred reader is no small thing. Not everyone is family—and there aren't that many kindred spirits in the world, are there? Which makes every single one of you all the more precious.

PS: I've changed the way Green originally checks the phone, because on older iOS versions you could see the photo library cover without unlocking (I tested it on my own phone and it worked), but it seems like after updating that's no longer possible?

Given that the story is set in 2026, I've updated the verification method to be based on the iPhone 15 running iOS 17.5.1. Taylor Ford hasn't changed her phone in two years (. As for what system updates might appear by 2026, I honestly have no idea.....

Chapter 64: The One Thing Taylor Ford Wants Most

The second filler item came on November 7th.

This filler item was again brought back by Remy, though compared to the alarm clock from last time, its connection to time was somewhat vague: it was a stiff paper train ticket.

The ticket listed its departure station as "Nest Central Station" and its destination as "Blackmoor City Central Station," with a date of November 16th, 2026—nine days away.

Normally, an Artifact itself, or the area near where it was found, would come with a description of its function, but this ticket had only a few short lines of text that, even after reading, left no one any clearer on what it was actually for:

TICKET

Please note: non-human entities are not permitted to board.

Please note: humans who have remained in the Nest for more than seven days, please accept your dissolution and death with resignation—even if a portion of you remains, please do not attempt to board.

Please note: this ticket is an anonymous, one-way, single-use ticket permitting one person to ride once.

Was it a ticket that could bring someone from the Nest back to Blackmoor City without needing a passage?

Being able to send someone back to Blackmoor City without following the rule of "returning via passage" seemed meaningful only in a very narrow set of circumstances—for instance, if a Hunter's passage was severed by some accident; after all, anything was possible inside the Nest.

If it had been a round-trip ticket—one that could take you from Blackmoor City into the Nest and back—Taylor Ford did know of someone who would be so excited he'd snap his own leash.

All in all, calling this ticket time-related was a stretch, but saying it had nothing to do with time at all wasn't quite right either.

In the end, two reasons pushed Taylor Ford to commit to using it as a substitute: first, the ticket was small enough to fit in the palm of a hand; second, it could change form.

Though the change in form was extremely subtle and entirely meaningless: it turned light blue in a man's hand, and light pink in a woman's.

"What color would it turn for someone who's gender-fluid?" Remy had said at the time, chewing gum. "This Artifact has pretty conservative ideas about gender—still doing the blue-for-boys, pink-for-girls thing in this day and age."

Whatever the case, the ability to change form was enough.

After the last "transaction," if Taylor Ford still pretended not to know that the target Artifact could change form, that would be far too obvious—Green would see through his ulterior motives in an instant.

Besides, the point wasn't to complete Wellesley's commission anyway, but to verify his own suspicions.

Having barely managed to drag himself through the 13th, Taylor Ford was unwilling to wait much longer, and quickly got in touch with Green; over the phone, Green seemed genuinely surprised that he'd found another Artifact so soon, but agreed to meet again—this time, the agreed-upon meeting place was once more the top floor of the Wellesley Tower.

If anything had changed, the security was noticeably tighter than before—three guards at every turn, five at every post; not only did Taylor Ford and his group have to pass through layer after layer of checkpoints, but even a janitor in the lobby was stopped, his person and cart searched inside and out by security personnel before he was allowed upstairs.

The one who came to receive Taylor Ford was the same bodyguard captain as last time.

"Someone who didn't know better would think this place was some kind of military installation,"

Taylor Ford stood at one end of the bridge, and deliberately chose the moment he was walking across it with the ticket—above the koi pond—to strike up a conversation: "You have so many people coming in to work every day. Do you check every single one of them?"

It seemed that no matter how many times he crossed it, the bodyguard couldn't get used to the dense mass of fish mouths rising high out of the water on both sides of the bridge, endlessly puckering at him.

He descended the bridge with a faint sheen of sweat on his forehead again, returned the ticket, and only then said: "Haven't you heard? This building has been cleared out. All the

departments that used to work here have been temporarily relocated to another building."

It seemed that calling Wellesley neurotic last time hadn't been quite fair—clearing every single person out of an entire building, now that was neurotic.

"No matter how safe it is here, he can't stay in this building forever," Taylor Ford said idly.

The bodyguard shook his head.

"That's not information I should be telling you... but wherever Mr. Wellesley goes these days, the security level is the same—if anything, even higher. As for where he might go, I'm afraid I can't say."

Last time, Green had at least let slip that Mr. Wellesley couldn't get away; this time, Taylor Ford didn't even know whether he was in the building at all.

"I really didn't expect us to meet again so soon."

As Taylor Ford and his group walked into the reception room, Green rose to his feet with a smile: "Since last time it's only been... hmm, today is November 15th, so less than two months since we last met. Did your group really find an Artifact in just two or three days this time?"

He said "an Artifact," not "the Artifact we're looking for," and Taylor Ford felt a faint tightening in his chest.

This guy was sharp and slippery—like a block of butter that had gained sentience. Surely he hadn't gotten suspicious?

"We got lucky this time," he said, and simply let out a sigh to go along with it. "But precisely because finding it went too smoothly, honestly, I'm not sure it's the one you're looking for. That said, since it's an Artifact discovered in the designated area, I have an obligation to bring it for your review, don't I?"

With Taylor Ford laying it out plainly like that, Green found it hard to object, and could only nod: "Morgan House Faction really does have professional integrity."

The group had just made it to the center of the room, near a low table, and hadn't yet sat down, when Green pulled a phone from his trouser pocket and set it on the coffee table first.

"There was an unfortunate incident last time—quite embarrassing, really," Green said with a smile. "To avoid any unpleasantness this time, let's all set our phones aside... no, no need to turn them off—what if something urgent comes up?"

Taylor Ford and Jane Lynch exchanged a glance but did not protest, and one after the other took out their phones, placing them face-down on the table, just as Green had done.

Green leaned down and pushed the three phones slightly apart, as if to clear space for the Artifact—even though the coffee table was otherwise empty.

"No need to bother," Taylor Ford said, remaining on his feet and pulling the ticket from his trouser pocket, holding it up in front of Green. "See, the Artifact is only this small."

"Oh," Green extended his hand. "The Artifact we're looking for should be bigger than—"

Before he could finish, Taylor Ford had already lightly pressed the pale blue ticket into his hand.

The ticket was small; the skin at the edges of both their palms inevitably made brief contact before parting.

The moment Green closed his hand around the ticket, Taylor Ford said: "This Artifact is strange—it turns blue in a man's hand and pink in a woman's."

Green's eyelid gave a small twitch. He immediately looked down and turned the pale blue ticket over, examining both sides in turn.

"...Isn't this tomorrow's train ticket?"

Green said, glancing at his watch. "To be precise, it's a ticket that takes effect four hours from now, and valid only for the 16th. Aside from the departure station and destination, there's almost nothing of value here... what could you even do with it?"

That said, the time he spent examining the ticket was nearly twenty minutes longer than the time he'd spent on the alarm clock last time—at one point he even picked up his phone, apparently texting someone unknown, fingers clicking away for quite a while.

Taylor Ford waited patiently throughout; after a while, Green finally looked up.

"I just consulted a few Hunters who work with Mr. Wellesley... after all, I've been retired for a long time and am no longer up to date on the situation inside the Nest, as I'm sure you'll understand. This ticket is not what we're looking for, but it is interesting."

"Oh?" Taylor Ford leaned forward. "Are you interested in acquiring it?"

Green furrowed his brow—a rare occurrence—and seemed to hesitate.

"I say it's interesting because it has no detailed description of its function. Generally speaking, running into an Artifact with an unknown purpose is like opening a mystery box... you might get a surprisingly good result, or you might lose everything, including your life."

He shook his head at that, and pushed the pale blue ticket back. "Personally, I don't buy Artifacts—if I buy, it's on Mr. Wellesley's behalf. It's just that our situation is rather particular lately, and it's not suitable to take such a big risk opening a mystery box."

...Wellesley was indeed afraid of something, and as time went on, that fear seemed only to be growing heavier.

Seeing that Taylor Ford hadn't moved, Jane Lynch reached out and took the ticket. The moment it entered her hand, it was immediately overlaid with a shade of pink.

"I see, understood," Taylor Ford said, making small talk while raising his eyes—only to feel a sudden jolt of surprise.

In that brief moment, Green was staring fixedly at the ticket in Jane Lynch's hand, as though he hadn't even registered what Taylor Ford had said.

What was that? Had he recognized the ticket?

"...Mr. Green?"

Green immediately turned his gaze away. "Sorry, what?"

"Would you like another look at the ticket?" Taylor Ford asked with a smile.

"No, that's not necessary. No, don't hand it to me..." Green waved a hand, declining the pink ticket Jane Lynch was offering him. "What were you just saying?"

"I was asking: if our House Faction opened this mystery box and brought you only the results, would you be willing to purchase it then?"

"Depends on its function." Green returned to his usual composure, smiling gently. "But given the expiration date, I trust you won't be bringing it back to me anyway."

This time he only walked Taylor Ford and his group as far as the elevator.

"Next time you come across something you're not sure about, you might as well send me a photo first," he said, standing at the elevator doors, his smile so thin it looked like it could be blown away with a breath. "A Hunter Director from Morgan House Faction should have basic powers of discernment, yes?"

The moment the elevator doors closed, Taylor Ford couldn't hold back anymore.

"Where did this character crawl out from? The way he carries himself—he doesn't look like Wellesley's secretary, he looks like Wellesley's illegitimate father. Hey, do you two deal with smiling-faced backstabbers like him all the time? It must be exactly like unclogging a toilet."

The bodyguard who still had to escort them looked deeply awkward, and could only pretend not to hear, keeping his face down as he led the group all the way to their car.

Taylor Ford's ever-inventive stream of complaints cut off abruptly the moment the car door slammed shut with a thud, and silence fell.

Only after the car had pulled onto the main road did he extend a hand toward Kogi, who was sitting up front in the driver's seat.

"Well?" Taylor Ford resumed his lazy air and asked quietly. "Hand it over."

"Yes, it really did go off—"

Kogi was a new hire in the HR department who had been waiting in the car all evening; he pulled a flat box from his pocket and handed it to Taylor Ford. "Not long after you all went upstairs, an Amber Alert sounded on your phone, Director. But it didn't go off on my phone—strange."

...He'd guessed right.

The last time Taylor Ford had received an "Amber Alert" was in the instant after he made skin contact with Green; no matter how he turned it over in his mind, he felt that one of the trigger conditions had to be "touching Green, who had previously triggered an Amber Alert."

Assuming the "Amber Alert" appeared specifically so that Taylor Ford could see it—which was very plausible, since it was clearly sent to Taylor Ford alone—then since Taylor Ford hadn't seen it last time, would it appear again once the trigger conditions were met?

The opposite of that premise was: "as long as the alert has been seen, it will not appear a second time."

Judging by Green's behavior, at least the opposite of that premise could be indirectly confirmed.

After all, if the alert would appear a second time regardless of whether it had been seen, as long as the trigger conditions were met, why would he ever give Taylor Ford another chance to

meet those trigger conditions?

To prevent Taylor Ford from receiving a second alert, he could never meet with Taylor Ford again—to say nothing of physical contact.

It was precisely because Green had seen the alert that he never received a second one.

In other words, in Green's memory, the "Amber Alert" was something that only ever appeared once.

Given that, it was perfectly understandable that he had formed the belief that "as long as you dismiss it, you'll never see it again."

Though having the converse of a premise verified doesn't necessarily mean the premise itself is true, as long as there was any possibility—however slim—of triggering the "Amber Alert" a second time, Taylor still had to try again and replicate the scene from before.

Fortunately, the odds had fallen on the side in his favor.

"I hope you won't hold this method against me."

Taylor typed in the passcode, opened the flat box, and took out his real phone. "Until I confirm what the Amber Alert contains, I can't let it lea—"

He stopped abruptly, leaving the words unfinished.

Taylor stared at the phone without blinking, the screen's glow bleaching his entire field of vision white.

Outside the car window, the neon lights and glittering nightlife of Blackmoor City seemed to drift away, growing more and more distant.

"...Taylor?"

Jane Lynch's voice calling out to him from the front felt as though it came from across an entire lifetime; to Taylor, it carried not a single scrap of meaning—like a ripple on water, it simply vanished.

All he could see was the notification on his phone.

! MAJOR NEST INFORMATION NOTICE !

This was the only complete line of human text; on either side stood yellow triangular warning signs, each bearing a single bold exclamation mark.

Most of the notification's content was written in script that was absolutely not any human language on Earth—it was as if black ink had twisted and churned, coiling into crawling things that wanted to burrow deep into a person's soul.

Yet woven among this "Nest script" were quite a few characters and symbols Taylor could recognize and read; by setting aside the non-human language and picking out only the parts he understood, he could still piece together a message whose meaning was just barely coherent.

The Hidden Nest Domination Game

Sole Competing Team

Keys collected so far: Key (symbol), One Tongue (symbol), Black Cube (symbol), Word-Editing Software (symbol)

Brianna

Not yet collected:

Vintage Radio (symbol)

Time (text)

???

Sole Competing Team holds a decisive advantage

New competitor Taylor Ford is hereby conscripted

...His reading of it was probably right, wasn't it?

The content of this message...should be saying that in the "Hidden Nest Domination Game," the one and only competing team so far had already gathered four items.

Given the existence of the "Key," that team was Wellesley's; and because they had already collected four items, they held a decisive advantage.

And now the "Nest Domination Game" was conscripting Taylor Ford as a rival to Wellesley? And the total number of items to be gathered was seven?

In other words...the "time Artifact" that Wellesley had commissioned the Morgan House Faction to find for him was one of the targets in the "Nest Domination Game"—was that right?

Taylor still had many uncertainties and unanswered questions—for instance, whether the game had a time limit, and what reward the winner would receive, which the notification hadn't

mentioned.

...Perhaps it didn't feel the need to explain.

Because the name of this game was the "Nest Domination Game," after all—wasn't it?

At that thought, Taylor quietly spoke up.

"Miss...do you have an Artifact on you that has something to do with time?"

The young woman standing before him—the one called Mai Minghe—cast her eyes downward, apparently lost in thought.

Her hair, even after being combed, still stuck out in all directions, as though she had cut it herself at home with a pair of scissors—completely unlike anything a woman her age would normally do; she had truly gone to great lengths to pass herself off as a vagrant.

"I'm sorry," Taylor said slowly, tightening his grip around her wrist. "It's just that I...no matter what, I want to be free."

It's finally out! This chapter is extremely long, but that's not really the hardest part—the real challenge was having to jump forward across several points in time...it required quite a few scene transitions.

Either way, Taylor's timeline has finally converged to November 18th, bringing him face to face with Mai Minghe.

PS: There were some edits to the previous chapter—if you didn't catch them, feel free to go back and take a look, though it won't affect the main storyline either way.

Chapter 65: Mai Minghe Trapped With No Way Out?

The boy's last few words drifted up faint and hazy, tinged with a milky fog, as if a single breath might scatter them.

Mai Minghe was still somewhat dazed, as though part of her soul refused to believe what was happening before her eyes; when she heard footsteps at the corridor entrance and mechanically turned her head toward them, she was still thinking that, aside from herself, no one else could have caught Taylor Ford's final words.

The four people who came around the corner from the corridor were all strangers to Mai Minghe.

She'd had little experience with physical confrontations in her life, yet even she could tell that these were almost certainly seasoned Hunters from Morgan House Faction—they stood there, blocking the corridor exit so completely that every escape route felt cut off; she couldn't push through, and she could barely breathe.

...To have it and then lose it again—was there anything in this world more bitter, more grinding than that?

On instinct, Mai Minghe tensed slightly and tried to pull her wrist back.

But thin as the boy was, he was far from weak; her tug didn't move him at all, and she didn't dare try again with real force—in front of five Hunters, she had no wish to give them reason to think physical restraint was necessary.

"Our director is asking you something," said the woman at the front of the group, her hair dyed raven-black, several silver studs piercing her lips, nose, and brow.

Her tone was not at all harsh—more like a bit-part actress who simply recited whatever the scene called for, without putting much feeling into it: "Don't just stand there. If you really took our Artifact, being pretty won't save you. I'm a loyal Morgan person through and through."

What was all this about being pretty or not?

Mai Minghe blinked, but it actually brought her back to her senses. She glanced at Taylor Ford, straightened her back, and drew a deep breath.

"What kind of child are you?"

She went straight at him: "Tricking me is one thing—whether your name is Taylor Ford or Taylor Red, that's your business. But haven't you read the situation? How can you not tell what matters more? In your House Faction, are things worth more than a human life?"

The dreamy, mist-shrouded look that had been on Taylor Ford's face just a moment ago gradually faded now, replaced by bewilderment.

"If I'd taken your things, I wouldn't have come here at all—you wouldn't even know I existed, so where would you go to find me? And then Jonah from your House Faction would have died for nothing. That's a human life. Is it that you're too young to understand what a human life weighs?"

This wasn't entirely something she said just to get herself free—she'd been holding it in since earlier.

"I told you everything about Jonah's condition and location. It's been hours since then. Have a look at what you've all been busy doing."

This time she wasn't only lecturing Taylor Ford—she reached out and swept the Hunters who had just appeared from the corridor into it as well, pointing at all of them in turn. Taylor Ford apparently hadn't expected that at all, and stood there blankly while she pulled her hand free.

Mai Minghe had no children of her own, but this wasn't the first time she'd scolded a younger person; never mind that she was usually even-tempered, gentle, and kind—when she was anxious, she had once scolded her cousin's grandson to tears.

"Think about it—if I'd truly taken your things, would I have dared come alone to your House Faction to report what I knew? You'd all better think carefully about what matters more and what matters less. If Jonah dies because of this delay, can you sleep at night, knowing you were his companions?"

The female Hunter covered in rivets, black leather, and fishnet looked over at Taylor Ford as if asking for help.

"We'll go rescue him, of course," the boy said, his tone now something very close to stubborn: "...But first I need to know whether you actually have what I'm looking for."

"Have what, my foot," said Mai Minghe. "After I arrived here, I even changed clothes. Even if I had it, I couldn't be carrying it on me."

There was a slight twinge of guilt in saying it, but after eighty-some years, she'd said guilty things more times than she could count, and by now she could say them as calmly as anything.

"If you truly have nothing to do with the Artifact we're looking for, I will personally apologize and make it up to you."

Having endured a thorough scolding, Taylor Ford was now wearing a long face without quite realizing it—that unconscious sulk was, in truth, perfectly suited to his age.

"But what needs to be settled must be settled. Logically speaking, someone who takes our Artifact would ordinarily just let Jonah die—they wouldn't come to report it.

"That said, there are many people in this world who are driven by principles so deeply ingrained they've become instinct. Whether that principle is 'human life comes first,' or 'money above all,' or 'seize the moment'—once it becomes instinct, people act on it without stopping to think. Such people tend to focus only on how to reach their goal, and rarely stop to ask whether they should be doing it at all. I think you're that kind of person."

Mai Minghe let out a breath.

She couldn't say Taylor Ford was wrong; she truly felt, from the bottom of her heart, that when a life was on the line, how could she not at least cry out on his behalf?

It was true that if Jonah died with no one knowing she had taken the Artifact, that would have served her interests best—she hadn't failed to think of it, but she had barely let it register, letting it pass through her mind in a flash.

Wasn't it only right to speak up for him?

But hearing Taylor Ford frame it that way, something about it didn't sit right.

"You're still so young," she said with a bitter smile. "Why do you look at the world with such cold suspicion?"

Taylor Ford paid no attention.

"So, first: I need to confirm whether you have the Artifact on you. Second: I need you to stay and be Morgan House Faction's guest for a while, until I bring Jonah back and can compare his account with yours. Third: if even Jonah can't say for certain whether you're connected to the Artifact, then out of caution I'll have to ask you to come with me to the Nest, to make sure you haven't hidden it somewhere in there."

He was thorough, but she wouldn't even get past the first hurdle.

Mai Minghe lowered her eyelids and looked at the hem of her clothes.

She had to do something; the situation she was in could not be escaped by words alone.

Suppressing wave after wave of unease, Mai Minghe steeled herself and said quietly: "All right. Then let's confirm the first point first."

The words had barely left her mouth before she slid both hands under her shirt hem, grabbed the fabric, and yanked it upward—the shirt was lifted to just below her chest, revealing a smooth, clean expanse of bare midriff.

"W—wait a moment!" Taylor Ford jumped back a step as though someone had stomped on his foot, and his eyes swept hurriedly away. "You don't need to undress right now—Remy!"

"Huh?" The heavily-studded female Hunter blinked.

"Take her somewhere and do the check," said Taylor Ford, tilting his head and staring at the floor.

"That's not exactly convenient for me either!"

When Mai Minghe lowered her shirt again, she caught a flicker of awkwardness cross Remy's face; Remy muttered, "Well, I don't mind personally, but I'd worry she'd be unhappy about it afterward..."

To Mai Minghe's eyes, these five people were scarcely different from kindergarteners; she herself didn't feel the faintest stir of emotion—what was there to feel?

Getting old was nothing to fear; what was frightening was losing the ability to act, and with it losing all dignity.

After her surgery, while she was still in the hospital, she couldn't get herself up to use the bathroom and could only watch as the nurse aides changed her adult briefs; many times, in the hands of those young women and young men, she felt not like a person who could feel embarrassed or have privacy, but more like a piece of meat.

As long as she could keep the Serpent Band and never return to that twilight state of helplessness and indignity, Mai Minghe was willing to risk anything—including, for instance, baring her midriff.

The Serpent Band had been coiled around her midriff and lower back the whole time, wound about two and a half times around.

Even back when her waist had been slender in her youth, two and a half coils was a considerable length—if anyone came to search her, it was absolutely impossible to conceal.

Mai Minghe wanted to leave them with the impression that she had no fear of being searched, loosening their suspicion a little; baring her midriff was the riskiest and most difficult move, yet also the most natural one—after all, most people start undressing from the top.

Even if the plan she was currently turning over in her mind ultimately failed to work, getting them to walk away with the mistaken idea that there was nothing on Mai Minghe's midriff would still give her an advantage.

It sounded difficult, but in practice it turned out to be considerably simpler than Mai Minghe had imagined:

She slid both hands under her shirt hem, pressing the fabric between the Serpent Band and her skin, effectively wrapping it around the Band; gripping the Serpent Band through the cloth, she peeled it—Artifact and fabric together—forcefully upward. By the time her midriff was exposed, the Serpent Band was coiled up at her chest, and because it had been pushed and compressed together, the two coils had no gap between them.

When she lowered the shirt again, the Serpent Band used that momentum to slide back down to her midriff and settle into place once more.

"If you're not going to search me here, then the changing room in the shower area will do," Mai Minghe offered on her own. "As for who does the search, I'll leave that to you—I don't mind. Just as long as it's a woman."

"Then I'll go get Jane Lynch," Remy had barely finished the sentence before Taylor Ford cut her off.

"Hold on," he said, having regained his composure, gesturing for the Hunters to bring Mai Minghe along; as they walked out, he said: "You and Jane Lynch go together. Take her to the changing room. There must be a Hunter present."

Everything was arranged quickly. Two minutes later, Mai Minghe was being escorted by Remy on one side and Taylor Ford on the other toward the front reception desk; Jane Lynch was already waiting there, and perhaps because Mai Minghe had managed to trick her, her expression was none too pleasant.

Mai Minghe glanced at the receptionist girl, who was sitting there with just her face visible above the desk, staring blankly at her.

She had noticed it earlier—back when she borrowed and then returned the comb from the receptionist girl.

Perhaps it was because Morgan House Faction also didn't want Hunters covered in blood making their way through the office area; the shower room and the office area were separated, with the front reception hall in between.

The office area was behind a security door, accessible from the shower room only by passing through the reception hall.

When Mai Minghe had borrowed the comb from the receptionist girl at the time, it wasn't because she only knew the receptionist girl and was going out of her way—it was that the receptionist girl was simply the only person Mai Minghe, in the shower room, could have borrowed a comb from; and after freshening up, she had no choice but to wait for the receptionist girl to lead her through to meet "Taylor Ford."

Looked at from the other side: to go from the office area to the shower room, one had to pass through the front reception hall.

"You had us fooled," said Jane Lynch—having misjudged someone in front of her superior, her tone had turned sharp. "Who exactly are you?"

"Just someone who happened to be passing by," Mai Minghe muttered.

"I'm armed," Jane Lynch warned. "Let us search you without any tricks."

"I understand."

Mai Minghe sighed and looked back, noticing that Taylor Ford had already sat down on the sofa at the other end of the reception hall—her heart gave a small lurch.

"Can I return the comb to that young woman? She thought I was a vagrant at first and didn't dare ask for it back. She should dare now."

Even as she spoke, she had already started walking toward the reception desk—but both Remy and Jane Lynch were on high alert; how would they let her simply walk up to the reception desk on her own?

Sure enough, she had barely taken one step before Remy seized her shoulder with a heavy grip. Remy barked: "Don't move. You'll have plenty of time to return it after we're done searching."

"Let her take out the comb."

Taylor Ford, who had been watching her intently all along, was curled on the sofa; now he spoke up without warning: "Show it to me—I'll return it for her."

As expected...someone with a mind this meticulous would surely suspect she was trying to use the excuse of returning something to stash the Artifact at the reception desk, wouldn't he?

Mai Minghe didn't know whether Hunters could identify Artifacts at a glance; but thinking about it logically, even the most experienced Hunter must have moments of uncertainty—it couldn't be a hundred percent every time, could it?

Even counterfeit-detection machines make mistakes, let alone a human eye.

Besides, she didn't need much time.

Just one instant—the instant their gaze shifted away from her and landed on the comb...

The front reception hall was an enclosed space with no windows, and the only elevator required a key card to operate.

This was Morgan House Faction territory, and three people were watching Mai Minghe, two of whom were Hunters.

On top of that, she had just carried herself with complete openness, as if she had nothing on her—as if she wasn't afraid of being searched at all—and with all these factors in place, as long as Hunters were still human, Mai Minghe felt they would all, in that one instant, loosen their attention just a little.

With one guardian flanking her on each side, never leaving her shadow, Mai Minghe walked up to the sofa and handed the comb to Taylor Ford.

Taylor Ford sat on the sofa and reached out his hand—he took the comb, and in that same instant, took Remy and Jane Lynch's attention along with it.

It was only the subtlest shift, the tiniest flicker of their gaze, but Mai Minghe caught it.

When a person is pushed to the brink she's been pushed to, they always manage to unleash tremendous potential.

No one would have guessed that when Mai Minghe made her move, she would choose to run toward where Taylor Ford was sitting: without a sound, she suddenly planted one foot on the sofa, and in the same moment the others began to lift their eyes from the comb, Mai Minghe had already pushed off the back of the sofa chair and leapt backward, throwing herself straight into the wall behind her.

Someone's hand—she didn't know whose—grabbed at her calf, sharp and aching.

Fast enough reaction; but still a step too late.

The screen on the wall, which had been playing a Morgan & Morgan promotional reel, had already gently opened a passage and swallowed her whole.

After Taylor Ford's little speech, Mai Minghe should probably call him cynical for someone so young—but that word doesn't translate cleanly into Chinese; rendering it as "愤世嫉俗" truly sounds strange, so I made up my own term instead. It's a bit of a Frankenstein job, not very elegant—sorry about that.

The clue about the screen in the front reception room was one I buried deep, with the dedication of a cat burying its business, and it never came up again for over ten chapters—I figured everyone had probably forgotten about it by now...

But I also worried the clue was buried too deep and might backfire—maybe instead of feeling like a carefully laid thread, readers would just think I pulled it out of thin air at the last second. Not *deus ex machina*, but *deus ex screen*...

PS: The fact that today's update is this late tells you everything you need to know—I got stuck again, aaaaargh.

Chapter 66: Mai Minghe Re-Enters the Nest

...Tell me, how did things end up like this.

She'd left the Nest less than a day ago—how was she back inside already?

Mai Minghe cradled her head in both hands, utterly at a loss about what to do next.

She had tumbled headfirst into the Nest roughly ten-some minutes ago.

Mai Minghe had originally assumed she would drop back into St. Louis Hospital, which meant she'd have to watch out for "Jonah" and the spindly Resident, and dodge the Morgan House Faction pursuers on top of that—so she'd need to slip away from St. Louis Hospital at the very first opportunity.

But she hadn't expected the Nest to be so considerate, sparing her that trip entirely.

The place she'd landed was a bathroom stall—she couldn't tell exactly which bathroom it was, but there was an advertisement for alcoholic beverages taped to the back of the door, so it definitely wasn't a hospital restroom—and on top of that, she'd landed square on the toilet seat.

Was the landing spot random every time someone entered the Nest?

Then how did House Faction Hunters ensure they all came in together and moved as a group?

The moment the Morgan House Faction Hunters saw her run, they'd certainly follow her straight into the Nest—where would they land? Would they come after her first, or go rescue Jonah first?

From the look of things, they at least couldn't have landed in this quiet little restroom—otherwise she would have heard something by now.

Mai Minghe steeled herself and eased the door open a crack, peering through the gap.

...A woman was standing at the sink, touching up her makeup in the mirror.

Was she a Resident?

Why would a Resident need to touch up her makeup? Did the woman know that someone had appeared in one of the stalls?

Forget it, I'll wait until she leaves before going out, Mai Minghe thought.

Because the woman was standing at the far left end of the sink counter, right up against the wall, from Mai Minghe's angle with only a sliver of door open, she could only see the woman's back—not the mirror.

Seen from behind, the woman wore a slender-fitting pale lotus-pink dress, a white-gold thin belt, and heels in the same color family as the dress; she looked not only normal but rather elegant—yet this was the Nest, after all, and who knew what kind of face she might reveal once she turned around?

This was the Nest, wasn't it?

After experiencing far too many unexpected things, she couldn't even guarantee that something "unexpected" wouldn't happen in that regard.

Mai Minghe quietly retreated, put the toilet lid down, and sat on it.

Through the gap beneath the stall door she could see the tiled floor outside; if the woman left the restroom, she'd be able to see her feet walking past.

The partitions on both sides of the stall didn't reach the floor below or the ceiling above.

Sitting on the toilet lid, Mai Minghe felt a prickling unease in her chest; she kept glancing down at the floor of the adjacent stall, then looking up at the top of the partition, constantly afraid that somewhere, without her noticing, something that shouldn't be there had appeared.

Yet several minutes passed, and both neighboring stalls remained quiet and empty; the entire restroom was still dead silent, and there were no heeled feet walking out the door.

Could it be that the woman had already noticed her and was waiting outside without making a sound?

Mai Minghe's gaze swept again and again over the empty floor beyond the door, and the thought grew louder and louder in her mind; she was gradually becoming unable to sit still—she couldn't just stay here forever.

But at the very least, one thing seemed confirmed by now: after all this time, even if the Morgan House Faction people had followed her in, they hadn't landed anywhere nearby.

Mai Minghe didn't know how much longer she waited before she finally stood up and, again without a sound, eased open a crack in the door.

...The pair of enormous white eyeballs she'd imagined staring back at her through the gap existed only in her imagination, as it turned out.

Well—the most frightening thing really was scaring yourself.

The woman was still standing at the sink touching up her makeup, and hadn't even turned her head.

Weren't there harmless Residents in the Nest too? She seemed to recall "Jonah" mentioning that during their conversation in the morgue—harmless Residents were probably rare, but what if she happened to run into one?

That thought contained more than a little wishful thinking, so Mai Minghe didn't boldly swing the door open and walk out; she sat back down on the toilet lid.

She hadn't locked the door: first, because she was afraid the sound of locking it would startle the Resident outside; second, because she worried the stall itself might not be safe, and if she needed to escape she couldn't afford to waste time unlocking it; third, because if someone outside tried to come in, Mai Minghe could brace her leg against the door from the toilet, and there would still be time to lock it then.

Thinking of this, she tested it—lifted her leg and pressed her foot against the door to check she could brace it quickly—confirming she could. Verifying things within her control was a way to keep herself a little calmer.

She lowered her foot, and her gaze fell on the alcoholic beverage advertisement on the back of the door; she felt a vein throb sharply at her temple.

Earlier, she'd been so worried about what might crawl through the gaps above and below the partitions that she hadn't looked at it carefully at all—she'd only registered it as a liquor ad. But now, for some reason, she couldn't shake the feeling that the advertisement was somehow unsettling.

Gather in this moment, share in the mellow

Above that single line of eight large characters, the left third was taken up by a close-up of a wine bottle; on the right stood a elegantly made-up female model, lifting a half-filled glass of wine to her smiling red lips.

Perhaps because the ad was placed in a women's restroom—targeting female consumers—the scene of the female model drinking clearly depicted her gathered with female friends; seated across

from her was a young woman visible only in profile, the two of them clinking glasses, both smiling radiantly.

...Wait.

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes.

The model whose face was visible was raising her glass to her own lips; but the woman visible only in profile was in the middle of clinking glasses with her—two stemmed glasses touching lightly on the table between them, the clear liquid tilting ever so slightly.

...Where had the third glass come from?

At first glance she'd assumed there was a third person at the gathering; but looking more carefully now, there were only two female models in the image.

Mai Minghe followed the stem of the middle glass to the hand holding it, then the wrist, the arm, and finally discovered a fork at the elbow—the model whose face was visible, it turned out, had two forearms extending from her elbow; one was clinking glasses with her friend, the other was raising a glass to her lips.

No—saying they extended from the elbow wasn't quite right either.

Although at first glance it did look as though the model had two left arms, if you leaned in and looked carefully, you'd find that the left elbow was actually two overlapping images, with the arm holding the glass having its elbow shifted slightly out of alignment.

At the bottom of the advertisement, where the product copy should have been, were these lines of text:

Multiple reflections, embrace the possibilities

This is where the joy begins

In the moments of your life that are truly worth cherishing, make the right choice

Disclaimer: What you see has been processed with PS; please carefully assess the risks

...What did that mean? Not one of those lines had anything to do with alcohol.

Mai Minghe stared at the advertisement, dazed, for a long moment.

Aside from the extra arm, she couldn't spot anything else strange about the image; she even ran her hand over it—it was a completely ordinary piece of paper glued on, and she could have

peeled it off if she'd wanted to.

Could this be some new thing she didn't understand, something that young people were into these days?

Take "PS," for instance—she'd heard the social worker mention it before and knew it was a young-person thing with something to do with photos, something that could apparently make people look more attractive—beyond that, she didn't know.

But it felt like something wasn't right.

She quietly eased the door open another crack and looked again—the woman was still standing in the same spot touching up her makeup, seemingly not having moved even slightly from before.

Still hadn't left.

She looked at the advertisement on the back of the door, then at the woman's back through the gap, then back at the advertisement again.

Could there be some connection between the two? Or rather, did this advertisement contain some kind of information related to this place?

Otherwise, why did the ad copy read as if it were speaking directly to her?

The idea seemed far-fetched—but wasn't the Nest itself an extremely far-fetched place?

The way Mai Minghe saw it, inside the Nest, common sense was the last thing you should use to dismiss something.

She'd look at the advertisement more carefully.

With the meticulous focus of a detective examining a murder scene, Mai Minghe went over the advertisement inch by inch; by the third pass, she finally noticed something off.

The model shown in full face and the model shown only in profile were different colors.

"Color" didn't refer to a difference in skin tone—it was the light, the light quality.

The model in full face was bathed in a slightly yellow, slightly dim tone, as if she were sitting under the soft, low-lit glow of a restaurant bar—fitting enough for the ad's setting.

Yet the model in profile on the other side of the image—her hair and skin alike—appeared brighter and whiter than the woman across from her; though the difference was subtle, it gave the

impression that the light illuminating her was certainly not a soft, warm yellow, but rather a white light.

The side of the image closer to Mai Minghe was where the two figures were brightest; in other words, if this was the actual location depicted in the image, the light source was on Mai Minghe's side.

But if that were the case, something else didn't add up: in the image, embedded in the ceiling behind the two models were several small spotlights; one of them, perhaps because the bulb had been replaced, was different from the others' yellow glow—it shone with a white light.

The light source should have been on her side—so why had it ended up across the way?

Or put another way—if the light source was clearly across the way, how could it possibly be illuminating this side?

Could there be white lights on both sides, with the one on her side simply not captured in the photo?

As that thought occurred to her, Mai Minghe glanced at the extra third arm. After a few seconds, her gaze drifted back down to the text below.

"Multiple reflections"...reflections?

Reflections implied mirrors...

In the advertisement image, neither of the two female models had a reflection.

A mirror...

Mai Minghe stood up from the toilet lid.

It suddenly occurred to her that she had only ever seen the back of the woman touching up her makeup outside the door—she had never once seen what the woman was facing.

Logically, there should have been a mirror there.

Chapter 67: Mai Minghe's Starting Point

Mai Minghe had pulled at the door twice just now, and both times she had only opened it a narrow crack before stopping.

To her mind, this was perfectly reasonable: if she opened the gap too wide and that woman touching up her makeup noticed someone in the stall, what then? She had to be careful.

...So she had assumed all along that opening the door only a sliver was her own decision.

The crack of the door—it was the result of her brain deliberating and measuring, of her arm muscles obeying their orders.

It was only when Mai Minghe tried to pull the door open a little wider to get a look at the mirror on the other side of the makeup woman that she realized she had been wrong.

It turned out the door could only be pulled open a thin crack; pull any harder, and it wouldn't budge at all, as though it had been sealed with poured steel.

How could this be? Was the door broken?

Mai Minghe stood frozen in place and, knowing it was impossible, still looked down at the gap beneath the door—the tile floor on the other side was empty, with not a single pair of feet standing there.

So there was no one on the other side pulling the door shut to keep her from opening it.

How strange—had someone looped a rope around the door handle and pulled it taut from outside?

Through the crack in the door, the back of the woman touching up her makeup still stood quietly by the sink, pressing heavy and still into that single sliver of Mai Minghe's view.

She listened to her own breathing grow gradually more rapid, then forced herself to slowly breathe out one long exhale. Exhaling longer than inhaling steadies the nerves—she couldn't remember where she'd heard that theory.

After that, Mai Minghe fought down her discomfort and slowly reached her hand out through the crack in the door.

Very quickly, she could only see the heel of her own palm; her fingers curled around the edge of the door and disappeared into the unseen other side, like plunging into cold water—or as though once out of sight, they no longer belonged to her.

If something outside the door suddenly grabbed her hand, she could only count herself unlucky—to have stumbled into a dead end on her very first foray.

Even so, after feeling around the door handle and finding no rope, Mai Minghe finally withdrew her hand completely—still intact, still her ordinary hand.

And yet, now she felt at a loss.

The gap beneath the door panel was quite tall, reaching about halfway up her calf—a person could crawl out through it...

She had to leave this stall; she just wasn't sure whether crawling out under the door was actually a good idea.

The Nest had to operate by some logic, didn't it? Even the most terrifying things should have a set of rules—"please swim out under the door after using the restroom"—what kind of rule was that?

Was it calling her a maggot?

That was what she thought, but after a moment's hesitation, Mai Minghe bent down anyway.

She wouldn't crawl out just yet—crouching down to get a better look at the situation first was reasonable enough, since this was the only exit; beyond that, she had no other ideas for now.

Crouching down, her field of vision was still limited—she could see only the same expanse of empty tile.

Mai Minghe simply dropped to her knees on the floor, palms braced against the cold tiles, sitting back on her heels; before looking out, she reflexively glanced upward.

Beneath the ceiling and along the walls on either side of the stall, everything was as it should be—no face was peering down at her.

Good. Nothing. No one.

She reassured herself and leaned forward. Then she looked out—

Mai Minghe's gaze landed on a woman's back.

The person outside was half-crouched on the restroom floor, wearing the same ZARA outfit bought by Morgan House Faction, both knees on the ground, palms braced against the floor, sitting back on her heels—presenting the soles of her shoes.

As though sensing a gaze from behind, the person lifted a head with unevenly cut hair; then, after a brief pause, she suddenly shifted one knee backward.

Immediately after, she began crawling rapidly toward Mai Minghe—backward, hands and feet both moving.

Mai Minghe shot to her feet, and in her panic her back slammed into the toilet paper holder with a dull thud—the sound exploded in her mind like a thunderclap, blasting a layer of hot-and-cold sweat across her skin.

Panic churned through her mind like shrapnel from an explosion; her feet were directly in the path of that figure retreating toward her, and almost on pure instinct, Mai Minghe scrambled up onto the toilet, eyes locked on the gap beneath the door panel.

Several seconds passed, and the stretch of tile outside seemed empty again—another Mai Minghe never crawled in backward as she had feared.

The sound didn't seem to have disturbed the makeup woman either; through the crack in the door, the figure in the fitted suit still stood motionless in the same spot.

That back on the floor just now—it really had been her own, hadn't it?

The posture, the clothes—identical to hers in every way, yet the moment she jumped up, the floor outside was empty again.

She steeled herself and looked down; still only a stretch of empty tile.

No good... She didn't understand what was happening, but crawling out under the door panel no longer seemed like an option.

Good thing I'm still young, Mai Minghe thought, her heart still hammering. Otherwise that just now could have triggered a stroke.

She crouched on the toilet lid—it wasn't large, and she had to steady herself against the wall with one hand to keep her balance.

Fortunately, the toilet cistern was built into the wall, and above where the cistern would have been, a ledge had been constructed—meant for setting things on, presumably—which was

convenient to brace against for now.

...It would also work as a foothold, wouldn't it?

Once she'd caught her breath, Mai Minghe looked at the ledge, then glanced up at the stall wall.

Standing on the ledge and gripping the top of the partition—she could climb over into the adjacent stall...

She wondered whether the door of the neighboring stall could be opened.

At least it was worth trying—better than sitting here helplessly trapped.

Well. Ever since falling into this stall, she had been afraid a face might lean over from the neighboring partition to stare at her; and yet in the end, she was the one who would be leaning over to peer at whoever was next door.

As Mai Minghe silently reflected that life was truly unpredictable—the older you get, the more you revere fate and stop putting all your faith in your own strength—she carefully stood upright on the toilet.

Before climbing over the right partition, she hesitated.

Standing this high, her line of sight just cleared the top of the partition. All she had to do was turn her head and she should be able to see the makeup woman outside and the mirror facing her—at least the upper half of it. So—should she look?

The human mind was a strange thing.

She had tried to pull the door open earlier precisely to sneak a glance at the makeup woman's reflection. Back then she hadn't been too tense—perhaps because the door panel was there as a barrier.

But now her eyes floated above the partition with nothing around her to hide behind, leaving her exposed, and she found herself reluctant to turn her head—even though that barrier had only ever been a psychological comfort, hadn't it?

In the end, Mai Minghe slowly turned her head.

The makeup woman's face floating in the air above the stall, staring at her; or perhaps she had locked eyes with the woman in the mirror; or perhaps there was no mirror facing the makeup woman at all—various thoughts flashed through Mai Minghe's mind, but none of them came true.

What she hadn't expected was that even after standing on the toilet to look out, she could still only see the makeup woman's back—by rights, standing this high, she should have been able to see even the reflection in the mirror clearly.

Yet looking out, there was still only the makeup woman's unmoving back.

It was as if the area where the sink stood happened to be set back into a projecting alcove, and the ceiling blocked both the mirror and Mai Minghe's view.

Had the restroom been structured like this when she was looking out through the door crack earlier?

The disorientation from the shifting spatial layout left Mai Minghe faintly dizzy.

She shook her head hard, and once the dizziness passed, she reached out to grip the partition again, braced her foot on the ledge, heaved—and pulled her upper body up over the top of the wall, letting her gaze fall down into the next stall.

In the stall to her right, the front-facing female model was seated on the toilet lid, head tilted back, one hand raised holding a wine glass, as though she had long known Mai Minghe would appear—and she split open a wide red smile up at her.

Mai Minghe flinched in fright and instinctively tried to pull back, but forgot she was hanging over the partition; her feet slipped and she tumbled off the toilet, the back of her head striking hard against something.

In terror and searing pain, she forced herself not to cry out, clamped one hand over her mouth and nose, and quickly stole a glance through the gap under the partition.

The floor of the right stall had clearly been empty just moments ago—no one there. But now, sweeping her eyes across it, she saw a pair of women's legs in black mid-heel lace-up ballet flats—it had to be the front-facing model's.

How could this be... how could a model from an advertisement suddenly appear inside the right stall?

Mai Minghe pressed her back against the partition wall, held her breath, shivering in wave after wave of cold, and watched those feet, waiting.

The feet in the right stall were equally motionless.

As the terror gradually ebbed, Mai Minghe slowly stood up, her legs feeling as though they'd been left to soak in water—drained of all strength.

On some inexplicable impulse, she cast a glance through the gap beneath the left stall's partition as well.

She saw the same pair of black mid-heel lace-up ballet flats.

This time, when Mai Minghe steeled herself and climbed up onto the partition to find the same front-facing female model sitting in the left stall as well, she at least managed not to be startled badly enough to fall to the floor again.

In the stalls on both sides, at some point unknown to her, a front-facing female model had taken a seat.

Mai Minghe held the left model's gaze for a moment, then slowly looked away, letting her eyes settle on the model's outstretched hand.

The outstretched hand held a wine glass aloft, as though she were in the middle of a toast.

And the right one—right, the right model had raised a wine glass to her lips.

Apart from the difference in the two models' poses, the layout and arrangement of the left and right stalls were identical to her own—yet what made Mai Minghe's heart pound hardest was that the doors of both stalls were half-open, wide enough.

Even if they couldn't be opened all the way, she would only need to turn sideways to slip through.

Of course, that meant Mai Minghe would have to climb down from the partition, squeeze past the female model, and edge her way sideways out through the restroom door...

The stall wasn't wide, and the model was seated in the center on the toilet—even if she (or should it be "it"?) didn't move, Mai Minghe would likely brush against her; to say nothing of the fact that the model's eyes kept following her.

Being watched by something like that was already unbearable—let alone pressing right up against it.

Could it be that neither side offered a way out?

But the doors on both sides were open—it was genuinely hard to resign herself to giving up without trying, and besides, she had to get out somehow.

Mai Minghe looked back and forth between the two stalls several times, and both identical faces kept gazing up at her—though deeply unsettling, she looked often enough that she gradually, somehow, grew used to it.

The layout on both sides was exactly the same, and the models were positioned identically.

Both doors were half-open, and neither had an advertisement posted on the back—Mai Minghe couldn't see the back of the right stall's door directly, and only confirmed this after stretching her arm out as far as it would go to hook it closer.

The left model's pose was a toast; the right model was drinking alone.

The left side was closer to the makeup woman; the right side was farther away.

Her own door was not an option.

Mai Minghe sat back down on the toilet lid, buried her face in her hands, and stared blankly at the advertisement on the back of her own stall door, her mind drifting in uncertain thought.

This situation was a different kind of strangeness from encountering a Resident.

The first possibility: the Nest had deliberately created this predicament with no deeper meaning—purely to torment people for sport.

The second possibility: the current situation was like a puzzle, containing clues for how to leave; if she wanted to get out, she would have to solve it and find those clues.

Mai Minghe dismissed the first possibility without a second thought—because dwelling on it had no value whatsoever. If it were true, she was finished no matter what she did, so what was there to think about?

Within the second possibility, the clues she needed to find...

Staring at the advertisement for several minutes, Mai Minghe suddenly drew a sharp breath, and a single sentence burst out of him: "This cubicle — is it a 'starting point'?"

Thank you all for understanding me. Last chapter, everyone was urging me to rest, and while I was touched, I felt too embarrassed to actually take a break... For the umpteenth time I find myself puzzled and in awe — how on earth do people manage to post ten thousand words a day?

How about this: I already have time off next weekend anyway, so starting the week after, could I take Saturdays off?

Honestly, it's not that I'm afraid of my stats dropping that makes me reluctant to rest (what's left to drop at this point) — it's mainly that I feel like I'd be letting down everyone who supports a niche story like this, and letting down my editor's faith in me...

I wish I were a faster writer — not only posting daily, but bonus chapters too; not just bonus chapters, but running two stories at once (I had a dream recently with such a twisty plot that I kind of want to write it now).

Sigh, I'd be better off daydreaming about winning the lottery instead.

Chapter 68: The Conditions for Mai Minghe's Departure

Mai Minghe had grown up in an ordinary household.

She was the child of an early last-century immigrant family; her parents had fled famine and war, and had always believed that any spending beyond food and clothing was suspect of wasting money—and wasting money was the greatest sin of all.

In the first ten years of her life, she never received a single Christmas gift; the first time she played a board game was in fifth grade, at a classmate's house, when the classmate's parents brought one out.

Her classmate's family had a small cabinet full of games Mai Minghe had never played: Scrabble, Life, Connect Four... and Monopoly.

How could she ever forget Monopoly? Monopoly in the fifties was nothing like the polished sets that came later—and yet the first time she placed her little wooden token on the square marked "Go," she felt certain she would remember that moment for the rest of her life.

Mai Minghe truly did remember it for the rest of her life.

On a Monopoly board, how do you find the starting square?

The answer to that question was utterly obvious: the starting square is the one that says "Go."

In the same way, she suddenly realized that her own stall might be a starting point—and for an equally simple reason:

This is where the fun begins

Three stalls, and only this one had an advertisement posted on it, spelling out that line in plain words.

"Fun" was of course nonsense—no one who came here could have any fun—but regardless of whether it was fun or not, once she stopped seeing it as an empty advertising slogan, it seemed to point somewhere with unmistakable clarity.

If she treated this stall as the starting point, the third line of copy made a lot more sense.

"At the moments in life most worth cherishing, make the right choice"—wasn't that simply telling Mai Minghe to pick a path?

It also matched her current situation: on the surface, it seemed she could exit from either the left or the right.

The question was how to tell which side to take.

Both sides looked deeply uncomfortable, both like dead ends.

Setting aside the possibility that the Nest was tormenting her on purpose, if one direction was a way out, then the clues and the basis for that judgment were most likely right here in this advertisement.

The two female models in the ad were each bathed in a different-colored light; the light source was clearly on Mai Minghe's side, yet the corresponding colored lights were far behind the models...

Her gaze returned to the first line of copy.

Multiple reflections, embrace the possibilities

Mai Minghe slapped her forehead, and a sharp "smack" rang out through the dead-silent bathroom stall, where three pairs of feet sat side by side.

Hadn't she just thought of mirrors because of the word "reflection"? How had she failed to follow that thread any further?

The light source was clearly on her side, yet the corresponding colored lights were behind the two female models—didn't that mean the women were actually standing beside a mirror?

No, wait, that couldn't be right—if it were a mirror, the two female models should have reflections, and they didn't...

The fourth line of copy might be a hint for that problem, but Mai Minghe couldn't quite make sense of it.

Disclaimer: The image has been digitally retouched. Please carefully assess any risks.

That was deeply unfair. If this line was meant as a hint, it should have been written in language even an elderly person could understand—oh, right, the Nest probably had no elderly people.

Well, that still wasn't fair. It wasn't as though she had chosen to fall behind the times.

In any case, what the line was essentially saying was that the photo had been processed in some way, making it look different from reality, which was why it warned people to look carefully and judge for themselves—wasn't that it?

Could there really be a technology that could seamlessly erase part of a photograph? That would be quite remarkable.

Assuming such a technology existed—since the mirror was beside the two women, what the viewer saw was the model facing forward, yet her reflection in the mirror should have shown her in profile.

Since the forward-facing image remained, what had been erased was the reflection in the mirror.

So then, what was the deal with the "third wine glass"?

"Clinking glasses" versus "drinking alone"—that was also the one difference between the two female models in the left and right stalls.

Mai Minghe looked back and forth several times between the advertising copy, the first line—"Multiple reflections, embrace the possibilities"—and the fourth line's disclaimer.

After thinking it over carefully for a while, she took a deep breath and stood up.

"It's fine," she murmured to herself as she climbed up onto the toilet, "it's fine. You've thought it through pretty thoroughly—there's nothing more you could figure out. Even if you close your eyes and pick at random, there's still a fifty percent chance you'd get it right... Don't be scared. In this life, you've weathered bigger storms than this, haven't you?"

As she had gotten older and begun living alone, her home had grown quieter and emptier with each passing day.

Mai Minghe had gradually developed the habit of sometimes asking the pot in the kitchen what it felt like eating today, sometimes singing a song to herself, sometimes coaxing herself to be a little more forgiving—wasn't it just a careless mistake with the money? Who doesn't make mistakes?

Muttering a few words like that settled her heart a little.

No matter how strange and bizarre the Nest was, it still had to follow some logic—even if the logic was entirely its own.

Mai Minghe climbed up onto the partition the same way she had before, stepping onto the ledge.

The female model's face, frozen in a smile, gradually turned around as Mai Minghe climbed over the partition wall and stepped down onto the platform on the other side.

The wine glass in her hand was still stretched far out ahead; the model's face had already slid halfway around from her shoulder—as if her neck were a pat of melting butter too weak to hold it in place, and that face was quickly sliding down to the top of her back.

The female model was very close now, close enough that if she folded both arms behind her, she could seize Mai Minghe.

With one foot on the ledge and one leg still draped over the partition, Mai Minghe—who considered herself fairly level-headed—felt a wave of dread wash over her in spite of herself.

The next step would mean extending her foot down and landing behind the female model.

Behind her, and yet right in front of her.

The two of them—one person and one... Mai Minghe truly couldn't say what the model counted as—stood frozen in the dead silence for a dozen or so seconds, neither moving.

Slowly, Mai Minghe extended her foot downward and set it on the joint where the toilet met the wall.

The model's eyeballs rolled downward to look at Mai Minghe's foot, the whites of her eyes showing in large half-moons—because her eyeballs, or rather its eyeballs, had turned down, but her eyelids remained stretched wide open, as though they couldn't move at all.

Equally immovable was that smiling red mouth; a row of teeth, half-hidden and half-exposed.

This was unbearable—this thing was far too close...

And yet this was not the closest it would get.

When Mai Minghe climbed down off the toilet, physical contact with the female model became unavoidable: even though she had deliberately chosen the side without a toilet paper roll, the space was still narrow enough to barely fit her.

She pressed her back flat against the partition, sucked in her stomach, and shrank into the corner with the desperate wish to fold herself into a trash bin; the model's face still hung at the top of her back, and Mai Minghe almost had the illusion she could feel its breath.

When Mai Minghe tried to squeeze outward, she bumped into the model's shoulder exactly as expected, and that head swayed slightly with the contact.

It's fine—not unpleasant, not revolting, nothing like the feeling when she had been touched by the elongated Resident before—

Mai Minghe simply threw caution to the wind, stopped looking at the model altogether, clenched her teeth, shut her eyes, and took one large step outward; she felt that body press flush against her and slide past—and when she opened her eyes, she had already made it to the door.

She quickly turned sideways and stood in the gap of the half-open door; only then did Mai Minghe glance back at the female model.

One arm still stretched straight out, a glass wine cup held in its hand, as if waiting for someone to clink glasses. From the back of its head, a curtain of light brown waves hung loosely over the front of its chest.

Carrying within her the resolve to face death and the hope of finding life beyond it, Mai Minghe turned her head away and stepped out through the stall door in a single stride.

In the dead silence, she found herself still alive.

...Did she—did she choose correctly?

She truly had chosen correctly.

She stood on the tile floor, breathing hard, heart pounding—there was no Mai Minghe lying on the floor outside.

Ahead of her was a row of sinks, and at the far left of the row stood the back of a woman touching up her makeup.

Mai Minghe's gaze came to rest on the space above the sinks—the place where a mirror should have been.

No wonder... no wonder she had climbed up and looked down earlier, and had still seen only the back of the woman touching up her makeup.

Because on the other side of the sinks, where the wall and mirror should have been, stood the same back of a woman touching up her makeup; and beside that woman's back stood another figure whose back Mai Minghe recognized at once—the same ZARA casual outfit, the same badly hacked-up hair on the back of a head.

...The "mirror" that should have reflected a face was instead reflecting a back that had no business being there?

Mai Minghe stared blankly at the back of the woman touching up her makeup, then looked at the bathroom door. If she sprinted from here and rushed out...

Wait—something in the edge of her vision had seemed off as she swept past it—Mai Minghe snapped her head around for a quick look, and only then did she see that there were only two toilet stalls in the bathroom in total.

One was the stall she had just crawled out of, where the female model sat; the other must be the one she had originally fallen into.

The stall she hadn't chosen had somehow vanished—at some unknown point in time?

Or had it simply never existed at all?

By the time Mai Minghe turned her gaze back around, the back of the woman touching up her makeup was standing right in front of her.

"Why did you come out of the left stall?"

A thin, reedy female voice came from that back of a head. Its right hand finally lowered from the motion of applying lipstick, still holding a tube of lip gloss.

Mai Minghe's voice and breath seemed to have seized up somewhere in her chest, unable to escape at all.

"Please answer carefully." The back of the woman's head spoke from within its thick hair. "Why aren't you speaking? Did you choose at random, happened to land on the fifty-percent chance, and now you can't explain yourself?"

Its tone made her heart clench—as if something dangerous would happen if she didn't answer.

"No. That's not it."

The moment Mai Minghe spoke, she found that her voice was trembling, like a plucked string that hadn't yet settled. "The scene where the female model clinks glasses with someone—that's the actual shooting location... right? That's why I chose the left stall."

The back of the head was silent, saying nothing.

Mai Minghe had no idea whether it was waiting for her to continue explaining, and even less idea what was about to happen; she couldn't help but keep talking, as though filling the silence with sound could delay the arrival of whatever unknown next step was coming.

"There was a mirror beside the model, and the retouching process erased her reflection in it—that part was actually quite easy to spot. But why erase the reflection, and why does an extra hand appear? I spent a long time thinking about it and couldn't figure it out... until I tried to understand the first line of the ad copy: 'Multiple reflections, embrace the possibilities.'

"That line is vague and not easy to parse, but a few key points can be drawn from it. First, there is more than one reflection; second, the reflections differ from one another, which is why there are different possibilities; third, I can choose one of those possibilities."

Trying to explain her own thought process to a frozen back-of-a-head had a genuinely nightmarish quality to it, absurd and uncanny...

All the more so because, right behind Mai Minghe, through the half-open door of the stall, another back-of-a-head was "watching" her.

Two figures—one in front, one behind—like mirror images of each other, with Mai Minghe sandwiched between them.

"Though it's a bit of a leap... based on that line of ad copy, I thought—could it be that in the ad image, the reflection that was erased from the mirror was different from reality? One version is clinking glasses; the other is drinking alone.

"Why erase the mirror reflection? Because if it were left in, you'd only need to look at the reflection to know which side was clinking glasses and which side was drinking alone. Now, through some technique, most of the reflection has been erased—leaving only a single difference: the third hand holding the glass.

"That way, anyone who sees the image has no way of knowing whether the female model in the actual shoot was clinking glasses with someone or drinking alone."

In other words, you can no longer tell the reflection from the real—once that clicked, the rest was easy enough to work out.

After all, the advertising copy read "Gather in this moment, share in its smoothness"; by that measure, a scene of two people clinking glasses would naturally convey "gathering" and "sharing" far better than drinking alone.

Thinking it through that way, the actual shoot must have been the "clinking glasses" scene that matched the copy.

That was exactly the reasoning Mai Minghe had held onto when she stepped out from the left stall.

If she had been in her aged body right now, no matter how clear her mind, Mai Minghe felt she never could have indulged in such "wild thinking."

That kind of "wild thinking" belonged to the young—older people had a harder time accepting new things, precisely because they struggled to dislodge fixed perceptions and lacked flexibility of thought.

With a young brain, it seemed she had naturally come to possess a young way of thinking—what was that called again?

She remembered hearing something about it before... "embodied cognition"?

"So... that's why I chose to come out from what I thought was the 'real' side, between the two options. That should be right, shouldn't it?"

The woman touching up her makeup stood completely still with her back turned and said, "No."

Mai Minghe froze. "What?"

"The advertisement says 'multiple reflections,'" the woman said, her voice thin and soft. "But if there is only one reflection and one actual shoot, it can hardly be called 'multiple reflections.'"

Mai Minghe listened in a daze—that did seem to be sound logic.

"In truth, both are reflections. Before you made your choice, there was no such thing as a 'real' one."

The back of the woman's head said: "Whichever you choose becomes the real one. If you had chosen to come out from the right stall, then the female model drinking alone would be the real shoot."

"Miss—may I call you that? Miss, are you saying it didn't matter which side I came out from? That all that thinking I did was for nothing?"

"Whether it was for nothing depends on how you look at it. I was rather hoping you'd come out from the right stall. The most ideal outcome, of course, would have been for you to crawl

under the door—but a dead end that obvious is hard to fool even the greenest Hunter. Ah, well."

The back of her head laughed a few times, the way one might speak—"Ha. Ha. Ha."—each syllable slow, enunciated clearly, evenly weighted, not sounding like laughter at all, only like someone saying the words "ha ha ha."

"Although both are reflections, the one you made real is also the one that aligns with the rule hints."

Mai Minghe didn't quite follow. "You mean... the reflection that doesn't align with the rule hints could also become real?"

"Yes," the back of her head said. "This restaurant can operate according to the rules, or it doesn't have to. If you had chosen to make the possibility that 'doesn't align with the rule hints' come true, this restaurant would be governed by chaos, disorder, and randomness.

"But since you've now made the possibility that 'aligns with the rule hints' come true, it means the rules, the logic, and the hints have all come online."

"Come online"? Online how, what line?

Was that a young person's expression too? From context, it probably meant something like "taken effect"?

The back of her head smiled at Mai Minghe.

No mouth, no features—just a curtain of hair covering the back of a skull that by all rights should have been incapable of showing a "smile"—and yet... it felt as though the scalp had stretched open like a face, pulling the hair into a curved, rippling arc, and Mai Minghe somehow read a smile in that hair.

"Would you like to leave this restaurant?" the woman who had been touching up her makeup said. "Then find my face."

I looked it up specifically—the board games mentioned in the story all have roughly a hundred years of history, so it's perfectly reasonable that Mai Minghe played them as a child.

I find rule-based horror very interesting, but the interest comes from novelty—once you pile on enough rules, they all start to blur together and lose their flavor: the same formula, do this, don't do that, when X appears do Z... I get bored of it pretty fast.

Didn't that animal-zoo rules horror story that was so popular a while back (was that the name?) end up releasing several sequels that barely made a splash? I think that's exactly why.

That reflection has little to do with the main text—what I'm writing doesn't really count as rule-based horror anyway (does it?).

So you won't get bored of it (card laid, card played) (jk)

PS: This chapter tortured me to death—I rewrote parts of it three times, drew diagrams at various points during the process, held up a mirror and took photos of myself—I looked like a complete lunatic...

Chapter 69: Mai Minghe's Face as She Responds to the Nest's Themed Event

Mai Minghe's gaze swept around the restroom and landed back on the back of the touch-up woman's head.

"Why?" she asked without warning.

The touch-up woman's back remained perfectly still. "...What do you mean, why?"

"I don't understand."

Mai Minghe had never heard of anything like this before: "I want to leave—what gives you the right to stop me? And what's all this about rules and hints? I never said I agreed to go along with any of this. Doesn't something like this require both parties to consent? What is this, some kind of forced transaction?"

The back of the head fell into silence.

"And another thing—you lost your face, so why are you making me find it? What does that have to do with me wanting to leave? It's not like you're going to use your face to open the door for me."

Nearly ten seconds passed before the touch-up woman slowly asked, "Have you...never been to the Nest before?"

"Of course I have," Mai Minghe didn't know if it could see her, but she wagged her finger at it all the same and said, "So don't try to pull rookie tricks on me."

"You need to find my face before you can leave." The touch-up woman emphasized it once more.

"Which is exactly why I'm asking you why," Mai Minghe sighed. "What's the connection between those two things? What's the basis for that? Let me put it this way—I tell you that you have to wash my feet before you're allowed to eat. Would you be okay with that?"

"No...no, I wouldn't..."

"Well, there you go."

A chill hung over the restroom as silence settled in for a long moment.

"Have you never...played a game?" the touch-up woman said, as though she had finally found the right word. "For a game to progress, you have to accept a quest—"

"A game like tag?"

"No, video games, console games, escape rooms—"

"Never heard of any of them."

The touch-up woman went quiet again.

"...You know epic novels? The Lord of the Rings?"

"Oh, that one I've read." Mai Minghe never expected that inside the Nest, she'd end up discussing human cultural works with a woman who only had a back. "You like it?"

"That's not—...Frodo accepted the quest of the One Ring and set out on his journey..."

"I get it," Mai Minghe said, "but I'm not Frodo. I don't want to accept the quest to find your face."

She stopped short of saying "I refuse"—what if the Resident flew into a rage?

"It doesn't matter, you have to go find it!" The touch-up woman's tone hardened. "If you want to leave, you must find my face."

"Why? Just borrow one from whoever's in that stall—it doesn't seem to be using it."

Mai Minghe wasn't trying to be difficult; she truly didn't understand—and she had a feeling that if she could get to the bottom of this, it might actually help with the whole "finding the face" business.

After all, it was starting to look like she was going to have to find that wretched face no matter what.

The woman's silhouette stood frozen for several seconds before she finally spoke again, her voice thin and careful: "I already told you—this is a restaurant. It can operate according to the rules, or it can operate without them. Your choice activated the rules, the logic, and the hints, and as a result, my face was forced to part ways with me. That is what the rules dictate."

Mai Minghe's attention, along with her ears, shot to attention.

"Let me ask you this—without a face, how am I supposed to eat? A restaurant is a place for people to eat, isn't it?" The touch-up woman's thin, delicate voice suddenly shot up, shrill and

frantic: "My face my face my face I need to eat I need to eat I need to eat—"

Mai Minghe instinctively stepped back half a pace and was just about to cover her ears when the touch-up woman's back of the head went calm again.

"I need to eat enough, and in time," she said slowly. "Because within this restaurant's territory, there are several other diners present at the same time. I need to eat enough before they do in order to hold this territory...Once you've found all the pieces of my face, I will start eating in earnest as a way of thanking you. Once I push the other diners aside, I'll allow you to leave the restaurant alive."

"Hold on—you mean that even after you get your face back, you still have to 'push the other diners aside' before you'll let me go? What if you can't push them aside?"

"Then all the more reason for you to find all my face pieces as soon as possible. The sooner I can start eating, the sooner I can let you out."

Even if it was a lie, she had no way to verify it.

Mai Minghe steadied her nerves and asked, "You said 'find all the pieces'—what do you mean, is there more than one piece?"

"I only have one face." The touch-up woman spoke from the back of her head. "The Nest is currently running a themed event...In response to this themed event, my face has shattered into seven pieces, scattered in various places throughout the restaurant. Your task is to follow the clues and collect all seven pieces of my face."

"What themed event? The Nest holds events?" Mai Minghe knew she should be moving quickly, but curiosity got the better of her.

Besides, it was rare to come across a Resident you could actually hold a conversation with—how could she not try to dig out as much information as possible?

"So you're not one of the Hunters who received a special summons invitation from the Nest, haha, ha." The touch-up woman spoke in her thin, delicate voice. "Since the Nest didn't issue you a 'summons invitation,' you have no right to be informed. Don't worry—not knowing about the themed event won't affect your ability to find my face. Now, can you go find it?"

She had originally thought she only needed to find one face; in the span of a few sentences, the difficulty had multiplied by seven.

"You have to give me some clues," Mai Minghe sighed. "Please, tell me everything you're supposed to tell me."

The touch-up woman's explanation took a worryingly long time.

Mai Minghe firmly believed that the faintest ink was better than the sharpest memory, so the moment the touch-up woman finished saying "all resources are available to you," she immediately went to the cosmetic bag on the counter, fished out the touch-up woman's light-brown eyebrow pencil, and stepped back into the bathroom stall—the female mannequin's face had rotated to her shoulder and was watching as Mai Minghe pulled down a few sheets of toilet paper.

As she leaned over the counter and wrote carefully on the toilet paper, the silhouette of "Mai Minghe" at the other end of the counter remained completely motionless, standing straight.

Under the gaze of her own back of the head, Mai Minghe jotted down row after row of key points on the paper.

"The rules maintain a certain degree of fairness. The seven pieces of face will be hidden in places that you, as an ordinary restaurant patron, would be able to see. They won't be hidden beneath the tiles behind the bar, won't be tucked inside the kitchen refrigerator, and won't be on the ceiling...and unless you receive a specific hint, they won't be hidden in another patron's clothing or bag either."

The touch-up woman seemed to think this point was important and emphasized it again: "As a general rule, they will be in places that an ordinary patron walking through the restaurant could spot with a careful look. Do you understand?"

That was a necessary constraint, at least—otherwise, shattered into seven pieces, each piece would be tiny, and in a restaurant this large, she could be searching until the cows came home.

The first piece was the forehead, including both eyebrows.

The second piece was the entire nose.

The third and fourth were the left and right eyes, respectively. From the philtrum to the chin, the section containing the mouth, was the fifth piece.

The left cheek and the right cheek were the sixth and seventh pieces.

Clues and hints were scattered throughout the restaurant—they might come from the written text on the menu, or from the conversations of dining patrons...all of it would need to be

unearthed by Mai Minghe, bit by bit.

In the process of finding the face, Mai Minghe held "priority rights," meaning she could search however she pleased without worrying about restaurant staff or other patrons stopping her.

"The restaurant is my home to begin with," the touch-up woman laughed softly. "I'm letting you search for something inside my own home—naturally no one will get in your way. However, the longer this drags on, the weaker your priority rights become. If you haven't found all seven pieces within thirty minutes, the other diners looking to claim my territory can start taking measures to slow you down."

Your hold on this territory isn't exactly ironclad then, is it—Mai Minghe swallowed that comment and only asked, "What kind of measures?"

"Within the first thirty minutes, every word they speak will have one of only two qualities: either clues and hints, or useless chatter.

"However, starting from the second half-hour, what they say will turn into nonsense, lies, and traps—no more clues or hints.

"Starting from the third half-hour, their actions will be unrestricted. They cannot kill you directly, but they can use indirect means to plant 'bombs' and 'dead ends' in the restaurant, or commission an agent to come after you."

Mai Minghe hadn't expected she'd have to risk her life to escape an environment that seemed, on the surface, not particularly dangerous—"Bombs? Dead ends? Agents?"

"A 'bomb,' you can think of as a place you shouldn't touch, or something you shouldn't say, or something you can't do, and so on. The specific forbidden zones are things you'll need to discover from the clues and hints. They'll lure you into triggering a forbidden zone, and if you fall for it, it's as good as detonating a 'bomb'...what happens to you after the detonation, I don't need to spell out."

The back of the head laughed softly. Even though it was Mai Minghe finding its face, imagining Mai Minghe's death seemed to bring it no small amount of pleasure.

"A 'dead end' is easy to understand. If you had crawled out under the stall door just now, you would have walked right into a dead end. Dead ends will always have a warning sign—like just now, didn't you see a reflection of yourself backing away toward you? However, the dead ends set by the other patrons may not have warnings as obvious as that one, so you'll need to be careful."

So once she left the restroom, if she still hadn't found all seven pieces after more than an hour, she'd be facing "bombs," "dead ends," and—"What's an agent?"

"You are my agent," the touch-up woman said. "The other diners may also find other Hunters to serve as their agents—if there happen to be any unfortunate Hunters nearby."

So there might also be a situation where she'd end up facing off against other Hunters?

Hopefully she wouldn't run straight into the Morgan House Faction Hunters—if they'd been sitting out in the restaurant this whole time, that would be quite the awkward situation.

Seeing that the touch-up woman's explanation was more or less finished, Mai Minghe let out a quiet sigh, carefully folded the sheets of toilet paper, and put them away.

The touch-up woman didn't even have a photo on her—she'd just have to search blindly.

"All right, I'll go out and find your face now."

After saying words that had never once left her lips in her eighty-six years of life, Mai Minghe asked, "Are you staying here to wait for me? If I run into a problem and need to ask, can I come back?"

"Yes, I'll be here waiting. Each time you find a piece, bring it to me right away. You can come back to ask questions, but don't forget—the more time you waste going back and forth, the worse it is for you."

The touch-up woman laughed softly: "I'm really looking forward to working with you. You want to get home soon too, don't you?"

Yesterday I had to make a work call, so I stayed up waiting until four-thirty in the morning, completely out of it. These past few chapters have been especially taxing on the brain—and I didn't have much of one to begin with. At this point it's been ground down to just a thin shell... eating grapes without spitting out the skins, except instead of grape skins, I'm spitting out brain skins.

Chapter 70: The Rules, Clues, and Hints of Mai Minghe's Restaurant

Pushing open the restroom door, Mai Minghe stepped into a short corridor.

She glanced left and right, slightly dazed, and followed the light, the music, the laughter, the scent of food, and the clinking of glasses forward, one step at a time—like someone slowly surfacing from a nightmare back into the human world.

Had what just happened in the restroom truly occurred? Searching for a face—how absurd a thing that was.

Compared to this restaurant, which felt so normal, so familiar, so warm—

Oh, right. She was in the Nest.

...After all, a typical restaurant in Blackmoor City probably wouldn't allow one guest to hold another guest's head inside their mouth.

Mai Minghe stared blankly at the man and woman seated at the table by the far wall—at least, in terms of body, they appeared to be a man and a woman—the one in the dress shirt had stretched their neck across to the other end of the table, their entire face and mouth stretched out taut by the head inside, bloated and swollen beyond measure, as though their skull had become pregnant.

A female neck adorned with a pearl necklace protruded from between those lips, connected to an upright body dressed in a slip dress.

That body raised one hand—wearing a wedding ring—and gently stroked the cheek of the man whose mouth held her (or its?) head; from within that cheek came the woman's muffled, soft laughter.

Was this how married couples in the Nest... expressed their affection?

The servers moving through the restaurant and the guests seated at the other tables seemed entirely unfazed by this, not a single glance cast toward that couple—nor did anyone look at Mai Minghe.

According to the lengthy explanation given by the woman who had been touching up her makeup, during the first thirty minutes, because Mai Minghe held the highest priority, she could freely inspect and search anywhere she liked; as long as she didn't initiate conversation with

anyone, no one would bother her—though naturally, in the next thirty minutes, that treatment would begin to deteriorate.

First things first: check whether there was a computer or television screen in the restaurant large enough for her purposes.

This was her last-resort escape route, and it had to come first...

But at that thought, Mai Minghe's train of thought broke off.

She watched a server walk past carrying a round tray lined with several wine glasses.

Each wine glass contained a small heap of flesh-colored, wrinkled somethings of indeterminate nature—except for one glass, where a tiny, naked, slack, and swollen human male was desperately clawing at the rim, trying to climb out, calling out in broken gasps as he struggled: "Help—help me, I'm a Hunter from Blackmoor City..."

"Wait," said Mai Minghe, grabbing the server's arm.

The face that turned toward her made her regret ever opening her eyes today.

"That... what's in those glasses of yours? Are those living people?"

The two thick, pink, fleshy tendrils extending from the server's eye sockets were remarkably expressive.

One tendril waved briefly over the tray and the wine glasses, as if taking a glance, then lifted, its tip pointing toward Mai Minghe.

"This is our latest wine," the server said in a perfectly ordinary voice. "Named—let me check the bottle. Ah, 'Andrew Cooper,' aged forty-two years. After he died in the Nest, his body dissolved and produced several bottles of wine. The selling point is that silky, wispy mouthfeel of a man going slightly bald, along with the aroma of bacon that's been soaking for years."

As it spoke, it picked up a glass and swirled it—the tiny man who hadn't yet managed to climb out immediately tumbled back down into the glass, as if he'd lost all strength, slumping against the side in the same flesh-colored, wrinkled heap as the rest.

Mai Minghe instinctively recoiled, and the server strode away.

Another table, apparently in the middle of a party, spotted the server carrying the drinks over from across the room and immediately broke into cheers; compared to the server, their

appearances were normal enough that her eyes felt like they could finally breathe—then, the next moment, as they all reached out to take their glasses, Mai Minghe immediately looked away.

When a person died in the Nest... something like this could still happen to them.

Mai Minghe couldn't quite describe the discomfort she felt in that moment.

That tiny figure in the wine glass was no longer alive—and yet was still calling for help.

She had never before seen anyone die in the Nest—she had heard from "Jonah" that Hunters who died in the Nest would be dissolved; but she had always assumed it was no different from a body being broken down by insects and bacteria, dust to dust, ashes to ashes.

Now, looking at all this... even in the face of danger, even with Taylor Ford trying to take the Serpent Band, going to Morgan House Faction to seek help for Jonah had still been the right choice.

She had never regretted it, and she regretted it even less now.

Mai Minghe steadied herself and took a careful look around the restaurant—it was a small establishment, its décor understated and elegant, with no second floor; a few steps in any direction was enough to take in the entire dining area at a glance.

But... there was no television.

The glass front door at the entrance was locked; she tried pushing it a few times, and sure enough, it wouldn't open.

The clock on the wall showed exactly one o'clock; outside the glass door, the Nest basked in the full bright light of afternoon, with dappled tree shadows on the road—this gave Mai Minghe a brief pause.

Perhaps it was a preconceived notion, but she had always felt the Nest was a dark and gloomy place; it had never occurred to her that, like Blackmoor City, it also had its own daytime.

Well then—it seemed she truly couldn't leave until she'd found all seven pieces of the face.

Mai Minghe sighed inwardly and strolled back into the restaurant.

Maybe she should bring a television screen next time? But what triggered her passage sense had to be a large screen—lugging an enormous screen around the Nest was hardly convenient...

While turning this over in her mind, she made a circuit of the restaurant, taking in the layout and all the dining guests, organizing everything into a mental map.

Entrance Glass Door

Long bar (servers, no guests) — Table 1 (empty) — Table 2 (two tables pushed together, seating six young guests apparently at a party)

Table 3 (the head-containing couple) — Central round table (empty, holding a large vase of flowers and a newspaper clipping) — Table 4 (against the mirrored wall, three female guests)

Table 5 (two men and one woman, appearing to be a couple and a friend) — Table 6 (against the mirrored wall, one male guest looking at a laptop)

Kitchen (door wouldn't open) — Decorative wall (covered with photographs and magazine pictures) — Short corridor to the restrooms — Restrooms

For now, Mai Minghe left the restaurant's menus and wine list untouched, and didn't yet read the newspaper clipping on the central round table—which, at a glance, was clearly a clue or hint.

The first thirty minutes were the most precious.

Only during this window would the Residents in the restaurant let slip clues and hints in conversation; once it passed, they would speak only in nonsense, lies, or verbal traps—physical clues could wait a little longer, they weren't going anywhere, but conversation had to be seized upon right now.

The guests and servers in the restaurant together numbered seventeen—far more than Mai Minghe had expected—and she worried thirty minutes might not even be enough; on top of that, surveying the layout had already cost her two or three minutes.

But then—how was she supposed to phrase her questions? None of the people in the restaurant would want her to collect all seven pieces of the face, would they?

After eighty-six years of life, this was the first time Mai Minghe had ever faced a situation like this.

She walked over to the large party table and prepared to listen in on the chatter of the young men and women for a bit—if she closed her eyes, it was truly hard to imagine the voices didn't belong to humans.

"...That tour group deal was such a bargain!" A young girl with golden collarbone-length hair patted her friend's shoulder and said to the table, "Xiao Wei and I booked it together, sharing one room, four days and three nights, only two hundred and eighty dollars..."

This is probably small talk, Mai Minghe thought, with some uncertainty.

From the conversation, this table seemed to be university students who hadn't yet graduated, and they happened to be swapping stories about their holiday trips and experiences. After listening for a while, none of it seemed to have anything to do with the restaurant, so Mai Minghe turned and walked toward the table of the head-containing couple—the man had been at it for several minutes and had finally, reluctantly, pulled his mouth away from his wife's head.

The wife's head was coated in dripping, viscous slime, her entire face glistening with a transparent, moist sheen, as if wrapped in a thin layer of jelly, her long hair plastered flat against her scalp and neck.

This time, Mai Minghe listened for a few lines, then spoke up.

"Is today your wedding anniversary?" She didn't know whether she needed to exchange pleasantries first, but given the limited time, she simply cut right in.

The wife glanced at her husband, then smiled at Mai Minghe. "That's right—our tenth anniversary. We're having lunch here."

She didn't sound reproachful, but the moment she finished speaking, the husband suddenly added in his own defense: "We're only having the one lunch because I've planned a boat trip for this afternoon. Don't let the size fool you—this restaurant has a long history, wonderful reviews, and many celebrities and distinguished guests have dined here."

Mai Minghe turned to glance at the decorative wall nearby and asked, "Are those photographs on the wall pictures of the celebrities who've eaten here?"

The celebrities of the Nest were obviously nothing like those of Blackmoor City—from a distance, those with human-looking faces were clearly in the minority.

They might also be clues.

"That's right." The wife seemed quite satisfied with the anniversary, her wet smile fixed in place the whole time, as if the muscles of her cheeks had been nailed there. "Douglas really does treat me well—he specially chose this restaurant and planned today's itinerary... and he even gave me an anniversary gift."

She stroked the pearl necklace at her throat and kept smiling. "This morning, before I even opened my eyes, I felt him creep up behind me, lift my hair, and wind something around my neck, pulling it tighter and tighter... Oh my, I thought he was going to strangle me, and I remember thinking, how sudden, this time."

The husband burst out laughing. "Well, it's not as if this is the first time I've tried to strangle you!"

At that, husband and wife dissolved together into laughter that Mai Minghe couldn't begin to understand.

"Oh, if there's one thing I'd complain about," the wife said, as if suddenly remembering something, "it's this: this restaurant never lacks for customers, so it does as it pleases. Look at that—perfectly good space, and they won't let anyone sit at the central table, just to memorialize the dead... So what if some celebrity who used to dine here passed away? Was there really a need to keep a vase of flowers there for them? It's an eyesore."

That's definitely a clue, Mai Minghe thought—though she could look at the newspaper clipping a little later; she still had quite a few conversations to get through.

The woman touching up her makeup had said that resources were free for the taking; Mai Minghe borrowed paper and pen from a server and wrote down what she believed might be the first rule.

1. The central round table cannot be sat at (?)

I'm catching a train this Saturday, and Sunday is the music festival, so I'll probably be taking Saturday off (I think)—after all, the Sunday festival is in the afternoon, so I might still manage to squeeze out a chapter update in the morning.

Qidian doesn't allow blank spaces, which means I can't use spacing to draw a seating chart in the main text... Not that it's strictly necessary, but I do like making readers feel at home (?).

If only Qidian allowed illustrations—my soulful artistic style could make an appearance every now and then and touch everyone's souls...

Chapter 71: Everything Mai Minghe Sees Seems Like Nonsense

The three female guests at Table 4 looked completely normal from head to toe—so normal, in fact, that Mai Minghe found herself a little unsettled.

They weren't Hunters, were they?

By the time she walked over and stopped beside their table, she had already begun to feel suspicious.

If they turned out to be Hunters called in by another diner, pretending to be guests to lull her into lowering her guard, and the moment the first hour was up they suddenly turned on her—that would be very bad.

"Oh, at my age, I've started paying attention to what I eat."

The female guest with a mole at the corner of her mouth said, "What can you do? Some of the things that seep down from Blackmoor City are delicious, sure—but the last time I ate a person's 'bedroom scent,' my entire face turned into that person's face, and it took days before it went back to normal."

...Probably not Hunters.

Mai Minghe found herself oddly relieved.

"True, it's not like when we first came into being," the other female guest, the one wearing glasses, said. "Back then our appetites were strong—we could digest anything. Hmm, all three of us were born from the same person's body, right? I remember that Hunter; her stomach was never great even when she was alive."

The three of them looked nothing alike whatsoever—how could they all have been born from the same person's body?

Mai Minghe glanced at the third woman—she looked the youngest, with dark brown skin—who let out a few smug little chuckles through her nose and said: "Not me, though. I don't watch what I eat. No wonder you two only ordered one fish."

Three people dining together, yet the table held only a single whole fish; among the other tables, the diner with the fewest dishes was the man staring at his laptop, and even he had two.

The fish's eyes kept darting from one person to another, and every so often a muffled, snickering "heh-heh" sound came from inside its belly, its slabs of flesh quivering along with it each time.

The bespectacled female guest raised a pale brown eyebrow and smiled: "What's wrong with one fish? Isn't it enough for the three of us?"

Mai Minghe decided all of this fell squarely under the category of nonsense. Before the fish's eyes could find her again, she turned and walked away.

The next table over was occupied by a middle-aged man who sat hunched over a laptop, brow deeply furrowed.

Like the three women, he looked no different from an ordinary person; even the food on his table was nothing more than a bowl of salad and a bowl of thick soup. He seemed to be dealing with something urgent—two phones and a laptop were spread across the table, and he was rushing back and forth between the devices, barely having touched his food.

"How long have you been sitting here?" Mai Minghe asked, noticing the thick soup looked like it had gone cold.

"Since last night," the male guest said without looking up. "Something urgent came up at work all of a sudden, and I can't even eat because of it. If you don't have anything important to say, I'm sorry, but I don't have time for small talk."

Did Nest Residents actually have to go to work?

Mai Minghe was just about to ask "what kind of work do you do," when she happened to glance up and swallowed the words back down.

His table, like the three women's, was pressed right up against the mirrored wall—one side of the seating backed against the mirror, the other side facing it.

Because he was sitting with his back to the mirrored wall, and had just bent down to rummage through his laptop bag, the laptop screen was reflected in the mirror—Mai Minghe started, and quickly moved around to his side to look: sure enough, on the laptop screen, she saw the man himself.

The man on the screen had his face twisted with terror; his white eyeballs looked ready to burst from their sockets, saliva and sweat slicking his face to a glistening sheen, his mouth opening and closing in a shape that looked like he was screaming "help."

Mai Minghe stepped back half a pace.

"Strange, did I forget to bring my power bank," the male guest muttered to himself, "terrible, my phone's going to die, where did it go... ah, good thing I brought the charger."

He pulled a charger with a cable from his bag, leapt up from his seat, and rushed toward the bar calling out "waiter"—as he passed, Mai Minghe caught a glimpse of his phone screen, which also showed his face: a gaping mouth had swallowed up the rest of his features, splitting his face open like a pitch-black hole.

Mai Minghe watched his retreating figure for a moment, then quickly walked over and opened his laptop bag.

Under normal circumstances, the face would only be hidden "somewhere an ordinary guest could see," but given a hint, it was also possible for it to be hidden in a diner's clothing or bag—that was what the woman touching up her makeup had said.

She wasn't sure whether what just happened counted as a hint; she didn't dare waste time, afraid the male guest might come back and cause more trouble. She spent only a few dozen seconds hastily searching through the laptop bag.

Never mind a face—the bag was completely empty, with nothing inside at all. The whole bag was like a stage prop.

Mai Minghe came away empty-handed, stood up, and glanced at the clock.

She had originally planned to make at least two full rounds; fifteen minutes had already passed, and she still hadn't managed to speak with one full table and two waiters—would there be enough time?

Mai Minghe hurried to the last table, where a couple and their friend were seated.

"I just went to get my teeth looked at," the male guest with ear studs said to the female guest with long hair. "You know how it is—my last set of teeth, they cost me a lot in compensation because the company they belonged to got sued, so they weren't very sharp or useful anymore. I went to the dentist and asked if there were any good new teeth available recently..."

The "teeth" got sued? Teeth could run a company—and pay damages?

Mai Minghe was certain she must have missed something; otherwise why couldn't she make sense of any of this?

The other male guest, who had one arm draped around the first, had clearly already known how the story was going to go, and shook his head with a sigh.

"Turns out that dentist was a total crook!" the ear-studded male guest said indignantly. "You'd think my old teeth could at least be traded in for a new set working in finance, right? I heard there's been a private equity fund in Blackmoor City lately that's been forcing a lot of bloody money out of individual franchise owners by acquiring chain brands—teeth that sharp, if they were mine, what couldn't I chew through? But guess what?"

The long-haired female guest shook her head.

So its "teeth" were... people from Blackmoor City? The more ruthless a person was, the sharper its "teeth"?

Mai Minghe's guess was quickly confirmed in the next sentence: "The dentist ended up fitting me with the most ordinary person! Sure, he'd stabbed some colleagues in the back before, but he bullies the weak and fears the strong—he's been keeping his head down and behaving himself for years... and now I can't chew through anything I eat. It's so annoying."

"Speaking of which, the taco you sent back to be remade—why isn't it here yet?"

The long-haired female guest was clearly not very interested in her friend's teeth, and turned her head to look around: "All they had to do was make the shell softer... you can't chew it but I can. Waiter!"

Mai Minghe didn't need to walk over; a waiter came hurrying up—she quickly lowered her eyes, not wanting to look too closely.

"I just checked with the kitchen," the waiter explained apologetically. "Here's the thing—the softest taco shell we make isn't made in-house; it's ordered from Cowboy Hill Chase. Given everything that's happened recently... I wasn't sure if you'd mind?"

What had happened recently? Was that a clue too?

The ear-studded male guest opened his mouth wide at the waiter—as far as Mai Minghe could tell, there were no teeth in his mouth at all—and asked: "Do you think my current teeth can chew through a Cowboy Hill Chase taco shell?"

"No problem at all."

"Then bring it," said the ear-studded male guest's boyfriend, waving a hand dismissively.
"We're not afraid of that."

Afraid of what, exactly?

Mai Minghe wanted to ask the waiter, but the other party moved too fast—before she could open her mouth, the waiter had already turned and headed toward the kitchen.

There was still another waiter at the bar; she glanced at the clock and hurried over.

The man who had been on his laptop was now standing at the bar, holding up a two-pronged charging plug and venting his frustration at the waiter behind the counter: "Your restaurant has a decent enough reputation—how do you not even have a working outlet? I can't get my charger to fit in at all! Is there anywhere else I can charge?"

"No," the waiter said. "I'm not in the business of charging people's devices."

The moment the irritated man left, Mai Minghe immediately stepped up and asked the waiter: "What's been happening with Cowboy Hill Chase recently?"

"Are you a reporter?" The waiter leaned its face a little closer—even as Mai Minghe strained her eyes to avoid it, a small sliver of it still crept into her peripheral vision. "That whole thing has nothing to do with us, none of it. Besides, hasn't it all already been in the papers? Why are you asking?"

The papers?

There was, in fact, a newspaper in this restaurant—the clipped article on the central round table.

In memory of the deceased celebrity, two chairs had been placed beside the central round table, as though someone were expected to come and dine. A large, vibrant bouquet of fresh flowers sat on the table, and unexpectedly, there was not the slightest trace of anything strange or repulsive about them—they were beautiful, full of life.

The clipping beside the vase carried an obituary for a female celebrity. In addition to the death notice, it appeared to cover her life story and cause of death—a dense block of text, accompanied by a photo of a sweet, smiling face—looking, for all the world, indistinguishable from an ordinary human being.

Only ten minutes left, and she hadn't found a single piece of a face; she couldn't afford to waste the chance to gather clues by reading a newspaper.

She had already made one round, but those had all been only brief exchanges; if she could linger a little longer at each table, who knew whether something might slip out?

Mai Minghe was naturally a bit of a rambler herself—she knew better than anyone that once someone got going, all sorts of things could slide out of their mouth before they knew it.

She simply started over from the table with the six young people, intending to go through the whole room again from the beginning.

"...I'd kill for Robbie's blue eyes, honestly, they're so stunning," one of the girls was saying, apparently chatting about a celebrity. "No wonder the lead singer of Sewer Boys was crazy about her."

Nest Residents were, surprisingly, quite... human?

"Come on, eat up, the food's going cold," said the girl with golden collarbone-length hair, cutting a trembling, sweating pink chunk of meat from her plate and taking a bite, her eyes lighting up: "Mmm, it's so good! Xiao Wei, do you want to try some of my 'pain meat'?"

Just hearing the name was enough to make Mai Minghe feel queasy.

The girl addressed as Xiao Wei—the same one who had just been wishing for blue eyes—looked at the pain meat her friend had just placed on her plate, then suddenly tilted her head to one side. The expression that crossed her face made Mai Minghe's heart lurch, and she drew back the step she had just taken.

"You're offering me some of yours, so of course I'll eat it."

Xiao Wei lifted her fork, but instead of spearing the pain meat, she stabbed a piece of broccoli from the golden collarbone-length girl's plate and put it in her mouth.

Huh?

Why...

Had she found the second rule?

Wait—if her guess was right, didn't that mean that after the first hour was up, Mai Minghe could never safely approach the three women's table again?

Two days in a row without much sleep, and a whole day of this—exhausted to death, downing coffee by the gulp and it's done nothing... Right, a research-minded reader in the comments, @奎醅, drew a floor plan of the restaurant, so I don't have to torture my soul trying to describe it!

(Not that I even know how to insert images in the Qidian backend.)

Chapter 72: Mai Minghe, Cowboy Hill Chase Company

To test her suspicion, Mai Minghe glanced at the clock and called out softly, "Xiao Wei?"

Xiao Wei turned its head, expression blank, its cheek puffing and deflating in rhythmic surges—the broccoli was apparently still putting up a fight inside its mouth.

"What?" It looked somewhat displeased.

"Do you... not like the pain-meat?"

"No, the pain-meat is fine."

"Then do you especially like broccoli?"

"Broccoli?" Xiao Wei said. "Oh, you mean that green thing I just ate? It isn't broccoli. It's steamed face-pore tumor balls with raised nodules, dyed with food coloring."

Mai Minghe desperately wanted to scrub her ears with her hands—the ears those words had passed through felt like they simply could not stop aching.

"...So you really love that steamed, steamed-whatever thing?"

"Not at all." Xiao Wei pointed to its face and said, "It's very hard to chew—the fibers are too thick. See, it's still thrashing around in my mouth right now."

The possibility of taste preference had been ruled out; the next question could now begin to directly test her suspicion.

"When you're invited to eat something, can you refuse?" Mai Minghe asked softly.

Xiao Wei swallowed what was in its mouth with a gulp and smiled.

"...That depends on you," it answered. "As long as you're willing to pay the corresponding price, you can certainly choose to be a rude and discourteous person."

"What price?"

Mai Minghe hurried to press the question. But she had momentarily overlooked something: during the first half-hour, what the diners told her would indeed be either "nonsense" or a "hint"—but the woman retouching her makeup had never said that just because she asked, there would necessarily be an answer.

Xiao Wei had barely opened its mouth and hadn't even started speaking when the other two young people laughed and called out to it: "Hey, it's your turn! Which celebrity makes you want to swallow them whole and take their place the most?"

Its attention was immediately diverted, and it began thinking with great enthusiasm: "Hmm... can I pick two and combine them? I want Robbie's eyes, and..."

After that, the young people's conversation drifted back to celebrities and famous figures, and no matter how many times Mai Minghe tried to interject, she came away with nothing.

She had only five or six minutes left—she couldn't waste all of them on Xiao Wei. Besides, she already had a fairly solid grasp of the second rule.

Who should she approach next?

A burst of laughter suddenly erupted from behind her, giving Mai Minghe a small start.

She turned to look and found that at the table where the lovey-dovey couple sat, only the husband's laughter remained—and it was twice as loud as both of them together had been—while the wife had clamped both hands tightly around her own throat with what appeared to be considerable force: her face had turned a swollen purple, the veins bulging fiercely, and her eyeballs were protruding so high they had nearly cleared her brow bone.

"Yes, yes, just like that," the husband said with what seemed like great delight. "Exactly the same face you made this morning when you received your gift—except the eyeballs need to bulge a bit more, until they pop out past the eyelids."

The wife finally lowered her hands, smoothed her long flowing hair, and said, "You still do it better. When I do it myself, my eyeballs never protrude that high."

With no time to marvel at the sheer depth of Nest residents' depravity, Mai Minghe was now doubly sensitive to anything connected to "faces." She quickly walked over a few steps and quietly studied the wife's eyes—but no matter how she looked, those eyes seemed entirely its own, not something that could be removed.

There were supposed to be seven faces. How had she failed to find even one?

Mai Minghe couldn't help but want to sigh. After silently grumbling about the Nest's baffling themed activities, she was just about to step toward the next table when the wife suddenly caught her in a sideways glance.

Then it quickly looked at the clock on the wall.

As the couple laughed and resumed their conversation, the hair on the back of Mai Minghe's neck stood on end.

...So she wasn't the only one keeping track of the time.

Were all the diners in the restaurant quietly waiting for the first half-hour to end?

The woman retouching her makeup had said that they couldn't directly attack her... tactics like setting "bombs" and "dead ends" could only begin after a full hour had passed.

That meant for the next thirty minutes, as long as she stopped listening to the diners and focused on uncovering the rules and hints, she would still be safe—for now.

Where on earth were those seven faces?

Even knowing that the diners' conversation contained clues, finding the seven faces was still incredibly difficult.

Take right now: Mai Minghe drifted slowly through the restaurant, and aside from the lone male guest staring at his laptop, every table around her was filled with people talking, the hum of overlapping conversations rising and falling.

Choosing to listen at one table meant she would miss the conversations at the other four—what if she had already missed a crucial clue?

Suppressing a creeping anxiety, Mai Minghe stood in the center of the restaurant and slowly swept her gaze around the room.

Plates of food on tables, the sound of conversation, the diners' faces, her own reflection in the mirrors, the expressionless server behind the bar... she suddenly felt as though she had been sealed at the bottom of a well, surrounded on all sides by walls she could not begin to understand.

"Last time I ran into a Hunter, he was so handsome," the female guest with dark brown skin said with a laugh. "It would really be such a waste if he didn't die in the Nest..."

"...When we go out to sea later, I'm planning to fish," the husband was proposing. "Who knows, we might pull up something good. Didn't a man fall into the bay in downtown Blackmoor City recently? If we managed to drag that corpse into the Nest, we'd really hit the jackpot."

"Have you been following Blackmoor City's entertainment news?" At the party table, one of the young people asked: "I've been very interested in human celebrities lately... I heard there was a

singer who had some kind of accident and almost opened a passage, but it never ended up happening. So many residents were waiting for her to come..."

"What a shame for her fans in the Nest!" Xiao Wei said with a laugh.

Mai Minghe turned around; the clock on the wall had just ticked to 1:29.

She was starting to feel a little lightheaded from listening to so much, and the conversation at the male couple's table had nearly slipped past her ears entirely.

"...I hate risk," the female guest at the male couple's table was saying at that moment. "The more people who know about this, the greater the risk— isn't that obvious? Why go looking for even more Hunters to join the competition? You should snuff it out with the very first person who finds out."

"Without any competition, the first person who knows would very likely collect all seven things themselves," the earring-wearing male guest said dismissively. "Think about it—what if that person doesn't enter the Nest themselves, but uses other Hunters to find the items for them? We can't kill every Hunter who goes into the Nest. If we let him keep searching at his own pace, sooner or later he'll gather everything."

"Then you could send a Resident who can go into the human world to kill him in Blackmoor City. Anyway, anything that involves risk, I hate..."

Just as the female guest said this, she suddenly stopped; every sound in the restaurant died in the same instant.

The scattered fragments of conversation that had been buzzing from all directions a moment ago—dizzying, disorienting—fell in that instant into a dead silence.

Mai Minghe looked at the clock.

...1:30.

The second thirty minutes had begun.

One breath later, the clatter of cutlery and the sound of conversation and laughter in the restaurant resumed their ebb and flow—as if they had never stopped at all.

There was no longer any need to listen to the diners talk, but just as Mai Minghe was about to walk toward the central round table, something stirred in her mind, and she remained where she was, tilting her head to listen for a while longer.

The party table was still chatting about the singer who had nearly entered the Nest; the couple continued discussing their sea fishing; at the male couple's table, they had begun analyzing what constituted "necessary risk"; at the three women's table, they were still going on about how the handsome Hunter needed to die in the Nest...

After 1:30, every table's conversation was still continuing along the same theme as before.

Which meant... in the last few minutes of conversation before 1:30, there had been no clues at all.

It was a simple piece of logical reasoning: during the first thirty minutes, the diners would only speak "nonsense" and "hints"; once the second thirty minutes began, "hints" no longer existed.

Since they were still continuing their earlier topics, that meant those topics had not been "hints."

Mai Minghe let out an involuntary sigh.

If those topics weren't hints, then what was?

When she picked up the clipping, she had hoped with all her heart that it would tell her something about the faces; but after reading a few lines, she couldn't help but be startled—she even forgot about the clues for a moment.

She hadn't expected that the deceased celebrity—the owner of the sweet, smiling face in the photograph—was a human.

"...Her last visit to the Nest had been when she was eight years old. While children stumbling into the Nest by accident are hardly rare, and we had long grown tired of killing them, Summer's singular personality and charming appearance quickly won her the adoration and welcome of the Nest's Residents, and overnight she became the universally beloved 'Nest's Daughter.' Sadly, after Summer returned to Blackmoor City, she never visited the Nest again in the twenty years that followed...

"Twenty years later, Summer's second visit to the Nest caused a sensation one can only imagine—it would not be an overstatement to say the streets emptied out to greet her. To think that a perfectly ordinary person from Blackmoor City could so thoroughly capture the hearts of the Nest's Residents—she even received a special lunch invitation from the 'Black Heart Restaurant'..."

Wait—Black Heart Restaurant?

Mai Minghe looked at the menu on the empty table number one. Wasn't that the very restaurant she was in right now?

"Summer's task was to successfully finish a lunch at Black Heart Restaurant—simple enough, wasn't it? Yet, as it turned out, it was precisely this simple thing that killed our 'Nest's Daughter.' She failed to uncover all the clues and hints in time, and so she never discovered the hidden rule that ultimately killed her..."

Mai Minghe's gaze came to rest on that line.

"Any human who touches any product from the 'Cowboy Hill Chase' company will die on the spot."

The third rule... so the rule was that she must not touch any product from the "Cowboy Hill Chase" company.

No wonder that male guest had told the server, "We're not afraid of that"—if Cowboy Hill Chase products only killed humans, then as Nest Residents, they naturally had nothing to fear.

Mai Minghe finished reading the clipping and set it back where she had found it.

When the young girl named Summer had entered this restaurant, that rule must have been buried extremely deep—which was precisely why it had ultimately killed her.

After her death, the Nest restaurant had turned around without missing a beat and printed that hidden rule plainly in the clipping, making it the most obvious rule of the next round of the task...

As if to mock Summer's death as utterly worthless.

At this moment, Mai Minghe had no desire to approach any Resident in search of clues.

The Nest schemed relentlessly to kill every person who entered—even its own "Nest's Daughter."

So what about her?

In this task of finding the seven faces, was there some trap hidden and waiting to kill her as well?

Yes... the woman retouching her makeup had only said that starting from the third half-hour, the diners could begin setting "bombs," "dead ends," and proxies.

But she hadn't said what would happen in the restaurant starting from the fourth half-hour, if Mai Minghe still hadn't collected all seven faces.

At that point, would the diners be able to come after her directly?

The mission of Mai Minghe looking for the face — I actually had the whole thing fully planned out: where the face is, how to find it, what the clues and rules are, what goes wrong... The thing is, when you've thought everything through so thoroughly, there's one problem: I can't be bothered to write it.

Chapter 73: Mai Minghe's First Face

Ten minutes later, Mai Minghe found the fourth rule.

The rule wasn't easy to find; but finding it required no logical deduction, only a little care.

The fourth rule was buried deep on the last page of the menu, at the very bottom beneath all the listings of drinks and spirits, written in near-matching ink of ant-sized, thin, faint characters: "Do not touch the faces of dining guests."

If Mai Minghe hadn't pressed her nose almost flat against the menu and gone over it inch by inch, she might have truly missed it.

The line below the rule was a definition of "face"—"the guest's forehead including both eyebrows, the entire nose, the left and right eyes, the left and right cheeks, from the philtrum to the chin."

The seven faces she was looking for, when placed on a diner's body, were precisely the parts that couldn't be touched... quite a fitting correspondence.

This also seemed to explain why the diners all looked so normal—if they looked like the waitstaff, who could say whether the flesh buds growing out of their eye sockets counted as part of "the face"?

On the slip of paper in her hand, Mai Minghe had organized a total of four rules:

First, no one may sit at the central round table (?);

Second, when a diner invites you to eat something, you must eat (otherwise there is a price to pay, price unknown; given that even Xiaowei refused to pay it, best not to risk it herself), but it seems you cannot eat the specific food the diner invited you to eat (so when Xiaowei was invited to eat the pain-meat, that's why she chose "broccoli"?);

Third, humans must not touch any products of the "Cowboy Hill Chase" company, or they will die on the spot;

Fourth, do not touch the faces of dining guests.

The rules had been found, yet Mai Minghe still had no idea what the hints and clues were, let alone where the seven faces might be hidden.

Could there be something she'd missed?

"What if I missed some clue earlier because I didn't have enough time?"

She hurried back to the restroom, pushed the door open, and stuck just her head in, calling out: "After all, I'm alone, and I have to question seventeen people—"

The back of the touch-up woman stood motionless in the corner of the restroom, still holding a large red lipstick in her hand.

"No, you haven't missed a thing. All the clues have already been given to you." It asked softly, "What's the matter—can't you find even a single face?"

"...I'll find them." Mai Minghe wasn't sure whether this counted as good news. She asked again, "After an hour and a half has passed, can the diners directly attack me?"

"They can."

Mai Minghe's heart lurched.

"Haven't I said so? The longer the time passes, the freer their movement becomes. From the fourth thirty-minute interval onward, all diners may move freely and attack you directly... I do so want to see what that scene will look like." The touch-up woman said with a quiet, drawn-out laugh.

"So I'd better find all the faces within the next hour?"

"If you want to stay alive."

"What if I only find one of the faces after the fourth thirty-minute interval begins and they snatch it from me? How do I defend myself?"

Mai Minghe truly didn't dare picture the sight of the diners in the restaurant all rising from their seats and turning to face her. She had not so much as a stick on her, and in such a small restaurant, there was nowhere to hide either.

She and the touch-up woman were, more or less, on the same side with aligned interests, weren't they? If she brought up the faces deliberately, perhaps the touch-up woman would offer her some means of self-defense?

Mai Minghe thought it through rather neatly, but the other party's answer disappointed her.

"There's no need to worry about that. Once a face is in your hands, the rules recognize that you've found it—just bring it back to me, since I'd like to start eating as soon as possible." The touch-up woman said softly, "As for how you defend yourself... aren't you a Hunter? Do you ask Residents to protect you every time you enter the Nest?"

She truly was not a Hunter—but Mai Minghe didn't say so aloud.

"But aren't you afraid that I'll die out there before I collect all the faces?"

"If you die, the restaurant rules go offline, the task is cancelled, and I can still reclaim my faces." The touch-up woman laughed softly. "You dying would be quite the substantial source of nourishment. It's just that once the task begins, we must all act according to the rules. Before you collect all the faces, the other diners may move against you—but once you have collected them all, they, like me, can no longer kill you; instead they must see you safely out."

"So no matter how things end for me, you always come out ahead?" Mai Minghe let out a bitter laugh.

"The longer you take to find the faces, the longer my stomach goes hungry—I have it hard too, you know." The touch-up woman said, "You've already wasted five minutes. Wasting time is extremely disadvantageous for you. Aren't you going out to find the faces right away?"

Mai Minghe, who couldn't even summon the energy to snap back, turned on her heel without another word and left.

So the entire restaurant task was a trap—one that had snared her completely.

From her perspective, there were landmines and dangers at every turn; she had to rack her brain and watch every step, and all she could win back was her own life, which was already the best possible outcome—yet for the Residents, the worst case was simply a return to the status quo.

In her entire life, she had encountered countless infuriating things, and this one could probably rank in the top ten.

The human world was unfair, and the Nest was no different.

Mai Minghe quickly swept through the restaurant several times, checking under tables, under chairs, and in every corner—there was no human face lying anywhere.

Even though she knew the diners couldn't touch her yet, she still kept far away from the table with the three female guests—when searching, she crouched down on the opposite side and peered

at the underside of their table from a distance.

After all, theirs was the only table in the entire restaurant that had nothing on it but a single fish.

If the second rule she'd deduced was correct, then the moment the female guests invited her to eat the fish, she was finished.

At that point, she would be trapped in a situation where she had no choice but to violate the second rule: she could neither refuse to eat, nor choose a different food to eat instead.

Judging from the current situation, the consequence of breaking a rule was almost certainly death; which meant that "the female guests inviting her to eat the fish" was essentially a death trap—checkmate.

So Mai Minghe not only kept her distance, but also deliberately avoided the female guests' gazes, refusing any eye contact with them whatsoever; yet looking under their table, she saw nothing beyond six human legs.

...Half of the second thirty-minute interval had already passed.

She took out the piece of tissue paper on which she had recorded key words in eyeliner pencil while in the restroom, compared the light-brown writing against the black ballpoint writing for a moment, then put it away again, still without a single clue.

Maybe she should go look at the decorative wall again?

Mai Minghe put away her notes, crossed through the dining area, and walked toward the decorative wall covered in photographs and magazine clippings.

For reasons she couldn't quite explain, some tables had food that was strange and revolting—like that fish and the "broccoli"—while others had food that was not only normal but even fragrant and appetizing, like the plate of steaming-hot tacos in the waiter's hands.

"Took long enough," the male guest with the earring complained as the waiter distributed the six tacos across the three diners' plates.

At the next table over, the head-bowed couple had lapsed into silence, one staring at the wall on one side, the other at the wall on the other side—Mai Minghe followed the wife's gaze and found it was studying its own reflection in the mirrored wall, its expression hollow and vacant, carrying an unexpected trace of melancholy.

Under the watchful eyes of the two waitstaff, Mai Minghe approached the decorative wall once more.

As if to emphasize their connection with the celebrities, the face of every celebrity in every photograph was sharp and clear, blown up large.

Most of the photos had been taken while the celebrities dined at this restaurant, with familiar backgrounds; below each photo was a name and a date—none of which Mai Minghe recognized, of course—and more than a few of the names weren't even written in human language; the moment her eyes landed on them, it felt as though countless dark, writhing things were crawling from her eyeballs into her brain.

She didn't dare linger on those, so her gaze settled only on the ones written in human script. Generally speaking, if the name was written in human language, the celebrity's appearance was also more or less human:

In the photo labeled "Pet Shop Owner, photographed June 21, 2024," a middle-aged woman with a sullen expression was captured only from the chest up, too close to tell whether she was holding a pet;

In the photo labeled "Robert Selges Jr., photographed Christmas 2025," a curly-haired man of about forty was draping an arm around a waiter's shoulder and grinning at the camera;

In the photo labeled "Robbie Margaret, photographed August 5, 2023," a brown-eyed woman with a long, graceful neck and an elegant hairstyle was tilting her head, laughing as she clinked glasses with something that didn't look human;

"Summer, died September 3, 2026"—in this photo, a girl with a taut expression and a pale face sat at Table Four, just reaching out to pick up a taco from the table in front of her.

Seeing it again, she still felt deeply unsettled. They had captured the very moment before Summer's death and pasted it on the wall...

The clippings' endless words of "fondness" and "regret" were soaked through with a twisted delight, as though her death were something the Nest's Residents could savor, toy with, and find endlessly satisfying forever.

Were all of these vile things in the Nest truly born from humans at their source?

Mai Minghe had no desire to look any further and turned to leave; but before she had taken a single step, she suddenly stopped and turned back.

Hadn't the touch-up woman said that things could be taken freely? Did that include photographs?

Mai Minghe glanced back at the waitstaff.

Behind the bar, those two faces that made anyone uncomfortable to look at were now staring straight at her—but even as she pulled a photograph off the wall and tucked it into her trouser pocket, neither of them uttered a single word to stop her.

Just as she thought... paper and pens could be taken, and so could photographs.

Since she couldn't bring Summer's remains back to Blackmoor City, she would at least take this photograph.

Even if it was only the last fleeting image of her before she died, Summer surely would have wanted to go home.

Mai Minghe turned around once more.

This time, just as she was about to take a step forward again, she suddenly froze.

...She had found the first face.

I'm about to die from exhaustion, haven't slept properly in an entire week... I have to get up early tomorrow to catch a bus—yes, not taking the train anymore, switching to the bus, I'm heading home like a migrant worker, because the music festival is in some middle-of-nowhere place...

I'm taking tomorrow off and won't be updating. Anyone who wants to come chat is welcome to. The day after tomorrow, before I head out to the music festival in the morning, I'll try my best to get a chapter written!

Chapter 74: Mai Minghe's Harvest in the First Hour

...Just now, Little Wei had clearly said that what it envied most was "Robbie's blue eyes."

The Robbie Little Wei mentioned, and the "Robbie Margaret" in the photograph—they had to be the same person, right?

The woman in the photo on the wall had her face turned to the side, mid-conversation, with only one eye visible—an eye that was unmistakably brown.

What if that eye was one of the face pieces she needed to find...

But the eye in the photograph should be flat and two-dimensional—how could a three-dimensional eye be passed off as one?

Even at her height of one-seventy-two, Mai Minghe still had to stand on her toes and stretch her arm to reach the photograph pinned at the very top. Her fingertips felt across the smooth surface of the photo, and even though she had already braced herself, she couldn't help drawing a quiet breath.

Eyelashes—

She had actually felt eyelashes on the photograph.

Beneath the lashes was a moist, smooth eyeball; at the touch of her finger, it flinched as if startled, rolling around with a spin.

This was hardly the time to admire the Nest, yet Mai Minghe couldn't stop a wave of wonder from rising in her.

"Huh? How did they do this—how is it hidden so seamlessly?" She looked around, almost wishing a Resident would come over and explain it to her, but the waiter only stood far away behind the bar, pointing its four fleshy growths from its eye sockets in her direction, motionless. "One is a photograph, and one is a living eye—how were they fitted together like that?"

But they truly had been fitted together.

She peeled the photograph off the wall, and the eye area of the photo was empty—a hole had been cut along the outline of the real eye; the human eye itself remained on the wall. When Mai Minghe looked up at it, its pupil happened to be looking down, meeting her gaze.

How to take it down?

Holding that question in mind, Mai Minghe reached out and worked at it a little—to her surprise, it was like pulling something out of mud: the eye gradually came loose from the wall.

It was indeed a three-dimensional human eye, but more than half of it had been embedded in the wall, leaving only a surface exposed to the outside; when it was positioned just right and framed within the hole in the photograph, it looked naturally like the eye of the person in the photo.

She'd finally found it...

Mai Minghe let out a soft breath, holding carefully in her palm that human eye wrapped in upper and lower lids, blinking every now and then, uncertain whether she felt more fascinated or a little frightened. She couldn't afford to linger; cradling the eye, she ran straight to the restroom—and all the way there, every diner stopped talking and stared as she ran past, their faces blank.

The makeup-touching woman seemed to have sensed it coming.

It was still standing in the corner of the restroom, but one arm had stretched out from behind its back, the hand that held no lipstick turned upward, extending a flat open palm toward Mai Minghe.

"That's my eye," it said, apparently delighted, its voice thin and sharp, words tumbling one after another: "Well done... Good, now hurry and find the next piece the next piece the next piece the next piece!"

This thing seemed rather unstable. Mai Minghe quickly backed out of the restroom.

A triumphant start—she was greatly encouraged.

"Maybe I actually have some potential as a Hunter," she murmured to herself as she walked back into the dining area, steering well clear of the table with the three female diners. "I've been in here twice now and I'm still alive..."

Her second life had only just begun, and she didn't even know what to do with it to make the most of this second chance.

She wanted to live completely differently from her last life—and perhaps trying her hand as a Hunter was exactly the way to start.

Even from a purely practical standpoint, she needed to figure out the workings of the Nest and the Hunters as quickly as possible—after all, there was a Hunter House Faction out there actively hunting the Artifact she carried.

"Don't even think about hitting the jackpot on your wedding anniversary," the wife at table three said, with a note of impatience: "Even if you managed to drag a corpse into the Nest, the odds of that corpse happening to have a passage are only one percent..."

The restaurant had filled back up with a low hum of conversation. As Mai Minghe wove between the tables, she was mentally reviewing whatever hints each table might have offered; the diners' current exchanges were ones she had no need to listen to, yet stray words kept brushing past her ears whether she wanted them or not.

"The Nest has been around so long, and it just keeps producing phenomena like this—nobody knows why. What do you expect anyone to do about it?" The man with the ear studs waved a taco, still deep in a discussion Mai Minghe couldn't follow.

"Oh, so that woman actually shoved her face into..."

That last sentence was like a hook—it stopped Mai Minghe dead in her tracks, her neck twisting involuntarily toward where the voice had come from. By the time she realized the speaker was the dark-brown-skinned figure at the table of three female diners, she and it were already staring at each other.

It seemed to have been waiting for exactly that—for Mai Minghe's attention to be reeled in.

"Looks like you don't have anywhere to sit?" the dark-brown-skinned one said at once, smiling as it called out to her. "Come on, sit here! Let's have a chat!"

It patted the empty chair beside it with a vigorous slap. The fish on the table, picked down to bare bones, gave a startled full-body shudder.

How could this be? Mai Minghe immediately glanced up at the clock on the wall—the first hour hadn't passed yet; there were still ten minutes left. The diners should only be able to say meaningless things to her, tell lies, or set verbal traps; they still couldn't take any action against her.

So was it inviting her over now so it would be easier to make a move on her in a moment?

Mai Minghe was afraid that saying anything more to that female diner might stir up some unexpected complication; she lowered her eyes, shook her head without a word, and turned to walk

away.

The female diner made a clicking sound with her tongue behind Mai Minghe's back, as if genuinely disappointed.

Six face pieces still to go—no matter how she looked at it, there was no way to find them all in ten minutes...

Mai Minghe passed by the table of the lone male diner, then suddenly paused, stepped back, and took a careful look at his table.

The thick soup and salad hadn't been touched. It was still staring at the computer screen in deep thought; if there was anything different from before, it was that one phone was missing.

Right—it had mentioned earlier that one of its phones had run out of battery. A phone dies, you put it away. That seemed perfectly normal.

But looked at from another angle: a phone that had appeared on the table during the "thirty minutes when hints are present" had vanished from the table during the "thirty minutes when hints disappear"—didn't that mean the phone was likely a "clue"?

The phone itself probably wasn't the clue, since there was still another identical phone on the table. The clue had to lie in the difference between the two phones.

The one that had disappeared—it had been the one that wouldn't charge...

By the time Mai Minghe's thoughts caught up with her body, she was already striding up to the bar; ignoring the fleshy growths the waiter kept trained on her, she propped herself against the bar and leaned in to look—and sure enough, there was the outlet the lone male diner had complained about as "broken-down and falling apart."

The Nest seemed to follow Blackmoor City's template and specifications, keeping even details like outlets in sync. A standard outlet in Blackmoor City should look like this:

| |

| |

The upper slot of the bar's outlet already had a coffee machine's plug inserted in it; the plug was the standard shape, meaning the upper socket was fine—but the outlet as a whole looked like this:

| |

/-\

The shape of the second row of slots looked uncannily familiar no matter how she stared at it... The plastic plate of the outlet was a pure white, yet those two narrow, elongated openings slanted outward in a splayed shape—weren't they just like a pair of nostrils?

"Hey, move out of the way—"

In her excitement, Mai Minghe didn't even hesitate to touch the waiter; she shoved aside its face, which kept leaning and probing around in front of her—the rules only said she couldn't touch the faces of dining guests; waiters weren't included—and reached in, feeling around the edges of the openings. Sure enough, the texture wasn't plastic at all; it felt more like skin.

It had been embedded in the wall. The entire nose had sunken into the surface behind the outlet, leaving only a pair of nostrils to serve as the sockets; even the ring of skin around the nostrils had been painted white—this was outright deception, practically cheating.

Mai Minghe tried gripping the outlet cover panel and found it wasn't sealed to the wall; she pulled hard, and the panel came off. Then, just as she had done with the eye, she worked the nose out of the wall little by little.

Finding two face pieces in one go, she was even more pleased than the makeup-touching woman—she pinched the nose by its bridge and placed it onto the makeup-touching woman's palm, which was stretched straight out behind its back.

"Well done," the makeup-touching woman said encouragingly, "but those two were the ones with no risk to your life to find—they're the easiest ones. You still need to keep pushing."

"Isn't this cheating?" Mai Minghe said, pointing at the nose. "The bridge of the nose is flesh-colored, but the ring around the nostrils that was exposed—that was painted the same white as the plastic. That doesn't seem fair."

"Of course it isn't cheating." The makeup-touching woman withdrew its hand, did something unseen, and when its hand came back down the nose was already gone—perhaps returned to its original place. "It's not as if there's nothing in this restaurant capable of painting my nose white. Besides, giving you clues while doing everything possible to hide them—that's what makes it fair, isn't it?"

When all was said and done, the operating rules of the entire restaurant had been set by the Nest's side; whether it was truly fair, and what fairness even meant here, were matters in which

Mai Minghe had absolutely no say.

Even if the Nest was merely tormenting her for sport, and there were no remaining face pieces outside at all, she was completely powerless—she could only push down that unsettling thought and try not to dwell on it.

Was there no way for a person to gain any measure of control over the Nest?

Mai Minghe let out a sigh. She felt she might be dreaming a little too big.

According to the makeup-touching woman, the remaining face pieces would be harder to find—and dangerous...

As she turned from the short corridor into the dining area, she was still turning over in her mind where the next face piece might be hidden; a second or two passed before she suddenly realized that every face in the room had lifted up from the tables.

Every face was looking at her, motionless, each wearing a wide, swollen smile.

The restaurant fell into dead silence.

Mai Minghe stood frozen in place, and at last slowly looked up at the clock.

The first hour—the safest hour—had just, in that very moment, come to an end.

The nostrils in /-\ shouldn't have that short dash in the middle, but the platform won't allow me to post blank spaces, so I added it just to show that the two slots aren't right next to each other—there's a gap between them.

Honestly, I'm quite pleased with myself for the hiding spots I came up with for the seven face pieces. (◦

This chapter was a real struggle to finish in time—the deadline was brutal—there are probably typos; I'll go back and fix them later.

Chapter 75: Mai Minghe — Bomb or Hint?

Under the dead silence of countless stares, Mai Minghe walked into the dining area one step at a time.

Every gaze converged on her, as if thickening the very air; the atmosphere pressed down heavy and sluggish, as if each step had to push through resistance before it could land.

But that frozen silence did not last. However long it felt, it was probably less than a minute in reality — then the restaurant erupted without warning into a roar of chatter and laughter, like a sound bomb detonating, and the shockwave made Mai Minghe's heart lurch.

...A bomb. Right — starting from this hour, the diners could set "bombs" and "dead ends" for her.

Dead ends came with warnings, so she could set them aside for now; but to avoid "bombs," there was only one way — find every single rule. She had only four rules in hand. Would they be enough to keep her clear of bombs entirely?

Were there rules hidden far deeper, lying in wait to blow her apart, the same way Summer had been killed?

But she didn't have unlimited time; once the third half-hour passed, her risk of death would spike sharply again. Right now, Mai Minghe had to choose between searching for the face and searching for rules.

The answer was obvious.

"Never done anything this nerve-racking in my entire life," she muttered, and when she came to stand beside the bowing couple's table, she continued talking to herself: "And making someone risk their life hunting things down — I don't know who came up with this..."

The couple glanced up at her, then exchanged a look.

"You're looking for the face, aren't you?" the wife asked, catching her off guard.

If the exchanges before had felt more like the couple reciting scripted lines at Mai Minghe, what was happening now felt like a truly independent conversation.

Mai Minghe studied it for a second or two and said nothing.

"I know where the face is hidden. We all do." That part wasn't surprising — but the wife's next line was. "I want to make a deal with you."

Simply talking to a diner wasn't against the rules.

What she had to watch was saying something she shouldn't; and given that her four rules might not be complete, Mai Minghe had no way of knowing what she couldn't say, so she answered with the fewest, most noncommittal syllables she could manage: "...Mm?"

"The two pieces you found just now are the easiest and the safest." The wife glanced toward the restroom and smiled. "The remaining pieces — if you go after them without knowing what you're walking into, you'll die on the spot."

"I still don't think you should be making a deal with her," the husband cut in abruptly, sliding a sideways glance at Mai Minghe. "We don't know how the others will take it. What if they try to stop you? You're the one stirring up trouble — and in the end, won't I be the one left to sort out the mess?"

The wife patted his hand soothingly. "Let me talk to her. Besides, if the deal works out, everyone gets a share — they'd have no reason to stop us."

Even though she didn't fully understand what they were talking about, Mai Minghe looked around the room.

On the surface at least, the other diners seemed not to have heard a word from this table, and were still eating and drinking, chatting and laughing, like a cast of perfectly adequate background extras.

...Was any of this meant to deceive her?

But "verbal traps" had been the method of the previous thirty minutes; in this thirty-minute window, the diners could already use something more direct, and more lethal.

Not understanding the other party's motive, Mai Minghe probed with another "Oh?"

Even God himself couldn't say a filler sound like that counted as "saying something she shouldn't."

"I can do my best to protect you — warn you of various dangers, including traps the other diners set for you, so you can survive," the wife said. "I'll also tell you where the face pieces are hidden, so you can make it out of the restaurant in the end."

Since when did windfalls like that exist?

This time Mai Minghe didn't dare even a filler word; she could only look at it, tilt her head to one side, and hope that the expression on her face accurately conveyed her skepticism.

"You're probably thinking: why would I help you, what do I get out of it — right?" The wife was quite perceptive. "I simply want you to stall for time."

Why?

"Did the woman who told you to find the face mention that this restaurant is her place of residence to begin with? The face is actually a tool she uses to maintain her hold over the restaurant.

"When the restaurant's rules aren't active, she can repeatedly reinforce her dominance over the restaurant through the act of 'eating.' It's only when the rules go live that she's forced into a corner, waiting for you to either die or find all her tools and bring them back to her."

This filled in some of what the woman applying makeup had revealed, and overall it was consistent — nothing contradicted.

"And what about us diners? We'd very much like a share of the 'restaurant' as a space ourselves. It's only when the face-finding woman temporarily loses dominance that we have the chance to consume some of what the 'restaurant space' holds... Oh, no, I don't mean what's on these tables. Under normal circumstances, what we eat isn't visible to you. There are a few things at other tables that are what we ordinarily eat, rendered in the shape of food."

The wife waved a hand over their table. The dishes on it looked not only normal but quite appetizing — nothing that resembled what a Resident would enjoy.

Mai Minghe thought of the "bedroom smell" the female diner had mentioned.

"Do you understand what I'm saying? As long as you're alive and haven't collected all the face pieces, that is the ideal situation for us — because it's an opportunity for us to nibble away at her territory while the face-finding woman is absent. By the time she returns, the Black Heart Restaurant might not even exist anymore. The rules don't go live very often; it would be a waste of a rare opportunity to let you die for nothing, or to let you finish the task by finding all the pieces too soon, wouldn't it?"

It narrowed its eyes in a smile and said, "As long as you cooperate, I can even give you a reward."

It sounded perfectly reasonable... but if that was the case, her husband shouldn't be worried about the other diners objecting.

Mai Minghe looked at the others, then turned back to the wife.

"They have their reservations — they don't dare offend the face-finding woman."

The wife, having understood her meaning just as expected, swept her long hair back over her shoulder and said, "As a show of good faith, I'm willing to give you a hint right now to help you find the next piece. I can't tell you the location directly — that's a rule restriction. But trust me, this clue is not easy to spot; without me telling you, you might not find it for another hour."

So regardless of whether she agreed to cooperate with the wife, she could get a piece of the face right now?

"Go ahead," Mai Minghe said aloud — two words that surely wouldn't break any rules.

Whether or not the wife was deceiving her, there was no harm in listening first.

But to her surprise, the wife said nothing; instead she pushed back her chair, stepped aside to make way for Mai Minghe, and turned toward the mirrored wall on the far side of the restaurant to fix her hair — while the husband let out a long sigh, sounding both helpless and irritated.

"A perfectly good wedding anniversary, and all this nonsense has to happen," it muttered.

Mai Minghe barely registered his words; she followed the wife's gaze, and her eyes came to rest on its reflection in the mirror.

...Could one of the clues be inside the mirror?

Come to think of it, from the moment she had fallen into the restroom, she'd been dealing with the concept of "mirror images" over and over; if one of the face pieces had a clue hidden in the mirror, that made perfect sense.

Seeing that she understood, the wife gave Mai Minghe a smile and said, "Off you go."

Mai Minghe nodded, said nothing, and walked away.

Starting from the spot where the six young party-goers were seated, she carefully scanned the reflections in the mirrored wall: the ceiling, the floor, the central round table, the three tables not against the mirrored wall... The other side of the restaurant was far from the mirror, as though another layer of space lay hidden within it; yet nothing appeared out of the ordinary.

While she was observing the reflections, the group of six with Xiaowei had also fallen quiet.

Wherever Mai Minghe moved, their reflected gazes followed her; whenever her eyes landed on a reflected face, they would inevitably meet that diner's reflected eyes — yet none of them made a move, only baring their teeth in a grin at her.

The male diner, however, paid no attention to what Mai Minghe was doing — at least on the surface — and kept his eyes fixed on his screen. Her gaze swept across the reflection of the back of his head, his back, and the edge of the laptop screen visible in the mirror, then moved on to the next table.

When she was still four or five steps from the next table, Mai Minghe stopped.

From what she'd seen so far, as long as she circled around the diners' tables without making direct eye contact, they wouldn't approach her on their own initiative; but if she happened to meet the eyes of those three female diners and they invited her to eat with them, she'd be trapped in a dead end. Even in a mirror, that risk was no small thing...

Mai Minghe kept her head turned away, keeping her gaze fixed on the far end of the restaurant.

In her peripheral vision, the blurred faces of the three female diners all seemed to be watching her without moving — two of them were seated facing her, their stares drilling straight into her; the one seated with her back to Mai Minghe appeared to have been watching her the whole time through the mirror.

She needed to observe their reflections in the mirror, yet she couldn't look directly into it...

What now?

Get another mirror and use it to look at what was behind her through its reflection?

But aside from the risk of meeting their eyes that way as well, Mai Minghe didn't have a suitable mirror. She had gone back to the restroom specifically to search the makeup woman's cosmetics bag, only to find a small mirror barely larger than her palm — far too difficult to angle properly to see the reflections behind her.

When she came back out of the restroom, however, an idea suddenly struck her.

"Hey, you've got so many celebrity photos on the walls — you must have a camera somewhere, right?" she asked, half hoping she might be lucky: "Could I borrow it?"

"There's no camera," the server replied.

"Now that's a lie. If there's no camera, what did you use to take the photos?"

One of the tendrils pointed at her flinched back slightly, as if expressing surprise. "A phone — who buys a dedicated camera just for that?"

...This wasn't a trap, was it?

Mai Minghe blinked a few times.

She remembered her first mobile phone — a flip Motorola with a tiny screen that glowed faint blue. She vaguely recalled it might have had a camera, but the photos came out tiny and blurry.

She had only ever used that phone for calls; at first she'd sent the occasional text, but stopped after a while because the keys were too small to read — let alone use for taking photos.

But today's smartphones were different — one entire face of the phone was screen; she hadn't expected that when used as cameras, they could be this sharp, indistinguishable from a proper camera. Perhaps because she had never used one, she had momentarily forgotten that phones could take photos too.

Speaking of phones, there was indeed one around...

Could it be a "bomb"? The rules said nothing about phones...

Mai Minghe drifted back into the dining area in a daze and thought it over for a moment, then glanced at the clock again.

She couldn't keep stalling — she had to make a decision. When information was incomplete, no amount of extra deliberation would help.

When she picked the phone up from the table, the male diner only looked up at her briefly and said nothing.

It seemed that after entering the third half-hour, the task's operating conditions remained unchanged — Mai Minghe could still make use of anything in the restaurant.

She had watched young people use smartphones, so she mimicked what she'd seen and swiped across the screen a few times; she wasn't sure what she had pressed, but the face that had been sobbing and wailing on the screen abruptly vanished, replaced by a grid of small illustrated squares.

What was all this supposed to mean?

One of the small squares had what appeared to be a camera icon drawn on it, and Mai Minghe tapped it tentatively.

When the screen suddenly went dark and then lit up to show the restaurant's interior, she was startled; Mai Minghe, with a somewhat ill-timed sense of novelty and curiosity, tapped around the screen at random, snapping several "click" "click" photos of the floor, her thumb, and her shoes.

By the time she finally figured it out, Mai Minghe still had her head turned away, not looking at that table of female guests, standing at a distance.

She only took one photo aimed at the mirror behind them—in the photo, the bespectacled female guest seemed not to have anticipated this move of hers, her surprise at raising one dark eyebrow caught perfectly in the frame.

Mai Minghe lowered her head and studied the photo for a moment.

She raised her head and glanced at the wife; the Resident seemed to have expected this, and smiled at her.

In the mirror... there was indeed a clue.

But Mai Minghe didn't know whether it was a clue leading to another piece of a face, or leading to death.

If she truly followed that clue to go looking for the next piece of a face... wouldn't that be breaking the rules?

So the wife had set up a "bomb" for her through those words, hadn't she?

Good lord, this chapter turned out way longer than I expected—I barely scraped it together in time. Thank goodness my outline was solid; if I'd gotten stuck even five hundred words, there'd have been no update today.

Speaking of which, who was it last time that said they were going to crash a music festival as a fan stalker lol

This trip I went on, the tickets and hotel were all piggybacked onto a friend's plans—I just handed over my bank card number and left it at that—so it wasn't until I actually got there that I found out the name of the music festival I was going to, and the more I thought about it, the more familiar it sounded...

This morning it suddenly hit me—oh my god! Wasn't there someone who asked me before whether I was going to this exact music festival?! At the time I didn't even know which one I was going to myself, so I figured it had nothing to do with me! Now thinking back on it, my cover's blown! (not really lol)

There's a chance we might have walked right past each other at the festival?

Chapter 76: Mai Minghe's Brush with Death and Snatching Chestnuts from the Fire

Modern phones were truly remarkable—even a mirror's reflection came out bright and clear in a photo, just like seeing it with the naked eye. Mai Minghe looked at the image a few more times and was finally convinced: in the mirror's reflection, the bespectacled female guest did indeed have a pair of black eyebrows.

But... she remembered that the first time she saw the bespectacled female guest, it had clearly had a pair of light brown eyebrows.

Its actual appearance, compared to its reflection in the mirror, showed a discrepancy in eyebrow color... Mai Minghe could only think of one explanation for this difference.

Between the two pairs of eyebrows—one inside the mirror, one outside—at least one of them belonged to the woman touching up her makeup.

The black eyebrows in the mirror—setting aside the fact that they were a reflection and seemed to move with the bespectacled female guest, as though they couldn't be removed—were, by color alone, impossible to belong to the woman touching up her makeup.

The tissue in Mai Minghe's pocket, the one with the list of notes, still bore faint brown pencil marks—written with the makeup woman's eyebrow pencil. By any ordinary logic, someone with thick black eyebrows would never use a light brown eyebrow pencil when doing their makeup, would they?

So it seemed the bespectacled female guest had somehow "worn" the portion of the makeup woman's face—her forehead and eyebrows—over her own forehead; the different color showing up in the mirror's reflection must have been a hint.

It made sense logically, but that didn't mean her nerves could settle.

Mai Minghe took two deep breaths and felt not the slightest bit of relaxation—if anything, a layer of sweat seeped from her palms.

Who could guarantee this wasn't a bomb packed with death, one that would blow her to pieces the moment she touched it?

She glanced again in the direction of that wife.

"You're scared?" the wife, seated a few steps away, twisted in her chair and whispered toward her. "It seems you guessed right—you'd only be scared if you'd guessed correctly. It's all right. Think carefully about the rules again. Go ahead."

...Using her own life to test the range of that rule's application?

It was rather ironic, when she thought about it—the Artifact on her body had given her a second life, yet it had also led her out onto a high wire.

Before her stretched a vast and unfamiliar world, while beneath her feet everything swayed, precarious, each step taken between life and death.

Perhaps she should have long since started treating herself as someone already dead.

If she wanted only to be reborn yet dared not—and refused—to die first, then where was the "rebirth" to come from?

Mai Minghe had made up her mind, but before acting she still took one more careful look at every diner's face in the restaurant, just to be safe: among the diners there were black eyebrows, dark brown eyebrows, and a few pairs of light gold and orange-red eyebrows—but the only color that matched the makeup woman's eyebrow pencil was the pair on the bespectacled female guest's face.

No matter what, it seemed she would have to snatch the chestnuts from the fire.

She kept her eyes straight ahead, without so much as a glance at the three female guests who had been craning their necks to watch her, and walked directly to the other end of the restaurant before turning around.

She must not touch a dining guest's face... violating that rule would likely land her in the same situation as Summer.

So what she had to do next was simple to say, yet anything but simple to do.

Mai Minghe lowered her head and pretended to look at her phone where she stood, tapping and poking at it for a while—on the surface she probably looked no different from any young person scrolling through their phone, but inside all she saw was a blurry smear at the edge of a cold sweat; her palm was clammy and hot, and she had to grip the phone carefully to keep it from slipping.

She didn't know which second it was when she suddenly bolted without warning.

Her phone hit the floor with a thud, pinning that moment to the ground where she'd started; that second stretched forward with each rapid stride she took, growing uncommonly long.

The single motion she had rehearsed over and over in her mind dissolved into a white, formless blur; as Mai Minghe was about to race past the back of the bespectacled female guest's seat, she crushed the cowardly urge to just keep running straight past and do nothing—and in the rush of air, she reached her hand out toward the bespectacled female guest.

With a sharp smack, Mai Minghe's palm struck the other's forehead.

Immediately after, she curled her five fingers inward.

From suddenly dropping her phone and breaking into a run to slapping her palm against the bespectacled female guest's forehead—the whole thing had taken no more than a single breath. Because Mai Minghe knew that her only chance hinged on one word: speed.

The moment the bespectacled female guest reacted—the instant it turned its head even slightly, letting its cheek brush her hand—both she and her second life would be finished.

Between her pinched fingers, Mai Minghe felt as though she had grabbed hold of something.

She didn't dare glance at the table for even a second; she raised her arm and didn't slow her feet at all, not until she was almost about to crash into the bar counter at the far end—only then did she finally brake.

She bent over, and everything—the restaurant, the bar counter, the waitstaff—was drowned out by a roar of white noise, pushed to the far edges of the world.

She listened to the violent, ever-quickenings heartbeats in her ears, not knowing which beat would be the last—but after waiting a few seconds, the lingering fear slowly receded like a tide, and she was still standing on solid ground.

Mai Minghe didn't dare look back at that table of three female guests; she slowly straightened up, raised one slightly trembling hand, and lowered her gaze.

A patch of forehead skin, complete with two eyebrows, lay in her palm—slightly crinkled, almost like some kind of stage prop.

...Found it. The third piece of face.

The wife hadn't lied to her; this wasn't a bomb after all.

Even though she had made the decision to take the risk herself, Mai Minghe still found it almost unbelievable that she was still alive at this moment.

Mai Minghe urged her two legs—which felt as though the bones had been pulled out of them—forward, walking on unsteady steps into the restroom, where she handed the forehead piece over to the makeup woman; when she walked back out, she caught the wife's gaze and made her way to their table.

"Didn't expect it—you've got real nerve. So? Do you believe me now?"

The wife smiled and said, "The rule is that you cannot touch a dining guest's face. If what you touched was only something the guest was wearing on their face, then of course that doesn't count as touching their face—no violation. If you don't believe me, go again and take off its glasses."

How could she possibly go and try again? She could barely stay on her feet.

In the corner of her vision, the three female guests' faces were fixed on her, staring hard; though not a sound was made, Mai Minghe could feel their dark, churning displeasure all the same.

"I said we can protect you—when the time is right, we'll tell you the locations of the last few pieces of face as well. That way, everyone comes out satisfied. Isn't that a good arrangement?"

For the first time, Mai Minghe found herself truly considering its offer.

"What does 'when the time is right' mean? I don't want this dragged out. I want to get out quickly."

She propped one hand on the table, unable to stop herself from leaning a little of her weight onto it.

Thinking about it now, since falling back into Blackmoor City in the small hours of the morning, she hadn't stopped once—she'd been either walking or running for her life, without even the chance to close her eyes.

Even a young person couldn't hold up under that kind of relentless strain.

"By the time the second hour ends, you'll definitely be able to leave," the wife said, seeming quite confident. "We're not the only ones looking to take a bite out of its territory—as long as someone takes the lead, the others will follow one after another. It won't take long."

"Then how will you protect me?"

The wife thought for a moment. "Are you aware that during the third half-hour, we cannot leave our seats?"

"I know."

"If you wander around the restaurant, even if I keep my eyes on you the whole time, there will inevitably be moments I can't watch you closely enough. We just discussed it, and we think the best approach is for you to stay by our side."

Mai Minghe froze.

During the third half-hour, no one could leave their seat—so if she stayed beside the 含头 couple the entire time, no one else would have the opportunity to bring harm to her. Of course, that was only on the premise that the 含头 couple wouldn't make their move on her the moment the fourth half-hour began.

"I have one condition," Mai Minghe hesitated a moment, then said tentatively: "Before the fourth hour begins, I'll leave your side and take cover near the bar counter. If you truly mean to protect me, don't let any of the diners come near the bar counter."

She desperately needed a few minutes of peace and rest, and she also had to think more carefully about what exactly the remaining clues to the last few pieces of face were—she certainly couldn't place all her hopes on a pair of Residents.

The wife exchanged a glance with the husband. "All right, if that will put your mind more at ease."

It seemed the wife had finally managed to convince the husband just now; the husband stopped complaining and even pulled out a chair, gesturing toward Mai Minghe: "Then sit here—in the middle. Between the two of us, we can both keep an eye on you."

Mai Minghe murmured her agreement, lifted one leg, and stepped around to the front of the chair, about to sit down.

Something deep in her mind gave a sudden lurch.

As though some missing piece had finally clicked into place, in an instant Mai Minghe saw clearly the full shape of the "bomb" right in front of her.

Her body was already descending into the seat—like falling into the icy water of a deep pool, knowing full well that falling in meant death, yet having already missed the moment when she

could have pulled herself back up.

At some point, both the 含头 husband and wife had leaned their heads toward the center of the table, faces turned to stare at her, wearing enormous smiles, their eyes wide and round.

As though they were looking forward to something very much.

...Dying here was absolutely not an option.

The regrets of her past life had not yet been made right in this one.

In a flash, Mai Minghe shot out her hand and grabbed hold of the edge of the table; she wasn't afraid of falling to the floor—she was only afraid of sitting down in that chair, even just a little—as she gripped the table's edge and wrenched her body hard to one side, she simultaneously swung her arm out and swept it backward with all her strength.

With a loud crash, the chair was knocked to the floor by her sweep; as Mai Minghe staggered and lurched, she was then tripped by the chair leg—she finally lost her balance, the world spun, and her entire back slammed into the floor.

She felt one foot still caught on the chair, and in her frantic haste she kicked it away hard; the chair slid one or two steps across the floor and, in the sudden silence of the restaurant, the sound was startling.

Mai Minghe scrambled up from the floor in a flurry, and without pausing to look at the diners, she first raised her eyes toward the central round table not far away.

At the central round table where two chairs had originally been placed, only one now remained.

She stared blankly at the empty space where a chair should have been, then looked again at the chair she had kicked to the floor.

Given that the seating arrangement placed a pair of chairs on each side of a dining table, the 中央 round table belonging to the 含头 couple should not have had a chair in the middle.

The white, bloodless wave of delayed terror was cut short by a furious shriek—"She almost sat down she almost sat down why didn't she sit down! Why!"

Mai Minghe startled.

The husband's face was instantly flooded crimson; he collapsed back against his chair and kicked the table legs again and again with tremendous force—several kicks landing on the wife's

legs, which it didn't seem to notice at all—and he howled like a child: "You said this plan would work! You said so! And instead you just let her find another piece of face! I wanted her to sit down—why didn't she sit down—we were so close!"

Mai Minghe pulled herself up off the floor on wobbling arms and legs, still unable to believe that she had escaped the consequences of breaking a rule at the very last instant.

She had still been too shallow in her thinking.

"The central round table cannot be sat at"—that rule likely contained two points: first, one cannot sit at the central round table; second, one cannot sit in a chair belonging to the central round table.

After all, no one sits on top of a restaurant table—if there were something that couldn't be sat on, it naturally referred to those two chairs.

While Mai Minghe had gone to the restroom to freshen up, the couple with the drooping heads had dragged one of the chairs over to their table—likely by having the waiter do it—and nearly tricked her into sitting down.

"I need to pack food to bring on the boat when I go out to sea, so if she doesn't die what am I supposed to eat, what am I supposed to eat, what am I supposed to eat!" The husband kept howling, it was unclear whether at his wife or at Mai Minghe: "Do you have any idea how hard it was to plan our wedding anniversary outing, so why won't you just go and die, why, why! Go die at sea for me!"

The wife sat completely still in her seat, letting her husband kick at her as he pleased, her pair of round, bulging eyes fixed on Mai Minghe—as though she meant to drive her gaze in like a blade and split her open.

"...Everything you just said was a lie?" Mai Minghe had yet to recover from her shock. "But the woman touching up her makeup used the exact same lines—was she lying to me too?"

The wife's analysis had sounded perfectly reasonable; but the reason it hadn't used a method that seemed to maximize its own benefit was almost certainly because there was information hidden in between that Mai Minghe didn't know—information that made Mai Minghe's death truly advantageous to it.

"Would you like to know the secrets of the Nest?" The wife twisted her face into a smile. "Once the Nest dissolves your body, once you become many Residents—won't you know everything

then?"

Mai Minghe turned her head and looked around.

She didn't dare look at the table with the three female guests; right now, every other table in the room, every face on every one of them, had turned toward her.

The young people at the party table peered at her from above the mess of cups and plates; the male guest with the ear stud and his boyfriend pressed their faces together, watching her without blinking, as though they had even forgotten the untouched tacos in front of them; the man looking at the laptop revealed a pair of eyes from behind the screen, like two faintly glowing black holes.

...These Residents truly could not be trusted.

She had to get out of here as fast as possible; the next piece of the face—she had to find the next piece of the face...

Four more pieces to go. Left cheek, right cheek, one eye, and the mouth.

And what were their clues, exactly?

Mai Minghe had thought all of today's courage had already been wrung dry from her—or perhaps it truly had been, which was why she was too exhausted to even summon the energy to be afraid.

When she looked at the tacos in front of the ear-studded male guest and a thought suddenly occurred to her, it was as though only a very small, very distant voice reminded her that products from Cowboy Hill Chase would kill any human who touched them.

Under the gaze of the many Residents, she walked over step by step and picked up the plate holding the tacos.

She wasn't dead. She hadn't dropped dead on the spot.

She supposed she should thank the wife for the reminder—she had only touched the plate, not the tacos themselves, so that shouldn't count as breaking any rules—if the tacos on the plate truly were Cowboy Hill Chase products, that is.

Mai Minghe flipped the plate over, and both tacos tumbled to the ground, spattering meat filling and sauce across the floor; the taco shells hit the tiles with a flat smack, like a pair of hands falling open limply.

On the inside of both "taco shells" grew countless fine, densely packed pores.

"There aren't many foods you can actually bite through, yet you still wouldn't eat these two tacos that ended up on your plate... because they were never Cowboy Hill Chase products to begin with, were they."

Mai Minghe crouched down and picked up the "taco shells."

...She was still alive.

"Always hiding the answer somewhere that looks like it'll kill you the moment you touch it—you Residents really do have a remarkable number of tricks up your sleeves."

Two more pieces of the face left.

Ten minutes until the end of the third half-hour.

I don't know why the chapters keep getting longer... but four thousand characters a day really is my limit. Unless it's a chapter that's really flowing for me, I might go over, but then I'm usually drained for a long time afterward and need a few days to recover...

Oh right, everyone, I'm planning to take Saturdays off from now on—you all probably already knew... right? All approved...?

PS: Every time summer hits, I want to stick someone's head in the freezer.

Chapter 77: Mai Minghe's Sixth Piece of Face

Less than ten minutes remained of what could generously be called "safe" time; Mai Minghe shoved the two cheek pieces into the outstretched hand of the touch-up woman, didn't even manage a single word, turned around, and charged back out—hope was right in front of her, just one eye and one mouth away.

But the moment she stepped through the door, she stopped again.

"Have you started eating yet?" Mai Minghe asked hurriedly. "You haven't found the mouth yet—can you even eat? Then again, you Residents don't really eat the way humans do with their mouths, right?"

The touch-up woman had her back to her, standing in the corner, and was silent for a moment. "...What?"

"What I mean is, I've already retrieved five pieces of face for you—if you've already started 'eating,' would that give you some suppressive effect over the other diners?"

To say that Mai Minghe wasn't the least bit afraid would have been a flat-out lie; just thinking about what life-or-death situation might be waiting for her out there made her not even want to leave this bathroom. "If you can suppress them even a little through 'eating,' I'd be a little safer too..."

"Oh, that." The touch-up woman seemed to recall something and said, "The threat they pose to you will keep rising as time passes—there's no way for you to increase your safety margin. Do you really expect me to protect you?"

"No—of course not."

Mai Minghe furrowed her brow, feeling the whole time like their conversation had somehow gone off track somewhere, though she couldn't pinpoint what had given her that sense of something "missing."

The longer time dragged on, the worse it was for her; she couldn't just stand here lost in thought like a fool.

"I'm leaving then," Mai Minghe tossed out, but her foot hadn't even moved before she pulled it back. "Actually—that lipstick in your hand, could I take it with me for now?"

The touch-up woman's silence stretched on for a precious few seconds. "Why?"

"I want to compare which mouth matches the color of your lip color, in case someone is wearing your mouth on their own face. Aren't the resources here for me to use as I please?"

Once lipstick was applied to a mouth, smearing could change the color entirely—and the shades weren't that different to begin with—so it would be more reliable to bring the lipstick itself for comparison.

The touch-up woman seemed to hesitate for a moment before saying, "Fine. Take it."

Afraid to waste another second, Mai Minghe quickly pulled the lipstick from its hand and strode out of the bathroom. As she walked, she examined the lipstick—it was a common design, nothing unusual about it; thankfully it was a bold red, which was far easier to identify than any shade of pink.

The only odd thing was that the extended tip of the bullet was etched with countless fine scratches; no matter how she looked at it, she couldn't figure out how they had gotten there or what had made them.

She filed away that strangeness in her mind, pocketed the lipstick, and slowed her steps once she was past the short corridor.

Like a thief casing a room, she first poked her head in and swept her gaze around the restaurant—just in case something was lying in wait for her.

...For some inexplicable reason, the Nest was strangely meticulous about realistic little details.

Mai Minghe felt a complicated mix of wanting to laugh and wanting to cry; nearly an hour and a half had passed since she arrived, and most of the diners would reasonably have "finished their meal" by now—sure enough, two servers were busily clearing away dishes.

At the table of six, the plates had already been cleared; one server had a stack of dishes balanced on their arm and was heading toward the kitchen.

The other server had just taken away the picked-over fish platter and was now heading toward the table of the head-bowing couple; Mai Minghe accidentally locked eyes with the fish—mostly eaten by now, it had gone still, lying motionless on the plate as if it had died there.

The three female diners at that table looked decidedly unhappy.

It made sense when she thought about it: their faces had been discovered, and their traps had been consistently foiled; perhaps since the fish was no longer of any use at the table, they'd simply had it cleared away.

This actually saved her some trouble; now Mai Minghe could observe the color of their mouths openly, without having to resort to the roundabout method of photographing the mirror.

But her attempt quickly ended in failure—no one's lips were anywhere close to the color of the bold red lipstick. Not only did they look different to the naked eye, but in the mirror's reflection, not a single person had even a trace of bold red lipstick on their mouth.

It seemed the mirror's hint about the color difference between inside and outside was something they'd only give once.

Could it be that they'd wiped the lipstick off?

But she couldn't touch the diners' faces to check whether someone was "wearing" another person's mouth.

With no other option, Mai Minghe had no choice but to begin searching through the restaurant; small as it was, compared to a single eye or a single mouth, it was still far too large.

Though anxious, she kept her footsteps deliberately slow.

Before each step forward, she scanned the floor, the ceiling, the dining tables, and the mirrors; only after confirming nothing was amiss would she set her foot down on the next tile.

The wife's face was like an enormous sunflower, pivoting ninety degrees as it tracked her the whole way; just as Mai Minghe was about to pass her and head toward the table of the male couple, her heart gave a sudden lurch.

Something was off—in that last sweep she'd taken, something was wrong—

Mai Minghe slowly turned her head toward the mirrored wall.

The friend of the male couple—the female diner—was watching Mai Minghe without moving, same as all the others; but in the mirror, the face it had turned toward Mai Minghe was Mai Minghe's own.

...Was this what a "dead end" warning looked like?

If her reflection were to overlap with her own face in the mirror, what would happen?

She didn't dare walk any closer.

Mai Minghe pulled her foot back and stopped not far from the wife's side, hearing it let out a loud, heavy click of its tongue—as if it was deeply displeased that she hadn't walked over there.

"I told you it wouldn't work," the wife said under its breath. "The hint was too obvious. Dead ends don't do it—we should try something else."

"I'm fed up," the husband said. "I want to go out to sea. Fishing for people out there might land a real prize—it's better than sitting here. Why isn't she dead yet?"

The wife gave its hand a soothing pat.

Setting everything else aside, Residents had such an irritating way of talking—all death and killing—Mai Minghe was just about to turn back when a thought leaped into her mind.

So far, every table except for the head-bowing couple had given her some kind of clue that led her to a piece of face. The head-bowing couple was crafty and infuriating, but surely they hadn't been spouting pure nonsense with zero clues hidden in it?

If there was a clue, what was it?

...To find the answer, perhaps she could compare what they'd said in the first thirty minutes against what they'd said afterward.

That wasn't easy, since this couple talked more than anyone else, and Mai Minghe would have to recall as much of their conversation as possible.

The first thirty minutes—"wedding anniversary," "anniversary gift is a pearl necklace," "strangling the neck," "going out to sea," "no one can sit at the center round table."

After that, they had still mentioned "wedding anniversary," "going out to sea," and the wife's string of deceptive lies.

Which meant...once they stopped giving hints, the couple never again brought up "the pearl necklace" or "strangling."

Mai Minghe's gaze settled on the wife's neck; that string of pearl necklace gleamed with a smooth, lustrous sheen, each pearl perfectly round—and each one was just a pearl.

It seemed to grow uneasy under her stare and shifted in its seat.

Mai Minghe glanced over; the two chairs beside the center round table had both been placed back in their original positions.

She walked over, laid one hand on the back of a chair, and couldn't help but feel a complicated swell of emotions at the thought that it had nearly become her grave just a moment ago.

Simply dragging it away without sitting down shouldn't count as breaking any rules.

"I just realized," she said, gripping the chair and dragging it behind her as she walked back, step by step, speaking under her breath to the head-bowing couple: "you two really love strangling. In the first half hour, you were still comparing whose eyes bulged higher when being strangled."

The wife and husband exchanged a glance; as if something had dawned on them, both stiffened in their seats.

To claim this piece of face, she had to act now—while the diners were still unable to leave their seats and couldn't lay hands on her directly. Otherwise, she might never get another chance.

The moment the chair swung up into the air, the wife hurriedly raised its arm to block; but Mai Minghe threw her full weight into it, wrenching the whole chair down from mid-air and slamming it straight into the back of its skull—with a dull, heavy thud, the chair drove its head and neck together into the surface of the dining table, arm and all.

The husband let out a howl; it sounded like fury.

Mai Minghe didn't let go for a moment—still gripping the chair back with both hands, she swept it horizontally across the back of the wife's head, then flung the chair sideways, sending it crashing straight into the husband's head and face, knocking it clean off its chair along with its whole body—the rule that they couldn't leave their seats seemed to be absolute; even after taking a chair directly to the face, when it hit the floor, its backside and the seat remained perfectly aligned without a gap.

The chair flew out and splintered apart across the floor, sending fragments of wood scattering in every direction.

Her hands now empty, Mai Minghe pressed down on the back of the wife's skull with one hand, pinning its face firmly against the tabletop, while her other hand swept aside the damp hair at the back of its neck.

Hidden beneath the hair, at the clasp of the pearl necklace, a human eyelid had been peeled back and pinned behind the eyeball, exposing a web of red veins; in the center of the white, a brown iris stared straight up at Mai Minghe.

She ripped it free from the necklace in one motion—the string snapped instantly, and pearls scattered across the floor, rolling out in a sweep of white.

The sixth piece of face had been found.

This chapter is a bit short—I wasn't in the best shape today; I haven't slept well for over a week straight, and I'm hot, exhausted, and mentally drained...

Chapter 78: Mai Minghe on the Importance of Taking a Nap

In eighty-six years of living, this was the first time she had ever lifted a chair and brought it crashing down on someone's head with enough force to kill.

It was also the first time in those eighty-six years that she had felt something stir from deep within her blood—an excitement and craving roused by violence; as if some fierce, primal animal instinct were howling inside her, urging her to pick the chair back up and keep smashing, smash the whole restaurant to pieces, smash every face in it.

...Was it precisely this darkness in human beings that gave rise to Nest Residents?

The thought poured into her scorching, restless blood like cold water. Mai Minghe quickly stepped back several paces from the wife, her heart pounding hard in her chest.

Perhaps humans truly were seventy percent water, and the circumstances of one's life were a vessel. Whatever color vessel you fell into, that was the color of light and shadow that rippled through you.

She steadied her breathing, turned, and walked toward the restroom. Just one last face to go, and she could get out of this wretched restaurant.

As she passed the clock, Mai Minghe glanced up at it. A few more minutes, and these Residents would be able to rise from their chairs. She didn't know what she would be facing by then—just thinking about it made her blood slowly run cold.

In this cramped little restaurant, she wasn't just dealing with Residents—she was dealing with fifteen of them.

The mouth—where on earth was that mouth?

She pushed open the restroom door. The woman touching up her makeup was already there, just like every time before, extending one hand behind her back as if she'd been expecting this.

As she handed over the eye, a helpless, faintly despairing anxiety welled up inside Mai Minghe that she could no longer suppress.

An hour and a half—that was hardly a short amount of time, so how had it vanished in the blink of an eye? If she hadn't been forced to make trip after trip back to the restroom to deliver each face, she'd have had at least ten or more minutes to spare right now—

The feeling of "diverging" during the conversation just now flashed through her mind like a sudden burst of sparks.

"What's wrong?"

The woman touching up her makeup stretched one hand straight back behind her, urging impatiently, "Didn't you find the eye? Give it to me."

The hand holding the eye was only inches away from the upturned palm reaching toward her, yet Mai Minghe stopped and didn't move.

She had been worrying about time the whole while, every passing minute feeling like another stone being piled onto her—yet she hadn't realized that she had been, without knowing it, wasting time all along.

...If she didn't hand it over herself, the woman touching up her makeup didn't seem able to reach out and take it by force.

"Can they come into the restroom in a little while?" Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and asked.

"Hurry up and give me the eye," the woman touching up her makeup said, extremely impatient.

"Answer my question."

"Give me the eye!" the woman touching up her makeup shrieked.

"You know, I should have realized something was wrong much sooner."

Mai Minghe tucked the eye into her trouser pocket, hand still gripping it tightly, the eyelashes pricking against her skin. "You were the one who told me that the moment I found a face, the rules would recognize it and I wouldn't need to worry about it being taken. Yet at the same time, you told me that the moment I found a face, I had to bring it back to you immediately...why?"

"You kept telling me, over and over, that time was tight—the longer it went on, the more danger I was in. But surely you know that running back here every time I found a single face wastes more time than anything else?"

Whether it was because the adrenaline rush from earlier had finally faded, or because she was truly spent, Mai Minghe was so exhausted she could barely stay on her feet. She simply walked

over to the wall and slid down to sit on the floor; she swiped a hand across her forehead and found her fingertips slick with sweat.

"Didn't I say? This way I can start 'eating' as soon as possible..."

"If you need the mouth to 'eat,' then finding you the other faces wouldn't help you eat either, and coming back would only waste my time."

Mai Minghe had no idea why she hadn't worked through this simple logic sooner. "So that means either you don't need the mouth to 'eat,' or that line of yours was nothing but a lie."

"I don't need the mouth to 'eat!'" The woman touching up her makeup shrieked in a sharp, thin voice, clearly irritated. "Didn't you already figure that out!"

"Then what is the point of your eating?" Mai Minghe asked. "You said at the start that only by eating could you strengthen your control over this restaurant as a space—the diner outside wearing the pearl necklace said the same thing. Is that right?"

The woman touching up her makeup suddenly went silent.

After waiting a few seconds and seeing that it seemed to have no intention of answering directly, Mai Minghe spoke again.

"Then logically, the more faces I bring you, the more you eat, and the stronger your control over the restaurant should become...yet that isn't what's actually happening, is it? In fact, no matter how many faces I bring you, your control over the restaurant has only been getting weaker. That's why the diners outside have been growing freer and freer as time passes. Isn't that right?"

"That's all determined by the rules..." the woman touching up her makeup said in a thin voice. "You don't understand—I can't rewrite the rules."

"If the rules have already determined it, then what does it matter whether you eat or not? It can't improve your situation at all." Mai Minghe shook her head and said, "In that case, there's only one explanation for why you've had me bring the faces back to you again and again."

The woman touching up her makeup paused, then said, "The third half-hour is just about up, you know?"

"You just wanted to make me waste time—drag things out until the diners could move freely and let them kill me." Mai Minghe said, "You also said that if I die, it would be a huge amount of

nourishment for you, and the moment I die, the rules would go off—go offline, right? The faces would return to you then. For you, that would be the ideal outcome."

"True—I never hid that from you." The woman touching up her makeup laughed. "You're just repeating back things I already told you. What exactly is your great discovery?"

"Then how would you bring about this ideal outcome?" Mai Minghe paid her no heed, sorting through her thoughts as she spoke. "Waste my time, make sure I can't collect all the faces, and let the diners kill me."

"It's not as if I can guarantee you won't collect all the faces—I gave you all the clues. If you can't find them, that's your problem..." The woman touching up her makeup trailed off, then let out an "ah-oh" and laughed: "The third half-hour just ended, by the way."

Mai Minghe turned her head. The restroom was utterly silent except for the sound of her own breathing. She thought she could hear the scrape of chair legs dragging across the floor as chairs were pushed back, but she didn't know how much of that was just her imagination.

"If you think the other diners won't come into the restroom, you're quite wrong," the woman touching up her makeup continued. "Hiding in here won't keep you safe either."

"And what would be the worst possible outcome for you?"

Mai Minghe knew she was taking a risk, but there were some risks she had no choice but to take. "That wife just now was setting a trap for me, but what it said was logically consistent with the information you gave me earlier—so I think there's one thing I can probably trust...and that is: as long as I don't die, and you haven't gotten all the faces back, and the rules haven't ended, the task is still running.

"That's the worst outcome for you, isn't it?"

"Not dying? How would you manage that?" The woman touching up her makeup gave a short laugh. She seemed to have stopped caring about the eye still in Mai Minghe's hand. "They're coming now, you know. Are you ready?"

This time it wasn't her imagination—Mai Minghe could already hear footsteps in the short corridor outside. Hesitant-sounding footsteps, not fast, but each step drawing closer to the restroom than the last.

She exhaled sharply; her throat clenched tight with tension, and that single breath trembled as it fell into the dead silence around her.

"I think there's one other thing you said that was also true—because you had no reason to lie to me at that moment."

The footsteps were almost at the restroom door now. And that was only the first one. Behind it, several more pairs of feet were rapidly following.

"Before you've collected all the faces, the other diners can lay hands on you—but once you have collected all the faces, they can no longer kill you, same as me, and must instead send you safely on your way."

The woman touching up her makeup stood rigid with her back turned, saying nothing.

"I found it. The seventh face."

Mai Minghe uncapped the lipstick, looked at the faint, hairline marks threading across the surface of the balm, and raised her voice: "The moment I find it, the rules will recognize it— isn't that right?"

The restroom door handle turned slightly and was pushed open a crack.

"The seventh face is on the back of your head. The very first time you explained the task rules to me, you couldn't even help yourself—you smiled at me from beneath your hair. The fine marks on the lipstick were left by your hair. You said the seven faces were scattered throughout the restaurant...you never said they were only scattered in the dining area. The restroom is naturally part of this restaurant too."

The restroom door went still.

"Now I've collected all seven faces, and none of you can touch me anymore. But I still have one eye in my hand...and I haven't handed it to you yet."

In the dead silence, Mai Minghe gave a quiet laugh. "You're just one face away from being restored and regaining control of the restaurant—yet at this very moment you've been brought to a standstill...this is the worst possible outcome for you, isn't it? Take a guess: would I reward the last face to someone who's been lying to me?"

"You...what are you going to do?"

Mai Minghe tucked the lipstick away and slid both hands into her trouser pockets, one gripping the eye and one gripping the lipstick.

"Nothing," she said. "I'm exhausted. I'm going to take a nap first."

I really am a hopeless looks-obsessed fool...it's such a wonderful thing that the world has so many beautiful people, aaaaaah

But the flip side of being a perfectionist who's obsessed with looks is never being satisfied with how you yourself look (◦

I'm blocked—completely, utterly stuck, gazing into an empty horizon with no idea where to go

As the title says.....

I could have taken a full, guilt-free day off on Saturday, and instead I'm blocked today!!

Completely stuck, can't even decide who to write about next—the kind of stuck where if I hadn't published this book and put it up for sale, it would get shoved into the graveyard folder forever—that's how stuck I am.

(I already have quite a few like that in my graveyard folder)

There's probably no update today—I'll spend today hammering out the outline, then write the update after that. Should be able to post tomorrow. So much for resting tomorrow—looks like I'll be grinding non-stop through next weekend again.

This must be the universe telling me it simply refuses to let me rest aaaaaaaaaaaaa

Ahhhhh, ahhhhhhhhh

Why don't I just do something else—if I had any talent or passion for songwriting, singing and dancing, drawing, or sports, how happy I'd be. Anything would be better than writing—this is not work fit for a human being aaaaaaa

PS: I didn't forget to set this one as a free chapter—not bad, right? I'm improving.

Chapter 79: Chase and a Resident in the Same Car?

A dead silence, a cold that froze into the skin and slowed the blood. As if, so long as he let it be, let go, he could gradually dissolve into a dark and empty universe.

Chase opened his eyes.

As always, when he woke, he never knew what time it was.

His normally precise sense of time had its breath cut off—strangled by the silence, the cold, and the darkness together. Every time he fell asleep, it was like dying once.

The process of waking was like an instinct that refused to accept death, urging him to climb out of the void's abyss inch by inch; when he opened his eyes again, there was still not a single thread of light to serve as the dividing line between the human world and the black depths.

The thin bed sheet slipped off his bare skin with a soft rustle.

The room's temperature was kept at a constant fifty-five degrees Fahrenheit, winter and summer alike; roller blinds imported from Europe paired with heavy blackout curtains blocked nearly a hundred percent of the light and shut out most of the outdoor heat.

Sometimes Chase thought that his grave would look just like this bedroom.

In this pitch-black room impervious to light, temperature, and sound, he would occasionally dream of the tall palm trees and blazing sun of Los Angeles—but each dream was more distant than the last, more blurred than the last.

Perhaps one day he would no longer be able to see the West Coast in his dreams.

In the darkness, he felt for his phone, which always rested in the same spot, turned it over, and lightly tapped the screen—November 19th stabbed into his eyes.

...So this day had come again.

Chase sat on the edge of the bed, elbows propped on his knees, head bowed, and sat quietly for a while.

The remnants of night slowly slid down his back; before him, the roller blind hummed open, and the overcast daylight stained his bare body with its grey.

Even today's weather seemed fittingly aware of the occasion—beneath low, heavy clouds, a dreary, unrelenting rain.

Every year, he knew that going would be pointless, yet he still carried every pointless gesture through to perfection.

His hair was combed back without a single strand out of place, his skin shaved clean, and even his cologne came from a bottle that was matte black. He put on a black shirt, a black suit, and fastened a dark black watch to his wrist; the only contrasting color on his person was the pair of pale silver hands on the watch face—one long, one short—ticking steadily in the darkness.

The snow-white bouquet that arrived every year on this day was waiting at his door when he opened it, just as always.

Only one car was left in the garage—fortunately, it was also black.

Chase stopped the car at the usual spot, holding an umbrella in one hand and the flowers in the other, and walked step by step up the green-covered slope.

Beneath the grey and overcast sky, the grass and trees were wrapped in a deep darkness, as if dim black smoke were rising from the soil and seeping into the branches and leaves. Tombstones stood silently in the drizzle and dark green, watching from a distance as Chase passed.

At the same bend in the path, he saw the familiar cars and Key House Faction's private bodyguards.

One bodyguard, holding an umbrella, stood in place and gave him a nod from afar, calling out: "Mr. Monroe."

Chase understood what he meant.

This same scene had played out at least a dozen times—like a dance rehearsed too many times. He knew exactly where he was supposed to stop.

The bodyguards stationed at the foot of the path were there to keep strangers from going up; later, Chase came to think they might simply be there to keep him out.

This section of the cemetery rarely had visitors.

He stopped and looked at the narrow path that continued upward, gradually disappearing into the dark green. From the end of that path—the grassy hilltop—one could see, in the far distance, a cluster of high-rises occupying a corner of Blackmoor City.

Thinking about it now, Damian had still been so young when he died that Chase didn't even know what kind of scenery he'd liked to look at.

Nearly twenty years had passed, and even Damian's face had grown blurry.

The Damian in his memory had laughter, had blond hair, had bright shining eyes—but Chase could no longer recall his features. Whenever he tried to remember Damian's face, what surfaced in his mind was only the photograph on Uncle Key's desk.

Chase bent down and placed the white bouquet on a bench by the side of the path.

Rain struck the wrapping paper, gathering into droplets that slid down the ribbon one by one; the paper grew soaked through, the petals trembling faintly—like a pale, smooth back, shuddering with sobs it could not hold back.

He stood holding the umbrella for a while, then turned his head and asked the bodyguard in a low voice: "Mr. and Mrs. Key—are they already up there?"

"Yes," the bodyguard answered.

"This year, they also..." Chase paused, then continued: "...don't wish to be disturbed?"

"Yes," said the bodyguard, lowering his eyelids.

Chase pressed his tongue against the inside of his cheek. He looked up at the path winding ahead of him and thought, distantly, that he probably wouldn't be able to hand the Rumor over to Uncle Key today.

...Though that was just as well.

There was one thing he might be able to accomplish by using the Rumor; the more he'd thought about it the previous night, the more he felt it was worth trying. But that idea could not be shared with Uncle Key today.

He stood quietly in the rain for nearly an hour, then finally gave the lead bodyguard a nod and said: "Thank you for your hard work."

"Mr. Monroe, are you leaving already?" The bodyguard was mildly startled, as if he wanted to check his watch but stopped himself.

It was a bit early today; Chase usually stayed much longer, not leaving until just before Uncle Key and Aunt Hai came down.

"Yes," Chase answered softly. "There's something I need to take care of."

What had lit up on his phone this morning alongside the date and time was a text message from an unknown number.

The sender's name was Sydney Ginn, seemingly a Hunter who usually operated solo; she said she had the latest information about the "Vulture" Resident and could provide it to him.

"Two o'clock this afternoon," Chase said when he called her back—no greeting, straight to the point: "Come to the address I'll send you, and we'll talk in person."

He hadn't actually expected the inquiry he'd put out to receive a response this quickly.

The Rumor had only taken effect on the 17th, and someone was already reporting in on the 18th?

Either this person was especially lucky, or they were trying to use some half-plausible information to get a piece of the pie from him—though the latter type of Hunter, the kind who sought their own destruction, had been growing rarer in recent years.

Temptation was a large nightclub, one of the properties under the Key House Faction.

On a rainy, overcast weekday afternoon like this, its signs were dark, its doors shut. A nightclub in daylight always looked pale and lifeless—carrying the kind of worn exhaustion of a performer offstage.

Chase sometimes came by to check on things. The red lights and revelry of an ordinary night, the long lines of glamorous men and women, the noise and laughter soaked in alcohol—all of it was gone this afternoon, leaving only a young woman at the entrance, holding a lopsided umbrella.

The umbrella was tilted to one side on her shoulder; she seemed entirely unaware of it, half her body soaked through by the rain and the music streaming from her over-ear headphones. Her foot tapped and bobbed to the beat, sending rain droplets splashing like musical notes on the wet pavement.

Was she the Hunter?

Chase found himself genuinely uncertain.

It might sound a little arrogant to say so, but it had been quite a few years since he'd encountered a Hunter who could look this relaxed and cheerful knowing they were about to meet

him.

Chase pulled the car up in front of her, lowered the window, and asked: "...Sydney Ginn?"

"Huh?"

The woman seemed startled. She took off her headphones and leaned down toward him.

The car window was like a picture frame—against a sky of grey rain, it revealed a wet face with water droplets streaming down it; her skin had gone pale from the soaking, and her wet hair, her wet lashes, looked all the darker and richer for it, like raven feathers in drifting mist.

...At this point, whether the umbrella was open or not hardly seemed to make a difference.

"You're...huh?"

Sydney Ginn looked at him, momentarily stunned for a second or two, her gaze bright and direct—unflinching—the kind of look that almost brought to mind a child who had just walked into Disneyland. "Wait, could it be...you're Chase Monroe?"

Chase rarely had this kind of illusion—the feeling that he himself had become a target someone else desired.

Was this person truly a Hunter? Did she not know who he was?

"They said you're the Key House Faction's second-in-command, and I honestly thought you'd be older," Sydney Ginn flashed him a smile, water droplets scattering as they slid off her chin.

"This is great—looking at a handsome guy is always better than looking at some old man."

For a moment, Chase couldn't find a single word to say in response.

By the time he recovered from that brief blank, just as he was about to open his mouth and tell her to wait by the entrance, he saw that Sydney Ginn had already straightened up and swiftly circled around the front of the car to pull at the passenger door—the quickness of her movement was what finally convinced Chase she was a Hunter.

"Hm?" She pulled, and the door didn't open. She looked puzzled, knocked on the window, and said indistinctly: "Open up."

Chase looked at her, then looked at his spotlessly clean car.

He had originally intended to speak with the Hunter on Temptation's second floor during the quiet afternoon hours; somehow, a few seconds later, a soaking-wet Sydney Ginn had squeezed

herself into the car.

"Sorry, I'm a bit wet."

So she wasn't entirely unaware of herself—she hadn't mistaken her umbrella for a spacesuit—then why had she gotten in his car anyway?

"Why did you get in the car?" Chase put the question into words.

"Huh?" Sydney Ginn looked even more baffled than he did. "Were we supposed to stand in the rain and talk?"

...Fine.

"Where are you headed? I'll give you a lift," he started the car and said: "Tell me about the Vulture on the way."

Sydney Ginn nodded and said: "I probably shouldn't ask why you want to know, should I?"

And yet you're asking anyway.

"No, you shouldn't." Chase felt he should prompt her to get started, so he asked: "When did you encounter the 'Vulture'?"

"Hold on, let me turn off the music first." Sydney Ginn took out her phone, stopped the music, then opened her notes app while she was at it, and said: "Hmm...the timestamp on my recording is November 17th, 12:16 a.m., so it looks like the encounter with the 'Vulture' happened not long after midnight."

In other words, the moment the Rumor had just come into effect, she had already become its first victim.

If she'd only made up a story to cheat him out of money, the timing would hardly be this precise; and so, even without having heard the full account, it already had a fair degree of credibility.

His luck was not bad—though, of course, Chase had long known this about himself.

"I need you to tell me everything from start to finish, and give me the relevant notes as well," Chase said. "Name your price."

"Money?" Sydney Ginn paused, then said: "I'm not short on money. I want something else."

"What do you want?"

He sensed Sydney Ginn glance his way.

"I've always worked alone in the Nest—it's free, but there are times when it's really inconvenient...I've heard you're quite capable?"

Chase had absolutely no idea where to begin answering that question.

"...In what way? I'm not a Hunter."

"That doesn't matter," Sydney Ginn said. "I just want a favor from you. You're not a Hunter yourself, but you have plenty of Hunters under you. When I need help, I'd like the Key House Faction's Hunters to lend me a hand—that's not too much to ask, is it?"

"I'd strongly prefer you to ask for money," Chase said, and he meant it. "What you're asking for sounds like a headache."

"That's exactly why I'm seizing the chance to bring it up while making a deal with the Key House Faction's second-in-command," Sydney Ginn said sincerely. "Asking for money would be such a waste. If you were in my position, you wouldn't ask for money either, would you?"

"...No, I wouldn't," Chase admitted after a few seconds of silence. "You can start. What was different about the 'Vulture' you encountered this time compared to before?"

Though he didn't turn to look, he could sense Sydney Ginn's body tense slightly; she involuntarily raised her hand and touched her own neck.

Like she was touching a wound that wasn't there—the thought suddenly struck Chase.

"The biggest difference is... the 'Vulture' I encountered no longer had to wait for a Hunter to die before it could take their form."

Out of the corner of her eye, she clenched one hand around her pants leg.

"It was as if even the Nest was doing everything it could to help the 'Vulture'—helping it copy the shape of a human being. Once it took on the appearance of its target, it also possessed the corresponding memories, and would even wholeheartedly believe itself to be the real person.

"I... I still can't help feeling terrified sometimes, even now."

Her voice dropped as she said, "I know—I escaped with my life. But I still can't stop myself from thinking: if everything inside the Nest was helping it... then maybe I'm the 'Vulture,' and I just don't know that I'm only a Resident from the Nest who wandered into the human world."

This chapter somehow took me three days to write—I'm being ground to dust at this point... Right now, sitting in front of the computer is a sack of one hundred and twenty pounds of tail-end flour...

That rolladen thing I mentioned isn't made up—it's the German rolladen shutter. If I had the money, I'd genuinely love to put one on every single window.

What Sydney Ginn wants is a favor—translating it as 人情 feels like it falls just a little short, but there really isn't a more fitting word for it.

Chapter 80: The Reason for Chase's Arrest

Sydney Ginn had no idea that after that one line—"I am a Resident who has entered the human world"—she had come within a hair's breadth of not making it out of that car alive today.

Chase had once grabbed a man in the passenger seat by the back of the skull, forced his head straight down, and smashed it into the glove compartment with such force that flesh and bone shattered the casing; amid the spray of debris inside the car, that man never lifted his head again.

To sit in his passenger seat was to hang your life in his hands.

But he held back that impulse to reach out—because Sydney Ginn opened her mouth just in time, and starting from the beginning, told him the full account of her encounter with the Vulture Resident.

"...Pretty terrifying, right? Not only does it copy your appearance, it makes you doubt whether you're even yourself."

Sydney Ginn let out a soft sigh, as if drawing a conclusion. "If I hadn't punched through the Resident's head and forced it back to its true form... it might have actually crowded out my existence and gone back to the human world in my place."

No matter how harrowing the danger and struggle had been at the time, telling it took only ten or twenty minutes; throughout, Chase listened in silence, without a word.

Only after Sydney Ginn finished did he finally ask: "So the way to deal with a 'Vulture' is to inflict irreversible physical damage on them?"

Between the moment his words fell and the moment Sydney Ginn began to answer, there was an extremely brief flicker of hesitation—a pause, there and gone in an instant.

Wasn't this the escape method she had figured out herself?

"Right... but there's one prerequisite condition,"

Her speaking pace slowed by a fraction compared to how she had been talking just moments before. The difference was extremely subtle, but to Chase it was still clear enough to be impossible to ignore—when a person speaks while thinking, while picking through what can and cannot be said, their pace always slows imperceptibly.

If this were an interrogation, that fractional drop in pace would have been the opening Chase decided to pry into.

"It has to believe it is human... only when it believes it has suffered an irreversible, fatal wound as a human, does it have any chance of 'dying.' Of course, it doesn't truly die—it just reverts back to its Resident form."

"That sounds logical enough." Chase cast her a sidelong glance and said quietly: "What I'd really like to know is what you're hiding from me."

Sydney Ginn was visibly startled; had the seatbelt not been holding her down, she nearly would have jolted right out of her seat.

"Huh? What hidden part—you—"

She stared straight at Chase, blinked a few times, and then suddenly let out a breath. "Fine, you caught it... I promise you, what I left out has absolutely nothing to do with the Vulture you want to know about. It just touches on a bit of my own privacy."

Chase smiled at her.

"If it had absolutely nothing to do with it, there would be no need to deliberately cut it out of your story."

"Who said I cut anything?"

Chase's right hand rested on the steering wheel, his index finger tapping softly, one tap at a time. Unlike a Hunter, the targets he tracked were not Artifacts—they were people.

Whenever a person let slip the faintest, almost irresistible scent of prey, he always found it impossible to suppress a surge of pleasure.

"So then... shall we go over your story again from the top?"

Sydney Ginn pressed her lips together.

"Just let me off at the intersection up ahead," she turned her gaze away from Chase and pointed at the road in front of them. "Everything I had to say, I've already said."

"East Orange Road?" Chase leaned forward to look at the street sign ahead and confirmed with great friendliness.

"...Yeah."

"Isn't that still pretty far from the place you mentioned?" Chase said in a reassuring tone, pressed down on the accelerator, and drove the car straight past the East Orange Road intersection, leaving it far behind. "I'll take you all the way there."

Sydney Ginn fell into silence.

That was hardly unusual; when targets who had fallen into his hands finally grasped their situation, they almost always went quiet for a while—though this girl was not a target he needed to deal with.

What was unusual was that, a few seconds later, Sydney Ginn suddenly raised her voice. She was clearly frightened—her voice trembled slightly—but beneath that thin tremor burned a red-hot anger.

"What kind of greedy person are you?"

"...What?"

"You wanted to know about the Vulture, and I told you everything. If you don't believe me, go find a lie detector—analyze the contradictions and loopholes." She glared at Chase and said: "The part that has nothing to do with you but matters a great deal to me—why do you absolutely have to know it? You're so greedy. Does every piece of information in the world have to flow your way?"

Chase was still trying to think of what to say when Sydney Ginn fired off another rapid string of questions: "Should I give you my bank account password too? Do you need to know what type of men I like? Can't the way I survive in the Nest be my own secret? You're so insufferable."

Despite the complete absence of color from her face, she closed both eyes, slumped back into her seat, and struck a perfect impression of someone settling in for a nap, saying: "Big deal being the second-in-command—if you've got the guts, kill me; if you don't, wake me up when we get there."

Chase turned his head and looked back at the road ahead; two or three seconds passed, and he still could not find anything to say.

It was a little absurd, but somehow, in the scene she had conjured up, it felt as though he owed Sydney Ginn an apology—which was truly absurd.

What she was hiding clearly had some connection to the Vulture; her ability to revise a story was only so-so, but her lips were remarkably stubborn.

Of course, Chase had handled more than a few targets with stubbornner lips than hers.

"I'm not an unreasonable person..."

He had just started that sentence when he drove through an intersection; in his peripheral vision, a dusty gray car parked along the left-side fork had its headlights flick on right at that moment, falling in behind him on the road.

Chase cut off his sentence and checked the rearview mirror.

Sydney Ginn couldn't help but crack her eyelids open a sliver and studied him with guarded wariness.

"If what you're hiding has little to do with what I want to know, then I could treat it as if I don't know..." He stretched out his right hand, long fingers lifting into the air, then letting each one fall back gently onto the steering wheel. "That's what I was originally going to say."

Sydney Ginn sat up slightly. "Huh?"

"Today isn't a pleasant day... even I'm a little off my game. It wasn't until just now that I realized you're a trap." Chase let out a low breath through his teeth. "Is that why you wanted to get in my car? To lure me into a snare?"

"What are you talking about?" Sydney Ginn asked blankly.

Her acting was pretty good, he had to admit.

"You've got nerve, and you play it naturally." Chase turned to look at her with a smile. "Using yourself as bait takes courage—worth praising."

If Sydney Ginn's face had been pale before, it was now as white as blank paper, as though soaked through with terror until it had gone translucent; if she were truly a professional Hunter worthy of the name "Artifact Hunter," she ought to be fearing for her life right about now.

"I... I don't understand what you're saying,"

Sydney Ginn instinctively reached out and fumbled at the car door, as though only then realizing Chase would never give her the chance to open it and jump out. "How did I... become a trap? What trap? Weren't you the one who said you wanted to know about the Vulture?"

At that moment, a sharp, spiraling siren wail erupted from the sky without warning.

The cars on the road scattered like startled fish, fleeing in every direction; within the span of a few breaths, the misty, gray drizzle filling the air was dyed by wave after wave of blue-and-red flashing lights. Heaven and earth became one vast aquarium pulsing with blue light, and Chase's car became the single fish encircled at the center by layers of police vehicles closing in.

"Police?"

What Chase had not expected was that Sydney Ginn seemed even more stunned than he was—she was so tense it no longer looked like an act, her lips drained of color, a thin film of sweat on her forehead; even at a slight distance, he could hear her quick, shallow breathing.

...Could it be that she truly knew nothing about this?

She glanced around in all directions from her seat, completely forgetting the standoff between the two of them moments before, and jabbed a finger at the one gap remaining in the surrounding ring ahead, urgently asking: "They've got us surrounded! Can you break through from there?"

Chase, however, brought the car to a stop. He glanced at her, then raised his chin toward the front.

It was as if someone had choreographed it to the beat: through that one remaining gap in the encirclement, a heavy dark-green military truck drove in and sealed it shut.

When the four letters "SWAT" came into view, Sydney Ginn couldn't help but double over, burying her face in both hands, and let out a groan. "Special Weapons and Tactics? What kind of operation is this? You... just what did you do? They're here for you, aren't they?"

"...You have nothing to do with this?"

"How could I possibly have anything to do with this?" Sydney Ginn lowered her hands, her face looking several shades worse than Chase's. "How would I ever get mixed up with the police? I—I can't get arrested—let me out of the car, whatever you did has nothing to do with me—"

What cut off her words was the rapid footsteps of several officers surrounding the car, and the dark, hollow muzzles they held trained on them.

Sydney Ginn stared at them, frozen.

"Hands behind your head, both of you, out now!" the lead officer barked.

Although a couple of days earlier, his reckless driving on the roads had also earned him a police chase and blockade, today's treatment was clearly something else entirely—they had even

deployed a SWAT unit fit for a battlefield.

Chase had done plenty of things, but he genuinely couldn't think of anything that warranted this kind of full-scale mobilization—or rather, the few things that could have earned him this sort of treatment had long since been buried and washed away by time; it seemed unlikely they would be dredged up years later.

"I don't even have a gun. Don't be so tense."

Chase lowered the window and smiled at the dark muzzles outside. "What's this about? You've come looking for me?"

"Chase Monroe?" The officer was clearly in the superior position, yet his whole body was wound as tight as stone, and he barked again: "Hands behind your head—get out of the car!"

"Is it because I violated traffic laws?" Chase said as he opened the car door and stepped one foot out slowly. "See, here's how I see it. Whatever I did, the fact that I don't run when I encounter police—that's me giving you face, isn't it?"

Several officers trained their muzzles on him. "You have the right to remain silent—"

On the other side of the car, Sydney Ginn had also been cut off by several officers; they were less guarded with her—two of them rushed forward, shoved her against the car, twisted her arms behind her, and it seemed they had snapped handcuffs on her.

Chase raised both hands to ear level and glanced back at Sydney Ginn.

Her eyes were wide open, as if she still couldn't believe she was being marched toward a police car; as if that police car were not a police car at all, but a black hole that would swallow her whole the moment its door opened.

Chase was not, after all, superhuman. With even the SWAT team deployed, he had no choice but to surrender and let the officers cuff him—the more he thought about it, the more certain he felt this couldn't be over his reckless driving from a couple of days ago.

The law, however, stipulated that it would not leave him guessing for long—it would provide him with an answer.

"Chase Monroe, you are hereby under arrest on suspicion of the premeditated murder of Wellesley," an officer said, and shoved him forward. "Get in."

My old computer crashed a while back, you know—I've been limping along on my e-ink screen ever since. Today my new computer finally arrived, and after spending over an hour setting it up, I booted it up all excited, only to find it's not compatible with my e-ink screen! It just keeps flickering the moment I connect them!

Spent another hour trying to fix the configuration. No luck. Staring at the LCD screen, I managed to finish this chapter in the very last moment, and my eyes are already sore and swollen—I honestly have no idea how well I even wrote it.

If I'd known it would go like this, I never would have bought the new computer in the first place... Aaaargh, what an absolutely miserable day.

Chapter 81: Two Ways to Handle the Chase Situation

Blackmoor City Central Police Department was built on the site of a private psychiatric hospital that had been abandoned in the early part of the last century.

The hospital had been constructed by a wealthy physician who seemed no more rational than his patients; the buildings that remained today looked much like the work of a mentally unhinged and twisted mind stuffed into the guise of a sensible, orderly doctor's coat.

In the ground-floor lobby, which resembled a train station, a ring of cave-like solitary cells had been carved out—windowless, each one unconnected to the next. From the officers' work area, you had to descend several steps before you could open the iron-barred doors of the cells.

Even a tall person looking outward from inside a cell could only see the steps and the legs of passersby coming and going—though from the opposite angle, when the officers sat at their desks, pairs of suspects' eyes peered up from the edge of the lobby floor.

Perhaps because the officers found this layout unsettling as well: when Chase was escorted into the lobby, every cell in the ring was empty. Sydney Ginn had been taken somewhere unknown.

A female officer set an electronic device with a glass panel on the desk and instructed Chase: "Press your four left-hand fingers first, then your thumb."

Chase raised his cuffed hands and pressed his left hand down first.

"One look at this kid and you can tell he's got blood on his hands."

A middle-aged man with a holster on his belt, holding a half-empty cup of coffee, sat at a desk nearby and said to the female officer: "Run his fingerprints through the database in a bit—I'm curious what'll come up."

"Captain Flay, is it?" Chase tilted his head and looked at him. "Jumping to conclusions before you find the evidence?"

The middle-aged man lifted his eyes from his coffee. "...You know me? I don't recall ever arresting you."

"You haven't." Chase gave him a slow smile. "I have a hobby—I like getting to know Blackmoor City's police officers. Especially the ones drawing two paychecks."

Flay's expression shifted, like a man who had just sat down and felt something dig into him—confusion flickering through before curdling into discomfort. He recovered his composure quickly, let out a cold laugh, and said, "We'll have plenty of chances to get acquainted, soon enough."

"I look forward to it," Chase said, almost courteously.

He had always known this day would come sooner or later, and so Chase had quietly kept a close eye on the people within Blackmoor City's police system: a lieutenant who'd held onto his badge only because he owed someone a favor, a captain whose wife had caught him cheating and left him with nothing, a precinct chief who turned a blind eye to some particular benefactor—there was always a moment when such things came in useful.

Unlike some Hunter House Factions that deluded themselves and everyone else into thinking they could go legitimate through shell companies, Chase had always been clear: the Key House Faction, like any Hunter House Faction, truly stood in the shadows where sunlight never reached.

Given how Chase operated, the fact that he had made it all the way to today before showing up on Central's radar—and under a fabricated charge at that—was nothing short of a miracle. His consistently good luck deserved most of the credit.

The question was: who had pinned this charge on him?

Chase was a long way from Wellesley's orbit; making him a scapegoat was not an obvious move. Getting him arrested this way had to serve some specific purpose—something beyond simply needing someone to take the blame.

And what role were the police playing in all this? A tool kept in the dark, or a useful attack dog?

It was ironic, in a way. In his usual line of work, Chase was the one asking questions during interrogations; today the roles were reversed—but precisely because he was himself an interrogation specialist, he understood something: even as the subject of an interrogation, as long as you knew what to do and what to watch for, you could extract the information you wanted from the process.

Now, it was time to wait.

After patiently waiting an hour or two in the cave-like cell, Chase was finally brought to an interrogation room. Captain Flay, with whom he had already exchanged a few words, and another officer Chase didn't recognize, were already waiting behind the table.

"Sit down," Flay said pleasantly, rapping the table. "Something to drink?"

Chase first glanced at the mirror on the left wall.

Even someone who had never set foot in a police station but had watched a few TV dramas would know it was a one-way mirror; in a case this significant, there were certainly people on the other side observing him—he just didn't know who.

"Coffee," Chase said, dropping into the chair, his cuffed hands hitting the tabletop with a thud. "These—are they staying on?"

"When dealing with dangerous individuals, we have to think about our own safety too," Flay said, unhurried.

Chase had always been careful; he did not believe he had ever appeared on any watchlist or come to the attention of the police.

In particular, on every November nineteenth—the day he went to visit Damian—he never carried any weapons. Judging purely by his record and the search results from his person and vehicle, the Chase who appeared on the surface was barely distinguishable from any law-abiding citizen.

Which meant someone had told Flay in advance that Chase was highly dangerous—someone who, naturally, had ties to Artifact Hunters.

He turned his head and suddenly smiled, giving the one-way mirror a light wave; the handcuffs clinked with a metallic ring in the air.

"Hey," Flay warned him, snapping his fingers. "I'm the one with questions here."

"I need a lawyer present," Chase said, leaning back in his chair and crossing his long legs. "After all, you're the professionals when it comes to manufacturing false cases."

A young officer came in and set a cup of clearly lukewarm black coffee in front of him.

Flay acted as though he hadn't heard, head bowed over a case file in his hands. "You know, AI technology has really come a long way. Most of what it can do strikes me as baffling—I can't see what good any of it is for humanity—but every now and then there's something that solves a real problem."

Chase raised his eyes and looked at him coldly.

"For instance, there's this one AI capability—remarkable, really. All it needs is a short voice sample, and it can analyze and recreate your voice, using it to say a full fifteen minutes' worth of speech."

Flay kept talking as he lifted his coffee cup. "Take what I've just been saying to you about AI technology—in the hands of the right person, that could very easily be turned into a Miranda warning. If you're thinking of suing the department for procedural misconduct, you're going to be disappointed. Whatever judge reviews the footage afterward will find that I've already informed you that you have the right to remain silent, and so on—all that standard boilerplate."

...No wonder he kept either looking down at the case file or raising his coffee cup whenever he spoke. The voice could be swapped out, but lip movements still had to be concealed.

They had arrived at the same idea, even if for different reasons.

"Are you sure you want to waive your right to a lawyer?" Flay set down his cup and suddenly turned serious. "I just told you, you're entitled to have one present."

Chase thought for a moment, then broke into a grin.

"Since you're planning to play it that way, I suppose I can cooperate as much as possible."

He raised his cup as well, feeling his tongue slide involuntarily along the inside of his cheek; he took a sip of the cheap coffee before setting it down. "Come to think of it, I really don't need a lawyer. Do you know why?"

Flay maintained his utterly reasonable expression. "Why?"

"Whether or not I had anything to do with Wellesley's death, you already know the answer better than anyone. The way I see it, there are two ways to handle this. One: you walk out of this interrogation room and tell whoever gave you your orders that framing a fine upstanding citizen like me was a mistake."

He paused, his gaze sweeping briefly across the one-way glass.

"Two: I hang your chief, you, and whoever gave the orders from the flagpole in front of the station."

Rather than anger, Flay laughed, the puffy flesh around his eyes swelling up in round bulges beneath his brow bones as the smile pushed them up.

"Bold words! When I first heard people warn me you were no ordinary character, I half didn't believe it. If you think you can make good on that threat from inside a cell, I'd buy a ticket just to watch."

So they had no intention of letting Chase walk free anytime soon—everything they'd done since he entered the interrogation room had made it abundantly clear: they were working for whoever was pulling the strings behind the scenes, and the business of investigating the case was just a pretense they could toss aside at any moment. The only thing still uncertain was what their backer's actual objective was.

But Chase already had a guess.

He raised his hand and wiped the tip of his nose with the back of it, using the motion to conceal Rumor as it rose from his mouth.

"I assume you won't be giving me a chance to make a phone call, either?"

"A phone call?" Flay asked in mock surprise. "Didn't you also just waive your right to a call?"

Chase smiled.

"Then I'll just have to borrow your phone," he said softly, almost as if speaking to himself.

Thank goodness for the Western setting, or there's no way this chapter could have gone up...

Things have been pretty stuck lately—even with an outline, I keep hitting walls. Probably not in the best headspace.

Shameless confession: when I'm writing, scenes and visuals naturally pop into my head, and I always feel like what I picture looks very Netflix...

Chapter 82 — Chase, Just Over a Minute

"Hm?" Flay looked up. "What did you say? I didn't catch that."

Chase said nothing. The other young officer had heard, though, and with a faintly amused air volunteered: "He said he wants to borrow one of our phones."

"Ha,"

Flay dug a phone out of his pocket, slapped it on the table with a crack, and slid it across the surface toward Chase. "You want to borrow this? Just say so."

Chase had barely lowered his eyes before Flay snatched the phone back, his manner like someone teasing a dog.

"But then again, you don't really need me to lend it to you, do you? A big shot like you — whenever you want to use my phone, just take it yourself."

Chase showed no irritation, only gave a small nod. "You're right."

He turned his gaze and swept it around the interrogation room.

The room's design was textbook standard: no window in the entry door, and the door only opened outward, to prevent anyone from blocking it from inside and turning the room into a sealed space.

The suspect's chair was bolted to the floor; the ceiling was flat and featureless, with nothing to grip. The room was small — roughly two and a half by three meters — and beyond three chairs, one table, and the recording equipment mounted on the wall, there was nothing else.

Everyone watching through the observation side was armed without question. At the slightest move from him, backup would pour through that door at any moment — this was, after all, Blackmoor City Central Police Department, and even setting aside the field officers and administrative staff, there had to be at least several dozen armed officers in the building.

He himself, by contrast, had nothing on him — not even his hands, which were cuffed together.

His only possession was the Rumor Artifact in his mouth, which was absolutely useless to him at this particular moment.

His gaze moved inch by inch through every corner of the room, which seemed to stir in Flay a mixture of anger and unease.

"What are you looking at? I'm asking you a question!" He slammed the table hard and demanded: "I'm asking you — when was the last time you saw Ivan Weston?"

...That bodyguard?

So the person behind today's events was after the same thing he was — the Artifacts that had scattered after Wellesley's death.

He had no idea who could have turned Blackmoor City's police apparatus into their own private army...

In the past, only one person could have mobilized the police for personal use, and that was Wellesley. But Wellesley had long since died — buried and all — so who else in Blackmoor City could it be?

Not knowing who it was didn't matter. Once he got out, he would find the answer in time. And if he couldn't get out today, the answer wouldn't matter anyway.

Chase raised his eyes and looked at the two men across from him, unnervingly calm.

The closer he drew to action — the slimmer his odds — the calmer he became.

After all, people only grow anxious when they cannot accept the consequences. Near the edge of life and death, he felt a distant sense that he was like someone who had grown tired of living — his emotions drained away, and he was simply arranging the last remaining tasks, one by one.

For instance, the first task was to reach for the coffee cup.

When he had set it down earlier, he placed it half an arm's length away, directly in front of the young officer — Chase was tall, and with a slight extension of his arm he could reach halfway across the table, so setting the cup at a distance looked perfectly natural.

With his hands cuffed together, gripping the cup with his right hand meant his left had no choice but to follow, hanging below the table's edge.

"Ivan ran off early the morning after Wellesley died. Did you know that?"

Flay was asking this just as Chase's fingers touched the paper coffee cup.

He flashed a row of white teeth and smiled at Flay.

The next second, Chase gave his wrist a slight flick, and the paper cup tumbled rolling across the table, coffee splashing out like watercolor from a painter's brush — the young officer reflexively lurched back, and Flay's gaze was drawn away for one instant.

One instant was enough.

The left hand hanging below the edge of the table — at the exact same moment the cup went tumbling — snapped upward without warning and seized the underside of the table.

The interrogation room table, not bolted to the floor, felt weightless beneath his hands; Chase simply lifted, and the entire table came up with ease — he was already on his feet, and the moment the table left the ground he drove a kick into its underside, sending it flying straight out like a cannonball.

The two officers, distracted for that single instant, had not yet reacted when the table came at them — they were still seated. Their shouts had barely left their mouths before both men, chairs and all, were knocked flat by the table's impact — a muffled, splintering crash of wood and bone spread across the concrete floor.

In just a few short breaths, every move had already been rehearsed into instinct in his mind.

Chase crouched low, launched himself, and landed squarely on top of the overturned table. His weight brought immediate screams from the two men pinned beneath it, and there was a faint sound that might have been the crack of an arm bone — his body swayed slightly, like someone standing on a seesaw, then quickly steadied.

Blackmoor City's officers were no fools — they would not bring their sidearms into the interrogation room precisely to prevent a situation like this one; so Chase only glanced down briefly and wasted no time searching for a gun.

As he stepped off the table, both hands closed around a metal table leg, and he wrenched it sharply — it snapped free; screws scattered across the floor with a bright, crisp clatter.

Chase timed every second with precise exactness: by the time he crossed the narrow room in a few strides, the interrogation room door had just been pushed open from outside.

If there had been any room left in him for feeling, Chase might have felt bored.

Not because he thought victory was assured.

He simply did things one at a time, knocking people down one after another — no tension, no fear. The metal table leg swept a gray blur through the air and struck the incoming officer squarely on the temple, sending him crumpling boneless to the ground like a clay figure, before the man even had time to squeeze the trigger.

Chase's hands were still bound together by the handcuffs, so that his every movement looked like a strange, fluid dance.

The metal table leg spun through the air out the door, startling the officers rushing up behind into stumbling back several steps; in that tiny gap, he had already bent down, reached out, and scooped the fallen man's handgun off the floor into his grasp.

"You—"

The young officer's furious shout came from behind him. He seemed to have only just managed to drag himself out from under the table, and had barely gotten one word out when he found himself staring directly into Chase's reversed gun barrel.

Every second timed without a moment's hesitation — the gunshot tore through the air inside the room; the young officer collapsed to the floor instantly, like a kicked-apart pile of building blocks.

If you're going to do something, you see it through to the end — until there is no road back.

Chase raised the gun and fired several shots toward the interrogation room door — not to bring anyone down, only to suppress the backup officers outside and keep them from rushing in all at once.

Using this opening, Chase stepped back a few paces, kicked the table aside, and planted a foot on Flay's chest.

It seemed that Flay had been in the middle of reaching up to overturn the table when Chase had jumped on it at exactly the right moment, crushing his arm through the tabletop; he was groaning now and hadn't managed to get up — not that it looked it, given that Chase had already flipped the entire situation on its head, but it had only been a matter of seconds.

"Get up," Chase looked down, gun held in both hands, muzzle drifting to rest on Flay's head. "Time to say hello to your colleagues."

Flay understood what Chase meant in an instant.

At the top of his lungs, with every ounce of strength he had, he bellowed toward the door:
"Don't come in! Nobody shoot! Don't do anything rash!"

"Good," Chase glanced at the door and smiled. "Now tell them to close it."

"Close the door, close it!" Flay shouted.

The interrogation room's soundproofing was excellent; the moment the door shut, Chase turned away without looking back, gave the handgun a light turn, and the one-way glass shattered in an instant — countless shards of silver light cascaded down like a waterfall, revealing the empty room behind it.

Less than a minute — more than enough time for whoever had been behind the glass to read the situation and walk away.

Chase transferred the gun to his right hand, crouched down beside Flay, lowered his head, and looked him over a few times like a predatory animal scenting its prey, then cracked a grin at him.

"Uncuff me," he said, in a voice barely above a whisper. "Now — may I borrow your phone?"

These last few chapters keep getting shorter — what used to be one chapter's worth is now split across two days... I haven't had a good night's sleep in two weeks. Probably the sleep deprivation, but my ADHD symptoms have been worse than ever...

Chase's reception always tends to be a bit muted, but I still really enjoy writing him — especially his fight scenes, which are so satisfying to write (in prose it might not hit as viscerally as a visual, but the images in my head are pretty great).

By the way, there is absolutely no need to criticize female authors for writing likable male characters. Straight women are the dung beetles of human society — we already eat poorly enough as it is, so give us a break. Not many people are going to mistake the emotional satisfaction of a fictional character for a fantasy about grim reality...

Chapter 83: Chase Switches Mobile Carriers

Criminal organizations generally prefer not to make enemies of the police.

The police are part of a massive state apparatus—a system that continuously absorbs fresh recruits as replenishment, and a violent collective that delights in abusing its power and covering for its own; once the police take notice of you, the trouble never ends.

This was also why Chase had always kept himself submerged beneath the surface, maintaining an uneasy but distant peace with law enforcement—not because he feared the law, since a person cannot fear something he doesn't believe exists.

By the same token, though, he would not submit to something he didn't believe existed either.

Since he could never "face justice," any confrontation with law enforcement would naturally mean war; so as long as it could be avoided, he had no desire to drag Key House Faction into a war.

But today, it seemed that avoidance was no longer possible.

Taking the Rumor from Chase was an outright declaration of war on Key House Faction—even though Chase still didn't know who had given the orders to the police.

He felt his tongue press up from inside his cheek and slide across.

The Rumor would always move on its own without any apparent reason; but it seemed that whenever it was repeatedly on its host's mind, the frequency of its movements would increase—"movements," of course, referring to Chase's tongue.

Involuntarily, Chase slowly licked his lips, as if to verify that he still held control over his own tongue.

.....In most power struggles throughout the world, there is always a tipping point where one side rises as the other falls.

Criminal organizations and Hunter House Factions are unwilling to provoke the police because the police become an inescapable nuisance; but when confrontation with the police becomes unavoidable, all one needs to do is become a nightmare more frightening and more trouble than they are willing to deal with.

Being the one who picks the fight is always easier than being the one who gets picked on.

".....Are you sure? That's the Blackmoor City police system we're talking about." The woman on the phone gave a low laugh and said, "You should know, once we start moving, we won't stop halfway. Have you thought through all the consequences?"

"I don't remember you being such a talker," Chase replied quietly.

"Just looking out for you." The woman on the phone was unperturbed. "But out of curiosity, let me ask you one thing. What about your own House Faction's Hunters? Why come to us instead of them?"

"They have other assignments."

"Heh, so when things get dangerous you call on us mercenaries?" The woman who went by the nickname Mercury drawled. "Quite the calculation."

This was not a moment when Chase had time for small talk.

Amid the wreckage of overturned tables, splintered chairs, and shattered glass, he still sat in the suspect's chair—the only piece of furniture in the entire room still standing intact.

Chase stretched out his long legs, his phone resting on his knee in a fragile balance that would tip at the slightest touch.

One hand hung behind the chair back, the other held the gun; the barrel tapped the chair again and again with a steady metallic knock, as though keeping time to a rhythm only he could hear.

Flay sat on the floor, handcuffed to a chair leg, his face only inches from the gun; each time it lifted slightly into the air, Flay would involuntarily dart a quick glance toward it.

He was tough enough, all things considered—the pain from his severed arm left him white-faced and drenched in sweat, yet he kept silent, ears straining to catch Chase's phone conversation.

"How soon can you get here?" Chase asked, cutting straight to the point. "Outside my door there are at least several dozen police officers looking for a chance to break in."

"Oh? How have you held out this long?" Mercury asked with easy nonchalance—had someone who didn't know the situation overheard, they might have thought she was asking about a cardio workout.

"Hostage, negotiations, a few bullets...and a bit of luck," Chase said quietly.

Mercury laughed, her voice bright and clear. It was hard to believe that someone so cheerful and quick to smile commanded the largest mercenary Hunter force in Blackmoor City—for many retired Hunters, working as a mercenary was perhaps the most fitting way to make a living.

For Hunters who frequently moved in and out of the Nest, the outside world had long since gradually changed in nature.

No matter how long they came back and stayed, human fear, love, or death had all been permanently separated from them by a thin layer—like food with no seasoning, like a photograph, like an experience recounted secondhand...whatever happened, nothing felt vivid or real.

.....What was that called again? Nest Dissociation Syndrome?

"Just for the fact that you have my phone number committed to memory, I won't let you down," Mercury said, in an almost cheerful tone. "If only every target you gave me were as easy to find as the Central Police Department.....we're already on our way. See you soon."

Chase let out a quiet breath of laughter through his nose.

After he slipped Flay's phone into his pants pocket, Flay finally hesitated and spoke.

"You.....what are you planning to do? Even if you call in some mercenaries or gang members, it won't do any good—they've probably already called in SWAT for backup. A few criminals are nothing against a special tactics unit."

A suspect taking police officers hostage inside Central Police Department might not have been a first; but a suspect actually calling in mercenaries—that was probably something without precedent in all of Blackmoor City's history.

"Criminals?" Chase looked at him with an interested glance. "You think I'm a criminal? They've kept you pretty well in the dark. What exactly did the person behind all this tell you?"

Flay shook his head—whether because he wasn't privy to that information, or because he was unwilling and too afraid to say.

"I'm your only insurance policy right now, I know that, and there's no way you'd ever let me go," he said, in a tone that was almost earnest. "You've killed police officers—there's no going back now, so I won't try to talk you into turning yourself in....."

He paused there and looked across at Chase.

Chase was facing the cracked one-way glass wall, which gave him a clear view into the room on the other side.

Someone had already had the idea of using the adjacent room a moment ago—apparently intending to launch a surprise attack from the side—but they hadn't expected Chase to have already shattered the glass wall one step ahead of them, spotting the anomaly the moment it began; now the far wall of that room was splattered with great swaths of blood, thin rivulets streaming down toward the floor like a crimson forest painted in a post-modernist style.

Below the blood-soaked wall, several bodies lay slumped on the ground, like a signature an artist had left in the corner of a painting.

".....Precisely because you can't turn yourself in, you need to make full use of the one hostage you have. I'm saying this not just for your sake, but for my own." Flay continued, "You should know, you do have a chance right now to escape from this police department."

Chase glanced at him.

"Even if you've taken the guns off them and have enough ammunition for the moment, how long can you hold out alone?"

Flay was pale with pain, but his words were still reasonably coherent: "Holding out by force has no winning odds. Getting out of the police department smoothly using the hostage in your hand—that's the best outcome, isn't it? For the sake of my own life, I'm willing to cooperate with you and help you escape. But if you can't see that and insist on calling in armed men, then once things escalate, getting out of here alive will be far harder."

Chase didn't answer, but reached into his pocket and took out his phone, glancing at the screen.

The wallpaper was a photo of Flay with his son; the two smiling faces lit up, jarringly out of place, in this interrogation room.

"Your people won't get here anytime soon,"

Flay seemed to mistake Chase's glance for checking the time and seized the moment: "Do you really trust them to risk their lives for you? They might not come at all. How long do you plan to sit here trapped? Aren't you afraid they'll throw in smoke grenades and disregard my life entirely? You'd be better off making demands now—have them prepare a car for you and get out of this police department as soon as possible."

The time ticked forward by one digit.

Not yet the moment.....Chase thought. He turned his head and fixed his gaze on Flay for several seconds.

Flay, caught under that stare, shifted involuntarily backward, the handcuffs clanking against the chair leg.

Flay was going to considerable lengths to create an opening for his colleagues.

The Central Police Department's main hall was circular; stepping out of any room along the second-floor ring, one could look down from the walkway and see the hall below. This meant that the moment Chase left the second-floor interrogation room, he would be handing the police an opportunity to surround him—no matter how skilled he was, could he dodge bullets flying at the back of his head?

Chase was confident in his own abilities, but not to the point of delusion.

"I can offer you an opportunity," Chase said quietly. "Tell me everything you know—who sent you after me, and what you know about it. Tell me now, all of it."

Flay was taken aback.

"Of course," Chase considered himself a very reasonable person, and so he was patient about it: "If I just told you that, you probably wouldn't obediently comply—looking at your face, it seems like it's been a long time since you've had to think quickly. Let me explain."

Flay's eyes shifted toward the door. The room was well-soundproofed, but the faint rustling of movement outside still filtered through.

"The people who know the inside of this matter are certainly more than just you. You have no unique, irreplaceable value. You can choose to tell me everything you know right now—consider it your apology to me."

Chase raised his hand and used the barrel of the gun to gently push aside a few strands of hair plastered by sweat to Flay's forehead; Flay seemed to exert great effort to suppress the flinch that tried to pull his body backward.

"You are, of course, free to not apologize. Once I've taken control of the Central Police Department building and every person in it, I'll find another person who knows the details—one

more polite than you, I imagine, shouldn't be hard to find. And what happens to the impolite ones? They go up on the flagpole."

Flay closed his eyes and drew in a long, deep breath.

"You might be·····a little unhinged."

Clearly, it had taken him considerable courage to say that out loud, but he said it anyway. Perhaps he was counting on the fact that he was the only hostage, confident that Chase wouldn't truly kill him.

"Take control of Central Police Department? You're oversimplifying things·····this is real life, not a TV show.

"Besides Blackmoor City's own SWAT unit, there are federal-level SWAT units, and the federal government also has a dedicated HRT—a Hostage Rescue Team. Depending on the situation, specialized military units can arrive on scene far faster than you'd think. Do you really believe a handful of armed men you call in can declare war on the military power of this country?"

Chase listened to the end, then simply gave a small nod.

Apart from a loose strand of dark hair that had slipped down his forehead during the earlier scuffle, his face showed not the slightest ripple of emotion.

"So that's what our tax money goes toward. Then are you suggesting that, whatever happens here, I make sure the news doesn't get out?"

After he said that, Chase tapped the phone screen—no notification, message, or call was showing on it, yet he suddenly let out a low, quiet laugh from deep in his throat: "Ah. They're here."

He turned his wrist, holding the lit phone screen up in front of Flay's eyes.

"What?" Flay asked blankly.

"Don't you see it?" Chase said, rising from the chair.

His black dress shirt was already wrinkled, and at some point had been splattered with blood stains that were nearly imperceptible; the smell of blood mingled with cologne like an almost dizzying poison. "Your chance has passed."

"Wha—what? I don't understand·····"

Chase's slender fingers tapped lightly twice on one corner of the screen as a hint; but he had no real intention of explaining things to Flay. Just as he was about to put his phone away again, Flay drew in a sharp, quiet breath.

...After all, he was a detective — his powers of observation weren't half bad.

"What is that?" Flay asked, dazed. "My carrier network icon... shouldn't it be showing a 'T'? What — what is that thing?"

Chase bent down deep, meeting his eyes face to face.

"See that? The character for 'Nest'?" He knew Flay wouldn't understand, but smiled anyway. "The Blackmoor City Central Police Department is now inside the Nest Communication Network."

I'm dying in this chapter... I'm so stuck, how can I be this stuck, did someone swap out my brain or something...

Chapter 84: The Police Station That Reached Chase

"What?" Flay asked blankly.

A beat cop at his level had probably never heard of the "Nest" before today.

Of course, Hunters weren't the only ones who knew the Nest existed.

In truth, among the major clients of Hunter House Factions, those who were merely wealthy were actually few and far between—ordinary rich people, if they lacked the right connections, might never even have a channel through which to hear of the Nest or Hunters. The biggest clients were either obscenely wealthy or high-ranking officials.

To say nothing of everything else—just Artifacts capable of helping someone "win re-election," "win an election," or "secure an appointment" had already passed through Key House Faction's hands several times; obtaining such Artifacts carried little risk yet fetched astronomical prices, making it the finest business of all—the only pity was how rare they were.

Of course, there was no need to worry about clients getting a bad deal.

No matter how much a client spent on an Artifact, they always managed to squeeze it back from the country several times over, dozens of times over.

"You're quite lucky. Most people could live their entire lives without ever catching so much as a glimpse of anything related to the Nest."

Chase walked to the doorway, kicked aside the table panel propped against it, and glanced back.

"Want to take a look outside?"

Flay's eyes went wide—he clearly couldn't believe Chase would voluntarily open the door. The interrogation room had been turned by him into a makeshift fortress against outside intrusion; it was also the only reason Chase had managed to hold out until now.

But Chase turned the door handle all the same.

The interrogation room door swung open, little by little, pivoting outward into the corridor, revealing a stretch of murky darkness.

The lights in the corridor had been switched off at some unknown point.

The old psychiatric hospital building had poor natural lighting. Each floor had only a sparse scattering of windows—and calling them windows was generous; they looked more like round holes punched through the wall, not even as wide as a human head.

Even though dusk hadn't fallen yet, once the lights were off, the inside of the building was dim enough that one couldn't help but squint just to make out the outlines of things.

Flay was squinting now.

Chase stood in the doorway, one hand still resting on the door.

The moment he saw what lay beyond the door, he sharply exhaled the breath he'd been holding in his chest and called out: "Quick, shoot—"

The shout died unfinished, cut off by himself in a sudden reflex, collapsing into a sound from deep in his nose: "Mm... mm?"

There were indeed officers outside the interrogation room; after all, this was the room where a suspect was holding a detective hostage, so of course police presence had been stationed in the corridor outside.

It was just that this "police presence" was probably unlike anything anyone could have imagined.

Chase stood looking at the corridor outside the door, hearing the muffled, rapid breathing behind him with perfect clarity. Flay had probably smoked for half his life, so there always seemed to be phlegm rattling around in his chest, surging up and falling back with each breath—after a long moment, amid that rattling, he finally managed to ask: "What... what's going on? You—you're Jenny from admin, right?"

A female officer stood in the corridor outside, facing Chase directly.

She was the only officer outside the door. She carried no weapon, but one hand gripped a telephone handset. The coiled cord hung from the handset, its end showing a clean-torn break where it had been ripped from the wall, still swaying faintly in the air.

Most likely, the Nest Communication Network had blanketed the entire Central Police Department at the exact moment she was calling outside for backup—catching her first in its reach.

"Did someone call the police?" The female officer tilted her head up toward Chase and asked, "I received a distress call... who made it?"

She had a round face, long lashes, and brown hair combed neatly back behind her head. She looked to be around forty. She had the air of someone very capable.

"Him," Chase said, jerking a thumb back toward Flay.

"What?" Flay startled, as though finally coming back to his senses. "Hey, Jenny, right—where did everyone else go? Why are you the only one here? Hey, take off my handcuffs!"

That last part, it wasn't clear who it was even directed at.

The female officer named Jenny seemed to have her gaze pulled by an invisible thread, her eyes turning toward Flay.

"Of course, I'll be right there." She looked at Flay and said softly.

As she passed by Chase, the female officer blinked.

As she blinked, the long upper lashes stayed fixed in place; from beneath the upper eyelid, a separate inner lid flashed downward and retracted back up into the upper eyelid in an instant.

Every time the Nest Communication Network Artifact was activated in Blackmoor City, it manifested with slight variations in detail, like a creator who disliked repeating themselves; no matter how many times one had witnessed it, it still managed to catch one off guard with something newly unsettling.

Before leaving, Chase glanced back—"Jenny" was crouching in front of Flay, as though comforting a frightened child, murmuring softly: "It's okay, it's okay now... the bad guy's already gone. It's just you and me now."

Flay's face was drenched in sweat; his eyes were dry, laced only with vivid red veins.

He had stopped talking entirely, just staring fixedly at "Jenny's" eyes, as though they were the most incomprehensible thing in the world.

The recording device on the wall continued to run, its small red light glowing steadily.

"I received a call from your ex-wife," the female officer said, raising the handset and gesturing for Flay to lean his ear toward it. "Even though you're divorced, when she heard there was a hostage situation at the station, she was very worried about you—go on, let her know you're safe."

Flay stared blankly at the handset, and at the severed, dangling cord below it.

From the handset came a faint, hurried female voice, seeming to call Flay's name—making him jolt with a sudden shiver—

What happened after that, Chase had no way of knowing.

He gently closed the door, shutting a Jenny who was no longer Jenny, and a Flay who was about to be no longer Flay, together behind the interrogation room door.

Standing in the dim, murky corridor, Chase smoothed the loose strands of hair that had fallen across his forehead back behind his head, then straightened his shirt cuffs.

The gun was tucked at his waist; it wouldn't be needed for the time being.

In the gloom of the corridor, several sets of rapid, heavy breathing drifted through the air; along with a sound like a windpipe being squeezed—a faint, wet rattling—encircling Chase on all sides.

He closed his eyes and let out a long breath.

Weaving around the faces embedded in the floor, Chase walked to the railing, grabbed it with one hand, vaulted over, and dropped down into the center of the first-floor lobby—a cheering whistle immediately rang out after him, echoing through the dim police station building.

"Beautifully done,"

A young woman swiveled her chair away from a desk, turning to face where Chase had landed, and smiled. Even in the dim light, one could clearly make out a clean, smooth face; and the dense text tattoos covering her neck—letters, symbols, and Chinese characters all together.

"So? We got here in time, didn't we?"

Chase rolled his shoulders and neck.

The entire Central Police Department had sunk into darkness and quiet; but that quiet was like a layer of uneasy, half-conscious sleep, always on the verge of waking—and beneath that sleep, dim nightmares stirred.

The mastermind he was after had almost certainly read the situation and left at the first opportunity; but just as he had told Flay moments ago, there had to be other people in this building who were in the know—the police chief, for instance.

"Find the chief," Chase instructed, "I have things to ask him. If you come across anyone who hasn't been 'reached' by the Nest Communication Network yet, round them up in the holding cells."

Mercury gave him something resembling a mock salute, said a crisp "Yes, sir," and asked with a grin: "And then? You're the boss—your call."

Chase looked around.

"Whatever I do, they'll remember my name now." He thought that over and let out a quiet laugh. "So... whatever you want to do, go ahead. Do as you please."

I'm truly going to collapse—updates are getting later and later, and the writer's block isn't getting any better; if anything, it's getting worse...

Chapter 85: It Would Be Nice If Sydney Ginn Were a Resident

All she had wanted was to sell a tip and trade it for a favor—how had things suddenly spiraled to this point?

All these years, she had been careful and cautious, never crossing paths with the police in any way... she wouldn't even speed while driving, precisely to avoid a moment like this one.

She hadn't done a thing since that incident, and yet somehow she was standing right here.

Sydney Ginn stood frozen, as though every muscle in her body had turned to thorns, wrapping and binding her in place—until the female officer called out again, and she snapped back to her senses with a jolt.

"Hey! I'm talking to you—can't you hear me? What are you spacing out for? Put your left hand up here and press your fingerprint."

Sydney Ginn looked at the fingerprint scanner under its glass panel, then looked at the female officer behind the desk.

It seemed she had been brought into the Central Police Department building ahead of Chase—probably because she looked less threatening. Outside the station it was still a noisy commotion; they were likely in the middle of bringing Chase in. He was obviously not someone to be trifled with, so the police had their nerves wound tight.

If the officer standing beside her right now could read Sydney Ginn's thoughts, he would certainly adopt a very different attitude toward her.

"What are you afraid of," the officer gave her arm a nudge, urging her along: "Didn't you say you had nothing to do with that man and just happened to hitch a ride? Getting your fingerprints taken is just for the record. If you haven't done anything wrong, pressing your fingerprint doesn't affect anything."

The hitchhiking story was the first excuse she had grabbed in her panic, and thinking about it now, it was truly foolish—it would never hold up under the police's cross-examination. But that was a minor detail, not even worth worrying about at this moment.

Sydney Ginn glanced at the officer who had escorted her inside.

...Could she take him down?

Most of the people in the main hall seemed to be administrative staff; if she could find an opening to take him down and then escape the station, she wouldn't have to give her fingerprints—ah, no.

They had already searched her the moment she arrived and seen her driver's license in her wallet. Her face, name, and address were all laid bare.

Then... could she kill him? He was the only one who had seen her license.

Sydney Ginn turned her head back and stared at the fingerprint scanner again.

Hopeless. She had nothing on her—they'd even confiscated her earrings. With just her two cuffed hands against an officer a full size bigger and broader than her, it was nothing but a pipe dream. And even if she could kill him, her wallet was still in the station's property storage.

"Hurry up," the officer pressed again.

"I won't," Sydney Ginn said, sounding almost like a child. "I don't want to give my fingerprints."

She knew she was making a grave mistake—this was practically announcing to the world that she had something very wrong to hide.

But sometimes people simply regress to a childlike state of mind—especially in moments of desperate, furious despair—and even knowing it's useless, they instinctively fall back on childhood tactics like throwing a tantrum or crying in protest, as though the world might take pity on them and give ground.

She could sense the officer and the female officer exchange a glance.

"Why don't you want to?" the female officer asked, slowing her tone. "What have you done?"

If I could tell you, wouldn't I have just pressed my fingerprint already?

Sydney Ginn swallowed that retort, stubbornly planted where she stood, hands clenched into fists.

"She's probably got something on her," the officer laughed, walked over, grabbed Sydney Ginn's wrist, and pressed her hand down. "I never really believed you were just hitching a ride... but it's looking like we've hit the jackpot here."

"Let go of me," she wrenched hard to pull her arm back. "This is excessive force!"

"Feel free to file a complaint," the officer said with a smile.

Sydney Ginn's struggling and shouting brought several other officers in the hall rushing over; in the sudden rush and confusion, someone slammed her head into the desk, someone else pressed down on her shoulders, and a mouse and pen holder went rolling off the table.

Her arm was yanked out and away from her body as though they meant to tear it off, flipping her sideways with it. A hand pressed down hard on her temple, and beyond the overturned office supplies scattered across the desk in front of her, all she could sense were figures moving all around her—and something cool and hard and flat meeting her fingertips.

They'd done it... they had taken it after all.

"Should've taken the easy way," someone said. "Take her straight up to the second-floor interrogation room. The other one's coming in any minute—don't let them see each other."

Sydney Ginn was hauled to her feet and walked step by step toward the elevator; the pain was barely registering anymore, and every step felt like moving through fog.

After so many years, she had thought that matter had long since dissolved into nothing. Sometimes it felt like nothing more than a distant nightmare; other times, she would forget entirely that such a scene had ever played out in her life.

And so, even when she had discovered "Candlefall," Sydney Ginn had never once thought to use an Artifact to erase that stretch of history: she had no desire to look back and face it again, preferring to bury it in the depths of her memory; and more importantly, she didn't dare tamper with it recklessly—she had no idea what she would become now if she changed the event that had been the turning point of her life.

But all these years... had it been waiting for her?

Was there truly no escaping it?

As the elevator doors closed, she faintly heard the station's front doors open, and the hurried footsteps of more than one person—it seemed Chase had finally been brought inside.

Sydney Ginn was too exhausted to even summon hatred for him.

Things had come to this; all she could do was think of another way to salvage the situation. As long as she had a chance to jump from a high floor, she could use "Candlefall" to make it so

she had never gotten into Chase's car today—as for what became of Chase, that was none of her concern.

But... once she was taken into custody, would she ever get the chance to reach a high floor?

The lowest floor from which Sydney Ginn had ever opened a passage was the sixteenth, and she hadn't dared try any lower. No one could say for certain whether a single floor's difference might mean plummeting to her death on the street rather than falling into the Nest.

And yet the police station, the prison, the courthouse—all the foreseeable places she might be taken—none of them would place her above the sixteenth floor.

Bail might be the only sliver of hope, but even that could be denied; especially for a serious crime suspect, the likelihood of bail was even lower.

What to do, what to do, what to do—

In that moment, even the screaming inside her head felt close to that of a Resident. Sitting in the dead silence of the interrogation room, listening to the storm of screams raging in her mind, Sydney Ginn found herself half-deliriously wondering whether she might truly be a Resident after all.

It was the first time she had ever thought: if only she were.

Because only a Resident could escape from a life like this.

The door had been locked from the outside, the soundproofing was good, and nothing could be heard; the camera in the interrogation room held its small red light steady, never blinking.

The red light stared at her without pause, recording her restless shifting through every second that ticked by. The police seemed to have suddenly forgotten she existed. Sydney Ginn waited for an unknowable stretch of time before the sound of the door being pushed open gave her a start—she turned sharply and saw two unfamiliar detectives enter the room one after the other.

To her surprise, they didn't sit down to question her.

"Come on," the older detective called to her. "We're moving you somewhere else."

"Where are we going?" Sydney Ginn asked blankly.

No one answered; the younger detective gave her shoulder a shove, and she stumbled up from the chair and was led out the door with one of them in front and one behind.

Because the entire building was designed as a cylinder, the second-floor corridor curved in an arc, lined on one side with door after door.

As Sydney Ginn stepped out of her interrogation room, her gaze happened to cross the open atrium of the main hall and fall unobstructed on the corridor opposite—where several figures in police uniform were accompanying a tall, lean silhouette, who had just stepped through a door that closed behind them with a thud.

Though it was only a fleeting glimpse, it was clear that the officers were treating that person with considerable deference; and the door they had entered was beside another interrogation room—one that looked no different from the one she had just left.

"Keep moving, stop looking around," the young detective shoved her again.

"Aren't you going to question me?" Sydney Ginn asked. "About my connection to him—I mean Chase Monroe—"

"We don't need you telling us how to run an investigation," the young detective said, utterly indifferent.

They simply didn't care?

Sydney Ginn found it hard to believe, and yet she couldn't stop the feeling from rising up in her.

"Don't you want to know whether he killed Wellesley?" she ventured, asking once more.

"Are you worried about him?" The older detective turned back and laughed. "Are you two a couple? What, do you think you're Bonnie and Clyde? Save your worry for yourself instead of him. We've all heard how much you fought against giving your fingerprints."

"Riding on Monroe's coattails, we're fast-tracking the both of you," the young detective also laughed. "Maybe we'll have your fingerprint comparison results within two days."

Sydney Ginn's heart sank—but at the same moment, she couldn't help a flicker of hope.

If their target was only Chase and they had no interest in the nature of her connection to him, then perhaps they wouldn't keep her detained indefinitely? After all, without a clear charge, even the police had a time limit on holding someone... she didn't know the specifics—she needed to find an opportunity to demand a lawyer.

As long as she could get home, everything that had happened today could be rewritten.

The whole way there, she never once saw Chase; she had no idea whether he had been taken to an interrogation room, and the cells were empty too—though, of course, that was before she herself was pushed inside one.

After the detective removed the handcuffs and locked the iron door with a clang, Sydney Ginn immediately rushed to the door and demanded: "Don't I get the right to see a lawyer? I need a lawyer!"

"Sure," the detective said, offhandedly. "Wait here—I'll come get you when it's time to make a call."

Sydney Ginn was about to argue when a muffled thud drifted down from somewhere above—not like a gunshot, more like something heavy being knocked over; the sound was largely muffled, but it couldn't entirely contain the deep, reverberating tremor that traveled through the building.

"What's going on?"

She heard someone shout from the hall outside. A chair scraped back, and hurrying footsteps broke into a run; from above came the barked order: "Open the door, now!"

"Please go, sir," someone said from far off amid the clamor, their voice indistinct, "—he's fighting back, it's dangerous, please fall back—"

The next second, a gunshot shattered the noise of voices, reverberating through the Central Police Department building that had once been an asylum.

...Chase had made a move?

Inside the Central Police Department?

I was really too stuck before, and in too bad a state, so I simply took a day off... I'm feeling a bit better today, and this chapter wasn't too difficult—maybe because it's from a different perspective.

I've been showing signs of depression relapsing lately, not sure why. I need to adjust properly.

Chapter 86: Sydney Ginn's Way Out

Her phone had been taken away long ago, and from inside the holding cell, she couldn't see the clock on the wall of the main hall. Judging by feel, somewhere around twenty or thirty minutes later, Sydney Ginn realized: this was bad.

The bulb in the cell suddenly went dark; the faint, dim light in the hall seemed to give up the ghost before it even had a chance to creep down the stairs.

She groped her way to the iron bars, her eyes swallowed by a murky, impenetrable darkness.

...It wasn't a power outage.

The voices that had been rising and falling throughout the Central Police Department—at the very moment the lights died, they vanished along with them, without a single cry for help, as though every person had dissolved into the dark.

The temperature dropped sharply, though not with the cold of winter or air conditioning; the air was thick and clammy, as if a film of saliva clung to the skin, and in the stillness, wave after wave of a fishy, chilling sensation crept over her.

Sydney Ginn knew this dim, suffocating feeling all too well, but she had never imagined that one day, in the middle of Blackmoor City, she would feel as though she were inside the Nest.

This was Chase's doing, wasn't it?

Had he used some kind of Artifact? Hadn't the police searched him? Or was it something that could be absorbed into the body?

The thought "no wonder he's second-in-command—even his Artifacts are this high-end" flashed briefly through Sydney Ginn's mind.

Occupational habit—even in a situation like this, the instinct kicked in and she found herself mentally calculating the estimated value of that Artifact.

The way things were unfolding was truly beyond anything she had anticipated—after all, she had never imagined anyone would dare to declare war on the police—she knew she should seize the opportunity and make the most of it, yet for the moment she couldn't think of what to do.

Since the lights had gone out, she hadn't heard a single sound, as if she were the only living person left in the police department. After hesitating a moment, Sydney Ginn called out tentatively: "Hello... is anyone out there?"

"Oh?" A voice responded immediately. "There's still someone locked up in here?"

It seemed to come from the stairs; the tone was unhurried and calm—no ordinary person caught off guard by a sudden Artifact would sound like that.

"Who are you?" Sydney Ginn asked.

"You should introduce yourself before asking someone else's name," the voice said—it was hard to tell if it belonged to a man or a woman, though listening more carefully, it was probably a man with a higher, thinner pitch. "Aren't you scared?"

"I was brought in under arrest," Sydney Ginn replied, giving nothing more away. "How did you get in here?"

"You're sitting right there in a cell—who wouldn't know you were arrested." The voice said, "I'm a mercenary who was hired. Our boss said that this time, the Blackmoor City police arrested someone they shouldn't have."

A mercenary?

"You're a Hunter?" Sydney Ginn thought of something she had heard before and asked immediately: "So it's true that some Hunters work as mercenaries? I'm a Hunter too—please, let me out."

"Well, I'll have to go ask the boss about that."

"Alright," Sydney Ginn said, clutching this like a lifeline, and quickly added: "You were definitely called in by Chase Monroe, weren't you? He knows me! You have to tell your boss—I'm Chase's—his friend. I was arrested with him."

"Got it."

Whether it was because of the Artifact's effect or not, no sound of retreating footsteps came from the top of the stairs—and thinking back, she hadn't heard him approach before he suddenly spoke up, either.

So this Artifact didn't just snuff out light—it smothered sound too; the only exception, it seemed, was conversation between people at close range.

Under that on-edge, restless anxiety, time passed especially slowly.

Just when Sydney Ginn was beginning to wonder whether this Artifact also had some effect on time itself, she finally made out in the dimness the vague shape of a pair of feet descending the stairs; as the person drew closer, she realized she had guessed wrong—the outline of the figure looked like a woman.

"Don't get too excited," the woman said. "Our boss is willing to let you out, but I have no idea where the key is."

Once she was down the stairs, the cave-like cell felt even darker; even standing face to face with only the bars between them, neither could make out the other's features—and yet, for some reason Sydney Ginn kept feeling that the other person seemed somehow familiar.

But the feeling was hazy and elusive, insubstantial—like a wisp of white fluff drifting in water; at any change of angle, it vanished entirely.

"So what do we do?" Sydney Ginn asked—whatever the case, the most pressing thing was to get out of the cell. "Oh, right—the detective who locked me up might have the key on him..."

"And where am I supposed to find him? I don't even know who he is," the woman on the other side of the bars answered. "Besides, who knows whether their bodies are even still intact."

"Is... is that because of the Artifact you're using?" Even in her urgency to get out, Sydney Ginn couldn't help being brought up short by those words.

"What else would it be?" At that, the woman seemed unable to suppress a note of pride, and said: "The entire Central Police Department has been severed from Blackmoor City. Even if someone walked right up to the front door, they wouldn't be able to see this building."

"It—it turned into the Nest?" That was Sydney Ginn's first guess.

"Turning the human world into the Nest isn't that simple—if only it were."

The woman sighed with genuine regret and said: "In any case, I can't open these bars, and I can't find the key. I'll have to use a somewhat unconventional method to get you out. That way I can also answer to the boss—after all, you are Mr. Monroe's friend."

...Dragged in here because of him, and now she'd have to ride his coattails to get out.

"What unconventional method? An Artifact?" Sydney Ginn asked.

"Yes," the woman's chin moved up and down in the dimness as she spoke. "Look down—take this."

Sydney Ginn stepped back half a step and looked down. She saw the woman slowly raise her arm and push her hand through the bars, holding something in it. She felt for it and took it—it was a phone, someone's, its screen dark.

"This is the Artifact," the woman said. "I'll call you in a moment. When you pick up, you'll be able to come to where I am through it. That way, you'll naturally be out of the cell—no key needed."

Though she had seen and heard of many Artifacts, Sydney Ginn still found herself marveling at how remarkable they could be.

"Do I need to unlock it?" she asked. "Face recognition, fingerprint—"

At that point, for no reason she could name, something inside Sydney Ginn gave a faint, sudden lurch—as if some piece of information locked away in her subconscious had just knocked on the door.

"None of that. Just answer when it rings."

"Alright," she came back to herself, and knowing she was about to be free, smiled at the woman with genuine gratitude and said: "Go ahead and call—I'm ready."

The woman's shadowy figure raised her other hand; it was hard to tell if she had been holding another phone the whole time.

She had only just pressed the thing to her ear when the screen of the phone in Sydney Ginn's hand lit up, bathing her eyes in blue; the incoming call showed an unfamiliar number, and one that didn't look like a normal phone number—which was to be expected, being an Artifact and all.

Just as she was about to press the answer button, Sydney Ginn paused.

In the upper-right corner of the screen, where the carrier signal icon should have been, there was instead a single character: "巢."

The 巢 from 巢穴—Nest?

The lingering sense of familiarity, that sudden lurch in her chest a moment ago...

Sydney Ginn raised the phone on an inexplicable impulse, angling the lit screen toward the woman's face on the other side of the bars.

She saw the face of the female officer who had taken her fingerprints earlier.

Except that the woman's face now had no eyes.

This chapter is short—I haven't been sleeping well and can't get my rhythm back, so I had to split one chapter's worth into two... I did my best to make it interesting.

Chapter 87: The Shape of Sydney Ginn's Rules

"...Answer it." The female officer urged.

As she spoke, her mouth opened a thin slit, and her voice drifted out from that strip of black. "Really now, why are you shining the light at me? You've seen it."

Where her eyes should have been, there were now only eyelids—not in the sense that the sockets beneath had become hollow voids.

If she had seen hollow voids, Sydney Ginn might not have been so startled that she lost her grip on her phone and sent it clattering to the floor; after all, empty eye sockets weren't something she'd never encountered before, and they weren't even among the most terrifying things in the Nest.

Squeezed between the female officer's upper and lower eyelids were layers upon layers of eyelids.

Beneath a wide-open eye, another eyelid extended, slightly drooping; beneath that drooping eyelid, another extended, half-lidded... eyelids in every conceivable state, growing out one after another, rows upon rows of lashes, forming the rough shape of an eye, with a tightly sealed eyelid crease at the very center.

When Sydney Ginn tore her gaze away, she was almost on the verge of retching.

"Someone help!"

Amid the unceasing ringtone of the phone, she stumbled backward several hurried steps into the cell and called out, "Chase Monroe! Chase! You're the one who dragged me into this—get me out of here right now!"

The female officer tilted her head, as though watching her with considerable interest.

"Inside the Nest Communication Network, you can't reach anyone just by shouting with your bare voice. Can human vocal cord vibrations travel through radio waves? Of course not—same principle," the female officer said. "It seems you've already figured out that I'm not one of the mercenaries Monroe hired."

"Obviously!" Sydney Ginn snapped.

She paused, her nerves settling slightly as she realized she was probably safe for now—if whatever stood outside the door could act against her directly, it would have done so already, and wouldn't have gone to the trouble of passing her a phone and giving her the chance to use its light to see the female officer's face clearly.

"You're a Resident, aren't you? The reason I almost fell for it was that I didn't know the situation—not because I'm an idiot."

"Such a lively girl... just a little stingy." From within that thin black slit on the female officer's face, a voice seeped out like drifting fog.

The incoming call ringtone on the phone on the floor fell silent, the screen's light faded out, and darkness reclaimed the cell; that face was swallowed by the black, which was somehow a relief.

"I am indeed a Nest Resident,"

The female officer's voice outside the door abruptly transformed into something like a sound of churning thick ink and howling gales—it seemed to be introducing its own name. Quite a few Residents had names that human vocal cords and lips simply could not produce.

"I didn't expect to speak directly with a girl from Blackmoor City like this—how nice. The words you speak aloud can only be heard by nearby Residents; no one else can hear them... after all, we're already inside the Nest Communication Network here."

Chase's doing, obviously.

...She had to stay as calm as possible if she was going to figure out how to get herself out of this.

From the looks of the situation, there was only one way to leave the cell: ask Chase for help—although Sydney Ginn still didn't know exactly what method he had used, it was clear that Chase was far more desperate and reckless than she had imagined; to escape his charges, he had turned the entire Central Police Department into this.

Not that she entirely couldn't understand it.

If she didn't have Candlefall and could command the kind of resources Chase had, she'd probably have done the same thing.

Right, speaking of which—"this"... what exactly did that mean?

Sydney Ginn glanced at the hazy silhouette standing outside the door ahead.

"How can a Resident enter the human world?" she asked, steeling her courage. "Didn't you say this place hasn't become the Nest? Then how did you get in?"

"I never said I entered the human world," the female officer replied. "There are a very small number of Residents who can enter the human world, but the conditions are strict, and I am not among them."

There are Residents who can come in...? No, that's not the point right now.

For some reason, the Resident in front of her seemed to rather enjoy conversation.

"If you didn't come in, then this female officer—what's going on with her?"

"She's a kind soul who let me borrow her body to have a look at the human world—unlike you, stingy little thing."

Sydney Ginn couldn't help but shudder.

Another question finally had its answer—if the female officer had already become a Resident, it wouldn't be possible for an iron-barred door to stop her; the reason the female officer was kept outside was precisely because the body was still a human body, only somehow... infiltrated by the Resident.

"How does the borrowing work?" she couldn't help asking. "If you already have one... borrowed body, why are you still looking for me?"

"When it comes to human bodies, who could ever have too many?" the female officer said. "The Nest Communication Network won't last forever, so of course I have to take advantage of the opportunity to infiltrate and corrupt as many people as I can."

...In other words, the "Nest Communication Network," beyond sealing off a section of the human world, was essentially a kind of "medium"—one that gave Nest Residents a channel through which to invade human bodies?

The Residents remained within the Nest, yet could extend their tendrils into human bodies within Blackmoor City.

Judging by the fact that she herself was still fine, within the range of the Nest Communication Network's coverage, some specific condition had to be met before a Resident could invade—namely, answering the phone.

Sydney Ginn mentally sorted through the information and questions she currently had.

First: under the Nest Communication Network, she absolutely could not answer any phone calls.

...But was simply not answering calls enough?

Before the lights went out, there had been no moment where every phone in the Central Police Department had rung simultaneously; in fact, she didn't think she had heard any ringtone at all before the Central Police Department was covered by the "Nest Communication Network."

Without answering a call... so how had the female officer just now gotten caught?

And thinking about it from another angle—if incoming calls couldn't be answered, did that mean outgoing calls couldn't be made either?

Second: under the Nest Communication Network, ordinary means of communication like conversation were rendered useless, because sound could not travel.

The Resident had also said that shouting aloud couldn't be heard by those outside; since the lights had gone out, she hadn't caught a single sound, which clearly proved that the ordinary rule of "sound traveling through air" had broken down here, or at least could no longer travel far—on this point, the Resident probably wasn't lying.

On this point, she had her doubts: how did Chase himself communicate? The Resident said he had brought in mercenaries—that much seemed plausible—but he still had to talk to them somehow, didn't he?

In total darkness, you couldn't write to communicate either, so surely even someone like Chase wouldn't be whispering into someone's ear, would he?

She still had far too little reliable information, but based on these two rules alone, almost every avenue she had for seeking help had been cut off.

Sydney Ginn couldn't call Chase; even if they were in the same building, Chase couldn't hear her shouting.

Wasn't this situation just absolutely infuriating?

"There's no way I'm the only one in this building who hasn't been infiltrated by a Resident, right?" she thought it over and ventured cautiously. "Why don't you go look for someone else?"

"Because Chase Monroe is a nuisance," the female officer answered with unexpected candor. "It seems he wanted to find some informant in this building, so he rounded up everyone who hadn't been infiltrated and locked them all together in one place. As a result, we Residents—who only manage to connect to the Nest Communication Network once a year—could barely get our hands on any targets at all. How unsatisfying."

So as expected, Chase not only knew how to avoid being infiltrated, he also knew how to communicate with his allies within the Network...

Thinking about it calmly, after being brought into the police department, everything on his person would have been confiscated immediately—the situation should have been identical to her own.

The sequence must have been: the "Nest Communication Network" covered the police department first, and only then was Chase able to break free of his confinement.

Which meant that Chase's methods for protecting himself and communicating within the "Nest Communication Network" were things Sydney Ginn could do as well... No, wait—if he had been able to call in mercenaries, that meant he had made an outgoing call at some point.

If he could call the mercenaries, it meant he had a phone—which was obvious—but it also meant that the phone he used was not his own.

Speaking of "not his own phone"...

Wasn't there one right there on the floor?

Sydney Ginn crouched down as soundlessly as she could and began feeling around on the pitch-black floor of the cell for the phone.

She didn't know whether the phone was the key, but she had to explore the shape of the rules piece by piece. This place might not yet be the Nest, yet what held dominion here was, without question, a host of the Nest's bizarre "rules."

"...Looking for this?"

When the female officer's voice rang out, Sydney Ginn realized she had found the phone—and at the same time, found the hand resting on top of it.

This chapter didn't make it out before midnight, because no matter what I tried at that hour, the plot wouldn't move forward—I knew what needed to happen, but it was like driving with

headlights down a dark road in the middle of the night: always a little hazy, every version feeling off. I rewrote it several times, and only now do I finally have a version I'm satisfied with, so I'm posting it right away.

Honestly, lately I've been at the point where I don't even want to write anymore. Even though I love telling stories, this kind of grinding wear is more than I can take.

Chapter 88: Sydney Ginn Realizes the Order of Two Things

When had it——

Even a Hunter's reflexes are sometimes no match for the moment a trap snaps its iron teeth shut.

Sydney Ginn had barely touched the female officer when she recoiled as if shocked; but before she could step back, something suddenly shot out from the dark depths ahead and seized her other arm.

It was... it was the female officer's other hand.

It had slipped both hands through the bars all along—the phone was both "bait" and a reference point; the moment Sydney touched the phone, she had already entered the female officer's grabbing range.

Though the one gripping her still wore a human body, it unleashed a strength that was nothing human; Sydney couldn't help but cry out in pain, feeling as though her left arm were a lump of dough about to be wrenched clean off—even if her skin split open and blood sprayed the next second, she wouldn't have been surprised, let alone found a way to break free.

"You had your chance and threw it away," the female officer wheezed out a laugh. "What they said when they took your fingerprints—not a word of it was wrong."

...This Resident—had it taken over the female officer entirely, memories and all?

Sydney was in too much pain to say a single word, yet at the same moment she realized she was being yanked rapidly forward; her weight and resistance were almost nonexistent against the Resident's monstrous strength, leaving her with nothing to do but stumble and lurch headlong—it was hard to believe that the hand clamped around her arm was even smaller than her own.

It was then that she did something almost no ordinary person would ever think to do.

No matter how quick a person's reflexes, in a sudden crisis there must always be a process of first "perceiving" and then "reacting."

If one were to analyze it deeply, "perceiving" actually contains two parts: first, grasping the nature of the situation; second, based on the situation, determining one's next course of action.

The most critical difference between a Hunter and an ordinary person lies not in physical skill or fitness—the greatest difference is probably that the time a Hunter needs to "perceive" and "react" is fast as a lightning flash.

And it is often exactly this that decides who gets to come home alive from the Nest, and who makes the leap from ordinary person to Artifact Hunter.

Sydney Ginn abandoned her struggle cleanly and without hesitation.

As she was being pulled straight toward the iron bars, she instead threw all her strength into pressing herself down to the ground and swept her arm hard across the floor, knocking the phone lying there—momentarily forgotten by everyone—skidding several steps away, into the cell.

The next second, half her face, her ear, and her shoulder slammed into the iron bars with a heavy thud.

She lay half-prone on the ground, her entire arm hauled out through the bars; her circulation had been cut off so severely that her fingertips had gone cold and numb.

For a moment she couldn't even tell whether the metallic tang was coming from the iron bars or from her own mouth and nose.

"You see,"

The female officer's face—with its long, thin slit of a mouth and its layered, overlapping eyelids and lashes—pressed through the iron bars until it was nearly touching Sydney Ginn's face.

"If you had just picked up the phone with a little hope in your heart, wouldn't that have been nicer? That would have been a humane mercy killing. Now your fear is so thick I can smell it even without crossing into the mortal world..."

"What do you want?" Sydney asked, her voice trembling.

Half of it was fear—she truly wanted an answer; the other half was stalling for time.

As she spoke, Sydney strained to stretch out one foot, searching the floor for the phone she had swept away earlier.

The female officer didn't answer her.

It was crouching outside the iron door now, eye level with Sydney who lay half-prone on the ground; it lowered its head, groping for something, and then from the lower edge of Sydney's field

of vision, a screen lit up—the female officer's face, nearly pressed against hers, was instantly illuminated again.

Its layered eyelids and lashes formed two bulging spheres, and it seemed to glance at Sydney.

Right—the female officer had been holding another phone in its hand all along...

At that moment Sydney's toes finally hooked the phone, and she began slowly kicking it toward herself little by little; she flicked her eyes over, and in one fleeting instant, made out the phone that had lit up.

The wallpaper on the phone's screen was a selfie of the female officer and a man—faces pressed together, eyes bright, one smiling, the other pouting, apparently a couple.

"Because it isn't your own phone, you have to make a call."

The female officer said something that made no immediate sense, then lowered its head and unlocked the phone with a passcode—no facial recognition technology would ever unlock for a face packed solid with layer upon layer of eyelids.

Was it planning to press the phone forcibly against its own ear?

Sydney was drenched in sweat, alternating between hot and cold.

Her other hand, still free, barely managed to reach the edge of the phone—but truthfully, she had no idea what she could do with it.

On the verge of "infecting" another human, the female officer seemed to be in good spirits and even offered an explanation: "Any communication or data exchange that takes place under the Nest Communication Network can allow a Nest Resident to reach you. Too bad you can't call out, or I'd really love to hear little Ji's voice..."

It kept its grip locked tight around Sydney's arm, wedging her shoulder between the iron bars, leaving her no room even to turn her head away.

Sydney had the phone in her hand now; but the phone she had staked her life to retrieve was cold and heavy and silent, still bringing her no hope whatsoever.

"So I'll just have to call a colleague who's also on the Nest Communication Network,"

The female officer said, selecting a name from the contacts list and pressing call. The first dial tone sounded from the phone—thin and muffled, as though pressed flat by the darkness—and

the female officer smiled, its phone-holding hand reaching through the bars to press directly against the side of Sydney's face.

This was a dead end, a hopeless trap——

In that instant of despair, only Sydney Ginn's survival instinct remained.

Two facts struck her mind in quick succession, seized by a nearly drowning Sydney like pieces of driftwood.

Looking back on it afterward, if she had realized these two things in the opposite order, she almost certainly would not have survived the Central Police Department.

The first thing: she heard the dial tone.

She heard the dial tone from the female officer's phone—and yet she was still alive and well; at the very least, before the phone was pressed against her, she was still herself, a living, warm-blooded human.

In other words—even a phone that was actively in a call, as long as it wasn't held up to your ear, was safe?

It sounds complicated in the telling, but at that moment Sydney had no time to think; every action was more like an unconscious reflex—in that hair-trigger instant, she suddenly raised her hand and used the phone in her other hand to shield her ear, the one exposed to the female officer, just in time.

Whether this would work, no one knew.

The very next second after the phone blocked her ear, the female officer's phone slapped against it with a sharp crack; through the barrier of one phone, the second dial tone sounded right beside Sydney's ear—this time, far louder.

...Still alive.

If her arm weren't still being held, Sydney could have gone completely limp; but the terror, the anxiety, the trembling dread she felt at that moment were, without question, all emotions that belonged entirely to a human being.

The second thing she realized came after the female officer's call connected—from some distant corner of the Central Police Department, a faint iPhone default ringtone began to sound.

...Sound could travel now?

With no time to wonder why she could suddenly hear it, Sydney seized the moment and shouted at a volume that could nearly tear her throat raw: "Chase Monroe! Get over here and save someone—I'm going to get killed because of you!"

These past few days I've kept seeing everyone encouraging me to rest more and telling me not to worry about updates—it's truly given me a lot of strength. When I'm in really bad shape I can't find the energy to reply to every comment one by one, but seeing your messages makes me feel supported and accepted, and I can truly feel how much you all want me to have nothing to worry about. That warmth means a lot.

Thank you all, I'm genuinely so grateful for your comfort and support—I honestly don't know what I've done to deserve it...

I'm already working on getting myself back in shape, so please don't worry—Hu Hansan... no, Natalie will recover.

Chapter 89: Sydney Ginn, Who Squeezes Through Every Crack

Chase arrived faster than she had expected.

She didn't know which cry it was that finally brought him; she only remembered the flashlight beam hitting her face all at once, blazingly bright, making Sydney Ginn flinch and squint against the glare.

The dialing tone that had been pressing steadily against her ear suddenly cut off—as if yanked up into midair—and the next instant the female officer's entire body was hurled against the wall, a heavy, muffled crash booming through the semi-underground cell.

The female officer's shriek, the smack of its phone hitting the floor, the rush of disturbed air and sounds of movement—all at once, the space outside the iron-barred door erupted like a small, chaotic grenade.

"Chase...?"

Sydney Ginn looked up just in time to see a tall, lean shadow bring its foot down hard on the female officer's phone. The screen shattered and snapped, and the dialing tone along with the distant ringtone instantly sank into silence.

He glanced over at Sydney Ginn; backlit as he was, only a sliver of his profile was visible—the light seemed to take on a kind of bone, clean and hard.

"You finally came!" Sydney Ginn's heart dropped back into her chest. She said, "Just now, I —"

She hadn't even finished speaking when she saw Chase suddenly step forward and snatch away the phone she had been holding over her ear as a makeshift shield—just one swift grab, yet it startled Sydney Ginn into a daze.

Ever since becoming a Hunter, she had paid particular attention to strength and agility training, and was by no means weak or slow. It was precisely because she had some physical strength of her own that she understood all the more clearly, from that single snatch, that the force behind his hand was something close to inhuman.

She absolutely could not get into a physical conflict with this person; when it came to that, she'd have to find another way to deal with it... Sydney Ginn thought, rising to her feet, and then

suddenly realized something.

The moment the phone left her, the dead silence around her returned.

The distant footsteps and the muffled sounds of doors opening and closing from just moments ago sank away in an instant, as though they had been pressed back down beneath the belly of the Central Police Department.

Huh? Could it be—

At that moment Chase glanced at the phone screen, saw that it was dark, and passed the phone back through the iron bars.

He was checking whether the phone was in the middle of a call, wasn't he?

In other words, he was perfectly aware that making a call under the Nest Communication Network would invite a Resident to invade—which was why he had confirmed the state of Sydney Ginn's phone first.

Sydney Ginn took the phone back, listened for a moment, then asked in a low voice: "So I can only hear the sounds around me when I'm holding someone else's phone?"

"Your mind works fast—you're a Hunter too, I take it?"

The one who answered wasn't Chase, but a woman standing behind him, holding the flashlight for him.

She was sitting on the steps with the flashlight held up in front of her, which made it impossible for Sydney Ginn to make out her face; only when the beam happened to sweep past did the dense lettering tattooed across her neck flash briefly through the light.

"That's right," Sydney Ginn said, irritation rising at the very thought of it, "I only wanted to trade him a piece of information, and I ended up getting dragged into the station along with him!"

The woman tilted her head back and laughed. "You'll get used to it. This man has a way of draining every bit of luck from the people around him."

Sydney Ginn's first and second responses would both have been rather rude, so she swallowed them.

"That female officer—is it still human? If you just leave it tossed aside like that, the Resident that's invaded it won't just let things go, will it?"

As if to confirm what she'd said, the female officer chose that very moment to stagger upright from the corner of the wall.

The space at the bottom of the steps, just outside the cell door, was already narrow; with Chase's large frame planted there, what little open floor remained was nearly gone, and the female officer only had to raise a hand to grab his arm.

Clearly, that was exactly what it intended to do.

Just as Sydney Ginn was about to call out a warning, the woman sitting on the steps suddenly let out a sharp, piercing whistle—the female officer jolted its head up, and for a split second, Sydney Ginn was almost reminded of a dog that had abruptly remembered its owner was in the room.

"Get out," the woman on the steps said, staring it down, her voice cold. "Don't touch my client."

Sydney Ginn's mouth fell open without her realizing it. She watched, dumbstruck, as the female officer said nothing, shuffled its way around, climbed the steps, and disappeared into the dim first-floor hall—and for a moment, she could barely keep up with what had just happened: "Wh—why did it..."

"They're all contractors." The woman offered a brief explanation—though if anything, the explanation only made things more confusing.

...Contractors?

Was "contractor" really a word that belonged in this moment?

Chase turned to the woman and asked: "Are you protecting me, or that Resident?"

"It's not easy to sign a decent Resident, you know. Have some understanding." The woman smiled. "Every single one of them I signed at the risk of my own life, going into the Nest."

Sydney Ginn's bewilderment grew thicker and thicker until her mind was practically fogged over; but before she could get a word in, she saw Chase had already turned away and seemed to be preparing to leave.

"Hey? Where are you going—let me out first!"

"I still have things to do. I don't have time to look for the cell key—just wait a bit."

That was absolutely not going to work.

Never mind that Sydney Ginn had, by nature, always despised being restrained and confined—there was already the very real question of whether Chase would even remember to take her along when he left.

And besides, if there was no time to find the cell key now, would there somehow be time when he absolutely had to go?

"Wait," she called out quickly, "you can't just leave me locked in here! What if another Resident comes?"

"Move to the back of the cell," Chase said without looking back. "You've already figured out the rule, haven't you?"

It seemed that as long as she wasn't directly touched by a phone in the middle of a call or with a call in progress, a Resident couldn't invade her—which meant the cell itself had become a natural protective circle.

But Sydney Ginn only wanted to get out.

Even if the back of the cell was the safest place in the entire Central Police Department, she could not stand being penned up in a space this small—she was a fully functioning, rational adult, and to have no say over where she went or what she did, to be bound and constrained by some outside will pressing down on her, limiting her every move: wasn't that itself the deepest possible insult to a person's dignity?

Of course, this mindset of hers hadn't gone to any extreme—Sydney Ginn also agreed, for instance, that people had to follow traffic laws when they drove. People were social animals and couldn't simply do as they pleased.

But being locked up and stripped of her freedom—even for a single minute—was unbearable.

"All you have to do is have a mercenary look for the key for me—it won't interfere with what you're doing at all. Hey, don't leave, you still owe me a favor!"

"I'll get you out of the Central Police Department—we're even."

By the time Sydney Ginn processed what he'd said, she felt a breath lodging in her chest—what kind of shameless logic was that? Hadn't she wound up in here precisely because of Chase in the first place?

But arguing over exactly how a favor ought to be repaid was not even remotely the right moment; just as she was racking her brains for how to convince Chase, the woman holding the flashlight spoke up.

"Honey," she said with a smile, "we're looking for their police chief, who's so spineless he's gone and hidden himself somewhere—we're really short on hands. But don't worry, I'll remember you. If he won't take you, I will—I have a soft spot for girls as quick and straightforward as you."

"Wait, let me out and I'll come with you—I'm an extra pair of hands too!"

Sydney Ginn's eyes lit up and she jumped at the chance to volunteer; but as she said it, she suddenly recalled something she had glimpsed earlier and couldn't help asking: "Is the chief a thin, tall person? Looks fairly young?"

Chase stopped on the steps.

From her angle, she could only see his dark trousers and shoes.

"No," the woman answered, "he's a fat man with a rather large belly."

Chase's voice came down from above: "Why do you think he's tall and thin?"

...There seemed to be an opening.

Sydney Ginn smiled silently, reached her hand through the iron bars, and tapped the lock.

"Let me out, and I'll tell you everything I saw. Either way, you said yourself you'd let me out sooner or later—so am I wrong? Don't look sour; you'd have to open the door first before you could finish me off."

It was only later that she learned: getting Chase to let out a long, drawn-out sigh was actually quite an achievement.

I've been going to sleep later and later every day lately—it feels like I'm about to cycle through all 24 hours at once... The more you encourage and comfort me, the more I feel I can't let you down. Updates can't just be dropped haphazardly, so even if they're short, I'll keep them coming—don't worry, I'll work within my limits and do my best to keep the quality up. When it really gets to be too much, I'll take a rest. Saturday's coming up fast anyway!

Chapter 90: Sydney Ginn Has Not a Single Simple Character

She had finally figured it out — Chase was a hunting hound through and through.

A hound has only one thing in its head: the target, and the chase — using the same approach you'd use with an ordinary person on him was like pouring water down a drain, not even an echo in return.

If anyone else had been in his position, they would have let Sydney Ginn out of the cell as a matter of both feeling and reason; yet concepts like "lending a hand" or "making up for the trouble you caused someone" seemed to not exist in Chase's dictionary at all.

But once there was an objective in front of him, everything changed.

When Chase had refused to help at first, Sydney Ginn had assumed that finding the cell key would be a huge ordeal, and felt a little uneasy inside, afraid that the information she'd provided would make him feel it hadn't been worth the trouble afterward — yet before she'd even had time to warm the cot with her backside, he had already returned.

"Huh?" Sydney Ginn asked, dazed. "Did you forget something?"

The tall silhouette gave no answer, but the crisp sound of keys clinking together rang out from his hand.

He already had the key?

Once he had a goal driving him, his efficiency was something else entirely.

Sydney Ginn hurried to the door, using her phone's light to watch as he slid the key into the lock, and couldn't help feeling both annoyed and amused: "Did you know all along where the key was? You were barely gone any time at all!"

"If you think that's too soon, I can always come back later."

Sydney Ginn quickly grabbed the open iron door and said, "No, no — I'm just surprised. How did you find the key so fast?"

She didn't really expect Chase to bother answering; to her surprise, he glanced at her and actually replied: "This is also a kind of hunt. The key is finding the right path."

...Sure enough, still a hound.

Sydney Ginn was about to slip out the door when a heavy thud rang out — "thunk" — and Chase grabbed the railing on the other side, his arm blocking the doorway.

"Now it's your turn," he said, looking down at her.

Sydney Ginn had only caught two glimpses of that person's face.

Even if she wracked her brain to pad out her description, the most she could offer amounted to no more than a few sentences' worth of information — claiming she wasn't worried that Chase might get fed up and lock her back in the cell would have been a lie.

That said, just as Chase needed a motive before he would lend a hand, he didn't seem to hurt people for no reason when he had no particular purpose in mind either.

When Sydney Ginn finished speaking, he was clearly unsatisfied, yet he still stepped aside and let out a snort through his nose: "That's it?"

"I was being marched at gunpoint," she said, seizing the chance to slip past him as she spoke, heading up the stairs, with Chase following behind her. "Even if I'd asked who those people were, they wouldn't have told me."

"Completely not worth tracking down a key to let you out," Chase said.

"Speaking of which, let's settle this one thing at a time — for the Vulture Resident, you still owe me a favor..."

As Sydney Ginn spoke, she reached the first floor; she raised her phone's light, looked up, and couldn't help freezing.

The first-floor lobby of the Central Police Department, which she had walked through several times not long ago, was now completely unrecognizable: most of the desks had been stacked high in several piles, some chairs and tables shoved over against the walls, and computers, phones, filing cabinets, and other miscellaneous items were heaped into mountains of junk across the floor.

"Hey! Do you know what crimes you're committing!" From beneath the floor at the far end of the lobby, someone was raging from inside a cell: "Who the hell are you people, daring to go after the Central Police Department?"

By rights, without a phone on them, they couldn't hear a thing from the surrounding environment; whether to call that person gutsy or just pig-headed was hard to say — they seemed to have been shouting into the silent void all along.

"So there are still people who weren't possessed?" Sydney Ginn instinctively stopped in her tracks, unwilling to go anywhere near the end where the police were being held. "I thought — aren't you worried they'll come after you afterward — wait, are you planning to..."

She cycled through several thoughts in the span of a few seconds, but Chase walked right past her as if he hadn't heard a single one of them.

"Well, well, you're out?"

The woman from earlier — the one with tattoos covering her neck — leaned over the second-floor railing and called out to Sydney Ginn with a grin: "Didn't you say you wanted to help find the chief? Come on up."

Looking up from the lobby, she could see several flashlight beams sweeping back and forth across the second floor, and the sounds of rummaging, drawers being thrown open, and people moving in and out never stopped; from the third floor up there was no atrium, so Sydney Ginn couldn't see it, but it wasn't hard to imagine there were plenty of people searching up there too.

If she used this opportunity while they were searching for someone —

Her split second of hesitation seemed to be clearly caught by the woman.

"Were you thinking of leaving?" the woman asked. "Can't blame you — this isn't exactly a place to linger."

She seemed far more reasonable than Chase, and apparently thought quite well of herself; if she could make decisions on her own, Sydney Ginn could probably have slipped out of the police department early.

The only problem was... Sydney Ginn couldn't help glancing at Chase's retreating back.

"You won't be able to leave, you know," the woman on the second floor said, with an almost gentle smile. "Did you think that getting out of the cell meant you had a chance to walk away?"

Something in her tone made Sydney Ginn pause slightly, and she looked up at her.

"The 'Nest Communication Network' is like a... hmm, have you read fantasy novels? It's like a 'barrier.' If I don't take it down, no one inside can leave, and no one outside can get in."

As she spoke, the woman on the second floor clamped the flashlight between her teeth, grabbed the railing with both hands, and vaulted cleanly over the second floor — she landed on both feet, rolled lightly, and steadied herself in front of Sydney Ginn.

"I'm Mercury. And you?"

She took the flashlight out of her mouth and introduced herself, then cheerfully reached out to hook her arm through Sydney Ginn's. "Come on, let's go find someone together... By the way, you and Chase — you're not actually friends, and you don't really know each other, right?"

Sydney Ginn stopped walking, and the moment Mercury stepped forward, she yanked her wrist free with force.

She had entered and exited the Nest alone so many times, and she was still alive — not simply because she was lucky. Aside from being quick-witted, she had every bit of the instinct a Hunter needed.

"I... I'll go with Chase to look for the person," she said softly. "I still have something... something to discuss with him."

Mercury stood in the dim, disordered lobby, her flashlight angled downward and lighting up a patch of floor; the beam caught her boots and her pants, climbed halfway up her body, then gradually dimmed and died away. Her face and her tattoo-covered neck sank together into the darkness, indistinct.

After two seconds, she slowly smiled: "Are you afraid of me?"

...Yes.

Sydney Ginn didn't dare say it aloud.

Back in the cell, perhaps because other things had been in the way, the feeling hadn't been so obvious; but now, she felt that in the Central Police Department at this very moment, the most dangerous presence was neither Chase nor the Residents who had invaded.

"Oh come on, it's not like I kill everyone I meet," Mercury sighed in the darkness. "Or are you saying you think I'm no match for Chase?"

"Stop saying 'Chase, Chase' all the time," the tall silhouette ahead halted, and seemed almost a little irritated. "Take my name out of your mouths."

Sydney Ginn seized the moment and quickly took a few steps to catch up, putting him between herself and Mercury — if anything happened, it was always better to let someone else go first.

"So... I'll go with you to find the person, then." She spoke toward Chase, but her eyes stayed on Mercury the whole time. "Consider it my thanks."

Mercury let out a small laugh, apparently unbothered, and turned to leave.

"That's what you'd call bullying the weak and fearing the strong,"

Chase said abruptly, after the two of them had been climbing the stairs in silence.

Sydney Ginn had a powerful urge to dig those words out of her ears and hand them right back to him.

"Bullying the weak and fearing the strong?" She had truly never met anyone like this in her life. "Who's the weak one? You? If you count as weak, then the only things that count as strong in this world are dead people."

"Flattery doesn't work on me."

"I wasn't complimenting you," Sydney Ginn's voice rose a pitch. "Has no one ever complimented you before?"

"Your instincts aren't bad."

Chase seemed to have decided she had complimented him just now and didn't look particularly displeased. "She retired from hunting roughly seven or eight years ago. You don't even know me, so you definitely don't know her."

"Oh?" Sydney Ginn perked up her ears and lowered her voice. "What's her background?"

"When the 'Nest Communication Network' comes down, it doesn't only possess people who are actively on a call." Chase said, gesturing for her to keep following him up to the third floor. "Anyone using their phone at the time — texting, scrolling through social media, listening to music — none of them can escape it."

Sydney Ginn couldn't help drawing a sharp breath. "But people these days are glued to their phones around the clock..."

"Exactly," Chase gave a quiet laugh. "Which is why it takes a large number of Residents. The only ones who can possess people are Residents who have signed a contract with Mercury. Do you know why she can sign contracts with Residents, but you can't?"

"Why?"

"Because those Residents are afraid of her down to their bones."

Sydney Ginn suddenly remembered the dog whistle from earlier; the female officer hadn't said a single word before she obediently walked away.

"Wait — I heard before that when someone is killed, if the victim feels overwhelming fear toward their killer, then when the corpse dissolves in the Nest and a Resident grows from it, that Resident will also be afraid of the killer in the same way. Is that actually true?"

"Not entirely."

Chase skipped over both the second and third floors without searching them, probably because there were already plenty of mercenaries there. "You have to personally force a newly born Resident to relive the memory of its fear toward its killer before the contract can be successfully signed."

Sydney Ginn almost nervously glanced back — Mercury wasn't following behind them.

"The funny part about all this, to me, is that you didn't dare go near her, yet you came to me." Chase said, stopping at the fourth-floor stairwell landing. "When I think about it, I suppose I really am not as frenzied a killer as she is..."

He still held a phone with its flashlight on; above the light was a swath of darkness, and his deep-set eyes were nearly impossible to make out.

"Let me ask you something."

Sydney Ginn looked up, dazed.

"What do you think will happen here after the 'Nest Communication Network' is withdrawn?"

"I really don't know," she said honestly. "This is the first time I've encountered an Artifact like this."

"That makes it interesting, then."

Chase leaned against the railing as if he wanted to rest for a moment, stretching out his legs. "You don't know what will happen after we leave, yet just now there was no question about it — you had thoughts of slipping away early."

"So what?" Sydney Ginn waved a hand around at the Central Police Department. "This place has been turned into something like hell by you people — isn't it the most natural thing in the world that I'd want to run?"

"Not natural at all."

As Chase spoke, he suddenly flipped the phone around and held it up in front of Sydney Ginn; before she could react, he had already turned it back.

"Is that my phone?"

Sydney Ginn stepped forward to reach for it, but before she could even raise her hand, Chase cast her a glance — a glance that made her suddenly come to her senses, and she forced herself to stop.

"Give me back my phone," she said, keeping her voice as calm as she could. "It's no use to you."

"Once you've answered my question, I'll naturally return it. Don't worry — I have absolutely no interest in your privacy." Chase slowly cracked a smile and said: "It seems like there's something going on with you, which is why you were extremely unwilling to have your fingerprints taken — am I right? I've already heard about it: several people pinned you down on a table and forced you to do it."

"...So what?"

"Now that's interesting."

The phone screen unlocked. Chase lowered his eyes, his long fingers sliding across the screen one stroke at a time. His hands were enormous—it seemed as though a single squeeze would shatter the phone in his palm.

"Your name, ID, phone, fingerprints, and every photo taken—all of it is sitting in the police department, and the important data has already been uploaded to the system. Yet the moment you walked out of that cell, you didn't have a trace of worry. You were puzzled over why I'm not afraid of survivors from the Central Police Department retaliating later... you don't even know what became of them, and yet all you're thinking about is getting out of here."

Sydney Ginn couldn't find a single word to say.

She wasn't foolish—she could already see where this conversation was heading.

"What good does leaving do you? All your information is already on record. Where could you possibly run? And yet you don't seem the least bit concerned—as though, as long as you can get out, nothing else matters."

He truly was a hunting hound... even in a place that seemed perfectly ordinary, he could still sniff out his prey.

"It makes me think of the story you told me—your encounter with the Vulture."

As Chase spoke, the phone screen flickered light and dark beneath his fingers as they passed back and forth across it, making him look as though he were standing right on the edge between reality and nightmare.

"In a situation that hopeless, you were absolutely certain the one who would end up gone was the Vulture, and the one who remained was the real Sydney Ginn. Why? Simply because the other one 'died'?"

He stressed the word "died," clearly not believing Sydney Ginn's account for a moment.

"There's a missing link—something that saved your life and kept you from losing your mind."

Chase's voice was very soft, like that of a gentle gentleman unwilling to raise it and startle Sydney Ginn. "That missing link... is also what you plan to repeat once you leave today—to save yourself one more time. Isn't it?"

I took several sleep supplements last night with the mindset of "sleep or die trying," and finally got a long rest... probably also because I knew I could take a day off over the weekend, which made things a lot easier. I ended up sleeping ten full hours, and waking up today felt completely different.

The author's condition shows up immediately in the updates—look, I went and wrote another 4,000 characters!

Honestly, if you all hadn't kept encouraging and comforting me, I might not have dared to rest on Saturday, or wouldn't have rested well at all. Right now I truly feel like you all saved my life...

Chapter 91 — Sydney Ginn: Just a Few Words Between Two People

...What now?

Sydney Ginn's first instinct was to deny everything outright; but a moment's thought told her it was pointless—it would be nothing more than filling silence with sound.

The reason Chase had laid it out so plainly wasn't because he harbored doubts and wanted to see what she'd say—quite the opposite.

He'd already been certain. Right now he was simply drawing out her reaction, looking for a crack, prying open the hands that held her secret so tightly.

Damn it all—what, did the Candlefall Artifact have some kind of distinctive smell? She'd accidentally gotten it on her, and Chase had caught the scent?

Quite a bit of time had already passed. Sydney knew that the longer she stayed silent, the more she looked like she was confirming Chase's suspicions; yet she'd thought of several excuses in a row, only to shoot each one down herself, and in the end she couldn't get a single word out.

"You didn't take me for a fool—no string of 'I don't know' and 'that's not how it is.' I appreciate that."

Chase lowered his hand, his body still leaning against the stair railing.

It should have been a relaxed posture, yet his body and limbs formed a kind of cage, trapping Sydney Ginn in the small space at the foot of the stairs.

He said quietly, "When I'm interrogating people, I don't know why, but there's always someone who just can't wait to try to fool me."

"You're right," she said.

Since there was no hiding it anyway, Sydney Ginn steeled herself and said: "I do have a last-resort trick I didn't tell you about. But so what if you found out? I'm not afraid to say it straight. It's my lifeline—I'd never just casually tell anyone about it, because you had no right to know in the first place."

If she had to admit she'd been keeping something back, the current time and place was, she supposed, the best possible moment for it—the Nest Communication Network certainly couldn't

last forever without a time limit, and Chase needed to find the Police Chief within a finite window; there was no way he'd drop everything now just to extract a confession from her by force.

As long as he didn't lay a hand on her right this moment, she'd have a chance to run; as long as she could run, no matter how much damage today brought, it could all be undone, erased... though the frustrating part was that the memories would remain.

If nothing else, using Candlefall as bait—dangling it before that woman called Mercury—was another option; if she could get the two of them fighting each other—

In the span of just a few seconds, Sydney Ginn had already run through several possible responses in her head; yet she never could have anticipated that Chase's next words would make all her mental preparations completely useless.

"You're right." He actually nodded. "I've said it before—as long as you don't stand in my way, I can be a reasonable person, even though you, like most people, don't believe it."

Could you really blame them?

Sydney Ginn didn't say it out loud; she'd wait and see what Chase intended to do next.

"There are countless good things in this world that belong to other people... like the Nest Communication Network. As long as something isn't a necessary condition for reaching my goal, I don't need to have everything in my own hands."

Before Sydney Ginn could dare to breathe a sigh of relief, she heard Chase continue: "But that part you've been hiding on you... has piqued my interest enormously. Should I call it intuition?"

Smell, Sydney Ginn thought, with that freak dog nose of his.

"What do you want?" she asked flatly.

"What do you want most?" Chase suddenly flashed her a smile and asked quietly.

"...What?"

"In this life that opened without your consent and that you have no choice but to see through to the end, there must be something you crave, a goal you want no matter what. Something that can ease and dilute the hardship and pain of life—something that even brings you comfort and satisfaction..."

As he spoke, Chase had already straightened up. He lowered his head and asked near Sydney Ginn's ear: "What is it? Tell me."

"I—"

Sydney Ginn opened her mouth, only to find she had no answer.

"No, there's nothing I particularly want..."

In the dim, narrow stairwell, time stretched its stride, walking through a few seconds of silence.

In the distance, the mercenaries still tearing through the Central Police Department in search of their target stirred the thick dark fog that the Nest Communication Network had draped over the building—with an occasional shout, an occasional sweep of light.

The conversation should have ended there, and yet somehow she heard herself speak again.

"I... I like money, I like beautiful people, I like good food, I like beautiful things, I like having fun... but I don't need anyone else—all of that I can get on my own."

Chase must be planning to trade what she wanted most for Candlefall, Sydney Ginn thought vaguely.

That wasn't an unfair proposition—yet it seemed she didn't have... didn't have any goal that could "ease the hardship of life and bring her comfort and satisfaction."

The wishes she'd had as a girl—things like living in Blackmoor City, having a beautiful house, owning plenty of money and pretty clothes—she realized now, looking back, that they had all come true one by one; yet when they did, she hadn't even noticed, let alone felt anything.

Even the happiness she felt was only ever a brief flash when she first obtained something, and then it passed.

"So?" Chase seemed to smile silently.

So what?

"Now that you have all those things—how does it feel?"

Sydney Ginn was quiet for a moment, not answering him.

By all accounts, the question wasn't hard to answer; she considered her days fairly happy—whatever she wanted to eat or do, she could get to it soon enough—even Anthony, whom she'd

killed afterward, had given her a stretch of happiness.

After half a minute, she finally said quietly: "...Not enough."

Chase waited in silence for her to go on.

"I always feel like there could be more, like I could experience more, like I want more... but if you ask me what 'more' means, I can't tell you."

Maybe he's an expert at interrogation, Sydney Ginn thought hazily—maybe she was in the middle of an interrogation right now and simply didn't know it.

What was the difference between a skilled interrogator and a psychologist, anyway?

He didn't answer.

"Come with me," Chase said quietly, and turned to head up the stairs.

Sydney Ginn startled, didn't follow immediately—she turned to look down the staircase first.

Within a few seconds, Chase hadn't even glanced back and was already nearly halfway up. If she turned and bolted right now, there was a real chance she could shake him off and make it to the third floor—she was no match for Chase in strength, but she might not be slower than him.

That fat Police Chief had managed to stay hidden all this time; surely hiding herself wouldn't be that hard?

The scales in her heart wavered back and forth a few times; then, as if moved by some inexplicable force, Sydney Ginn followed him up the stairs.

Why she hadn't run—she didn't know.

"We'll start from the fifth floor and work our way down."

As he spoke, Chase pulled out a phone from his trouser pocket—someone's, she didn't know whose—and showed her a photo from its gallery: a formal bust portrait hanging on a police station wall, showing a heavyset man with a restrained, authoritative smile. Below the photo were his title and name—none other than the Chief of Police who had gone missing.

"Ever since the Nest Communication Network came down over everything, no one has seen him. As far as I know, he's been inside the Central Police Department all day and never left, so he has to still be in this building. What's interesting, though, is that between me and over a dozen professional mercenaries, we've turned the place inside out and still can't find him."

Huh?

So he was already putting her to work finding someone?

Wasn't he just asking her what she wanted most so he could use it to trade for Candlefall—how had he just let that go?

By all logic, if Chase wasn't going to keep pressing her about Candlefall, Sydney Ginn should have been relieved.

Yet she didn't understand why, right now, she felt like she'd stepped on air—a hollow, lingering sense of incompleteness in her chest, even a faint hope that Chase might have kept asking her more.

...When it came down to it, the most important thing in her life, the thing she wanted most, wasn't Candlefall at all.

What it was, she still didn't know.

Sydney Ginn gathered her thoughts and tried to focus on the task at hand—besides, she couldn't leave without helping with the search.

She looked carefully at the photo and said, "When that tall, skinny guy walked into the room next to your interrogation room, there were several people from the police station around him. This fat one... might have been among them—I'm not entirely sure."

"Let's start searching from the first room."

"The door's locked," Sydney Ginn said, trying the handle.

Perhaps wanting to shake off the faint, hazy sense of loss in her heart, she made a genuinely ordinary joke: "You're with the Key House Faction—you should have a key, right?"

To her surprise, Chase suddenly froze.

He stared at Sydney Ginn without blinking, and after two seconds, a smile slowly broke across his face.

I wonder, after so many chapters, if anyone still remembers the Keys thing...

Over the past year or two I've been disciplining myself not to follow American political news too closely—I only have one life, and I can't afford the wear and tear—but with something as

infuriating as the Trump assassination attempt, I ended up reading all kinds of news and opinion pieces for ages anyway. Honestly... it nearly gave my heart punctures.

Chapter 92: Sydney Ginn's Special Talent Is Getting Dragged Into Things

He was a strikingly handsome man by all appearances, yet when Chase stepped into the shadows and slowly began to smile, Sydney Ginn felt as though ice had been poured into her stomach, and all she wanted was to escape from this pocket of darkness and flee back into the sunlight.

"Wh-what's wrong?" she tensed, stepping sideways. "I—I haven't done anything..."

Someone this good-looking and this terrifying at the same time—she had truly never met anyone like that in her life.

Chase reached out a large hand and, without any warning, patted her twice on the shoulder—before she could spin around and bolt, Sydney Ginn managed to realize just in time that he wasn't about to hurt her—but each pat still landed with enough force to send a dull ache reverberating through her bones.

"Not bad," he murmured, his gaze fixed on the door, as though lost in thought. "...You didn't mean to, but you did me a great favor."

What happened? What nice thing had she said?

Though she had no idea what he was talking about—and he likely wouldn't tell her—Sydney Ginn still asked on instinct, "That makes two favors you owe me now, doesn't it?"

Chase glanced at her.

His entire mind seemed to be occupied by something else entirely.

It was only because someone had spoken to him that he had reflexively swept his gaze toward the source of the voice; he probably hadn't even registered what Sydney Ginn had said.

Oh well—on second thought, it didn't really matter how many favors he owed her.

Even if Chase decided right now to crown her Queen of England, it would mean absolutely nothing to her...

Sydney Ginn grumbled to herself and looked at the door handle, which wouldn't turn at all.

The sign on the room's door read "Evidence Room"; no wonder the door locked automatically once it swung shut—evidence room doors did need to stay locked at all times.

But... hadn't Chase just said that he and the mercenaries had already turned the entire Central Police Department upside down? Surely they couldn't have simply skipped this one evidence room?

"If the door's locked, does that mean you haven't been inside yet?" she turned and asked.

"...I searched it once before—the door was open then." Chase surfaced from his thoughts, as if only now remembering there was still a Police Chief to find.

He lifted his chin, gesturing for Sydney Ginn to step aside, then took two steps back from the doorway to put some distance between himself and it. "Either someone didn't prop the door open when they left, or someone closed it on purpose."

Even though Sydney Ginn had braced herself, when he kicked the door, the heavy crash still made her shoulders involuntarily jerk.

The door was thick and heavy—Chase's first kick didn't break it open. The enormous crashes of each successive kick grew louder and more thunderous, like air pressure building without release, bearing down hard on the eardrums—until the door finally burst apart with a boom, as if the pressure had exploded outward, sending splinters flying and the door slamming to the ground.

...Mercury's mercenaries couldn't be so amateur that they'd leave without propping the door open, could they?

Sydney Ginn let go of her ears, stepped forward, and swept her phone's beam of light around the space behind the door.

She had already made up her mind.

The sooner she found the target, the sooner she could get out of the police station.

Whatever Chase's plans were, whatever "Candlefall" might get her in return—this day of being dragged into the police station was one Sydney Ginn was determined to rewrite no matter what. Once today was rewritten into "she had never contacted Chase at all," there would naturally be nothing left to say about any favors owed.

By then, Chase would not even know Sydney Ginn existed; after the history was changed, she would be the only one who retained any memory of meeting and spending time with him today.

Of course, that wasn't a bad thing at all—Chase was far too much trouble... so for now, cooperating with him kept him from being on guard around her.

To get out sooner, Sydney Ginn was even more eager than Chase; she stepped over the broken pieces of the door and walked straight into the room.

The evidence room was cool and dim, with a faint smell of dust drifting through the air.

As the flashlight beam swept across, it pulled into view rows of labeled paper boxes, large bags, plastic bins, and other containers lining the tall shelves one by one; as Sydney Ginn walked past, the evidence on the shelves behind her sank back into darkness.

"Doesn't look like anyone's here," she said, having quickly made her way around the room.

The evidence room was quite large—practically a small warehouse—but because it contained nothing but row upon row of shelves, each shelf divided into individual compartments by iron bars, there was nowhere for a person to hide; let alone the Police Chief from the photograph, who was a heavyset man.

Out of caution, Sydney Ginn even bent down to check underneath the shelves; the gap between the lowest shelf and the floor was barely wide enough for a mouse.

"Mm," said Chase, from beyond two rows of shelves, his flashlight cutting through the darkness like a pale-yellow wound sliced into the room. "Same as when I came last time."

If Sydney Ginn weren't so attuned to other people's emotions, she might have truly believed that Chase's mood was as calm as his voice.

"Don't worry," she said—she didn't even know why she was consoling him, it was probably just habit, a side effect of being a decent person. "Like you said, no one can get out of here, so he's definitely still in the building. If he's in the building, he can be found."

"...Mm." Chase gave a low sound through his nose; his flashlight reached the far wall, turned around, and headed back toward the door. "I'll go check the next room."

He didn't seem worried at all that Sydney Ginn might run—which made sense, since there was nowhere to run.

Even though now wasn't the time, Sydney Ginn couldn't help her curiosity, and she flipped open the lid of a paper box, sticking both her phone's light and her head inside.

As long as her life wasn't on the line, she always had a little extra curiosity and a little too little self-control.

Besides—a box in a police station evidence room? Who could resist taking a look at what was inside?

"What are the two of you doing in the evidence room?"

A voice drifted in without warning, startling Sydney Ginn into jerking her head up and nearly knocking the box over. Chase's flashlight reached the door first, illuminating a figure in the doorway; the moment she got a clear look at the person, it felt as though someone had driven a needle straight into her optic nerve.

The middle-aged man had clearly been completely taken over by a Resident.

Like the others who had been taken over, the Nest Communication Network had done its work on the eyes; below the man's brow bones, two enormous masses of eyes bulged outward—no, "masses" wasn't quite the right word.

Countless small eyeballs pressed tightly against one another like clusters of grapes, forming two large "bunches" that swelled and strained out of the eye sockets, drooping down to hang against his cheeks.

As the middle-aged man turned his head toward Chase, the two clusters of eyes slid stickily across his skin, swaying, every pupil on every eyeball shifting to face the same direction.

"Oh, it's you—Chase Monroe. We meet again."

Sydney Ginn glanced at Chase, two shelving rows away from her, and silently took a step back, lowering her phone's light.

He and Mercury seemed to have known each other for a long time; it would make sense if he also knew the Residents Mercury had signed contracts with... right?

"...Flay?" Chase asked in a low voice, as though not entirely sure.

"You can still recognize me?" The Resident opened its mouth, stretching the corners all the way to the limit, nearly touching that huge cluster of eyes. "The reason I ended up looking like this—I have you to thank for that."

Hm?

Wait, that wasn't right.

How was it that the consciousness dominating this man's body was not a Resident, but that "Flay"?

After being taken over, even if some of the original person's personality and memories remained, the Resident should be the one in control—just like the female officer at the cell door a moment ago. This "Flay" was remarkably resilient.

"I don't know who it was—someone left without following the rules... leaving the evidence room door wide open... I only just got the door closed properly, and you two have gone completely lawless—you actually broke the door."

The middle-aged man called Flay spoke as he swayed into the evidence room; his broad, heavy frame filled the doorway completely.

Without warning, it wrenched its neck in Sydney Ginn's direction and shrieked, "She dared to look at the evidence! She tampered with the evidence—evidence contamination contamination contamination contamination—"

The moment the screech rang out, it broke into a run straight through the gap between two rows of shelves, barreling toward Sydney Ginn like a cannonball—fortunately, her reflexes were sharp, having long since developed a nose for danger in the Nest; she turned and sprinted immediately, diving deep into the aisle between the shelves.

"I'll teach you not to touch the evidence, not to touch the evidence, not to touch—"

"Chase!" Sydney Ginn rounded a corner and burst into the aisle between another two rows of shelves, shouting furiously, "Why do I always get dragged into your mess? Do something!"

Debts go to the debtor—this Resident clearly had a grudge against Chase, yet it had come after her instead. What kind of sense did that make?

Most infuriating of all: when she ran straight to Chase's side, fully expecting him to step in and deal with the Resident like last time, he just stood there, brow furrowed, watching the two of them—one person, one Resident—run right past him, doing absolutely nothing. If there'd been a light bulb over his head, he'd have looked like a lamppost.

"What are you doing?" Sydney Ginn was fuming, shouting as she ran. "I don't have any weapons! Why are you just standing there?"

Chase slowly lifted his head from his thoughts.

"...I think I've been tricked."

Perhaps because nomadic blood runs in my veins, whenever I've been in one place for more than two years, I start to feel like I've been sentenced to life in prison... If people could just flow freely around the world, live like citizens of everywhere, stay somewhere for a while then move on—wouldn't that be wonderful?

Chapter 93: Sydney Ginn's Unexpected Trap

Who had been fooled?

The one who had truly been fooled was herself—the one who thought she could sell information about the "Vulture" for a good price.

It seemed Mercury was right: whoever got close to Chase was in for bad luck. Ever since Sydney Ginn ran into him this morning, her fate had taken a sharp turn for the worse. She was in Blackmoor City, yet she was about to die the way people only died in the Nest—at the hands of a Resident.

"What is wrong with this guy,"

Her fury at Chase was enough to fuel an entire speech, but Sydney Ginn was running for her life right now, every breath coming in ragged gasps, and so the rest of that sentence had no choice but to become a line of thick, heavy text in her mind: You think I can't survive without you saving me?

If she didn't show him what a professional Hunter was capable of, he'd probably think she was a lump of dough he could shape however he pleased.

With that thought in mind, as she sprinted down the aisle between two rows of shelves, Sydney Ginn swept one hand holding the flashlight forward while the other shot out to knock every box, case, and bag she could reach off the shelves; countless pieces of evidence of every description tumbled and rolled across the floor behind her.

They barely slowed Flay's footsteps at all, though.

If anything, they sent that half-man, half-Resident creature into an even wilder frenzy.

"You contaminated the evidence, you broke the chain of custody—must be punished, punished, punished—"

It shrieked as it stomped over the evidence bags, still closing in tight behind Sydney Ginn.

Because she was moving so fast, the flashlight beam lurched and swayed, slicing the surrounding darkness into a dizzying scatter of light and shadow.

She had to watch her footing, keep up her speed, and keep sweeping evidence boxes to the floor all at once—for a moment she almost wanted to shriek like a Resident. Fortunately, it seemed her luck hadn't been completely drained, because right at that moment, she finally knocked over a box that could save her life.

Sydney Ginn's brow twitched; she immediately ducked down, snatching up the just-fallen piece of evidence from the floor, and ripped the clear evidence bag off it in one motion.

This time, she sprinted at full speed down a different aisle; the moment she turned the corner, she slammed to a halt and spun around.

Her phone hit the side of a nearby evidence shelf with a sharp smack; almost simultaneously, Flay's face—no longer truly human—came chasing out of the dimness between the two rows of shelves.

Sydney Ginn raised the pickaxe in her hand high.

...She had been in such a rush just now that she had almost forgotten about this.

In the chaotic and dangerous Blackmoor City, how could the Central Police Department be short on murder cases? And where there were murder cases, there were in all likelihood murder weapons; and murder weapons were among the most important pieces of evidence.

So when she was standing right inside the Evidence Room, did she really need to worry about having no weapon?

On the rows of shelves all around her, inside box after box, lay who knew how many murder weapons—no matter how bizarre or how deadly, there was surely no shortage; all she needed to protect herself was to get her hands on one.

Sydney Ginn had full confidence in her speed.

Flay had probably not anticipated that she would suddenly have a weapon in her hands—when the sharp heavy iron tip of the pickaxe drove precisely and deeply into a great drooping cluster of eyeballs, the howl it let out seemed capable of tearing eardrums apart.

"Enough,"

Before she even had a chance to wrench the pickaxe free and give it another strike, Sydney Ginn heard someone utter a low, sharp command from somewhere amid Flay's piercing shriek.

The large, heavysset Flay seemed to lose all weight the instant his feet left the ground.

The pickaxe still jutted from his face, swaying; as his body arced through the air and was slammed hard into the ground, the pickaxe fell away with a clang, splattering a spray of viscous bloody threads.

Chase stood behind Flay, rising from the shadows like a tall tower.

"It's just a Resident—are you having fun playing with it?"

Sydney Ginn stared at him blankly, momentarily forgetting what she had meant to say.

Chase planted one foot on Flay's neck and lowered his gaze. He watched the man whose throat was making a grinding, clicking noise yet couldn't struggle free at all, and said, "This is a little hard to explain to Mercury... but if you can't control this man, that's not my fault."

Those words... seemed to be addressed to the Resident that had invaded Flay.

"Why—why can't it control this man?" The question escaped Sydney Ginn before she could stop it.

Chase glanced at her.

"That's perfectly normal. They only extend their tendrils into a person's consciousness through the Nest Communication Network, taking hold of the person's mind and body."

He gave a soft laugh that could almost make one's hair stand on end. "The purer, softer, and more sensitive a person's mind, the easier they are to invade. Police officers have witnessed endless darkness, blood, and violence—if you could cut open their psyche and examine it, it probably wouldn't be much different from a Resident's. It's perfectly normal for one to slip through their control every now and then."

Then... if a Resident attacked a person, what would happen to the Resident?

She wasn't concerned—she simply wanted to know.

But before Sydney Ginn could voice the question, there came a sharp crack, and Chase's black leather shoe had already driven deep into the space between the head and the shoulder—bones were ground to pieces within flesh and blood; the neck that should have connected the two seemed to suddenly become a thin layer of rubber.

She couldn't help but hunch her shoulders and squint her eyes, flinching back two steps as though it were her own neck being crushed.

And yet even with its neck bones shattered, white splinters jutting through the twisted skin and flesh of its neck, "Flay" seemed to still be alive; when that cluster of intact eyeballs swiveled toward Sydney Ginn, she nearly felt her stomach turn.

"It—what happens to it now?" Sydney Ginn asked quietly. "Residents can't die, right?"

"It's lost the ability to move," Chase said, clearly with no intention of elaborating further; the moment the words were out, he turned and walked away.

"Where are you going?"

The words flew out of Sydney Ginn's mouth before she could think, and she immediately wanted to slap herself.

If he wants to leave, let him leave—wouldn't it be better if he left? Why did she have to open her mouth out of curiosity—and now look, he's stopped walking.

"You come too," Chase's tone was exactly as though he were addressing one of his own House Faction Hunters. "At the very least you have a pair of eyes, and those are still useful."

...That didn't sound like a dig, and there wasn't the slightest edge to it; it was hard to tell whether he truly thought he was paying her a compliment.

Sydney Ginn gave the Flay on the floor a wide berth and asked quietly, "You said just now that you'd been tricked... what was that about?"

There was a degree of wariness behind the question when she asked it.

Unexpectedly, Chase did not seem to find it the least bit embarrassing to admit he had "been tricked," nor did he flare up in anger and humiliation over it.

He gave a casual "mm" and said, "That Police Chief almost had me fooled. Come along and you'll see."

"You know where the Chief is?"

"No," Chase stepped out the door, striding down the stairs as he spoke. "But I know who he is now."

Sydney Ginn paused.

"Didn't you already know that? You even looked at his photo." She knew she shouldn't be curious, but her body had already made up its mind for her—her feet went clomping after him.

"What do you mean? I'm not following you."

Chase was clearly not the type to enjoy idle conversation any more than he ever wasted a move in action; she rephrased her question ten or so different ways, but he gave no sign of hearing any of them, his expression never changing—until they reached the second floor, when he suddenly barked toward the courtyard: "Mercury!"

It startled Sydney Ginn nearly out of her skin.

In the Central Police Department, where communication devices were useless, the mercenaries appeared to have already divided up positions in advance; the moment his voice fell, Mercury's reply rang up from the lobby on the first floor: "What is it? I'm here."

"I'm afraid we've been tricked," Chase called down to the first floor. "Bring one of the people from the cells—I have questions for them."

Since there was no way out and her luck seemed to have been just about drained, Sydney Ginn, with the mentality of someone watching a TV drama, followed Chase down to the first floor and stopped in front of one of the cells.

Mercury led a man over, shot Sydney Ginn a meaningful smile, then turned to Chase and said, "This one values his life, very cooperative—didn't give me a single opportunity."

Sydney Ginn did not ask what "opportunity" she meant.

"What do you want to ask him?" It seemed Mercury's curiosity had been piqued as well. "Where did we get tricked?"

"You remember where the Chief's half-body portrait was hanging, right?" Chase asked.

Mercury's gaze moved toward the center of the first-floor lobby. "Of course—hung somewhere so conspicuous, like they were encouraging a cult of personality."

"And the Chief's name—you remember that too, right?"

"You're asking the strangest things." Mercury smiled. "Isn't it Ashley?"

Chase nodded, then turned to the young officer who had just been brought out of his cell, and put to him a demand that Sydney Ginn had not expected in the least—"Describe your Chief Ashley's appearance."

But her surprise had only just begun.

The young officer's answer left even Mercury stunned.

"She's in her forties, with a long, lean face and a darker complexion." He answered carefully, watching Chase's expression as he spoke. "Long black hair, always worn up in a bun. Thin lips..."

"Then who is this?" Chase opened his phone, pulled up the photograph Sydney Ginn had seen, and asked.

"That... is our previous Chief." the young officer said. "When Chief Ashley took office, the photo was changed."

There are some readers out there who, well, have been a bit too kind to me—saying my characters are three-dimensional. What's gotten into you all (Chopper face).

But honestly, I'm not satisfied with my own ability to write characters. The ones that are truly well-crafted—

I can only let the plot move forward for a while and let the characters gradually take shape along with it... For example, it wasn't until around chapter eighty that I felt Sydney Ginn and Chase had developed a distinct quality that I was reasonably happy with.

Well, just keep working hard... It's not like I can help it—telling stories is my passion.

Chapter 94: Sydney Ginn Was Blind to What Was Right Under Her Nose, Time and Again

According to the officer's account, Ashley Paige had only been promoted to Chief of the Central Police Department just over a month ago.

"Word is she has some very solid connections behind her, and she's handled a lot of trouble for some important people." The officer was, just as Mercury had said, remarkably cooperative—volunteering information even beyond what Chase had asked: "It's not like she became anyone's private army, but cops sometimes have to do the dirty work for people higher up. That's probably how she climbed to the top..."

"That's enough."

The moment those two words left his mouth, the officer fell immediately silent.

Chase drew a long breath, turned, and said to Mercury, "Have your people use that description to find her among those who've been taken over by Residents."

Mercury's gaze flickered slightly, then she smiled. "So that's how it is. Of course... you know how I am."

It felt as though they both understood what the other had left unspoken; the only one still in the dark was Sydney Ginn herself.

"How much time do we have left?" Chase asked.

Mercury glanced at the time on her phone screen and said, "Thirteen minutes until the network goes down."

Chase gave a small nod. "That's enough time."

This time, Sydney understood. The Nest Communication Network did have a time limit after all—they didn't have long.

Which meant that if she carefully cooperated for just thirteen more minutes, she would have a chance to slip away when the Nest Communication Network cut out...

Once she was out, this entire day could be undone and started over.

After it was undone... Chase would never have known her at all.

Still, having someone like him owe her a favor was certainly a good thing. Rewriting today would leave her with a vague, lingering sense of regret—but what had to be done, she still had to do.

She absolutely could not let her fingerprints end up in the police database.

"I'll help you search too,"

Sydney seized the moment and fell into step behind Chase as he headed upstairs, asking, "How did you notice something was off about the Chief's photo?"

Several mercenaries on the second floor were moving in and out of rooms along the corridor; a dark-haired woman even called out a greeting to the two of them. Every room door was thrown wide open, and a few had been unhinged entirely from their hinges—the technique unmistakably professional.

"Process of elimination,"

Chase swept his flashlight through a narrow interrogation room, found it empty, and strode on to the next.

"The Chief was still somewhere in this building, yet 'she' wasn't among those who hadn't been taken over, and there was nowhere in the building for 'her' to hide. The only group left that hadn't been carefully checked was the people who had been taken over by Residents."

He seemed to have found his footing on the matter, his mood improved, and with it came a little more patience for explanation: "If one of the people who'd been taken over was the Chief, Mercury should have heard about it from the Residents right away. So from the start, 'the taken-over group' wasn't the first batch I was paying close attention to—which made it entirely possible that the Chief was hiding among them."

"Then why didn't you suspect Mercury?"

Chase smiled, without a sound.

His flashlight beam landed on the face of an officer standing blankly in one of the rooms, then moved on. The figure was unrecognizable, but clearly male—it couldn't be Chief Ashley.

"Because Mercury would never help a cop." He said quietly. "Once she learned the target was the Central Police Department, she'd have come even if I hadn't paid her a thing."

Within the outline of that single sentence, a towering, boundless hatred could be dimly felt.

"Was it Flay's appearance that tipped you off?" Sydney guessed. "You realized the Chief might have been taken over, but the Resident simply couldn't control 'her'—so Mercury never knew?"

"Right." Chase said briefly. "But that fat man didn't look like someone capable of resisting a Resident's control."

She was starting to understand.

It wasn't exactly fair to judge by appearances, but the previous Chief had a look about him—bloated, hollow, waterlogged, and limp—that truly didn't seem like the kind of solid wall a Resident would crash into and fail to break through.

That alone was naturally enough to make someone suspect there was a trap hidden somewhere in the chain of events.

And Ashley was quick-witted too—she had probably spotted the problem in an instant and swapped the recently-changed photo right back. The Central Police Department had always had a tradition of hanging official portraits, and faced with a photo that large, Chase's people would naturally assume the Chief was the heavyset man in the picture, giving them no reason to go out of their way to verify it.

On top of that, the name "Ashley" works for either gender, so she didn't even need to change her nameplate; her trick of hiding in plain sight was nothing short of clever, buying her a solid twenty or thirty minutes.

Unfortunately, Ashley's luck had run out—after holding on for so long, she was exposed with only a little over ten minutes left before the Nest Communication Network would have released her.

Thinking it over to this point, Sydney kept her expression casual and raised the question she had most wanted to ask: "What happens here once the time limit runs out?"

Chase turned his head and glanced at her over his shoulder.

In the one or two seconds between her words falling and his reply, the silence stretched long enough to make her heart tighten; Chase had most likely already sensed that she was fishing for a chance to escape.

"You'll see for yourself when the time comes."

Since he wouldn't say, Sydney didn't press any further.

Whatever changes would come when the Nest Communication Network cut out, one thing was certain: she had to find an excuse to separate from Chase before that moment arrived.

Only then would Sydney Ginn have a chance to run.

She just hadn't expected that, five or six minutes later, the excuse would surface on its own.

Mercury had brought ten mercenaries this time; counting Chase and Sydney, that made thirteen people in total, searching a five-story building for a Chief who had been taken over by a Resident—and no matter how they searched, they simply could not find her.

Every person who had been taken over by a Resident was pulled under flashlight beams, their nightmare-like faces starkly illuminated one by one; but not one of them matched the physical description of Chief Ashley.

Even Chase, who was ordinarily unreadable, seemed to be edging toward a restlessness he could barely contain.

"Let's split up and do another thorough sweep," Sydney suggested. "Time is running short, after all. If I find her, I'll lock her up and come get you."

He only gave a low "mm" from the back of his throat.

The shadows inside the police headquarters building seemed to have seeped into Chase's eyes; just standing beside him was enough to make a person's back draw taut involuntarily.

Whether or not Ashley was found made no real difference to Sydney—yet after searching alongside Chase for so long, she had found herself genuinely invested despite herself. He had, after all, pulled her out of the Residents' hands twice; she had no wish to see him fail.

Besides, when a puzzle was right in front of you but the answer remained completely out of reach, wasn't that just infuriating?

It couldn't be that the especially self-preserving officer had suddenly decided to lie about this one thing, could it?

Sydney walked alone through the dim corridor on the fifth floor, ears sharply tuned, not daring to miss the faintest sound.

When footsteps echoed from further down the hall, she immediately aimed her flashlight straight ahead—and found a mercenary, the same one she had already seen once on the third

floor.

"Are there any taken-over people up ahead?" Sydney asked.

The woman had a bob cut level with her ears, side-parted bangs, and narrow eyes—she carried herself with a capable, efficient air. "Three of them, but none are the target."

"How strange," Sydney sighed. "That Chief is something else—it's a contained space, and yet she's nowhere to be found. Is there some kind of tunnel or hidden passage in this old psychiatric hospital building?"

At that, the mercenary smiled and said, "She's only been on the job a month. Even if there were, she wouldn't know about them."

"Fair point." Sydney nodded. "I'll go take a look further ahead."

"I'm heading downstairs then."

Sydney decided to do one final mental run-through of the situation—if the Chief still couldn't be found after that, she'd have to let it go. She needed to find an exit and get herself into position ahead of time.

At the start, Mercury and the mercenaries had rounded up every person who hadn't been taken over by a Resident and corralled them together; among that group, no one matched Ashley's physical description.

The mercenaries had been thorough—they had practically turned the place inside out—so if Ashley hadn't been taken over by a Resident, she would either have been found already, or she had blended in among the mercenaries themselves. But that second possibility was out of the question.

Mercury had said that when rounding up the unaffected people, she'd led the operation herself, person by person—how could she have failed to notice an extra stranger in her own ranks?

Once the rounding-up was done, the only people left in the building were the eleven mercenaries including Mercury, Chase and Sydney, and those who had lost their own will after being taken over by Residents and were now drifting through the police headquarters.

It was still quite possible that they had initially overlooked someone among the taken-over group and that Ashley was hiding among them; but now that every single taken-over person had been checked and Ashley still couldn't be found—had the Chief simply vanished into thin air?

A living person—how could she have simply ceased to exist?

Sydney let out a long breath and reminded herself that finding Ashley made no difference to her. The feeling of an unresolved, unanswered question was deeply annoying, yes—but she couldn't keep spending time on it. She had to get downstairs.

She turned and walked back the way she had come—with the power out, the stairs were the only way between floors. The mercenary from just now had headed in the same direction.

Watching the woman's retreating figure, Sydney suddenly froze.

That police chief named Ashley... seemed to be particularly good at hiding in plain sight. But who said she could only use that trick once?

Apparently hearing Sydney's quick footsteps behind her, the mercenary turned her head and asked, "What is it?"

The side of her face that turned was clean and normal—no sign of the telltale eye mutation that came after being taken over by a Resident.

"You..." Sydney stared hard at her and said in a low voice, "You shouldn't know that the Chief has only been on the job for a month."

The officer had given that information on the first floor; there had been no one else around them at the time. It seemed even the mercenaries had no particular desire to hang around Mercury and Chase.

The mercenary looked at her and didn't answer for a moment.

"Thinking about it now... there seems to be only one way Chief Ashley could have kept slipping past every search." Sydney drew a deep breath and said, "Push your bangs behind your ear and let me see your other eye."

If you can tell from my update times, my sleep schedule has completely flipped lately... Since it's already flipped, I might as well stay up a little longer each day and try to flip it back around...

Sometimes a story develops in unexpected directions—like recently, I was writing along and suddenly realized: wait, the police chief is actually a tough character? I thought she was just cannon fodder?

It's a curious feeling—like I'm slowly discovering the Artifact world right alongside everyone else.

Chapter 95: Sydney Ginn — An Offer She Can't Refuse

The dark-haired woman brushed her bangs aside, then let her hair fall back down less than a second later.

Sydney Ginn was caught off guard.

"Satisfied?" she said. "I happened to catch it on the news — that's how I knew the new Chief had only been in office for less than a month."

The entire building was saturated with a fog-thick darkness; only the two flashlights in their hands had carved open a portion of that darkness in the fifth-floor corridor, knocking out a few hollow patches of white light.

The light and visibility were both dim and murky — seeing anything clearly was out of the question — and the other woman had only brushed aside her bangs for a brief moment; even so, Sydney had still caught a glimpse of what lay beneath: a single human eye, normal in shape.

...Was she overthinking it?

After all, the Central Police Department's change of leadership was hardly a secret — it wouldn't be strange at all for someone to learn of it through other channels.

"Ah, and here I thought I'd uncovered the truth."

Sydney let out a breath and gave a rueful laugh. "I really am a little unwilling to let it go... As long as she didn't leave early or there isn't a hidden passage in the building, there was clearly only one way Ashley could have kept slipping through the search. How could I have been wrong?"

The dark-haired woman gave a slight nod, as though merely acknowledging that she had heard.

"Keep looking," she said. "It's the only option, after all."

Sydney took a step or two forward, closing the distance between herself and the dark-haired woman.

"Let me tell you my theory. Listen and see if there's something off about it."

The dark-haired woman considered in silence, neither agreeing nor objecting.

"I think Chase's deduction was correct. Chief Ashley was invaded by a Resident after the photo was swapped out, and underwent an ocular mutation... but unlike the others, she managed to hold onto her own mind."

As Sydney spoke, she studied the dark-haired woman's expression; in the dimness, the other woman only pressed her lips together slightly — impossible to read.

"And the 'mutation' of her eyes can't be severe — certainly nothing like what I just saw with Flay, countless little eyeballs crowded together in a string, dangling out of the socket. Chief Ashley's eyes — my guess is that at least one of them is normal."

The dark-haired woman lowered her face slightly, as if listening carefully, thinking carefully.

"Only if she was invaded and mutated would she have any chance of going undetected until now."

"How so?" the dark-haired woman asked.

Sydney lightly rubbed the tip of her nose. "Because... when the police arrested Chase, they happened to pick up a woman along with him — namely, me. It was precisely because I entered the picture that Chief Ashley was able to hide successfully up to this very moment."

"What does having you around change?" The dark-haired woman seemed perfectly willing to keep the conversation going and was in no hurry to leave.

"Ashley's hiding process can be broken into three stages, with more than one method at work."

Sydney said quietly: "In the first stage, I hadn't yet left the cell. At that point, the entire building had been sealed off — no one could come or go — and Mercury had rounded up every person in the building who hadn't been invaded and locked them in cells. At that time, Ashley covered her normal eye and exposed her mutated one, so Mercury let her pass."

The dark-haired woman nodded as if she found this entirely convincing.

"The second stage began when I left the cell. Chase and Mercury personally escorted me out themselves, making quite a bit of noise in the process, so the mercenaries in the building should all have heard about it — that in addition to Chase, a woman had been rescued as well. But they were busy searching the building for the Chief at the time, and even if they'd heard about my existence from Mercury, their colleagues, or over the walkie-talkie, none of them had actually seen my face."

"Ah," the dark-haired woman murmured softly, as if something had clicked. "You think Ashley seized the opportunity..."

"Exactly. At this point, she was still presenting herself with the appearance of someone 'invaded and mutated,' but she certainly wasn't going to sit dumbly in some corner and leave it to fate... If it had been me, I would have adopted the same strategy — moving constantly through the building, keeping myself safe while gathering information."

Sydney explained: "By the time Ashley learned of my existence, everyone still believed the Chief was a middle-aged, heavyset man — no one paid any particular attention to Ashley, who was female and appeared to have been invaded. So no matter how Chase and the mercenaries searched the building, they couldn't find any heavyset male Chief."

"I see," said the dark-haired woman, her tone carrying what sounded like genuine admiration.

"The moment Chase realized the Chief wasn't the man in the photo was also the most dangerous third stage for Ashley — he didn't just discover the Chief was a woman; he also realized that Ashley had retained her mind even after being invaded.

"I think it was at this point that Ashley cut off her long hair, and possibly changed her clothes as well."

Sydney paused here as she spoke — she had left an opening for the dark-haired woman to respond, but the other woman said nothing, so she had no choice but to continue: "In the third stage, Ashley only needed to avoid Mercury alone, and she could make the mercenaries mistake her for 'Sydney Ginn,' while making me and Chase mistake her for a mercenary."

Of course, this kind of situation was like walking a tightrope — she had to keep eyes in all directions and maintain her balance with every trembling step.

Even so, the strange state created by the Nest Communication Network couldn't be sustained indefinitely; even someone who knew nothing about Artifacts could arrive at the same conclusion by instinct alone — if Ashley could just hold on until Mercury and Chase's group had no choice but to leave, she would have won.

"Without leaving the building, and with no hidden passages inside, this is the only way Ashley could have remained hidden until now without being found. What do you think?"

"It sounds very reasonable. So did you find her?" the dark-haired woman asked.

Sydney fixed her gaze on the dark-haired woman. Now that the two of them were close, the other woman's features were clearer: a lean, long face, dark complexion, one eye narrow and sharp — her whole bearing was capable and serious.

"Could you let me take a closer look at your other eye?" she said quietly. "Or — would you be willing to come with me to find Mercury?"

The dark-haired woman slowly raised her hand and brushed her bangs aside again.

"Here, take another look." Her tone was light, as if she had already made up her mind. "I always knew this eye wouldn't hold up to close scrutiny."

Sydney's whole body went rigid.

Ashley was right — if you didn't lean in and look carefully, perhaps no one could have spotted the abnormality in that eye, because the degree of mutation was far too subtle.

Everyone has an ordinary eyelid that folds back when the eye is open, which is what allows one to close and blink.

But this eye was as if someone had cut an eye-shaped hole directly into the skin: no eyelid, no lashes — just an eyeball stuffed straight into the opening. A white eyeball.

"Your iris... is gone? Nothing left but a white eyeball?" She had been on guard for Ashley to strike at any moment, so the instant she made out the abnormality in that eye, she stepped back immediately and asked: "That 'iris' — did you draw it on with black ink?"

Ashley lowered her bangs and said, "Yes. My hands were shaking when I drew it, and it's not easy to get ink to stay on an eyeball — the pupil ended up the wrong size, not round enough, with uneven edges."

At first glance it wasn't as horrifying as Flay's eyes; yet as Sydney stood there being "watched" by that eye, she felt a different, hard-to-describe discomfort wash over her — she recalled that this was called the uncanny valley effect.

"Can I go back to normal?" Ashley suddenly asked. "And I don't just mean this eye. I heard you all mention 'Resident invasion'... In my mind, it's as if a pitch-black tornado has been raging the entire time. I have to grit my teeth and endure it, or else my sanity gets swallowed up."

"...I don't know." Sydney was telling the truth.

Unraveling Ashley's scheme and confirming the answer face to face — it felt rather satisfying; next, she should probably go downstairs and call for backup, right?

On her own, she might not be able to subdue Ashley — but on the other hand, Ashley couldn't subdue her either.

Actually, if she just shouted right now, the mercenaries on the fourth floor would probably hear her...

"I know you and Chase only ended up together by chance — you have nothing to do with him." As if reading her thoughts, Ashley suddenly said quietly, "So I have a proposal. I'd like you to hear me out."

Sydney looked up at her.

"Every record you've left behind — I can erase it for you afterward. The fingerprints submitted for comparison can have the comparison request withdrawn."

She spoke slowly, earnestly: "As you can see, after today, Key House Faction and the police force will be at war. Why drag yourself into it and pick a side? There's nothing in it for you — this isn't your fight. Pretend you never found me, and today you will have never existed here at all."

...Ashley's analysis was flawless, but unfortunately she didn't know that something called Candlefall existed in this world.

"I'm sorry, no. All I want is to leave," Sydney said. "Without turning you over, that process will probably be a lot less smooth for me."

What Ashley was offering her held no real temptation — even without Ashley, she could achieve the same result through Candlefall.

Ashley's brow furrowed slightly, as if she hadn't expected Sydney to flatly refuse such a tempting offer without even considering the future.

But she didn't press the matter; after a moment's thought, she immediately put forward another proposal instead.

"Then let me offer a different condition."

Ashley said quietly: "Your fingerprints have already been submitted and entered into the system — they're currently being run against every fingerprint on record from unsolved cases. I can choose not to withdraw them... and wait for the results."

For a moment, Sydney thought the Chief was threatening her; but the next second, she realized Ashley wasn't that foolish.

"I promise — no matter which case your fingerprints match, I can delete that case along with your fingerprints, completely and permanently, from the police database."

As if afraid Sydney might not understand, she emphasized it once more: "In other words, no matter what you've done in the past, with my help it will all vanish without a trace — as though you never did any of it. So — what do you say? Are you willing?"

How wonderful, tomorrow is Saturday — I get to rest for a whole day and do absolutely nothing! Even though there's no update, I'm still planning to put together a thank-you chapter tomorrow, otherwise it really wouldn't do justice to everyone's support during this time...

The thank-you chapter has to be free, the thank-you chapter has to be free, the thank-you chapter has to be free — okay, I've got it.

A thank-you chapter! This time I definitely won't charge for it — it says so right in the title.

How did this end up turning into one thank-you chapter a month without me even noticing... I really do mean to express my gratitude in a timely manner.

If I can't manage my time properly, how am I supposed to be king of the pirates — and for the sake of being king of the seas (no typo), I really do need to work on my time management. Isn't that right?

This time I went through a very long low period, and I'm grateful that everyone stayed with me through it all. Those words feel exactly right to me, because you all came here just for the fun of reading — you had no obligation to offer comfort, support, or patience; yet you did all of that with such sincerity and warmth... I'm truly moved.

For your sake, I really do need to take better care of my own state of mind...

I also feel rather ashamed — there have been so many purely supportive tips, and I've put off properly thanking everyone until today.

First, a five-point prostration to Moonstone — thud — flat on the ground, to say thank you AND sorry. The tip was way too generous, I can't even bring myself to look at it. It's mostly because I'm easily dazzled and haven't seen amounts that large very often... and I took this long to say thank you! Thank you — seriously, tell me, what can I do to make it up to you...

Xi Xia You Mu Ming Li, my friend — I opened the July tip list and you were the very first name I saw! I get it, you're cheering me on and showing your support, but the amount is a little much, don't you think? We're practically family here...

Thank you, Dad — laughing that bright, easy laugh of yours — I really do owe you quite a bit, and we're close enough that you truly don't need to show support with money! Even though you never ask for anything in return, I still want to give something back, argh

Thank you to the toxic Wee-gal (honestly, the moment I first saw your username I remembered it immediately, and I'm not sure why)

Thanks to Long-Gao-Gao De Yu (you tip so often that at first glance I thought I had my dates mixed up — then I looked again and felt a wave of dread, like, what on earth did I do to deserve this...)

Ehehe, Joiiii (watching your reader level climb at a speed my update schedule simply cannot keep up with... surely you're saving a little bit to treat the local author to a meal when I visit?)

Thank you Lingxiao Zhuyou (hey? Feels like you disappeared for a while? Then suddenly such a big tip... a welcome-back surprise?)

Big patron b1111111111 (primary contributor to the field-research fund — by now you've basically covered all three meals of the day, haven't you? Lucky it's a New York research trip; if it were a trip into the Nest...)

And reader 20190620111919738 — this numbered reader would rather tip me than spend the money changing their username. Just look at that devotion! Though I do have one nagging question: I'm thanking you, but do you even know I'm thanking you? (

Yingyou, back on the monthly thanks list again — thank you, always showing up rain or shine. Honestly, I keep shearing your wool so often I'm starting to think I should buy you some minoxidil, just in case

Can't leave out Tiejia Baitang, as punctual as someone paying me rent — I genuinely feel a little embarrassed about this. I'm out here like a landlady, just being kept by you, and I haven't even done anything to deserve it...

Also need to thank Qianxue x — tipped a whole string all at once! Are you a new reader too? (Wait, why did I say "too" — it's not like anyone else is new here)

Good to see Haynes again (Haynes every single month! Should I start calling you Auntie...
no, sorry, I take that back — I have a habit of speaking before I think)

Thank you YQ A-Qing (you just quietly tip and support without a word — you don't even come to collect the debt I owe you. Though to be fair, I'm a pretty shameless debtor by now)

Thank you Csmshksdaaa — wait? Are you a new reader from Artifact Report? You must be, right? Right? Right? I don't think I've seen you before?

And Caizi cv — ah, seeing a familiar name feels like coming home...

Of course there's also Junmi Xi (your support is evergreen as always... honestly I feel like I could just copy-paste most of these names from the last thank-you chapter?); and Non-Edible Cat Gummy Bears (this is pure check-in-style tipping — every update day I can practically see your name appear in the backend, and it's starting to make me nervous)

Also want to thank Duokaishuida (mm, getting chubby), Erikakoo (you're not a new reader — come pick up your plaque), MARGINAL Yu (see, all familiar faces), San Jiu Ai Chi Hong Dou Gao (forgot to say — yes, I love it), Qinglin ohp (slightly unfamiliar?), Yong Sai Huxi De Shamo Zhiwu (I feel like I've seen you before...)

Thank you BK Hongshu, DStorm (another old friend), Ciel Mo (I am kept by a dedicated rotation of women), Zi Ya (you're one of them), Xiayu Mao Mao (and you), Banlan De Nongwu (I always think of a marble cake), Du Ziruo, Xinshi AtRnoname (new reader?)

New line — thanks to Yongyuan Zhan Zai Jidan Na Yi Bian, Qianhui Yan Yu Xiangrikui, Ya'er (you're here!), Yoleen Yu (dreaming back to the end of the world), Yiban Luoguo Xiao Touming (I see you too), Yu Xia Xie Wuchu Bu Zai, Shijie Daoshu Di San Haichang (why third-to-last?)

Another new line — catching my breath

Thank you Sanxi Yi, _Zhaozhao_, Yinglong Xiang Chi Guilingao (seeing your comments puts me at ease), Xiwei Youye, Ken Yi Kou A-Yun Hehehe (just really craving spare ribs huh), Shandong Zaitao Wajueji (relieved to hear you haven't been caught yet), Liu Jinqi (same as the guilingao person!), Yue Zhuo Xihuan Maoxian Gushi (seeing you feels just like seeing Liu Jinqi! You three are the Peace-of-Mind Squad), Yi Bei Bairimeng Bu Jia Tang (I specially put you here, because you're the fourth member of the Peace-of-Mind Squad)

Thank you Hua Le Wo Shi Fenzhong Xiang De Mingzi (worth the effort), Nuozhadanmasi Zhi Ka (end-of-the-world series), Jiang Shi Tiantian De (Jiang Tian! It's been a while, Jiang Tian), Mama Suo Zuoren Yao Youya

Sorry for stockpiling such a long thank-you chapter again. But look — gather all the women willing to keep me together in one place to thank them, and suddenly my operation looks like it's thriving...

But truly, you really are the one and only thing that can make me sit back down at my desk and keep typing, when I'm discouraged, drained, exhausted, or depressed.

(Because honestly, otherwise I'd have bolted ages ago — it's not like the platform can put out a warrant for my arrest, right?)

Chapter 96: Sydney Ginn's Choice

...The "Nest Communication Network" could reach its end at any moment.

Even though Sydney Ginn knew perfectly well what truly mattered, when she heard the words "it's as though you never did it at all," she lost herself for just an instant and forgot to breathe.

Her feet were rooted firmly to the ground, and for that one moment, she couldn't make herself take a single step forward.

Things had long since changed—she no longer had to worry that one wrong step would send her foot plunging into a pool of blood.

In that instant, it felt as though erasing the records would let her genuinely pretend it had never happened—she'd had that kind of fantasy more times than she could count, sweet and hollow all at once.

"Is that alright?" Ashley was watching her expression intently, and the question snapped Sydney back to her senses. "I know who to call in a favor with, to have the database—"

At a moment like this, what truly mattered wasn't verifying whether Police Chief Ashley could pull it off or keep her word; for Sydney Ginn, there had always been only one way to keep herself in an unassailable position from start to finish—get out in time.

She could simply agree on the spot and walk away.

After that, she could decide whether to hand Ashley over depending on the situation: if turning her in would be more advantageous, it wouldn't be hard to say the word; if Chase had no suspicions, she could just let her go.

For Sydney, it was a no-cost deal—if Ashley kept her promise, all the better; but even if Ashley broke her word afterward, what would it matter?

The situation wouldn't change in any fundamental way—it would simply be the same as before, just another trip into the Nest.

"You don't need to say anything more," she cut Ashley off. "Fine. Let's do it that way."

Ashley was taken aback—she clearly hadn't expected Sydney to agree so readily, without even asking a single "how can I be sure you'll keep your word."

Such a response was naturally beyond Ashley's ability to trust; when Sydney Ginn turned to leave, she grabbed Sydney's shoulder and called out in a low voice: "Wait!"

"Let go," Sydney said quietly. "What do you want?"

Ashley released her, brow furrowed deeply, as if she couldn't figure Sydney out. "You're so... loyal to Chase? I thought you were just someone who got caught up in this by accident."

"I was."

"Then why won't you help me with this?" Ashley seemed to have already made up her mind that Sydney was throwing in her lot with Chase.

She was not a Hunter, and hadn't arrived at the same conclusion as Chase—that Sydney had her own means of saving herself—anyone could only understand the world through the lens of their own experience, and a police chief was no exception.

"I've already promised that the police won't stand against you. Are you saying you'd rather trust a dangerous stranger you happened to meet than the police?"

So agreeing right away had actually aroused her suspicion instead... Sydney nearly wanted to sigh.

"I know he seems decent, but you absolutely cannot trust him because of that." Ashley seemed to have misread something, and spoke in a low, urgent voice: "He may be connected to many criminal cases, and his upbringing and environment were extremely unstable—the perfect breeding ground for an antisocial personality. When he was a teenager, he killed his stepbrother with his own hands—"

Sydney had already been preparing to walk out, but when she heard that, she involuntarily turned her head.

"What?"

Apparently seeing hope of persuading her, Ashley drew a breath and steadied herself as best she could.

"He recently came onto my radar, so I ran a preliminary investigation on him. Around Chase Monroe, there have always been a string of deaths that can't be easily explained... Setting aside his mother, who disappeared in an accident, the first suspicious death was his foster father's biological son—his stepbrother, Damian."

As Sydney's hand holding the phone dropped to her side, both their faces sank together into a dim half-darkness.

"...Is that true?" she asked quietly. "Chase killed his stepbrother? And possibly his mother too?"

"Yes. If he could do that to his own family, do you still think he's trustworthy? Do you think he'd have any goodwill toward someone he barely knows?"

"That can't be right," Sydney pushed back instinctively. "What about the person who adopted him—did they just let it go?"

"No," Ashley said quietly: "I don't think that stopped his foster father from not reporting it to the police and keeping him around, because his foster father isn't an ordinary person. He isn't clean either; he needed someone to do his bidding—an enforcer, someone ruthless enough to turn on his own kin. Chase is an extremely dangerous criminal, and I am a police officer. You're a smart person—you should be able to see which side is more advantageous for you."

...Killed his stepbrother, huh.

"But I don't dare fully trust you either," Sydney said. "Once you're out of danger, who knows whether you'll keep your word?"

Hearing her doubt, Ashley seemed to breathe a sigh of relief, and hope appeared in her eyes.

"I know—I've only given you a promise, and it's hard for you to believe me. Truthfully, I have no way to prove it other than my word. All I can do is stake my character on it—I would never repay kindness with betrayal. Besides, what would I gain from breaking my promise afterward? I can see that you're well-acquainted with this strange phenomenon, and you're no ordinary pushover..."

In her urgency, she'd been speaking fast, and only at that point did she suddenly seem to choke on something, stopping short, staring at Sydney without blinking.

"You... what are you doing?"

Ashley swallowed her shock and slowly asked: "...Why?"

Sydney looked at her, and after a moment, let out a soft sigh.

This chief was a truly exceptional person—her powers of observation, agility, and adaptability were all first-rate; if Sydney tried to fob her off with a lie at this point, it would be

disrespectful.

"I'm making a call,"

Sydney raised the phone that had been hanging at her side and turned the screen toward Ashley. On the phone was a dialing screen; and at just that moment, a faint, low ringtone sounded through the phone. If both of them hadn't happened to go quiet at that exact instant, it would likely have gone unnoticed.

From the moment the female officer had handed her this phone, Sydney had been careful not to let it lock its screen again—she hadn't imagined she'd end up putting that to use here.

"How did you notice? I didn't look directly at the screen when I pressed the numbers, and I tried my best to cover my finger movements."

She had held the phone screen toward herself, used her peripheral vision to spot a row of digits for reference, then pressed the other number keys based on their approximate positions—had the two of them been standing somewhere brightly lit, it wouldn't have been hard to catch; but Sydney hadn't expected that even in the surrounding darkness, Ashley had noticed that small movement of her fingers.

"When you were pressing the keys, your fingers kept blocking the screen light one tap at a time."

Ashley seemed to lose all the energy she'd had a moment ago while trying to persuade her, and stood where she was, asking quietly: "Why? What exactly is your relationship with him?"

"If I said there's no relationship at all, you wouldn't believe me anyway, would you?"

Ashley shook her head, as if letting the words brush past her—sure enough, she didn't believe a word of it. "No relationship at all, and yet you'd go this far for him?"

"I might have been a little impulsive."

Sydney answered, knowing full well even as she did that sometimes the more truthful something was, the harder it was to believe. "Embarrassing as it is to say, I'm a fairly impulsive person... Of course, I know why I acted on impulse, but I have no intention of telling you why."

Ashley fell silent. She stared at Sydney, looking as if she found it both absurd and like a warning, and said: "Getting tangled up with someone like that... aren't you afraid you'll regret it? No—you will regret it."

I have a regret cure.

Sydney thought quietly to herself, though she had no idea whether that regret cure would work the way she wanted it to...

The "Nest Communication Network" cut off all outside signals; calls could only be made between two phones inside the same building.

Chase still had Sydney Ginn's phone in his hand, so all she had to do was call her own number—once Chase saw the incoming call, he'd naturally be able to figure out who was calling, because the only person in this building who knew Sydney Ginn's number by heart was Sydney Ginn herself.

Even so, even knowing Chase would certainly be able to figure out it was her, she hadn't expected him to come this fast.

She raised her eyes to look past Ashley.

Behind the chief, in a darkness the flashlight could not pierce, a tall, dark shadow had appeared at some unknown moment—arriving nearly without a sound.

As if she sensed it, Ashley closed her eyes.

"...Hello there, Chief."

Chase lowered his head and rested one large hand lightly on Ashley's shoulder. He smiled, his voice drifting up like mist from the depths of a cave. "I've had a few questions I've been wanting to ask you for a long time."

Finally finished writing!

Chapter 97 — Chase: The End of the Nest Communication Network

Chase had always been lucky; but the moment he caught Ashley just before the Nest Communication Network ended was not entirely due to luck.

"Let's split up and search more carefully,"

as everything was drawing to a close and Chief Ashley still came up empty-handed, Sydney Ginn finally could not hold back, and suggested to him: "There isn't much time left, after all. If I find her, I'll lock her up and come get you."

Chase knew she was looking for a chance to slip away.

Perhaps because her "rescue measure" was too valuable to carry on her person, she hadn't brought it with her. That meant Sydney Ginn would have to leave on her own to use it without anyone noticing; it was possible it was hidden somewhere in the Nest—

So what?

Chase made a low sound of acknowledgment in his throat.

When Sydney Ginn left in a hurry, as if running away, he did not even turn his head.

Her and whatever she had hidden away didn't matter right now.

Once the Nest Communication Network ended, everything that had happened inside the Central Police Department today—including the identity of whoever had orchestrated the attack on him—would be swallowed into shadow, and retreat from the world along with the Nest, vanishing without a trace.

It wasn't that he cared about what charges would be pinned on him—whether he had killed one person or two, whether it was Wellesley or some street sweeper who ended up dead, it made no difference to Chase.

But as time continued to dwindle and he still couldn't find any trace of Ashley, another thought gathered like storm clouds, growing heavier and darker, pressing lower and lower against his chest.

.....What was he, exactly?

Chase knew full well he was nothing.

As an orphan, in the eyes of the world, he was just Uncle Key's dog.

Eliminating him served no real purpose, unless whoever it was held a personal grudge. What worried him more was that the true target of whoever was pulling the strings was Key House Faction; today's events were meant to remove him as an obstacle.

If Ashley's intelligence disappeared from the world along with her, did that mean Key House Faction would have to guard against arrows flying from unknown directions, starting from today?

But until he found Ashley and got a name out of her, everything was pure speculation—

When a man's face caught the edge of his vision, Chase's eyes flickered and his thoughts snapped apart; he turned around, reached out, and pinned the mercenary's shoulder with his hand.

The mercenary was so startled he nearly let out a shriek, and stared at Chase, stuttering: "M-Mr. Monroe....."

"What were you looking at?"

Chase had actually followed the mercenary's line of sight and caught a distant glimpse of Sydney Ginn's back disappearing up the staircase; but he asked anyway—because in the instant the mercenary had spotted Sydney Ginn's retreating figure, a flicker of surprise had crossed his face.

A flicker of surprise that had no business appearing at this particular moment, and it snagged in his vision.

Mercury's mercenaries, by now, should all have heard that he hadn't been brought into the police station alone—that another woman had been released from the cells along with him.

If they knew that, then what was he surprised about?

The mercenary had, after all, once been a Hunter; he steadied himself now, and said carefully: "I didn't mean anything by it... I just thought she looked unfamiliar, so I looked a second time."

Chase studied his expression.

He felt as though he could already dimly make out Ashley's silhouette, dissolving into the shadows, and the faint tracks she had left behind while fleeing and hiding.

This was a hunt; to be a hunter in the human world, you had to know where to look, and what kind of clues to look for.

"Right," Chase said quietly, "was that the first time you'd seen her?"

The mercenary's neck seemed to go stiff; he gave a small, barely perceptible nod.

"You should know that there was a woman brought into the station along with me, right?"

"Yes... I know."

Chase looked at him and asked, "Before this—did you see another woman somewhere, and assume she was my companion?"

The mercenary's face went a little pale. By this point in the conversation, he should have pieced the clues together as well.

"Yes. Black hair, cut to the jaw, covering one eye....." he answered quietly, "She even asked me, 'Where did Mercury go?'"

.....So that was it.

In that instant, Chase almost wanted to laugh.

So Ashley had been exploiting the gap—that Chase didn't know the mercenaries, and the mercenaries hadn't seen Sydney Ginn—to hold on all this time. She asked "where is Mercury" because Mercury was the one person who both knew all the mercenaries and knew Sydney Ginn, making her the greatest danger.

Had she been invaded?

Thinking back on it now, she almost certainly had been, otherwise she couldn't have slipped through the first wave of arrests Mercury had led—but the extent of the change likely wasn't severe; probably only one eye had been affected.

Mercury was Mercury, through and through. Chase had only just told her that "Ashley's appearance looks normal," and she had immediately worked out the connection, even clapping her hands and laughing out loud: "No wonder she'd been hiding this long—that was the only path left to her!"

Now that he knew where to look, the rest was just legwork.

Starting from the first floor, Chase swept through every possible hiding spot and every face he passed, moving like a gust of wind through floor after floor; behind him, Mercury and the mercenaries searched while closing in, cutting off any chance for Ashley to slip back into the crowd.

When he stepped onto the staircase leading to the fifth floor, he caught the faint sound of a conversation drifting from deep down the corridor.

".....I've already promised that the police won't move against you....."

He lightened his footsteps and climbed another step.

It was Ashley... he hadn't expected Sydney Ginn to find her first.

It sounded as though Ashley was working to bring Sydney Ginn over to her side; every word she said was reasonable, and tempting.

Ashley, as Chief of Police, had offered to wipe the records clean entirely; and Sydney Ginn happened to have a case on her that couldn't be exposed. Since she had no idea what would happen once the Nest Communication Network ended, she had no reason to refuse.

Even taking into account that Sydney Ginn had a "rescue measure," at best she would stay neutral, or play it by ear—there was no one in the world who would choose Chase.

As he walked up, his fingers stretched and flexed, preparing in the dim silence for the confrontation ahead.

".....The first suspicious death was his foster father's biological son—his stepbrother, Damian."

Chase stood frozen in the darkness for several seconds, not moving at all.

He suddenly remembered that today was still November the nineteenth, that the day hadn't passed yet. It was as if once the Nest Communication Network had descended and cut off all outside signals, he had exhaled and allowed himself to quietly let the date slip from his mind.

Years ago, he had watched a film called *The Truman Show*.

If someone told him that everything that had happened today was just a special program for November the nineteenth—staged to make him hear the name "Damian" without any warning, to bring him to this moment, to make him face once again the words "he killed his stepbrother with his own hands"; and that outside this program, Uncle Key and Aunt Hai were watching his face, waiting for his reaction.....

By the time he came back to himself, Chase realized that at some point he had slightly hunched forward, a layer of cold sweat on his skin.

It was laughable. So many years had already passed.

Since he had killed, he had killed... even if he could do it over, he would still kill Damian.

And spend the rest of his life atoning for it.

The two women's conversation seemed as far away as the other side of an ocean, fragmented, with only scattered pieces drifting toward him.

"What's in it for me if I break my promise?" Ashley was still pressing, ".....You're not an ordinary person to tangle with....."

Chase continued up the stairs, deliberately making no sound with each step. Ashley was one thing; but Sydney Ginn was a Hunter—if she noticed him too early, things would get complicated.

Although he was confident he could physically subdue both of them, Chase was unwilling to leave any room for accidents.

It shouldn't be long now—before the moment Sydney Ginn nodded.

When a faint vibration came from his trouser pocket, he had a full second where he couldn't make sense of what was happening.

There was only one person who could call that phone.

.....But why?

He took out Sydney Ginn's phone, glanced at the unfamiliar number on the screen, listened for a moment to the conversation between the two women at the far end of the corridor, and finally came to his senses, moving step by step toward Ashley's back.

Sydney Ginn stood in a space that was half pallid grey, half dim shadow, her face and expression impossible to read.

The first time he had seen this girl, he had assumed she was someone light and easygoing, someone who had never encountered anything truly significant in her life; she became a Hunter probably the way some people develop a taste for horror films.

Someone like that—even if she had gotten herself mixed up in some trouble—belonged on a fundamentally different track of human existence from someone like him, sunken deep in darkness.

Now Chase wasn't so sure anymore.

He slowly broke into a smile at that half-lit, half-shadowed Sydney Ginn, and gently placed his hand on Ashley's shoulder.

"Wait—"

Ashley's whole body was taut, but she seemed to have already made up her mind, her words tumbling out quickly: "You just want to know how you ended up getting dragged in here, don't you? I'll tell you—you don't need to take this to the point of killing anyone! The person who hired me didn't tell me much, but I know that arresting you was meant to remove you from the picture; he did it because of who's behind you—"

This was bad.

When Chase felt a sudden jolt in his chest, he also realized that there weren't many things that could make him lose track of time, yet on the way up the stairs just now, it had happened twice in succession—Ashley's words would never be finished.

The Nest Communication Network ended at that moment.

In the next instant, the second half of Ashley's unfinished sentence became a long, high shriek of laughter; she threw her head back violently, and two long arm-shaped shadows suddenly shot out from her eye sockets, startling Sydney Ginn back a step.

Countless shrill, frenzied, hollow laughs and wails echoed through the Central Police Department. The waves of sound surged and crashed against the walls, as if the Residents, in their final retreat from the human world, were giving one last curtain call and reveling in it.

Chase heard none of it.

The second half of Ashley's last words drowned out every sound and every madness around him.

Even at the cost of going to war with the entire police system, he had still let whoever was behind it all succeed.

Lately I haven't been feeling hungry, and I have no idea why—I usually don't remember I need to eat until my body starts feeling weak and listless. Counting calories all day: have I eaten enough today? Seems like I haven't, let me add a piece of fruit...

And yet somehow I'm not losing any weight eating like this—life really makes no sense, does it?

Chapter 98: Chase's Supreme Luck and the Failed Snipe

The Residents' final frenzy at their curtain call was as fierce as it was brief.

The shrieking laughter that had surged and crashed through the Central Police Department was cut off all at once, as if some raving madman, mid-howl, had been shoved headfirst into water without warning—and in the slowly sinking echo, like the last throes of a dying thing, silence crept back in on quiet feet, seeping into the building inch by inch.

Chase charged toward the stairwell.

Those who had never been invaded by a Resident and knew nothing of Nest Residents were still dazed by the sudden transition from screaming to dead silence, not yet having come back to their senses.

Even Sydney Ginn was still staring at Ashley, who had just collapsed, frozen in place, not yet remembering to run—when he turned and walked away, she seemed to have called something after him, but he hadn't caught it, and had no patience to spare for a reply.

The moment Chase made sense of Ashley's half-sentence, his world became like a movie reel at fast-forward: the background blurred and stretched until nothing was clear. Every surging rush of color existed for one purpose only—to reach a destination as quickly as possible.

The mastermind had set a trap to capture him not only to get hold of "Rumor," but also to remove him from the board entirely—because Chase was the greatest obstacle on the path to the Key House Faction.

So what would that person do when they discovered the situation had shifted, that Chase had used the Nest Communication Network to seize control of the entire Central Police Department?

Would they simply retreat home, pray to the heavens, and hope Ashley wouldn't give them up—pretending nothing had ever happened?

Of course not.

Once you'd made a move against the Key House Faction, you had to be prepared to see it through to the bitter end.

If Chase put himself in the mastermind's position, after the original plan fell apart, the natural move would be to adapt on the fly—to strike at the true target while the greatest threat

was still pinned in one place and couldn't move freely. In other words, Uncle Key had likely been in danger for some time now.

...Were he and Aunt Hai still in the cemetery?

What good were just a handful of bodyguards?

He had already wasted too much time... he didn't even dare think about what it would mean if it was already too late.

Chase's tongue burned with something like chemical acid—a scorched, bitter tang.

He instinctively reached for his phone to call Uncle Key, but the moment his eyes landed on the fluffy ball keychain dangling from it, he froze—and remembered only then that it was Sydney Ginn's phone, still on him.

"Wait—"

Just as he recalled Sydney Ginn's existence, Sydney Ginn herself came running up from behind, calling out breathlessly as she ran: "Wait a second—Ashley's not dead! Did you know she wasn't dead? What's going to happen to them?"

It was less that she had caught up to Chase on her own initiative, and more that she had been chased into catching up.

Behind her, the arm-shadow that had erupted from Ashley's eye sockets was gone, and her eyes had returned to normal—but her gaze still couldn't focus; her neck twisted to one side, one eye aimed at the ceiling, the other at the corridor wall.

Ashley stumbled and lurched, chasing after Sydney Ginn—with every step, her limbs swung loose and slack, her spine tilting back and forth, like a marionette being dragged along at random.

"...Where are you going?"

Ashley could speak again this quickly?

Even Chase, who at that moment had no attention to spare for his surroundings, couldn't help but start at the voice behind him.

"Where are you all going? Where, where, where? Take me to watch TV, watch TV, watch TV —"

"What's wrong with her?" Sydney Ginn seemed pained to even look at her, hurrying after Chase and rushing down the stairs. "She didn't turn into a Resident, did she? The way she's talking —"

"She's not a Resident."

Chase tossed out those few words, raised his hand, and flung Sydney Ginn's phone back to her—she caught it in a fumbling scramble. "There you go. Weren't you trying to leave?"

Never mind that Sydney Ginn was just someone whose method of saving his life had piqued his curiosity; even if she could turn into God the moment she stepped out of the police station, he didn't have a single scrap of mental energy left to give her.

Right now, there was only one thing that mattered in the entire world.

The cleanup at the Central Police Department would have to be handed over to Mercury entirely; he still needed to borrow a few of her mercenaries—how much firepower had the mastermind sent toward the cemetery?

Uncle Key couldn't reach him, so he should have called for House Faction Hunters immediately... but who knew if they could hold out? Why was there not a single missed call on his own phone right now?

Or had things already turned so dire that the Hunters who'd gotten word and rushed to help didn't even have time to send him a message?

The first call to Uncle Key was declined by a soft, impassive female voice: "We're sorry, the number you have dialed cannot be reached at this time..."

Chase barely suppressed the urge to snap his phone in half and called Aunt Hai instead; this time the call went through, but no one ever picked up.

Something had happened. Something had happened after all.

The last thin thread of hope he'd been holding onto was extinguished by those two unanswered calls.

"Mercury!"

He burst onto the first floor and had barely called her name when he saw a group of people who had never been invaded by Residents being herded at gunpoint by the mercenaries, filing out of the cells and into the center of the lobby.

...Right—this was Mercury's favorite part of the whole operation.

Especially when she got to carry it out inside a police station... she'd probably been looking forward to this for a long time.

Someone had switched the circuit breakers back on; the lights inside the Central Police Department flickered on and off, as if bewildered, illuminating the wreckage that now filled the building. People who had been invaded by Residents and then abandoned were scattered across the floor in twos and threes, slumped here and there—Ashley appeared to be the first person in the entire building to have gotten back on her feet and regained the ability to speak.

A mercenary wearing gloves was carrying a large coil of iron chain and dropped the whole thing by the front entrance of the police station with a loud clatter, clearly preparing for the upcoming lockdown.

"Give me a few men, a walkie-talkie, and a vehicle. Have them drive and follow me."

Chase grabbed his gun, which he'd left on the lobby table earlier, along with his personal belongings retrieved from the police station's storage, and said to Mercury: "This place is yours. We'll settle accounts later."

"What's the rush?" Mercury was perched cross-legged on a table, her eyes burning bright with excitement she couldn't keep down. "Any specific requirements for the cleanup?"

"Handle it however you see fit. I don't want any loose ends."

"Understood—one deluxe oversized package coming right up," Mercury said, in high enough spirits to joke about it; she snapped her fingers and tossed Chase a set of car keys.

As she turned to go round up her people, Chase headed in long strides toward the front entrance.

His own car had been taken away by the police somewhere, but Mercury's convoy was parked right in the middle of the police station yard, bold as brass; even with all the modifications, you could still see the silhouette of the military trucks they had once been.

He unlocked one of the vehicles and turned around.

"How much longer are you going to follow me?" He glanced at Sydney Ginn and asked.

This woman had more than a little cunning to her; Chase had a fairly good idea of why she'd been quietly trailing him all this way without a word.

It was obvious she'd noticed that Chase had something urgent and important to deal with, and no longer cared in the slightest where she went, what she did, or whether she even left at all—which meant following him had become a risk-free proposition.

Whereas if she didn't stick with Chase, she'd risk running into someone like Ashley, or being detained by Mercury—and getting free of that later wouldn't be easy.

"Oh, this is far enough—I'm already out." Sydney Ginn glanced back at the police station and said, "Good luck. I'll be on my way."

Chase said nothing and pulled the car door open—but before he got in, something stirred in his mind, and he recalled the moment when Sydney Ginn had been in his car and instinctively touched the back of her neck.

She had been talking about the part where the Vulture attacked her... the lingering fear on her face, as if her neck had once suffered a near-fatal wound, she herself unaware that she was touching an old scar.

But when Chase looked, he found her neck smooth and unblemished, without so much as a faint mark.

...He hadn't had the time to think it through further, but something about that detail nagged at him, as though it concealed something.

"Hold on," he leaned out again, and even knowing the situation was urgent, he forced down his impatience and said: "You don't need to worry about the fingerprint records."

Sydney Ginn blinked. "Why not?"

The rain had stopped by now, and the daylight was still struggling to survive beneath the heavy overcast. Her hair had dried at some point; it was only then that Chase noticed she didn't actually have black hair.

Once her hair dried, Sydney Ginn's hair color came out a shade lighter—oddly enough, just one or two tones brighter, and yet it made a person look entirely different.

The reason Chase had such an untimely thought at that precise moment was that he kept feeling like Sydney Ginn, with her lighter hair, looked vaguely familiar.

He had absolutely never met Sydney Ginn before.

What he meant was that her appearance right now made him feel as though he had once met someone who seemed very similar to her... as for when, where, and who that person was, all of that had simply slipped away—none of it had ever been important enough to him to remember.

And so the sense of familiarity hadn't even lasted a full moment before it was gone.

"All the records they made today—I'll take care of them afterward."

Chase finished speaking, closed the car door with a thud, paused for half a second, and finally spoke once more through the window: "...Call it my way of saying thanks."

He didn't know why she had chosen not to cooperate with Ashley and called him instead, but Chase kept the debt in mind regardless.

"Hm?" Sydney Ginn had clearly put it together as well, and called after him as he started the car: "That's separate from the favor you already owed me before, right?"

Chase, having already wasted a few seconds on conversation, naturally had no intention of stopping to settle the score.

On the drive to the cemetery, Chase probably broke every traffic law currently on the books; if there were any yet to be written, he'd likely broken those too.

He drove with one hand while trying to reach the House Faction Hunters; just as he'd expected, every Hunter who was skilled and experienced enough to have been called away by Uncle Key in his place was completely unreachable.

Chase took a slow, deep breath, wrenched the steering wheel, and turned onto the narrow road leading down from the cemetery hill.

Those Hunters were probably in the middle of a fight right now.

Looking at it from another angle... something had gone wrong, but the situation most likely wasn't over yet, and nothing had been decided. That wasn't the worst possible outcome.

As he drove in a straight line toward the cemetery, Chase silently cursed himself for an idiot.

Of course the people most likely to be in the middle of a fight couldn't be reached right now—but the logistics personnel who had distributed weapons and Artifacts before the Hunters set out would certainly be the ones with the clearest picture of the situation at this moment—

Why hadn't he thought to contact them?

Just as Chase reached down to grab his phone, two or three sharp, thunderous cracks rang out in quick succession, and something wrapped in a gust of wind sliced through the air directly above his head; a small hole appeared in the bulletproof windshield, and from it, countless spider-web cracks spread in every direction.

To the shriek of tires against asphalt, the military truck was wrenched sharply off to the roadside.

Chase threw himself flat across the seat; the initial shock of nearly being shot swept through him like a sudden detonation of blood—and then drained away just as fast. His heart was still pounding violently, yet he had already slipped back into that detached, almost otherworldly calm, reaching out to close his hand around his gun.

...Uncle Key is definitely still in the cemetery, he thought. Uncle Key is still alive.

That was why the puppet master had stationed a sniper on the road leading to the cemetery.

And a remarkably skilled one at that.

While Chase had been driving at high speed, that person had still managed to lock onto his skull, seize the precise moment, and with a single .44 caliber, cleanly put two shots through the bulletproof glass in quick succession before sending a third bullet straight for his forehead—there weren't many people in Blackmoor City capable of that.

If not for the fact that he had, at that exact instant, suddenly bowed his head to make a phone call...

"Senior, your luck is just unreal, isn't it?"

A vaguely familiar voice drifted in from outside the car, sounding as though it had no idea what to do with him.

"People used to say you had good luck, and I never really took it to heart. But of all moments, you had to bow your head right then. Do you have some kind of luck-boosting Artifact on you?"

Chase closed his eyes and let out a slow, quiet breath.

"Long time no see," he said coldly. "I just learned that on top of being a Hunter, you moonlight as an assassin."

"Sorry, but you should've just stayed in the police station. I didn't want to assassinate you either, Senior."

Chase reached out and gripped the door handle.

He paused for a second or two before speaking.

"It seems you've already forgotten the lesson from the last time you crossed me, London Moon."

My schedule has been all over the place these past few days, so I've just been posting and calling it done without checking comments—I just looked and saw some readers getting into an argument over shipping... I'm feeling a little conflicted, like I'm caught in the middle (not really).

How do I put this—I love writing about feelings and bonds (I've even caught flak for it, but I'll keep writing them anyway). I've always felt that the feelings and bonds between people are complex, subtle, and deeply moving, but they don't have to be romantic (I also can't write romance to save my life—I genuinely have no idea how).

I think readers who've followed me since the apocalypse story probably all get this about me—when I say I understand your "shipping," I mean it in a broad sense: a resonance with emotional bonds, not a literal wish to see any two characters fall in love (regardless of gender). That's right, isn't it?

So I think with that shared understanding as a foundation, there really isn't anything worth arguing about, because when it comes down to it, everyone likes the same kind of thing.

I hope this story keeps giving you moments of joy... that's all I need.

Chapter 99: The Trouble Chase's Good Luck Brought

It takes most people four years to complete enough credits to graduate, but Chase had spent five and a half years before finally earning his degree from Blackmoor University.

Because the guiding principle he followed when scheduling his courses was simple: the fewer, the better.

From very early on, Chase's life had already veered completely off the normal track. That he would ever attend university like an ordinary person was, in itself, rather strange—thinking back on it now, perhaps it was because in Uncle Key's original plan, Damian was always meant to go to college someday.

Every so often, walking across campus and watching the young faces laughing and chatting around him, Chase felt as though Blackmoor University was a simulation game; as if he were only surfacing from the true, dark reality beneath, stepping briefly into a sunlit game of make-believe to catch his breath.

If not for the university's minimum course requirements, he might still technically be enrolled at Blackmoor University to this day—after five and a half years, the number of people he knew, and who knew him, probably wouldn't have added up to twenty.

London Moon was one of them.

It had been several years since he had thought of that name.

"Who are you working for?" Chase asked. "If you come over to my side, I can forget today ever happened."

Outside the car, the road was completely silent.

The only sound came from the highway far below at the bottom of the slope—cars passing by at intervals, their passage cracking through the air like a whip.

He had come too fast; Mercury's mercenaries hadn't caught up yet.

"...Thank you."

Several seconds passed before London Moon finally spoke. Chase remembered that she was someone who was, more often than not, composed and courteous—and this moment was no

exception.

"It's a pity... if this were just a job, I never would have taken it in the first place."

"I don't recall any personal grudge between us."

While speaking, Chase slowly pushed open the car door. It swung halfway open and stopped—still no movement outside.

Judging by the direction the voice was coming from, London Moon was still posted by the roadside ahead; the gun in her hand was likely trained on this car, ready to fire the moment a target stepped out—but regardless, he couldn't stay inside the car forever.

"Of course not," London Moon said from a distance. "What happened a few years ago was nothing more than a dispute between House Factions. Besides, I left Knight House Faction long ago."

"Then why?" Chase asked, his voice nearly calm.

His situation right now was far from ideal: he had been keeping low behind the steering wheel, unable to raise himself, because the moment he showed his face behind the glass, the other side would open fire immediately—he couldn't even see London Moon's position, let alone return fire.

Normally, if an initial ambush on a moving vehicle fails, the attacking party closes the distance, surrounds and suppresses the target vehicle with gunfire, and shoots the driver inside before they can bail out.

But London Moon hadn't done that.

Not because she had no intention of killing him—otherwise she wouldn't have aimed at his forehead just now. Most likely she understood clearly that without enough numbers to form an overwhelming force, if she approached a car with Chase in it, the one in danger would become herself.

That was the irritating thing about running into someone who knew you: they understood your strengths and your weaknesses all too well.

What's more, London Moon could advance or fall back as she pleased—if she could kill Chase, she would; if she couldn't, keeping him pinned down still wouldn't stop whoever was on the other side from attacking Uncle Key.

"There's a somewhat personal reason I had no choice but to move against you."

London Moon said that much and no more—it was as good as saying nothing. "For the same reason, I can't tell you who hired me for this job."

This exchange had already lasted nearly a minute; having talked this long while wrestling down his anxiety, Chase had finally found a way to get rid of London Moon and continue on to the cemetery.

Because from beneath the seat on the other side, he had spotted an empty black duffel bag—it looked like the kind Mercury's mercenaries used to carry weapons.

"That's fine," Chase said with a quiet laugh. "If you won't tell me, once I get to the cemetery, there'll be plenty of people willing to talk."

Before the words had fully left his mouth, he grabbed the empty duffel bag and flung it out through the half-open car door—and in the instant the bag left his hand, Chase had already sat up.

The moment the bag hit the ground, two gunshots exploded in midair; the duffel bag leapt up from the pavement and was sent tumbling several steps forward.

...Found you.

Chase drove his foot into the windshield—the glass, already laced with spider-web cracks, couldn't withstand the force, and with a shattering crash it gave way all at once, cascading down like shards of silver—even as the fragments still hung in the air like threads of falling rain, he had already fired three shots in rapid succession toward where London Moon was.

London Moon had assumed that the moment he risked stepping out of the car, there was no way he could pay attention to two places at once.

And it was precisely in that moment that Chase was able to sit up and fix his gaze on what lay ahead—catching, when she fired, that brief small flash of white light among the shadowed trees.

He didn't know whether he had hit London Moon, and he didn't waste time finding out; the instant the shots were fired, Chase hurled himself out through the car door, rolled across the ground, and when he sprang back up, he had already crossed half the road and plunged into the trees along the roadside.

Chase held the gun in both hands, kept low, and pushed forward at a rapid pace toward the cemetery up the slope.

His goal was not to kill London Moon—though of course, if a chance to do so presented itself, he would not let it pass—the most important thing right now was to get to Uncle Key's side immediately, without wasting a single moment.

"I'm sorry, senior."

When those words rang out, Chase finally sensed that something was wrong—but it was already too late.

When he had opened his eyes this morning, he never could have imagined that on this very day, in Blackmoor City, he would be stopped in his tracks by Artifacts twice in a row: the first time he had more or less walked into it himself, but the second time, he had been tricked.

London Moon was not a professional sniper. Her main identity was that of an Artifact Hunter.

"Besides knowing how to shoot, I need a few other tricks up my sleeve if I'm going to come stop you single-handedly."

As London Moon drew closer, her voice grew nearer as well; Chase slowly straightened up, lowered his gun, and fixed his gaze steadily on her pair of blue eyes.

Ill-timed as it was, in this moment he felt, faintly and unexpectedly, a trace of nostalgia for the past.

And there was something else—a brief flicker of familiarity from just moments ago, but it slipped away before he could catch it, like a drifting bottle bobbing up and down in some distant wave. No matter how he turned it over in his mind, he couldn't figure out where that feeling had come from—but it certainly wasn't because he knew London Moon.

Chase couldn't afford to waste time on something as intangible as a "feeling."

"What Artifact is this? At first glance, the surroundings have barely changed."

He pulled his attention back, swept the gun around him in a circle, and let the muzzle settle on London Moon again. "If I fire at the 'you' standing in front of me right now, it probably wouldn't mean anything, would it?"

Beneath the brim of her cap, London Moon gave a soft laugh.

These past few years had perhaps been kind to her; for all the time since graduation, she looked not a day older, still the same young person she had been not long after first enrolling.

"That's right, because I'm not there at all. I was actually surprised you noticed you'd stepped into an Artifact zone so quickly. How did you figure it out?"

The word she used was "there"—as though she herself were standing at a different location entirely, watching Chase from a distance—and the direction and distance of her voice had clearly been altered along with everything else, because she sounded as if she were standing right in front of him.

Chase gripped his gun and slowly looked around him.

"This Artifact activated without a sound... but its limitations aren't small either, are they?"

"That's right. Unfortunately, once you entered the environment this Artifact created, I can see you, but I can no longer touch you." London Moon shrugged and pulled her cap lower, its shadow falling across half her face. "Since I couldn't kill you, all I can do is try to keep you trapped."

...And here he was, standing here doing nothing, while Uncle Key might be facing death at the cemetery up on the hill not far away.

Chase tightened his grip on the gun, jaw clenched, and slowly forced out a smile.

"If anything happens to Uncle Key, you'll all regret it," he said quietly. "Every second I'm trapped here is one more second the person behind you will spend alive in my hands... no matter how much they beg for a quick death."

London Moon looked at him, then let out a quiet sigh.

"Chase," she said, lowering her eyes, "you're suffering so much. It would've been kinder if I'd just shot you back there."

Chase said nothing.

"Any threat you make against that person is useless," London Moon said. "That person already lives in hell every single day, and isn't afraid of your retaliation or revenge."

"Who is it?"

He knew she wouldn't answer; but Chase asked anyway.

Even if London Moon just said a few more words, it would help—sound echoing within an Artifact's space was itself a form of interaction with it, and might give him some information.

"What you want to know, I can't tell you. But there are some things I can say."

London Moon lifted her eyes from beneath the cap's brim and smiled with what seemed like self-deprecation.

"I know that if one were to absorb and consolidate the power of a Hunter House Faction, that person would have a chance of obtaining what they want. As for why they came after Key House Faction and no one else—the only explanation I can offer is that your luck was too good: the Artifacts scattered and lost after Wellesley's death, and you found them on the first try. For the sake of that person's salvation, I had no choice but to come and take away what you hold most dear... Living seems to mean choosing between making mistakes and doing harm, doesn't it?"

She gave Chase a small nod. "I should go. I'm sorry—I can't wish you luck."

Chase as a character is strange—he's always easy to write for the first two chapters, then immediately becomes a struggle, and this chapter was no exception... Fortunately the original is in Chinese, otherwise a form of address like "学长" would be very hard to find the right word for.

Today I broke my favorite mug... it sounds like such a small thing, but it's the kind of thing that brings you down in a way that's completely out of proportion.

Chapter 100: Chase Hides a Door Here

It seemed like only a few steps, and London Moon vanished in a flash, disappearing into the air.

But her words sent countless thoughts, feelings, worries, anxieties, guilts... and so many fragments of memory that had resurfaced for reasons unknown crashing through Chase's mind like an avalanche.

For one brief moment, he stood rooted in place, like a victim buried under ten thousand tons of snow, unable to move.

That person had struck against Key House Faction because he himself had found Wellesley's Artifact? If he had never found it, would Uncle Key have been spared?

Was it a coincidence? For a dead man, why did Wellesley's name keep coming up over and over again?

Why had London Moon gone so far for that person—even to the point of making an enemy of Chase?

...Was Uncle Key still alive?

How was he supposed to get out of here?

Chase closed his eyes and drew a long, deep breath.

When a thousand tangled threads all tear at your mind from every direction at once, the most important thing is to pull yourself free from the knot of emotion and thought, and put distance between yourself and everything.

The worst that could happen was simply this: Roland Key was dead, and after he charged up the hillside, he would die too.

Accept it, and a person could find calm again.

Stop thinking about whether Roland Key was dead or not; Roland Key was already dead, and Chase was already dead.

If the outcome was death for both of them, then all his anxiety and fury right now was nothing more than meaningless noise before the final movement.

For now, the path ahead was only one, plain and clear—as for whether each step he took led toward that final movement, toward death, or toward hope, that fell within the domain of fate.

When Chase opened his eyes, the blizzard in his mind had spent itself, leaving behind a vast, boundless expanse of stillness and white.

Within the House Faction, he was often called upon to evaluate and appraise the Artifacts that Hunters brought back, and so he had encountered and studied a great many of them.

Artifacts were remarkable things; yet the more you saw of them, the more you realized that these objects—which perhaps had no business existing in the human world—were not entirely unpredictable. There were patterns to follow.

What London Moon had used on him was likely a "detached-type" Artifact—just as the name implied, the Artifact's physical body and the Artifact's effect could be separated from each other.

She had used the Artifact to create a "cage" that closely resembled the surrounding environment; once Chase unwittingly stepped inside, she could take the Artifact itself and leave—this type of Artifact was naturally more flexible and safer for its wielder, since they didn't need to stay and hold a position; but the drawback was that the effect's scope was quite limited.

For instance, London Moon herself had acknowledged that she couldn't reach through the Artifact's effect to land a killing blow on Chase.

Another point... was that the "effect" left behind on its own, compared to a heavy-hitting weapon at the level of the Nest Communication Network, wasn't particularly powerful; in fact, most of the time, there was even a "key to breaking free."

It was like a room; what Chase needed to do was find its "door."

He spent half a minute carefully surveying his surroundings.

This cemetery was the most expensive burial ground in the entire state, sprawling across a full hillside. The main road—the one he had gotten off from—wound its way up toward the summit; on either side of the road stood a thin strip of trees, their shadows falling across the green in shifting, mottled patches.

Looking past the trees beside him, Chase could see a wide, gently rolling expanse of dark green grass in the distance, and beneath the thick, dull gray layers of cloud pressing down on the earth, the headstones standing like so many sullen, brooding faces.

It looked like rain again soon.

Looking back, the modified truck he had abandoned was still slanted at the roadside, nearly brushing against a tree. All around him was silence; somewhere along the way, even the sound of cars on the distant highway had been shut out beyond the Artifact's boundary.

"Too quiet," Chase murmured toward the long-departed London Moon.

She had been surprised just now—surprised that he had immediately realized he'd walked into an Artifact trap. That was because Chase knew everything about this cemetery with absolute familiarity, including exactly what sounds could be heard in every corner of it.

"For you, this place should always just be a quiet graveyard."

He listened to his own voice echo in the air. "But for me, the moment I stepped into the trap, it was like a film being suddenly paused. All the subtle sounds that should have been there vanished at once—naturally, that was the biggest warning signal there is."

Back in their university days, London Moon, as a junior at the same school, had discovered her passage and would always come to Chase—a person without a passage—and to another person who didn't work as a Hunter, asking all kinds of questions; it seemed that from that time on, he had formed the habit of explaining things and answering her doubts.

...So that habit was still there. Even when she was long gone, he still had to answer her questions.

Chase let out a soft, quiet laugh through his nose—though there was no amusement in it.

By rough estimate, his line of sight extended a few hundred meters before being blocked by the terrain and the trees in the distance.

A few hundred meters was plenty far enough; a single detached-type Artifact couldn't possibly cover an effective range of several hundred meters in every direction.

Which meant... if there was a "door" within this Artifact's effect, then he must have already seen it.

He just didn't yet know which of the things he'd seen was the door.

Then let's start by testing the boundaries of this Artifact's effect.

Chase raised his gun and fired a shot toward the cemetery beyond the tree line—the report was far louder than anything before it, rattling his ears with a sustained, ringing hum—nothing

like the sound a gunshot should make in an open outdoor space.

The moment that thought surfaced, Chase immediately had his answer.

The bullet had barely touched the air among the trees when it began to slow and thicken, as if it had bored into a wall of gel, growing slower and slower; until it gave one small shudder, finally lost all momentum entirely, and after hanging suspended in the air for a brief instant, dropped onto the grass.

Chase repeated the process, firing one shot each in several other directions, including straight up; even with two strips of cloth torn from his shirt stuffed into his ears, the ringing still hammered through his head—but at least he had now mapped out the full extent of this cage around him.

What enclosed him was an independent space roughly a dozen meters on each side; no matter what he did within it, it could have no effect on the outside world.

The Artifact's effect was plain—simply a transparent box impervious to outside force, sealed over him, probably with a time limit too; if it had one single distinguishing advantage, it was likely the ability to create an illusion in place of the Artifact's owner—meaning the owner could use "themselves" as bait to lure a target into the transparent box.

If a House Faction Hunter had brought this in, Chase would price it at sixty thousand at most.

But plain as the effect was, it was quite effective—wasn't he stuck inside right now?

...Where on earth was the door?

He swept his gaze around once more, then walked up to the "wall" and felt along it carefully: if not for the ring of transparent, yielding something surrounding him in the air, there was nothing to see with the naked eye at all.

The scent of trees and fresh grass, the faint rustle of his own clothing, the heavy clouds pressing low over the earth, everything was—wait.

Chase spun around sharply, as if reaching on instinct for a thought that was about to brush past him.

Something was wrong with one spot.

Something that shouldn't be here was here—did that mean he'd found the door?

The clue has already been given, dear clever readers—can you guess the answer?

...For some reason, when I was writing this chapter, it was like my brain was poisoned—this line just kept playing on repeat in my head: "dear clever readers, you can surely imagine the tone and inflection."

Chapter 101: Chase Breaks Through, and Flying Bullets

In Chase's imagination, he could almost "see" a transparent barrier — soft as water — "flowing" out of the Artifact without a sound.

It spread across the ground as if following invisible channels, forming a square; the transparent barrier rose gradually from all four sides, folding at the corners, flowing toward each other in midair — until it finally merged and fused together, forming a transparent box capable of trapping a person inside.

"...Using cheap tricks like this on me," Chase murmured, reaching out to grip the tree branch tightly.

To be fair, this Artifact's effect was not actually bad — it activated without a trace, and its walls could ignore physical damage from the outside; even a Hunter trapped within it would be hard-pressed to think of a way to escape.

But perhaps London Moon hadn't anticipated that, despite Chase having no passage, his knowledge and familiarity with Artifacts was something no ordinary Hunter could match.

Over the years, the Artifacts he had evaluated and tested for the Key House Faction — conservatively speaking — numbered several hundred; even an ordinary Hunter who regularly ventured into the Nest might not encounter that many Artifacts in an entire lifetime.

When he noticed that beneath the low, overcast sky, a blurry tree shadow was floating at his feet, Chase understood almost immediately how this particular Artifact effect had formed.

The transparent barrier formed four walls, folding inward and flowing up into midair, until they finally "bonded" together... and it was precisely at the point of bonding that the light shifted: light seemed to be concentrated and bent, so that beneath a sky thick with gloomy clouds, this tiny irregularity in the light cast a faint, blurry tree shadow below.

The door. Found it.

As with many structures in this world, the weakest point of this Artifact effect should be exactly where two faces met.

Chase planted one foot on a branch, held firmly to the trunk, and carefully straightened himself up little by little.

He had forgotten how old he was the last time he climbed a tree; now, standing nearly two meters tall, trembling on a branch, it was honestly more nerve-wracking than dealing with Residents.

...If he hadn't been trapped by an Artifact, but ended up unable to move because he fell out of a tree, that would truly be the sort of thing he couldn't die in peace over.

Next time he saw London Moon, he'd make her climb a tree too — using an Artifact on her was already giving her too much face; stringing her up with a plain rope would be the only truly satisfying option.

Thinking this, Chase raised his gun and squeezed the trigger toward that faint, blurry halo in midair — the kind that looked as though it was just a sliver of light filtering through thin clouds.

The first bullet plunged into the gel-like light; before it could fall, the second followed close behind; the third and fourth bullets churned up a howling, thunderstorm gale of wind that grew stronger and stronger, pounding the light and shadow, making it shudder harder with each shot, until finally it tore through and ripped the air open — and after the transparent barrier flickered and trembled like a shimmering water-curtain several times, one bullet at last did not fall back onto the grass but instead vanished beneath the distant sky.

Yet the barriers all around still stood firm, refusing to collapse even though a crack had been torn open.

Chase clenched his jaw and had already mentally torn London Moon into seventeen or eighteen pieces.

Never in his life had he imagined that one day he would be forced to scramble up and down between trees, gauging distances, gripping trunks to test how far he could swing — he truly could not think of a single difference between himself and a monkey.

When Chase finally climbed to the highest point he could reach and flung himself desperately upward into the air, he had fully prepared himself for a thudding crash to the ground.

Perhaps his luck had not yet abandoned him — in the instant just before he would have scraped the "ceiling" and plummeted back down, Chase felt as though countless antennae had sprouted all over his body, and a faint, cool breath of air brushed faintly across his skin; he snapped his hand open in a desperate grab, fingers clamping hard onto that narrow, elongated tear he had blasted open with his bullets.

If anyone had happened to be walking past on the road at that moment, they would have seen a black-haired, black-clothed man nearly two meters tall hanging in midair over nothing — and not only hanging there, but kicking his legs and clawing with his hands, hauling himself bodily into empty space, his expression fierce and furious and not without a fair measure of wretchedness.

...After all, a man of thirty years, having to be born all over again — no one could come through that without looking wretched.

Come to think of it, even an Artifact effect this "simple" would be the stuff of dreams for most people.

The transparent barrier had been punched through, yet it remained whole and solid.

It looked for all the world like nothing but open air, yet Chase could walk on it step by step; glancing down, the ground lay a dozen or so meters below, watching him from a distance with an almost forlorn look.

As long as he could get free of the Artifact effect, the rest was no problem.

From his position of advantage — high up with a clear view in every direction — Chase scanned his surroundings and found that London Moon did indeed seem to have left early; he shoved that future corpse to the back of his mind, found his bearings from the top of the "box," leaped forward through midair, seized a tree branch to slow his descent, and landed lightly as a leopard on the ground.

When he returned to the car, he found that London Moon had slashed the tires.

"The conditions that help you achieve your goal are sometimes hidden in the details. If you can catch what others miss, you naturally have better odds."

Many years ago, he seemed to have said something like that to London Moon.

Clearly she had worried that a single Artifact effect might not be enough to hold Chase, and was dead set on delaying him as long as possible.

Chase cursed under his breath, grabbed the phone that had saved his life and the walkie-talkie Mercury had given him from the car, and set off at a full sprint up the hillside.

No calls had come through on the walkie-talkie yet, which meant those mercenaries were still at least a few kilometers out; right now, the only thing he could rely on was the gun in his hand.

When Chase charged at full speed onto the small path he had walked countless times before, the first thing he saw was the white flowers he had left on the bench that morning.

The snow-white bouquet, which no one had touched, still lay where it had been. The wrapping paper, soaked through by the rain and then half-dried, was flecked all over with blood; some of it had splashed onto the petals, dotting them like someone trying to transfer their life to the flowers.

From high up on the hillside, a muffled cry reached him from the distance — the sound of someone fighting. Fighting?

Chase snapped back to his senses, stepped over the motionless bodies of the bodyguards and the strangers on the ground, and sprinted up the path; in that moment he even forgot he might be a target himself, and shouted at the top of his voice: "Uncle Key, where are you!"

"It's Chase!" someone cried out from the distance. "Over here! Quick — Mr. Key is in danger!"

A House Faction Hunter?

In what felt like only a few breaths, Chase had already charged to the top of the hill and into the cemetery.

There was a question he had been too focused on rushing to the rescue to notice until now; it wasn't until he burst into the cemetery that he suddenly realized something was missing from this attack — something that should not have been missing. Sound.

To be more precise: gunshots.

Since driving into the cemetery, apart from the shots he himself had fired, he had never heard a single gunshot coming from the hillside.

This was clearly a life-or-death confrontation — so why had not a single shot been fired?

The answer to that question was now hovering, dense and countless, in midair, nearly blotting out the sky and earth.

Several motionless bodies lay in silence beneath the vault of the sky.

"Get down!"

Roland Key's deep, resonant voice barked out from ahead without warning — Chase had barely begun to feel a surge of relief, and had not yet even looked to see where Uncle Key was,

when a bullet gleaming with a metallic sheen moved to occupy the center of his vision.

On the hillside, with Damian's grave at the center, an untold number of bullets hung suspended between heaven and earth.

Viewed from a distance, they looked like a flock of small birds caught mid-flight — frozen in the air at the moment they broke formation and scattered in all directions.

It was only when Chase came crashing into the cemetery that they seemed to activate; several bullets tore through the air with a sharp, piercing shriek and drove straight for his face.

Writing this far following a style where I switch perspective one protagonist at a time — they say necessity is the mother of invention (though that phrase doesn't quite fit here) — I'm thinking of trying something new going forward... I'll need to take advantage of this weekend tomorrow to rest and think it through properly. If it works out, great; if not, I might be facing another round of "I don't understand what's going on" criticism...

Chapter 102: Chase Steals a Moment from a Sky Full of Bullets

Looking back on it, Chase thought he had survived that day mainly because of two reasons.

The first was that the bullets hovering in midair had suddenly accelerated—still lethal, but lacking the high pressure of propellant charge, and thus inferior in kinetic energy and velocity to rounds truly fired from a barrel. Had those bullets been fired from a handgun at less than ten meters, not one Chase but three couldn't have dodged the fate of being shot through.

The second reason was Uncle Key's warning.

Before Chase had even made out the situation on the hillside, Uncle Key had already spotted him.

If Uncle Key had shouted even half a second later, the bullets—however slow—would have been enough to bore into his forehead.

The instant his brain converted the words "get down" into action felt endless, as though it could hold his entire life within it; the full weight of thirty years, compressed to the distance of a single hair's breadth as a bullet grazed his cheek.

The next second he crashed hard to the ground, his shoulder driving into the recoil of the impact, and shreds of grass, flecks of mud, and specks of dirt erupted into the air around him.

Those bullets blazed past just above Chase, as if dissolving into the leaden sky, and not another sound came from them.

...What was going on?

He had no time to look back. He had barely braced himself off the ground and started to lift his body when he heard someone shout ahead of him—"Roland Key is here, bullets!"

Chase understood the implication of those words immediately and leapt to his feet.

Scattered across the hilltop lawn—now a scene of carnage strewn with bodies—several cars sat at crooked angles, apparently driven up by Key House Faction Hunters during the rescue, all of them now with their tires shot through, unable to move.

He couldn't make out who had spoken, because the person was positioned behind a car some ten or more meters away, only reaching a hand out into the air to wave and calling out, "Over

here!"

By the voice, it was the same person who had told him to hurry up the slope.

The few bullets floating in midair swooped down at once like raptors that had caught the scent of blood and heard the call—circling halfway around the car before plunging toward the spot where the person had raised their hand.

"Un—"

He hadn't even gotten the word "cle" out before Roland Key's shout cut over him, still those same two life-saving words: "Get down!"

Obedying his command was almost instinct by now.

As Chase felt his body lunge forward, he heard that familiar sound of air being torn apart once again from behind his head—and in that instant, he suddenly understood.

Those few bullets that had grazed past his face earlier would not behave like ordinary rounds, unable to check their momentum and destined to strike something else and meet a bullet's end. When they missed, they simply floated back to a stop in midair—and only when Chase jumped back up did they wheel around and come surging at the back of his head again.

...Was someone controlling the bullets?

The moment that thought surfaced in his mind, the dull thud of a close-quarters struggle came from behind that car, accompanied by a low groan of pain, as though someone had been struck—and then a body hit the ground hard.

Chase clenched his jaw, every muscle in his body trembling, and barely managed to hold himself down without leaping up again.

Even with the best of luck, dodging bullets three times in one day was beyond all reason—he couldn't afford to be reckless and assume he'd survive a fourth. Sure enough, just as he had predicted, the bullets that had flown over his head found no target and came to a halt in the air one after another.

They could clearly have swooped down and riddled him where he lay on the ground, yet they stopped...

In other words, was his instinctive hunch from just now truly correct?

The bullets themselves were ordinary rounds, unable to track targets by sound or body heat; otherwise they wouldn't have spared whoever was crouching behind a car or lying flat on the ground. Only when a target was exposed within the controller's line of sight—or when someone called out the target's position—did the bullets come streaking in.

No wonder Uncle Key had told him to get down—the controller wasn't anywhere on this stretch of cemetery, and due to the angle of the terrain, could only see people who were standing?

Uncle Key...

Chase shot a quick glance toward the distant car, pushed down his anxiety, and forced his emotions out of the picture. He propped himself on both forearms and crawled forward a few paces until he could finally see the ground beneath that car.

The body that had fallen behind the car was wrapped in a bright yellow rain jacket.

...Not Uncle Key. Today was Damian's memorial—that was absolutely not Uncle Key.

Blood began flowing again through his veins; whatever had been pressing hard against his chest suddenly released.

He hadn't been hit. After all, Roland Key had been one of Blackmoor City's foremost Hunters in his prime.

But before Chase could even exhale, at least twenty or thirty bullets in the air began to move—in a single breath, they were already raining down on the open ground behind that car like a flock of birds diving beak-first to strike prey; the lower half of the yellow-rain-jacketed body still exposed beneath the car was caught in the onslaught, battered and shuddering under the bullet-storm.

Was Uncle Key still in the same spot?

The very moment Chase nearly lunged to his feet and charged forward, a low voice called to him from far away just in time: "Don't go over there!"

He turned his head and only then noticed that not far ahead, a Key House Faction Hunter had been hiding there all along—the Key couple who had come in the rain to pay their respects to Damian had set up a large shelter umbrella on the lawn, and the Hunter named Michael was hunched behind a chair under the umbrella's shade, still gripping a blood-streaked knife.

"The moment you stand up, those bullets will find you," Michael said in a hurried whisper. "After putting down one yellow rain jacket, Mr. Key knows better than to stay put—he's probably not been hit. Don't charge over there and throw your life away!"

Chase kept his eyes fixed on the space behind that car.

After the volley of bullets, there was silence from behind the car; he couldn't see Uncle Key, and he couldn't call out to him.

"I got here late," he said, his voice hoarse. "What happened here? How many of us are left?"

Michael seemed to notice the gun in his hand and said, "The gun won't work anymore—there's an Artifact effect blanketing this whole area. Every bullet we fired has been intercepted and taken control of. Instead of killing anyone, they've become weapons the enemy is using to trap and kill us. We didn't see it coming at first, got blindsided, and lost a lot of people all at once."

Chase looked up—he was lying flat and his field of vision was limited, but even so he could dimly make out several bodies lying in the distance; some in yellow rain jackets, some not.

"The Artifact effect doesn't discriminate—if the yellow rain jackets fire a gun here, their bullets get intercepted all the same. But since this is their home turf, it doesn't matter to them; there are more than enough bullets already floating in the air.

"They're sweeping the area searching for us. The moment they spot someone, they signal the bullets overhead to come down... Those of us still alive have scattered and are hiding in different spots. I'd guess the others are doing the same as me—trying to quietly take out the yellow rain jackets when they get close. If you can't take them out and they call your position, the bullets all come down at once... I have no idea how many Key House people are left, but casualties on both sides must be heavy."

...In other words, if Uncle Key hadn't called out to warn him just now, he wouldn't have exposed his position or been put in danger.

He glanced again at the car where Uncle Key had been. He had to get over there—he needed to see with his own eyes that Uncle Key was unharmed and get him out—but how?

Before Chase could come up with a plan, another figure in a bright yellow rain jacket appeared in the distance—though Michael had said every bullet fired from a barrel would be suspended in the air, that person still carried a Desert Eagle and was walking step by step toward the car where Uncle Key had been hiding.

In that instant, Chase realized what he intended to do.

Not only did Chase want to know whether Uncle Key was still alive—so did whoever was orchestrating the attack from behind the scenes.

There weren't many places to hide on the cemetery grounds; most of it was open space. Even if Uncle Key had narrowly escaped that volley of bullets earlier, he could only dart back and forth among those few cars and couldn't get far—as long as someone was sent over, finding Uncle Key's position wouldn't be difficult.

Having learned from the first yellow rain jacket being killed at close range, the second one wouldn't make the mistake of closing in recklessly—and besides, there was no need to get close.

When the yellow rain jacket spotted where Roland Key was hiding, all he had to do was fire one simple shot—the moment that bullet was intercepted and suspended in midair, it would serve as the perfect signpost pointing the way. At that point, the many bullets already floating overhead would surely pour down on Uncle Key before he could even rise and flee.

When the image of "Uncle Key being shot" flashed through his mind, it was like a needle—it nearly drove Chase to leap to his feet. He bit down hard on his lip and forced himself to stay still.

It wasn't that he feared risking his life; throwing this life away was nothing. But there was only one chance to save Uncle Key—the moment the yellow rain jacket found him.

"Michael," he said, eyes fixed on the yellow rain jacket, but issuing the order to the Hunter under the umbrella: "Get out of there—go hide somewhere else."

"...Huh?"

Whether Michael understood, Chase didn't know.

Because in the very next second, just as the yellow rain jacket was about to step between the two cars, he stopped dead, having clearly spotted a target. He had an earpiece on; he spoke quickly into it while hurriedly stepping back a few paces, then raised the gun in his hand toward the space ahead of him.

Chase was always quick, but in that moment he erupted with a speed even he had never anticipated.

The instant he sprang from the ground and hurled himself toward the shelter umbrella happened so fast it was like a frame of film a director had decided to cut—simply snipped out of

time—and when Chase grabbed the umbrella's pole and wrenched it straight up out of the ground, a gunshot boomed in the distance at almost the exact same moment, nearly splitting the gray sky apart.

Now all he could do was trust that Michael had been right—that the bullet fired by the yellow rain jacket would be intercepted all the same.

At the moment of the gunshot, the controller's attention had to be fixed on the yellow rain jacket; and it was precisely in that brief instant of distraction that Chase had the opening to act.

The massive shelter umbrella—heavy and long—became a blur in his hands.

Accompanied by a clanging, clattering series of impacts, Chase sent a good number of the bullets floating nearby spinning away or sweeping up into the umbrella; midway through his sprint, he swung both arms with his full body's strength and flung the umbrella far toward where the yellow rain jacket stood.

The moment it left his hands, Chase was already close; he launched himself upward, landing flat on the car's hood, rolling in a single motion, and dropping down on the other side.

The instant he crouched down, he heard a rapid series of impacts on the car's other side—he knew those were the bullets that had been chasing him, unable to stop in time, all slamming into the car. If he had rolled over just a fraction slower, his back would have taken them.

By any logic, no matter how fast he ran, he couldn't outrun bullets hovering in midair.

But Chase had used that brief moment of the controller's distraction to knock away and sweep up a wide swath of nearby bullets with the umbrella; the controller had to round the bullets back up and accelerate them in pursuit again—and that was what gave him his slim opening.

The moment his feet hit the ground, Chase didn't waste even a blink—he lunged straight at the yellow rain jacket, who had just barely stumbled out of the path of the flying umbrella. Before the man could even push himself up off the ground, Chase's hands were already clamped around his throat, pinning him hard to the earth.

It was at that very moment that the walkie-talkie tucked at Chase's lower back crackled to life.

It was hard to fathom that less than ten minutes had passed since London Moon's attack — and now Mercury's mercenaries had finally arrived at the cemetery.

Before picking up the walkie-talkie, Chase yanked the yellow raincoat's earpiece away first; through it, he heard a man's voice asking urgently: "...Report in — where do I shoot?"

He let out a low, breathless laugh.

...The mastermind's window of attack against the Key House Faction had come to an end.

My schedule is slowly shifting back to the old routine... I'm hoping it'll stick this time and stop changing on me — I'm going to find a hammer and nail and pin this schedule down for good. Tomorrow I've got something new up my sleeve (nervous anticipation)

Chapter 103: Brushing Past Brianna

Rain is a nuisance—drizzling on and on without rest, like swaths of long white grass swaying through a dim and dreary world.

Her long hair hung loose down her back, the ends soaked through, heavy on her head; across her black coat, a layer of silvery-white fuzz seemed to bloom.

"...Are you still waiting outside for me?" Brianna asked quietly.

"Yes," London Moon said. Her voice was like a small, weightless wisp of feeling—warm and nostalgic—trapped inside Brianna's earpiece.

"When you saw me today, did you think I was still like before?" she asked, deliberately.

London Moon was silent for a few seconds before she said, "...People change."

Brianna laughed softly.

Just like always, she was forever trying to find a balance between "truth" and "comfort."

"Why did you come out?" London Moon seemed to want to change the subject. Her voice came through the earpiece: "It's still not safe. The cleanup crew Key House Faction brought in just pulled out—there could still be people nearby."

She always steered conversations back to business—call it "business," for lack of a better word—perhaps because business was all they had left to talk about now.

Brianna raised her hand and lightly pressed the corner of her eye, trying to push her overactive tear ducts back into submission.

Seeing that her fingertip had come away slightly wet, she touched her lashes with another finger; she checked—no mascara on the pad of her finger.

"You... hey, are you crying? It was just one failed attempt. You weren't caught, so there's still a chance—don't be sad."

London Moon sounded a little at a loss: "I just think it would be better if you stayed hidden a while longer. It's not only the cleanup crew I'm worried about—I'm also afraid Chase Monroe might circle back. From what I know of him, he won't be content to walk away empty-handed..."

"Why do you even care about me?"

She knew she shouldn't say it, yet she couldn't stop herself—the words came with a masochistic sting and a faint, sickening thrill. "If I died, you'd be able to breathe easier, wouldn't you? If Chase and his mercenaries had found me just now, you could've washed your hands of this whole ugly mess."

Brianna had always known that the attack she had arranged against the Roland Key couple had a time limit.

Chase wouldn't be held at the central police department forever; once he arrived and called in reinforcements to search the graveyard, it would only be a matter of time—she didn't know Chase well, but she knew he was no fool. The moment he showed up, he would realize the person controlling the bullets had been somewhere on the hillside near the cemetery and would naturally order a search.

The bullets could only cover the section of the graveyard where Roland Key was; so when Chase's people stopped going to that section and began searching the surrounding area, Brianna's ambush had no choice but to end—and she herself had no choice but to go into hiding.

And so she hid within the cemetery for several hours, waiting for Key House Faction's people to give up the search, waiting for the cleanup crew to clear the scene... By the time she finally emerged, the world was again thick with drizzle, and dusk was drawing near.

"Don't say that—of course I don't want anything to happen to you." London Moon said softly. "I understand that you're suffering more than anyone... That's exactly why I want to help you."

Brianna took a deep breath and said, "...Sorry."

Both of them fell silent at the same moment for a few seconds.

"Be careful," London Moon said gently. "The Roland Key couple have both been taken to the hospital. Chase may very well go back to lie in wait."

"Haven't they already swept this cemetery several times over?" Brianna said, a little lazily. She opened her umbrella to shelter herself from the drizzle, but didn't move to walk away just yet. "All my people are dead, and they found nothing in the cemetery—why would he come back?"

Brianna knew that if she couldn't kill Roland Key before Chase launched the search, today's attack would count as a failure. But she had long prepared for failure as well—and as things stood now, every precaution she had arranged in advance had come into play perfectly.

Take, for instance, the question of method: there were many ways to stage an assassination, so why go to the trouble of using an Artifact to control the bullets?

On the surface, this approach had two advantages: first, it could seal off the area, preventing Roland Key from slipping away in the chaos; second, a small portion of the bullets could be concealed among branches, leaves, and undergrowth to deliver unexpected, hidden kills—in fact, the moment Key House Faction believed they could finally withdraw to safety was also the moment they took the most casualties, because no one had thought to guard against the leaves, gravestones, and grass.

But beyond those two points, there was a third; Brianna had never put it into words, and London Moon had never thought to ask.

...She naturally could not allow the killers she had hired to fall into Key House Faction's hands.

Since the ambush on Roland Key had failed today, there was no reason for those killers to walk off the hillside alive; Brianna had dressed them in yellow raincoats both to tell friend from foe during the attack, and to make it easy to eliminate them afterward.

Every person she had hired—everyone who had seen her face—died on that hillside.

No matter how furious and restless Chase might be, no matter how unwilling to give up, in the end he still hadn't gotten so much as a single thread of information about the person behind it all.

Chase was only ever reacting to events, after all. She was the event itself.

"Don't let his talent for using force to inspire fear fool you—that doesn't mean his mind isn't sharp."

London Moon continued to reason with her: "Back in university, I was fairly close to him—I saw with my own eyes just how meticulous he could be. Since the cemetery is where it all happened, it's also the most likely place to have left traces behind... Never mind him—if it were me, I'd go back for another look too."

"You have a point," Brianna sighed softly, her thoughts drifting to old memories stirred up by London Moon's words. "Once, when I came to visit you at your school, I saw him once, though we barely exchanged a word. He certainly left an impression."

Back then, she and London Moon had only just begun seeing each other, and every happiness and anxiety was still vivid and raw... Looking back now, it felt like a past life—a story that belonged to someone else entirely.

Only then did London Moon remember; she gave a small "oh," as if a light had switched on: "That's right, you did meet him once. But so many years have passed—after just that one encounter, he's probably forgotten long ago."

Brianna glanced back.

London Moon's worry that she might walk straight into Chase's hands was not entirely unfounded. Though she had prepared thoroughly and didn't fear running into Chase, out of caution it would certainly be safer to wait a little longer and leave only after dark had fully settled in...

"...No," Brianna said abruptly. "I don't want to."

"What?"

Brianna had no desire to keep looking at that ornate, apartment-sized vestibule mausoleum. She turned her head away and said quietly, "Nothing. I don't want to go back and hide in there."

London Moon paused before saying, "...Are you afraid?"

Afraid?

Of course not.

"Hiding inside his tomb makes me sick."

As she spoke, Brianna straightened her coat and made sure no grass or dust had clung to her—if she truly did run into Chase on the road, she couldn't let her appearance give her away and make him suspect she had been in the cemetery all along.

"Who does he think he was? His wife built him a vestibule mausoleum this grand, as though he had some great and glorious legacy worth commemorating. He was a greedy, shameless, arrogant, insular rat his entire life. The idea of him sheltering me from wind and rain after his death is nothing short of laughable."

London Moon said nothing; she only listened in silence—her quiet like a form of acceptance and permission.

Brianna had told her everything. London Moon knew her shame and her disgrace, knew how far-fetched this plan of hers was, knew how slim her chances of success were; and she knew too that the person Brianna was right now could hardly be called good or righteous—that to reach her goal, she was willing to use any means necessary, paving her road with human blood.

Yet London Moon still simply listened, quietly and steadily, and stretched out her hand to Brianna whenever she needed it.

The more London Moon accepted and supported her, the more tormented Brianna felt.

"No—what let me hide from Key House Faction's search wasn't this mausoleum either."

Brianna let out a cold laugh and followed the narrow path through the grass toward the exit, saying, "The Key House Faction hunters were thorough—they even broke open the lock and went inside the mausoleum to look. If his wife hadn't kept an empty grave plot for herself, I would have been caught long ago."

The black umbrella spread a shadow above her, concealing her face.

Brianna turned up her coat collar—mid-November, colder still in the rain, so a coat wouldn't draw attention—pulling it up as far as she could to cover her face before she felt at ease.

To leave the vestibule mausoleum, she would have to pass by the hillside where the Roland Key couple had been attacked.

She listened to her own heels clicking against the stone path, stepping forward one by one; even with no one around, Brianna kept her eyes deliberately away from that hillside.

What a pity.

The moment she realized Chase was momentarily unable to leave the police department, and that the Roland Key couple happened to be in this very cemetery—in that instant, every step of how to ambush them had surfaced in her mind with perfect clarity...

She couldn't help but sigh.

Who could have known that such a flawless opportunity would still end in failure.

When she thought about it, if the target of this attack had been any other House Faction, she might have succeeded already; perhaps she shouldn't have gone after Key House Faction, because Key House Faction had Chase—

As though her thoughts had taken shape in reality: when Brianna lifted her eyes, she found a tall figure walking toward her along the path ahead. His dark clothes still carried a trace of dishevelment, his shirt soaked through by rain, clinging faintly to his shoulders and arms.

...London Moon truly had a gift for prophecy. Brianna nearly let out a bitter laugh.

Chase had no umbrella; the rain had turned his skin pale, yet his dark hair was still slicked neatly back; the moment the two of them came face to face on the path, he fixed his gaze on her almost as if he had caught a scent of prey, and did not look away.

No—on second thought, that was only natural.

After all, appearing in such a sensitive and suspicious time and place, he would stop to look twice even at a stray dog—yet even this, being caught face to face with Chase, was something she had prepared for in advance, so there was no need to panic; few people came to this cemetery, but some always did, and she was simply an ordinary visitor paying respects at a grave.

She reminded herself of this quietly, maintaining the same pace and bearing, and walked forward to meet Chase.

Just as they were about to pass each other, Brianna gave Chase a slight nod from beneath her umbrella.

She was shorter than him, and her head was lowered—she couldn't make out his expression.

Had he noticed anything? What did his face look like?

Brianna had no way of knowing, and couldn't lift her head to look; all she could do was keep up the appearance of calm and take the next step.

The moment her heel touched the ground, she was almost afraid Chase would hear her breath catch, that he would turn around and grab her by the arm—

But Chase did not reach out to grab her.

In the corner of her eye, he gave a slight nod in return, said "Ma'am," and walked past Brianna.

This chapter took way too long to write... Speaking of which, in Western cemeteries there is a type of structure called a vestibule mausoleum—it's built above ground like a house or a shrine that you can actually walk into. That's where Brianna was hiding.

The reason I call it "that thing" is because there's no equivalent word for it in Chinese... I could only call it a "tomb" in the text... making it sound like I was writing Tomb Raider...

Chapter 104: Why Chase Was Followed, and the Phone Alert

Chase stopped dead in his tracks.

The tall woman in the black coat, holding a black umbrella, had walked past him at an unhurried pace, her heels clicking against the ground with each step growing fainter—he spun around sharply, his gaze locking onto her retreating figure.

The woman's long hair hung loose down her back, the ends damp and slightly curled; she appeared quite slender, the pair of calves and ankles visible beneath her coat thin and fine-boned.

Chase furrowed his brow, unable to say for certain why he had stopped.

It was as though something subtle had scraped hard at the edge of his awareness the moment the two of them passed each other, hooking him into turning back around... What was going on?

She couldn't possibly be the one who had controlled the bullet...

Had he seen her before?

Or was it simply because she had appeared here, at this particular moment?

Thanksgiving was next Thursday; some people made a habit of visiting the graves of deceased relatives before the holiday, so the cemetery had seen slightly more visitors than usual lately. After sending Uncle Key and Aunt Hai off to the hospital, Chase had spotted three or four ordinary people paying their respects nearby—fortunately, the cemetery grounds were vast, and they were far enough away that none of them had noticed what had happened on this hillside.

If the woman just now was simply one of those grave visitors, there was nothing remarkable about it at all.

Intuition and suspicion are two feelings that can be difficult to tell apart; but Chase had no habit of trying to distinguish between them.

Whoever gave him reason to suspect, he'd let that person be the one to put his mind at ease; he certainly wasn't going to let doubt and hesitation cost him the chance to grab that woman.

The thought process sounds lengthy in the telling, but in reality it took only the span of a single breath—Chase had already broken into a stride, heading straight for the woman with the

umbrella; she was walking at a leisurely pace, which naturally meant she hadn't gone far, and within just a breath or two, the rush of air he stirred hit her square in the back.

The woman was clearly startled by the sound of Chase's footsteps, and as she twisted around in a hurry, the black umbrella sent a ring of glistening raindrops scattering through the air.

Their eyes met, and the color drained from her face in an instant—she moved to shrink back—but at this distance, Chase had yet to meet anyone who could slip out of his reach.

His hand, like some great pale beast, opened wide amid the streaming rain and clamped down on the woman's shoulder; his fingers dug in hard, and he gave a sharp yank, pulling her stumbling toward him, the pain drawing a low, sharp intake of breath from her.

"Collar down,"

Standing beneath the shadow of her umbrella, Chase fixed his eyes on the woman and ordered: "Let me see your face."

...Even he himself felt that the way he'd said that made him sound exactly like the most contemptible kind of criminal.

The woman seemed too frightened to think straight—one hand still half-gripping her coat collar, she could only stare at Chase for a moment, neither speaking nor moving—Chase lost patience, and without caring that she was a woman, he knocked her hand aside with one sweep and pulled open her coat collar, fully revealing the face beneath it.

The moment his gaze landed on her face, Chase was taken aback instead.

Honestly, even before seeing her face, he hadn't known quite why, but he'd had a vague sense—perhaps seven or eight parts certain—that he had seen her before; yet now, looking at her, he found himself genuinely caught off guard.

It was clearly a face he had never seen before.

Chase had a sharp memory for faces—once seen, no matter how much time passed, he could recognize them again.

Sometimes he might not be able to recall the specific features of a person—Damian, for instance, who had been dead for many years—but when that person appeared before him again, he would never mistake it for a first meeting.

And this woman in front of him—he was absolutely seeing her for the first time.

She really was just an ordinary person who had come to visit a grave?

That was a bit awkward...

"Sorry," Chase said reflexively, releasing her collar. "I thought you were—"

Before he could finish, he suddenly heard his phone ring loudly from inside his pocket; the ringtone was abrupt and sharp, cutting off the rest of the sentence he hadn't finished—and wasn't quite sure how to finish.

As if saved by the bell, Chase quickly pulled out his phone and stepped back two paces; the woman seemed badly shaken, and as he looked down at the screen, she shot him a look as though he were a madman, then turned and hurried away.

On the screen was a phone number not saved in his contacts, yet Chase, after a brief moment of surprise, recognized it—because he had already received several calls from this number today.

He glanced up at the retreating figure of the unfamiliar woman, then looked back at the phone screen, and finally, after a fleeting moment of hesitation, chose to answer the call.

"...Sydney Ginn?"

"It's me," the woman's voice on the other end sounded quite surprised. "How did you know? Did you save my number?"

"No." Chase kept his eyes fixed on the direction where the unfamiliar woman had disappeared, and answered.

She wasn't the one who had controlled the bullet, he had never seen her before, and he hadn't spotted her during his search of the cemetery either... so she really was just someone who had happened to come by afterward to visit a grave?

"...Talking to you sometimes makes it really hard to keep a conversation going." Sydney Ginn muttered.

"What do you want?"

"Quite a lot, actually." Sydney Ginn sounded a little reluctant to start, hemming and hawing on the other end of the line for a moment before finally asking with some hesitation: "I have a few questions I want to ask you... The first one is—can you really erase the records from the police system? How would I know you actually did it? What if you're lying to me?"

Chase was already in a foul mood, and this nearly made him laugh out of irritation.

"What do I gain from lying to you?" he shot back. "I could just not erase your record and be done with it—why would I bother lying to you about it?"

"Oh—oh oh, right." Sydney Ginn seemed to remember something, suddenly seeing the logic. "Then the second question is—what's going to happen with the Central Police Department? None of the people the Residents took over actually died, so won't they keep investigating us afterward?"

"That's a long story—Mercury has her own way of handling things."

Chase had no patience for chatting with her right now—even if Sydney Ginn did strike him as somehow special.

"You can call me again in a couple of days to ask about the details. In any case, don't worry about that. Their main target is me, and I'm not even afraid—what are you in a rush about."

"I just have a guilty conscience." Sydney Ginn said this rather candidly. "Wait, don't hang up yet—I still have one more question, the most important one!"

How did she know he was about to hang up?

Chase held back his impatience and asked, "What question?"

"The police were trying to arrest you today—but how did they know where you'd be?"

The moment Sydney Ginn asked this, Chase knew he wouldn't be hanging up anytime soon.

She went on: "Did you tell anyone about your whereabouts, or about where you were meeting me? Were you being followed today?"

"...Neither." Chase said slowly, as though a chill, slow to arrive, was seeping into his awareness.

So many things had gone wrong today, one after another, that he hadn't even begun to think about this until now.

If the police had tried to arrest him at the cemetery, that would have been easy enough to understand—he came every year on the nineteenth of November to go through the same fruitless ritual.

What was strange was that the place where the police had surrounded and moved to arrest him was somewhere he hadn't even known he would be going beforehand—the road he had taken while driving Sydney Ginn home.

"The only person who knew where I'd be was you, because we'd agreed on a meeting place," he said quietly into the phone. "...And the person who got into my car and had me drive down that road—was also you."

"Hold on, are you jumping to a conclusion right now? Because the way you just said that makes me feel—well, not scared exactly, but I don't like it."

Sydney Ginn seemed to realize things were looking bad, and quickly explained: "I have nothing to do with the police! Think about it—if I wanted to set you up, would I let myself get dragged into it too? Would I let them take my fingerprints?"

The tightly coiled muscles throughout Chase's body slowly relaxed.

Whatever else could be said, Sydney Ginn's behavior at the police station had looked every bit like someone facing impending ruin if those fingerprints weren't erased.

"I've been thinking about this ever since I left the police station. Why were the police able to find you so precisely? And you don't seem like someone oblivious enough not to notice being followed."

Sydney Ginn was one of the few people who dared to speak fairly freely in front of him—hard to say where she got the nerve. "So I've been wondering—is it possible that the person who was being followed wasn't you, but me?"

"Are you an idiot?"

"...Talking to you sometimes really makes it hard to keep a conversation going."

Sydney Ginn seemed to swallow something back before saying: "I'm obviously not an idiot, but I'm easy to tail. Because I tend to get distracted by my surroundings, and I'm not used to staying on guard all the time here in Blackmoor City. On top of that, I never would have imagined anyone had reason to follow me—who would ever think to suspect they were being followed out of nowhere?"

"Get to the point," Chase prompted.

Sydney Ginn fell into an unexpected silence for a few seconds, as though what she was about to say was difficult for her.

"No matter how I think about it... if I was being followed at that particular time... there's only one person I can come up with, no matter how I look at it."

Chase waited for her to continue.

"Um... do you know someone named London Moon?" Sydney Ginn said haltingly. "If you don't, please don't jump to any conclusions impulsively—let me think of other possibilities... It's mainly because she was right there when I arranged to meet you. But it might not necessarily be her..."

Chase gripped his phone tightly.

"I know her," he said quietly.

Sydney Ginn went silent for a moment, as if this answer was a great disappointment to her. "R—really?"

"She fired a few shots at me today, too," Chase said. "Come to the address I'm about to send you—tell me in person. I could use the extra hands anyway."

If London Moon was still keeping tabs on Sydney Ginn, then Sydney Ginn coming to the cemetery might very well draw London Moon—or at the very least, her people—back to the cemetery as well.

London Moon probably wouldn't be foolish enough to walk into a trap, but he might as well try. At worst, it would just mean seeing Sydney Ginn again.

"But it's almost dark out..."

"Five thousand dollars."

"Has the address come through yet?" Sydney Ginn's tone shifted immediately.

"Sending it now," Chase said, and hung up.

The call screen disappeared; he lowered his eyes and was about to unlock the screen when he noticed he had received a push notification at some point—it looked like an Amber Alert.

...Wait. Not an Amber Alert.

Though it looked similar at first glance, the first line read—

! NEST MAJOR INFORMATION NOTICE !

I spent a good few hours today going back through the story from beginning to end, and finally figured out what had been bothering me all along, and resolved a major issue I hadn't even

realized was there... This chapter suddenly became so much easier to write, and the pacing picked up too!

Chapter 105: Chase, the Fourth Contestant

...An unknown Nest Domination Game?

Chase stood alone in the dim darkness after nightfall. After a few seconds, he couldn't help but glance at his phone screen again; the blue-white glow lit up his field of vision, yet somehow made everything feel even less real.

So while the hunters under his command had been going in and out of the Nest time and again, risking their lives and bleeding for money, a plan like this had been running deep in the world all along...

The "Key" that Taylor Ford wanted to take from Wellesley—it was because of this, too.

Of the notification he had received, human text made up only half.

The other half was clearly Nest script—like twisted, churning blots of ink, as though deep holes had been punched through row after row of human language; even with his iron will, if he stared a moment too long, it seemed as if vague eyeballs were peering at him from within those depths—he had to look away immediately, take a breath, before he could shake himself free of the hallucination.

Still, even with only half the text in human language, the information he needed was already perfectly clear.

The Unknown Nest Domination Game

Two contestant teams have already joined—you're falling behind, Chase

Contestant Team One: Wellesley Team

Major Setback! Artifacts scattered and lost! Progress rolled back to 2/7, leading advantage drastically reduced

Brianna

Currently collected: black cube (image), word-editing software (image)

Not yet collected:

vintage radio (image)

Key (image)

Time (text)

a tongue (image)

???

*

Contestant Team Two: Taylor Ford Team, joined November 15th, progress 1/7

"Boy genius" lives up to the name! Within just four days, already struck and obtained—

Currently collected: Key (image)

Not yet collected:

vintage radio (image)

black cube (image)

Time (text)

a tongue (image)

word-editing software (image)

???

Now recruiting new competitor — Cuckoo's Child, Chase Monroe

Will you join will you join will you join figured you'd join even if you did

What a way to write a notification... truly a repulsive little message.

Chase felt his tongue lift, press against the inside of his cheek, and slide past.

Setting aside his shock and disgust for now, from this notification alone, the situation was already more or less clear.

Reading between the lines: Wellesley had been the first to learn of the "Nest Domination Game," had kept it tightly under wraps, and had been working in secret to win dominion. But after his violent death, the Artifacts he had collected scattered and were lost—one of them, the Key, had recently fallen into Taylor Ford's hands.

Winning the "Nest Domination Game" apparently required collecting all seven Artifacts—that was the most critical piece of information; the many other questions could all be set aside for now.

...Did this notification count as yet another stroke of good fortune the heavens had handed him?

He had always hoped to bring the Key House Faction to the pinnacle of worldly wealth and power.

For anyone, that was a vast, chaotic goal—one that depended almost entirely on fate—yet now, a road leading straight to that destination had laid itself out before him, so clear and simple it was almost unbelievable.

If you've monopolized the Nest, could you still fear losing your grip on the world?

Of course, he hadn't forgotten that he couldn't enter the Nest.

But so what?

The other competitors chasing Artifacts could stay in the Nest for seven days at most—they would always have to come back to the world in the end.

If the one who ultimately ruled the Nest turned out to be someone who didn't even have a passage... that would truly be delightfully unexpected.

While Chase was lost in thought, his phone buzzed. He looked down and saw a message from Sydney Ginn.

"What's the address? I still haven't gotten it."

Before he could reply, a row of typing indicators appeared on the screen; soon, another message came in. "Are you feeling like five thousand is a bit much?"

...Truly leaving him without words.

Didn't she claim she wasn't short on money? The way she talked, she sounded more like someone who'd been broke so long it had become a habit.

Though one more complication had landed in his hands, even if Chase joined the "Nest Domination Game," it wouldn't change what needed to be done right now—after all, the people who had attacked the Key House Faction might or might not be connected to the "Nest Domination Game."

To find out who was pulling the strings, he still had to keep searching this graveyard for any trace of a clue.

"Come to this address," he sent Sydney Ginn a message. "Stay alert on the way—if anyone's following you, tell me immediately."

He thought about it and felt uneasy, so he did something uncharacteristic and sent a second message: "Will you be able to tell?"

"You really underestimate me," Sydney Ginn replied after a moment. "I'm a solo hunter—no House Faction looking after me—and I've lived just fine till now. I'm in the cab. Forget the fare, let's just call it making a friend."

Someone in Blackmoor City was actually offering a cab fare as the price of friendship with him—it seemed that the longer you lived, the more you'd see.

Chase held himself back, chose to treat that last message as if he hadn't seen it, and put his phone away.

The streetlights came on—like a row of eyes just barely waking, still bleary with sleep. Beyond the hazy glow along the roadside stretched a vast dark expanse, and gravestones looming like black shadows.

Now there was no one stopping Chase from walking up the hillside.

He found a concealed spot and looked down over the path below the slope; from here, he could spot Sydney Ginn from a distance, along with anyone who might be following her—he watched the graveyard, while Damian's gravestone stood quietly behind him, not far off, watching him in return.

Chase never once looked back.

Sydney Ginn arrived much sooner than he had expected.

When Chase saw her again, she was wrapped head to toe in a light, thin, obviously cheap plastic raincoat—the kind sold to tourists on street corners during rainstorms—and walking toward him from down the road, she looked exactly like a large garbage bag peering around in search of someone.

He sighed inwardly.

London Moon had apparently not sent anyone to follow her—perhaps because Moon assumed Sydney Ginn had already served her purpose and stopped paying attention to her; or perhaps because whoever was pulling the strings had burned their fingers and pulled back for now, unwilling to return to this place of trouble.

Not only was there no movement in the graveyard, but the person he had left at the cemetery entrance also reported seeing only a single yellow taxi—and the only person who stepped out of it was Sydney Ginn.

"Don't worry,"

After the two of them met, Sydney Ginn patted the raincoat on her body and said, "I deliberately hailed a cab from far away from home, and I bought this raincoat to cover my face. No one followed me the whole way—I'm sure of it."

Chase glanced at her.

The displeasure she had shown upon learning that London Moon was behind their arrest seemed to have vanished entirely, leaving no trace on her face now.

It was almost the most natural thing in the world for a woman to develop feelings for London Moon—back when he used to go out drinking with Moon, Chase hadn't received so much as a slip of paper, while Moon could rack up a whole stack of phone numbers—but he couldn't tell whether Sydney Ginn was one of them.

"How do you know London Moon?" Chase asked.

"I borrowed money from her once when I was buying something in the Nest. When I paid her back, we met at a hunter bar, and I happened to hear you were asking around about the Vulture... When I contacted you, she was sitting right next to me counting her money."

Sydney Ginn's expression remained as impassive as ever. She let out a long breath and said, "I thought I'd run into a decent person... Should've known—hunters, how many of them are actually worth anything."

"And you?"

"I'm obviously not worth much either," Sydney Ginn said without a hint of shame. "Look at it this way—if she had someone follow me to the graveyard, with you waiting here, that tail would have had no way out alive. A decent person wouldn't help you do something that costs lives just for five thousand dollars, right?"

Chase couldn't help but crack a smile.

She had tracked down Police Chief Ashley on her own—that alone proved she was far from stupid; with plenty of time to think on the way over, she would naturally have worked out why he was willing to pay to bring her here.

"...Funny, I'm not a good person either." Chase said slowly. "I have a proposal—perhaps only someone of the same kind would agree to it."

"What proposal?"

"London Moon doesn't know we've already been in contact, and she has no idea you've found out what she did." Chase said quietly. "I want you to keep in touch with her—whatever excuse you need—and let her believe there's nothing going on between you and me... When the time comes, you'll become a trap I've set for her."

Before Sydney Ginn could answer, he continued: "Don't you want both your freedom and the support of a House Faction? Agree to my terms, and the Key House Faction will become your backup support. No constraints or orders from a House Faction, yet with a House Faction's resources at your disposal—an opportunity like this, I don't think you'll come across a second time."

"Sounds like she really did something that made you furious."

Sydney Ginn tilted her head and thought for a moment, then suddenly smiled and held out a hand toward Chase. "Sure, no problem. Let's do it."

Chase looked at her hand.

Handshakes meant nothing, but he reached out his large hand to meet hers all the same—less like a handshake, more like one hand swallowing the other—and in the warmth and the rain, their fingers and palms pressed and intertwined for a brief moment.

As their hands separated, Chase heard a buzz of phone alerts sound from somewhere on her.

"Hm? Is that an alert?"

Sydney Ginn lifted the raincoat and pulled out a phone, its screen blazing brightly.

She had only just looked down when her wrist was snapped—with a sharp crack—into Chase's tight grip; he hadn't used much force, yet Sydney Ginn hissed in pain and asked, "What are you doing?"

"Let me see too," Chase stepped closer, his shadow falling over her. "...Well?"

Oh thank goodness I finally got it posted before midnight! I didn't get a chance to read everyone's comments on the last chapter—let me go check them out and reply...

Chapter 106: The Second Favor Mai Minghe Extorted

Mai Minghe felt as though she were floating upward from the bottom of a deep, dark river.

Someone was shaking her, one nudge at a time, coaxing her consciousness to drift up toward the light—reluctant as she was, she finally opened her eyes.

"...You actually managed to fall asleep," said a head of long, loose hair, the back of it filling her field of vision.

Mai Minghe stared at it, momentarily dazed.

Her memories from before she'd fallen asleep were a beat slow in returning—and when they did, she couldn't help but suck in a sharp breath, stumbling backward and nearly slamming into the wall. "What are you trying to do?"

She quickly flexed her fingers inside her pants pockets to check: lipstick in the left hand, eyeball in the right—both still there; the eyelashes were still lightly pricking the skin of her palm.

Falling asleep in the middle of a wolf pack—even Mai Minghe was a little surprised at herself; she must have been utterly exhausted.

The binding power of the rules was truly something; once the face pieces were in her hands, the Resident couldn't snatch them back—not even while she slept.

The long-haired woman crouching on the ground with her back to Mai Minghe was silent for a second or two before she finally spoke: "What am I trying to do? You're asking—you're asking me what I'm trying to do? I'm the one who wants to ask what you're trying to do! You won't give my eye back—what exactly do you want, what do you want, what do you want—"

"Easy now, calm down," said Mai Minghe, sitting up from the floor. "I just woke up and I have to hear this—it's a bit much."

The long-haired back of a head considerably stopped.

The two of them—one person, one back of a head—stared at each other for a moment, until the back of the head was the first to concede. "What do you want?"

What do I want? The question caught Mai Minghe off guard.

What can I want?

She'd been dragged into this face-finding game without any say in the matter, had risked her life gathering all the pieces, and in the end could only hope to leave with her life intact—no gains, no losses. But wait—from the way this Resident was talking, did that mean she actually could make demands?

"...You put me through all of this. There ought to be some compensation, right?" she ventured.

The back of the head's silence stretched on for several seconds, which was tremendously encouraging to Mai Minghe.

"On top of compensation, you'd also need to give me something in exchange for your eye, right? Fair is fair—that's only reasonable." Mai Minghe intended to open high, in case the other side tried to lowball her. "They say the eyes are the windows to the soul, don't they—and Helen Keller said, if only I had three days of sight—"

"Will you shut up!" The back of the head suddenly let out a sharp cry. "Are you some old granny? You never stop talking!"

...That one stung a little—well, it was a Resident, after all.

It seemed to take a deep breath—which made sense, now that there was a nose on the other side—before saying: "Fine. I understand. You want something out of this before you'll give my eye back and get out of here. All right."

Mai Minghe hadn't expected it to agree so readily, and was caught off guard.

"Wh—what kind of compensation?" she asked, hesitating.

"The lipstick is yours," the Resident said, with a vague note of pride.

"You've already used this lipstick—who'd want it? Besides, I don't even wear—" Mai Minghe suddenly caught on. "Oh, it's that—it's an Artifact?"

"Of course. Did you not realize? We Residents can't use Artifacts, and have no use for them—so it's completely useless when you humans try to use Artifacts against us. But with certain rare Artifacts, even if we can't use them, we still develop a desire to possess them to varying degrees, and this lipstick is one of them." The back of the head said: "Generally speaking, an Artifact that even Residents want to possess tends to have a longer shelf life after it leaves the Nest—you're getting a good deal."

It was probably trying to make the lipstick sound more valuable; Mai Minghe nodded along as she listened—but then abruptly froze.

"Sh—shelf life?" She stared blankly at the back of the head. "What shelf life?"

Through the thick, dense curtain of long hair, Mai Minghe couldn't read the Resident's expression at all.

It paused for a moment, and when it spoke again, its tone had shifted entirely—as if something like a laugh were caught in its throat; a sharp, lilting voice, like the corners of a mouth curling upward.

"...You didn't know?" it asked slowly, as if leading her to a realization. "Don't tell me...you haven't been a Hunter for very long? How many times have you even been inside the Nest?"

Mai Minghe said nothing.

"Ha. Ha. Ha." The hair trembled with each laugh. "So you truly didn't know. Every Artifact that leaves the Nest and enters the human world has a 'shelf life.' Once that shelf life runs out, the Artifact itself—along with any effects it produces—disappears entirely."

It was the first time Mai Minghe had ever heard this.

She sat on the ground in a daze, lifting her hand several times as if to reach up and touch the Serpent Band on her body, yet found no strength at all flowing through her muscles.

Did the Serpent Band have an expiration, too? Once it ran out, she would revert to eighty-six years old—no, probably older, because her body had continued aging through all the time she'd worn the Serpent Band; it would be eighty-six, plus however much time had passed since then.

If the Serpent Band's shelf life was short...then this vibrant youth she felt right now was nothing more than a fleeting dream before she said goodbye to the world.

She could not accept that.

"I...where can I see the shelf life?"

"For the lipstick, it's on the label on the bottom. Though you won't be able to see it until you're out of the Nest—because Artifacts inside the Nest don't have a countdown."

She certainly knows a lot... That thought reminded Mai Minghe to quickly ask: "Then what about an Artifact that's been taken out and brought back in? Does the countdown pause?"

"It pauses. Once it returns to the human world, the countdown resumes."

At least inside the Nest she didn't have to worry about growing old again—but she remembered Jonah saying that the longest a human could stay in the Nest at one stretch was seven days; beyond seven days, the Nest would break them down and absorb them.

At that, the back of the head let out a sharp, thin little laugh. "So you know nothing at all, yet you managed to squeeze something out of me—truly not someone to be underestimated. That gives me an idea..."

Mai Minghe sensed nothing good in those words, and scrambled to her feet in one motion, hastily stepping back two paces to the side—only to see the back of the head turn slightly, still keeping its back perfectly straight toward her, and say: "Why are you running? I know what the second compensation should be now—it won't cost me anything, and you won't be able to refuse."

"What is it?"

"A few minutes ago, a Hunter who had wandered into a local game failed to clear it." The back of the head's words gave Mai Minghe a start.

"That Hunter should have received their punishment—nothing too severe, really: just lose half their life, so they'll never be able to stand again. However, if you're willing, the contents of that Hunter's punishment could be changed...changed to 'answering every question you ask honestly and completely, and informing you of everything there is to know about the Nest'—in other words, to serve as your guide."

For a moment, Mai Minghe almost suspected it was lying. "You have the authority to make that decision?"

The back of the head paid her no mind and simply said: "If you agree to these terms, set out now and meet that Hunter at the entrance to the Brooklyn District Library. How about it? Do you accept?"

This is a transitional chapter, so it's on the shorter side—but the long-awaited Mai Minghe is back!

Chapter 107: Mai Minghe's Experiences in the Nest?

She hadn't seen the back-of-head call anyone, so how had it gotten in touch with the library and arranged for that Hunter to meet Mai Minghe?

Could it really have that much decision-making authority?

It would be impossible to say she had no doubts; Mai Minghe wasn't naive, and she had wondered whether the back-of-head was simply trying to trick her into returning the eye.

But on second thought, she still reached into her pocket, pulled out the eye, and handed it over: "Fine, it's settled—here you go."

"That easy? No lecture first?"

The Resident was caught off guard, but its arm didn't slow one bit—it snapped up and back in a flash, catching the eye in a reverse grip.

At that moment, a deep, utterly despondent sigh rose from just outside the restroom door, as though someone had pressed their lips to the gap—listless and deflated: "How annoying. It's over—go back, go back. Nothing left to play with."

Judging by the voice, it sounded like the husband.

"Can I leave through the restaurant's front door now?" Mai Minghe asked.

"You can," said the back-of-head. The hand gripping the eye disappeared in front of it for a moment, and when it dropped back down, it was empty. "You're not afraid I'm just deceiving you?"

"If you haven't deceived me, then no one ends up disabled. If you have deceived me, still no one ends up disabled. Given that, why wouldn't I agree? Either way, I can still leave the restaurant."

As she said this, Mai Minghe pulled open the restroom door and found the short corridor outside already completely empty. The diners who had crowded in just moments ago had vanished in a single breath.

She glanced back at the back-of-head.

The next words she spoke—she didn't know if they were meant for it or for herself: "Besides, in one lifetime, how many things are truly worth taking so seriously? Try more things. Even if you

end up doing something foolish, that's not so bad."

Saying something like that to a Resident—chances were it couldn't understand—she shook her head with a small smile and stepped outside.

The back-of-head said nothing, watching her leave the restroom through a thick curtain of dense hair.

The waitstaff and diners inside the restaurant had all disappeared; the glass doors stood wide open, and outside it looked overcast. There was no telling what time it was—the daylight hovering over the sidewalk was a dull, washed-out white, going through the motions.

Just before stepping out, Mai Minghe instinctively glanced back—only to find the back-of-head standing pressed right behind her, silent and still, nearly frightening a scream out of her.

"What are you doing?"

"All the important landmarks nearby are on the signposts—just follow them and you'll find the library. It's not far." Its back still turned to Mai Minghe, it raised one arm, seemingly pointing at an angle toward the direction beyond the restaurant. "Good luck."

Good luck with what?

It had even come after her just to point the way... could Residents be kindhearted? Could they have manners?

The glass doors slammed shut behind Mai Minghe with a bang.

The buildings lining both sides of the sidewalk bent and tilted, watching her through window after window like so many eyes as she walked hesitantly toward the intersection—in the direction the back-of-head had pointed, a pole stood beside the corner.

The pole was hung from top to bottom with layer upon layer of signs, so many that one almost worried it couldn't bear the weight; each sign pointed in a different direction, and some of them were separated by no more than the width of a finger.

Was she supposed to navigate by this thing? Wasn't it a bit imprecise?

From at least fifty or sixty signs, Mai Minghe finally picked out the one that read "Brooklyn District Library"—roughly ten kilometers from where she stood.

Even at a brisk pace, that was a two-hour walk.

Lucky she had slept a while back in the restaurant and gotten some rest... she had no idea how long she'd been asleep, but judging by how her body felt right now, she seemed capable of walking.

She had to hand it to a young person's body, she thought—rest for a little while and it was full of life again.

Following the direction the signpost indicated, Mai Minghe set off on foot, and at first she walked with something almost like a tourist's curiosity, looking all around, finding everything simultaneously familiar and strange.

This was her first time seeing the Nest in daylight.

At first glance, she almost could have convinced herself she was still in Blackmoor City—buildings, roads, subway stations, overpasses, plazas... like great outlines sketched between heaven and earth, giving the Nest an overall silhouette uncannily similar to Blackmoor City's twin.

Sometimes she walked down a street she recognized, and before she even turned the corner she'd think there might be an Asian Market around the bend—and when she turned and looked up, it was the same Asian Market.

But the fact that it hung the same sign did not mean Mai Minghe dared to walk inside.

Blackmoor City's market would have nothing more than meat, vegetables, and fruit; the market window in the Nest had no hanging roast ducks—instead, bundles upon bundles of wet hair dangled from the hooks.

"How disgusting...?"

She truly did find it disgusting, yet people sometimes can't help rubbernecking at a crash scene—Mai Minghe stopped anyway and stared for a while.

Perhaps because it was the "Asian Market," every bundle of wet hair was jet black. Some thick, some thin, each bundle attached to a pale, bluish-white patch of scalp; the hooks were driven straight into the scalp.

The bundles of hair hung side by side, close enough to form a curtain.

Mai Minghe stared at them blankly for several seconds before she suddenly noticed that in the corner, two bundles of hair were being slowly parted by someone—and behind the hair, a face

as round and white as a flat dumpling, like a moon nearing the middle of the month, was gradually becoming full as it turned toward her.

She didn't dare linger another half-second; before the eyes behind the wet hair had fully emerged, she turned and bolted.

"Stop running,"

From the shadows by the roadside, a face suddenly jutted out—like a mushroom pushing up after a rainy day—and flashed past the corner of Mai Minghe's eye. "You're running the wrong way!"

As if she'd fall for that after eighty-six years—

Mai Minghe ignored it completely and kept running down the sidewalk, only to step straight into night.

It wasn't that she'd run so long she'd lost track of time—she had literally plunged headlong into nighttime. Suppressing her shock, she gasped and stepped back, retreating into the dim white daylight; looking ahead, the light was normal, still a cloudy afternoon.

But taking one more cautious step forward, the entire city was suddenly swallowed by night: streetlamps cast pools of amber-orange, and windows and neon signs all blazed to life.

...One step, and just like that it was dark?

Full of astonishment, she tilted her head back and looked up at the night sky.

A cloudy night sky, too thick to let any starlight through; now and then the wind blew past, parting the pitch-black clouds, and a pale, somehow faintly familiar moon was gradually becoming full from between the dark clouds—

Mai Minghe jolted, and understood everything at once.

She cursed under her breath, squeezed her eyes shut, and scrambled backward as fast as she could for several steps, flailing her arms wildly at her sides—"thud"—her hand seemed to crack against glass, and she sucked in a sharp hiss of pain.

When she cracked her eyes open just a sliver, she found herself standing right in front of the Asian Market's shop window, exactly as she'd expected.

The several minutes of frantic running just now—all of it had apparently existed only in her own mind.

At some point, a perfectly round hole the size of a head had appeared in the window glass, just large enough for Mai Minghe to put her head through.

From where she stood now, her head must have already gone in before she pulled back—lined up exactly with that swelling, round-moon face gradually revealing itself from between the black hair.

"You look that revolting, and you still try to lure customers into your shop?"

Mai Minghe was both frightened and furious, and she truly wanted to grab a brick and hurl it through the window—but after thinking it over, she decided it was better not to make trouble. She pressed one hand over her eyes and felt her way back to the road she'd come from, made a wide detour, and finally managed to avoid that Asian Market.

What she didn't know was that the Asian Market was only the beginning.

The walk she had initially expected to take two hours ended up taking four or five, with all manner of accidents, illusions, and traps along the way—Mai Minghe walked all the way into the night before she finally spotted the distant silhouette of the Brooklyn District Library.

The library was a sizable building; its main entrance faced a flight of steps leading onto a plaza. Somehow, a car had veered crookedly into a streetlamp pole and sat there already coated in a thin layer of dust.

When Mai Minghe, dragging her aching, sore feet, made her way step by step toward the library, a figure sitting on the steps leaped up at once—which gave her a start.

"You got here so fast?"

The speaker was a young man; from too far away to make out his face clearly, she could only vaguely tell that he seemed very tense, arms wrapped tightly around himself, as if that might protect him somehow. "Weren't you coming from ten kilometers away? How did you get here in less than half a day?"

What—was he saying ten kilometers should have taken even longer?

Mai Minghe wanted to ask, but she truly had nothing left—not even a young body could be pushed like this—she wobbled down to the foot of the steps and collapsed onto them with a thud, then gave the young man a limp wave.

Even his footsteps as he came down toward her were full of hesitation and uncertainty.

"Um... I thought I was really in for it this time, but it turns out this is what my punishment ended up being." He stopped a few steps above her and paused. "I thought there'd only be one person who needed a guide. Did the two of you enter the Nest together?"

Mai Minghe sat motionless on the steps, her neck rigid, for several long seconds.

Good lord, it's three minutes to midnight—I truly published this right at the edge of life and death... I'd originally wanted to write about the inside of the Nest through Mai Minghe's eyes, but I'd barely gotten through the Asian Market scene and this chapter was already two or three thousand words...

Chapter 108: Mai Minghe's Post-Rationalization

Night seeped through the air; when the wind stirred, a chill rippled out in layers of black.

Two people?

Was there someone else here besides herself and him?

Mai Minghe slowly turned her head and stiffly glanced to her side; there was no one there.

Beneath the night sky, the Nest's silhouette looked like a Blackmoor City warped and twisted by some disaster; the plaza below the steps was wide, dim, and equally empty.

...Then it must be behind her?

She turned around bit by bit, like slowly unrolling a painting, until from the edge of her field of vision, a shoulder, an ear, a head of hair gradually came into view...

Mai Minghe finally saw clearly—a few steps behind her, someone had appeared without her noticing.

It was a young girl with short, disheveled curly hair and a pale face; whether from sweat or tears, her eyeliner had smudged slightly at the corners.

She was staring at Mai Minghe, and as if to stop herself from crying out, she pressed one hand tightly over her mouth—a star tattoo visible on her wrist. The reason Mai Minghe could see it so clearly was that the girl had been edging slowly backward in small increments, and had moved just into the pool of light at the edge of the steps.

Why are you backing away from me? Who should be backing away from whom here?

When it sank in, Mai Minghe was genuinely stunned.

"You... when did you..."

Before she could finish, a rapid sound of footsteps suddenly came from the other direction, and Mai Minghe turned her head at once—the young man had apparently sensed that something was wrong; he bounded up the steps in a few quick strides and stared at the two of them from a distance, asking in a low voice: "Do you two... not know each other?"

"No... no, we don't..."

The young girl slowly rose to her feet, eyes still fixed on Mai Minghe. "I didn't see her at all on my way here... Just now, when you said there were two people, I got a fright. I looked up, and suddenly there she was."

"Wait," said Mai Minghe, forcing herself to her feet from the steps despite her exhaustion, "I don't understand what's going on—when did you appear behind me?"

She looked at the girl, and the first conclusion that came to mind spilled out: "Are you a Resident?"

Without waiting for the girl to answer, Mai Minghe turned to the young man and asked: "Can Residents disguise themselves as humans? You can work as a guide, which means you're an experienced Hunter—you should know this well enough, shouldn't you?"

The young man paused for two seconds, then let out a long, heavy sigh and sank down onto the steps, burying his head in his hands.

"Why does it have to be like this—"

He let out a long, miserable groan: "I just wanted to finish the guiding job and go home! I don't have much time left in the Nest—why does even a guiding job have to be this complicated..."

Mai Minghe glanced over and saw that the curly-haired girl looked just as dumbstruck as she felt—if she were a Resident, her emotional reactions seemed far too normal and vivid for that to be the case.

"Although I'm not sure whether you're human or a Resident,"

the young man lifted his head, looking utterly dejected, and spoke without looking at either of them: "I'll explain anyway—you two can both listen. My punishment is to complete twelve hours of guiding work, so no matter which of you is the actual client, the sooner I start, the sooner it ends."

"She's the Resident," the girl cut in immediately. "I know myself. She's the Resident!"

The young man scrubbed hard at his face, as though he had no desire to be the one making that judgment.

He glanced at his watch before speaking: "All Residents, Artifacts, Rule Domains, and the countless trap zones scattered throughout the Nest... put it this way—everything you see in the

Nest has only one source, and that source is human beings."

Mai Minghe stayed on guard and waited for him to continue.

"When a person dies and dissolves within the Nest, enormous quantities of... 'Nest matter' are born from their body, their interests, their thoughts, their personality, their knowledge and experiences, and even their genetic makeup. Residents are among these. It's not at all rare for a single person's body to produce two or three Residents. It varies from person to person; I've heard of cases where the 'Nest matter' produced after someone's death contained over a dozen Residents."

This young man was genuinely well-suited to being a guide—even when faced with one human and one Resident, he could explain all of this so clearly and methodically.

"So you asked the wrong question. It's not 'can Residents disguise themselves as humans'—it's that some Residents simply are human, or rather, were human in form to begin with. Residents that look completely identical to humans are not few in number inside the Nest, and they're troublesome because they're easily mistaken for Hunters."

He gave a wry smile and said: "To make it even more ambiguous—you two have no way of being sure right now that I'm not a Resident either, do you? So yes, running into this type of Resident is quite unpleasant."

"Then... what do we do?" Mai Minghe glanced sideways at the girl. "You're a Hunter—you should have some way of telling which one of us is the Resident, right?"

"Why are you looking at me? It's you," the girl said, frowning. "Are you planning to just keep playing dumb forever?"

"...Residents are Residents, after all, and their behavior will inevitably differ from humans in some way. Many Residents also have special abilities. Look carefully and there will be plenty of telltale signs. For instance, exactly what you two just described—not seeing it anywhere along the way, and then turning your head to find it right beside you."

The young man said this, then pulled his coat tighter around himself. "But if the Resident is dead set on blending in and passing as human, it will naturally take care to hide those telltale signs... The few methods I know for telling them apart may not be of much use in a situation like this."

I see... so it could stay hidden a little while longer.

"What's the purpose of this Resident infiltrating our group?" the girl asked, keeping her eyes fixed on Mai Minghe.

This girl really had no manners.

"There are many possibilities, but they all come back to the same root."

The young man clicked his tongue, reached toward his trouser pocket, then stopped himself, looking dispirited.

"I forgot... I'm trying to quit smoking. Anyway, a human being is an extremely valuable resource for a Resident. A human who dies at a Resident's hands and is promptly absorbed can bring the Resident all kinds of benefits...

"Let me just go over the most common ones. Keep in mind, a single Resident can't get all of these benefits at once—I'm only saying they're common.

"First, a human body can serve as breeding material for a Resident. Residents have no reproductive ability on their own. That is to say, once a type of Resident is produced, it is unique. If it wants more of its kind and to grow into a community, it must borrow a human body—finding within that person's body and mind something that resonates with its own essence, and using that to reproduce."

So if an old woman died in the Nest and gave birth to a Resident with an intense longing for youth, that Resident would seek out the same desire—"wanting to stay young forever"—in other humans...

Mai Minghe mapped her own situation onto this and understood the point; but of course she said nothing aloud.

"Second, as far as we know, Residents can only be seriously wounded, not killed—at least I've never heard of anyone managing to kill a Resident. But that doesn't mean they live forever. Residents do have a natural lifespan."

The young man's gaze traveled between the two of them a couple of times, then he moved up another two steps, as though he'd rather be inside the library to have this conversation.

"Killing a person lets the Resident absorb some measure of lifespan from them—how much is added is random. From a Resident's perspective, even a random extension of one day is better than nothing, right?"

"Stop moving up," the girl called out, a little uneasily. "I don't know much about the Nest—that's exactly why I need you as a guide. If you leave me alone with it and I get taken out, what then?"

The young man's expression froze for a few seconds before he finally let out another sigh.

"Right... you can't die. I mean, the person who hired me as a guide can't die. If she dies, I can't complete twelve hours of guiding work, and heaven knows what will happen to me."

"What other benefits are there for a Resident from killing a human?" Mai Minghe asked.

The young man glanced at her. "Quite a few. But if we're talking about one of the most coveted goals—a Resident can gain certain special abilities by killing a human."

"What kind of special abilities?"

"Oh, there are plenty." The young man folded his arms and said: "There's a type of Resident called a 'Vulture'—after a person dies it can take on that person's appearance, which is its special ability. I've also heard of one that, when it activates its ability, can make people forget everything that happened in the past ten seconds... apparently it nearly wiped out an entire House Faction Hunter team."

"Either way, the thing to do now is just flush out the Resident, right?"

The girl said, quick and to the point: "Sooner or later you'll have to tell us apart anyway, and you're not going to be comfortable spending twelve hours with a Resident either. How about this—whatever method you use to figure it out, don't say it aloud, just do it, and catch us off guard. Once you've found the Resident, I'll help you take it down—that Resident, you agree too, right?"

"That's about all we can do, but it's easier said than done."

The young man took a breath and stood up. "If a Resident doesn't even know it's become a Resident, it's even harder to find."

Mai Minghe startled. "...It doesn't know it's a Resident? That actually happens?"

"Of course." The young man gave a wry smile and said: "Generally speaking, if the Hunter who dies in the Nest was experienced and knew the Nest well, the Residents produced after their death have a strong sense of self-awareness and won't mistake themselves for humans. But what if the person who died was someone who wandered into the Nest by accident and knew nothing about it at all?"

"That person might not even know what a 'Resident' is. The Resident that emerges from them will, with a certain probability, have no idea it is a Resident at all—it may even regard itself as human all along, rationalizing its own birth in its own mind, weaving a convincing story, such as having been rescued just before death."

Mai Minghe stood motionless in the darkness of the night, yet felt as though something inside her mind was gradually growing bright.

"I've heard that Residents who even believe themselves to be human are completely indistinguishable from humans in appearance and behavior—they can even return to Blackmoor City just as a human would. However, this state cannot be maintained for too long; the instincts of being a Resident will always, slowly, rise to the surface."

...So that's how it is.

Mai Minghe felt as though she understood.

So that's how it is so that's how it is so that's how it is so that's how it is so that's how it is

For a while I couldn't sleep at all; lately I can't seem to wake up... and even at this hour I had to chug several big cups of coffee just to finally finish the update. How am I supposed to sleep tonight aaaaaaa

Hey everyone, this is not a sick note, truly it isn't

Today I ran around outside like a rat in a maze, accomplished absolutely nothing, and came home full of frustration—I wanted to kick down every single one of those offices. What's the point of sitting there taking up space if you won't get anything done? Tear them down and build public restrooms instead!

I sat down when I got home and realized it's already this late...

I'm writing the update right now, but I only have fewer than 200 words so far, and I'm a little worried I won't make it out before midnight, so I'm giving everyone a heads-up in advance.

Taking a day off is out of the question — even if I post at midnight, you can read it when you wake up.

Chapter 109: The Truth of Mai Minghe's First Hundred Chapters Revealed!

"Libraries are an extremely important type of landmark."

The young guide climbed the steps while glancing back at the two behind him from time to time.

Guides usually look back out of fear that group members will stray or fall behind; he looked back out of worry that the two would walk too close to him, and whenever they sped up, he would remind them: "...Step back a little, keep your distance from me."

Mai Minghe turned to look at the girl.

The girl always kept a distance of two or three meters between herself and Mai Minghe, and when Mai Minghe turned around, the girl happened to be staring straight back at her, unblinking, without a trace of expression on her face. The light along the edge of the steps illuminated her chin, her nostrils, and the space below her eyes—she looked, all things considered, like a thoroughbred Resident.

Their eyes met, and only then did the girl suddenly speak: "What time is it?"

How would I know, Mai Minghe thought, I'm not even wearing a watch, what an absolutely stupid girl aaaaaah

"...It isn't just libraries—any place where the crystallized products of vast amounts of human thought and activity have gathered is the most dangerous and deadly, yet as long as you know what you're doing, it is also the most orderly and most rewarding."

The guide had reached the ground in front of the library entrance by the time he finished saying this. He turned to face the two on the steps and gestured: "Alright, keep this distance from me—about four or five meters is fine, don't come too close. We're heading into the library now."

"If the library is so dangerous, why are we going in?" the girl asked.

What a convincing disguise—it sounds just like a real person.

"Because the method for identifying Residents is inside the library," the guide said, and pushed the door open ahead of them.

The library was small, only three stories tall, with a sunken reading area carved out of the center of the first floor.

The same library in Blackmoor City was probably simple and comfortable in style—at least in the memories of Mai Minghe's old woman, it was a mid-twentieth-century modernist building—but this version in the Nest looked more like ruins that had been abandoned for over a decade.

As if the thick, murky darkness and the smell of rotting leaves inside had soaked into their throats, the three fell silent in unison.

Three pairs of feet picked their way through garbage, wooden branches, scraps of paper, and broken bricks, the sound of their footsteps rising and falling, echoing through the dim building.

...When had Mai Minghe died?

Looking back now, the old woman must not have held on while she was in the hospital.

At the very moment her heart gave out and her life hung by a thread, an Artifact happened to walk in—not only saving her life but restoring her youth—how likely was something so dreamlike, so novelistic, to truly happen to a person? One in ten thousand? One in a hundred thousand?

The old woman died unknowingly in the Nest's hospital ward, giving birth to a young-faced Resident who still believed herself to be human—that, clearly, was the far more probable outcome.

...She herself didn't even know she was a Resident, so there was even less chance that other Residents or Hunters would ever find out.

Ahhhh, truly unexpected.

The life belonging to Mai Minghe had, in the end, run its course.

She had made a trip to Blackmoor City, completed a challenge at the restaurant, and thought a new life was beginning—only to find, at the very moment she encountered the guide, that she had recalled a detail she had been deliberately ignoring all along...

Her fierce resistance to losing the Serpent Band had, in truth, stemmed from how desperately she wanted—wanted, wanted, wanted—that Artifact. She craved it even if it was useless; she simply wanted to possess it. The gaunt patient had been the same way.

What normal person would be so fixated on finding someone to rescue Jonah? If Jonah hadn't shouted from behind her the moment she plunged headfirst into that screen—

"Get someone to save me, and the dead one gives you half!"

How had Jonah seen through her? The other Residents clearly hadn't. Maybe it was because his situation had been peculiar at the time—his core was a Resident's, but his outer body was human...

Whereas her outer body was a Resident's, yet she believed her core was human...

When Jonah looked at her, it might have been like looking in a mirror—just the reverse, hahaha.

And that was why she had kept on walking and walking through Blackmoor City!

Walking from the dead of night until noon, all because she wanted to find Morgan House Faction and get them to send as many Hunters as possible into the Nest—the more the better, the more the better, the more the better.

...Oh dear, she needed to calm down—she couldn't completely abandon the identity of "Mai Minghe" just yet.

The moment she heard there was a Hunter to serve as her guide, she agreed without hesitation.

That woman's back of the head—even if it had handed her its Artifact, she wouldn't have wanted it. That woman had a possessive streak for lipstick; she had none. She had gotten the lipstick into her hands and hadn't looked at it once since. Would a Hunter ever not read the instructions for their Artifact?

It assumed she was a human, so it must have thought she would welcome any Artifact with open arms...

But compared to an Artifact, the living, warm guide up ahead—radiating the faint scent of salt—was so much more precious!

He had no idea, did he?

There was no need to figure out who was a Resident and who was human at all, because both she and that girl were Residents, Residents, Residents, Residents.

Mai Minghe turned her head, and in the darkness thick with the smell of rotting leaves and damp mold, she slowly smiled at the girl.

This was the first human she had encountered since awakening, and she would not let that girl get to him first.

So consuming a human came with so many benefits—ah, she truly couldn't help but start imagining: would it be better to gain a special ability, or to extend her lifespan by fifty years?

No, no—before making a move on the guide, she really did need to keep playing the part of a human first and earn the guide's trust; after she and the guide joined forces to drive off that girl, only she and the guide would be left in this library...and at that point, she could do whatever she wanted with him...

"...What time is it?" the girl suddenly asked.

This time she didn't lower her voice; the words drifted out into the darkness, and the guide's silhouette ahead turned to look back.

"Let me check," he said, raising his wrist.

A grown man wearing a glow-in-the-dark watch—and if she wasn't mistaken, the face seemed to have a cartoon character on it; quite a funny sight—it was probably a children's watch he'd prepared for the lightless places inside the Nest.

Residents truly are something else—from four or five meters away I can see the cartoon on that watch face clear as day, like it's right in front of my eyes. I really am something else.

"...*&#, it's already the 19th," he sighed. "Twelve hours of guiding...that's way too long."

What?

Mai Minghe tilted her head. What had he just said? It was muffled; she hadn't caught it.

"Speak up, I didn't hear you," she said, in a perfectly normal tone. "What time did you say it was?"

"Oh, I said it's twelve twenty now."

So much time had already passed...though counting from when she started looking for a face, it really was about time for midnight.

"Do you see those computers in a row up ahead?"

The guide raised his hand, pointing toward the other side of the first-floor hall. "It's a bit dark—let's go take a closer look."

No need at all—Residents' eyesight is simply beyond what humans can match, and perhaps her own eyesight far surpasses that of other Residents and humans too.

In any case, she could see the entire computer area with perfect clarity; on the desk in each small cubicle stood a silent computer screen. At least Mai Minghe's old woman had known what a computer was.

"Once each of you has opened a computer, I'll send you a survey questionnaire."

Still keeping his distance warily from the two, the guide entered one of the cubicles first and said, "The survey contains questions that will help me identify Residents. As long as it isn't a case of 'a Resident who believes itself to be human,' they will generally give themselves away somewhere in the questionnaire."

He bent down and pressed something, and the low hum of a computer starting up rose from his direction.

"Honestly, I never thought this method would actually come in useful one day. After all, generally speaking, what Resident would ever cooperate so obediently with filling out a survey? But now that both of you are being this cooperative...come to think of it, that's actually rather strange."

He stopped short at this.

The guide's expression had gone a little off.

Without turning his head, he only shifted his eyes, quietly studying the two of them from the corner of his gaze—and in the glow of a screen that had just come to life, that moment was captured exactly by Mai Minghe.

Oh dear, she couldn't let him grow wary ahead of time.

"Hmm...surely it can't be that both of them are Residents," he murmured, almost to himself, and couldn't help clearing his throat, his voice a touch strained. "No...it shouldn't be. After all, the Nest's punishment for me was to come to the library entrance and guide a young short-haired female Hunter..."

"Of course they can't both be Residents," Mai Minghe said quickly. "This survey—does it only ask questions? And that's enough to catch a Resident?"

"This thing has a name—it's called the Roundabout Truth Survey. Once you've both opened your computers, I'll walk you through it step by step. You can turn your computers on now."

The short-haired girl walked into a cubicle far on the other side, bent down, and a moment later a low hum of startup noise rose from her direction as well.

Mai Minghe froze, suddenly realizing a problem.

In the experiences and memories of the old woman before she died, there was no knowledge of how to operate a computer...She had seen computers, and she had seen young people using them.

But how was she supposed to turn one on?

Finally finished writing this, oh my god...

Chapter 110: Mai Minghe's First Day as a Resident?

"Really?"

In the dim light, the guide's expression of disbelief was plain to see. "In this day and age, someone who doesn't know how to turn on a computer?"

Mai Minghe truly didn't know what to say, and could only press her lips together and nod.

She had just bent down and fumbled around in the near-total darkness, and had indeed felt a computer tower — a metal chassis, cold to the touch — but had no idea where in the darkness her fingers were supposed to press, and everywhere she touched was the same blackness, impossible to make out.

Nothing to do but tell the truth. She hadn't expected things to go badly right from the start. How irritating, how irritating.

"Do we even still need to do the survey?" The girl let out a cold laugh. "Hasn't the Resident already given herself away? If she were an old woman, fine, but what twenty-something young person doesn't know how to use a computer? So she's definitely a Resident."

"Even if she is a Resident, she grew from a person — she should have whatever knowledge the person had."

The guide spoke as he walked around the computer area, not forgetting to wave at Mai Minghe to step back, then crouched down and pressed something. "A Hunter who died in the Nest was also a person living in a modern metropolis like Blackmoor City — how could they possibly not know how to turn on a computer? There really are all kinds of people in this world."

You can accept that the Nest exists yet find it strange that someone doesn't know how to use a computer — how rude, how ignorant.

Mai Minghe took a deep breath, trying to push down her irritation.

Her eyesight, for whatever reason, kept fluctuating — clear one moment, blurry the next. Mai Minghe squinted and still couldn't make out what the guide had pressed, but in any case, the screen on the desk lit up.

"Begin Your Journey to a New Cognitive Experience"

A line of large text floated over a near-blinding royal-blue wallpaper.

"From here on, you need to be careful — you have to follow the steps I tell you, exactly." The guide's anxiety showed clearly in the blue cast of the screen light on his face. "The Resident is one thing, but if the Hunter among you dies at the computer, I'll be in serious trouble..."

You could die? The computer is that dangerous?

Too bad the guide knows how to avoid the danger — I won't be able to wait around for an easy victory after all...

"Listen carefully. From now on, keep your eyes fixed on the desktop, and try to concentrate. After staring at it for a while, a folder will appear in the upper-left corner..."

Stare at the desktop?

Mai Minghe lowered her head and, following the guide's instructions, fixed her gaze on the dim desktop.

The screen's glow was like many blue-tinged hands, layered and overlapping, reaching out from the screen into the darkness. Above the partitions it had not yet touched, the darkness still swayed and lurched, dragged along by those same hands.

Ever since she had discovered she was a Resident, her field of vision had been different — the darkness kept rippling like water. So this was what a Resident's sight was like: as if her very eyeballs had gone unhinged, and at the edge of her peripheral vision in the swaying darkness, a face was peering out —

That face opened its mouth.

"...What time is it?"

Mai Minghe startled, and realized it was that girl, who had leaned her head over the partition and was speaking to her in a low, breath-like voice.

I'm not wearing a watch — why are you asking me instead of the guide? So annoying, so annoying, so—

Mai Minghe suddenly remembered that computers usually display the time. Young people's computers had everything, and a clock display was the least of it.

The thought only made her more annoyed: if there's a clock on the computer, just look at the computer — why do you keep asking me? This girl is so rude — wait, no, this is actually a good

opportunity.

To make the guide notice her strange behavior.

"Why are you leaning over here?" Mai Minghe turned her head and asked loudly. "Why won't you cooperate with the guide—"

She stopped mid-sentence and froze.

There was no face at the edge of the partition. That girl was standing one partition away, and had only just lifted her eyes from her screen at the sound of Mai Minghe's voice.

"Are you hallucinating?" the girl said irritably. "Or is your Resident nature getting impossible to suppress?"

Well, for a Resident, stretching her neck out long enough to reach across an entire partition wasn't exactly impossible, was it?

"Guide, she really did just put her face right next to mine," Mai Minghe quickly called out to the guide across the way. "Didn't you see it?"

"I didn't — there's a partition between us." The young man looked pained, as if he truly had no desire to be dragged into this. "Are you saying her face stretched over an entire partition to reach your side?"

"It's true!"

"I see," the guide said, unable to hold back a long sigh. "If this is supposed to be an accusation that she's a Resident, it's a bit too naive... let's set that aside for now. If you both want to prove you're not Residents, the only way is to complete the Roundabout Truth Survey."

"Understood. Let's continue then," the girl said.

Look at you, all attentive like a model student — what is that supposed to be? Quite the impression of a human being you're putting on.

I need to find a way to get rid of her before the truth survey ends.

Mai Minghe had no enthusiasm whatsoever for starting the Roundabout Truth Survey, and felt no particular guilt about letting her gaze drift away from the desktop.

What did puzzle her, however, was that the girl kept asking her for the time again and again — shouldn't there be a clock on the computer? Just look at it.

It took her a good ten-odd seconds to find the small time display on the screen.

Thur-Nov-19

00:20

...Hm?

How was it still 12:20?

Well, maybe the computer was running a few minutes slow — you had to adjust a watch's time every now and then, so maybe computers were the same.

The last time they'd asked the guide to confirm the time had been only a few minutes ago, so a discrepancy of a few minutes was perfectly normal.

"Has the folder appeared yet?" the guide asked. "There should have been enough time by now."

Other than the screen, there was only a keyboard and a mouse on the desk — where was any folder supposed to be?

"Not yet," Mai Minghe said, playing along with a show of diligence. "I'll keep staring at the desktop... I haven't dared blink this whole time."

Estimating that about a minute had passed, she snuck another glance at the time on the screen.

00:20

Huh? Had her sense of time changed since awakening as a Resident? Less than a minute had passed since she last looked, so it still showed 00:20?

How strange, how very strange — it really was after midnight, that much was certain, but why had the time stopped moving forward?

Wait a moment.

When they'd left the restaurant, it hadn't been dark yet — it should have been before five o'clock.

And then they'd walked and walked and walked and walked.

Walked for four or five hours.

Hmm? Hmm? Hmm? So it should be past midnight now? Adding it all up — ten o'clock... or eleven at the latest... that would make more sense, wouldn't it?

No, no, no — she had a strong feeling that it was after midnight, she was absolutely certain.

She had seen the clock face with her own eyes, the hands already past twelve — that couldn't be wrong, and counting from when they'd left the restaurant all the way to now, it had to be past midnight.

Huh? But that's strange — adding it up, it clearly wasn't yet midnight. What was going on?

"What's the problem — it appeared, didn't it?"

The guide's voice rang out without warning. Mai Minghe's head snapped up, and she found him a few paces away, glancing at the screen and then back at her — his expression guarded and suspicious. "The folder appeared. Why did you say you couldn't see it? Click on it."

"What?"

Mai Minghe looked over blankly, and only then belatedly noticed that a small blue folder had appeared in the upper-left corner of the blue-lit computer screen — everything was blue, so it really wasn't easy to tell at first glance.

So "folder" meant something that appears on the computer screen?

And the thing she was supposed to stare at wasn't the desk surface, but the computer screen? Really — then why call it the "desktop"? That was easy enough to misunderstand.

It seemed that while she'd been staring at the clock, she had inadvertently stumbled into bringing the folder up.

Mai Minghe had watched young people use computers before and had a rough sense of things — if she moved the mouse, a cursor on the screen would move along with it. She tried moving the mouse over and clicking, and sure enough, a new screen opened.

That's rather impressive. I should get myself a computer someday — and a phone too. Oh, but wait — she could never go back to Blackmoor City. She'd already discovered she was a Resident.

"Good. You'll find several files inside the folder."

The guide was watching Mai Minghe as he took one step back after another, as if worried she might suddenly lunge at him from behind — had he already grown suspicious? That wasn't good.

format conversion document.doooooocx

Blackmoor City Secrets.png

Resident Registration Form.html

Non-Resident to Resident Application.html

Non-Resident Registration Form.html

"First, click on the Resident Registration Form," the guide said, nerves taut. "And be careful — whatever you do, don't accidentally click somewhere else. A Resident might be fine, but if a human clicks the wrong file, there's nothing I can do to save you."

"Why click on the Resident Registration Form?" the girl asked.

"Because we're trying to find out which one of you is the Resident, aren't we?" the guide explained. "If you're a Hunter, there's no way you'll be able to complete the Resident Registration Form. On the other hand, a Resident might be capable of completing the Non-Resident Registration Form — that is, if the Resident believes herself to be human."

The girl said "understood," then pulled back her chair, stood up, walked a couple of steps toward Mai Minghe's side, and looked at her computer screen.

"The form... name."

"What?" Mai Minghe was taken aback.

"The guide's name?" she asked again — though from her expression, it was hard to tell just who she was asking.

But she should have been asking the guide; and sure enough, the guide answered.

"...*%&%."

Mai Minghe nodded.

Reed Hydes — the guide's name was Reed Hydes. What was going on? She'd been calling him "guide, guide" this whole time — was it that as a Resident, her memory kept cutting in and out? That wasn't good. Could she compensate by absorbing a human—

Hm?

...Had she actually heard what the guide said just now?

How did she know the guide's name was Reed Hydes?

The guide's name was Reed Hydes — nothing more to it than that, simply because it was easier to remember once rendered into a Chinese name...

Chapter 111: The First Hour with Reed Hydes as Guide

The secret to happiness in this life comes down to one thing: manage your expectations.

Reed Hydes sat on the steps outside the library door, gazing out at the dark, empty parking lot ahead, and let out a long breath.

He had thought for certain he'd have it in hand this time... had thought he wouldn't need to come back to the Nest again. Yet he never expected that at the very last step, a single overlooked detail would cost him everything.

No one falls from a peak that close to their goal without suffering for it.

He had escaped the fate of being paralyzed from the waist down—that should have been cause for relief...

But looked at from another angle, he had pushed himself so hard for so long, only to barely maintain the same position he'd started from. Wasn't that its own kind of misery?

So there it was—whether a person feels happy comes down entirely to the gap between what they hoped for and what they actually got.

He understood all of this perfectly, yet Reed Hydes couldn't help feeling a sour mix of emotions—disappointment and disorientation in equal measure—as he sat blankly on the steps, waiting for the "short-haired young female Hunter" who needed him as a guide.

Well, fine. At least he'd kept his life and both legs this time. If anything, he had that female Hunter to thank for it.

He had no idea what had happened on her end that let her take his punishment in his place...

He glanced at the luminous watch on his wrist.

It was ten forty-nine. The 19th was almost here.

He didn't know whether ordinary watches came in glow-in-the-dark versions and hadn't bothered to look—he'd just ordered a children's luminous watch off Amazon, and when it arrived he found the face printed with a Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles cartoon. Whatever, as long as it told the time. Maybe he wouldn't need to come to the Nest much longer anyway.

Reed Hydes was not cut out to be a Hunter. He knew that clearly.

His desire for money and material things had never been that strong—enough to live on, enough to save a little, that was all he needed. No point throwing his life away, going into the Nest again and again just to earn more than he could ever spend if he was dead. Look at this—if his punishment hadn't been swapped out this time, the rest of his life would have been...

"You got here fast."

Reed Hydes jolted and sprang up from the steps. A figure was walking toward him from the far end of the parking lot, features too indistinct to make out at this distance. A little uneasy, he pulled his jacket tighter and called out: "Didn't you start from ten kilometers away? How did you get here in less than half a day?"

Ten kilometers in the outside world was a two-hour walk at a steady pace; but this was the Nest—never mind half a day, there was a very real chance that most people simply wouldn't make it there at all.

Whether his punishment would revert back to paraplegia from the waist down if she died along the way was a question Reed Hydes hadn't dared to let himself think about until just now.

She clearly didn't know much about the Nest, so she must have had good luck to arrive this smoothly.

The figure gradually stepped into the light—she appeared to be Asian, and even from a distance he could make out a head of short, tangled black hair.

She had probably been walking for four or five hours, and the exhaustion had drained her face pale. She dropped onto the steps with a thud, lifted a limp hand in a wave, smiled, and greeted him.

"Well... I thought I was really in for it this time. Didn't expect the punishment to turn out to be this."

Reed Hydes hesitated and walked down toward her, stopping a few steps above. "You're the one who needs a guide?"

"That's right," she caught her breath and looked back at him with a smile. "Did you wait long?"

"Oh, not really,"

Reed Hydes found a smile pulled out of him without his noticing—even though his mind had been a tangled mess just moments before. He came down the steps and said, "Maybe an hour. That's nothing in the Nest."

Perhaps it was the clean, uncluttered lines of her face—when she smiled, it felt like an exceptionally pleasant autumn afternoon. She wasn't very old, yet something about the way she looked at you made you feel gently held, the way you might feel with an older relative.

"Is that right?" the woman said, visibly surprised. "An hour and that's nothing? What time is it?"

"Ten fifty-four," Reed Hydes said, holding up his wrist so she could see.

"I've been walking all this time," she laughed. "Oh, I know this—Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles."

Seeing that she was clearly exhausted, Reed Hydes asked, and she gave a wry smile: "Haven't slept in two days. Just kept walking and walking. Young man, you all must have somewhere to rest in the Nest, right? You can't go seven days without closing your eyes."

"Young man"—now there was an old-fashioned way of putting it.

"Of course. House Faction Hunters have their own private safe points, and even solo operators like us know of a few public safe houses where you can rest and sleep."

Reed Hydes sat down beside her and said, "By 'safe' I mean no Residents and no interference from the Nest itself. You still have to be cautious around other Hunters. But generally speaking, no one wants to disrupt the order of a public safe house and make themselves everyone's enemy."

"Why don't you sit for a while," he suggested. "Then I can take you to the nearest safe house from here. There are things to keep in mind when you're resting there too."

"You're quite well-suited for a guide, young man," the woman said approvingly. "You explain things very clearly."

"Then let's get started? I have twelve hours of guiding to do—the sooner I start, the sooner the punishment ends. I don't have much time left in the Nest anyway, so the sooner I finish guiding, the sooner I can go home." Reed Hydes smiled and said, "What's your name? I'm Reed Hydes."

As he spoke, he extended a hand.

By rights, you should be doubly careful in the Nest and never casually touch a stranger or an unfamiliar object; but some people simply carry a kind of presence that makes you ease and loosen around them, like... like going back to your grandmother's house as a child.

Besides, they still had twelve hours ahead of them.

"My name is Mai Minghe," the woman smiled and shook his hand.

"Are you new to being a Hunter? Where would you like to start?"

She tilted her head and thought for a moment. "Being a Hunter... I imagine it's pretty interesting?"

"It really is—there's no way to call it dull." Reed Hydes answered honestly. "Whether it's interesting or the stuff of nightmares, though, that depends on the person."

Mai Minghe suddenly threw her head back and laughed, her voice bright and clear; she didn't seem the least bit worried about drawing something out of the night, and she almost seemed to light up the small patch of ground around her.

"Then why don't you start with the Residents?" she said. "I don't know much, but I've already run into quite a few Residents in the Nest... they really are something strange."

Compared to navigating a path through the Nest or escaping a Rule Domain, talking her through what he knew was about the easiest assignment he could have asked for.

"Then let's start from... hmm, from the very beginning. All Residents, Artifacts, Rule Domains, and the trap zones scattered throughout the Nest—let's put it this way: everything you see in the Nest has only one source. And that source is humanity."

Mai Minghe's eyes went wide.

Starting with the Residents that arise from human death, Reed Hydes walked her carefully through everything he knew about Residents; a few things he couldn't recall on his own surfaced one by one when Mai Minghe's questions prompted him.

He hadn't known how much there was to say until he started—and once he did, he realized that just the single topic of "Residents" contained an enormous wealth of information. By the time his throat was going dry, he checked his watch and found that over an hour had passed without his noticing, and they still hadn't moved on from Residents.

Mai Minghe listened with total focus and attentiveness—Reed Hydes almost understood the sense of accomplishment that must come with being a teacher. If there was one complaint, it was that this particular student could be a little long-winded at times.

"Remarkable. Think of how many people must have spent how much time accumulating all this experience," she said admiringly. "Human knowledge really does need to be passed down. Now—is there any way to check whether there's a Resident hiding in your surroundings?"

"A foolproof method? No. Not that I know of, anyway."

Reed Hydes replied: "But there are some things that commonly cause problems—things you should get in the habit of checking first wherever you go. Be thorough about it. It can save your life."

As he spoke, he looked around, with a sensation almost like giving a field lesson, and said: "The library is a very important landmark—hmm, there's too much to cover inside. Let's start with the parking lot."

He had already swept the parking lot when he first arrived, and walking Mai Minghe through it again, he felt steady.

"The most essential items in the Nest are a flashlight and spare batteries. Because you can never afford to take any shadow lightly."

He spoke while pulling out his flashlight, the beam sweeping through the night like pulling back a corner of a curtain—on the concrete floor revealed beneath the darkness, a curled-up figure came into view. "See that? Right there!"

Mai Minghe looked closely and drew a sharp breath. "Oh?"

A baby of about one or two years old was crouched on the ground, head drooping between its legs, eyes shut tight, completely motionless.

Reed Hydes stepped around the baby and said, "Don't worry. This Resident is sleeping. It's harmless right now."

"How do you know?"

"It's snoring."

Wasn't that obvious?

Mai Minghe stared at him, mouth half open, as though she had a hundred questions she couldn't make sense of ready to burst out at once.

"Besides shadows, you also need to be especially careful of anything humanoid, or anything that has a human face printed on it." Reed Hydes said, sweeping his flashlight onto an election poster on a utility pole. "This one... well... humans don't look like that, so it's comparatively less dangerous."

Defend the Nest's independence—take the fight to them!

A more careful approach than before, to eradicate risk at the root and face the issue with greater seriousness

Vote for me

Mai Minghe leaned in for a look and made a face. "Hmm... humans really don't look like that. But... two black dots inside a circle, with a red line for a mouth—how is anyone supposed to tell who the candidate is?"

Reed Hydes shrugged. "What if that's just what the candidate looks like?"

Mai Minghe laughed again.

"What else is there?"

"Quite a bit more, let me think..." Reed Hydes swept his flashlight toward the cars and said, "Oh, right—anything that was clearly brought into the Nest by a person and has a space to hide in, you can't be too careful. What Nest Residents love most are things that carry the scent of people."

The two of them approached a car, and Reed Hydes swept the flashlight over every inch of it inside and out, then walked Mai Minghe through how to search and check for signs of a Resident's presence. When they finally straightened up, Mai Minghe let out a breath and said, "I hadn't thought of that—it really is physical work. We've been talking for a while now. It must be almost midnight, right?"

"Twelve twenty," Reed Hydes glanced at his watch. "It's already the 19th."

Something glinted faintly in his peripheral vision, and it suddenly reminded him there was one more thing that also needed careful attention. "Oh, right—mirrors! Look at these side mirrors —"

Reed Hydes bent down, his gaze falling on the car's side mirror.

Mai Minghe's face was reflected in the side mirror, small and indistinct.

Half a second later, Reed Hydes realized that the reason her face looked blurry was not because of the dim light or simply because she was standing far away.

He stiffened and turned his head.

The car trunk, which he had checked just moments ago and found clear of danger, was now open—gaping wide at the night behind it like a mouth stretched open.

Beside Mai Minghe, a figure had appeared at some point without anyone noticing.

Where a face should have been, there was instead something like an oval screen made of skin, constantly flickering and cycling through all manner of features — one moment a man with a square jaw, the next a chubby woman with a small nose and beady eyes, then an adolescent who hadn't yet grown into their looks, then a young girl with eyeliner.

It seemed entirely indifferent to its own shifting, flickering face, and raised one hand, which held a white cloth.

As though Mai Minghe's face were a glass window, the white cloth in its hand began wiping in slow circles, and with each wipe, Mai Minghe's face blurred a little more.

"Let's start over from the moment you first arrived at the library," the flickering-face said softly, and before it had finished speaking, its face suddenly locked into place.

Reed Hydes saw herself.

Why is my schedule and update time drifting later again... another chapter like Brianna's showed up, and now I've developed a taste for it lol.

Didn't fall asleep until five yesterday, nearly dozed off all day today, and tomorrow night (wait, should I say tonight now?) I still have to go watch my friend's kids for a bit...

Planning to take them to the arcade — my philosophy is whatever makes kids happiest, that's the way to go.

Chapter 112: Reed Hydes's Lucid Dream

.....What was going on right now?

Should he run?

The Resident had spindly limbs, its clothes far too short for its long arms and legs; its head was completely bare, a wig perched crookedly on top, as if worn purely for show.

After it had swapped onto Reed Hydes's face, it seemed to have little interest in him personally, and continued wiping at Mai Minghe's features one stroke at a time, not sparing him a single glance.

If he ran now, he could probably get away.

But... what about Mai Minghe?

Her features were fading away with each wipe—like marker lines that were stubborn but could still be erased completely—gradually thinning and disappearing.

Just moments ago she had been a person with bright, open features and a gentle smile; now, when he looked up again, all that remained on her face was a blank expanse of skin with faint contours—countless pores seemed to have taken over the function of her nostrils, pulling the skin in a faint, rhythmic rise and fall, as though breathing.

At this point, was there any saving her? She looked more like a Resident than the Resident itself.

Even if he drove this Resident off, how was he supposed to restore her face—

"Ah, there we go."

The Resident suddenly stopped its hand and said in a thin, delicate voice: "Mm, now I'll begin adding back the appearance from eighty-six minutes ago."

What?

Reed Hydes figured he wasn't in immediate danger, so he quickly glanced down at his watch. The time was... still 12:20—less than a minute had passed since the Resident appeared.

Eighty-six minutes ago... would be 10:54—the exact moment Mai Minghe had just arrived at the library entrance and asked him for the time.

Thinking back, that Resident had indeed said something earlier—"Let's start over from the moment you first arrived at the library."

"Start over"—did it mean in terms of appearance? What difference could there possibly be between how someone looked eighty-six minutes ago and how they looked now—what was the point of starting over?

He had no idea whatsoever; he had never even heard of this kind of Resident before.

Reed Hydes felt as though he had turned into a statue with no feet carved out—unable to rush forward to help, yet unwilling to turn and flee; for the moment, he could only stand rooted to the spot, watching the Resident wearing his own face reach out toward Mai Minghe's face once more.

Each of its movements was swift—in no more than a single breath, Mai Minghe's features had been restored—and sure enough, she looked no different from before.

No. That wasn't right.

There was a difference, though it wasn't a change in her features themselves...

At this moment, a faint sheen of sweat glistened on Mai Minghe's forehead. Her complexion was pale, her eyelids half-lowered, her breath coming in shallow gasps—as though she were utterly exhausted all over again. The hour the two of them had spent sitting on the steps chatting and resting seemed to have been completely wiped from her face.

.....It really was the face from eighty-six minutes ago! So that's what it meant!

Ill-timed as it was, Reed Hydes found himself feeling a flicker of admiration.

These Residents kept inventing new ways to harm people—thinking about it, it must be quite a lot of work. His ex-girlfriend had complimented him on this: he was a considerate person.

Mai Minghe, her face now etched with exhaustion, seemed unable to see the two "Reed Hydesees" beside her, and walked straight toward the library entrance, her feet dragging heavily with each step.

"Wait, what's going on here?"

Reed Hydes worked up his courage, and when the Resident turned to follow her, he called out: "What are you going to do to her?"

That face—the one he had seen in the mirror for twenty-seven years—turned from its shoulder toward him, a pair of dark, hollow eyes fixing on Reed Hydes.

"You're not the target, so get lost," it said flatly. "I'm only eliminating future contestants today. Count yourself lucky."

Future contestants? What was it talking about?

The mind, thoughts, and logic of a Resident were like a shattered kaleidoscope—packed with shards of every color and shape, twisted together—and were often beyond human comprehension. What it chose to call a Hunter probably didn't matter anyway.

Reed Hydes looked toward the exit at the far end of the parking lot.

.....If what it said was true, this was a perfect opportunity to escape.

He didn't yet know what consequences came from serving as a guide for less than twelve hours; but if Mai Minghe died at a Resident's hands, the consequences and the responsibility surely wouldn't fall on him, would they?

Besides, he had already gotten well clear of the Rule Domain where he'd failed—could that group of Residents really drop out of the sky and cut off his legs?

He looked back again and saw Mai Minghe drop onto the nearby steps with a thud, wave her hand at the Resident wearing his face standing above her on the steps, and greet it.

.....That was a scene that had played out more than an hour ago.

Wait—could it be that by restoring a person's outward appearance to what it had been at some point in the past, everything that person saw and thought was sent back to that same moment in time?

No wonder the Resident said "start over"... but what was the point of repeating history once more?

By the time Reed Hydes snapped back to himself, he realized he was already walking toward Mai Minghe; the other "Reed Hydes" on the steps immediately raised its head toward him.

"Don't mind me, I won't get in your way," Reed Hydes raised both hands and said to it: "I just want to watch what you're doing—broaden my horizons a bit. Next time I'll know what to expect."

The Resident stared at him with its dark, hollow eyes; after a second or two, it turned its head away.

It clearly did not want Reed Hydes watching from the side—that face was his own, and he knew it better than anyone; even the faintest flicker of irritation and sullen displeasure was something he could recognize.

But as much as it disliked it, it still held back and didn't move against Reed Hydes—perhaps because Mai Minghe had already begun her "re-enactment of history," leaving it no time to spare.

That guess wasn't unfounded, because the moment the Resident turned its head away, it immediately spoke to Mai Minghe: "……Did you two come together?"

What "two people"? Reed Hydes was a little confused.

As soon as the words were out, the Resident took two steps to the side—there were at least five or six steps between them, yet in the blink of an eye, it was standing behind Mai Minghe.

Through several rapid, flickering shifts, by the time Mai Minghe turned her head around, her gaze landed squarely on the face of a young girl with eyeliner.

A few seconds passed, and in the dead silence beneath the night sky, two eyes slowly curved downward on that young girl's face, and the two corners of the mouth curved sharply upward—as if skin had been sliced open with a knife, cutting three deep, arching lines.

……What was that? What was it so pleased about?

To his surprise, neither the Resident nor Mai Minghe uttered another word after that.

The wind had died away under the night sky at some point; the air hung dead and sticky, and every movement of hand or foot met a faint resistance, as though pushing through jelly.

Mai Minghe held her half-turned posture, staring directly at the Resident, her gaze unfocused, completely still.

Meanwhile, the other Resident was busy: its face shifted between Reed Hydes and the eyeliner girl at varying intervals, and for no discernible reason.

Reed Hydes tentatively edged a few steps closer toward the two of them, careful not to draw the Resident's attention.

……Mai Minghe wasn't entirely motionless.

The light on the steps fell directly on her face: her pupils trembled and flickered, as though she were witnessing something that had seized her complete attention; every now and then, Mai

Minghe seemed to be trying to speak—her lips half-open, barely moving—yet no sound came out at all.

A person who believes they are speaking in a dream might look exactly like this.

It felt as though... Mai Minghe was sinking, wide awake, into a dream.

What was she seeing?

If he called out to her, would she still be able to hear?

Reed Hydes hesitated briefly, then forced out a few loud, deliberate coughs; the sound crashed into the night and rolled far away—but Mai Minghe was like a stone, unmoved.

The Resident let out two thin, soft laughs.

"You can't startle her awake. That's what you were trying to do, wasn't it?" It kept its gaze fixed on Mai Minghe, its face now shifted back to Reed Hydes's. "She has already fallen into the 'lucid dream' I created... everything she sees and hears is content I have carefully constructed for her. Since she was already conscious to begin with, how could she wake up again?"

"You actually call it that?" Reed Hydes was momentarily taken aback. "My instincts really aren't bad at all. Just now I was thinking, the way she looked—"

"Shut up," the Resident snapped back, "Do you want me to drag you into the 'lucid dream' too?"

Reed Hydes dutifully closed his mouth and swallowed the rest of what he'd been about to say.

He closed his mouth not because he was afraid, but because he didn't want to push the Resident into a corner—he had already formed a suspicion in his mind.

It probably couldn't create two "lucid dreams" at once and hold two people under its control, could it?

As he had explained to Mai Minghe before, humans were a precious resource to Residents—something like a great tonic; if it could control two people at once, this Resident would have made its move long ago.

For whatever reason, it had given that slot to Mai Minghe rather than to him—perhaps she truly was some kind of "contestant." In any case, as long as Mai Minghe was still in the dream, he was safe.

Well, his luck today had certainly turned around.

As Reed Hydes pondered this, he sat down on the steps, studying Mai Minghe's state, and asked in a casual tone: "Hey, big brother—are you a big brother? Or a big sister? I'm curious: you've got her under a lucid dream—what's the end goal here?"

The Resident's brow snapped into a hard furrow—it had been fixed on Reed Hydes's face for several minutes now, which was unsettling to look at—and it seemed both displeased and unable to suppress a flicker of smugness; it let out a thin, sharp laugh and said: "I'll tell you, as long as you'll shut up after. She'll follow the script I've written for her, and she'll gradually be assimilated by me very soon."

"Then why are you wearing my face? She can't see or hear the real world—even if you had no head at all, she'd never know. And you keep switching back and forth between two faces..."

Reed Hydes was speaking quickly, and then suddenly slapped his forehead. "Could it be that inside the 'lucid dream,' there needs to be one 'me,' and also another character? You're playing both roles yourself?"

"Shut up shut up shut up shut up kill you kill you kill you but I'll have to wait a bit"

There it was—Nest Residents were always like this; after a few normal sentences they'd lose all sense of punctuation entirely. That fragmented, rapid-fire way of speaking was like a punctured artery spraying blood—listen to enough of it and it felt like getting slapped in the face.

"What do you mean by 'assimilation'?" Reed Hydes watched Mai Minghe's dazed, dreamlike expression and asked: "You mean become like you? She still has a full head of hair and hasn't gone bald yet..."

He had figured that if he could provoke the Resident into anger, it might accidentally slip up and perhaps even lose its grip on the control—but before he had even finished the sentence, Reed Hydes himself was suddenly so startled that he leapt to his feet right off the steps, nearly stumbling and tumbling down.

It was as though an invisible hand had pinched the inner corners of Mai Minghe's eyes and pulled them toward each other—the bridge of her nose vanished, the two inner corners pressed tightly together, separated only by a thin layer of skin, on the verge of merging.

Just as a dreaming person will sometimes murmur in their sleep, Mai Minghe's voice was muffled and faint, yet Reed Hydes still caught it.

"So that's how it is so that's how it is so that's how it is"

Assimilation... could it mean Resident-ification?

Perhaps the most fragile thing in this world is my sleep schedule...

Chapter 113: Reed Hydes and Mai Minghe's Resident-ification Progress Report

On a human face, a millimeter of difference makes all the difference in the world.

The two corners of Mai Minghe's eyes had been pinched inward by less than a centimeter, and it was already difficult to look at.

The skin folded into several layers at the corners, and the exposed eyeballs were still white, white all the way through, not a trace of red veins—as though no matter how much skin you pulled back, beneath it there was only one enormous, perfectly round white sphere.

If Reed Hydes had not quite made up his mind a moment ago, he finally stopped hesitating now.

Mai Minghe had sunk too deep into the dream—the "Resident-ification" had already begun. Even if he felt a pang of sorrow at a fellow's misfortune, what could he do about it?

Was he supposed to turn a Resident back into a human being?

When all was said and done, the two of them were nothing more than strangers who had crossed paths by chance.

What a pity—Mai Minghe seemed like a decent person... not something you came across often among Hunters.

If she were an ordinary person struck down by a serious illness, Reed Hydes would have been willing to donate to her cause; or if she were a lonely old woman, he wouldn't have minded doing volunteer work for her.

But she was a Hunter.

Dying in the Nest was a fate every Hunter ought to have mentally prepared themselves for.

Reed Hydes stood there for a few seconds, took one last look at Mai Minghe, and finally turned around and walked down the steps one by one.

The Resident laughed softly. "Giving up—you finally gave up—are you scared too?"

"...Yeah."

Reed Hydes was not the kind of person to deceive himself; there was no point pretending he wasn't scared.

The other reason he had decided to leave was that the speed at which Mai Minghe had begun Resident-ifying was simply too fast.

How long had the "lucid dream" even been going? And yet her two eyes were already nearly merging together from the transformation.

At this rate, forget about saving her—in three to five minutes, what Reed Hydes would be facing first would be two Residents: one wearing a wig, and the other "Mai Minghe."

He had no idea exactly when the moment of Mai Minghe's complete Resident-ification would arrive, but he knew it could come at any time.

Reed Hydes had no intention of being caught off guard by that moment.

"Bye-bye," the Resident said cheerfully. "You're so good at reading the situation—I'm sure you'll last another two or three days."

...There really was never a kind word from a Resident's mouth.

It was clearly having a conversation with him, yet Mai Minghe couldn't seem to hear a single word of it... well, that was a pointless observation—if she could still perceive the outside world, she wouldn't be getting gradually assimilated by the "lucid dream" in the first place.

As Reed Hydes passed by the car that had crashed into the utility pole, he noticed the trunk lid was still open.

He craned his neck for a look; besides some odds and ends, there was nothing inside.

A thought that suddenly surfaced made him stop involuntarily, and he turned and called out loudly: "Hey, can I ask one last question?"

"Shut up keep it down will you noisy or what no sense of public decency public decency public decency none at all"

He had heard more absurd things from Residents before; Reed Hydes didn't bat an eye.

"I checked the trunk—it was empty. So how did you crawl out of it?"

"Fool! I didn't crawl out of the trunk at all."

...Huh?

Because he had noticed the trunk was open the moment he first saw the Resident, Reed Hydes had always assumed it had come out from there—but right, just because two phenomena occurred side by side didn't necessarily mean one caused the other.

"Don't try to fool me," Reed Hydes said, probing. "I checked everywhere and didn't see you anywhere."

On the distant steps, the Resident suddenly turned its head and looked at him.

Just when he thought the Resident had finally lost its patience and was about to make a move on him, it turned around together with Mai Minghe and walked back up the steps; before turning away, it tossed out a laugh.

"I was standing in the shadows there the whole time," it said. "You and I were face to face, looking each other in the eye—more times than you could count... but as long as I covered up your memory of seeing me with a 'lucid dream' where nothing happened, wouldn't it be the same as never having seen me at all, from your perspective?"

...The "lucid dream" could be used that way?

He had thought the other party had let him go; but had he long since already become a victim of the "lucid dream"?

How strange—why didn't the Resident go all the way when it was trying to harm someone?

Before Mai Minghe arrived, couldn't it have dealt with him first, and then had its hands free to deal with Mai Minghe?

Or was it that... he still hadn't come out of the "lucid dream" even now?

If he kept thinking along those lines, Reed Hydes would soon lose confidence in whether his present self was even real; that kind of mental state was undoubtedly far too dangerous—he hurriedly slapped himself across the face.

It stung quite a bit, but only after the slap landed did he realize that a "lucid dream" wouldn't be unable to patch over even that small a flaw—the slap had been for nothing.

He looked up and saw the Resident leading Mai Minghe forward, walking step by step toward the library. They were too far away for him to tell whether Mai Minghe's face had deteriorated further.

Forget it—there was no shortage of things in this world beyond one's power to change... time to go.

Reed Hydes had just lifted his foot when another question came to him.

The Resident didn't seem to have any reason to lie... if it had been standing in the plaza the whole time, why had the trunk been open?

"...Dear listeners... today is Thursday, November 19, 2026."

When a man's voice floated up suddenly out of the darkness, tangled in the crackling hiss of static, Reed Hydes nearly had his heart stop for a beat—the sound was far too close; he spun around sharply, but beside him there was still nothing but the same abandoned, empty car.

The difference was that the screen inside the car had now lit up with a soft glow.

Nest Radio 173

Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion

This was... the car had picked up a broadcast signal from inside the Nest? There was a broadcast inside the Nest?

Not knowing whether it might be another "Rule Domain" or some trick of the Resident's, Reed Hydes backed away a few steps in wariness and prepared to go around it.

The broadcast signal seemed unstable; it cut out with a crackle for a few seconds, and when it came back on, it rooted his feet to the spot.

"...Today's 'Honorary Resident Introduction' features a subject with truly exceptional abilities. Its 'lucid dream' can cause Hunters to assimilate into any state it designates..."

Reed Hydes had been chosen as a guide precisely because of his experience, yet every single thing that had happened tonight had exceeded the bounds of what he knew.

"Make a sane person live through a scenario of going mad inside a 'lucid dream,' and that person will truly go mad—impressive, isn't it? Make them believe they are a murderer, and they will begin to take pleasure in killing. Of course, for our purposes, none of that is particularly meaningful.

"The 'Dream Playwright' generally makes the affected Hunter believe that they do not exist. From that point on, all of that Hunter's memories, emotions, and body become the 'Dream Playwright's' to claim.

"Tonight, however, it has made a rare and remarkable choice... it intends to assimilate the Hunter directly into a Resident... a Resident that retains everything of its predecessor, rather than one born from a single fragment, will become extraordinarily powerful, far surpassing an ordinary Resident..."

So that Resident was called the "Dream Playwright"?

From the sound of it, once Mai Minghe became a Resident, she would become far more troublesome and terrifying than an ordinary one?

Reed Hydes lifted his head and saw the "Dream Playwright" and Mai Minghe walking up the distant steps together, as though they hadn't heard the broadcast coming from inside the car.

No wonder. If it had heard, it would surely never have allowed the car's broadcast to keep playing, complete and uninterrupted, through to the next segment—

"Next, allow me to introduce our listeners to the 'Dream Playwright's' method of attack in detail."

Reed Hydes had no idea how much longer Mai Minghe could hold on.

He kept his eyes fixed on the two figures who had paused momentarily before entering the library's front door, and listened to the broadcast, silently praying in his heart that the male host would get to the point as quickly as possible.

"The 'lucid dream' requires material," the host said, in a calm and gentle voice. "The voice, expression, manner of speech, behavioral style, and so on of characters in the dream—all of it must first be gathered in large quantities from a source, before that material can be used to reconstruct a convincing character within the dream.

"Beyond that, if the target involves people the subject already knows, or scenes the subject has already experienced, the believability when they are reproduced in the 'lucid dream' will increase geometrically, and the target will find it nearly impossible to break free through their own strength alone.

"After all, if you find yourself on the moon all of a sudden, that's a little strange, something to be wary of—but if you're chatting with your wife in your own bedroom, that's perfectly normal, isn't it?

"For this reason, our 'Dream Playwright's' paired ability is to allow the target to 'start over' by redrawing a person's past appearance..."

Hurry up, Reed Hydes stared at the figures on the steps, urging silently to himself—it should say something about how to break the "lucid dream," right?

He was starting to wonder whether the host would truly give away information about the Resident.

But the broadcast did not disappoint him.

"Waking the target is not impossible. However, the longer the sentence spoken, the harder it is for it to enter the dream; the sentence must be short enough, and repeated many times, for it to penetrate the lucid dream with ease. Think of this characteristic as: short sentences can generate greater 'pressure,' like the tip of a nail."

No wonder he had said so much just now and Mai Minghe hadn't taken in a single word—the sentences were too long?

"What might be good to say? Most likely, something that can make the target notice that something is wrong... you must guide the target toward discovering the difference between the 'lucid dream' and the reality outside it... remember, the 'lucid dream' is constructed from 'the reality the target has already come to know'..."

The static in the broadcast grew louder and louder, and finally, with a soft rush of white noise, silence returned to the car.

The key parts had been said far too briefly—exactly what should he say to wake Mai Minghe?

But compared to groping forward in the dark before, piecing together rules on his own, Reed Hydes had to admit that this was already an extraordinarily valuable set of clues.

He fixed his eyes on Mai Minghe's retreating figure, and suddenly broke into a run, making straight for the library steps; taking two steps at a time, it didn't take him long to catch up to the pair—person and Resident.

The sentence had to be short, and it had to make Mai Minghe notice the gap between the "lucid dream" and reality...

And the material of the "lucid dream" was the hour or so the two of them had shared just now...

The Resident whipped its head toward Reed Hydes, revealing a young girl's face, its expression wary and agitated; but from the neck down, it was still its own body in its own clothes

—no watch.

Reed Hydes looked down at his children's glow-in-the-dark watch.

00:31

It seemed... he thought he knew what to say now.

His mind was made up, but when Reed Hydes looked toward Mai Minghe, there was a moment when he nearly choked and forgot the very question he had meant to ask her—

From deep within Mai Minghe's two eye corners, which had nearly closed the distance between them, several fingertips were probing out from behind the skin of her face, pinching the flesh between her eyes tightly together.

Because an update was pushed back once this week, the rest day got pushed back a day too... going forward I'll keep Saturday as the fixed rest day, so you don't have to keep adjusting to me.

I've been reading Frieren: Beyond Journey's End lately—I'm only about 30% into the first volume, and I'm already so grief-stricken my chest feels tight... it's very moving, but for highly sensitive people the impact is intense; I have to take a long break after reading just a little.

Chapter 114: Reed Hydes Finishes the Form?

...The only reasonable explanation was that, within the "lucid dream," he too had been assimilated into a Resident.

Otherwise, the state he was in right now was truly mortifying; anyone who didn't know better would probably think three Residents had gotten together to study at the library — Reed Hydes leaned his head close to Mai Minghe's ear and opened his mouth.

"What time is it what time is it what time is it what time is it what time is it?"

If that wasn't the way a Resident talked, what was?

Reed Hydes kept his mouth busy the whole time, chanting "what time is it, what time is it" while inwardly laughing bitterly to himself.

Hadn't the car radio said that short sentences were like sharp nails — they needed enough "pressure" to pierce through into a "lucid dream"?

No matter how sharp a nail is, you still have to hammer it repeatedly before it drives into the wall; by the same logic, even the shortest sentence would be useless if said only once, right?

The first time he asked her what time it was, it sank without a trace, as expected; Mai Minghe showed no reaction at all, though it did draw a glance from the Resident.

See — no choice but to try a few more times.

He had no idea what was unfolding in the dream, but Mai Minghe — whose appearance could no longer be called human — and the Resident with its ever-shifting face were walking step by step into the library; he had no choice but to follow behind the two of them, "what time is it"-ing endlessly.

"Shut up, you!"

The Resident finally lost its temper, and with a sudden sweep of its hand, the force from its fingers grazed past Reed Hydes' face.

"You don't seem to be talking at random... don't tell me you know a great deal about lucid dreams? Doesn't matter you won't succeed this is completely useless I must kill you kill you kill you just wait until I free up my hands and you're finished"

"The word 'succeed' really shouldn't be used for doing a good deed,"

Reed Hydes ducked swiftly behind Mai Minghe, dodging the Resident's next swipe; its five fingers curved into claws, and just as they were about to strike Mai Minghe's ear, they jerked to a hard stop.

"Why do you say my approach won't work?" Reed Hydes asked, tucked behind her.

"Fool!" the Resident shrieked with laughter. "Even if she happens to hear your question once or twice, I'll rationalize it away within the lucid dream! All I have to do is smooth over the gap with reality isn't that easy enough there are plenty of ways to handle it and do you really think just because you asked her, what she hears is necessarily your voice?"

Reed Hydes froze.

He had wanted to ask "how do you smooth it over," but the words didn't come out. First, because the odds of the Resident giving him a straight answer were slim; second, because once he thought about it even a little, he figured it out himself.

If Mai Minghe heard "what time is it" in the dream but assumed it was the young girl character casually asking the guide for the time, then she might not pay it any mind at all — especially considering that her self-perception by now had very likely already shifted to that of a Resident.

"You've thought it through rather thoroughly,"

He followed the one person and one Resident into the library lobby, keeping his distance from the Resident and staying ready to duck behind Mai Minghe the moment things turned bad.

"I'd thought that if she heard the 'guide' asking her what time it was inside the lucid dream, she'd definitely find it strange and it would create a crack..."

The Resident paid him no mind, its one face frantically busy — switching to Reed Hydes' face one moment, the young girl's the next.

To it, Reed Hydes figured he must be like a fly that couldn't be swatted — annoying, but not enough to interrupt whatever it needed to do.

Clearly, it was time to change tactics.

"Whoever's face you wear is whoever's voice speaks to her in the 'lucid dream,' right." Reed Hydes thought for a moment and said, "Your name is 'Dream Playwright'... so what exactly is the

script of the 'lucid dream' you've written for her?"

The Resident slowly turned its head toward him. "How do you know... my name?"

By now the two people and one Resident had passed through the center of the library's first-floor lobby and were heading toward a dim corner — and never mind that it was a library inside the Nest; the lobby had a computer area all the same.

"...I guessed," Reed Hydes said, steeling himself.

"Wrong wrong wrong wrong"

Right, here we go again.

"There's no way a human could guess my name someone must have told you someone doesn't want to see a future candidate become a supremely powerful Resident who obeys my every command I understand now that's why you suddenly knew how to break my lucid dream someone is interfering with me"

Without punctuation, it gave the impression of a caterpillar endlessly burrowing deeper and deeper into the ear.

While it spoke, Mai Minghe drifted forward as if sleepwalking and came to a stop beside a computer cubicle.

The light in the lobby was extremely dim, and if you weren't paying close attention, you could almost miss the fingers reaching out from the corners of her eyes, gripping the skin there.

...As though trying to fold her eye sockets into the shape of a bow.

"It doesn't matter. I don't even need to ask how you found out."

The Resident's manner of speaking suddenly returned to normal, and even its tone grew calm. It turned to look at Mai Minghe and switched to Reed Hydes' face again.

"The 'you' in the dream has already told her to open the computer. I'll be freeing up my hands very soon... all I have to do is erase your face and paint over it with what you looked like ten minutes ago, and you'll replay everything for me all over again yourself."

"What makes you think I won't run," Reed Hydes' heart was hammering, but he kept up his bravado. "Before she's fully turned into a Resident, I'll turn around and run — watch me."

"Then it comes down to whether you can tell the exact moment she's about to become a Resident... oh, wait." It turned its head and frowned at Mai Minghe. "Someone doesn't know how to turn on a computer?"

...Reed Hydes honestly wasn't sure, in that moment, which was stranger — that Mai Minghe didn't know how to turn on a computer, or that a Resident found it strange that she didn't.

The Resident ignored him and watched Mai Minghe without moving. After a few seconds, it crouched down and switched the computer on itself — water and electricity ran normally in the Nest, and computers could start up just the same.

This might be an opportunity...

Taking advantage of the Resident's back being turned, Reed Hydes leaned in and whispered a rapid string of "what time is it?"s into Mai Minghe's ear.

Even knowing the "Dream Playwright" would rationalize away every question he asked, he had to keep asking — and ask in doubled, tripled quantities, so that more and more "what time is it?"s could seep into Mai Minghe's ears.

...Lucid dreams are constructed from real-world material, the car radio had said.

In other words, the "Dream Playwright" couldn't conjure things from nothing — it couldn't turn its own imagination into the "lucid dream" its target was trapped inside.

That was also why it had waited for the two of them to talk for over an hour before finally making its move on Mai Minghe — because it needed enough material, specifically material of "Reed Hydes," to fabricate the lucid dream.

That young girl was probably also "material" it had taken from somewhere else, wasn't she?

If his analysis was correct, then inside the lucid dream, every time Mai Minghe checked the time, she would only ever see one time — specifically 00:20, which Reed Hydes had told her once in reality.

He had never told her any other time, so the "lucid dream" had no material for anything after 00:20.

That being the case, Mai Minghe ought to notice something was wrong, right?

Reed Hydes felt his reasoning was sound — he certainly couldn't find any flaws in it himself, and he had long since lost count of how many times he'd repeated the same sentence.

But the problem was that even after talking until his mouth ran dry, the Mai Minghe in front of him looked exactly the same as before — no change at all.

She should have heard him at least three or four times by now, so why hadn't she wavered?

If she was too dense to notice that time had stopped flowing, she'd deserve to die here — and he couldn't be blamed for it.

"Things having come this far,"

the Resident spoke up without warning, startling Reed Hydes. "I almost don't want you to give up anymore."

He stared blankly at the "Dream Playwright" for a moment, then glanced at Mai Minghe. The Resident's face had shifted back to the young girl's.

"Humans who die in the Nest come in all kinds, but every last one of them fears 'failure'... because 'failure' is a wound — it means you aren't good enough. Anyone who claims not to fear failure is someone who needs to comfort themselves with lines like 'failure is the mother of success.'"

It fixed its gaze on Mai Minghe, its smile growing wider and wider.

"For us Residents, the mental bruising that 'failure' inflicts on humans is something as beautiful as a purple-black bruise..."

"Tell me something I don't know," Reed Hydes said. "I've failed in the Nest plenty of times. Same speech, one Resident spits it out, the next one picks it up — a truly recycled, recirculated, reused little monologue."

As long as he could keep the Resident talking, he could buy Mai Minghe a little more time, right?

"Sure, then let me tell you something you don't know." The Resident laughed. "Since waiting around is pointless anyway... hm? Why that expression? Did you think that while I'm talking, the lucid dream just pauses?"

It patted Mai Minghe on the shoulder; she didn't move.

"Deep inside the 'lucid dream,' there is a 'Resident Registration Form' I crafted with great care. Right now, she is following the instructions of the dream's 'guide,' step by step opening the

computer, staring at the desktop, preparing to begin filling out the Resident Registration Form... when the form is complete, she will become a Resident entirely."

The Resident adjusted the crooked wig on its head, and on the face that belonged to Reed Hydes, a tilted smile appeared.

"The script of 'Mai Minghe discovering she was a Resident all along' has been playing out for a while now, and the ending is almost here. No matter how much or how little I say, she won't be waking up anymore."

Reed Hydes stared blankly at it, then glanced at Mai Minghe again.

If she was following the guide's instructions... then he had to make her stop trusting the guide.

"The guide is a Resident!" he shouted as loud as he could. "The guide is a Resident the guide is a Resident — its name is Dream Playwright its name is Dream Playwright —"

Did sentences of five or six characters count as long?

Reed Hydes didn't manage many repetitions before he lost his chance.

The hand the Resident had resting on Mai Minghe's shoulder suddenly shoved her away; Reed Hydes had been so focused on repeating the sentences that his awareness lagged a step behind, and by the time he realized what was happening, he had lost his shield.

The next second, the Resident slapped him across the face —

It might sound strange, but in that instant, his mind, his blood, his breath, his very pores... Reed Hydes almost felt as though his entire existence was about to be knocked clean out of his skin.

When his awareness steadied again, he was lying sprawled on the ground, the world spinning around him.

He slowly raised his head and dimly realized he had to run — right now.

No — if he ran now, it might already be too late.

Starting from where her eyes should have been, as though torn apart, Mai Minghe's face had been severed into two halves — upper and lower: below the brow and above the cheek, a stretch of dark, hollow void was exposed.

Two hands were prying at the edges of the dark gap, widening it further and further.

From within that slowly expanding void, slowly, a head squeezed through.

...He recognized it — the head pushing its way out through Mai Minghe's face was also Mai Minghe.

"Resident-ification is complete," the Dream Playwright announced.

Things have been so hectic lately — it's been a long time since I've written a thank-you chapter, and there are so many things I just can't find the time for. My day seems to have fewer than 24 hours — more like 16 at most. Whoever has been skimming hours off the top, please come forward and turn yourself in.

Chapter 115: Reed Hydes and Schrödinger's Mai Minghe

"First time seeing this, I take it?"

A smile curved across that young girl's face. "A living person, whole and complete, becoming a Resident while retaining everything they originally were... you've never seen it before, have you?"

Reed Hydes lay there on the ground in a daze, knowing full well he should get up and run, yet inexplicably let out a sound of agreement: "Y-yeah... that's right..."

"Never seen it? Then take a good look." The Resident said with a thin smile.

Reed Hydes felt he might be endorsing that suggestion with his life.

What was unfolding before him had never happened even in humanity's deepest nightmares: Mai Minghe was crawling out of Mai Minghe's skull, inch by inch.

Two hands gripped the edges of the face, and the forehead, eyebrows, eyes... slowly rose upward, two overlapping human faces emerging from the dimness.

He was both terrified and unable to look away—as though his own gaze had pinned him in place. Just processing the visual signals his eyes were sending was enough to exhaust his mind completely; he couldn't even think to run.

On top of one head, another head had grown.

The Mai Minghe whose neck had stretched out from within the face slowly opened her eyes.

"How strange," the newly emerged face murmured. "How strange."

"What's strange about it?" the Dream Playwright asked from the side. "Come on out. Father is waiting for you."

"...Father?"

Mai Minghe turned her head to look at the Dream Playwright; the face below didn't turn, so the two faces of Mai Minghe were twisted in opposite directions.

The Resident seemed to have forgotten that its own face still wore the likeness of a young girl.

"Yes, hurry up and crawl out. You've been reborn."

"Reborn..." she said in a dazed murmur. "Right. I've been reborn."

Mai Minghe—was it still Mai Minghe?—looked down at Reed Hydes on the ground again.

"Ah... Reed Hydes,"

she murmured, not a trace of light in those pitch-black eyes, the lips on both faces opening and closing in perfect, synchronized rhythm. "I remember you... how strange."

"What's so—so strange about it?" he heard his own voice ask, trembling.

Resident Mai Minghe lowered her head and peered into the interior of the Mai Minghe shell below. "The inside... and the outside, they're the same, yet a little different."

What was she talking about? Reed Hydes couldn't make sense of it.

Before he could even ask, the Resident grew impatient. "Hurry up and crawl out of that body! What are you dawdling for?"

Mai Minghe paid no attention, her gaze falling on Reed Hydes's watch. "...What time is it?"

Reed Hydes jolted, raised his wrist to look, and stammered: "Tw-twelve thirty-eight."

Mai Minghe's head—atop Mai Minghe's face—tilted to one side.

Beneath the newly emerged face, there seemed to be nothing but an endlessly long, slender neck; no shoulders had appeared yet.

"The outside is the real Nest, isn't it?"

She said it out of nowhere, then lowered her head to look inside the original shell again, the way a person might stretch open their waistband to look at their own legs. "This inside... is a man-made little world... it's twelve twenty..."

If a lucid dream were described as a little world, that could work—but that sort of thing was for Mai Minghe and the Dream Playwright to debate.

His mind had apparently finally recovered from the visual shock, and Reed Hydes's reason came back online.

The sensible thing was to get out of there—what was the point of chatting with a newly made Resident?

"Now that you've been reborn, you don't need to concern yourself with your old world anymore," the Dream Playwright said, apparently holding back its impatience. "You're a Resident now. Hurry up and crawl out."

"I can't. I can't crawl out."

Those words made Reed Hydes, who had been slowly backing away, freeze.

He kept his ears pricked and crept as quietly as he could toward the door. Both Residents seemed uncertain about the situation and neither paid any attention to him as he inched toward escape.

"Oh, could it be that this is simply what your Resident form looks like?" the Dream Playwright seemed to have reached an understanding. "Hmm, 1.7 faces isn't bad—quite striking in its beauty..."

Mai Minghe looked at it with a hollow gaze and said softly, "No."

"What do you mean?"

"I understand now... the reason it's so strange is because I was tricked, isn't it?"

Reed Hydes's footsteps halted.

In the dim hall, he had put several meters between them, and could barely make out the expression on Mai Minghe's face; he only heard her say: "This inner world is man-made... I filled out the Resident Registration Form and only then saw the passage leading out... to emerge as a Resident."

Compared to before, Resident Mai Minghe's thoughts and speech both seemed very loose and scattered.

"Yes,"

the Dream Playwright clearly judged there was no longer any need to keep up the deception, and smiled thinly: "That was a lucid dream I scripted. Did you like it? The ending of the dream's script was that you honestly filled out the Resident Registration Form and finally awakened as a Resident—feels great, doesn't it?"

It tilted its head back, the faces on it cycling through rapidly, like a performer about to complete a grand opera throwing their head back for the final high note.

"Being a Resident is so wonderful so joyful so blissful being a Resident is so wonderful so joyful so blissful no worries no worries no pain no stress just be yourself to your heart's content oh oh oh"

Only when its final shrieking note faded did Reed Hydes realize he had somehow slid to the floor again—even as he desperately pressed his hands over his ears, he still couldn't stop the fragmented notes from piercing through his fingers and drilling into his mind.

...His brain was like a piece of cloth riddled with a thousand holes, swaying and drifting in the dim hall.

"But I was thinking about other things the whole time," Mai Minghe said, still perfectly calm—befitting a Resident. "While filling out the form... I kept wondering, why is it still twelve twenty? Why do I know the guide's name? Why am I missing an hour?"

The expression on the Dream Playwright's face went completely blank.

It tilted its head back to look up at Mai Minghe's elevated face and said, "What?"

The two—no, 2.7—Resident faces regarded each other for a moment before the Dream Playwright said, "So what? You still filled out the form."

"Yes, because generally speaking, it's very hard for a person to realize they've simply and suddenly entered a dream, so they can't discover the truth."

Mai Minghe tilted her head; this time, the face below tilted with it.

"By the time I realized I wasn't actually a Resident, the form was already filled out, and my Resident-ification was set to begin... ah, how ironic, how ironic, how ironic"

Reed Hydes couldn't help but wince.

"The last question on the form was: 'As a Resident, do you still possess the human body you had at the time of death?'" Mai Minghe suddenly grew calm and said.

The Dream Playwright smiled.

"That question was specially designed so that you, as a complete human being, could become a Resident directly! A fully intact human who becomes a Resident will surely be stronger than anyone else."

Mai Minghe raised one long, slender hand to scratch her head—her other hand still rested on the face below.

"When I saw that question, because I had been thinking the whole time, I answered it without much thought: 'Yes.'"

The Dream Playwright seemed to be patiently conversing with its own creation: "So what? I told you—you can only write the true answer. Only a true answer can turn you into a Resident."

"Hmm... I was deceived by your lucid dream into believing that I had died of a heart attack while in the Nest's infirmary."

Mai Minghe murmured: "But here is where the problem lies... at the moment I answered the question, I both possessed and did not possess 'the body at the time of death.' So my answer was both true, and not true."

"What do you mean, both possessed and did not possess?" The Dream Playwright stood in place, its face blank, and asked.

Resident Mai Minghe, since showing her face, smiled softly for the very first time.

"The body I had when my heart attacked was an eighty-six-year-old body. The me who believed she was a Resident was only in her twenties. The same body, sixty years apart, because of an Artifact."

Reed Hydes's eyes went wide.

"So that eighty-six-year-old body... I both have it, and I don't."

She murmured softly, "Is this your first time turning someone into a Resident? The answers you sought were all black or white... but that question couldn't be answered with a yes or a no..."

Resident Mai Minghe raised both hands, looking at them, then looked down at the body below.

"It seems that because of the dual state of my final answer, I've ended up in this strange form... I, it seems, am both a Resident and a human... the states have been superimposed."

The Dream Playwright went silent for a moment.

"Is that so..." it propped its chin in its hand like a person might, and murmured: "Well, as long as you're a Resident, I suppose the rest doesn't matter..."

Could she still return to being human?

But Reed Hydes understood—that was none of his business.

What happened to Mai Minghe was not his to manage; the one thing he should do was get away as soon as possible.

Even if she needed rescuing, that was the responsibility of her House Faction, not his.

He had to go, right now, he had no obligation—

Neither Mai Minghe nor the Dream Playwright noticed Reed Hydes quietly slipping out through the library's front door; or perhaps they noticed, and simply didn't care.

...This Nest run, from start to finish, had been thoroughly miserable.

He burst through the front door and charged down the steps in one go, and was striding past that abandoned car when he suddenly heard someone call out from inside it in a low voice: "... Reed Hydes?"

Every hair on Reed Hydes's body stood on end; he stumbled back two steps before realizing that the car's radio had come back on.

"Our lucky listener today is a Hunter from Blackmoor City—Reed Hydes," the host said quietly from inside the car. "Ah... thank you so much for calling in. So, what are you up to right now?"

Reed Hydes stood frozen, looking at the library, then at the car.

The next moment, he heard his own voice coming from the car's radio—slightly breathless from the shock and the running.

It was truly him, not someone else pretending; because every single thing that voice said was a thought inside Reed Hydes's head.

"In the Brooklyn District Library... a Hunter I only met recently, Mai Minghe—she seemed like a good person, very gentle... but it looks like there's no saving her. I've never encountered Residents like those before... I have no way to fight them. I had no choice but to abandon her and run, just like that time years ago..."

"Oh dear. The twists of fate..."

The host let out a soft sigh. "I hope you don't take the cruelties and mockeries of fate to heart. This time is different, I promise. Look—someone is already on their way to save her... she really is a lucky person."

Reed Hydes didn't catch what the radio said after that—because he had already broken into a run the moment his own voice began to speak.

He still had enough sense to know that no matter how strange the night was, he couldn't go crashing through the Nest like a headless fly—every step had to be carefully tested and checked, and only after finding a safe path could he cautiously set his foot down.

At that pace, Reed Hydes naturally couldn't move fast.

He raised his wrist to check the time and found it was already twelve forty-nine; but when he looked back, the library and the plaza were still visible—he hadn't gotten far at all.

"Excuse me,"

a soft, indistinct voice suddenly rose from the darkness ahead, and Reed Hydes didn't even think to be afraid—he had been frightened so many times tonight that his nerves had gone numb.

"I noticed you seem to have come out of the library. Could you be Reed Hydes?"

A slight figure nearly six feet tall, hood drawn over its head, emerged step by step from the darkness of the road ahead.

Judging by the build and voice, it seemed to be a young man.

"Mai Minghe... is inside that library, isn't he?"

Well then, a title with three names in it — who else could pull that off but me...

Speaking of which, whether it's the apocalypse or Artifacts, I always run into the same problem: not knowing whether to use "he," "she," or "it" to refer to a certain character.

I feel like the characters I write always drift outside the boundaries of pronouns...

Chapter 116 — Dual-POV: A Resident Who Doesn't Bite the Hand That Feeds Is No Resident at All

Mai Minghe lowered her hand and gently touched the face beneath.

Aside from the eyes being sliced clean in half and the orbital bones hollowed into a pair of small concave sockets, the feel of it seemed no different from the newly grown second face.

How strange, she thought.

Where had the "top of the head" above the first face gone?

With great curiosity, Mai Minghe twisted her head a full hundred and eighty degrees and found that the upper half of the skull was hanging off the back of the head like an open box lid — the back of the first head below, of course.

She reached out with her newly grown hand and poked at the top of the skull a few times, finding it quite solid — no need to worry about it falling off when she moved.

The sight of herself fiddling with the back of her own head — if any human were present to witness it, they'd probably think this scene was straight out of a nightmare...

Speaking of humans, that Reed Hydes seemed to have just run off.

After waking from the dream, her memories returned, and so did the lost hour or more; after a moment's thought, she understood that the person who had repeatedly asked "what time is it" in her ear must have been Reed Hydes.

After she had fallen into the lucid dream, it seemed he hadn't given up on saving her — he had done everything he could to make her aware of the gap between the dream and reality... that was about right.

In other words, it was precisely because he kept repeating and repeating and repeating and repeating

that she had let her mind wander while answering the question, had left the answer incomplete, and ended up in a superposition state between Resident and human.

The fact that she'd ended up like this was entirely Reed Hydes's fault.

And she'd let him get away.

Must catch him must catch him must catch him make him pay make him pay make him pay.

She slowly stretched her neck toward the direction of the main entrance and listened for a while.

The face below was still breathing; the newly grown face no longer needed to — so in the dark library hall, there was only a single faint sound of breathing.

...After becoming a Resident, she could hear so many, many things she couldn't hear before.

From outside the library doors, Mai Minghe heard the sound of dust motes rolling across the surfaces of objects; the sound of molecules pushing through the air as a human's scent diffused outward; the sound of human footsteps retreating, the ground trembling faintly in their wake...

And the sound of Reed Hydes talking with someone else.

Crystal clear, like a white moon against a black sky.

I'm truly remarkable — I can hear everything from this far away.

Reed Hydes instead of fleeing was chatting away how very stupid of him but this made things quite convenient for her she used to be a good person so the taste she now preferred was also good people appetite rising appetite rising appetite rising.

"Wait — where are you going?"

She had barely taken a step when the Resident beside her moved ahead by several strides and blocked her path.

This one's face was a total blank, with a crooked wig perched on top of its head — no, it was probably hair that had grown crooked into the shape of a wig?

"Come with me," the Dream Playwright pointed toward the door and said, "Tell Father what abilities you have, and then we need to go kill someone."

Her newly grown second head and second neck had made her at least forty centimeters taller than before. Mai Minghe bent down slightly, looked at it, and asked, "...Why are you Father?"

"It was I who gave you new life."

"...You were in the dream too?"

The Dream Playwright was quiet for a moment before saying, "What you call me doesn't really matter. Just come with me... You're eager to try killing someone too, aren't you? After all,

it's your first kill after becoming a Resident — it's an important one. I can give you the best possible target, not far from here."

"Sure,"

Mai Minghe tilted her head and thought it over, then both mouths smiled at once, and both spoke at once: "Then let's go — you lead the way."

She watched quietly as the Dream Playwright turned around, presenting its back to her.

Reed Hydes's pounding heart had barely begun to settle when he looked the boy up and down.

"You... you're her friend?"

The other party had both hands tucked into the front pocket of his hoodie, his face shadowed beneath the hood, only a pointed chin visible.

But judging by his build and frame, he seemed to be underage — if he was a friend, the age gap with Mai Minghe was far too wide.

A sudden flash of inspiration struck him, and he said, "Ah, could it be that you're her grandson? Did you come to rescue your grandmother?"

The words landed like a dropped brick, with no one to catch them, hitting the ground with a thud and shattering the conversation.

In the dead silence of the night, the boy was quiet for several seconds before he spoke, deeply puzzled: "...What did you say? Grandmother?"

Hm, so it wasn't a grandparent-grandchild relationship after all? And here he thought he'd figured out the truth.

Fair enough — the boy didn't know when Mai Minghe had become young again; it was entirely possible he was a friend she'd made after returning to her youth.

But regardless of who this person was, it was already too late now.

"She's inside the library — but I'd advise you not to go in. Her current state..."

"Is she in danger?" the boy asked.

...That question was truly difficult to answer.

If anything, it was probably the two of them who were in danger right now.

Reed Hydes took a deep breath. For a moment he had no idea where to even begin explaining — if he didn't start from the beginning, it wouldn't make sense; but if he did start from the beginning, who knew when Mai Minghe back there in the library would decide to embrace her Resident nature and come out hunting?

"She was turned into... mm, turned into a superposition state between a Resident and a human by a Resident. It wasn't a case of someone dying and a Resident emerging from the corpse — it's that the whole person became..."

He'd witnessed the entire thing with his own eyes and still barely understood what had happened; if this boy heard it, he'd probably think Reed Hydes had gone mad. "I don't know either... whether there's still any possibility of recovery..."

The hooded boy thought for a moment and asked, "The body — is the body still the same as before?"

Reed Hydes was taken aback. "Ah, the body is still the same body."

"I understand," the hooded boy said quietly. "I'll go save her now. You can leave."

He really was Mai Minghe's friend, wasn't he? And he seemed quite loyal to her too... just slightly unaware of how deep the water ran.

"You really want to go in? The way she is right now, it's too dangerous — you could get yourself killed."

"Yeah, got it," the hooded boy seemed too lazy to explain himself; he had already stepped around him, hands still tucked in his pockets, and said, "Weren't you leaving? Why are you still standing here?"

What a thing to say — truly worthy of a bratty kid going through his rebellious phase; just the words alone were enough to grate.

But once he saw what Mai Minghe looked like, that self-confidence of his would probably evaporate entirely.

"Don't say I didn't warn you!" Reed Hydes called out after him, but the boy didn't look back, only waved a hand dismissively.

He watched as the boy's figure grew smaller and smaller, yet he himself remained rooted to the spot, unmoving.

...He couldn't quite say why.

If he had to find a reason... Reed Hydes found his thoughts drifting involuntarily to the boy's hands.

When he had said "you came too late," the boy's hands had remained perfectly still in his pockets, not moving an inch.

...That was a little strange, wasn't it?

What a person says can be disguised and polished, dressed up in any number of ways; but a person's body language is rarely under the control of a lying will — it tends to become the subconscious's way of leaking the truth.

When someone hears that a person they deeply care about is in danger, why would their body still be so relaxed, so composed?

In other words — were they truly friends?

If they weren't friends... was the boy really going in to save Mai Minghe?

Reed Hydes glanced at the boy's retreating figure — his pace was quite fast; in the span of just a minute or two, he had already crossed into the plaza in front of the library.

Well, even if he had ill intentions, what more harm could come to Mai Minghe in the state she was in? If anything, he was the one who should be worrying about whether that boy could make it out alive.

Oh no — if the boy died too, a new Resident would emerge from his corpse... wouldn't this place turn into a Resident convention?

Once the Resident density got that high, even he wouldn't be able to leave, so right now he absolutely had to immediately—

Before the thought had even finished forming, a tremendous crash split the night, as if the library had taken a direct artillery hit — the front doors burst apart into flying fragments that scattered in all directions, sending a dark shape hurtling high up into the night sky.

The silhouette flew past a streetlamp; the crooked wig on its head caught the light for a single brilliant flash, then vanished as the figure tumbled down somewhere out of sight.

Reed Hydes froze for just an instant — but even an instant was already too long.

The one that had flown out... was that the Dream Playwright?

By the look of things, had it been knocked flying?

As that thought surfaced in his mind, another shadow came charging straight out of the library — a figure with one head rising tall above another.

"Reed Hydes ahhhh Reed Hydes ahhhh get over here get over here let me kill you—"

The shadow moved almost like a cannonball, shooting toward him in a straight line; the long flight of steps and half the plaza might as well have been just a few strides to her — the boy happened to be standing directly in Mai Minghe's path, and only at the last moment did he throw himself sideways, barely escaping the fate of being sent flying by a full-body tackle.

Wait — what had she just said?

Reed Hydes suddenly registered it, and as a cold sweat erupted across his entire body, Mai Minghe's two faces, one above the other, were already clearly visible before him.

Why did she want to kill him?!

He couldn't even manage a shout — he turned and made to run; but the moment his gaze hit the dark, impenetrable road ahead, he slammed on the brakes.

No good — ahead was a complete black box, running in blindly was too dangerous—

In that moment of crisis, Reed Hydes didn't know which nerve fired, but he suddenly dropped low, squatting down flat on the ground.

A wall of shadow tore a gust of wind past the top of his head; Mai Minghe's lunge missed, and she arced through the air in a parabola before landing with a thud on the road ahead of him — then, one after the other, both faces swiveled back toward him.

The potential a person unlocks in a moment of crisis was truly remarkable; if he hadn't ducked in time, he'd have been caught squarely by Resident Mai Minghe.

Even in the thick of it, Reed Hydes still found a moment to marvel at this; knowing he couldn't flee forward anymore, he simply spun around and ran back toward the library plaza.

Mai Minghe flashed a sharp smile and fell into pursuit.

"Hey! Mai Minghe is right here!"

Reed Hydes sprinted with everything he had toward the boy ahead, shouting at the top of his lungs, "Weren't you looking for her? Come find her then!"

For this chapter I wrote a Mai Minghe POV, a Taylor Ford POV (two versions), a Reed Hydes POV... felt like none of them were quite right — writing from any one perspective couldn't capture what I had in my mind, so I finally settled on dual POV.

Once I switched to dual POV, everything immediately clicked! As for whether it reads smoothly for you all... well... que sera sera que sera sera que sera sera.

(The comments section has recently been gradually undergoing Resident-ification — let's all work together to build a wonderful Nest!)

Chapter 117: Reed Hydes Leads Mai Minghe Astray

Watching Reed Hydes lead the Resident Mai Minghe along like someone flying a kite, the boy suddenly sprang up from the ground in a clean, nimble leap—so fluid and precise that Reed Hydes felt a flash of hope.

The next second, the boy turned and bolted.

...Where are you going?!

Weren't you so confident just a moment ago?

Reed Hydes desperately wanted to shout what was on his mind, but running for his life had already consumed every last ounce of his strength, and he still couldn't shake Mai Minghe closing in behind him—he was genuinely afraid that if he opened his mouth, he'd bite his own tongue off first.

Never mind. If he couldn't shout, he'd just run toward the boy.

The boy sprinted across half the plaza, glanced back, and upon seeing that Reed Hydes had been trailing the Resident Mai Minghe after him this whole time, had the nerve to call out in protest: "Why are you chasing me?"

Reed Hydes ran with a heart full of bitterness. What a thing to say—wasn't it you who was looking for her in the first place?

The boy landed on the back of a car with a thud, ran up onto the roof, and shouted down at Reed Hydes from on high: "Don't come over here!"

Reed Hydes was furious enough to spit, and finally seized a moment to shout back: "Then where am I supposed to go?"

"How should I know?"

Even in a moment this dire, the boy still took the time to adjust his hood properly, his face still buried in shadow. "Why did she turn into this?"

Didn't I already tell you? What are you so shocked about—

Just as Reed Hydes was on the verge of spontaneously adopting a Resident's way of thinking, the boy suddenly barked: "Watch out!"

Instinct lit up his mind in an instant; his knees bent, and with practiced ease, he dropped into a crouch on the ground once more.

A move doesn't have to be fancy—it just has to work.

A long shadow swept overhead through the night sky, like a shark slicing through black waves in search of prey, grazing past him and lunging forward to snap at empty air—he felt like a small fish hiding at the bottom of the water, with no idea how much longer he could survive.

The Resident Mai Minghe's feet touched down on the ground ahead, stirring up a faint cloud of dust. She was clearly displeased.

"Are you ever going to stop using that move? So annoying, so annoying, so an—hm?"

Her rapid-fire repetition broke off halfway, interrupted by confusion.

Mai Minghe had noticed the car in front of her.

She straightened up, her neck gradually lengthening, and within a single breath she was face to face with the boy on the car roof—for some reason he had failed to seize the chance to run and was still standing there on the car.

To turn and run now would be too late—it would mean showing his back to her; the boy had no choice but to stand frozen on the car roof, motionless.

"...I've seen you before, not long ago," the Resident Mai Minghe said, tilting her head as she looked at him. "Hmm...let me think, the name is right on the tip of my tongue, what was it again, umm..."

Even if the boy's name were Jesus, Reed Hydes could not afford to stay there a second longer.

With Mai Minghe distracted, this was the perfect moment to flee the plaza—if not now, when?

But the moment Reed Hydes moved, he heard the boy on the car call out with sudden, desperate hope: "Look, he's about to run—aren't you going to chase him?"

The high head didn't budge; the lower head whipped around to face backward in an instant.

...Hunters. Not a decent one among them.

Reed Hydes knew full well that at this rate, he would eventually run out of road against Mai Minghe.

She had just become a Resident and hadn't yet fully adapted to her new Resident body—this was her weakest moment. Of course, "weakest" was only relative to herself.

But if he let her chase him long enough to warm up, things would take a very bad turn.

"Wait, wait—"

He called out to Mai Minghe's first head: "Why are you killing me? I was trying to save you just now—even if you won't repay the favor, you can't turn around and bite the hand that helped you. He's the one here to cause you trouble—go take it up with him!"

At those words, the second, elevated head also snapped around abruptly.

"It's you who made me like this you kept buzzing buzzing buzzing buzzing buzzing buzzing in my ear on and on it's all your fault I got stuck I want to kill you use your blood as lubricant lubricant lubricant lubricant slick slick slick slick crawl out"

There is no reasoning with a Resident; aesthetics, logic, and conscience are all things that no longer exist in a Resident's mind.

In his entire life, Reed Hydes had never been pushed to the point of wanting to cry from sheer frustration—but now, for the first time, he was getting close.

"Hold on!"

Perhaps it wasn't yet his time to die—just as Mai Minghe was about to lunge at him, a shout rang out and stopped her. It did not belong to the boy.

The shout came so unexpectedly that Reed Hydes, the boy, and Mai Minghe—3.7 faces in total—all turned toward the source at once.

It was a human body lying on the ground.

At first glance, the body appeared to have no head, yet it was speaking, its voice muffled: "What's the point of killing him? He's nothing but an ordinary Hunter—there's no satisfaction in it."

Caught between gratitude and bewilderment, Reed Hydes stared blankly for two seconds before recognizing it: the one speaking was the Dream Playwright.

The reason he hadn't recognized it at once was that it had taken Mai Minghe's blow with devastating force; the Dream Playwright was lying flat on the ground, its neck bent all the way back, skull tucked beneath its own back, face pressed against the pavement.

A Resident indeed—folded into that shape and somehow still alive.

"Listen to me," the Dream Playwright said quickly. "Do you see the one on top of the car? Now that would be a satisfying kill! Kill him first, kill him, kill him—he's hollow and fresh and sorrowful and beautiful and full of venom, absolutely delicious."

"That's a bit offensive," the boy objected, then clamped his mouth shut as Mai Minghe turned her head toward him.

Reed Hydes held his breath with all his might and silently stepped back one pace.

"What was it I knew you from..." Mai Minghe stared at the boy and murmured, as if she still hadn't remembered.

Good—she seemed to have forgotten about him for the moment.

Reed Hydes stepped back again.

The Dream Playwright was surprisingly considerate and knew just how to appeal to Mai Minghe's sensibilities.

"You don't need to remember—just kill him. You're so strong right now; killing him would be effortless. Kill him first, and I'll have your father set this ordinary Hunter aside for you to deal with afterward. Isn't that the best of both worlds?"

In the time it took to say a sentence or two, it had already propped itself up on its elbows and crawled forward like an inverted spider, skull still dangling down its back, moving on all fours toward Reed Hydes and cutting off his path.

...If he fought it, wouldn't the Resident Mai Minghe behind him exploit the opening?

Trapped between two Residents, Reed Hydes felt as though his teeth were about to shatter from clenching.

"A Resident made from an entire human being—truly remarkable. Even I'm a little afraid."

The boy on the car was clearly just as tense, yet he still let out a short, breathless laugh. "But I've already met Jonah...and I know where the Artifact is. To get my hands on it, I don't need to fight you at all."

"Jonah?"

Mai Minghe tilted her two heads, one to each side, with a look of puzzlement.

"That's so familiar, I know that name, I know he has some kind of connection to you. I absolutely must figure it out—that's what you think I'd say, right? You think I let him distract me? How naïve. The only one I want to kill is you, only you, only you, oh my most beloved Reed Hydes —"

By the time Reed Hydes realized that Mai Minghe had only been feigning distraction, her newly grown head had already launched itself at his face.

The rushing air swept up his hair; the strands sliced through the darkness beside his ears. That face—which looked no different from an hour ago—swallowed his entire field of vision at terrifying speed.

Only a few steps behind him was the Dream Playwright, slowly straightening up and blocking his escape.

"Wait—"

But the Dream Playwright called out urgently and, rather than closing in for the kill, pivoted away from Reed Hydes and moved to intercept the lunging Mai Minghe. "We can't let Taylor Ford get away! He's already a contestant!"

Contestant? Taylor Ford? That name——

Whatever was going on with that name held no meaning for Reed Hydes anymore, because against the Resident Mai Minghe, the Dream Playwright was like a dog trying to spin a plate—utterly useless as an obstacle.

It seemed she merely swatted carelessly, and the Dream Playwright went flying high into the night sky and the glow of the streetlights once again.

Reed Hydes hadn't even had time to process that information when a tremendous force slammed into him.

The concrete ground seemed to rush up to meet him, as if intent on shattering every bone in his body; Reed Hydes' vision went black, and he lost consciousness for a brief instant.

When he came back to himself and his vision returned, he was lying on the ground.

Mai Minghe's two faces—one above, one below—were both staring at him without blinking; her body loomed over him like an enormous canopy, pressing him beneath her shadow.

...It was over. It looked like today was truly the end.

"I'm going to savor your death slowly," Mai Minghe said, both faces drawing in a long, audible breath at the same time, the sound loud, the tone almost tender. "A human who carries old wounds but still holds onto just a little kindness—that must be rare. I need to take my time with you. Like the way I used to save my packaged pastries when I was little..."

How she intended to consume him—Reed Hydes, amid the shock, the blankness, and the despair, could no longer think.

Perhaps it was some kind of self-protective mechanism, cutting off all perception in advance—even as his body trembled uncontrollably, his emotions had gone numb, and he couldn't squeeze out even a single cry for help.

And even if he could call for help, what then?

Taylor Ford, who was quietly approaching from behind Mai Minghe and casting a long shadow on the ground—would he truly save him?

Taylor Ford didn't so much as glance at him—his gaze was fixed unwaveringly on Mai Minghe's waist and midsection.

How unexpected, that the very last thing he would see before dying would be Mai Minghe's two faces...

That thought had barely surfaced in Reed Hydes' mind when he noticed the lower of Mai Minghe's two faces—its eyes shifting ever so slightly outward.

Before he could even react, a lightning-fast shadow suddenly swept across Mai Minghe's flank.

By the time Reed Hydes registered that it was Mai Minghe's arm swinging out at Taylor Ford, even Taylor Ford's reflexes weren't fast enough to dodge.

He stumbled backward, barely avoiding the peak of the force, yet her hand still struck a heavy blow across his chest; the dull crack of her fist connecting with his jaw sounded so painful it made one's skin crawl—like the night itself had been silenced with a hand over its mouth, and something had snapped.

"Don't think I don't know——"

Before Mai Minghe could finish the sentence, a burst of sharp, cheerful music suddenly blared from a car stereo nearby, making everyone present flinch.

"Attention, now broadcasting an emergency notice from the Nest for Mai Minghe!"

A synthetic electronic doll-voice, sounding extremely excited, announced loudly into the night:

"Following the Wellesley Team and the Taylor Ford Team, the Nest Domination Game now calls upon Mai Minghe—Human/Resident superposition state—to become the game's newest contestant! You possess an unprecedented state! Power that sweeps all before it! As a special courtesy extended to a Resident, you are granted time to consider! If you choose to participate, please respond within 24 hours!"

My sleep schedule, my sleep schedule, my sleep schedule...

This chapter came together fairly smoothly—I originally thought I might post earlier, but ended up pulling another all-nighter...

Chapter 118: Reed Hydes and Taylor Ford's Proposal

Reed Hydes hadn't expected that, the moment the broadcast finished, he would be the only person in the whole scene who had calmed down even slightly.

The broadcast hit everyone like a boulder crashing into their minds, and in a single instant, it stirred up wave upon wave of silent, churning emotion—everyone except Reed Hydes.

Contestants, games, none of that mattered to him.

All he cared about was whether he could use Mai Minghe's distraction to escape from under her.

Resident Mai Minghe seemed to have not expected to be called out by name, and even less expected the content of the broadcast.

This time, she truly forgot to kill anyone; she straightened up, both heads turning toward the car in unison, her confusion so thick it seemed like it could seep out through the hair at the back of her heads.

"...Hm?"

Reed Hydes remained lying on the ground, not daring to get up rashly, and could only scramble backward like a beetle with all four limbs, desperately suppressing the trembling sounds of his breathing.

"Contestant?"

Both of Mai Minghe's heads tilted to one side in unison as she murmured softly to herself, "... Nest Domination Game? Following the Wellesley Team and the Taylor Ford Team... following the Wellesley Team and the Taylor Ford Team..."

The next second, a face suddenly slashed across the night sky, accompanied by a piercing shriek, bearing straight down on the boy: "I remember now Taylor Ford isn't that you isn't that you so you're a contestant too"

Taylor Ford clapped one hand over his cheek, scrambled up from the ground in a single roll, and stumbled back several steps—he snapped out of the daze he'd been in moments before all at once.

He kept his eyes fixed on the face lunging down at him, as if unacquainted with fear, and through the gasping breaths pain wrung from him, he actually laughed and asked, "Never would've thought you'd be invited too... so, are you going to participate?"

Reed Hydes suddenly remembered why the name "Taylor Ford" had sounded familiar to him.

Generally speaking, people willing to enter the Hunter trade tended to have a few screws loose to begin with; anyone who reached the pinnacle of fame among Hunters was probably not a normal person in any conventional sense—in other words, let Taylor Ford deal with Mai Minghe. Wasn't he supposed to be formidable?

At that question, Mai Minghe actually paused to think for a few seconds.

Reed Hydes seized the moment and picked up his pace, scrabbling outward on all fours with a rustling scrape.

"Of course I'm participating,"

She suddenly burst into loud laughter, both faces tilting back into the night sky together. "A game to dominate the Nest I absolutely have to participate I absolutely have to participate as long as I participate no one will be a match for me hey broadcast broadcast broadcast broadcast can you hear me"

The car was silent, and from a distance, the interior was pitch dark.

"Hey,"

Mai Minghe either had truly forgotten about Reed Hydes, or was confident he couldn't get away—she actually began walking step by step toward the car, moving farther and farther from Reed Hydes.

"What's going on? Didn't you just tell me to reply? How did the sound just disappear all of a sudden..."

She raised one hand and slapped the roof of the car several times hard, as though she were dealing with a broken household appliance.

"Say something, I want to parti—"

The word "cipate" hadn't even left her mouth before a dark shape lunged straight at Mai Minghe; its long, piercing shriek sliced through the night like a blade, sharp enough to set

eardrums trembling on the edge of shattering—"AHHH no no no no I won't allow it I'm going to kill you you can't participate"

Mai Minghe looked almost bored; she raised her hand and swept it like a casual flick, and the Dream Playwright went flying for the third time.

With a thud, it landed perfectly, squarely, and without an inch of deviation right beside Reed Hydes—Reed Hydes felt all four limbs go numb, his entire body locking up.

If he had voiced every curse screaming through his mind in that instant, he would have wondered whether he himself had turned into a Resident.

Was the Dream Playwright an idiot?

Was it riding a roller coaster here, free of charge but at the cost of its life?

It knew it couldn't withstand a single blow from Mai Minghe—so what was it lunging at her for?

Well, great—Mai Minghe's attention had finally been drawn back in this direction, and she slowly turned her body toward the pair of them, one human and one Resident.

Reed Hydes didn't move a muscle, sitting rigidly half-upright and half-reclined on the ground, even his breath held still.

The Dream Playwright's sheer willpower was truly something to admire.

It was hard to say which blow had done it, but one of them had knocked its neck back into proper alignment; yet the bones seemed thoroughly broken, and its head drooped down onto its chest, dangling by a neck that was like a floppy cloth sack.

Beaten to this state, and not only was its wig still on, but its will was still intact.

"You cannot compete!"

It shrieked like a child throwing a tantrum: "You've clearly been turned into a Resident already—just look at yourself, is there even a shred of humanity left in you? What kind of superposition state is this? Superposition my ass! You're just a Resident, and Residents can't compete—this is cheating cheating cheating cheating!"

Mai Minghe smiled.

The two smiles, one above the other, were both strangely gentle and indulgent.

"No matter how unhappy you are, I was still invited." She said it with near-perfect calm. "Since I was invited, I'm going to participate. Of course, if you really can't stand watching me compete, I could also help by gouging out your eyes... oh, you don't have eyes."

The face currently drooping onto the Dream Playwright's chest was, at this moment, still blank.

Reed Hydes doubted even his own nightmares had ever produced an image this deeply unsettling to look at.

"Hmm... forget it, why should I bother caring what some insignificant little nothing thinks."

Mai Minghe tilted her heads, as if talking herself into it. "The car broadcast has gone quiet, and I don't know if my reply to participate has been acknowledged..."

At that, she suddenly turned both heads toward Taylor Ford beside her. "As the only contestant present, Taylor Ford, you should know how I can reply to confirm my participation, right?"

"Sorry, I don't know either."

Taylor Ford still had one hand pressed to his face; it seemed the blow from earlier had hurt badly enough that his words came out somewhat muffled. "When I was drafted, there was no room to disagree, and I certainly didn't need to send any reply."

"I see."

Mai Minghe's emotions had settled considerably, and she continued to stare at Taylor Ford without blinking.

But when she spoke, it sent a jolt through Reed Hydes and plunged him back into despair—"Reed Hydes, did you think I'd truly let you leave?"

"Y-you're not going to participate in some game?"

He hadn't crawled more than a few steps before he was forced to stop again, and for a moment he was nearly on the verge of tears. "Aren't you busy enough? With everything on your plate, why do you still have to kill me?"

But the one who answered him was not Mai Minghe—it was the Dream Playwright beside him, which had completely run out of patience.

"Shut up, you!" it shrieked furiously. "Always asking always asking always asking, aren't you sick of it?! Does it matter so much why she wants to kill you? Just make it simple— isn't dying fine?"

"Besides, why shouldn't she kill you? Don't you know what you look like? You're exactly the type—looks a little tired, a little hollow, like you've seen it all, but deep down soft and kind and incapable of fighting back. As long as someone finds your sore spot and bullies you to death, you'll just curl in on yourself and suffer in silence, won't you?"

The Dream Playwright gave a sniff and said, "If I were a female Resident, I'd want to kill you too. You have exactly the kind of face that makes women want to watch you cry."

Even in such a dire situation, Reed Hydes was left completely stunned.

"Is that your specialty?" Taylor Ford said out of nowhere. "You're very good at summing people up?"

...What was that supposed to mean? It sounded almost like he was agreeing with it.

"Just you wait Taylor Ford don't think that because I can't beat her I'll let you go too I'm going to eliminate all the contestants all the contestants all every single one hmm how many are there now"

Mai Minghe's two faces looked back and forth, first at one, then at the other, as if she had some degree of interest in what each of them was saying; but if she was most interested in anyone, it was undoubtedly Reed Hydes.

Just as he was drowning in deep regret, wishing he could go back a few hours and cut off both his own legs, Taylor Ford called out to him.

"Tell me—is she like this because of this Resident?"

"Hm? Oh, yes," Reed Hydes sat on the ground, watching Mai Minghe advance toward him step by step, already beyond despair. "...So what?"

"Is she in a superposition state of human and Resident?" This question from Taylor Ford was addressed to the Dream Playwright.

"She said so herself," the Dream Playwright muttered. "I see nothing but Resident in her—no human at all."

Mai Minghe's shadow fell over Reed Hydes—even though he had already felt finished once just moments ago, it seemed the heavens hadn't had enough, and were making him feel finished all

over again.

"Since the Nest Domination Game also acknowledges that she is in a superposition state of human and Resident, it should be correct."

In truth, aside from Mai Minghe's two faces, he couldn't even make out Taylor Ford's shadow—he could only hear that soft, indistinct young voice carrying on a back-and-forth conversation with the Resident nearby.

"So what so what are you annoying I'll just kill you first and deal with her after"

Mai Minghe bent down toward Reed Hydes.

"Easy now," Taylor Ford said, perfectly composed. "I want to ask you—since you can overlay a Resident state onto her, can you remove it?"

The moment those words were spoken, the square fell suddenly silent.

All four of Mai Minghe's eyes turned toward Taylor Ford's direction.

"Huh... huh?" the Dream Playwright murmured. "Re-remove it... in a lucid dream, I can place a 'Non-Resident Registration Form'... but..."

"But she's too strong right now, and none of us can resist her—right?"

Taylor Ford said quietly, "But what if the three of us temporarily joined forces?"

I figured I'd take advantage of Saturday's day off to properly reset my sleep schedule and go to bed early—and I did fall asleep quite early, knocked out at six in the evening, and slept until eight...

Great, going from bad to worse to worse to worse.

Chapter 119: The Shifting Situation That Taylor Ford Set in Motion

The Dream Playwright raised a face as blank as its mind and uttered a single syllable:

"...Huh?"

It might be a bit shameless to say so, but Taylor Ford had always suspected that if you added up the current Reed Hydes, Dream Playwright, and Mai Minghe together, their combined intelligence would barely be enough to shine his shoes.

Reed Hydes, well, you could at least say he was scared; the other two Residents had both had their reason snuffed out by obsession — though being smarter than them was nothing to be proud of.

"What do you mean, 'huh'? I've been watching for a while."

He swept a glance over the hairless, featureless Dream Playwright and said, "If I'm not mistaken, the reason you're so obsessively set on turning her into a Resident is because you believe it would both disqualify her from the competition and let you order her to eliminate the other contestants — including me. Two birds, one stone. Am I right?"

Taylor Ford had considered the possibility that he couldn't be the last contestant the Nest had recruited — this game had probably only just begun.

He had also considered that future opponents would likely be difficult to deal with, and that both finding and holding onto the seven target Artifacts would grow harder and harder; even the thought that "the whole game is just a prank" had crossed his mind at some point.

But he hadn't expected the "Nest Domination Game" to cheat — the bald Resident had put it perfectly: Mai Minghe competing in her current state was outright cheating, wasn't it?

Since Resident Mai Minghe couldn't simply be removed from the competition, the only option was to restore her to human form first, and then remove her.

...If the Nest had a master, it could only be him.

"Yes — yes, exactly!"

The Dream Playwright had no facial features, so its expression was unreadable, but its tone sounded like it had found a kindred spirit: "Isn't that right? Who could have guessed she wouldn't

recognize me as her father, wouldn't listen, and still insisted on competing? Both plans fell through. Hmm, I should've just turned you into a Resident instead — you're quite thoughtful..."

"Save the chatter."

Taylor Ford watched Mai Minghe's back and said, "Restoring her to human form is currently the optimal solution for all three of us. Correct?"

From his angle, he could only faintly make out Reed Hydes' eyes, clamped tightly shut, his breathing quick and shallow.

With nothing covering his mouth, Reed Hydes still only managed a few urgent "mmph mmph mmm"s of agreement — as though he was afraid to even breathe the air around Mai Minghe.

"True," the Dream Playwright said, "so what should we do?"

The Dream Playwright, bare of both hair and features, finally hauled itself up from the ground — Residents inside the Nest, no matter how severe their injuries, would slowly recover; just moments ago it had nearly been folded flat by Mai Minghe like a blanket, and yet here it was, standing upright and lifting its head again.

Something that can't be killed...how could it be allowed to compete as a contestant?

"I don't understand why, but Reed Hydes seems to hold a very strong pull over her."

As Taylor Ford spoke, he drew a gun from his waist and aimed it at the back of Mai Minghe's head.

"For her, killing Reed Hydes is the top priority. Look — even though I just loudly announced my entire plan to you all, and she heard every word clearly, she's only paused. She still can't bring herself to move away from Reed Hydes.

"Using Reed Hydes as bait, with me suppressing her movements, you use the 'lucid dream' to trap her while you have the chance. Can you do it?"

Fortunately, Reed Hydes had warned him briefly earlier, worried he might rush into the library and fall for the Dream Playwright's tricks, which had given him a rough understanding of the Dream Playwright's methods.

A decent person. Not exactly cut out to be a Hunter.

"You little..." the Dream Playwright wobbled as it spoke, "you've got quite a head on your shoulders, haven't you?"

"How confident are you?" Taylor Ford asked softly, not sparing it a glance.

"Never tried it before, so I don't know. All I know is I can't restore a Resident to human form, but she isn't just a Resident — she's a superposition state of human and Resident. So why not give it a shot?"

The Dream Playwright's face was a blank void as it said, "Worst case, it fails and the two of you get killed by her. I can't die anyway. And if you die, one fewer contestant isn't a bad thing either — well, well, well, I really can't lose either way."

For some reason, it seemed extremely eager to eliminate contestants...but this wasn't the time to press for details.

"The activation condition for 'lucid dream' is that I must stand within one meter of the target for seven uninterrupted seconds," the Dream Playwright said quietly. "If one of you can keep her occupied for seven seconds, and the other can guarantee she doesn't send me flying during those seven seconds — and she doesn't run — then 'lucid dream' can be activated."

"Occupied for seven seconds?" Reed Hydes, upon hearing this, finally let out a wail: "Me? By her? For seven seconds?"

The head beneath Mai Minghe slowly rotated around to face her back, and half a pair of transversely-bisected eyes stared straight at Taylor Ford.

"What a childish plan...how are you going to suppress me? Do you think shooting me with a gun can do anything to me?"

Taylor Ford let out a short laugh.

"I know it won't, big sis."

As he spoke, Mai Minghe's second head continued staring at Reed Hydes without moving.

It seemed she truly desperately wanted to devour Reed Hydes.

"But when you go to attack the Dream Playwright, using the momentum of a bullet to knock your arm aside — that much is still doable. If you don't believe me, go ahead and start eating Reed Hydes right now."

"Don't be so generous with me!" Reed Hydes yelled.

Taylor Ford held the gun steady, perfectly still, aimed at Mai Minghe.

His jawbone was probably fractured — waves of intense pain surged through him one after another, like ripples on water, making his vision blur and swim.

He needed to move quickly.

"If you go for the Dream Playwright, I'll provide covering fire and Reed Hydes will take the chance to run. If you come after me, then the Dream Playwright will go and kill Reed Hydes — right, Dream Bro?"

The bald Resident startled, then caught on: "Right, right. Killing a person is nothing."

"What kind of alliance is this?" Reed Hydes, still on the ground, was furious.

"And if you go for Reed Hydes first — that would be far too convenient for us."

Taylor Ford suppressed the pain and gave a low laugh, saying, "No matter what you do, you can't both stay a Resident and successfully devour Reed Hydes. If you ask me, you might as well accept your fate and go back to being human. Doesn't the human part of you long to return to the way things were?"

Mai Minghe slowly rose to her feet.

She still didn't leave Reed Hydes — her feet planted on either side of the Hunter lying on the ground, trapping him between them. She hung both heads low, silent for several seconds, before saying, "...It does."

Taylor Ford said nothing, slowly pulling out his phone with his other hand.

"I can feel it — part of me really wants to go back to Blackmoor City...wants to sleep a long, long sleep that I haven't had in years, then wake up and fry a plate of toast and eggs, brew a cup of coffee. I want to take a walk in Central Park, watch people walk their dogs, tease the babies in their strollers.

"I also want to get a few more Artifacts, try them out, play around with them, then sell them — feel the thrill, the adventure, the money. If I could make some Hunter friends along the way, even better. I've never used a smartphone; I want to buy the smartest one there is. There are so many things I want to experience..."

There was no telling what Reed Hydes' head was made of — he actually looked like he was a little moved: "Mai — Mai Minghe, you really are still human..."

"But...after becoming like this, inexplicably, my head filled with so much more information..."

The Dream Playwright nodded in deep agreement: "Yes. A Resident's knowledge comes directly from the Nest. I won't claim it's everything, but it's certainly a great deal."

"So I know that once I turn back into a human, I'll be constrained by the time limit on the Artifact I'm carrying. However long it can last — that's however long I can exist..."

Hm?

Taylor Ford's heart lurched.

Earlier, Reed Hydes had said, "Is she your grandmother?" — and Mai Minghe had said she'd never used a smartphone.

Add to that the fact that the Artifact she was carrying was related to "time"...could it be...

Mai Minghe hung her heads low, both faces buried in four hands, as though utterly exhausted and despondent.

"And on top of that I'd lose the overwhelming power that surpasses humans who would be stupid enough to turn back into a human besides maybe I can enter Blackmoor City in this form too it's all mine it's all mine it's all mine Taylor Ford do you think you're so clever one force crushes ten have you never heard of that I'll kill him kill him kill him Reed Hydes is mine dead man"

With a startled cry, Reed Hydes was snatched up and hurled high into the night sky.

"Breaking the standoff you created is simple simple simple"

The torrent of words burst out like a blister that had swelled past its limit and suddenly ruptured — and yet even that wasn't as fast as Reed Hydes being swung like a weapon through the air and flung straight down — at the sound of the wind, Taylor Ford instantly knew something had gone wrong.

It seemed he'd gotten ahead of himself. Mai Minghe's intelligence was more than enough to shine shoes after all.

Before the thought had even fully crossed his mind, he had already spun around and broken into a run.

In the night, Reed Hydes' long drawn-out cry of "aaahhh" did not come crashing down onto his head — it shot off in another direction entirely — Taylor Ford didn't even need to look back to know that Reed Hydes had slammed headfirst into the Dream Playwright.

Two human-shaped shadows collided and merged, tracing a high parabolic arc through the corner of his vision like something out of a cartoon, and then — bang — crashed together into the ground, sending a tremor through the earth.

But Taylor Ford had no spare energy to worry about either of them right now.

Of course — Mai Minghe had figured it out too...

All she had to do was use Reed Hydes as a weapon to slam into the Dream Playwright — that would both keep the Dream Playwright down for a while and leave Reed Hydes too battered to run away. Best of all, he wouldn't die from it either, because the Dream Playwright was there to cushion the blow.

This created a window that was brief — but long enough to kill Taylor Ford.

Sure enough, almost the next instant, Mai Minghe's footsteps pressed in close behind him.

As Taylor Ford sprinted beneath a streetlamp, the shadow he cast on the ground had already gained a round second head beside it — in a race for speed, he was no match for Mai Minghe.

There was only one way to make Mai Minghe turn around.

Taylor Ford made a sharp turn and stopped dead in his tracks; that instant was nowhere near enough for him to articulate his threat in words —

As though he couldn't even see the Mai Minghe lunging at him, he took aim solely at Reed Hydes.

The bullet grazed past Mai Minghe's ear, and the gunshot tore through the night wind.

Hm? What was I going to say — there were several times while writing that I thought, I absolutely have to put this in the author's note, and then I posted the update and forgot all about it...

These little scraps of rambling inside me — if I don't write them down, isn't that a waste? (not really)

Writing chapters is just an excuse to ramble in the author's note after, after all, after all, after all~

Chapter 120: Double-Pendulum Mai Minghe and Hunter Taylor Ford

Hate hate hate hate hate Taylor Ford so angry

That gunshot had been far too close—pressed right against her cheek; for an ordinary human, it would have been enough to rupture an eardrum.

But the moment the blast crashed into Mai Minghe's ears, she felt as though all four of her ears had suddenly sprouted countless plump, fleshy sacs; the boom plunged into those sacs and was "bounced" right back out—not even a ringing remained.

A Resident's body truly is remarkable.

She could still hear everything with perfect clarity: for instance, the sound of a bullet striking a human body—bones shattering, flesh and muscle spiraling and twisting around the impact, a hollow cavity being torn open alive.

Hit it truly hit it hate Taylor Ford so much

Taylor Ford had clearly been right at her fingertips; one strike, and this boy would have become a corpse that could never get in her way again.

Yet the moment the sound of a bullet tearing through a body reached her ears, Mai Minghe could no longer hold back—she let out a furious howl, dropped Taylor Ford, and spun around to charge straight at Reed Hydes.

Want to eat him whole don't want to see him burst apart in blood and flesh that's no different from just buying an ice cream and watching it fall on the ground Reed Hydes is her delicacy he cannot die he cannot die good people must stay alive to be eaten by her

However, Mai Minghe knew full well that no matter how fast a Resident moved, it was no match for a bullet.

Reed Hydes was probably dead, wasn't he?

The part of her that was still human seemed to wail from deep within her mind—Reed Hydes's death would be because of her—the thought coiled and refused to disperse, endlessly, insufferably.

Mai Minghe lunged forward and dropped to the ground before the two overlapping figures, and when she fixed her eyes on them, she couldn't help but startle.

.....Someone had indeed been shot—but it wasn't Reed Hydes.

Reed Hydes was drained of all color, his limbs gone weak, his face glistening with sweat and tears; whether from fear or pain he couldn't manage to get up at all, and he remained collapsed beside the Dream Playwright—staring at it blankly, not even noticing that Mai Minghe had come rushing over.

Those who have never experienced it firsthand can hardly imagine the force of a bullet's impact.

The bullet had buried itself deep into the Dream Playwright's chest, as though a great pit had been scooped out; its back was shoved high up into the air by the bullet's force, yet somehow the skin and bone did not shatter.

It would not die from this, but having its chest cavity nearly snapped in two was still no small matter for a Resident; it clawed desperately at Reed Hydes's jacket, yanking half of it down, grunting and wheezing—clearly in tremendous pain.

Not that it mattered what happened to the Dream Playwright.

"You're fine," Mai Minghe took a closer look at Reed Hydes and relaxed. "The ice cream didn't fall on the ground. How nice."

".....Huh?"

Reed Hydes tilted his face up, eyes shimmering with tears, his lips wet with saliva—flushed and red, trembling without cease: "Wh—what ice cream?"

Mai Minghe gently patted the top of his head. "Don't be scared. Does it hurt?"

Reed Hydes's eyes darted swiftly to the side.

"C—compared to it... maybe it's not so bad....."

So it was. Humans truly are creatures that constantly orient themselves through comparison.

Taylor Ford, standing some distance behind her, had not taken the opportunity to put distance between them—instead, he walked a few steps closer.

Hmm.....that's a little strange.

Now that she thought about it, the distance between herself and the Dream Playwright was currently less than one meter.

Even in that wretched state, it wasn't dead yet—it could still activate its ability; perhaps it was silently counting down the seconds, waiting to pull her into a "lucid dream."

She needed to move more than a meter away.

After becoming a Resident, her sense of time had grown muddled; all she could say was that it didn't seem like seven seconds had passed yet. Just as she reached out, preparing to grab Reed Hydes and drag him somewhere else with her, someone behind her gently squeezed the trigger.

.....So that was the plan.

Use Reed Hydes to lure her in, then shoot at her from a distance; Mai Minghe wouldn't die, but as long as her legs were injured and she couldn't move more than a meter away within the remaining few seconds, the goal would be accomplished.

The bullet's shriek tore through the night sky once again.

This time, Taylor Ford was ruthless—one shot followed immediately by another, a relentless stream of muzzle fire pouring into the darkness, the gunfire sounding as though it meant to shatter the entire plaza—and every shot was aimed squarely at her legs.

Nice thinking—too bad, I'm nothing like a small fry like the Dream Playwright.

A second neck suddenly shot upward, dropping straight down from her back; her second head swung like a pendulum behind her, whipping back and forth at high speed until it blurred into a smear—some bullets were knocked aside by the rapidly swinging head; others were caught by the wide-open, black-hole mouth.

Even Taylor Ford probably hadn't anticipated this move—amid the hail of gunfire, he actually let out a startled "Huh?"

"Do you really still have a human superposition state?" The gunfire ceased, and Taylor Ford couldn't help but complain: "What kind of human is like this?"

This body is adapting more and more how accommodating humans' imagination of the body still is pathetic laughable

Mai Minghe retracted her neck and kicked the Dream Playwright away with one foot. She wiped the bullets embedded in her skin away with one swipe, spat out the bullets in her mouth,

and only then grabbed Reed Hydes and hauled him far behind a car to hide him—that way, if the Dream Playwright tried to walk over and kill him, she would hear its footsteps first.

With the car in the way Taylor Ford can't shoot at him either hmm I really am quite clever

Reed Hydes's expression looked as though he was desperately wishing for a quick death.

But that wish couldn't be granted just yet.

"What a pity—I can't stay here with you." Mai Minghe murmured to him. "To keep you from running away, I'll just have to make it hurt a little more."

Before she finished the last words, Reed Hydes let out a long, agonized cry.

Really—screaming so loudly, when she hadn't even put much effort into it.

If she compared him to an ice cream, the force with which she gripped his ankle and snapped the wristbone was, at most, the equivalent of sniffing that ice cream's cool, milky fragrance—it didn't even count as a lick.

Mm but listening to it feels so good so good

.....As much as she hoped that Reed Hydes would be her first kill as a Resident, the situation being what it was, there was nothing else to be done—she'd just have to kill the most troublesome obstacle first: Taylor Ford.

As soon as that thought completed itself, Mai Minghe had already snapped her head around again and lunged straight toward the boy.

"I really don't like your flavor full of deadly poison full of deadly poison I don't like eating flavors that are sharp and painful and bite back"

After a brief chase, Taylor Ford seemed to realize he couldn't outrun her; he stopped on his own, turned, and fired at her—bang bang, several shots in a row.

He already knew it was useless, so why waste the bullets?

It seemed that no matter how clever a child was, they turned foolish when death came knocking.

Mai Minghe used the same trick as before, deflecting the incoming barrage once more; after a few dodging, lunging steps, she was standing tall right in front of Taylor Ford.

He was gasping for breath, a gash split open along one side of his jaw; as he managed a faint smile, a bead of blood slid down his chin.

Taylor Ford was, admittedly, a very beautiful person—but Residents only cared about flavor, not appearance.

"Reed Hydes is ice cream, and I'm deadly poison? That's hardly fair."

"You're about to die, and you're still quite composed." Mai Minghe said softly. "The Resident that was born from you—I'm going to keep tormenting it....."

"Before you make your move, let me ask you one question?" Taylor Ford didn't wait for her answer and cut in first: "If Reed Hydes were to die at someone else's hands, how would you feel?"

Mai Minghe paused.

The Dream Playwright wasn't nearby, so there was no need to worry about the seven-second countdown; as much as she hated to admit it, she was genuinely at a loss right now.

This was not the reaction of someone on the verge of death; to say she had absolutely no interest in hearing more would certainly be a lie—Residents had their curiosity too.

"That would be absolutely unacceptable," Mai Minghe said with heartfelt sincerity. "Just imagining him dying at someone else's hands makes me so heartbroken, so heartbroken—heartbroken enough to tear every human being into pieces."

The boy seemed not to have expected that answer. "Heartbroken? That feeling of heartbreak—it probably comes from your human side, doesn't it? The part of you that is still human doesn't actually want him to die, does it?"

"That's none of your concern."

"I'm sorry," Taylor Ford let out a low, quiet laugh, his voice slightly muffled: ".....I'm going to make you heartbroken."

Mai Minghe startled. "What?"

"While you were chasing me, the Dream Playwright walked over to the car and pulled Reed Hydes into a 'lucid dream.' Its head may be broken, but it can still walk——"

"Impossible impossible impossible if it had walked over there I would definitely have heard it you lying child I'll kill you kill you kill you"

Mai Minghe twisted both heads around at once, her gaze falling on the empty plaza.

Where the Dream Playwright had been just moments ago—it was truly gone.

How could that be? How could she possibly not have heard it?

How had that small fry's movement managed to slip past——

"I fired a lot of shots just now," Taylor Ford said slowly. "Oh—was the gunfire too loud?"

……Had he calculated this all along?

Being pulled into a lucid dream doesn't necessarily mean dying immediately the Dream Playwright has to convince Reed Hydes that he's already dead for him to truly die in other words she has to go save him right now

……Her desire to kill Reed Hydes with her own hands had completely overwhelmed her thinking and reason.

Good.

Taylor Ford watched Mai Minghe's retreating figure and exhaled a long, trembling breath.

The moment she became aware that Reed Hydes was in mortal danger, she stopped caring about killing Taylor Ford and spun around to charge straight toward that car; in the darkness, her furious howl was like countless sharp spines driving themselves through a person's eardrums, punching them full of holes.

Anyone who didn't know better would have thought that was her child.

He exhaled, dragging his endlessly trembling legs forward, one step at a time.

Like a hunter tracking wounded, exhausted prey—except that the wounded and exhausted one was him, and it was also him who had just brushed past death.

"It's too late for you to go now—the Dream Playwright has already finished its job and left."

He was far away, but he knew Mai Minghe had certainly heard him.

He had never encountered a Resident with such terrifying hearing—if she hadn't been a helpless old woman who had never used a smartphone before obtaining an Artifact, today's odds might well have looked very different.

Taylor Ford knew that the sound of him typing on his phone—tap tap—had certainly been heard by Mai Minghe; what she didn't know was that those sounds meant a text exchange—as long as he showed the Dream Playwright the messages, the two of them could achieve a basic level of coordination.

Amid the howling, Mai Minghe lunged behind the car and grabbed a figure off the ground, dragging him out from behind it.

Reed Hydes's face had been completely drained of color, yet he seemed to have forgotten his pain and fear—his eyes were wide open, fixed on whatever scene he was seeing in the dream.

One.

"Wake up you're not dead you're not dead you're not dead you're not dead"

Two.

Taylor Ford raised his gun at Mai Minghe and emptied every remaining bullet into her—he didn't even bother to aim away from Reed Hydes.

Having to defend herself while making sure Reed Hydes wasn't shot—that, for him, was the most ideal outcome.

He had fired too many shots earlier; by the fifth second, the bullets were spent, yet Mai Minghe sat on the ground completely intact, her second head slowly drifting back into position.

.....What a monster.

The second head suddenly paused mid-air, dipped downward, and locked onto Reed Hydes's face.

Whether it was from the swinging motion of her "pendulum" earlier, his jacket hood had been knocked slightly open, exposing a patch of skin on the top of his head.

Oh no, it looked like she was about to find out.

Six.

Mai Minghe froze for a moment, then grabbed the hood and yanked it hard downward.

At some point, Reed Hydes's head had gone bald on top; only a wig remained, hanging crookedly but stubbornly on his head, refusing to depart along with the hat—if the technique used

to secure that wig could be brought back to Blackmoor City, it would surely be worth at least one patent.

Mai Minghe finally realized he'd been tricked, let out a furious roar, and leapt to his feet.

Seven.

The shriek cut off abruptly.

The emotion drained from Mai Minghe's face; as though he had seen something, he slowly relaxed and sat back down beside Reed Hydes—no, beside the Dream Playwright.

.....It worked.

"That scared the life out of me,"

Taylor Ford finally let go of all his tension; his whole body felt like it had collapsed, and he dropped to the ground in near exhaustion, his hands instinctively rummaging around in his pockets for a cigarette—unfortunately, Jane Lynch hadn't let him bring any when he entered the Nest.

"I thought I was done for just now... Didn't expect it—after taking a bullet to the chest, you're still pretty quick on your feet, Dream Brother."

I made a mistake yesterday—Mai Minghe buried two faces in four hands, but I wrote it as four pairs of hands...

If it really were four pairs of hands that would be far too many... uncomfortably cramped.

Chapter 121: Mai Minghe's Car Really Does Have a Lot of Screentime

Mai Minghe sat on the ground, motionless, staring blankly at the plaza ahead.

...Honestly, the situation was getting worse and worse, more and more difficult to handle.

In her peripheral vision, Reed Hydes's face had become a vast shadow, pressing in unbearably close, yet she could feel no warmth of breath.

That face stared at Mai Minghe in silence for a few seconds, then slowly drew back, shrinking to normal size; the crooked wig on the other's head came back into view.

"My 'lucid dream' just reached its conclusion."

The Dream Playwright said, "She's also finished filling out the 'Non-Resident Registration Form,' so by rights she should have returned to her human self. But why isn't there any reaction..."

Mai Minghe's gaze drifted through the darkness, utterly unfocused.

"When did it end?"

Taylor Ford was cautious as ever—even after cooperating with the Dream Playwright and turning the situation around single-handedly, he was still sitting several meters away, unwilling to come within one meter of the Dream Playwright.

"Wasn't that when the second head retracted? It was right around then."

The Dream Playwright studied her, then called out to Taylor Ford in the distance: "You saw it too, didn't you? Before that head fully retracted, it reached out and put the top of the first head's skull back on. That should mean she's already recovered."

...That was absolutely not something a normal person would say.

"This is the first time I've ever run into a situation like this... Could it be that all the back-and-forth transformations broke something?" The Dream Playwright crossed its arms. "Should I knock on her head?"

"Do you think she's a house? Knock once and a second head comes out to answer the door?"

Taylor Ford laughed softly, drew the pistol he'd just fired empty, and slotted in a fresh magazine.

"Hey, aren't we allies now?" The Dream Playwright's eyes drifted toward him. "You're so guarded. It really hurts the feelings."

Reed Hydes's groan drifted out from beneath the car.

"I... can I come out now?"

Just from the sound, it was clear he had suffered tremendously—if voices had bones, his would have been fractured clean through, held together by nothing but skin, trembling and barely intact. "Whether she's recovered or not, I don't want to stay this close to her anymore."

"Come on out," Taylor Ford replied. "It'll be a good chance to see how she reacts."

Reed Hydes, using three limbs, dragging one injured foot, slowly emerged head-first from under the car.

It was precisely because he had been right there beside her that his scent, heartbeat, and breathing had all been pressed up against the Dream Playwright's—enough to fool Resident Mai Minghe, who had been desperate to save him.

As he crawled, he kept glancing back at Mai Minghe with obvious unease—seeing that she showed not the slightest reaction to him, he finally let out a long breath and collapsed onto the ground in exhaustion.

"What is all this," he said, covering his face with both hands, every word thick with grievance: "Why am I so unlucky..."

Mai Minghe sat where she was, her expression blank.

"You'd better crawl a bit farther away," Taylor Ford suggested. "We still can't be a hundred percent sure the second head won't come back out."

Reed Hydes forced himself to his feet and, in Mai Minghe's field of vision, limped away a few more steps, hissing through his teeth; she still just sat there in a daze, without sparing him so much as a glance.

The overwhelming, all-consuming hunger she'd felt earlier—the "no one but him" craving—had now vanished entirely into thin air; in its place was—

"It looks like she really is broken."

The Dream Playwright said suddenly, its face returning to a complete blank.

"A human turning into a Resident and then a Resident turning back into a human—I've never heard of that before, and the odds of success were never high to begin with. But it doesn't matter, I'll just kill her and be done with it clean and simple once and for all no loose ends should have done this ages ago honestly Residents can't outplan fate ah well"

Taylor Ford gave a short snort of laughter and said quietly, "...Can't keep the act going anymore, can you?"

The Dream Playwright startled and turned toward him. "Huh?"

She had to strike now—

Mai Minghe suddenly leaped to her feet and drove her fist with every ounce of strength she had straight into the not-yet-fully-healed gunshot wound on the Dream Playwright's chest; for a moment, her right hand sank almost entirely into its chest, with nothing visible above the wrist.

The Dream Playwright had clearly not anticipated her sudden attack at all and took the blow squarely in the chest—but after Mai Minghe lost the strength of a Resident, it merely stumbled back two steps before steadying itself again.

Bad—

The thought flashed through her mind even as Mai Minghe suddenly ducked low and lunged toward the back of the car; a gunshot shattered the air with a crack, leaving a faint ringing in her ears.

"Hm?" The Dream Playwright seemed momentarily confused. "What's going on?"

"It looks like she retained all her memories after returning to her human self."

Mai Minghe scrambled up from behind the car, still hunched low; she could only hear Taylor Ford's voice from far away: "...Doesn't feel great, does it? The moment you come back to yourself, your own memories tell you that you were once a superposition state of Resident and human. And to make things worse, there's a Resident on one side and a human on the other, both watching and waiting."

This kid was sharp in the most infuriating way.

The moment the "lucid dream" ended, Mai Minghe had already returned to her true self—but how could she dare show it?

The instant anyone knew she had recovered her humanity, the Dream Playwright, who wanted to kill her, and Taylor Ford, who wanted to take the Artifact—wouldn't they both move against her immediately?

Under the gaze of both a human and a Resident, even after coming to her senses, Mai Minghe hadn't dared give herself away—she could only sit there motionless, stalling for time while she thought of a way out—but the Dream Playwright's desire to kill her was far too urgent.

"Wait?" Reed Hydes finally caught on. "She's already recovered as a human?"

The Dream Playwright turned a blank face toward Mai Minghe behind the car.

"Well then, that's just perfect, die, die, die"

At the moment it lunged straight at her, Mai Minghe grabbed the door handle of the car beside her.

...Taylor Ford had guessed right—she had remembered everything.

So naturally she also remembered that when she was still in the Resident superposition state, Taylor Ford had fled toward this very car to escape her—at that moment, he had slammed down onto the trunk, used it as a step, and jumped up onto the roof.

In other words, the trunk had been open at the time; ever since she had carelessly fallen into the Dream Playwright's trap, the car's trunk had remained open.

...The trunk was open—did that mean there was a good chance this car was unlocked?

"I should have killed you long ago—"

Mai Minghe pulled the door handle, and the door slid open without any resistance.

"I never should have let you turn into a Resident in the first place—"

She quickly pulled her hand back, rolled across the ground, and swung her foot up in a heavy kick against the half-open door—the Dream Playwright, lunging straight at her, was slammed full-on by the door; though it had neither mouth nor nose, it let out a strained "ugh" and tumbled to the ground.

"Aaaaaa!msoangry so angry so angry hmph not bad for a future contestant pretty quick on your feet"

What a bafflingly candid Resident.

Taylor Ford was probably heading this way right now.

Mai Minghe kept herself pressed tight against the car, not daring to expose even a sliver of herself; while the Dream Playwright hadn't yet gotten up, she stole a quick glance into the car's interior—by the dim light of the plaza's streetlamps, she spotted a key left in the ignition.

A lucky break?

Could this car still actually run?

But there was no other option—she had to try.

Mai Minghe had never moved so lightly and swiftly in her entire life; like a stray cat dodging people, she vaulted into the car, then twisted her body and stretched out her arm to grab the wide-open car door.

When the door shut with a bang, the Dream Playwright slammed heavily against it, one step too late—its blank face crashed hard into the door's window glass, which was splattered with saliva.

...How strange—it had no facial features whatsoever, so where was the saliva coming from?

This was no time for puzzling over that.

When her peripheral vision caught a figure outside the car, Mai Minghe immediately flattened herself against the seat.

The next instant, a heavy gunshot rang out through the night beyond the car; the driver's side window and the rear passenger window behind it were pierced by a spiraling gust of force and exploded outward and inward into countless glittering shards.

The Dream Playwright outside the window had no time to dodge and took the bullet square on—that blank face caved inward, the bullet pressing it into a mass of crinkled folds, like a steamed bun whose filling had been pushed in from the wrong side.

"You did that on purpose didn't you Taylor Ford I'm going to kill you kill you too"

What was it even using to make sounds? Residents were structurally extraordinary—once she was safe, she'd have to feel her own head to make sure it was still there.

Seizing the moment, Mai Minghe turned the car key; the sound of the engine catching alight also ignited a spark of hope in her chest.

Though she hadn't driven in a decade or two, at least cars hadn't evolved into something she couldn't figure out.

As long as there was a steering wheel, a gas pedal, and a brake, even someone who had never driven before would have a chance of escaping from here—because she didn't need to dodge pedestrians at all; if anything, running them over would be better.

...Was she the only person in the world who drove like this?

To avoid getting shot, Mai Minghe had most of her body curled up, wedged between the driver's seat and the passenger seat.

She couldn't sit up, couldn't see the road through the windshield—barely managing to keep one hand on the steering wheel, stretching one leg far out to press the gas pedal, navigating by memory toward the exit, while shouting out through the shattered window: "If you don't want to get run over, let me through!"

Whether Taylor Ford had gotten out of the way, and where exactly she was driving—she could only guess by feel.

Because the only things in Mai Minghe's field of vision were the car ceiling, a hanging ornament on the rearview mirror, and the night sky outside the broken windows—if not for how utterly bizarre the circumstances were, it would have almost felt like she was camping inside the car.

"Don't you run you're so infuriating so infuriating so infuriating I regret everything one wrong move and everything falls apart"

The Dream Playwright's howling grew more and more distant, yet it stubbornly kept after the car.

After careening along recklessly, lurching and zigzagging, Mai Minghe soon heard Taylor Ford's distant curse—young as he was, his cursing was vicious—and something stirred in her; she shouted out the window: "Besides me, isn't there another contestant? Dream Playwright, go cause him trouble instead!"

She had no idea whether the Dream Playwright had truly been redirected, but with a car, escaping for her life had suddenly become far simpler and safer; before long, as Mai Minghe half-sat up, she could already see the road outside the library.

Just as she could see that one press of the gas pedal would carry her completely free, she slammed the brakes.

Mai Minghe glanced at the rearview mirror and carefully sat up, first looking back over her shoulder—then turned around and called out to Reed Hydes, who was slumped by the side of the road: "Hurry up and get in!"

Reed Hydes stared at her blankly, his face even paler than before.

I actually remembered my rambling section for today!

First—Reed Hydes should be renamed Adu in this chapter, because he crawled out from under a car.

Second, I was browsing Xiaohongshu and stumbled across a classmate!

She's now a beauty blogger with a massive following! But she was always pretty growing up, and definitely didn't have protruding teeth—so to see her now teaching people how to correct an overbite, complete with before-and-after comparison photos...

I immediately lost all faith in the authenticity of blogger content...

Chapter 122 — Mai Minghe: Her Decision

The atmosphere inside the car was awkward for a moment.

Not that it was hard to understand why — barely ten minutes ago, Mai Minghe's strongest desire had been to devour the young man sitting in the back seat.

Now the desire had faded, but the memory stretched between them like a wall, and neither of them had forgotten.

How a person was supposed to break the ice and smooth things over with their former prospective meal was perhaps a question that had never once been raised in all of human society.

Mai Minghe felt she should say something — something to properly put Reed Hydes at ease.

But the harder she tried, the more words failed her, and the silence in the car grew heavier and more unbreakable — after grasping about in near-despair for a while, she finally managed to blurt out a question: "W-why were you sitting on the side of the road just now?"

In the rearview mirror, Reed Hydes was watching the back of her head with undisguised wariness.

After two seconds, he said: "...I wanted to get away from all the trouble, so when you were driving around crashing into things, I slipped out of the plaza."

"Ah, oh, right, right."

On the road beneath the night sky, Mai Minghe kept her speed steady and grasped for something to say. "So why didn't you keep running? Sitting in the middle of the road isn't exactly safe."

Reed Hydes's gaze swept over her like something physical — it felt like getting hit in the back of the head with a branch. "...Didn't you crush my ankle? I was in too much pain to walk."

...Even more awkward.

"About that — I'm really sorry," Mai Minghe said sheepishly.

She had lost count of how many times she had apologized, but set against what Reed Hydes was actually going through, words always felt a little hollow. "I truly didn't mean to — well, no, that's not right either. I did mean to, at the time."

"That kind of apology only makes people angrier — you might as well not bother," Reed Hydes suggested.

She was the one who had put him through all of this; however much he wanted to resent her, in Mai Minghe's eyes, she deserved every bit of it.

When she thought about it carefully, after surviving a near-death experience of being eaten, the fact that he had found the nerve to get in the car at all was already no small thing — Mai Minghe decided to approach from that angle when trying to comfort him.

"Don't worry, you can ride easy — I'll make sure you get back to Blackmoor City in one piece," she said. "I've completely returned to normal. If you don't believe me, you can touch my head."

"You could give me all the money in the world and it still wouldn't be enough to make me touch your head," Reed Hydes said, deeply displeased.

"Hey, I really am fine — if you don't believe me, should I touch it myself and show you?"

Mai Minghe had grown almost anxious about it, wanting to prove just how safe she was — even if Reed Hydes didn't trust her, she wanted him to be able to settle down.

She raised one hand and rubbed her hair vigorously, parting it back and forth to expose her scalp, then knocked on her skull a couple of times — "thud, thud" — and the moment that dull sound rang out, her hand froze. Both of them fell silent for a few seconds at the same time.

"Y-you see, everything's really fine," she said, stumbling a little over the words.

Reed Hydes was perceptive as ever: "Did you just think of that line of Taylor Ford's — 'knock on your head, and a second one might answer the door'?"

...Yes.

Even just imagining it — a second head burrowing out from inside her own — made her insides run cold.

Reed Hydes let out a sigh. "You remember everything?"

Mai Minghe swallowed.

"Yes... it's like having a nightmare, except you remember every detail with perfect clarity. Do you know that feeling? Something utterly absurd that should never have happened, yet while it was

happening, it felt completely natural... I even remember what it felt like to turn two heads in different directions at once. Just thinking about it now makes my skin crawl."

She thought about it for a moment, then found a way to look at it from the other side: "Well, forget it — it was an experience, wasn't it? A rather strange one, a rare one at that. Life is about constantly having new experiences — otherwise, what's the point of living?"

"The price of your experience was me."

"...I'm sorry."

After another pause, Reed Hydes spoke. "You were... truly planning to eat me back there, weren't you?"

Of course.

In that moment, there had been no flavor in the world more tempting or delicious than him.

"...You were in real danger back then," Mai Minghe said with feeling. "I still remember that craving — that hollow, ferocious hunger that made me want nothing more than to swallow you whole... and yet I couldn't bring myself to, because once you were gone, there would be nothing left, and I'd have to take it slowly. And a Resident's way of 'eating' isn't quite the same as an ordinary person's..."

She had been describing it in quite a lot of detail, but heard no response; when she glanced back, she realized she probably shouldn't have gone into quite so much detail — Reed Hydes had gone pale, refusing to meet her eyes, curled into the corner of the back seat with one hand gripping the door handle as though ready to throw himself out of the car at any moment.

"That's all in the past now," she hurried to reassure him. "I'm back in a human body. I have absolutely no desire to eat anyone right now, and I've never killed anyone. Look — aren't I driving you to your safe house right now?"

"Speaking of which..."

Reed Hydes hesitated before opening his mouth, his hand still not releasing the door handle. "How do you know this safe route?"

"Do you remember — when I was turning into a Resident, I said the Nest had poured a huge amount of information into my mind?"

"Mm... and the safe route near the library is part of that information?"

"Right, except that from a Resident's perspective, it isn't called a 'safe route' — it's actually a route that Residents need to be especially careful about tonight, one they need to actively avoid. Places Residents can't travel through generally have fewer traps and Rule Domains, which means for humans, they become safe routes."

Most Hunters had to carefully probe and observe their surroundings while on the move; but no matter how cautious a person was, there were always times they blundered straight into a trap.

Mai Minghe had no such concern right now — she simply had to drive by the information in her memory, which was also part of why she had been able to leave Taylor Ford far behind.

Even if that young man had any number of people under his command, they would never move as efficiently as Mai Minghe, who actually knew which way to go.

The unfortunate part was that most "safe routes" were not permanent; after some time, the routes might shift, and she would not be able to travel them so freely — after all, once she was no longer a Resident, the time-sensitive information in her mind would stop being updated.

"How long can a safe route last?" Reed Hydes had grown interested and asked, "Why do safe routes even exist?"

"How long they last — there's no fixed answer, since the Nest is a place of chaos and darkness."

Mai Minghe could now talk about the Nest with confidence and ease, fluent in it as if she were describing a place she had clocked years working at.

"Some safe routes have held for over a decade. Others change within a day or two. Sometimes an entire path becomes unusable all at once; sometimes it shifts partway through and you have to take a slight detour — all sorts of situations."

As for why they existed, she honestly couldn't say for certain.

"The Nest is saturated with countless... what would you call them — force fields? Rules? Intentions?"

Mai Minghe thought for a moment and said: "All in all, these 'force fields' each have their own properties — they pile up, overlap, interlock with one another, one great tangle of chaos. In some places where certain 'force fields' collide, humans are unaffected, but for Residents it's extremely dangerous.

"If I were to put it in terms of an analogy — safe routes are like the gaps between two tectonic plates. If a Resident walks through that gap, they might get crushed into rubble by the plates pressing together, or be pulled in two opposite directions and torn in half."

It felt genuinely strange; the things she was now holding forth on so fluently were, from her earlier perspective, nothing more than the ravings of a madwoman — and yet the listener in the back seat was hearing it all with great interest.

"I never imagined it — originally I was supposed to be the one guiding you, and here you are telling me all kinds of things about the Nest."

Reed Hydes mused on that, then glanced at his watch. "Mm, just over seven hours left. Once we get to the safe house, I could sleep—"

He glanced at Mai Minghe with unmistakable wariness and changed his wording: "Actually, I'm not that tired."

...Why did he just refuse to trust her.

The punishment Reed Hydes had been assigned was to serve as Mai Minghe's guide for twelve consecutive hours; since neither of them had died and neither had been eaten by the other, it was only fair to assume the "twelve-hour" requirement was still in effect — Mai Minghe suspected that if not for that, Reed Hydes wouldn't have gotten in the car at all.

"Is your safe house well hidden?" Mai Minghe asked, a little worried. "Taylor Ford won't find it, will he? He's probably still looking for me."

The possibility that the Dream Playwright had taken Taylor Ford out — that she barely gave a second thought. That kid was too sharp and cunning; she would sooner worry about the Dream Playwright.

"If he's dead set on searching every corner of the Nest for you, then no matter how well hidden it is, it won't matter."

Reed Hydes seemed low on energy — whether from the foot injury or sheer exhaustion, she couldn't tell. "Why is he so determined to make trouble for you? Is it because of that — the Nest Domination Game? Even though you've turned back into a human, he still doesn't want you participating?"

Mai Minghe fell silent.

She glanced at the car's display screen, which had been completely quiet this whole time — Reed Hydes had told her that when the little screen lit up, there would be a broadcast.

"He wants the Artifact I'm carrying."

Mai Minghe said quietly, "In my last life, in this world, I wasn't able to hold on to much that was precious to me — so this Artifact is the one thing I cannot hand over, no matter what. When it expires, so do I. All I want is to keep it... keep it, and then I might be able to try living one full and complete life. As for that Domination Game — I have no interest in joining."

She simply longed for a new world; she wanted to see wonders she had never seen before.

Scheming and striving for nothing more than the right to rule over and control another group of beings — just hearing about it made her feel drained. And ruling the Nest would indirectly mean ruling the Hunters, wouldn't it?

Once the Nest had a "king," how dull it would all become.

"I don't believe that game is real for a second, but your way of thinking about it — I actually find it pretty understandable," Reed Hydes said after a moment of thought. "But do you know?"

"Know what?"

"The expiration date on that Artifact of yours."

Mai Minghe startled. "I... I don't know yet."

"It should be written on the Artifact itself." Reed Hydes pointed ahead and said: "That apartment building up there — that's my safe house. If you want somewhere safe to take a look at the expiration date... I can let you use the safe house for the time being."

Yesterday I had a dream — the kind I like best, which is rare.

I dreamed I was leaving Earth aboard some kind of fully transparent vessel. The ascent was thrilling, heart-pounding; when I looked back, I found the surface of the planet was a new world I had never seen before... The specific details have gone fuzzy, but I still remember the sense of awe and dazzling wonder.

So my passion for writing is also about creating different worlds and exploring them in imagination, because I believe the finest experience in life is "seeing something for the very first time."

Chapter 123 — Sydney Ginn Is Not the One Unraveling the Truth

...Were these even human hands?

Being grabbed by the wrist by Chase felt like having her hand sealed inside steel and concrete — Sydney Ginn even suspected that if Chase wanted to, he could snap her hand clean off at the wrist.

The pain was so sharp she nearly lost her grip on the phone, but he saw this and didn't loosen his hold one bit.

"What do you need to see?" Sydney Ginn suppressed her shock and tried to speak in her usual tone. "We're just partners. Why should I let you check my phone?"

From Sydney Ginn's angle, Chase was perfectly backlit; the streetlight lay docilely across his shoulders, as if afraid of heights, unwilling to fall any further, unwilling to plunge into the abyss of him.

She was shrouded in his shadow and couldn't make out his expression.

The pain made Sydney Ginn's breathing turn heavy; Chase was dead silent. Two seconds passed in silence — he said nothing, and gently slipped the phone from her hand.

"This should be something that concerns me directly," he said, as if by way of explanation, finally releasing her hand. "I'll give it back when I'm done."

"My phone — how could it have anything to do with you?"

Sydney Ginn rubbed her wrist and watched the light from her phone screen illuminate Chase's face in the darkness.

He stared at what was on the screen and said nothing.

She thought about how Chase could have just snatched the phone outright, yet he'd taken it gently and even offered an explanation — and somehow that made her a little less angry. Pfft, what nonsense. It was her phone; not even the president had the right to look at it. He did whatever he pleased, and only because she couldn't beat him in a fight.

She might have a bit of Stockholm syndrome, Sydney Ginn thought to herself.

"When you're done, you should at least let me see it too," she said. "That's my phone."

She didn't dare move in closer, because she didn't know whether Chase would allow it.

What if he expressed his disagreement through violence? No point taking a beating for nothing.

Chase stared intently at the phone without answering a word.

"Hey,"

Sydney Ginn called out, but he still seemed not to hear her, his brow furrowed tight.

She was speaking perfectly civilly — why was he ignoring her?

"Is this any way to treat a partner?" Sydney Ginn just came out and said it loudly. "With a style like yours, no matter how good-looking you are, your luck with women can't be great. Don't tell me women usually delete your number the second they're done sleeping with you?"

This time, Chase finally reacted — he looked almost startled, nearly fumbled the phone, and raised his eyes with a rare flash of embarrassment. "You did that on purpose, didn't you?"

"Of course I did," Sydney Ginn replied. "Otherwise you wouldn't even look at me."

Chase calmed back down and fell silent again, still holding her phone, lost in thought. His tongue pressed against the inside of his cheek and swept across.

His hands were absurdly large, nearly swallowing her phone whole; even if she angled her eyes to sneak a peek at the screen, she still couldn't see a thing.

"I'm saying —"

She'd barely gotten a word out when Chase cut her off, saying quietly: "I asked you today — what is it you truly want. Have you found an answer to that?"

...Huh?

Why bring that up all of a sudden?

"It's not like I've been diagnosed with a terminal illness," Sydney Ginn rubbed the tip of her nose and said in a muffled voice. "I still have plenty of time to figure it out slowly. Why are you asking this now?"

Chase thought in silence for a moment, then handed the phone back.

"...I didn't expect you to be summoned too."

Summoned? What was that supposed to mean?

Sydney Ginn took the phone back and found an Amber Alert on the screen — no, wait. That wasn't right.

What was this?

As her attention sharpened and she bent her head to read, she could still feel Chase's gaze fixed firmly on her.

The Unknown Nest Domination Game

Three competitor teams have joined so far, but none of them are as charming as you

Ugh, she hated that line — and Chase had seen it too

Competitor Team One: Wellesley Team

A crushing setback! Artifacts scattered and lost! Progress rolled back to 2/7, lead advantage greatly diminished

Brianna

Currently collected: black cube (image), word-editing software (image)

Not yet collected:

vintage radio (image)

Key (image)

time (text)

a tongue (image)

???

*

Competitor Team Two: Taylor Ford Team, joined November 15, progress 1/7

The "boy genius" reputation is well-earned! In just four days, a decisive acquisition —

Currently collected: Key (image)

Not yet collected:

vintage radio (image)

black cube (image)

time (text)

a tongue (image)

word-editing software (image)

???

*

Competitor Team Three, Cuckoo's Child, Chase Monroe Team, joined November 19, progress
1/7

Currently collected: a tongue (image)

Do you want to take his tongue do you want to take his tongue go ahead go ahead

Not yet collected:

Sigh, refer to the above and work it out yourself — so many people, it's really a bother

Now summoning new competitor — Gold Blood Pear, oh no, Sydney Ginn

Typo hehehehehe

...What an irritating way to write this.

She stood there staring at the phone, feeling as though a long time had passed, with Chase's gaze pressing down on the top of her head the entire time.

Sydney Ginn had no idea what expression to wear when she finally looked up, to make it through this moment.

The date Chase joined...was today?

She glanced at the time.

November 19, 8:11 PM

No wonder the moment her phone went off, he immediately demanded to see it — he'd probably just received the same notification himself.

She couldn't keep pretending to read the notification forever...the most important question right now was: why had Chase shown her this summons?

If he deleted it immediately, all she could do was complain a little — she couldn't do anything to him, and she naturally wouldn't become his competitor.

In other words, he was permitting Sydney Ginn — or more precisely, he wanted her to join this Nest Domination Game.

He was even willing to expose which Artifact he had in hand.

Why?

Her gaze lingered on "vintage radio" for half a second, then quickly moved away.

No matter how she looked at it, it seemed like the one she had hidden in the Nest... if that was the case, then that was probably why she'd been summoned — because she already had 1/7 of the progress, she got called in?

But Chase didn't know that.

Why did he want her to see the summons?

"This can't be real," Sydney Ginn raised her head and said. "What does it even mean? Collect seven Artifacts and you gain dominion? This isn't a video game... it must be some kind of prank from the Nest."

Even though she found it hard to believe, trying to bluff her way through with "I don't believe it" probably wasn't going to cut it.

"...I've been trying to figure out what conditions need to be met to receive a summons."

In the silence that was growing heavier and harder to breathe in, Chase finally spoke; but instead of lifting the tension, his voice seemed to press it further down, making it heavier still.

"Do you want to know how I received my notification?"

Sydney Ginn very much wanted to know.

She was curious, yet had to keep up the act of not believing, of not being interested, and for a moment her expression tied itself in knots. "You — don't tell me you actually believe this? I think it's a prank — anyway, tell me what happened first."

In the dark where light could not reach, Chase gave a quiet laugh.

"My foster father was targeted for assassination today. While I was here searching for the person behind it, I happened to run into a woman and had physical contact with her — what kind

of face is that."

Sydney Ginn wiped her face. "Go on."

"...After I touched her, a summons notification appeared on my phone."

Chase tilted his head slightly; the rain-dampened skin of his neck held a muted sheen, the light barely catching it.

"I didn't know her, but afterward I thought about it — Wellesley is buried in this cemetery too, not far from where I ran into her. Could that woman have some connection to Wellesley?"

"If she's someone from the 'Wellesley Team,' then I was summoned after coming into contact with her.

"After I was summoned, I ran into you, and then you were summoned as well. Thinking about it that way — could it be that the first condition for being summoned is physical contact with a competitor?"

...That seemed fairly reasonable.

"What is this," Sydney Ginn muttered, "so this summons spreads like a virus?"

She paused, suddenly realizing something.

"You just said 'the first condition.' You think there's a second one?"

"Yes."

Chase tapped her phone screen and said, "Taylor Ford joined too. From the notification, he was empty-handed when he joined; he only acquired an Artifact afterward. In other words, the Nest took a liking to him — probably because of the reputation he built on deceit."

That tone — it seemed the two of them were on very bad terms.

"As for fame," Chase said, "you have none whatsoever." He didn't seem the least bit worried about offending her.

"That's true," Sydney Ginn took the fact in stride. "I keep my feet on the ground."

"Not just you — I have no fame either."

Chase seemed to know what she was about to say, and raised one hand. "Don't forget — the one doing the summoning is the Nest. I'm not a Hunter; I shouldn't have any reputation in the Nest at all... which means neither of us meets the second condition."

"So then?"

"Besides 'physical contact with a competitor,' there's one other thing about me that stands out. I think that's the third condition — and the reason both of us were summoned."

Chase took a step forward, pressing into the space around her.

...This was bad.

Sydney Ginn already knew where this conversation was heading.

"I was summoned because I had one of the target Artifacts and then came into contact with a competitor."

He lowered his head and asked quietly, "...Which Artifact did you get?"

I drew a hand-drawn portrait of my second daughter today and handed it over to Qidian, because they wanted the author to participate in a charity event to help visually impaired children — so the cat drawing will serve as my profile picture.

Black cats are hard to photograph, but so easy to draw — a blob of black, two green circles, and you're done.

Haven't drawn in a long time; I'm getting into it — I'll draw the eldest and the third one too in a bit, and make it a family portrait.

Chapter 124 — Sydney Ginn: A Partnership of Mutual Hidden Agendas

...No way, how did he figure that out?

She'd only accepted one notification, that was all.

How could a single notification leave her with no secrets left to keep?

Sydney Ginn tilted her head back. Chase's face loomed over her like storm clouds swallowing the moon, blocking her entire field of view.

The most difficult part was that they were standing too close together — she still couldn't read his expression.

It was like driving a night road with no signposts; when she couldn't see through her opponent's intentions, all she could do was muddle through with deliberate vagueness.

"I have gotten my hands on several Artifacts," Sydney Ginn decided to play dumb first. "But I sold them all."

"Don't play dumb," Chase said in a low voice. "It won't work on me."

She bit her lip and said nothing.

Fine rain pattered ceaselessly against her plastic raincoat, whispering and hissing — for a moment, it was the only sound between them.

"When we were at the Central Police Department, you admitted that you had a 'contingency measure.'"

Chase seemed to be thinking even as he spoke, his words unhurried: "With it, you weren't worried about your fingerprints going into the police files, and you weren't even worried about not getting your personal belongings back. I've always felt that the way you carry yourself — it's like you have a do-over pill."

...Huh?

"There are seven target Artifacts in total. Aside from the last one, which is just a question mark, the others all have visual or written descriptions." Chase said: "One of them is 'time.' Thinking about it carefully now — the Artifact you have that can turn a situation around, is it

related to time? And precisely because it's related to time, you're not afraid no matter how bad things get."

Truly... truly unexpected.

Sydney Ginn chewed on her fingernail, thinking: this guy Chase had sharp instincts and was good at analysis — but he probably hadn't realized that every step of his reasoning was correct, yet he'd arrived at a completely wrong answer.

The target Artifact in her possession wasn't Candlefall — it was the vintage radio.

However, Sydney Ginn had never before exposed any clues related to the radio, and Chase had been thrown off by the word "time" in the summons notification, so it was perfectly understandable that he'd reached this conclusion.

In any case, she couldn't admit it right away — she had to put up a little more resistance first, so that Chase would believe her all the more firmly in the end.

Regardless of whether the Domination Game was real, she wanted to protect the vintage radio as much as possible — even at the cost of Candlefall.

After all, Candlefall had come from the vintage radio in the first place.

The radio could still provide her with more Artifact information in the future; Candlefall couldn't do that — it had exactly one function, "altering the past," and even then it couldn't be aimed and fired at will, so it wasn't particularly useful.

From the contents of the notification, the person who had discovered she possessed the vintage radio was the next competitor in line, not Chase — she'd deal with that when the next competitor appeared; for now, she just had to get through this hurdle.

As for denials and deflections, those came without a second thought — open her mouth, and she'd have as many as she needed.

"No, I really don't, I don't have it — if I had an Artifact that could manipulate time, would I need to earn that five thousand dollars from you? What price couldn't I sell for? I'd be richer than you..."

Sydney Ginn let her mouth run freely while her mind spun at full speed.

...From the look of things, Chase seemed to completely believe in this so-called "Nest Domination Game," convinced that collecting seven Artifacts would let him rule the Nest.

Well — such a sharp person, and he was already certain after seeing just one notification. No wonder they say the greatest con artist is yourself.

No matter how clever a person is, their own desires will blind them to what's right in front of them.

Since he believed she had a target Artifact on her, he must be determined to get his hands on it, right?

Wait.

Which meant she absolutely could not let Chase take it by force?

Even if the end result was the same — Chase getting away with news of Candlefall — the manner in which it happened made all the difference to her.

If Chase decided he had to use strong-arm tactics, she wouldn't just lose Candlefall for nothing — she'd likely have to endure some rough treatment on top of it, and the cooperative relationship they'd just established would go up in smoke.

But if she could turn this situation to her own advantage...

"Even if I did have one," Sydney Ginn reached that point in her thinking and shifted her tone slightly, "I would've sold it for money long ago."

"So what you want is money?" Chase lowered his head and looked at her as he asked.

Sydney Ginn already knew what she needed to do.

"Who doesn't want money," this part was the honest truth from the bottom of her heart, "would I have become an Artifact Hunter if it weren't for money?"

Chase raised his hand; Sydney Ginn's body tensed.

But he only gently pulled down her raincoat hood — as if to get a clearer look at the expression on her face.

Fine rain settled into her hair and onto her eyelashes; Sydney Ginn blinked involuntarily a few times. Through a mist-blurred field of view, Chase's gaze pressed down on her face.

His hand was still resting on the back of her neck — spread open, it could cover her entire skull.

One surge of force from that hand, and she would go down.

She underwent extensive physical training in her daily life and wasn't afraid to get physical with ordinary people, but against Chase in terms of brute force — never mind her, even a professional boxer might not have the odds in their favor.

So no matter what, she had to avoid becoming Chase's enemy...

Besides, what she was giving him wasn't the real target Artifact.

"...The thing you want most — is that it? The thing you'd give up everything else to have, no matter what; the thing that could make this life feel worthwhile... for you, is it money?"

More or less?

No, that wasn't quite right either.

"More precisely, it's what money can bring."

Sydney Ginn felt as though the words left her mouth on their own.

"You definitely grew up surrounded by money, so you don't feel it. Let me tell you — money doesn't just bring material comfort and a better life. Money can change a person's species."

"Species?" Chase seemed to go genuinely blank for a moment.

"A little money still can't change it completely. It takes an astronomical amount."

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment and said: "Take Wellesley and me, for instance — we're two entirely different species. Our perceptions of other people, of fate, of the ground beneath our feet... our ways of thinking are worlds apart. Body, mind, environment, information — with the wealthy at the center, everything can be remolded. In other words, different creatures live in different worlds.

"The gap is as vast as the one between a human being and a laboratory worm."

Chase said nothing; it seemed this was a direction he had never thought in.

Wealthy young people generally never had this feeling — if it were a spectrum, the Sydney Ginn of the past sat on the left end, Chase was somewhere near the middle, and the small cluster of people represented by Wellesley occupied the far right, in the zone that meant "a different kind of creature entirely."

"You asked me at the police station, what is the thing I want most. I thought about it for a long time after I got home... if it's just pleasure from money, just acquiring material things, there's

a little excitement at first and then it passes — fleeting."

Sydney Ginn knew that she had to lay her true heart completely bare, with no concealment of even her darkest self, if she was going to earn Chase's trust.

She hadn't said a single false word from beginning to end — she was only layering the weight of truth on top of his misunderstanding.

Untimely as it was, she found herself feeling a flicker of gratitude toward Chase: if he hadn't pressed her, she might never have pushed this thought any deeper herself.

"So I think... what I want isn't money itself, and it isn't the things money can buy. What I truly want is the power that comes with money."

As she said this, she turned her head aside and brushed his hand away from the back of her skull.

"If I had that kind of power — power that could reshape everything — would I still be standing here, taking this from you?"

Chase looked at her for a moment, then suddenly let out a quiet laugh.

Even the laugh was tight and heavy, as though it could serve as a weapon to suffocate someone with.

"Good."

He stepped back half a pace, and it was as though the air suddenly began to move again. "I like people with strong, simple desires. Easy to work with."

...Easy to control, more like.

Sydney Ginn said nothing, only lifting her eyes to give him a sideways glance.

"You can't win this game on your own,"

Chase said calmly. "That's not me looking down on you — I'm simply stating facts. And if you can't win the game, you'll be essentially cut off from any real money."

"You're not great with words, you know that?"

"But what you want doesn't conflict with my goal. No — rather, if you're willing to cooperate with me, the sooner I reach my goal, the sooner you can have what you wish for."

She stared blankly for a few seconds before asking: "Your goal?"

"...If we win the game," Chase said quietly, "the Key House Faction will be able to rule the Nest, and from there, control the world."

"You... all of this is for the Key House Faction?"

Chase turned his head and glanced at the small path beside them leading up the slope, avoiding her gaze. "...Yeah."

"You could easily have used force to beat the information out of me, and then killed me." Sydney Ginn asked, lost in thought. "Why didn't you?"

"You've forgotten," Chase gave a quiet, self-deprecating laugh. "I don't have a passage. I need a Hunter who can enter the Nest. I have plenty of Hunters under me, but the fewer people who know about the Domination Game the better. Besides, you've already been summoned. Rather than killing you and letting the Nest replace you with someone more troublesome, it's better to work with you."

"...That's almost a little insulting. So if I tell you what I know, you'll tell me everything you know too, right?"

Chase considered it and nodded. "Fair enough."

Sydney Ginn raised her hand again and extended it.

"In that case, let's call this a renewed partnership."

After all that denying she'd just done, she needed to give herself a way out — she thought about it and said: "I don't know whether what I have truly counts as a target Artifact, but I do know of one that's related to time."

Chase released her hand and said: "'Know of'? Not 'possess'?"

"It's a long story — I'll tell you slowly."

Sydney Ginn said that, then tilted her head back to look at the sky and said: "But we can't just keep standing in the rain to talk, can we? It'd be better to find somewhere safe and private... where do you live?"

Chase suddenly shot her a look.

"Why are you looking at me like that? We can't go to my place either. I've learned my lesson — I can't let men know where I live."

"Why not?"

"Don't even get me started — I attracted a stalker recently, looked totally respectable on the surface..."

"Is your story going to take very long?" Chase interrupted.

"Quite a while, actually — it's closely tied to an Artifact."

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment and added: "It's also related to the 'Vulture' you wanted to know about. Oh right — you can tell me why you were asking about the Vulture now, can't you? What's going to happen to the Central Police Department? Did London Moon attacking you have anything to do with the Domination Game? Is the tongue right inside your mouth? Do you have two tongues? How do you eat and talk? Oh, I have so many questions—"

Chase closed his eyes for a moment, and finally said: "...Let's go. My car is over there — I know somewhere better."

"Speaking of London Moon, that five thousand dollars..."

"...I know. Give me your PayPal account."

"An electronic transfer, of course — lovely. You definitely don't have trouble with money laundering. Oh, by the way, can I borrow the Key House Faction's accountant sometime?"

"...You're stressed about even that — why not just accept Bitcoin?"

Pale grey curtains of rain drifted through the dark night, and the cemetery hillside lay frozen in silence.

Beneath the cover of night, the slope and the graves watched the two figures walk further and further away, their voices gradually fading into the end of the road.

Why is the title getting longer and longer?

When writing Chase and Sydney Ginn together, I noticed something remarkable: these two never run out of things to talk about.

With everyone else, neither of them seems to have nearly as much to say.

By the way, I went back recently and reread the beginning, and I do think switching perspectives every four chapters is a bit fast. I had a feeling at the time that it might be too

frequent, but back when I was posting one chapter a day, it wasn't so noticeable—reading them all in a row, though, it really shows.

Should I adjust it? But it's already posted... hmm...

Chapter 125: The Fantastical Life of Sydney Ginn

Sydney Ginn felt that Chase was a person severely lacking in common sense.

Had this man truly grown up in human society?

According to him, he had even gone to university — but could he really get along with ordinary people there?

"I said I wanted somewhere safe and private to talk,"

she wanted to take a deep breath, yet at the same time was instinctively holding her breath, reluctant to inhale too much of the surrounding air. "And this is what you consider safe and private?"

"Besides the two of us, who's going to hear anything?" Chase shot back.

Sydney Ginn shivered before she could even answer.

She'd been wearing a plastic rain poncho that looked like a garbage bag — it hadn't kept out the damp, and now the cold hit her all at once, sending her muscles into trembles.

Chase, by contrast, had clothes soaked through by the rain long ago; his skin was a waxy, pale blue, and you could tell just by looking how low his skin temperature was — yet he seemed completely unaware of the cold.

"Generally speaking, when a normal person is looking for somewhere discreet to have a conversation, a corpse freezer shouldn't be the first thing that comes to mind, should it?"

Sydney Ginn gestured at the refrigeration units in front of them — wall upon wall of large drawers — and perhaps it was all in her head, but she could have sworn each drawer was seeping cold air outward.

"Couldn't you put your ability to come and go from the morgue as you please to better use somewhere else?"

"This is the ideal place to talk." Chase said flatly.

Having not been hit yet — and not seeming likely to be — Sydney Ginn was no longer particularly afraid of his expressions. "Why?"

Chase stared up at the body drawers above them, as though Sydney Ginn weren't sitting beside him but lying in one of those drawers, and said slowly, "...First — Uncle Key is right here in this hospital, in the ward building next door."

"Ah, you're worried the assassins will come back." Sydney Ginn understood.

"I plan to keep watch without showing my face until he's discharged, so I've only posted a few people outside his room. If someone takes that to mean I'm not nearby, all the better."

Sydney Ginn had never imagined that "ambition" and "loyalty" could coexist in one person — the look on Chase's profile almost made her feel sorry for the assassins.

Why on earth was London Moon going up against him? She truly couldn't figure it out.

What kind of price would it take... no, London Moon didn't seem like the type to be driven by money the way she was.

"And the second reason?"

"Safe. Private." Chase said, as if stating the obvious.

It really was quite safe — on either side of the room stood large refrigeration units for bodies; the two of them sat on the floor of the aisle between the cabinets, like a pair of water ghosts who had just escaped from their drawers.

It was private too; there were no windows in here, and no matter who came through the door, they would spot them immediately.

"Are you cold?" Chase suddenly turned his head to ask.

"Hm? Yes," Sydney Ginn started, "I didn't think you were capable of noticing other people's —"

"Good," he turned his head back, "you talked too much on the way here. Now that we're in here, you should be able to get to the point."

Was that the third reason?

"You weren't exactly holding back either," Sydney Ginn said indignantly. "It takes two to keep a conversation going."

Before the topic could drift any further, she let out a sigh and said, "Fine — lucky for you I'm not squeamish about this place. Where was I? Oh, right — the Vulture Resident disappeared, and

when I woke up, my shoulder had no wound, and my hunting knife was gone."

Even though their partnership was a tangled product of fear, desire, and calculated self-interest, Sydney Ginn found that no matter who it was with — the simple act of recounting that experience to another human being, in full and without holding anything back, was in itself something close to a comfort.

No wonder therapists usually just listen and never talk.

"...That whole thing has been weighing on me, and it really has been quite awful to carry."

Once she had poured out every last bit of her nightmare of an experience, she felt considerably lighter, and let out a long breath.

"'Candlefall' is enormous — I saw it, and there is absolutely no exit large enough to fit it through. I imagine it was generated directly in the exhibition hall on the lower level? And there's no way to cut it down, so even if I could get it out, it would be nearly impossible to bring back to Blackmoor City. It's a real headache..."

The moment she started complaining, one grievance led to another and she went on and on: "Useless candle — couldn't even deal with one stalker, and in the end I had to get my hands on another Artifact myself to make him disappear after I got back — ah."

Sydney Ginn froze, and shot a sidelong glance at Chase.

She'd been venting so cheerfully that she'd accidentally let slip the fact that she'd killed someone...

Chase, however, seemed not to have heard, lost in thought about something.

"Um, that, when I said 'disappear' — it's not what you're thinking, it was —"

"Stop trying to backpedal," Chase cut her off with a frown. "Killing someone is nothing to be this flustered about. Key House runs a funeral home — why do you think that is?"

"Impressive!"

Sydney Ginn straightened up with a look of admiration. "What I used was a grape soda — it dissolves a person completely, turns them into soda water... just takes a breath to do it. Oh? See, even you think it's convenient... all right, I'll grab some for you next time I see them. How many cans do you want?"

She pulled out her phone, created a new note, named it "Shopping List," and solemnly typed: "Grape soda, Chase, five cans, markup of three thousand."

Chase glanced back and caught a glimpse of it — for some reason, a flare of irritation came over him.

"Can't get two words of actual business out of you before you start thinking about pocket change."

His temper, it seemed, was half directed at himself, because he too kept getting pulled off course — "Say it again — at the beginning, it was the Vulture Resident that took on your appearance, and then went and touched 'Candlefall'? It thought it was you, so it was also trying to alter your history?"

Sydney Ginn put her phone away and nodded.

"So something that is not human in nature — as long as it takes on a specific person's form — can manifest that person's timeline?"

"Possibly," Sydney Ginn said, a little puzzled. "So what?"

"So what?" Chase glanced at her, his gaze heavy and hard. "The ability of 'Candlefall' to change the past is probably not the point at all."

"What?" Sydney Ginn was startled.

Chase thought for a moment, then suddenly pressed his hand against the floor and stood up in one clean, decisive motion.

"Get up — we need to go. You can't handle this alone, and I can't leave tonight, so I'll find you someone to help."

"Wait," she saw Chase heading for the door and called out urgently: "What kind of help? What's wrong with 'Candlefall'? You haven't explained anything — how are you acting like you already have a plan? I still want to sleep tonight, I haven't slept properly in days..."

Chase stopped at the doorway and turned to look at her.

Good thing there was no one else here — Chase, dressed all in black and soaked to the bone, standing in the morgue, looked for all the world like the Grim Reaper who had just finished collecting souls on a rainy night.

But when this particular Grim Reaper spoke, he had at least some patience: "...The Vulture's mutation was caused by Wellesley. I've already told you that."

"Yes," Sydney Ginn said hesitantly, "th-thank you?"

"...No one is looking for credit."

Chase seemed to suppress a flare of annoyance and said, "I've never been able to work out why he did what he did. There are still a great many mysteries surrounding him, and now that I think about it, they likely all have some connection to the Nest Domination Game. If we can uncover the truth of what he went through while he was alive —"

"Oh," Sydney Ginn couldn't hold it back — a small, startled exclamation escaped her: "Your mind works so fast!"

Chase looked away, his expression still sober, but he didn't look entirely displeased.

"That's just the professional instinct of an interrogation specialist, I suppose — everything can be turned into a means of uncovering the truth."

Sydney Ginn grew excited and even clapped a few times: "I can't believe I never thought of that. It really is a possibility — if we brought Wellesley before 'Candlefall' and pressed his hand against the candle, maybe... hm? Wait."

At that, she finally caught up with herself.

Even without a mirror, she could feel the color draining from her face.

...Who exactly was supposed to bring him?

Wasn't it going to be her, obviously?

Was she supposed to carry a corpse and jump off a building?

"Wellesley wasn't cremated,"

Chase had been watching her expression the entire time, and clearly had no intention of offering any comfort — he stated the facts plainly: "I'll find you someone to help. Tonight, the two of you will go to the graveyard, dig up his body, and bring it into the Nest. Whatever reaction appears on 'Candlefall,' record it on camera for me."

He was serious?

"Hold on," Sydney Ginn watched him about to open the door and hurried after him, saying: "Even if it were a fresh one, I wouldn't say a word, but Wellesley has been dead for several days now, hasn't he?"

"Don't worry — bodies are generally embalmed before burial," Chase said considerately. "It won't decompose on you."

In the space of just a minute or two, he had thought everything through so thoroughly that Sydney Ginn, caught off-guard by this ambush, didn't even know where to begin refusing.

"D-digging up a body is still a little too..."

Chase gave her two pats on the shoulder, each one feeling like it might drive her an inch into the floor.

"I'll leave this to you," he said, slowly breaking into a smile. "You do need to prove your worth to me, don't you?"

Two hours later, Sydney Ginn was sitting in a graveyard again.

She watched a small excavator trundle toward her across the grass in the distance, and for a moment felt almost a sense of unreality — that day alone she had been arrested, passed through a Central Police Department blanketed by the Nest network, received a summons, made a trip through the morgue...

And now she was supposed to team up with some subordinate of Chase's she had never met before, and in the dead of night, dig up Wellesley's grave together?

At exactly what point had her life turned into a fantasy story?

The small excavator came to a stop not far away.

As for this "very reliable helper," Sydney Ginn couldn't muster much enthusiasm — a helper, sure, but the person probably served more as Chase's eyes and ears than anything else.

"You're Sydney Ginn, right? Sorry to keep you waiting — thanks for your trouble."

Someone poked their head out of the excavator's cab, and even in the darkness you could see the bright, easy smile on her face.

A person who radiated such warmth and energy was now waving at Sydney Ginn with great enthusiasm in the pitch-black graveyard: "I'm June! Chase told me to come help you steal a corpse!"

The numerical legion has arrived! What a shame she's not the main character.

Speaking of which — yesterday morning I took the dog out for a walk, and for the first time in my life I saw two pigeons standing face to face on a power line, pressed right up against each other, smacking each other with their big wings — flap flap flap flap, the noise carrying through the air for quite a distance...

They were going at it with total dedication, neither willing to surrender first — they'd get tired, take a breather, then suddenly land another slap out of nowhere...

I was absolutely floored. At my age (18), I stood on the side of the road for ten minutes watching pigeons slap each other.

Chapter 126 – Sydney Ginn, for One, Is Not an Empty Coffin

...If Han June's voice had been any louder or more enthusiastic, Sydney Ginn figured they wouldn't need the excavator at all—the corpse would answer "hello" on its own from underground.

"Keep it down," she quickly hushed her—since when had this corpse become something she was stealing with her help?

Han June laughed, her voice bright and crisp, as though it could tap little sparks of silver light across the night sky: "You know, the first rule of thievery is that you can't act guilty."

She said it with complete ease, clearly without a shred of guilt—the next hill over could probably hear it; she hopped down from the excavator and stepped into the beam of Sydney Ginn's flashlight, her face illuminated.

...First impressions were right after all. Han June had to be the single most unsuitable person in the world to be sent out stealing corpses at midnight.

Her short hair was dyed a lustrous pink-silver, and her eyes and smile were both wide and bright; even in the dead of night, nothing could dim that clear, sunny quality about her—as though all the world's troubles could pass right through her heart like a gentle breeze and warm sunlight.

She wasn't even wearing any jewelry, and yet she was somehow a little blinding.

Chase had sent such a dazzling person to dig up a grave at midnight—was he afraid nobody would catch them?

"Haven't said hello yet—hi there," Han June said with a smile, extending her hand.

Sydney Ginn hesitantly shook it.

She and Chase had already tested this: even when an ordinary Hunter made physical contact with them, it wouldn't trigger a game summons—so satisfying only the first condition was, indeed, not enough.

"Don't worry, I've got you. I'm a professional, and I've made all the necessary preparations." Han June said, patting her own chest. "Relax—Chase himself said I'm reliable."

She was wearing a staff uniform printed with the name of a funeral company, but one uniform alone wasn't enough to put Sydney Ginn's mind at ease.

"Isn't this the most expensive cemetery around," Sydney Ginn said suspiciously. "The security should be pretty tight, shouldn't it? Even if you're pretending to be a staff member, showing up in the middle of the night is still very suspicious..."

She hadn't said anything remotely funny, yet Han June burst out laughing and clapped her on the shoulder: "You're hilarious!"

How exactly am I hilarious?

"If someone comes along and gets suspicious, just kill them, right? One comes, you kill one; a squad comes, you kill the squad—it's not like there's any shortage of places to bury them. You were being so careful I almost believed you."

...What a sunny, straightforward killer.

That unit of measure—"squad"—made it pretty clear that in her head, the target had already shifted from security guards to police officers.

Sydney Ginn wasn't affiliated with any House Faction, but she knew that each Hunter House Faction had its own style: the Morgan House Faction operated more like a corporation, the Knight House Faction was mysterious and secretive, and the Key House Faction... had a style closer to a drug cartel.

That must be Chase's influence.

Han June's smile remained as bright and sunny as ever: "But don't worry—I've lost count of how many times I've been to this cemetery. I've prepared thoroughly, so killing anyone shouldn't be necessary for the time being."

"Do you... do you dig up corpses often?" Sydney Ginn asked carefully.

"This is actually the first time. Before, I always came to bury them."

Han June said this as she looked over the vestibule mausoleum, which resembled a small palace, and furrowed her brow. "Hm... so it's this type of tomb. Can't say I'm surprised, with a wealthy family like this..."

"Bury corpses? Do you actually work for a funeral company?"

She seemed to know quite a lot about burials.

Han June had already walked several paces away, but she doubled back specially, smiling as she gave Sydney Ginn a slap on the shoulder—which stung quite a bit.

"You're so interesting—no wonder Chase said not to chat with you for no reason. I bet it's because he was worried we'd enjoy ourselves too much and forget to work."

Sydney Ginn stared at her blankly.

"Those are just bodies the House Faction needed taken care of. Come to think of it, back then, we hadn't started running the funeral home yet."

Han June lifted an axe and a construction notice board out of the cab.

"Before a coffin is buried, they have to dig a hole first, right? Before the funeral, we'd dig the hole deeper and wider, bury the bodies we needed to dispose of at the bottom, fill it back up, and leave just enough room for the coffin. Most people would never suspect that there were more bodies buried deep beneath the grave they'd purchased.

"Sometimes you could squeeze seven or eight people under a single coffin—impressive, right? They won't be lonely in the afterlife. I think of it as doing a good deed."

"I think that mindset of yours is even more impressive," Sydney Ginn said honestly.

"We also take jobs for body disposal—if you ever need it, just let Chase know."

Han June shouldered the axe and walked toward the burial chamber. "I'm not doing that anymore lately—I've been interviewing new recruits. Chase says I'm likable and can attract people to join, which is almost embarrassing to hear. Oh right, at first I thought Chase was sending me here to interview you, but based on his description of you, I don't think that's really necessary."

"Does that mean he said good things about me—that I already meet the standard for hiring?"

Han June's laughter could practically knock the lock off the burial chamber door on its own.

...Sydney Ginn had found the reason Chase sent this person to help her: it was definitely payback.

She watched Han June prop the notice board up by the path, then let out a small "Hm?" through her nose and asked, "This... is an Artifact, right?"

It was a simple-looking thing—plain enough that anyone walking along the path would see it at once: a white board bearing a single line of large, calm blue letters—"Nothing is happening here."

What a... brazen lie it was.

"This Artifact is really handy," Han June urged her, "go stand on the path and look at it."

Sydney Ginn did as she was told and walked to the path, pretending to be a guard who had sensed something was off and come to check.

She swept her flashlight across the excavator beside her, let it linger on the notice board for a few seconds, then moved past it and lit up Han June's face.

She nodded and walked away.

...What a peaceful, tranquil night. Everyone was resting soundly.

Nothing to see here—time to go home and sleep.

It wasn't until she had walked a full ten-odd minutes and was nearly at the cemetery gate that Sydney Ginn snapped back to herself with a start: "Wait—how did I fall for it too?"

She had known it was an Artifact and still got fooled without missing a beat; what hope did someone who didn't know stand?

There was no way Han June had done that by accident.

Otherwise, why hadn't she called out to her the moment she started walking away?

Sydney Ginn jogged all the way back, panting, and arrived in front of the Wellesley grave to find that Han June had vanished—the door to the vestibule mausoleum had been forced open, its lock smashed, the door hanging half-open; as she drew near, a heavy yet sharp crashing sound rang out from inside, rattling the night.

That Artifact was truly remarkable.

Han June was making the kind of racket you'd expect from a construction site, just a few steps away—yet the moment Sydney Ginn so much as glanced at the notice board, she was immediately lulled back into a sense of gentle breezes and peaceful nights.

"Hey, Han June," she covered her eyes to avoid looking at the board and hurried into the burial chamber, sweeping her flashlight around. "Artifact or not, you're being way too loud—"

"Back from your walk?"

Han June waved at her cheerfully from the excavator cab. "Pretty impressive Artifact, right? You looked so focused walking away that I didn't call out. Besides, an outsider like you wouldn't

have been much help anyway—just leave it to me!"

Sydney Ginn stared blankly at the two marble sarcophagi sitting side by side in the chamber, then at the excavator that had been driven inside.

The marble sarcophagus lid on the left, engraved with Wellesley's name, had already been violently knocked askew.

Under Han June's control, the digging bucket had been repurposed as a mechanical fist, slamming the marble lid downward again and again—Sydney Ginn couldn't get a word in edgewise, because any sound she made would have been swallowed whole.

No wonder she'd been sent off. It was so Han June could destroy the sarcophagus without restraint.

Truly worthy of being Chase's person—a lawlessness passed down through the family.

When the sarcophagus lid crashed to the floor with a thunderous boom, it revealed a lacquered black coffin inside—so there was a real coffin within the marble sarcophagus; Sydney Ginn didn't know much about the materials, but one look told her it was expensive.

"It's not buried underground?" She had never attended a funeral, and found the whole thing rather fascinating.

"Above-ground mausoleums are constructed elsewhere and then placed on the burial site. For one this large, it was probably built on location. Either way, the coffin is stored inside the chamber—it doesn't go underground. The buried-in-the-earth kind is a whole different process."

Han June, true to form, knew her way around this subject. She stepped down from the cab, took one look at the coffin, and asked abruptly: "Did Wellesley die badly?"

"Hm? No, I don't think so—wasn't the cause of death something like cardiac arrest?"

"Then why wasn't there an open-casket funeral?"

Han June raised her flashlight and examined the coffin for a moment. "You see, for an open-casket funeral, they use a coffin with a lid split into two halves. You open the top half so the family can take one last look.

"This coffin has a lid that's one solid piece... You can certainly open it all the way to view the remains, but a lot of people find it undignified, so generally speaking, it's closed-casket funerals that use this style."

Whatever the topic, Han June wore that same sunny expression: "Usually, a closed-casket funeral means the body looked really bad—like it had been crushed by a car and even the mortician couldn't fix it up. Oh, I know—it's definitely because the family didn't want to look at him."

"How could that be the reason—have some respect for the dead. Look at the empty space beside him," Sydney Ginn pointed to the side. "His wife still wants to be buried with him someday."

"Hm, doesn't matter—all we need is Wellesley's body."

Han June gave a breezy wave and directed Sydney Ginn to the foot of the coffin—where, it turned out, there was a sealed keyhole for the lid.

Sydney Ginn took the tool she was handed and struck the keyhole several times as hard as she could—to be honest, she had no idea what she was doing. "Are you this... talkative around Chase, too?"

With someone like this in their House Faction, how did Chase still have the nerve to say she talked too much?

But to her surprise, Han June actually looked a little embarrassed, and let out a sheepish laugh.

"Not a chance. Around Chase, my mind goes completely blank—all I can manage is 'yes' and 'okay.' You couldn't beat a single word out of me."

Sydney Ginn couldn't picture it.

Chase was intimidating, sure, but not to the point of leaving someone speechless—especially not someone this refreshingly candid about killing people.

"Why? Because he's good-looking?"

Han June startled so badly she nearly sent the axe in her hand flying straight at Sydney Ginn's face; she had just gotten out a stuttering "Wh—what are you saying" when the burial chamber suddenly echoed with a muffled thud.

The sound wasn't loud, but both of them fell silent at once.

The burial chamber had finally returned to a deathly stillness.

They looked at each other. After a few seconds, Sydney Ginn was the first to speak.

"That sound, unless I heard wrong... came from in there, didn't it?" She pointed at the coffin and asked in a hushed breath.

From the very beginning, many of you reader friends (I got fat, so you all have to be fat friends with me) guessed that Wellesley wasn't dead—that the coffin was empty.

Whether he's dead or not, we'll get to that—but the coffin is definitely not empty...

P.S.: Han June is truly, genuinely a talker—another great tool for padding chapters, except she's only a side character... what a shame.

Chapter 127: Sydney Ginn's Party of Three, Some Casual Chat

June stared at the coffin and thought for a moment.

When she raised her head again, all traces of suspicion had been swept clean from her face, and her eyes were bright with a smile as she said: "Right, it came from inside!"

...What are you so excited about?

"Could he not be dead?"

Sydney Ginn involuntarily took a step back, her mind already racing through countless possibilities. "They buried another living person?"

"Don't be scared, I'm here—step back a little," June said, raising the axe in her hand.

Wait—

Amid the heavy crack of the axe smashing through the coffin lid and the wooden splinters flying in all directions, June's next words leaped through the air like musical notes: "Open it up and we'll know, won't we?"

Should she call her reckless, or just refreshingly direct? Who knew what would be inside once it was opened?

And besides—why did she seem almost eager about it?

But even if Sydney Ginn had any objections or protests, in the very next second, she forgot them all entirely.

Through the crack that had split open in the coffin lid, a flesh-colored shadow flashed past—as though whoever was inside had been startled and was trying to dodge the axe.

"Keep smashing, keep smashing—"

Sydney Ginn immediately abandoned the position she had held two seconds ago and urged: "There's really something alive in there!"

June had exceptional stamina and no small amount of strength; she threw herself into it and needed only three or four strikes to smash a jagged-edged hole in the upper half of the coffin. She seized one of the pointed wooden shards jutting out like a spike, gave it a hard wrench, and tore it

off with her bare hands, forcing the hole in the thick planking to expand until it was roughly the size of a human head.

...Was having enough brute strength a requirement for joining Key House Faction?

Sydney Ginn craned her neck and peered into the hole.

In the burial chamber, lit by nothing but a single work lamp, the darkness below that hole was thick and murky—but as the two of them watched, a thin line of flesh-colored shadow slowly surfaced along the edge of the hole, growing wider and wider.

A crown of a head, like a mushroom after a rainy day, squeezed its way out of the hole bit by bit.

Wood splinters had lodged themselves in the head, apparently unnoticed; accompanied by the occasional snap of a breaking shard, a complete human face soon emerged from the coffin.

It was a small-featured man with hair that had gone half gray-white, covered in sawdust; his skin sagged loosely, and every crease in it radiated severity.

The two women and the face regarded one another—you look at me, I look at you.

Sydney Ginn glanced at June; June caught her gaze and passed it along to the head sticking out of the coffin lid, like a relay race of eyes.

After a few seconds of silence, June finally scratched her head with a slightly sheepish expression and laughed: "Hey, Sydney Ginn—keep an eye on him... I'm going to look up some photos of Wellesley on my phone first."

"You don't recognize him either?"

Sydney Ginn felt an inexplicable wave of relief. "I was just thinking—I've heard his name so many times, but what his face actually looks like, I really..."

"Right, right," June, having found a kindred spirit, was also pleased; she took out her phone and said: "He doesn't really show up in the news much. The occasional appearance he does make has nothing to do with me."

"He's not a good-looking celebrity or some tech billionaire who loves the spotlight—who would bother memorizing the face of some dried-up old man? It's not like remembering him would put money in my pocket."

"See, I knew you'd understand me." June lowered her head and opened a webpage. "If there were just a corpse in the coffin, we'd know it was Wellesley without even searching—but now..."

"You two are incredibly rude,"

the head said out of nowhere, in a voice that was neither loud nor particularly animated—Sydney Ginn almost missed it entirely. "Never mind digging up my grave, but is now really the time to be discussing whether I look dried-up? I'm asking you to let me out right this instant."

"That tone of yours doesn't sound like someone who was buried alive by mistake."

June kept her head down, her fingers tapping at her phone screen. "Let me see—oh, there's a photo..."

"Well?"

June suddenly looked up and flashed the phone screen at Sydney Ginn. "Look—it really is him. He looks so ordinary."

The two of them exchanged a glance for a second or two, then simultaneously turned their eyes toward the head protruding from the coffin lid.

"...Vulture?" Sydney Ginn said softly.

June had no idea how much intelligence she'd gotten from Chase, but she showed no surprise at the word.

She seemed to have connected Wellesley with "Vulture" already, and said: "There's no way they would have buried a living Wellesley... so it must be a Vulture after all."

Sydney Ginn felt like her brain was a ball of yarn that a cat had been batting around for far too long—she couldn't quite sort herself out.

"But... why would there be a Vulture here?"

Chase had told her that the behavioral change in "Vulture" had been brought about by Wellesley using an Artifact—before, a "Vulture" had only ever wanted to take on the appearance of a dead person.

Now a "Vulture" no longer needed to wait for someone to die; it could transform into its target completely, and thanks to the Rumor Wellesley had set in motion, it could even enter Blackmoor City.

"It entered Blackmoor City—does that mean... Wellesley has always been a Vulture? Wait, no—the thing about Vultures being able to transform into living people only started on the 17th, but Wellesley died on the 16th..."

"Don't overthink it," June walked over and patted her on the shoulder. "I'm here—let me figure it out."

Sydney Ginn shot her a grateful look.

True to being someone Chase called "dependable"—

She hadn't even finished the thought before she saw June raise the axe again.

"Wait—"

It was exactly like the whack-a-mole game at an arcade: the axe came down hard into the coffin lid, sinking into the hollow; with a dull thud, the head vanished.

"Is that your only move?" Sydney Ginn stared at the spot where axe met coffin and asked: "How exactly is this your way of figuring things out?"

"If it survives a hit from an axe, then it's a Vulture."

June flashed her a toothpaste-commercial smile. "If it's Wellesley himself—but how could it be him!—if it were him, well, he's technically already dead by all accounts, so dying a second time would just be him getting what he deserves."

Sydney Ginn tilted her head and thought about it. "You... you actually make a lot of sense..."

"Chase always says, there's no need to overcomplicate things—what's it called, Occam's Razor." June lifted the axe, aimed at the hole in the coffin lid, and said: "Let me go again—"

"Please don't," came a muffled voice from beneath the coffin lid. "...I'm a Vulture."

Huh?

Sydney Ginn was genuinely startled; she rushed to the side of the coffin, peered down through the hole, and said: "W-wait, that's not right—aren't you supposed to wholeheartedly believe that you are Wellesley?"

"I'd very much like to believe that myself," said the voice beneath the coffin lid. "But when I opened my eyes, the circumstances no longer allowed me to think of myself as the true Wellesley."

"Why not?"

Sydney Ginn grew even more confused, and took the opportunity to explain to June: "The one that turned into me—even when it was standing face to face with me, it rationalized everything and believed I was the Vulture. It was hell-bent on killing me."

"Is that so. What a fortunate colleague." The Vulture inside the coffin said, in a dry, flat tone. "My situation is different. When I opened my eyes, I was already inside a coffin."

"And that's how you knew you were a Vulture?"

"Impossible not to know."

It even let out a very human-sounding sigh.

"When I transform into a target, their emotions, experiences, and memories are all copied into my mind. So... I retain a clear memory of Wellesley's last moment of death."

The two outside the coffin couldn't help exchanging a glance.

As if afraid that the living people outside wouldn't believe it, it added by way of explanation: "The last thing he saw was the carpet of his study pressed right up against his face, and then everything went dark. I know he is already dead. Since 'Wellesley' is dead, then who am I? Push yourself to think about it, and the answer becomes obvious."

"Wouldn't you think you had just come back to life?" June asked, axe still raised and ready to go.

"At first, I did think I had come back to life."

The Vulture that had taken on Wellesley's form was now capable of communicating like a normal person—which felt genuinely strange— "But when you broke open the coffin lid just now, light came in, and that illusion shattered. My worst suspicion turned out to be true."

"What suspicion?"

Something shifted faintly inside the coffin, producing a knock. The coffin was large; "Wellesley's" frame was slight, yet it kept bumping into the corners.

Hold on... Sydney Ginn suddenly had a feeling she understood.

"Because right beside me lies the true corpse of Wellesley."

The Vulture sighed again.

"No wonder I was still able to copy his appearance even after opening my eyes inside the coffin... because the man himself was right behind my back."

Honestly, not knowing what Wellesley looked like is completely understandable—when I was writing this, I tried to recall and I truly couldn't picture what Buffett looks like...

Sorry about that, Mr. Buffett.

Oh, right! I have an idea—writing nothing but a thank-you chapter feels a bit dull, and considering how many bonus extras I owe, why not have the characters in the story express my thanks for me instead! That settles it, I'll post it this Saturday...

Chapter 128 — Sydney Ginn Moves a Resident Out of Its Coffin

"Here, coffee."

Sydney Ginn reached out and took the canned coffee, looked at it, then looked at June, and sat down beside her.

"You came so well-prepared."

June pulled open the tab and said modestly, "Not at all—when you're pulling an all-nighter, these are just the essentials. I have sugar-free too, just say the word."

"This one's pretty good." Sydney took a sip of the coffee and said, "What else did you bring?"

"If you're hungry, I also brought donuts—the classic cop breakfast set."

June said that and then cracked herself up. "Oh, speaking of breakfast—after an all-nighter, I always want to eat something greasy and satisfying... Once they open in the morning, let's go to IHOP together?"

...How to put it—after enough strange experiences, you couldn't help but stop being fazed by things.

For instance, Sydney was currently sitting shoulder to shoulder with a Key House Hunter she'd just met, inside Wellesley's burial chamber, watching a human head poking out from the coffin lid, leisurely drinking coffee...

No matter how she thought about it, something about this really should have felt wrong.

"There's a corpse ten steps away," Sydney thought about it and felt she'd put her finger on the oddness. "And you're still thinking about breakfast?"

"Excuse me, I have a question." Wellesley's human head suddenly fixed its gaze on the two of them and spoke up: "Have you two forgotten about me?"

Both of them glanced over at it.

"I believe I've provided you with some heavyweight information."

The Vulture could barely suppress a faint smugness on its face—it must have been a vestige of Wellesley's. "And your reaction is to sit down and drink coffee? Did a second me popping out of the coffin bore you to tears?"

The two exchanged a glance.

"Didn't expect a Vulture to have such a strong sense of self," Sydney remarked. "Doesn't it get in the way when you're copying someone else?"

"Maybe it's Wellesley who had the strong sense of self," June offered, trying to be fair.

"Fair enough. We haven't forgotten you," Sydney turned to reassure the Vulture. "We have to figure out what to do next, don't we? We need to keep our wits about us to deal with you."

Thinking about it that way, her luck was really quite good.

She still didn't understand who had stuffed the Vulture into Wellesley's coffin, or why—but with the Vulture here, it was the same as having access to Wellesley's memories. Which meant she no longer had to strap a corpse to her back and jump off a building.

Still, figuring out how to subdue the Vulture and get it over to Chase was going to require some thought.

While it was stuck under the coffin lid and couldn't get out, this was the best time to make a plan—and grabbing a coffee in the meantime wasn't too much to ask, surely.

"It's not the strong type, but once it starts thrashing, we'll have a hard time. Did you bring rope?" Sydney asked.

"Of course," June said.

After all, the original plan had been to carry a corpse into the Nest—rope was naturally a must.

"We'd have to knock it out first before tying it up, right?"

"An axe to the head didn't do a thing—how are we supposed to knock it out?" June sighed. "Besides, for safety's sake, we shouldn't get too close to it."

"Makes you wonder how whoever stuffed it in there managed it—"

"Excuse me!"

Wellesley's head seemed to have finally reached its limit; in a rare display, it raised its voice and called out: "What exactly are you two trying to do?"

Both of them startled.

"My demand is simple—I want out of this coffin. And as I see it, you two need something from me as well. Given that, why don't we cooperate temporarily?"

Perhaps because it had "inherited" Wellesley's way of thinking, it spoke with that same measured, methodical cadence.

"What kind of cooperation did you have in mind?" June asked.

"You let me out, and I'll cooperate with whatever you need." The head said with complete seriousness, "Likewise, I ask that you not tie me up. Once this matter is settled, you let me go free."

"Where would you go?" Sydney asked.

"I've worked hard to make it to the human world—naturally I intend to make the most of the opportunity and live on as a person."

"This Resident talks in such a flowery way," June muttered, then looked at Sydney. "What do you think? We really can't trust it, right? Its goal is to leave—so the moment we let it out of the coffin, it'll definitely look for a chance to run."

"Hmph. What do you know."

Wellesley's head let out a derisive snort and shook itself. "My word is worth its weight in gold. Without integrity, how would one maintain a business reputation?"

"You've gotten too into the role," Sydney pointed out. "You're not the real Wellesley—who's going to believe that line from you."

The head froze, and then, remarkably, looked a little offended: "I am his personality right now! Do you think overriding his personality is something I can do lightly?"

Letting it out was clearly not an option, but figuring out how to transport it was genuinely tricky.

Not to mention—even if Chase was an expert interrogator, he surely hadn't interrogated a Resident before. Would he even be able to squeeze any information out of it?

She thought for a moment; noticing June hadn't said anything, Sydney turned around to find her typing away with a tap-tap-tap.

"I'm filing a report to Chase," June said. "Everything that's happened up to now."

June was asked a few times before she finally looked up with a slightly sheepish smile at Sydney.

...What a dedicated employee.

"He doesn't seem to have seen my message yet—no reply." June set down her phone and began singing his praises with what seemed like genuine admiration. "Chase isn't only incredibly sharp at analysis—he has this ability to cut straight to the crux of a matter, even through a pile of distractions..."

The crux of the matter...?

Put that way—the Vulture's greatest desire was to get out of the coffin... and what they needed was to safely deliver the Vulture to Chase.

A flash of inspiration struck Sydney, and she slapped June on the shoulder hard enough that coffee nearly sloshed out of her hand. "I've got it!"

"Got what?" June coughed for a moment, then asked.

"Can you get Chase to send a light truck over?"

"That's doable... but why?"

"Doesn't this thing want out?"

Sydney pointed at the Vulture and said, "Then under no circumstances can we open the coffin and let it out. And actually, we don't need to worry at all about how to transport it—isn't there an excavator right there?"

June looked left and right, her eyes lighting up as she grasped the idea: "That's right!"

Sydney couldn't hold back her smugness and broke into a grin: "Since the Vulture is already trapped in the coffin, letting it out and then tying it up again would just be pointless extra steps. We can take the whole thing—Vulture and coffin together."

"You've picked up that Oc-something's Razor principle too."

June leapt up from the ground and drained the last of her coffee in one go—her habits as a Hunter ran deep; even outside the Nest, she tucked the empty can into her bag and left nothing behind.

No matter how much the Vulture protested, the two paid it no mind, and with every ounce of strength they had, slowly hauled the coffin out of the burial chamber inch by inch.

The bucket wasn't wide enough to lay the coffin flat, so they had to stand it upright inside instead, which ended up blocking more than half the cab window—meaning Sydney had no choice but to walk ahead of the excavator, calling out directions to June, who couldn't see the path.

"This won't do at all,"

The Vulture was sweating with anxiety but couldn't come up with a convincing enough reason to make them let it out, so it could only plead and protest over and over: "Residents have rights, Vultures have Vulture rights... Ah, would you straighten the coffin—the corpse is slumped on my shoulder!"

"Residents don't care about that sort of thing," Sydney said.

"But I'm running on Wellesley's mind right now!" the Vulture snapped.

Nobody cared about the Vulture's wellbeing.

Just as the two—coffin in tow—were about to leave the burial chamber, June's phone chimed; she immediately pulled it out and glanced down.

"Is it Chase?" Sydney asked.

June had sent the solution and the truck request along together just now, and this message was probably Chase's confirmation—she was still turning that thought over when she saw June suddenly cut the engine and jump back down to the floor.

"What's wrong?"

June didn't answer. She walked straight to the other empty burial chamber, shone her flashlight inside, and looked it over carefully.

No one knew what she was looking for; a full minute or two passed before she suddenly let out an "ah" and reached in to pinch something between her fingers.

"There really is something... How did Chase know this burial chamber might have something in it that shouldn't be here?"

Sydney's curiosity piqued, and she leaned in as well.

In the beam of the flashlight, she saw a long, slender strand of red hair dangling from June's fingers.

Not sure why this chapter was such a struggle to write—and I still have a meeting to get through. Truly a rough day.

Sigh, if only I could write full-time.

Chapter 129 — Sydney Ginn Thinks Back: This Is the Second Time She's Encountered a Vulture

The man's dead — what's the point of such a grand, expensive coffin?

Sydney Ginn had no qualms about speaking ill of the dead; she'd cursed Wellesley up and down more than a dozen times already.

This man, even in death, couldn't let go of his rich-person airs. Just look at how much trouble he'd caused the people digging his grave.

The coffin was heavy and wide; even standing upright in the bucket, a large section of it wobbled and swayed out over the edge, as though it might topple headfirst off at any moment.

"I've tied a rope around it once,"

Sydney Ginn held one hand up against the rain and shouted to June in the cab: "Give it another try — it shouldn't fall over this time, but don't drive too fast."

It was as if the sky itself refused to let them carry the coffin away in peace; they'd barely left the burial chamber when the rain started up again — great fat drops, with an infuriating cheerfulness, generously pelting the earth once more.

The coffin's surface had been lacquered to a glossy sheen, and now that water was pooling in the bucket, it was even more unstable; after the harrowing incident of the coffin rolling across the ground, even with the ropes hastily tied around it, neither of them could quite feel at ease.

And the Vulture wasn't making things any easier — one moment crying out "he's grabbing me," the next thrashing about, slamming back and forth inside the coffin with loud thuds — if Sydney Ginn, trudging through the rain alongside it, hadn't been afraid of cracking the coffin lid, she would have gladly swung her fire axe straight at its face.

"Careful — there's a downhill slope ahead." She shouted to June, who gave a nod.

Visibility was terrible in the rainy night cemetery; the flashlight beam was filled with silver-white threads of rain, draping a fine white net over the whole world.

Amid the rumble of the excavator and the sound of the rain, June called out loudly: "You were saying you encountered an upgraded Vulture in the Nest once before?"

Even through the rain, the engine noise, and the muffled thuds of the Vulture slamming against the coffin, the two of them managed to carry on a back-and-forth conversation.

"Yeah," Sydney Ginn said, raising her voice. "I thought it was strange at the time — I wasn't anywhere near death, so why was a Vulture following me?"

She recounted the situation briefly, and even through the darkness and the curtain of rain, she could feel that June's gaze held a fair amount of sympathy — though not for the reason she might have expected.

"Even though your qualifications... hmm, what I mean is, it's not out of the question — if you put in a word through Chase, you could come to Key House as an intern. Work on your strength, go into the Nest a few times with our Hunters to get some experience."

June's tone was that of someone coaxing a drifter to earn an honest living. "Being a Hunter isn't something you can coast through — you have to keep learning. Look, even a Vulture can..."

Sydney Ginn caught her meaning and felt a surge of irritation.

"What do you think you're saying?! You're saying that as a Hunter, my skills are nothing to write home about?"

"Oh, those are your words, not mine — I was still looking for a nicer way to put it." June's face showed not a trace of embarrassment.

Unlike other Residents, the Vulture was barely dangerous beyond its ability to take on a target's appearance — it wasn't even physically stronger than an ordinary person.

From the perspective of an uninformed outsider, a perfectly healthy Hunter with no injuries had nearly been done in by a Vulture — that was genuinely not something you'd want on your résumé.

"You'd have had just as much bad luck in my place,"

Sydney Ginn was deeply unhappy; she stepped closer to the cab to make sure every word landed squarely on June's face: "Do you have any idea what kind of situation I was in when I ran into it? Unless you can fly, you probably would have fared even worse than me."

"Oh?"

Oh, my foot.

Sydney Ginn refused to let it go, and described the environment she'd been in at the time: the traffic lights on the road refusing to turn green, a hopscotch grid drawn across the path ahead, and a row of residential buildings on the side that she wasn't allowed to trespass into...

"I was essentially trapped — it was like the whole environment was working in the Vulture's favor. To move forward, I had to pass through the Hopscotch grid. And then that thing was just outright cheating! Halfway through, every single square turned 'copied.'"

She thought about it, then said hesitantly: "...Was I just especially unlucky that time?"

"Maybe so," June said, only briefly, which was rather unlike her usual style.

The two fell silent at the same moment.

In the sound of the rain, the small backhoe pressed slowly over the ground.

The cemetery was vast, covering an entire hill and its slopes; Wellesley's burial chamber was tucked deep within its depths.

Both to reach the gate sooner and to avoid being spotted, the excavator stayed off the main path and instead wound through the narrow lanes between the rows of headstones — fortunately, June knew the cemetery well enough that getting lost was no concern.

The rain grew heavier and heavier, thundering against the eardrums; conversation became impossible.

Sydney Ginn was still wearing only that garbage-bag of a raincoat, the rain beating down so hard she could barely hold her head up; she'd sweep the flashlight over the path ahead, then signal with a wave of her hand, and the excavator would rumble forward after her.

After a few minutes of this, she heard June shout something, turned to look, and called back: "What? Did you say something?"

Now was not the time for talking, and June knew it.

Through the window half-blocked by the coffin, she seemed to decide it was too much trouble, changed her mind, said nothing, and simply waved a hand to tell Sydney Ginn to keep going.

The path ahead looked equally flat and undisturbed; Sydney Ginn turned the flashlight back forward and waved again.

The excavator's wheels rolled forward, pressing onto the road ahead.

In the fragmented light and shadow of the flashlight, the rain, and the darkness, Sydney Ginn almost thought the sight of the excavator crashing down and lurching forward was a trick of her eyes — but the next second, the massive coffin that had broken free from the bucket came rolling and crashing toward her like a boulder swept up in a mudslide.

She didn't even have time to cry out before the shadow swallowed her whole.

Every hair on Sydney Ginn's body stood on end; she threw herself sideways with every ounce of strength she had — the coffin, which had to weigh several hundred pounds, grazed past her back and slammed into the ground with tremendous force, sending a spray of water into the air; she barely dodged it, but having no way to check her momentum, she crashed headfirst into a stone tomb beside her.

The flashlight went out with a crack.

She touched her forehead and felt something wet and warm, with the metallic scent of blood.

Not good — she couldn't let the Vulture get out...

Her consciousness had taken a knock, and like a rotting tooth just about to fall loose, it swayed and lurched in step with her body and her footsteps, unsteady and dragging.

After a moment's rest, Sydney Ginn forced herself to her feet, stepping through puddles of uneven depth, and made her way toward the coffin as quickly as she could.

A few steps away from it, she stopped again, pulled out her phone, and shone a light on it — and let out a breath of relief.

Although the coffin had crashed down in its entirety, the lid, thankfully, had not been knocked open.

It appeared to have rolled over; lying on its side now, Wellesley's head was still half inside the hole, and it seemed the impact had snapped his neck, leaving his head drooping crookedly to one side.

A Resident would not die so easily, of course.

When she tried pulling at the coffin lid, the Vulture had its eyes closed, groaning in pain: "What happened..."

The lid didn't budge — seeing that it was indeed still locked, Sydney Ginn felt her heart settle back into her chest; she had no time to deal with it, and turned to head straight for the excavator.

The phone's flashlight had a limited range and wasn't particularly bright; it took her several passes before she finally accepted what she was seeing, and she couldn't help feeling a bit stunned.

On the very path she had walked over moments before, a large pit had caved in, catching the excavator perfectly and pulling it down inside, tilting it at an angle, half-swallowed by the earth.

It looked almost as if someone had dug a trap in the road — light enough for a person's weight to pass over without the ground giving way, but the moment a backhoe loaded with a coffin crossed it, the earth immediately collapsed.

"June!"

She called out and circled around to the cab; with the machine half-buried in the ground, she could reach out from where she stood on the path and grab June's shoulder without any trouble. "Are you alright? Are you hurt?"

"That hurt so much..."

June had taken a worse impact as the driver; she'd been rattled around inside the darkened cab and couldn't manage to pull herself up for a long while. "The Vulture—"

"It's still in the coffin," Sydney Ginn said quickly. "Thank goodness the coffin didn't break open."

"Good," she hissed through her teeth, murmuring, "Help me up first."

"Alright,"

Since the excavator was tilted, Sydney Ginn set her phone on the ground to light the way, took hold of June's hand, and hauled her out. "How did such a huge sinkhole just appear out of nowhere in a cemetery?"

"Yeah, that's the thing," June muttered, "I filled in the pit I dug around here too..."

Sydney Ginn nearly shoved her back in.

"You dug a pit?" Her voice shot up eight octaves; she was so angry she momentarily ran out of words, and could only repeat herself: "You dug a pit?"

"No, you've misunderstood,"

June was still half-stuck in the cab as she hurriedly explained: "I was just trying to tell you earlier — I dug a grave around here. Didn't I mention it? Before burials, I have people come in to

widen and deepen the hole..."

"You dug onto the road?"

"No, no," June said quickly, in a reassuring tone: "I was working on the grave to the side. Even though we widened the pit, it shouldn't have extended into this area here... and besides, I filled it back in."

"Then how do you explain the pit on the road?" Sydney Ginn bit back her frustration and still let June brace against her as she backed her way out of the cab.

"Could it have something to do with all the rain?" June said quietly.

"Get out and on solid ground before you say anything else," Sydney Ginn said flatly. "Watch yourself — the edge of the pit is right here, and the soil is loose and slippery—"

She'd barely finished her sentence when everything around them suddenly went dark.

The two of them went still.

The phone's flashlight was hardly adequate in the rainy night, unable to illuminate very far; but its presence or absence still made all the difference.

"Please don't tell me it's out of battery. I haven't had a chance to charge it all day..."

After her heart skipped a beat, it was now pounding twice as fast as before. Sydney Ginn let go of June's hand, turned around, and felt around on the ground for a moment.

...The phone was gone.

I can take a break tomorrow!

After writing a character appreciation chapter, I can take a break... I'm planning to go see Alien — if I don't go soon, it'll be off the screens...

Appreciation Chapter: Extras Edition (let me see if this works)

"You're lying to me." Mai Minghe said with certainty.

"I'm not," Reed Hydes let out a long, heavy sigh, not understanding why the task of being a guide kept getting harder. "Why would I lie to you about this?"

"You seem like a good kid," Mai Minghe hesitated, but still couldn't quite bring herself to believe it. "But how can something this good exist in the world? You just put my story on that thing called the Internet, say a few words, and people give me money?"

"It's true," Reed Hydes said, with a complicated mix of feelings, turning the computer screen to show her.

"Even I don't know why they all like you so much... I mean, how come none of this good fortune ever comes my way? Look — this is the list."

Mai Minghe instinctively reached for her reading glasses, grasped nothing but air, and only then remembered she didn't need them anymore.

The reading glasses may no longer have been needed, but the habit and gesture had not changed; she bent forward, instinctively squinting, pressed close to the computer screen, and read each character aloud one by one: "July 26th, Toxic Sister Wei, donation — oh my, this much? That's enough to feed me for a whole week! Is this Internet thing some kind of scam? Why would Sister Wei give this much money without ever even meeting me?"

Mai Minghe's heart thumped with joy; she thought about it, then felt something wasn't quite right.

"Is it in US dollars? Aren't these just numbers? Is it really for me? I don't think she's toxic at all — she seems like a kind person."

"Pay back in dollars — dream on," Reed Hydes muttered. "These days, digital numbers are money. Keep reading."

"July 23rd, Shejiang wasn't there, wow, they gave a lot too! I'm feeling kind of flustered. And then there's Csmshksdaaa—" Mai Minghe sat up blankly. "What's that? I can't pronounce it."

"It's a name. Hurry up and say thank you."

"Oh, oh, thank you! I wonder what that child's parents were thinking when they named them..."

"It's not a real— never mind."

"Your father laughed heartily and said— hmm, what did my dad say?"

Reed Hydes tilted his head back and stared at the ceiling for several seconds before letting out a long sigh. "Say thank you!"

"My father laughed heartily and said: thank you." Mai Minghe dutifully repeated.

Reed Hydes kept scrolling down the list. When he reached July 26th, Mai Minghe squinted at it and leapt up from her chair again.

"Gunsmith Rousseau gave this much too?" She didn't know what to do with her hands and feet for a moment. "She only heard about what happened to me, and she just gave money like that? Oh, this girl, she's a bit too free with her spending... how do we thank her?"

"You could do a live stream inside the Nest," Reed Hydes said with a straight face — and immediately regretted it.

"What's a live stream? Does Gunsmith Rousseau like live streams? Is she into the Nest?"

Reed Hydes had no choice but to spend ten minutes explaining what a live stream was; when he finished, Mai Minghe shook her head. "That won't work. There's no signal inside the Nest."

He stared at Mai Minghe, and after a moment, finally spoke.

"Your grasp of new things is like something a dog has chewed on — you can't tell what's missing and what's still intact."

"Keep looking," Mai Minghe said, unbothered and now curious, pointing at the computer. "Who else is there from late July?"

Reed Hydes cleared his throat and decided not to let her read aloud anymore — because if he wasn't careful, she'd start rambling, and this list alone could take her until next year.

"World's Third-to-Last Sea Intestine—"

"Third-to-last, can't be good." Mai Minghe said. "Sea Intestine is a type of sausage, right?"

"Lucky Seven Treasures," Reed Hydes continued as if he hadn't heard her. "Chriswell, Xiwi Quiet Night."

"I used to have a classmate named Chriss— as for the other two, are those pen names?"

One word away from the truth, and she would have gotten it right.

But explaining what a username was would take another round of talking; so Reed Hydes nodded and said approvingly, "Right, they all write novels."

After that, there were even more novel writers.

"Silkflow Shimmer, Fish Growing Taller, Crazy Strawberry Toast, Sanzhu, New Account 883 Classmate, Jinjiang Qinshui, A Name That Took Me Ten Minutes to Think Of, Yuezhu Likes Adventure Stories, Why Hasn't Sanjiu Finished Collecting Friends Yet—"

Mai Minghe sat with her mouth half-open and thought for a moment. "What is it?"

"What is what?"

"A Name That Took Me Ten Minutes to Think Of — what is it?"

Reed Hydes buried his face in his hands.

"Who is Sanjiu? I don't know them either. And how does a fish grow taller, why would strawberry toast go crazy, are there adventure stories..."

Reed Hydes looked at the list and felt that the remaining three names — Ishgard Red Dress Doll Tomato, Mia'ao, and Yinglong Wants to Eat Herbal Jelly — would probably stir up even more questions.

Maybe I should just do the thanking myself, he thought. Something like Red Dress Doll Tomato — if he actually said that name out loud, would he even make it home today? What if she asked him why he was meowing in a minute?

But then again...

Reed Hydes, born and raised in Blackmoor City, was also a little curious. What was herbal jelly?

Writing a thank-you chapter this way is actually pretty fun hahaha

But the problem is, after writing all that, I've only finished thanking people from late July, and August hasn't even started yet...

At Mai Minghe's pace, thanking everyone from August would probably run to four or five thousand words — looks like I'm not getting any rest today lol.

Let's save thanking the August grandmas for next Saturday.

Feels like there have been fewer people around these past couple of days — could it be that school's starting?

Surely not all the grandmas are students, right lol

Chapter 130 — Sydney Ginn and the Lightning Vision

...Could the rain have washed the soil away, causing the phone to slide into the pit?

Sydney Ginn thought that unlikely: the phone had been placed behind her feet—no matter how heavy the rain, how could it have gone around her, looped back, and fallen into the pit?

She groped around in the darkness; but where the phone had been, and everywhere nearby, there was nothing—her hands found only empty air.

"Hey, June,"

Sydney Ginn searched everywhere and came up empty. Anxious and irritated, she wiped the rainwater from her face and said, "Come help me look. It should definitely be somewhere around here."

"That... I'm afraid I can't do."

"Huh?" Sydney Ginn turned around, ready to demand an explanation—but when she saw June's state, she froze.

June was moaning softly, slowly sliding down along the excavator until she sank to the ground, curling in on herself.

"When I was lying down just now, I didn't feel much... but the moment I stood up, I suddenly really want to throw up."

"Want to throw up?" Sydney Ginn hurried back to the excavator and crouched down beside her. "What's wrong? Are you dizzy?"

"Yeah," June said. "A little."

This is bad—she probably hit her head during the accident earlier... The moment she stood up, the symptoms came rushing in.

Sydney Ginn felt around her head. She couldn't feel any bleeding, but she still couldn't set her mind at ease.

"We can't stay at the edge of the pit. If the collapse spreads, we'll be in serious trouble."

Although June's injury wasn't light, she still had her wits about her. "Nowhere near the excavator is safe—better to stay away from it."

Sydney Ginn draped June's arm over her own shoulder and asked, "Can you still stand?"

"Yes," June caught her breath and answered. "It shouldn't be serious—I'll be fine after resting a bit. I've taken harder hits than this before."

Being a Hunter really isn't easy.

"Alright then, I'll help you over to one of the graves so you can sit and rest for a bit." Sydney Ginn supported her up and warned, "Don't you dare throw up on me."

"I'm injured. I need warmth and compassion,"

June shot back feebly, "the kind of compassion where you comfort me even if I throw up on you."

"Sorry, I wasn't born with that. You hit your head, but not your mouth, huh?"

She helped June along, walking far from the excavator before guiding her to sit down on the base of a grave.

Seeing that June seemed fairly stable, Sydney Ginn relaxed slightly, and an idea suddenly struck her.

"You still have your phone on you, right? Call my number for me—I'll go look for it."

"I do. Lucky my phone didn't fly out during the accident. Otherwise, getting in touch with Key House later would've been a real problem."

June pulled out her phone, entered the number Sydney Ginn recited, and put it on speakerphone—the dial tone rang quickly, which meant the phone still had battery; but Sydney Ginn strained her ears and heard nothing except the rush of rain.

So quiet...

Something told her it shouldn't be this quiet... and it wasn't just the missing ringtone. There was a feeling, lingering in her chest, like something was absent.

"Did you put it on silent?" June asked, snapping her attention back to the immediate problem.

Did I put it on silent?

Sydney Ginn wasn't sure herself. "Well... sometimes I find calls annoying and I do put it on silent... whether I did today, I honestly can't remember."

June stared at her with the look of someone watching iron refuse to become steel. "You're quite a rare breed of Hunter—this careless. Even without a ringtone, the screen should still light up, right?"

"Oh, right, let me check—"

Prompted by that, Sydney Ginn turned around—and saw only the curtain of rain, endlessly falling through the pitch-black darkness.

Perhaps the distance was too great; the world was all darkness, and there was no sign of any small phone light anywhere.

If the phone was face-down, it would be even harder to spot—but regardless, she had to find it.

Joy Jo was right, losing it really is no different from losing a child. Maybe from now on she should just hang it around her neck.

"I'm going to look. Keep the call going, sit still, and don't wander off," Sydney Ginn instructed.

"Why would I wander off?" June said. "It's you who needs to be careful—don't get too close to the excavator."

True enough, but the most likely place for the phone to turn up was right near the excavator.

Sydney Ginn walked back to a spot not far from the excavator and found a branch. Like a blind person feeling for the path ahead, she swept it back and forth across the ground—the collapsed section was right between two rows of graves, and she tried to comb over every inch of the ground as carefully as she could. It took a good while, and still she found no phone.

That's strange... there were only two people and one Resident here.

When the phone disappeared, only Sydney Ginn had been mobile; June was trapped in the cab, and the Vulture was locked in the coffin.

No one else was around—so how could the phone have simply vanished into thin air?

Looks like there's no choice but to head back for now...

After all, June couldn't stay on the call indefinitely.

Given the situation, there was no way to haul the excavator back out of the collapsed ground by human strength and keep driving it—Key House would have to send people to come and retrieve the coffin and the Vulture.

Fine. When they sent someone, they'd surely bring flashlights—it'd be easier to search with a flashlight. The odds might be better then.

In that case, she should have June call Key House as soon as possible. The rain was getting heavier and heavier; it sounded like a thunderstorm—she'd already heard thunder rolling in the distance several times.

A bolt of lightning split the heavy night sky, and for one instant, the world turned white as snow.

Sydney Ginn stopped dead in her tracks.

Her field of vision sank back into darkness; only after a breath's worth of time could she faintly make out the shapes around her again.

The spot where June had been resting was a grave about ten or so meters from the excavator.

But now, when Sydney Ginn squinted and peered through the dimness toward it, she found the grave was empty.

...Where had she gone? Wasn't she dizzy?

No—wait. That's not right.

That wasn't the most important thing to focus on right now.

Sydney Ginn slowly turned her head toward the excavator, not far from where she stood.

That split-second flash of lightning had illuminated everything with merciless clarity, as though it had stripped the world of a layer of skin.

At the time, she had only looked over without thinking—her gaze had instinctively come to rest on the excavator...

The cab was not empty.

Where there should have been someone, there was no one; where there should have been nothing, there was.

The visibility was terrible, and she'd lost her flashlight—so it wasn't until that instant of blinding brilliance that Sydney Ginn suddenly realized there was something beneath the cab seat, in a spot almost entirely swallowed by the earth, something... someone, crammed in there.

She looked up.

The grave where June had been resting was still empty.

Sydney Ginn walked toward the excavator step by step, remembering June's earlier warning not to get too close—had she meant the ground might keep collapsing?

She reached out with the branch and gently prodded the shadow wedged beneath the seat.

By the feel of it, it really did seem like a person...

The position this person was in would have placed them directly beneath where June had been sitting, pinned firmly beneath her.

With someone lying beneath her the whole time, how could June have not noticed—or had she noticed, and said nothing?

With a dull roll of thunder, another bolt of lightning swept across the sky, like a camera flash, searing the lit image into Sydney Ginn's vision.

"June?"

Her mind was a tangle of confusion, yet she instinctively dropped her voice low, as if afraid of being overheard. "Did you... did you come back?"

Even as she said it, she knew that was impossible.

Half of June's body was wedged beneath the seat; if you weren't looking carefully, it was easy to miss that someone was hidden there at all.

She appeared to have lost consciousness and wasn't moving; an excavator component—she couldn't name which one—seemed to have come loose and struck her, and it was still pressing down on her face.

"Wake up,"

In that moment, Sydney Ginn understood everything at once, and a wave of cold seemed to wash through her, each one colder than the last. She kept her voice down and shoved June's legs hard, twice. "Wake up, quick—something's wrong, it's the Vulture—"

Only now, at last, did she understand why everything had felt too quiet just a moment ago.

Come to think of it, she hadn't heard "Wellesley's" voice in a long time.

June let out a low moan, and finally stirred.

"It hurts..."

Her every movement was so heavy and sluggish it was maddening—Sydney Ginn kept glancing back, afraid that while June slowly came to, someone else might appear at her side.

"Have you been here the whole time?" Sydney Ginn asked under her breath. "You never came out?"

Whether from cold, fear, or the dark memory of the last attack surging back, every word she spoke trembled and wavered.

"Huh? What?" June seemed a little dazed. "Did I... did I black out? What happened to the ground?"

"Let's talk once you're out," Sydney Ginn didn't dare waste time. She grabbed June's hand and tried to pull her up—but the pull sent a jolt of pain through June.

"I've got it, I've got it," she said, hissing through her teeth. "I'm stuck."

In the vast darkness, Sydney Ginn could only make out June's vague silhouette—she seemed to be pushing off the ground with one hand, slowly wrenching herself free from the soil and the space beneath the seat, and at last managed, with some effort, to sit upright.

June sat inside the cramped cab—and then stopped moving, making no further effort to climb out.

...What was wrong?

She seemed to be staring behind herself, straining to make out something in the darkness.

The clamor of the rain had overtaken the world, crowding out almost every other sound.

A second or two later, Sydney Ginn felt it—as though someone was standing directly behind her.

My update schedule keeps drifting later and later, just like my sleep schedule... but I finally finished this chapter!

Chapter 131: Sydney Ginn's Assault on the Vulture

The person behind her was—

Sydney Ginn drew a quiet breath and told herself to stay calm.

Stay calm and think. In the current situation, there were two key points.

First, the ground had caved in, forming a large pit that had not only swallowed the lower half of the excavator but caused the whole machine to tilt and topple into it.

Both June Han had been wedged down below, following the angle of the excavator's tilt—and that was crucial.

Because of that, when Sydney Ginn stood blocking the middle, whoever was standing on flat ground behind her had no line of sight into the excavator's interior.

Second, she could say with certainty that at this moment, there should be only three people in this section of the cemetery: herself, June Han, and the Vulture.

She had no idea how the Vulture had slipped past her, or when it had left the coffin—but between the two of them, it had chosen to take the shape of June Han.

Which meant...

Without moving her feet, Sydney Ginn gestured toward the June Han inside the excavator—a single motion: stay quiet.

Whether the other could make it out clearly was up to fate now—if she was the real June Han, then she hoped she'd be sharp enough to understand that this was not the time to speak.

"June Han?"

Sydney Ginn turned her head and glanced back, doing her best to mimic the casual tone she'd used not long before, and complained without missing a beat: "I've been looking all over for you! Didn't I tell you to sit still and rest, not go wandering off? What are you doing sneaking up behind me like a ghost—you nearly gave me a heart attack."

One or two seconds passed before June Han's voice came from the darkness behind her.

"...What are you looking at?" she asked quietly. "Is there something in the excavator?"

Even though Sydney Ginn understood rationally what she needed to do, her body remained stiff and rigid.

Fortunately, the night was very dark; any unnatural expression or posture should be hidden—as long as her voice sounded normal, she might just be able to pull it off.

"Nothing. It's empty," Sydney Ginn replied, naturally.

The dim darkness behind her fell silent for a moment, then two nearly sharp-edged words rose from it.

"...Empty?"

"Yeah. Where on earth did my phone go—I can't find it anywhere. Are you still keeping the call connected?"

The June Han resting on the grave platform did have a phone, but that alone didn't prove she was the real one.

During the accident, June Han's phone had very likely been knocked out and picked up by the Vulture; after all, Sydney Ginn's own phone had gone missing too.

"Didn't I tell you not to get close to this pit?" June Han didn't answer but asked instead.

"...Ah, you did, but this is the most likely place it could have fallen." Sydney Ginn kept talking as she slowly reached her hand into the excavator and felt around.

Where had June Han left the axe she'd used to smash the coffin?

It should be on the floor of the cab, shouldn't it?

Had it been thrown somewhere during the accident?

If the June Han she had helped out of the excavator was the Vulture, then the Vulture knew perfectly well there was still a real June Han inside.

When it heard Sydney Ginn say "the excavator is empty," it would inevitably react in one of two ways: one, it might believe the real June Han had already climbed out on her own.

In that case, it would definitely come over to check for itself.

Two, it might believe Sydney Ginn had found the real June Han and was lying.

Whichever reaction it had, she had to stall for as long as possible, delay it as late as she could—ideally until after she had found the axe.

"Oh, by the way," Sydney Ginn said, still feeling around, using the question to hold the attention of whoever stood behind her: "I wanted to ask you something."

"What?"

"You passed by the coffin on your way over here, right?"

The coffin had rolled out of the excavator's bucket and fallen in front of the pit.

Earlier, fearing the ground might keep collapsing, she had supported June Han and walked about ten meters forward before sitting down on a grave mound—on the way there and back, they would have had to pass by the coffin.

Tonight was Sydney Ginn's first time meeting June Han, so she didn't know her well; on the surface she seemed easygoing and fearless.

But she was, after all, someone even Chase considered reliable.

For something as sensitive as grave-digging, Chase had entrusted it to only one person—June Han.

If anyone tried to tell her that a person like that, after an unexpected accident, would walk right past the coffin without sparing it a single glance, that would be the truly suspicious thing.

"Oh, yeah," the June Han behind her said, right on cue: "I went to check on it."

...A Vulture wearing June Han's face naturally wouldn't stumble on something like that.

Inside the excavator, the real June Han pressed both hands tightly over her mouth—perfectly still, not making a sound.

When Sydney Ginn's hand brushed against her foot, she felt it shift slightly, gently nudging her hand aside.

In that corner, Sydney Ginn's fingers closed around something cold and heavy—metal.

"How was it?" she asked deliberately. "Is the Vulture still inside the coffin?"

As she waited for the answer, she held her breath without thinking.

"...Mm, still there," said the June Han behind her. "When I went to check, the thing was actually pleading with me."

"Is that so," Sydney Ginn exhaled and said. "That's a relief, then."

Before the words had fully left her mouth, she had already wrenched her body around sharply—her arm swung out in a half-arc with the motion, and the axe in her hand came crashing down hard toward the figure behind her.

Her strength was no match for June Han's, so the surest way to win was to catch the other completely off guard—

And yet the blow she had spent all that time coiling herself up for, then hurled out in a single explosive instant—though its speed, force, and wind were nothing short of ferocious—still found nothing but air, sending a scatter of raindrops flying.

When they were companions she hadn't noticed anything, but the moment they were face to face, she realized June Han's physical technique was extraordinary—the Vulture wearing June Han's form was indistinguishable from the real thing; an instant before the axe struck, it had already ducked into a crouch, dodging the blow and planting both hands on the ground in the same movement.

It braced against the ground in order to—

Sydney Ginn hadn't even finished working that out clearly when the other's sweeping kick tore through the dark and sank deep into her calf.

...Was this the force of a human leg?

In that instant, the pain was so violent that her mind went blank for a moment.

She was not suited for close-range combat; added to that, the rain had made the ground slick, and after a blow to her leg like a shot-put, she instantly lost all grip on her balance—by the time she came back to herself, her shoulder had slammed hard into the earth, and even her bones seemed to be ringing.

Right—the axe. She couldn't let it get the axe.

Sydney Ginn jolted back to alertness and realized at once that the axe had already flown from her hand during the fall, landing several steps away.

Gritting through the pain, she was just about to roll over and get up to grab it when June Han stepped forward, cutting her off, and flipped a hand toward her—just as Sydney Ginn braced for a blow to the head, a blinding flashlight beam burst into her eyes.

"What are you doing?"

She couldn't even get her eyes open, shielding them with her raised arm, seized by a sudden rush of panic and fury, shouting without turning around: "June Han, why aren't you out here helping!"

"Move your arm," the June Han in front of her suddenly ordered.

...It didn't look like she was about to hit her?

Sydney Ginn hesitated, then lowered her arm.

There was nothing else to do—she couldn't beat her in a fight, and she was still flat on the ground, so she'd just have to play it by ear.

In the phone's light, Sydney Ginn squinted and vaguely made out June Han standing before her, holding up her phone so the glare fell directly over her face.

She bent down and grabbed Sydney Ginn's chin, tilting it upward.

What was she doing?

What was going on?

"Gone..." the June Han in front of her murmured. "So you saw the other June Han."

The Vulture arc is relatively short—by my estimate it should wrap up in about four chapters—but anything involving the Vulture is a real headache, and it got complicated enough that I actually made an Excel spreadsheet just to work through the outline...

Chapter 132 — June: Can the Vulture Read Minds?

Late at night. A torrential downpour. The ground suddenly caving in...

Everything was far too coincidental.

June raised her head, shielding her eyes from the rain with one hand, and squinted at the overturned coffin lying in the distance.

In the darkness, it was nothing more than a looming, indistinct mass—as though the night itself had been carved into the shape of a coffin, gathering a deeper patch of black within.

The phone kept ringing, one long tone after another—"beep——beep——"—and beyond that, there was only the roaring sound of the rain pouring down.

She turned and watched Sydney Ginn's figure retreating into the distance.

That girl had said that when she went to check on the coffin, she had even reached out and tried to pull the lid open—but it hadn't budged; which meant the coffin hadn't been thrown open, and the Vulture should still be inside.

Once she felt a little better, she'd go take another look.

The fall she had taken just now had hit her hard; sitting on the cemetery platform now, she could faintly feel her consciousness drifting like a fallen leaf on the surface of water, spinning slowly round and round.

The first call had disconnected automatically after no one picked up. June raised her phone and pressed redial.

"Beep——" The dial tone sounded again.

This time, the tone hadn't even finished its second ring before it cut off abruptly; the moment the call connected, June hadn't even had time to process what was happening.

"Hello? Hello, who is this?"

Sydney Ginn's hurried, shallow breath was nearly drowned out by the rain: "You—are you June?"

"...Sydney Ginn?"

June startled, and looked up toward the distant figure.

Sydney Ginn, who had just walked away, didn't seem to have found her phone at all; instead, she had picked up a stick and was sweeping it across the ground like a blind person feeling her way forward.

Which meant...

June lifted her eyes, fixed them on the coffin, and went rigid.

...The Vulture had gotten out.

Once a Vulture fixed on a target, it became identical to that person in every way—appearance, physique, manner of thinking, memory, emotion—without the slightest difference.

Sydney Ginn had also told her that it would even believe with absolute sincerity that it was the real person—

"It really is you,"

The Sydney Ginn on the phone was now speaking in a rushed, uneasy voice: "Whoever has a phone is the real person, so you're the real June, right? I'm a little foggy-headed right now..."

"Where are you?" June fought back the dizziness and looked around.

"I'm behind the coffin."

Sydney Ginn exhaled a low, shaky breath and said, "The ground caved in suddenly just now—I almost got crushed by the rolling coffin, and I lunged sideways to get out of the way... not only did my flashlight roll off somewhere, but I hit my head too."

How had everyone ended up hitting their heads? Was that going around?

"I think I lost consciousness for a bit. When I got up and came to check on the coffin, I found that the lid had been knocked open and the Vulture had escaped."

At this point, Sydney Ginn threw in a tearful complaint: "Honestly, running into a Vulture once was bad enough—and now I've run into one twice in a row..."

She paused to collect herself, then continued: "I was about to go get you, but I saw two people walking over... I couldn't see clearly, but I figured it was probably you and the Vulture, so I hid first. Did it take on my appearance? Why did you call me? Did you figure out it was the Vulture too?"

June stared at her phone, a slight frown forming on her brow.

The Vulture really was a hateful thing...

The simplest way to deal with a problem was to eliminate the problem itself—but that approach was useless against a Vulture.

"...Just now, when the Sydney Ginn with me was helping me out of the excavator, her phone was lying on the ground the whole time lighting the way—but while it was still on, it suddenly disappeared. I called her, and she went to look for it."

"I see..." Sydney Ginn murmured. "So that was the excuse the Vulture came up with."

"How do you mean?"

"The Vulture can copy our appearance, but it can't copy a phone. To explain the fact that it didn't have one, it said the phone had gone missing—that's the only explanation, isn't it."

"But when it was helping me out, the light really did go out all of a sudden."

"Huh?" Sydney Ginn was also taken aback. "Was it definitely the phone that went dark?"

June herself hesitated for a moment.

The light had indeed gone out suddenly just now, but she hadn't actually seen what the light source was—whether it was truly a phone.

Sydney Ginn had been leading the way, and had been holding a flashlight the entire time.

What if what had suddenly gone dark was actually that missing flashlight?

The heavy rain had softened and loosened the ground. Sticking a flashlight into the soil with the bulb facing up wouldn't be hard to manage; and as long as you picked the right moment to stomp the bulb out, you could create the illusion that "the phone suddenly disappeared."

She looked over—the Sydney Ginn who had just left had already walked quite far and wouldn't be turning back anytime soon.

"I'm coming to you now. Stay put," June said quietly. "I'll check on the coffin while I'm at it."

To avoid moving too quickly and triggering another wave of dizziness, she slowly rose from the platform and walked step by step toward the coffin.

The Vulture's goal had to be to take on a human form and slip into Blackmoor City—that much was certain. As for what it intended to do once it was among people, that was a separate

question.

But given that, after escaping from the coffin it hadn't taken the chance to slip away, but instead stayed and took on Sydney Ginn's appearance to muddy the waters... what was it trying to accomplish?

Was it afraid of being hunted down?

But after escaping from the cemetery, it could simply take on the appearance of some random stranger—even if Key House Faction were determined to track it down, they'd have no way to find it in a sea of people.

Without catching the Vulture and asking it directly, thinking it through on her own probably wouldn't yield an answer.

"Over here,"

Sure enough, a figure quietly rose from the shadows behind the coffin and called out softly to June: "The Vulture didn't notice you coming, did it?"

Whether this one was the Vulture was still far from clear...

Hmm, she didn't know what Chase's relationship with Sydney Ginn was like—if she just brought out the axe to tell them apart, would Chase get angry?

Using the light of her phone screen, she studied the Sydney Ginn in front of her carefully.

"The Vulture really is impressive! You two are identical," June said with sincere admiration. "Even your clothes are the same... can the Vulture copy clothes now?"

"The clothes are the same too?"

Sydney Ginn startled, and thought it over.

"The last time I encountered the Vulture, our clothes were different... well, it's possible that since it was just me and the Vulture at the time, copying my clothes or not didn't matter for whether I could attack it."

"But the Vulture can't copy physical objects, can it?"

"I think this probably doesn't count as copying objects." Sydney Ginn said hesitantly. "The Vulture was already wearing clothes to begin with. It just made its own clothes match the

target's... just like how the Vulture itself has a body of its own—it just made that body look like mine."

That made sense... the explanation held up.

Things the Vulture hadn't originally had—like a phone or a hunting knife—couldn't simply appear out of nowhere.

But even becoming an expert on Vultures, she still couldn't tell which one was the real Sydney Ginn!

June sighed inwardly and said, "Is the cut on your forehead bad? Let me take a look."

"Huh? Oh, sure..."

Holding her phone in one hand, June quietly pinched a bit of mud from the ground with the other.

She leaned in close to Sydney Ginn—close enough to hear each other breathe.

Did the Vulture need to breathe too?

In the light of the phone, there was indeed a shallow gash on Sydney Ginn's forehead.

"Tilt your head back—let me see how deep it is."

As she spoke, June lifted Sydney Ginn's chin; her mud-covered index finger pressed right against the underside of it.

"Looks pretty shallow," she said, withdrawing her hand.

As she pulled her hand back, her finger made a light swipe, leaving a smear of mud.

Sydney Ginn didn't seem to notice that she had been marked. "Didn't expect you to be so gentle."

With rain this heavy, any mark made anywhere else would be washed away before long.

All things considered, the underside of the chin was the one spot that, even if it got wet, was most likely to retain the mark—and also the spot that could be touched as naturally as possible.

"What do we do now?" Sydney Ginn asked.

"You stay put. I'll go check on the coffin."

June walked around to the front of the coffin in a few steps and examined it carefully using only the light from her phone screen.

A head drooped crookedly through the broken opening in the coffin lid.

Perhaps because the death was recent and the preservation had been done well, if you didn't look at the snapped neck bone or the section of the forehead that had been caved in, it looked almost like a pale, sleeping person—it was the real Wellesley.

Just as the marked Sydney Ginn had said, the coffin lid was indeed open.

June stared at the gap in the lid and brooded for a moment, then suddenly tucked her phone into her pocket and went over to grab the lid—her strength was considerable, but she had just taken a bad knock and was still nauseated and reeling, so it took her several tries before she managed to move the lid.

Yet no matter how much force she put into it, she couldn't get it to close all the way.

June took out her phone again and looked closely at the spot that was keeping the lid from shutting, and only then realized—whether from the fall or from water damage, she couldn't say—that the bottom of the lid had warped; once it was opened, it could never be closed again.

She was breathing hard. She let go and stood in place, thinking for a moment.

Running through what was known so far...

One: the coffin lid had warped and could not be closed once opened.

Two: the marked Sydney Ginn had said the lid was open; the Sydney Ginn who had helped her said the lid was tightly shut.

Three: the real Wellesley's head was drooping through the broken opening.

With that, the answer was clear as day—

June's heart lurched, and she immediately rounded the coffin and rushed in a few quick strides toward where Sydney Ginn had been standing.

She moved too fast and couldn't help but feel the world spin; for a split second, her legs nearly buckled and she almost fell to her knees.

June managed just in time to brace herself against the coffin and steady herself, and looked up—only to freeze.

The spot where Sydney Ginn had been standing just moments ago was now empty.

When had she slipped away?

Under normal circumstances, June would never have failed to notice someone beside her disappearing.

But the torrential rain, the pitch-black night, hitting her head inside the falling excavator...

A line Sydney Ginn had said earlier surfaced abruptly in her mind: "It's almost as if the whole environment is helping the Vulture."

June took a deep breath and strode around the coffin, heading in the direction of the other Sydney Ginn from earlier.

Despite the dizziness and discomfort, she forced herself to mentally sort out two key questions.

The first was: why had the Vulture run?

She had only just drawn her conclusion after seeing the coffin lid—yet the Vulture had apparently sensed something was wrong and vanished a step ahead of her.

Had it slipped away because of her conclusion just now?

But it couldn't read minds.

Without the ability to read minds, it had no way of knowing that June had grown suspicious of it—so why had it run?

The second question was: what would the Vulture do next?

That one wasn't hard to answer.

Just now, the Vulture had realized that June had seen through its identity, so it naturally couldn't stay put any longer. It had to go somewhere else and pretend to be the Sydney Ginn who had "gone to look for her phone," in order to throw June off.

Unfortunately, she had long since lost sight of the real Sydney Ginn who had gone to look for her phone—in conditions like these, the moment someone walked even a little farther away, they vanished into the black, rainy night.

...It really was as if the whole environment was helping the Vulture.

June stopped in her tracks.

...Was this Sydney Ginn—bent at the waist, leaning into the excavator—the same Sydney Ginn who had just been looking for her phone, or was it the Vulture that had just arrived?

I actually really enjoy writing analytical deduction scenes—it's fun to write them too—I just don't know whether they're fun to read...

Chapter 133: June's Chickens and Rabbits?

In the dim, misty rain, Sydney Ginn stood before the excavator and glanced back at June.

Her expression was hard to make out, but her tone was natural—nothing sounded off.

"...You passed by the coffin on your way here, didn't you?"

June paused slightly.

"Oh, yeah, I went to check on it."

That was the most natural answer; she couldn't have walked past the coffin without taking a look.

"How was it? Is the Vulture still inside?"

June was just about to open her mouth and answer when she stopped herself.

Regardless of who was standing in front of her, how to answer this question was worth some thought.

To figure out whether the other person was the Vulture or Sydney Ginn, all she really needed to do was check the mark—but the problem was, if the other person wasn't the Vulture and was the real Sydney Ginn, then the fact that she'd left a mark would be exposed.

The Vulture was definitely somewhere nearby. She didn't know where, but that's what June's gut was telling her.

The mark was her trump card; at the very least, she should only reveal that move when she could see and check both Sydney Ginns at the same time—otherwise, all the Vulture had to do was reach up and wipe it away, and her only advantage would be gone.

Moreover, there was another matter weighing on her mind.

Why had the Vulture slipped away early?

Shouldn't it have been wholeheartedly convinced that it was Sydney Ginn herself?

Had it evolved again since the last shift, and could now "read minds"?

On that point, she had to verify it.

"...Mm, still there."

After a few seconds of thought, June finally answered: "When I went to check, the thing was still begging me for mercy."

When the real Sydney Ginn had gone to check the coffin, the lid had been shut tight and the Vulture was still inside.

But the Vulture knew that when she had gone to check the coffin, she had only found a dead Wellesley.

In other words, the only one who could tell she was lying was the Vulture.

And from the Vulture's perspective, June had no reason at all to lie to the real Sydney Ginn—meaning that through this act of lying, June was sending the Vulture a signal: that she believed the one behind the coffin was the real Sydney Ginn.

If the Vulture had truly "read" her thoughts through some means, then it would realize that by sending that signal, she was proving she was saying one thing while thinking another.

With that, four possible scenarios could be laid out:

1. The Sydney Ginn by the excavator was the real person—she believed the Vulture was still in the coffin, and so she would have no reaction to what June said;

2. The one by the excavator was the Vulture, and it could not "read minds." It would think that June believed the one behind the coffin was the real Sydney Ginn. What reaction it would have remained to be seen;

3. The one by the excavator was the Vulture, and it could "read minds." It would discover that June was deliberately lying, saying one thing while thinking another—on the surface, the lie was directed at the "excavator Sydney Ginn," but if you thought about it more carefully?

What her mouth said was "the one behind the coffin is the real Sydney Ginn"—but when she had checked the coffin just now, the thought turning over in her mind had been exactly the opposite.

So why deliberately send this false signal?

Naturally, because June had already figured out that the Sydney Ginn by the excavator and the Sydney Ginn behind the coffin were one and the same person. In that case, it would certainly make a move;

4—

"That's a relief," Sydney Ginn let out a breath and said.

The next second, she spun sharply around, swung her arm, and a heavy rush of wind split the rain curtain and sent droplets flying as she brought it straight down toward June's head.

So it really was the Vulture in scenario three?

June had already mentally prepared herself; before it could close in, she ducked sharply at the waist and dodged the axe that came whooshing over her head.

Was that what it had been groping around for inside the excavator just now?

Sydney Ginn's technique and strength were far inferior to hers, and even with an axe in hand, June felt not the slightest disadvantage; she went with the momentum of her dodge and threw herself forward onto the ground, enduring a faint dizziness and still managing to catch herself with both hands.

It seemed that in that instant, Sydney Ginn had hesitated for a split second—as if she had sensed danger coming—this thing's combat instincts weren't entirely useless after all.

As the thought flashed through her mind, June swept her leg in a low arc and landed a heavy kick against Sydney Ginn's shin.

Under her foot, Sydney Ginn seemed to become a scarecrow bundled from sticks—she immediately lost her balance and fell to the ground, the axe flying from her grip and landing with a heavy thud several steps away.

June yanked out her phone, turned on the flashlight, and pressed the beam hard against her face.

Sydney Ginn couldn't open her eyes in the glare and couldn't get up right away; furious and seething, she yelled, "June, why aren't you hurrying up and coming out to help!"

...Huh?

In that moment, June could only feel like letting out a helpless laugh.

Well then—scenario four?

She first quickly glanced up at the excavator.

Because the excavator was tilted and sunken into the pit, it wasn't easy to see the people on the ground outside the pit from the cab's angle.

Even though she was already eighty percent sure, June still grabbed Sydney Ginn's chin and tilted it up—sure enough, the chin of this Sydney Ginn was clean, not just free of any mark, but without a single smear of mud.

"You saw another June...?"

Sydney Ginn froze.

"All right," June said quietly, "stay to one side. I'll handle what comes next."

It was just a Vulture—nothing to make a fuss about. Compared to Chase and his kind of overwhelming force, a Vulture could evolve a dozen more times and still not be worth a second glance.

As June took a few steps forward and picked up the axe, Sydney Ginn scrambled to her feet behind her and asked in a hushed voice, "If—if you're the real June, why did you lie and tell me the Vulture was still in the coffin?"

If she were to recite all four scenarios she'd run through in her head just now, neither of them would be going anywhere tonight.

"It has your phone on it," June turned around and answered. "If you don't believe me, you—"

She hadn't finished the sentence when a dark shape suddenly lunged out of the excavator, bearing straight down on Sydney Ginn; the latter had no time to dodge, let out a startled cry, and was knocked back into an embrace by the shape, sending both of them tumbling to the ground in a great splash of water and mud.

"June!"

Sydney Ginn's voice rang out from between the two Sydney Ginns as they struggled and grappled with each other—there was no telling which one had called out: "It's turned into me, hurry up and help!"

June stood where she was, axe in hand, watching the two Sydney Ginns scrap like fighting cats for a moment, then let out a long sigh.

...The Vulture was no great threat, but it was truly insufferable.

"Both of you, stop moving," June ordered. "Whoever moves again gets flattened like a groundhog."

Both Sydney Ginns valued their lives equally; the moment the words fell, they both let go at the same time and sat there panting, glaring at each other.

They'd rolled around in the mud for several rounds, and now both were equally covered in mud, grass, scratches, and streaks of blood.

June looked down—sure enough, the phone that had just been on the Vulture was now lying on the ground between the two Sydney Ginns.

The Vulture truly was a pest.

"I don't know why you won't just slip away in the dark and blend into Blackmoor City. Wasn't that your wish? You had to go and take on our appearances to confuse us... well, never mind, this works out fine too."

She didn't expect the Vulture to respond, of course, and sighed again. "Tilt your chins up. Let me see."

The two Sydney Ginns exchanged a glance, then both hesitantly tilted their chins up.

...Well. After rolling around in the mud, each Sydney Ginn's chin was muddier than the other's.

Wonderful.

"Have you figured it out yet?" the Sydney Ginn on the left complained. "I've been tilting my head back so long my neck is sore."

"My neck isn't sore," the Sydney Ginn on the right said, trying to cozy up to her. "June, take as long as you need—the one who doesn't want you to look is definitely the Vulture."

"The one whose neck isn't sore after holding that pose is definitely the Vulture!"

"That's such a childish way to tell us apart—how can you even say that out loud?"

Both Sydney Ginns weren't tilting their heads back anymore; they were glaring daggers at each other.

June thought to herself, Chase's warnings really weren't unfounded—no matter what was going on, Sydney could drag it completely off course.

"Can you two be quiet for a moment? Let me think..."

"Mm. The reason the Vulture didn't take on my appearance is because Sydney Ginn couldn't get rid of the real me. But if it took on Sydney Ginn's appearance and managed to fool me, it could use my hand to kill Sydney Ginn."

June held the axe and thought for a moment, then said, "Your goal was to get one of us killed—and since Sydney Ginn is weaker, you chose her. That's right, isn't it?"

Of course, the Vulture wouldn't respond to her.

Both Sydney Ginns started protesting—"How can you look down on people like that" and "I'm a solo hunter, you know"—and those kinds of words drifted through the air for a moment.

"I have a lot of questions, but there's nothing to be done—I'll have to wait until after we've caught the Vulture to ask them."

June flashed a grin at the two of them on the ground. "Roll up your pants legs—let me see."

"Today is really the worst," one Sydney Ginn muttered, slowly rolling up her pants to reveal both shins. "Even my underwear is soaked through."

"Who isn't," the other Sydney Ginn said, also starting to roll up her pants leg. "Why are you looking at our legs? Is this some kind of chickens-and-rabbits puzzle?...Wait?"

She stopped halfway through, suddenly struck with realization. "Right—you kicked me earlier, so there's a bruise on my leg!"

The Sydney Ginn on the left froze visibly, her flustered panic plain to see.

"Wait, a bruise? But—"

She looked down, quickly pulled up her pants leg, and glanced at her own left shin.

Before she could say another word, June's axe had already cleaved through the night and the rain, coming down with a heavy blow.

See—the Vulture arc has finally reached its end!

Lately I've been in a state of "content starvation"—novels, manga, shows, you name it—constantly searching for things to consume, but the more I read and watch, the pickier I get, and the harder it is to find something I can lose myself in...

Chapter 134: June's Whack-a-Mole, 2026 Edition

Truth be told, June had no god's-eye view of the situation, and she couldn't claim to be one hundred percent certain before she swung.

There was still some chance that this axe stroke would kill the real Sydney Ginn.

But June only needed to land the first blow to confirm who she was hitting.

The one whose skull cracked like a watermelon and leaked something red — that would be Sydney Ginn.

The one that felt almost springy when struck, yielding and pliable, sinking into the mud along with the axe — that would be the Vulture.

The reason she knew so precisely what hitting the Vulture felt like was, naturally, because she had landed squarely on the Vulture.

It even reminded her of a candy she'd eaten once — a thin hard shell on the outside, and once you bit through it, soft, springy gummy underneath. The sensation was exactly the same.

"Oh? Not bad — this is actually kind of fun to hit!"

June swung one axe stroke after another and found herself genuinely enjoying it, laughing as she said, "You could turn this into a game — each hit scores based on force, with a one-to-three-second stun effect, and you can't let the mole find an opening to get back up. Hey, Sydney, want to give it a try?"

Sydney Ginn on the left was staring blankly at June; after watching only a few swings, she couldn't bear to watch any more, and as if fighting back the urge to vomit, she wrenched her head away.

Well, fair enough — the Vulture still wore her face, after all.

Watching your own face get deformed blow by blow under an axe, sinking bit by bit into the mud, neck shattered, yet still blinking, still begging for mercy — that wasn't something anyone could stand to see.

"Stop hitting me," the Vulture called out, its voice muffled and indistinct, swallowed by the mud.

The ground had been pounded into a hollow, and its twisted, misshapen skull lay flat against the bottom of the pit, like a potsticker.

Not only had every tooth been shattered, but even the bones of the jaw were gone — it took some imagination to piece together what it was saying: "It's not easy for me to recover from this, you know. Just tie me up and be done with it. I was wrong, isn't that enough?"

"First get rid of my face!" Sydney Ginn leapt to her feet, furious.

"No," June shot that down immediately. "If it turns into me, it won't be nearly as easy to hit."

"Then tell it to go back to its own face! Out of everyone I know, you're the one I hate listening to most."

"How many people do you know?" In the span of those few exchanges, June had already nearly pounded the Vulture's skull into pulp. "Go find some rope. Count them while you're at it."

Sydney Ginn seemed not to realize she'd been talked into doing the grunt work, but she was quick about it and fished the rope out of the pit in no time.

June still wasn't satisfied and thought of another measure.

She dislocated and shattered every joint in the Vulture's limbs one by one, then signaled to Sydney Ginn to thread the rope through the broken gaps as she bound it — that way, even if the Vulture could regenerate its joints, the rope running through the fractures would prevent the bones from reconnecting.

"How did you know which one was the Vulture?"

After the two of them had trussed the Vulture up tight, she couldn't help asking. "And you were so sure of it — you just swung the axe, clean and decisive!"

...The words "there was a chance I had it wrong" were not something June could quite bring herself to say at this moment.

"When the Vulture was inside the excavator, it definitely saw me kick you," she said, nodding toward Sydney Ginn's leg.

Sydney Ginn blinked a couple of times. "And then?"

"I asked to see both your legs — from its perspective, that wasn't without purpose. It would have assumed I'd thought of something on your legs that could tell the two of you apart. So, after I kicked you, what might the real Sydney Ginn have that the Vulture wouldn't?"

"Oh, so that's why it brought up the bruise."

But Sydney Ginn suddenly frowned. "Wait, but if I did have a bruise, wouldn't the Vulture have one too, when it transformed into me?"

"That's where a certain question comes in,"

June planted a foot on the Vulture to keep it from trying anything, and answered, "When the Vulture copied you, which version of you did it copy? Before you were kicked, or after?"

Sydney Ginn paused.

"I'll tell you — it was before."

"How do you know?"

"Because when it burst out of the excavator, it had already taken your form."

June pointed to her own eyes, indicating she had seen it with her own two eyes.

"Meaning it had never gotten close to you after I kicked you — a Vulture has to get close to its target to copy it, right? It's not a phone operating system that can push an update the moment it's online."

"Right," Sydney Ginn understood now. "Because of the timing, it could only copy the version of me without a bruise."

"Exactly. Though that one demand of mine actually had two traps built into it."

Sydney Ginn shot her a skeptical look. "Aren't you the type who'll reach for the axe whenever you can? You actually set traps?"

When brute force could solve everything, who would bother with this kind of thinking — it was only because she couldn't go straight to violence that she'd been forced to use her head.

June kept those thoughts to herself and said, "One: it assumed what I wanted to see was a bruise. But only a minute or two had passed since I kicked you — bruises don't form that fast. If it actually conjured up a bruise, that would be suspicious in itself."

"What if it conjured up redness and swelling instead?"

"That wouldn't work either. Because the second trap was this: the light was dim just now, and I moved fast — I'm fairly sure it didn't get a clear look at which leg I'd kicked."

Before Sydney Ginn could catch the word "fairly," June quickly continued, "Your reactions at the time proved it clearly enough. It knew I was looking for a bruise, but it stopped midway through rolling up its pant leg; whereas you, the moment you heard 'bruise,' immediately glanced down at your left leg on instinct.

"And the Vulture was waiting on exactly that glance. Bruise or swelling — it needed to conjure it on the right spot."

When she noticed that while the Sydney Ginn on the left looked down at her leg, the "Sydney Ginn" on the right flicked a quick glance over at her instead — that was when June had essentially confirmed which side was the Vulture.

"I'll give you that — you're genuinely reliable."

Sydney Ginn let out a sigh and picked her phone up from the ground. "What now?"

"I have far too many questions." June looked down. "But we'll have to wait a bit before asking them."

The way the Vulture looked right now — it would probably get banned even in an underground film...

But a Resident was a Resident. Not only was it still alive, it had somehow, incomprehensibly, managed to hold itself together in a human shape.

The skull, shattered beyond any hope of reassembly, lay scattered across the ground along with the skin of its face, blood, and hair.

Yet when the two of them dragged the Vulture, these fragments of face-skin and crushed bone maintained the rough shape of a skull and were dragged along with the body — no matter how thoroughly the flesh was pulverized, it seemed nothing stopped each piece from acting like an "asteroid," orbiting the "Vulture core."

Sydney Ginn's tolerance for the grotesque was already far higher than most people's, and even so she kept her neck twisted away, refusing to look at the Vulture at all.

June had no choice but to keep her eyes on the Vulture herself — she also found it somewhat revolting. Honestly, if she'd known it would end up like this, she would have held back a few swings.

"Can you talk yet?"

When the Vulture's face had gradually reconstituted itself back into something resembling a human shape, she said, "Don't try shifting into either of us. Turn into Wellesley."

To allow it to become Wellesley once more and recover the knowledge and information he'd held in life, the two of them had deliberately dragged the Vulture over beside the coffin.

"Can't... can't do it anymore," the Vulture said indistinctly — something in its mouth was still moving, though it was unclear what. "He's been dead too long."

June froze.

"Who are you trying to fool? The original Vultures had to land on a hunter's fresh corpse before they could take shape—" it was the first time all day she had truly lost her temper; she was midway through the sentence when she caught Sydney Ginn glancing at her.

"Why do you think they called us Vultures? Because we follow people right when they're on the verge of dying."

The Vulture showed not the slightest fear of her anger, and said listlessly, "The reason we wait for the exact moment of death is because the body is still warm and fresh. When I was sealed inside the coffin, Wellesley had only just died, and I could still take his shape. Now he's about as close to cured meat as you can get — you want me to turn into cured meat? Isn't that asking the impossible?"

June wiped the rain from her face and deliberately drew a long, slow breath.

This didn't sound like a lie, and the Vulture had no reason to lie... In that case, bringing it back had no value.

It seemed they had no choice but to keep following the original plan. Fortunately, they still had the real Wellesley's corpse — they wouldn't be walking away empty-handed, and Chase's task could still be completed.

But regardless, the Vulture could not be left in the world of the living.

"What did you come into the human world to do?" June asked.

"To live," the Vulture said, with great feeling.

June couldn't help it — she kicked its slowly-reconstituting head.

"You wouldn't want to stay in this condition forever, would you?"

The Vulture's mouth was kicked apart again. It made a muffled "mmph."

"The way I see it, you just wanted to kill someone. Otherwise you'd have slipped away during the chaos earlier. You had every chance to leave and didn't — you stayed behind, shifting into me, then into her. That was because you wanted to see someone die, wasn't it?"

The Vulture took a moment to let its mouth recover before speaking. "You're smart enough, but you're half wrong. The one I want to kill is her. That's why I stayed — I was waiting for an opening to kill her."

Sydney Ginn startled, and pointed at herself. "Me?"

"Not just you." The Vulture spoke through its crumbling, torn lips. "Chase, Taylor Ford, and that — what's her name — Brianna..."

The two of them exchanged a glance.

Chase had mentioned it — there was a competition taking shape within the Nest, and both he and Sydney Ginn had become participants...

This thing could absolutely not be allowed to remain in the human world.

"All that ambition, so little to back it up," Sydney Ginn remarked. "Just who do you think you could kill?"

The evolved Vulture seemed deeply unable to tolerate having its professional competence questioned, and was so incensed that it blew several bloody bubbles: "Who says I can't? Didn't I just have the two of you running in circles?"

Hearing that, June found herself reminded of something.

"You have one trait now that you didn't before — it seems like whenever you're about to attack someone, your surroundings cooperate with you as much as possible. Is that right?"

The Vulture only gave a noncommittal "hmpf."

Sydney Ginn held out her hand to feel the rain — in the less than ten minutes since they'd pulled the Vulture out, the torrential downpour of thunder and lightning had faded to a thin, wavering drizzle.

A single Vulture could, it seemed, forcibly manufacture favorable circumstances within a small radius.

"That part's one thing... but how exactly did you manage to 'have us running in circles'?"

June crouched down beside the Vulture, looked at it, and asked, "Are you saying that after you shift into one of us, you can still retain your own consciousness as a Vulture?"

Writing the Vulture in this chapter, I couldn't resist throwing in a potsticker comparison — but in a Western-set story, who would ever mention potstickers!

I racked my brain and couldn't think of a food similar to a potsticker... tortilla? You don't pan-fry those in a deep pot either, right?

Eventually I decided to let it go and just keep writing — if I thought about it any longer I'd start getting hungry.

So I'm shamelessly asking you all to forgive my lack of professionalism (。

Chapter 135: June and Chase's Orders

"My, my—who would have thought that someone as clever as you could be fooled by a trick like that."

Its face was still a splattered mess of radial spray patterns, yet the Vulture was preening with self-satisfaction.

But June didn't take it to heart; instead, she flashed it a smile. "You're so clever—go on, then, tell me."

"Ever since the 17th, my thoughts and mind have gradually been growing clearer."

If the Vulture hadn't been tied up and unable to move, June suspected it would have tapped its own temple to show off how smart it was.

"Before, I was in a daze, driven purely by instinct—in essence, no different from a wild animal."

It even seemed to sigh wistfully at that.

"But after the 17th, it was as if I'd woken from a long dream—my thoughts connected in my head. While I was locked in that coffin, I examined myself properly for the first time."

The two of them couldn't help exchanging a glance.

Residents capable of thought were actually not that rare; but for a Vulture that had previously acted on instinct alone to undergo this kind of change—what was the reason?

June had a faint feeling that Chase knew the answer.

Not just Chase—Sydney might know as well. After their eyes met, Sydney immediately looked away.

"Have you ever wondered why we Vultures, after taking human form, believe so wholeheartedly that we are the real person?"

The Vulture seemed to be speaking these words aloud for the very first time, and was remarkably patient about it: "Because our purpose is to leave the Nest and enter Blackmoor City. Only by believing with our whole heart—from inside to out, from body to mind—that we are human can we have any hope of entering the human world."

Sydney furrowed her brow slightly and said, "I think I understand now. This time, when you woke up, you were already in the human world..."

"Exactly. Not only did 'believing wholeheartedly' become unnecessary, but I was also in a state where I fundamentally could not regard myself as the real person.

"I was maintaining human form while simultaneously maintaining the awareness of being a Vulture—in all of Nest history, that is probably a first."

It really did seem quite pleased with itself.

"During my time in the coffin, I thought about many things, and out of sheer boredom, I even ran a few experiments. For instance... 'incomplete transformation.'"

June was taken aback.

"You—you can keep part of yourself from transforming?"

"Yes, yes, exactly."

The Vulture spoke as though it had finally found a kindred spirit: "I thought to myself—I've already made it into the human world, so do I really have to lose my own consciousness again the next time I transform? I wasn't willing to do that."

That made sense; a creature with lower intelligence would never think to preserve its sense of self.

Only after intelligence improves and self-awareness strengthens would one begin to resist losing it.

"So I devised a method... transforming most of my body into the appearance of the target, while keeping one small area—somewhere others couldn't see—still in its original Vulture form. That way, could I not preserve my consciousness?"

The answer went without saying; the two of them had just experienced it firsthand.

Sydney drew a sharp breath and asked, "Which part did you keep just now?"

"My butt," the Vulture said matter-of-factly.

...That was certainly a safe choice.

Thinking about it, there were actually quite a few hidden spots that others couldn't see—even if from now on everyone stripped down to swimwear the moment they encountered a Vulture, it

still wouldn't be foolproof: private areas, the scalp, the soles of the feet, the inside of the mouth...

The Vulture as it was now had become a very troublesome Resident, especially in a crowd.

Yet hunters entering the Nest in groups was standard practice for every House Faction.

"After I taught myself 'incomplete transformation' without any guidance, you two were the first humans I encountered."

As it said this, the Vulture's mood seemed to suddenly grow complicated; it looked at June and said, "Everything was going so smoothly... and then you had to go and throw a wrench in it."

"Hm? What happened?" Sydney turned to ask.

Right—she still didn't know what June had run into on her end.

June hit the highlights of her own experience and deductions for Sydney—they'd already sent word for backup, and while they waited for people to arrive, there was nothing else to do anyway.

"I think when you went to check the coffin for the first time after the ground caved in, the lock had already been knocked open."

"Yes."

The Vulture was surprisingly cooperative and volunteered: "When you came, I was indeed still inside the coffin and hadn't pushed the lid open yet. From inside, I reached out and grabbed the lid.

"You couldn't pull it open from the outside, so you assumed the lock was intact. In fact, the moment you left, I pushed the lid up and crawled out."

Sydney glared at it, furious—the Vulture's trick was simple enough in hindsight, but it had been genuinely hard to tell at the time: unless you opened the lid yourself, there was no way of knowing whether it was locked or whether the Vulture was holding it shut from inside.

June continued: "The one lucky thing in all of this was that the coffin lid had warped. Once it had been opened, it could hardly be closed again—that's why I realized that whoever had been hiding behind the coffin with me was the Vulture."

Once the coffin lid could no longer be shut again, the first Sydney saying "the coffin is still locked" could be taken as essentially establishing what she had seen as fact.

"But how did you manage to slip away one step ahead of me, before I even started to suspect you?"

June still had a lingering question: "The moment I thought you might be the Vulture and went back to the coffin, you were already gone. Don't tell me you can read minds?"

"Oh my, aren't you supposed to be clever,"

The Vulture, true to its nature as a Resident, smiled in the most grating way possible. "How could you not figure that out yourself?"

When June turned to go find the axe, Sydney patted her on the arm.

"I think I know... after all, I've fought 'myself' in person before." she said.

"Hm?" The Vulture made a sound through its nose.

"The moment you stood up, the Vulture hiding behind the coffin had already transformed into you. It had your way of thinking, and it knew what you would see—combining both, it naturally knew what conclusions you would reach and what you would do next."

"Oh, that's true." June tilted her head and thought for a moment. "I really can't hide my own thoughts from myself. Now that the answer's out, it's so simple."

She smiled at Sydney. "Who knew you were this sharp!"

Sydney's face fell flat. "Do you say things like that to Chase, too?"

"Of course not—I can barely show him enough respect as it is."

"So you do know that's not exactly respectful?"

This girl truly loved chatting with her, June reflected to herself.

Once she got started she couldn't stop—Sydney probably liked her quite a bit, if she was being honest.

That's what she thought, so that's what she said—Sydney, upon hearing it, went red in the face.

Could have been embarrassment, could have been irritation—hard to say.

"Speaking of Chase, the timing is just right."

June pointed at the Vulture and said to Sydney, "Keep an eye on it—I need to give him a call and report the situation."

As she walked to the side of the road with her phone, she heard Sydney muttering behind her: "...How much is he even paying her to be this devoted..."

It's not about money!

June very much wanted to turn around and shout back, but before she could, the ringing on her phone cut off abruptly, then after a pause, a male voice came through: "...Go ahead."

"Yes,"

June involuntarily pressed her feet together and straightened her back, standing at attention exactly as she had in the military.

"Just now, the Vulture escaped and transformed to attack Sydney Ginn, but the situation has been brought back under control."

She then went on to give a full summary of everything—the Vulture's heightened intelligence, the environmental factors that had aided it, the mechanics of "incomplete transformation," and its intended targets—reporting every piece of intelligence one by one.

"Can it revert back to Wellesley?"

That was Chase all over—straight to the crux of the matter.

And he didn't seem at all surprised by the Vulture's new behavior—he had clearly already received intelligence on this.

"I'm sorry, no longer—the time of death has been too long." June said. "At least, that's the Vulture's own account."

Although she'd extracted a fair amount of information from the Vulture, she was well aware it wasn't because of any skill on her part—it was entirely because the Vulture didn't mind telling her.

Its mind had evolved, and it had developed the urge to show off and gloat, like a bird displaying its plumage; at its core, this had never been an interrogation.

The Vulture could neither die nor feel pain.

The only thing she could do was smash its form apart and cause it some inconvenience; it posed no fundamental threat, and she had nothing truly tempting to offer.

She didn't need to say as much—Chase understood it perfectly well.

"...So it's come to this after all. It doesn't matter—I never trusted intelligence from a Resident's mouth to begin with."

Chase was neither disappointed nor angry; his voice remained as even as ever.

"Bring the Vulture and the body and enter the Nest immediately—there will be people waiting to handle the scene. Once it's done, bring Wellesley's body back to be cremated. Everything has been left where you opened your passage—"

He paused, then said: "You'll find a paper bag in your backpack."

June was taken aback.

"As you've said, the Vulture now is different from before, so there's an idea worth trying."

Chase finished giving his orders in a low voice, and June glanced back at Sydney.

Somehow she'd found a tree branch and was poking it around inside the Vulture's half-reformed face, prompting a continuous stream of muffled grunts of protest.

"...Understood," June answered. "Leave it to me."

Someone asked earlier whether Chase had a contingency plan—he does, as it turns out...

Tomorrow I can rest again! How should I write the bonus chapter this time—which character should make an appearance...

Bonus Thank-You Chapter (Who is it today?)

Bonus Thank-You Chapter · Extra Edition (Who is it today?)

"Why did you bring her along?"

Chase finished the cold remark and finally looked up. "What—you think I couldn't have handled today on my own?"

June seemed to have left every mouth she had at the door before stepping inside.

She stood with hands clasped, back straight, eyes forward, and answered only: "That was absolutely not what I meant."

Chase, without sparing a single glance at Sydney loudly slurping a cola on the reception room sofa, reached out and picked up a sheet of paper from the table.

The paper had a printed list of names to thank, from August 1st through August 10th.

Though questions about how this world operated still lingered, by now every Hunter in Blackmoor City understood that this was something they would have to do from here on out.

Chase cleared his throat and let his gaze settle on the first name.

The room fell completely silent.

A minute passed, then another.

June stole a sideways glance at him, then shifted her eyes to the paper, and before she could be caught, returned to staring straight ahead.

It was Sydney who finally couldn't hold back and broke the silence: "What's wrong—is there a character you don't recognize?"

"What's there not to recognize in the three characters for 'tip'?" Chase tossed the paper back onto the table and said, "She... mm, hit—hit—"

"Thank," June said quietly, "...not hit. Can't hit."

Chase lowered his head, raised one large hand, and wiped his face—like a hero at his last stand.

"Come on, someone gave such a generous tip and you can't even say thank you,"

Sydney had already crowded over; one look at the amount and her eyes lit up. "Thank you, thank you! That's wonderful! And she's supported us more than once—honestly, am I really that great... Wait, does whoever says thank you get to keep the money?"

"No." June said, stone-faced.

"Oh." Sydney Ginn glanced at Chase and gave him a shove. "Say thank you."

"...Thank you," Chase forced out those two words from lips that were nearly pressed shut.

"Next one," Sydney Ginn pointed at the list and looked at him.

Chase looked back at her.

The room fell into dead silence again.

"Long... tall... fish," he struggled through the words as if he were an alien learning human language for the first time. "That is truly a phrase I never once imagined would come out of my mouth in my entire life."

"Thank you so much," Sydney Ginn called out toward the paper.

At the next name, the stiffness on Chase's face seemed to deepen even further.

"Jo," he said, then got stuck, lifted his head, and looked at the two beside him with something almost helpless in his expression. "Do I have to say all five i's?"

"You don't have to," June said, looking flustered.

"Say them, say them all," Sydney Ginn said, visibly delighted.

"...Thank you, jo-with-five-i's."

The name oJino, however, made Chase's brow relax slightly.

"Jin," he said quietly, "thank you."

"Where did the two o's go... the whole vibe just changed..."

Sydney Ginn muttered, only to be shot a glare by June.

"Messenger AtRnname, thank you." For some reason, Chase said this name with perfect fluency, his expression completely unchanged—as if he were naming a House Faction Hunter—and when he finished, he gave a small nod, as if approving of the name itself.

"The name Liujinqi is not only familiar, it sounds lovely too," Sydney Ginn said, simply snatching the list and taking over the job.

Chase showed absolutely no intention of protesting.

"Non-Edible Cat Gummy Candy," Sydney Ginn said, then paused.

"What is it?" June asked.

"Given how often this name appears," she said seriously, "I have reason to suspect it's actually an Artifact. The frequency is way too high..."

The other two immediately became alert.

"An Artifact?" June leaned in as well. "Could it be that an Artifact's clue snuck onto this list? Now that you mention it... some of these names do feel uncannily familiar..."

"Right? Like this one—Crazy Strawberry Toast—does eating it make people crazy?"

Sydney Ginn's eyes lit up with a golden gleam as she said, "A Daydream, No Sugar—doesn't that mean the Artifact's function is related to daydreaming?"

"Ciel Mo is probably just a username, not an Artifact," June said. "Ishgard Red Puppet Tomato, Gugu and Guagua, Lucky or Not Lucky... those all sound like usernames people would actually pick."

"Then thank you all," Sydney Ginn said loudly, "if you're not Artifacts."

"These two—Qing in Twenty-Twenty-Five, and An Umbrella Won't Help When It's Clear—they're a pair, right? Hunter partners, or something else..." June said. "The more I look at this list, the more meaningful it feels. It doesn't seem that simple..."

"Right?" Sydney Ginn turned serious and set down her cola. "Yu Yuan Eats Taro Balls, Sunshine Rots Away All My Attachments... hmm, I can't figure out what any of that has to do with an Artifact. So we just say thank you then?"

Just as the two of them were remarking on how unusually quiet Chase had been, he suddenly rose to his full height, startling them both.

"This one," he said, staring hard at the last name on the list. "Get ready to move."

"Wait wait wait," Sydney Ginn hurriedly raised both hands, "this is a thank-you list, why are you radiating so much killing intent..."

She glanced over and saw that the last name on the list was "Blackmoor City Resident."

A Resident had come in?

Today's thank-you chapter was completed despite all the drama—how wonderful, how truly wonderful.

Artifact Report subscriptions are actually quite low; it's entirely thanks to everyone's tips that we manage to make the rankings every now and then—I'm almost embarrassed about it...

Chapter 136: June's Corpse Isn't All That Easy to Use

After running into so many complications right from the start, June had expected that bringing the Vulture Resident and the corpse into the Nest would be even harder.

As it turned out, things went smoothly in a way that defied all expectations.

June took charge of the Vulture Resident while Sydney Ginn handled the corpse; after dumping the whole collapsed, chaotic, impossible-to-sort-out mess onto the relief Hunters, the two of them entered the Nest separately.

It wasn't that they didn't want to go together—June was uneasy about splitting up—but they couldn't go together.

She hadn't asked Sydney for the details, only had a rough idea, but their passages seemed to be too far apart to converge, so they had no choice but to regroup inside the Nest.

Throughout the journey, she stayed on high alert; no matter how reluctant the Vulture Resident was to return to the Nest, it never found an opening to exploit against June.

In the end, the two of them—one person, one Resident—arrived safely and on schedule at the entrance of the Museum of Modern Art inside the Nest, right within the allotted time—Sydney Ginn was at the door, dragging a suitcase, waving furiously at her.

"See, you were worried I couldn't manage on my own, but here I am, and I even got here before you did."

Sydney Ginn still seemed to be holding a grudge—before they'd set off, June, unable to stop worrying about her, had found at least ten different ways to probe and hint at her concerns.

"Mm, very early, good work,"

June's praise slipped out almost on its own: "Dragging a suitcase that heavy all by yourself—impressive."

"...Are you talking to a child?"

Sydney Ginn muttered, then glanced at the limp, broken human form in June's hands and couldn't help shuddering.

"We're already inside the Nest—why are you still carrying it? Why not find somewhere open, untie the rope, and give it one good kick? So much less hassle. Keeping it right next to you is nerve-wracking."

It was true—having the Vulture Resident along was an enormous nuisance.

The moment it sensed an opportunity to attack, even the surrounding environment would start reshaping itself to help it.

To keep it from getting any ideas, every few minutes June would carefully re-break and smash its body, tighten the ropes, and seal its mouth shut.

On top of staying vigilant in every direction the whole way through, by the end she felt more exhausted than she ever had before—the mental pressure seeped into every crack, saturating her body until she was nothing but a wrung-out, sodden towel.

And on top of that, she still hadn't had a chance to change out of her rain-soaked clothes, so she really was practically a wet towel.

"Don't you think I'd love to throw it away if I could,"

June sighed and said, "I'm keeping it just in case. If the corpse doesn't work, we might still need to force it to turn back into Wellesley... I know, I know, it said it can't anymore. But who knows if that's true? Even a partial transformation would help."

Sydney Ginn shuddered again.

"Then you'd better keep a close eye on it," she warned. "This is where I had my last life-or-death fight with the Vulture Resident—I'm still haunted by it."

According to her, at some unknown point, a massive candle had formed on the first floor underground—over a person's height, and dozens of meters long.

Given its size and length, there was no way to move it out without demolishing the building above.

It couldn't be taken back—that was somewhat of a problem...

Sydney Ginn had discovered it by chance, which meant there was no guarantee a second Hunter wouldn't find it too; how were they supposed to make it Key House Faction's property rather than a sightseeing spot open to anyone?

They couldn't exactly mark the perimeter the way an animal would.

But people are strange that way—even as June was fretting over how to move the candle out, she was also quietly dreading that she might step into the first floor underground and find the candle gone.

When she finally stopped in front of the enormous candle that stretched across the exhibition hall, June stared at it for a few seconds, then turned and clapped Sydney Ginn on the back with a grin: "You weren't lying!"

"Ow, that hurts—of course I wasn't lying!"

"I was worried. If this turned out to be a trap and there was no candle at all, I would've had to fight you."

June let out a long breath, patted her chest, and said, "Don't let your small build or your lack of experience fool you—I actually really enjoy going on missions with you. Makes everything feel light. If I absolutely had to kill you, I'd at least need three... one day where I couldn't eat."

"How did it go from three days down to one?" Sydney Ginn was so annoyed she couldn't even find the right thing to be upset about. "Can we just get started already, honestly!"

She muttered under her breath, dragged the suitcase to the center of the hall, and unzipped it to reveal the corpse inside.

Wellesley had been dead for several days, and after the embalming, his body had long since gone rigid.

Before setting out, they'd had no choice but to smash all the joints, and with tremendous effort managed to fold the limbs over each other and curl the body into a shape that fit inside the suitcase.

After doing something like folding a corpse, Sydney Ginn seemed almost numb by the time she was hauling it out—her face wore an expression of pure resignation—and at the same time, June wasn't idle either.

The first thing was to tie the Vulture Resident firmly to a pillar.

Only after confirming it couldn't break free did she take out her phone and photograph the candle and all the explanatory text on the surrounding walls, one by one.

Next, she pulled a folding tripod from her backpack and set up a camera directly facing the candle; beyond that, she also held a small handheld camcorder in her hand.

One to record the entire process, one to capture the candle's contents.

"I'm ready, we can start recording," June called out.

"Can we swap tasks? Why am I always the one touching the corpse?"

To avoid direct contact with the body, Sydney Ginn had put on a pair of work gloves. She dragged Wellesley over to the candle, lifted one of his hands, and pressed it against a spot at random.

"Go check the top of the candle—has his birthday appeared yet?"

June's lens swept across Wellesley.

Wellesley's pallid, grayish face lolled limply beside the candle.

His stiff corpse—joints smashed, folded and then stretched back out—was twisted into a distorted shape like an elongated "Z," both legs dragging on the ground, his upper body suspended in the air by one hand.

This was the man who had once been surrounded by admirers and had his word treated as law, a billionaire without rival... reduced now to a discarded piece of equipment.

If anything, the more wealth one had in life, the more pitiful the sight after death.

Hmm, why was she even feeling sympathetic toward him.

As June's lens moved away from Wellesley and settled on the candle, her heart gave an involuntary jump.

"It's showing—great, the corpse works."

She said with a grin, "So pressing a dead hand to it works too. I wonder if a severed hand would also work... hmm, something to try next time. We could try both a living hand and a dead hand—lots of potential there, lots of potential."

"Even if Hunters aren't a wholesome bunch, you really have no restraint," Sydney Ginn muttered. "When's his birthday?"

The inscription "1967.5.22" had appeared at the top of the candle—consistent with the information they had looked up before entering the Nest.

"How far back does Chase want to know about him?" Sydney Ginn asked.

"Oh, he never actually gave me a range. How about... one year?" June frowned and said, "But if we go through it day by day carefully, would that really take us a year?"

"Honestly, I'm not too sure either. Last time I didn't even get a proper chance to use it..."

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment, then suggested, "I think we should start from the day he died—what do you think? We look at what happened on the day he passed, maybe there's a clue there."

"Sure, whether we start from the beginning or work backward, we'll have to look through it all anyway."

As she spoke, June strode toward the tail end of the candle. The last day of Wellesley's life corresponded to the very end of the candle—the candle could not foretell the future.

Sydney Ginn set down the corpse first, knelt on the ground, and opened the fire groove corresponding to November 16th.

Before long, the candle in the camcorder's lens softened and melted, drooping downward, and a transparent, lustrous sheet of Candlefall hung suspended in midair like the surface of a still lake.

June held her breath.

Even though she had known intellectually what she was about to see, the moment she truly saw a tiny, living Wellesley dragging his feet as he walked into a study, she couldn't suppress the astonishment rising inside her.

...This was what he had experienced, what he had seen, on the last day of his life?

No matter how long you'd been a Hunter, Artifacts and the Nest could still catch you off guard.

The tiny Wellesley appeared to be dealing with work, sitting alone at his desk, motionless for a good while.

He was alone the entire time—could it really have been a heart problem after all...

Sydney Ginn reached out a hand and gently stirred the Candlefall, as though fast-forwarding a film, nudging the time forward—but then the Candlefall suddenly went blank, the study and the little figure both gone.

June looked up and met Sydney Ginn's equally startled expression.

"What happened?"

Sydney Ginn adjusted the flow back and forth a few times without figuring it out, then grabbed the corpse's hand and gave the candle a hard slap, as though she thought it was a broken television.

"Did I go too far? Has it already died out here?"

June looked at the spot the corpse had touched and asked, "Does the corresponding date only appear when the person themselves touches the candle?"

"That's right," Sydney Ginn answered.

"Look," June said, pressing the lens closer. "This section here—it should be showing November 15th, right? The part we melted is already the very end, so what you accidentally touched just now was the position for the day before."

Sydney Ginn looked.

After a few seconds, she asked, "...Where's the date? Why isn't anything showing?"

"Drag the corpse along and let's move toward the middle," June gestured, "and see whether the dates before this section are continuous."

That question was answered half an hour later.

The candle, which should have displayed every moment of Wellesley's entire life, was now shrouded in a thick fog that gathered and dispersed in turns.

Wherever the fog obscured the surface, either the dates were missing, or the scenes were missing.

Over a span of roughly one year, they had pressed the corpse's hand to the candle twenty-five times, but only twelve presses had produced a date; of those twelve days, only three had complete events with clear scenes.

The two of them exchanged a look, and from their expressions, June knew they had both arrived at the same answer.

"It's because he's dead, isn't it," Sydney Ginn guessed. "If we'd come even a little later, there might be nothing left on the candle at all."

"Sure enough, the function of altering the past isn't so easy to use."

June felt the strong urge to sigh. "I was already thinking on the way here—if a dead person's experiences could also appear and be changed, wouldn't that mean death could be reversed? Turns out there are limits to it after all."

"So what do we do now?" Sydney Ginn asked.

June looked at her.

"Why are you looking at me?" Sydney Ginn grew wary.

"Nothing... since the records are incomplete, we can only document what's left. Going through it bit by bit—that's a real grind. Think you can manage?"

For some reason, reverse psychology always worked on Sydney Ginn.

"Step back with your camera," she snapped into action at once, "the corpse is coming through!"

This chapter title could open a whole debate between June and Lin Sanjiu—"Is a Corpse Useful or Not?"—with Lin Sanjiu on the pro side, and June on the con side.

Speaking of which, Sydney Ginn's small build is only small in relative terms. Compared to Chase and June, she's a little chick; compared to me, she's a female strongman.

If I had to drag someone weighing over a hundred and forty pounds back and forth, I couldn't do it... and I suspect most people couldn't either.

Chapter 137: Key House Video Records (I)

2026.11.20

6:37 AM

REC.

Location: The Nest, Museum of Modern Art, Basement Level 1 Exhibition Hall

"...Is this fun?" June's voice asked from off-screen.

"Solving problems—why wouldn't it be fun?"

Sydney Ginn tilted her head back, flashed a breathless grin at the camera. "My method for moving the body isn't bad, right? You didn't even think I could pull it off."

Beside her was a bizarre contraption—a corpse merged with a suitcase.

Wellesley had been stuffed back into the suitcase once more; this time, the body wasn't curled up inside—only his legs were secured in the case by the zipper, and when the lid closed, it caught right at the corpse's hips.

The upper half of the body leaned against the telescoping handle, held in place by a belt; from a distance, it looked just like a person sitting on top of the suitcase of their own accord.

Wellesley had been buried in a suit, and his trouser waist was bare—no belt, of course.

"...As long as you're willing to do the work," June's voice said off-screen. "We need to melt the candle sections from January 2026."

"On it!"

Sydney pushed her makeshift body-cart with one hand and steadied the corpse with the other, rolling straight across the frame, the echo of wheels filling the entire hall.

In the camera's view, the fire grooves beneath the tail end of the candle had all been opened, lighting a bright line of flame across the floor.

Short stubs of candle had all turned to Candle Tears, drooping down into mid-air; the tears hung suspended, flickering and glowing in the light and firelight.

Of the Candle Tears that had dripped down, at least half were hollow and semi-transparent—incomplete images and scenes floating on the surface like fallen leaves drifting on a lake.

"Perhaps because the one who touched the candle is a dead man,"

June explained from off-screen: "Roughly sixty to seventy percent of Wellesley's pre-death history preserved in the candle is missing. I plan to melt all the candles covering roughly the last year before his death and then record whatever history is recreated."

From somewhere off-screen, Sydney called out: "You can actually speak normally, you know?"

"What's that supposed to mean—the people watching this recording are—never mind." June cleared her throat and asked, "Have you found the January section yet?"

With her words, the camera followed along, and Sydney appeared on screen with her makeshift body-cart.

"Found it,"

She had just tucked Wellesley's arm back in and was repositioning the body, steadying it so it sat upright. "The fire groove is open too—we should be able to see the history any moment now."

The Candle Tears slid down softly, reflecting fragmented scenes and the tiny figures of people coming and going.

"Hey, this one is..."

June seemed to give a start—the camera immediately zoomed in, and a close-up of Wellesley filled the frame.

Her voice explained from off-screen: "This is the first image preserved from January; everything before it is blank."

As a shrill, droning alarm rang out, Wellesley looked as though he'd been waiting for it—he snatched his phone from the table in one swift motion.

"So it's finally here... Now I'm an official participant too. Hmm—though you joined before me, you're still on my team."

He looked down at the phone screen, scrolled a few times, then tossed it on the table. "But... is this for real? Gather a few specific things and you can control the Nest? It all feels a bit like a game."

Beside him stood a shadowy figure.

The figure was thin and faint—nothing was discernible beyond a rough human shape, and whatever the other person said in reply had been swallowed up by the Candle Tears.

The Candle Tears went blank for a moment before Wellesley surfaced in them again, a small smile on his face.

"...With our resources, and without any competitors, gathering seven Artifacts shouldn't be difficult at all, should it? What's more, a few of them seem very similar to things I already have in hand. Do you know how to verify which ones they are?"

Then, another stretch of blank.

"It seems we won't be learning the verification method." June called from off-screen, "Sydney, scrub the timeline a bit."

A hand that could only belong to Sydney reached gently into the Candle Tears and nudged them forward, skipping past several scenes.

June spoke from outside the frame, watching the Candle Tears' contents and narrating as she went: "Less than half of January's events have been preserved. The history that follows doesn't seem to have much to do with Artifacts or the Nest—it's mostly memories left over from his work and daily life... Hmm, you can speed up a little."

"Exactly—if we don't speed up, twenty-four hours of content in the Candle Tears would take us twenty-four hours to watch. Who could stand that."

As Sydney spoke, she skipped through January and the footage moved into February.

In early February, Wellesley received a text message confirming he had just acquired one of the target Artifacts—though which one specifically remained unknown.

"Less than a month, and he already got his hands on a target Artifact. The old man wasn't blowing smoke after all."

Sydney sounded a little reluctant to admit it, as she scrolled forward a few times and fast-forwarded past the parts unrelated to Artifacts. "Having money really is something—even Artifacts can be collected just like— huh?"

"What is it?" June asked.

Sydney's hand paused, then nudged the Candle Tears back a little. "He just said something that sounded a bit like... let me listen again."

The Candle Tears were wound back a few days, and in the frame, Wellesley's conversation with several men and women began to "play" again.

"That person— isn't that the Blackmoor City Mayor?"

June seemed to startle—her hand reached into the frame from off-screen, pointing at a man seated behind a desk. "There's a national flag standing behind him too... That room must be the Mayor's office."

"Mr. Wellesley, I don't understand your reasoning here."

In the Candle Tears at that moment, the Blackmoor City Mayor was speaking in a consultative tone: "The current Chief of Police at Central has an impeccable record—both in seniority and performance—and has done us quite a few favors. His term isn't up yet; suddenly proposing to replace him like this..."

"He has always done his job well. I have no grievances against him."

Wellesley leaned back in his chair, voice low; the Mayor had to lean forward to hear him.

"So if there is anything I can do to help make up for this transfer, just say the word. But I need Ashley Paige in his seat before October. Consider it a favor I owe you."

Off-screen, Sydney drew a sharp breath.

"This Paige... well, it's not entirely unworkable." The Mayor flipped open a folder and glanced at it. "I'd like to ask—why?"

But just as the conversation reached that point, the Candle Tears went blank again.

"That Ashley—Chase and I both know her!"

Sydney sounded quite worked up: "When we were brought into Central Police Department, we dealt with her... Wait, so it was Wellesley who put her in office? Why? Do they know each other? These gaps in the Candle Tears are so frustrating."

"He may not have told anyone his real reason," June said. "Let's keep watching."

The next couple of weeks' worth of content had little to do with Artifacts or the Nest—Wellesley seemed to have a good relationship with his wife, and even in the fragmented, half-

chewed-up remains of history, several scenes of the two of them dining and chatting together had survived.

Then, near the end of February, Wellesley received a phone call.

The call was brief; from the video footage, all that could be heard was him saying a few things like "thank you," "I won't forget this favor," and "have him come find me," before he hung up.

As though sensing the importance of the call, the camera lingered on the Candle Tears—neither of them reached out to fast-forward.

Wellesley sat at the table, considered for a moment, then picked up the phone again.

"...It's me. The Mayor has issued the internal transfer order... Yes. He's asked for a little time, but the Chief of Police at Central should be replaced before October. Now that this matter is settled—when can I expect to receive it?"

Whatever the person on the other end said, Wellesley's brow furrowed.

"...You don't know either? Isn't this your source?"

His tone was heavy and sharp, without any courtesy: "Receiving it now versus receiving it only after Ashley officially takes office—that's a gap of seven or eight months. Do you know how much progress we could make in seven or eight months? Are we supposed to just sit around waiting? Here's what I'll say: if I haven't received it within one week, you go into the Nest and find out."

"So it does have something to do with the Nest after all... It looks like, once Ashley takes over as Police Chief, he's supposed to receive something." June murmured.

"Receive what?" Sydney asked, blankly.

"Look carefully at the next week's history," June's voice took on a more serious note.

Yet the surviving history from that one week was especially sparse; in some scenes, not even a single sentence was completed before everything broke off into blank.

"Go frame by frame," June said. "Even if only one word survives, we can't let it slip past."

The recording silently captured every surviving image in the Candle Tears.

At some point in early March—the exact date unclear—Wellesley suddenly said: "It will be delivered to me in a form that cannot be forged?"

The line surfaced from a stretch of blank with no beginning and no end, flashed by and was gone.

The scene, the image, the person he was speaking to—all that context was missing, leaving only that one sentence behind.

"What on earth is this thing?"

Sydney was clearly burning with curiosity, examining the Candle Tears over and over again. "If the truth isn't in the Candle Tears, I'll be absolutely miserable."

"He's probably about to receive it," June mused. "Let's look more carefully."

Despite living in the information age, Wellesley seemed to be a man of old habits, still keeping up the custom of reading a physical newspaper every morning.

This scene had appeared several times before: when he finished breakfast, a servant would bring him the paper.

In the camera's frame, Wellesley unfolded the Blackmoor Times as usual—then his movements stopped cold.

Facing the empty dining table, he murmured: "It's here... I've received it."

On the newspaper, where the front-page headline should have been, only a single line of four large characters remained.

"Artifact Report"

As everyone knows, I have two cats.

Both cats eat the same cat food, in the same amounts, and neither gets treats (one gets an upset stomach from them, the other simply refuses to eat them).

Living together like this, eating and sleeping side by side, and yet one cat is skin and bones while the other is so fat that picking it up is a health hazard—I truly cannot understand why this is.

PS: The title of this book finally appears on the page! Proof that I didn't just pick it randomly! How wonderful, how wonderful!

Chapter 138: Key House Visual Record (II)

Artifact Report

Only those who have changed the world deserve the right to move forward

Dear Contestant Wellesley:

Upon learning that Ms. Ashley Paige is set to be appointed Chief of the Blackmoor City Central Police Department this coming October,

the Nest sincerely thanks you for your enthusiastic response and the decisive action you have taken toward this end.

For the change and influence you have brought about, the Nest wishes to offer you a token of return, in hopes that it may lend you a hand on the road ahead.

Artifact Name: Extracorporeal Telomere

Artifact Function: By wrapping a telomere chain around the body externally, the user can reverse their age and restore themselves to the peak of their physical, mental, and psychological condition.

As long as the chain remains on the user's body, they will maintain this peak state and will not age with the passage of time.

Upon removal, the user will immediately revert to their original condition, plus the aging that would have naturally accumulated during the time the chain was worn.

If the user has not yet reached their peak (for example, if they are still an adolescent), this Artifact will have no effect.

Although it is called a "chain," it is biological in texture, will not rust, and can be safely worn in the shower.

Capture Window and Location:

Beginning on the 13th of each month, the "Extracorporeal Telomere" may be captured within the Nest in the areas corresponding to St. Louis Hospital, Broom Street, and the Blackmoor University Law Department.

It appears to be black.

Note: The Extracorporeal Telomere may change shape before and after capture. If you observe a black object of non-chain form moving around, please take care to note it as well.

Causal effects produced after this Artifact enters the human world: Is it the origin that set everything in motion? Hard to say. Further details unknown.

Usage Time Limit:

(PS: At this point an image gap appears within the Candle Tears. From the usage time limit onward, several lines of text are replaced by a series of broken, intermittent blanks, with only the following three words remaining visible.)

Domination Game

Target

Preference

(PS: From "Preference" onward, the text becomes clear again.)

Action Points to Obtain the Next *Artifact Report*:

1. Replace the Blackmoor City Mayor with a "Vulture" Resident.

If this option is completed, the probability that the "Nest Domination Game Target Artifact" will appear in the next *Artifact Report* is 78% (hereafter referred to as the "Target Probability");

2. Acquire the Hunter House Faction Knight House Faction; Target Probability 61%;

3. Find a method to transfer a passage; Target Probability 95%.

Complete any one of the above actions before December 1st, 2026, and you will receive another *Artifact Report*.

The number of actions completed corresponds to the number of *Artifact Reports* received.

The Nest hereby wishes you smooth sailing, the capture of your target, and the seizure of the highest throne in the Domination Game.

Please also take good care of yourself—on the path toward becoming the Ruler, the closer one draws to the end, the more dangerous and arduous the road tends to become.

"What is this?"

From off-camera, June murmured, "There's actually something called an *Artifact Report*? Who wrote it, and who sent it to Wellesley? Can information from the Nest be delivered directly into the human world?"

"Eh, who cares who wrote it—it's not like the Nest is short on mysteries without answers."

Sydney was rather unbothered about it. She said, "The action point Wellesley chose to complete was the first one, right? The reason he wanted to bring the Vulture into the human world was to replace the Mayor, right?"

The camera wobbled slightly.

From the feed of a second camera mounted on a tripod, both women could be seen turning their heads at the same moment to glance at the Vulture bound to the pillar.

"So all that scheming to get the Vulture into the human world—it was to complete the first action point," June murmured. "Fortunately, he died before he could finish it."

"Knight House Faction hasn't been acquired either, right?" Sydney asked.

"Not as far as I know."

June thought it over and said, "The third action point has the highest probability of getting intelligence on the Target Artifact. Wellesley wouldn't have let that slip by. Let's keep watching carefully. If he truly found a way to transfer a passage before he died..."

She didn't finish the sentence—she stopped.

Two seconds passed. Sydney let out a soft "Hmm?" "Chase... does he want to enter the Nest?"

"Honestly, I can't say for certain. Chase doesn't really talk to people about how he's feeling."

"Having the option is better than not having it, isn't it?"

With those words, the camera feed dimmed as Sydney's face filled half the frame.

She waved at the camera and said with a smile, "We'll keep looking for clues on this. Once you've finished watching, think about how you're going to thank me."

June looked flustered for once: "I'm not doing this to thank you—this is my assignment—"

"Yes, yes, I know. The moment the camera's on, you get so stiff and proper. Who even are you." Before stepping out of frame, Sydney said, "Keep watching."

Although nearly seventy percent of the content had vanished along with Wellesley's death, the remaining thirty percent still amounted to an enormous volume of information.

The two of them fast-forwarded through the historical footage from time to time based on the content; even at the accelerated pace, they were forced to swap out the battery once along the way—June was meticulous, and the footage before and after the interruption matched up seamlessly.

A minor incident from the end of April drew no attention from anyone—not the Wellesley on-screen, nor Sydney and June watching from outside the frame; the moment he accidentally cut his hand was fast-forwarded past and flashed by in an instant.

In early May, he made a nighttime trip out, and the last car in the convoy suddenly flew sideways and slammed headfirst into the back door of a building along the road.

"Hey, that was me," Sydney said, looking a little sheepish, snickering a couple of times. "Didn't think it would end up on here... scared him half to death, didn't it."

"No idea what he went out for that night," June said, skipping past another blank stretch with her hand. "There's just so much missing."

In any case, Wellesley seemed quite satisfied with his progress in collecting the Target Artifact.

In September, on a whim, Wellesley decided he wanted to go for a late-night swim in the pool at home.

His home had an indoor infinity pool; from the water, you could look out and down over most of Blackmoor City from a great height—when this scene first appeared in the Candle Tears, both women couldn't help but let out a gasp of admiration.

Wellesley had just slipped off his bathrobe at the edge of the pool and was about to get in when he suddenly remembered he'd left behind a glass of vegetable juice he'd poured earlier, so he turned and went back inside to get it.

"Let's just fast-forward past this part," Sydney said, stifling a yawn. "I'm so sleepy. It's past ten in the morning and I still haven't slept."

"Sure, that works. I'll speed it up a bit."

June said so and reached out to do it—then stopped.

Wellesley walked back out carrying a glass of celery juice; for no apparent reason, he swept a glance toward the far end of the pool and froze.

He strode over quickly; the urgency in his step puzzled both June and Sydney watching from outside the frame.

In the water at the corner of the pool, a long power strip lay sunken at the bottom.

The cord attached to the power strip crawled out of the pool and up onto the edge, running all the way to the wall outlet, where the plug was inserted.

"Who's there?"

In his agitation, the glass slipped from Wellesley's hand and shattered on the floor. "Who's hiding here? Get out!"

The footage ended abruptly there, cutting back to a blank expanse.

"The historical footage from just now said it was only him at home that evening, right?" Sydney asked blankly. "...The housekeeper had taken leave, the servants had gone out, his wife hadn't come back yet. Wasn't he the only one home? At least on this floor—the bodyguards were downstairs too."

June thought for a moment.

"Right," she said slowly. "And on the side facing the pool there are floor-to-ceiling windows facing the bar area directly. If someone had been tampering with anything by the pool, he shouldn't have failed to see them just now. Could that power strip have been in the water the whole time, and neither of us noticed it?"

"Let's keep watching—did he find anyone in the house?" Sydney said.

Wellesley, appearing in the footage once more at this point, was saying into his phone: "Dylan, bring a few people up. Something's come up at home."

The search footage was also absent from the Candle Tears; the two of them watched all the way through to October without ever learning whether he had found anyone in the house that night.

Even from the thirty percent of memories that remained, it was clear that Wellesley had grown increasingly rattled and jumpy; the way he carried himself, perpetually anxious and on edge, made it seem as though he would only feel safe if a bodyguard were holding him at every moment.

"And in the end, we still couldn't make out how he actually died,"

When the recorded content reached the end of the candle, Sydney stretched out in a long, full-body yawn. "I'm done. I'm practically dead on my feet. I've done what Chase asked of me—I'm going home."

"It really has been a long night," June said, setting the camera down on the floor.

The frame showed only the two pairs of feet; they walked over to the fire groove and turned off the flame, and the Candle Tears slowly withdrew upward, disappearing from the frame.

"Are you leaving too?" Sydney asked.

"No, I'm planning to stay," June said. "Chase wants to see Wellesley's life history, but now that only thirty percent is left, it won't be easy to give him a proper account—he definitely won't be satisfied. I'll push the Vulture a bit harder and see if I can get it to transform back into Wellesley."

"How much is he paying you a month, exactly," Sydney said, equal parts impressed and bewildered. "Are you gunning for Key House Employee of the Month?"

"Just go already," June said, seeming to have a lot more to say, then swallowing it all back down.

"Alright, I'm off. We can figure out what to do about the Candle Tears later."

With the sound of those departing footsteps fading away, the exhibition hall gradually returned to silence.

June did not pick up the handheld camera; rustling sounds filled the exhibition hall—it sounded as though she had unzipped her backpack and then opened a paper bag.

"Oh, it really is in here," she said quietly.

The Vulture's voice cut in without warning.

"See? I told you I wasn't lying."

It seemed to have fully recovered—its speech was clear and fluid.

"That man is dead and dried out like a piece of cured meat. There is absolutely no way I could access his memories and thoughts by transforming into him—that much is certain. So even if you waste any more time torturing me, it'll still be..."

"I know."

The Vulture was silent for a few seconds. "You know? Then why did you..."

Its words came slowly; midway through, a question it clearly couldn't hold back any longer finally forced its way out: "Actually, never mind that for now—who are you? How come I didn't see you earlier?"

June's voice came from off-camera.

"It doesn't matter who I am. What matters is—you've been close to the girl who just left, and you remember her, right? Her name is Sydney Ginn."

"Yes... I remember her."

"Good," June said, her tone calm and unhurried. "I need you to take her form and touch the candle."

Lately, as I write, I've gradually developed a habit of trying to avoid rhyming sentences (I wasn't very careful about this before, but recently I've been quite mindful of it). After all, this isn't poetry—rhyming sounds nice in the moment, and then it's over, but a novel is so long that having a sudden rhyme sneak in partway through always feels odd to me.

By the way, lately I've had a sudden urge to write a lighthearted comedy! I've even thought of a title already...

Chapter 139: Key House Video Record (III)

2026.11.20

12:09 PM

REC.

"Next up — Sydney Ginn's personal history."

The handheld camera that had just been set down on the ground was picked up again by June, held level, framing a section of smooth white candle.

Her voice came from off-screen: "...The Vulture cooperated well enough to take on Sydney Ginn's appearance — perhaps because of the Artifact on my face, it couldn't identify me and couldn't copy my form."

As she spoke, she turned the camera lens toward her own face.

On screen, June had a paper supermarket shopping bag pulled over her head, with three holes cut out — one for each eye and one for her mouth.

She couldn't help but laugh at herself; the eyes visible through the holes in the paper bag crinkled with amusement. "This does look a bit strange."

The lens immediately swung back to the Vulture — it had already taken on Sydney Ginn's appearance by now, but its expressions, movements, and physical habits looked nothing like Sydney Ginn.

"For the sake of convenience, I let it keep one part of its own body, so while it looks like Sydney Ginn on the outside, its mind is still its own."

June's voice came from off-screen: "But the Vulture told me it only handles the transformation — it makes no guarantees about how completely Sydney Ginn's history will appear in the candle.

"Because the last time it was in close contact with Sydney Ginn was at the museum entrance — which means there was a gap of seven or eight hours between when it last touched her and when it transformed into her.

"The Vulture says that if too much time has passed, it can't transform; and even now that it can, the further back the memories and history go, the blurrier they'll be. That thing is more trouble than it's worth."

"At least have the decency to turn away before you say that — you're acting like you never want to work with me again."

June ignored the Vulture and continued from off-screen: "For that reason, there's no need to start from the day Sydney Ginn was born unless it becomes necessary."

"What I think will be worth paying attention to — what'll be valuable to us — should mainly be after she became a Hunter. So I'm going to work backwards, recording all the significant events of her Hunter career."

"Are you making a documentary?" The Vulture grew impatient. "Finish sooner, split sooner — do you think I enjoy being led around by you like this?"

As it spoke, it walked toward the candle on its own; the rope tied around its neck was still held at the other end by June, swaying in the air before pulling taut.

At June's instruction, the Vulture placed its hand on the candle and opened the fire groove.

Candle Tears once again flowed slowly through the air, revealing another person's life.

On the 20th and 19th, Sydney Ginn had spent most of her time together with Chase and June; the moments she was alone amounted to nothing more than rest and meals.

On the 18th, London Moon appeared on screen.

That day, Sydney Ginn had gotten in contact with a man named Anthony.

When the two of them met at a bar, he seemed to have already had a vague feeling about something and refused to drink the soda first — yet his instincts still couldn't change the outcome of him dissolving into a puddle of grape-flavored soda.

Sydney Ginn went home to get money, called London Moon out, and at Between the Backlights, learned that Chase was asking around about the Vulture.

"So that's where she found out the time and place of Sydney Ginn's meeting with Chase," June said from off-screen. "Looking at it this way, Sydney Ginn really wasn't on their side."

Whether Sydney Ginn had truly been kept in the dark about the attack on Key House, or whether she was an inside contact arranged in advance by London Moon — that was one of the

questions Chase needed to resolve.

"Next, it looks like the full sequence of how she encountered the Vulture," June said, narrating as she adjusted the flow of the Candle Tears forward. "I'll speed it up a little — as long as I can confirm she didn't lie at any point during this, that's enough."

Within the Candle Tears, the scenes of Sydney Ginn stepping onto Hopscotch, calling a cab, and fighting for her life against the Vulture in the underground exhibition hall all matched what she herself had described.

"That person's temperament really isn't suited for being a Hunter,"

as June watched, she couldn't help but remark, "once you get past her initial defenses, it's like she doesn't know how to lie anymore."

She reached out again and adjusted the Candle Tears forward. "This section is her experience entering the Nest on the night of the 16th... Ah, so her passage is jumping off a tall building."

When Sydney Ginn climbed over the railing and fell in a straight drop from the heights, the only sound in the frame was the wind from that night — not even June's breathing could be heard — until Sydney landed inside the Nest and pulled herself up out of the murk, at which point June let out a long breath.

"This must be her safe house," she said briefly. "For some reason, Sydney Ginn didn't turn on the lights."

"That's because you can't," the Vulture cut in unexpectedly. "I don't remember the specifics very clearly — you'll have to ask her in person. All I remember is that the moment you turn the lights on in that room, something goes wrong; leaving it dark is actually safer. Counter-intuitive, right? That's exactly why — because people only feel safe when there's light, whatever's in that room can use that to harm them."

Out of the murky darkness of the Candle Tears, only the rustling sounds of Sydney Ginn's movements could be heard; before long, a male voice rose from the darkness.

"Welcome to Nest Radio 173," the voice said quietly. "This is the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion — I'm your host."

"What's this?" June immediately turned to ask the Vulture.

"We Nest Residents can't just spend all our time hunting Hunters, can we — we've got to do something else." The Vulture juttied its chin toward the Candle Tears. "This is the program we listen to most."

In the Candle Tears, Sydney Ginn took out her phone but didn't even dare turn on the flashlight.

She held the phone in her mouth, using its faint screen glow to spread a map of Blackmoor City on the ground, marking it up and adding notes.

Because the room was too dark, her screen light only reached the map, which meant that even with the Candle Tears, it was still impossible to make out clearly what Sydney Ginn was using to listen to the broadcast.

Despite the complete darkness, June recorded the entire process.

"The next stretch is her life in Blackmoor City," June said, scrolling through the Candle Tears. "It looks like that broadcast brought her more than one Artifact — even her lodgings were the price a major client paid for an Artifact..."

On the whole, for a few years before 2026, Sydney Ginn had been nothing more than an ordinary Artifact Hunter.

To an average person, her experiences might have read like fantasy fiction; but to other Hunters, there was barely anything worth recording.

Depending on the content, the flow of the Candle Tears was adjusted faster or slower, and in the span of two hours, it moved through four years of Sydney Ginn's life.

"So far I haven't seen what it was she did wrong in the past." June said this, then let out a sigh. "The handheld camera is running low on battery."

In July 2020, under the pressure of financial hardship, Sydney Ginn had entered the Nest five times in a row.

The effects of "Nest Dissociation Syndrome" were not limited to creating a sense of distance from everyday life; the mental turbulence and disorientation would not stabilize simply because she entered the Nest.

It was precisely because Sydney Ginn, while her mind was in an unstable state, had gritted her teeth and forced herself back into the Nest yet again in search of Artifacts she could sell, that she

ended up failing completely in that particular local script.

"Losers have to accept their punishment, you know,"

a Resident whose entire upper face was nothing but a thick pair of lenses smiled at Sydney Ginn and said: "But you're quite lucky, little miss — you don't have to die or go mad. All you need is to be cursed by me."

"...A curse?" Sydney Ginn's face went pale — terrified, yet unable to suppress a flicker of hope. "What kind of curse? If I just let you curse me, I can go home?"

"That's right. Take a look."

Character Curse

Miss Sydney Ginn, congratulations!

From today onward, you are no longer simply an ordinary human being — on top of your previous identity, you have gained one more, like a good Napoleon mille-feuille, hahahahaha.

Your new identity is: Novel Character.

What does that mean?

Your daily life remains unaffected — you can continue living just as you did before.

However, under this curse, while you remain a person, you have also become a character in a novel.

Suppose that this world is a novel, and you are a character living within it. Whether you know it or not, an untold number of pairs of audience eyes are watching and observing this world — including you.

As a novel character, you naturally have a fixed, unalterable fate.

After being cursed by me, your fate is:

No matter from whose perspective it unfolds — the moment the "audience" learns of what you experienced in February 2017, you will die.

Unbelievable, isn't it? Hard to understand? What exactly does it mean?

As the one who lived it, you know better than anyone what you experienced and what you did in February 2017.

This is the greatest secret of your life — and you had best keep it a secret forever.

When the "audience" finally sees your secret, you will meet your end without fail.

So then — how might the "audience" come to see your secret?

Think about it with the premise that "you live inside a novel" in mind!

For example: if you recount the past to someone else — the "audience" will certainly know.

If someone else digs into your past — the "audience" might find out as well.

If someone tells you that they already know your secret — the "audience" will, of course, find out at once.

In other words: the moment your secret occurs as an "above-the-table plot point," the audience will see it, and you will die.

The safest approach is to never let anyone else find out, and to never breathe a word of it yourself.

As long as you keep the audience in the dark forever, you can go on living, Miss Sydney Ginn.

P.S.: If your comprehension is a little lacking — you may not even understand the terms of the curse before you die under the audience's gaze.

"Chase,"

after a brief silence, June called out from off-screen without warning.

She was quiet for a few more seconds before she finally said: "...Looking at it this way, the thing Sydney Ginn can't let the police find out about — it seems to have happened in February 2017."

As a principled writer, I can't take back what I've already said, right — so as long as everyone learns Sydney Ginn's secret, she will die.

(Heh heh heh heh, I've practically carved flowers into the fourth wall by now.)

Chapter 140 — The Key House Footage Chase Saw (Part Four)

2026.11.20

4:42 PM

REC.

"Sorry, Chase, I have quite a bit to say next. I want to gather my thoughts and leave you a record for reference."

The handheld camera was set down on the floor, and the frame was filled with flickering firelight.

The fire groove that had just been opened was still burning.

June's shoes stood on the other side of the frame; she had taken hold of the Vulture and led it away from the candle for the time being.

For a moment, no one touched the candle, and no one opened the fire groove.

The candle's section dated February 10th, 2017, sat frozen and silent, as if waiting for June's decision.

"Based on the contents of the curse, I can understand why she didn't melt out the Candle Tears from 2017 to change and erase that secret. A novel character's significant actions all fall under 'on-stage plot'—if she, as a character, went and changed things, the secret would be exposed to the audience.

"But what strikes me as strange is: if Sydney Ginn knew she had been placed under this curse, why didn't she change the curse itself?"

June finished speaking, paused for a few seconds, then said, "I think you've already arrived at the same answer, Chase.

"I've gone over the matter of her being cursed from every angle, multiple times. My conclusion is that the history can be changed, but... it would likely do more harm than good.

"Let me explain my thinking now.

"Although the description of Candle Tears says that one can 'reshape the past' through them—the way to reshape it is to reach your hand inside the Candle Tears and apply physical force to

whatever you can touch. In other words, what a person was thinking in their mind in the past cannot be changed through the Candle Tears."

She let out a sigh.

"And Sydney Ginn's failure in that particular script back then was precisely because she made the wrong judgment. There's no way for me to change what was going through her mind at the time.

"So I thought—take a step back: could I keep her from entering the script in the first place?

"I looked into that option too, and just as quickly gave it up. Because based on the circumstances at the time, not entering the script would likely have put her in even greater danger."

At this point, June picked up the camera and played back the history of Sydney Ginn stepping into the local script in 2020.

"Chase, look—the reason she entered the script back then was that she had no other path to take. Even if I reached in and pushed her, I'd only be pushing her down an even worse road... compared to dying, being cursed was the better outcome.

"So what if I take yet another step back?

"Go after an earlier cause—keep her from entering the Nest on that particular day? I considered that option too, but it's equally unworkable. She was desperately short of money at the time, and I can't send money into the Candle Tears to give to her.

"As long as she needed money, she would have entered the Nest around that time regardless. That local script ran for a week—she was bound to walk into it.

"And the indirect reason she was so short on money... I think it's likely inseparable from her secret. Because after 2017, her life began to grow very difficult."

June paused, and the frame was quiet for a few seconds.

"It looks like history can be changed, but when you actually think it through, not only is it risky—it might all amount to nothing. No matter how you change it, everything circles back to where it started. Wasn't that exactly what happened with Anthony? All of this... has led me to a thought."

She paused and said, "Perhaps, no matter who tried, the critical turning points in Sydney Ginn's life cannot be changed."

The Vulture had been standing nearby, listening in silence, and at that it finally let out a sound: "Hmm?"

It asked, "You mean only her critical turning points can't be changed? Can other people's be changed, then? Why?"

"This is just my guess," June said. "My reason for thinking so is simple. She was hit with the Character Curse in 2020, but didn't discover the Candle Tears until 2026."

"...So? I don't follow."

"Really, your intelligence hasn't improved much at all. Chase would have understood long ago."

June muttered in complaint, but explained anyway: "Didn't you catch it just now? When Sydney Ginn received the Character Curse, one line read—'As a character in a novel, one naturally has a predetermined, immutable fate.'"

The Vulture let out a sharp cry: "Ah!"

"...If you get it, you get it. What are you shouting for."

"So in 2020, her fate was sealed by the Character Curse and made immutable—meaning even though she found the Candle Tears in 2026, it's useless to her? The power of the Character Curse is greater than that of the Candle Tears?"

June made a sound of agreement.

"Whether Sydney Ginn thought of this herself, I'm not sure; but I believe she must have realized that the fact of her being cursed would be very difficult to change."

June continued: "Still, her future still holds countless possibilities. She isn't dead yet, so the 'novel' keeps moving forward.

"This is, after all, only a curse—it doesn't mean this world was truly written by someone, and it certainly doesn't mean the future is fixed. So she can only start from today and look for a way to break and eliminate the curse—her past has already been set in stone."

She gave a soft laugh and said, "Looked at from this angle, she's really not that different from an ordinary person who has no Candle Tears."

The Vulture made a low sound and said nothing more.

"Of course, Chase, I haven't forgotten my purpose today. I'm not here to save Sydney Ginn from the curse—I'm here to let you learn her information... and her greatest secret should naturally be included in that.

"But I am unwilling to let her die because of me.

"Besides, if she were dead, even if you knew everything about her—what use would that be?"

The camera was lifted, tilted downward, and then came the sound of June muttering to herself.

"As luck would have it, the handheld camera only has 5% battery left."

As she spoke, she took the camera back in hand and swept it around the exhibition hall.

The Vulture glanced at her from the corner of its eye—the exhibition hall seemed noticeably darker than before, though it was hard to say whether that was just an illusion.

"I've made a decision."

Her voice was calm—so calm it was difficult to imagine the danger she was about to walk into.

"...After Sydney Ginn received the curse, I had to accept that the world she lives in is like a novel with an audience. In that case, I am included in her 'novel' as well... I can only assume that right now there is an audience watching me, or watching this world through me."

She turned the handheld camera toward herself, and the supermarket paper bag on her head came back into frame.

June smiled faintly; behind the holes in the paper bag, her eyes crinkled.

"One: I must complete the mission. Two: I cannot let Sydney Ginn die. I've thought about it for a long time, and there is only one way to satisfy both conditions at once."

Behind June, the Vulture suddenly turned its head slightly toward her and stole a glance—in that instant, Sydney Ginn's face slid and collapsed off its features all at once—and it immediately turned back.

June didn't notice—or if she did, she made no reaction.

"The way is... simply to cut off the perspective of 'June.'"

As she spoke, she walked toward the candle again, and this time, she opened the fire groove at the position marked February 10th, 2017.

According to the curse's "directions," Sydney Ginn's secret had taken place on the afternoon of February 10th, and the event itself had lasted roughly one hour.

But June didn't linger—the moment the flame leapt out, she immediately turned and walked away, not sparing the candle a single glance.

"As you instructed, after entering the exhibition hall, I set up one camera on a tripod and kept one in my hand.

"Let me give the conclusion first: I never once looked at the camera on the tripod, so I believe whatever it recorded will not be seen by the 'audience' either."

She walked and talked as she spoke.

"Why did I arrive at this conclusion?

"Novels, when you get down to it, come in two types. One kind is told by an omniscient author; the other unfolds through the perspective of the novel's characters. The curse placed on Sydney Ginn must be the second kind—otherwise her past would have been exposed long ago, and there would be nothing left to conceal.

"On top of that, the curse itself mentioned 'regardless of which perspective it unfolds from'—which further supports my view. Only when the secret is exposed through the perspective of us 'characters' will the audience see it along with us.

"In other words, what I see, the audience can see. What I cannot see, the audience cannot see either."

The handheld camera's frame was now fixed on the wall and a pillar; judging by the position, the candle should have been behind June.

"Because I've been watching the handheld camera's footage the whole time, it has very likely become, like me, a perspective visible to the audience. But I have never once looked at the other camera—so I believe the audience knows nothing of what it has recorded.

"When only that one camera is filming, and I know nothing of it, the audience will be kept in the dark. Because the perspective of 'June' has been cut off."

She gave a quiet laugh.

"Next, I will turn off the handheld camera so it doesn't pick up any sound.

"Then I'll use one hand to steady the camera on the tripod, to make sure nothing goes wrong with it... like it getting quietly stolen by something.

"Finally, I'll close my eyes and find something to block my ears—that way, even if someone suddenly held a large mirror in front of my face, I still wouldn't see Sydney Ginn's secret."

She paused for a few seconds; behind her, the fire groove beneath the candle let out a soft crackling sound.

Going by what had happened just now, the Candle Tears should have started flowing by this point, and the replay of history could begin at any moment.

"I don't have much time left."

Not a tremor could be heard in June's voice.

"I know that when a person is in a weakened, exhausted, or unguarded state inside the Nest, it draws Residents twice as strongly. Right now I check both boxes... and there's a Vulture right beside me.

"But I only need to hold on for one hour—that should be fine. Even with my eyes shut and my ears blocked, I'm confident I can still fight. I won't push myself too hard; don't worry, if things turn bad I'll give up and retreat—I value my life too.

"As for you, Chase, the problem of how to watch Sydney Ginn's history while hiding it from the audience—that one I'll leave to you."

The handheld camera's recording reached its final words from June here.

"Goodbye, Chase."

The screen went black.

Chase's reflection appeared on the dark screen.

He closed his laptop and raised his head, looking at the woman sitting across the table from him.

She wore her jet-black hair straight and long, her face round and pale as snow, her eyes small and narrow, with a sharp, crimson smile on her lips.

The longer Chase looked at that face, the more it reminded him of a Japanese Noh mask.

Beneath the table, his large hand unconsciously snapped a pen in two.

"...Is there anywhere you're feeling unwell?" After a long moment, he finally asked in a low voice.

"No, I'm fine. To walk out of the Nest without a scratch—I was quite lucky this time."

"Is that so."

Chase paused, but couldn't find anything more to say.

"If there's nothing else, I'll head off now, Chase."

The woman before him gave him a nod, turned around, and walked toward the door.

"June," Chase couldn't help calling out to stop her.

"What is it?" She turned her head, revealing that face like a Japanese Noh mask.

What was there to say?

Everything he needed to ask, he had already asked June countless times before.

No matter who asked or how many times they asked, she would only ever answer: "What are you talking about? I've always looked like this."

Halfway through writing this chapter, I was hit with a powerful sense of déjà vu, which sent me into a spiral of self-doubt—I sat there for a long time wondering whether I'd written a similar scene before...

Doesn't seem like it though!

By the way, I've finally used up the outline I'd been saving up, so I might just be dead from here on out...

Chapter 141 — Chase Watched That Recording

Before heading home, June said her goodbyes to a few of the Hunters she was close to.

She said she'd been exhausted for a full day and night, and was going home to sleep it off properly.

She said she was sorry and saddened about the Hunters who had been wounded or killed in the cemetery, and that she planned to visit the injured at the hospital first thing after waking up the next morning—she even asked when Key House would be arranging the funerals.

...All in all, she seemed to truly believe she was June.

As if she had simply swapped out her shell, while everything beneath it remained unchanged.

And judging by her behavior, that did seem to be the case: not only had she returned the camera to Key House in good order, but she had handed over both the paper bag Artifact and the single red hair found in the empty coffin to Chase as well.

Was it out of some last remnant of June's sense of responsibility? Or something else entirely?

"Jun—June hasn't left home since she got back,"

the subordinate on the phone gave an almost imperceptible tremor in his voice when he said the name "June."

"She's probably sleeping, like she said she would. From the rooftop on my end I can see she drew the bedroom curtains, then the lights went out—no movement since. No reports of her leaving through the front door either."

Chase let out a low, heavy "mm."

Ever since June—he'd call her that for now—had left his room, Chase had put two Hunters on her tail.

From what she'd said to whom when she left, which route she took home, whether she'd had contact with anyone along the way... he'd even instructed his subordinates to describe in detail the way she tucked her hair back.

Because he wanted to know: when June tucked back the long, straight black hair she had never worn that way before, what kind of ears and skin would be revealed underneath.

Though once he'd thought to ask, he realized he'd never paid close attention to June's ears and skin in the first place.

"Stay on her tonight, don't move. Don't let her go to the hospital to visit anyone tomorrow," Chase said, barely keeping a swell of inexplicable anger out of his voice. "The ones who survived—seeing her looking like that would finish them off."

"Understood," the subordinate replied. "And if she makes a move?"

"Then bring her back to me. Tied up." Chase said, and hung up.

It was already a turbulent time, manpower was stretched thin, and now he had to pull two people off to keep watch over June.

On top of that, she'd always been well-liked, and a turn of events like this had immediately added another layer of unease to Key House's already anxious atmosphere.

As second-in-command, Chase had spent half an hour doing nothing but trying to settle people down; Kingsley had been brought in by June, and to keep her from recklessly charging into the Nest, he'd had no choice but to lose his temper.

And when June came back—

He pressed his fingers to the bridge of his nose.

...If she could come back at all.

Chase drew a long, deep breath and leaned back in his chair.

Uncle Key's injuries weren't serious; he had already been discharged in secret and would receive private medical treatment at home for the time being, so there was no need to keep a watch at the hospital. The red hair had been arranged to be sent to the lab tomorrow, to see whether it could yield any useful information.

He glanced at his watch.

11:43... seventeen more minutes and it would be the 21st.

Chase thought for a moment, then opened his laptop again.

Even if only thirty percent of Wellesley's lifetime memories had been recorded, the content worth mining and the leads worth chasing were staggeringly abundant—he was confident that

among all the participants, he was the first to have learned of the existence of the "Artifact Report."

...In the last Artifact Report Wellesley had obtained, the third action point was: find a way to transfer a passage.

Completing that single action would yield the next Artifact Report; and in that next report, there was a 95% chance the target Artifact of the Nest Domination Game would appear.

With odds that high, Wellesley would have made it his priority, pouring his efforts into tracking it down.

If someone in Blackmoor City already knew how to transfer a passage... perhaps there was a passage out there, waiting to be taken.

If he simply followed the trail Wellesley had left behind, could he find it?

Could he, too, have a passage?

Chase raised that large hand laced with white scars and swept the hair that had fallen across his face back behind his head.

Even though it was already neatly in place, he couldn't help running his fingers through it two or three more times, as though hoping the motion might help him settle his thoughts.

There was only one problem.

Searching through the countless fragments of Wellesley's life for any thread connected to a "passage" would be a time-consuming, laborious process.

...He didn't know how much time June had left.

Chase closed his eyes and let out a long breath.

He muttered a low curse at June under his breath, his irritation getting the better of him, and simply turned the room temperature down a few more degrees—he had finally made up his mind.

He clicked open the footage from the stationary camera and dragged the progress bar to the part where June was about to "cut off the viewpoint."

Chase hit pause and studied the frame carefully.

This was the footage from the camera on the tripod; at this moment, June was standing on the left side of the frame because she needed one hand on the camera.

From the camera's angle, he couldn't see June herself—only the blurred, vague shadow she cast on the floor. Even so indistinct, it was clear that the top of her silhouette was perfectly square, because that was the shadow cast by the supermarket paper bag around her neck.

Filling the center of the frame was a length of candle gradually melting; Candle Tears drooped through the air, and a small image of Sydney Ginn—roughly seventeen or eighteen years old—had surfaced within it.

On the right side of the frame was the Vulture, whose joints June had temporarily dislocated.

The Vulture's face still seemed to retain a faint trace of Sydney Ginn's features, though twisted and warped out of shape, leaving only the barest suggestion of human facial structure.

With its joints broken it couldn't stand, so it lay limply on the ground, looking for all the world like a melting scoop of ice cream that had toppled out of a cone.

Dislocating its joints was really only a marginal precaution—after all, it wouldn't be long before the Vulture recovered.

A rope was still tied to it, trailing across the floor, passing through the frame, disappearing into June's hands on the left side—from what Chase knew of her, that rope was the real safeguard.

Never mind harming anyone; if the Vulture so much as sneezed, the movement would travel along the rope straight into June's hands.

The Vulture likely understood this as well.

Chase hit play.

"...As for you, Chase—how you're going to watch Sydney's history without the audience seeing it, that's a problem I'll leave to you."

June's calm voice came from off to one side of the frame: "Goodbye, Chase."

The words settled, and she switched off the handheld camera.

The blurred shadow bent down; the handheld camera was set on the floor with a quiet knock.

Chase let out a low hum through his nose.

Just like June, barring any surprises, he should by now have been drawn into Sydney Ginn's "novel world" as well—one of the character viewpoints.

Difficult as it was to believe, he still had to assume that at this moment there were "readers" watching him, watching everything he could see.

Not that it would change in the slightest what he was about to do.

He already knew what to do.

This was perhaps a method only he could use.

If the readers could only see this world through him, then as long as he didn't cooperate, Sydney Ginn's secrets would never be exposed.

As long as he refused to play along—building a wall between himself and the readers through sheer force of will—they could stare themselves blind and still not take away a single piece of information.

Chase turned off the computer's sound.

On the screen, Candle Tears continued to fall, rippling out into a lake suspended in the air.

Nearly a decade ago, Sydney Ginn's greatest secret was beginning to play out on the screen, frame by frame—

yet every bit of Chase's attention was fixed on everything except Sydney Ginn's secret.

If Sydney Ginn was like a newborn puppy—unable to suppress her curiosity, her attention always pulled along by the slightest stir—then Chase was the opposite extreme.

When he focused, the world seemed to bleach away and recede, until nothing remained between heaven and earth but himself and whatever he had fixed his gaze on.

Over the following hour, Sydney Ginn's secret played on like a film, flickering and shifting within Candle Tears, casting shifting shadows of light and dark across the floor—yet not a single frame of it entered Chase's field of vision.

For the entire hour, he sat in silence, staring at the Vulture and the shadow June cast on the floor.

Boredom, curiosity, restlessness—these were only distant, unfamiliar words.

When it came to running down his quarry, he had endless patience and self-control.

When the hour had passed, Chase still hadn't moved. Sydney Ginn's secret had perhaps come to an end, but he couldn't rashly let his attention drop just yet; besides, he still needed to wait for

June to appear in the frame again.

"Her secret's over," June's voice came from off-screen. "Nothing happened the whole time—I was on edge for nothing. We can go home now."

As she spoke, she walked into the frame, approached the candle, turned off the fire groove, then pulled the paper bag off her head—revealing a face like a Noh mask.

The Vulture, as though entirely unsurprised, gave a soft, quiet snicker.

Chase hit pause and closed the video.

He had collected the information he needed.

First: throughout that hour, the Vulture had not shifted position.

Perhaps because it had endured considerable torment, or perhaps because it knew any movement would be detected, it had lain obediently on the floor the entire time—except once, when it had suddenly turned its head slightly in June's direction.

It had stared unblinking at June's back for a few minutes; then that twisted face had shown an expression that could have been a smile or rage—equally distorted either way—before it looked away again.

Chase had noted the time: it was around half past five.

Second: at half past five, June's shadow had not changed.

In fact, throughout the entire time Chase had been watching, her shadow had shown no change at all; nothing had appeared nearby, and no other silhouette had been added to hers.

She had been standing facing the wall...

Which meant that whatever had encountered June had come from the direction of the wall—whether it was too small to see, blocked by June herself, or simply had no physical form at all.

It seemed the next step would have to be a search for clues inside the exhibition hall.

As expected, he still needed to go find a passage.

Turning this over in his mind, Chase opened the video file recorded by the handheld camera.

...He was confident the "readers" had just failed to learn anything about Sydney Ginn's secret through him.

And they never would.

The second half of the chapter title is: so what (jk)

By the way, I can only read more serious same-sex literature like *Brokeback Mountain*—I'm not sure why, but BL is just something I can't get through at all.

There are quite a few stories with interesting and novel settings that I find genuinely compelling, but the moment I see the words "gong" and "shou" in the description I can barely bring myself to click on them, and on the rare occasion I do manage to steel myself and open one, the instant the first male lead appears I simply cannot continue no matter what.

So whenever someone recommends a novel to me I fall into traps all the time—accidentally stumble into BL and my soul retreats all the way back to my grandmother's house...

Chapter 142 — Chase Arrived Before Him

"Chase, you're going to make me blush."

Under Chase's large hand, June spoke in a tone of near-perfect calm: "I don't have feelings for you like that, but I'm a woman, after all."

.....Was this a personality shift that had come over her after something happened to her, or had one night spent with Sydney Ginn been enough to make her glib-tongued?

His hand paused, and Chase finally said quietly, "Shut up."

"Okay."

June, as she was now, still obeyed orders just as well as ever—even with her hands and feet bound and a tear ripped open in the back of her shirt.

Early that morning, Chase had been jolted awake by a phone call in the middle of a dream.

The subordinates he had sent to keep watch on June the night before told him over the phone that they'd had no choice but to drag her back to the House Faction and lock her in the containment room.

"I have no idea how she spotted us....."

The subordinate on the phone still sounded shaken: "By the time I realized, she was already standing right behind me, perfectly still, just watching. She wasn't showing any aggression for the moment... but we weren't comfortable leaving it at that, so we tied her up."

After locking June in the containment room, the House Faction Hunters—perhaps to test what she truly was at this point, or perhaps out of collegial sympathy—brought her water and food.

"She... seemed like she didn't recognize any of it."

It was what came next that made Chase throw on his jacket and rush over immediately—and it was that same reason that had suddenly given him a hunch.

"Her concept of things is intact—she still knows people need to drink water and eat. But the way she actually behaved was... like she was seeing water and food for the very first time in her life. I told her to drink some water, and she said sure, that she happened to be very thirsty—that

she hadn't had anything to drink since she left the Nest. That was already off. Then I watched her hesitate for a few seconds and stick her fingers into the bread."

Her strangeness had grown worse since yesterday.

In that case—could it be that what was happening to June wasn't "some form of transformation that had already occurred," but rather "a transformation that was still in the process of occurring"?

If it was a process, then perhaps it could still be stopped, even reversed—but how much time was left?

Chase gave a quick pull with both hands, and the autumn sweatshirt tore apart like paper, splitting into two pieces with a long ripping sound, exposing June's back.

The heavy, suffocating dead-white of the Noh mask was indeed spreading down from her neck inch by inch, and had by now crept past the middle of her back.

Chase thought for a moment, then pressed a cloth-wrapped finger into the dead-white skin and asked, "Do you feel anything?"

"I do," said June, not the least bit concerned about her current predicament. "I feel you poking me."

June was like a dead end: beyond the visible, surface-level strangeness, every probe and attempt to dig deeper that Chase made ran straight into a wall.

He had to make a trip to the underground exhibition hall and find some clue as to what had turned her into this……

But June couldn't wait for him much longer.

Judging by the rate it was spreading, the most optimistic estimate was that the color would have taken over her entire body—the same shade as the Noh mask—by the day after tomorrow at the latest; what would happen then, no one knew.

"Why not let me go instead,"

It wasn't as though no one had volunteered, Tianxi being one such person, approaching him just now. "Even June got caught off guard—if you send someone else, you won't be able to rest easy, will you?"

Chase glanced at the time on his phone screen.

November 21, 2026

8:10 AM

Like June, Tianxi was one of the most capable Hunters in the House Faction.

But he had taken a minor injury during the cemetery battle, which made him far more attractive to Nest Residents and other strange things than an ordinary Hunter would be right now.....

The scar on the back of his hand seemed to throb and tighten, a dull ache.

He knew his own abilities were second to none—yet for all that strength, he always seemed to be useless when it mattered most.

"You want me to sit at home while you, a wounded man, walk into the Nest?"

Chase held himself back, held himself back again, and in the end never said the words aloud.

In the end, he only said briefly, "Let me think about it."

After Tianxi left, Chase sat in silence for a few minutes and then pulled up the footage from June's handheld camera again.

The means to let him into the Nest had to be buried somewhere in Wellesley's past—and as long as it had been recorded, he was going to find it.

It was over half a year ago that Wellesley had received the first—and only—Artifact Report.

On the surface the Artifact Report was brief, but digging deeper, one would find that it was packed with a great deal of hidden information—for instance, the description of the third action point spoke of "transferring a passage" rather than "obtaining a passage."

That single difference in wording may well have determined the entire way Wellesley chose to act.

The methods for getting someone who had no passage to "develop" one on their own had a rather limited audience—people who didn't know the Nest existed naturally had no reason to want a passage; and of those who did know, a good half of them wished they could go their whole lives without ever setting foot in the Nest, and would sooner close a passage off than develop one.

After all, a case like Chase's was probably hard to find anywhere else in all of Blackmoor City.

But "transferring" a passage was a different matter entirely.

At its core, a transfer was about "taking."

Who the passage went to and what was done with it afterward didn't really matter; what mattered most was the ability to strip a passage away from someone.

Amid the endless chasing, fighting, clashing, and seizing among the Hunter House Factions, was there any more thoroughly devastating way to crush a rival than to ensure they could never enter the Nest again?

If something like that were to exist, even the faintest whisper of it would be enough to strip away every rival's wariness of Wellesley's wealth and power—he would instantly become everyone's target.

Whatever he had thought of, Wellesley had likely thought of it too.

This was a task Wellesley would never hand to a major House Faction; he wouldn't even issue it under his own name—after all, the moment "Wellesley" was attached to anything, it became the center of attention.

As long as Wellesley had supporting intelligence in hand, he would much rather assign this task to a fringe minor faction or a solo Hunter, hide it somewhere inconspicuous, and bury it among other trivial, unremarkable commissions.

And on top of that, he would probably wrap it in a disguise—something like "looking to open a passage"—to keep it buried deep beneath the surface.

Hunters were few in number relative to the general population; yet the Hunter world was still vast enough to harbor countless dim corners, and even Chase wouldn't claim to know every nook and wrinkle of it.

.....At a time like this, he needed to find the world's scavengers.

"Mr. Monroe,"

Martin Hartley picked up Chase's call on the very first ring. "I didn't expect to hear from you again so soon..... What is it—did we miss something?"

"No," Chase replied. "Whether it's the police station or the cemetery, you cleaned everything up very thoroughly."

"Much appreciated. So is there something else I can help you with?"

"I need some information."

Martin Hartley was quiet for a few seconds.

".....Mr. Monroe," he finally spoke, "the reason I've been able to keep doing this line of work for so long is that I know where the lines are—I know what can be said and what can't. What work we've done isn't our secret; it's our clients' secret."

"I know."

"If someone came to me asking about Key House, you wouldn't want me spilling anything about the cemetery either. I've survived this long because my mouth stays shut—money can't pry it open."

Chase let out a short huff through his nose, a silent smile.

"Don't worry—what I want to ask about won't affect your livelihood or your life. I don't even need money to get you talking..... Consider it a favor to a regular client."

Martin gave a puzzled "Hm?" and asked, "What do you want to know?"

"I'm not after information on the major House Factions. What I want, on the contrary, is the small fry and nobodies—the cheapest, most forgettable part of the jobs your people have taken on."

".....Eh?"

Martin paused, then laughed. "Mr. Monroe, you really do think sideways. As long as it doesn't touch any major clients' secrets, there's no problem with you knowing what odd jobs we've done."

The time span Chase wanted to cover was far too long—had he not been one of Martin's largest clients, there was no way the man would have had the patience to pull up his records first thing in the morning and spend an hour or two walking him through every odd job taken over the past several months.

".....We're not the only organization that handles cleanup for Hunters,"

By the time he finished going through the records, Martin's mouth was dry; he kept reaching for water as he spoke. "You might need to check with some of the others——"

"No need. I've already found my target." Chase said quietly. "It's right there in your work records."

His instincts had, once again, led him straight to where the quarry was hiding.

"Oh? Which one? Can I ask?" Martin was taken aback.

"Of course not." Chase smiled slightly and said.

In the early hours just after November 18th began, one of Martin's people had taken an urgent request requiring them to dress as police officers and go to a scene to defuse a situation.

The request itself was nothing unusual; what was unusual was the situation they'd been asked to defuse.

An unknown Hunter had gone to visit an elderly woman who hadn't been able to leave her floor for years, late in the dead of night—somehow, the woman ended up discovering a passage and disappeared. To keep the nurse aide she had called over from turning the whole thing into an unmanageable incident, that Hunter had been forced to call Martin's people.

.....Bingo.

Whether it was the Hunter's House Faction or their base of operations, both had the unmistakable air of small fry far removed from any center of wealth or power.

Even though the other party was a Hunter, that didn't stop Chase from bulldozing straight through the door of their office like a wrecking machine—the moment they heard him give the name "Chase Monroe," the head of that Hunter House Faction went white as a sheet and lost all will to resist.

"H-how did you know?"

He swallowed hard, as though using sheer willpower to keep his legs steady and stop himself from collapsing.

"We..... we did take on a commission and locate an Artifact that could extract a person's passage and transfer it to someone else..... We haven't been able to reach the client this whole time, and we've actually been pretty anxious about it."

There were almost no words in the world, no language, that could describe what Chase felt when he heard the next sentence.

"But—but..... Mr. Monroe, do you know Taylor Ford? On the evening of the 19th—wait, no, it was already past midnight by then, so that would make it the 20th..... Anyway, it was very late, but he came to our door personally, offered a very high price, and bought the Artifact."

Oh my god, I finally made it right at midnight after rushing the whole way!

This chapter is packed with information—I managed to squeeze it all into a little over three thousand words…… Very proud of myself.

My ability to pad chapters with filler has declined once more!

Chapter 143 — Chase: The Person Who Died on the 18th

The urge to seize the world in these two hands and twist it, grind it to nothing—dark, so dark, like the roaring waves that surge skyward when a typhoon strikes, capable of swallowing everything between heaven and earth.

Was he truly fated, in this life, to watch everything he wanted vanish before his eyes the moment he reached for it?

When the pitch-black, wave-like tide of emotion finally receded, Chase found himself still standing in the center of the room.

His hands trembled faintly a few times, then settled back into stillness.

Beyond that, the room itself—and everyone in it—was somehow completely unharmed.

No body lay at his feet, no furniture had been reduced to splinters on the floor... given the force of that impulse just moments ago—one so overwhelming it had blackened his very vision—even Chase found himself faintly surprised.

He had kept himself from erupting, yes, but that pitch-black, storm-like surge of emotion had evidently been too vivid to contain, vivid enough to strike the Hunter standing across from him.

Chase pulled out a chair and dropped into it, crossing one leg over the other.

Only then did he raise his eyes. "Put the gun away. You won't need it."

The middle-aged man drew a sharp breath, opened his mouth, seemed to search for words, and found none.

The gun in his hand drifted downward, hanging suspended in mid-air; it trembled, wanting to rise again—then finally, with something close to defeat, was slammed down onto the table.

"It's not our fault," the middle-aged man said, wiping a hand across his face, his smile bitter. "We just made a deal—sold an Artifact. Isn't that what Hunters do?"

"Tell me from the beginning," Chase said, watching him. "Start from when you received the commission."

The man named Javier seemed afraid to take his eyes off Chase. His hand groped behind him for several seconds before he found his own chair, dragged it over, and sat down.

Across the table, he hesitated a moment—then, to Chase's surprise, asked, "...Could it be that you're the client, Mr. Monroe?"

Chase slid him a look from beneath his eyelids.

"Did I... did I sell your thing to Taylor Ford?"

"You don't know who the client is?"

That Wellesley would not use his real name was something Chase had long anticipated; he had simply assumed Wellesley would send the commission through someone else's hands—but it turned out Javier didn't even know who his client was.

Javier startled slightly, then drew a slow, deep breath.

"So it really isn't you... All right, everything I tell you from here on is the truth. I have no reason to lie anymore."

He lowered his head, eyes on the table, and said: "I never met the client in person. Early this past March, I received a phone call. The man on the line called himself 'Omar.' He gave me some intelligence, asked us to go into the Nest and find an Artifact, and wired us a deposit without any hesitation—quite a generous one."

Chase already had no shortage of questions at this point, but he stayed quiet and kept listening.

"Intelligence about the Nest is always valuable. The fact that he could get his hands on Artifact intel meant he was no ordinary figure, and the deposit was three times what we'd normally get. At first I couldn't figure out why he'd come to a small House Faction like ours—six or seven people at most."

Javier paused, his fingers unconsciously stroking the phone he had set face-down on the table.

The back of the phone was printed with a pink, round cartoon character that looked like something called Gerbo.

"We don't have the numbers to keep rotating people in and out of the Nest—each trip is brutal, takes a real toll on you—so it wasn't until late October that we finally found the Artifact.

"Strange thing was, Omar used to call constantly at first, checking on our progress every few days. But once September rolled around, he went a whole month without calling once."

Javier frowned. "When I called him to tell him we'd found the Artifact, Omar's reaction was... cold. No, 'cold' might not be quite right. Hmm..."

Chase gave it a moment's thought, then cut in: "Frightened? Guarded?"

"Yes—exactly!"

Javier stared. "How did you know? That's exactly how it felt. He was the one who commissioned us to find the Artifact, he was anxious about it at the start, and yet when we finally found it and called him—"

"It was as if your call was a death sentence being served to him. Am I right."

"Did you somehow hear that phone call?" Javier's face was full of disbelief.

...So that's how it was.

Omar was, in all likelihood, Wellesley himself.

That he would react this way to the good news Javier had brought was not entirely unexpected.

In the Artifact Report, there had been one line written explicitly: "Please also take great care of yourself—on the road toward becoming the Ruler, the closer you draw to the end, the more dangerous and arduous the path becomes."

The meaning of that line—Wellesley had likely grasped it in September, when, for no apparent reason, a power strip had appeared in the swimming pool. Now Chase understood it too.

The more one collected, the closer one drew to completion, the more severe the mortal danger the participant would face.

The Artifact that transferred passages was not one of the seven targets in the Domination Game, but its appearance carried a 95% chance of bringing with it an Artifact Report containing intelligence on a target Artifact...

With danger lurking in every shadow and nerves stretched to the breaking point, it was perfectly understandable that Wellesley would seem cold and distant when Javier called.

"The last time I spoke with Omar was in early November. He said that since we had already obtained the Artifact, we would know its purpose by now. He couldn't simply take our word that we'd found what he wanted—he needed us to take the Artifact and carry out one test with it

first... Once we had truly transferred a passage from someone else, he would fulfill his promise to me."

He hadn't said "pay the remaining sum"—he had said "fulfill his promise."

"Back then I was trying every possible way to hand the Artifact off to Omar as soon as I could... We couldn't take a passage from an existing Hunter—we could only target an ordinary person who didn't know the Nest existed. You have no idea how much effort it took before I finally found, through hospital records, an elderly woman I thought was likely to have a passage."

That elderly woman had also become the very lead that brought Chase here.

"But it all fell apart at the last moment... That old woman fell into her own passage. She's dead by now, I suppose."

Javier's expression flickered, as though he wanted to laugh at himself but couldn't quite manage it.

"Since early November, I haven't been able to reach Omar at all. Now his promise has come to nothing, we've gotten an innocent old woman killed, and all I'm left with is an Artifact I don't even want to look at anymore... So when Taylor Ford came to my door, I heard the price was right and handed it over to him."

Chase forced himself to release the armrests of the chair before he crushed them.

Before he asked about Taylor Ford, he still had a few questions that needed answering first.

"You must understand what it means—an Artifact that can transfer a passage," Chase said, his voice level.

"Of course."

Javier seemed to have anticipated this question, and understood what Chase had left unsaid.

"It was precisely when I realized that what I was being asked to find was an Artifact capable of transferring a passage that I understood why Omar had come to me."

"Oh?"

"Give this commission to any other Hunter House Faction, and that deposit might as well have been thrown into the sea—even if they found the Artifact, not many people would honestly hand it over to some Omar who came out of nowhere."

Javier gave a bitter smile and raised a hand toward Chase.

"Setting everything else aside, Mr. Monroe—if I had brought it to you first, how much would you have paid for it? Probably far more than Omar could have offered."

He didn't know that Omar was Wellesley, so the misunderstanding was hardly strange.

"Something like this appearing in Hunter circles would cause an absolute storm—I can easily imagine the scale of profit it could bring, and the scale of danger.

"So no matter who else in this world Omar could have commissioned—anyone but me—he couldn't be certain of getting it back. Only I... only I would guard his secret with my life."

As he said it, his hand moved involuntarily again to the phone case.

Chase waited for him to continue.

"I have a four-year-old daughter. She was diagnosed last year with congenital nephrotic syndrome," Javier said, head lowered. "There is no treatment other than a kidney transplant."

Chase understood.

"The promise Omar made to me was 'a kidney.'"

He said it slowly: "He had already proven to me that he was capable of fulfilling that promise. So no matter who it was—no matter how much money they offered or how much they threatened my life—there was no way I would hand that Artifact over to anyone else. I kept the secret airtight, not a single word leaked out. The person I sent to take the old woman's passage was a kid I trusted with my life."

The room fell quiet for a moment.

Chase finally spoke. "Is she still alive?"

Javier said, almost numbly, "She took a sudden turn for the worse... She passed on the 18th."

Chase said quietly, "...I'm sorry."

Javier shook his head.

After several long seconds, he said: "I don't want to go home, and my wife doesn't want to see me. So I came to the office... figured I'd sleep here for a couple of days. Honestly, when Taylor Ford showed up, I couldn't for the life of me figure out where he had gotten word of it."

Taylor Ford had never received Wellesley's memories from before death—there was no way he could have tracked down this place following the same trail Chase had. And Javier would never have gambled with his daughter's life by letting the Artifact information slip.

So how had he found out?

"Are you certain it was Taylor Ford?" Chase asked.

"Should be," Javier said, his attention lifting from the phone case. "I'd never seen him in person before, but I'd heard plenty of talk about him. Extraordinarily young—seventeen, eighteen?—and so good-looking it made me dizzy for a moment."

His description of the visitor's appearance that followed was indeed one that could only belong to Taylor Ford—even if Chase despised Taylor Ford, he had to admit that in all of Blackmoor City, faces matching that description were rare.

"On top of that, he has the Morgan House Faction behind him, and his financial power is nothing to underestimate—that much money transferred over instantly," Javier said. "It was definitely Taylor Ford, no question."

The only one who could have gotten a step ahead of him and spoiled his plans was likely none other than Taylor Ford.

"What time exactly did he come?" Chase asked.

"I'd had quite a bit to drink and was about to go to sleep... I only remember it was in the early hours," Javier furrowed his brow, thought for a moment, then suddenly picked up his phone. "I had the liquor delivered from a nearby wine shop—let me check the call time."

The wine shop would have delivered roughly thirty minutes after the call; that put it at eleven-thirty on the night of the 19th.

"I drank everything, and I was getting ready for bed when I heard the doorbell... At least two hours had passed since I'd received the liquor."

Javier rubbed his chin; stubble rasped against his fingers.

He looked at his phone and said, "So Taylor Ford must have come somewhere between one-thirty and two in the morning on the 20th."

"He didn't tell you to keep it secret?" Chase already knew the answer as he asked.

"Ah, no." Javier startled slightly. "He actually told me that if anyone came looking, I was free to say the Artifact was in his hands—said it was fine."

Happy Mid-Autumn Festival to everyone!

Look at me updating through rain and shine—consider this my holiday greeting to you all (?)

I was completely useless on Saturday, just lying around, and forgot to write the thank-you chapter... I'll definitely get to it this Saturday for sure—my apologies, everyone.

While writing this chapter, I realized that the correct spelling is "综合征" rather than "综合症"—a bit counterintuitive.

Chapter 144 — Taylor Ford, and Meanwhile, He's Out Here Feeding a Cat?

"Hmm, I still don't know what to call you..."

Under the cover of night, Taylor Ford reached into his pocket, pulled out a small bag, tore it open, and pinched out two heart-shaped jerky treats.

"Kitty? Meow-meow? Here, kitty? Come out, I've got snacks for you."

He tossed the two small pieces of jerky onto the sidewalk, crouched halfway down, and waited patiently for a while.

The nights in the Nest seemed far darker than the world of the living—as though not only one's sight, but one's very heart would be swallowed up by the darkness, inch by inch.

But Taylor Ford rather enjoyed this darkness.

Immersed in it, it was hard to tell where his own edges ended and where the Nest began; as though, if he soaked in it long enough, he too would become part of the dark.

Before him now, the darkness remained utterly still.

"What's the matter—you don't like these?"

He narrowed his eyes and peered at the snack bag in the dark.

"The ones they bought are salmon-flavored. Hmm, maybe next time I'll switch to chicken flavor... oh, meow-meow? You're here?"

The bushes by the sidewalk suddenly rustled and stirred, parted by something moving through them.

An enormous black shape—so massive that Taylor Ford had to tilt his head back just to see the top of it—rose silently from between the branches, stepped onto the sidewalk without a sound, as if it meant to occupy every inch of his vision and every inch of the space around him.

...Even though this wasn't the first time seeing it, it was still overwhelming.

"The food's over there," Taylor Ford pointed at the jerky on the ground. "Not me—don't eat me."

The black shadow, larger than a locomotive, loomed motionless before him.

On instinct, he touched the jaw Mai Minghe had injured.

It was definitely cracked—the skin was bruised and swollen too; he'd made do by slapping a large bandage over the wound, though even the bandage seemed to know it wasn't up to the task, soaking through with blood and forever threatening to slide off.

To Residents and other things in the Nest, he must be especially tempting right now.

Maybe seeking out meow-meow hadn't been the best idea—though it was a bit late to say so now.

"Meow-meow, have you gotten even bigger?"

Taylor Ford slowly straightened up; the black shape still towered at least a meter above him.

"The intimidation just keeps growing... I told you, the snacks are over there—why are you staring at me."

In the dead silence, the shadow lifted one paw and stepped half a pace toward him, lowering its head ever so slightly.

The next instant—if Taylor Ford hadn't pulled back fast enough—his entire right arm might have been swallowed into the shadow's mouth, leaving him with nothing but a shoulder; the cat jerky and the bag together were sucked into its maw, and the plastic packaging rustled and crinkled around inside for a moment.

"So you thought two pieces was too few?"

Taylor Ford let out a breath and laughed. He thought it over, then, while it was chewing, quickly reached out and gave it a pet.

The shadow let out a deep, rumbling "Hmm?" from its throat and abruptly turned its eyes toward him—if not for two faint crescent-shaped glints of reflected light, it would have been nearly impossible to find those two equally pitch-black eyes within that vast mass of darkness.

Taylor Ford clasped his hands behind his back and pretended nothing had happened.

Its fur was coarse and long, but felt thick and smooth to the touch—a genuinely fine cat, and well worth the risk of that one stolen pet.

There were many creatures in the Nest—though they too were born from human remains, they were different from Residents and posed no danger to people, at least not while a person was

still healthy and strong. Someone must have been a cat lover in life, for their death had brought cats into the Nest as well.

...Let's just call it a cat for now. There was no need to nitpick about such things.

"Was it good?"

The shadow said nothing.

Cats couldn't talk, of course.

Taylor Ford smiled and said, "I'm looking for someone. A young woman, driving a car—she left in this direction not long ago. Oh, right, there should've been a man with her too. Did you see them?"

Beneath the night sky behind the shadow, a long, thick tail slowly rose—a sight that made the heart seize.

It lazily flicked its tail a few times; each time it struck the sidewalk, the ground trembled faintly.

"...Does that mean you saw them? Which way did they go?"

This time, the shadow of the tail held still in midair, steady as a signpost, pointing in one direction without moving.

Taylor Ford opened the timer on his phone, which he'd had ready well in advance.

A full five minutes later, the tail suddenly bent midair and swung to the right—meaning they had turned right after five minutes of driving.

The cat's tail indicated directions in the air like this for a while longer before finally lowering itself slowly.

The shadow—so immense it made breathing feel difficult—lowered its head, sniffed left and right a few times, confirmed that Taylor Ford had no more offerings, then turned away and vanished back into the bushes.

"Such a good, obedient meow-meow—I'll come feed you again next time."

Taylor Ford couldn't even remember when he'd first discovered it: the cats of this particular kind in the Nest, once fed a treat, would respond to certain basic requests.

Find a place where a wild creature might take shelter—like a sidewalk by a thicket—toss some jerky on the ground, make a calling sound, and after a while, the cat would come out.

So far, the locations where the cat had appeared spanned nearly all of Blackmoor City, seemingly unbounded by any range or distance limit; but the cat had grown larger, so he'd need to bring an extra bag of snacks next time, to make sure it didn't decide he was part of the meal.

Come to think of it, it was all the Dream Playwright's fault that he'd lost track of Mai Minghe in the first place.

The Dream Playwright's only real danger lay in its ability to drag someone into a lucid dream without warning; once you were on guard against it, all it could do was harass you relentlessly—like stepping on a huge wad of gum, impossible to shake off no matter how hard you tried, and if you were careless, it would stab you in the back on top of that.

"My combat skills may not match a Resident like Mai Minghe, but if you dare tangle with me, that seems like a bit too much underestimating, don't you think."

He'd originally planned to just walk away, but after being blocked twice in a row by the Dream Playwright, Taylor Ford had started to lose his patience.

He stood on the Dream Playwright's chest and asked, "You thought that because you keep recovering and won't die, there's nothing I can do to you?"

The Dream Playwright had never stopped trying to drag him into a lucid dream—and it was precisely that which had let Taylor Ford spot his opening.

"You have to hold your face directly in front of the target, perfectly still for one to two seconds, before you can initiate a lucid dream on them, right?"

Taylor Ford said this as he dragged over a nearby advertisement pole. "Your movements are far too predictable—riddled with openings at every step."

By that point, the Dream Playwright was no longer able to answer him.

Its face had taken three shots at close range from Taylor Ford; its skull had been torn apart by the spinning bullets, bored through front to back into a hollow—large enough to fit a hand through.

Taylor Ford had to put in considerable effort before he managed to bend the pole over his knee.

If he had strength like Chase's, he certainly wouldn't break a sweat over something this minor. Would he have that kind of strength when he came of age?

Maybe he should find out what Key House was feeding their people.

Random thoughts were a decent distraction from jaw pain; while he mentally planned how to wangle a meal at Key House, Taylor Ford inserted his handgun into the hole in the Dream Playwright's head and fired a shot at the ground.

A tremendous bang erupted along with flying chunks of brick, as if a small tornado had spun up inside the Dream Playwright's blown-open skull; fragments embedded themselves into the bone all around, making the Dream Playwright's body shudder and twitch like a dying fish.

Taylor Ford put his whole body into it and drove the straight end of the pole through the hollow, plunging it deep into the ground.

He used the Dream Playwright's own clothes to bind its hands together; when it was all done, the Dream Playwright was like an insect pinned to the ground by its own head.

"Work hard at recovering,"

Taylor Ford didn't forget to offer some encouragement: "If your core is strong and your neck muscles are up to it, you might manage to sit up after struggling for ten minutes or so... Too bad I won't be around to see what you look like with a pole sticking through your head—that would've been pretty funny."

He turned to look, and Mai Minghe's car had long since vanished; Reed Hydes, who had been standing by the roadside, had also disappeared after her car drove past—how was it that, after turning back into a human, he was still thinking about him?

"See, she's gone."

Still annoyed, Taylor Ford gave the Dream Playwright a few kicks with the tip of his foot and said, "Consider this a lesson—don't go causing trouble for people next time."

Lucky that he'd brought a bag of snacks, which was how he'd managed to track down Mai Minghe's direction again...

Both were creatures of the Nest, yet meow-meow was useful and adorable—how could the gap between them be so vast?

With Mai Minghe having gone on ahead, there was no need to worry about running into any danger along this stretch of road—she'd become the scout; whatever lay in wait, she'd probably encounter it first.

Still, Taylor Ford remained cautious: he walked out onto the road and followed the route Mai Minghe's car had taken, moving step by step through the Nest's dark night, keeping his path as much between the tire tracks as he could.

When she had driven away, Taylor Ford had managed to glance up for a moment from his struggle with the Dream Playwright and noted that Mai Minghe's car had been traveling at roughly thirty miles per hour.

The five minutes she covered by car was naturally a completely different distance from five minutes on foot... What a headache.

Taylor Ford walked on, calculating, staying alert, occasionally scouting the surroundings—even with meow-meow's directions, it was no easy journey.

He found the car Mai Minghe had driven away in after more than thirty minutes of walking.

It was parked crookedly at the roadside, its nose jammed right into the alley between two buildings; from the parking position alone, it was hard to tell which of the nearby buildings the two had gone into—the Nest, which had inherited the layout of most of Blackmoor City, was packed just as densely with structures.

"Whichever building it is, they should've settled somewhere around here, right?"

Taylor Ford took the signal transmitter from his backpack and muttered to himself.

The Dream Playwright naturally had no reason to keep Mai Minghe's secrets—it hadn't even needed pressing before it had told him that Reed Hydes was going to guide her for twelve hours.

That meant they weren't going to leave the Nest anytime soon; and with Reed Hydes's injured foot limiting how far he could walk, the two of them most likely intended to hole up and rest.

Leave a signal here, wait for the House Faction Hunters to come, then search carefully—

Before that thought could finish, a sudden explosion erupted from an old residential building behind him; Taylor Ford spun around sharply and caught a burst of flame shooting out from a window, lighting up the night for one brief instant.

...No way, that easy to find?

Was this truly not a trap, or some scheme to lure him away?

Well, trap or not, there was nothing to be done about it.

Taylor Ford sighed, knowing he had no choice but to go over and take a look regardless.

Before taking a step, he pulled out his phone and checked the time.

November 19, 2026

03:22 AM

I saw the suggestion Tang Mian Ye Lao Lao raised earlier and thought it made a lot of sense, so I've changed the time of Javier's daughter's death (lol).

This just goes to show there's no foreshadowing tied to her time of death—any day works (lol).

On another note, I've been thinking a lot lately about that lighthearted comedy story... don't let the lack of a character arc fool you (there isn't really a plot anyway—I'm planning to write it as loosely connected standalone episodes), because I've already got the title figured out, which is genuinely a first for me.

Even though I don't make as much money as other web novel authors, writing is truly enjoyable for me... I'd be happy to do it even as a paid day job (just kidding, sort of).

Fake & Funny Magic Item Series, Vol. 1

Today is September 18th, tomorrow is September 19th.

The above is something anyone could tell just by glancing at a calendar.

So why am I saying it?

Because today I shall be employing a wondrous magical artifact

One possessed of an inconceivable power of erasure and compression

Such that the moment it is revealed unto the world

The two scheduled chapter updates for September 18th and September 19th

With a single *whoosh*

Become just one update!

Is that not inconceivable? Is that not magical?

I am filled with unending amazement — technology truly has advanced so far

So what, you ask, is the name of this artifact?

【A note stating that the author's sham money-grubbing workplace somehow obtained complimentary tickets to a game, and somehow those tickets ended up in her hands, so she's taking tomorrow off to go watch said game, and on top of that today's outline ran dry and the update was going terribly, so she figured she might as well just write one chapter across the two days】

In short: a leave-of-absence note

Thank you, thank you all, dear readers, for the stones you are pelting me with

My goodness, are you all in construction and renovation? You've certainly got no shortage of rocks

Chapter 145 — Lying in Wait Is a Skill in Itself for Taylor Ford

...Those two had walked right into one hell of a place.

Taylor Ford was full of displeasure, standing beneath the dim yellow bulb in the entryway, silently letting out a long breath.

If he'd had a choice, he wouldn't have walked into this apartment building and brought trouble on himself either.

Based on the intelligence gathered so far, the Artifact on Mai Minghe was, without a doubt, the one Wellesley had commissioned Morgan House Faction to retrieve — which meant it was very likely one of the seven targets in the Nest Domination Game.

Even if it wasn't one of the seven targets, Taylor Ford figured he'd better get his hands on it regardless.

Up until the moment Mai Minghe fled, she had yet to successfully join the Nest Domination Game; if she truly intended to join, then that Artifact couldn't be left in her hands — a Mai Minghe who had reverted back to an old woman could hardly be counted as a competitor anymore.

Even though her power had plummeted after she was confirmed not to be a Resident, a competitor was still a competitor, and the fewer of them the better.

Faced with an old woman, perhaps even the Nest's summons would be rescinded?

Thinking it through like that, even knowing full well the danger, he had no choice but to follow them in — this apartment building was surprisingly forthright, not hiding a single thing about the dangers within, spelling it all out plainly in the notice posted outside the door.

Standing in the entryway, Taylor Ford let his mind drift back for just a moment, and that notice surfaced before him again with perfect clarity.

NOTICE

In response to tenant needs, this apartment will undergo internal renovation and refurbishment beginning at 1:30 AM on November 19, 2026.

The scope of renovation covers Floors 1 through 5; Floor 6 will remain temporarily unchanged.

During the renovation period, some things inside the building will inevitably come loose and regain their freedom; within the affected floors, hazardous zones of unknown variety will also form, which will not be particularly welcoming to those who are not yet ready to die — please try to understand while remaining alive.

The renovation and refurbishment will continue until 1:30 AM on November 20, 2026, and does not include the stairwell.

During the renovation period, the elevator will not be available for use.

Trust us — you won't want to use the elevator anyway.

After all, one of the reasons we are conducting this renovation is to put a stop to the ongoing disappearances of tenants who have been using an elevator that does not exist.

Should any tenants lack the ability to foresee the future, or find themselves unable to change reality through hindsight, and have inadvertently entered the building before the time this notice was posted, we ask that you kindly wait until the renovation has concluded before leaving.

(This notice was posted at 1:30 AM on November 19, 2026.)

For tenants who have not yet entered the building, we recommend seeking shelter elsewhere; those unfortunate tenants too destitute to find anywhere else to go are also advised to exercise caution and keep safety in mind — do not forget logic and common sense, such as not following suspicious individuals into dark Garbage Chutes.

Because this building has no Garbage Chute.

In the interest of a more comfortable living environment in the future, management sincerely thanks you for your cooperation, and apologizes for any inconvenience and risk of death you may be forced to endure.

What kind of luck was this — Taylor Ford couldn't help but grumble silently to himself.

Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes had most likely treated this apartment building as a safe, long-term refuge, which was why they had come straight here without a moment's hesitation — yet as it turned out, the moment they stepped inside, the renovation notice had been posted at the entrance, sealing them both in.

The timing was almost too perfect, as though the apartment building had opened its mouth and waited specifically for the two of them.

Before he made up his mind to follow Mai Minghe and the others inside, Taylor Ford finally remembered that he had a whole team waiting for him somewhere in the Nest — he'd probably better let them know about this first.

"Director, doesn't the renovation end on the 20th? Things on our end are wrapping up soon — we'll be able to head out and meet up with you shortly."

After he finished explaining the situation, Remy's voice came through the long-range walkie-talkie with a piece of advice that sounded not especially hopeful.

"Once we arrive, we could just wait at the entrance. If she comes out alive, she'll fall right into our hands; if she dies inside, we can go in after the renovation ends to retrieve the Artifact — it might even be safer that way."

"Going in after it ends probably won't be any safer than going in now," Taylor Ford replied at the time, seated beneath the notice and setting up a signal transmitter.

Based on his experience with the Nest, whenever words like "renovation" or "construction" appeared — anything suggesting change — nothing good ever followed.

This safe house might not even be usable afterward.

"Besides, right now it's only... hmm, only four-thirty in the morning."

Taylor Ford glanced at his phone and said lazily.

"Waiting at the entrance for over twenty hours would attract plenty of things on its own... and after surviving twenty-plus hours out there, we'd still have to go in and take our chances. Whether we go in early or late, it's all the same—"

He stopped, unable to help himself, and let out a long, drawn-out yawn.

Remy paused, then asked, "...Director, are you alright?"

"I'm fine. I got a little hurt earlier — even yawning hurts like hell." Taylor Ford wiped at his eyes and said.

Jane Lynch probably never imagined that, even though she'd stopped Taylor Ford from bringing cigarettes into the Nest, he would end up downing five painkillers in one go just because he couldn't take the pain.

The drugs were kicking in now, and not just his mind but his very bones felt loose and scattered, as if each one wanted to drift off in a different direction and float free from his body.

As for the result — his jaw still hurt quite a bit, only now his head felt as though a layer of gauze had been draped over it. This world really did know how to deceive people.

Somewhere in his five years as a Hunter, Taylor Ford had forgotten who it was that once said that if he pulled himself together and kept clean and operated with real discipline, he might become a far more formidable Hunter than he was now.

What kind of Hunter he could become was hard for him to say; but as for keeping clean and living with real discipline — Taylor Ford wasn't sure he would have made it to seventeen.

"Director, you're not going in alone ahead of everyone because you're bored of waiting, are you?" Remy suddenly asked.

"Of course not, what are you talking about — don't say things like that, I'm a professional."

This time, Remy's silence stretched a few seconds longer than before.

"I genuinely don't understand you," she said at last, letting out a sudden long sigh, "personal safety is the top priority we'd all love to have tattooed on our foreheads, but for you it seems like it's just a nice bonus — no, it's more accurate to say it's something you could take or leave."

"Now you're making me blush with all that praise."

Remy burst out laughing unexpectedly. "Who's praising you! Forget it — after working with you for most of a year, I'm almost used to it. Director, if you want to go in, go in. Be careful, and don't die."

She thought it over and added: "If you die in there too, I might not be able to recover your body. If a Resident born from you ends up loose in the Nest — everyone else might as well retire early."

The several Hunters standing behind Remy seemed to have overheard the exchange and grew unsettled; Taylor Ford simply pretended not to hear, and as she turned to reassure them, he clicked off the walkie-talkie.

He had never really expected anyone to stop him from going in.

Remy was sharp enough to sense that his perfectly reasonable-sounding explanation was just an excuse; but she had guessed wrong — it wasn't boredom that made him want to go into the

apartment building alone.

Taylor Ford did not like being alone with himself.

When he was on his own, he was either not quite clearheaded, or he had to be doing something.

He got to his feet, took one last look at the notice, and pushed open the apartment building's front door.

Through the front door was a very narrow entryway.

A single dim yellow bulb hung in the entryway; its barely-breathing light sagged limply in the air, casting an uneven glow that left countless dark, creeping shadows pooling in every corner of the building.

The interior of the building was a standard rectangle — stepping into the entryway, to the left was a short flight of steps leading up to the first-floor apartments.

Following the steps upward with one's gaze, a row of dark-brown apartment doors came into view, one after another, all shut tight, standing in the dim and murky corridor.

To the right of the entryway was a row of old metal mailboxes; on a blank stretch of wall beside the mailboxes, a sheet of paper had been slapped up crookedly, with someone's handwriting on it:

Welcome to use this elevator :D

No wait, you absolutely must use this elevator, LOVE

XOXOXO

...But even if someone genuinely wanted to take the elevator, how would they even use it?

Taylor Ford quietly reminded himself not to go near this stretch of blank wall.

He turned to look — at the far end of the entryway, almost directly facing the front door, was a staircase leading up to the second floor.

The explosion had occurred on the third floor; judging by its scale, it hadn't been too severe, and no uncontrollable fire had broken out afterward — the two of them were most likely still alive.

So he'd better head up to the third floor, then?

Hmm... but there was still plenty of time.

Mai Minghe and the others must have also discovered that this apartment building was no longer safe; this notice was probably not just the one posted at the entrance — people already inside the building should have been made aware of the situation as well.

Within the Nest, a portion of the traps, scripts, and Rule Domains liked to drape themselves in a veneer of fairness, reasonableness, and logic, operating according to a consistent set of rules — and by all appearances, this apartment building was one of them. Since the notice mentioned a "management office," it was clearly more reasonable to assume it would ensure that every "tenant" received the notice.

In that case, the reason why Mai Minghe and the other were on the third floor was also perfectly clear.

They must have realized, just as he had, that the sixth floor of this apartment building was a safe zone.

At least until any further changes to the rules appeared, the sixth floor was safe for now.

"This apartment building really is a nasty piece of work..." Taylor Ford muttered, looked around, and decided to head to the staircase first.

The twenty-four-hour restriction window — that had to be deliberate design, didn't it?

Over such a stretch of time, it was hard for anyone to stay on edge the entire time; no matter who it was, everyone needed somewhere safe to rest and recover.

That meant everyone who came in would try to make it to the sixth floor.

Running from the first floor to the sixth floor also meant going through every danger from floors one through five — whether anyone could make it to the edge of the safe zone alive was still anyone's guess.

And even if someone managed to reach the sixth floor and hide out in the safe zone until the renovation ended, they'd still have to come back down floor by floor to get out; by then, there might very well be a fresh round of deadly surprises waiting for them.

No wonder the safe zone was set on the sixth floor... no, more accurately — no wonder there was a safe zone set up at all.

Only with a distant "sanctuary" could people be exposed to danger to the greatest possible degree.

But even knowing all this, what could one do about it?

This move by the apartment building — it was an open trap.

Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes didn't seem to be fools either; but even if they had figured this out, didn't they still have no choice but to climb up floor by floor?

Well then...

Taylor Ford thought: he might as well head up to the sixth floor and wait for them.

Sorry, dear readers — I truly don't know what good it does me to put together an Excel spreadsheet for an outline...

I noticed yesterday that I'd written the date wrong at the end of the last chapter, and I kept wondering — how were readers already guessing it wasn't Taylor Ford who took the vacuum device when I hadn't even written to the 20th yet?

Then I looked closely, and sure enough, the date was wrong — I'd written the 20th.

After I slunk back and quietly changed it back to the 19th, I opened the outline just to be safe, and immediately felt my eyes well up...

There was a key plot point in Chase's section that I had completely forgotten to write!

Aaagh, aaagh, aaagh

What is even the point of me writing this outline, friends — is it truly impossible to write a new chapter without leaving something out?

If I had to make a mistake, I'd rather get the chapter number wrong...

Chapter 146 — Taylor Ford Apartment, Second Floor

Going it alone as a solo operator has plenty of advantages, of course — but that doesn't mean it has no drawbacks.

For instance, after Taylor Ford took out his phone and snapped several photos — click, click, click — capturing all the resident mailboxes, he stood alone in the silence and found himself missing Remy a little.

If she were here, she would definitely say things like "worthy of a director," "so careful with the details," "most people wouldn't even think to take photos" — flattering words like that; whether she truly meant them or not, they were pleasant to hear either way.

After all, the mailboxes all had room numbers and names on them — they might come in handy later.

Taylor Ford pocketed his phone and looked around, feeling the particular regret of a celebrated performer with no audience — no matter how professional you were, without someone nearby to stroke your ego, wasn't it like wearing your finest clothes on a dark night?

Oh well. Remy wasn't here, but up ahead there were still two future victims; once he seized the Artifact, he could show them the photos afterward.

Taylor Ford turned his head and glanced back.

The staircase was at the far end of the apartment building, past the front entrance — meaning he had to walk through the entire first floor, past every apartment door, before he could reach it. This, presumably, was a distortion the building had developed inside the Nest.

Under normal circumstances, a residential building wouldn't be designed so that you had to pass a row of other people's front doors just to go upstairs — it was inconvenient, and residents would have to put up with unnecessary noise.

By comparison, the "elevator" was exactly where it should have been — except there was no elevator in the right place.

Since Taylor Ford had entered, every apartment on the floor had been perfectly quiet, and the gaps beneath the doors were all dark.

If you listened carefully, the only sound in the entire building was his own breathing — not the faintest trace of any movement from Mai Minghe and her companion upstairs; and the looping maintenance announcement that had been playing when he first came in had faded away too, leaving silence behind, as though it had never happened at all.

Those two hadn't died, had they?

Taylor Ford moved step by step toward the staircase, keeping his footsteps as quiet as possible; the corners of his eyes never left the tightly shut apartment doors alongside him.

His vigilance seemed to have been unnecessary, though — by the time he reached the staircase without incident, the first-floor apartments remained utterly silent, and nothing had happened.

It looked like ignoring the soft voice calling from behind the door of Room 103 after he'd entered the building had been the right call.

Standing before the staircase, he slipped off his backpack and, while staying alert to his surroundings, reached inside and rummaged around.

The backpack issued by the Morgan House Faction was fully equipped.

After Taylor Ford had taken over Hunter operations, he had added one more item to the standard supply list — "disposable phones" — and what he pulled out now was exactly that: a simple handset worth no more than a few dozen dollars.

He opened the ringtone settings, picked a tune at random, and the phone began playing it on a loop without end.

Like the guns, blades, signal transmitters, and flashlights, everything in his pack had been purchased in bulk by the Morgan House Faction — the same model for everyone — and was handed out to each person upon entering the Nest; whatever was left over had to be returned to the supply department afterward.

This wasn't because the Morgan House Faction was stingy.

It was because this way, whether in terms of ownership or in name, everything they carried belonged to "the Morgan House Faction" as a concept, rather than to any individual — and so he left the disposable phone behind on the floor; even if he never got the chance to retrieve it, Taylor Ford didn't have to worry about it coming back to bite him.

To the tinny, relentlessly looping ringtone, Taylor Ford tapped his toe around in each direction before stepping onto the staircase.

After climbing two steps, he was finally forced to confront his mistake.

...He really shouldn't have taken so many painkillers just now.

Walking on flat ground had been one thing, but now, climbing the stairs one step at a time, Taylor Ford was quietly regretting it: his two legs felt like a pair of overcooked hollow pasta noodles — not only limp and boneless, but seemingly intent on sliding out from under his hips with every step; before each stride, he had to work to pin them in place first.

Well, there's still plenty of time, he consoled himself — just take it slow.

Worst case, he'd adjust the plan: instead of waiting for Mai Minghe on the sixth floor, Mai Minghe would end up waiting for him on the sixth floor. As long as she didn't find out, the result would be the same either—

Taylor Ford snapped his head around.

The space at the bottom of the staircase was still dim and quiet.

The ringtone that should have been playing on and on had gone silent.

He hadn't climbed far — he could still see the phone lying exactly where he'd left it, with nothing visibly wrong.

Taylor Ford hesitated, then walked back down a few steps; just as he was nearly at the first floor again, the phone's ringtone suddenly blared back to life — startling him enough that his head cleared a little.

He could hear it when he came back down, but not when he climbed up...

So the sounds on each floor were confined to that floor alone? Above and below were acoustically sealed off from each other, unable to carry between them.

If that was the case, it explained why it had been so quiet from Mai Minghe and her companion upstairs — even if they were currently wrestling with dinosaurs, he still wouldn't hear a thing.

Taylor Ford gripped the handrail, staring at the first-floor landing for a few seconds.

...Why design it this way?

After a moment's thought, he arrived at a guess that wasn't particularly encouraging.

No, wait — if that guess was right, then how long had he already been on the staircase?

He had to move, now.

"Honestly, not even a moment to relax,"

he muttered under his breath, turned around, and drove his two noodle-like legs to carry him up the stairs as fast as they could — and as he climbed, he kept glancing back over his shoulder.

The first floor remained perfectly still — nothing out of the ordinary.

If nothing was wrong below, what about the staircase above?

Taylor Ford looked up, and immediately froze.

What met his eyes was only a flat, unbroken ceiling — not the underside of another staircase rising above him, as he'd expected.

Strange — where had the staircase gone?

The question had barely crossed his mind before Taylor Ford had his answer.

He cast a glance at the stairs beneath his feet and murmured to himself, "Trying to send people on a wild chase, is that it?"

The staircase on the first floor had been placed at the far end from the entrance, forcing anyone through the entire length of the floor and past every apartment door — following that logic, the second-floor staircase was probably the same.

If the stairs from the first floor to the second were on the east side, then the stairs from the second floor to the third were likely placed all the way at the western end...

This apartment building had no intention of letting anyone simply go up and down the stairs — it demanded that you walk through every single floor before you could reach the next staircase. As a layout, it was more thorough than most museums, refusing to let anyone miss a single point of peril. Truly insufferable.

Complaints aside, Taylor Ford picked up his pace and ran toward the second floor — and as he stepped onto the last stair, he couldn't help glancing back.

The staircase behind him was empty; the first-floor landing was no longer visible. That phone was probably still faithfully playing its ringtone down there.

Taylor Ford lifted his foot and stepped onto the second floor.

Almost in the same instant, his ears caught an extremely faint sound — like a power switch being flipped on.

The next second, human voices, footsteps, the opening and closing of doors, the chopping of vegetables, the sloshing of laundry, laughter, arguments, lessons, snoring — a rush of noise came pouring out of the hallway like a wave and broke over Taylor Ford.

He looked up, and a small jolt of surprise went through him.

Every apartment on the second floor had its door wide open.

Through the open doors of the first few apartments, visible just a few paces from each entrance, stood a television set.

The screens flickered with shifting light and shadow, their glow spilling out warmly into the corridor — they seemed to be playing some kind of drama. "How am I supposed to trust your promises," "Xiaomei! Go answer the door, your mom's home" — fragments of dialogue tumbled over each other in a noisy jumble.

All those sounds that had erupted so suddenly — they were all coming from the televisions.

This was going to be a problem... so the second floor had this many screens?

Mai Minghe was no fool; she had to know he hadn't given up and was still following close behind.

She wouldn't have abandoned Reed Hydes and run off on her own, would she?

In order to escape, she had already exposed the fact that her passage was through "screens" — and from the look of things, it had to be a large screen. At least 24 inches or bigger.

When Mai Minghe had been marched through the Morgan House Faction offices, she'd passed plenty of computer monitors along the way and had opportunities to escape — yet she'd ignored every one of them, waiting until she was brought into the reception room before throwing herself headfirst into the large television on the wall playing advertisements. The most obvious difference between the two, naturally, was size.

Indeed — it was hard to imagine how a person would squeeze through a screen that was too small.

Things connected to the Nest always made sense in the most unexpected ways.

Every television screen behind these apartment doors was well over 24 inches — if Mai Minghe wanted to leave, she certainly could...

But she was a decent person. Maybe she couldn't bring herself to abandon an injured Reed Hydes and go first.

Whether she'd left or not, he'd have to go upstairs and look.

The staircase to the third floor was, as expected, placed at the far end of the second floor — visible from a distance. To go up, he would indeed have to pass through the corridor flanked by apartments on either side, walking past screen after screen.

"Hey, young man — hold on a second."

On the television in Room 201, a woman who looked to be in her fifties or sixties, with heavy drooping eyelids, suddenly turned her head toward the corridor and called out to Taylor Ford through the screen.

...She can see me?

"I'm a very easygoing person — I go by gut feeling, and the moment I laid eyes on you, I could tell you're not a good person," the woman said, a smile she couldn't quite suppress spreading across her face. "I like you enormously."

Whether she was easygoing or not was debatable, but she was certainly rude.

Taylor Ford said nothing, didn't even look directly at the television, and stood by the door of Room 201 as though he hadn't heard a word.

But the woman's next sentence made him suddenly understand something.

Mai Minghe was still in this building.

Through these televisions, she likely had no way back to Blackmoor City.

"I like you, so I'll tell you a secret." The woman on the television leaned close to the camera, and her face pressed into the screen until it filled the frame in shadow. "...The world inside the television — that's the real world."

Yesterday I wrote 2,600 words, and it was already past midnight — I truly couldn't keep going, so I told myself to sleep first. Took some melatonin before bed. And then — I slept like the dead, utterly lost to the world; if my cat hadn't been hungry and kept meowing, I think sleeping the

whole day away would not have been a problem at all... Sorry for posting so late. The one silver lining is that, fortunately, no one's reading anyway.

Don't worry — it won't affect the thank-you chapter!

I saw a comment earlier from a friend asking what happens when a bullet is fired and can't be retrieved — I thought it was a great question, and this chapter gave me a chance to work it in. The Hunter world is full of details like this, accumulated over years — the experience of dealing with the Nest — and I think it's exactly these kinds of details that make the world feel real.

It's that time of year again (?) — Gratitude Saturday!

Today's way of giving thanks will be a little different from before; after all, the same format gets old if you see it enough times.

So the Hunters of the Artifact world have decided that starting today, they'll serve as tour guides and friends to everyone on the thank-you list — sharing things that usually stay out of sight, things that never get explained in the main story.

Please don't worry about who I am — I'm just the host of the thank-you chapter.

First, let's welcome the top tier of the thank-you list —

"Thank you to Ironclad Baitang, Joiiii, YQ Aqing, 9-Nine-5-Five,"

Sydney Ginn gave a proper bow and said, "Not only have all four of you tipped generously, you've stayed with us through it all — such devotion deserves to be repaid with Artifacts. Do you still remember the vending machine in the Nest?"

She turned cold, pointing behind her at London Moon without looking back, and said, "I bought the Artifacts on her card, so please don't feel the least bit embarrassed. I picked out the four most expensive items we had today — and if you don't want them, feel free to throw them away."

London Moon scratched her face, took a few quick steps to catch up, and asked quietly, "... Are you mad? I didn't plan this from the start — the timing was just too perfect. Who could have known that I'd only stepped out to collect a payment, and end up hearing you say you were going to meet Chase..."

"So it's my fault now?" Sydney Ginn glared daggers at her. "Did I tell you to stop being a decent person?"

Without waiting for London Moon to answer, she had already turned away and taken out a cardboard box.

Sydney Ginn pulled a bag of chips from the box and said, "The first Artifact — who should it go to... Hmm, how about this: I'll lay everything out and you four can each take what you need."

"Hold on, I was actually just thinking—"

"Stay out of it. Shut your mouth."

1. **【Banana】**

A single banana. By every measure — appearance, weight, and smell alike — it is a banana. Bright yellow, lightly speckled, at the perfect point of ripeness.

For some reason, Sydney Ginn stared at it and found herself spacing out.

2. **【Explosive Spicy Corn Chips】**

Inside the purple-red bag — bigger than a human head — more than 98% is air. Net weight: 50g, ten chips in total. A small pickaxe comes included in the bag; when it dropped out of the vending machine, it hit with a tremendous clang, leaving a dent in the slot.

"Th-this..." Sydney Ginn stammered a little, and glanced over at London Moon.

The latter shrugged, her mouth sealed tighter than a zipper.

3. **【NestCafé Gold Label Latte Coffee】**

A small 250mL canned coffee, sweetened. Something about the name feels like it has one extra character — though it's hard to say which one shouldn't be there.

4. **【Good Companion for Taking the Subway Series: Sage for Warding Off Evil Spirits】**

A bundle of organic sage, bound together with white gauze, with a lighter included. Beside the product name, the white cloth also bears a single printed line: Subway use only.

Sydney Ginn stared at the four items, mouth half-open, and turned to London Moon.

"What... what do we do?"

"Now you think of me?" London Moon said with a wry smile. "I was trying to bring it up just now — when you were buying things, you were so focused on getting the most expensive ones that you forgot to note down the Artifacts' function descriptions. But don't look to me either — I don't know what any of them do."

After a brief silence, Sydney Ginn said hurriedly, "Then — then I'll go back and check, you wait here! You — mm, the rest of the thank-you list, I'm leaving it to you!"

Watching her patter off into the distance, London Moon reached out and picked up the thank-you list; her gaze lingered on the page for a moment, and she let out a soft laugh.

"Your father laughed heartily and said... I met you once before. Shandong fugitive excavator operator... ah, still haven't been caught? You can also commission me to do the catching — my rates aren't high.

"BoiledFish, now that's an unfamiliar name... Can something taste good if you just boil it plain?"

London Moon seemed to sink into genuine distress over this question. She couldn't work it out, and kept raking her fingers through her thick, slightly wavy short hair until it was even more disheveled. "How about you cook some for me next time so I can try?"

"Right, next up there's wmy-can't-learn-this, Is this our first time meeting, and b11111111111 — how many 1s is that exactly?"

She squinted and counted for a moment, then looked up. "...My eyes are going blurry."

On the August 10 – 31 thank-you list, there were quite a few names that felt strikingly familiar — even though today was London Moon's first time doing acknowledgments, they all felt like old faces: Little Fu Comrade QAQ, Ginger Is Sweet Sweet, Does Sanjiu Love Red Bean Cake, Du Zirou, Csmshksdaaa...

"Show the list to the others in a bit — they each seem to have their favorites."

London Moon pointed to the names "Yuezhu Loves Adventure Stories" and "Always on the Side of the Egg," and said, "That one — oh, Mai Minghe — seems to like you the moment she sees your names."

Reader20240528111708033 was probably a string of digits no one could ever commit to memory. Yu Yuan Eats Taro Balls, Zhuo Fan Yue Er, Jun Mi Xi, How Come Sanjiu Still Hasn't Finished Collecting Friends, Mia Ao, Non-Edible Kitty Gummy... were all old familiar faces — after all, every thank-you list had to be read aloud on a loop across the Nest and Blackmoor City.

There were unfamiliar names too — "Is Luotai2020 a new arrival?" she murmured.

"In any case, to thank you all for your support, I've decided to share a secret that not many people know."

London Moon had only just started entering the Nest when she was in her junior year of college; one day, after she sold the first Artifact of her life, Chase came looking for her with a peculiar expression on his face.

"For you," he said, and held out an envelope.

"What is it?" London Moon weighed the envelope in her hand a few times — it was light as air. "Senior, are you confessing your feelings?"

She had already figured out that Chase was utterly hopeless at dealing with people who had slippery tongues and said whatever came to mind.

Though she usually spoke gently, she occasionally couldn't help needling Chase — for some reason, there was a strange, satisfying thrill to it, like watching a towering building on the verge of collapse.

"Even if I were confessing, I wouldn't come to you," Chase said with a straight face. "A girl from the research institute asked me to pass this along — she seems to think you and I are close."

"We are close."

As she spoke, London Moon had already opened the letter — probably a love letter, she thought to herself.

Though, in this day and age, someone still writing a love letter by hand was genuinely astonishing...

Wait.

"What — what is this?" London Moon was taken aback. "What did she tell you?"

"What did she write?" Chase raised an eyebrow and asked.

"This is... an offer."

London Moon rubbed her nose hard, feeling that what she was about to say was truly difficult to get out: "Mm... she says her side project has started making money, she's financially comfortable now... she's asking me whether four thousand a month would be enough..."

"To hire you as a project assistant?" Chase asked.

Sometimes, this senior of hers was truly naive.

She really couldn't bring herself to say it.

"No... c-companionship."

Even Chase was stunned. "She wants to keep you? Why?"

"Well, it seems like..."

London Moon wiped her face, and decided she wouldn't say the real reason after all.

Brianna often drove over to find her in one of the family's luxury cars, which apparently had given the letter-writer a significant misconception.

"It seems like after I sold the Artifact, I suddenly had a lot of cash on hand, and she got the wrong idea about me," London Moon said flatly.

...The full story behind this — Chase still didn't know it to this day.

The August acknowledgments are finally done! They keep getting longer and longer!

Chapter 147: It Wouldn't Be So Bad if Taylor Ford Crossed Over Too?

"Look at you, not even batting an eye."

The woman in the TV in Room 201 stepped back again and sat down in her chair, and the shadow no longer pressed against the screen.

She looked just like someone being interviewed, facing the camera directly.

"The way I see it, it's not that you don't believe me—you're just too cautious, right? Since you came upstairs, you haven't spoken to me, haven't met my eyes, and you won't even stand directly in front of any of the TVs. You've been holding your gun the whole time... quite the sharp mind for someone so young."

That wasn't exactly the kind of compliment he was looking for, Taylor Ford grumbled inwardly.

Besides, wasn't that just common sense?

He had no idea how the TVs on the second floor worked or how they attacked people—who in their right mind would waltz right up to one?

"The woman who came upstairs before you—the moment she saw the TVs, she walked straight over and even touched a few of them."

...That had to be Mai Minghe.

Only she, upon seeing so many TV screens, would feel like she'd found a way out and approach them with a sense of security.

When she had turned into a Resident, she'd said that a vast amount of Nest information had been poured into her mind; looking at it now, either the information had disappeared after she returned to being human, or the apartment information simply hadn't been among it.

Either way, it was good news for him—after all, what Hunter would want their quarry to know more than they did?

Room 201—he might as well call the woman on the TV "201," since Taylor Ford had no intention of asking her name—turned to glance toward the far end of the corridor, as if she could see the staircase leading to the third floor through the TV screen as well.

"I can't be bothered to harm you—believe that or don't, your choice. I'm only offering my advice... if I were you, I wouldn't rush to charge down this corridor and go upstairs in one go."

Taylor Ford kept his eyes lowered and said nothing.

There was a fairly common self-preservation rule in the Nest: treat the abnormal as if it doesn't exist. The safest course of action right now was to stay silent while gathering information.

Though his mind was already made up, what 201 said next made his heart give a sudden lurch—he nearly looked up at her.

"Because this place offers humans a chance to choose their fate anew."

...What did that mean?

Taylor Ford glanced toward Room 202.

Room 202's door was a bit further away, and he couldn't make out the content on the TV screen behind it.

That meant that for anyone who had just come up to the second floor, Room 201 served as a guide and introduction—everyone would hear 201's explanation before they could see what was on the next TV.

"As I said just now, the worlds shown on each TV are real... they are all different 'realities.' That's right—in the universe, there is more than one reality."

The woman in Room 201 explained calmly: "If it helps you understand, you can think of them as parallel worlds.

"Borrowing concepts from fiction and film—you can 'cross over' into these parallel worlds.

"In some parallel worlds, humans might use magic, and you'd be a sorcerer. In others, you might have won a 1.3-billion jackpot. Once you enter, that lottery-winning fate becomes your real life. It's also possible that you'd find your soulmate in one of those TVs... well, a bit early for someone your age, but it has happened before.

"The life—or rather, the fate—that binds you right now is not necessarily the only one you'll ever have. Whenever you please, you can swap out this life, just like changing clothes."

Taylor Ford stared blankly down at his own body.

The woman in Room 201 had clearly witnessed the reactions of many Hunters before; without waiting for him to speak, she smiled and said first: "Of course, even after entering another reality, you're still you. If you became someone else entirely, wouldn't 'you' essentially be dead?"

She continued: "As for how to choose which reality in the TVs... speaking of that, your caution is correct—though being cautious of me is unnecessary, since I would have warned you regardless.

"When you're watching the content on a TV, don't stand directly in front of it. Stand to one side at the doorway. There are two ways to enter a TV's reality: one is to charge headfirst into the screen, and the other is to stand directly in front of it for more than thirty seconds, at which point someone will come to bring you in.

"If you don't want to enter, it's simple—just don't stand directly facing a TV for thirty seconds, or walk past quickly."

...The entry conditions were that lenient?

Taylor Ford felt that he could probably engage in conversation now.

"What if someone's passage is a screen?" he asked. "After they crash into the screen, will that person return to Blackmoor City?"

The woman in Room 201 stared at him for a few seconds, then shook her head and smiled.

"Is it that what I said just now didn't feel real to you? Or do you think the second-floor TVs exist only to harm people? You've listened to my whole introduction, and your focus is still entirely on your original purpose."

Taylor Ford did think exactly that—even if the worlds behind the TVs were truly real, they were probably no good; these TVs were likely just like Venus flytraps, designed by every possible means to pull people in.

There was no chance he would choose to enter any reality—as long as he crossed the corridor and got to the third floor as quickly as possible, that was enough.

"This once-in-a-millennium opportunity that humans have always dreamed of will disappear once the restoration period ends... of course, whether you change your mind and whether you'll regret it afterward—all of that is your business."

The woman in Room 201 paused, then said, "Let me answer your question from before. The question you asked, incidentally, was one the woman who came upstairs before you also asked. That question, fundamentally, doesn't hold up."

"Doesn't hold up?"

The moment it took Taylor Ford to repeat those three words gave him enough time to think; by the time the words left his mouth, he already had a faint sense of the answer.

"Of course. Her 'passage' is still a 'screen'—that hasn't changed. What changes is only the 'destination.' Who says that once you enter a passage, it can only ever lead back to Blackmoor City? That may have been the case before, but today is different. Today is a rare opportunity."

"I see," Taylor Ford breathed out. "The woman who was here before—she probably didn't choose to enter any of the TVs, did she?"

"That's not something I can tell you."

Yet at this moment, Room 201 scrunched up her eyes and the bridge of her nose into a smile. "Though, in one of the realities shown to her, people don't slowly grow old..."

Taylor Ford quickly darted a glance at her—but Room 201 said no more.

"What about you? Is where you are also a reality?" he asked. "You seem to know quite a lot about the backgrounds and experiences of the people who come here."

"No, I'm different. I appear on this TV to introduce the second floor to those who enter it. In truth, I don't exist."

As she said it, Room 201 tilted her head to one side, and her entire neck and head abruptly melted, losing their shape and surface, like a sudden collapsing flood of flesh-colored liquid that poured into her shoulders and torso—yet her voice continued.

"You see, I'm just an artificial image."

The melting of the image served as a conclusion, bringing Room 201's presentation to an end.

Had his question been what triggered the end of the presentation?

But then, Room 201 had already told him all the important information—it did seem like the right time for it to end.

Taylor Ford walked past the door of Room 201 in a few steps, and before he had quite reached the doorway of Room 202, he stopped—from inside Room 202, the TV sound that had been suppressed to background noise suddenly swelled loud, seizing the center of his attention.

Taylor Ford had already mentally prepared himself to see a parallel-world version of himself; but what he never could have anticipated was that what was playing on the TV in Room 202 was... a wildlife documentary.

"This little fox named 'Taylor,' now seven months old, has just left its mother this autumn. Born in Yellowstone Park, Taylor is seeing the deep, slanted red sun of autumn for the very first time..."

On the TV screen, a red fox with a coat of fluffy, lush fur—beautiful as something out of a painting—rolled around in a patch of grass blanketed with colorful fallen leaves, and as it stretched a lazy yawn, its two small hind paws reached high and long up into the air.

The world of wild animals... was indeed a kind of reality.

But... generally speaking, would anyone give up being human and choose to become a wild animal?

Wild animals, after all, lived in the harshness of nature—

Oh, wait, not Taylor.

Taylor Ford stared at the lower-right corner of the TV screen in Room 202, and for a moment his mind went completely blank.

The second-floor apartment was quite thoughtful—as if displaying the documentary's title, the lower-right corner read: "Taylor: The Happiest Fox on the North American Continent."

...To be the happiest fox on the North American Continent—Taylor was doing far better than he was.

Taylor Ford felt that he really ought to avert his eyes and cross the corridor to the third floor as quickly as possible; however, the reason he was still standing outside Room 202 without moving came down to two things.

First, if all it took was not looking at the TVs to cross the corridor, that seemed almost too easy—it was hard to believe the Nest could have a place that generous.

Second...

Taylor Ford stared fixedly at the little red fox on the screen, feeling at once sweet and troubled, a warm fullness swelling in his chest.

The second reason was, of course, that Taylor was simply too adorable.

He even understood now what Residents meant when they talked that way—Taylor was just cute, cute, cute, and being a fox like that seemed like it wouldn't be so bad, would it?

Come to think of it, the love people have for little animals like cats and dogs is truly something fierce. Take the chapter where Taylor Ford was feeding the cat—the cat had clearly ratted out Mai Minghe's whereabouts, yet when I looked at the comments, everyone was unanimously praising the cat, saying how cute it was...

Ah well, humans will always lose to cats. This theorem holds true everywhere under heaven.

Chapter 148: Taylor Ford Wouldn't Be Moved

The first autumn of his life—crisp and cool, with a faint sweetness in the air.

The brilliantly colored leaves on the trees layered over one another, cut against the deep blue of the high sky.

The cool breeze stirred his thick, lustrous red fur, like a thousand gentle scratches across his skin, making him want to open his mouth and let out a small, sharp little cry.

The nearby rabbit colony had multiplied recently, just like his fur, and he could eat his fill every day; when he had nothing to do, he liked to lie in the grass, using his nose to sort out the greetings that animals sent drifting through the air.

A good stretch was just—so—wonderfully good.

The tips of his ears gave a slight twitch, and Taylor suddenly pulled back, his dark eyes darting around.

He shot upright, the tips of his ears like two sensors, trained on the grass ahead.

Something had just burrowed through the soil in front of him, sending the clumps of dirt trembling one after another—was it a groundhog, or a very large earthworm?

Taylor's eyes lit up. His drowsiness vanished in an instant and he became sharp and alert; in his mind, he had already mapped out the full plan for this momentous hunt.

The movement was happening underground about two meters ahead. He padded forward on all fours, closing in on that patch of grass, thinking: first, he'd leap up high, then dive headfirst straight down, landing right on top of the thing.

His mother had taught him this—

Taylor Ford jolted with a start and wrenched himself to a stop, lurching backward—so abruptly that he nearly toppled over from the force of it.

He blinked, and the grass, the trees, and the sky in his vision disappeared, a cold sweat breaking out across his back.

He was still standing in the second-floor corridor of the apartment building, doors open on either side ahead of him. Light and shadow alternated through the doorways, giving the hallway

the impression of breathing.

The television inside Room 202 was right in front of him—at some point it had come to within two or three steps of him.

If—if he had truly leaped toward that "groundhog" just now...

He would have plunged headfirst into the television and into the reality of the red fox Taylor.

Taylor Ford realized he was standing face-to-face with the television in Room 202. He quickly walked forward a few steps and stopped beside the door of Room 203—he had been standing there for less than thirty seconds, and no one had come out of the television to receive him—only then did he dare to glance back.

On the screen, Taylor had stopped too.

It looked left and right at the grass, its moist black eyes carrying a faint sense of confusion and loss, as though the groundhog might have gotten away.

Just that one glance, and Taylor Ford felt as though he could sense the cool breeze again, clear as a mountain stream, and he remembered again—beneath the vast open sky—his expansive, free, and unbounded life.

He let out a quiet sigh and cut away his gaze, turning his head.

"Sorry, Taylor."

Taylor Ford said softly.

If he had been born as Taylor, living a pure and free life like a wild animal didn't seem so bad.

It was a shame he had already spent so many years as a human.

Being human was clearly so bitter; yet he seemed reluctant to willingly give up the part of himself that could feel that bitterness.

Wild fox Taylor—perhaps that could only be a dream a prisoner cherished in his cage, something to comfort himself with from time to time.

Taylor Ford stood by the wall and glanced toward the door of Room 203—this time he had learned his lesson and immediately looked away.

The woman in 201 had said all the right things, but she had no good intentions after all; she had only told him half of it, concealing the most critical part and turning it into a trap.

She had never said that before entering the television, he would first experience the television's reality firsthand.

So once he stared at a television for too long, he would fall into a hallucination—seduced by the "new life"—and step into the television one step at a time. Wait—but had he been watching Taylor for very long just now?

It seemed like only a short while?

If even just a few seconds of watching were enough to drag him into a hallucinatory experience, then the safest approach would be to not look at all, and simply walk straight past...

But Taylor Ford didn't move.

A path that looked perfectly sensible and obvious on the surface—wasn't that precisely the kind of thing that set off a person's instinctive wariness?

He couldn't quite figure out, in that moment, what kind of trap might be triggered by simply walking upstairs; but calling it caution would be too generous—it was more like the instinct built up over years of experience as a Hunter.

Besides, even if he wouldn't choose any other life or reality, he couldn't help wanting to see what options he had.

Taylor Ford pulled a stopwatch from his backpack and set a fifteen-second reminder for himself—roughly the same length of time he had spent watching Taylor before falling into the hallucination.

When the fifteen seconds were up, it would give a soft buzz; not as attention-grabbing as an alarm clock, but there was no better option at the moment—he could only hope it would jolt him out of the hallucination when the time came.

After all, he couldn't count on the element that had snapped him to his senses in the "Taylor reality" to appear every time.

Taylor Ford raised his eyes, and his gaze landed on the television screen in Room 203.

Although the content in each television was a parallel reality, when presented on screen, it adapted to its medium and took the form of a program or film—at this moment, the television in

Room 203 appeared to be showing a lifestyle interview with the son of a wealthy tycoon.

"Today, Tailan is bringing us to his family's private island for a tour..."

The voiceover carried a hint of barely concealed excitement: "We've just stepped off the helicopter, and as you can see, the Ford family's luxury estate is built on the cliff's edge of the island, overlooking the entire island and the breathtaking expanse of the Pacific Ocean..."

Calling it a luxury estate was no exaggeration whatsoever: if you wanted to go from the main house dining room to the home theater after dinner, you had to take one of those little golf carts to get there—the swimming pool you passed along the way was so vast it was practically a water park, complete with waterfalls and a bar.

Taylor Ford was hardly a stranger to wealth, and yet he was still dumbstruck.

...Han Ford would probably leap straight in without a second thought.

In this reality, Han Ford seemed to have become quite the remarkable figure.

What was strange, though, was that the fifteen-second timer had long since buzzed, yet he remained a viewer outside the television, with no sign of slipping into any hallucination about being a tycoon's son.

As an experiment, he watched the television in Room 203 a little longer—and ended up watching for five full minutes, still standing right where he was with a perfectly clear head—truly, he had wasted all that caution for nothing.

"Does that mean..."

Taylor Ford tentatively stepped past Room 203, murmuring to himself as he walked: "Only a reality that I'm truly drawn to becomes a hallucinatory experience for me?"

Thinking that, he couldn't help looking back.

"Do I want to be a fox more than I want to be the son of a world-class billionaire?"

Hmm, that probably shouldn't have been said out loud.

The apartment had heard it now; so next up in the televisions, wouldn't they all be adorable free-roaming ani—

The word "animals" hadn't fully formed before Taylor Ford came to an involuntary stop.

Because the him on the next television was quite far removed from any adorable animal.

"...Is this a dig at me?"

He pointed at the television inside Room 204, protesting to no one in particular: "Who would want to be a Resident in your rundown apartment?"

Being a Resident was one thing—but a Resident who had to hold down a job.

The Taylor Ford on the Room 204 television was an unremarkable-looking short man with a perpetually wooden expression, working as the building manager of this apartment.

The Residents inside the television weren't particularly polite to him, and when they looked at him, their faces showed none of the dazzled, entranced expressions he was used to seeing.

"Mr. Ford,"

A round, chubby female Resident hammered open the building manager's door and complained: "The Garbage Chute is back again, this time on the fourth floor—can't you go deal with it? What's going on? Didn't you just drive it out not long ago? Mr. Ford, have you been giving it a proper lesson or not..."

Taylor Ford was absolutely furious.

"What is this?" He pointed at his own face and addressed the corridor wall: "If you looked like me, would you want to trade it for a face like his? And he's clearly not very bright!"

The short building manager in the television pulled his wooden, blank expression and picked up the electric shock rod behind the door, dutifully heading up to the fourth floor to catch and drive out the Garbage Chute—the chubby Resident hadn't been wrong; he really did seem to be struggling at his job, because before the Garbage Chute could do anything, he had already shocked himself into hopping about in pain.

After finally finishing the work, he came back downstairs with his hair blown out into a wild explosion from the electric shock, looking thoroughly beaten up—just in time to see the Resident from Room 607 returning home.

The building manager's face flushed red all at once, his nervousness visible to the naked eye.

After struggling with himself for a while, he finally shuffled a couple of steps closer to the Resident from 607 and stammered: "M-Miss Xing, you're back... waiting for the elevator?"

The Resident, whose looks by Nest standards might have been considered quite attractive, turned her head at the words and gave an expressionless "mm."

"So, uh, it seems like you've been getting home pretty early lately..."

"Oh, the elevator's here," said Miss Xing, already looking like she wanted to get away from the building manager as soon as possible, one foot already stepping forward. "I'm off."

Before she had even finished speaking, she bowed her head and aimed it at the paper posted on the wall—bent down and ducked through, and she was gone; leaving behind only a dazed Taylor Ford, standing in the lobby, forlornly smoothing his hair.

"Mediocre looks, mediocre ability—fine—but you also come with a one-sided crush subplot that's obviously going nowhere? How is that any different from insulting me?"

Taylor Ford even felt something like frustrated exasperation rising in him: "He's so hopeless. Nowadays it's other people who have crushes on me. If I had to live his life, I definitely wouldn't be such a sorry mess—"

...Oh? Could this also be a way of luring someone in?

Using provocation, working in reverse?

If that was the case, the apartment was hopelessly naive.

A reality this completely incapable of stirring his heart—no matter how exasperated Taylor Ford felt, he would never fall into a hallucinatory experience over it. He could walk away without a backward glance.

After that, Taylor Ford encountered a few more realities, and the television in Room 206 nearly pulled him in a second time—in that reality, he was the underground king who ruled Blackmoor City.

Approaching thirty, Taylor Ford had become a crime boss whose name no one in the underworld dared to speak directly; he commanded considerable wealth and influence that reached almost everywhere, having turned Blackmoor City into virtually a nation within a nation.

Every Hunter House Faction had become a branch under Taylor Ford's command, and as for the likes of Key House and Chase Monroe, they had long since become the bones he stepped on during his climb to the top.

"That reality was pretty good, but just walking in like that isn't quite right."

Taylor Ford pulled himself out of the hallucination and switched off his phone and timer—his double insurance—and laughed a little sheepishly.

Now that he had mentally prepared himself for the apartment's tricks, breaking free was much smoother.

"Isn't that basically saying I can't manage it in my own life, so I'm going to pick the fruit from someone else's reality? Hmm... not exactly classy."

The apartment wasn't large—four more rooms past Room 206 brought him to Room 210 at the end of the corridor.

Hmm...?

Taylor Ford felt a faint sense of something off, but the feeling flickered and vanished before he could grasp it.

For now, as long as he didn't let the television content draw him in and drag him into a hallucination, he could make his way to the end of the corridor one step at a time and head upstairs without trouble.

Up through Room 208, there hadn't been much that could truly move him; and he didn't know how high an opinion this apartment had of itself—it had put out three realities in a row set within the apartment building itself. The television in Room 208 even showed Taylor Ford walking down the stairs and entering Room 208.

"Even if you kept my face, I still wouldn't want to move in,"

He muttered to himself as he passed Room 208, and just as before, stopped at the doorway of Room 209, lifting his eyes toward the interior.

"...Taylor," a woman's voice on the television inside Room 209 called out softly, right at that moment.

Taylor Ford hadn't even registered what was on the television—the moment that call reached his ears, he plunged straight and deep into the hallucination.

There's nothing dangerous in today's chapter, but I had quite a bit of fun writing it. I personally find parallel realities pretty interesting—not sure how everyone else feels after reading it.

On that note, there's one thing I have to praise Qidian for: among the current web novel platforms, it seems like Qidian is the one actively cracking down on plagiarism. Either way, you can often see in the author's backend that Qidian has taken down books for plagiarism.

Chapter 149 — The Only Home Taylor Ford Had Ever Known

"...Taylor, there's still over an hour before the next gas station. You might as well get some sleep."

Taylor Ford looked up from his phone and glanced at his mom.

The car's air conditioner hissed and whirred as if it might shear off its own blades, yet the cabin remained stifling.

The faint smell of her sweat, the half-empty Red Bull she'd left sitting, the lingering scent of cheap shampoo, the bag of fast-food trash on the back seat — it all fermented the air into something heavy and warm, making him faintly dizzy.

He felt like he'd just forgotten something...

Oh well. If he could forget it, it probably wasn't important.

"You promised, remember — when it's time, you're taking over. I'm about to drop dead. I've been driving four or five hours already."

His mom's curls were bunched into a messy ponytail that swung behind her neck as she turned to look out the window. "Didn't expect the road to be exactly the same as it was ten-some years ago — barely a car in sight... You'll be fine, right?"

The highway stretched ahead without end, as though it would go on forever across the open land.

"Of course. I'm not a kid anymore."

Taylor said it and looked back down at his phone, and for some reason the sight of his old handset gave him a small, vague jolt of surprise — it was years old; of course it was worn. That much made sense.

A classmate — a girl, to be precise — was asking him when he'd be back, saying she wanted to hang out.

"I have no idea," he typed quickly. "My mom took me back to her hometown. I'll be spending the whole summer break there."

"Are you dating anyone?"

His mom suddenly twisted toward him, her face caught between trying to look casual and barely containing her nosiness. "Is it Rachel from last time? Or little Annie who wanted to go to the dance with you? That's my son — handsome and driven, so popular..."

Knowing his mom as well as he did, Taylor knew a compliment always had a 'but' coming.

"Honestly, for the last few years I thought you might be gay. Who knew girls' tastes would change like this — no one wants the tall, muscular, rugged type anymore, huh? Like that actor, you know, the really slim one, what's his name, Timothée —"

"Mom!"

Taylor stared at her. "Are you trying to compliment me or insult me?"

His mom tilted her head back and laughed out loud. "Oh come on, I'm just saying, lately you've been going hard on the milk... Are you worried that if you don't grow a little taller, you'll miss your shot?"

Even with no one else in the car, Taylor flushed red with embarrassment.

"Stop making things up, I just — I like drinking —"

"You're perfect the way you are," his mom said suddenly. "You don't need to change a single thing. And of course, if you want to change, that's fine too — whatever you become, you'll still be the best."

"...You're only saying that to prepare yourself for when I come out, aren't you?"

His mom laughed again.

"You're still laughing," Taylor gave a cold snort. "I thought coming back to your hometown would make you nervous. But you're exactly the same as always."

"Nervous my ass," his mom slapped the steering wheel — thwack. "We got through the hardest years without any of them, just the two of us. You're all grown up now. What do I have to be scared of?"

She was warming up to it, one hand gesturing in the air.

"If they dare treat you badly, we turn right around and leave! Worst case, we drive another twenty-some hours back home. They're the ones who should be nervous. Still, your grandma does miss you terribly — last time she snuck out to see us, you were only seven or eight..."

Some things, you know you shouldn't say, yet you can't help yourself.

"Was it worth it — for Han Ford?" Taylor said quietly.

His mom thought in silence for a few seconds, then sighed. "Well... I was a few months younger than you are now. My taste back then... honestly wasn't great. He was good-looking and gentle, and I fell for him just like that. But my parents' anger wasn't entirely because of Han Ford."

Taylor paused.

"Was it because of me?"

His mom had gotten pregnant with him while she was still a minor.

Across this state and the surrounding ones, there wasn't a single place today where abortion was legal. And back when it still was, more than ten years ago — or perhaps even further back than that — that option had already existed in name only.

Having a child meant that her plans, her dreams, had all come to nothing — her life, barely begun, had been suddenly hijacked by a cluster of embryonic cells. The next twenty years, her whole life, would never come back to her.

Her family ran a farm back home; according to his mom, even her dreams smelled of corn and soybeans.

That family had no money to spare and could never act against their faith to quietly scrape together enough to send their underage daughter somewhere else for an abortion — it seemed the only option was to hand her off to the young father, a man they barely knew.

When Han Ford took her away, it was as if the whole family let out a breath of relief.

In the dozen-odd years the two of them had lived together, one unspoken rule held firm: his mom never told him a lie.

"Yes — because of you, and because of me," she said calmly. "Han Ford ended up looking almost like a savior, afterward."

"After you left — did you ever think about not keeping me?"

Most people might say something reassuring, something about wanting to keep you, but his mom only ever told the truth: "Where would the money have come from? Keeping you was actually the cheaper option. At least it bought nine months to save up a little."

Taylor couldn't help laughing. "So I'm the cheaper outcome?"

His mom put on an exaggerated show of regret, shaking her head over and over. "Who knew you'd turn into shoes, and phone upgrades, and college fees... What can you do — just have to keep footing the bill."

"As if I don't work too!" Taylor protested.

In their household, a father who had vanished without a trace for over a decade was not a raw wound, not a subject too painful to raise; his mom never brought him up on her own, but she never shied away from talking about him either.

Taylor could barely picture Han Ford's face anymore; from the photographs, he really had been a strikingly handsome man.

Han Ford seemed to have known it too — after they moved with Taylor to Blackmoor City, he began to say he was still too young, that he couldn't shoulder this kind of life, that he refused to bury his future in diapers, that he couldn't raise a child... Then one day, he was simply gone.

Not that the mother and son were flush with money, but if you asked Taylor what had been bad about these past ten-odd years, he couldn't come up with an answer.

He had no complaints.

Once he started university, maybe his mom could pick up the thread of the life she'd cut short at seventeen and keep going; he'd already thought it through — if she ever wanted to go to college herself, then she absolutely could not let it slip that she was his mother. Going to school with his own mom would be mortifying.

"Oh, right," his mom said suddenly. "Your grandma told me on the phone that the lock on the bedroom they've set up for you is a little broken — you have to close the door two or three times before it latches, and the only locksmith in town isn't around right now... You really have to be careful. Don't keep opening and closing it over and over."

Taylor understood at once, and felt a tightening in his chest.

"Honestly, this strange constitution — didn't she pass it to me, and I pass it to you? And they still haven't fixed the lock." His mom grumbled.

"I'll remember. Don't worry." Taylor reassured her.

"The first time I found out you could enter the Nest too —" his mom suddenly stopped herself and said no more.

She took several heavy breaths before she finally said, with emphasis: "...Anyway, you must never, ever go to that kind of place."

Taylor reached out and gently patted her arm.

"I don't want to either," he said with a smile. "That one time I went as a kid was already enough to scare me half to death. Mom, what do you think happens when someone gets scared half to death, but it happens twice?"

His mom tried not to laugh and failed. "What a terrible joke!"

The straight road beneath the vast sky cut through endless cornfields, wheat fields, and open plains — perhaps it truly had no end.

As long as you kept going, maybe there would always be wind ahead, and sunlight, and road.

When they finally spotted a car pulled over on the roadside, neither of them had quite registered it yet.

"That woman's waving at us," his mom said, slowing down. "Did her car break down, or what? Out here in the middle of nowhere — what a headache."

Taylor looked up and saw a woman standing beside her car, her face drawn with distress.

"I'll go take a look. You stay in the car." His mom said, unclipping her seatbelt.

She'd lived in Blackmoor City for over a decade, but the moment she was back in her hometown, the straightforward, warm-hearted country girl she'd once been seemed to take over again. "If you need a tire changed, I can give you a hand."

Taylor didn't move. He watched his mom open the car door and walk over; the two women talked for a moment.

Snatches of their voices drifted in on the wind, everything swollen and loose and still in the summer heat.

His mom nodded and followed the woman toward her car — and then, through the rear window, a gun appeared.

Taylor froze in his seat, unable to process what he was seeing.

"My — my bag is in the car..." his mom said, raising both hands, her voice trembling. "Can I go back and get it for you?"

"Get in," said a man through the rear window.

The soft click of Taylor opening his car door seemed to startle his mom more than the gun itself; she spun around — just in time to meet Taylor's eyes across the distance — and at that same moment the door behind her swung open, and a hand grabbed her arm.

"Mom!"

Taylor felt as though his whole chest had caught fire; he jumped out of the car and was about to charge around the hood when his mom's voice cracked through the air: "Don't come over here!"

Taylor stopped dead.

His mom's eyes flickered with light and shadow, like waves that wouldn't settle.

The man was wrenching her toward the car; the handgun was still pressed against her side.

But her attention seemed to be somewhere else entirely — fixed only on Taylor. "Taylor, don't you come over here — do not come over here, no matter what!"

That was impossible. How could he not? Mom —

Taylor could not let her be dragged away like this, and yet for reasons he couldn't explain, her words nailed his feet to the ground.

"I never lie to you — you remember that, don't you?" His mom managed a faint smile. "If you come over, you'll never be able to go back."

Never go back?

Go back where?

The only home he had ever known in seventeen years was right here, right in front of him.

He didn't want to go anywhere else.

This chapter is a parallel reality — meaning that if Taylor Ford's real life is only half of a broken whole, then the parallel reality is the other half. What they share in common is probably his origins. By writing a history that never existed, I'm trying to hint at Taylor Ford's true history — I'm not sure whether this approach will land...

Chapter 150: Taylor Ford's Brief Ten Minutes

When he came back to his senses, he was standing in the dim, narrow hallway of the apartment building.

One more step and he would have passed the door of Room 209; reach out a hand and he could have touched the television screen.

Hot sweat, labored breathing, disorientation, a dull aching pain on his face, and tears—his limbs had gone weak, and in a daze he looked up at the screen.

Mom had just been dragged inside, and the car door slammed shut with a bang.

The woman serving as bait had hurried into the car; moments later, it sped away.

On the endless, silent highway stretching between heaven and earth, all that remained was Mom's car parked at the roadside—door half-open, empty, with no Taylor Ford inside.

He had clearly charged forward just now.

He hadn't obeyed, he had made his choice; but when Taylor Ford rushed out, something tripped him—he stumbled, and when he steadied himself again, he found himself back in the apartment hallway.

Taylor Ford covered his mouth and looked down to see a backpack lying at his feet.

The backpack that had been hanging from one shoulder had slipped off and fallen to the ground at some unknown moment, tripping him just enough to jolt him awake.

No... it was probably not that simple.

The hallucination on the second floor of the apartment was as vivid and intense as reality; when the backpack had fallen to the ground, he hadn't even noticed, so being tripped by it alone wouldn't have been enough to shatter the illusion the apartment had created.

Could the real reason have been that sentence Mom said?

Taylor Ford suddenly lifted his head.

If he charged into the screen now, drove after them, called the police immediately—it still wasn't too late, he could still save her—

...Don't be ridiculous.

He didn't even know whether the woman driving in that television reality was actually his mother, because Taylor Ford had never seen his mother before.

Even the only photographs were blurry and washed out, leaving the images murky and indistinct; and besides, photographs were too thin a thing to build up a true, fully-rounded image of a real person.

He didn't even know if that had been a real parallel reality.

When he bent down to pick up the backpack, his fingers were trembling, and he grabbed at the strap several times before he got a firm hold.

Gazing at the screen—the highway, the summer sky, and at the end of that road the grandmother's house he would never get to see—Taylor Ford stepped back from the doorway of Room 209, one step at a time. As he moved away from the screen, a sharp cry for help suddenly rang out from inside Room 209: "Taylor!"

She was calling his name—it was Mom—

The urge to charge back in and the reason pulling him away were two forces he could not balance; he became a small boat helplessly tossed between two raging torrents, his legs giving out beneath him as he dropped heavily to the floor.

Taylor Ford let his head fall between his knees, wrapped his arms around his legs, and began to cry softly.

Some distant part of his mind was still analyzing the situation; thoughts came one after another, parting the fog that crying had brought on and making their way into his head.

The first possibility was that he had misunderstood.

She had said those words only to get Taylor Ford back to the car—the other side had a gun, and if he was shot, there would be no coming back from that.

That still meant Mom had wanted to save him.

The second possibility was... a parallel reality created by the apartment, and a mother within that parallel reality, shouldn't have been something that would proactively warn him not to enter.

What she said might have been just another form of "Venus flytrap."

The mother in the parallel reality wanted him to know how much she loved him and how desperately she hoped he would be safe; to that end, she was willing to make it look like she was driving him away from the parallel reality—only that way would Taylor Ford willingly choose to —

He refused to keep thinking about it.

In the reality on this side of the television, he didn't know whether his mother truly looked the way she did on the screen, and he had never spent seventeen years with her.

In the reality on the other side of the television, he didn't know if that was his mother.

If the parallel reality was false and the mother a false image—rationally speaking, that might actually be the easier conclusion. But for some reason, Taylor Ford didn't even want to entertain the thought.

If the parallel reality was real, not something the apartment used to harm people, then that would mean...

Taylor Ford had let his mother be kidnapped and done nothing.

Either way, it felt like it was designed to torment him.

Wait...

Taylor Ford lifted his head in a daze, staring at the shifting light and shadow on the wall across from him, and felt his entire mind seized by a thought that had suddenly surfaced.

There was one way—only one way—to know the truth for certain.

All he had to do was go in.

Whether the parallel reality was a lie, whether there was truly a mother waiting for him—all he had to do was enter the television in Room 209 to find out, wasn't that right?

Of course, if the parallel reality didn't exist, going in would mean the end of "Taylor Ford."

To say Taylor Ford clung fiercely to his life would be an overstatement; but to say he could abandon it without a moment's hesitation would not be quite right either.

After all, if he went in... what about Han Ford? What would he do?

Just as he was sitting there in a blank daze, a pair of cool hands reached up and closed around his neck.

The next second, those hands locked around his throat like iron shackles.

Taylor Ford jolted, and the moment he instinctively reached up to grab at those hands, a force yanked him straight backward—the back of his head cracked against the tile floor with a thud, hard enough that everything went black.

In that flash of an instant, Taylor Ford thought of the shifting shadows he had just been staring at on the wall, and understood everything at once.

When he had staggered away from the doorway of Room 209, when he had collapsed to the floor sobbing, his vision blurred with grief, he hadn't noticed that he had fallen right in front of the doorway of Room 210.

The television in Room 210 had been trained on his back the whole time; unlike the others, it had made no sound at all, as though it, too, had understood that waiting quietly was the best approach.

In his disoriented state, Taylor Ford had naturally sat there for a full thirty seconds without realizing it—those hands had come to "receive" him into the parallel reality of Room 210.

As those hands gripped his throat and dragged him toward the inside of Room 210, Taylor Ford nearly burst out laughing.

Could this be any more absurd?

He had just abandoned the reality where his mother was, and now the apartment wanted to drag him into some other place that heaven only knew what it was? Did it think he would just meekly accept his fate and go in?

As he was dragged past the doorway, he struggled to stretch out his arm and grabbed hold of the door handle—the pressure on his throat instantly multiplied several times over, clamping down so hard that blood roared into his head and his vision blurred to nothing.

Clenching his teeth hard, Taylor Ford fought through wave after wave of dizziness from the lack of oxygen, steadying himself with one hand while barely managing to reach behind his back with the other until he found his gun.

In the narrow space, a rapid string of shots rang out like explosions, and the sound left his ears completely numb.

He couldn't tell whether he had hit the television; he only felt the hands at his throat ease slightly, and he seized the moment immediately, rolling over and leaping to his feet, then bolting out of Room 210.

One hand pressed to his throat, Taylor Ford bent over and gasped for several breaths.

After stepping a few paces away from the line of sight directly in front of the television to make sure he wouldn't be pulled in again, he finally looked up and glanced at the screen in Room 210.

...How ridiculous—he was playing the role of a father in a family portrait.

Taylor Ford hung his head and let out a broken laugh, the sound starting weak and hollow before gradually hardening into something brittle and sharp, each burst of laughter laced with heavy, ragged breaths.

"...Too eager," he said to the hallway. "The moment I hit thirty seconds, you couldn't wait to come drag me in?"

The apartment was silent, with no reply.

On the television screen in Room 210, there was still only a family portrait.

"If you had waited just a little longer, I would have stood up on my own and walked back to Room 209."

He stood there breathing hard, wiped his face with his hand, and smeared the sweat, tears, and seeping blood all across his sleeve.

"You've manipulated human hearts to this degree, and yet it never occurred to you that someone might walk back in of their own accord?"

But thanks to its impatience, Taylor Ford had actually come back to his senses.

"I never had a mother to begin with. All these years, it's only ever been me and Han Ford." He said it with near-calm. "The woman you showed on that screen has nothing to do with me."

He paused, then let out a self-mocking smile.

"A more ideal mother than her—I couldn't tell you how many times I imagined one when I was little," he said. "None of that changes this reality, does it."

Already at this age, and he had nearly been taken in by the image of a mother—this was not something he could ever tell the Hunters in the House Faction; it was embarrassing enough as it was.

Taylor Ford took out his phone and checked it.

The last photo in his camera roll was the one he had taken of the mailboxes.

He put his phone away, looked up toward the end of the hallway, and said, "Had enough fun? Then I'm heading upstairs."

The second floor of the apartment looked like nothing more than a hallway full of various parallel realities, but the hidden means it used to harm people were quite numerous.

What was strange, though, was that Taylor Ford felt no anger.

He had fallen into the hallucination like a fool, bickered with his mother, worried for her, been frightened, sobbed in a daze of grief...

After being toyed with so thoroughly, Taylor Ford had expected to feel furious enough to want to burn the building down—but he found not a trace of anger in his heart.

He turned around in the hallway and, rather than walking toward the staircase at the far end, walked back without a word to stand in front of Room 208.

He looked at the television screen, hoisted his backpack higher on his shoulder, and drew a quiet breath.

Time to go. Time to head upstairs.

As he charged headfirst at the television, Taylor Ford squeezed his eyes shut.

...Whatever else could be said, he had still, briefly and truly, been loved by his mother for ten minutes.

A note for my readers: since I have a family birthday celebration this Friday, I'd like to request a day off—no update on Friday, moved to Saturday instead.

Chapter 151 — Taylor Ford, the Mantis Stalking the Cicada on the Third Floor

In the last instant before entering the screen, Taylor Ford heard a distant, exasperated woman's voice.

The figure in Room 201 who had been responsible for the briefing seemed to have returned at some unknown point—no one knew how long she had been back—and had finally lost her patience and cursed aloud: "What is going on, got past again by——"

The second half of her sentence was cut off by the screen.

Taylor Ford's body merged into the screen without sensation; as his vision blurred and cleared, he dropped once again through the doorway of Apartment 208—this time, into the reality behind the television screen.

Inside the apartment was a darkness that seemed to have accumulated thick layers of dust, swallowing all light; the television that had originally been placed by the door was gone.

He switched on his flashlight and swept it across the narrow living room, finding no television there either.

Taylor Ford opened the apartment door without a sound and stepped into the corridor.

In the dim and silent corridor, every apartment door was shut tight, including Room 201's; no televisions, no light, no sound.

Led by the beam of his flashlight, Taylor Ford left Room 208 and walked step by step toward the stairwell at the far end of the corridor.

A few steps ahead stood Room 209, door closed.

Even if he opened the door to Room 209 right now, there would be no television inside, and no reality with a mother existing on any screen—would there.

After all, the "reality that could lead to all the different realities" was no longer the reality he occupied—that sentence was a bit circular, but in short, he was back.

Taylor Ford did not touch the door of Room 209.

He walked straight ahead, past Room 210, his footsteps never pausing; Taylor Ford raised his flashlight, and the beam fell on the entrance to the stairwell—between Room 210 and the stairs, one last apartment door stood waiting.

That was Room 211—a room that had not existed in the previous "second-floor apartment corridor."

Taylor Ford really wanted to scoff; but after crying, his nose was congested and stuffed up, so instead he just drew in a hard sniff.

The second floor of this apartment had gone to quite some trouble to deceive people.

After shattering an illusion, resisting the "welcoming," and finally making it through the entire corridor, wouldn't anyone want to rush straight up the stairs and leave the second floor as quickly as possible?

But the trap was in that "staircase" ahead.

Taylor Ford had been crying until his head swam, yet he hadn't lost his instincts as a Hunter—if there was one thing suspicious about the whole process of walking through the corridor, there was no doubt it was only one thing.

That was the pair of hands that had reached out from the television to "receive" him.

The setup of "receiving" people felt slightly unnatural—not that it couldn't exist, but its presence should have been there to serve some purpose.

Taylor Ford had initially assumed it was meant to forcibly drag people into the television, but on closer thought, that didn't feel right.

If someone wasn't tempted by the reality inside the television, they wouldn't fall into the illusion; someone who hadn't fallen into the illusion would certainly stay alert and careful, never standing directly in front of the television, so there would naturally be no opportunity to "receive" them.

Looking at it from another angle—when someone fell into the illusion, or was distracted and off-guard like he had been just now, they might accidentally linger for thirty seconds, giving the hands a chance to appear—but if that were the case, weren't they driven off far too easily?

Taylor Ford wasn't even sure whether his bullet had hit the television, yet the hands had already released his neck, giving him the chance to break free.

After waiting so long for a piece of prey to linger past thirty seconds, they simply let go that easily?

The sense of wrongness had been growing steadily since he broke free, until it was impossible to ignore any longer.

Thinking deeper—after a Hunter had nearly been dragged into a television by those hands, what would happen next?

By any reasonable logic, still shaken and frightened, a person would quicken their pace and head straight for that "staircase leading to the third floor."

Preventing people from lingering in front of the televisions probably also carried a layer of suggestion: stopping and starting between the apartment doors (illusions) was always unsettling—what if you ended up standing in the wrong spot? Of course it was better to get upstairs as quickly as possible.

The moment he became aware of this, Taylor Ford stopped moving.

Come to think of it... he was truly glad he had photographed all the residents' mailboxes when he first entered the apartment building.

When he saw that the last room at the end of the corridor was Room 210, he had felt a faint sense of wrongness; and when Taylor Ford pulled up the photo on his phone just now, he finally understood the source of that unease—in the row of second-floor mailboxes, there were clearly eleven of them.

Eleven mailboxes, corresponding to eleven apartments—so where had the very last apartment gone?

Taylor Ford had two guesses.

One: a massive screen had been stretched in front of Room 211, and the staircase he could see was actually a projected image—likely able to pull people in just like the television screens.

Two: from the moment he reached the second floor, he had already entered a parallel reality, one in which Room 211 did not exist.

Either way, both possibilities pointed to the same conclusion: he could not walk up the staircase ahead.

Walking up it would mean he had fully committed himself to a parallel reality different from his original life.

Counting from when Taylor Ford began entering the Nest on a regular basis at age twelve, he had encountered more Rule Domains, scripts, traps, and other ill-defined territories not yet named by Hunters than he could count...

Though there were occasional exceptions, one general rule held: among the rules conveyed to Hunters, there might be concealment, there might be traps, but outright brazen deception was rare.

The woman in Room 201 had made it clear from the very beginning—behind the televisions lay real parallel realities.

In that case, wasn't the reality Taylor Ford originally came from equally real?

Relative to those other realities, wasn't his own reality also a "parallel reality"?

Among all the television content on the second floor, the only one that matched his original reality—that is, the reality in which the second floor contained a staircase one could use normally to go up and down—was Room 208.

What a masterful deception—the true exit wasn't at the exit at all, but hidden inside a room.

If the trap of the second-floor apartment corridor was not "luring people into other realities" but rather "ensuring people could never return to their original reality"—then everything made perfect sense.

Even the words his mother had said were explained; because even if he had gone back then, it would not have been his original reality.

Thinking of her, Taylor Ford paused.

He drew in another breath and let it out slowly.

...Everything in the second-floor apartment corridor was already behind him.

Since he had not chosen that reality, there was no need to think about it anymore.

Before entering the corridor and after leaving it, Taylor Ford's life had not changed; and what he needed to do had never changed either.

Only by taking the Nest into his own hands...

When Taylor Ford reached the stairwell, he turned to glance at his left—there was nothing but a blank wall.

He drew his gaze back, gripped his gun, crouched slightly, and climbed the stairs one step at a time.

The woman in Room 201 had only gotten out half a sentence, but from those two words "got past again," he should not be the first person to have seen through the second-floor trap—Mai Minghe ought to be somewhere upstairs.

She could see through traps; her mind turned quickly enough.

Still, Taylor Ford was not only cautious but fast—from the moment he entered the front door to now, barely more than half an hour had passed; considering Mai Minghe had a dead weight with an injured ankle beside her, the two of them might still be stuck on the third floor.

So as not to be fooled by the same trick, he had also counted the mailboxes in the photo; the third floor did indeed have only ten apartments.

Just as he was about to step onto the last stair to the third floor, a tremendous bang split the air—Taylor Ford's heart lurched, and he immediately crouched down on the step.

The smell of gunpowder he hadn't noticed before, the spreading thick smoke, the fine dust and debris drifting in the air—all of it came rushing at him together with the explosion; he quickly covered his mouth to keep from coughing out loud.

"Reed Hydes!"

Through the rippling aftershocks of the explosion, Mai Minghe's voice was rasping from somewhere deep in the corridor: "Didn't you say one of your feet was injured? What are you running around for! I really should have crushed both your ankle bones when I had the chance!"

When Reed Hydes replied, his voice sounded close—yet Taylor Ford couldn't work out where he actually was. "You've developed a taste for hurting people? You were just apologizing to me, was all of that fake?"

Mai Minghe sounded both furious and helpless; but no matter how loudly she shouted, no one could tell where in the apartment she was. "Not fake, not fake, I'm sorry, all right? I'm begging you, stop running around!"

"Who's running around," Reed Hydes said, clearly unconvinced. "I'm trying to find a way upstairs! You're not planning to betray me here, are you?"

Hm? He had no idea what kind of trap the third floor was, but from the sound of it... seemed like quite lively content?

Taylor Ford stretched his neck up from the step below and took a look at the third-floor corridor.

The corridor was blanketed in a haze of white smoke, but a rough outline was faintly visible.

Wasn't the staircase right at the other end of the corridor?

It looked like you could just walk straight across and go up... was it not that simple?

Really, it was a rare stroke of luck to be in the position of the mantis stalking the cicada—if he could stay on the staircase and quietly watch what they were dealing with for a bit, wouldn't he have a much better idea of what to expect when it was his turn to go up?

Unfortunately, lingering on the staircase wasn't an option.

This hidden rule inside the apartment building was something Taylor Ford had suddenly realized on his way up to the second floor.

He didn't yet know how long a person could linger on the staircase at most; but he had no desire to be chased by danger and scramble up to the third floor in a panic.

For now, he'd see whether he could slip upstairs quietly without the two of them noticing...

He took a tentative step onto the last stair.

Taylor Ford did not walk into the third-floor corridor as he had imagined.

When his vision swayed and then cleared again, he found himself standing in the entryway of an apartment.

The door bearing the number 301 was slowly swinging shut behind him, closing without a sound.

Before him was an exceptionally spacious living room—large and impressive, yet deeply wrong.

The building itself wasn't big to begin with, yet it could still be divided into ten apartments, which alone said everything about how cramped the individual units must be; so how could the

living room of 301 alone be this spacious?

Taylor Ford looked left and right, and noticed an envelope resting on the key hook mounted on the wall beside the door.

"For the third player to enter," read a line of text on the envelope.

So that would be for me, then?

Taylor Ford took the envelope down, opened it, and found inside a sheet of A4 paper printed densely with small text; he scanned it quickly—sure enough, it was an introduction to the third floor.

He stood where he was, read through the rules on the paper quickly, and slipped it quietly into his bag.

Reed Hydes' voice was coming from roughly twenty meters away, calling out to Mai Minghe and asking where she was now; the two of them went back and forth, both hollering at the top of their lungs.

...Neither of them had any idea that a third person—Taylor Ford—had now joined the third floor.

The more I read, the more I feel like the Artifact Report isn't really a web novel—it's just being published in web novel format.

But it's also quite far from traditional published content, so what exactly it is, I genuinely don't know...

Chapter 152: Mai Minghe — Fortunately, Reed Hydes Was Someone She Could Trust and Work With

Sometimes karma comes around just a little too fast.

Mai Minghe wiped her face with her hand, and when she lowered it, found it smeared with streaks of black ash; her face and body must look like a zebra's by now.

Several small explosions in quick succession had left a swarm of flies buzzing in her ears that she couldn't shake off, but that was nothing compared to the injury on her foot — she carefully set her burned foot down on the floor and hissed a sharp breath through her teeth.

Life in her second life was certainly rich in experience; in just a few days, she'd suffered every kind of torment she'd never once encountered in her first eighty-six years.

Before they'd split up, Reed Hydes had given her a roll of bandages; with her foot wrapped, she could bear a little weight on it and just barely walk — but not fast, and with a pronounced limp.

They had barely made it up to the third floor and had only just figured out the rules when a microwave suddenly exploded behind her, the fire catching her shoe — luckily that microwave was right by a window, and the blast shattered the glass, sending most of the flames out through the opening; she'd only suffered superficial burns, which was a blessing amid the misfortune.

Sigh — after the "find the face in the restaurant" and "television reality" ordeals, she had almost formed a fixed assumption that the Nest's traps were all solved through intellect and careful thinking...

But ever since they'd reached the third floor, she and Reed Hydes had become two fish forced to swim in separate directions, with no room to think — just one explosion after another to dodge.

No matter how fast your mind worked, it couldn't stop a bomb!

Mai Minghe let out a sigh and checked the bedroom one more time.

The wardrobe, the pillows, the fan, the curtains... good — nothing so far had started a countdown to explosion, which meant she might be able to catch her breath for just a moment.

Mai Minghe pulled the crumpled rule sheet from her trouser pocket and decided to read it again, searching between the lines for a way out.

The most glaring feature of this wretched place was that every ordinary piece of household furniture and everyday object, without exception, could randomly explode at any moment — never mind the microwave; even the leftover cold pizza on the kitchen counter had suddenly set off a pepperoni-scented fireworks display in the middle of the room.

What would explode, and what triggered the explosion, left absolutely no trace; even the countdown warning before each blast only gave three numbers — "three, two, one," boom.

And that was only if you actually saw it; if you missed the red countdown digits flickering on an object, it was annihilation erupting from dead silence without any warning at all.

But how could any person possibly keep eyes in the back of their head every single second and never miss a thing?

And yet that wasn't even the most unfair part about the third floor.

The moment you came up the stairs, you weren't deposited into the corridor at all — you were shunted directly into Room 302 beside it. After running and fleeing and taking several blasts, Mai Minghe had finally pieced together the full picture:

It turned out that the dividing walls between all the apartments on both sides of the corridor had been knocked down, essentially turning each side into one enormous apartment; the interiors still retained some partitions, and you could make out traces of different residents having once lived there.

They'd even knocked down the walls — all just to make it easier to catch the fish in the blast, wasn't it?

But even if she wanted to dash into the corridor and sprint straight upstairs in one go, she couldn't — the rules had accounted for exactly that.

Earlier, Mai Minghe had found a pen and, sorting through pages of filler text, circled and organized the actual rules; those were what she was reading over again now.

A. Within a one-meter radius around a player-resident, if another person appears, the floor beneath the one who arrived first will immediately explode.

If two (or more) people enter the one-meter range simultaneously — with no first-or-last order — then the floor beneath all of them will explode at the same time.

She remembered: at that moment she and Reed Hydes had been standing together, reading the letter and discussing it side by side, and the instant they understood this rule, both their expressions changed — the very next second, they'd scrambled apart in a flustered hurry.

At first they had only separated by just over a meter, still within each other's line of sight; but after being chased apart by several random explosions, she had lost track of where Reed Hydes even was.

B. Any object may randomly explode at any time; before it does, red countdown digits (from three to one) will flash on the object.

C. After any explosion (regardless of cause), there is a certain probability that an unexploded bomb will appear in the affected area.

D. A player-resident carrying an unexploded bomb will be exempt from the effects of random object explosions — meaning they can move freely anywhere on the third floor, and even if an object explodes right in their face, they will not be harmed in the slightest.

E. An unexploded bomb that no one has picked up will explode on the spot after ten minutes.

An unexploded bomb that someone has touched will quietly disappear after ten minutes.

F. When a person carrying an unexploded bomb encounters a person without one within a one-meter range, Rule A is nullified; the person carrying the unexploded bomb will simultaneously sustain the dual explosion of both the floor beneath their feet and the unexploded bomb on their person.

If both people have unexploded bombs, or neither does, Rule A applies as normal; Rule A takes priority over Rule D.

G. Once twelve unexploded bombs have all detonated, the staircases leading to the second and fourth floors will open. To use the fourth floor as an example: before the conditions are met, if anyone attempts to force their way up, every single step on that staircase will turn into a bomb and explode simultaneously.

This means not only will the person trying to go up lose their life, but no one after them will ever be able to reach the fourth floor either. The same applies to the second floor.

...The rules had quite a few clauses, but they were easy enough to understand.

Yet every time she read through them, every time she analyzed the rules once more, Mai Minghe couldn't help but feel the same thing: how utterly vicious.

The third floor was a trap designed specifically for multiple Hunters, and from the looks of it, the more people there were, the harder it would be to get through — because every single rule was riddled with room to harm others for one's own gain.

No — it was more accurate to say that whether you were alone or working as a team, getting through the third floor had its own distinct difficulties either way; whereas if a person were to secretly push others onto bombs and use someone else's life to collect unexploded bombs, that one person would have a very good chance of making it upstairs in the end.

If she'd known it would be like this, she might as well have just stayed in the second-floor corridor...

But there was no such thing as "if I'd known" in life.

Mai Minghe crumpled the letter into a ball, thought about throwing it away, then didn't, and tucked it away again.

Although she and Reed Hydes had been scattered apart by the blasts, as long as they followed each other's voices, they could still regroup.

Since they'd come upstairs, there had been seven explosions in total so far — three seemed to have been near Reed Hydes, two near Mai Minghe, and two more appeared to have occurred in places where no one was present — after both of those, she had seen no unexploded bombs appear at the scene.

According to the rule letter's description, unexploded bombs were very conspicuous — a large black sphere that would appear in the center of the floor.

She had just called out to Reed Hydes across the distance, asking if he'd seen any unexploded bombs, but the last explosion seemed to have sent him running even farther away; on top of that, his hearing had been rattled by the blasts just as badly as hers; with too much distance between them, their exchanges had started going completely off the rails —

"What a hundred thousand? Who's giving me a hundred thousand?"

"I'm asking if you've seen any unexploded bombs!"

Reed Hydes, who had apparently run off into the Room 301 apartment cluster on the other side of the corridor at some point, shouted back blankly: "Oh, are you asking if we're a meter apart? Far enough — we're definitely more than a meter apart!"

...Forget it, no more shouting. They needed to meet up, and fast.

The rules of the third floor were cunning and vicious, but whoever had designed them hadn't counted on the people coming upstairs being her and Reed Hydes.

Mai Minghe would never use someone else's life to set off the mines.

And Reed Hydes — she had watched him through her own Resident eyes, making her own assessment — not only was he not that kind of person, but even if such a thought occurred to him, he wouldn't be able to bring himself to act on it.

Being able to trust your companion meant they were already standing on undefeatable ground.

Yesterday was my birthday, and I got neither fun nor food out of it — just trudging through bitter wind and driving rain, frozen and shivering, like a sorry wretch looking up at everyone on the street as if they were my grandfather. Toward bedtime I started getting a sore throat and I'm genuinely afraid I've caught a cold.

I finally managed to get into bed and thought, at last this day is over — but then I fell asleep and the stomachache started... All told, adding up those twenty-odd scraps of sleep I managed through the night, I got three hours at most.

I'm exhausted beyond words. Keeping this chapter short — I'm barely holding on.

Chapter 153: Mai Minghe — Any Object Might Explode

The Nest truly was a strange place, apparently unconstrained by the law of conservation of mass.

Within just a few minutes of an explosion, the site would restore itself to exactly the way it had been before — even the microwave that had burned Mai Minghe in the first blast was now sitting back on the windowsill counter, waiting for its next chance to explode.

Right — restored to its original state meant it could explode all over again.

The third-floor apartment gave them absolutely no openings; the kind of stroke of luck where "once something blows up it becomes a safe zone" simply wasn't going to happen here.

What kind of person had to die to create such a vicious apartment in the Nest?

If a good person died, why couldn't a paradise show up in the Nest instead?

Mai Minghe let her mind wander as she hobbled along on her heels, making her way toward wherever Reed Hydes might be.

The apartments on the right side of the corridor — 302 through 310 — had all been dissolved into one enormous unit; only two entry doors remained, 302 and 310, positioned at either end of the hallway, while every door in between had been sealed shut and couldn't be pushed open no matter what.

The left side, 301 through 309, was naturally the same.

Mai Minghe was in the even-numbered apartment on the right side of the corridor, but at some point Reed Hydes had apparently made his way over to the odd-numbered apartment on the left.

To find him, she would first have to pass through the interior of the even-numbered apartment, come out through door 302, cross the corridor, enter through door 301, and then pass through the interior of the odd-numbered apartment...

Wait — wasn't that logic exactly the same as deliberately placing the safe zone on the sixth floor?

Forcing people to be exposed to maximum risk at every turn.

Mai Minghe lamented that she had lived her whole life too old-fashioned and proper, so that even the curses coming to mind now always felt a little too mild, not vicious enough to satisfy.

Better to just keep moving — she glanced at the microwave that had already blown up on her once, and stepped past it unevenly, hurrying by.

As long as nothing right ahead happened to be counting down, the faster she moved, the less likely she was to get caught in another explosion.

Judging by the layout of the apartment interior, she should be in unit 304 now — the second apartment on the right after coming up from the second floor. She still had to pass through one more unit before she could reach the corridor, and along the way, who knew how many —

A thunderous boom erupted from somewhere deep in the apartment.

It was a small explosion after all, at some distance from her and muffled by the walls, so it sounded smothered, like something had been clamped over it — the floor shuddered once, then settled back to stillness.

She could only tell that it hadn't come from the even-numbered side; the blast had happened in the odd-numbered apartment across the hall.

Surely it hadn't gone off right next to Reed Hydes again?

The thought made her quicken her pace immediately.

As she was about to leave the kitchen area, Mai Minghe glanced back over her shoulder.

The microwave displayed the time — even after being blown up and restored, it continued ticking forward accurately. She wasn't wearing a watch, so the objects in the apartment were her only way to track the time.

The last microwave explosion had been at 3:42 AM, shortly after they'd first arrived on the third floor and just figured out the rules; Mai Minghe had happened to glance at the time a split second before it blew, which was why she remembered that moment so clearly.

The microwave now read 4:29 AM.

Who knew how much longer they'd have to endure on the third floor before they could leave...

Mai Minghe reached out and pushed open the kitchen door.

At the instant the door swung open, the corner of her eye caught a thin, elongated "2" — stretched so far it had nearly lost its original shape — in blood red.

2? Where — how was it already at 2 —

1

There was no time to think, no room to spare her injured foot — she wrenched herself sideways and threw herself down onto the kitchen floor behind her; the next second, a wall of scalding wind wrapped in heat, accompanied by a deafening blast and flying splinters of wood, ignited the surrounding air in an instant.

Tile floors won't burn —

Mai Minghe couldn't stand up and had no time to try; she scrambled across the tile floor on all fours, putting every limb to use as she clawed away from the flames spreading behind her from the explosion. The kitchen filled with thick smoke almost immediately, and she couldn't help coughing uncontrollably.

Too vicious, she thought — by now she had figured out where the explosion had come from.

Who could have guessed that the thing to turn itself into a bomb this time was the door frame?

And not even the outer edge of the door frame, the part a person could actually see — it was the side of the frame with the latch hole, which only became visible once you pushed the door open.

In a spot like that, even if there was a countdown, who could have seen it in advance?

She wasn't sure whether to call herself lucky or unlucky — she had pushed the door open right when the countdown hit 2. Unlucky, in that she'd walked straight into it; lucky, in that she'd still had one number's worth of time to react, and so hadn't been caught in the full force of the blast. But lucky? She had still managed to open the door at exactly the moment the door frame exploded.

If she'd been truly lucky, she would have stayed far away from the door frame to begin with...

Hm?

Mai Minghe sat up in the smoke, pulled up her shirt hem to cover her nose and mouth, and as she waited for the smoke to clear, a thought suddenly surfaced.

Come to think of it, why had almost every explosion so far happened right next to someone?

Weren't they supposed to be random?

Mai Minghe tucked that thought away for now — before she could analyze it further, she needed to find Reed Hydes first.

Just as objects restored themselves to their previous state, the fires produced by the explosions didn't burn on indefinitely either; both the flames and the smoke gradually died away and disappeared within a few minutes, and the kitchen returned once again to exactly how it had looked before the blast.

This time, no unexploded bomb had turned up either.

When she pushed the door open, Mai Minghe's heart was still pounding — she swept a quick glance at the door frame. The door frame played innocent, a strip of pure white.

...Oh, go to hell.

Through the kitchen was unit 304's living room; with the wall gone, she could walk directly from 304's living room into 302's.

Mai Minghe opened the front door of unit 302 and stuck her head out into the corridor, taking a look around first — no Reed Hydes, as expected.

Her ears were full of buzzing and ringing; unless something was close by or loud enough, it was nearly impossible to hear clearly. Fortunately, the lights on the third floor were all on, so at least she had her vision to rely on.

Mai Minghe pushed open the door to unit 301 and swept a quick look inside.

The layouts of the apartments on either side of the corridor were similar, so unit 301's living room connected straight through to unit 303's — at first glance, it looked quite spacious and grand, almost impressive. For searching purposes, though, it was actually convenient: nothing was hidden from view.

She froze.

Why wasn't Reed Hydes here?

When she had pushed the door open, she had been seventy or eighty percent certain that Reed Hydes was inside unit 301 — not only because the two of them had still been carrying on that

disjointed conversation moments ago. Now that she saw he wasn't there, she was so taken aback that she stood rooted to the spot for several seconds.

She had clearly felt like he was in unit 301 just now...

Hm? Strange — why had she felt that way?

She hadn't been able to hear clearly, she couldn't see inside before opening the door, and Reed Hydes had never said anything about being in 301... it really must have just been her imagination.

"Hey — Reed Hydes!"

She called out — though calling was probably pointless; the buzzing of flies in Reed Hydes's ears couldn't be any less deafening than in hers.

Between the two of them right now, their combined hearing was probably no better than their own eighty-six-year-old selves.

Mai Minghe hobbled through the connected living rooms of units 301 and 303, and in the bedroom at the far end of unit 303, she found Reed Hydes — or more precisely, she found Reed Hydes's backside.

Under the backside were two feet: one healthy, one wrapped in bandages.

The posture was somewhere between kneeling and sprawling — either way, the rest of his body had been stuffed under the bed.

Mai Minghe couldn't get within a meter of him; she called out twice, and he didn't seem to hear her.

There was nothing for it — she glanced around, grabbed a handful of soil from a potted plant sitting in the corridor, stood in the doorway, and threw it at Reed Hydes.

A thud sounded, followed immediately by a bang from under the bed, as though Reed Hydes had startled and knocked his head against the bed frame.

"Hey, are you okay?"

Mai Minghe immediately winced for him, feeling a little guilty. Poor kid — he'd already had such a rough time today. "Does it hurt?"

"What did you say?" Reed Hydes called out from under the bed, his voice muffled.

Still calling out, he reversed himself and crawled out from under the bed, emerging disheveled and dusty.

The two of them were actually only a meter or two apart, yet both had to shout at the top of their lungs, mouthing every word with exaggerated clarity — "What were you doing?" Mai Minghe asked from the doorway.

"Looking for unexploded bombs. The wardrobe door suddenly blew up just now." Reed Hydes answered, pointing at the wardrobe.

He suddenly looked down, stared at the dirt scattered all over the floor around him, slapped at his trousers several times, and demanded: "Wait — what did you throw at me?"

Oh, that doesn't matter, Mai Minghe waved it off.

"Lucky I saw the countdown in time. But there was no chance to run out of the bedroom by then — I could only dive into the corner of the room, and that was just barely enough to dodge the blast wave without getting hurt."

He wiped the dust off his face, frowning.

"The bedroom was billowing with smoke at that point, and I was coughing so hard my eyes were streaming. But I think I spotted a round black shadow on the floor in the smoke... I thought, maybe an unexploded bomb had finally turned up? Only the fire was burning too strong, so I couldn't go over to get a closer look. But once the room settled back to normal, I looked again — the floor was completely empty."

Mai Minghe understood, and couldn't help frowning along with him. "You thought the unexploded bomb had rolled under the bed?"

"Exactly," Reed Hydes said, getting to his feet reluctantly, "but I checked everywhere. Nothing."

Nine explosions in total, and there should have been at least one unexploded bomb by now; yet the one faint lead they'd had might well have been just a shadow conjured by smoke, firelight, and streaming eyes.

If the odds of an unexploded bomb appearing were this low, how many more explosions would it take to fulfill the conditions for opening the staircase?

At this rate, the stairs would never open — she and Reed Hydes would be blown to death first.

"Didn't two of them go off in spots where no one was around?" Mai Minghe asked, clinging to both anxiety and faint hope. "Do you know where? Maybe those two explosions left behind unexploded bombs."

Reed Hydes pulled a miserable face and shook his head.

"One happened in the living room of unit 301 — I went to check; nothing. The other one wasn't in an unoccupied spot at all... that one was right next to me too."

"You've run into five explosions?" Mai Minghe was startled, and looked him up and down urgently. "Are you hurt anywhere?"

Reed Hydes's face scrunched up into a look so pained it could have wrung out bitterness by the drop.

"My hands got burned, and my back is aching where debris hit me... if this keeps up, I honestly don't know if I'll last until the first unexploded bomb shows up."

Mai Minghe bit her lip; unease was like weed seeds pressing against the inside of her chest, ready to split it open.

Nine times now, and not a single unexploded bomb in sight...

"Let's try to move together as much as possible — keeping more than a meter apart, of course," she said. "You're more badly hurt than I am, so if we find an unexploded bomb, you should hold on to it first — just to be safe."

"Huh? Is that really okay?" Reed Hydes blinked.

This kid really was such a straightforward soul — it was only a promise, he hadn't actually gotten the unexploded bomb yet, and he was already grateful: "If I'm holding it, it won't explode, which means it can't help open the staircase..."

Mai Minghe waved her hand, just about to tell him not to worry about it, when the hair on her back suddenly stood on end—a thin, stretched red light flashed past with the movement of her hand.

What was that?

When she lowered her head and made out the source of the red light, she also realized she had noticed it far too late.

The hand she had used just moments ago to grab a fistful of dirt and throw it at Reed Hydes—there was still a bit of dirt stuck to her fingernails that hadn't been flung off.

Right now, on that tiny bit of dirt caught in the crease of her fingernail, a small "1"—the size of a sesame seed—was glowing.

I opened the app today and nearly slid right off my chair from the shock of seeing 奎离姥姥's tip—oh my god, this has to be the biggest tip I've ever seen since I started writing! Ten thousand!! An actual ten thousand!!

And Qidian is taking five thousand of it!!

I feel grateful and terrified and heartbroken and guilty all at once—can you imagine?

Is the Artifact series really that good? I'm so overwhelmed—have the people praising it been brainwashed by me, tricked by me? Did I accidentally start a cult?

And 奎离姥姥 would be the one who's fallen deepest into it so far?

I keep feeling like this counts as telecom fraud on my part—am I going to show up in a police bulletin in a couple of days?

奎离姥姥, the surprise you gave me was truly too enormous—so enormous that I'm starting to wonder if the Artifact series can even live up to it!

How can I ever repay this gesture? At the very least I'd have to write several bonus chapters just for you—on top of that, I'll mail you my ID card, split one of my cats with you, and if that still doesn't feel like enough, I'll make you twenty pounds of dumplings too...

We're all just ordinary people—who could have imagined that one day I'd be getting treated like a live-streamer? How do streamers usually thank their big tippers—do they also make dumplings?

Chapter 154: Mai Minghe — The Fisherman Who Came Back Empty-Handed

In that instant, reason and thought were both completely useless.

Pure instinct, driven by fear, made Mai Minghe move without thinking.

In that hair-thin gap between the "1" disappearing and the explosion beginning, she had somehow still managed to do one thing.

Mai Minghe had been standing in the doorway talking the whole time, resting her hand against the door frame on several occasions; the moment the red countdown number flashed into view, her hair stood on end, and she instinctively swept her hand across the door—

It was as if the explosion began in the very next instant.

Sharp pain drove into her nerves like an awl; her fingers, as though imbued with some strange power—wherever they swept, things detonated, bursting along the door frame one after another into tiny, brilliant flashes of light the size of fingernails; wood splinters flew, and the flashes linked together into a thin, leaping, rising line of flame.

It wasn't until Mai Minghe's back slammed into the wall that she realized she had blacked out and stumbled backward out of the room; even through the ringing in her ears, she could hear her own cry of pain, as if she were trying to expel all the agony in her fingers through the force of her voice.

"Fire!" Reed Hydes was shouting at that moment, muffled and distant, as if filtered through some barrier. "Smother the flame with your clothes, hurry!"

Cold sweat, panic, trembling muscles, and the momentary bewilderment that comes with pain when a person is injured—all of it pressed down on every nerve like a thick, suffocating fog.

His shout brought her back to her senses; she realized there were still flames on her fingers, and quickly grabbed the hem of her clothing and pressed it hard against them—the moment she did, it wrenched out another long, wailing cry.

"Okay, okay, the fire's out, it's out, that's good..."

Reed Hydes didn't dare walk toward her; he could only crane his neck and scan the floor from a distance, as if searching for something.

Amid the cold sweat, tears, and trembling, Mai Minghe released her grip on the clothing, and for a moment, couldn't bring herself to look at the fingers hidden beneath it. Her hand had become a boundless source of agonizing pain, with no sense of its shape left at all.

"Oh, thank goodness, thank goodness," Reed Hydes suddenly let out a sigh of relief and said, "There's only blood and a fingernail on the floor... you scared me to death. I was afraid I'd look down and see half a finger blown clean off."

...It wasn't severed?

Only then did Mai Minghe finally muster the courage to steal a glance at her fingertip.

Through the mess of blood and flesh, the entire nail was gone, leaving only torn, gaping skin. The nerve was likely damaged too, but small mercies—the injury stopped there; her index finger was still intact.

"What was it that suddenly exploded?" Reed Hydes asked, rummaging through his backpack for the first-aid kit.

Oh, right—the soil caught under her nail had shown a countdown, and he had no way of seeing it.

Breathing through the pain, Mai Minghe took a deep breath before explaining, "It was the last bit of soil still on me..."

Reed Hydes' mouth fell half-open; he glanced at the soil scattered across the floor, then instinctively took two steps back.

He set the first-aid kit on the floor and gave it a hard shove so it slid over to Mai Minghe's side.

"That swipe you made probably spread and thinned out the soil that was about to turn into an explosive, which weakened the blast... and it was only a tiny bit to begin with, right?" he asked, watching Mai Minghe begin to treat the wound.

"Right," she said, the end of a bandage clenched between her teeth, her words muffled through her teeth. "That's why I never even saw the countdown."

A blast countdown appearing at a scale so small you'd almost need a magnifying glass to see it—that was practically cheating.

Her right hand was injured, leaving only her left to clean, disinfect, and bandage the wound; it was always clumsy going, and the final dressing left something to be desired—she could only endure for now and get proper treatment once she was out of the Nest.

Fortunately, as people grow older, their tolerance for pain grows thicker too; she had endured far worse during her time suffering in the hospital.

"By the way, what about the unexploded bomb?" Reed Hydes asked. "Is there one in the hallway near you? There's still nothing in the room."

Prompted by this, Mai Minghe looked around in every direction—she even checked inside the potted plant's soil—and still found no unexploded bomb.

Ten explosions, and both she and Reed Hydes were battered and barely mobile—and not a single unexploded bomb had appeared?

Reed Hydes seemed to lose all his energy at once.

He sat on the bedroom floor, gazing across at Mai Minghe from a distance, and let out a bitter laugh. "Looks like those rules on the third floor of the apartment were just there to mess with us! I've never come across a Nest trap that doesn't leave even the slightest way out... I honestly don't know what to do anymore."

"Are there really places like this?" Mai Minghe felt a pang of dread. "Places where the rules mean nothing and only exist to torment and kill people—are they common in the Nest? I don't have anything like that in the information I have."

"I really don't know."

Reed Hydes stared blankly for a moment, then said, "At least I've never personally encountered one, and I don't think I've heard any other Hunter mention it either... Generally speaking, when a place spells out its rules clearly, those rules are supposed to be real and valid."

"The rules we're dealing with right now could still be real," Mai Minghe said hesitantly, "but that doesn't necessarily mean there's a way out."

After all, if you wanted to split hairs, the phrase "there is a certain probability of an unexploded bomb appearing" left a lot of room for interpretation: ninety percent was a

probability, and 0.000001% was a probability too.

"Technically speaking, yes—but in practice, the Nest is much like the real world; it still tends toward the interpretation most people would make based on everyday common sense."

Reed Hydes shook his head. "Generally, when we say 'a certain probability,' we don't mean a statistically negligible one, right? We'd just say 'an extremely small probability.' And another thing—have you ever thought about it: since people can't leave personal belongings behind in the Nest, what happens to shed hair? What about skin flakes? What about the carbon dioxide we breathe out?"

Mai Minghe was taken aback. "I really never thought about that..."

"Because by ordinary usage, none of those count as 'personal belongings,' right? In the real world, when has any announcement ever told you to keep your personal belongings secure and then gone out of its way to clarify, 'not including hair, skin flakes, or carbon dioxide?'"

"That's true. When you put it that way, I think I understand..." Mai Minghe said. "The boundaries of the Nest's rules are drawn by the common-sense understanding of the majority."

"Exactly. Language is inherently an ambiguous tool for communication—looking for loopholes or being pedantic about it serves no purpose." Reed Hydes seemed pleased as he said it, and even paid her a compliment: "You catch on fast."

"If the rules seem to have left us a way out, why haven't we seen a single unexploded bomb until now?" Mai Minghe glanced at him and asked. "What do we do next?"

Reed Hydes cleared his throat. "...I don't know either. Wasn't I just explaining things to you? As for what to do—your guide needs to think it over too."

With that, both of them fell silent.

They had been shouting and speaking at full voice earlier, but when the sound retreated from Room 303, it wasn't replaced by dead silence—a droning buzz still floated persistently in their ears.

Mai Minghe couldn't even make out the soft sigh she exhaled.

"The rules are truly unfair," she said, feeling the nerves in her fingers pulsing with each throb, watching the bloodstain seeping through the gauze. "...Where's the 'random' in any of this? The explosions have been following us around the whole time."

This was also why she hadn't gotten up and moved: if the explosions were going to follow her no matter where she went, she might as well stay in one spot and wait, if nothing else to conserve her energy.

Reed Hydes also let out a sigh.

"Right—sometimes, the rules you see on the surface aren't necessarily all there is... what's specifically hidden underneath has to be figured out from the situation. Isn't the real world the same way? Where there are rules, there are unwritten rules; where there are written regulations, there are unwritten constraints. Sometimes, the subtle, unpleasant aspects of the real world are all magnified several times over inside the Nest."

Mai Minghe looked at him.

This kid was young, yet he already seemed to have accumulated a great deal of weariness and bitterness; the current era, compared to when she was young, seemed more complicated and bewildering, more liable to leave people at a loss.

The rule "any object may randomly explode" was now, in hindsight, probably missing a modifier—"any object near a person may randomly explode" was likely the truly complete version of the rule.

Hmm, though that didn't seem quite right either, since one explosion had occurred in an unoccupied area...

Mai Minghe couldn't work it out—probably because her thoughts had long since been riddled with holes by the relentless stabs of pain.

"Let's get up," said Mai Minghe, soaked through with exhaustion and pain, having nothing more than this one thought left to her. "If we're standing, it'll be easier to run or dodge."

Reed Hydes had taken quite a beating as well; when he climbed to his feet, his hands and legs were slow and unsteady.

"Let's find somewhere open to wait—staying cooped up in this bedroom isn't good; the space is too small, and the next time an explosion happens you might not be able to get out of the way."

As she said this, Mai Minghe, who had been about to head toward Room 305, suddenly paused and looked back.

Somewhere open...

Come to think of it, ever since they'd read the rules, they seemed to have been instinctively avoiding areas with things in them, trying to stick to open ground.

When she thought about it, of course they had.

The connected living room shared by Rooms 303 and 301 held two sets of furniture in different styles that served the same functions—originally two separate households, naturally they would have two sets of everything—but as it happened, both households had placed their large pieces—sofas, coffee tables, televisions, bookshelves and the like—against the wall on the right-hand side, directly across from the front entrance.

That way, anyone coming in through the front door would naturally be walking on the empty half of the floor.

Looking back at it now, it was almost as if a path had been cleared on purpose.

"What are you looking at?"

Reed Hydes' voice startled Mai Minghe back to her senses. "You have to move away from the doorway first so I can get out."

"Oh, right," Mai Minghe responded, pulling her gaze away.

She hadn't quite figured out yet what it meant—the fact that she had been instinctively sticking to open spaces the whole time.

"Hold on, I'm going back to take a look. Keep your distance and go wait for me in 305."

With that, Mai Minghe turned and walked into the connected living room shared by Rooms 301 and 303—she was careful to stay on the "open path" and didn't go near the furniture.

If a large piece of furniture like a sofa exploded at close range, rolling or diving wouldn't be enough to escape the damage... the entire apartment would be swallowed up.

But if the explosions followed the person, that meant she could, in turn, "choose" what to make explode, thereby reducing the likelihood of something like a sofa going off—by simply not going near large pieces of furniture.

Thinking about it this way, the Nest's rules seemed unfair on the surface, yet they also concealed a balancing mechanism...

The phrase "balancing mechanism" circled through her mind a few times, then vanished without a trace—like a fisherman who hadn't caught a thing, leaving empty-handed.

Mai Minghe crouched down and lightly ran her hand across the living room floor of Room 303, coming away with a palmful of dust.

Then she looked at the "open path" she had walked and the bedroom floor—neither was as dusty, as if the residents had been cleaning on a regular schedule.

What did that mean...

"What's going on?"

While she was thinking, Reed Hydes had already gone into Room 305, and called out from a distance: "What are you looking at?"

"Coming, coming," Mai Minghe said, turning to walk toward him.

In the next moment, a still-life painting hanging on the wall beside him lit up with a red "3" from within the bouquet of flowers.

"Jump left!" Mai Minghe snapped sharply — almost at the same moment, a flicker of red suddenly mixed into the light above her head.

I didn't sleep well again last night, and I'm completely exhausted today. When I think about it carefully, I really have accumulated a lot of writing debt... I feel anxious, but also very happy.

To think that someone actually wants to read the garbled mess churned out by these donkey hooves of mine, and I even owe them chapters — it seems that grinding the millstone must come paired with a con. Other people run pig-butcherings; I run a millstone-grinding scam.

Chapter 155 — Mai Minghe Catches Someone Red-Handed

A framed painting and a flush-mount ceiling light — in everyday life, neither amounts to much.

Yet when they turned into bombs, detonating simultaneously less than three meters apart, it was as though space itself had begun to expand at breakneck speed, shattering and splintering apart, giving Mai Minghe the illusion that she was about to be buried here — so slow, it turned out, was the human body; so soft and sluggish.

The ceiling, the wall where the painting hung, and on the other side of that wall, the outer corridor...

In those brief moments, it was as if everything was exploding, collapsing, crumbling into fragments that came crashing down.

A three-digit countdown had snatched one life back for Mai Minghe — but one life was all she had managed to keep: in the smoke, the firelight, and the crumbling apartment, she stumbled and lurched through the battering airwaves, and a chunk of concrete found the back of her head at just the right moment — a searing flash of pain, and she lost consciousness.

How long she was out, Mai Minghe had no idea.

By the time she finally opened her eyes again, the apartment had long since returned to pristine wholeness — it felt as though even the dust had obediently settled back into its original position, not a single particle more, not a single particle less, not a single particle shifted, forming together with the walls and floor a perfect illusion that nothing had happened at all.

The ringing in her ears was gone; in its place was something more like water packed solid inside her ear canals — she could not even make out the sound of her own groans.

Mai Minghe worked her jaw open and shut several times, then tapped gently at the shell of her ear with her fingers, and only then managed to confirm, with some effort, that she had not gone deaf.

...At least not yet.

A few more rounds of this, and who could say.

"Reed?"

She was clearly shouting, yet the sound reached her muffled and dim, as though she were underwater. "Can you still hear me? Are you all right?"

She hauled herself upright with great effort, each step shambling like a zombie out of a movie.

There were still no unexploded bombs nearby — not even anything that came close to resembling a "black sphere."

Mai Minghe considered whether the unexploded bomb might simply be very small, or whether the blast had sent it rolling under the sofa; but within her range of vision, everything looked exactly as it had before the explosion.

...How could this be?

If this side had produced no unexploded bomb after the blast, Reed's side should have had one by now, at least.

Mai Minghe crossed through the corridor and walked into Room 305, where the still-life painting that had just exploded once seemed to be hiding behind its glass frame, suppressing laughter with great effort — the glass trembled and shimmered with dancing light and shadow.

...Her vision must have gone blurry too.

Not far ahead, Reed was leaning against the wall and sitting on the floor, his mouth opening and closing, apparently having been calling out to Mai Minghe the whole time; yet she could hear nothing.

They soon discovered that as long as they kept more than a meter between them, neither could hear a word the other said.

Never mind hearing — Mai Minghe felt as if her entire being had been wrapped and submerged in murky water. She slid down the wall to sit on the floor, gave a wry smile, made a circle with her hand, and pointed at Reed.

Reed understood immediately, shook his head, then pointed back at Mai Minghe.

Mai Minghe shook her head as well.

...Neither of them had found an unexploded bomb.

In that moment, the expression on Reed's face — how to describe it? It was like someone who had known all along they were about to be slapped across the face, yet still clung to the hope that

maybe it wouldn't happen; and then, right in the middle of that hope, got slapped across the face anyway.

Twelve explosions. Unexploded bombs: zero.

Mai Minghe sat blankly on the floor, and for a moment, she could not even muster enough energy to drag disappointment out from the blank emptiness of her thoughts.

Right — was there anything in the information the Nest had fed them that might help resolve the problem at hand?

Her mind felt heavy and sluggish, as though she had to push it along beat by beat before her thoughts would move forward.

She was soon disappointed — for all its richness, the information the Nest had provided could not explain why the rules given by the third floor of the apartment differed so drastically from what was actually happening.

No matter how she looked at it, an unexploded bomb should have appeared by now.

She dug her fingers hard into her hair several times, and in the anxious dread of not knowing when the next explosion would come, a question suddenly surfaced in her mind — "Reed, what time is it?"

As she said it, Mai Minghe mimed the gesture of checking a watch.

Reed glanced at his children's cartoon watch — the fact that it was still running was something of a minor miracle in itself.

Then he held up one finger for "four," followed by two fives.

Four fifty-five?

Both of them had already lost half their lives, yet from the last time she had checked the microwave's time display, only twenty-five minutes had passed?

In those twenty-five minutes, she had been caught in three explosions — no, wait, that wasn't right, she couldn't count it that way.

After all, Mai Minghe had been unconscious for a while.

Given that Reed had not gone looking for her, it could be inferred that she had not been out for long. Assuming she had been unconscious for about five minutes, it was more accurate to say

that in twenty minutes, she had been caught in three explosions: once by the door frame, once by the dust particles, and once by the ceiling light.

...Wasn't that too frequent?

She and Reed had gone up to the third floor shortly before 3:40, and the first explosion — the microwave explosion — had occurred at 3:42 AM.

From 3:42 AM to 4:29 AM, when she next saw the microwave, thirty-seven minutes had passed, and she had only been caught in two explosions.

The gap between those first thirty-seven minutes and the following twenty was far too wide.

Could the explosion frequency also be random?

If it was random, there was nothing more to say — she would just have to keep her head down and take the hits.

But if it wasn't... then sometime before four-thirty in the morning, something must have happened that had suddenly caused the frequency of explosions targeting her and Reed to spike.

The thought jolted Mai Minghe; she was just about to call out when she stopped herself.

She thought for a moment, then began frantically gesturing at Reed — but gave up on her own before she'd even finished — what she wanted to ask was too complicated for hand signals; she would need paper and pen.

Before Mai Minghe could even get up to look for some, she saw Reed turn and rummage through his backpack; almost as if he could read minds, he held up paper and a pen, tilted them toward her in a questioning gesture, as if to ask, "Is this what you need?"

This kid had remarkably sharp instincts — he was an experienced Hunter, after all, and truly came prepared.

He rolled the paper and pen into a tube and tossed it over; Mai Minghe caught it with one hand and quickly wrote a line on the paper.

"Do you remember roughly what time the no-man's-land explosion happened? If you don't, an estimate is fine."

Reed looked at the paper, furrowed his brow, and thought for a few seconds.

Then he held up "four" — his hand lingered in the air for a moment, and with some hesitation, he held up "two" and "five."

In other words, a few minutes after the "no-man's-land explosion," the frequency of explosions around them had increased?

Why would that be?

And moreover, that was the only "no-man's-land explosion" so far — wasn't that too unusual to ignore?

Even if Mai Minghe couldn't hear anything right now, if an explosion had occurred somewhere on the third floor, her feet on the floorboards should have felt the vibration.

There had been no vibration at all...

Vibration...?

Wait... she lifted her head blankly and stared at the framed painting on the wall of Room 305.

Several shadowy thoughts that had been circling in the depths of her mind since just moments ago now surfaced one by one.

The width of the corridor... it was more than a meter, wasn't it?

About a meter and a half to two meters?

Which meant... which meant...

Mai Minghe grew more and more unsettled by the guess forming in her mind; she laid out all the facts and clues she had gathered so far, trying to see the full picture they assembled.

The no-man's-land explosion had occurred only once, at around 4:25.

When Reed went to investigate the site of that explosion, he had found no unexploded bomb there.

After that, starting from 4:29 AM, the frequency of explosions targeting her and Reed had risen — yet not a single unexploded bomb had been found.

The apartment's rules seemed unfair on the surface, yet maintained a kind of hidden balance — for instance, explosions occurred right next to people; but conversely, people could avoid triggering large pieces of furniture by simply not going near them.

In the living rooms of Rooms 301 and 303, a clear, furniture-free "walkway" had been carved out.

At the same time, in the center of the Room 303 living room, there was a patch of floor where the dust was noticeably thicker and deeper than elsewhere.

...And: whoever was holding an unexploded bomb was unaffected by explosions.

Mai Minghe shot to her feet, apparently startling Reed, and winced sharply from the pain herself.

She hurried to gesture for Reed to hand her the paper and pen, then quickly wrote out a few lines — truthfully, managing to finish writing without an explosion occurring in the meantime was a stroke of luck in itself.

"We need to figure out what to do!" Knowing full well that Reed couldn't hear her, Mai Minghe shouted anyway as he read the note.

Reed finished reading and looked up at her, his face full of confusion; even so, despite clearly having many questions, he gave a nod.

Mai Minghe didn't dare waste time — she turned immediately and headed toward Room 301, limping as she went. Per the note's instructions, Reed should have been calling out something behind her just then; of course, she couldn't hear a word.

A few steps out, she glanced back.

Reed appeared to have finished calling out, and had turned to head in the direction of Room 309 — both of them had injured feet, so no matter how hard they pushed, they couldn't move very quickly; all they could do now was pray that explosions wouldn't hit both of them at once.

If her guess was correct, only one more explosion would occur — and it would be near her.

About a minute or two later, as Mai Minghe was nearing the doorway of Room 301, she spotted the countdown to the next explosion.

This time, the scales of luck finally tipped a little in her favor.

Not only did she see the countdown numbers in advance, the object about to explode was nothing more than a small ceramic dog figurine, barely the size of a fist — the only problem was that once the explosion went off, her position would be exposed.

When a small burst of flame erupted behind her, Mai Minghe could no longer spare a thought for the injury on her foot — she yanked open the door to Room 301 and rushed into the corridor. In that instant, even before she had taken in the full scene ahead of her, she was already certain beyond any doubt.

"Don't move!"

Mai Minghe stepped forward to plant herself in the center of the corridor, raised her eyes, and roared: "Take one step and I'm coming at you!"

A little more than a meter ahead of her, Taylor Ford was standing in the middle of the corridor.

For some reason, he was holding a broom and a dustpan; he stared at her blankly, blinking a few times, as if he hadn't yet registered what was happening.

Particularly productive today — the update went out late, but I've somehow developed a completely unfounded confidence in my own efficiency. I'll try to write some extra content in a bit; let's set today's goal at twenty thousand characters —

Done laughing? Let's chat — where is everyone going for National Day holiday?

Chapter 156: Hunter Positions One Minute After Taylor Ford

Taylor Ford glanced back.

The dim yellow light stretched down the long corridor, thickening into murk at the far end, vaguely shrouding the last two apartment doors.

As if in response to his gaze, Reed Hydes chose that exact moment to push open the door of Room 309.

He strode to claim the center of the corridor, looked up, and came face to face with Taylor Ford — seemingly startled — and called out from a distance: "Holy crap, you're actually here?"

...So this guy hadn't noticed him at all. It was the old lady who'd found him.

Taylor Ford greeted him with a smile that didn't reach his eyes — how could he smile sincerely right now.

He was stuck in the corridor, and no matter which way he moved, Mai Minghe and the other could charge within one meter of him and trigger an explosion.

Judging by how confident those two looked, it meant... they had already confirmed that he was carrying an unexploded bomb; whoever was carrying one, regardless of who arrived first, was always the one who got blown up.

Taylor Ford let out a sigh, leaned the broom and dustpan against the wall, and said: "Although I knew I couldn't keep my scheming under wraps forever, you figured it out much sooner than I expected."

Mai Minghe stared at him, her expression wary, yet faintly tinged with confusion.

Was there something hard to understand about that?

Taylor Ford was momentarily puzzled too; he had no choice but to make his compliment more explicit: "You think fast — you're quite the formidable opponent."

Mai Minghe opened her mouth halfway, as if to hide something, her eyes drifting to one side.

...Why wasn't she responding?

"What's wrong?... Don't tell me you think my compliment wasn't good enough?" Taylor Ford was genuinely baffled. "First time I've met someone who loves being praised even more than I do

— oh! You can't hear me!"

This time he laughed in earnest, loud enough for it to ring out.

"Ha, I had a blind spot there — makes sense, after getting blown up over and over, which french fry could still hear people talking..."

Never mind that Mai Minghe couldn't hear clearly; it didn't stop her from sensing the insult. She furrowed her brows, glared daggers at Taylor Ford, pointed at the broom and dustpan, and shouted: "What's the deal with that? What have you been doing? You — write it down."

Taylor Ford thought for a few seconds.

That was actually a very good demand. If she hadn't made it and just had her and Reed Hydes close in from both ends, it would have given Taylor Ford more trouble — after all, everything had gone smoothly since he'd come up to the third floor.

"Writing is so slow,"

He pulled out his phone and mimed typing; Mai Minghe hesitated, as if just remembering that phones had that function, then nodded.

What followed was her watching Taylor Ford's fingers fly and dance across the screen, a long block of text appearing in no time at all — her eyes and mouth both widened, unable to conceal her astonishment — as if Taylor Ford were not typing, but performing a high-wire aerial act.

"You wrote all this? In just that little bit of time?"

After Taylor Ford slid the phone across the floor to her, Mai Minghe picked it up and clicked her tongue in admiration: "That's some real speed — whoosh whoosh, and the words just appeared. Look at this, so much written."

Hm?

Taylor Ford glanced at her — he never would have expected someone to credit the phone's performance to him — had he known, he would have included the part where he photographed the residents' mailboxes too.

What he had done after reaching the third floor did indeed amount to quite a lot, written out.

If one traced it back to its root, the very first thought that set off everything Taylor Ford did afterward was his realization that there was an "imbalance" in the rules.

When you thought about it carefully, the rewards and risks for someone carrying an unexploded bomb were completely disproportionate.

By all logic, the third floor of the apartment should have been trying its best to encourage people to pick up unexploded bombs — only by keeping the bombs from detonating and letting them quietly disappear could anyone hope to linger on the third floor longer.

Yet someone who picked up an unexploded bomb only gained immunity to explosions for ten minutes — earlier, when Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes were shouting back and forth, Taylor Ford had heard every word clearly enough to know that before he'd come upstairs, the two of them had been encountering a random explosion roughly once every ten minutes on average.

Spending one unexploded bomb to be immune to a single random explosion that you could have dodged by your own reflexes anyway — that benefit was already small enough, wasn't it?

But set it against the risks, and that benefit nearly vanished entirely — regardless of who arrived first, the moment anyone came within range of someone carrying an unexploded bomb, the latter would instantly take the combined blast of both the unexploded bomb and the floor beneath them.

In other words, death.

To run the risk of "dying the instant anyone comes near you for ten minutes," the unexploded bomb absolutely had to offer something greater in return — but what?

To figure that out, Taylor Ford first had to get his hands on an unexploded bomb.

Odd-numbered apartments on the left side were Reed Hydes's, even-numbered on the right were Mai Minghe's — so of course he had to follow Reed Hydes!

Taylor Ford swept a glance at Mai Minghe's foot, shoes off and wrapped in bandages.

He hadn't known yet at the time that Mai Minghe's foot was injured too, so he immediately decided to tail Reed Hydes with his fractured ankle — as it turned out, it was both the correct and the lucky choice.

Not long after Taylor Ford quietly fell in behind Reed Hydes, a fourth explosion went off near Reed Hydes.

And it was in that very explosion that Taylor Ford spotted the unexploded bomb.

Mai Minghe seemed to have reached that part; she snapped her head up and shot him a glare.

"Glaring at me won't do any good — the apartment practically handed that one to me."

Taylor Ford muttered under his breath, "Besides, given our positions, was I really supposed to tip him off and say, hey, you dropped your unexploded bomb?"

When the explosion hit, everything ahead dissolved into chaos; small as the device was, it still blew half the wall apart.

Shards flying outward, fire spreading outward, hot air coiling upward... through all that chaos, Taylor Ford followed the sound of something rolling, looked down, and found an unexploded bomb — small, black, and round — trundling across the floor toward him. A windfall.

But just before he bent down to pick it up, Taylor Ford stopped.

As for why... it was because the bomb had "rolled" over.

The rules only stated that "an unexploded bomb not picked up by anyone will detonate after ten minutes" — a bomb rolling across the floor toward him hadn't been picked up by anyone, had it?

So what if he found something — Taylor Ford had glanced around at the time and quickly spotted a broom and dustpan snapped together — and used the broom to nudge the bomb along, rolling it forward; would that count as "being picked up by someone"?

"That's how Nest rules work — you have to keep probing and feeling your way, analyzing and reasoning, before you can truly map out the edges and the full picture."

Knowing full well Mai Minghe couldn't hear him, Taylor Ford still couldn't help saying: "Same as in real life — the phenomena and events inside the Nest have rich, complex textures and subtly graduated degrees. Understand them too simply, and you'll simply be finished."

With the first unexploded bomb, he swept it along with the broom, rolling it all the way into Room 301 — at this point, Reed Hydes was still coughing in the smoke and flames.

If it blew up, that would prove that touching an unexploded bomb with a tool didn't count as a person handling it; if it quietly disappeared, that wasn't ideal, but not a waste either, because Taylor Ford would have gained information.

Fortunately, it blew up ten minutes later.

"Does that mean... the 'explosion with no one present' in Room 301 — that was an unexploded bomb going off?"

Mai Minghe stared at the phone, murmuring to herself — she probably had no idea how loud her "murmuring" actually was.

Taylor Ford gave a nod.

Beyond the staircase progress ticking up to 1/12, he hadn't expected that after the first unexploded bomb went off, a second one would appear at the scene — sure enough, the rules had also stated that any explosion, regardless of cause, had a chance of producing an unexploded bomb.

Reed Hydes had been one apartment away from Room 301 at the time; by the time he limped over to the blast site, Taylor Ford had long since taken the unexploded bomb and slipped back into the corridor.

"The second unexploded bomb, I kept it on me — here, this one."

Taylor Ford unzipped the side pocket of his backpack and gave Mai Minghe a look at the black sphere inside.

Reed Hydes at the other end of the corridor cut a rather pitiful figure; he probably couldn't hear anything either, and could only crane his neck and wait — Taylor Ford, in a charitable spirit, flashed the unexploded bomb in his direction too, and watched the look of shock and envy cross his face before, satisfied, tucking it away.

"I wanted to test what the unexploded bomb's true benefit actually was, but instead you managed to catch me by my weak point."

Although Mai Minghe couldn't hear him speak, she had been reading the Rumor all along; now she picked up the thread herself: "The benefit you discovered is... let me read on."

Taylor Ford touched his nose.

Normally, this was the part where someone would praise him for being quick-witted; regrettably, the only two people in the audience were also his victims, and both were glaring at him.

Still, these two victims were remarkably convenient for the one targeting them.

Mai Minghe could only put her weight on her heel with one foot, walking with a "thump thump" — she might not have noticed it herself, but to Taylor Ford's ears it was as clear as an announcement over a loudspeaker. Reed Hydes was even louder — he had to hop on one foot.

After Reed Hydes hopped his way back to Room 303, Taylor Ford quietly followed.

Staying just outside one meter of the other person while getting as close as possible was, in fact, a tricky thing to manage; fortunately, both victims were very considerate and constantly broadcasting their positions.

It was through following Reed Hydes that he realized the true benefit of carrying an unexploded bomb.

This benefit had two parts:

First: when the person holding the unexploded bomb drew near others, the chance of an explosion around themselves was reduced, while the chance of an explosion around those others was significantly increased.

Since Taylor Ford had come up to the third floor, he hadn't encountered a single object exploding; but not long after he began tailing Reed Hydes, the other man blew up again — it was impossible not to think along those lines.

The second part of the benefit appeared after others encountered an explosion.

"When half the room was fire and thick smoke, I walked in with the broom and dustpan."

This was too entertaining for Taylor Ford to hold back.

"Reed Hydes was huddled in the corner of the room — seemed like he couldn't even keep his eyes open, poor guy. I stayed a meter away from him, swept the floor a bit, and swept out an unexploded bomb. The fire wasn't even out yet when I left."

Of course the broom would catch fire too; but so what?

He was unaffected, not even feeling the heat, and everything in the apartment — including the broom — would reset.

When Taylor Ford heard Mai Minghe loudly announce to the entire world that she was going to find Reed Hydes, he stepped back into Room 301 and did one more thing.

"You moved the furniture!"

Mai Minghe stared at the phone screen and called out: "The furniture in Room 303 was definitely not arranged like that. You shoved all the big pieces — the sofa and the like — to one side, which is why I felt a handful of dust right where the sofa should have been..."

So she had noticed the dust...

He had noticed the dust himself at the time too, but there was no way he could stay behind to mop the floor, so he'd left it — and sure enough, it became one of the clues Mai Minghe used to discover his presence.

"Why move the furniture? Reed Hydes would have noticed too if he'd come back..."

Mai Minghe was absorbed in reading now, murmuring to herself.

Taylor Ford glanced at the time and allowed himself a small smile.

...Less than a minute left before the unexploded bomb on him disappeared.

When that happened, he only had to walk a few steps toward Mai Minghe and the floor beneath her feet would explode — the positions of hunter and prey would, once again, be reversed.

I got cocky too soon yesterday—spoke too loudly about being efficient, and today I paid the price... Maybe my productivity is conserved somehow: go over quota one day, and the next day you have to make up for it...

Chapter 157: Taylor Ford's Pleading Cat Head

There were two reasons for moving the furniture, both to help Taylor Ford track his prey and speed up the detonations.

First, the cleared path fixed the pair's range of movement. Taylor Ford was in the hallway, separated from them by a single wall; he could close in or pull back as he pleased, and the two of them remained completely within his grasp.

Second, if he needed to enter the room, the large pieces of furniture piled together could serve as a hiding spot at a critical moment—he could just sit down behind the sofa. Anyone without an unexploded bomb on them wouldn't dare wander among the large furniture.

As for whether Reed Hydes might suddenly turn back and notice the furniture had been rearranged—there was no need to worry about that either. Taylor Ford only had to walk ahead of him, and explosions would keep going off along his path. Staying alive would already be a struggle; who would have the mind to wonder whether the coffee table had wandered over to the window for a view?

"Ah, that pocket!"

At the other end of the hallway, Reed Hydes suddenly called out: "The pocket on his backpack where he keeps the unexploded bombs—it's flat! Mai Minghe!"

...Eyes that sharp—he had to be starving for it.

No matter how loudly he shouted, Mai Minghe kept her head down looking at her phone; but Reed Hydes, in a pinch, had enough quick thinking to crouch down and bang hard on the floor. The dull, muffled shuddering beneath his feet finally made Mai Minghe look up.

"Unexploded bomb!"

Taylor Ford glanced back, and Reed Hydes was waving his arms and gesturing with every part of his body—"The unexploded bomb in his bag is gone, time's up, run!"

The moment Mai Minghe understood, Taylor Ford gave her an apologetic smile and lifted one foot.

The instant he took that step, her expression changed completely; she turned and fled toward Room 302. Her injured foot made it hard to walk, but she paid it no mind, lurching forward in a

stumbling rush and tumbling through the doorway.

"Oh well, she got away."

With a faint sense of regret, Taylor Ford turned to look down the hallway and found that Reed Hydes had hobbled his way into Room 310 as well.

The door swung shut with a thud, followed immediately by the clatter of a lock being turned several times.

If he hadn't been out of earshot, Taylor Ford would have genuinely wanted to tell him not to bother—he had already tried it himself; you couldn't lock the exits here. The beauty of tracking deaf people was that no matter what he did, neither of them could hear a thing.

Never mind trying the door lock—Taylor Ford had even taken a walkie-talkie call just now.

He stood in the middle of the hallway, hands on his hips, looking around, and smiled without a sound.

Honestly, it took so much to get them to fall for it.

Taylor Ford's particular talent was that while others thought one step ahead, he had already thought three; it wasn't ideal to say so himself, but there was no one else around to say it for him.

"The reversal of hunter and prey," "he just has to walk forward and they'll be blown up"—these were precisely the things he had wanted them to understand. Only once they understood would they hurry and run.

Otherwise, if he wanted to kill people, couldn't he just pull out his gun? Why wait for the unexploded bombs to disappear?

He had never thought that human lives were worth the weight of heaven.

No matter what it was—when something multiplied like cockroaches crawling all over the earth—heaven couldn't bear that weight; heaven would exhaust itself trying.

That said, Taylor Ford took no pleasure in killing. Taking a life was something you did when necessary; right now, it wasn't necessary.

Besides, if he killed them, would he then have to get blown up himself?

To keep the two of them from coming to their senses and coming back out to detonate the floor beneath his feet, Taylor Ford moved to the center of the hallway. Whether it was Room 302

or Room 310, both were well over a meter away from here—enough of a safety buffer. And moreover, this spot was also well away from where he had set down the broom and dustpan.

The phone was still in Mai Minghe's hands as she fled, so he could only estimate the time—at the very least, there were still four or five minutes left, right?

Just wait then... the moment he relaxed, Taylor Ford broke into a string of yawns.

The painkiller hadn't worn off yet; a white fog seemed to drift through every limb of his body.

When Mai Minghe and the other one realized he hadn't chased after them, they would likely assume he had gone after someone else instead. For the time being, both of them would need to keep running—they couldn't come back yet—

"Taylor Ford!"

Taylor Ford startled sharply, his half-finished yawn cut short, nearly biting his own tongue.

"So young, and already such a skilled liar!"

Mai Minghe's head appeared from the opened door of Room 302, her face full of indignation. "You want to use the same trick again, don't you—do it all over?"

Taylor Ford stood there with his mouth half open, the corners of his eyes still wet from the yawn, and turned his head toward her.

"You wrote such a long piece, but the most important part, you left out."

Mai Minghe perhaps thought she was just speaking, but in fact the ceiling above was shedding dust from the vibration. She pointed at the dustpan by the wall and said, "There's at least one more unexploded bomb in that dustpan, isn't there?"

Taylor Ford blinked a few times and said nothing; saying something wouldn't help anyway.

"I almost forgot—you have a gun. If you wanted to kill us, we would both have died back there already; you didn't need to wait for the unexploded bomb to disappear."

Up to this point she was correct. The old woman was not easy to fool.

"You just wanted us to run so you could go back to the dustpan and retrieve an unexploded bomb to carry with you."

...This part was wrong.

"You never said why you were carrying a dustpan, and now I finally understand. Unexploded bombs clearly look heavy and are pretty big—just sweeping with a broom obviously wouldn't work well. You'd need a dustpan to stop them from rolling all over the place."

One could only expect this from someone who had already lived a full life—she was very experienced with something as primitive as sweeping a floor, unlike Taylor Ford, who had picked up a broom for the first time today.

"You said in the phone message that you stole one unexploded bomb from Reed Hydes."

"Stole" was not a nice word for it.

He had walked in with open intentions and walked out with a clear conscience—it was Reed Hydes who had chosen to close his own eyes.

"But there's more than one unexploded bomb, isn't there? When the ceiling light and the hanging picture exploded at the same time because of your presence, Reed Hydes and I fled in opposite directions to get away from the blast.

"Meaning, for those few minutes, both of us were far away from you. When there was no one near you, the probability of explosions around you returned to normal—something exploded, and another unexploded bomb appeared, right?"

She shook her head and said, "The odds of an unexploded bomb appearing aren't low—they just all ended up landing on you. You caught two unexploded bombs in the dustpan and nearly had me fooled."

Taylor Ford hadn't expected her to catch even that detail; he instinctively asked, "How did you figure that out?"

Though Mai Minghe couldn't hear him, she must have guessed his question.

"When I walked toward Reed Hydes, the light and shadow were flickering in the glass of the hanging picture, but the floor beneath my feet stayed completely still. Taking into account that I can't hear anything now... it must have been something on the ceiling or the wall next door that exploded."

Taylor Ford nodded and said, "An old piece of chewing gum stuck to the wall exploded. Pretty disgusting."

Mai Minghe stared at his lip movements, baffled.

What came next was a little bit like showing off, but he meant it sincerely: "I had one unexploded bomb on my back and two rolling around in my hands at the time—they were so heavy, and honestly quite tiring."

Even when Mai Minghe had suddenly rushed out at him, he had stayed unhurried, setting the dustpan and the two unexploded bombs against the wall, neatly concealed behind the broom.

The two unexploded bombs had been clanging and bumping against each other at the time, and Mai Minghe hadn't heard a thing—who knew when he would ever run into such a conveniently considerate victim again.

"You scared us both off, took one to carry on you, and then planned to use the same trick again—use us to set off detonations and steal our unexploded bombs, right?" said Mai Minghe.

...Why did she keep calling it stealing.

Taylor Ford thought for a moment, shook his head, then pointed at the dustpan and held up two fingers.

"There are still two?" Mai Minghe caught on quickly. "You didn't take any? Ah, come to think of it, you really were standing pretty far from the dustpan..."

She looked at the dustpan and asked, "Are you waiting for an explosion?"

Taylor Ford nodded again. She was the deaf one, but she had ended up turning him into the mute.

"Why?"

I'd tell you but you can't hear me anyway—Taylor Ford gestured at her, signaling her to toss him her phone.

Mai Minghe gave a soft "oh" and raised her hand.

Just as she was about to throw the phone, Reed Hydes's shout suddenly rang out from behind her: "Don't give it to him!"

Taylor Ford had already readied himself to catch the phone; now his expectation came to nothing. He glanced back and found that Reed Hydes had returned as well, now working furiously at the other end of the hallway to perform a mime act with lines.

"Don't give him the phone!" He shook his head wildly and raised both hands, making an emphatic gesture of stopping.

Mai Minghe hesitantly lowered her arm.

"We young people," Reed Hydes pointed to himself, then to Taylor Ford.

Who are you calling "we young people"—you look nearly thirty, Taylor Ford grumbled silently. You're really riding my coattails.

"Phones are very important! Very precious!"

He genuinely didn't know how to express that in gestures, so after shouting it, he froze for a few seconds—then simply pulled out his own phone, cradled it in the crook of his arm, and supported it from underneath with one hand. As though soothing a baby, Reed Hydes held his own phone and rocked it gently, rhythmically.

...He even squeezed out a few traces of maternal tenderness from his otherwise frantic expression, directed at the phone.

This guy was truly insufferable.

Taylor Ford suppressed his irritation and looked back around, meeting Mai Minghe's expression of sudden comprehension.

She smiled and tucked her phone into her trouser pocket.

...No wonder those two were partners—they thought exactly alike.

A phone was important, sure, but in a matter of real consequence, what did sacrificing one phone amount to? Did he honestly think a phone could tie him down?

But wait...

Come to think of it, "escaping from the third floor of the apartment" wasn't actually that significant a matter.

The truly important thing was obtaining the Nest game target item that Mai Minghe was carrying; getting off the third floor was a mutual interest they all shared.

He couldn't use the two of them to detonate items, couldn't steal—couldn't take their unexploded bombs. It had its inconveniences, though he hadn't planned on keeping his presence hidden from them forever to begin with.

If this current experiment successfully confirmed his hypothesis, then... cooperation didn't seem out of the question.

No—better yet, if he cooperated with them at this stage and earned their trust, it would make things considerably more convenient when the real business came.

Then he might as well go along with it and act suitably anxious.

Several thoughts flashed through his mind and he had already made his decision; he immediately pulled a long face, looking regretful and helpless and urgent all at once, raised both hands, and said: "I give up, all right? I give up!"

Even if they couldn't hear him, they could make out something from it.

"Do you have paper and a pen?" Taylor Ford gestured at Reed Hydes, who quickly tossed him some.

Half a minute later, the paper he unfolded and held up for the two of them read, in large characters:

I'm testing out an idea

It could speed up clearing this floor

If we work together, we might be able to get out soon

What do you say?

I know I was wrong, I won't hurt you anymore, just give me back my phone when we get out

On a whim, he also drew a little cat head in the bottom right corner of the page, with the word "Please" written on it.

Looking back at the previous chapter, I always feel the writing isn't concise or refined enough—but getting a sentence to be precise and tight takes repeated thought and revision, and with the update rush, there's truly no time for that; I can't write short, so I write long instead.

Chapter 158: When Taylor Ford Exploded, a Glimmer of Breakthrough Appeared

"...Almost there, step back a bit, both of you."

Taylor Ford gestured like a traffic officer, waving the other two back. Once they were both pressed against the wall, he covered his own ears and gestured for them to do the same, saying, "Find something to plug your ears—if you two go any more deaf, it'll become my problem."

Since they couldn't hear him anyway, Taylor Ford muttered to himself, "Who still writes by hand these days? Scribbled out all that nonsense just now, my hand's starting to ache."

The two understood what he meant and hurried to find something to plug their ears. Reed Hydes was clearly deeply uneasy about him—even as she tore strips of bandage and rolled them into balls, she kept shooting sharp glances his way—a completely pointless precaution.

If he wanted to shoot someone, would he care whether they were watching?

At this point, cooperating and getting out early was obviously in everyone's best interest.

Taylor Ford slowly took out his earphones; they chimed softly as the automatic noise-cancellation switched on.

For an explosion, the noise-cancellation might not be enough—he also covered his ears with his hands and opened his mouth; whatever protection that bought him, it would have to do.

As if waiting for all three of them to be ready, the dustpan and broom leaning against the wall were suddenly swallowed, from the inside out, by a blinding burst of light—without any warning.

A thunderous crack shattered a small pocket of space, and then, almost immediately, came a second sound like a muffled thunderclap—the explosion had gone off twice.

The dustpan and broom erupted outward, scattering countless shards and sparks, as though they had suddenly burst into a blazing ball of light. The wall cracked apart with a boom and caved inward, leaving a gaping crater; bricks tumbled down, smoke and dust billowed up, and for a moment no one could keep their eyes open.

All three had been prepared for the explosion—huddled in a corner or crouched behind a backpack—and only had to endure a moment of thick, rolling smoke; when the corridor fell quiet again, the three looked across at one another and found that, aside from being covered in ash and grime, none of them were hurt.

"Both unexploded bombs went off?" Mai Minghe called out loudly.

She had clearly noticed something was off: "That's strange—didn't those two unexploded bombs appear at different times? They shouldn't have gone off at the same moment, should they?"

Before answering her—and answering her would mean writing quite a few more words, which Taylor Ford really couldn't muster the energy for—he walked over first and picked up the broom, which had returned to its original state.

An unexploded bomb rolled out from the edge of the dustpan and was stopped by the broom handle.

"One didn't go off? No, wait, that's not right..." Mai Minghe furrowed her brow. "There were definitely two separate explosions just now..."

Taylor Ford figured that even without his explanation, she might very well work it out on her own—that would save him the trouble—but at that moment Reed Hydes called out, "Write it down already! Weren't you supposed to be cooperating with us? Explain what happened."

Like I owe you?

You vague, soft-looking guy, you look like an ice cream that's half-melted already.

Taylor Ford shot him a sideways glance but still pulled out paper and pen and wrote quickly:

There were indeed two unexploded bombs just now.

One of them reached its time limit and detonated.

When it exploded, it set off the other unexploded bomb nearby, which hadn't reached its time limit yet.

This is exactly what I suspected.

Think about it—the unexploded bomb is the only one that appears in the form of an actual "bomb," right? Even the name makes that clear.

So why is it specifically distinguished from ordinary objects?

As a bomb, if an explosion occurs right beside it, wouldn't it also be detonated?

That's what I wanted to test. The results, as you can see, are very promising.

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes as she finished reading, then looked up with an expression of open admiration.

"You're quite something, kid—your way of thinking is sharp and yet perfectly logical."

She even clapped her hands and said aloud, "That's right—the rules only state that an unexploded bomb appears after an explosion, so when an ordinary object explodes, it can't possibly detonate an unexploded bomb that doesn't exist yet. That created a blind spot for us—we assumed an unexploded bomb simply wouldn't go off until its time was up. But you saw right through it! This kid is no ordinary person—great things are ahead of you."

Taylor Ford felt a warm glow wash over him, his mood lifting; once Reed Hydes had read it too, he flipped the paper over and kept writing.

By speeding up the detonation of existing unexploded bombs, we also increase the rate at which new ones appear.

The clear conditions are now at 3/12—we still need 9 more steps to unlock the staircase.

Going forward, we need to create more explosions, collect unexploded bombs, and concentrate them in one place.

"How do we create more explosions?" Reed Hydes called across, the suspicion in his voice still unmistakable.

The old woman glanced over at him a few times as well—she seemed to have arrived at the same possibility.

To generate more explosions, they would still have to rely on Taylor Ford's earlier discovery: the person carrying an unexploded bomb would go and increase the number of explosions near the others.

After the two of them read that line, both Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes began shaking their heads repeatedly.

The two of them were decent enough, at least—neither said "then let you be the one to get blown up"—people who flip the moment the roles are reversed, Taylor Ford had seen more than he could count.

He took out a fresh sheet of paper and wrote:

Even if we're increasing the explosions near others, there's a way to minimize injuries.

We're lucky—a fourth unexploded bomb appeared here.

Step one: one of us equips it.

Then the person carrying the bomb clears out an open space—a room, for example.

Everything in the room, including large pieces of furniture like desks and wardrobes, must be completely removed.

Then place a few small objects in one corner of the room—the smaller, the better.

Step two: the person carrying the bomb stands at one end of the room; the other two stand at the opposite end.

More than one meter apart, less than two.

This increases the chance of explosions occurring near the other two.

But what can explode is no longer an endless, random assortment of objects—in other words, the options are narrowed down to just the few small things we've placed there.

Once we know where an explosion is likely to happen, we can be prepared in advance.

And with three pairs of eyes watching, we can spot the countdown even earlier, reducing the chance of injury further.

"In theory, that does seem workable..."

Reed Hydes frowned and called out, "Then why not just do it out in the corridor? There's no furniture there to begin with."

Taylor Ford's hand was truly aching now, but he had no choice but to keep writing.

The main reason is that we don't know what's on the other side of the corridor walls.

The corridor is narrow and long—limited space to dodge.

What if the wall behind where you're standing happens to be right next to someone's television, or a hanging painting? If that goes off, then what?

We also can't clear out every apartment behind the corridor walls.

Finding a room is the most reliable option—with the walls stripped away, we can confirm that there's nothing around us that, if it exploded, would ruin everything.

"Your thinking is remarkably thorough—when I was your age, I didn't have a mind like that."

A gentle smile spread across Mai Minghe's face as she said, "And most people, when they write something like a notice or a list, tend to misjudge the spacing—the further down they write, the more cramped it gets. But look at yours—it's as if you measured out the distances beforehand! Word by word, clean and easy, exactly the right amount of space left, written in the largest possible characters, filling the whole page perfectly."

Taylor Ford paused, looked down at the page he'd written, and found it was exactly as she said—the old woman had a remarkable eye, he thought; he'd never even imagined he could be praised from that angle.

Once he took the Artifact from her, she would go back to being an ordinary old woman...

Taylor Ford thought of an elderly couple who lived in the apartment below his.

The old woman had her snow-white hair permed into a soft, full puff; though her skin was dry and wrinkled and slack, she still put on lipstick every single day. She came downstairs at a fixed time each morning to walk her dog, and on the occasional encounters in the elevator, she would grumble that she was getting old while the dog was still young—the dog had four fast little legs, and she always struggled to keep up.

He felt a little bad about it, as far as Mai Minghe was concerned... but when the time came to act, he still had to act.

He was going to win the Nest Domination Game.

"I understand," Reed Hydes called out. "But who equips the unexploded bomb? I don't trust him to do it."

His suspicion hadn't faded, but convincing him wouldn't be hard.

After all, Taylor Ford was the only one with two good hands and two good legs, capable of pushing heavy furniture; and besides, as long as the two of them knew where he was, the person holding the unexploded bomb was actually at a disadvantage.

With only a few minutes left before the unexploded bomb detonated, the three of them finally reached an agreement—given all the factors involved, the efficiency was remarkably high—and

Taylor Ford grabbed the unexploded bomb, waved for the other two to follow, and led the way into Apartment 301.

He had already picked out the spot earlier; he had anticipated all along that things might come to this.

Inside Apartment 301, there was a small room being used as a home office—it didn't have much in it, and right beside it was the corridor hallway shared by two apartments, making it a relatively open space; dragging out the desk was already half the work, and the rest of the room was cleared in no time.

With the surrounding walls stripped away, it actually became a reassuring factor: even if someone tried to rush toward another person, the latter would have no shortage of room to flee.

Of course, that consideration was mostly to put Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes at ease.

Taylor Ford wasn't at all worried about the two of them turning and attacking him—the two of them together couldn't even scrape together three working limbs, and this wasn't a narrow corridor anymore.

On his way into the room, he had already casually picked up several small objects.

Taylor Ford set a few odds and ends in the corner of the room—eye drops, a charging plug, a pen, that sort of thing—then stepped back and waved to the two of them not far away, calling out, "All right, get in here! The unexploded bomb's almost gone—let's move fast and try to set off at least one or two more before it's up."

Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes entered the room one after the other and took their positions.

They stood about a meter apart from each other, and kept more than a meter's distance from the row of small objects; behind them, Taylor Ford entered the room as well.

When the first small object—a black hair clip—detonated with a boom into a bright burst of flame, all three of them let out, in unison, their first cheer since entering the apartment.

"We're really fine," Mai Minghe said, almost moved. "It seems like as long as we control the number of objects in the surrounding environment, we can truly make it out of here safely!"

That's right, Taylor Ford thought—everything was going according to plan. Very smoothly.

Writing is a strange thing—the outline you draft doesn't mean the final result will match it; there are far too many factors that can produce unexpected chemistry during the writing process.

For instance, this particular arc of the plot is indeed following the outline, but before I wrote it, I always assumed it would be tense, high-pressure material—who could have imagined that once these three people ended up together, the atmosphere would turn light and endearing?

Today's update might go up a little late.

I've been writing for an hour, three hundred words, and every single word looks wrong to me—I want to tear it all down and start over, except I've already torn it down and started over several times.

This update has been more painful to write than the last two days of my life have been to live.

Yesterday I'd planned to go out and mail a letter (yes, the kind with an envelope and letter paper) and then come home and write the outline for the thank-you bonus chapter, but I couldn't find anywhere to mail it—the first post office location I went to was closed, the second one said they only accept parcels, and I walked for a solid two hours following the map, with the help of many kind people (nobody knows how to mail letters anymore these days), only to discover that you need to find a mailbox to drop it in—and do you know where there was a mailbox?

Right at my front door.

Walked for over two hours, and in the end I mailed the letter right outside my own home.

I was already exhausted from my period on top of everything else, and by the time I got home I was barely different from a zombie—dragging one foot behind the other, brains in very short supply.

Today's awkwardness is worse than yesterday's—it's wedged into me until my whole body aches, and my mood isn't great, so you all get some rest first; if fate wills it, we'll meet again.

Chapter 159: Taylor Ford and Mai Minghe's Judgment

You had to give it to the Nest — it was putting in the effort.

Even though Taylor Ford had pushed the rules to their limit and whittled the explosives down to a handful, the third floor of the apartment still racked its brain to manufacture crisis after crisis for the three of them — and each one came with a new twist.

Of course, with him there, not a single crisis was truly lethal; so the apartment could only be awarded a certificate of diligence, at best.

For instance, after the fourth explosion, an unexploded bomb appeared — rolling out across the floor, tumbling toward Reed Hydes' feet before stopping dead.

It hadn't even touched his shoes yet. Was something wedging it in place?

The thought had barely surfaced in Taylor Ford's mind when he suddenly realized that one of the small objects lined up on the floor had gone missing — knocked away somewhere by the blast — a pen.

"Get back!"

Taylor Ford understood at once. He gestured with his hand and shouted at Reed Hydes: "Back off now — out of the room!"

Reed Hydes startled, then stumbled backward; as if sensing that its prey was about to escape, the pen that had been wedging the unexploded bomb in place promptly detonated.

It set off the unexploded bomb, and the center of the room erupted in a thunderous blast of shattering and collapse.

The unexploded bomb's force was far greater than that of any of the small objects; if he hadn't warned Reed Hydes to flee in time, losing a leg would have been the least of the man's worries.

Thinking about it that way, those two running into him was actually pretty lucky for them.

With that thought, Taylor Ford — half-reclining against his backpack as a cushion — stretched his long limbs out in a languid sprawl.

He extended every last fingertip.

"Done now?"

Even with prior preparation, Reed Hydes had still taken a face full of sooty black from the explosion. Now, from that blackened pot-bottom of a face, a pink mouth opened and closed:

"That's twelve unexploded bombs detonated, right? Can we go upstairs?"

Because the recent series of blasts had been relatively low in intensity and the two had been careful to protect themselves, their hearing was returning — albeit somewhat hesitantly — and they still had to shout to be heard.

"Should be," Mai Minghe glanced at Taylor Ford. "...You weren't asleep just now, were you? That was twelve, correct?"

The two of them had served as bait to trigger the explosions, and with the injuries they'd taken on top of that, they looked nothing short of wretched — standing there, they were a walking anti-war poster.

Taylor Ford, however, had had an easy time of it: he only needed to stay put, and whenever an unexploded bomb appeared, he used the broom to sweep it out of the room so they could all congregate together in the distance — after doing this twice, Taylor Ford had realized there was no reason he needed to be standing.

After all, the explosions didn't affect the person carrying an unexploded bomb, so he didn't need to dodge; sweeping while lying down worked just fine.

And if he was going to lie down anyway, he might as well grab his backpack to use as a cushion.

Propped up like that, he could trigger explosions just by crossing his legs.

Snacking while telling Mai Minghe and the other two where to take cover was even easier — directing them didn't require his mouth at all.

"Haven't I been putting my heart and soul into this the whole time? How could you say I was asleep—"

Taylor Ford didn't finish. He stopped and let out a yawn, eyes glistening with tears.

"We were getting blown up over and over, and you could barely keep your eyes open." Mai Minghe shook her head and said, "The staircase should be open now, right?"

"Definitely open — the unexploded bombs have gone off thirteen times now."

"Thirteen already?" Mai Minghe was surprised, then exhaled in relief. "Then we're fine."

She was about to walk over to Reed Hydes when Taylor Ford called out to stop her: "Don't go over there."

"Why not?"

Reed Hydes also turned around, his blackened face blank with confusion.

"The rules only say that after twelve unexploded bombs detonate, the staircase opens; but the rules never said that once the staircase opens, the previous rules become void.

"In fact, I think all the rules are probably still in effect. It's not just that the moment you go over to him, something explodes at his feet — if we linger here long enough, objects will still randomly detonate."

"Why?" Mai Minghe was taken aback. "To use your younger generation's phrasing — haven't we already cleared this level?"

"Because a thirteenth unexploded bomb appeared just now," Taylor Ford said with a lazy shrug.

Mai Minghe stood there with her mouth half open, her expression full of lingering fear; it seemed she'd worked it out.

"That's devious — you're right, the rules are probably still running. If everything ended the moment the twelfth unexploded bomb detonated, how would a thirteenth one ever appear?"

"To be safe, we still need to keep more than a meter apart and get upstairs as quickly as possible." Taylor Ford turned to Reed Hydes and added the same warning.

"You don't need to spell it out for me so clearly," Reed Hydes said, somewhat displeased. "I heard you. I'm not stupid."

"Oh?" Taylor Ford finally opened his eyes wide, looking genuinely surprised. "Really?"

Reed Hydes, as it turned out, truly wasn't stupid — to keep himself separated from Mai Minghe, he insisted on letting the old woman go first, even though this was yet another precaution that served no real purpose.

And so, with Mai Minghe in the lead, Reed Hydes in the middle, and Taylor Ford bringing up the rear, the three of them maintained a spacing of over a meter and filed out of the room one by one.

Really — before he had shown up, Reed Hydes clearly hadn't trusted Mai Minghe much either; it seemed that no matter what, everything came down to comparison.

Taylor Ford tossed away the last unexploded bomb on his person — reducing the probability of further explosions near the other two — and sure enough, all three of them reached the staircase leading to the fourth floor without incident.

"Looks exactly the same as before,"

The three stopped at the foot of the staircase, and Reed Hydes offered a superfluous observation. "Makes me a little uneasy... Is it really open? I keep worrying that the moment we step on it, the whole staircase will blow."

"It's fine," Mai Minghe said.

"How do you know?" Reed Hydes asked.

She turned her head and gave a slightly sheepish smile, pointing down at her feet.

"Well... while you were talking just now, I'd already put one foot up. I wasn't really thinking about it, but then you said that and gave me a scare."

This didn't mean Mai Minghe was reckless — because Reed Hydes had been worrying over nothing in the first place.

Once all the conditions of the rules were met, the outcome was fixed; the Nest never lied about that.

Watching Mai Minghe carefully shift her weight onto the heel of her injured foot, grip the handrail, and climb two steps, Taylor Ford called out from a distance: "Hold on — before you go up, shouldn't you give me back my phone?"

Mai Minghe turned her head and furrowed her brow slightly. "Now?"

"When else?"

Taylor Ford said slowly, "Nobody knows what's on the fourth floor. If something happens to you up there and you take my phone down with you, all the work I put in just now would've been for nothing."

"Why not give it back when he leaves the apartment?"

Reed Hydes, keeping his distance of over a meter from the staircase, interjected: "Doesn't he want the Artifact on you? Give him back the phone and he can make his move without hesitation."

"I can pull out my gun right now and make my move without hesitation too." Taylor Ford glanced at the back of his head and said, "If I were targeting you, I could hit you with my eyes closed."

Reed Hydes immediately twisted around to glance at him, instinctively pressing his back against the wall, and probed cautiously: "How about you hand over the pistol too?"

"Do you think a phone matters that much to me?"

"I hear kids these days have a serious addiction..."

"Alright," Mai Minghe waved her hand. "Stop bickering. Taylor Ford, I'll give you back the phone."

"You're really giving it back?" Reed Hydes startled.

"After all, like he said — if he truly wanted to take my things, he could shoot me dead and take whatever he likes."

Mai Minghe pulled the phone from her trouser pocket, tossed it first to Reed Hydes, then watched as he tossed it to Taylor Ford.

"I just want to ask — on the third floor, you needed us as bait to trigger the explosions, so you had reason not to kill me. But now that the staircase is open and you don't need bait anymore, why still no shot? I'm someone who doesn't have many days left regardless. Dying in the Nest — there'd be no consequences for you."

Taylor Ford caught the phone and looked up at her, momentarily caught off guard.

"Well..." He thought for a moment. "In case the fourth floor still needs bait..."

Mai Minghe tilted her head and watched him — she didn't look convinced.

"Besides, all of us in the Hunter House Factions know to avoid unnecessary deaths, to not let people die in the Nest..."

"You're not exactly someone who plays by the rules." Mai Minghe said.

Taylor Ford was at a slight loss, and lowered his head.

He looked at the phone screen lighting up with 5:33 AM and asked, "Why are you asking this?"

...Two minutes had already passed.

"Because I believe that, at your core, you're not a hopeless villain."

Mai Minghe let out a sigh and leaned against the stair railing. "When I was still half-Resident-ified, that was a different matter. But I've come back to being human, and we've crossed paths here in the apartment — weathered explosions together, chatted through pen and paper, cooperated to clear the level... I think you can no longer shoot me as cleanly and decisively as you could back on the plaza."

Taylor Ford ran a hand through his fluffy, disheveled hair a few times.

"Are you trying to say I'm a good person?" he said quietly. "That's too subtle a compliment — I almost didn't catch it."

Mai Minghe smiled faintly.

"I suppose it is a compliment. My life hasn't been entirely wasted — at the very least, I've spent I-don't-know-how-many years reading people... These days, one look up and down and a few exchanges, and I can get a rough sense of someone."

Taylor Ford gave a small cough.

"You can tell that you can't bring yourself to act against me, can't you?" she asked.

Taylor Ford nodded.

...Nearly three minutes now.

"I have another feeling," Mai Minghe said. "One I think is just as correct as 'you can't bring yourself to act against me.'"

"What is it?" Taylor Ford asked immediately.

Right now he was desperately hoping Mai Minghe would stay right there and keep talking a little longer.

"I think this small shred of reluctance isn't enough to stop you from pursuing what you want. No — I don't think anything in this world could."

Mai Minghe looked at him, her voice carrying the weight of a sigh.

"When you don't want to do something yourself, you use the environment or other people to accomplish your goal for you — isn't that right?"

Sorry everyone, no rambling today — this chapter nearly killed me. I'm feeling terrible, going to go lie down...

Chapter 160: Mai Minghe — Hidden Threads, Still with Cards to Play

Mai Minghe had lived eighty-six years, yet this was the first time she had ever encountered a young man like Taylor Ford.

She had always felt that the process of a child growing up was like a small corner of the world gradually solidifying into substance.

Orange juice, eggs, and bread; the scolding or stories they heard; pocket money lost at the arcade; the first person they ever liked; tenderness or indifference; love or abuse — all things in the world either flowed through them or were absorbed into their bodies, becoming the soul and flesh that growing up required.

But the things inside Taylor Ford seemed to have dissolved away before they ever had the chance to solidify.

He was shrouded in a vague, drifting mist — hazy and indistinct. The form he presented had not been shaped by the world; it was only a chance configuration of shifting clouds, and with a change of circumstances, it would scatter and transform once more.

Perhaps it was because he was so fine-looking — when he smiled faintly through that haze, one felt as though stars and moonlight lay behind it, as though a deity stood there; but the nature of stars and moon is only rock, and deities do not exist.

That was Taylor Ford.

He was perhaps a person of very few desires; only that once he wanted something, nothing remained an obstacle.

What did the "freedom" he sought actually mean?

Why would winning the Nest Domination Game grant him that freedom?

Mai Minghe had many questions; under different circumstances, she might even have hoped that Taylor Ford would get what he wished for — but when it came to the Serpent Band, she absolutely could not let him take it.

From the moment Mai Minghe led the way toward the stairwell, she had been thinking about what Taylor Ford's next move would be.

He had never once left her line of sight, and everything he did, Mai Minghe had seen with her own eyes — so it was impossible for Taylor Ford to have set a trap in advance. And yet, for some reason, she could not shake the feeling that she was walking step by step into one.

Taylor Ford was unwilling to kill with his own hands... yet he refused to give up on the Serpent Band. That meant something ahead would do the dirty work for him.

What was it?

This apartment building had only just been put into repairs without prior notice; neither Taylor Ford nor his team had known in advance what was inside or what might happen there.

In other words, he had deduced the danger through his surroundings.

If he could manage that, then she ought to be able to as well...

Mai Minghe stood on the stairs, a rapid string of guesses flashing through her mind.

Was it through an explosion? But she was already on the staircase — no longer within the range of the third floor. If he had wanted to blast open the floor beneath her feet, he should have acted while she was still walking there.

Just then, Taylor Ford suddenly spoke: "Would you be willing to hand it to me yourself?"

"You mean the Artifact on me?" Mai Minghe shot back.

Did this child actually think that after she had been brought down by the Serpent Band, she would still have the strength to walk on and hand it over to him?

"Yes," Taylor Ford nodded. "I don't have to make things hard for you. If I can get it peacefully, that would be for the best."

As he spoke, he skirted around Reed Hydes, keeping a meter's distance from him while pressing close to the other side of the corridor, until he stopped one meter in front of the stairwell entrance.

With that, the three of them formed a triangle — Mai Minghe on the stairs, and facing her, Taylor Ford and Reed Hydes on either side.

Wait.

Right in front of her, he had deliberately moved to a position just one meter from the stairwell entrance. The only purpose Mai Minghe could think of: the moment she dragged her

injured foot down the stairs and stepped onto the floor below, he could rush within that one-meter range and detonate the floor beneath his feet.

In other words... Taylor Ford wanted to trap her on the staircase.

The danger was coming from the stairs?

Just as Mai Minghe realized this, she saw Reed Hydes fix his eyes on something behind her and sharply suck in a breath — before she could even turn around, she heard a rattling clatter, and a crushed, empty cola can came bouncing and tumbling down the stairs, rolling to a stop on the third-floor landing.

...A cola can?

"It's here," Taylor Ford murmured, his voice half-dazed, half-regretful.

What was here?

Mai Minghe spun her head around, and a vast shadow swallowed her entire field of vision.

A gaping, pitch-black maw with glinting metal edges pressed flush against the ceiling, blocking off the entire staircase.

Behind that maw, what seemed to be a long body trailed after it, scuttling swiftly down the stairs step by step; the vaguely familiar, squarish black void had not yet come crashing down, but a rank and rotten stench had already surged forward and smothered her face —

The Garbage Chute?

A Garbage Chute that had no business existing in an apartment building?

"If you come down, I'll detonate the floor beneath you."

Taylor Ford's tone carried not the slightest trace of threat or killing intent, as though he were simply recounting a sorrowful ending from some television drama.

"It only treats people as garbage,"

he said, as the Garbage Chute came thundering down the stairs, on the verge of crushing Mai Minghe — "but it leaves Artifacts behind."

"You—" Reed Hydes cried out.

Taylor Ford didn't look at him; he raised his hand and fired a shot in Reed Hydes's direction.

He hadn't aimed at Reed Hydes — the bullet struck the wall, seemingly only to force him back; the latter did indeed stumble backward several steps and shouted something, but Mai Minghe could no longer make out the words.

From somewhere deep within the darkness of the Garbage Chute, as though spun together from sharp, thick stench, came a gleeful shriek:

"Garbage garbage garbage humans are all garbage I'm here to sweep away the garbage—"

...So that was it.

Demanding her phone back only after she had stepped onto the staircase was simply one of Taylor Ford's ways of keeping her there.

But how had he known that the Garbage Chute was actually a Resident roaming the corridors?

Shadow, foul stench, paper scraps, wet tea bags, plastic bags, and the howling darkness from deep within the chute — all of it came crashing down on her at once; the putrid black void was already pressing against her back.

Below, Taylor Ford stood motionless, waiting, ready to trigger the explosion at any moment.

Yet in that instant, Mai Minghe didn't hesitate for even half a second — she threw herself forward and leapt off the staircase.

Reed Hydes let out a faint, indistinct cry of alarm.

Her full weight came crashing down onto her injured foot, as though the wound itself might explode — a searing pain shot through her, sharp enough to split her vision.

Mai Minghe gritted her teeth against the pain, wasting not a moment, and immediately rolled herself back onto her feet; the Garbage Chute had by now charged down to the very first step, and just before it touched the third-floor landing, it screeched to a sudden halt.

As she had suspected — it only attacked those who remained on the stairs.

"Garbage garbage come back here garbage belongs in the garbage bin I won't leave once I'm here I won't go until I collect at least one piece of garbage I won't leave you can't go back upstairs anymore—"

Can't go back upstairs?

Mai Minghe could no longer restrain her fury, and did something she likely never would have done in a calmer state of mind: she spun around and seized the metal lid at the mouth of the Garbage Chute with both hands.

The endless shrieking from deep within the chute cut off, replaced by a single sound: "...Hm?"

Mai Minghe clenched her teeth and poured every last ounce of strength into it, her hands locked in a death grip on the mouth of the Garbage Chute — and with sheer brute force, she wrenched it off the step. There was a resounding crash as the mouth of the Garbage Chute slammed heavily into the ground.

For a brief moment, even it seemed stunned.

Taylor Ford, at that same moment, was just as stunned, his mouth hanging open.

"You said you'd detonate me — go ahead then!"

Mai Minghe felt the massive Garbage Chute beginning to inch and wriggle its way back, and realized she was losing her grip on it. In a furious snarl, she said: "Where do you think you're slithering off to? Where's all that bravado from before?"

Without giving the Garbage Chute a moment to recover its senses, she whipped her head around and barked at Taylor Ford: "I'm standing right here — blow me up! Blast me and this thing together; it'll clear the way upstairs for you nicely."

Taylor Ford blinked several times, looked at the Garbage Chute, looked at Mai Minghe, then looked at the Garbage Chute again.

"I'm of the opinion that a garbage-to-garbage confrontation shouldn't drag in the Garbage Chute."

From deep within the Garbage Chute came a voice that reeked of foul grease: "Let go of me — and that's not a request."

As though he hadn't heard it at all, Taylor Ford rubbed his nose, his voice muffled: "...You figured it out, then."

"Obviously."

Mai Minghe felt that she truly could not hold the Garbage Chute any longer and released it; it immediately retreated back to the first step — but as she had expected, it did not leave. The pitch-black square maw sat there, blocking the entire staircase.

That fact only made her fury at Taylor Ford burn hotter.

"You little — not only are you the most skilled liar around, you're also exceptionally good at making people forget that you love to lie. I've figured you out now: any word out of your mouth could be a trap."

Taylor Ford scratched his hair and tucked the gun back at his waist.

"What?" Reed Hydes had collapsed to the floor and was looking around in confusion. "What's going on? What did he lie to us about?"

"There's no telling how far in advance he had all of this planned,"

Mai Minghe suppressed her anger and said: "He wanted me to linger on the stairs, to draw out the Garbage Chute and let it do the dirty work for him. But to trap me on the staircase, he had to cut off my retreat — in other words, he had to find a way to make me feel I couldn't come down.

"That way, as long as I hesitated even for an instant when the Garbage Chute came charging down, I wouldn't have been able to escape its attack."

Taylor Ford let his brows and eyelids droop and heaved a sigh.

"There was no thirteenth unexploded bomb," Mai Minghe said, eyes fixed on him. "Was there?"

Reed Hydes startled, and turned to look at him.

Taylor Ford's lies had been laid down like hidden threads in the grass — buried long before anyone had any reason to think a lie was even necessary. Before anyone had seen the need for it, he had already quietly slipped the fiction of "the thirteenth unexploded bomb" into everyone's minds.

Everyone knew Taylor Ford had his eye on the Artifact on Mai Minghe's person; but who, at that moment, could have imagined he would take the initiative to fabricate a lie that forced him to keep his distance from her?

With "

By then, she would have been dead, and Taylor Ford would not have lifted a single hand.

He would have done nothing but say a few words.

"Do you truly believe that getting me killed with a few words leaves your hands clean — leaves your conscience light?"

Mai Minghe looked at him, and for a moment she almost wanted to laugh, unsure whether what she felt was anger, disappointment, or pity.

"Unless you put a bullet through me, you will never be able to take my Artifact. Give it up."

Taylor Ford shrugged.

"Is that so?" he said lazily. "I wouldn't be so sure."

A tightness seized Mai Minghe's chest, and she said nothing. Was he just putting on a brave face?

"You're right — I'm not particularly inclined to shoot you." Taylor Ford's eyes were half-lidded, his voice loose and distant. "You're a good person. You went out of your way to warn us, and because of that, we were able to save Jonah. Your judgment is good too — when you praised me, you meant it sincerely."

Mai Minghe said nothing.

"But the thing you carry — if it's one of the seven targets, then it matters far too much to me. Enough that... I wouldn't limit myself to a single plan of action."

Whatever impression Taylor Ford gave with his perpetually hazy, languid manner, when he moved, he was far more agile and precise than Mai Minghe had anticipated — especially when his opponent had a fractured ankle.

Reed Hydes had been driven back by that gunshot and had fallen to the floor; he had only just begun to push himself up along the wall when Taylor Ford was already at his side, one hand closing gently around the hair at the back of his head.

"Did both of you forget about the elevator?"

As Taylor Ford said this, he gave a push, and drove Reed Hydes's head into the wall.

I drew a rough floor plan of the building, but after uploading it I realized I forgot to label the entry door and mailboxes... anyway, make do with it — as long as you can see that the wall beside the staircase leading to the fourth floor has "elevator" written on it, that's all that matters.

Chapter 161: Mai Minghe, A Person About to Die

Mai Minghe had truly forgotten about the elevator.

Because the elevator doesn't exist, anyone who uses it disappears——?

That made no sense at all. She had lived eighty-six years and never heard such nonsense.

That absurd, nonsensical warning had appeared once, hollow and empty, and was never brought up again; it was easy to forget, since there was no elevator shaft in the building and no elevator doors on the walls——which was only natural, because the elevator didn't exist.

And yet Taylor Ford had kept the nonexistent thing in mind all along, and had put it to use.

In the moment he shoved Reed Hydes into the wall, Mai Minghe suddenly understood his intention.

At that instant, Reed Hydes was tilted sideways, his entire upper body swallowed by the wall, his injured foot unable to bear weight, his other foot losing its balance.

Taylor Ford's hand, gripping the small strip of shirt still outside the wall, was the only force holding him back——a lifeline that could snap at any moment; one release of that grip, and Reed Hydes would fall into the nonexistent elevator and become a nonexistent person.

"If you pull him out now, it's not too late."

The boy looked at Mai Minghe and said, "But I'm about to let go. Do you want to come over and grab him?"

Mai Minghe stood frozen in place, unable to move or speak.

This time, Taylor Ford's plan was laid out in plain sight; with just a moment's thought, she could picture exactly what came next.

But even knowing what he was going to do——so what?

Her chest was hollow, her heartbeat had slipped away at some point, sinking into the wound, throbbing in the split flesh, as if the entire body had been reduced to a single thick nerve.

.....Was she truly going to walk up to Taylor Ford for the sake of a stranger she had only met tonight?

Mai Minghe glanced around in a daze, instinctively searching for some way to go around him, some means to sidestep the confrontation.

But there was nothing useful in sight.

"There's no way to have it both ways——keeping the Artifact and saving him. You've seen that for yourself, haven't you?"

Taylor Ford tilted his head, lashes half-lowered, his eyes beneath the shadow like dark clouds in a night sky.

"I really am about to let go. I'm not bluffing this time."

His voice was light, almost drowsy, as he said, "Three——"

Mai Minghe couldn't help herself; she moved.

Garbage Chute had been resting its chin on the first step the whole time, as if watching a show; the moment she took a step forward, from deep within its dark tunnel, a wave of foul air came huffing and puffing out, like laughter.

"You're actually going over haha you're such an idiot humans are garbage one less of you is one less piece of trash why don't you just jump in too"

Amid its rapid-fire spray of words, Taylor Ford said quietly:

"Two."

Mai Minghe wiped her eyes, dragged her feet forward——one part of her wanting to move faster to reach him before he let go, another part of her wishing she would never arrive.

Of the two, the second feeling was stronger, nearly enough to pin her in place and root her feet to the ground.

A faint, distant voice was telling her that she had already shown she was going to save him, and that was enough; even if Reed Hydes disappeared into the elevator, she couldn't be faulted, could she?

After all, who in this world could save someone just by wanting to? She was already on her way——she simply hadn't made it in time. How could she be blamed for not making it in time?

Even if Reed Hydes became a ghost, he couldn't fault her for not walking fast enough on an injured foot.

".....One."

As if seeing the stickiness in her steps, the moment "one" ended, Taylor Ford cleanly let go.

For an instant, her mind went blank.

By the time Mai Minghe came back to herself, she found she had already lunged forward, and in the very moment Reed Hydes was about to fall completely into the wall, had seized his belt with both hands——only his lower half was still outside the wall now.

It was almost as if someone had bricked Reed Hydes into the wall; the sensation was close to dragging a person out of quicksand, the kind where one wrong move and she herself might be pulled in too.

Mai Minghe gritted her teeth, gripped him with both hands, and edged back little by little.

Taylor Ford stood just one step away and murmured, "Then.....pardon me."

The words fell, yet he didn't move immediately.

He first glanced at Reed Hydes, as if gauging the right moment to pull him free of the wall——in the despair that kept closing in on her, Mai Minghe suddenly realized that he had never intended to kill anyone.

If he acted too late, Mai Minghe would have a chance to back out; but if he acted too soon, she would lose her strength and let Reed Hydes fall back in.

"It's on your waist, right?"

Taylor Ford seemed a little embarrassed, cleared his throat, and reached through her clothing to press down on the Serpent Band on her body.

In that moment, she wanted to cry out, to shake him off, to retreat——but she couldn't let go, and she couldn't run.

".....Sorry."

When Reed Hydes crashed down onto the stairwell floor with a thud, his face had turned completely bluish-purple.

It was as though his windpipe had become a drinking straw, pinched shut by teeth; even as he strained to draw air into his lungs, barely anything went in——his hoarse, ragged gasps gradually grew distant and indistinct in Mai Minghe's ears, as if a layer of fog had settled over them.

She must have fallen to the floor; the ceiling looked so high from here.

So she had finally been brought back to her true form.

To live one last time in her most vigorous state before the decline, to see the wonders of the Nest……she still didn't know whether to call that the world's mercy toward her, or its cruelty.

She had never once gone to retrieve an Artifact as a Hunter.

Her quiet, careful life in Blackmoor City would ultimately fade away after she was gone, leaving no trace behind.

At least Reed Hydes had been saved, and had not died because of her.

Regret, unwillingness, relief, longing……those emotions seemed to surface, and yet seemed not to——she couldn't quite tell.

Because in the moment the Serpent Band left her body, the capacity to feel had aged and numbed along with her body, unclear and blunted, like the dull ache of arthritis on a rainy day.

"Mai——Mai Minghe?"

Reed Hydes finally caught his breath and scrambled over in a panic, calling out in a trembling voice. "Is it……is it really you? You were……you looked like this before?"

A warm hand pressed against the bony ridge of her back and tried to lift her——but she slid back down.

Even leaning on something requires muscle and strength.

An elderly person at the stage Mai Minghe had reached could no longer even hold a lean——like a hollow, withered shell with no bones left; when helped upright, she would simply slide back down along Reed Hydes's arm.

The apartment corridor, Reed Hydes, and Taylor Ford standing not far away with a pitch-black serpent coiled in his grip, all seemed to suddenly grow larger than before, while at the same time going dim and indistinct.

It seemed her condition was far worse than it had been before she encountered the thief.

That made sense——ever since she had put on the Serpent Band, she had endured untold hardships and accumulated untold exhaustion and injuries; having it all suddenly pile onto an eighty-six-year-old body, it was already a miracle she wasn't dead.

"Why did you save me?" Reed Hydes murmured, at a loss.

What was there to ask "why" about?

If one person had to die, it should naturally be the one whose life had already reached its end——that was only right.

Could she let a young person die in place of an old one?

"Taylor Ford, give her the Artifact back!" Reed Hydes suddenly raised his head and shouted. "How is this any different from killing her?"

Taylor Ford didn't move; he seemed to murmur something, too faint to hear——by all rights, having obtained what he came for, he should have left long ago, yet for some reason he remained standing where he was.

Was it simply because the staircase was blocked by Garbage Chute?

No——since he had made this plan, he would naturally have known how to get away.

……So why was he still here?

Mai Minghe couldn't turn her neck; she could only just manage to shift her eyes toward him.

Even without seeing clearly, she could still faintly sense that some emotion had taken firm hold of Taylor Ford just then, pinning him to the spot, unable to move at all.

……How strange.

It was clearly she who was about to die, yet the one who was afraid was Taylor Ford.

Today was especially exhausting. This chapter was supposed to be a dual-perspective one, giving everyone something satisfying (?)——but I'm so tired I'm nearly in the same state as Mai Minghe, so it ended up a little shorter.

Writing this chapter, there was a constant internal monologue running in my head: I truly am not cut out for power-fantasy writing. I know it too——this development really has zero catharsis, none of that protagonist-claws-back-from-the-brink-and-delivers-a-face-slap moment, just the inevitable course of events……ah, well. Being niche is only to be expected.

Chapter 162 — Taylor Ford Still Refuses to Be Abandoned by Life

He had thought that the moment he pulled the Artifact free from Mai Minghe, he would feel excitement and joy.

No—perhaps there had truly been a fleeting moment of joy?

Only for some reason, it was far less intense than Taylor Ford had imagined.

That tiny sliver of joy was thin and cool, and before he could even register it, it had vanished somewhere—like a cheap thing that couldn't withstand the passage of time.

When Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes collapsed together onto the corridor floor, Taylor Ford turned his head away and didn't look.

He lowered his eyes and took out his phone.

As the bodies hit the ground with a dull thud, he bowed his head and lightly tapped the screen.

The wallpaper lit up on the screen; it was a seagull, perched on the long wooden railing of a pier.

Between sky and sea, there was nothing but a vast white fog; the wooden railing receded into the distance, dissolving and disappearing into the mist. The seagull gazed far into the depths of the fog—no sea in sight, no sky in sight, nowhere to go.

...It still hadn't come.

Reed Hydes rolled over and clawed his way up from the floor, having just barely escaped with his life—he coughed and gasped desperately while crawling over to the other figure lying nearby.

All of this was told to Taylor Ford by his peripheral vision; he hadn't looked up, and was still waiting for his phone to vibrate.

"Mai Minghe!"

Reed Hydes called out, his voice trembling, as though he didn't quite dare to look directly. "Is—is it really you? Were you... were you like this before?"

Like what?

Why wasn't Mai Minghe getting up?

Even an old person could get up, couldn't they?

The questions flashed through Taylor Ford's mind; he still didn't look up. Beneath his gaze, the time jumped to 5:39 AM.

...Still no notification about obtaining the target Artifact.

Last time, when he had accidentally obtained the Key, he had barely touched it before his phone immediately vibrated and chimed, congratulating him on obtaining the first target Artifact in the "Nest Domination Game."

At that time, he had been inside Blackmoor City.

But that didn't prove that one couldn't receive messages from the "Nest Domination Game" while inside the Nest—hadn't Mai Minghe received a broadcast notification when she was in the library plaza?

The notification she received was somewhat different from the summons notification he had received; strangely enough, the broadcast had even given her a choice of whether or not to join—he had been given no such right, simply swept into the game and made a participant.

But that difference in content wasn't enough to prove that the form of the notification would also change; if someone was inside the Nest, they should still receive a notification.

It still wasn't...

Could it be that it wasn't one of the target Artifacts?

If it wasn't—

Though he had long prepared himself mentally, disappointment still welled up unavoidably; the black serpentine Artifact suddenly began to twist and coil faintly in his hand, as though it truly were a snake about to come alive.

Taylor Ford instinctively turned his eyes and glanced at the Artifact.

Just past the web of his thumb, there happened to be a row of numbers.

The countdown that would appear on the Artifact after entering Blackmoor City had paused and stopped changing once he returned to the Nest, and would remain so until the next time he left—

Hm?

Taylor Ford's heart gave a start; he nearly thought he had misread it, and carefully read each word and number again.

This—did Mai Minghe know?

"Mai Minghe!"

Reed Hydes called out at just that moment, and Taylor Ford followed the sound and looked up—his gaze finally falling on the person who had just slid down from his arm.

That... was Mai Minghe?

Taylor Ford froze.

...That was a person?

Thinking back on it afterward, that was both his first time seeing Mai Minghe without her Artifact, and his first time in his life seeing a human being on the very brink of death, utterly spent and worn out.

For a moment, Taylor Ford even thought the apartment building was playing some trick—that it had started conjuring horror-movie hallucinations—and wondered what other monsters he might see next. Zombies?

By the time he came back to himself, he found that his gaze had already flinched away and escaped, now fixed on something safe to look at.

At least Mai Minghe's clothes were still soft and thick as before, showing no intention of weathering and falling apart along with their owner.

They just looked empty and hollow, as though they weren't being worn by a person at all, but wrapped around nothing but a mass of grey, deathly stillness.

Taylor Ford couldn't comprehend it.

He had never thought about growing old, though he often thought about dying.

At thirty, he already felt like he was getting on in years.

But until the moment his life was taken from him, he would always look exactly as he did now—wouldn't he?

Only this face, these hands, this body, this mind... this was Taylor Ford.

If he became something else entirely, how could that still be called Taylor Ford?

And the Mai Minghe from a few minutes ago—agile and warm, voice full and clear—and the one now lying on the floor, were absolutely not the same person. No matter what reason told him, he could not accept that the two were the same individual separated by decades.

"Taylor Ford, give the Artifact back!"

Reed Hydes suddenly raised his head and shouted, equal parts fury and fear—and yet he dared to hold Mai Minghe in that state, which took a different kind of courage altogether. "How is this any different from killing her?"

Taylor Ford opened his mouth; his breath caught in his throat. After a second or two, he said something he himself found utterly stupid.

"...Where's Mai Minghe?"

To think that he would one day say something so foolish.

Fortunately, it seemed no one heard clearly what he said.

Reed Hydes lowered his head again—apparently because Mai Minghe in his arms had moved slightly; exactly what was happening, Taylor Ford didn't know, because he didn't dare look.

He kept his gaze fixed on Mai Minghe's top, afraid she would move, and afraid she wouldn't.

If he had simply been looking at a dying stranger with no connection to him, it would have been one thing—the feeling would probably have been something like seeing a strange deep-sea creature: "Oh, so there are creatures like this in the world."

But just a few minutes ago, Mai Minghe had been one of his kind.

"What? What did you say?" Reed Hydes murmured down to the person in his arms. "Can you say it again?"

...She could still speak?

Reed Hydes bowed his head and brought his ear close to that mouth—cracked and hollow as a split in dry earth, withered and dark.

Taylor Ford almost felt a flicker of admiration for him.

It seemed Mai Minghe could indeed still speak.

There was a sound like faint airflow—impossible to say whether it was parched or viscous—halting and slow and hoarse, enough to make one's hair stand on end.

No matter how hard he listened, he couldn't make it out; after a pause, Taylor Ford steeled himself and asked, "What... what did she say?"

Reed Hydes raised his head, shot him a furious glare, said nothing, then gently laid Mai Minghe back down on the floor and stood up.

"Are you really going to let her die?"

He limped over and demanded, "Even if you won't give the Artifact back to her, you should at least bring her back to Blackmoor City and get her to a hospital, shouldn't you?"

Taylor Ford actually took half a step back—then remembered that Reed Hydes had an injured foot and was barely managing to stand, so there was no need to back away from him at all.

"She just said 'save me,'" Reed Hydes said, words coming fast. "Can you really bear it?"

...He was lying.

Perhaps because Taylor Ford was himself an expert at deceiving others, he was also extremely sensitive to other people's lies; the moment that thought jumped into his mind, doubt arose.

Things had come to this point—why would Reed Hydes lie?

The next second, before Taylor Ford could even open his mouth, the black serpent still gripped in his right hand suddenly gave a violent twist.

In that moment, it seemed to sprout two legs from nowhere—it stretched out its tail end and planted itself upright on the ground; the instant it had taken root and steadied itself, it swung its body sideways and began to thrash violently, as if trying to shake free of Taylor Ford's hand. Taylor Ford had only just turned his head toward the Artifact and hadn't yet made out what change had come over it, when Reed Hydes, in the corner of his eye, lunged and threw himself forward.

...So that was it.

As Reed Hydes slammed full into his chest and sent him crashing straight down onto the floor, Taylor Ford's mind went crystal clear—he understood everything.

In his tilting backward field of vision, the ceiling rapidly expanded to fill more and more of his view, and a dark shadow was swiftly shooting upward and swelling—just as the back of his

head struck the floor with a heavy thud, the shadow, finally free of any hand, reared up against the corridor ceiling and stood.

Its head tilted to one side, its four limbs long and spindly—it had unmistakably taken on a human shape.

As though searching for something, its head rotated slowly in all directions, and then it set off in a lurching, unsteady gait in another direction.

So it was that kind of Artifact—one that could change shape...

"Don't move," Reed Hydes pinned him down and shouted furiously. "Don't even think about going after it!"

The back of his head throbbed with a dull, persistent ache—the impact had been no small thing; the vague fear and disorientation Taylor Ford had felt moments ago seemed to have been knocked loose by the blow, and he recovered some measure of clarity and calm.

"Get off me," he said, both embarrassed and a little angry. "That's what Mai Minghe told you just now, wasn't it? To wait for the right moment, knock me down, and make me let go?"

"So what if it was?"

Reed Hydes had abandoned all concern for the fact that they were two men, and pressed his entire body down, trying to use his own weight to pin Taylor Ford in place—when both of them were on the ground, the disadvantage of his injured foot wasn't so significant.

"It was her dying wish entrusted to me, and I will see it through!"

"Get the hell off me!" Taylor Ford roared, slamming a fist into his kidney. "That thing has nothing to do with time at all—"

Reed Hydes couldn't even manage to hiss in pain, yet still pressed down hard against his chest; Taylor Ford saw stars from being pinned like that, and tried to reach for his gun, but his entire gun-side body was pinned down and couldn't move.

"...That word 'dying wish'—seems like it's in the wrong place."

The two people struggling on the floor both suddenly went still.

Reed Hydes was the first to react; his eyes lit up, and he scrambled off Taylor Ford in a flustered hurry. He turned his head—at almost the same moment as Taylor Ford—and saw the figure who had risen from the corridor floor.

Mai Minghe's face was pale, with a faint glimmer of tears in her eyes, still seeming shaken.

But her eyes were clear, black and white distinct, her skin and hair warm and lustrous—she had returned to being her young self, one of his kind.

The Artifact was gone.

"My words could only count as a dying wish if I were actually dead." Mai Minghe said softly, smiling gently at Reed Hydes. "Thank you. You've saved my life again."

Reed Hydes got to his feet; Taylor Ford still sat blankly on the floor, staring at her.

"You... you knew that Artifact could change shape?" After several seconds, he asked quietly. "You knew it would choose you?"

"Compared to someone young, it seems to know that I need it more. That was how it was the first time I encountered it."

Mai Minghe looked down and slowly ran a hand over her side.

"I knew that when released by someone, it would take on a human form... and that in human form, it might walk toward me again. If I wanted to keep living, the only way was to make you let go. In a moment of complete despair... that was the last desperate struggle of an old woman who, no matter what, refused to be abandoned by life."

She raised her gaze and looked directly into Taylor Ford's eyes.

It was difficult to say what expression she wore; it was like the sea that had grown still and solemn again after a storm of countless emotions had churned through it.

"Do you still want to take it?" Mai Minghe asked, her voice nearly calm. "If you do, you still have a way."

Taylor Ford sat there for a moment, then shook his head.

"Seeing what I looked like just now—did it frighten you?" Mai Minghe watched him and continued to ask.

After a few seconds of silence, Taylor Ford nodded, almost meekly.

"...Go ahead and tell me," Mai Minghe paused, then said suddenly: "You don't have to hold back out of pity. You saw it just now, didn't you? This Artifact's expiration—how much time does it have left?"

I don't even know whether to blame today's short-form social media content for shattering people's basic sense of reality, but in real life, for an ordinary person or an ordinary company, a million dollars—especially a million in cash you can produce on the spot—is truly a massive sum of money.

Speaking of which, you have to hand it to Musk—scrounging around for backers and investors, cobbling together 44 billion, buying Twitter, and then turning it into a toilet. So that's what it truly means to treat money like dung...

Chapter 163: Mai Minghe — Entropy, Loss of Control, and Reluctance

The third-floor apartment corridor had never been this quiet.

The only sound came from the Garbage Chute blocking the stairwell.

Though it didn't move, from time to time they could hear something tumbling, knocking, and falling deep inside it — as if someone were truly throwing garbage in.

Once, they heard a faint human voice rise from somewhere deep within the chute, calling out a greeting to no one in particular: "Hey, you too? Nice not having to work or better yourself, right?... I'm happy just being garbage... Easy, carefree."

"You think that's going to trick someone into climbing in?"

Reed Hydes finally couldn't hold back. He looked up at it and said, "We're talking about something serious — can you keep it down?"

The Garbage Chute made no sound, like a perfectly ordinary garbage chute.

"...Is it true?" A few seconds passed, and Mai Minghe said softly.

"You haven't seen it?" Taylor Ford shot back.

Mai Minghe shook her head blankly.

All three of them were sitting on the corridor floor; the life-or-death struggle of moments ago felt like it belonged to a different chapter of history entirely.

Compared to the Nest, compared to all its traps, the thing that had flickered past just now — the thing waiting for everyone at the end of life — was far darker and more terrifying. In the face of utter extinction, schemes and stratagems, quarrels and arguments, all became absurd.

"We originally planned to rest in the apartment and check the Artifact's expiration."

Mai Minghe said quietly, "When we first came in, the apartment was still safe — the renovation hadn't started yet. I had Reed Hydes look around, but he didn't find any time or text either..."

"At the time I thought maybe it could only be seen if you took it down," Reed Hydes nodded and continued, "but if you took it down, she would turn into... you saw for yourself. The two of us

were still discussing what to do when the apartment suddenly entered its renovation period, just like that — after which there was simply no way we dared take it down."

He still seemed not to trust Taylor Ford — which was understandable enough, given how badly the two of them had been deceived by that child; and the most troubling part was that there was no way to tell whether Taylor Ford had lied, or what his reason for lying might be.

If what he had said just now was also a lie, that would be wonderful...

But he was telling the truth.

Mai Minghe lowered her head and drew a long, slow breath.

Those three words leapt from her mouth without warning, as jarring as a fist to her own gut: "Nine months?"

The air seemed impossible to draw into her body, and her mind went completely blank.

She could only repeat the same words over and over: "That's too short — too short. I only have... this is too short."

"To be precise, two hundred and sixty-seven days remain," Taylor Ford leaned against the wall, lashes lowered, murmuring: "...not even nine full months."

The corridor sank into silence once more.

"Didn't the Nest flood your mind with a huge amount of information?" Reed Hydes suddenly asked, brow tightly furrowed. "Are there any Artifacts with a similar function? You have nine months to go looking..."

Though the volume of Nest information in her mind was vast, it was scattered, random, and without any order; Mai Minghe thought for a moment and shook her head.

"I do know the locations of some Artifacts... but none with a similar function," she said slowly. "The more precious the effect, the rarer the Artifact — that holds true wherever you look."

Perhaps she should count herself fortunate that, at the end of her life, she could still have the dream of nine months of renewed youth.

"Life — it's all backwards. It should go in reverse."

Without realizing it, Mai Minghe heard herself speak softly.

"People should experience death first, then move into a nursing home. Then, because they're not old enough, move back out. Buy a gold watch, start working. Work for decades, grow young enough to retire — drink, throw parties, get ready for high school, then middle school... all the way down to becoming a child. Nothing requires you to be responsible for anything, and you become a tiny infant, back in the womb. At the very end of life, you disappear, becoming a gleam of light in your parents' eyes."

It was something George Carlin had said many years ago — she'd happened to hear it once and never forgotten it.

"You two are still too young. You probably can't understand."

Mai Minghe smiled slightly and said, "When I was young, I thought I would never change. It wasn't a rational conclusion — just a vague sort of confidence. I've forgotten how old I was when I suddenly noticed that my wrists, even when held flat, had several crease-like lines on them. As if I had originally been made of cardboard, and the wrists had been folded so many times they could no longer lie smooth."

Taylor Ford unconsciously glanced down at his own wrist.

He was seventeen — full and fresh, like the first dewdrop of a morning, his eyes refracting the hazy white light of the sky. On his wrist, naturally, there were no lines at all.

Taylor Ford raised his head, as if about to say something, but his gaze suddenly fell on her feet, from which she had removed her shoes.

Because of the bandaging, she hadn't been able to fit her shoes back on, and her toes were exposed beyond the bandage.

"Why... do you cut your toenails straight across?" he asked blankly, a question with nothing to do with Artifacts. "Cutting them square like that... does that have something to do with getting older too?"

"Fingernails grow more brittle and thin with age; toenails grow harder and thicker. Cut them in an oval and the edges dig into the flesh, growing inward — unbearably painful, and it causes inflammation."

Even Reed Hydes, who was somewhat older, showed a look of surprise, as though he were hearing this for the first time.

"Never imagined that even something like toenails would betray you as you get older, did you?"

Mai Minghe tried to smile again. "Aging... it's a process of gradual entropy, loss of control, and betrayal."

She lowered her head and gently wiped her eyes.

"I thought that after all these years I had grown used to it, had accepted it — that everyone grows old, everyone dies... Now I realize I never accepted it at all. I had simply, without noticing, aged until I no longer had the energy to resist."

"I'll keep an eye out for you."

Reed Hydes said suddenly, "If there's an Artifact with a similar function — something that could give your youth back — I'll find a way to get it for you no matter what. After all, you saved my life."

Mai Minghe nodded.

After he spoke, he shot a sideways glance at Taylor Ford.

"Don't you have anything to say? She even took the time to go and deliver a message for you, which let you save the people from your House Faction. You should know how to repay a kindness, shouldn't you?"

Taylor Ford tilted his chin up slightly.

"That has nothing to do with me. I may be the director of the Morgan House Faction, but their lives and deaths are naturally their own responsibility — just as this life of mine is the only one I look after myself. I've never counted on anyone to keep me in their heart. Still, keeping an eye out for you on the side wouldn't cost me much."

He said this, then paused, and raised his eyes.

Taylor Ford had gradually recovered from the shock of a moment ago, and was once again the young Hunter, Taylor Ford.

"...As long as you're not my competition, that's fine," he said, with something close to calm.

Mai Minghe said nothing in reply.

With Taylor Ford's mind, it was impossible he hadn't noticed that she still hadn't formally refused to join the Nest Domination Game; he hadn't pressed her to refuse while he had the chance — was it because her time was running short?

Even if she joined, she would die of natural old age within nine months, so she wouldn't count as a rival worth guarding against?

No — he had most likely settled on something else entirely: with the time Mai Minghe had left, she could only pour everything into searching for a way to extend her life, with no attention to spare for anything else, let alone competing with anyone in the Domination Game.

"Jonah's already been rescued?"

She steered the conversation away from the inevitable conclusion, asking, "You didn't go over?"

"I went. I pulled him out of that whole nest of worms and brought him away — which wasn't easy, I'll have you know — so what more do you want from me." Taylor Ford shrugged and said, "The remaining pest removal work didn't need me to do personally, so I came out to track you down."

"Is Jonah all right?"

Even though the person who had spoken with her and briefed her at the time had not been Jonah himself, Mai Minghe still remembered the faint comfort that another human's company had brought her in those first moments of fear.

Taylor Ford glanced at his phone screen.

"Yeah, it was close — he almost couldn't be saved at all. It's five forty-eight now... about twenty or thirty minutes ago, I got a call over the walkie-talkie. They told me Jonah's Resident had been expelled and that he needed to be taken back to Blackmoor City for the next stage of treatment. The rest of our people have arrived here as well."

At that point, her ears and Reed Hydes' had been ringing — they hadn't heard a thing.

"Are you saying the Morgan House Faction Hunters are already waiting outside the apartment door?"

Reed Hydes whipped his head around to ask. From the look on his face, he seemed to still be a little shaken — he really hadn't been very polite to Taylor Ford just now.

"Yes."

Taylor Ford swept a glance at Mai Minghe. "After all, if that Artifact really is the target, I have to get my hands on it without any slipup."

Lucky that the Serpent Band wasn't one of the target Artifacts... Mai Minghe thought.

How many Artifacts were needed in total? The summons notice had said almost nothing — only asked whether she wanted to join; how had Taylor Ford come to know more details?

Or had the summons notices they received been different?

"In any case, since you don't have what I want, I'm just waiting to leave."

Taylor Ford said this as he stood up — he looked at Mai Minghe and Reed Hydes, then looked at the Garbage Chute that had been waiting patiently nearby all along.

"Where are you going?" Reed Hydes asked blankly. "The way upstairs is already blocked by that thing..."

"I'm not going upstairs."

Taylor Ford laughed softly and said, "We all fell for it — haven't you noticed?"

I'm exhausted — sleep has truly been a problem lately, night after night of not being able to sleep... Tomorrow I still have to go see the ophthalmologist. It feels terrifying, like a failing student heading into an exam.

But I haven't forgotten about the electric scam victims — the Platinum Alliance! I'm designing a new kind of bonus chapter, hoping it can feel more participatory rather than just watching the characters perform.

Chapter 164: The Trap Taylor Ford Set from the Very Beginning

It seemed like the first time he had ever felt this indescribable feeling.

The "Serpent Band" had returned to Mai Minghe not because of any awakening of conscience on his part, but because Mai Minghe had seized the last fleeting opportunity and made Reed Hydes knock him down at the critical moment — ever since she had recovered, Taylor Ford had been carrying this strange, unfamiliar, and conflicted feeling.

On one hand, he wanted to do something for Mai Minghe — make her happy, help her forget the nine-month countdown for a while; on the other hand, he felt a burning unease, quietly guarding himself against her — as if she were about to make things difficult for him and he needed to stay on guard.

But Mai Minghe didn't mention a single word about what had just happened, as though the person who had tried to take her things was someone else entirely.

"Tricked?" she only asked calmly. "Your mind really does work fast. What did you find?"

For a fleeting moment his mind could barely hold onto, Taylor Ford seemed to feel a faint sense of bewilderment.

...That's it?

Hadn't she just nearly died a moment ago?

There was no way she didn't mind at all, was there?

In an exceedingly rare moment, Taylor Ford genuinely didn't know how to face her attitude.

"You can both fully recall the apartment renovation notice now, right?"

He had no choice but to push down that strange, burning feeling and say, "I only glanced at it once from outside the door, but after I entered the building and thought back on it, every single word was crystal clear — as if I had deliberately memorized it. I imagine it's the same for you two."

The two across from him both nodded.

"That's true..." Mai Minghe said thoughtfully. "We noticed something was off after we found the apartment had started its renovation and we couldn't get out. We had entered the apartment

first, and the renovation only began afterward — so the notice posted outside the door, we never saw it at all."

"Then how did you know what the notice said?"

Reed Hydes touched his not-particularly-useful head. "It just... surfaced in my mind..."

Taylor Ford nodded and asked, "It wasn't from a broadcast, was it?"

"How could there be a broadcast?" Reed Hydes glanced at him. "What residential building has a broadcast system? It's not a dormitory or a prison."

Being made to feel stupid by someone who was clearly stupider than him — that truly made Taylor Ford seethe.

"I heard one," he said coldly. "Or rather, I remember hearing one."

Mai Minghe made a sound of surprise. "Hm?"

"At first I thought the reason the apartment imprinted the notice into people's memories was to ensure that everyone would follow the rules in the day ahead and not forget them.

"But if the only goal was to keep us from forgetting the rules, they could have just posted a copy on every floor, couldn't they? To go to the trouble of leaving such a vivid and deep impression — while not a single posted notice exists inside the building — something is definitely off."

"Something's off?" Reed Hydes muttered. "You and the apartment are in the same line of work, so you can't con each other?"

Mai Minghe laughed softly; Taylor Ford had just opened his mouth to respond when he heard her laugh, glanced at her, and swallowed back every one of the ten cutting remarks he'd had ready for Reed Hydes.

Suppressing his irritation and keeping a straight face, he asked Reed Hydes, "How many years have you been a Hunter?"

"About... five or six years," Reed Hydes answered, puzzled but willing.

"How many times have you entered the Nest?"

"Sometimes more frequently, sometimes after earning a big payout I'd stay out for a long time. There were plenty of times I needed to recover from injuries too — like this foot injury of

mine, that'll take at least two or three months to heal. Call it an average of five to seven times a year... thirty or forty times, roughly."

Taylor Ford made a low sound and lifted his chin. "I've gone in a hundred and forty-six times."

If not for her injured foot, Reed Hydes might have launched out of her seat.

"How is that possible? No one could take that — how old are you even? The physical toll, the mental pressure, and on top of that, Nest Dissociation Syndrome—"

Who didn't know all this useless trivia? Taylor Ford couldn't even be bothered to listen.

"All right — I'm not saying this to pull rank. After going in as many times as I have, I've seen countless Nest traps, and even when I encounter an entirely new one, the instincts I've built up still kick in... I can say with considerable confidence that the notice in our heads was put there to help us die more efficiently."

"Wait," Mai Minghe couldn't help saying. "What I know about the Nest was directly instilled in me by the Nest itself. One thing I know is that the Nest cannot lie about 'rules'..."

Perhaps because the Nest was a product of humanity, and one of humanity's most fundamental desires is "fairness" — no matter how many flaws, no matter how imperfect, humans have never stopped using technology, institutions, and thought to push back against the injustice of the world and of humanity itself.

Correspondingly, even though every inch of the Nest existed to claim human lives, it was still obliged to give its opponents a relatively equal playing field — and "rules" existed for precisely that reason.

In Hunter circles, this was already a common, foundational understanding.

"You're right," Taylor Ford said. "Every rule in the notice posted outside the apartment door is real. But what I just said was about 'the notice in our heads.'"

"Our memories were tampered with?" Mai Minghe immediately understood what he meant.

"Hold on — you're one thing, but the apartment directly giving us a falsified notice with tampered content — isn't that unfair too?" Reed Hydes raised an objection. "How is that any different from lying outright in the rules?"

Mai Minghe furrowed her brow and thought for a moment.

"You have a point... but there's one exception."

She seemed to be mentally re-examining every rule in the notice, her words coming at an unhurried pace.

"For instance... the apartment deliberately left us clues. If we're holding clues and still fail to spot the false rule mixed in, then it can't be called unfair on the Nest's part."

"Exactly, there are quite a few clues—"

Taylor Ford was about to continue when Mai Minghe stopped him.

"Wait, let me think. If you can figure it out, I should be able to as well." She murmured, "Young people these days know so much — I can't fall behind."

For some reason, even in such an insignificant detail, Taylor Ford found himself wanting her to succeed. "Should I give you a hint?"

Mai Minghe thought for a moment and said, "All right."

"The memory wasn't tampered with — it was added to."

Mai Minghe froze, then drew a sharp breath.

"You figured it out?"

"I think so... but if that counts as a clue, isn't it awfully small and hard to notice?" Mai Minghe said hesitantly.

Since she could say that much, it meant she had found the problem.

Reed Hydes had absolutely no intention of bowing his head to ask Taylor Ford for the answer, and only urged her on: "What clue? Tell me — no need to be coy with me."

"In the first few paragraphs of the notice, there's a detail that — how to put it... at first glance it just looks like careless writing, as though the logic wasn't quite sorted out when it was written."

Notice

Paragraph One: In response to residents' needs, this apartment will begin internal renovation and reconstruction starting at 1:30 AM on November 19, 2026.

Paragraph Two: The renovation and reconstruction covers floors 1 through 5; the 6th floor will remain unchanged for the time being.

Paragraph Three: During the renovation period, some things within the building will inevitably come loose and regain their freedom; within the floors under renovation, hazardous zones of unknown variety will also form, which will not be particularly friendly to those not yet ready to die — please stay alive and bear with us.

Paragraph Four: The renovation and reconstruction will continue until 1:30 AM on November 20, 2026; the renovation does not include the stairwell.

"If I told you that one of these paragraphs was not in the original notice, which one would you say it is?" Taylor Ford asked.

Reed Hydes stared blankly for a few seconds, then his brow suddenly smoothed and rose, spreading into an expression of dawning realization mixed with confusion.

"One of either Paragraph Two or Paragraph Four?" he asked.

This blunt, unremarkable person had at least not reached the final stages of stupidity.

"That's what I thought as well — after all, both Paragraph Two and Paragraph Four contain the same piece of information: the 'scope of renovation.'"

Mai Minghe explained: "Assuming all the information is accurate, from a structural standpoint, writing it as 'the renovation covers floors 1 through 5, excluding the 6th floor and the stairwell' would be more concise and clear, wouldn't it? The same piece of information split into two parts and placed in two separate locations feels slightly unnatural."

If one of the two had been quietly inserted into the memory after a person walked through the door, that would explain things neatly. In Taylor Ford's case it was like that; in Mai Minghe's case, the false rule had been added to her memory together with the real notice.

The end result was the same — they had accepted the entire notice wholesale.

"Just that?"

Reed Hydes blinked and pushed back: "You don't understand... maybe people in your era had very high standards for writing structure. But our generation scrolls through social media and short videos every single day — forget grammatical logic, we don't even have the attention span to read long texts. No, forget attention span — scroll enough and your intelligence actually drops. Writing whatever comes to mind, leaving something out in Paragraph Two and tacking it on in Paragraph Four — that's completely normal."

"Scroll what?" Mai Minghe blinked a few times. "You can scroll through socializing? Like polishing shoes?"

"No... when we get back I'll help you register an account and you'll see for yourself. Oh, it's addictive once you start, you can't quit — I'm not even sure whether I should set one up for you or not."

"We're getting off track," Taylor Ford couldn't help saying. "Our time on the third floor is probably limited — let's get to the point sooner."

"Limited?" Mai Minghe was immediately on alert.

From deep within the Garbage Chute, someone faintly and vaguely let out a sigh, as though very disappointed.

As expected...

After detonating all twelve unexploded bombs, if you neither went down nor went up, wouldn't the third floor become the only safe zone?

Just like the second-floor corridor — if a safe zone simply appeared the moment you cleared a section, that would be too good to be true.

The most likely guess was that after a certain amount of time, the traps on each floor would reactivate; as for whether that guess was correct, Taylor Ford had no intention of testing it on himself just yet.

"In any case, Mai Minghe is right."

As Taylor Ford spoke, he gestured for the two of them to stand up and walk with him.

There was no target Artifact here, so there was truly no reason for him to say another word to either of them — he could simply leave on his own; yet not only was he patiently explaining the apartment's traps, but when he waited for the two of them to get up, he even reached out a hand to help Mai Minghe to her feet... why, he himself didn't know.

Was this what "guilt" felt like?

That sort of unnecessary thing — he wanted no part of it.

Taylor Ford pushed the thought down and explained:

"If both the 6th floor and the stairwell fall outside the renovation scope, then even someone with the worst attention span and the most scattered logic wouldn't need to split them into two separate paragraphs — because they're naturally bundled information. But let's set that aside for now and grant that your point has merit.

"The issue is that the one who wrote the notice wasn't a person. It was the apartment — which deliberately wrote the notice in a slightly unnatural way."

He waved a hand to signal Reed Hydes not to speak for the moment — whatever objection he was about to raise, there was nothing new in it anyway.

"I said there were quite a few clues, right? Another clue is this line: 'the renovation covers floors 1 through 5.'"

"And what kind of clue is that?"

Reed Hydes leaned against the wall, following behind Mai Minghe in single file, walking with Taylor Ford toward the stairwell to the second floor. As they walked, they each glanced back at the Garbage Chute a few times — the Garbage Chute lay quietly on the fourth-floor stairwell, staring back at them through a square black void.

"The renovation scope implies danger. Floors 1 through 5 are under renovation, so floors 1 through 5 are all dangerous," Taylor Ford said. "But what danger did you two actually run into on the first floor?"

The two of them froze.

"None," Mai Minghe answered. "As soon as we realized the sixth floor was the safe zone, we headed straight up to the second floor..."

"I didn't run into any danger on the first floor either," Taylor Ford said. "Isn't that strange?"

Because the apartment building truly was under renovation, the second and fourth statements in the notice couldn't both be false at the same time — either one was true and the other false, or both were true.

Setting aside the possibility that both were true for the moment: if the second statement was true, then the first floor fell within the renovation scope; if the fourth statement was true, the first floor still fell within the renovation scope.

Either way, there should have been danger on the first floor — that much was beyond doubt.

"The second floor had parallel realities, the third floor had a bomb, and the floors above that must each have their own challenges and traps."

Taylor Ford explained as he walked: "Since logic tells us the first floor must also be dangerous, the real question becomes — what is the danger on the first floor?"

"Could it be that we went upstairs so fast the danger didn't have time to..." Reed Hydes trailed off, feeling that wasn't very likely herself, and shook her head without finishing.

Right, like you think you could outrun anything, dragging that injured foot around.

Taylor Ford grumbled silently.

"I understand now," Mai Minghe finally murmured. "You, child... your mind is far too sharp."

Taylor Ford felt both flattered and a little heat creeping into his face.

"The danger on the first floor was precisely that it could plant non-existent memories into our minds."

Mai Minghe understood everything now, and said with a sigh: "The first floor added an extra line to the notice inside our heads — 'the renovation scope does not include the 6th floor.' That way, we'd foolishly run all the way up to the sixth floor and all the way back down, and who knows which floor we'd collapse on before losing our lives.

"I had originally thought the safe zone was placed on the sixth floor to maximize our exposure to danger. But if someone was made to believe the safe zone was on the sixth floor when the sixth floor was just as dangerous — wouldn't that be an even better way to kill someone?"

Taylor Ford nodded.

He should have caught the contradiction much sooner.

When he was on the first floor of the apartment building, everything around him had been dim and eerily silent — yet by the time he was heading upstairs, extra memories had surfaced in his mind: memories of hearing the broadcast, memories of hearing someone calling for help from Room 103.

The memory of silence and the memories of all those sounds had coexisted in his head at the same time, yet he had effortlessly overlooked them, rationalized them away.

"When facing the outside world, people naturally put up their guard. But who would ever suddenly doubt their own memories?"

He smiled faintly. "Still, looked at from another angle... if the first floor can only keep adding non-existent memories, doesn't that make it the safest floor in the entire building?"

This trap — looking back, it was buried across 19 chapters... the timeline is a bit long, I'll admit.

I know my dear readers all have sharp minds (but will still willingly let me scam them), so when I lay out clues I'm like a dog burying bones or a cat burying its business — I try to bury them as deep as possible.

The broadcast Taylor Ford heard and the sound from behind the door — I tried my best to make those two pieces of information feel abrupt when I wrote them, to create an out-of-nowhere effect... I hope when you all read them, they did feel a little off too.

I've attached a screenshot of the clues from Chapter 139 to save everyone the trouble of flipping back. After all, I just figured out how to insert images, and I'm on a real kick with it now — I'm dying to stick something in every chapter whether it needs it or not.

Chapter 165: Mai Minghe, the Elderly, and a Romantic Comedy?

The second floor had indeed "respawned."

The word "respawn" was one Reed Hydes had taught her — apparently it came from computer games.

He'd started explaining on the way downstairs, and by the time the three of them reached the second floor again, Mai Minghe had worked out what "respawn" meant; she'd also picked up along the way what an online game was, what an NPC was, and what "grinding monsters" meant — Reed's favorite game seemed to be Warcraft, and in his eyes nothing could ever surpass it.

Taylor Ford was the first one down the stairs; he turned around and extended a hand to Mai Minghe.

Ever since the struggle over the Serpent Band, he had, without quite noticing it himself, become a few degrees more considerate and attentive — but Mai Minghe acted as though she hadn't noticed, and said nothing to acknowledge it.

She rested her hand on the young man's naturally and limped down the steps, asking, "Do you like playing these... monster-grinding games too?"

"They're called role-playing games," Reed corrected from behind.

"What?"

Taylor Ford's expression was hazy, as though he were following a sound out of deep fog. A moment passed before he seemed to remember what a "game" even was, and he answered, "Oh, no... I don't play games. Never have."

"Well, well — worthy of a high-ranking Hunter from a major House Faction," Reed muttered, and stepped off the stairs himself, reaching out a hand.

Taylor Ford immediately pulled his hand back.

The moment all three of them were standing in the hallway, the hallway's light bulb blazed on with great ceremony, as if welcoming their arrival; just like last time, every apartment door stood wide open — but this time there were no television screens behind the doors.

Did the trap's contents change with every respawn?

Mai Minghe was about to ask Taylor Ford, but the moment she turned her head, she froze.

Taylor Ford's shoulders had no head on them.

His neck had disappeared into a television set; the TV seemed to sense Mai Minghe's gaze and turned toward her as well — the screen.

She was startled, and instinctively tried to cry out — but to her surprise, though her mouth fell open, not a single sound came out.

Huh?

What was going on — did she have to go deaf first and then mute?

With a flash of alarm, she turned her head again and found that what sat atop Reed Hydes's neck had also become a television.

The pitch-black screen on Reed Hydes's television gleamed with faint reflections and shadows; Mai Minghe stared at his screen for two seconds, then slowly raised her hand and let it settle, hesitantly, on top of her own head.

Mm... hard, cold, and perfectly square.

Her own head had, sure enough, also become a television.

Well then. All three of them had been transformed, turned into a combination set of televisions — who would have thought this place was an appliance store all along.

For some reason she felt as though she still had a mouth, but couldn't make a sound no matter what; just as Mai Minghe was groping around searching for her mouth, Taylor Ford tapped her on the shoulder.

What was it?

She turned her head toward the young man — or rather, turned her screen — the weight wasn't heavy, but the size was considerably larger than an actual head, and every turn and twist felt strangely awkward.

Taylor Ford raised his hand and pressed, with slight force, on the spot near what would have been her temple.

With a soft electric "click," Mai Minghe saw her own screen's light reflected in Taylor Ford's screen.

Her head had powered on.

...That was barely something a human being could say.

"It seems you need to turn the TV on before you can speak to each other — don't worry, it should be temporary; once we're out it'll be fine."

Taylor Ford had even offered her a word of reassurance.

He turned on his own television too, and from the TV set around his neck, the young man's voice came through together with a crackling static hiss. "What image is on my screen?"

"...Please stand by, searching for signal." Mai Minghe answered honestly.

Taylor Ford was silent for a few seconds, as though trying to process and digest this fact.

"What about me? What's on my face?"

"Same message."

Not just Mai Minghe — after Reed Hydes powered on, his screen displayed the same line as well.

Before the "signal" was found, none of the three dared to move rashly, and could only stand at the top of the stairwell and wait patiently.

Of the three, Reed Hydes adapted to the strange situation the fastest and was already offering suggestions; he said that to pick up the signal better, everyone should try spinning in circles, sticking their heads near the windows, or stretching their necks upward as far as possible — all such suggestions were treated by Taylor Ford as electrical interference, heard and ignored.

When the signal arrived, the second floor's rule explanation arrived with it.

From that moment on, the sounds of Taylor Ford and Reed Hydes at her side disappeared entirely.

They presumably couldn't hear her voice anymore either.

Even though she knew rationally that the two of them were right there beside her, Mai Minghe felt as though she had been left utterly alone; she could only watch the explanation by herself, and walk alone into the trap that was waiting for her next.

TV Life

When deeply absorbed in reading a novel or watching TV, just about everyone has had thoughts like "what if I were so-and-so" or "what if this happened to me," haven't they?

Wouldn't it be fun if you occasionally had the chance to truly experience a film or TV drama's plot as one of its characters?

See — the Nest isn't so stingy with humanity, is it? It's not simply out to kill you at every turn.

Before killing you, the Nest will also provide you with some novel experiences.

Have you noticed that your head has become a television?

Good — that's exactly right.

Next, the television that is your head will broadcast a film or television drama, running no longer than 65 minutes.

You are one of the characters in the film or drama — not the lead, mind you; your luck isn't that good. Oh, unless it's a tragedy where the lead ultimately dies — then you may just get to play the main character after all.

As the plot unfolds, you must sense danger one step ahead and, with the limited capabilities of a supporting character, carve out for yourself a correct path — one that keeps you alive.

For you, this will be a fully immersive, all-angle experience, essentially indistinguishable from reality.

If you die within the film or drama, you will truly die in reality as well.

You cannot see the real environment — only the world of the film or drama — but your physical body remains on the second floor of the apartment building. This means that the actions you take within the cinematic world will also guide your body as it moves around on the second floor.

For example: in the cinematic world you are being hunted by a killer, you must run to escape, and two paths lie before you — you choose Path A, and your body may crash into a bedroom wall; you choose Path B, and you may fall out of an apartment window.

Only by choosing the correct path can you make it smoothly downstairs from the second-floor apartment.

Simply walking straight ahead along the corridor is useless, because your sense of direction within the cinematic world has changed completely — you will have no idea which direction the

corridor lies in.

Please note: taking the wrong path will not necessarily kill you. Most of the time, a wrong turn will only cause you to collide with furniture or walls.

However, your head-television is, after all, a delicate electronic device that cannot withstand impacts, so after three to seven collisions (depending on the severity), your head-television will shatter.

Your head will shatter.

So please, enjoy your supporting-character life in the cinematic world!

P.S.: The Nest thinks you're a decent person, and has specially arranged a lighthearted cinematic world for you — a romantic comedy! How about that? Nothing could be safer than this, right?

Oh my...

Mai Minghe very much wanted to scratch her head, but the moment she reached up, she touched the cool surface of a television casing.

She had to find the right path down the stairs while the male and female leads were busy falling in love — that genuinely didn't sound too difficult.

She wondered what kind of film or drama Taylor Ford and Reed Hydes had each drawn.

Would they make it downstairs all right?

I haven't been sleeping well these past few days, and today I'm too exhausted, so I kept it short. Also — the dungeon on the way downstairs doesn't need to be written in too much detail, right? I'll keep this part brief.

What a shame, no chance for an illustration today — that won't do; I need to think about how I can create more opportunities for illustrations...

P.S.: Qidian has all sorts of tricks — to unlock the illustration feature in the backend, you have to exchange it with "ink." I didn't even know ink was a thing! As a result, I've been checking in on the backend every single day, and I finally saved up enough ink to unlock illustrations. After all that effort, wouldn't it be a waste not to use it as much as possible?

Another P.S.: Next Saturday I'll be doing a giveaway draw in the Doomsday Ticket post — I'm going to let AI do it for me; never doing the stupid paper-ball-rolling thing by hand again.

Chapter 166: A Nest Where Mai Minghe Gets Off Easy?

...It wasn't just her sense of direction that had changed.

Mai Minghe quickly discovered that her basic perception of spatial scale, physical movement, and everything else had become completely unreliable.

When she opened her eyes, she had become a college student lazily flipping through a book on the grass—but when had she sat down? Hadn't she been standing the whole time?

She stood up, stretched out both arms, and tried to feel her way around as she walked, searching for where the walls were.

The apartment was small and the hallway narrow—by all reason, she should have touched a wall within a few steps; yet she felt her way forward for over a dozen paces, changed directions several times, and found nothing but empty air on all sides.

Had her sense of "walking" gone wrong?

Was she convinced she was moving in some direction, when in fact she was just treading in place?

Mai Minghe couldn't even feel her injured foot anymore; the character she was playing in the romantic comedy hadn't hurt her foot.

In other words... her perception of the surrounding environment and her own movements had entirely become those of the supporting character she inhabited, and she could only act through the role's storyline.

Though she had reached this conclusion, Mai Minghe was still unwilling to accept it and took a few more groping steps forward—the punishment for trying to circumvent the rules and force her way out of the trap came immediately.

"Watch out!"

Before she could turn around, a guy seemed to drop out of nowhere, zeroed in on her, and launched himself at her like she was an unguarded American football—"There's a hole there!"

She didn't even have time to cry out before she found herself knocked flat on her back, her head hitting the ground with a solid thunk.

"Sorry about that, I hit you a bit hard. Are you visually impaired? Where's your cane? Do you need me to help you get home?"

...She hadn't even caught a glimpse of the leads' faces, and her head had already taken its first solid knock.

How many more knocks she could take, Mai Minghe didn't know—and the film world offered no indication whatsoever.

It hadn't even been five minutes; at this rate of progress, she figured she wouldn't survive long enough to see the leads' first date.

Even Mai Minghe, with her good temper, couldn't hold back her anger, and she shouted at the figure who had appeared in the guise of a guy but was nothing more than the Nest's punishment: "Get lost! You've got rocks in your head!"

...Hm? She'd never said anything like that in her life.

Something felt off—it wasn't that she couldn't hold back her temper; it was that this character simply had a blunt, fiery personality.

Sure enough, the rules explanation at the start had only given a rough outline. For instance, it hadn't included a single word about "being influenced by the character's personality."

There were surely far more subtle and intricate rules still waiting to be figured out...

Mai Minghe didn't dare go around randomly feeling and testing things anymore; yet over the next ten minutes, as the plot proceeded without incident, she grew more and more bewildered.

Because she still had no idea who the leads were.

Everyone naturally sees themselves as the center of the universe; without the camera's selective framing and focus, Mai Minghe had no way of telling which person around her was the real protagonist—let alone that at this age, when hormones ran high, everyone around her was either already in a relationship or desperate to be in one.

In other words, was the plot unfolding somewhere she couldn't see?

Then how was she supposed to find a way out?

Mai Minghe hadn't expected that she would spend the first thirty minutes of the film world drifting aimlessly like a headless fly, still completely in the dark about where the story had gotten to.

If the film world hadn't had scene transitions and hadn't moved at a normal flow of time, she might have burned through the entire duration of the Serpent Band without ever finding the leads—it was precisely because of several sudden scene cuts that Mai Minghe was able to cross-reference the people present in each scene, filter through the cast, identify those who appeared in every scene, and from those, zero in on the most attractive-looking pair, a man and a woman, who looked the most like protagonists.

So it's you, the female lead, Mai Minghe thought.

The girl from last night, stumbling around drunk in the small hours, clutching a cat that was clearly wearing a collar, insisting that Mai Minghe help her sneak it into the student apartment and give it a home... well, now that she thought about it, that did have the hallmarks of a romantic comedy heroine.

"Mac!"

The next day, when Mai Minghe, the cat, and the male lead crossed paths in the apartment hallway, the male lead started, then strode toward the cat—well, that made sense; who else could the cat's owner be? This world revolved around the two of them.

"Mac, how did you end up here?" The male lead scooped up the cat and cast a suspicious glance at Mai Minghe standing nearby.

Whatever she did in this situation, surely it wouldn't get her killed here, would it?

If she gave up the female lead, wouldn't that actually help speed up the two leads' romance?

What followed gave Mai Minghe a firsthand taste of the domino effect—and also revealed a hidden, unstated rule embedded within the film world.

She had given up the female lead who had catnapped Mac, but hadn't anticipated that the two were apparently in the "bickering rivals" stage, at the point where they couldn't stand each other.

The female lead thought she'd done something kind, only to be chewed out by the man she despised; furious, she stormed off and left Mai Minghe alone in the apartment.

...The moment she was far from both leads at once, this world ceased to be a romantic comedy.

It started with an unfamiliar phone call, the caller introducing himself as a classmate she'd met at some party, asking whether Rachel was in the room—her phone wasn't going through.

No wonder she was the female lead; truly popular.

Mai Minghe sighed to herself and answered, "She's not."

"Just you, then?"

"That's right."

Two seconds of silence from the other end, then a word of thanks, and the line went dead.

Now that autumn had set in, the wind had turned a little cool.

The college girl, at a momentary loss for what to do, sat in the cool breeze reading for a while; when Mai Minghe felt cold and stood up from her chair to close the window, she glanced down—and saw a face pressed against the base of the window from outside.

The strange man had his mouth slightly open, staring fixedly at her, unblinking, breathing in slow, heavy pants; his trousers had dropped to the ground, one hand busy, but in the other he gripped a sharp knife.

Even knowing full well that everything before her was an illusion, Mai Minghe felt every hair on her body stand on end; for a moment she was gripped by such dread and revulsion that it was as if she had just swallowed a beetle, its countless tiny legs scratching and scrabbling at the walls of her stomach and throat.

The natural first reaction of an ordinary college girl was to turn and run.

In her panic, Mai Minghe stumbled and fell—if she hadn't just barely dodged the corner of a nearby table, she would have cracked her head again.

Where had the female lead said she was going?

Mai Minghe scrambled out the door, frantically trying to recall what Rachel had said before she left.

Only by returning to the leads' side would this world revert to the harmless, bloodless romantic comedy it was supposed to be—as long as she could see through this in time, the Cinematic Life trap wouldn't be truly lethal.

Fortunately, Mai Minghe's luck held out; when she ran into the school parking lot, she ran into the male lead, who had just settled the cat in his car.

"Are you all right?" the male lead asked with concern, then, inevitably, brought up the female lead: "Isn't Rachel with you?"

The moment the lead appeared, even the weather seemed to brighten—the sun was radiant, the air suffused with a pale golden light, everything gleaming as though freshly wiped clean.

The lighting on the scene and the visual style had shifted back to the romantic comedy register.

"There—there's a pervert..." Mai Minghe gasped out, and described what she'd just encountered.

This character didn't seem to have much stamina.

"Did he realize you'd seen him?" the male lead asked, his expression turning serious.

Mai Minghe could only nod frantically.

True to his role in a film aimed at a female audience, the male lead was both gentle and resolute; he said at once, "Get in the car. We can't stay here—that man might be looking for you. I'll take you to file a report right now."

But what would it actually be like to ride in a car inside a film world?

Was she right now sitting on her apartment sofa, pulling an invisible seatbelt out of thin air and buckling it?

Mai Minghe sat in the passenger seat, a vague unease settling over her, and turned to look out the window.

The female lead was standing on the road just outside the parking lot, a tall young man beside her; the man was holding a photograph printed on plain white paper and, though visibly anxious, was clearly good-looking—he was pointing at the photo and talking to the female lead.

The scene flashed past in an instant.

Mai Minghe stared at the road streaming past outside the window, frozen.

...The photograph—wasn't that a cat?

Wait.

Was that man looking for a cat? Could he be looking for the cat in the back seat of the car right now?

Wasn't it the male lead's cat?

Coincidence? Had someone else also lost a cat?

No, no. The world of a film is finite; the same element doesn't appear randomly more than once. If two cats had gone missing at the same time with no connection to each other, that kind of plot would only leave the audience confused.

Come to think of it, even though the man beside her had appeared in every single scene transition... it was also possible that for those first thirty minutes, the male lead simply hadn't been on screen near her, wasn't it?

Just now, even the sky and the sunlight had turned warm and inviting again... could that be because the female lead was standing nearby?

"Don't worry," the man beside her said, his voice reassuring. "Whatever happens, I'll get you to the police station."

...That shouldn't be a particularly difficult thing to manage, should it?

His tone didn't sound much like reassurance; it sounded more like he was reminding himself, steeling his resolve.

What—was he being tempted by some other thought? Was there actually a possibility he might not take Mai Minghe to the police station?

And now that she thought about it—why had he pretended the cat was his?

Right, her phone—

Transformed into an ordinary college girl, Mai Minghe finally understood the critical importance of a phone; but when she patted herself down, she realized she'd bolted out too fast and left it behind.

Mai Minghe sat in the passenger seat, biting down hard on the inside of her cheek, doing her best not to let anything show on her face.

...Someone who steals another person's cat is not a good person.

"That man really is bold," the former male lead murmured. "Broad daylight, and he still had the nerve to wait patiently under the target's window for his chance..."

"Bold" wasn't a word you'd use about a pervert, was it?

What exactly was he admiring?

At a red light, the car came to a stop.

She placed her right hand on the door handle, pointed with her left toward the road far on the driver's side, and screamed with everything she had.

"That's him! Right over there—he followed us!"

"What?" The former male lead whipped his head around immediately.

Mai Minghe seized the moment, slapping the lock button with her left hand to unlock the car; her right hand pulled the door open, and she scrambled to jump out—only to be yanked back by the seatbelt.

An invisible seatbelt, yet it could still hold her?

Frantic and furious, she saw the former male lead had already turned his head and was reaching toward her; she jabbed the seatbelt release, and leapt out the car door—and the next second, slammed headlong into empty air.

She stood dazed between the wall and the car, momentarily unsure whether to worry about knocking her head or about the man behind her whose hand was already reaching for her back.

Surely getting out of the car was the right call? This man was deeply suspicious, wasn't he?

Mai Minghe spent a precious second or two in a stupor, and only after nearly being dragged back into the seat by the former male lead did she abruptly realize—the way out, though narrow, was right in front of her.

Between the invisible wall and the car, wasn't there a long, narrow space just barely wide enough for one person?

And she was standing right in it.

Mai Minghe desperately shook off the hand in the car, turned sideways, and like a flustered crab scuttled quickly toward the back. Her instinct seemed correct — the space grew wider the

further she went, and before long she could no longer touch the walls on either side. Mai Minghe broke into a jog on the open road.

The car hadn't been driving long, so she hadn't gone too far from the school. After sprinting madly for several minutes, Mai Minghe spotted in the distance the female lead walking in her direction — and beside her, the true male lead.

The moment she recognized them, her heart dropped back into her chest, and her legs nearly buckled beneath her.

The two of them, at this life-or-death moment, were still trading barbs back and forth, putting on a full-blown bickering-lovers act:

"You were in that car just now too?" the boy asked pointedly. "Let me guess — did Rachel hand you over to him as well?"

"I already said I was sorry. I thought it was a lost cat," the female lead snapped. "Why don't you put a tag on your cat?"

"Because it never occurred to me that someone would do charity work with another person's cat."

"Go sit and wait for me at the coffee shop over there," the female lead said, ignoring the male lead and turning to Mai Minghe. "Once I get the cat back, I'll come find you."

...Romance comedies truly were a terrifying genre.

Within and beyond the male and female leads' field of vision, there was a maniac ahead and a potential maniac behind — yet the moment the two of them met, in their back-and-forth bickering, their incidental physical contact, their eyes accidentally meeting... the world turned bright and soft again, golden-pink with the shimmer of romance floating in the sunlight.

By the time they tracked down the cat-thief, things probably wouldn't be serious at all — if anything, it would probably turn into a string of comedic moments, wouldn't it?

Mai Minghe stood there blankly, watching the two of them hail a cab.

She didn't want to leave the safety zone around the male and female leads, but since the male lead needed to open the car door, she had no choice but to step a few paces aside — and then her vision abruptly dimmed, and the sky, the road, and the two leads all vanished from before her eyes at once.

...W-was it over?

Mai Minghe felt her breathing hadn't quite caught up yet, but the pain in her injured foot returned first, burning like fire.

It seemed like only forty minutes had passed... it hadn't pushed all the way to 65 minutes. Was the Nest going easy on her after all?

As her eyes gradually adjusted to the dark, she found herself standing at the top of the staircase leading down to the first floor.

Sitting nearby in the dimness was Taylor Ford.

The TV on Taylor Ford's neck was gone, replaced once again by that face so strikingly handsome it made you wonder if he was a figment of someone's imagination.

"You made it out alive too? Going by the runtime, you were in a TV episode as well."

He greeted her lazily, flashing her a smile. "We just need Reed Hydes and we can head downstairs. Though... I have no idea what the first floor has turned into."

Since this part isn't very closely tied to the main storyline, I'll just skim over what happened when they went downstairs — after all, if I wrote out every sub-scenario in detail, I'm afraid the Artifact Report would take another nine years...

Oh right, the lottery for the Doomsday Amusement Park stage play tickets apparently officially opened today (?)!

The production company is called the Hard to Please Theater Studio — they're running one draw, I'm running one draw, and apparently the official Doomsday account is also running one (to be confirmed).

Chapter 167 — These memories of Mai Minghe's—they shouldn't all be implanted ones, right?

"Your TV drama only lasted twenty-four minutes?"

Reed Hydes's voice shot straight up, nearly punching a hole in the ceiling. "Why? Why only twenty-four minutes?"

Taylor Ford shrugged. "Sitcoms run about twenty-something minutes per episode. That's perfectly normal."

"Do I look like I care how long a sitcom episode is? It's this blatant injustice and favoritism —"

Reed Hydes glanced at Mai Minghe, held back for a moment, then couldn't help himself: "The TV world you experienced was pretty easy, wasn't it."

Mai Minghe gave him a somewhat sheepish smile, with the guilt of someone who had gotten off lightly.

Reed Hydes had taken on all the suffering that she and Taylor Ford had been spared—he'd ended up in a sci-fi mystery thriller and performed at maximum intensity for sixty-five minutes; by his own account, he had been fighting to survive the entire time, cornered into dead ends more times than he could count.

"Even when I wasn't getting my head slammed into a television set, there were traps everywhere!"

Reed Hydes said bitterly, "Stay away from the main character and you'd easily die in some piece of foreshadowing or a side-plot. Stay close to the main character and something bad was guaranteed to happen to you. And then—I found what seemed like a safe, peaceful place in the show, but it turned out to be more dangerous than anything else. The moment I got sucked in, my mind started going hazy... For a while, I even forgot who I was. I forgot that I didn't actually belong to that world."

In other words, if you only focused on staying safe, you'd gradually be "swallowed" by the TV drama world?

Even though he had just barely escaped with his life, staying on the second floor any longer meant not knowing when the traps would "reset" again—Mai Minghe offered him a few kind, encouraging words, while Taylor Ford was completely unbothered and cut straight to the point: "Done crying? Let's go. Time to head downstairs."

"But we still don't know what the first floor looks like now," Mai Minghe said.

"We won't know until we go down and look." Taylor Ford was about to head downstairs, then paused and said, "That said, I think it's probably unchanged."

"Still just adding memories into our heads?" Reed Hydes asked. "But the second floor's content changed..."

"Compared to the first floor, the biggest difference with the second and third floors is that they're 'stages.' After we clear them, there's a brief moment of calm—enough time for us to leave and for the stage content to reset. The first floor is different.

"The first floor has never had a 'stage.'"

Mai Minghe understood immediately—since the first floor had never had a "start" or an "end," it likely wouldn't reset either, like a tape on an endless loop.

"That tape analogy is way too dated. I've never even seen one."

She shared the thought aloud, and Taylor Ford laughed. "Speaking of tapes, though—that reminds me, we should make a recording."

"What do we need a recording for?" Reed Hydes asked.

"If the first floor keeps filling our heads with memories that don't exist, we need to be able to distinguish the most critical facts." Taylor Ford pulled out his phone and said, "For instance—that there's no life-or-death hatred between us anymore, and no need to kill each other. If I open a voice recorder, state a key fact, and you two each say you agree... then if we need it later, we can play it back and it'll keep us from being fooled by false memories."

"That's really thoughtful of you," Mai Minghe couldn't help but remark.

The three of them pooled their ideas and brought up every key fact they could think of: besides the no-mutual-killing point, there was also the time the apartment would reopen, the fact that the sixth floor wasn't safe, and that no Artifacts had been found anywhere in the building so far... and so on.

After spending seven or eight minutes on the second floor, the group felt it was becoming unsafe and walked down the stairs, continuing the recording on the staircase; Reed Hydes glanced back at the hallway every so often, and out of concern, called out tentatively: "Hey, uh, Chute—you don't need to hurry over, we're heading downstairs in a second."

A few seconds later, from deep within the hallway, the Garbage Chute's voice drifted over—sounding, just by its tone, like it carried a faint whiff of something unpleasant.

"...No rush, no rush, take your time, treat the staircase like your own home—make yourselves at home, make yourselves at home."

"Add one more," Reed Hydes quickly said into Taylor Ford's phone. "Lingering in the stairwell will draw the Garbage Chute."

The three of them exchanged glances and decided there was nothing else worth recording; Taylor Ford had just turned to head downstairs when Mai Minghe suddenly pressed a hand down on his shoulder.

"There's one more thing to add—I only just thought of it," she said. "This recording was made voluntarily by us, for the purpose of keeping our memories accurate, and is completely trustworthy. At the time of recording, we were not in any danger, and nothing capable of mimicking our voices was present."

Even Taylor Ford was moved to compliment someone else: "That's a good addition. Alright, let's get downstairs, quick."

The first floor was exactly as it had been when they entered—quiet and dim.

The group stopped in the open space of the first-floor entryway, all on high alert, scanning the surroundings in wide sweeping looks; yet several minutes passed without anything happening.

"No reset," Mai Minghe let out a breath of relief. "Looks like you were right—the first floor doesn't follow a 'stage' format, so its traps don't change."

Taylor Ford was about to nod when he suddenly furrowed his brow and let out a low, "Hmm?"

"What is it?" Reed Hydes seemed to have also realized he was someone the Nest would never look kindly upon, and had grown a little jumpy.

"Hmm, no, it's nothing..." Taylor Ford looked around. "I remember that before I went upstairs, I set a disposable phone on the floor with the ringer on, let it keep ringing, and then headed up. But... the phone is gone now."

Silence fell over the first-floor entryway for a few seconds after he finished speaking.

Mai Minghe knew full well that all three of them had probably just arrived at the same thought.

"Why did you put the phone on the floor?" Reed Hydes asked.

"I remember I wanted to test whether sound could travel between floors."

Taylor Ford shook his head and said, "After walking up a few flights of stairs, I couldn't hear the ringtone anymore. I didn't bother with it and headed straight up to the second floor—it wasn't important anyway. Just now, coming back downstairs, I was focused on watching out for possible dangers on the first floor, so I only noticed just now that it's gone."

The group fell silent again for a moment.

"So... did you actually leave a disposable phone down here?" Mai Minghe said.

That thought had no doubt been drifting through all three of their minds for a while now.

Taylor Ford shook his head. "I don't know."

"It's probably a memory the first floor just added to your head, isn't it?"

Reed Hydes looked around and said, "There's a renovation notice posted outside the door, and once you come in you can't get back out, so no one would have come in. As for Residents... besides the Garbage Chute, we haven't seen any other Residents in this building. Who would have taken the phone?"

Taylor Ford crouched down and rummaged through his backpack for a moment, apparently unable to find the disposable phone. But when he raised his face, there was no trace of relief there.

"The phone really is gone—but I still can't say for certain that any of it happened. It might have just fallen somewhere else. I'm not even sure whether I actually brought a disposable phone in with me... Still, what would be the point of planting a false memory like that?"

The group discussed it for a while, couldn't make heads or tails of it, and had to let it go for the time being.

A person's existence is, at its core, the continuity of that person's own memories.

When memory can no longer be trusted—when you have to stay vigilant at every moment, repeatedly scrutinizing and cross-checking—Mai Minghe found that the mental strain was unexpectedly immense, and extraordinarily draining.

After all, doubting yourself is the most exhausting thing there is.

Within less than half an hour, everyone was giving out, like ice cream slowly melting away (wait—why "everyone"?)—they went from standing at attention, to bending over to rub their legs, to crouching half-seated, until finally the whole group had collapsed entirely, backpacks and limbs strewn every which way across the floor.

"From last night until now, not a single wink of sleep," Mai Minghe let out a long yawn. "How about we take turns sleeping for a bit?"

The suggestion immediately won Taylor Ford's approval.

"Maybe once we're asleep, the memories won't keep getting added. Honestly, at this point I can't even tell which memories were quietly slipped in and which ones were originally mine."

"You dare sleep inside a Nest trap?" Reed Hydes scrubbed his face hard. "What are you thinking—even if you had amphetamines to keep you going, you can't sleep here!"

"Do you have amphetamines?" Taylor Ford suddenly opened his eyes.

...This kid—the moment he heard something like that, he seemed to perk right up.

"No," Reed Hydes said.

Taylor Ford immediately closed his eyes again.

He didn't seem concerned at all that Mai Minghe might bear a grudge and take advantage of the moment to get back at him. Leaning back against his backpack and adjusting his position, his voice already thick with drowsiness: "Then what are you going on about... If you're too scared to sleep, you've got the first watch."

Mai Minghe had dared to sleep in front of Residents—she certainly wasn't going to lose sleep over sleeping near a human.

She lay down against the wall too, using her arm as a pillow, and murmured encouragingly to Reed Hydes: "Hang in there, stay sharp, remember to listen to the recording often... I'm done for."

It had only been the night of the seventeenth when the thief broke into the house, yet looking back, it felt like half a year had passed.

In the three days since that night, Mai Minghe hadn't slept a single complete night through, and had long been soaked through with exhaustion.

Even inside a Nest trap, the moment her eyes closed, her brain couldn't wait to throw the switch, and she dropped straight into a dreamless, undisturbed pitch black.

She didn't know how much time had passed—when someone finally shook her by the shoulder, nudging her awake one push at a time, she came to in a daze and thought, for a moment, that the social worker had arrived.

"...It's your day to come again?" she asked, voice hoarse.

"What?" The one who answered was a young man's voice. "It's me—Reed Hydes."

Reed Hydes?

That was—oh, right.

She was young again; from a body on the edge of death, she had once more become the self she remembered...

Right, she was young again—but the road ahead was only nine months long, and then she would collide once more with an unavoidable end.

Mai Minghe pushed herself up, her mind still heavy and foggy. "I remember now... We're in the apartment. Is it my turn to keep watch?"

"No," Reed Hydes said quietly. "Taylor Ford and I decided there was no need to wake you. We took turns keeping watch, right up until now—we can leave."

She blinked, mildly startled. "What?"

"It's already 1:30 on the twentieth." Reed Hydes said, gesturing at the empty hall. "The apartment renovation period is over—we're finally allowed to leave. Taylor Ford left a little while ago."

That he had left without a single word to her didn't seem particularly surprising.

After all, what could he have said once Mai Minghe woke up? "Sorry"?

"Then we should get out of here soon too," Mai Minghe sat up and made a concerted effort to pull her scattered, drifting thoughts back together. "Memories—have your memories had any problems?"

"Plenty of memories that don't belong to me have probably been stuffed in, but I have absolutely no way to tell which are which." Reed Hydes gave a wry laugh. "What are you planning to do next? Head back to Blackmoor City?"

She was about to nod, but stopped.

"No, I want to go to the car first," she said quietly. "Hopefully it's still where I parked it..."

"What do you need the car for?"

Mai Minghe thought for a moment. "There's a memory I'm not sure whether it was implanted in my head only after we came down to the first floor. At the time I couldn't record anything on Taylor's phone in front of him, and I had no chance to quietly jot down a note... so I wanted to verify it with you."

Reed Hydes nodded blankly. "Go ahead—though I can't guarantee my own memory is correct either."

"It's fine. I just want to confirm one thing. After Taylor took my Artifact, you tackled him and pinned him down, right?"

"Yeah. I was really worried about getting back at him for that..." Reed Hydes said with a troubled look.

"At that moment, did he shout something like, 'Get off me, that thing has nothing to do with time'?"

Reed Hydes froze.

He searched through his memory for a moment, then said with some hesitation, "Yeah... yeah, he did say something like that."

It wasn't out of the question that the apartment had planted this memory in both their minds simultaneously; but at this point, Mai Minghe had no choice but to believe it.

"He was caught off guard by you, so those words slipped out unintentionally. I believe it was the truth.

"To win the Nest Domination Game, Taylor needs to find the target Artifact. After learning about my situation, he suspected that the Artifact on me might be one of the targets he was looking for.

"In other words... the target Artifact isn't just something related to time—he even believed it could reverse a person's age."

Reed Hydes was no fool; by now he understood completely. "You want to..."

"Yes,"

Mai Minghe nodded, glancing out at the pitch-black night beyond the apartment window.

"I'm not ready to accept my fate. I still want to live. If that target Artifact can reverse time, then it's my greatest hope."

And yet, intelligence about the target Artifact seemed to only be provided to players after they had joined the Nest Domination Game...

She had no interest in dominating the Nest, but now she had no choice but to join.

"When the in-car broadcast sent out its recruitment invitation last time, I hadn't given a response yet, so I still have a chance to enter."

As she spoke, Mai Minghe stood up and pushed open the apartment door together with Reed Hydes. The night breeze was cool; with eyes closed, it felt almost no different from the outside world.

"I understand—you think the broadcast on the car might sound again and let you enter."

Reed Hydes said this and let out a sigh. "The Nest truly lives up to being a human creation... even this place, where power and hierarchy were supposed to have no hold, is finally going to change."

Mai Minghe held the door open and let Reed Hydes step out first, then followed after.

After leaving the apartment, she looked back once.

Cynthia, I will get you out of here... even if you've already become a Resident by now.

Come to think of it, I remember seeing several people ask why they can't just leave the apartment... you're probably all reading pretty fast and skimmed over the rules? You can't leave until it's time.

I'm working hard to pick up the pace and get back to the main storyline—you've probably noticed... Maybe it's because I haven't slept well in a very long time, and Mai Minghe ended up following suit and couldn't hold on either, so she had to get some sleep in the story too...

Chapter 168: The Footstool in Taylor Ford's Home

"...No broken bones. Consider yourself lucky."

A voice was drifting nearby, rising and falling like fog, with no clear source.

Taylor Ford found it familiar; after a moment's thought, he placed it—Dr. Cole, the one who worked with Morgan House Faction.

Hunters returning from the Nest sometimes sustained injuries that were hard to explain; when a hospital visit wasn't an option, a cooperative private clinic that knew the whole story was invaluable.

Dr. Cole seemed to materialize out of the mist, walking up to him with a white paper bag in hand.

"Treatment is done. From here it's rest and follow-up. I'd recommend you stay out of the Nest for the next month or two..."

Taylor Ford pressed a hand to his jaw; even through the thick medical bandaging, he could feel his pulse surging with something close to fury—throbbing in and out, like a fingernail tip pinching his nerve endings, releasing, then pinching again.

"...Surface wounds I can manage, but Nest Dissociation Syndrome is completely beyond me. No medical school teaches that."

At that point Dr. Cole, following Taylor Ford's gaze, looked down at his own desk. "...What is it? What do you see?"

Above the desk floated a dense mass of fog, as if a deep black cavity had cracked open in the space itself.

Another Dr. Cole was leaning out of the mid-air cavity, his neck drooping limply onto the desktop, staring at Taylor Ford without blinking from behind his lenses, mouth opening.

The mouth on that face stretched wider and wider, until it became yet another deep black cavity.

From within that deep black cavity in the face, a slightly smaller Dr. Cole was poking his head out, drooping limply downward, staring at Taylor Ford, mouth stretching open.

Like a set of Russian nesting dolls, the black voids and Dr. Cole's face cycled on, one nested inside another; Taylor Ford felt that if he kept looking, by the time he made out the smallest Dr. Cole, he would be sucked into some abyss and never find his way back to the living world.

Even knowing that, he still couldn't tear his gaze away.

"Hey!"

A snap of fingers cracked sharply right beside his face; Taylor Ford jolted, and the scene on the desk vanished.

"What did you see?"

Taylor Ford turned his head in a near-daze and found a tired face perpetually shadowed by stubble. Dr. Cole was standing in front of him—the real one, a properly sized human being.

"Hm? No, nothing... when did you get back?"

"I've been standing in front of you for several minutes now," Dr. Cole said, raising an eyebrow.

"Is that bag for me? Make sure you give me plenty of painkillers," Taylor Ford said, with a vague memory of having already made that request once. "I have absolutely no tolerance for pain."

Dr. Cole placed the paper bag in his hands and shook his head.

"I've prescribed you more than enough—so much it's almost reminding me that medical ethics exist. No supplements within the month. Humor my curiosity: what did you just see? Hallucinations?"

"Something like that," Taylor Ford said, rising from the treatment chair. "Hallucinations blended with what's real, with a distinct Nest flavor."

"Don't those hallucinations affect you when you're inside the Nest? Having hallucinations in there sounds pretty dangerous."

He seemed to have some interest in Nest Dissociation Syndrome—though Cole probably thought of it as just a mental illness with an unusual cause. Explaining more to someone with that view was pointless; he wouldn't be able to offer any real help.

"They don't."

Taylor Ford had already opened the door and turned back with a smile. "It's like being home—why would you feel homesick when you're already there?"

Dr. Cole stood there blankly for a few seconds, then only after Taylor Ford had walked out did he lean into the doorway and call after him: "Is someone picking you up? You really shouldn't be driving like this."

"I know," Taylor Ford said, waving him off without looking back. "I called an Uber."

After saying goodbye to the nurse at the front desk—who also served as the receptionist and looked so worried she was nearly in tears, repeating over and over that he absolutely had to come back for his follow-up—Taylor Ford discovered, with mild surprise, that it was almost dark outside.

Hadn't he returned to Blackmoor City from the Nest somewhere around four or five in the morning?

He pulled out his phone and checked: it was already 5:40 PM on the 21st.

A day and a half had dissolved into fog and drifted by in a haze.

After thinking for a while, he vaguely recalled having fallen asleep at the clinic; Dr. Cole had gone to treat Jonah first, and Taylor Ford had been unable to hold on while waiting and had drifted off. In hindsight, it was more like losing consciousness.

When he'd been woken afterward, and how the treatment had gone—all of it felt like a dream with blurred edges.

In this state, the sensible thing, strictly speaking, would be to have someone take him home.

But since arriving at the clinic, he hadn't been able to reach Han Ford—probably off playing golf again. And Taylor Ford had no desire to let any outsider know where he lived; after taking over as Hunter Director, he had quietly rented a small apartment where he could hole up whenever he wasn't working or didn't want to go home.

Uber worked just fine. Very safe.

He'd get out, the driver would leave, neither would know the other—practically no loose ends.

Taylor Ford let out a long yawn, watching the Uber disappear into the distance, then turned and crossed the street—he barely glanced before stepping off the curb, immediately drawing a

chorus of sharp brakes and angry horns—his feet felt like they were treading on clouds, and he walked on, deaf to it all, onto another nearby sidewalk.

Though he had rescued Jonah this time, it meant nothing to him personally.

He needed to get his hands on the next target Artifact as soon as possible, yet everything he knew about Artifacts—no, about the Nest Domination Game—amounted to just two notifications from the Nest.

The first summons notification had listed each Artifact with only a brief name or image; where to find them, what they did—he had no idea.

The second notification had been sent to congratulate him on obtaining the Key, but it was difficult to feel pleased about. Because the last line of that notification read: "The target Artifact you currently hold will become intelligence for the next participant. Please be sure to protect it carefully."

He had seen the Wellesley Team's holdings, so the next participant could see his as well... which meant the last one to enter was at the greatest advantage?

Taylor Ford decided he was not in a state to think right now.

He put the key to the lock and tried three times before finally lining it up with the keyhole; he turned it, but it wouldn't budge.

Taylor Ford stood at the doorway in a blank stupor as thoughts cycled through his head in quick succession—"wrong key," "someone broke in and locked it from the inside," "still in the Nest"—until he squinted and realized this wasn't his apartment door.

He'd think it through in the morning; by then, he should be a little more himself...

He finally opened the correct apartment door, casually tossed the key and backpack onto the entryway floor, and pressed the light switch.

On the single sofa in the living room, Chase lifted his head.

In that instant, nearly all the fog in Taylor Ford's mind cleared away.

The dusk outside the floor-to-ceiling window cast a faint, nostalgic dark-orange glow across him; fingers intertwined and resting in his lap, Chase looked almost serene.

He was leaning against the sofa back, long legs stretched out, feet propped up in front of him.

Taylor Ford had never bought a footstool for that sofa.

What was sitting on the floor, being used as a footstool for Chase to prop his feet on, was Han Ford—bound hand and foot, his face an ugly color.

Chase looked at Taylor Ford and smiled slowly; his teeth were even and close-set, a dull white, as if they had torn through too much flesh and bone over the years and been stained with a layer of death that no washing could remove.

His gun... had been returned to Morgan House Faction's supplies department.

Taylor Ford glanced at his father on the floor, then back at Chase. He closed his eyes and let out a long, heavy sigh.

"Unhappy to see your father?" Chase tilted his head; a glint of light flickered across his neatly combed black hair.

"You see..."

As he spoke, he lifted one foot slightly, tapping the heel against Han Ford's shoulder a few times, pressing Han Ford's body down a few inches. "This is the fundamental difference between us."

Taylor Ford very much wanted to say something, but Han Ford spoke first, trembling: "Taylor... what—what is going on? Why is he..."

He didn't often call him Taylor. He'd said it made him think of Taylor Ford's mother.

Taylor Ford pinched the corner of his eye.

...What a headache.

He should have taken a few painkillers before leaving the clinic.

The products Hunters dealt in were unusual, and so were the channels through which they obtained them—but that was all.

At its core, this business was still just business, and everyone was in it for the money.

Just as steel traders didn't go around assassinating each other, Hunters were rarely willing to spill blood among themselves; they were all in the same trade, and unless you absolutely had to snatch food right from someone else's mouth, it was best to leave some room.

Situations that demanded a fight to the death had grown rare—after all, life mattered more than money—and a scene like this one, fangs fully bared, trouble brought down on family, was a first even between Taylor Ford and Chase.

"Stop talking," Taylor Ford said the words toward Han Ford but didn't look at him once, eyes fixed on Chase: "Let me think."

He and Chase had always had a mutual distaste for each other, but that alone wasn't enough to make Chase suddenly abduct Han Ford. If anything had changed between this meeting and the last time they'd seen each other, Taylor Ford could only think of one thing.

The Key.

But even if Chase knew the Key was in his hands, if he thought it was just a slightly more valuable Artifact, he wouldn't openly declare war like this; the fact that Chase was sitting here could only mean one thing.

...Chase had been summoned by the Nest?

That was absurd—he wasn't even a Hunter, let alone someone with a passage.

Was the Nest really that desperate?

If Chase truly had a passage now and was a participant in the game... then even setting aside today's events, Chase had to die.

No doubt Chase felt the same way about him.

"Your face..." Chase's gaze paused, drifting over the bandaged wound on Taylor Ford's face. "What happened?"

Hm?

"Are you actually worried about me? I'm so touched."

As he spoke, Taylor Ford suddenly crossed the room in a few strides and dropped heavily onto the other sofa—startling Han Ford into a flinch.

Who cared; he was barely holding together, and if Chase was going to kill Han Ford just because Taylor Ford sat down, that was just Han Ford's bad luck.

"I'm almost envious that you've been spared this kind of suffering," Taylor Ford said, touching the bandage on his face. "Got hit by a Resident in the Nest. It really hurts."

Chase didn't react. "When did you get hurt?"

What did this slick-haired cockroach want to know that for?

Taylor Ford paused for a moment, then said with a smile: "Last night."

Chase thought for a few seconds. "...Take the bandage off."

Well, if he had a gun right now, Taylor Ford thought he'd shoot Chase dead first and then put a bullet in Han Ford.

He was silent for a moment, then reached up and removed the bandage. The nurse was definitely not going to be happy about this.

From across the living room, Chase studied his injury for a while—Taylor Ford looked a complete mess right now; the wound was swollen with bruising, held together by several stitches.

"...Looks like a real injury. Where were you between midnight and one in the morning on the 20th?" Chase furrowed his brow slightly, as if something had come to him, and asked.

Last night? What had happened?

"Even if I told you, you couldn't go there," Taylor Ford said, with an air of deep sympathy. "If you really like the place that much, I can take some photos of the Nest next time and let you stick them on your fridge."

Han Ford's eyes were practically bulging out of his head with anxiety, but Taylor Ford acted as if he didn't see it.

Chase, however, seemed not to have heard any of it—showing neither irritation nor any response—and simply crossed his arms, as if faced with a problem he couldn't quite work out.

"Impossible..." he murmured to himself, then glanced over at Taylor Ford. "Strange."

Seriously? He just took everything at face value?

Even though Taylor Ford had told only the truth, he still found it oddly easy for Chase to believe him—Chase should have known to be on guard against his lies.

It felt like... there was something in between, something Chase already knew but that he had yet to discover.

"I truly didn't find what I was looking for," Chase said quietly, one large hand drifting unconsciously in a light, idle motion, his five fingers like long white leaves that begin to fold closed

when night falls. "Not at your place, not here either..."

Was it the Key?

Taylor Ford held back, and said nothing.

If what Chase was searching for wasn't the Key, he couldn't very well be the one to tell him about the Nest Domination Game.

"I have two questions for you now. Your answers will determine whether or not you become an orphan."

Taylor Ford barely managed to swallow the words "like you?" before they left his mouth.

"First—has there been an Artifact circulating recently that can replicate someone's appearance?" Chase asked.

Taylor Ford froze, and suddenly understood.

Someone impersonated me? Is that why Chase asked where he was last night?

Right... no wonder he wanted to look at his injuries just now. The wound on his face was fresh—whoever was impersonating him wouldn't have known about it yet.

"I haven't heard of anything like that," Taylor Ford said honestly. "At least not anything Morgan House Faction has handled."

Chase said nothing.

He stared at the back of Han Ford's head, his expression close to calm, yet the damp, glistening sheen on Han Ford's forehead refused to fade.

"The second one isn't really a question—it's more of a... command." Chase glanced at him and smiled. "It's fine. You would have found out sooner or later anyway."

Taylor Ford raised his eyes.

"The Key in your possession," Chase said, extending one hand, his tone flat: "is one of the seven target Artifacts—the one called 'the Key.' Give it to me."

The recent chapters have been pretty long, huh? Long chapters actually aren't great—subscriptions have been dropping. Speaking of which, I really do need to thank the victim of tel—the target of tel—no, the Silver Alliance patron, for organizing the timeline. Without that, the timing in today's chapter might have gone wrong again...

Chapter 169: Taylor Ford's Key of Uncertain Origin

For a moment, Taylor Ford was in a daze, thinking he'd returned to that summer highway.

His mother stood beside the car, grabbed by the arm, just as he was now—caught in someone else's hands, powerless.

But this time he had a choice—it didn't matter that he'd chosen wrong last time, as long as he walked toward her now, he could stay forever, and keep her there too—

"Sit back down."

Chase's voice fell over him like a splash of cold liquor, jolting Taylor Ford back to his senses and into the present.

Only then did he realize that at some point, without knowing it, he had risen from the couch.

This episode of Nest Dissociation Syndrome... truly wasn't mild.

His body had long since left the Nest, but his spirit still clung to the space between the Nest and the living world in fine, trailing threads, as though caught in a dream.

His father sat on the living room floor, face pale and stricken, slick with greasy sweat; his shirt was soaked through, dark patches spreading from his armpits, the outline of the undershirt beneath faintly visible.

His usually immaculate hair had collapsed entirely, drooping limply across his forehead, thinning enough to expose a high hairline. Han Ford looked years older than usual, and gazed at Taylor Ford with something like pleading, calling out softly: "...Taylor?"

Pathetic, pitiable, and yet impossible to look away from.

"That—that key, what is it?" Han Ford said quietly, in a fawning tone. "Since he wants it, just give it to him—a key doesn't matter to us, does it?"

When he was small, the Han Ford who had lectured him to eat every last grain of rice and never waste money—whenever that same man spoke in that fawning way, it made Taylor Ford feel utterly wretched, unsure whether he wanted to rage or cry.

"Children should listen to their parents more," Chase smiled soundlessly; but the next three words held no trace of that smile—low, slow, and full of menace. "Sit. Down."

Taylor Ford had to bend his knees and lower himself back onto the couch inch by inch.

The room fell into a brief, dead silence lasting several seconds.

"Why would they conscript you?" Taylor Ford suddenly felt a cold laugh rise in him, each word like a bullet. "You're not even a Hunter. What could you possibly do?"

"I can take your key," Chase said calmly. "Your father in exchange for your key—fair enough."

His tongue gave a light push against the inside of his cheek, then slid away and vanished.

Did this person think that was cool or something? Tongue-flicker.

Chase's legs remained draped across Han Ford's shoulders in what seemed like idle ease, as though he wasn't exerting any force; yet Taylor Ford knew full well that he had no chance of pulling Han Ford out from under Chase's feet by himself.

Only the key could buy his father's life.

But that wasn't the most pressing problem right now.

"...I'm young, so I have a question."

Taylor Ford crossed his arms, his oversized hoodie hanging loose around his lean frame like a loose embrace.

"Say I hand you the key—then what? Would you really let me live and keep competing with you? I can't see any way out of this alive for either of us."

"I'm not like you. I keep my word—give me the key, and I'll let Han Ford live." Chase broke into a smile and said, "As for you... there truly is no way out for you."

Taylor Ford immediately swept a glance at Han Ford.

The latter startled, his face draining another shade of white—it wouldn't be an exaggeration to say he looked as though he'd lost everything; for a moment, he seemed so panicked he even forgot his own predicament, and though he didn't dare turn his neck, he strained his eyes as far back as they would go and said: "Mr. Monroe, you mustn't act rashly—there's no grudge between our two House Factions—"

"This has nothing to do with House Factions," Taylor Ford cut him off in a low voice. "You don't need to say anything."

This was enough...

Knowing he didn't want his son to die—this was enough.

Taylor Ford studied Chase for a moment.

He suddenly exhaled and said, "All right, I understand."

Chase's hands remained folded in front of him the whole time, seemingly unarmed, but there was very likely a gun hidden at his waist, or some kind of Artifact—more likely both. Still, given his physical ability, even bare-handed, Taylor Ford couldn't claim much of an advantage.

Dying wasn't particularly extraordinary—but dying at Chase's hands would be like drowning in a toilet bowl; the funeral would be a joke in itself.

And yet he couldn't just leave Han Ford to his fate.

Seventeen years of living, always half-convinced that if he looked down, he'd find an iron shackle around his ankle; never knowing when it would rattle and clank into place.

A faint smile crossed Taylor Ford's face.

"I give you the key, you let him go. Once he's gone, if you can kill me, you're welcome to try."

"Tài Lán!"

Han Ford called out at once; having said that, he didn't know what else to say, and went blank.

A few seconds later, neck still rigid, he tried to reason with Chase: "I don't understand—is there really something that has to end with one of us dead? Take the key, and we'll bury the hatchet..."

While he rambled on, Chase had already given a small nod—it seemed he wasn't the least bit worried about whether the freed Han Ford would go and tip someone off or bring back help.

Taylor Ford stood up, walked to the door, bent down and picked up the ring of keys he'd tossed on the floor earlier, and began to work one free from the ring.

Chase raised an eyebrow.

"It's just hanging on the same ring as your house key?"

"Wrong," said Taylor Ford. "It is the house key to this apartment."

"...Oh?"

"The best place to hide a leaf is in a forest— isn't that obvious? Don't tell me you don't even know that?"

As he spoke, Taylor Ford unclipped the entry key and held it up for Chase to see, then said, as if something had just occurred to him: "Or wait—could it be that you don't even know what the target key looks like?"

Watching the other man's face remain impassive and silent, Taylor Ford gave a soft smile.

"After I obtained it, I had a lock made to fit it and had it installed on my apartment door. I knew someone would come for it sooner or later, so I prepared in advance. Needless to say, no ordinary person would ever think my front door key was the target Artifact—and even now, even if I hand it to you plain as day, you still won't trust that it's real, will you?"

"Words out of your mouth are even less credible than a Resident's. Besides, given the relationship between you and your father, my skepticism is well warranted."

Chase smiled with something approaching pity—Taylor Ford truly wanted to smash that smile off his face and drag a Nest Resident out of his mouth.

"Throw the key to me."

After his words landed, Taylor Ford still gripped the key tightly, unmoving.

...Who could feel at ease with this?

After a few seconds, it was Han Ford who cracked first, calling to him in a small voice: "Taylor..."

"I know," Taylor Ford let out a long, heavy breath.

He raised his arm and flung the key across the room—deliberately off-aim, throwing it into the air about half a meter to the side of Chase; but Chase was tall and long-limbed, and without even standing up, he merely shifted to one side and stretched out an arm, catching the key from midair.

But the moment Chase's body shifted even slightly, Han Ford twitched as though he'd been electrocuted, instantly drenched in a fresh flood of sweat.

...Which meant, it seemed, that the right foot pressed beside Han Ford's neck had never moved at all. The edge of that shoe had been pressed firmly against his skin the entire time, so

much so that Han Ford didn't even dare turn his neck.

Surely not—this wasn't some spy thriller, did someone really go that far as to put a blade in their shoe?

What a garish way to kit yourself out, Taylor Ford thought—garish, ostentatious, tasteless.

Then again, knowing about one weapon on him was better than knowing nothing at all...

Chase lowered his head and studied the key for a moment.

Taylor Ford knew exactly what he was looking at; on one side of the key, there was a small engraved inscription: "7704 days."

No hours, no minutes—the key's countdown was counted only in days—

"Why only days?" Chase did, in fact, ask exactly that.

The key turned over once between his fingers.

"How would I know," Taylor Ford yawned, not bothering to look at him. "The key's too small—no room to write more."

"...Still twenty-one years left?" Chase said this more to himself than anyone.

But Taylor Ford seized on it immediately: "What's the matter—afraid you won't outlive the key?"

The glance Chase swept up at him was like a gust of wind bursting through a narrow crack—it stung.

"Next question," he closed his fist, and the key disappeared into that large hand. "How did you come to have it?"

Taylor Ford couldn't help but want to smile bitterly.

"We're done for," he turned to Han Ford and said. "He's going to kill you."

Han Ford stared. "Huh?"

"Because what I'm about to say is the truth, and there's absolutely no way he'll believe it." Taylor Ford sighed. "As for why—men his age lack an open and receptive mind."

Chase didn't seem to find him amusing in the slightest.

Before he pushed him further toward anger, Taylor Ford spoke first: "I don't know how this key came to me."

"Run out of lies?" Chase gave a cold laugh.

"Even if you killed him right now, this is all I have to say." Taylor Ford shook his head. "Would I use something no one could believe as a lie? Only the truth makes people refuse to believe. One day I came home and the key was already sitting on the table—I picked it up and—"

He cut himself off just in time, and in that same instant, filled the gap with another sentence.

The side effects of Nest Dissociation Syndrome were truly not to be underestimated—he'd almost let it slip.

"...I realized it was very similar to the key Wellesley had acquired, and that it was likely one of the Nest's seven target items. Meeting you today finally confirmed my suspicion completely."

Today's chapter is short because I'm exhausted today—not because I'm cutting corners on your subscription! The thing is, I stay up late every night, and then in the morning I keep getting woken up by scam calls—truly burning the candle at both ends...

Today I got woken up by a YTO Express call asking what room number I was at at a hotel. I was completely confused—a hotel? I haven't stayed at that hotel in nearly half a year?

The person on the other end heard that and immediately had their answer: Got it! This is a scam package. I'll take care of it for you—I reckon it's empty anyway!

At the time I was half-asleep and didn't ask further, but thinking about it now—people are running scams with packages? How does that even work? Should I look into this (not really)?

Chapter 170: Has Taylor Ford Told Too Many Lies Before?

The downside of lying constantly is the "boy who cried wolf" effect—when you finally tell the truth, it's nearly impossible to make anyone believe you.

But someone who truly knows how to wield lies as a weapon can tell as many lies as they want and still have the ability to make people believe the next one—and one key to that is knowing when to tell the truth.

What Taylor Ford was saying right now was the truth.

"It's almost as if someone handed me the target Artifact and wanted me to win." He shrugged and said, "Who knows—maybe the Nest has a special fondness for me? Well, you definitely wouldn't understand what it feels like to be liked."

If Chase had even five grams of brain left in his skull, he should have realized that the means of acquisition wasn't the issue right now; because the same method wouldn't work a second time—the target Artifacts couldn't all be gathered in one place for someone to collect trip after trip, this wasn't a bank vault.

Chase tilted his head and thought for a few seconds.

"I believe you,"

he suddenly said, which actually startled Taylor Ford.

"You joined the game on the 15th and had the Key before the 19th. During that time, you didn't linger in the Nest for any extended period, and you didn't go off the radar—in other words, you had no time to go searching for the target Artifact. Besides, lying to me about this serves little purpose, and could easily cost you more than it's worth."

Taylor Ford could feel his own expression drop sharply, before he could control it.

He knows too much...

Information like join dates should have been written in the Nest's recruitment notice—so that was the advantage of joining later? You could obtain intelligence on the person before you? Just like he had obtained some intelligence on the Wellesley Team.

The question was...

"Surprised? Ever since you climbed to a position you don't deserve, your whereabouts have been easy to track." Chase smiled and said, "The side effect of Morgan running a Hunter House Faction like a corporation is that nobody ever stops to think on their boss's behalf."

"Congratulations, congratulations, you know everything under the sun."

Taylor Ford gave a few dry claps and jerked his chin toward his father, who was still staring blankly to the side. "Per our agreement, you should let him go now, shouldn't you?"

"Per our agreement, I'll let him go when you hand me the target Key. Not yet."

Chase set the Key down on a nearby coffee table and said, "I've had enough fun teasing the kid. Give me the real Key."

Taylor Ford glanced at the Key on the coffee table.

Chase hadn't pocketed it—normally, even if you had doubts about it, it would be safer to pocket it first and then press for answers.

But he had deliberately left the Key to the side, clearly to convey one message: I am one hundred percent certain this Key is fake.

Could slicking your hair back with oil actually help your thoughts flow more smoothly?

"Why do you say it's fake?" Taylor Ford asked.

"It seems you still don't understand your situation."

As those words landed, Chase's right foot remained firmly planted on Han Ford's shoulder, but his left foot suddenly lifted and swung sideways in a fierce kick to Han Ford's temple—the latter's head snapped to the side as if it might fly clean off his shoulders, and he let out a hoarse, strangled shriek of pain, twisting and struggling but unable to break free; when Chase set his left foot back on his shoulder, the toe of his shoe was already spattered with flecks of blood.

Even without using the shoe fitted with the blade, the blow to Han Ford's temple was like being struck with a hammer—skin split, flesh torn, blood streaming freely, leaving him gasping and groaning without stop.

...Taylor Ford felt as if something had seized the nerves behind his eyeballs, his vision contracting in pulses, the rush of blood humming in his ears.

"Do you understand a little better now?" Chase asked with near patience. "How many times do you think your father can take?"

"You won't kill him..." Taylor Ford said through gritted teeth, one word at a time. "Otherwise you'd lose the leverage you're holding over me."

"Don't worry," Chase split into a grin. "Making someone wish they were dead for a day and a night—I'm quite good at that too."

"Tai—Tài Lán..." Han Ford called out, his breathing ragged.

"Alright, alright," Taylor Ford raised both hands and said through clenched teeth, "Stop hitting him. I'll give you the real Key."

Chase just watched him without a word.

Outside the windows, the sky was gradually darkening; inside, only the LED strip along the ceiling cast a soft, diffuse warm glow. The floor lamp was off, and the room still held a faint dimness.

Taylor Ford stood up and said, "I'll go get the Key—don't get suspicious, I hid it in the kitchen."

The small open kitchen was on the other side of the living room, directly facing the sofa by the floor-to-ceiling windows, and remained under Chase's watchful gaze the entire time.

Stepping inside and sweeping a quick glance around, you could see that the kitchen had indeed been searched, but not extensively—not even thoroughly, since the contents of the drawers hadn't been dumped out.

Strange... the Key was such a small target, could you really tell just by opening a drawer and glancing in whether it was there or not?

Going by Chase's style, he would sooner tear the apartment apart.

Despite the confusion, now was not the time to dwell on it.

On the kitchen counter, a soft, pale, swollen thing had appeared—bloated and whitish, like a lump of proofing dough—with facial features vaguely resembling Han Ford's, and short, uneven limbs jutting out from its body at all angles.

A few coarse hairs poked out from the folds of the dough-lump, giving it a thoroughly unpleasant appearance.

It dragged its body along, inching and squirming toward the wall, as if trying to imitate a slug and crawl up the surface—on the wall hung a cheap decorative print bought from TJMaxx; in the

picture, a small cat was raising one paw as if to high-five someone, with the words "U'RE OKAY" printed below.

The "Han Ford dough-lump" tried several times and failed to climb up, growing so desperate that its doughy face twisted out of shape.

No one but himself should be able to see this thing... because neither Chase nor Han Ford in the living room had reacted to it at all.

The symptoms of Nest Dissociation Syndrome had not yet subsided.

Taylor Ford looked away and said, "I stuck the Key to the inside of the microwave."

Before he finished speaking, his hand had already slid off the microwave and swept across the knife block, smoothly drawing out a knife. Taylor Ford swung his arm and the blade flew from his hand, spinning toward Chase's face—at the same time, he rapidly pulled out several more knives.

Even Chase could no longer stay seated calmly on the sofa, and leaped to the side; Taylor Ford immediately shouted at his father: "Get over here, now!"

The moment the words left his mouth, he had already locked his eyes on Chase's figure and began hurling knives one after another.

Han Ford, amid a mixture of terrified cries and unintelligible broken words, frantically flattened himself and crawled across the floor with all his might toward the exit—except for his hands bound behind his back, the scene was surprisingly similar to the soft, muddy "dough-lump" on the counter.

Taylor Ford threw the last knife and lunged out of the kitchen in two strides, grabbing his father by the back of his collar, straining to drag him toward the door—but Han Ford suddenly lifted his head.

His gaze trembling, he stared into his son's eyes, opened his mouth, and let out a scream that barely sounded human.

Every drop of blood in Taylor Ford's body seemed to stop.

He raised his head, and the first thing he saw was a black plastic handle protruding from Han Ford's lower leg.

The blade was completely invisible—it had sunk entirely into the flesh of the lower leg, and the other end, pressed against bone, had pierced straight through his father's leg and into the floor.

Because the knife wasn't long enough, every tremor from Han Ford made the tip scrape against the floor with a sharp, gut-wrenching sound.

Behind Han Ford, Chase was looking down at the father and son, a slow smile spreading across his face.

The next moment, Taylor Ford felt as if a cannonball had struck him in the gut, launching him backward several steps to slam hard into the refrigerator, his vision going dark for a brief instant.

By the time his sight cleared, Han Ford had already been dragged back; Chase was now sitting on the coffee table, one foot pressing down on Han Ford's back.

He was tall and heavy, his weight bearing down on both the coffee table and Han Ford simultaneously, and for a moment you weren't sure whether to worry that the coffee table would give out first, or that Han Ford would.

Chase lowered his head, and his lighter clicked with a sharp snap, lighting a cigarette; he held it between his teeth, tilted his head back, and drew a long drag, exhaling smoke that drifted and curled softly through the air.

"...If your son keeps this up, even I'll start worrying about your life, Mr. Ford."

"Tài Lán!"

Han Ford's face was slick with sweat and tears, and he called out over and over: "Give him the Key, give him the real Key! What Key could possibly be more important than your father? Are you really going to let me die here today?"

Only then did Taylor Ford steadied his breathing. He closed his eyes briefly and said in a low voice, "I understand... I know."

"You said the same thing just now," Han Ford immediately screeched, "Don't lie to me again—just give it to him, you have to give him the real Key!"

Taylor Ford said nothing, stood up, and walked to the kitchen trash can.

The "Han Ford dough-lump" was still on the counter, trembling all over, as if it too could feel Han Ford's pain. He pretended not to see it, bent down to open the trash can, and pulled out an empty garbage bag.

"I stuck the Key to the inside wall of the trash can," Taylor Ford said, eyes cast down, his voice carrying a faint nasal edge.

This time, Chase examined the small, jet-black, flat and wafer-thin object in his hand and murmured, "...485 days, 21 hours, 12 minutes. So there is a countdown. Was the 7,704 days on the previous Key something you had engraved?"

"...Yes."

Taylor Ford knew that until the countdown ticked down to 11 minutes, Chase probably wouldn't let Han Ford go.

"Oh, it really is counting down... and it truly is an Artifact."

Chase watched the last digit flip to 11, said those few brief words, and fell into a short silence.

"You should let him go now," Taylor Ford said quietly.

Chase lowered his eyelids and glanced at Han Ford.

His face held no expression, but in that instant, the thought of "might as well kill him while I'm at it" came through clear and loud, almost like a silent broadcast that everyone in the room could hear.

After a brief hesitation, Chase lifted his foot.

The next moment, he yanked the knife out of Han Ford's lower leg with a sharp pull—a scream and sprays of blood splattered across his face; Chase squinted, flicked the knife in his hand, and sliced through the ropes binding Han Ford.

"Take care now, Mr. Ford. When you need help arranging your son's funeral, don't be shy—feel free to ask."

Han Ford couldn't manage a single word and crawled for the exit using three limbs; but Taylor Ford called out to stop him: "Wait, take my door key with you."

His father froze, glanced at the key on the coffee table, then glanced at Chase.

"No." Chase said without looking up.

"What, aren't you so confident that one isn't the real thing?" Taylor Ford immediately grew impatient and couldn't help asking with a sarcastic edge.

"Well... when he comes back with help to collect your body, he will need a key."

Chase smiled, and said to Han Ford, who had barely managed to stand and taken several steps, "Alright, come get it."

Han Ford seemed unable to process everything that had happened, unable to keep up with how things were unfolding; but since Chase had given the word, he turned back in a daze, dragging his bloodied leg, and bent down to pick up the key from the coffee table.

Chase's hand silently found his neck, and a second later Han Ford was slammed heavily to the ground—like a firecracker, he exploded in a cry of pain.

Taylor Ford's eyelid twitched sharply several times; when he spoke again, the anger and anguish in his voice were not entirely performance anymore: "What are you doing? Are you going back on your word?"

"Not at all."

Chase looked at the small black flat object and said, "I just thought of something... it is an Artifact, but is it actually a Key? It bears absolutely no resemblance to an ordinary key, so why would you have thought it was a Key in the first place? You tell too many lies—I have to keep myself guarded."

Finished unusually early today! Posting an update in the middle of the night... I don't know what to say—I remember someone once shared the advice that keeping a fixed update schedule helps retain readers, but my posting times are all over the place, like I'm actively trying to shake my readers off.

Chapter 171: Taylor Ford's One-Line Trap and the Way Out

...No. Something was off.

Taylor Ford tried to block out his father's cries of pain, gasping, and desperate pleading, focusing as hard as he could on what Chase had just said.

That speech was strange.

Of everything Chase had just said, the rest could be set aside—the single most critical point was that one line: "How did you know it was the Key?"

He had already explained that: he had noticed it was "very similar to the Key in Wellesley's hands."

Had Chase stopped believing that explanation?

Or was he simply trying to draw out more details?

Taylor Ford had a strong feeling that, in terms of thinking, he seemed to be one step behind Chase—but where exactly he had fallen behind, he couldn't figure out no matter how hard he tried.

The fog of Nest Dissociation Syndrome seemed to rise again from a corner of his mind, drifting and hazy, making his thoughts now bright, now dim.

"Won't talk? Caught on that something's wrong?"

Chase suddenly smiled and gave a slow shake of his head, almost like a teacher looking at a student who just couldn't get it. A moment ago he had seemed to be waiting for an answer; now, somehow, he had become the one who had the answer.

"Your brain's running a bit slow today. You caught on a little, but you haven't figured it all out yet."

Taylor Ford looked up blankly.

"Then let me be direct."

Chase stood up and tossed the black flat object with a flick of his wrist into the far corner of the room—the corner farthest from him—where it bounced off the floor-to-ceiling glass window and fell back down onto the floor.

Taylor Ford glanced at where it had landed.

"That Artifact wasn't something you hid in the trash can beforehand. You only pretended to pull it out when you opened the trash can just now—it was on you the whole time, wasn't it?"

Taylor Ford said nothing, but his expression must have given him away.

"Surprised I know?" Chase tilted his head. "You really aren't yourself today. Didn't I tell you clearly just now—I already searched your house and your apartment from top to bottom?"

Taylor Ford was suddenly struck—right, he had been wondering why the search had seemed so incomplete...

"Thanks to a new member on our side, I knew before I even walked through the door that within a five-kilometer radius centered on your apartment, there was exactly one Artifact. I searched the entire apartment and found nothing worth mentioning... though I did find a few guns in the bedroom."

Chase stood in the center of the apartment's living room, alone, yet somehow blocking every possible option.

...Fine. He hadn't been counting on slipping past Chase's watch to get into the bedroom and grab a gun anyway—the guns were gone, and that was that.

Taylor Ford pressed his lips together.

"And after you arrived, the Artifact count went up by one."

Chase said slowly, "The black flat piece you handed me is without question an Artifact, and it must be something you just brought through the door. I was able to take it from you without issue—I suspect it's because you wanted to give it to me. If I'd kept holding it, I'd have ended up in danger eventually, wouldn't I?"

Han Ford drew a sharp breath and looked at his son. "Is it true? Is what he said true?"

Taylor Ford just wanted to press hard on his own temples and clear some of the fog from his mind, so he could find a way to seize the advantage again.

As much as he hated to admit it, Chase was entirely right.

The black flat piece, though its name was unknown, had a function called "owner-binding": it bound to an owner only once, at the moment of capture, and could never be transferred to another owner again.

That was also why Taylor Ford was able to carry it at all—in principle, once the contract was signed, all Artifacts obtained by Morgan House Faction Hunters during a deployment belonged to Morgan House Faction, with Hunters receiving only a post-mission share; even as Hunter Director, without purchasing it outright, one held only a brief and restricted borrowing right.

The black flat piece had been captured by Taylor Ford.

Once handed to another person, after more than three minutes it would begin to slowly produce a neurotoxin capable of seeping through skin—rather than selling it off as an ordinary poison, Morgan House Faction simply went along with it and did him the favor of letting it belong to Taylor Ford.

Chase was saying slowly now: "You told me one true thing—that when you came home, the 'Key' was already sitting on the table. And the moment you saw it, you decided it was one of the seven target Artifacts. The reason you gave was 'because it looked very similar to the Key in Wellesley's hands.'"

"So what?" Taylor Ford pushed back, bracing himself.

...Chase really was an extremely difficult person to deal with.

Under the influence of Nest Dissociation Syndrome, Taylor Ford had nearly let slip the fact that his phone would ring as a notification—so he had hastily covered it with another reason: "because it looked very similar to the Key in Wellesley's hands."

On second thought, now that the lie was out there, it would be a waste not to make use of it.

He had used that excuse to set the "black flat piece trap" for Chase—but the plan had fallen apart at the last moment, and Chase had clawed his way out of it all the same.

The trap was simple enough in one sense, and yet lethal in another.

Keys in the world all look more or less alike.

If Wellesley's "Key" looked like an ordinary key, then when Taylor Ford first laid eyes on the unfamiliar key sitting on the table, he should have had no reason whatsoever to think of Wellesley—because any key in the world, when you got down to it, bore some resemblance to the "Key" in Wellesley's hands.

In other words, since Taylor Ford had been able to connect it to Wellesley's "Key" at first glance, the target "Key" must look drastically different from an ordinary key.

Once that logic clicked into place, Chase naturally wouldn't believe that the first key engraved with "7704 days" was the real one—because it looked far too much like an ordinary key.

And as it turned out, he hadn't believed it.

Everything that followed—the thrown-knife ambush, the seizing of Han Ford—was Taylor Ford's overture to getting the black flat piece into Chase's hands; naturally, if Han Ford could escape first, so much the better. The knife that had caught Han Ford in the calf was something he had not anticipated—in that instant, Taylor Ford felt as though every organ in his chest had clenched into a small block of ice.

In terms of effect, Chase had been briefly fooled; though not long enough—not enough to poison him to death.

Up to that point everything had gone smoothly—so how had Chase grown suspicious again?

"...It seems you still haven't understood what I was asking."

Chase spoke with an almost unhurried calm. "If Wellesley's 'Key' looks completely different from an ordinary key, how did you know which Artifact in his hands was the Key? The person who originally found the Key has already been silenced—it's not like Wellesley would have written you a special letter to tell you, would he?

"So either you have a very deep connection with Wellesley's side, or your reason was a lie. Which do you think is more likely?"

Taylor Ford truly wanted to sigh.

When he had set the trap, he hadn't thought it through deeply enough—and he had been somewhat rattled. Whether because of Nest Dissociation Syndrome or because of Han Ford, he couldn't say.

In the past, even a slight lapse hadn't led to any serious consequence, because most people's minds couldn't keep up with his.

But with Chase, it was different—even the smallest hesitation or oversight could be caught, turned, and used against him.

"Since your reason was false, the black flat Artifact you went to all that trouble to put in my hands is definitely not something benign."

Chase reached behind his back with one hand and drew a pistol, aiming it at Han Ford.

"So let me ask you again. How did you confirm what the 'Key' was?"

He truly was like a hunting dog, always the first to catch the scent of blood on the wind—even when that blood wasn't from his original target.

"All right, I understand," Taylor Ford buried his face in both hands, then dragged them heavily back over his head. "I'll talk. You don't need to bluff."

Chase's response was to click off the safety.

"Twenty-four hours after obtaining a target Artifact, you receive a phone notification congratulating you on having secured the target."

Taylor Ford said with a sigh, "Like the Amber Alert, it doesn't stay in your message center—you can take it or leave it. Along with the congratulations, the notification says that the next competing participant will be able to see my possession information... who could have guessed the next one would be you?"

Chase was silent for a few seconds, then clicked the safety back on. Han Ford let out a long breath, looking like he was about to cry.

On the kitchen counter, the "Han Ford dough" was still clambering up the wall one lurch at a time, then falling back down.

"Why twenty-four hours?" Chase asked suddenly.

Out of a long stretch of truth, he had zeroed in immediately on the one false note and pressed it...

Taylor Ford would honestly rather Chase just beat the information out of him than use his brain like this.

If he relied on brute force alone, Chase would already be a corpse by now.

"That point was also explained in the notification."

He answered smoothly as ever: "You have to hold a target Artifact for twenty-four hours before ownership can be confirmed. Which makes sense—otherwise, if someone merely touched a target Artifact without actually securing it, anyone who went looking for them afterward would be chasing nothing."

Chase glanced at the key on the table engraved with "7704 days."

Taylor Ford already knew what he was about to say, and got there first: "Your earlier reasoning had one flaw. The black flat piece is the Artifact I left inside the house, and the 'Key' is the Artifact I brought in just now."

He was taking a calculated risk—the new member under Chase who could detect Artifacts was almost certainly Kingsley Roselyn; her detection range was vast but imprecise, and she couldn't pinpoint whether there was an Artifact stuck to the trash can inside a small apartment.

"Is it the one on the table?"

"No, the real 'Key' is in the backpack." Taylor Ford kept his expression relaxed, though the muscles along his back had been slowly tightening. "I'll go get it—don't jump to conclusions. There are no weapons in my bag."

Chase let out a low hum through his nose—something between mockery and a cold laugh.

"Don't move." He turned the gun in a different direction. "Your father can go."

Han Ford froze. On the kitchen counter, the "Han Ford dough" immediately went still.

"Chase, what—what do you mean?" Han Ford asked, his breath trembling.

Did he even need to ask?

Regardless of whether Chase believed what Taylor Ford had just said, the scope of where the "Key" could be had already narrowed—narrowed to the point where there was no need to keep Taylor Ford alive any longer.

"Dad," Taylor Ford said quietly, eyes fixed on Chase. "Leave now. Go get help."

Chase's expression didn't change at all at the words "go get help"—he looked completely unbothered, as though he wasn't worried in the slightest. But he did spare a warning for Han Ford, who was limping toward the door: "Don't touch the backpack."

Catching that thin sliver of a gap when Chase's attention shifted to Han Ford, Taylor Ford moved.

...Even if it meant throwing himself against a wall, he had no other choice—he had to ram open a way out with his own body.

And besides, among all the Hunters in history, perhaps only a handful knew one rare piece of intelligence—

When Nest Dissociation Syndrome progressed to a certain degree of severity, it could become a weapon.

I like packing information into my chapters.

For example, in a 3,000-character chapter, I might load in five information points—A, B, C, D, E—plus two foreshadowing threads, F and G. I can't promise it's always riveting, but the substance is there.

So since you've already paid to subscribe, it might be worth reading a little more carefully—otherwise, if there are five information points and you miss three and only catch B and E, isn't that basically throwing money away?

The result is you're unhappy, I'm unhappy, and honestly that subscription money would have been better spent on a skewer of grilled meat.

If F and G leave you puzzled, that's completely normal—once I finish this arc, if you're still puzzled, feel free to discuss.

For example, in the last chapter, Taylor Ford set a trap, Chase saw through it, and the two of them were sparring in the shadows without ever bringing it into the open. I hope this new chapter made the trap clear enough (I was a bit worried that Taylor Ford's talent for deception might leave readers confused).

When I was writing Domsday before, I was always troubled by this feeling that what I wrote and what many readers saw were not the same thing.

Once I saw someone post a rant about how a certain plot point made no sense, and I read it carefully only to find—I had never written that plot point at all.....

Why does this happen?? I've always been puzzled by it.

Chapter 172: Has Taylor Ford's Key Actually Been Counting Down All Along?

The punch Chase drove into his back knocked the vision clean out of Taylor Ford.

Every bit of breath was squeezed out of him; bones, organs—it wouldn't have been surprising if any of them had shattered. With that single blow from Chase, his own body and the world around him became a sheet of total darkness.

In that total darkness, Taylor Ford had only one thought, sharper and stronger than even panic.

The gun.

He had to knock him over. He had to take the gun.

For most people, Chase was the entrance to a dead end; but Taylor Ford had no choice but to throw himself at that dead end with everything he had, if he wanted to wring life from death.

In a dim haze, he thought he heard his father call out "Tai Lan!"—that guy was still there, did he have no read on the situation at all—the thought flickered past, and the next second, his shoulder and body slammed into what felt like a slab of reinforced concrete.

Was this a human body? Even the body temperature was so low it felt like an illusion.

"Get out of here!" Taylor Ford roared—at Han Ford, of course.

He had thrown every ounce of his strength into that charge and still taken a punch, barely managing to crash into Chase—yet Chase only stumbled back a single step before steadying himself again.

Before Taylor Ford could curse his luck, Chase had already grabbed him by the hoodie's hood; he treated Taylor Ford like a leech stuck to his body—one peel, one fling, and with a heavy, crushing force, he hurled Taylor Ford sideways through the air.

Heaven and earth flipped; the coffee table rushed up to meet him, growing larger and larger in his vision—

He thrust both hands against the coffee table, rolled half a turn, hit the floor, grabbed the table and shoved it hard—the table shot straight into Chase's shins.

If that were enough to knock him over, he wouldn't be Chase.

Chase leapt up onto the coffee table at just the right moment, looming from above, the dark muzzle of the gun in his hand already trained on Taylor Ford—at this distance, the two of them were barely a hand's breadth apart; there was no time left to dodge or resist.

Taylor Ford simply stopped moving and fixed his eyes on the muzzle.

Or rather, he fixed them on the air in front of the muzzle—which isn't easy to picture, since air is invisible.

But when Nest Dissociation Syndrome grew severe enough, the harder you tried to focus on something, the more it dissolved into a cloudy haze; as Taylor Ford concentrated, a gray-white mist began to billow and rise in the air before him—a mist only he could see.

Beyond that drift of mist, the gun muzzle was a faint, indistinct shape; and then Chase pulled the trigger.

With a thundering gunshot, the muzzle flash lit the gray mist bright for an instant, the haze flickering between light and dark in a murky tangle.

...Now.

Taylor Ford launched himself upward, sweeping his arm across the coffee table, and seized the key—which had not slid off—the one engraved with "7704 Days." Gripping it like a blade, he drove it hard into Chase's shin.

Though his combat skills were no match for Chase's, Taylor Ford's strength and speed were nothing to dismiss.

Catching Chase off guard and too slow to dodge, the tip of the key sank deep into his leg, and Taylor Ford yanked hard—fabric and skin tore open together, and droplets of blood burst and scattered into the gray-misted air before him, never falling back down.

Chase drew a low, sharp hiss of pain. Even without looking up at his face, his shock and disbelief were nearly as unmistakable as the gunshot.

Surprised, weren't you, giant?

Didn't expect that putting a bullet aimed at my forehead would do absolutely nothing, did you?

The pain finally jolted Chase into motion; he stepped back off the coffee table, swinging a kick at Taylor Ford with his other leg—but this time, Taylor Ford was ready, and he twisted aside, the wind from the shoe slicing through the air and brushing past his ear.

"Where did the bullet go?" Chase couldn't hold back in the end. "Where did it go?"

"Up your ass."

Taylor Ford absolutely had to say that. He would have burst if he hadn't.

The truth was, driving this body into action right now was no easy feat; under the influence of Nest Dissociation Syndrome, his limbs felt as though they were drifting loose from him, floating away.

Talking back and forcing his scattered body parts to pull together at the same time, he was just getting to his feet when, from the corner of his eye, he noticed that the "Han Ford Dough Figure" had somehow half-crawled, half-walked its way to the middle of the living room.

He froze for a moment, then snapped his head around.

"Han Ford!"

Taylor Ford looked up to find his father still standing in the entryway, and roared: "If you don't leave now, what exactly are you planning to do by staying?"

"But... but..."

The "Han Ford Dough Figure" suddenly twisted its face toward Chase's direction and let out a small, sharp cry.

Hm?

Could a hallucination of his own making also serve as a warning? Was it because his subconscious had detected that Chase was making a move?

The thought flashed through Taylor Ford's mind at the same moment he smoothly rolled to the side, diving toward the center of the living room and escaping the gun muzzle trained on his back, calling out to Han Ford: "Grab the bag and go!"

That shout nailed Chase's movement in place for just a beat.

"Don't touch that bag," he raised the gun toward Han Ford, still standing on the coffee table. "This is your last chance to leave. Three—"

Chase's countdown, even with only a single number, was worth more than all ten things Taylor Ford had just said.

Han Ford dragged his injured leg and lunged for the door; at the same moment, Taylor Ford had already thrown himself at Chase on the coffee table, swiping at the gun with a backhanded grab.

Chase didn't even turn his head—as though he'd anticipated it—and gave a slight twist of his body, elbow swinging up through the air to slam down hard toward Taylor Ford's face. In that instant, Taylor Ford barely managed to accomplish two things.

The first was, of course, protecting his face. What a joke—did anyone think this face was something just anyone could easily grow? If it got smashed up, what would he have left to show the world?

Chase was clearly just jealous. The jealousy of men was truly ugly.

The second thing: even while dodging, Taylor Ford kept his eyes locked on his own hand.

Through the swirling haze, he could still faintly make out his hand; it didn't disappear, it was simply soaked in the gray mist, as though it had come slightly unmoored from his body, floating adrift on some distant shore—the distance between him and it feeling far greater than the length of his arm.

Which meant that places he couldn't ordinarily reach could now barely be reached.

Of course, it didn't feel like seizing a gun with his hand—it was more like flying a kite, and snagging the gun with the kite's tail.

It sounds like a long process, but in that instant it was a flash of lightning; even Chase likely hadn't seen clearly exactly how Taylor Ford had suddenly stretched his hand by half an arm's length and grabbed the barrel—Chase gripped the handle tight, Taylor Ford refused to yield; as the two struggled, the gun went off accidentally, a rapid "da-da-da" of thundering shots that punched a string of bullet holes through the coffee table, the floor, and the TV screen.

Too bad none of them hit Chase.

If only the mist could envelop Chase too, making him vanish completely into the gap between the Nest and the human world, just like the bullets—that would be so convenient...

But for people without Nest Dissociation Syndrome, without a passage, that gap seemed not to exist at all; no matter how long Taylor Ford's eyes told him they were soaking in the mist, it never affected them in the slightest.

Chase's strength ultimately had the upper hand; even with Taylor Ford straining every bit of energy he had, the gun muzzle was still slowly, inch by inch, swinging toward his face.

He had to keep his eyes on the muzzle—

The thought had barely formed when Chase suddenly freed one hand and drove an uppercut into Taylor Ford's jaw.

In that moment, the world blurred, and he almost thought he could smell the scent of teeth and skull grinding to powder and drifting everywhere—something like calcium and lime.

His head was knocked back involuntarily, his gaze naturally leaving the muzzle.

So Chase had figured it out—when he kept his eyes on the muzzle, the bullets would disappear?

...Was he going to die?

The next instant, the gun fired; the bullet carved a tunnel through the air, its endpoint his throat.

Yet the blankness and release Taylor Ford had imagined would come when a bullet struck him never arrived.

There was only Chase's irritating voice, letting out a low, unhurried "Hm?"

What?

Taylor Ford looked down and happened to see the "Han Ford Dough Figure" slide off his collarbone and splat onto the floor, its uneven limbs wobbling a few times before it righted itself and crawled away.

Chase paid it no attention whatsoever, glancing around and saying, "The bullet disappeared again?"

Wait.

Hallucinations produced by Nest Dissociation Syndrome... weren't just hallucinations? They were the same thing as the mist? Also a "gap"?

No, this wasn't the time for analysis—

Taking advantage of Chase's momentary distraction, Taylor Ford finally wrenched the handgun away, stumbled back several steps, and couldn't quite believe it, scanning the gun over a few more times.

He'd really taken it? This was a real gun?

"You have a bulletproof Artifact?" Chase seemed to think he'd already figured it out and frowned. "Could it be that you don't have the Key on you at all?"

His doubt made perfect sense: with Kingsley Roselyn, he knew exactly how many Artifacts were within this area—the total was fixed, so if Taylor Ford had an extra bulletproof Artifact on him, then naturally there would be no Key.

"Go tell it to the maggots," Taylor Ford said, and couldn't help but smile, raising the muzzle at him.

...Was heaven maybe just a little too fond of Chase?

The tiny fraction of a second it took to pull the trigger was somehow enough for Chase to successfully hurl himself out of the way and dodge the bullet—was that even reasonable?

The bullet missed its target and continued straight ahead, hitting the entire floor-to-ceiling window; the glass shattered in midair into a cascading silver rain that fell straight down through the rising night sky outside, sending a wave of distant screams rippling up from the street below.

Wind, car horns, the shouts of people—all of it poured into the small apartment at once—

"Gunfire, someone's shooting in that building!" Blackmoor City residents were well acquainted with shootings and identified it in an instant: "Call the police!"

Chase seemed to forget his wariness of the bullets entirely; he came straight at Taylor Ford like a fired cannonball, throwing a fist at his face.

If that punch connected, it was all over—better to just bend his knees and drop flat on his back—which was exactly what Taylor Ford did.

With a clang, something else hit the floor along with him: a key.

Taylor Ford had no time to look; he rolled aside, Chase's fist already smashing into the floor behind where he'd been; he scrambled to his feet and trained the muzzle on Chase, squeezing the trigger in a rush.

...Empty.

How was that possible? There were definitely more shots left—

Chase turned to look at him and laughed. "Counting bullets won't help you. Did you think I brought a fully loaded gun?"

Taylor Ford was too furious to get a single word out; he raised his arm and flung the gun at the floor, then stepped back in large strides. Chase ignored him entirely, and instead picked up the key from the ground.

He held the key up, glanced at it, then looked at Taylor Ford.

Across half the apartment living room, the engraved line on the key—"7703 Days"—glinted faintly in the light.

These past few days while writing the main chapters, I keep catching myself wanting to fast-forward to when the real Key finally appears—

But I don't have a face made for spoilers.

Speaking of which, I'm very sensitive to writing style in web novels. I don't need the prose to be beautiful—I just need it to read smoothly and have correct punctuation; otherwise, no matter how good the plot is, I find it very hard to get through. That said, I also can't stand that style on certain competing platforms where every other line makes you jolt in discomfort.

I remember as a kid I wasn't nearly this picky—I could read anything, and I didn't even have much of a reaction to misogynistic novels, reading them with relish... Looking back now, there was a female lead named Loli, and she was exactly what her name implied. Good lord, I want to go on Alibaba and buy an electric chair.

Chapter 173: Dual-Perspective View — Casualties Already Decided?

If he hadn't met Taylor Ford, Chase might have gone on mistakenly believing he had a fondness for children.

Though he'd already steeled himself mentally, Taylor Ford was still harder to kill than he'd anticipated.

The odds of successfully killing him showed no sign of improving, yet the desire to kill him blazed hotter than ever, like oil poured on fire—Chase had met people who were crafty and good at lying, but someone with sixty-odd rabbit holes to bolt into, endlessly inventive and slippery as an eel, had entered an entirely different category; it made him so infuriated he wanted to blow Taylor Ford and the entire building into ash.

Take the Key in his hand, for instance—who was to say Taylor Ford hadn't made two copies at the time, one engraved with "7,704 days" and one with "7,703 days"?

Putting on a show by producing one first, then pocketing it while the moment allowed, then letting the second one drop—making everyone think the fake Key was counting down.

That was the first possibility.

There was also a second: one of the two was the real Key, and Taylor Ford had used its count to make several fakes.

If the real Key was counting down to 7,703, he'd first produce one marked 7,704; or if the real Key was at 7,704, he'd drop the 7,703—and once it reached 7,703, he'd still have a 7,702 waiting.

He was like a rabbit warren with layer upon layer of tunnels; when dealing with him, a person couldn't even tell whether they'd fallen in, let alone how many levels deep they'd gone.

Judging from the sudden appearance of an extra bulletproof Artifact, since the total count was off, it seemed as though there was no true "Key" in this apartment at all—if the opponent were an ordinary Hunter, logic taken this far would be enough to call it settled, a conclusion reached.

But the opponent was Taylor Ford.

Taylor Ford's greatest skill was using fragments of truth and lies to conjure a dazzling kaleidoscope; once you fell into it, you were trapped in a mirror maze, with no idea where the exit

was.

He couldn't possibly have no other tricks—was there an Artifact concealing the existence of another Artifact? Or could it be that the target Key wasn't an Artifact at all?

Chase had originally been certain the Key was somewhere in the apartment, certain he could kill Taylor Ford—but now, incredibly, he wasn't sure anymore.

No. He shouldn't let Taylor Ford lead him astray.

Even if he couldn't get the Key today, killing Taylor Ford alone would be progress.

Chase hesitated for a moment, then still left the Key engraved with "7,703 days" on top of the TV cabinet.

While those thoughts were turning in his mind, Taylor Ford had retreated into the corner by the floor-to-ceiling window—what had been a floor-to-ceiling window was now a gaping hole through which the night and cool wind poured endlessly in, jagged shards of glass jutting up like broken teeth along its edges.

Why run to the window? Wasn't that a dead end with nowhere to hide?

The humanoid chicken-bone figure immediately gave him his answer; Taylor Ford crouched beside the window, keeping his eyes fixed on Chase without daring to look away, and called out at the top of his lungs: "Help! Someone's attacking me!"

...Did he have even a shred of dignity as a Hunter?

"His name is Cha—"

The word "se" hadn't even left his mouth when the blood-red cleaver—the one that had just been used to stab through Han Ford's calf—flew straight at Taylor Ford's face; his reaction wasn't slow, he wrenched his head hard to the side, the blade grazed the tip of his nose and skimmed past, tumbling out into the night below the window.

From the street below came a ripple of commotion and the faint, blurred sound of screams; fragments of the voices startled up by the falling blade were carried in by the wind.

"There's someone up by that window... what if they fall... call the fire department, it's dangerous..."

At ten floors up, you couldn't make out anything unless someone shouted; even the occasional clearer words seemed to drift over from neighboring buildings.

Right now, the second drawer of the TV cabinet beside Chase held a gun—but it was useless to him.

It was one of the weapons he had hidden in various corners of the apartment after searching the place. Knowing Taylor Ford would be difficult to kill, he had prepared these backup measures—but he hadn't expected the bullets to stop working entirely; pulling the gun out now would only add another layer of risk without getting him any closer to killing Taylor Ford.

He had originally believed Taylor Ford's gaze was making the bullets disappear, but even after nearly shattering the man's jaw, the bullets had still vanished without any line of sight involved.

That was something he could think over afterward.

Being able to make bullets disappear while being unable to make himself disappear just meant a slower, more painful way to die.

"Do you prefer being beaten to death blow by blow over a clean death from a bullet?"

Chase snatched up a knife from the floor—the one Taylor Ford had just thrown at him—and had already run through his next move in his mind: one long kick to bring the target down, the knife to follow immediately into the back of the neck, ending every future trouble in tonight.

He didn't even trust kicking Taylor Ford out the window; he had to watch Taylor Ford's vital signs go still beneath his own hands.

Taylor Ford seemed to sense the danger, his body going taut as he pressed against the window frame and stood, sweeping his gaze around as though searching for a weapon.

Chase gripped the knife and had just taken one step forward when, in the darkness exposed beyond the shattered window, a flash of white light suddenly blazed.

He immediately stopped.

He'd almost forgotten.

Luck was small, but it came at the right moment—fortunately someone had just lit a camera flash below, which reminded him in time.

Chase had no use for wasting time on his phone, but it wasn't hard for him to imagine that down on the street below, in the nearby apartment buildings, from the neighbors' windows across

several floors—people had probably already raised phone after phone toward Taylor Ford's apartment: some snapping photos, some recording video, and quite possibly some livestreaming...

Standing inside the room was one thing, but if he attacked Taylor Ford in front of the window, his face would be captured by who knew how many phone cameras.

If Taylor Ford was using this move to buy time, Chase still had no choice but to give him that time—Chase cursed under his breath and pulled from his coat pocket a remote control the length of his index finger.

The instant Chase raised the remote control toward his own throat, a fleeting, hard-to-name expression crossed Taylor Ford's face—something like exhaustion, something like a bitter smile, something like a man about to burn his bridges.

...He was going to make a move too.

As the thought rose, Chase pressed the "replace" button on the remote.

If anyone was watching through a phone camera at that moment, they would have seen a massive goat head wrapped in a black robe pull back the remote with one hand, then lunge toward the young man by the window in long strides; and at the same time, the young man neither dodged nor yielded—he lowered his body and drove himself straight into the goat head's chest.

Even if it were a splinter of wood rather than a sharp knife, with Chase's strength, he could still drive it into a person's flesh.

The moment the two collided, Taylor Ford's flesh offered almost no resistance.

Skin, muscle—layer after layer split apart beneath the knife's tip, tore open, sending a spray of blood misting outward, staining the light and the air red.

No matter how much he despised Taylor Ford, once he truly moved to act, Chase had long since cast aside all emotion; his mind was windless and still, like a quiet lake's surface, reflecting every detail of that single instant.

At the very last moment, Taylor Ford twisted his body slightly, deflecting away from the vital organs, and met the blade with his back and shoulder instead.

Chase knew Taylor Ford wasn't dead yet; he also knew Taylor Ford's other hand had weakly looped around his left shoulder, cool fingers pressed against the collar.

Chase's right hand gave a sharp jerk and pull, and amid Taylor Ford's hoarse, strangled cry, he wrenched the knife free from where it had been wedged between bone and muscle; he raised the knife again, this time finding the back of Taylor Ford's neck.

In the darkness beyond the shattered window, one after another window flew open in the surrounding buildings, and countless distant camera flashes blinked on and off; one moment lighting stray sparks of reflection on the broken glass and the knife's edge, the next plunging all the struggling and bloodshed into a heavy, sinking dark.

It was as though this were a blood-soaked red carpet, and the world was waiting to see which performer could walk it to the end.

The knife's tip sank into the back of Taylor Ford's neck.

Just one fraction of an inch more—enough to snap the cervical bone—and there would be no more Taylor Ford in this world; most likely Taylor Ford himself, when it came to the matter of death, didn't have much resistance to it.

But Chase couldn't summon that final fraction of force.

His vision flickered and blurred.

In the seventeen years since he was born, he had never hurt like this.

The knife hadn't gone deep—it hadn't fully penetrated the back of his neck—and as Chase lost his strength, it clanged back to the floor.

The wound across half of Taylor Ford's body felt as though alcohol had been poured over it and set alight; he felt as if both his body and soul had become a sheet of paper burning in the fire, curling and warping, perhaps never able to return to their original shape.

Cold sweat, confusion, terror—and he was probably crying out in pain without even realizing it...

Beyond all that dazed, chaotic agony, something heavy thudded to the floor nearby; the vibration through the floorboards was what pulled Taylor Ford slightly back to his senses.

He turned his head, and through a hazy, unfocused field of vision, confirmed that it was indeed Chase.

Though Chase had fallen, he hadn't lost consciousness as Taylor Ford had expected—he was still fighting against whatever was invading him.

Taylor Ford gasped for breath and fumbled across the floor, but couldn't find the black flat piece—it had probably fallen somewhere when Chase went down, leaving his skin.

He had endured a stab that nearly killed him, forcing himself to rush forward and wrap his arms around Chase, precisely so he could quietly press the black flat piece against the skin inside Chase's collar.

The time Chase had held it—even less than three minutes—had been close enough; when the black flat piece was pressed against him again, it should have begun to take on neurotoxic properties—the reason Taylor Ford had fled to the floor-to-ceiling window was specifically to find a chance to pick it up.

This plan, if it had been the Taylor Ford of ordinary times, would have been discarded immediately: he had never used the black flat piece before—who knew whether the neurotoxin could penetrate and take effect at once? Who knew how potent the toxin's effects were?

Too many unknowns, too much risk, and on top of that, putting his own body and life on the line, enduring pain?

But facing Chase, his usual tricks—clever schemes, traps, rigged deceptions—all seemed to slam into walls one after another, producing no effect.

Without trading his own flesh and blood for it, he couldn't buy Chase's death.

Taylor Ford trembled as he seized the knife, dragged his body forward, and forced himself through the pain still curling through him like paper in flames, crawling inch by inch toward Chase, who lay not far away.

The neurotoxin's effect was strong—but not strong enough.

Chase was on his knees, his back arched, something deep in his body seeming to convulse over and over, surging toward his mouth; all his strength seemed to have converted into the force of his body's spasms, and this was probably the first time he had been so completely out of control—he couldn't even manage to push himself upright.

But he was still alive.

A man who fought like a rampaging bull—let him retch on the floor for a while, and he might just recover.

Taylor Ford was anxious, but every movement still sent the world spinning around him.

Lifting the knife to kill someone was, in reality, impossible—one arm seemed to have already died in his place, hanging heavy and dead at his side, unable to be raised. The other hand was trembling even when he made no effort to move it.

Besides, killing him with his own hands might bring complications later—this was Blackmoor City, after all.

But...

Taylor Ford looked up at the floor-to-ceiling window with every pane of glass shattered, then looked at Chase.

Even speaking was difficult now; his mouth was full of the taste of rust.

He gripped the knife and made his way in front of Chase, breathing hard as he said: "...Now it's my turn to give you a knife back."

After saying that, he waited—but found that Chase seemed to have been so poisoned that his mind was clouded, and Taylor Ford's voice was too faint and feeble; he apparently hadn't heard.

"Now!" Taylor Ford strained to raise his voice, desperate to make him pay attention: "It's my turn to give you a knife back!"

The dazed Chase—whether he finally heard or caught sight of the knife—fell back weakly on his hands and feet; Taylor Ford followed close, driving the knife into the floorboards, but still leaving him just enough of a gap to stagger and tumble backward—

Chase fell from the tenth floor.

From below the window outside came a wave of cries.

I've slept less than eight hours over the past two days, and I'm still managing to update—everyone should read more while you can, because who knows how much longer I'll last.

Chapter 174: Taylor Ford's True Key and a Father-Son Moment

A faint, washed-out red light rippled across the ceiling, like blood diluted by water.

Consciousness dissolved into black fog, nearly blotting out his vision. Taylor Ford blinked slowly twice before his mind finally connected the visual signal to its meaning.

That was... a fire truck's lights.

He opened his eyes, and this time held them open. The longer he listened, the more ominous the sounds outside the window seemed... surely not?

"You can let go now!" someone outside the window called out, muffled and indistinct.

Let go of what? Why?

Taylor Ford dragged a body that felt like it no longer belonged to him over to the window and looked down.

...Should he call it expected yet surprising? Chase really did have remarkable luck.

Or should he say that fate was a strange thing, thoroughly steeped in irony?

The thought that followed, in Taylor Ford's hazy consciousness, was doubly absurd:

If he hadn't been planning to kill Chase with the black flat piece, Taylor Ford wouldn't have been able to save Chase's life.

It was precisely because, not long before, Taylor Ford had stood at the window looking as though he had nowhere to go, swaying on the edge, calling out for help—that passersby below had called the fire department, and the firefighters had set up a large square air mattress on the ground below.

It seemed that even with a clouded mind, Chase had managed to grab the outward-opening window on the seventh floor just in time as he fell—he had tumbled out through the floor-to-ceiling window rather than jumped from the roof, so the neighboring window below was within arm's reach.

When Taylor Ford peered down, he caught a glimpse of Chase, who had just let go, dropping straight down and landing in the air mattress with a heavy thud, sending the left side dipping low and the right side lurching up, the whole thing swaying and shuddering.

The crowd of onlookers seemed to cheer a few times; then someone seemed to say, "Why... goat head..."

Taylor Ford dearly wanted to heave a long sigh, but sighing took too much effort. Before the passersby below noticed him, he slowly retreated into the living room and lay flat on his back amid the wreckage of the floor.

He had no energy left for regret—he could only lie there in a kind of numbness, feeling his body heat being steadily carried away by the blood flowing out of him. For every inch the blood receded, another inch of him froze solid.

Chase probably rarely got the worse end of a deal this badly.

Taylor Ford smiled, faint and distant.

He had failed to kill his target, gotten himself poisoned, and fallen from a building; even after treatment and recovery, he would still have to deal with a string of police inquiries and other headaches.

And the most critical key—Chase hadn't even come close to touching it.

It wasn't the key engraved with "7704 days," nor the one engraved with "7703 days," and it certainly wasn't in Taylor Ford's backpack.

The true target key had been in this apartment from the very beginning—the one and only Artifact that Kingsley Roselyn had detected.

It sat in plain sight, in a place Chase's eyes had swept past who knew how many times.

The "Han Ford dough figure" slowly crawled over to his side, craning its neck to peer at him, as though studying Taylor Ford's injuries and calculating his odds of survival.

Given that you saved my life, I'll forgive you for it... Taylor Ford thought, dimly.

This hallucination that looked like Han Ford also had Han Ford's temperament: seeing no way out of Chase's grasp, it had immediately wanted to raise its hands and surrender, handing over the key like a good little thing—and when Taylor Ford refused to offer it up himself, it had even tried to do it on his behalf.

That was why it had been hopping up and down, trying to climb up the kitchen wall...

Because the key was on the wall.

Taylor Ford slowly blinked once in the direction of the kitchen; he still couldn't make out the blur. But knowing the key was still there was enough.

Chase really was thorough... even after seeing through the black flat piece, he'd kept his composure, probing and waiting at the same time...

Was it because somewhere in his subconscious, he had sensed it too?

Between "looks like a key" and "doesn't look like a key," there was actually a gray zone in between.

The more information Taylor Ford gave—whether lies or truth—the harder that gray zone became to hide in.

The true answer lay somewhere in that gray zone.

The "target key" bore no resemblance whatsoever to an ordinary key in appearance, yet anyone who laid eyes on it would immediately think of a key.

Taylor Ford had almost no experience with crafts; the result of his own handiwork surprised him as much as it satisfied him.

The day he received the key, he had already worked out how to hide it.

First, he had the apartment key copied several times, then had a series of numbers engraved on them—from 7702 to 7704; after that, he made a trip to a store and picked out a decorative painting at TJ Maxx.

Not because he liked the painting—though the little cat was admittedly quite cute—but because just below the painting, there happened to be a blank space.

The metal letters and adhesive he ordered from Amazon arrived the next day; Taylor Ford took the painting out, spread it on the table, picked out a "U," held a ruler against it, and carefully pressed it onto the blank space below the little cat.

The letters "U" and "R" he had bought were applied as well.

Next, Taylor Ford took out the true target key, selected the letter "E" from within it, and connected it after "U'R" to form the phrase "U'RE."

...Yes, the target key was, in fact, three black metal letters.

They could be separated or joined together to spell "KEY."

They bore no resemblance to a key whatsoever, yet if they suddenly appeared one day on the coffee table at home, never mind Taylor Ford—anyone would have instantly thought of a key.

He took out the "O" he had bought from Amazon, pressed it in place, then joined the "K" from the key to it.

And so the target key "KEY" was broken apart and hidden within the phrase "U'RE OKAY." Once the adhesive dried, he carefully fitted the target key back into the picture frame along with the little cat image and hung it on the wall.

...Chase had probably never taken such a bad loss in his entire life.

Not only had he failed at the last moment and brought trouble on himself, but it was also because while he was poisoned, curled on the floor, heaving dry retches, Taylor Ford had seen it.

His cheek bulged outward, pushed up from within by a tongue.

In a moment of confusion and mortal danger, no matter how insufferable Chase was, putting on a show was out of the question—so there was only one explanation for that bulge in his cheek, wasn't there?

Taylor Ford tilted his head slightly; through the haze and fog, he made out Han Ford's face, looking down at him from nearby.

"You... you're back?" He wasn't sure whether he'd spoken aloud or not. "Did you go get someone?"

Han Ford kept looking down at him, silent.

There was no telling whether he had or hadn't.

Taylor Ford lay there in a daze for a while, then suddenly jolted awake and said to his father, "Oh right, Dad... when I went into the Nest this time, I saw Mom."

The blurred face of Han Ford seemed to shift slightly. When his mouth opened to speak, a few strands of something seemed to tremble: "All these years, she's been in the Nest?"

"Mm... no, not exactly. It was a parallel reality... a parallel reality that had Mom in it."

"Child, you don't even know what she looks like."

"I know... but I just felt it—that was Mom, I couldn't be wrong. Such a shame... Mom's photos have all gone blank since then..."

Han Ford fell silent again.

After some unknown stretch of time, Taylor Ford said quietly, "Dad..."

"Mm, I'm here."

"Will you stay?"

Han Ford paused. "Do you want me to stay?"

Taylor Ford thought for a moment. "I don't know... I think it would feel very reassuring, but also very painful. Sometimes I think it would be better if you were dead, yet I'm also afraid of you dying."

He knew he should keep the Domination Game as secret as possible, but saying it now seemed fine enough.

"But... maybe I've finally found a way to set everyone free..."

If Artifacts had post-story bonus skits like manga do, it should go something like this:

Uncle Key lay in his hospital bed, mulling over who had struck against Key House Faction and what to do next, what he should have Chase do—then he turned his head and found Chase being wheeled in, settling into the bed beside him.

PS: Yesterday I complained offhandedly and worried you all! You're truly so kind—honestly, I feel like even my mom doesn't worry about me the way you do...

I feel terrible about it; I shouldn't have said it in such a scary way. I'm fine—insomnia is an old problem of mine, and a lot of remedies just don't work. Thankfully it comes and goes, so all I can do is wait for it to ease up on its own. Just have to push through it.

Also, to those telling me to stop updating and rest—that's basically a wish web novel authors wouldn't dare make even when lighting incense at a temple...

Chapter 175: Sydney Ginn and June Act Together

In a haze of drowsiness, Sydney Ginn was vaguely aware that she was lying in her own bed at home, the bedroom dim, hovering between sleep and waking.

Every time she came back from the Nest, she would sleep until the world turned upside down.

It wasn't just that she couldn't sleep properly inside the Nest and had accumulated a sleep debt; it was also that the kind of exhaustion she felt wasn't something an ordinary person could normally comprehend—how to describe it?

It was as though after dying, one's soul still wandered the earth without rest, crossing mountains and rivers for a hundred years, then came back to life as a person again, carrying all a hundred years' worth of fatigue.

Her body seemed to know, too, that a trip to the Nest was not a normal experience any person should have. Like deep-water diving—doable, but the human body wasn't built for it; to fight off and recover from the Nest's effects, the brain would crave an abnormally enormous amount of sleep.

What's more, she hadn't even had time to properly rest from the last trip before she'd gone into the Nest again with June, so Sydney Ginn had already thought, as she climbed into bed, that sleeping three or four days straight this time wouldn't be surprising.

How long had she been asleep? she wondered hazily.

"...More than a day," a voice beside her answered.

Oh, that long already. So today should be...

"It's November 21st now. Nine o'clock sharp in the evening."

Shouldn't she get up and eat something? Sydney Ginn rolled over in bed, burying her face in the silk pillow; sleep still hung over her like the dark of night, not letting in a single ray of light.

"Did you know? The Blackmoor City Hunter London Moon has quite a few devoted fans."

Hmph. London Moon.

"There's an Artifact channel on Reddit—it doesn't get much traffic since not many Hunters use it—and it's practically turned into a fan page exclusively for London Moon."

...Wait.

She was alone at home, asleep. Who was speaking?

Sydney Ginn bolted upright in bed, all sleepiness gone in an instant, her heart hammering as though it might crack through her sternum, every hair on her body standing on end.

And yet the dim bedroom still held no one but her.

The voice had seemed to come from right beside the bed, but the bedside was completely empty. Sydney Ginn reached out and felt around—the edge of the sheets was cool to the touch, clearly undisturbed by anyone sitting there.

She turned on the bedroom light, swept the room with her eyes again, and still uneasy, grabbed her phone from the nightstand, switched on the flashlight, and crouched down to peer under the bed—thankfully, there was nothing under it but dust, and no person.

If she'd been met by a pair of eyes under the bed, that would have been more than enough to do her in.

Strange. Had she been dreaming?

The voice had sounded like a man's, faintly familiar.

Dreams were illogical like that—men wouldn't like London Moon, wouldn't care whether she had fans... probably not, anyway.

Whatever. Since she was already awake, she might as well eat something.

Her mind was filled with delivery app menus, and she just wanted to pull up a food delivery app right away—but the moment she raised her phone, the two lines reading November 21, 2026, 9:04 PM immediately caught her eye.

Sydney Ginn froze. 9:04?

The time the dream voice had announced just now happened to match the real time exactly?

She stared at a screen full of app icons, unsure whether to chalk this up to coincidence and let it go.

After all, she was starving—her stomach felt like it was on fire... yet her fingers, as if guided by some invisible force, slid past Uber Eats and tapped open Reddit instead.

This wasn't the Nest; there was nothing strange going on here, it was fine, it had to have been a dream...

Sydney Ginn thought about Mexican food as she typed "Artifact" into the search bar.

The first round of search results was a sprawling, varied mess. She thought for a moment and added the word "Hunter"—this time, she found a very quiet little subreddit with a name that made no attempt at concealment, brazenly called "Blackmoor Hunters"; total members: 17, currently online: 3.

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes and took a slow, deep breath.

It's fine—it was perfectly normal for a few Hunters to want a place to chat online, and with traffic this low, the average person would never dig it up... it wasn't necessarily what the dream had described.

The first post in view had been made at 8:40, titled "I ran into big sis London Moon"—and despite how quiet the subreddit was, it already had more than twenty replies.

Sydney Ginn stared at it blankly for several seconds.

She had no idea how to process this. Not daring to click in, she scrolled down a little further and found that posts about Artifacts or the Nest were few, and when they did come up, the language used was very oblique—most of them trailed off or resulted in meetups arranged offline.

More of the posts were about London Moon.

"I really love her, does anyone know which House Faction she's with?"—few had replied.

"So happy, logging a two-hour hangout with London Moon in N"—this was one of the hottest posts in the subreddit; N seemed to be shorthand for the Nest.

"I've been converted without any warning"—somewhat understandable, perhaps.

No... no, don't get distracted by the posts.

Why would she dream about something that, in reality, she'd had no idea even existed?

Sydney Ginn stared blankly at her own bed. The edge of the sheets held no warmth, no wrinkles; even the stale, close air of a bedroom sealed up for more than a day carried no scent that shouldn't be there, as though nothing had ever disturbed it.

From the moment the voice had gone silent to the moment she jolted upright, there simply hadn't been enough time for anyone to flee the bedroom; besides, she hadn't heard the door open.

The strangest thing was... that voice had somehow slipped into her sleep and dreams, yet it had been talking about London Moon's fan page.

Why not say something meaningful?

Sydney Ginn was no longer hungry.

She opened the first post—the encounter post that had been made just twenty minutes ago.

The following is the content of the post:

u/Liblipluck

Ever since I got back from N last time, I've had intermittent ringing in my ears, like I'm keeping bees in my skull. Today was my fourth follow-up appointment, and right there at the entrance I ran into big sis London Moon!

She was startled when I recognized her, like she couldn't figure out why I would know who she was. I told her you're quite famous, and she got embarrassed—it was so adorable aaaa (now I get why the Residents talk like that).

I wanted to take a photo with her, but London Moon said it wasn't convenient right now, which was a shame. She seemed to be waiting for someone or something—she was being quite discreet. Ha, and I still spotted her! Today I am the Hunter of Love.

First reply:

I'm so jealous, where did you run into her?

OP:

Ah, I don't know if I should say, since she seemed to be taking care of something there. She was very gentle—she chatted with me for a bit before telling me it wasn't convenient right now.

The replies below that didn't seem particularly significant.

Sydney Ginn hesitated, then tapped on the OP's profile and browsed their post history—nothing worth noting; then she opened their comment history.

This time, after scrolling down a few times, she stopped.

Under a post about health and medical care published about half a year ago, the OP had replied to another user saying that she also had a minor issue that had been bothering her for a while, and that she was planning to try a certain private hospital—reportedly one in which the Wellesley Group held a stake, with steep fees, but whose doctors, equipment, and treatment plans were said to be highly cutting-edge.

London Moon... the Wellesley family... was there a connection?

Sydney Ginn thought it over and decided to give Chase a call.

Chase looked like he'd be pretty frightening, and after actually interacting with him—he was pretty frightening.

Still, he had something of a business mindset; mutual benefit and cooperation wasn't impossible to work with. Since he'd laid out the terms of their arrangement, she would hold up her end of the deal and pass along information. Besides, he always gave off the feeling of someone who didn't know how to interact with people normally and had locked himself into a pose he couldn't climb down from.

Hmm, could she call him a different kind of incel? Though not quite as repulsive as the word implied...

"Hello?" An unfamiliar woman's voice picked up.

Sydney Ginn's hair practically leapt off her head.

At this hour, to pick up Chase's phone without a second thought? Well, who'd have thought—was it possible he'd somehow managed to build an intimate relationship with a wom—

"Are you a friend or family member of this patient?" The unfamiliar voice cut through her thoughts.

...Patient?

"What?"

"One moment, let me check... ah, here—Chase Monroe. Are you a friend or family member?"

"Ah, well..."

Sydney Ginn wasn't quite ready to accept the new role fate had assigned her, and the word "yes" wouldn't come out; but another sentence slipped out before she could stop it: "Did he die? I knew he was—"

She hadn't even gotten to "bound to go early" before the other party cut in, speaking quickly and matter-of-factly: "He was poisoned and fell from a building today; the fire department brought him to our hospital, but someone requested a transfer, so he was just taken away. He was brought in alone, was still unconscious when transferred, and his phone and driver's license were left behind here. You can let him know that his things are being kept with us."

A torrent of thoughts crashed into Sydney Ginn's mind all at once, and she didn't know which one to grab hold of first.

Turned out no woman would ever— no, that wasn't it.

How did he manage to get both poisoned and fall from a building? One way to go ought to be enough—no need to gild the lily... no, that wasn't it either.

Which hospital?

Had he been picked up by the Key House Faction, or...?

Was this even any of her business? Should she call June?

A stampede of thoughts thundered through like wild bison across a plain, kicking up a cloud of dust as they passed, leaving only a single question behind.

"The hospital he was transferred to is...?" Sydney Ginn asked.

The woman on the other end of the line—whether a doctor or a nurse, Sydney Ginn couldn't tell—gave the name of the private hospital in which the Wellesley Group held a stake.

At some point, Sydney Ginn had risen to her feet at the edge of her bed.

She recalled that back at the cemetery that day, Chase had said something about "London Moon shooting at me."

"Has the ambulance already left? How long ago?"

The woman replied: "Less than ten minutes ago, I think—it probably hasn't reached the receiving hospital yet."

And once it did, what would happen?

Sydney Ginn felt the answer to that was already quite clear.

Chase could not die yet.

She hastily threw on a coat—pajama pants with sneakers—grabbed the backpack she took into the Nest, and rushed out the door; as she called a car, she also dialed June's number.

For some reason, Key House Faction people seemed to be in fashion today when it came to not picking up their phones.

Undaunted, she called again a second time, then a third, until she finally heard the line connect.

"...Sydney Ginn?" June asked slowly.

"Don't tell me you've been asleep until now too," Sydney Ginn said, then reminded herself not to get sidetracked and added, "Anyway, set that aside for now—do you know about what happened to Chase?"

"What happened to Chase?"

The hospital had said he'd been brought in alone, so it seemed the Key House Faction still hadn't gotten word yet.

Did that mean what he'd gone through before getting poisoned and falling had something to do with the "Domination Game"? That he'd been keeping the Nest Domination Game as quiet as possible, which was why he hadn't brought House Faction members along as backup?

Sydney Ginn skipped over the part about the voice in her dream and relayed everything to June, saying, "You'd better bring people over there quickly too, in case something happens to him. Oh—I mean, I'm already downstairs, but if you don't need me to go, I'll just head—"

"No, I need you there."

June's voice was quiet and distant, seeming a little different from before, though it was hard to say exactly how. Something of her usual liveliness was missing. Even upon hearing that Chase was in trouble, she was remarkably calm.

"I'll head out right away too... let's meet at the hospital in a bit," she said, and her tone carried what sounded like a smile.

Having written this far, I want to say—weaving together a multi-POV storyline is actually even harder than writing dungeon arcs... eating an egg yolk pie to fuel the plot.

Chapter 176: Sydney Ginn's Path of Love

Sydney Ginn had imagined several scenarios.

For instance, she spots London Moon at a glance, and with irrefutable evidence laid before her, London Moon flies into a furious rage and opens fire—bang, bang; or perhaps she finds Key House people surrounding and infiltrating the hospital building, unleashing all manner of Artifacts, turning everything around her into a howling, unearthly chaos.

The one thing she hadn't considered was that she wouldn't even be able to get through the door.

"I'm sorry, we operate on a whitelist system."

In a lobby that could pass for either a private hospital or a luxury hotel, an elegantly poised middle-aged woman spoke to her from behind the reception desk: "Our emergency department is not open to the public, nor do we accept walk-in patients. Only those who have made an appointment and been added to the whitelist may enter this hospital."

"My frien—my cousin was just transferred here, brought in by ambulance. Don't believe me? Check the records. You have records, right?"

Sydney Ginn remembered that on her way in, she had happened to see an ambulance leaving after completing its delivery. An idea came to her. She said, "He's unconscious. I'm here to... I'm here to handle the paperwork and pay the fees."

She was here to hand over money—surely they'd have to let her in for that?

"I'm sorry," the receptionist said politely. "Please call the hospital's general affairs line, explain your situation to them first, and make an appointment. We operate on a whitelist system."

"Doesn't running a whitelist system cause problems for a hospital?"

Sydney Ginn's voice had risen by no more than a hair's breadth above its previous level, yet the broad-shouldered Black man standing by the metal detector door—wearing a black security T-shirt with what appeared to be a weapon at his hip—turned his head toward her.

Her voice dropped back down: "...What's the general affairs number?"

Armed with a number she already knew would be useless to call, Sydney Ginn walked out of the hospital building.

She glanced down at her pajama pants and sneakers, and half-suspected that her outfit had made getting in even harder; but at this point, she had no choice but to think of a way to slip past the front desk.

Originally, Sydney Ginn had simply not wanted Chase to die—she had even entertained the thought that since Key House already knew what was happening, perhaps she didn't need to come at all.

But now that they wouldn't even let her through the door, her mood shifted entirely: on what grounds could London Moon get in while she couldn't? Wasn't that practically the same as London Moon being the one keeping her out?

First she was used as bait, and now she couldn't even get through the door—was there no end to the humiliation?

Never mind whether that logic held up—that was the feeling, plain and simple.

The more they refused to let her in, the more she wanted in; even if Chase had already turned into a corpse by now, she had to get in there and see it with her own eyes.

Easier said than done, though—after circling the building once, she found that this hospital truly did resemble a high-end hotel: no climbable windows on the ground floor, and the side doors and staff entrances that accommodated hospital beds and stretchers were all fitted with combination locks.

Sydney Ginn considered picking the locks, but being a Hunter didn't mean she knew how to do everything; besides, she wasn't optimistic enough to believe that forcing a lock open wouldn't trigger an alarm.

What was she supposed to do—Chase was going to actually die soon.

She circled back to the front entrance and called June from the parking lot to talk through the situation—and of course, no one picked up.

It was abundantly clear that Key House people treated their phones primarily as decoration, with the secondary function of making callers anxious.

A woman stepped out of a taxi and walked toward the entrance. It was late at night, yet she wore a wide-brimmed straw sun hat.

Sydney Ginn was just about to look away when she immediately turned her head back for another glance.

Beneath that wide-brimmed straw hat hung a curtain of jet-black, perfectly straight long hair—so heavy it was almost like a dark cloth weighing it down. Behind the dark cloth, a round, bloated, snow-white face flickered in and out of view.

The woman didn't spare Sydney Ginn so much as a glance. As she passed a few steps away, Sydney Ginn's heart clenched, and she couldn't help but take two steps back.

Th-that wasn't a mask, was it? Was she here for a face consultation?

...Looking like that, wouldn't life be trouble at every turn?

She watched as the woman walked through the main entrance and came to a stop at the reception desk as well.

Sydney Ginn followed her inside, positioning herself at an angle where the guard couldn't see her but she could faintly make out the conversation.

"I'm sorry, we operate on a whitelist system..."

This woman hadn't made an appointment either?

The sun-hatted head slowly leaned over the reception desk, stretching out a neck that grew longer and longer, and murmured something too low to make out.

Her hair, black in a way that didn't look human, hung thick and heavy as oil, spilling across the counter.

"Please don't lean over like that..." The receptionist's voice of protest suddenly softened and became inaudible.

The security guard seemed to sense something was wrong and strode over, demanding in a low voice, "Is there a problem here?"

To keep the guard from spotting her, Sydney Ginn quickly drew back two steps; but when she leaned forward to look again, she realized she had missed something—no one was speaking anymore.

The receptionist, the sun-hatted woman, and the security guard stood like three frozen statues, motionless and silent.

After a few seconds, the sun-hatted woman turned around and, as though no one else existed, walked toward the gate with the metal detector at the other end of the lobby.

The receptionist and the security guard remained exactly where they stood, not moving a muscle.

Huh? What's wrong with them—

Oh, wait—never mind them, the opportunity was right here, wasn't it?

Sydney Ginn slipped through the door and quickly shot a glance at the two people at the front desk, finding that neither reacted to her at all. She didn't dare follow too closely behind the straw hat; only after seeing the woman enter the elevator bay did she hurry through the metal detector gate herself. She glanced back—the security guard was still standing with his back to her.

As she walked toward the elevator bay, she called June again.

This time the phone had barely rung before it was picked up.

June's voice was very low and kept cutting in and out, as if the signal was poor: "Sydney, we... ran into trouble on the way..."

Sounding quite warm and familiar.

"I barely managed to sneak in. Where are you?"

Sydney Ginn stepped into the elevator bay and saw that one elevator had just left the first floor and was heading up—it must have been the one the straw-hat woman had taken.

"The signal over here... is bad... someone attacked us. Go find Chase first, make sure he... I'll be there soon."

"I don't even know where to find Chase—it's not like they're going to tell me—"

Before she could finish, the call dropped.

Sydney Ginn stared at her phone, feeling almost like laughing bitterly.

Wonderful—Key House had so many people, and not a single one had shown up, leaving the entire task of rescuing someone to fall squarely on her shoulders?

Surely afterward she'd need at least a ten percent stake in Key House just to consider the debt repaid?

This private hospital was small, and unlike an ordinary hospital, it had no directory signs posted for patients; it seemed quite confident that everyone who came for treatment already knew where to go.

Looking at the row of elevator buttons, Sydney Ginn could only press two out of (Chase's) sheer luck—not for any particular reason, just like a moth hurling itself at a flame, bumbling along blindly; it mostly came down to whether Chase's fate was sturdy enough to hold.

It didn't seem particularly sturdy.

Because when the doors opened, it appeared to be a lounge and recreation area with a dining room—presumably prepared for inpatients and visiting family. Did Chase count as an inpatient?

Even if he wasn't formally admitted, they couldn't have killed him the moment he arrived, could they?

If the goal was to finish him off as quickly as possible, there would have been no need to go to all the trouble of transferring him here.

Sydney Ginn thought back to when she had received the recruitment notice—Chase's target Artifact profile had been exposed to her as well. He had "a tongue."

Could it be that the Wellesley Team already knew about this? Even without a leader, they were still remarkably proactive.

A competing team transferring another player who possessed a target Artifact into their own faction's hospital—there had to be more to it than simply wanting to kill him. They would need to get the Artifact as well.

The question was how long retrieving the tongue would take; however long that process lasted, that was how much time Chase had left.

But where on earth was he? With no information at all, how was she supposed to—

Sydney Ginn suddenly stopped in her tracks.

On the third-floor emergency level, a nurse's station finally appeared that resembled those in ordinary hospitals.

She had assumed a place where the wealthy received medical care would be under tight management; but to her surprise, the two nurses at the station were standing shoulder to shoulder with their backs to the hallway, watching something she couldn't see, completely motionless for several seconds.

Sydney Ginn didn't dare pass up the opportunity by waiting for them to turn around—she crouched low and tiptoed, slipping into the waiting area behind the nurse's station. The waiting area was empty; as she stepped inside, she happened to see a brown-haired girl emerging from a restroom further away.

It wasn't the straw-hat woman, it wasn't London Moon, and it certainly wasn't the utterly unreliable June; the girl's face was unfamiliar, someone she had never seen before.

She quietly scanned her surroundings; when the girl's gaze landed on Sydney Ginn, she immediately looked down and, as if nothing had happened, sat down in a corner of the waiting area.

...How could there be someone even more furtive than herself?

The next second, the brown-haired girl suddenly knitted her brows, rubbed her ear hard, then lightly tapped it twice, as though something inside was bothering her.

Something stirred in Sydney Ginn's chest.

...It couldn't be, could it?

She thought back to the chance-encounter post. The author had said they'd run into London Moon at the entrance, but hadn't mentioned whether they themselves had been on their way out or on their way in...

So this brown-haired girl really was her? The love-struck Hunter?

Now that was some burning devotion—waiting this long without leaving, channeling every bit of a Hunter's tracking ability into chasing an idol.

Which meant... London Moon was on this floor?

Wait—London Moon's target was Chase; if she was on this floor, then Chase was also—

Before Sydney Ginn could finish the thought, a door in the corridor ahead suddenly opened. A doctor rushed out as if fleeing, face pale and visibly tense; someone behind him pulled the door shut.

This guy Chase's luck really was something else, Sydney Ginn thought, breaking into a full sprint, cursing him silently—if she had been even a minute later, she would have missed this exact moment.

Beneath the room door, everything suddenly went black.

Yesterday I watched Platform 1, it was really good! Today I'm watching Platform 2. I happened to come across a high-quality recommendation in a sea of marketing and content accounts on Xiaohongshu... quite a find.

Chapter 177: Sydney Ginn Meets an Old Acquaintance Far from Home

Sydney Ginn skidded to a hard stop just a few steps away from Chase's hospital room.

The room that had suddenly gone dark was ahead of her on the right side of the corridor; on her left was a doctor's office.

The doctor who had just hurried out of Chase's room with a grim expression had crossed the corridor and gone into that office—nothing strange about that in itself.

What was strange was that when she rushed over, she realized the doctor hadn't actually walked in.

Sydney slowly turned her head.

The doctor was still frozen in the doorway of the office, back to her, unmoving, arms hanging at his sides.

Looking past his shoulder into the room, she could only make out a sliver of the simply furnished office—there was no telling what had suddenly stopped him in his tracks.

The security guard downstairs, the nurses' station—they all seemed to have fallen into the same frozen stillness...

Sydney quickly glanced back and found that the Love Hunter had half-risen from her chair, neck craned forward, staring at her from a distance with a face full of suspicion.

"What are you doing?" Sydney couldn't help asking her, then flicked her eyes back to the doctor's motionless back.

"Nothing," the Love Hunter said, still not sitting down, still watching her. "What are **you** doing?"

She just wanted to see if Sydney was going after London Moon, didn't she?

There was no time to get tangled up with her over this right now.

Sydney swept one glance at the doctor's back, said not a word, and strode briskly toward the hospital room, shoving the door open and rushing in—after a brief flash of darkness before her eyes, the light came back, and she was already inside, the door slamming shut behind her with a clang.

...Huh?

Sydney blinked hard twice.

A hospital room—it was, without question, a hospital room, the kind any person walking in would have no choice but to call a hospital room.

But somehow it just felt off, as though what she saw was completely at odds with what she had expected—even if she'd walked in to find a Chase-butchered slaughterhouse behind that door, it wouldn't have struck her as quite this strange.

The room was larger than she'd imagined, holding a full six beds—three on each side—each surrounded by a curtain of pale blue privacy drapes. In the far corner near the ceiling, a small television hung silently, dusty and dark with no one watching it.

The room was dim; of a row of flush-mounted ceiling lights, only two were on.

Sydney spotted Chase at once—he was lying in the middle bed on the left, still unconscious, but his chest rose and fell in shallow breaths, so at least he wasn't dead.

Apart from him, two other beds were occupied.

The bed across from Chase had its curtain drawn all the way shut—that patient was likely already asleep; beside Chase, in the bed farthest from the door, the curtain was drawn halfway, and a pair of bare feet with pale, bluish-white skin poked out from the foot of the bed.

It was too strange. Sydney stared at those feet, unable to shake the almost stubborn sense of wrongness gnawing at her.

If something felt wrong, all the more reason to leave as soon as possible.

She didn't want to linger here a second longer. She stepped forward, grabbed Chase's arm, and hauled with every ounce of strength she had—she strained hard enough to make a sound in her throat, and managed only to drag his upper body up at a forty-degree angle.

This was a problem she hadn't thought about at all before coming in: Chase was nearly two meters tall, built with dense, heavy muscle, probably well over two hundred pounds—nothing like slight little Wellesley. If he wouldn't move on his own, she'd need a tractor to drag him out of here.

"Hey,"

She patted Chase's cheek—thinking back on how he'd dragged her into that mess at the Central Police Department, she showed absolutely no mercy, each slap landing with a crisp,

satisfying crack.

"Get up, stop sleeping, come with me now. Hey, Chase! Don't tell me you can't bear to leave this—"

Sydney's head snapped up.

Right—her head had been so crammed with information tonight that she hadn't thought of it immediately.

Wasn't this supposed to be a hospital for the wealthy and well-connected? They even had a whitelist system.

So then... would the wealthy and well-connected really be packed into a six-bed ward?

Surely the hospital hadn't set up a six-bed ward specifically for people who couldn't afford a private room?

No matter how she thought about it, that explanation didn't hold up.

"Hey, please, just wake up already,"

Sydney lowered her voice, shaking Chase harder. If he didn't wake up, she wasn't even confident she could lift him into a wheelchair. "Something's not right here—"

"...Little girl."

She froze at Chase's bedside, still bent at the waist.

A second passed before she realized it was the patient in the next bed—the one with the bare feet—who had spoken. Whatever illness he had, his voice churned with something murky and thick, unpleasant to hear, almost like a Resident's—

Wait.

Oh, hell. You've got to be kidding.

She hadn't jumped out of a window.

"Where are you trying to take him?" the patient asked.

"Ah... he can't afford the hospital bill," Sydney said, making it up on the spot while scanning the room in slow sweeps, hoping to find more clues. "The hospital's kicking him out. I'm taking him home."

"You've come at the perfect time."

The patient behind the curtain said flatly, "I'm sick, I can't get around easily—I was just about to need someone to do me a favor."

As he spoke, the patient behind the curtain shifted with a rustling sound. The pair of feet outside the curtain remained perfectly still—white as powdered skin, toes splayed left and right at awkward angles.

Could anyone turn over in bed without their feet moving at all?

Sydney stared at those feet and said nothing, quietly digging her fingernails into the soft flesh of Chase's inner arm.

"A little girl like you really shouldn't be so rude. I'm asking for your help—won't you even say a word back to me?"

"...Wh-what kind of help? Can you really not move?"

"I'm not getting around easily—I'm a patient. Help me get him to... hmm, what is he to you?"

Torn between giving up on Chase and turning to leave or trying a little longer, Sydney hesitated—then chose the latter. "C-cousin. My cousin."

"Help me pry your cousin's mouth open, would you?"

Sydney blinked. "What?"

"Pry his mouth open. Now."

The patience of the patient behind the curtain seemed to be wearing down, bit by bit, and the thick, churning quality in his voice grew heavier—as though he intended to use his throat as a blade and blend a cup of meat-worm pulp.

She still didn't know what method London Moon had used, but at this point, Sydney had no more doubts.

"Why?" she asked soundlessly, hand slipping into her backpack, feeling around inside, buying time with questions. "What are you going to do?"

"Ugh, why does everyone I run into have so many questions? The old lady last time just kept going and going..."

The patient behind the curtain complained, but told her anyway: "There's something inside your cousin's mouth—I find it rather interesting. Pry his mouth open for me, let me get a good feel... Now."

The last two words spiked up sharp and sudden, like a wasp's stinger jabbing into a nerve without warning; Sydney's vision swam and she nearly doubled over and vomited on Chase.

"O-okay, okay, I get it, calm down."

She used her free hand to pinch Chase's cheeks and worked his mouth open. "Is that good? Then what? What is it you want?"

"A small, pink thing."

The patient behind the curtain slowed his words, as though his tongue were swelling slowly in his mouth, soaking and stirring through a mouthful of pooled saliva.

"How to describe it... there's really nothing else to say... just that I want it I want it so much I want it so badly I want it so much I can't stand it and if anyone gets in my way this time I'll truly lose control lose control lose control lose control"

London Moon, you piece of shit.

Sydney's hand finally closed around the cold, heavy grip—and as she pulled it out of the backpack, the bed curtain was yanked open at that same moment—the pair of feet was still lying on the bed, but from the upper half, a tall, thin black shape had risen up and pressed against the ceiling.

I know that if this title appeared in Doomsday, it would be a very popular chapter—heh heh, rubbing hands together like a fly: did anyone get confused by a time-and-space mix-up? Got you!

Speaking of which—when Doomsday ended, I looked back at the early chapters and felt genuinely ashamed of the pacing in those opening arcs: no rhythm, barely any character building, just barreling through the plot with one explosion after another. I don't know how to put it—I just thought it was juvenile. These days I might ramble a bit more, but I'm much more comfortable with the pacing.

Today's chapter is short because my sleep debt seems to have caught up with me—I've been groggy and drowsy all day.

Chapter 178: Sydney Ginn's Life on Earth—Creative Ways to Court Death

Who could say whether the Resident had originally intended to make a move, but when it caught sight of Sydney Ginn, it suddenly froze.

Its forehead, brows, and eyes were visible above the curtain rail, fixed in an unblinking stare at Sydney Ginn.

The lower half of its face kept stretching longer and longer, like dough being slowly pulled apart by someone's hands—until it couldn't hold itself together, and tore open in a long, narrow black void with a ragged ripping.

From within the void came a voice: "...What's that thing in your hand?"

Sydney Ginn glanced down at her secret weapon—she had paid a fortune to have someone source the materials, grind and custom-make it, a process that had taken two months of work alone. She'd just received the package after returning from the Nest this time, and today was the very first time she was putting it to use.

Who would have thought that something made to deal with Residents would end up being used in Blackmoor City?

Did London Moon even know what he was doing? What if it wandered outside?

"This... is a toy I brought for my cousin," Sydney Ginn thought for a moment and said. "You wouldn't know, but he's a big guy with a childlike heart—I figured he could play with toys while he's in the hospital..."

As if she'd ever tell a Resident anything about her secret weapon.

Besides, she still needed to read the situation before deciding whether to fight—even with a cooperative arrangement with Chase, she couldn't throw her life away.

"A little girl like you, quite the liar. No wonder you're a Hunter—nothing good about you."

Huh? Her identity had already been figured out? Was it because she hadn't looked startled when she saw it?

No, that didn't seem right.

Ordinary people would pay attention to an opponent's reactions and analyze what their next move might be, but Residents rarely thought that way.

Their attitude could essentially be summed up as "I am the natural order of things, so I do as I please"—in other words, extreme self-centeredness.

If a Resident was paying attention to a human's reactions, there was only one possible reason: it could draw pleasure from doing so, or gain some advantage from it. Otherwise, no matter how turbulent a human's emotions ran, they would be invisible to it.

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment and lowered her secret weapon.

"Take whatever you want. I won't stop you."

"You couldn't stop me anyway."

...She really wanted to smash that arrogant, ugly face to pieces.

"I have a question for you. What's the name of the hospital you're in?"

The Resident's lower half was clearly lying flat on the bed, yet its upper half slowly climbed off the edge.

And yet the two halves remained connected, forming a single tall, spindly silhouette—though how they were connected was impossible to say.

Looking at the middle of its body for even a moment made you feel as though your own consciousness had bent, like a spoon submerged in a bowl of water; your awareness warped and slipped sideways in the dizziness, and no matter how long you stared, you still couldn't make out what its body truly looked like.

"...St. Louis Hospital."

The upper half of the spindly figure slowly slid over to Chase's side; the moment its long, thin fingers touched Chase's jaw, Sydney Ginn pulled her hand back like a flash of lightning.

"St. Louis Hospital? You're not lying to me?"

She remembered now—that hospital was apparently a fairly high-traffic safe house; she'd never been there herself, but she'd heard that people often opened their passages and found themselves landing inside St. Louis Hospital.

It believed it was still in St. Louis Hospital, which meant...

It wasn't a Resident that had entered Blackmoor City—it was London Moon who had Docked a section of the Nest to the door of a hospital room in Blackmoor City?

From the look of it, only this one room had been connected, and it didn't seem possible to access the wider Nest from here.

So that was how it was... The Resident believed it was still inside the Nest, which was why it was treating every human it saw as a Hunter.

"Before you saw him, did anything happen here?" Sydney Ginn asked. "Did another Hunter come through? A young woman with short hair—hey, I'm talking to you!"

The spindly Resident paid her no attention; its fingers had already moved, pinching Chase's jaw.

The moment skin made contact, Chase—who was unconscious—jolted as though an electric current had passed through him. His lips trembled, his throat bobbed up and down, and even unconsciousness couldn't seem to suppress his urge to retch.

Sydney Ginn even felt a flicker of concern—if the second-in-command of Key House Faction, of all people, choked to death on his own vomit, what on earth would they write on his tombstone?

The Resident slowly lowered its face—about as long as a baseball bat—until it hovered just above Chase's mouth, and drew a long, deep breath.

"Yes yes yes that's the smell that's the one that's right so stupid so lovable so easy to manipulate humans such simple simple minds mudlike cognition cognition cognition what cognition do you even have so self-righteous oh"

It was like watching someone who'd drunk a whole case of liquor, drunk out of their mind, hunch forward and let out a great "blaaaah"—everything spewing and splashing down—and Sydney Ginn almost felt certain she'd been splattered in the face.

It abruptly raised its hand and shoved the entire thing into the long, narrow, vertical black void on its face, edges ragged and uneven.

Sydney Ginn stared blankly as it reached deep into the void in its face and pulled out a tiny human head.

The head was the size of a quarter, with a complete set of facial features and ears, and behind it trailed a tiny body; the whole figure was bare, stripped of all hair and sex organs,

impossible to tell male from female at a glance.

Pinched between two long, thin fingers, the tiny figure thrashed and tumbled without stopping, screaming and wailing—but it was so small that even its cries of agony sounded like shrill cartoon sound effects:

"Please let me go, I'm begging you, let me go, I'll never steal your Artifacts again, I have a wife and kids, let me go home—"

"Nonsense."

The Resident regarded the tiny figure with something almost like tenderness and said, "Terrible personality, ugly to look at—who would ever have children with you?"

"You—what are you doing?" Sydney Ginn asked, stumbling over her words.

She looked at the unconscious Chase, then at the tiny figure descending toward his mouth. It was going to put the tiny person in his mouth...?

She probably needed to do something fast, to help Chase out.

But caught in fear, confusion, and dizziness—along with an inexplicable urge to laugh—she felt a powerful sense of unreality wash over her. No need to force herself to summon courage; maybe she'd wake up in another moment or two.

"This Artifact isn't easy to retrieve."

Perhaps because she was being well-behaved and not interfering, the Resident struck up a conversation with her: "Once it was captured by humans, it only responds to humans—wouldn't you say that's forgetting its roots? It can only jump from one human to another using a specific exchange of words as a bridge. Useless thing—nowhere near as easy to retrieve as what the old woman had on her. What a shame."

She understood now. No wonder London Moon had connected to the Nest—he was using the Resident to steal the Artifact on his behalf.

Never mind that Chase was unconscious and couldn't speak; even if he were awake, there was no way he'd cooperate in completing whatever exchange of words was needed. Through ordinary means, it was impossible to get a tongue out of Chase's mouth—London Moon was planning to steal from a thief.

"So how are you going to get the Artifact out?" Sydney Ginn asked, tightening her grip on her weapon. "Have the tiny person speak with him? Say what?"

The Resident grabbed the tiny figure, who was still screaming and begging for mercy, and crammed it into Chase's mouth in one brutal motion, like stuffing in a wad of rotten cloth.

Amid shrieks, the tiny figure struggled and twisted violently, thrashing about between Chase's teeth, slamming against them so hard it cracked its head open and bled—fine, tiny spatters of blood sprinkled across Chase's teeth.

"I'm the best at catching Artifacts—even an Artifact that only responds to human speech can be tricked by my little person..."

The Resident said this with evident delight, lowering its head and training a pair of eyeballs that looked exactly like the backs of heels on Chase. "Find the Artifact, grab it, and bring it out for me."

Its hands were pressed against Chase's face the entire time; pink foam, tinted by blood, gurgled steadily from the corners of his mouth—even Sydney Ginn, no doctor, could see that if this kept up, Chase might not last much longer.

She made the decision to save him—not because she and Chase had a mutually beneficial working arrangement. At least, not only because of that.

Because she and the man lying on the hospital bed were both human, and the thing across from her was not.

"You're very patient. You've talked quite a lot."

She gave the Resident a compliment. Why not.

"Oh, one more thing—did you believe in a religion when you were alive?"

"Hmm?"

The Resident rolled its heel-like eyeballs upward; even the calluses around the edges of the eyeballs seemed to radiate surprise. "...Religion? You mean like a faith? What a boring thing. Hmm... the body I was born into, I think it was Christian?"

Good. A big religion.

Jaw clenched, Sydney Ginn twisted her weapon and suddenly swung it high, sweeping it in a wide arc straight at the Resident's face.

"What do you think you're doing little girl how naive—"

The Resident rattled out nine words at blinding speed, and before the tenth could leave its mouth, the weapon crashed into one of its heel-like eyeballs.

"A hammer? A toy hammer can't do anything to me—"

The Resident abruptly went silent.

In the dead stillness, a callus above the other eyeball folded down like an eyelid and blinked once.

It turned toward the eyeball beside it and stared at its companion.

The other eyeball had taken a direct hit from the dark, heavy hammer-weapon, and was slightly caved in.

The next second, the hospital room was filled completely with the Resident's howl.

When you heard it howl, it was a suffocating kind of terror: like waking up one morning and finding you cannot open your eyes.

You become disconnected from your own body, your thoughts trapped in absolute darkness, unable to see the world any longer, unable to speak a single word, your body dead and rigid—yet you know you will go on living, buried alive in an eternal darkness like rubble.

...The sound of breathing—seemingly your own—finally seeped slowly through the rubble-like darkness.

The Resident's howl was somewhat weaker than before, but kept spraying out in a torrent:

"What is that what is that what is that"

Sydney Ginn recovered her vision with great effort and found she had somehow fallen to the floor, knocking a hospital bed sideways.

Her secret weapon had been flung by the Resident halfway across the room, landing in the corner by the door; near the ceiling, the Resident was twisting and shrieking without pause—"What did you use what is that it hurts it hurts it hurts so annoying there's an indescribable discomfort like the feeling of being humiliated given physical form so strange it hurts so annoying I'm definitely going to turn you into a tiny figure that catches Artifacts too"

...Catch me first, then we'll talk.

Sydney Ginn gritted her teeth, pushed herself up, and lunged onto Chase's hospital bed, reaching out to grab the tiny foot dangling from his lips, ready to wrench it free with all her strength.

With a loud "swoosh," the curtain on the opposite bed was yanked back hard, revealing a face that appeared to have finally reached the end of its patience.

"Are you done?" London Moon snapped furiously. "You really have no shortage of creative ways to get yourself killed!"

I finished watching *The Platform* 2 as well—I thought it was great, but I still had a few unanswered questions, so I went online to look up interpretations. What I found shocked me: it was a sea of criticism...

I spent half a day on Reddit and noticed something fascinating: when reading a book, many people look at A and call it B. The same thing, apparently, can happen with film—and isn't film the most direct visual medium there is? Even images can fail to communicate?

I'd originally planned to just read someone else's analysis, but in the end I wrote one myself...

What can I say—at this point, I think the least realistic part of the film is probably the message relay system. Humans are simply incapable of passing a message on accurately.

Chapter 179: Sydney Ginn Sails a Ghost Ship into the Harbor

In that instant, two thoughts shot straight up from the bottom of her heart, and Sydney Ginn couldn't tell which came first and which came second.

First: because London Moon had given her such a fright, she hadn't yet lunged at Chase—she'd stopped midway and spun around sharply—and as her peripheral vision swept across the hospital bed like a panning camera, Sydney Ginn suddenly noticed that pressed tightly against the lower side of Chase's bed was a row of gray-white, strip-like shadows.

That glimpse had lasted no longer than a white horse flashing past a crack in the wall, and the moment her gaze landed on London Moon, a lightbulb blazed to life in her mind, illuminating an answer.

...So it was its hand all along.

The Resident had been crying out in pain on the other side of the bed, while quietly extending an arm beneath Chase's bed, reaching over to Sydney Ginn's side, waiting for prey to walk into the trap.

If London Moon hadn't called out to her just now and she'd gone ahead and lunged straight forward, she would have handed herself right into the Resident's grasp.

The second thought was: London Moon, as the one who had caused all this, still had the nerve to shout at her?

"And you're glaring at me?"

London Moon's blue eyes went wide, her expression one of disbelief. When she had leaped off the bed, she moved with the lightness and agility of a cat. "Did someone invite you here? What does any of this have to do with you?"

"And what does it have to do with you?" Sydney Ginn shot back, keeping the Resident in her peripheral vision.

"My involvement in this matter is none of your business."

"If your involvement is none of my business, then what business is my involvement of yours?"

"You're both infuriating!"

The Resident let out a sudden furious shriek, and both women fell silent at once.

Its long face swiveled back and forth like a rattle-drum—left toward London Moon, right toward Sydney Ginn—and seeming to realize the trap would no longer work, it whipped its arm back from beneath the bed and pressed it once again against Chase's jaw.

Chase, who had barely stopped convulsing moments ago, instantly became an electrified dead fish once more.

Sydney Ginn sighed and cast him a worried glance.

He had no passage, had never been inside the Nest, and unlike Hunters who grew more resistant to things from the Nest the more they went in; word was that ordinary people who were unlucky enough to have their first physical contact with a Resident—for whatever reason—could fall directly into shock.

Chase wouldn't go that far, but he was already unconscious from poisoning, and there was no telling how many more minutes he could hold out under the Resident's hands.

...Besides, vomiting while lying flat on your back would definitely cause him to choke to death. That problem was actually more pressing than shock.

"You—I'm talking to you, stop getting distracted!"

The Resident extended a long, slender finger and pointed at Sydney Ginn from across the room, crying out: "You actually hid a companion? No problem, I'll just kill you all kill you all kill you all that'll do it kill you I can slowly study your weapon after"

"Wait,"

London Moon raised one hand, exactly like a student asking to answer a question. "She and I aren't together."

The Resident's one eyeball—the very one Sydney Ginn had struck into a shallow dent—rotated toward London Moon.

...The moment had come.

Honestly, Sydney Ginn could admit it herself: sometimes she was quite impulsive.

The moment she thought of something, if she didn't act on it immediately, her whole body felt like it was crawling with ants; worse still, before her mind had even finished forming the thought, her body had already moved first—like right now.

In the brief instant that the Resident's attention was divided, she had already rushed to the side of the bed, her fingertips digging hard into Chase's shoulder, hooking him and yanking him forcefully downward.

Chase was just as heavy as before, but this time Sydney Ginn wasn't trying to carry him away—she only needed to drag his upper body off the bed and let him hang head-down toward the floor, which was far easier.

The very moment she wrenched his upper body off the bed, the air in the ward was suddenly shaken into a reverberating hum by a gunshot.

Sydney Ginn's heart nearly leaped into her throat. She looked up and saw the Resident stumble back two steps, shaking its hand again and again; a bullet squeezed out from the skin of its palm, tumbled to the ground, rolled with a crisp rattling sound, still wrapped in wisps of white smoke.

She turned her head and saw London Moon holding a Desert Eagle, its muzzle not yet dared to lower.

The two women exchanged a glance—one brief, fleeting look—and had already traded everything they needed to know.

...Just now, the Resident must have been about to grab her, and London Moon had stopped it with a single bullet.

A bullet couldn't kill a Resident, but the force was strong enough to block and injure—though against this particular Resident, it didn't seem to have done much damage.

Fair enough—London Moon still had some conscience in her after all.

"That hurts! And you say you two aren't together?" the Resident howled.

A "splash" of liquid hitting the floor made Sydney Ginn instinctively glance toward the source of the sound, and she immediately breathed a sigh of relief.

Worth it—worth the risk she'd taken to wrench Chase into that Death of Marat pose.

He was head-down now, and the blood, stomach acid, and foam in his mouth all came pouring out together—it seemed he hadn't eaten today, so there wasn't much vomit—but it had flushed out that little figure too, halfway.

The little figure's two bare legs were now dangling from Chase's chin, while the upper half was still hidden inside his mouth.

She had no idea how he'd describe this scene once he woke up.

Forget it—let the little figure dangle for now. She truly had no desire to grab it with her own hands; pulling out some unexpected complication would be the last thing she needed—the most pressing matter right now was getting her weapon back.

In the short time that Sydney Ginn had been distracted by Chase-the-Marat, London Moon had been trying to negotiate cooperation with the Resident.

"...I also want you to take the Artifact, because that man is my opponent—I have no use for that Artifact myself, but I don't want it staying on him either."

Pure nonsense, trying to trick a ghost—she was definitely planning to double-cross it—but should she say so now?

Hmm, tipping the Resident off about that didn't exactly seem like it would benefit her either.

While she hesitated, London Moon had already continued: "You find her annoying, don't you? How about this—I'll help you drive her away, and you take the Artifact. In exchange, you don't lay a hand on either of us. What do you say?"

Drive her away?

What a charming thing to say—as if she were some stray dog. Sydney Ginn shot her a furious glare.

"Last I checked, I haven't died yet—since when do you get to decide what happens to me?"

London Moon ignored her, but shoved both hands roughly through her short hair a few times, ruffling it into waves, as if hoping that would help her shake off her restlessness.

She always dressed like a young man—loose shirt, wide trousers—and if Sydney Ginn hadn't been sharp-eyed, she might well have missed the faintly visible bulge at the small of London Moon's back beneath her baggy T-shirt.

Another gun on her? Well-hidden indeed.

"Don't listen to her—she can't fight. I'll hold a gun to her head, and she'll leave on her own." London Moon fixed her eyes on the Resident and added: "You wouldn't want to push me too far and have me cancel the Docking, would you?"

Sydney Ginn had already been slowly backing away, but at those words she couldn't help asking: "What Docking?"

Unexpectedly, the Resident had the same question: "What Docking?"

"Haven't you noticed? Although this hospital ward is still the Nest, it's a portion I've extracted and Docked into the real world. Because this place was originally a hospital room too—the same nature, the same dimensions—the Nest ward was able to overlay and replace it, like a ghost ship sailing into a harbor."

Sydney Ginn understood at once.

Was this one of the reasons she had risked having the Key House Faction discover her, just to transfer Chase to a different hospital? The other reason was probably that transferring him made it easier to kill him.

Within the Nest, there exist two kinds of Residents: one kind with no interest in Artifacts, and another kind who, upon seeing an Artifact, are like hyenas catching the scent of rotting flesh.

London Moon needed the second kind of Resident to extract an Artifact she couldn't retrieve herself, so she could double-cross them and take it.

The lucky Resident chosen here happened to inhabit the hospital's territory, so London Moon could Dock the Nest hospital directly with the real-world hospital—something that would naturally be difficult to do in a large, busy public hospital.

London Moon pointed at the ward door and said, "In other words, beyond that door lies a hospital somewhere in Blackmoor City. Regardless of whether they have a passage or not, any human who pushes that door open can walk into this portion of the Nest."

The Resident's eyes lit up.

Its eyes were shaped like the back of a heel, but Sydney Ginn could see the brightness in them regardless.

Still—why tell it that? Was she trying to bring about the end of the world?

"People can come in, but you can't go out," London Moon said. "Not only can you not enter the real world—you can't reach anywhere else in the Nest either."

The back-of-a-heel blinked. "Why?"

"I said—this is an extracted portion of the Nest. Right now it's connected neither to the Nest nor fully to the real world...there's still a small gap between the Nest and the real world. We're sitting inside that gap."

The Resident seemed completely captivated by this topic, no longer paying any mind to Chase.

One representative of evil and one Nest Resident were chatting away, seemingly absorbed; neither of them noticed that Sydney Ginn was inching her way toward a corner of the room.

Her weapon was lying just a few steps away.

Sydney Ginn kept her eyes fixed on the Resident, not daring to let her gaze slip.

Seizing one opening after another whenever it wasn't looking, she extended the tip of her foot and slowly nudged the weapon closer to herself—then she suddenly dipped her waist and stretched out her hand, scooping it up.

"To think you managed to find such a rare and tricky Artifact...Docked to the real world? My, my—even though I can't enter the real world myself, just hearing it makes my heart race."

The moment Sydney Ginn straightened up, she saw that stretch of thin, towering shadow fling out a long arm and sweep it through a half-arc through the air—at a speed the eye could barely follow, it slammed into London Moon with full force.

"Hand that over to me too!"

Sydney Ginn actually has a bit of ADHD—not sure if everyone could tell...

Speaking of which, while writing this I went and looked up *The Death of Marat*, and found that his death looked a little different from how I remembered it—his head and shoulders are just tilted to the side, not hanging completely down the way Chase is.

But anyway, as long as you all have a picture in your head, that's good enough...

What a lazy author, using the name of a painting instead of writing out the scene description lol.

Chapter 180: Sydney Ginn, the Genius Troublemaker

Thank goodness London Moon took that hit.

The Resident's swinging arm moved so fast it blurred into a shadow—if London Moon's body hadn't intercepted it, Sydney Ginn genuinely wasn't sure her hammer swing would have connected.

As London Moon stumbled back and fell, the Resident recoiled as though scalded, yanking its arm back, its furious shriek spiraling and echoing beneath the ceiling:

"So annoying so disgusting what is that thing what is that thing truly repulsive unpleasant feels like an insult what on earth is it hmm I'm actually a little curious now"

Compared to last time, the Resident had taken the same hammer blow, and felt the same pain.

Yet hearing it now, the sound didn't bring the same terror of being trapped in suffocating darkness as before—only a faint dizziness and blurring of vision.

Why? Had she gotten used to it that quickly?

...Or was it simply not screaming as viciously as before?

The Slender Patient rubbed its own arms vigorously, and across its face—so far removed from anything human—a faintly human expression surfaced: something like the look of a person who'd had dog excrement smeared across their face.

"Are you all right?" Sydney Ginn kept her eyes fixed on it while reaching a hand down toward London Moon on the floor.

"...Not dead yet." London Moon's face had gone white with pain; she paused, then gripped Sydney Ginn's hand with the one not holding the gun, and pulled herself back up.

"Who did you say couldn't fight?"

London Moon shot her a sideways glance. "You really need it to see you as a threat?"

What answered her was a voice that sounded as though thick, viscous mucus was churning in its throat.

"Whether she's a threat or not—let me first see what she's holding."

The Slender Patient had just been rubbing its arm beside Chase's hospital bed a moment ago; somehow, without either of them noticing, that meter-long face had crossed the room and was now floating beside Sydney Ginn's shoulder.

Both of them froze, slowly turning only their eyes.

...The Resident's lower half was still on the hospital bed. Within the dark, narrow gash on its face, a dense mass of blurred human faces surged and receded in silent screaming, and at a glance it looked like a fleshy flower blooming out of the darkness.

"Don't keep the big guy waiting—go ahead, show the big guy that Docking thing you've got on you." Sydney Ginn said.

London Moon closed her eyes for a moment.

The Resident laughed evenly, the laughter cut into equal, flat segments with no rise or fall, like sounds produced by forcibly contracting a diaphragm.

"I was talking to you. But she works too—I want her Artifact. Which one of you gives it to me first? Whoever gives it first, I'll let them die."

...Was that supposed to be encouragement?

"Whoever resists gets to live with me forever."

That first one was the encouragement, then.

"Don't look at me," London Moon said, though it wasn't clear who she was speaking to, "the Docking Artifact is single-use—it's a saltwater fish. I salt-roasted it at dinner because you have to eat it for it to work. So attacking me is pointless; I couldn't throw it up even if I tried, it's been fully digested."

"Oh? You eat dinner pretty early—it's barely past nine. How long does the fish's effect last?"

"Until tomorrow morning— is now really the time to be asking about that?" London Moon pointed at the Resident beside them and demanded.

...Was this Resident so at ease because of curiosity, or because of confidence?

Sydney Ginn tightened her grip on her weapon, stole a glance at the Resident, then looked at London Moon.

Their eyes met briefly, nothing more—not a single word exchanged.

"Then let me show you the weapon," she said, suppressing her nerves as she spoke to the Resident: "This is a weapon I designed and built myself, based on my experience in the Nest..."

"Isn't that just a hammer?"

At first glance, the weapon in her hand did look like a rather foolish hammer.

It looked foolish because its shape wasn't as streamlined as an ordinary hammer—the handle was even a square-sectioned rod, which seemed awkward to grip.

The "hammerhead" was nothing more than a rectangular block jutting from the end of the rod, densely covered in carved text—and though the block was metal, it looked far less heavy or menacing than a normal hammer.

"It's not quite that simple—"

Sydney Ginn raised the hammer and said, "Hmm...let me put it this way, and you'll understand. The person who gave birth to you—what party were they a voter for when they died?"

Hard to say whether it was curiosity that killed the Resident, but the Slender Patient obediently answered: "Chris—"

That was enough.

Before it could finish the word, Sydney Ginn quickly pressed a spot on the "hammer," and from the other end of the square rod, a blue block painted with a donkey instantly flipped up; she spun the "hammer" in her hand, reversing it end-for-end, and swept the blue-block end across to strike the Resident in the face.

Its howl of pain hadn't even left its mouth before London Moon opened fire.

Countless bullets poured into its facial cavity, battering the Slender Patient like clusters of autumn leaves trembling in the wind, its face-skin rippling and shuddering as it was driven back step by step—while its mouth seemed to hold a leaping, bright tongue of fire.

London Moon emptied the gun quickly; she tossed the Desert Eagle aside, stepped between the Resident and Sydney Ginn, and barked back at her: "Get out now—I didn't bring a spare magazine!"

What? Wasn't there still another gun at the small of her back? Why wasn't she using it?

The question that flashed through Sydney Ginn's mind was not the one that came out of her mouth: "Why didn't you bring a spare magazine?"

"If it weren't for you, my original plan didn't require firing a single shot—go, now!"

But the narrow window they had bought was already closing.

As London Moon turned to shout those words, a face behind her was growing longer and longer; the skin of it seemed unable to hold, splitting into countless thin, ragged, narrow dark seams.

The widest one was aimed directly at the back of London Moon's head.

"Watch out!"

The weapon in Sydney Ginn's hand spun through the air toward the Slender Patient—this time, the Slender Patient watched it coming, neither dodging nor deflecting, and took the blow with a dull thud.

The face it had stretched forward shuddered from the impact and crumpled inward, but that was all.

"Now I understand no wonder your weapon is as aggravating as a booger so you were exploiting the residual human traits in us Residents truly sly and scheming and utterly unprincipled for a girl but you didn't expect this did you I got used to it so quickly the effect gets weaker each time weaker weaker weaker weaker weaker weaker weaker"

Sydney Ginn's vision swam.

...She truly hadn't expected that. After all, this was her first time putting the theory into practice; but Sydney Ginn couldn't even muster the energy to feel frustrated right now.

Every word the Resident spoke was like fingers plucking at her nerve endings, swinging her consciousness into dizziness and a floating sensation, as if she'd drunk a large amount of bad liquor—every organ inside her jolted awake, mutinied, and jostled to crawl upward through her esophagus.

By the time she came back to herself, she was already crumpled softly on the floor, her weapon nowhere to be seen.

London Moon was clearly not much better off, but had managed to remain barely upright and was clutching Sydney Ginn's arm—likely trying to get Sydney Ginn to leave quickly. Only she was too weak and shaky to speak, and could do nothing but hold on.

"What was written on the block you hit me with the first time? Hmm, I answered Christian, so was it engraved with scripture?" The Resident asked with keen interest, in no hurry to act, striking up a conversation instead. "But I'm not afraid of scripture."

"No, it's not..."

Sydney Ginn put in great effort to ensure only words came out, and not her organs.

She had to stall the Resident and buy London Moon time to use the gun at her back. Maybe it was a trump-card weapon that could give them both a chance to escape...she had to hold onto some hope.

"It's...Satanic doctrine...the number 666, hexagrams, goat eyes...atheist manifestos..."

Anything that would make a Christian feel uneasy, troubled, or taboo—Sydney Ginn had carved all of it on there, which was why a block no bigger than a fist was engraved so densely.

Residents are all born from human bodies.

If a human held strong beliefs, the Resident born from them would retain and inherit some trace of similar beliefs. Reciting scripture to a human wouldn't make them drop to the floor writhing—so a Resident born from that person, cut from the same cloth, would naturally be unaffected in the same way.

Among all the Hunters in the Nest, not one had ever been protected from a Resident just by wearing a cross.

But Residents seemed more sensitive to things like "consciousness" and "intent" than humans were—perhaps because they were beings born from abstract concepts like thought, consciousness, and personal desires and drives.

An "intent" that merely made humans feel uneasy and uncomfortable, if given physical form and struck with force, could inflict considerable pain on a Resident—this was a theory Sydney Ginn had developed from her accumulated observations inside the Nest and then put into practice, and it had turned out to work, at least a little.

"Well, I've been a patient at St. Louis Hospital for four or five years, and this is the first time I've come across thinking like yours. Not bad—a natural-born Hunter."

The Slender Patient even offered a word of admiration. "So if I had been Muslim before—hmm, that one's too straightforward, never mind. What if the body I was born from was a

Buddhist? What if it was an atheist?"

Naturally, there were different methods for those too.

A Resident born from a Buddhist, struck in the face with the concept of the emptiness of all things, would in theory have its hostile intent diminished; asking an atheist Resident about the nature of "Residents" and the "Nest" should also leave them confused for a while.

And if all else failed, there were still the blocks bearing the two-party emblems—one with a donkey, one with an elephant; meet an elephant, use the donkey; meet a donkey, use the elephant.

Sydney Ginn had even accounted for the possibility that non-voters and foreigners might die in the Nest, and had prepared blocks representing both left and right ideologies mounted at intervals along the rod—whichever one was needed, a press would pop it out.

The Resident had said she had no principles, and that wasn't entirely unfair—the world's mainstream belief systems had been reduced, in her hands, to mere weapons.

Now it was clear: this was a weapon suited only for ambushes, not for prolonged combat.

The brief few seconds Sydney Ginn had bought by exposing her hand—London Moon hadn't used them to attack, and instead, once she'd recovered some strength, urged her again: "Get out of here! This has nothing to do with you—let me have a word with this...Resident...big guy."

At a time like this, still thinking about negotiating? Why not reach for the gun at her back—

Sydney Ginn drew a breath.

She suddenly understood.

London Moon had said it just moments ago: she had no intention of fighting the Resident—her plan hadn't even called for firing a gun; she'd brought it probably only as a precaution.

She wasn't planning to fight, and she was planning to steal from a thief...

Which meant that whatever London Moon had concealed at her back held no destructive power, but could extract an Artifact from the Resident through some other means.

In other words, London Moon's original plan had most likely been to hide somewhere nearby, wait for the Resident to make its move, then seize "a tongue" by surprise, and make a dash for the exit to cancel the Docking—as for Chase, he would probably be left in the Nest forever.

He had no passage, so he wouldn't need to act; he would simply die after seven days on his own—if he could hold out that long.

The realization flashed through her mind; she didn't even have time to look at London Moon before a dark shadow suddenly swept over her face—the next second, Sydney Ginn and the person who had tackled her rolled together onto the floor.

In mid-air above them, the Resident's long arm—with its unknowable number of joints—stretched horizontally across the space; its hand reached across the gap and slammed into the door frame, like a spider with too many long legs.

If London Moon hadn't just tackled her, they would both likely have ended up like flies swatted flat against a wall by a spider.

"There's no meddlesome round-head this time—you two can't deal with me the way that old woman did..."

The Slender Patient didn't seem to know what it was saying, but was in a good mood regardless. "I want all of you to die here today and become nutrients and the best outcome would be for you to birth new Artifacts for me Artifacts Artifacts Artifacts I want Artifacts I want them so badly so badly so badly so, hm? What is this?"

It lowered its head, extended two fingers like safety bollards, and pinched a gun up from the ground.

...A plastic water pistol.

"This is what you've been hiding on you the whole time?" The Resident turned its head, looked at the two people on the ground, and took a long, deep sniff. "What kind of liquid is inside? The smell is strange."

London Moon smiled a silent, bitter smile.

She shot a glance at Sydney Ginn and said quietly: "You really are a genius at ruining things... Great, now that it's gone, I can't even get the Artifact. Are you ready to retreat together?"

This chapter ran quite long to write, but in reality only a few minutes may have passed. During those few minutes, Chamara has been dead the whole time—no need to worry, everyone.

I've genuinely had a bit of bad luck these past few days—nothing catastrophic, just a relentless stream of petty, grinding little problems... I console myself that luck evens out in the

end, so a big windfall must be coming my way. And if it doesn't, well, the universe owes me another enormous debt.

Chapter 181: Sydney Ginn — A Key House Loyalist on Outsourced Contract?

The conversation that followed was one between Sydney Ginn and London Moon — carried out in scattered fragments stolen between running, dodging, fleeing, finding cover, and the occasional counterattack.

Naturally, the fluff has been trimmed.

If it were transcribed verbatim, it would inevitably be riddled with heavy panting, collision sounds, the sharp screech of shoes skidding across the floor, and meaningless shouts like "Ah—" "It's coming—" "Over there—" "Are you trying to get yourself killed—" — along with every manner of profanity directed at the Resident.

For several minutes, the Slender Patient didn't let out that nauseating, dizzying shriek even once, and simply kept swatting at the two of them like it was swatting flies — in hindsight, Sydney Ginn had only one explanation for it.

Residents have a powerful sense of curiosity, don't they?

If two people are arguing loudly in the street, anyone passing by can't help but perk up and catch a snippet — Residents are born from humans, so inheriting that nosy streak isn't surprising at all.

Whatever retreat plan London Moon might have had originally, it was completely laid bare in the process of the two of them arguing while running for their lives.

"I've been wanting to leave for a while now," Sydney Ginn said — naturally, this too came out in broken fragments — "so do I grab Chase's feet while you lift his shoulders, or what?"

London Moon, in the middle of everything, still managed to shoot her a look that said she thought Sydney was an idiot.

"Never mind whether the Resident will even give us time to carry someone — do you really think I'm going to help you rescue the very person I came here to assassinate today?"

"How deep does the grudge even run? Do you really have to kill him? Dead men are bad for business down the line — think it over."

The Slender Patient's arm shot out like a frog's tongue, but Sydney Ginn sidestepped it and it hit nothing; when London Moon fired back a reply, its attention shifted to London Moon.

"It's not some blood feud between me and him — but it's also none of your business. Didn't you just meet him? Why are you throwing yourself into this for his sake? Ha, truly worthy of being the senior I know..."

"Senior? You went to the same school?"

After receiving a confirmation — and another attack courtesy of the Resident — Sydney Ginn said, breathless, "I came here today specifically to rescue him, and now he's just hanging there, and you want me to turn around and leave? What kind of half-finished nonsense is that?"

"Half-finished can keep you alive — going all the way through might just get you killed!"

"No, but then what did I even come here to do today? If I'd just stayed home and kept sleeping, couldn't I have lived just as well?"

"Yes!" London Moon seemed to have reached the end of her rope. "I wish you had stayed home sleeping! Nobody invited you here to mess things up, alright?"

"That's not necessarily true... who told you to use me as bait? I'm on your senior's side now."

Between those few lines, Sydney Ginn dove and rolled, snatched the hammer off the floor, and swung it up just in time to strike the hand coming down at her — since each cube's effect began to wane after the second use, she switched to the left-side cube this time, and sent the Resident stumbling back several steps with a pained shriek.

"Since I got here, I've been beaten up, fought for my life, and had my mind attacked — I've already suffered so much. And now you want me to give up? Can I really just accept that? All that suffering for nothing?"

Sydney Ginn shouted this as she ran, and in the same motion reached out and grabbed at the little figurine in Chase's mouth — she didn't even have the spare attention to be disgusted by its slippery nakedness. But she hadn't expected that grabbing it would introduce her to an entirely different flavor of disgust: the little figurine seemed practically fused to Chase's tongue; when she pulled, it didn't budge at all.

Now the David-in-the-Pietà was sticking out its tongue.

"...Have you ever heard of the 'sunk cost' theory?"

London Moon glanced at Chase, and her face twitched. The expression looked like it was saying, "I might as well have let me kill him."

"I know what it is. So what?" Sydney Ginn said. "Let me ask you — who sank my costs? Whoever sank them is responsible for pulling them back up."

"...The Resident."

The Slender Patient made a small sound — "Hm?" — "Nonsense. The culprit is obviously you."

"See? Even the Resident has more sense than you!"

London Moon seemed to finally reach her limit.

The next time Sydney Ginn was attacked by the perfectly reasonable Resident, London Moon simply turned and walked toward the ward door, dropping a parting line: "You don't want to leave, fine — I'm leaving. I'll cancel the Docking. Good luck."

"Huh?"

Sydney Ginn rolled under Chase's hospital bed and barely ducked the blow, but those words genuinely rattled her: "Wait — hey!"

In truth, she hadn't held out any hope — she'd assumed London Moon was really going to leave.

And yet London Moon truly did stop at the door.

She had one hand on the door handle and didn't move for nearly a full second.

After a beat of confusion, Sydney Ginn suddenly realized that the reason she hadn't pulled the door open was because she couldn't.

London Moon frowned and looked up at the door first, then turned to glance at the Slender Patient — as if for a split second, she'd thought the Slender Patient had stretched out its arm and was holding the door shut.

Both Sydney Ginn and the Slender Patient were seized by curiosity at the same moment, and asked in unison: "What's going on?"

"...Someone on the other side is holding the door shut. I can't pull it open."

As she said it, London Moon clenched her teeth, braced herself, and yanked at the door with all her strength; she clearly had no small amount of force, yet the door didn't budge in the slightest.

"Who's out there?" London Moon demanded.

"Mm... there's a smell..."

The Slender Patient kept its eyes fixed on the door, took several long, deep sniffs, and absentmindedly attacked Sydney Ginn a few times — projecting the energy of someone punching in at work.

But Sydney Ginn was flat on the floor under the hospital bed, rolling back and forth to dodge the Resident's attacks, desperate to know who was outside the door, and unwilling to let the little figurine burrow completely into Chase's mouth — her attention felt like it had taken a bomb hit, blown apart in every direction with nothing left intact, and she had no idea what to focus on first.

Just as she was at her wits' end, her gaze swept across the floor and she suddenly noticed the locked wheels on the hospital bed's legs.

Right... there was still that option.

She didn't know why, but this was a good moment — for several seconds, no one in the room spoke, and even the Resident left her alone.

In the silence, a familiar female voice suddenly drifted through the gap at the edge of the door.

The voice pressed up against the outside of the door and asked, quietly: "Excuse me... is Sydney Ginn in there?"

London Moon and the Slender Patient both turned to look at her.

"June!"

Sydney Ginn shot up in surprise, forgetting she was still under the hospital bed, and cracked her head against it with a solid thud. "I'm here — Chase is here too! What took you so long? How many people did you bring? Get in here and help!"

Outside the door, silence fell.

For some reason, in the long, nearly frozen quiet that followed, neither person nor Resident said a word.

"That... is someone you know?"

London Moon had already turned and walked back. She finally broke the silence, standing in a corner well away from the Slender Patient, and said in a low voice: "Are you sure?"

Sydney Ginn paused. "She's from Key House. I know her."

"Do people from Key House... usually press their nose and mouth against the door gap to talk?"

What?

Outside the door, June spoke again.

This time, alerted by London Moon, Sydney Ginn heard it too — clearly and unmistakably — the voice carried a peculiar texture when it came through; it made her almost able to picture it: June's cheek pressed against the doorframe, nose and mouth wedged into the door gap, breath warm and damp against the panel, voice threading itself inch by inch into the ward.

"...You can't come out yet."

June's voice drifted through the door gap, quiet and unhurried: "Do you want to leave? Make sure Chase Monroe is safe and sound, bring him along, and I'll open the door for you."

For some reason, chapters from Sydney Ginn's perspective are hard to write seriously... I suppose that says something about what kind of person she is.

Today's chapter is short, because I'm so tired I've started nodding off at the screen... what can I say — I really need to lie down and let my brain reset. The moment I actually get ready for bed, I'm instantly wide awake. Works better than Red Bull.

Haven't put on the classic traditional performance in a while.

Here's the thing — it's not that I'm too exhausted and want to take a day off. It's that I haven't taken a day off in so long, I'm worried you'll all be frightened.

Hey, that rhymed.

You see, a leopard can't change its spots, and it turns out I've gone... let me count... three years and nine months without a single day off. You must all be feeling uneasy, not sure whether the person on the other end of the screen is actually me, or whether I've been possessed.

You know how it is — aliens disguising themselves as humans. It's been in the news.

To prove that I am, in fact, human — that I genuinely can get too exhausted from chronic sleep deprivation to summon the energy to update — I have to take a day off just to confirm my own existence.

Honestly, I don't know when it'll be my turn to get replaced by an alien... I can barely wait.

When that happens, all my exhaustion, headaches, and update obligations become that poor sucker's problem. Come on, already — where are the aliens?

Chapter 182: Sydney Ginn's Allegiances Shift by the Second

For a brief moment, both Sydney Ginn and London Moon froze.

London Moon hadn't expected someone to suddenly appear and block the doorway; Sydney Ginn, on the other hand, couldn't understand why Han June had dumped the whole mess squarely on her shoulders—had she lost her mind?

In the brief silence brought on by suspicion, confusion, and shock, the first one in the ward to react was the elongated patient.

Drawn by some barely audible, faint rustling, Sydney Ginn looked up just in time to see an arm in midair extending joint by joint, spanning the width of the room, and in the blink of an eye—smack—it slammed firmly against the door.

Even if Han June was willing to open the door, could she push it open now?

"So strange so jealous so unfair I want to go out too how did you get to the other side of the human world I can smell you smells don't lie you're something from the Nest what are you what are you"

Sydney Ginn's heart plummeted straight down into her gut.

...What had happened to Han June?

Had she been infected inside the Nest?

"That has nothing to do with you. I want that person—Chase Monroe."

Han June's voice came from outside the door, calm and quiet: "Stay out of my business. As long as you let him out, you can do whatever you want with the other two Hunters. I don't care."

So no matter who conceded in this negotiation, both she and London Moon would end up with nothing good?

Sydney Ginn, pressed flat on the floor, swept her gaze around the room and spotted London Moon's plastic water gun—the one with the unclear purpose—which the Resident had casually tossed aside earlier and landed on the floor next to its own hospital bed.

She and London Moon exchanged a glance.

At that moment, the elongated patient made a show of considering for a moment, then smiled. "Then why don't you just come in and take him yourself? What are you afraid of? Are you scared that if you come back to the Nest, you won't be able to leave?"

...No time to worry about Han June now.

Sydney Ginn silently made a gun gesture toward London Moon with one hand, opening and closing the other over the "muzzle" to mime water splashing everywhere, then pointed behind herself—she hadn't really expected London Moon to understand, but the latter somehow did, and even gave her a nod.

Before Han June could answer, the elongated patient spoke again, its voice suddenly thicker and stickier:

"I've decided—all three people in this room are mine...whether Artifact or flesh and blood I want them all I want them all I want them all who cares about you who wants to cooperate with you this world should revolve around me to begin with my desires are the most important thing the most important thing"

Trouble—it seemed like it was about to get serious.

The thought had barely formed when the patient's other arm shot out like a cracking whip, sweeping across half the ward, lunging toward London Moon in the corner.

As the air split open, the skin of its arm split open too, in thin, fraying ribbons.

Accompanied by a howling rush of wind, tumor-like human faces crowded and pushed out from the splits in the skin, one after another, rising and falling in a chorus as they cried out:

"Why should I share with anyone I hate everyone else they're all mine they're all mine every Artifact money food resources dead people in the world it would be best if I could hoard it all even if I can't use it even if I waste every last bit of it I still won't give even a scrap to anyone else"

This Resident...was truly very human.

London Moon had also anticipated the patient's attack—she let out a shout of "Go, now!" and threw herself onto the nearest hospital bed, rolling aside, the arm grazing past barely above her head before smashing into the wall, sending the entire ward shuddering and raining down flurries of dust.

She'd dodged the arm, but not, it seemed, the faces packed inside it.

Sydney Ginn only heard her suddenly cry out in pain, but there was no time to look at what had happened—seizing the moment when the elongated patient's attention was off her, she quickly rolled across the floor under Chase's hospital bed, grabbed the plastic water gun, and jumped to her feet with the hammer in one hand and the water gun in the other.

One look, and she sucked in a sharp breath, crying out in alarm: "London Moon!"

London Moon hadn't been able to dodge in time; on her back and shoulders, three or four blurry-featured, tumor-like human faces had sprouted up like mushrooms after rain.

"Such beautiful eyes such a beautiful face such lovely skin give them to me give them to me I want them I want them look at me I don't even have a single hair"

London Moon landed a punch on the face that was pressing toward her own, driving it back a few centimeters—only a few centimeters, because the base of its neck was fused into her right shoulder, having dissolved away a patch of fabric.

The faces growing out of her back and along her waist, she couldn't reach.

"Your turn," said the elongated patient, one hand braced against the door, swinging the other at Sydney Ginn again.

Sydney Ginn had no time to spare for London Moon; she dove desperately between the hospital beds, her shoulder slamming into Chase's bed and knocking it skidding back a few paces.

The Resident's arm swept overhead, tearing down the curtain and ripping the rail from the ceiling; from the ensuing chaos, several faces came fluttering down like a flock of birds, like enormous mushrooms hopping on one leg, swarming toward Sydney Ginn.

She swung the hammer and sent one lunging face flying, then kicked another away. Half her body under the bed, half exposed, she shouted: "London Moon! Can you still hold on? Cancel the Docking, now!"

Without canceling the Docking, with the ward door blocked, they had nowhere to run; cancel the Docking, and at least they could flee back into the Nest.

"No!"

London Moon could at least still speak, though every word seemed to be wrung out through gritted teeth: "If we cancel the Docking, all three of us will be thrown into random locations inside the Nest—"

Sydney Ginn froze.

Chase, unconscious, thrown alone into a random location inside the Nest—that was essentially a death sentence; but that still wasn't the worst of it.

"These faces are drilling into my body. I'm running out of time. If I'm thrown into the Nest right now—" London Moon's words broke off, cut short by a cry of pain she could no longer suppress.

She didn't need to finish. Sydney Ginn understood.

Those faces parasitizing a person's body were, in essence, products of the Nest; and Nest products, as a rule, could only exist within the Nest.

The best and fastest way to rescue London Moon from the parasites would be to immediately cross back through the doorway and return to Blackmoor City—like bacteria submerged in alcohol, the vast majority of Nest products would break down and vanish in the human world.

But if they fell into the Nest, who knew how long it would take to get back to the human world?

Neither London Moon nor Chase had time to spare.

Sydney Ginn's attention lapsed for just an instant—and a face had already landed on her chest; the Resident's arm yanked Chase's hospital bed aside, exposing her and the face together under the light.

She hadn't been parasitized yet—she had to avoid skin contact, right?

Sydney Ginn's scalp crawled with terror; in her frantic panic, the corner of her eye caught a flash of pale blue. She grabbed the curtain that the Resident had knocked down, draped it over the face, wrapped it up, and slammed it hard onto the floor—and only after dodging another sweeping strike from the Resident did she belatedly register that London Moon had made it to her side.

"Give me the weapons!"

She turned her head and saw that the face on London Moon's shoulder could no longer be called a face—it looked as if something heavy had come crashing down on it, caving it into a hollow, concave bowl of flesh.

Even with the horrifying state of her body, London Moon still seemed to have kept her wits and composure.

"I'll hold it off," London Moon ordered. "You get Chase to the door!"

Drained of all color, her face was ashen, faces sprouting from her body—and yet she had still noticed that Sydney Ginn had already unlocked the wheels on the hospital bed.

Sydney Ginn's hesitation lasted only a flash, and she threw both the hammer and the water gun to her.

From here on out, her back was entirely in London Moon's hands.

Once her mind was made up, Sydney Ginn didn't waver for even half a second.

She didn't spare the Resident a single glance, bent down, seized the hospital bed, and ran with it toward the door; London Moon didn't spare Chase a single glance, swept past her, and threw herself straight at the Resident behind Sydney Ginn.

The Resident swung an arm at her, as expected—she didn't know what London Moon did, but the blow was cut short halfway through, replaced instead by a howl from the Resident so dizzying and nauseating it made the stomach turn.

"My foot! My foot my foot my foot!"

Sydney Ginn forced back a surge of bile.

Just dizziness; even if she died, she would die running.

Behind her, London Moon's shout echoed through the entire ward: "Chase is coming through! It had the door pinned—open it for us!"

"Open the door!"

Sydney Ginn pushed the hospital bed forward, Chase's head lolling back and forth at the edge. The ward door was only a few steps away now. "We're coming through!"

It was right at that moment that she heard the thin, sharp voice.

Only when she heard it did Sydney Ginn suddenly remember that the little figure had never left Chase's mouth.

It was now poking its upper body out from between Chase's lips, both arms wrapped tightly around its own chest—though it was impossible to make out what it was holding in them.

"I got it! The Rumor Artifact is so unhappy about it—it's been struggling this whole time trying to get back into his mouth, but I've been holding it so tight tight tight tight tight it can't escape!"

So the Resident's top priority was, after all, the Artifact.

The moment the little figure called out, the elongated patient immediately wanted nothing more than to get it into its hands at once.

Its other hand seemed to have been tied up by London Moon; when Sydney Ginn hurriedly looked up, she caught a glimpse of the hand that had been braced against the door—the one that looked as though it had grown countless tentacles—releasing the door and swiping down toward Chase's face.

Wasn't this the chance to get out?

Honestly, at this point, as long as she could hand a living Chase over to Han June in exchange for her own and London Moon's lives, Sydney Ginn would be satisfied.

As for whether the tongue Artifact could be kept safe—that wasn't her responsibility; she'd even be fine handing it over to the elongated patient.

But she never could have imagined that, right now, in this very ward, there was actually someone else who didn't see it that way.

As the elongated patient's hand clawed down toward Chase's face, London Moon arrived in great bounding strides—in barely under ten seconds, she looked almost indistinguishable from a corpse that refused to admit it was dead.

...How much was she getting paid? To risk her life this desperately over an Artifact?

The Resident's hand closed first around Chase's face—and the little figure inside his mouth.

It felt as though all it needed to do was squeeze and yank, and by the time it lifted its hand, Chase might have nothing left above the back of his skull.

"Open the door!"

Sydney Ginn had no other option; she could only shout in fury, hoping to push Chase out before it was too late—but the hospital bed was no lightweight, and with the Resident's hand pinning Chase down, those few steps between her and the doorway felt as vast and uncrossable as a chasm.

London Moon, having just arrived, didn't say a word—she leveled the plastic water gun directly at the thin, fraying black splits running along the Resident's arm.

A stream of black, filthy water shot straight into the splits, almost as if driven by fury.

The faces inside the arm's splits took a direct hit from the black water; the splits were far deeper than Sydney Ginn had imagined—almost none of the black water was wasted, every last drop pouring into the Resident's arm—and a damp, metallic, earthy smell immediately drifted through the air, faintly reminiscent of spoiled beer left in the sun for three days and then soaked by rain.

...What was that stuff?

But the howl she'd braced for never came.

The Resident's hand was still pressed against Chase's face, and everything looked the same as before—no. Wait, that wasn't right.

Sydney Ginn suddenly realized that the Resident had stopped moving.

The little figure seemed to still be inside Chase's mouth, letting out a puzzled "Hm?"

When Sydney Ginn turned her head, she found that the Resident's face was right up against her back, less than a fist's width away.

Those two eyeball-like lumps at the base of its feet stared directly at Sydney Ginn, completely motionless.

"Wh-what happened?" Sydney Ginn's breathing was unsteady; she was afraid that even a slightly louder voice might shatter the fragile quiet. "What did you spray in there?"

"Ayahuasca,"

London Moon spoke through gritted teeth, stepping over to Chase's side and using Sydney Ginn's hammer to slowly, bit by bit, lift the Resident's hand—trying to gently pry it away and retrieve the little figure and the Artifact. "Similar to your hammer in a way—it only works the first time it's used."

Sydney Ginn blanked for a moment before remembering what Ayahuasca was.

"A hallucinogen—does it work on Residents too?"

London Moon seemed to have no energy left to talk with her.

She was terrified of startling the Resident back to full wakefulness, so she moved slowly and gently, even keeping her voice low: "Don't stop me. This Artifact—I have to, today—"

"You lied to me."

June's voice drifted through the gap in the door, faint and distant.

"You're still some distance from the door... and I haven't heard Chase say anything either. Whether he's even still alive, I don't know. Please have him say a few words to prove he's alive, and I'll open it—"

She had interrupted London Moon's words, and now she couldn't finish her own; all that came from outside the door was a heavy, muffled thud, followed by what sounded like a skull cracking against a wall and a body tumbling to the floor.

Sydney Ginn startled—and in the next second, the ward door was kicked open.

"Sister London Moon!"

The brown-haired Love Hunter was standing in the doorway, swinging an iron rod from who-knows-where, and called out: "I got the door open for you—huh? What happened to you—"

She couldn't finish her words either.

The ward door slammed into the wall with a "thud," startling the lanky patient into a jolt, who let out a "mmph," as if about to surface from the hallucination.

...This was the only chance.

"June!"

Sydney Ginn raised her voice with every ounce of strength she had, and while London Moon and the Resident had yet to react, she shoved the hospital bed toward the doorway with everything she had: "Catch your Chase right now!"

The Resident seemed not yet fully awake and hadn't tightened its grip. The bed slipped out from under its hands and rolled all the way to the doorway; the Love Hunter startled and instinctively stepped aside.

In that instant, Sydney Ginn suddenly realized she might have made a mistake.

June had most likely been knocked down by the Love Hunter, so there was no one outside to catch Chase—and if London Moon told the Love Hunter to block the bed—

London Moon seemed to let out a sigh.

It was the kind of sigh a person exhales when they have given a hundred and twenty percent and must still accept a less-than-ideal outcome—exhausted, yet carrying a faint trace of relief.

"Go, quickly," she called to Sydney Ginn in a low voice, "the Resident is waking up."

At the same time, Sydney Ginn was already running toward the ward doorway—Chase's bed had clipped the wall at the entrance and sent him tumbling off the mattress and onto the floor.

Only then did Sydney Ginn suddenly notice that a woman wearing a wide-brimmed sun hat was crouching on the floor outside the door—she had simply been blocked from view by the Love Hunter before.

...Who was that?

The woman in the sun hat reached out, grabbed Chase, and dragged him from the Nest into the real world.

I can't write the Chinese translation of "ayahuasca"—I can only use the transliteration—because I'm afraid of getting flagged. If you're curious, just look it up yourselves; it doesn't affect the plot anyway.

Yesterday I finally managed to sleep a bit longer, and today the results showed immediately—I wrote over four thousand characters! Rest truly is the medicine that keeps you going.

By the way, I've opened a side-story volume and plan to ask the editor to move it in front of the main text—in the future, any of you readers who are interested can go read the extras before the main story.

Chapter 183: The Moment Sydney Ginn Has Been Waiting For

The few seconds of escaping through the door were pure chaos.

Under extreme tension, all Sydney Ginn could see were swaying blobs of color and limbs; the air was riddled with shard-like screams and collision sounds, and someone's urgent shouting... she hadn't seen it happen, yet she simply knew—the Resident behind her had woken up.

The terror of being half a second too late and never making it back to the human world was stronger than any other motivation. She shoved aside the obstructing hospital bed, grabbed London Moon and lunged out through the door—but her feet caught on Chase—and just like that, Sydney Ginn tumbled into the corridor and fell back into the human world.

London Moon crashed down beside her, and the several human faces on her body instantly let out piercing shrieks.

Sydney Ginn looked up and found she couldn't even make out London Moon's features anymore, because those faces were rapidly and profusely billowing smoke—like effervescent tablets dropped into water—and shrinking at a furious rate amid the rolling white vapor.

That meant she was going to be fine, right?

The Hunter of Love rushed over with the momentum and speed of a Cupid's arrow; she steadied London Moon and asked urgently, "Sister, are you all right? Does anything hurt?"

Good—someone was looking after her.

Sydney Ginn turned back and found that the hospital room door had become a picture frame, framing the elongated patient's face—at some point, its face had filled the entire doorframe, as if desperate to squeeze through with eyes about to burst; yet it was always just one fingernail's width short of the corridor and the human world, unable to cross over.

"London Moon——"

Before she could finish calling out, the next second the elongated patient's face—and the doorframe it gripped so tightly—began to rapidly recede and shrink, plunging into a dim murk in the depths—it seemed to be howling, only Sydney Ginn heard nothing.

In another blink, the space behind the door was empty, and it had become an unfamiliar private hospital room with an antechamber and an inner room.

"It's over," London Moon said breathlessly. "The Docking was cancelled... it can't come back."

Sydney Ginn hadn't even had time to nod before she heard Chase let out a joyful shriek.

"I'm back! I'm back in Blackmoor City, I'm back in the human world!"

"...Chase?"

Sydney Ginn called out in a daze, then realized Chase's eyes were still tightly shut and he was unconscious—the straw-hat woman had her back to her, bent down, and was pinching Chase's mouth open.

A bare little figure immediately popped its head out.

Its two hands were no longer clutched tightly to its chest—it seemed to have put the whole Artifact business completely out of its mind; it looked around, saw the elongated patient was already gone, and immediately stepped one foot out from Chase's lower lip.

"I'm free hahahahaha I survived I'm back in the human world I'm going to find a wife Hunters with experiences like mine are one in ten thousand such a rich life history is all wealth from now on follow me and she'll have endless benefits heh heh heh"

For several seconds, no one in the corridor said a word; they could only stare at it blankly.

The bare little figure jumped down to the floor and suddenly broke into a run, whooping as it thundered off toward the other end of the corridor—with every step it took, it grew a little larger; by the time it ran into the empty waiting area at the end of the corridor, the bare little figure had become a bare, full-sized person.

Only what ought to be there was, as always, entirely absent.

No one thought to go after it—naturally, since everyone was busy keeping their distance.

Sydney Ginn stared slack-jawed as it disappeared around the corner, having no idea where it had run off to, and for a moment even wondered if she was the one who had accidentally drunk the Ayahuasca and was having hallucinations.

A lump slid across Chase's cheek.

"It... isn't it also a product of the Nest? Shouldn't it disappear outright, just like the faces on you? This is the human world——"

Sydney Ginn had been saying these words to London Moon, but before she finished, she suddenly realized something—belatedly—and couldn't continue.

...Wasn't the corridor a little too crowded?

The stretch of corridor in front of the hospital room was packed, full of people.

Sydney Ginn raised her head and slowly looked around.

The Hunter of Love still had her arm around London Moon's shoulder, but her other hand gripped an iron rod tightly, as if ready to swing at any moment.

Chase was unconscious, so he could be set aside for now; the woman beside him still had her head lowered, face hidden beneath black hair and the straw hat—could she be a helper that Han Six Months had brought?

Surrounding them was a ring of backs that Sydney Ginn found vaguely familiar.

A tall, heavily muscled security guard; a woman in a front-desk uniform; two nurses in pale blue; a doctor.

No one spoke, and no one moved—they simply stood with their backs to Sydney Ginn, silent and still.

Sydney Ginn suddenly leaped to her feet, remembering abruptly that someone who should have been here was nowhere to be seen.

"Who are you people? Where's June? June!"

"...I'm right here."

Sydney Ginn followed the voice and turned her eyes in a daze.

The straw-hatted head of thick, petroleum-black hair slowly turned away from that woman's shoulder, little by little, revealing a snow-white, puffy face.

Tiny black holes for eyes, like a mosquito's; a sharp, red mouth.

But compared to the first time she had seen it in the parking lot, the face before her was not complete: like a mask that had been smashed apart, several patches of snow-white were missing from the chin, cheeks, and forehead, exposing dark, hollow gaps beneath.

...Counting carefully, the Noh mask-like face was missing five pieces.

From that mouth came June's voice: "...You did well. Big Brother Chase is still alive."

Sydney Ginn snapped her eyes shut.

When she opened them again, maybe she'd wake up—still lying in her own bed at home.

"You're still as spirited as last time. As for me, I ran into a bit of a tricky problem."

Sydney Ginn opened her eyes.

"A problem? You mean your face?"

The Noh mask wearing June's voice paid her no mind, and simply continued: "You see, I originally wanted to visit a friend. But I've been back in Blackmoor City for two days, and I've found it's not easy to visit him..."

"Never mind that for now—let's talk about your face first."

"The first problem is that I need someone to guide me——"

"Have you looked in a mirror? I think you should see a doctor—or a carpenter."

London Moon couldn't help herself and called out: "Sydney Ginn."

She snapped her head toward London Moon, momentarily unable to keep her voice under control: "What? She's not June at all!"

"...I know. Just hear what she has to say first."

London Moon's voice was soothing, even a little gentle. She glanced at the silent backs of the hospital staff nearby and said, "Those five ending up like this seems to be connected to her somehow."

Sydney Ginn took a long, deep breath.

"The first problem is relatively minor—the second one is more troublesome."

The June who looked like a Noh mask carried on as if oblivious to them: "Chase Monroe is really such a meddler. He used to sell a defensive Artifact to that friend of mine I need to see. This makes it rather difficult for me to get close to him... honestly, why be so inhospitable? Anyway, if there's anyone in the world who understands the limits of that Artifact and knows how to approach its owner, it can only be Big Brother Chase."

She still mixed in a portion of June's speech patterns and habits, as if June were nothing more than one of the raw materials that had formed her.

"Who is the person you want to see?" Sydney Ginn asked, keeping her voice as steady as she could.

"June" paid her no heed and simply continued.

"Chase has to wake up and regain consciousness before he can take me to see that friend. Aren't we in a hospital right now? I don't care what method you use—get him revived. I've decided to give you thirty minutes. If he hasn't woken up by then..."

"Wait, there's a doctor here."

London Moon pointed and said, "You seem to have him under your control, right? Just have him go treat Chase. I promise we won't get in your way— isn't that enough?"

"June" didn't move, but the doctor seemed to hear a silent command and slowly turned around.

He looked exactly like a normal person—or rather, he looked exactly like a normal person with a dazed expression, in the middle of sleepwalking.

The only difference was that near his hairline, there was a patch on his forehead that was not human skin, but a small, hard, smooth piece of snow-white.

Its edge and size fit perfectly with the missing piece of "June's" forehead.

"Unfortunately, that won't work. There must be other doctors around—go find another one. This one is unusable."

Sydney Ginn found herself instinctively looking for a hammer—she spotted it in London Moon's hand; but London Moon was staring at her and shook her head.

"Why is he unusable?" It was the Hunter of Love who ended up asking.

True to her Hunter nature, she immediately had a theory: "Did you infect them? Will they slowly grow to look like you? Will they then infect others?"

"June" seemed puzzled.

After two seconds, she spoke: "No. It's just that when I inserted a piece of my face into his forehead, a root accidentally went too deep into his brain—seems it went in too far, so he's unusable now."

A root? This thing had roots underneath?

Wait—then what about June, whose entire face had been covered—

Just as Sydney Ginn was about to speak, Chase, lying on the floor, let out a low, muffled groan.

I suddenly remembered something from a few years ago—I was commissioned to write *Milady for Honor of Kings*, and after it came out, a male reader specifically sent me a private message criticizing my shallow understanding of the West and lecturing me that I should learn more about Western society; at the very least, read more Western literature.

What can I say—at the time, besides feeling surprised (I hadn't realized *Milady* was set in a real-world Western society), I also thought: even a British sociologist wouldn't dare claim to fully understand the "Western society" they live in, so you can always criticize someone for not knowing enough. Needless to say, that goes doubly for me.

By the same logic, if you tell anyone "you should read more books," the other person doesn't have the nerve to say "I have already read every book under heaven."

This ensures that such guidance is absolutely correct.

As you can also see, offering this kind of guidance requires no qualifications whatsoever—only the confidence to pronounce judgment on the world.

That confidence is something I genuinely need—where can I order some?

P.S.: The bonus chapters from the tipping event have been moved to the foreword section before the main text—welcome to those who haven't read them yet.

Chapter 184: Sydney Ginn Always Keeps Thinking About the Same Person's Artifact Report

His eyelids trembled faintly, as though resisting some deep temptation, opening and closing several times before finally, slowly, parting.

Sydney Ginn hadn't known Chase long, but she would have wagered that before tonight, almost no one in the world had ever seen him wear this expression—a light, boyish bewilderment and blankness, as if the identity of "Chase Monroe" hadn't yet caught up with him, hadn't yet settled onto his shoulders.

For one brief instant, she suddenly wondered: if Chase had never entered Key House Faction, what kind of person would he be now?

Perhaps no one would ever know the answer—including Chase himself.

Because of where she was standing, Chase caught sight of Sydney Ginn first.

"Hey," Sydney Ginn gave him a little wave.

The faintest flicker of disbelief had just risen on Chase's face when "June" immediately leaned her head over: "You're finally awake?"

The moment he saw clearly, Chase recoiled as if he'd touched a live wire, and his head knocked against the wall with a thud.

London Moon couldn't hold it in—a stifled "pfft" escaped through her nose.

That laugh, barely suppressed and ultimately lost, made Chase glance sharply at her. He braced one hand against the floor and tried to push himself up, but he swayed and his body was too weak to find any strength.

"What... what's going on?"

In the end he could only lean against the wall and sit there with effort, his gaze sweeping around a few times. He reached behind his lower back—he must have been reaching for a weapon. Of course, having gone through two hospitals in succession, there was no way he still had one; his hand found nothing.

"Don't worry, nobody wants you dead right now," Sydney Ginn offered by way of comfort.

"Right, London Moon?"

London Moon looked away and said nothing, as though she wasn't entirely satisfied with that.

"I don't understand this situation," Chase said quietly.

Never mind him—Sydney Ginn had been conscious the whole time and didn't dare claim she fully understood it either.

But the single most important point was one that not only she understood clearly; Chase needed to understand it clearly too.

"I saved your life," she said solemnly. "The details, and things like how you'll repay me—we can talk about all that in a bit."

Chase blinked at her blankly.

Sydney Ginn glanced at London Moon and made an urging gesture.

"It's true," London Moon said with a sigh. "Without her tonight, you wouldn't have survived."

"That is indeed a fact." The Noh-masked June added a line of her own.

"I don't know any of you, but if Sister London Moon says so, then it must be." The Love Hunter chimed in as well.

"All right, I get it after hearing it once."

As his consciousness and memory returned, Chase gradually reverted to his usual self—no matter who he faced, it was as though he were always searching from somewhere deep in his eyes, probing, sniffing out weaknesses to exploit.

Apparently reading that "June" had no intention of making a move, he slowly asked: "... What about those two men who were guarding you?"

"June" pointed to the missing fragments on her own face, then pointed to the silent hospital staff standing nearby.

"True to form, Chase—first thing you do is worry about the House Faction's people. Don't worry. When I left Key House headquarters, I pulled my face's fragments out of their faces. They definitely took a serious psychological hit, but their lives should be fine."

Chase's gaze shifted back and forth twice; he seemed to grasp her relationship with those hospital staff members.

"I fell from the building—I must have been brought to the emergency room... but this doesn't look like an ordinary hospital." He fixed his eyes on London Moon and said, "Why are you here?"

"Even if I said I came to visit a patient, you wouldn't believe me, would you, senior?" London Moon gave a soft laugh and stood up.

She was in quite a sorry state: not only was her complexion terrible, her body covered in scrapes and dust, but the places where human faces had grown from her clothes had left behind several large holes, making her look not much different from a vagrant.

"You came to kill me, and Sydney Ginn saved me from you?" Chase leaned against the wall and asked quietly. "How did you know..."

"In this day and age, a video of someone tumbling off a building with a goat's head is enough to spread across the entire internet in minutes—especially when the person who uploaded the video swears on their life that what they saw with their own eyes was not a goat's head."

London Moon handed the hammer back to Sydney Ginn, dusted herself off, and said with a smile, "Senior, I'm not entirely disappointed that you survived. There'll always be a next chance to assassinate you—until we meet again. Oh, and if I were you, even if I couldn't walk, I'd crawl my way out of this hospital as soon as possible."

If Chase had still been his old self, he would never have let her turn around and walk away so easily—but right now, the slightest movement drained the color from his face, and he was completely powerless to stop London Moon.

Just as London Moon and the Love Hunter had taken a few steps toward the exit, Chase suddenly asked out of nowhere: "Who is Brianna?"

London Moon stopped dead.

She stood motionless for a few seconds, then turned her head. In those eyes was something like a polar sea frozen beneath a blue sky.

For some reason, she glanced at Sydney Ginn first.

Then, slowly, London Moon said: "...Brianna has been dead for a long time."

Chase gave a cold laugh. "Impossible."

"No—I'm not lying to you."

London Moon lowered her eyes and said, "Brianna is no longer in this world. If she were still alive... I wouldn't be here right now, trying to assassinate you."

"Huh?" Sydney Ginn was confused. "You're killing him because that's Brianna's dying wish?"

But London Moon didn't answer her.

As if she hadn't heard a word, she didn't spare Sydney Ginn another glance; she simply raised her foot and walked away. The Love Hunter followed behind her, looking back over his shoulder several times with wariness written all over him, as if worried someone might ambush them from behind.

"Aren't you leaving?"

"June" suddenly looked at Sydney Ginn and said, "He's already awake. I don't need you anymore. You should do what that blue-eyed one did and leave early—that's the smart thing to do."

"If I'd known you were going to turn out like this, I should've just let the Vulture make a backup of you," Sydney Ginn said furiously, pointing at her, then turning to Chase: "She says she's June!"

Chase glanced at "June" and said, "...She is."

Sydney Ginn felt as if someone had shoved a fist into her mouth.

"I truly am June."

That snow-white face, missing five fragments, said plainly: "But I can also not be."

Before Sydney Ginn could process that, Chase snapped his head up. "What do you mean?"

"Exactly what I said. I already told you just now—I need you to take me to see a friend. Once I've met that friend, I will be them, and no longer June."

Sydney Ginn blinked, trying to make sense of it: "Then—then what about June?"

"June will still be in this world at that point."

The Noh mask beneath the straw hat spoke in a matter-of-fact tone.

"My first question is... are you saying you haven't fully 'alienated' June yet?" Chase was still weak; merely sitting up straight and asking that single question left him slightly breathless.

"June" let out a sigh, as if Chase were being rather slow.

"I said—I am June. But I can also not be."

"I know—"

"Right now, I haven't yet made my final decision about who I should become. Only after I've met that friend will I be able to make my final decision."

Chase gave a slow nod.

"My second question is: who is the person you want to meet?"

His words had barely fallen when Sydney Ginn suddenly heard her phone buzzing and vibrating inside her bag. She pulled it out, and as she looked up, she met Chase's gaze.

"...The Nest?" he asked quietly.

Sydney Ginn nodded.

The two of them only learned afterward that at the very same moment she received the message, in another hospital in Blackmoor City, a phone inside a cardboard box holding unclaimed belongings received the exact same message—the phone screen lit up, casting its light on a photo of Chase on a driver's license beside it.

«Artifact Report»

Only those who have made a change in the world deserve the right to advance

Dear lovely competitor Sydney Ginn:

Congratulations on qualifying to receive an Artifact Report. If you are able to complete the following action points, you will receive a report containing detailed intelligence on an Artifact.

Sydney Ginn's eyes skipped over a long passage of introductory text and landed directly on the final section.

Action points for obtaining an «Artifact Report» :

1. Bring June to meet the Blackmoor City Mayor.

If this option is completed, the probability of a "Nest Domination Game target Artifact" appearing in the next «Artifact Report» is 99.99% (hereinafter referred to as "target probability");

2. Acquire the Hunter House Faction Knight House Faction. Target probability: 56%;
3. Find a method for transferring a passage. Target probability: 73%.

Complete any one of the above actions before December 31, 2026, and you will receive a corresponding «Artifact Report» , taking an important step forward in the Nest Domination Game.

The new chapter may have typos or small bugs, because I'm very anxious and pulled another all-nighter—not in the best shape, to say the least... I don't know what kind of world I'll be waking up to see.

Hey everyone, I'm working on the outline.

I've been through all the emotional hits that needed to be felt, but you don't need to worry about me—two days of feeling down is about enough, it's time to pull myself together. Can't let the ones who care suffer while the ones who don't get to gloat.

There's still a lot to do, and a lot I can do. The way to push back against this world is to just do more.

Today I need to sort out the outline for the next phase... I was supposed to do it yesterday, but I wasn't in the right state, so it got pushed to today.

I'm working on the outline now, but I'm afraid I won't make it before midnight—go to sleep if you need to; there will definitely be an update waiting when you wake up tomorrow morning.

Chapter 185: The Reason Behind Mai Minghe's Rules

Mai Minghe felt as though she were walking through the deep sea.

The flashlight beam shouldered aside the crushing darkness, straining against the weight of ten thousand fathoms of water, barely carving out the small pocket of light and air she needed to survive.

This was the high-powered flashlight Reed Hydes had brought into the Nest—six bulbs packed beneath a single plastic panel, and when switched on, it blazed bright enough to bleach the eyes white. But the moment she turned it toward the Nest, toward the darkness ahead, Mai Minghe could almost hear the Nest snickering.

The two of them had no choice but to follow that beam closely; fall even a step behind, and they might tumble into the endless black, never to climb out again.

"How much farther?" Reed Hydes asked, the words coming out with effort.

He had been dragging his injured foot along for nearly ten minutes, half his life already spent; though Mai Minghe had found him a thick tree branch to use as a crutch, it was better than nothing—but only barely.

"I remember it being around here somewhere,"

Mai Minghe wasn't having an easy time of it either—every time pressure hit the wound on her foot, blood welled out in little pulses. She swept the flashlight in all directions and, from out of the darkness, a bus stop with a glass canopy floated into view.

The bus stop stood on one side of the road. The road itself was deserted—the car she had driven in was nowhere to be seen.

"I parked near a bus stop... but I didn't note which stop number it was, so this might not be the right one."

Mai Minghe held the flashlight high and swept it up and down the road—the only vehicle nearby was a yellow taxi, sitting dusty and low on the other side of the street, a call-for-ride phone number printed on its body. If she dialed that number, would she actually get a ride?

Unfortunately, the Nest knowledge in her head held no answer to that.

"After we got off, it took us no more than fifteen minutes to walk to the apartment building," Reed Hydes said, trying to piece things together. "Given that distance, there shouldn't be more than a couple of bus stops."

Mai Minghe studied the bus stop carefully, growing less and less certain whether this was where she had parked; then the flashlight beam drifted across a sign, and she drew a sharp breath.

"What is it?" Reed Hydes startled.

"I understand now," Mai Minghe aimed the flashlight at the sign and said, "Look—it clearly says no parking at the bus stop. The car must have been towed."

Reed Hydes stared at the sign for a few seconds, then looked at her.

"First of all, it's not 'our' car—you half-found, half-stole it... And second, does the Nest have traffic laws? Who enforces them?"

Mai Minghe searched her memory for a moment. Ever since her one transformation into a Resident, she had become a sort of "Nest encyclopedia" that no longer received updates; throughout their journey, Reed Hydes had asked her no small number of questions.

"Yes," she said, letting out a heavy sigh. "There really is a Traffic Cop Resident... The only one in the entire Nest holding that position."

"Really? What does it look like? I'd like to know so I can watch out for it next time."

"I don't dare think about it," Mai Minghe said, a little embarrassed. "Just knowing it exists is enough to make me feel like the blood has stopped flowing through my body—all four limbs go numb. If I were to actually picture what it looks like, I'm afraid I'd faint dead away."

"I've run into Residents that produce a similar effect. Why does that happen?" Reed Hydes simply sat down on the bus stop bench and asked.

"Do you know what a QR code is?"

Reed Hydes was genuinely taken aback. "You know about QR codes?"

Mai Minghe shook her head and laughed. "Ha—how would I know about that?"

"...Huh?"

"I asked whether you knew, because I wanted you to explain it."

Mai Minghe tapped her own temple and said, "The Nest information in my head does include an explanation for this kind of effect... and the explanation uses the phrase 'QR code,' which I don't understand at all. Isn't it strange? Information that exists inside my own head, yet I myself have no idea what it means."

"The basic principle... is roughly that the positions of black and white pixels on a matrix represent the binary values of '1' and '0,' which are then combined to form meaning."

Mai Minghe understood even less now—but it seemed to mean something like "a graphic that carries information."

"Certain Residents—and some of the Nest's scenery as well—have color patterns on their faces that are arranged like QR codes, in a special configuration. The moment the naked eye sweeps across them, a person automatically reads the message they want to transmit. For example, the message on the Traffic Cop's face issues a command to the body, causing the limbs to gradually go numb."

"Wonderful—so you only find out who you've run into after you're already paralyzed."

After sitting down, Reed Hydes seemed even more exhausted than before. He hugged his arms around himself, slumped and deflated, like a worn-out mattress someone had left by the roadside.

"Since the car's gone, what do we do? Come back for it next time?" He clearly just wanted to go home.

Mai Minghe had put him through enough, and she didn't want his foot injury to drag on any further; but the words "nine months" hung like a ticking bomb wired to her nerve endings, weighing constantly on her mind.

Joining that "Nest Domination Game," then following its clues to find the "time" Artifact—that was the closest lead she had right now, and the only one.

Her gaze swept around together with the flashlight beam, and as Mai Minghe looked at the taxi across the road, an idea suddenly came to her.

"Wait here for a bit and don't move. Shouldn't there be an in-car radio in that taxi too? Maybe any radio will do—after all, you said yourself that the other car wasn't mine either, right? So why does it have to be that one? I'll go check if I can get the door open."

Reed Hydes craned his neck and asked, "Is the car definitely empty?"

"Looks like it. Don't worry—if it's not empty, I'll turn right back."

She left the flashlight with Reed Hydes and took his phone for light instead.

Smart phone—for all that the smartphone looked like a brick, it lit up the instant you touched it, responding to a fingertip with remarkable sensitivity. On the screen was a photo of Reed Hydes hugging a large white dog; the two looked utterly different from each other, yet the grin they each wore had exactly the same quality.

"When we get back, teach me how to use one of these," Mai Minghe said, making sure to mention it before she walked off.

"Sure, sure—now hurry up and get back."

Across the dim road, Reed Hydes sat behind a pool of light, watching as she circled around to the driver's side of the yellow taxi.

On the way here, Mai Minghe had already confirmed that the car was empty—or rather, that there were no Residents inside.

All she needed was to pry the door open, or smash the window, and she could switch on the in-car radio. Even back when she'd been half herself and half a Resident, she had wanted to respond and join in, but the in-car radio had been completely silent then; she could only hope the station would come through clearly this time.

Mai Minghe stood beside the road, phone held up, leaning down to peer into the car.

The driver turned his head toward her.

Before her thoughts shattered and she suddenly collapsed, the last thing that flashed through Mai Minghe's mind was: thank goodness she had come over with Reed Hydes's phone—

The photo of Reed Hydes hugging the large white dog was dimly reflected and projected on the car window glass, covering just enough of the driver's face.

Thank goodness... the "QR code" hadn't been read in full.

I'm too tired today, so this one's a bit shorter. Wait—I feel like I've said that at least sixty times already.

My mom and I are great at trading compliments. Today I told her that, aside from not being in a relationship, she has Liu Xiaoqing's resilience and spirit; my mom said Liu Xiaoqing can't compare to her, because she has me as a daughter.

Chapter 186: A Ping-Pong Ball Between Mai Minghe's Four Walls

The cold, hard, rough road surface pressed against Mai Minghe's cheek.

She had fallen sideways onto the roadside, eyes wide open, unable to move a single muscle.

Reed Hydes's phone screen hadn't gone dark yet, and by that faint glow she could make out the taxi's tires on the other side, the road surface, the dull white dividing lines...

The screen went out.

Even with darkness before her eyes, even as she heard the taxi's rear passenger door being quietly opened, her gaze remained fixed on that same scene.

Because "unable to move a single muscle" meant even her eyeballs had frozen in place. Her fingers, still curved around the phone, happened to keep their grip on it by virtue of that very rigidity, so she hadn't dropped it.

The taxi's rear door swung open and swept past her body, grazing her shoulder, jostling her ever so slightly.

From the back seat that should by all rights have been empty, a pair of hands—or something like hands—reached out, seized Mai Minghe by the collar, hoisted her upper body upward, and with a single fling sent her flying toward the trunk of the car.

Her five-foot-eight frame, in those hands, seemed to weigh no more than a rag doll—one toss was all it took to send her sailing across half the length of the car and sliding to a stop beside the rear wheel.

"...Mai Minghe?"

A muffled shout rose from the other side of the road. "You—where are you? Say something! That thing on the ground... what is that?"

Had Mai Minghe still been capable of thought, she would have realized that when she had accidentally glimpsed part of the driver's face just now, she had been bent over, hidden by the car—so Reed Hydes on the other side of the road still had no idea she had been caught and knocked to the ground.

With the phone light gone, he had no way of telling that the dark shape that had suddenly surged up from the ground behind the car was, in fact, Mai Minghe.

"Mai—"

The trunk lid snapped open.

Reed Hydes had barely started his next sentence before he swallowed it back, as though startled.

In the heavy, airless dark of the night, only a soft rustling sound broke the silence:

A pair of hands reached down from the open trunk, groped until they found Mai Minghe's collar, seized it, and with a swing of the arm flung her again—she flew like a ragdoll once more, landing beside the rear passenger door on the other side of the car.

Mai Minghe could feel the road surface scraping hot and stinging against her legs through the fabric of her clothes, but the pain stopped at the surface of her skin and could not produce the faintest echo in her mind, which had gone as blank and unyielding as stone.

In other words, her skin registered "pain," while her mind remained utterly indifferent to it.

"Mai Minghe...?"

Reed Hydes seemed to have stood up, holding his flashlight high, but across the road he appeared vague and uncertain, not daring to confirm what he was seeing—then as soon as the rear door opened, he immediately swung his flashlight away, as if afraid to look at whatever was inside.

From within the empty back seat of the taxi, a pair of hands reached out again and flung her toward the front passenger door.

Door by door, she was passed around the car in a relay, as if the whole thing served a single purpose: to have the front passenger door open last, so that the final pair of hands could drag Mai Minghe inside, lift her into the front passenger seat, and prop her upright.

"Mai Minghe!"

The door slammed shut, cutting off Reed Hydes's shouts from the other side of the road.

Mai Minghe slumped softly in the front passenger seat, her head lolling against the window; the taxi driver sat directly to her left, with nothing between them—no partition, no distance at all.

It seemed to slowly turn its head toward her.

Small mercy, she didn't need to fear seeing its face in full; her eyes still couldn't move, and she could only stare straight ahead at the windshield, the glove box, and a yellow sticky note affixed to the glove box.

Though all her capacity for thought had been frozen solid, her language center still helped her recognize the meaning of the words on the paper.

Oops!

If you're reading this warning,

it means you've violated Rule Three of the Passenger Rules, "remain in the back seat," and have gone and moved to the front.

Pfft.

Now there's no escaping no escaping no escaping no escaping no escaping

If you've made it this far, you've probably noticed that you've lost the ability to think and to act—hmm, actually that seems like a paradox, because if you've lost the ability to think, you can't notice anything at all.

Anyway, this is the punishment for violating any one of the Passenger Rules.

As a small parting gift to see you on your way,

you may have four thoughts again.

Each thought, if converted into words, would be roughly fifty characters long.

Of course, even if one of those thoughts is "count how many characters this thought has," you still won't be able to count—after all, having a thought and having the ability to act on that thought are two very different things.

I wonder what those four thoughts will turn out to be? How exciting, how curious~

Aside from these four thoughts, you won't be able to think about anything else.

Four thoughts are four walls, and your helpless, pitiful, futile mind

can only bounce back and forth between those four walls like a ping-pong ball, over and over,

until at last you die, dissolve, and become nourishment for the Nest's growth.

There's no escaping no escaping no escaping no escaping no escaping ever again, stay here forever, hahahaha

She could read the warning, but only in the sense of recognizing the meaning of the words.

Mai Minghe was still incapable of forming any thoughts about the warning's contents—the words entered her eyes much like a slide projector casting text onto a blank white wall.

The one difference was that somewhere deep inside a slide projector, there would presumably not be that intermittent, formless dread of being locked inside a narrow cell—the dread of stone walls pressing close around a body, with no gap, no light.

The engine had started at some point without her noticing.

Amid a faint smell of gasoline and the low rumble of the motor, the taxi pulled away—without switching on its headlights—and drove in a straight line into the darkness ahead, a darkness that seemed impossible to tear open.

Outside the window, a figure seemed to be coming toward them with a flashlight, limping hurriedly forward; but before he could draw close, the taxi had already sped past him, and that figure shrank into a rapidly dwindling point of light in the rearview mirror.

"Hey! Let her go!"

Reed Hydes's faint cry was left behind in the darkness, swallowed up like an illusion, until it was gone.

Mai Minghe could not move—if she could still be said to possess the concept of "waiting," then she was waiting for the first thought to rise from the dry, blank expanse of her mind.

In the barely perceptible jolting of the car, her forehead continued to knock softly, again and again, against the window glass.

She lost count of how many times it had knocked when, all at once, a thought surfaced in her mind.

The car she had arrived in hadn't disappeared by coincidence, and the taxi hadn't appeared by coincidence either; the Residents trying to kill the contestants were not only the Dream Playwright...

There was also the taxi driver right beside her.

Today's chapter is short—not because I'm tired, but because I'm stuck...

Look at this plot. How could I not be stuck?

Chapter 187: Mai Minghe's Precious Contest Candidate

Human thoughts, when examined closely, are almost always made up of complex and tangled components.

For instance, when you're rushing home and the thought "I haven't fed the cat today, she must be starving" crosses your mind, that thought is more than just those words alone—it likely also contains an image of an empty bowl, the sound of disgruntled meowing, the memory of a hungry cat winding around your feet and nearly tripping you.

All of these elements come together to form a single thought: I haven't fed the cat today, she must be starving.

Just as the first thought had risen alongside the face of the Dream Playwright, the second thought arrived in Mai Minghe's mind accompanied by an image as well.

Inside a rough scrawl of a circle, two black dots for eyes and a red curved line for a mouth—a face so crude it would seem too simple even for a kindergartner's drawing, and yet it was the candidate depicted on a campaign poster in the library square.

That campaign poster now floated, clear and vivid, in the blankness of Mai Minghe's mind.

To defend the Nest's independence, we must take the initiative and strike first!

Using a more cautious approach than before—eliminating risk at the root, facing the problem with greater seriousness—

Please vote for me.

So that's how it is...

The Nest's Residents had split into two factions. The one that invited her to compete was one side, and the one trying to kill the contestants was the other—the in-car broadcast undoubtedly belonged to the former, while the driver belonged to the latter.

Once the second thought had been translated into words, it was no longer or more complex than the first, yet it still offered no visible way out.

If anything, the second thought felt more like a further deduction built upon the first; that is to say, arriving at just this one conclusion had already used up the budget of two thoughts.

Of course, this wasn't to say that Mai Minghe was actively thinking about how to escape—she was entirely incapable of thinking about that.

"Some Residents want to kill the contestants" and "the in-car broadcast belongs to the other faction"—these two thoughts flickered and rolled back and forth through her mind, and beyond them, she could think of nothing else.

All that remained in Mai Minghe was the survival instinct of a wild animal caught in a trap, desperate to break free in blind terror—an instinct that, like flowing blood, neither formed thoughts nor needed to.

The taxi continued gliding smoothly through the darkness.

Even without streetlights, without headlights, without even moonlight... it was as if the car itself were simply a part of the darkness flowing along with it.

At an intersection it turned right, the motion nudging Mai Minghe gently against the door.

Her head pressed more tightly against the glass, and Reed Hydes's phone slid a little deeper into her hand, its screen briefly lighting up.

Neither Mai Minghe nor the driver reacted to this in the slightest.

Mai Minghe because she was incapable of reacting; the driver, for reasons unknown—whether it hadn't seen, or simply didn't care. The screen went dark again soon after, and the dim quiet of the car returned.

She shouldn't be feeling pain!

The third thought struck without warning, so forceful it was like someone had driven a fist into her temple.

Skin sends nerve signals to the brain when friction is applied—that was how she'd felt the sting of the road surface against her legs. She shouldn't be feeling pain. And yet she did, which meant her connection to her body hadn't been completely severed.

Rising alongside the third thought was a scene from her memory just moments ago:

She had leaned down toward the empty driver's seat, the phone screen casting light on the window glass, and the driver had turned its head toward her. The photo of Reed Hydes and the big white dog had vaguely obscured part of the driver's face.

But the third thought stopped there.

Not having seen the driver's face fully. The connection to her body not being completely severed. The next logical step that should have followed naturally was wrenched to a halt.

How much of the bodily connection remained, what that meant, what she could do about it—every such thought was blocked out by a high wall; apart from the three thoughts flickering back and forth, Mai Minghe could only stare blankly at the pitch-black road ahead.

The taxi turned right again.

This time, as the car straightened back out, she felt the phone slip forward slightly.

Her fingers had been curled to light the screen earlier, and had since been locked in that same position.

Now her fingers couldn't move, but the phone had shifted, so this time it made contact with a different part of the screen.

A woman's voice suddenly rang out inside the car—even Mai Minghe startled as if she'd been pricked.

"...The Supreme Court replaced two justices in one go, both on the younger and more conservative side—one is forty-three, the other forty-nine—which means that for the next thirty years, all we can do is watch the law retreat further and further, growing ever more conservative..."

If Mai Minghe had still been capable of thinking, she would certainly have wondered what part of the smartphone she'd touched to make it speak on its own—and moreover, they were inside the Nest, where no signal from the outside world could reach, so how was it playing something that sounded like a radio broadcast?

Mai Minghe could not think.

She only sensed that the driver beside her turned its head and looked around several times, apparently baffled, and let out a sound: "Hm?"

It released the steering wheel and began, inch by inch, slowly leaning its body toward Mai Minghe; its head blocked part of her field of vision.

Fortunately the car was still dim inside, and even with her eyes unable to close, Mai Minghe couldn't make out its face clearly.

"What, strange..."

The driver muttered indistinctly, searching up and down her body for the source of the sound.

The female host in the phone, completely oblivious, continued discussing the long-term consequences of the Supreme Court's new appointments: "Of course, I think calling it 'conservative' is no longer accurate—this is an extreme right-wing ideology..."

Meanwhile, the car continued moving steadily forward, and even seemed to observe an invisible traffic rule, stopping for a few seconds before driving on again.

"What are you saying?" the driver said, its speech muddled. "Why can you still talk..."

It was at that exact moment that the fourth thought crashed into Mai Minghe's mind.

The driver couldn't see.

Or rather, it had no sense of sight, because it wasn't truly a driver at all.

The taxi and the driver were different parts of the same thing, and it could only perceive Mai Minghe's presence—it could not see that the source of the voice was a phone.

"It wants to kill me."

"The in-car broadcast belongs to the other faction."

"The connection to my body hasn't been completely severed."

"The driver can't see."

Clearly... clearly these four thoughts, taken together, seemed to hide a way out—and yet Mai Minghe could not escape from between them.

"Why can it talk, why..." the driver murmured. It hadn't returned to the driver's seat, and yet the taxi came to a sudden, jarring stop.

The phone slipped in her hand, and Mai Minghe felt her fingers brush the right side of the screen—instantly, the phone's playback seemed to fast-forward, jumping to a completely different line of audio and switching to a male voice.

"Hm?"

The driver snapped upright and began searching frantically around the interior of the car. "Is that the man from before? Where is he..."

Every door on the car—front, back, hood, and trunk—suddenly began opening and slamming shut in rapid succession, banging and clattering—and as it thrashed about, Mai Minghe, who had

been leaning against the passenger door, lost her support the moment it flew open, and slid out of the car.

With a thud, Mai Minghe's upper body hit the road, while her legs remained inside the car.

The fall caused her fingers to touch the phone screen again, instantly changing the playback once more.

The original woman's voice drifted lightly through the dead and silent darkness of the road: "Thank you all for listening to this episode—feel free to leave us a comment with any thoughts or feedback..."

"Ah, I see."

The driver said softly, as if it had finally figured it all out—whether it had realized everything was just a phone mishap was impossible to tell.

Even without being able to form that clear thought herself, Mai Minghe felt her heart sink instinctively.

She kept revisiting the thought "the connection to my body hasn't been completely severed," over and over again—she didn't know what good it did to repeat it, and she couldn't think about why; it was her survival instinct, forcing her to run through it again and again.

"It's a radio broadcast," the driver said, as if it had finally found its answer. "She can't talk—the broadcast turned on."

A pair of hands reached out from the passenger seat and grabbed Mai Minghe again, pulling her back inside the car.

At the same time, the driver reached out and pressed something on the in-car broadcast—apparently trying to turn off a broadcast that had never been turned on in the first place.

Mai Minghe's heart suddenly began pounding.

"...Found you."

A man's voice rose from the in-car broadcast, quiet and unhurried.

His voice was low and soothing, as if he had been a radio host for a very, very long time.

"So it was you... who caught my precious contest candidate."

Oh lord, I have no idea why I write myself into corners like this—always backing myself into a dead end. It was the same way when I was writing the apocalypse arc... but at least back then, even if one of the two—body or mind—was stuck, the other was still free to work with. Mai Minghe, though? Mind frozen, body frozen, no resources, no tools, no way out whatsoever. I was so stuck I genuinely thought I was going to abandon the story right here... which is why the update took this long. Sorry about that, everyone.

麦明河这个可好，思维不能转，身体不能动，没有任何资源手段，毫无脱身办法，卡得我真以为要在这里弃坑了……所以拖到现在才更新，对不住姥姥们。

Chapter 188: Mai Minghe's Answer Beneath a Glittering Starry Night

Even if she couldn't clearly form the thought "I'm saved," hope was an instinctive fuel—one that set Mai Minghe's blood racing faster—yet in the very next second, the driver did something unexpected, yet entirely in keeping with its nature.

It reached out again and, with a sharp slap, switched the radio back off.

Mai Minghe sat there in her seat, dazed.

Her thoughts were still bouncing like a ping-pong ball between four high walls.

After being pulled back into the car, she was no longer leaning against the window—instead her body had tilted sideways toward the driver's seat, leaving the in-car radio squarely in her field of vision: so close, yet impossibly far.

The driver was muttering indistinctly: "I'm in the car—can't I just drive away... keep looking for her. By the time you find me, she'll have already dissolved into my seat. Who knows what kind of Resident will be born from that..."

It was nothing if not a creature of action; the taxi immediately started up again, gliding without a sound into the darkness ahead.

The radio did not come on again.

She had no way of sensing or estimating the passage of time—so it could have been minutes, or it could have been hours—when suddenly a dark shape loomed over her: the driver leaning across toward her.

"Hmm? Why hasn't her body started dissolving yet?"

It reached out a hand, as though to touch Mai Minghe, then froze mid-air. "Time's long past due... do humans have shells? Could the shell just be too hard..."

"My connection to my body hasn't been completely severed."

"My connection to my body hasn't been completely severed."

Mai Minghe repeated this to herself, over and over.

The driver seemed to reach a decision. "So annoying—being this stubborn, sitting in my car like a big lump, refusing to dissolve for so long, shameless. I can't keep waiting for you—if you

won't dissolve, then I'll just have to start a—"

Its voice suddenly stretched out, slowing to a crawl, as though calling out to someone, casting itself into the vague and formless darkness beyond the car; at the same time, the taxi accelerated.

"Car ac—"

The taxi turned into an intersection ahead and slammed to a sharp halt right in the center of it. The force of inertia shoved Mai Minghe forward; her body pitched forward and struck the dashboard.

Was it luck? Had the car simply not stopped cleanly? Or had the last remnant of physical function, driven by the will to survive, finally stirred?

She couldn't think through any of it; only, at the very moment the driver drew out the next syllable in a long cry, she knew that two things had happened at once.

"Crash—"

From the road to Mai Minghe's right, two blinding white lights pierced the darkness; a car that had appeared from nowhere was hurtling straight toward the taxi's passenger side—in an instant, the glare had bleached everything in her vision white, and she seemed to hear the sounds of metal colliding, warping, bones being crushed.

But she didn't truly hear any of it.

What Mai Minghe truly heard was a faint crackle of radio static from inside the car.

The radio had switched on again.

"Crash crash crash crash crash—"

The driver suddenly raised its voice and began to shout; the word "crash" reverberating through the cabin again and again drowned out the static.

Then, in the next second, everything stopped dead.

The driver's cries cut off.

The car that had been hurtling toward the passenger side froze in place just inches away, as though a film had been abruptly paused.

The headlight beams poured in like a violent white flood bursting through a gate, scouring the darkness from a patch of night, washing everything beneath it into sharp, clear relief.

In the corner of Mai Minghe's vision, a figure stood amid the white flood of light between the two cars—indistinct, impossible to make out clearly.

The driver turned its head to the right.

The figure stepped closer to the passenger side, step by step; its shadow grew larger and larger, falling over the car window.

Mai Minghe's forehead was still pressed against the dashboard, and she could only barely catch the figure's outline in her peripheral vision—no details were visible at all—when the passenger door was suddenly pulled open from outside. The cool night air and the blinding light rushed in together, and Mai Minghe shivered.

"Well done,"

a low, unhurried, gentle male voice said from beyond the door. "I didn't expect that even reduced to this, you still wouldn't give up."

The driver said, hesitantly, from beside her: "...Thank you?"

The man's voice—which, just moments ago through the radio, had seemed so at ease—paused at that, as if he truly didn't know how to respond for a moment.

"...I was talking about her."

"Oh."

The driver seemed to turn and look at Mai Minghe, then asked abruptly: "Why hasn't she dissolved? If she'd dissolved earlier, you'd have been too late even after finding us. Is there something special about her that makes you value her this much?"

"Quiet."

The man's voice from outside the car said, almost as though amused: "You creatures—wandering the Nest in a fog, with no awareness of anything—driven purely by desire and instinct. There's something almost innocently endearing about it."

Mai Minghe felt someone grasp her shoulders and begin pulling her out of the car—yet the position of the male voice hadn't shifted at all; he sounded as though he hadn't moved a single inch.

The driver seemed to watch steadily without moving, and for some reason made no move to stop them. Perhaps it understood that resisting now would be a meaningless struggle.

"Not killing her this time doesn't mean anything."

It murmured: "As long as she enters the Nest again... every last one of us will go all out to hunt her down... no—even if she doesn't enter the Nest, we will do everything in our power to kill her first..."

Mai Minghe was half-carried, half-supported by someone, then set down by the side of the road, lying flat.

She hadn't managed to see the man's face the entire time; even now, her eyes could only stare straight up at the Nest's star-scattered night sky.

...The Nest's night sky was beautiful to the point of terror.

"You are unwilling to see the Nest dominated, and she is the one person who has absolutely no interest in dominating it... yet you have marked her as your greatest target and are determined to kill her before anyone else, at any cost."

The man's voice from outside the car, having said this much, seemed to carry a smile: "Taken to its most extreme, stupidity can, paradoxically, produce something remarkably shrewd."

"That's because we know! Once she dies, you'll—"

With a loud bang, the taxi door was slammed shut, cutting off the driver's unfinished words.

The man's voice from the radio seemed unwilling to let the driver finish; whatever he did after shutting the door, the taxi fell completely silent afterward, as if it had been abandoned.

Mai Minghe heard a pair of footsteps walking toward her.

Footsteps utterly indistinguishable from a human's: one step at a time, steady and calm; she could even make out the distinctive sound of a heel striking the ground—which meant the newcomer had a pair of feet, and in the Nest, that was something genuinely worth mentioning.

"You've worked hard,"

the man from the radio was now standing right beside Mai Minghe—yet she simply couldn't see him. "Now that you've returned to being human, do you still want to join the Nest Domination Game?"

She had no way to answer—Mai Minghe thought—she had only four thoughts—

Wait?

Hadn't it been more than four thoughts for a while now?

When had she been able to think again?

"Still can't speak? Then let's watch the night sky together for a while... such a brilliant and vast universe—it's beautiful, isn't it?"

The man's voice drew closer, accompanied by faint rustling sounds, as he seemed to sit down beside her. "The Nest's night sky, like Blackmoor City's night sky, is one where you cannot see any stars."

What? But before her eyes, it was clearly a sky full of stars—

"The stars you see are memories from my childhood. I have rearranged the starlight from those memories; if you look at them for a while, you'll gradually return to normal."

The Milky Way tilted, reflected in Mai Minghe's pupils, as if another brilliant, boundless universe had been mirrored there.

"...I'll join."

She didn't know how much time had passed before Mai Minghe heard herself answer in a hoarse voice.

Well, the update has looped back around to this point again. Hmm, I was going to say something... forgot what. Honestly.

But the main plot is moving along smoothly—something to celebrate, really. Who knows, maybe this means the story can wrap up a little sooner.

Chapter 189: Mai Minghe — Hurricane Makes Landfall in Florida

Was this truly not a dream?

She lay on the road, the cosmic galaxy cascading before her eyes.

Beneath the silent black night, among buildings and streets that resembled Blackmoor City yet stood utterly empty, only a single car was parked. Its engine was still running, the headlights washing half the road in light; the low rumble of the engine, along with white exhaust fumes, drifted lazily upward into the star-filled night sky.

Beside Mai Minghe, however, was someone who seemed to exist only as a voice, without any physical form.

"Have you made up your mind? Aren't you afraid? You heard it just now, didn't you?" the person was asking.

So this is the Nest...

The thought came to her suddenly.

She had always felt, in the past, that she had been placed in the wrong spot.

She had followed others through life the same as everyone else, never knowing what other paths looked like, and no one had ever pointed another path out to her — because it seemed most people were also concealing the fact that they didn't know the way either.

She had been born with a pair of eyes, yet had only ever seen one corner; her feet were shod in shoes that didn't fit, and when she walked, she had wondered if the fault lay with her own feet.

She felt like she could still do something more.

That feeling had wound around her for decades, all the way until the age of eighty-six, when she finally discovered that she truly could do something more.

After so long and wasted a stretch of time, to now have one more chance to make up for it — how could she possibly shrink back at a moment like this.

"I'm not afraid."

Mai Minghe answered quietly: "If I don't participate, will they just let me go? I don't know why, but they've set their sights on me — naturally they won't rest easy until they've pulled me up

by the roots. Since that can't be changed, I might as well follow my own heart and do what I want to do. Wouldn't you agree?"

If the person was willing to tell her the reason she had been targeted, this was the perfect moment; but he said nothing of the sort, and instead asked, "What is it that you want to do?"

It seemed asking him wouldn't get her an answer, Mai Minghe thought. The other person's tone and manner were both subtly and politely conveying exactly that.

She still couldn't sit up from the road, couldn't even turn her head — only her lips, teeth, throat, and tongue had recovered first.

"...I want to see things I've never seen before," Mai Minghe said. "I want to pick more daisies."

The male voice gave a low "mm," whether or not he understood, but didn't ask further.

"May I ask you a few questions?" Mai Minghe said. "I can see that you don't seem to mean me any harm."

"You're reading it right," the person gave a small laugh.

"This Domination Game... did you organize it? Why would you let outsiders come and rule over you?"

"Me? Oh, you've misunderstood. Compared to ordinary Residents, I'm a bit stronger, but I don't have the power to conjure up a Domination Game from thin air."

The night was quiet for a few seconds; as though the person had heard Mai Minghe's silent puzzlement, he continued: "You know that everything in the Nest originates from humanity, right?"

"I know."

"The Domination Game is no exception — it too is something born from within human beings.

"It's not that the Nest wishes to be ruled. Rather, among the humans who gave birth to everything in the Nest, there has always been a portion who exhaust every scheme trying to control another portion. If everyone were equal, that kind of person would suffer worse than death. When that kind of person dies inside the Nest, their desires don't die with them — and so the 'Nest Domination Game' was born."

Mai Minghe was slightly taken aback — so that was it; now it all made sense.

"To put it in terms of an analogy: the 'Nest Domination Game' is to the Nest what a hurricane making landfall in Florida is to the real world — a natural disaster that cannot be resisted. The faction of Residents that wants to kill you is like saying, if the hurricane is going to hit the shore, let's demolish the shore first — very foolish. Without you, sooner or later there would be someone else."

"Then what role do you play?" Mai Minghe asked, cutting straight to the point.

"Me... I'm probably in the faction thinking about disaster recovery and reconstruction."

What did that mean? It was a bit hard to follow.

Before she had time to figure out how to ask, she suddenly noticed that her fingers were beginning to regain movement; Mai Minghe's fingers twitched gently a few times, and it seemed the person noticed, because he immediately asked, "Any other questions? I can't stay here forever."

Mai Minghe quickly asked: "Why did you come looking for me? Who was it that invited me to participate? The Nest?"

"Do you know what kind of person is best suited to lead humanity?" the person answered her question with a question of his own.

"...I've never thought about it."

The person laughed.

"The person best suited to lead humanity will never feel an urgent desire to lead humanity — and so they never enter the competition. That is the paradox of fate for humans as a group. From my limited perspective, I can't see any way to break out of it."

Was he hinting that she shouldn't win the game? Mai Minghe was a little confused.

She had no interest whatsoever in ruling the Nest to begin with — her own mind, thoughts, and intellect were limited, as any person's are.

To arrange something as wondrous and far beyond imagination as the Nest according to her own severely limited mind — Mai Minghe could hardly think of anything more pointless than that.

"I really can't tell that you're a Resident," she said with complete sincerity. "You're so rational... and you sound very learned."

The person suddenly laughed — different from the polite, radio-host manner of laughing before; this time, his laughter was nearly cold and furious — a sound no different from ordinary laughter on the surface, yet it seemed to carry within it an indescribable hatred, making one's very organs slowly clench.

"Is that so? Then I really must thank you for the compliment."

He said this as he stood up from beside Mai Minghe — he had been so close, yet remained completely invisible.

"After all, my education is quite low — I only ever attended primary school. As for being rational... perhaps it's because I'm still completely myself, and have never been dissolved."

What did he mean by that...?

Could it be that, as a Resident, he had not been born from within someone's body, but rather had become a Resident directly from a complete, whole person?

It seemed that wasn't impossible — hadn't the Dream Playwright come very close to turning himself into exactly that kind of Resident?

"Wait, I still have a companion — do you know where he—"

Before Mai Minghe could finish the question, she was cut off.

"Once you've recovered and gotten to your feet, you'll find him."

The person returned to his usual soft and low tone and said: "There is also one more thing. As a contestant in the Domination Game, you are at a considerable disadvantage compared to others... The 'Nest Domination Game' hopes that all contestants can stand on as equal a starting line as possible. After you return, you will receive an 'Artifact Report,' as compensation for your disadvantage."

Mai Minghe wanted to ask what an "Artifact Report" was, but the person had already turned and walked away; even though he seemed to have no physical form, each step still landed firmly on the ground. Only at some point — it was impossible to say which step — he simply vanished, and no next step ever came.

As the stars gradually faded and darkness merged back with the sky, Mai Minghe pressed one hand against the ground and was finally able to get up and move freely.

The taxi and the host had long since disappeared; on the road there was only one car — which, by the look of it, was the very car she had driven here before vanishing.

Because the headlights were still blazing, she saw at a glance that inside the car that had nearly run her over, a figure was slumped softly over the steering wheel — it was Reed Hydes.

Mai Minghe dragged her feet over and opened the car door.

Right now, leaving the Nest together with Reed Hydes was the most pressing matter; the parts that the man just now had glossed over without mentioning could wait until she was home to analyze.

(That's right, I'm calling out Ma Zhilong by name.)

Speaking of which, I have a feeling — I'm not sure if it's right — but after using Xiaohongshu for a long time, I think it genuinely is one of a kind in China for life experiences, food, entertainment, and lighthearted content; but after a while, I can't help but sense that the platform's vibe is a little... self-serving and misogynistic.

I might be stepping on some toes, but I'm not done yet — don't misunderstand.

I also want to say: the garbage from content-farm accounts is overwhelming.

Posts pushing books for traffic love to hold up a book, take a photo — but the book is turned sideways, showing you only the pages, never the spine or title. The intent is pretty obvious.

Hardly a single book they recommend is worth reading, but the recommendation copy is all "stayed up all night," "mind-blowing," "plot twist," "burst into tears," "hair-raising" — as if you're sitting in an electric chair while you read.

That's all I have to say — not too offensive, I hope.

Chapter 190: Mai Minghe, This Is Way Too Real

When Reed Hydes first came to, he seemed unable to tell reality from nightmare—in terror and confusion, he thrashed desperately to break free from the car, his face drenched in sweat and tears, letting out something between a whimper and a scream: "Let go of me! Let go of me!"

"Shh, shh... it's okay, it's okay."

Mai Minghe held his shoulders tight; even after taking two blows from him she didn't let go, keeping him firmly pressed against the seat: "It's me—I'm Mai Minghe. It's all over, you're fine, I'm right here."

Reed Hydes sat in the circle of her arms, breathing in ragged, heavy gasps, the violent heaving of his back slowly settling at last.

After a few seconds, he said quietly, "...Mai Minghe?"

"Yes, it's really me."

Once he had calmed down a little, he seemed somewhat embarrassed; Mai Minghe released him and gave him a few gentle pats on the back. She was quite good at soothing people—even if he was nearly thirty, that wasn't much different from a child.

"Feeling better? Can you talk?"

Reed Hydes scrubbed his face hard and looked around. "I... did I really get into this car?"

"What happened?"

"I... I saw that empty taxi take you away and didn't know what to do. I couldn't catch up, so I just kept walking along the road... and as I walked, I saw you driving this car, appearing from around the corner..."

"That wasn't me," Mai Minghe said with a wry smile. "I was completely frozen on the taxi the whole time."

"I know that now, but back then it was like I fell into a nightmare with no warning at all."

Reed Hydes looked at the steering wheel in front of him and said, "I clearly saw you driving toward me. I walked over to look, but found you sitting in the passenger seat, telling me to get in. Just like being in a dream—I couldn't feel that anything was wrong; everything seemed perfectly

natural... After I got in, you said a public passage had opened and we could drive back to Blackmoor City together..."

He shuddered involuntarily, yet his expression was utterly blank. "Huh? What happened after that? I only remember it was terrifying..."

Once a person wakes up, a dream dissolves rapidly—it seemed something in the Nest could control people through dreams, and the method was not quite the same as the Dream Playwright's.

One made people see a false reality while awake; the other submerged them completely in sleep.

Perhaps it was the opposing faction... one of the Residents trying to kill her. She would have to be careful from now on.

Mai Minghe gripped his shoulder with one hand and said reassuringly, "It's fine—it was just a dream, it's over now, you're perfectly okay. This isn't a dream anymore. Look, here's your phone—what kind of dog do you have? What's her name?"

Reed Hydes looked down at the lit screen and a faint, fleeting smile crossed his face. "I don't think phones ever appear in dreams... well, you might not believe me, but her name is Ice Cream."

Mai Minghe was momentarily at a loss for how to respond. Remarking that pets resemble their owners might not be the most polite thing to say.

Reed Hydes seemed unwilling to stay in the car a moment longer; as he climbed out, he asked, "By the way, what happened to you?"

Mai Minghe had made every effort to give a brief summary, yet it still rambled on for several minutes of back-and-forth—but Reed Hydes sat by the roadside without any impatience, and in fact seemed to slowly recover his composure amid her meandering account.

"Lucky I hesitated for a moment and didn't call you back."

He stared at his phone, still shaken, and said, "I asked if you knew how to use your phone for light, you said yes, and turned and walked away, right? I kept my flashlight shining ahead of you the whole time, so it wasn't until you were almost across the road that I realized—you were using the screen for light."

"Isn't that how you do it?" Mai Minghe blinked.

Reed Hydes showed her: the back of the phone immediately blazed with a bright white light. "See, phones have a flashlight too."

How remarkable.

Mai Minghe turned the phone over and over in her hands, and suddenly remembered that the thief who had broken into her room had also used light that way—lucky she hadn't thought of it just then.

"I was so exhausted at the time, I figured the car was empty anyway, so it didn't matter what kind of light I used... Good thing I didn't call you back to teach me the flashlight, or you probably would have dissolved in that taxi."

Reed Hydes thought for a moment, then added, "While you were sleeping in the apartment building, I was worried I'd fall asleep myself, so I put on a podcast I'd downloaded to listen to—that's why it was left on the screen. I never expected that one little thing would end up helping you so much. They say 'luck is part of skill,' and I suppose that's not entirely wrong."

Before Mai Minghe could ask, he raised one hand first: "Wait until we're back—I'll explain what 'downloading' and 'podcasts' are then. This is no place for that conversation."

Mai Minghe grinned at him. "You really are a kind-hearted kid. I was half afraid you'd go back to acting like you'd never met me once we returned."

Reed Hydes paused. "That just feels... inhumane somehow..."

Compared to the constant danger and torment they had endured, the journey back to Blackmoor City was remarkably smooth—they didn't encounter a single Resident intent on killing Mai Minghe. By the time she registered her surroundings again, she was back in Blackmoor City, only Reed Hydes was no longer beside her.

She landed in the same spot as before: Mai Minghe rolled off the large dumpster, and dragged her injured foot home one hissing step at a time.

Aside from the worn-out old apartment she had lived in for decades, she had nowhere else to go.

Several days had passed since the thief's visit; the intruder had surely given up by now. Mai Minghe reached out and turned the door handle, finding it still unlocked—one push and it swung open. The apartment was empty, the air cool and faintly stale, everything exactly as it had been before she fell into the Nest.

Whether Mai Minghe was in this world or not made no difference to anyone.

She walked into the dim, narrow living room and found the light switch in the same spot her hand had found it for decades—smooth and yellowed with age.

The moment the light came on, Mai Minghe stood dazed and suddenly felt as though the past few days had been nothing but a dream. Like this apartment, her life wore the same stiff, familiar face it always had, arriving now at an ending she could not escape...

Until she looked down and saw her own two hands.

Mai Minghe stood motionless in the middle of the room, as though those young hands possessed some irresistible enchantment—she stared at them for a long while without being able to pull her thoughts away—until the telephone rang with a bright trill, snapping her back; she strode over and grabbed the receiver.

"Hello?" From the receiver came a small, distant Reed Hydes. "Are you home?"

"Yes," Mai Minghe let out a breath of relief. "Oh, it's you."

The last time anyone had called her felt like two or three years ago.

"I just remembered, you might need me to take you to see someone about your injuries. There are doctors in Blackmoor City who can treat Hunters..." Reed Hydes said. "Don't forget to bring cash—they don't usually come cheap."

"Oh, that's fine, I can just go to a regular hospital," Mai Minghe said, a little puzzled. "Do I really need to find a doctor who specifically treats Hunters?"

On the other end of the line, Reed Hydes paused.

"Go to the hospital? Do you have ID and health insurance?"

"Hm? Of course I do—" Mai Minghe had barely begun before she stopped cold, drawing in a sharp breath. "Right!"

She was no longer the eighty-six-year-old Mai Minghe listed on the insurance policy.

"Exactly." Reed Hydes was entirely unsurprised; he had clearly seen this coming. "All your old insurance documents are probably useless now. If you can only pay cash, a Hunter clinic would be far more convenient and reasonable."

That was a problem—by the looks of it, she had become a complete off-the-books existence. No ID, no insurance, and no telling how much longer her bank account would remain accessible.

The pension had always been meager to begin with, but if she couldn't collect it and couldn't pay rent, she would even lose this apartment...

She had told herself she was back in reality, but this was way too real.

Looked at this way, the Artifact Report business could wait a little longer—how to keep herself afloat had become the pressing matter at hand.

The money a solitary old woman could draw on would be woefully inadequate compared to the expenses that came with being young.

She truly hadn't imagined that at eighty-six years old, she would have to find ways to earn money again.

"Money..." Mai Minghe murmured a sigh to herself.

"Hm?" Reed Hydes's attention sharpened. "You don't have money?"

Mai Minghe replied honestly, "Not very much."

Reed Hydes went quiet for a few seconds, as though he found this very tricky: "A Hunter like you—I've really never seen—"

Right—she was already a Hunter!

Mai Minghe's spirits lifted at once. She suddenly realized that since she was a Hunter now, she should naturally be earning money the way Hunters did—speaking of which, hadn't she brought back an Artifact this time?

"Could you teach me how to figure out what an Artifact does, and where to find buyers?"

As she spoke, Mai Minghe slipped her hand into her trouser pocket and pulled out the small lipstick she had retrieved from the restaurant.

Today is a transitional chapter, relatively straightforward to write. I'm not sure whether the other side of Mai Minghe's life as a Hunter will be interesting to everyone... Personally, I find it quite enjoyable to gradually uncover what the Hunter world looks like, and now Mai Minghe can go be my pathfinder goose.

I'm writing the update right now—things have been a bit busy today.

I was out running around all day, and on the way I spotted a vintage clothing store having a sale—well, I nearly couldn't leave; walked out with three pieces of clothing for forty yuan.

Just got home not long ago and started writing, but I'll most likely not be done by midnight...

Everyone go to sleep if you need to sleep, grab a late-night snack if you're hungry, fight crime if you're fighting crime, go on your assassination mission if you've got one, order your male model—ahem—whatever kind of night you're having, there'll definitely be an update ready when you wake up in the morning.

Friends out fighting crime, please, as a favor to me, don't arrest the friends who are assassins—thank you, thank you. Readers are hard to come by; we can't afford to wipe each other out.

Chapter 191: Mai Minghe Accidentally Corners the Doctor

Although Mai Minghe was eager to find her first Artifact client, the most pressing matter was still to take care of her body's needs: treatment, food, sleep—any one of those could come first.

Since Reed Hydes was more seriously injured and had to be treated first, she decided to go along with him to see the doctor.

Having a phone was convenient—when he called a cab and it was nearly downstairs, one phone call was all it took for Mai Minghe to head down and wait. Once she sold the Artifact, she'd have to get herself a smartphone too.

"What's this?"

The moment he got in the car, Reed Hydes found a paper bag pushed into his arms.

"I figured you had to be starving," Mai Minghe said, sitting down and pulling the car door shut. "I made you some toast sandwiches, and there's a box of juice too."

"Isn't this an elementary school lunch?"

Reed Hydes seemed both amused and a little embarrassed, and had just started handing the paper bag back when his stomach let out a long, gurgling tirade against him. After Mai Minghe urged him a couple of times, he sheepishly took out the sandwich, bit off a large mouthful, and mumbled while chewing: "...It's like I suddenly have a grandmother."

"Too bad there's no Ice Cream to feed," Mai Minghe watched him, clearly pleased. "I just love watching animals... and people eat."

"You didn't forget to bring money, did you?" Reed Hydes glanced at the sandwich and said.

"The money in my account—I withdrew it all." There hadn't been much to begin with; originally it had been enough to last her to the end of her days.

"Huh? You know how to use an ATM?"

Even the driver in the front seat couldn't help glancing up at Mai Minghe in the rearview mirror—who would be that shocked that a woman who looked to be in her twenties could use an ATM?

"Have you never spent time around elderly people?"

Mai Minghe wasn't afraid of being overheard; let the driver be confused—he'd never be able to make sense of it anyway. "As I recall, ATMs existed back in the seventies."

Reed Hydes smiled sheepishly, a smear of mayonnaise at the corner of his mouth. "My grandmother's generation all passed away quite early—I never got to meet any of them."

The clinic that catered mainly to Hunters was located in an old building in the Little Italy District. Fortunately the elevator ran around the clock, which was the only way two people who couldn't scrape together a single good pair of legs between them could make it up to the third floor.

Reed Hydes had already made an appointment with the doctor before they came; even though the front desk was unmanned and the lights were dim throughout, the clinic door was unlocked. He pushed it open and called out: "Dr. Nate?"

Mai Minghe had imagined that a doctor who treated Hunters for a living must be something else entirely—would he look like a gangster? A tough guy? Or some kind of mad scientist?

What walked out was just an ordinary man, looking as though the weight of life had been pressing down on a main artery, draining all the color from his face; he looked more like a patient than a doctor.

Then again, being called in before five in the morning to deal with injuries, his complexion was bound to be poor.

A thick stack of newspapers was piled on the desk in the office, which made Mai Minghe feel oddly at home. These days, even the little kiosks selling newspapers and magazines seemed to have vanished from the streets of Blackmoor City.

But for some reason, the dates on all the newspapers appeared to be the same day—it seemed Dr. Nate had bought every edition of every paper for that one day.

"Dr. Nate, how have things been lately?" Reed Hydes was remarkably good at tolerating pain; even with a bone fracture, he could still draw in a hiss of cold air and make small talk with the doctor.

Dr. Nate glanced at Mai Minghe and let out a long sigh. "A new Hunter?"

His eye for people was that sharp?

"I told him," Reed Hydes said.

The thought that she could now be introduced to others as a Hunter gave Mai Minghe a small, involuntary surge of pride.

"I truly don't understand what you Hunters are made of," Dr. Nate shook his head, studying the X-ray. "This line of work isn't something a normal person can endure, and yet you just keep throwing yourselves into it, one after another... I've had enough, for my part. I'm planning to retire soon."

"Why the sudden thought of retiring?"

Dr. Nate seemed reluctant to get into it. "...I'm pretty sure there are no Hunters in the Bahamas."

He disliked Hunters so much—so why had he started working with them in the first place?

Puzzled, Mai Minghe looked up and, over the back of the doctor as he bent down to apply the splint, caught Reed Hydes's eye.

Strictly speaking, why the doctor wanted to retire had nothing to do with either of them; if this doctor retired, they could just find another one.

But at that moment, it hadn't yet occurred to Mai Minghe that if she ignored everything that didn't concern her, she would never make it as a Hunter—because Artifacts could be hidden beneath any surface.

"Doctor, you've had this clinic open for about twenty years, haven't you?" Reed Hydes asked.

"That's right."

"So who was it that suddenly made you think this Hunter business was frightening?" He made no effort to conceal his curiosity. "Some people really have no consideration for others."

Dr. Nate was quiet for a moment, and only after he finished applying the splint did he say: "Someone like Chase Monroe... it's gone beyond 'no consideration.' He's too ruthless in what he does."

She had no idea who that was—some Hunter, presumably—and Mai Minghe let her gaze drift back over the pile of newspapers on the desk.

Dr. Nate surely had a smartphone. She'd heard there was nothing you couldn't find on a smartphone, yet he had still gone out and bought every edition of every newspaper for that day...

When someone couldn't afford to miss a single source of information, whatever it was, it was no small matter.

"Are you worried that something is about to come to light?" Mai Minghe asked.

The shock made Dr. Nate's face practically leap off his skull.

"Chase Monroe..." Reed Hydes murmured under his breath, "the number-two man in the Key House Faction. I've heard about his brutal methods too. But if he pulled you into something, the payout would certainly have been substantial... ah, no wonder you can suddenly afford to retire, Doctor."

Even without knowing who was who in Hunter circles, Mai Minghe understood one thing: if Reed Hydes said the payout was "substantial," then it was definitely not some simple, above-board piece of good fortune.

"Someone didn't end up dead, did they?" she ventured cautiously. "You saw something, Doctor?"

"You don't know Chase Monroe's reputation," Reed Hydes said. "Odds are it did involve a death. My guess is Dr. Nate is afraid the whole thing will blow up and he'll end up an accessory."

"And that is exactly why I can't stand you Hunters!"

Dr. Nate slammed the prescription sheet down on the desk and lost his temper: "Every last one of you is like you've got some kind of compulsion—catch one whiff of something and you'll track it all the way back to your great-great-grandmother's grave. Not one more word out of either of you. If this gets out, don't think I won't drag you both down with me."

Both of them fell silent; but Mai Minghe, lips pressed tightly together, still couldn't entirely suppress the corners of her mouth.

"What are you so happy about?" Reed Hydes asked.

"Does this mean I have a bit of a Hunter's instinct?" Mai Minghe asked, smiling.

"Seems like it," Reed Hydes smiled too. "Coming out with an Artifact on your first time into the Nest—that really is something."

Strictly speaking it had been the second time, but the difference was small enough that Mai Minghe felt she could accept the compliment without too much guilt. Dr. Nate was displeased, but

treatment still had to continue; while he attended to Mai Minghe's injuries, she and Reed Hydes chatted idly back and forth, and the conversation drifted to the Black Heart Restaurant.

"...I only just found out—they can actually go out to sea, and they fish out there. It seems to correspond to the Central Bay area of Blackmoor City— ow!"

Mai Minghe cried out in pain and pulled her foot back, looking at Dr. Nate in front of her— she found his expression was even worse than her own. "What's wrong? You nearly took a strip of skin right off me."

"You two... you're not here with some ulterior motive, are you?" His eyes had darkened several shades, and he turned them back and forth between the two of them. "What did you hear? Why did you come to me?"

Both of them were more bewildered than the other.

"Ulterior motive?" Reed Hydes said. "We came to get patched up, obviously."

"Then what was she just talking about—something about going out to sea from Central Bay—what did she mean by that?"

Reed Hydes had said before that people who dealt with Hunters generally understood the Nest only in a vague, surface-level way—unless a Hunter was willing to take the trouble to explain it all; and even then, no Hunter would dare claim to know the Nest inside and out—there were even people who could deal with Hunters regularly while still refusing to believe the Nest existed.

Mai Minghe didn't know how much Dr. Nate knew, but at that moment, she had no time to think about whether she should say more or less.

Because in that instant, a fragment of information from the Nest—perhaps because it had finally found a connection—drove itself sharply into her mind, carrying its own momentum, and tumbled out of her mouth before she could stop it.

"The sea of Blackmoor City is something special. Although Nest Residents cannot come ashore into Blackmoor City through the sea, there are times when Residents, while out at sea, can dredge up things that have sunk into Blackmoor City's waters and bring them into the Nest."

Dr. Nate stared at her blankly, then instinctively turned his head and looked at the thick pile of newspapers on the desk.

It was as if an answer had finally fallen into his hands, and he didn't know whether to be afraid or relieved.

"You two... you should go," he said, setting down the bandage and pointing toward the door. "I just remembered—there's something urgent I need to take care of."

I'm quite fond of this sort of chapter with a slice-of-life feel (?)—even if it does risk feeling like filler... 2,600 characters; if this were a TV drama, it would probably fill about ten minutes of screen time.

On another note, there have been a few small good things lately, like buying three pieces of clothing for forty yuan, and finding the haircut that was destined for my soul.

No matter how many days I go without washing my hair, I wake up every morning with fluffy, voluminous hair! I never used to wear my hair down because it looked bad, but now I finally understand how people feel when they head out the door with their hair down...

It feels like the eighteen-or-so years before I met this hairdresser were all wasted—I'll go wherever she goes; I'm half-tempted to propose to her.

Grateful Saturday (double edition)

I'm sorry, dear readers, because I haven't been sleeping well, there were a few Saturdays I quietly glossed over, shamelessly pretending nothing had happened—looking back, that's what you call taking advantage of people's goodwill.

Today, in addition to the (long-overdue) thank-you chapter, there is also a Silver Game extra chapter, which has already been posted! It's at the very front of the book in the related works section (updates to that section don't trigger a notification—ugh).

Today I am doubly devoted and doubly smooth.

Today's thank-you chapter is a bit different—rumor has it that Hunters in Blackmoor City have received a mission connected to thank-you gifts, and the Nest has grown a little restless.

It's not that the Residents especially want to thank anyone—it's that they always suspect whoever expresses gratitude is the one who ends up with the money. The logic is backwards, but you can't exactly say they're wrong, can you.

So today's thank-you chapter is mainly the Residents testing the waters, while also drumming up some sponsorship for the Nest—to see if any readers out there would be willing to become their

long-term patrons.

"Isn't this the September thank-you list?"

The Slender Patient lifted a sheet of paper with its equally slender fingers, and its heel-like eyeballs rotated a few times.

"Has there been a time lag between the Nest and reality? It's already November on our end... hm? Oh? There's a delay? So they're even late with their thanks? What unruly humans."

"My billing tier is high, so I'm starting with the biggest donors," it said, looking over the thank-you list, its heels lighting up.

"Gunsmith Rousseau! Always such generous donations! Humans waited a whole two months to organize a thank-you—which proves humans don't deserve you at all. Don't you agree? We Residents are far more considerate, far more appreciative."

Dream Playwright leaned in for a look as well—to express surprise, it had specifically swapped to the face of a pretty girl, eyes wide open.

"As long as you sponsor our Nest, we can report your donations around the clock, twenty-four hours a day." The elongated patient said gently, "What else do you like? Do you like tuna? We have an ocean too. I can also arrange Residents to dress up as tuna and do a gunsmith's shuttle right at your feet. What a pity Rousseau died too soon — can't drag him into the Nest..."

"That might have to be a bonus chapter," the Dream Playwright said, its blank face lighting up. "I can write the bonus chapter content."

"I'd be willing to star in it," the elongated patient said. "You have to come watch. Mm... next one is..."

"The tall-tall fish?"

The elongated patient shot upright from the waist, its legs still lying flat on the bed.

"A long-term gold patron! Someone who speaks my language — look, I'm tall too, aren't I? Come visit the Nest sometime, and we can discuss how to get taller and taller, the taller the better, so tall you could reach out and strangle someone on the 30th floor just like that."

Its gaze — well, its foot-gaze — looked downward, seemingly bracing itself for a phonetic challenge.

"Thank you, Csmshksdaaa..." it said, one letter at a time. "Though saying your name takes a full minute, we Residents have nothing if not long lives. Besides, we're usually free with nothing to do. I am willing, with my low, phlegm-laden voice, to call out to you again and again — what are you doing?"

The Dream Playwright withdrew its hand, tilted up its blank face, and said, "Humans don't seem to like phlegmy voices."

"Isn't that even better — it's supposed to make them suffer — oh right, I'm soliciting sponsorships."

The elongated patient looked rather troubled.

"French girl Meixiang," it said, then stopped and smacked its lips. After a moment's thought, it said it again: "French girl Meixiang..."

"What is it?"

"Nothing, it's just that as a gold patron, she has a certain charm... a certain flavor... she seems like she might taste very good..."

"You can't eat her."

"Oh, thank you... French girl Meixiang."

The Dream Playwright took the thank-you list out of the elongated patient's hands — the patient was still slowly savoring the name.

"Let me take over. Next up is — oh my, Little Yi's Grain Storehouse? This must be a new gold patron, right? An unfamiliar face, which means you haven't taken the wrong path for very long yet and haven't become inextricably entangled with humans. It's not too late to turn back now and come over to the Nest."

Across its blank face drifted an expression of someone who felt they had said something quite good. Never mind how that expression got there — it was there.

"Next, thank you, Firefly Flood the City. See, it's a good thing I fetched the list in time, because Patient Brother simply cannot appreciate this kind of aesthetic. Those of us in literary arts have a deeper feel for the imagery of your name... but words alone don't count for much — come to the Nest yourself, and I'll light up every warning sign for you, fill the whole city with howling in your honor."

It turned a page, then swapped on a gentle face — it truly did swap on Mai Minghe's face — and said, "Oh, the next three seem to be regulars in the seats of honor for this chapter.

"Thank you, Messenger AtRnname, Three-Drinks-Love-Red-Bean-Cake, and Catch-a-Little-Cloud-Cat. May I ask: what is your impression of the Nest? What has moved you to donate so generously and so persistently? Surely it's the Residents, isn't it? Does it really matter who you're tipping? I hope the three of you will think carefully about this — take it from d— take my advice: switch your support to the Nest."

It turned another page.

"Between September 1st and September 20th, there was this much support all along..."

"Thank you, Colorful Dense Fog, Non-Edible Kitten Gummies, Can't Think of a Name, Yuyuan Eats Taro Balls... Always Stand on the Side of the Egg? Why? I could crush an egg with one squeeze.

"Mm, and also: Not at Shejian, One Tail Hair, Junmi Xi, Pengxiao Xi, A Cup of Daydream No Sugar, Pupupi, The World's Third-to-Last Sea Sausage, Qoushi Seventeen... This batch of names also has a note that says 'long-term stable wool supplier' — what does that mean?"

"Thank you, Blackmoor City Resident — wait a moment."

The Dream Playwright stared at the list for a long while, growing a little confused. "This is a resident of Blackmoor City, right? Not one who escaped from the Nest? You're not allowed to sneak in on your own, kid..."

"The next page is... hm? There are this many long-term stable wool suppliers?"

"Isn't this the earlier gold patron Luotai 2020? And also, thank you, Ginger Is Sweet, Moheli Rain Owl, Mia Ao, Candy Little Salt Ice, Expects to See Me as I Am...

"Moon Falls into Cotton Candy — how whimsical. And also Qinglin Ohp, Dandelion and Cooking Smoke, Shandong Runaway Excavator — this one's untraceable, is that it — Cat Cat Tail Worm, Foodie Ding Xiaoqi, BMZZ83, Lucky or Not Lucky, The Cat of March Seventh, Thorns of Silence."

The Dream Playwright rattled off all the thanks in one breath, then paused.

"Gratitude, as a behavior, seems somewhat at odds with the nature of us Residents."

From beneath its crookedly worn wig came a suppressed groan. "All this thanking is actually starting to hurt... So, are there any gold patrons willing to sponsor the Nest?"

【Don't forget to check out the bonus game at the beginning of the work, everyone!】

Chapter 192: Mai Minghe Officially Steps into the Hunter World

When Mai Minghe woke, the bedroom was shrouded in darkness, and through the curtains, only the night seeped in.

She was lying in her familiar bedroom; at the edge of her vision sat the railing of her nursing bed. Hanging from the railing was a plastic bag containing tissues the social worker used to wipe her mouth, leftover sweet biscuits, and other trash Mai Minghe had no way of throwing away without getting up.

So it had all been a dream...

The despair, the loss, the fear of that instant hit her like waking to find herself trapped in a car, wrapped in an iron coffin, sinking to the bottom of a deep river.

Just as Mai Minghe was on the verge of tears, she suddenly noticed a dull, throbbing pain coming in waves from her feet; and everything in the room seemed clearer than usual... Right—she could actually make out the plastic bag now.

She felt her way up from the nursing bed to a sitting position, and the first thing her eyes landed on was her own foot, hastily bandaged up like a pillow.

Not a dream... it wasn't a dream.

Mai Minghe sat motionless on the bed, slowly recalling—no, savoring—every single thing that had happened over the past few days.

Whether good, bad, or terrifying, it all felt precious to her. Mai Minghe had never imagined she could still be wrapped in the glow of youth, wandering through a world of wonders, witnessing all manner of dark daisies.

Even the doctor who treated Hunters was so furtive, so full of secrets he couldn't tell a soul... She had truly thrown open the doors to an underground world.

It seemed she needed to adjust her mindset—from here on out, she would likely encounter life-and-death situations from time to time; the ordinary-person instinct she'd had earlier at the clinic, of wondering whether to call the police, probably didn't have much of a place anymore.

No matter how skittish Dr. Nate was, at her insistence he had at least treated the wound properly, and before they left, Dr. Nate had sold each of them a crutch—since Hunters were

frequently injured, he kept a small storeroom in his office stocked with braces, crutches of all kinds, folding wheelchairs, and the like, all sold at prices well above market rate.

Leaning on her crutch, Mai Minghe picked up a small clock and found it was half past one in the morning—already the 22nd.

When she and Reed Hydes had gone to the doctor, it had still been the 21st, around four or five in the morning; after coming home, she hadn't even managed to eat before collapsing into bed and sleeping straight through until now.

Reed Hydes had warned her once that after coming out of the Nest, people generally needed to sleep for a long time; but sleeping for nearly twenty hours in one stretch was truly beyond what Mai Minghe had expected.

Had that kid been awake for ages already?

A single visit to the clinic had wiped out half of elderly Mai Minghe's savings; the first thing young Mai Minghe thought of upon waking was to quickly find a buyer for the lipstick Artifact—she hesitated a moment, then took out the slip of paper with Reed Hydes's number on it.

He had said to call him once she was up, any hour was fine, since Hunters had no normal schedule to speak of... so half past one in the morning should be alright?

The phone rang once, then again, with no answer; just when Mai Minghe was nearly starting to doubt she had the right number, she finally heard Reed Hydes let out a drowsy, muddled "hello."

He had obviously been jolted awake, and sounded deeply aggrieved: "...You're up already?"

"Y-yes..." Mai Minghe had the strange sense that she'd done something wrong.

After a bout of rustling noise, Reed Hydes sounded as though he might cry. "You slept the same as me—barely twenty hours. How are you already awake?"

Barely?

Was "barely" really the right word here?

"You're truly not tired?"

"Not tired at all," Mai Minghe said, puzzled herself. "I slept twenty hours—how could I still be tired?"

"Most Hunters sleep a day or two after coming out!"

Could it be that older people simply needed less sleep?

"And your head is clear? No ringing in the ears, no hallucinations, no sense of disconnection from your body?"

He sounded even more like a doctor than Dr. Nate.

"None of that," Mai Minghe answered, twisting her waist, kicking her legs, rolling her shoulders, and running through a few mental arithmetic problems—aside from being hungry enough to eat someone alive, she felt absolutely fine.

"That's quite rare... Could that black strip Artifact of yours have some function that wards off Nest Dissociation Syndrome?"

He didn't expect an answer. After thinking it over, he said, reluctant but resigned, "Well, you're already awake... Fine, let's just head to Between the Backlights now. The sooner we're done, the sooner I can get back to sleep... mm, I can grab a meal while I'm at it."

Between the Backlights was a bar that seemed to be known to everyone in Hunter circles—especially among solo hunters and small-House Faction Hunters.

Between the Backlights at two in the morning bore none of the thinning crowds or fading energy of other bars at that hour; the moment the two of them pushed the door open and walked in, they were hit full in the face by a wall of noise, music, warmth, and the smell of alcohol.

"Oh!" Mai Minghe couldn't help widening her eyes.

The bar's layout and décor were more or less what she'd expect of any bar; the most striking and remarkable difference was the clientele.

It seemed as though everyone here knew that inside Between the Backlights, they no longer had to hide the part of themselves that belonged to the Hunters; the shadows of both the Nest and Blackmoor City seemed to interweave and overlap within this single bar, forming a space that belonged to Hunters alone—distinct from either world.

At the bar counter sat a man with a bowl cut, repeatedly dropping eye drops into his eyes for some reason; as Mai Minghe passed the counter, she happened to catch his companion reminding him, "Hey, half a minute's up—time for the drops."

"Hasn't been half a minute, has it? Didn't I just do it... ugh, so annoying."

The bowl-cut man said this, then turned his head, and his left eyeball suddenly burst into loud, cackle-filled laughter—"oh-ha-ha-ha-ha"—hurling a string of impressively creative profanity at him.

He seemed startled; amid his companion's gleeful "told you so," he quickly put a drop in the eyeball, and only then did it grumble itself quiet.

...But what did he do when he slept? Mai Minghe thought blankly.

In a corner, a few young people each had a beer in hand and were heatedly arguing about something; listening closely, she realized they were squabbling over the split from selling an Artifact.

A blonde girl said, "We got this Artifact at the cost of Xiao Bu dying!"

Someone had died—Mai Minghe's heart lurched.

Then the blonde girl shoved the chestnut-haired girl beside her and said, "Xiao Bu, don't you think you deserve a bigger cut?"

...So Xiao Bu, the one who had died, was also right there. A kid who even in death wasn't about to give up drinking beer.

Mai Minghe didn't even feel like anything was off anymore.

At another table, a woman with a ponytail was mid-conversation when she finally lost patience, said "got it," stood up, tilted her head back, and tossed what looked like a handful of candy beans into her mouth—the next second, her entire body rapidly swelled with knotted muscle that filled her loose tracksuit to the seams, until it seemed that even a careless bump into her would shatter someone's bones.

As the ponytail woman headed for the door, the man she'd been talking to called after her: "Remember—make sure to leave your fingerprints!"

What kind of criminal activity required you to leave your fingerprints?

Was this bar always this interesting?

Mai Minghe's curiosity had long since swelled to bursting; if she were a balloon, it would have inflated her all the way up into the sky by now.

Reed Hydes, injured and sleep-deprived (the latter debatable), reminded her quietly: "You're craning your neck too much—pull it back in. If we make someone uncomfortable, we're both

injured; who could we possibly take on?"

Mai Minghe started—and in that moment, she did something entirely in keeping with the atmosphere of this bar.

She reached up to feel the top of her head and reflexively asked, "Did my second head pop back out?"

Someone in the booth beside her glanced over, then turned away and went back to their conversation.

"Hey, this spot just opened up—let's sit here."

The man who'd just asked for fingerprints had settled his bill and left; Reed Hydes quickly gestured for Mai Minghe to claim the seats—the bar was packed, every spot full, with new customers trickling in all the time, so finding a seat was no small feat.

Once the two of them sat down, they dared not leave their seats, heads tilted back, eyes locked on the servers weaving through the crowd, trying to catch one for their order—in that regard, Hunters and ordinary people were no different.

"Why is it called Between the Backlights?" Mai Minghe asked. "The name has a kind of literary feel to it—not the sort of name you'd expect Hunters to come up with."

"Looking down on Hunters now, are you," Reed Hydes said with a laugh. "The bar owner used to have an explanation posted inside the shop. It stuck with me."

While they waited for a server, he explained: "Supposedly, in Japanese aesthetics—which particularly prizes the beauty of shadow—'backlight' is a frequently used image because it carries a sense of the hidden and the hazy. And since backlight only exists because one place is darker than another, 'backlight' also contains within it the longing of one place for another. Doesn't that sound a bit like the Nest?"

"And 'between' carries meaning too. The world is not a whole assembled from parts—it's just that we happen to name individual portions of the whole 'streets' or 'hills.' Between those named parts, there runs a continuous, ambiguous place that can't be expressed in words—that is what 'between' means. 'Between the Backlights' is, in truth, the very essence of the Nest: the place each and every one of us Hunters returns to, again and again..."

Just as Mai Minghe was lost in wonder, Reed Hydes suddenly thrust his arm up and called out loudly: "Excuse me! Hi! Over here—we haven't ordered yet!"

...He pivoted fast.

The bar menu was limited; after Reed Hydes ordered two burgers, two plates of buffalo hot chicken wings, and two plates of fries, he looked up at Mai Minghe. "What do you want?"

"All of that is for you?"

Mai Minghe consulted her stomach, which found it not entirely unreasonable, and promptly told the waitress: "Then... I'll have the same. And add a Caesar salad."

As soon as the waitress left, Reed Hydes suddenly froze.

His gaze traveled past Mai Minghe's shoulder and landed on a booth diagonally behind her; he seemed to stop himself from staring, yet his eyes drifted over every now and then as if pulled by a string.

"What's wrong?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Don't turn around," Reed Hydes said quietly, dropping his gaze to study the wooden tabletop in front of him. "Speak of the devil... what a coincidence, really."

"What devil? Who did you see?"

Reed Hydes coughed once and covered his mouth with one hand. "Chase Monroe is sitting right over there."

Today's chapter came out a little late because I found it so interesting to write (don't tell me if you don't like it)—I got more and more into it, and it kept getting longer... The name *Between the Backlights* was planned out all the way back when Sydney Ginn first appeared, and it's finally landed here, a hundred and eighty chapters later.

The unfortunate news is that I need to take a leave... Qidian has organized an event and invited me to go be a human backdrop (eight hours a day, good lord), so on the 21st, 22nd, and 23rd, I probably won't have time to write updates.

Of course I'll try my best to squeeze out updates—I just don't know how much I'll manage, so I'm giving everyone a heads-up in advance.

Chapter 193: Mai Minghe's Lipstick

Pretending to look for the waitress, Mai Minghe turned back around with an air of indifference, letting her gaze sweep across the corner booth behind her, then circle the rest of the bar, completing the act before turning forward again.

Even without having seen him before, she recognized Chase Monroe at a glance—his looks and bearing were nearly impossible to mistake.

Chase Monroe was not alone.

Sitting beside him was a girl with long chestnut-brown hair, bright and elfin-looking, the sort of face that drew people in immediately; across from them sat a dark-haired woman wearing a sun hat woven from straw, even though it was the middle of the night and they were indoors.

Because that booth was tucked at the far end of a corner, the woman in the sun hat had her back to the entire bar, facing only the other two, so her face was impossible to see.

For some reason, neither Chase nor the chestnut-haired girl would let their eyes rest on the person sitting across from them—their gazes veered left and right, parting around her like a river splitting around a stone.

Right up until Mai Minghe turned back around, no one at that table seemed to be speaking; the atmosphere felt distinctly strange.

"Didn't I tell you not to look..."

Reed Hydes, speaking with a hand pressed over his mouth, was now slumped face-down on the table, complaining at her, as though he wished he could melt and flow away along its surface.

"Ah, it's not like I noticed right away."

Mai Minghe, hungry enough to have fished all the ice cubes out of her glass, was chewing as she spoke: "I just remembered—I think I've only ever seen his back before. This is my first time seeing his face straight on. The young man is really something! Tall and built, you can tell even when he's sitting down. The way you described him, I thought he might be some kind of eyesore... but that face of his doesn't come from a wicked heart."

Young teeth were truly something—the ice cracked and crunched in just a few bites, ground to nothing. Beneath that sound, it was even harder for anyone farther away to catch what she was

saying.

Reed Hydes lowered his eyes, his expression somewhere between aggrieved and defeated; he didn't answer her.

"I have a niece by marriage, been set on handsome men since she was little—she'd be thrilled to see him. The two of them would even look good together; my niece is tall and pretty... oh, wait, I just remembered, she must be at least fifty by now."

Reed Hydes buried his face in his hands.

"It's just a little odd... he just got out of the hospital, didn't he? How'd he end up at a bar this fast? Young people these days, no idea how to take care of themselves."

Reed Hydes lifted his face out of his hands again, a light kindling in his eyes that could only be called "gossip."

"The hospital? How do you know?"

This time when Mai Minghe looked up, it was a genuine search for the waitress.

"Good looks are a matter of features—his complexion is sickly. Please, I've seen how many sick people in my life? One glance and I can tell his body isn't right—and he's drinking with that going on? Besides, under the collar of his jacket, you can still see his hospital gown."

Reed Hydes was visibly fighting the urge to look again and asked, "Really? How come I didn't see the hospital gown?"

"Not every hospital gown looks like a hospital gown, but that particular style I happen to have seen before." Mai Minghe reminded him, "I've been living in Blackmoor City for eighty-six years."

Reed Hydes seemed to feel a quiet stirring of admiration. "Right."

The two fell into a brief silence.

Mai Minghe pricked up her ears, sensing that no one at Chase Monroe's table seemed to be speaking either—or if they were, their voices were too low, swallowed by the noise of the bar.

"This is quite a coincidence..." she said hesitantly. "What do we do? Does it affect what we have planned?"

Reed Hydes thought it over seriously.

"I was startled too just now... but when I think it through, I don't feel like it's a big deal. If our conversation with Dr. Nate truly had any special significance, it would've been just one phone call for Dr. Nate—he'd have known long ago. Looking at the situation now, either he doesn't know, or he knows and it has nothing to do with us."

Reed Hydes used "he" when referring to Chase Monroe; after all, people are extremely sensitive to their own names, and even with the bar being noisy, what if he heard?

"Most people in this bar probably know who he is, but look—everyone's minding their own business, no trouble at all. His reputation may not be great, but he's not a rabid dog; as long as there's no conflict, he's not going to go around biting strangers one by one. If you ask me, we do what we came to do, act like we don't know him, and there's nothing to worry about."

He talked himself into it and gave a nod; just then, the waitress arrived carrying a great many plates.

The moment they saw the food, nothing else in the world existed.

The two of them would have gladly buried their faces in the plates; their chewing could not begin to keep pace with the furious, ravenous urge to feed more food into their mouths like an assembly line—unfortunately, even Hunters couldn't grow an extra mouth.

Before long, both their cheeks were steadily swelling and puffing out, looking for all the world like a chipmunk and a squirrel that had suddenly gained sentience; the two rodents, separated from each other by small mountains of chicken wings, fries, and burger patties, were still laboriously chomping their upper and lower jaws together, swallowing as hard as they could.

"You two might want to drink some water in between," said the waitress when she passed by, unable to look away. "Did you just wake up right after coming out of the Nest?"

"Yep, jus' woke up," Reed Hydes somehow managed to locate his tongue amid a mouthful of food and use it to speak. "We got shome Arfifacts we wanna shell."

The waitress had seen enough of the world to keep a straight face; she could even understand him: "Artifacts to move? How many?"

"One shec."

"Flag me down when you're ready."

By the time the two of them set down their hands, sweaty and breathless, the table held nothing but wreckage—empty plates, used cups, and crumpled wads of dirty napkins. Mai Minghe was almost gasping; she leaned back in her chair, feeling simultaneously happy, satisfied, and stomach-sick.

"Does everyone in this bar know about the Nest?" she thought back to the exchange between the waitress and Reed Hydes and asked. "They all seem pretty well-versed in Hunter habits."

"As far as I know, from the owner to the kitchen staff, they're all retired Hunters," Reed Hydes said. "In the beginning it was just a bar, apparently, but it gradually started doing everything else too—moving Artifacts, finding buyers, putting out word, tracking people down, you name it."

And so the moment had finally come.

Mai Minghe took the lipstick out of her pocket and set it on the table.

"So then," she said—she could feel that her eyes must be bright right now—"what does this Artifact do?"

Reed Hydes flashed her a smile, as though caught up in her excitement.

"Seeing you like this really takes me back to when I first started out... Look carefully over the lipstick, see if there's any brand marking, label, or shade number."

"Shade number? You know your stuff."

Reed Hydes scratched his head. "I wouldn't say I know that much about it. Besides, my ex-girlfriend used to love putting me in women's clothes."

...He really didn't treat her like an outsider.

Come to think of it, since getting her hands on the lipstick, Mai Minghe hadn't actually had a proper chance to look at it.

A line of text was printed along the body of the tube, quite conspicuously; she found it without any trouble.

[Countdown: 1173 days, 1 hour, 02 minutes]

Under Mai Minghe's gaze, the clearly printed text suddenly shifted, becoming 1173 days, 1 hour, 01 minute—she startled slightly, then laughed: "So even printed text can count down?"

Just like an ordinary lipstick sold in the world above, the bottom bore a small label.

—Flock Over Sky—

7g, Origin: the Nest

The shade name "Flock Over Sky" was utterly baffling.

"Keep reading—see if there's any more description below," Reed Hydes encouraged her.

The label was only that one small strip of paper; where else could there be room for more?

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes and leaned in close to the label, and sure enough, she spotted several more lines of text so small they were nearly maddening to read—strange, when she'd been farther away just now, had those lines been there?

Once applied, speak freely.

Say whatever you want, without worrying about what the other person might not want to hear, or whether your words contradict each other, whether they're true, or whether they sound absurd.

In fact, it's best to say plenty of opposing things—try to cover every angle.

Even if one sentence is "I'm going to kill you" and the next is "I'm going to save your life," as long as you apply this lipstick (colorless) and say enough words, the listener will seize upon the one sentence they want to hear, disregard all contradictions, and be moved to deep conviction on your behalf.

As for how many lies you tell in the process, how many slips you make—it doesn't matter. Like a flock of birds passing through the sky, they fill the air for a moment and then vanish in an instant; if anyone tries to recall it afterward, they won't be able to grasp a single flaw, won't be able to remember a thing.

Note: Once more than 50% of the lipstick has been worn away, the effect disappears. No lipstick lasts forever—remember to touch up frequently.

...What use was a lipstick with an effect like this?

It wasn't a brainwashing effect where a single sentence could make someone believe unconditionally; from the description, it seemed you had to say a great deal, relying on luck to stumble onto what the listener wanted to hear, and then rely on the lipstick's effect to make it stick.

If you couldn't hold someone's attention from the start, who would sit there patiently while you kept on talking?

Mai Minghe couldn't hide her disappointment and handed the lipstick to Reed Hydes.

Reed Hydes took out his phone, first photographed the label and said "I'll need this in a moment," then enlarged the photo on the screen—the tiny text that had given Mai Minghe a headache was suddenly much easier to read.

Smartphones truly were remarkable; once this lipstick was sold, she wondered whether the money would be enough to buy a new phone.

Reed Hydes stared at the screen in silence for a full ten-plus seconds.

Just as Mai Minghe thought he was simply at a loss for how to console her, he finally let out a long, slow breath—only then did she realize he had been holding it the whole time.

"What is it?"

"This time..." Reed Hydes looked at the countdown, seemingly not hearing her. "Three years... three years. Even the timing lines up perfectly, and there's one extra year on top."

"What lines up?" What extra year?

Reed Hydes handed the lipstick back and fixed his gaze on Mai Minghe, as though weighing something. After quite a while, he finally spoke: "This lipstick... should be an Artifact that came into being only within the last few years."

"How can you tell?"

Reed Hydes seemed to find the explanation too much trouble and simply waved it aside. "How do I put this... in the right hands, it could sell for over a million."

"How much?"

Mai Minghe leaned forward, her voice slipping out of control; the chestnut-haired girl in the corner immediately darted a glance over at her.

Reed Hydes, however, showed little sign of excitement.

It wasn't the look of someone watching another person's windfall while feeling conflicted; his expression was one Mai Minghe couldn't quite read.

"Over a million—that should be no problem."

He thought for a moment and said, "The bar will take a cut for the commission, but their client network is fairly large, so I think it's worth it. Among the clients I know personally, I don't think any of them need it..."

"There's something you're not telling me," Mai Minghe said quietly.

Reed Hydes paused, then nodded.

"Any Hunter would sell it for the highest price without a second thought—and that probably includes me. It's just that, once it enters the world above... I don't know what kind of impact it might bring."

All right, the new chapter got censored again.

Chapter 194: Mai Minghe's Emergency Supplemental Report

Who knows what effects it might cause?

With only that one vague sentence to go on, Mai Minghe truly couldn't figure out what Reed Hydes's reservations were.

She hesitated and asked, "When other Artifacts flow into the human world... do Hunters ever know what consequences they'll cause?"

Mai Minghe asked in earnest, but Reed Hydes misunderstood.

He gave a wry smile and waved his hand. "You're right. Not just this one—whenever we sell any Artifact, we never know who it'll end up with, what it'll be used for, or what kind of effect it'll have.

"Having reservations about just this one Artifact is its own kind of hypocrisy... cough, I've sold plenty of Artifacts I should and shouldn't have. If I truly wanted to be responsible to society, I never should have become a Hunter in the first place."

"That's not what I meant..."

"It's fine," said Reed Hydes, lowering his gaze. No matter the moment, he always looked somewhat weary. "Hunters don't have moral dilemmas."

Mai Minghe watched him with a near-blank look, instinctively wanting to offer a few words of comfort, but she had absolutely no idea what he was talking about.

When she thought about it carefully, it seemed like something that was unavoidable.

Before the thief had shown up and she'd obtained the Artifact, there had been several years during which, though she was alive, she had already completely disconnected from society.

Her world had been nothing more than that apartment bedroom with a crack in the wall; no matter how long the TV stayed on, the only sound that ultimately circled in her mind was the low hum of the oxygen machine.

The social workers would only chat with her about the weather, her health, her medication, her meals... she had never imagined she might once again have any connection to the world beyond her bedroom window.

If she could go on living in her young body from now on, she would come to understand this world again. Until then, she might as well ask Reed Hydes for his opinion first.

"So what you mean is... should I sell this lipstick?"

Reed Hydes glanced at it.

"Sell it. The effect it causes isn't unprecedented—it's already happened before. Humanity doesn't need outside help to race headlong toward its own ruin... if you can make some money along the way, why not?"

Mai Minghe didn't quite follow, but she understood one thing: young people today seemed far more suspicious and pessimistic about the world than she had been in her youth.

She hadn't met many young people, but not a single one of them could be called hopeful—Taylor Ford was like that, and so was Reed Hydes.

When Mai Minghe had been in her twenties and thirties, she hadn't doubted for a moment that the world was getting better and better.

"Then sell it," she nodded and said. "I need the money."

Whatever she could get for it. A million was probably a stretch—she still didn't think a lipstick could have that much power.

If whatever you said after putting it on was believed by everyone who heard it, that would be remarkable; but the lipstick's actual function seemed more like a watered-down version of that.

Reed Hydes took a few more photos and videos, then raised his hand and signaled to the waitress.

The waitress looked at Mai Minghe and smiled at her. "New blood?"

Mai Minghe nodded. "Yes, I've only been in this business a few days..."

"I'm Megan," said the waitress, extending a hand.

Mai Minghe quickly extended her own hand and clasped it; she vaguely worried that she'd just been handling the fries and chicken wings and wasn't sure she'd wiped her hands clean enough—but Megan laughed.

"Give her your lipstick—she handles the preliminary inspection," said Reed Hydes, rubbing his face hard. "That's how they verify the authenticity of Artifacts being sold."

...Why didn't he say so earlier?

"That said, we'd better use the back room." Reed Hydes suddenly remembered. "The item's quite valuable."

Megan glanced at the lipstick in Mai Minghe's hand, nodded, and led the two of them through the bar, pushing open a staff door at the back; behind it was a short hallway leading to the kitchen, the office, and a storage room. Megan opened the office door and said to them both, "Please, come in."

Without any oddly dressed Hunters around, the office looked like nothing more than an ordinary small office.

The one thing that set it apart was the photograph hanging on the back wall:

Megan was dressed in hunting gear, leaning on a double-barreled long hunting rifle, standing before a stretch of trees. With her other hand—the way you'd hold up a big catch of fish or a trophy stag—she was proudly holding up a...

"A Resident?" Mai Minghe drew a sharp breath.

Dangling limply from Megan's hand was a long, slender white strip of a thing; though it looked exactly like a leftover Halloween ghost costume, you could faintly make out that it seemed to be full of grievance and indignation—it was a Resident, and yet looking at it like this, it was honestly not very frightening at all.

"That was taken inside the Nest?"

"Yep," Megan said cheerfully. "Back then I discovered a way to temporarily immobilize a Resident, and the very first time I used it was on that one—how could I not take a photo to commemorate it?"

"What method?" Mai Minghe asked immediately.

"Are you interested in buying the information?" Megan smiled. "That was seven or eight years ago. I don't know how reliable it still is, but I could give you a discount."

...Hunters really were a trade that wouldn't release the hawk until they saw the rabbit.

Sell the lipstick first, then worry about the rest.

"Oh, he really wasn't wrong about that."

Megan studied the lipstick carefully and glanced at Reed Hydes.

"If the right buyer can be found, they'd be willing to pay a high price... but by the same token, if no buyer fits, you won't get a good price for it. Its applicable audience is very niche."

Reed Hydes put on a proper businesslike air and said, "That's exactly why we brought it to Between the Backlights."

Megan unscrewed the cap, twisted up the pigment, and let out a soft "Hm?" "What's with these streaky marks?"

"The Resident hid its mouth in its hair," said Mai Minghe—every sentence she spoke these days was one she'd never imagined she would ever say in her life. "Those were probably made when it applied the lipstick to the back of its head."

"Oh, so it's an Artifact taken out of a 'scene,'" Megan murmured.

What did that mean?

"Residents generally can't use Artifacts, so even if they're holding one, it serves as a prop within the scene." Reed Hydes explained. "For instance, if the lipstick was taken from a scene of 'a Resident putting on makeup,' then to that Resident, it's just a lipstick—it doesn't have the Flock Over Sky effect."

Mai Minghe searched through her internal knowledge base on the Nest—she found that this classification system was one used by Hunters; the Nest itself paid it no mind at all.

"Artifacts that serve as scene props are generally unaffected."

Megan lightly dabbed her fingertip against the pigment, but the streaky marks remained. "...Its appearance was altered by the Resident, which means its function has changed as well..."

"So it can't be sold?" Mai Minghe grew anxious—that was what she cared about most right now.

"Not necessarily. Let's put it up and see. If a buyer requests further testing before committing, we'll go from there."

Reed Hydes added quietly, "Some House Factions run that service—paid inspection. But I don't think it's necessary for the lipstick... you just put it on and say whatever comes to mind in front of me. It's not dangerous anyway."

Mai Minghe nodded and asked, "Where do we put it up?"

For the goods that Hunters brought in to sell, Between the Backlights seemed to have a well-established process in place—only Mai Minghe couldn't make heads or tails of it.

"Have the photos and videos been AirDropped over?" Megan handed the lipstick back and asked. "We don't handle that part—you should know that."

"Already done," said Reed Hydes.

...What had dropped through the air?

Mai Minghe watched, baffled, as both of them pulled out their smartphones.

"Between the Backlights has an official channel on Telegram where Artifacts for sale get posted... ah, never mind, you won't understand."

Megan immediately looked up at Mai Minghe at those words; the latter, supposedly a person in her twenties, currently wore an expression of complete and utter bewilderment.

True to her past as a Hunter, Megan had an instinct to dig to the bottom of things even when they were none of her business—seeing that Reed Hydes wasn't going to explain, Megan seemed to come up with an idea and smiled at Mai Minghe. "Give me your phone number? We can exchange WhatsApp, or email addresses."

"She doesn't have a phone," Reed Hydes covered. "Her phone... got stolen."

"That must be really inconvenient," Megan said, momentarily taken aback, but she seized on another opportunity. "It's two or three in the morning—nowhere to buy a new one right now. Is it urgent? Would you like to buy mine?"

Hm?

Megan opened a drawer, took out a phone in a green case, and slid it across to Mai Minghe.

"I just got a new phone—this old one's already been wiped clean. I can let it go for a good price."

Mai Minghe looked down at it—she wasn't sure what good looking would do her; she couldn't tell quality from poor, or make anything of the model number.

"The model's not that old. Still, buying a new one would probably be better..." Reed Hydes said from the side.

Megan's old phone didn't look old at all—it was sleek and shiny black; the moment Mai Minghe lightly touched it, the screen lit up with a line of text: "Welcome."

Those two words, somehow, quietly moved Mai Minghe.

What a thoughtful phone—it was welcoming her; surely it was hoping for a new owner too?

"Alright," she said, her heart giving a sudden warm flutter. "I'll take it."

Megan was thoroughly pleased, her smile widening across her face—she must have been a fine Hunter once; she had not the slightest shame about her own desires.

The price of the used phone was indeed reasonable, which made Mai Minghe feel even more certain she'd made the right decision.

Only Reed Hydes kept saying regretfully, "Ah, the feeling of tearing open a brand-new phone box—you won't get to experience that now..."

"But I have one right now. Otherwise I'd have to wait until you'd slept off your nap before you could take me to buy one—"

Before Mai Minghe could finish her sentence, the phone suddenly buzzed and vibrated in her hand.

The other two both startled.

"That's strange—did it connect to WiFi?" Megan was puzzled too. "How is it getting a signal..."

When Mai Minghe looked down, the words on the screen were no longer "Welcome"—she immediately tilted the phone upright, angling the screen away from Megan's line of sight.

«Artifact Report»

Emergency Supplemental Issue

Only those who bring change to the world deserve the right to move forward.

Dear contestant Mai Minghe, this Artifact Report is an emergency supplemental issue sent to you under unforeseen circumstances. We hope you can seize this unexpected opportunity and claim your first target.

Be advised: at this moment, a target Artifact is rapidly approaching your location.

Description: black cube

In the face of the risk ahead, please exercise extreme caution.

Wishing you swift success.

From tomorrow through the 23rd, I'll be serving as a human background prop, so I'm not sure how many words I'll be able to squeeze out for updates—just giving everyone a heads-up in advance.

I also have no idea whether a slow-moving story can afford to have gaps in updates—guess I'll find out this time...

Chapter 195: Chase the Good Hound Never Lets Go

After the two of them finished reading the Artifact Report, Sydney Ginn put her phone away and instinctively exchanged a glance with Chase.

Then they both turned their heads and looked at "June."

At some point, a vivid red smile had risen high on the snow-white Noh mask.

"You see,"

"June" said in a tone full of encouragement: "The three of us share the same interests and the same direction forward. We'll need to cooperate well from here on out."

She still spoke in June's voice as she talked, which made everyone deeply uncomfortable; even so, Chase found himself reminded of something else by what she said.

Why had it only been sent to Sydney Ginn?

Had his own phone received the Artifact Report as well?

Since this operation's target involved June, he, as a directly involved party, should have received a copy too—even "June" herself had said the "three of them shared the same direction."

Right, his phone...

Chase patted himself down.

All his clothes had been swapped out for a patient gown; his driver's license, wallet, phone, keys... all of it was gone, he had no idea where.

"Are you looking for your phone? You were transferred here from the previous hospital," Sydney Ginn immediately guessed his intent and said, "They said you can pick it up after you're discharged."

"...Got it. Then let's go right now."

It wasn't just about getting his phone back as quickly as possible; this hospital was on a rival's turf, and the longer they stayed, the more trouble could brew.

Chase propped one hand against the ground, his muscles trembling through several contractions before he finally squeezed out just enough strength to pull himself upright—it was

the first time since reaching adulthood that he had felt his body this powerless.

That thin black shard of Taylor Ford's seemed to poison whoever it touched... if his reaction had been even a little slower at the time, he likely wouldn't have made it this far.

That guy's injuries must have been severe as well... he knew exactly how hard he had struck.

If internal organs had ruptured, even a Hunter-affiliated clinic couldn't handle it; he'd have to be sent to a proper hospital.

Where had Taylor Ford been taken?

"Do you need help?"

He came back to his senses to find Sydney Ginn's hand hovering in midair, more a gesture of politeness than any real offer of assistance.

"I'm worried I won't be able to hold you—you might flatten me. Mm, I'm not calling you fat, but you really are heavy..."

"Let him help you walk," June cut in.

She waved her hand, and the tall security guard who had been standing silently in the corridor the whole time suddenly turned to face them.

At the corner of his mouth, a small sliver of snow-white fragment was embedded, like a ceramic mushroom sprouting from deep-brown human skin.

The security guard stepped forward and took Chase by the arm, looking every bit like someone steadying an elderly woman.

"What about the others?" Sydney Ginn asked.

"Just pull the pieces off my face," June said.

"Will there... will there be any consequences?"

"Each person will have their own aftereffects, depending on where the fragment was embedded. As for the specific effects, I don't know, because I don't care."

June's tone was flat. She waved at the other four people, and all four turned around at the same moment.

"What exactly are you?" Chase asked in a low voice.

"I'm June."

...He truly wanted to kill her.

And yet, beneath that Noh mask, it might still truly be June.

If just having a single fragment embedded left aftereffects, then June, with her entire body...

Chase slowly exhaled.

Save her first. Figure out the next step after that.

One by one, the snow-white fragments wrenched free from each person's face and floated slowly back toward "June's" face; trailing behind each one were several tiny filaments, like a cluster of jellyfish with hard shells.

Each person was left with small round black holes at their eye corners, cheeks, and chins.

They were clearly all human, yet if you looked down into those black holes, you saw none of the fat, muscle, or blood vessels beneath the skin—only straight, sunken dark shafts, like well mouths plunging into nothing, enough to make even Chase unwilling to look for long.

Once the fragments were gone, each person stood dazedly in place, blinking slowly.

Only the doctor reacted differently: when his fragment rose free, it left a small black hole in the center of his forehead; at first glance it almost looked as if someone had driven a spike clean through his skull—then his eyes suddenly rolled back and he dropped straight to the floor.

Sydney Ginn quickly jumped to the side, stared at the doctor lying on the ground, and said in a small voice, "Is he... dead?"

"June" seemed to feel the question wasn't worth a reply.

Chase suddenly said, "Wait."

"June" turned her head toward him.

Chase pulled his patient gown sleeve down over his hand and carefully reached out, gently closing his covered fingers around the fragment that had just been extracted from the doctor's forehead and now floated in midair.

"What are you doing?" Sydney Ginn was immediately alarmed. "I went through so much trouble to save you just now—"

"...It's fine. She still needs me to take her to the Mayor."

"June" fixed her gaze on him, unmoving.

Chase used his sleeve to wipe the tiny filaments trailing from the fragment.

He could even feel the filaments sense a living person and instantly "light up" with excitement, trying to burrow through the fabric and into the skin of his hand—the moment he finished wiping, he immediately pulled his hand back and flung the fragment away.

"There was a little... brain tissue on it," he explained to the two of them, who were both staring at him.

This one fragment alone had its filaments contaminated with tissue from the victim's body.

The thought of filaments bearing the brain tissue of their previous victim then burrowing into June's body and skin was unbearable.

Until June was dead, she was still his subordinate, and that meant it was his responsibility to look after her.

"Let's go," Chase said.

Stepping over the unconscious staff on the floor, the group of four left the hospital without much trouble and got into a taxi; just before they got in, "June" pulled the fragment off, leaving the blank-faced security guard on the roadside.

Recovering the phone went smoothly; though the nurses at that first hospital seemed not to have expected the patient himself to show up so quickly, and tried several times to persuade him to stay for more tests.

"So I did receive one too," Chase said, shaking off the nurses and opening his phone right away to find his own Artifact Report—at the very top of the report, it read "the detestable contestant Chase."

...The favoritism in that wording was far too obvious.

Compared with the 99.99% probability, the other two task points were naturally not worth considering.

"So what's next?" Sydney Ginn looked him over a few times and said, "Your color right now is really... I'm not feeling very optimistic about eventually collecting on whatever you owe me."

This girl seemed to say whatever came to mind, never stopping to consider social niceties or how her words might land on the listener.

But she wasn't wrong either.

Chase truly needed to sit down right now—the brief exchange with the nurse and the short walk out of the hospital had already left him a little light-headed.

It wasn't just light-headedness; unusually for him, he was also chilled all over, and he had even asked a nurse for an unclaimed lost-and-found jacket that no one had come to collect in ages.

"...I know what I sold the Mayor. No amount of manpower alone can bypass his security."

Chase sat on the edge of a flower bed at the hospital entrance, wearing the ill-fitting jacket, hands tucked tightly together against the night wind; if you swapped out June and Sydney Ginn beside him for a cardboard sign and a dog, it would be a picture-perfect image of a beggar.

...Lucky that no one from Key House was around.

"I can get you in front of the Mayor, but your fragment won't be able to penetrate him."

Chase looked at "June" and said, "That Artifact has already been absorbed into the Mayor's body and become part of him, so it protects him around the clock, twenty-four hours a day."

"Something that impressive—why didn't you sell it to the President?" Sydney Ginn muttered.

"The President wasn't interested; he has something better."

"You've met him?" Sydney Ginn was startled.

"Never in person—only heard about it. No matter how many crimes I've committed, I'm not about to suffer that kind of ordeal. Don't let me get off track."

"If you don't take the bait, how can you get off track?"

Fair point—Chase turned his head away and continued addressing "June": "But based on what I know about that Artifact, I can roughly work out how to numb or circumvent its guard mechanism. The catch is that it would require me to use an Artifact specifically capable of acting against it."

"Doesn't Key House have one?" June asked immediately.

"No."

Like other Hunter House Factions, the Artifacts Key House kept rather than sold were generally things that helped Hunters survive inside the Nest, secure Artifacts, or gain a combat

advantage; Key House rarely dealt in assassination, so naturally it would have no stockpile of that kind of Artifact.

"That won't do—you have to make the Mayor one of my body options."

"June" thought it over and said, "That report or whatever you two received—I don't care about it, it's got nothing to do with me. But if I can't become the Mayor, I'll just have to stay as June forever, so you had better think this through."

Chase suppressed the urge to sigh. "...I know. I'm working on it."

"Hey, I have an idea—why don't we go to Between the Backlights?"

Sydney Ginn had been listening this whole time and now said, without warning: "Having Key House Hunters go into the Nest to search around at this point would be too slow, wouldn't it? Better to go to Between the Backlights and put out a wanted-to-buy notice, see if anyone has something suitable."

...That wasn't a bad idea.

Besides, he was in serious need of a stiff drink right now.

He checked the time: it was currently 1:05 AM on November 22nd.

Only the 22nd?

So much had happened over the past few days—it had been so drawn out that it felt like months had passed. He needed a drink to settle himself.

Letting "June" try to hail a cab would only result in taxis pretending not to see her and speeding past; by the time she'd even started trying, Sydney Ginn had already called an Uber.

"June" sat in the front passenger seat—startling a yelp out of the driver—while the two of them sat in the back; the car started up and cut through the city streets, speeding toward Between the Backlights.

Less than ten minutes into the drive, Chase's phone rang.

"...Tianxi?" He picked up. "Why are you calling at this hour?"

It had only been a few hours since he last contacted the Key House Hunters; they likely still had no idea he had already stepped back from the brink of death once tonight.

"Brother Chase, there were quite a few tests lined up at the lab, so I had them work overtime to push it through—I just got the results a moment ago."

Chase was momentarily startled, then remembered: what Tianxi was referring to was the red strand of hair June had found in the coffin.

"And?"

Tianxi paused. "The technician tonight only went back to the lab because I pressured and persuaded him... and not long after, he called me from the lab."

...That was not a good sign.

"He said it wasn't human hair. It was a high-temperature synthetic fiber filament... in other words, it was a strand of wig hair."

Chase's mind suddenly flashed back to the woman on the cemetery path who, when he grabbed her, had spun around sharply.

The umbrella scattered a ring of water droplets; shadow covered the upper half of her face.

With the umbrella between them, he could only see the wet tips of her hair... he couldn't tell whether there was anything unnatural about the hair at the top of her head.

"Understood." Chase said slowly. "Your call came at the right time—there's actually something else I was just about to ask you to handle."

"Sure, what is it?"

"Taylor Ford of Morgan House Faction was badly wounded tonight and should have been sent to a hospital. First, I need you to arrange for someone to find out which hospital he was taken to; second, I'll send you an address. Go there yourself and search the place thoroughly—by whatever means necessary—and find the Artifact hidden in that apartment."

"No problem," Tianxi said cleanly.

After hanging up, Chase sent Tianxi the address of Taylor Ford's apartment.

With injuries that severe, just staying conscious would be a struggle for Taylor Ford; he couldn't possibly have had the energy to move the Key to a new hiding spot.

The Key had to still be in the apartment.

Hello everyone! I've been away for three days without any updates, which also meant I couldn't see any of your messages to me — how to put it, I've been feeling genuinely a little lonely.

I'm finally back now, and I have to say, the stars may not align between me and Qidian — every time is such an ordeal, and this time not only were there delays, I even wore myself out and caught a cold...

A cold is nothing — I thought after being gone three days I'd come back to a full house — hm? Nobody here? Oh no, I got ahead of myself.

Chapter 196 — Chase: A Good Leader Knows How to Put the Right People in the Right Place

"...A rare... a rare guest, Mr. Monroe."

The bartender, who looked for all the world like a droopy-eared Shar-Pei, recognized Chase and couldn't help but let his perpetually sagging brows lift ever so slightly into a flat line — then he caught sight of June, and nearly shattered his glass.

He glanced around first, as if searching for something to defend himself with; finding nothing, he settled for pretending he hadn't seen June at all, and said, "If there's anything I can help you with, just say the word... though, uh, we don't do any rough stuff in the bar."

Chase sometimes wondered just what kind of reputation he had.

It wasn't as though he had violent tendencies.

"We're here to post a wanted listing," Sydney Ginn spoke up on his behalf, apparently aware that he was low on energy.

The Shar-Pei bartender seemed to notice her for the first time, and startled again.

"Hm? It's you? Since when did you and... hm, what listing? Go ahead. We've got an unusually good crowd tonight — might be able to close the deal on the spot."

He seemed to swallow quite a few words along the way.

The bartender wasn't wrong — the bar did appear to have more patrons than usual, though if Chase had closed his eyes, he might have mistaken the place for dead silent tonight.

That was because the moment the three of them walked through the door, the noise of the bar seemed to recede like a tide, dropping away all at once to expose a wide stretch of silence. Countless pairs of eyes swept over them — unwilling to linger, yet unable to look away entirely — and only once they began speaking with the bartender did the bar behind them slowly fill again with scattered whispers.

This wasn't entirely because of Chase.

Everyone seated here was a Hunter; they only needed one look at June's face to know this was something that had come out of the Nest — and even if she wasn't a Resident, she was certainly

not a fully living person.

If Chase hadn't been the one accompanying her, someone would likely have raised a protest already — or worse.

"I need an Artifact that can paralyze another Artifact."

Chase watched the bartender pull out paper and pen, jotting down his words one by one.

"...Functions along the lines of paralysis, temporary incapacitation, forced disruption, disabling alertness, or bypassing a target's attention — any of those will do. Also, I've heard that a few months back, an Artifact surfaced that could make others perceive the user as 'one of their own.' Is that right? If anyone is willing to sell that one, the price is negotiable."

Outside of collecting, testing, buying, and selling, Chase made a habit of keeping track of every new Artifact that surfaced in Hunter circles, and he rattled off the names and handlers of four or five of them from memory.

"...As for the ones I just mentioned — feel free to ask around whether anyone can contact the sellers to put them on the market."

"Very thorough and comprehensive," the bartender nodded, tucking away the paper and pen. "With such a targeted list, you should have news before long."

Even June's Noh mask seemed to take on an expression of satisfaction.

"We don't have to wait here, do we?" Sydney said, stifling a yawn. "Just have him give you a call when there's news..."

She stopped mid-sentence, then pivoted abruptly: "Wait, actually, staying half an hour might be fine — hey, is your kitchen still open?"

Chase glanced at her, reached into the pocket of his too-tight jacket, and slid a card across to the bartender. "Use this. And get me a whiskey on the rocks."

"Repaying your debts already?"

As the waitress led the three of them toward a corner of the bar, Sydney couldn't resist adding, "Good start. We can work out the other repayments in more detail. There are other repayments, right?"

"...Is my whole life the currency in your transactions?"

"There are other repayments, right?" Sydney repeated, with more emphasis.

"...Yes."

Chase gave in and turned to the waitress. "Keep my whiskey coming. Actually — just leave the bottle."

A Hunter who had just woken up seemed to have a stomach made of rubber, capable of expanding without limit.

Tianxi called again just as Sydney was hard at work demolishing a mountain of buffalo hot wings piled before her — six to an order, and she had apparently ordered five.

She was eating with such intensity that sweat beaded her forehead, manners forgotten entirely; her smacking and chewing were loud enough for even Tianxi to hear.

"Chase, are you... are you eating?"

"...That's not me."

Chase couldn't look at food right now without his stomach turning. He refused to look at the table full of burgers and wings, and equally refused to look at June across from him, leaving his eyes with nowhere to land but the bar entrance in the distance. "Any news?"

"The apartment nearby has been secured by Morgan House Faction Hunters. There's someone sitting in a car on the street below keeping watch, and there are people stationed both in the corridor and inside the apartment itself. I sent someone in to blend in and get a general read on the situation — without using force to break through, there's no way to get past the apartment door."

Even severely injured, Taylor Ford had left no gaps... if anything, if he had truly left an unguarded apartment, Chase would have suspected a trap.

"Chase," Tianxi said, not without misgiving, "do we need to resort to force? We've always kept the peace with Morgan House Faction, and there's no conflict of interest between us..."

Hunter factions were all driven by profit in the end, and none were eager to fight and kill without cause.

And beyond that, they all held power that had no rightful place in the human world — if a conflict broke out between factions, the consequences would be impossible to predict.

When Chase had first taken the position of second-in-command years ago, it was precisely this realization that led him to deliberately steer Key House Faction's style closer and closer to that of a street gang — when everyone else had reservations about resorting to force, he, as the only one with no such reservations, held the advantage.

Only back then, that approach had been directed at individuals. Moving against a faction's Hunter Director would be tantamount to declaring war...

"You're not eating, are you?"

Sydney suddenly lifted her face from the chicken wings, the lower half of her face mottled orange-red from the hot sauce. She directed her words at June across the table: "If you're not eating, stop staring at me — you're staring so hard it's killing my appetite."

...It was hard to imagine what she looked like when her appetite was good.

She had, as expected, pulled Chase's attention away again; his gaze swept across the wreckage of the table and landed on June's face — which was, as expected, leaning quite close to the food.

It looked more like curiosity than hunger. Perhaps whatever occupied her body didn't experience hunger.

June hadn't eaten or drunk anything since coming out of the Nest — even on that count alone, this needed to be dealt with quickly — wait.

"Hold off on using force. I may have an idea..." Chase spoke into the phone, his eyes fixed on the Noh mask the whole time. "Stay in the area and keep watch. Wait for my word."

He hung up. Neither of the two at the table asked a single "what's going on."

Chase drained his second whiskey; the cold liquid set his throat alight, like a flame made of ice. He set down the glass, felt his head clear somewhat, and surveyed the bar around him, thinking through his situation.

The unspoken rule of the Hunter trade was: no violence inside Between the Backlights.

This bar was like one of those brief watering holes on the African savanna — lion and zebra alike could coexist peacefully here. But that was before the Nest Domination Game.

Now, the four players in the competition would never let old customs stop them when a target Artifact was within reach...

"Are you done?" Chase asked.

Sydney was eyeing the last half of a burger with something like regret, seemingly reluctant to let it go, still turning over how she might fit it into her stomach.

"Done," she finally put the burger down. "What is it? You're leaving? Fair enough — someone's out to kill you, it's not exactly safe for you to stay here."

"...Thank you."

Only remembered now, after finishing every last bite.

"I have something I'd like to ask of you," Chase said.

"What is it?"

There was no tactful way to say what came next, so he went straight to the point: "Someone who talks as much as you surely has plenty of friends who are just as fond of gossip, right?"

"The way you talk—"

"Five thousand."

"Go on."

"If you put the word out that I'm at Between the Backlights, how confident are you that London Moon will hear about it before tonight is over?"

Sydney blinked, apparently wanting to ask "why" and "let me think" at the same time; the two impulses tangled on her tongue, and she simply pulled out her phone and started scrolling carefully through her contact list.

"I think it's doable,"

Hard to say how much of that was directed at the five thousand dollars.

"She has a friend named Joy Jo. Joy Jo and I are both in the same Telegram group — she was the one who recommended I join..."

"But London Moon can't know the information came from you."

"That's fine too," Sydney said without batting an eye. "I have a friend named Amber — she's an accountant for Morgan House Faction. She can tell the Morgan House Hunters, and I'm sure there are Morgan House Hunters in that group..."

What a web, woven entirely out of tongues.

"Then make it happen." Chase nodded. "The sooner the news reaches London Moon's ears, the sooner you get paid. By morning, the deal's off the table."

Sydney's eyes lit up; she didn't even ask "why," just bowed her head and began typing at a rapid-fire pace.

"I don't understand."

A sentence slowly leaked out from within June's rigid Noh mask. "London Moon... she's the one who just tried to kill you, right? You're physically weak right now, and you're voluntarily giving away your location to her. Aren't you afraid she'll strike while the iron is hot and come at you again?"

London Moon could be quite lethargic at times, especially when she was emotionally volatile. She probably wouldn't make another move tonight; but whoever was behind her might be another matter.

"I am afraid."

Chase poured himself a third glass of whiskey. "Look — even lifting this bottle right now, my hand is trembling slightly. Let alone fighting."

"I don't understand. Then why are you still—"

Chase took a sip of his whiskey, looked at her, and smiled. "I was just thinking — I am the only person in this world who will help you transfer into the Mayor."

June, behind the Noh mask, looked at him and said nothing.

"This Miss Sydney Ginn — setting aside whether she even has the means to bring you before the Mayor — even if she could, she would only bring you there. Because the moment she accomplishes that step, she collects her reward. She would never spend her own money buying Artifacts for you."

Chase set down his glass and said slowly, "The only person who will acquire Artifacts, bring you to the Mayor, find a way through the Mayor's defenses, and help you transfer successfully... is me. If I die, you'll be stuck living as an ordinary Hunter named June forever."

"...So?"

"Someone's going to come looking for trouble with me very soon."

Chase leaned back in his chair; unfortunately the booth was too small for him to stretch his legs out.

"Do you want me to stay alive? Then when the time comes, it's all up to you."

My cold seems to be a bit worse today — this chapter came out a little fuzzy-headed.

Writing fiction is wonderful. If I weren't writing, I'd be an introverted person with few friends, and there's no way I'd ever receive this many birthday wishes in my lifetime — I'm completely wrapped in everyone's warmth... I'm so happy!

Chapter 197 – The Person Chase Narrowly Missed

His right eye was blocked, his vision a hazy blur of white.

Chase could only vaguely sense that several small tentacles were drifting and spreading before his eyelid, like fingers reaching toward him again and again; once or twice, the tentacles had even grazed the skin beneath his eye.

He remained seated where he was, motionless, letting that small shard of snow-white porcelain hover before his eye.

Sydney Ginn beside him had long since turned her head around; in his peripheral vision, her eyes were wide as saucers, and she stammered: "Wh—what happened here? I was just chatting for a moment..."

Chase tilted his head, dodging the small white porcelain shard with its bristling tentacles, picked up his glass from the table, took a sip, and settled back into his seat.

"You can't make a move, can you?" he asked calmly.

Noh-mask Han June said nothing.

That snow-white, swollen face was now missing a small piece of its chin.

"If you take control of me, I lose my value as 'Chase Monroe'—you'd just have a puppet." Chase took another sip of his wine and smiled. "Even with my phone and my cards... do you know how to make a transfer? Do you know how to use an Artifact?"

"Han June" still did not speak, but the answer was perfectly clear.

She didn't even know how to eat or drink—she'd once thought that to deal with thirst, she had to stick her fingers into a loaf of bread.

That was back when Han June had first returned; the "Han June" of today no longer even felt thirst. The further she drifted from humanity, the more it meant she had no choice but to depend on Chase.

"Besides, when you stab someone with a shard, it doesn't hurt you at all, does it?"

Sydney Ginn set down her phone and played peacemaker: "Then why bother throwing a fit over it? Just think of it as doing a favor. Besides, it works in your favor too."

"Han June's" eyes—black as pinpricks—swiveled toward her.

"Think about it: someone wants him dead right now, and they're in the shadows while Chase is out in the open. What if they get to him before you even see the Mayor? What would you do then? Draw them out first, deal with them, and then Chase helps you with your business—wouldn't that be foolproof?"

...Five thousand bucks well spent.

When Sydney Ginn was willing, she could truly be called perceptive.

"Han June" sat perfectly still for a long while, not even the rise and fall of breathing visible—she was like an enormous doll.

After a moment, she finally spoke: "...This is using me."

"How can you call it using? It's mutually beneficial." Sydney Ginn said sincerely.

After a silence of indeterminate length, that small shard of snow-white porcelain slowly turned around and drifted away from Chase's eyelid, floating back to the chin area of the "Noh mask."

The tentacles swayed as though sending a signal, and from the fractured edge, more tentacles reached out to meet it; they coiled and tangled together, drawing gradually closer until the white shard remerged with the "Noh mask."

Looking at it this way... the tentacles didn't seem to be embedded inside Han June's body—unlike the hospital employees who'd been controlled.

Perhaps that was one misfortune out of many that counted as a small blessing.

Chase took another sip of his wine.

As if nothing had happened, he turned to Sydney Ginn and asked, "How did it go?"

"I'd say it's about eighty percent settled."

Sydney Ginn looked at her phone and said, "Joy Jo was online the whole time just now, but a few minutes after your location was sent out, she went offline. I suspect she went to contact London Moon—and you want to know why I'm so sure? Because last time, a friend asked me to look into..."

"Alright, you don't need to go into that much detail. I get it."

When she didn't talk, Chase felt like his brain was doing laps; when she did, the room practically spun around him. "I trust your judgment."

Sydney Ginn's face lit up. "Now that I know you better, I've realized you're actually not bad at all—your problem is just that you've never marketed yourself well."

A compliment that somehow felt uncomfortable.

Even if London Moon learned he was at Between the Backlights, whether she would actually tell whoever was behind this—and whether that person would act tonight—were still two things entirely beyond Chase's control.

All he could do was use himself as bait and wait quietly for the other side to take it.

Fortunately, Hunters were all a patient sort—

"This is so boring,"

Sydney Ginn was like she had ants in her pants; in just a few minutes, she had already shifted in her seat four or five times beside Chase. "There's nothing good to look at on my phone either—do we really have to just sit here and wait? Ugh, you're not much of a conversationalist either..."

"Then talk to her." Chase said, barely keeping his patience.

"You know perfectly well that's not an option—"

Unless absolutely necessary, Sydney Ginn wouldn't even spare a glance at "Han June"; in that regard, Chase was exactly the same.

Sydney Ginn was mid-complaint when she suddenly looked up and said, "Oh, more people just came in—business is really good for them tonight."

The newcomers were a man and a woman.

The man had a smooth, fair face, his manner veiled in a layer of weariness—not the kind that came from poor sleep, but more like the exhaustion of someone who had spent their whole life managing their circumstances, always being chased along by fate.

The woman beside him, however, seemed to be visiting Between the Backlights for the first time; she turned her head this way and that, her eyes bright and darting, as if she couldn't take it all in fast enough.

She looked like someone who had just been released from prison.

Not only because she was curious about everything she saw—but also because her hair was obviously cut by herself with a pair of scissors, and her clothes had been grabbed at random without any thought to matching or style; beneath her skirt she was even wearing trousers. In Blackmoor City, probably only the inmates of Blackmoor Prison lacked the right or the pressure to put any care into their appearance.

Yet on closer inspection, it seemed impossible that she had ever been to prison.

Her air was gentle and substantial, calm and composed; as if standing beside her, a person could gradually let their tense muscles go and speak without any hurry. After all, she felt very... very kind?

Wait—could that word even be used to describe a young person?

Chase reconsidered his own vocabulary.

The two of them weren't particularly remarkable among a bar full of Hunters; Chase swept his gaze over them and promptly put them out of his mind.

They seemed to have recognized him too—before ordering, they had snuck what they thought were inconspicuous glances at his table. Being recognized was nothing unusual; Chase simply pretended not to notice.

"Why haven't they come to kill you yet," Sydney Ginn muttered under her breath, "I'm dying of boredom. They might as well be killing me... "

A paper napkin turned over and over in her hands without stop, nearly rubbed into powder.

To pass the time, she craned her neck, putting on the air of a chronic busybody, letting her gaze wander from table to table to see what others were doing and saying—and as she watched, she suddenly drew her neck back and said quietly, "Hey, that table is selling an Artifact."

She was referring to the man and woman.

Selling an Artifact through Between the Backlights—that was probably the move of a solo hunter, someone with no House Faction's distribution network to rely on.

"Can't quite make out what it is... it's pretty small."

With nothing better to do, Sydney Ginn had turned herself into a live commentator for someone else's Artifact sale, regardless of whether Chase had any interest. "Oh, the man who looks like M seems pretty uncertain about that Artifact—"

Looks like what?

Chase bit his tongue and said nothing.

"They've called Megan over," Sydney Ginn went on broadcasting, "oh, impressive—they're going with Megan!"

"So what?" Chase asked.

He rarely came to Between the Backlights himself and had no idea what it meant to go off with a server.

"They must think their Artifact is valuable, which is why they don't want to do the photographing and uploading out here. There's a small office in the back of the bar—generally, anything of higher value gets negotiated back there."

Sydney Ginn was quite experienced in this area and explained it with great clarity: "Doing it in the back is not only more discreet and private, it has another benefit. Once the Artifact's information has been uploaded, if the owner doesn't want to return to the bar floor, they can take the Artifact and slip quietly out through the back door—that way, they can reduce the risk of being watched and followed."

"Afraid of being robbed? But if someone waits at the back door, doesn't that amount to the same thing?" The one asking was Han June.

Sydney Ginn refused to look at her and said, "I said 'reduce the risk.'"

Seeing that the timing seemed about right, she opened her phone and checked.

"Oh, it's out—it's a lipstick."

Chase took the phone and read through the Artifact photo and description.

"Would this thing be useful against the Mayor?" Sydney Ginn leaned over, her hair and warm breath drifting against his arm. "If it could make the Mayor believe you mean him no harm..."

The moment the word "Mayor" was spoken, Noh-mask Han June immediately stretched her neck, her head floating out over the center of the table.

"It still won't work. This lipstick's target is humans—even if it fools the Mayor, it won't fool the Artifact inside him."

Chase said this, then sank into thought for a moment. "Still, maybe I should buy it."

"Why?"

He didn't answer—the reason was simple enough; he just didn't feel like saying it.

As long as the lipstick was out in the world, there was a chance Taylor Ford might get her hands on it. His natural talent for lying absolutely did not need a lipstick to give it an extra edge.

"Let's go,"

Chase rose first, signaling another server to take him to the office. To avoid any misunderstanding or unnecessary complications, he also held up Sydney Ginn's phone and showed the other party the lipstick information that had just been uploaded, saying, "I want to purchase this. The owner is in the back, right?"

"That's right—selling to Key House Faction, the price will definitely be good," the server said cheerfully, walking ahead and leading all three of them into a short corridor.

As luck would have it, however, the server named Megan told them the owners had just left.

"They suddenly received some kind of news—I don't know what—and rushed off immediately. All I heard them say as they left the office was, 'don't want to get mixed up in this muddy water.' I'm not sure what they meant. If you hurry now, you should still be able to catch them."

Megan thought for a moment and added, "The back door is right around the bend in the corridor. I'll go with you—it'll be easier that way."

Of course, even though Megan had once been a Hunter herself, there was absolutely no chance she would agree to go off somewhere alone with "Han June"—and besides, her own body was frail; she couldn't move quickly.

Chase naturally let his gaze settle on Sydney Ginn.

"You and her go stop them. I'll wait here."

"True, we can't let you go—they might just shoot you on the spot." Sydney Ginn muttered to herself even as she quickened her pace, heading for the back door together with Megan.

Chase listened to the sound of the two pairs of footsteps hurrying to the far end of the corridor; a door was pulled open.

Megan called out faintly—it sounded like she was calling for the people outside to wait—it seemed they had followed the others out through the door, because a moment later the door

slammed shut and the corridor fell quiet again.

Now all the warm, living people were gone, and the only one left beside Chase was "Han June."

After a moment, in the pale, narrow corridor, she slowly twisted her head toward him.

"...Something's wrong." Han June said. "Whether or not they caught up with those people, they should have come back by now."

Chase made no sound.

Han June tilted her snow-white, swollen face upward, directed toward the back door, and was silent for a few seconds.

"I think there might be something outside the door." She said flatly.

My updates are just like my sleep schedule—getting later and later... I'm afraid tomorrow I might not make the midnight deadline anymore.

Speaking of which, I had a dream last night where I was in a haunted hospital, trapped in a corridor. A tall dark shadow followed me—as long as I kept repeating certain lines of a song, it wouldn't make its move, but it also refused to leave, and just stayed right behind me...

It was a dream with a deeply oppressive feeling...

It's that time of year again—time to sort out the outline.

Everyone get some sleep first—by the time I finished organizing the outline, it was already this late. I probably won't make it before midnight, but there will definitely be an update when you wake up tomorrow morning.

We've already endured three days of no updates, so what's a slightly late one!

We're a big-hearted bunch around here—we don't sweat the small stuff.

Chapter 198: The Error That Fate Corrected for Brianna

She remembered being six or seven years old, living in a high-rise apartment in the bay area, back when her father was already very wealthy and her mother was still alive.

To her young self, the living room was practically the size of a football field.

The floor-to-ceiling windows were like a vast, breathtaking painting—Blackmoor City at its most dazzling and resplendent, suspended between the skyline and the bay, reflected into a sea of stars made of human hands.

When she pressed her forehead against the floor-to-ceiling window, she could see the sweeping night view beyond; when she stood up straight, she could see herself, and in the glass behind her, the faint reflections of her parents.

Only a vague, shadowy portion of them—wavering and unreal.

"Don't bring it out at home," her mother was saying, a note of wariness in her voice.

As she spoke, her mother stood far away, separated from her father by the sofa, the side table, and an entire stretch of carpet. "That thing is dangerous, isn't it? Brianna is still here."

Hearing her own name, Brianna instinctively turned around.

It was strange—she was right there beside them, and her mother knew she was right there, yet in that moment her mother seemed to both remember she was home and forget her at the same time—perhaps because her mother's attention had been seized, as if against her will, by whatever her father held in his hands, leaving no room for anything else.

"It's fine," her father said.

He seemed to have truly forgotten she existed; her name drew no reaction from him at all. Without looking up, he said: "As long as it isn't activated, it won't cause any harm to people."

"How... how do you activate it?" her mother asked, her feet not moving any closer.

"As for using it... even the Hunter who sold it to me hasn't fully mastered how it works. Otherwise, I doubt he would have ever parted with it."

Her father's eyes never left the object in his hands for even a moment; he seemed utterly captivated by it. He hadn't answered her mother's question at all—in fact, whether her mother was

there or not seemed to make no difference to the conversation he was having with himself.

He said a few more things after that, which Brianna couldn't remember, except for one sentence she hadn't understood at the time, which had lodged itself in her memory for reasons she couldn't explain: "Roland Key seems to think that I can only observe the results after inputting commands..."

Her mother listened for a while, and seemed to say something like "I don't understand any of this." Her father shook his head, his interest in continuing the conversation with her already gone.

"These things are all dangerous—just don't drag Brianna into it," was all her mother insisted.

"How is this dragging her into it? How can she afford not to know?"

Her father suddenly let out a cold laugh.

"She doesn't even have a brother—it's entirely possible that the empire I've built will one day end up in her hands alone. That's already a bad enough situation. If she's going to be just like you on top of it—ignorant and afraid of Artifacts—I might as well donate the whole family fortune right now."

Her mother lowered her head and said softly, "I've been seeing a doctor too. It's just that at my age, it really isn't easy to conceive again..."

At that moment, her father suddenly remembered Brianna's existence, and as if on purpose, called out to her: "Bri, come here."

She walked over slowly and stood by the armrest of the sofa.

Looking down, Brianna finally got a clear look at what her father had been holding in his hand all along—it was small, similar in both size and shape to the puzzle cubes children played with; her father's hand could close around it completely.

The difference was that this cube was pure black all over.

It was as if a piece of space had been broken off and hollowed out, collapsing into a square black hole—swallowing a portion of space whole, yet it was impossible to say where exactly its edges were.

It seemed to possess its own gravitational pull, drawing one's gaze and thoughts steadily inward with no way to pull free; by the time she came back to herself, several minutes seemed to have already passed.

"Interesting, isn't it? Come with me to the dockside warehouse tonight. I want to test a few ideas, and you can get some grounding in Artifacts too—basic operations, categories of properties, that sort of thing."

Brianna glanced at her mother. She seemed to want to object, but said nothing.

"Okay, Dad." In front of her father, she was always better-behaved than usual, as though she were making up for the mistake of not being a boy.

Wellesley gave a small nod, his expression unreadable as to whether he was satisfied.

At that time, he still seemed to hold some expectations for Brianna.

At that time, Brianna had not yet gained her half-siblings, nor had she yet realized that she would one day be unable to play even the role of an "ordinary woman"—at that time, it would still be a very long while before Wellesley removed her name from his will.

Brianna had few memories of spending time with her father in her early years.

But how she wished that at six or seven years old, when she had gone with Wellesley to the dockside warehouse to test Artifacts, she had paid more attention and committed everything he did to memory.

If she had known how Wellesley used that black cube, she would feel far more certain about eliminating Chase tonight.

"He's at 'Between the Backlights,' all right," London Moon said over the phone, her voice languid. "I had someone confirm it."

She still had feelings for Chase—Brianna knew that.

When London Moon had first started out as a Hunter, it could be said that half of what she learned had been through Chase; some of the techniques and tricks he had taught her, she still used to this day.

After all, if London Moon weren't the type to hold on to old sentiment, there would have been no way to force her into killing Chase in the first place.

Brianna could very well imagine how conflicted London Moon would feel when it came to dealing with Chase—every time London Moon experienced a surge of emotion, she would sink into this kind of languid stillness afterward; tonight, it seemed, there was no counting on her to make a move.

"Can't you just switch to a different target?" London Moon asked, as expected. "Your goal is just to acquire a Hunter House Faction, right? Does it have to be Key House? Even with his widow and those kids keeping an eye on things, you should still have enough money to buy out a small House Faction, shouldn't you?"

If all she wanted was to absorb a Hunter House Faction, then it was true that it didn't have to be Key House specifically.

But Chase was someone who had to die.

As the most long-standing player of the Nest Domination Game, Brianna had previously completed a special action point; its reward was that she could, from time to time, receive progress notifications from the Nest.

The most recent progress notification had been sent to her on the evening of the 19th. The content was simple, but far from welcome: following Taylor Ford, Chase Monroe had become the third player to join the Nest Domination Game.

Surprising? Not really.

Because she had seen it coming—the Nest seemed to truly despise Chase Monroe.

Since Brianna had joined the Nest Domination Game, she had witnessed four players come and go—one had been left permanently disabled and withdrew from the game voluntarily; one had disappeared inside the Nest and never came back alive; the other two had been eliminated by Brianna and Wellesley working together.

In her experience, players could only appear in the Nest's progress notifications if they had made some truly major breakthrough.

For instance, she hadn't known that Taylor Ford had joined the game until he had already obtained one of the target Artifacts; and she still didn't know what it was that Taylor Ford had gotten his hands on—that particular piece of intelligence was currently only known to those who had joined the game after him.

But Chase was different—she had no idea how, but even before he had joined the game, the Nest had been feeding her information about him one thing after another: first that he had obtained "a tongue," then that he had joined the game, as if the Nest couldn't wait for her to put him down as soon as possible.

Of course, Chase wasn't the only target she had to eliminate.

The Nest Domination Game was like a meat grinder—Taylor Ford and Chase were simply the latest batch of flesh being fed into it.

After Chase, there would likely be new players... because generally speaking, the number of competitors tended to hover between four and five; as long as no one had collected all seven target items, whoever died would simply be replaced by someone new.

She still hadn't received any notification about a fourth player entering the game—was it because the fourth player didn't yet exist?

Or because the Nest was unwilling to tell her?

"I'll go myself," Brianna said.

Her thoughts had been wandering for a moment; in the end, she only said to London Moon briefly: "I'll bring something with me and deal with him myself."

Without waiting for London Moon to respond, she got there first: "Don't worry—if you don't want to make a move tonight, I'm not angry with you. Unless he's willing to withdraw voluntarily, Chase has to die... If anything, I'm the one who owes you an apology in this matter."

A few seconds passed before London Moon said quietly, "You... don't say that."

She let out a soft breath.

Brianna thought she could almost smell the tea-like fragrance of the mint candies London Moon always ate.

"Even if he's unwell right now, we absolutely cannot let our guard down around him. What's more, the moment he left the hospital, he showed up at a place like 'Between the Backlights,' full of all kinds of people—I strongly suspect it's a deliberate lure. If he has something up his sleeve, just to draw you in..."

"All the more reason to strike when he's down, isn't it?" Brianna said. "Even if it is bait, I'm willing to take it. What I'm bringing isn't an ordinary Artifact—I have confidence in it."

She had thought she had long since come to terms with and accepted the reality of things; but it wasn't until London Moon sighed and said, "All right, then you absolutely must be careful," that she suddenly felt a pang of disappointment—so London Moon truly had no intention of making a move after all.

So London Moon had truly decided to let her handle Chase on her own.

Really, she found her own convoluted state of mind a little insufferable; she said one thing with her mouth while quietly hoping for something else in her heart.

The bond they had once shared, the patterns they had fallen into together—all of that was long gone, and she was still sulking over it in the shadows, like some immature girl testing how much a lover cared.

...The me right now is truly disgusting.

Brianna thought, with a numbness close to total.

Lost in her thoughts, she didn't notice for a moment that the car had been gradually slowing down until it came to a stop at the entrance of a dim alley running between tall buildings.

"We've arrived," the driver switched on the interior light and said respectfully: "The back door to that bar is just ahead, down this alley, Mr. Green."

Brianna raised her head and caught a partial glimpse of her current face in the rearview mirror.

A lean, pale, repulsive male face.

I scratched my head hard before writing this chapter, enjoyed myself thoroughly while writing it, and when I finished, actually thought it wasn't half bad—let me have my moment.

It's a bit late going up, but... good things are worth waiting for... right...

Is it a little shameless of me to say that?

I know a lot of you have more or less guessed it already—this chapter isn't exactly an earth-shattering bombshell, right?

我知道很多人其实都多少猜到了，这一章也不算是地震式大惊奇，对吧？

Chapter 199: The Person Command Brianna Accidentally Entered

Brianna turned the Black Cube over in her hands a few times.

She slowly ran her thumb across each face of the cube, pausing on each one for a second or two—just long enough to murmur a single phrase: "Enter command: check countdown."

When she reached the fifth face, and the command had been repeated for the fifth time, the Black Cube finally responded.

On the face directly opposite the one being touched, a line of dark, mist-like text suddenly projected outward; it floated in the dim alley like something that might not be there at all.

"Countdown: 4470 days, 12 hours, 34 minutes."

Brianna pressed her finger firmly against the fifth face and waited patiently for a few seconds, until the text was drawn back into the Black Cube and vanished.

She already knew quite well how much time remained on the Black Cube's countdown.

The reason she had checked again was simply to locate this one face—the only face on the Black Cube that would respond to an entered command with an informational result.

That concept was not easy to grasp at first hearing; back then, even after Wellesley had spent half the evening explaining it to Brianna in that dockside warehouse, it had still taken her a while to understand.

"For instance, say I have a command: 'I want to eat an apple.'"

Wellesley held the Black Cube and explained to Brianna, who was only six or seven at the time: "Only if you enter the apple-eating command into this one particular face will the face opposite it give you an informational result."

As he spoke, he demonstrated it once, and sure enough, a line of black, mist-like text appeared on the corresponding face:

"Apple: a plant of the genus *Malus* in the subfamily *Maloideae* of the family *Rosaceae*, also known as the forest plum. High in nutritional content, edible, and widely consumed.

In major religions it may carry mystical significance, even classified as forbidden fruit. Please assess your surroundings (are you in an environment where the only other person you can see is a

naked male human named Adam?) before consuming."

Below that were several more long paragraphs—perhaps because there was simply a great deal of information to be said about apples.

Brianna had been young then, and understood only half of it; she had no patience to read all the text to the end—especially since there were quite a few characters she didn't recognize—but under the weight of her father's eyes fixed intently on her, she felt that she had no choice but to nod and say, "I understand."

"Good. You're not stupid," Wellesley said. "Now I'll teach you how to find the face that outputs informational results."

The Black Cube had six faces in total: three command input faces and three result output faces, paired in corresponding sets of two.

Every face looked identical, with no way to mark them, and the moment it was moved even slightly, there was no telling which face was which anymore.

To locate a specific face, the only method was to use the "countdown query command" and test them one by one; only the face that was the Information Command Input Face would yield a countdown.

"Remember this method of locating it. Press the Information Command Input Face with your left thumb, press the information result output face with your left index finger, palm facing up, thumb pointing toward yourself."

Wellesley did not hand the Black Cube to Brianna—in fact, she had not been allowed to touch it at all that entire night—and it seemed less that he didn't trust his daughter's safety than that he didn't trust the Black Cube's safety.

He held the Black Cube up in his left hand and had Brianna stand beside him, pointing at it as he said: "The face that wraps around to the left of your thumb is the General Command Input Face. Now tell me—what will appear on the face directly opposite it?"

Brianna's hair stood on end—whenever she was with her father, she could be tested without warning at any moment, and even when she knew the answer, she still felt the panicked helplessness of a young animal falling suddenly into a trap.

She stammered for several seconds before she managed to voice her guess: "Is—is it the General Result Output Face?"

It was hard to tell whether the look on Wellesley's face was disappointment or satisfaction.

"Correct," he said. "If you tell the General Command Input Face, 'I want to eat an apple,' what do you think will appear on the output face?"

"...An apple?"

Not through any sleight of hand, but an apple conjured from nothing—Brianna thought that was already an extraordinary enough guess; that was exactly how extraordinary Artifacts were.

"Then let's try it."

...What happened in the next twenty or thirty minutes gave Brianna nightmares every night for years afterward; she would always wake up screaming, drenched in cold sweat, hunched over the edge of her bed and retching.

Her mother quietly took her to see a child psychologist, but she knew that whatever had crawled out of the Black Cube was something she could never tell any psychologist—otherwise it would stop being an ordinary nightmare and become something serious enough to get her committed to a psychiatric ward, and then it would no longer be possible to hide it from her father.

Wellesley never knew she had suffered nightmares for years afterward, but even if he had, Brianna could already guess what he would have said.

After all, this was what came with dealing with Artifacts and the Nest—what was something like this?

If you couldn't even handle that much, weren't you just useless?

That Artifact—no, every Artifact—should never have flowed into the human world.

Hunters who brought them into the world of the living for money were all sinners. On that point, her former self and London Moon were no exceptions.

The Nest had no business existing in this world either.

If there had been no Nest, no Artifacts, perhaps Wellesley would by now be nothing more than a department manager at some ordinary company—and she herself would not have turned into something neither human nor ghost.

But that was another life, another kind of fantasy.

...She had to take it away before she could close it for good.

Brianna pressed the Information Command Input Face with her left thumb, palm facing up, thumb pointing toward herself.

These were not the slender fingers she had looked at for over twenty years; the knuckles were thick, the hair on the back of the hand clearly visible.

She tried her best not to look at the hand before her.

As Wellesley had taught her many years ago, she located the General Command Input Face, then used it to find the Person Command Input Face.

She placed her thumb on the Person Command Input Face, walked quietly to the side of the bar, and aimed the Black Cube's Person Command Input Face at the bar's back door.

A command had to be both concise and precise—it could leave no gaps open to misinterpretation—for the command "I want to eat an apple" back then could have been interpreted in countless wildly wrong ways.

For the user, this was no small challenge; a command that seemed perfectly clear to you might produce something entirely unrecognizable once it had been fed into the Black Cube.

Fortunately, Wellesley had left behind a command manual he had compiled through trial and error—by following it, she could get the results she wanted.

"Enter command,"

Brianna stood in the alley, sensing what seemed to be a faint, illusory drizzle drifting down through the night.

"...Form a 'Person Dismantling Space' here."

The Black Cube disappeared from her hand—Brianna quickly stepped back a few paces.

No one but the user could perceive with the naked eye that anything unusual had appeared in the alley; a motion-sensing lamp above the back door lay pale and stark across the dim shadows, while in the wet corner of the alley wall, a few cigarette butts soaked in the damp beside a crushed aluminum can.

Only Brianna could see it: the Black Cube swelling and expanding into a black cubic space three meters tall, with the Person Command Input Face pressed flush against the bar's back door.

Anyone who pushed open the bar's back door and took one step forward would walk into the Black Cube and become a "Person Command" entered into it.

After that, it was a matter of calling the driver to enter the bar, asking a server to pass a message to Chase Monroe, telling him to go to the back door to meet someone.

He had used himself as bait to draw Brianna out—so there was no way he would refuse an invitation to come to the back door...

Brianna lowered her head and reached into her trouser pocket for her phone, but her fingers were trembling slightly, and the phone slipped and fell to the ground.

Truly useless, she cursed herself silently, and bent down to pick it up.

Since the night at the dockside warehouse, tonight was the first time she had expanded the Black Cube and used a Person Command—the moment she saw the Black Cube swell open, memories from years ago instantly blazed back to life and rushed into her mind, scorching every nerve.

Even this male body, which had never once experienced the interior of the Black Cube, could not help trembling faintly.

The feeling of going from a living person to an "entered Person Command"—she had experienced it firsthand—though not in this body.

That night, Wellesley's eyes had held a very strange light.

His neck stretched forward, fixed unblinking on the expanded Black Cube.

Perhaps because he had been holding his daughter's hand the whole time, Brianna too could see the Black Cube—and the Person Command Input Face pointed squarely at the two of them.

"Dad," she tried to step back, but her wrist was gripped tight and she couldn't move. "What is this...for?...Dad?"

Her clothes were still soaked through; the terror left behind by the "I want to eat an apple" command, along with the black blood coating her, still drifted heavily through the air—Brianna used every last bit of her strength not to scream and run.

"Don't be afraid. No one will die." Wellesley said. "I've already tested this function once."

Brianna said nothing. She didn't dare speak, and didn't know what to say.

"It can break a person down into...resources, or recombine them into a new form. It seems you can also make certain modifications to a person that you want...though last time I didn't manage to get the modification right. Oh, right."

The words "Oh, right" came out stiffly, as though he were deliberately pretending he had only just remembered.

Wellesley slowly bent down; that slightly sallow face of his grew enormous as the moon, pressing into the corner of Brianna's field of vision.

She didn't dare turn her head to look at her father.

"Bri, walk inside, and let Dad see if he can change a few things."

...Black threads of rain soaked her hair and shoulders; when Brianna came back to herself, she found she was braced on her knees, breathing in ragged gulps.

The phone was slick with sweat. This male body sweated at the slightest thing.

The childhood memory had cost her a minute or two, and she hadn't called the driver right away—but in that brief span of one or two minutes, someone had already pushed the back door open and walked into the Black Cube.

...It wasn't Chase.

The writing really is getting later and later—well, fine, fine.

I don't write power-fantasy fiction, so both male and female characters run into setbacks.

But whenever I write a scene where a female character hits a wall, some readers who've projected themselves onto her might find it unpleasant to read, and I'll very easily get accused of not loving my female characters. (That's the truth—the actual phrasing was far worse; I won't give examples, it just upsets me.)

Female character encounters difficulty = the author doesn't love her. I still haven't figured out where that logic comes from.

But honestly, I still stand by what I've always said: writing and reading fiction is about finding a kindred spirit. Someone who truly understands the story I'm telling would never arrive at that kind of misunderstanding.

PS: Allow me to blow my own horn for a moment—I think the transitions between memory and present in this chapter are really smooth. Let me just put my hands on my hips in satisfaction.

Saturday, also known as Thanksgiving-two-days-late, brings a top-secret document of unknown authorship.

[Top-Secret Investigation Notes]

[Whoever finds this is forbidden from opening it without permission. I have placed a curse on it.]

[The time span covered by this list: September 20 – October 31]

[All persons named in this document are suspected of continuously funding the occurrence of anomalous incidents in Blackmoor City]

Note: But can money really override common sense and make the impossible possible?

The next step in the investigation is to find the people on the list.

What connection do they have to all the strange occurrences in Blackmoor City? There seem to be "Hunters" in Blackmoor City—is that slang?

Could this list perhaps be a list of Hunters?

Where did the money they gave go?

Hmm? Why has the author already concluded they are "they" [feminine]?

...How strange—could I have been affected by those bizarre things too? Never mind, let me look at the documents first...

Blackmoor City Resident

[Note: This is the first name in late September, and it seems to carry enormous weight. But this is clearly an identity... What is this Resident's actual name?]

Next to her name, someone had written in very ugly handwriting—

"Grandma rarely makes it to Blackmoor City, so coming is fine, but why bring gifts! You gave such a generous tip—I absolutely have to write a bonus chapter now, and Grandma will take it back to the Nest!"

[What does this mean? The Nest? I seem to have heard "Nest" come up several times during the investigation... This Resident's granddaughter seems to want her to take the bonus chapter back to the Nest. I'll draw a line connecting the two: bonus chapter — Nest.]

Your Dad laughed his warm, easy laugh and said, Joiiii

"Why do you two always tip so much," the ugly handwriting wrote. "Sorry it took over a month before I had the nerve to thank you—duly noted, next time I'll have Chase pour you drinks and wait on you at dinner."

[Note: Sure enough, neither is a real name. Your Dad is a lost cause, but Joiiiiii might be connected to a real name—worth investigating further. Who is Chase? Someone whose job is to keep guests company at meals?]

Non-Edible Kitty Gummy

[Oh no! I was just looking at this name and felt a wave of warmth and fondness—how terrifying. I'm a detective conducting an undercover investigation, how could I— Oh, a little kitty you can't eat like a gummy... so cute...]

[Snap out of it!!]

"You already treat tips like a daily check-in as it is... Who do you like? Say it!" said a handwriting beside it.

The name on the next line was:

Little Meow Left a Paw, Csmshksdaaa, Reader20190620111919738

"It's usually the same few sheep letting me fleece them over and over—like you two. But the number-name who never changed it—no matter how many times they tip, every reunion feels like meeting for the first time." The ugly handwriting said.

[Little Kitty and Little Meow must be closely related. Little Meow walked across the keyboard and typed out that garbled Csmshksdaaa... I think I understand. But how do you explain the string of numbers? It looks like a date... Could it be that Little Meow typed out the gibberish on June 20, 2019 at 11:19?]

Never Ask How Many Flowers Bloom

[What a beautiful name! It makes you can't help but wonder—what wrong turn did she take, to end up on this list.]

[How strange—the author feels herself developing an inexplicable sense of closeness toward the names on the document...]

[The name on the next line is one the author is seeing for the very first time, and yet it feels remarkably familiar... Almost like... coming home to find Grandma waiting...]

Hujiangjiu, Eye Mask, Dodge the Soda, Accomplice Structure, Messenger AtRnname, Iron-Clad White Crabapple

"Heh heh heh, how are you all doing?"

The ugly handwriting said while rubbing its hands together. As for why handwriting can rub hands—that's a minor detail not worth dwelling on. "Is Accomplice Structure a new recruit who just joined our phone-scam operation? All the others are old acquaintances of Grandma's—seasoned victims."

[New intelligence: this may be a fraud operation. But would fraud victims keep sending money even knowing they've been scammed?]

The ugly handwriting scrawled on crookedly:

"Next we have Umbrella-in-Sun-Still-No-Use, Qiu Shiqi, Moon-Zhuo-Loves-Adventure-Stories, Junmixi, Liujiinqi, Ziya, Nostradamus's Card—I know every single one of you!"

[Quite the extensive social circle. But truly, every single name feels so familiar.]

"The only one who looks a little unfamiliar is Yuechenheming—new here?"

"Thank you Yixiu-Ishgard-Red-Doll-Tomato, Mottled-Dense-Fog, Xiwei-Quiet-Night, Du Ziruo, Atuonuo, Ciel Mo, Yinglong-Wants-Turtle-Jelly, Moon-Falls-Into-Cotton-Candy, Dang-How-Did-I-Berry-Out, Yuecho! Without Grandma's regulars, this story wouldn't survive a single day."

What story?

Ashley closed the notebook.

She set the notebook on the table with one hand, propped her chin with another, reached out from her eye socket with another to smooth her hair, and tapped gently on the table with yet another.

...This matter seemed to run deeper than she had thought.

[P.S.: There will also be a Silver-tier thank-you bonus chapter tonight, in the Author's Notes section at the front of the work—current progress: 0.]

Saturday is supposed to be a rest day, but unfortunately I didn't rest well—less than ten hours of sleep over two days. Don't worry though! I'll still go update the Silver-tier thank-you chapter in a bit!

Chapter 200 — Sydney Ginn: Everyone Is Keeping Very Calm

"Wait!"

Pushing open the back door, Sydney Ginn stepped into the night with one foot.

In the dim, damp alley, the faint smell of a nearby garbage bin drifted through the air; apart from the two of them, there was no one else in the alley.

The man and woman ahead heard the call and turned around—somehow, after stepping outside, they had stopped in their tracks and gone no further, and were now only a step or two away from Sydney Ginn.

At her shout, as the two turned their heads, both wore expressions of blank bewilderment, as if just waking from a deep dream—as though, before Sydney Ginn had come out, they had been standing outside the door, spacing out for a few seconds.

These two people—why did they seem a little off?

Was it the environment?

The pale motion-sensor light above the back door looked like it was about to die; it illuminated nothing, and instead cast a ghastly pallor over the two of them, as if some invisible black mist were drifting around them like a ghost.

...She probably didn't look much better herself.

"You're looking for us?" the soft-looking, seemingly easy-to-push-around man asked carefully. "Do we know each other?"

"No," Sydney Ginn answered—at that moment, Megan had also followed her out, and the back door slammed shut behind them with a thud.

"Are you looking to sell an Artifact?" she asked the slender woman. She had noticed back in the bar—the item belonged to that woman.

"She's interested in your Artifact," Megan added. "You could head back inside and talk it over."

"...Megan?" The M-making genius tilted her neck forward slightly, squinting as if uncertain.

After the back door closed, everything around them was dim and dark; they couldn't quite make out each other's faces—the other two might not even know who had come running out after them.

"It's me," Megan said.

With a Between the Backlights staff member present, there should have been no question about it: the other two would surely have been happy to follow her back inside to negotiate and deal with Chase—yet Sydney Ginn was already turning to open the door when she heard the woman ask, "Can we do this another time?"

"Huh?" Sydney Ginn was taken aback. "Why?"

"Sorry about that," she seemed to smile with a hint of embarrassment. "It's a bit inconvenient right now. If you're in a hurry, we could find somewhere else to talk—how does that sound?"

Sydney Ginn remembered that back in the bar, the woman had given off a sense of gentle warmth—and now that she spoke, her voice was indeed steady and warm, easy to feel close to just from hearing it.

"Sure," Sydney Ginn agreed without hesitation. "Wait for me a moment—the one who actually wants to buy is my companion. I'll go get him."

"Please be quick, then,"

the woman said softly, standing beneath a row of half-visible "XX" characters floating in the air.

"No problem, he's just inside," Sydney Ginn turned around and reached out to pull the door—and in that same moment, a thought surfaced in her mind, a beat too late.

...XX?

What XX?

Why were two inexplicable letters floating above that woman's head?

The thought flickered past; she lowered her eyes and found her hand wrapped around the back door handle.

That didn't seem particularly strange—she had been about to open the door anyway.

But what was strange was that her feet hadn't moved yet.

By all logic, she should have been a little distance from the door; she'd need to take at least half a step forward before she could reach it...

Sydney Ginn's gaze followed her own hand upward, and she understood quickly.

It turned out her arm had separated at the elbow.

The forearm and upper arm had parted ways at some point, and the forearm and hand were now drifting serenely in midair, hooked around the door handle.

At the break in her upper arm, there was no blood, no ragged flesh or wound—as if that spot had always been just a smooth, rounded patch of skin.

...Huh?

Faced with such a strange sight, what surprised Sydney Ginn was precisely that she felt no surprise at all.

She turned her head back toward those behind her—after twenty-eight years of life, this was the first time she had ever turned her head so easily and smoothly; she felt none of the pull of skin and muscle, none of the constraints of bone and tendon, as though her neck had become a pat of melted butter.

No—more like there was no neck at all.

Sydney Ginn felt her head floating lightly in the air as it turned again to face the man and woman behind her. Her body was still facing the back door, standing at a distance.

The man and woman, along with Megan beside her, seemed unsurprised at the sight—no one screamed or questioned it.

Megan also had "XX" floating above her head, though the man's read "XY."

Ah—those were chromosomes.

...Why was this happening?

Sydney Ginn's peripheral vision seemed to catch something.

She glanced in that direction and found a cloud of grayish-white mist drifting quietly in the air beside her ear.

Like a speech bubble in a comic strip, the grayish-white mist trailed off into a long point at the end, aimed directly at her, as if indicating it had come from her.

Inside the cloud speech bubble, words were floating.

(Emotions. Current emotions: panic, fear, confusion, surprise, doubt, bewilderment)

Looking more carefully, everyone had a cloud "speech bubble" floating beside them, and the emotions written inside were all more or less the same.

"Does anyone know what's happening right now?" Megan asked calmly.

"I don't," the woman said, her voice soft but entirely without emotion. "How strange—I've never seen anything like this before."

Beside her ear, the cloud speech bubble, in addition to the various emotion labels similar to Sydney Ginn's, contained one extra word: "novelty."

"Oh, look,"

the man said, lifting his head—as he did so, his head floated lightly off his body. "There's even more stuff in the air now..."

(Passage — leaped from a tall building)

(Passage — crashed through a large-scale screen)

(Passage — seawater)

(Passage — struck the ceiling while leaping into midair)

Four heads bobbed and drifted in the air, and for a moment no one spoke.

As long as no one claimed their own passage, no one would know which passage belonged to whom; though at this point, concealing one's passage served no purpose whatsoever—it was nothing more than a Hunter's ingrained habit.

"Rather than saying there's more, I'd say it's more accurate to say that things from within us are being projected out into the air," the woman analyzed.

"That's true," Sydney Ginn agreed.

"Once you can't feel your emotions, even if you rationally know something is wrong, you have no drive to want to break free of it," Megan said.

"Right—your emotions are floating beside your ear, not inside your head, so you can't feel them," the weary-looking man replied. With "XY" above his head and not "XM," it really didn't add up.

Just from his tone, it sounded as though they were all sitting through a very dull meeting: "It turns out that pure reason alone isn't enough to drive a person to act."

Sydney Ginn thought, though, that with heads and bodies already separated, how much reason any of them had left was honestly hard to say.

"Oh—my Artifact," the woman suddenly murmured.

She said it like an exclamation, but it came out flat and toneless.

Sydney Ginn followed her gaze and noticed that on the woman's torso, which had struck out on its own, a long black shadow like a serpent had loosened and unfurled outward—it turned out that besides the lipstick, another Artifact was wrapped around her body.

Looking closer, the lipstick was also drifting in the air beside her.

The man let out an "ah" and started, "Good thing you didn't—" then stopped.

In both her and the man's emotion speech bubbles, "worry" had appeared.

Yet her voice, when she spoke, sounded exactly the same as before—not a trace of worry: "... Can you open the door?"

Sydney Ginn realized she was being addressed.

"I can't see very well right now. My head keeps feeling like a balloon floating in water—it doesn't quite obey me, and I can't look wherever I want at will. I imagine you're all the same?"

Sydney Ginn had been about to nod, but since the woman was right, she made a sound of agreement instead.

"From what I glimpsed before I lifted my head just now, it looked like our bodies are still 'leaking' a lot of things outward. 'Leaking' might not be quite accurate, but I'm not sure how else to describe it... like we're melting."

"Are we dissolving into... separate pieces?" Sydney Ginn guessed.

"Possibly."

That guess seemed to meet with everyone's unanimous agreement.

If this continued, and their cognitive and language-processing faculties also came apart, the group would be completely unable to communicate.

"If we can get the door open, we might be able to call for help from inside the bar," Megan said.

Without emotion as a driving force, forcing oneself to act still seemed not entirely impossible.

Sydney Ginn said "I'll try," and her head swayed and drifted toward the back door—she turned too far, ended up facing the alley head-on, and had to laboriously turn back little by little.

Wanting to look back at the door was probably just habit; after all, her hand and her head were no longer attached to the same body.

She didn't know how the bioelectric signals generated in her brain were supposed to cross a physical distance and make the muscles in her faraway hand contract and exert force; she could only chant "open the door" over and over in her mind like a monk reciting sutras, picturing herself pressing down the door handle.

After running through this in her head several times, Sydney Ginn felt that two or three minutes must have passed—and the door still hadn't moved.

"You can do it," the weary man's encouragement gave no one any strength at all.

Sydney Ginn wanted to try harder but didn't know how. No matter how hard she pushed in her mind, her hand remained in the distance, watching from across the river.

Still, she forced herself to keep trying—without emotions as a driving force, taking action was so dry and laborious—she didn't know how many attempts it took, but the door handle suddenly dipped downward, and the door was pulled open a crack.

"Wonderful," Megan said, composed.

No—wait...

The door hadn't been pulled open by her, Sydney Ginn suddenly realized—it had been pushed open from the inside.

The person pushing had only pushed it open a crack before stopping.

She strained to let her head drift toward the gap in the door, trying to make out who was behind it.

"...There's nothing outside. No one there."

Through the narrow crack in the door, "June's" eye—dark as a black pore—met Sydney Ginn's gaze exactly.

And yet, from behind the snow-white Noh mask that was no wider than a single crack, it was impossible to tell whether she was lying, or whether she had even seen Sydney Ginn at all.

"Go outside and check,"

Chase's voice came from behind "June." "They might have gone farther off—search carefully."

He still used the tone of someone giving orders to a subordinate; only the person in front of him could no longer be considered his subordinate.

"I'd rather not," June said. "Their lives or deaths have nothing to do with me."

For a few seconds behind her, no one spoke.

"...Then get out of the way," Chase finally said in a low voice. "Let me go."

Well, it's a good thing everyone is emotionally stable in this chapter, because I've been pulling three consecutive all-nighters, on top of menstrual cramps, and right now I'm so exhausted my heart feels completely dead inside—even if you asked me to write a chapter full of emotion, I couldn't manage it...

P.S.: The Silver Arc bonus side-story arc has been updated.

It's completely stuck ahhhhh

You won't believe how long these 1,663 words have taken me. I'm going insane...

From eight o'clock all the way to midnight, didn't even eat, and it just wouldn't come out no matter what!

Even I feel like November's updates have been pretty unstable—I'd planned to turn over a new leaf at the start of the month, but right out of the gate I got so stuck I nearly lost my mind, with absolutely no idea what word number 1,664 should be!!

It's just that stuck!!!

I know the rough direction this plot arc is supposed to go, but I just can't write it!!!!

Chase has been the most stuck-on character since I started this novel!!!!

I want to kill this guy!!!!

Chapter 201: Chase the Traitor, Chase

"That's not happening."

Han June had turned herself into a human-shaped adhesive, wedged in the gap of the door, using her body to fuse the wall and the door into one solid mass, with no intention whatsoever of stepping aside.

For Chase, having made a demand only to have a subordinate dismiss it so matter-of-factly was, by all accounts, a first in his life.

By reflex, he lowered his voice and asked, ".....What did you say?"

That deeply threatening tone usually produced immediate results; but landing on Han June now, it was like dust settling into a corner—the world kept right on turning.

"I said no."

Han June said it plainly.

She didn't turn around; her face was still pressed against the door gap, her voice filtering out from the black hair at the back of her head: "Didn't you all keep stressing that just now? Your life is important right now—I can't let you go out there and throw it away."

Throw it away? He——

Chase's legs, like two hollow wooden rods barely holding his body upright, chose that exact moment to tremble slightly, abruptly reminding him of reality.

Since his mid-teens, Chase had gradually built an immense confidence in his own physical ability and reflexes; his strength, speed, and adaptability had long since become part of him, as natural and self-evident as breathing.

The way a person never worries they might suddenly forget how to breathe, he had never once imagined that his strength might fail him.

Just now, he had instinctively moved to grab Han June and fling her aside to clear his path.

It wasn't even a conscious thought; after countless repetitions of well-worn muscle memory, violence had become a default route—the shortest, the most efficient.

Only now, that confidence hadn't had time to recalibrate itself and catch up with reality.

.....With a body in this state, how was he supposed to bring Sydney Ginn back?

"You said just now that you sensed something outside the door," Chase said quietly. "You didn't see anyone—so what exactly did you sense that felt suspicious?"

Over the top of Han June's head, he could make out a sliver of the alley beyond the door.

Just as she had said, the space outside was completely empty—not a single person.

The motion-sensor light above the door glowed with listless indifference, and fine threads of white rain slid softly through the light and shadow; the darkness of the alley inside was disturbed and scattered by that pale, floating glow, breaking into layer upon layer of shadow.

"Just a hazy feeling—like something extra had appeared. But I can't tell where it is, how big it is, what it looks like....."

Han June's face was still pressed to the door gap as she said: "If I could see whoever's out there trying to assassinate you, I'd have no problem killing him, and that would put your mind at ease so you could take me to see the Mayor. But I can't see anyone, and yet I sense something outside the door—how could I possibly let you go out there and get yourself killed?"

"Since Sydney Ginn stepped on the landmine for you, you should be heading out through the front entrance right away. She's not essential to me meeting the Mayor anyway."

Chase stiffened.

.....What on earth was she talking about?

What front entrance did Between the Backlights have?

Hearing his skepticism, Han June turned her head and stared at him, motionless, as if frozen, for a second or two.

"I don't understand. A front entrance is a front entrance—what do you mean, 'what front entrance'?"

"Between the Backlights doesn't have a front entrance," Chase said. "The original front entrance—the one you had to walk down a flight of stairs from the sidewalk to reach—was sealed off years ago."

Han June paused, as if she wanted to say something, then stopped herself. An indescribable expression seemed to drift across her round, full face.

After a few seconds, she drew out a slow, elongated "oh," looked at him, and said something with an unclear meaning.

"I see.....Let me think about what arrangement would work most in my favor right now."

If it weren't for the slim hope he still held that Han June could be revived, he would truly have liked to kill her.

Chase closed his eyes and drew a long, slow breath.

.....He was getting anxious.

The way he'd been thinking about this had gone wrong the moment Sydney Ginn disappeared: fundamentally, he shouldn't even be thinking about rescuing Sydney Ginn right now.

Sydney Ginn was nothing but a distraction.

If she was still alive, then dealing with the assassin would naturally save her too; if she was dead, thinking about how to rescue her was a waste of time.

The crux of the matter was that the assassin had already arrived; so where was the enemy, and what method were they planning to use?

For those two questions, he could make some inferences: the enemy was likely somewhere in the alley, near the back door, and might have set some kind of trap—only if the enemy was using an Artifact, it would be very difficult to judge what form it would take, or through what channel it would be triggered.

Chase had handled a trap-type Artifact before—one that could exist in particle form, diffused throughout the atmosphere.

Once released, an entire area the size of Blackmoor City would be saturated with the trap; however, only when the target exhaled and their breath merged into the atmosphere would the Artifact particles home in on them, rapidly concentrating in that short window to suffocate the target to death.

No matter how carefully guarded a person was, they could not live in a vacuum forever; no matter where they hid, they could not escape air—and as long as the target remained alive, the Artifact particles would keep spreading.

That Artifact could only be used once, and it still sold for a price so staggering the number of commas was nearly uncountable.

From that point on, Chase came to understand two things:

First, he—and every person on Earth—was now breathing in Artifact particles that could no longer be triggered; second, Artifacts could exceed imagination, and there was no reliable defense against them.

If the assassin was working for Wellesley's side, they certainly wouldn't be short on fine tools……Seen that way, he supposed he ought to thank Han June for holding him back.

The other side had guessed he would leak his own whereabouts—wasn't that the whole point, to lure the assassin in?

So the assassin had played along and set the trap beside the only exit—Between the Backlights was semi-underground, leaving Chase no other way out; he would inevitably walk right into it.

Only, from the assassin's perspective, it was truly terrible timing that Sydney Ginn and her group happened to come out at precisely that critical moment—they had inadvertently revealed the danger to Chase one step ahead of schedule.

Chase knew that his luck had always been very good.

Even a trap had a girl who had just saved his life stepping into it in his place.

……No matter how far beyond imagination an Artifact might be, there should still be traces to follow.

Even a particle Artifact couldn't hide from an atmospheric composition scan.

"Open the door," Chase said suddenly. "I'm not going out. I just want to look outside—see if there are any clues."

"Is that so?"

If Han June grabbed him, he wouldn't be able to force his way out regardless—but Chase didn't say that.

"Han June," he asked quietly, "has any promise I've ever made you turned out to be a lie?"

The snow-white Noh mask looked at him, frozen in silence for a moment.

Beneath that masklike face, a part of the real Han June still existed.

"……All right."

She finally slowly pushed the door open, but her feet didn't move an inch—she stayed right in front of Chase, using her own body to block the doorway.

"If someone comes rushing over and starts shooting, I will shut this door immediately, you know."

What Han June said was "shut the door"—not fight back; so it seemed that face-fragment shards piercing into a person's body were indeed slower than bullets, after all.

Chase stood behind Han June and watched as the alley opened up before him.

Threads of rain drifted down from the sky, settling into the uneven gaps between the paving stones; the black puddles shuddered under the rain's touch, sending out fine, flickering glimmers of light.

The area right at the doorway was empty; standing on the inside and looking out at an angle, he could only see two or three meters out—there, two large garbage bins cast their dark silhouettes. If someone were crouched behind those bins, he wouldn't be able to see them at all.

The left side returned nothing to his gaze but a stretch of empty dimness, as if no human breath had disturbed it yet that night.

"Can we go back now?" Han June said. "There's nothing to see."

Chase didn't answer her, still staring fixedly at the darkness and the alley outside.

"The only door is temporarily unsafe, so go back and sit tight and wait to receive an Artifact that can help me get to the Mayor. We leave when we have it. Never mind sitting a few hours—we'll wait even if it takes days, weeks—and by then, this back door, no, this door, will probably be safe."

It was indeed the arrangement most in her favor. As for whether Sydney Ginn would still be alive by then, it didn't factor into Han June's considerations in the slightest.

"Give me a few more minutes," Chase said.

"What are you doing?"

".....Watching the rain."

Han June had no idea what he meant. "What?"

He wasn't lying. He was watching the rain.

No poet, no farmer, no meteorologist in the world had likely ever watched rain with the same focused, meticulous attention as he did now; every thread, every drop, every tiny splashing bead—he couldn't afford to miss a single one. To get a clearer look, Chase half-crouched, half-knelt on the ground, opened his phone's flashlight, and lit up the alley floor in a brilliant white sweep.

A few minutes later, under Han June's repeated urging, he finally stood back up.

"Seen enough?" Han June asked.

"Yes. Seen enough."

Chase's compliance was almost meek. He lowered his head and said softly near Han June's ear, ".....About three meters. Square."

"What?"

She hadn't misheard—she simply didn't understand.

"I promised I wouldn't go out the door."

Chase straightened up, tilted his chin to signal that she could close the door now. "See—haven't I been perfectly well-behaved and stayed inside?"

The door opened outward; Han June leaned forward slightly and stretched out her arm to reach for the handle, and while she reached, she said, "Oh. Thanks?"

"Don't mention it."

Chase watched her back as she leaned forward, and extended one hand toward her.

"But I never said I wouldn't push you out."

He said these words in a murmur—only after he had used every last ounce of strength in his body to shove Han June into the alley.

The chapter title fully reflects the deep, blood-soaked grudge I hold against Chase.

This chapter has finally been ground out, but I have a feeling tomorrow will be even more stuck, and this block could last several days—if I don't finish Chase's section, this human skin of mine is going to get peeled off over and over by the blockage.

Is it easy for me to wear a skin I drew myself?! ?!

Chapter 202 — Chase's Karma Comes Fast

"June" plunged into the curtain of rain and the dark alley, and vanished.

So there really was something wrong here — he had already hinted to June about the trap's size and shape in advance — three meters, square —

Chase fixed his gaze on the rainy alley before him, thoughts flashing through his mind one after another, fast as lightning.

The moment June fell in, she should have immediately understood what the hint meant, and to protect herself, she would do everything in her power.

As long as Sydney Ginn wasn't dead yet, he could seize this chance —

The next second, it was as though part of the gears in his mind was suddenly seized by an iron hand, and every thought ground to a halt.

From the empty, dim rainy alley, a line of text floated up.

The text faced him directly, formed seemingly from mist, hovering faintly in midair, only a shade darker than the night — it vanished in an instant, but before it disappeared, Chase managed to catch every word.

"Person Command input error; error reason: not fully human"

Wait — what did that mean?

Chase had no time to think it over. The next second, another June suddenly reappeared in the empty alley — or rather, more accurately, many pieces of June.

It was fortunate that he was someone who had seen a great deal, because otherwise he might not have been able to realize, in that first instant, that the cluster of things that had reappeared was actually June at all.

Because that cluster of things couldn't even be pieced together into a human shape.

The moment Chase raised his eyes, the first thing he saw was a snow-white Noh mask floating alone in midair.

It looked as though it had truly become a mask — solitary, connected to neither skull nor body.

The skull floated in the air several steps away, and like the body, had been broken apart and encased by many gray-white cloud-like "frames"; the encased portions likewise had text floating over them.

XX?

(Organs with transplant value) (Organs without transplant value)

(Reproductive system resources)

(Body shell, containing spores, cannot be further dismantled)

(Head, containing black hole, cannot be further dismantled)

(Passage, temporarily sealed)

(Emotions: astonishment, fury, sense of betrayal and exploitation, curiosity)

(Knowledge and skills)

(Desires)

There were even more "cloud frames," stacked one on top of another, all closely surrounding the snow-white Noh mask, seemingly all dismantled from June's body; there were so many that in a single glance, Chase couldn't take them all in.

He only remembered that nearby there also seemed to be a sun hat, a phone, and her clothes and shoes.

Even without fully understanding what was happening, in that split second, he had a dim intuition — dismantling a person, especially an adult, a Hunter, into individual parts, would yield a great many of them.

He had no chance to carefully examine those cloud frames one by one.

That great mass of dismantled parts appeared before him for only an instant, as if lit up by a flash of lightning, and then vanished from midair — accompanied by a faint tremor, a Noh-mask "June" reassembled and whole, fully clothed, slammed heavily into the brick wall on the other side of the alley.

...Thrown out by the trap?

"June" slid down the brick wall to the ground, braced herself with her hands and feet, and climbed back up; from that Noh-mask-like face, there was no way to tell whether she felt any pain.

She even reached down to pick up her phone, put her hat back on her head; she glanced first at the doorway where Chase stood, then turned to look down the alley to Chase's right — but what June saw there, Chase could not know.

Chase knew he ought to call out to her, yet for a few seconds he could only grip the doorframe tightly, barely holding up his trembling, still-powerless body.

How to describe it?

In the very first instant of sudden injury, the human mind is actually blank and bewildered; at that point, the brain hasn't yet reacted to the injury, hasn't understood it, doesn't yet know it hurts.

He stared at the "June" across the alley now in the same way as a person who had just been hurt — his mind a wasteland of emptiness and confusion.

After a few seconds, Chase released the doorframe.

The alley was roughly three to four meters wide, and within a square area of three meters on each side pressed right up against the door, the rain was falling more slowly than elsewhere.

It wasn't a steady, uniform slowness.

When the rain was about to fall at a height of three meters above, it would suddenly decelerate, as if entering some invisible substance of great density; that invisible substance seemed to taste the countless raindrops, find them not to its liking, and spit them back down to the ground.

It was through the rain that he had initially determined the trap's range and shape.

But it wasn't until June was thrown out that Chase suddenly noticed another problem.

...Sydney Ginn was dead.

He thought, almost blankly.

"June" had been dismantled into that state, yet was able to reassemble into a human shape and be flung out by the trap, thrown against the wall across the way — there was only one explanation: she was not a complete, purely human being.

This trap seemed to react only to humans.

Sydney Ginn was human — vibrantly, warmly human.

Other than humans, this invisible substance had no interest in the rain or in June, who was mixed with non-human parts; and anyone who fell into its hands would likely be dismantled into the scene he had just witnessed.

That line of text had also indirectly confirmed his guess — "Person Command input" should mean it could only take in humans.

Chase knew his luck always came at the cost of other people's lives — it had been that way since the car accident when he was young. Nobody had ever asked him whether he wanted that kind of fortune.

"June!"

That shout made June spin around, and gave Chase himself a quiet start as well.

"Who did you see over there?" Chase barked. "Move, now!"

By this point June had done more than just turn her head to look.

The invisible square had not completely filled the alley; it left a half-meter gap between itself and the opposite brick wall.

Before Chase had shouted, June had been moving sideways, step by step, out through the gap between the square trap and the wall — she seemed to have said something in the direction of the alley to her right, but her voice was low, and through the rainy night and the square trap, Chase couldn't make it out.

Someone was there; and it had to be the person who had come to assassinate him, and had killed Sydney Ginn by accident instead.

If everything went as expected, that person should be Brianna from the Wellesley Team, or someone she had sent.

...The would-be assassin seemed to be talking with June.

"June!" He barked again.

June turned her head.

In the darkness, that snow-white Noh mask seemed to float in the shadow beneath her hat brim.

That face locked onto Chase, unmoving, for a few seconds — and then, without any reaction at all, it turned away again and continued toward the alley on the right.

Soon, she walked beyond the reach of Chase's sight.

She had said before that if she saw the assassin, she wouldn't mind killing them for him... was June moving to act right now?

Chase truly wished he could believe that answer.

But the Noh mask that had turned toward him just now was entirely intact, snow-white and cold.

If she were going to act, why hadn't she sent a shard flying first?

He had been struck by a shard back in the bar. Although June hadn't truly driven the shard into his eyeball, Chase knew those face shards were very difficult to dodge — especially when the assassin had no idea what they needed to dodge.

But Chase couldn't step out through the door, and Between the Backlights had no second exit that would let him circle around to reach the back alley — and in an instant, he had once again fallen into the predicament he hated most: he had become so helpless that he seemed to have no choice but to stand by and wait, placing his hopes in someone else.

...Absolutely not.

He stripped off his jacket, crumpled it into a ball, swung his arm hard, and hurled it into the alley.

The jacket flew into the air and abruptly lurched to a stop — in that instant, it was as though it had dropped into liquid, its downward momentum suddenly sluggish; then the jacket was flung back out of the trap, just like June, flying into the wall across the way, sliding to the ground, the rain pocking it with dark wet spots as it slowly crumpled out of shape.

Sure enough, the trap had still not been withdrawn.

He didn't know why, but June now seemed to risk turning against him.

Chase immediately ducked to the side, standing inside the doorway — this way, at least for now, he could avoid the possibility of being attacked from outside the door; he took out his phone and quickly sent Tianxi a message.

"Bring people, alley behind Between the Backlights, Artifact trap, activated from the west alley entrance"

The one stroke of fortune within the misfortune was that he had sent Tianxi to stake out Taylor Ford's apartment tonight; Tianxi and the squad he had brought could come over directly from Taylor Ford's apartment, far faster than gathering people and setting out from Key House.

But fast as that was — could they arrive before the two people outside made their move?

Chase pushed the thought down — whether or not Tianxi could make it in time, he couldn't do nothing.

Just as he was about to put his phone away, he suddenly paused.

Sydney Ginn had called June to come tonight... which meant that, whatever else she might have forgotten, she still remembered how to answer a phone call.

In the instant June had been dismantled, he had also seen clearly that a phone was floating in midair.

Which meant...

The thought had barely risen before Chase was already acting — he quickly dialed June's number.

The dial tone rang again and again; faintly, through the square trap, he could hear the muffled sound of June's phone ringing.

He didn't know how many rings it took, but June finally picked up.

No one spoke on the line — only the soft static of rain, and the sound of traffic from the distant road.

Chase could almost picture it: that snow-white, puffed-out face, like a great moon rising from the horizon, pressing silently against the phone, waiting for him to speak first.

He knew he didn't have many chances, and had to nail June's attention with his very first sentence, so she wouldn't hang up.

If possible, he also needed to find out what was happening right now.

That meant thinking about what the other person had said to her, that had made June hold back — that answer didn't seem too hard to imagine.

"...What conditions did they offer you?" Chase asked, his voice low.

"Oh, you guessed it — true to form, Chase."

June said, with flat indifference: "...It's only the Mayor. I can arrange a meeting whenever I want. What Artifact don't I have? Don't worry.' That's what this person just said to me."

The assassin's response had been much quicker than he had expected.

"You want Chase to fall into your trap, is that it?"

Before Chase could figure out how to respond, June spoke again — clearly addressing the assassin now: "Since you seem quite sincere, I may as well tell you. He's very physically weakened right now. Find someone to give him a push from behind, and he'll fall right into your trap."

...He really wanted to kill June.

Chase thought this while licking his dry lips.

Honestly, if I keep up this schedule, I probably don't have many days left either...

I have Christmas socializing to get through because work clients are coming to play. As an introvert, I blew past my social quota for the year back in January, and at this point I've used up my entire 2026 allowance too, ahhh—

P.S.: The chapter title reflects my schadenfreude toward Chase. Without him I wouldn't have been stuck all night. Lowest popularity, highest difficulty!

Chapter 203: What Chase Does Best

Turning away from the doorway, Chase felt, somehow, a faint urge to laugh.

Yes, the situation was a complete disaster right now.

He was weak, powerless; every step he took made his muscles tremble.

The fact that he had "Rumor" had almost certainly been exposed — and the people who knew probably weren't limited to Brianna.

After Uncle Key was attacked and injured, he still hadn't had a single proper conversation with him; and the person who had gone after him had, not long ago, sent Key House Faction Hunters to their graves.

Even as he ran himself ragged, the Artifact that could grant him a passage still didn't know whose hands it had fallen into.

The girl he'd met by chance — who had helped him more than once — was by now most likely dismantled into countless pieces, unrecognizable.

June, once a cheerful and reliable subordinate, was one of the very reasons he was now caught between a trap and an attack with nowhere to go — and at this moment, over the phone, she was saying to that assassin in an utterly flat tone: "...Have someone come at him from behind right now. There's still time."

Before he could even bring his finger down hard on the screen, June had already hung up on her end.

Yes, everything was a complete disaster.

But the vague feeling stirring in his chest right now — how to describe it?

If he had to make a comparison: it was like a poor man's son returning to the slums, a hyena welcoming the night, a prison escapee being locked up again — the chaos, absurdity, and hopelessness of this moment were exactly the kind of life Chase was used to.

He was like some mutation of a contaminated fish, returning to poisoned water and feeling, oddly, relieved.

Faced with chaos, he could do whatever the hell he wanted — that was how he had always gotten by.

He didn't know when the assassin had sent subordinates into the bar, and it didn't matter anymore.

Chase walked down the steps by the door.

He moved along the corridor, his footsteps unsteady and slightly swaying, but his eyes stayed fixed on the end of the hallway — fixed on the door that led into the bar.

That door could be pushed open at any moment; someone with a tense face might walk through it, perhaps carrying a weapon capable of splitting a skull with a single blow —

It didn't matter.

Never mind being poisoned — even if every bone in his body were shattered, as long as there was still a breath left in him, he would never let the person who had marked him as prey walk away alive.

From the moment he decided to kill Damian over a decade ago, Chase had been ready to trade his life for another's. He just hadn't known back then that the place he would ultimately die would be this ordinary, narrow hallway lined with offices.

...Wait.

He stopped dead, braced a hand against the wall, and glanced over at the office.

The door wasn't fully shut — it was left ajar, a thin gap showing.

Right...

Tonight, Between the Backlights was doing brisk business; the server who had brought Chase and his group in and handed them off to Megan had gone straight back to tend the bar.

At the time, Megan had told them that the Hunter with the lipstick had just left and they could still catch up — and since it was better to have her there when approaching that person, she had left quickly with Sydney Ginn.

Megan must have assumed she'd be back in a minute or two at most, so she hadn't bothered to lock the office door.

Chase swept a quick glance toward the end of the corridor.

The door at the end of the hallway had a round panel of frosted glass set into it, and through the glass he could now make out a blurry silhouette drawing closer — someone about to push the door open and come through.

Chase made his decision without hesitation: he turned, stepped into the office, immediately swung the door shut behind him with a quiet click, and locked it.

Almost the instant the lock caught, he picked up the sound from outside — a heavy set of footsteps passing through the hallway, just a few steps away, separated from him by a single door.

Judging by the sound and the faint tremor in the floorboards, whoever had just walked past was also a big, heavyset figure.

Chase had a sharp sense of time; getting from the office to the back door would take roughly forty seconds.

Once that person reached the back door, found no one there, looked around in confusion, and contacted their boss, that alone would take at least a minute. When they finally figured it out and turned back from the back door, they'd pick up the pace — probably reaching the office door in about twenty seconds.

Which meant the safe window he had was only two minutes.

He had to come up with a plan within two minutes.

He swept his eyes rapidly around the room.

Aside from a photo on the wall showing Megan having captured a Nest Resident, it looked like any ordinary office: a computer, a desk, a chair, a filing cabinet, a safe...

A safe?

Chase's gaze sharpened.

It was only slightly larger than the safes commonly found in hotel rooms and used the same kind of combination lock. Judging by its size, there was no way it could hold any heavy-duty weapons — was it a handgun? Or an Artifact?

If it was the bar's cash take for the day, it was completely useless to him.

But even at peak physical condition, Chase couldn't crack a safe with his bare hands — he was only human, after all.

No point wasting time on the impossible; just a few seconds later, Chase dialed the bar's front desk phone at Between the Backlights.

He had no idea whether Between the Backlights had any dealings with Brianna — but equally, there was no sign whatsoever suggesting the two were in league with each other.

This was a blind gamble either way.

After several rings, he heard that Shar-Pei-faced bartender's voice again: "Hello, Between the Back—"

"I'm Chase Monroe. We just met."

The bartender was clearly startled. Even without seeing him, Chase could tell he was probably looking around: "Huh? Mr. Monroe? Didn't you just—"

"Quiet. Listen to me."

Chase cut him off: "There's a safe in your office. What's in it — an Artifact or a weapon? Name your price. I want to buy everything inside."

The call timer showed ten seconds had passed.

"Huh? Wait, I don't understand, how did you — are you actually in—"

"I don't have time," Chase said, putting more weight into his voice. "Answer my question."

Without June in front of him, his threatening tone still worked just fine.

"Well, for security reasons, the safe doesn't have weapons or Artifacts." The bartender did press down his questions and answer first: "There's no problem with you buying it — just please try to keep a low profile afterward."

When the bartender said "no weapons and no Artifacts," Chase was briefly stunned — it wasn't as though that possibility hadn't existed, but actually coming face to face with it as reality still left anyone momentarily at a loss.

He barely caught the bartender's next few sentences, and it was only the sudden mention of the name "Sydney Ginn" that snapped him back.

"...She should know about it, because she comes in often and has me mix drinks with central nervous system depressants for her."

Chase blinked.

Sydney Ginn had been coming here regularly to buy drinks laced with CNS depressants?

He glanced at the screen and saw that forty seconds had passed on the call; by now, the assassin's subordinate should have realized he wasn't at the back door.

One minute and twenty seconds left.

"You just said... the safe is full of medicine?"

"That's right," the bartender said. "Things that are hard to get hold of, prescription items, the kind of things Hunters might need from time to time."

Wait... there might still be a chance.

"Do you have amphetamines?" Chase asked.

The answer was yes.

If they had CNS depressants, having CNS stimulants on hand was only natural.

He knew that Key House Faction and himself had reputations — not entirely flattering ones — but that he could, in just a few sentences, half-persuade, half-coerce the bartender into giving him the combination first and settling the bill later was something even Chase found mildly surprising.

"We have both short-acting and long-acting—"

The bartender had barely gotten the introduction out when Chase, already staring into the open safe, cut in: "Which one is the short-acting?"

When he ended the call, it had been exactly two minutes and fourteen seconds.

He tilted his head back and dry-swallowed several pills.

Taylor Ford's poison mixing with amphetamines — no one could know what the outcome would be.

Chase sat on the edge of the desk and waited quietly for his body's next response. Would it be unconsciousness? Nausea? Or a creeping wave of euphoria?

Of course Chase didn't care whether it brought him any pleasure; he only needed it to do one thing.

Give him his strength back.

Out in the hallway, a set of footsteps — heavy and fast — was charging toward the office. They were finally here, considerably later than the two minutes Chase had estimated.

So this one wasn't very bright — only genuine confusion over where Chase had gone could have cost him that extra minute or more.

The office door handle twisted — it didn't turn. Then someone landed a heavy kick against the door with a thud.

"Chase Monroe? You're in there, aren't you?" An unfamiliar voice rumbled through the door.

Chase stayed where he was, sitting on the edge of the desk, motionless. Even short-acting medication didn't kick in this fast.

He said nothing; the person outside said nothing either and began shouldering the door repeatedly — the office door wasn't particularly solid, and after just a few impacts, the door frame was already showing signs of giving way, splintering into jagged slivers of wood.

Chase watched calmly as the door finally burst open and a broad-shouldered, heavysset figure crashed through — their eyes met, and the man jolted, quickly pulled up short, and leveled a handgun.

"I've heard about you. Everyone says you're ruthless and vicious, that nobody wants to cross you."

The man studied him steadily for a few seconds, then smiled, the gun still trained on Chase.

"The way I see it, it's only because you had subordinates that you could strut around like that. Alone, you're not so bold after all — you even hid in a room and locked the door. So you're actually this afraid of dying?"

Chase raised both hands and slowly stood up from the desk.

His leg muscles didn't tremble. He straightened up without trouble.

But it still wasn't enough.

"Move," the man said, gesturing with the gun and tilting his head toward the door.

Chase looked at him and slowly broke into a smile. "...Where are you taking me?"

"Enough talk — out you go." The man grabbed Chase's arm with his free hand and shoved him toward the door. "To the back door!"

"Alright, alright, I'm going." And Chase, true to his word, obediently entered the hallway.

The two of them moved through the corridor one in front of the other, heading toward the back door; as they walked, Chase explained to the man who kept urging him to hurry: "I'm injured. I can't walk fast."

"Up."

At the bottom of the steps by the door, the man gestured with his gun, indicating Chase should go up first.

Chase climbed the steps slowly and came to stand again in the open doorway. Outside in the dark of night, fine threads of rain were still drifting down like white fur; he didn't see June.

Perhaps she and the assassin were waiting nearby.

He felt the man step up behind him and reach out.

As the man's grip closed on him, Chase gave a light, unhurried turn of his arm backward and locked his hand around the man's arm at the same time.

In truth, he hadn't fully recovered his strength; after all, he'd only taken prescription medicine, not an Artifact.

...If he told that to the man who was now wide-eyed and helplessly toppling outward, he surely would have died feeling aggrieved.

What should I say today — I've about exhausted insults aimed at Chase, and I can't keep poisoning just him.

Oh! Today the cat food delivery was made by a total hunk! Who could have expected it — sitting at home minding my own business, a handsome guy rings the doorbell, and I went downstairs looking absolutely wrecked, wearing pajamas as old as I am (18), and carried the cat food back up feeling deeply ashamed of myself.

Chapter 204: Chase Runs His Mouth, Chase Monroe

"What, did you really think I'd let him fall completely into the trap?"

Chase crouched at the doorway like an enormous spider forced to fold its long legs.

There was still only the one motion-sensing light in the back alley, yet he found his senses sharpening—the edges of his vision began to glow with a faint, buoyant light.

...That felt good.

It was as though fate had suddenly taken pity on him, willing to bow its head and yield to him for once.

The more he watched the scene before him, the more he couldn't help finding it absurd; even as he spoke, he was interrupted by his own laughter several times: "...I waited so long for you to deliver someone to me—how could I let that go to waste?"

If anyone had seen him now, they would most likely have thought Chase was carving up a body.

One knee on the ground, he leaned slightly forward, arms extended outward—though not daring to reach fully into the night beyond the door.

Chase's two hands were gripping a pair of men's calves.

The calves lay perfectly still; the trouser legs had twisted and ridden up, exposing coarse leg hair and black socks beneath. Tracing upward from the calves, past the knees, halfway up the thighs—there was only empty air.

No blood, no wound, only a smooth, clean dividing line, with no visible cross-section.

On one side of that line lay the night alley; on the other was Chase, stifling laughter, not daring to let go.

When he had flipped the man over and shoved him out the door into the alley, the man had naturally struggled, arms windmilling as he tried to grab the door frame.

At that point Chase had decided to help him along—he'd kicked the man squarely in the backside, and in the instant the man's feet left the ground, Chase moved fast: he bent down,

snatched the man's calves, and hauled them back, leaving the man's upper body pitched into the trap while only half a pair of legs remained outside.

Thank goodness for big hands.

"Can you hear me talking, through that square thing?"

Chase asked, not really expecting an answer. "I wonder what it looks like from your angle... his upper half got dismantled, didn't it? If only half of him is dismantled, can he still be alive? Oh—are you wondering why I bothered keeping his legs? The reason is, of course—"

He stopped himself.

Chase vaguely suspected it was a side effect of the amphetamines, making him so talkative.

Why was he so eager to share?

There was a reason for leaving the man's legs, of course—he just didn't need to say it aloud, even though the other party, separated by a square-shaped trap, might not be able to hear clearly anyway.

He had originally assumed the square trap was pressed right up against the doorway.

Without leaning out, he couldn't see the sides of the door frame; and since the door opened outward, the closer to the doorway, the more the rain was disturbed, making it nearly impossible to judge the trap's exact distance from the door by the fall of the rain.

But with the person the assassin had sent him, everything became perfectly clear: the man's thighs lay half a step outside the door, and above the thighs there was nothing—meaning the vanished body had drawn Chase a boundary line marking where the trap began.

...So the trap starts there, Chase noted, studying that stretch of ground, quietly measuring it in his mind.

It was like parking a car—a person couldn't always stop exactly midway between the cars in front and behind. For a square Artifact to deploy at a position only half a step from the door was already quite a remarkable degree of precision.

A narrow gap like that—to others, it might seem useless, meaningless.

The bar door was recessed into the wall; meaning there was a gap between the trap and the door, but between the trap and the wall, there was almost no space at all—not even enough to

sidestep along the wall. If one could only squeeze between the door and the trap, what could be accomplished even if you managed to stand there?

And yet... in all matters under heaven, the hardest thing is simply to push open the door.

Chase could already see that sliver of light leaking from the exit; he just needed to think a little more.

Taking drugs carelessly was a truly terrible thing; without noticing, he found himself speaking again: "...If his upper half were fully shredded, his only fate would be death."

The pair of calves had been motionless for quite a while now; he let go, and the legs remained limp and unresponsive where they fell, the ankles twisting softly.

He pressed one hand to the back of the man's knee joint and held it there for a moment.

"Your Artifact is remarkable though... his popliteal artery is still beating."

Chase raised his head, looking out at the dim alley where strands of rain drifted and swayed, and said quietly: "His entire upper half should have been dismantled... which would mean 'dismantling' doesn't threaten life?"

June had been thrown back out unharmed—not because she was no longer human and therefore couldn't be killed, but because after "dismantling," a person could be reassembled?

In other words, Sydney Ginn might still be alive?

Fortunately, that sentence he managed to hold back in time and did not say aloud.

Chase wanting to save someone unconnected to Key House Faction—as long as he never said it himself, probably no one in the world could imagine it, nor would anyone believe it.

"This thing isn't an instant kill, yet you still went to such lengths to get me to step into it..."

Without a doubt, it was to extract Rumor from his mouth.

Rumor's unique method of transfer meant it couldn't be taken by ordinary means.

He didn't know how the bodyguard Ivan had gotten his hands on it, but there was no way to dig Rumor out of the mouth of a dead man who couldn't speak.

Rumor seemed to sense itself being thought of; right on cue, it shifted in his mouth, pressing a bulge against his cheek, then settled back.

"Setting the trap flush against the door and waiting for me to walk in—that was a workable plan. But once I saw through the trap, you chose to follow the idea of an idiot who couldn't even manage a glass of water, and have someone push me in from behind... That part is very interesting."

When June was thrown to the far side of the alley, he had seen it clearly—the square trap also had a small gap between itself and the opposite wall, just enough for a person to stand.

Even if the square trap only accepted living people, if the assassin stood on the far side and shot him in the legs, then whether he fell forward or backward, Chase ultimately would have had no way to escape being dismantled, would he?

Not shooting from the far side—there could only be one reason for that: shooting from the far side wasn't possible.

Why couldn't they shoot from the far side?

Hadn't the rain passed right through the square trap?

His phone buzzed and vibrated; Chase glanced at the screen and saw it was June calling. He thought about it for a moment, then gave a low laugh.

Chase declined the call.

"First hypothesis... you were worried I had a gun, and that my bullets would be thrown back out like June was, scattering into stray shots and getting you killed instead. At first glance, that hypothesis seems very reasonable."

But after June had switched sides, the assassin should have known clearly that he carried no weapons at all.

"Second hypothesis... requires a little imagination—first, we have to slip free from the constraints of ordinary reality."

On the face directly opposite him, a line of text had once flashed by in an instant:

"Person Command input error; error reason: not fully human."

When he first saw it, Chase's full attention had been on "not fully human"—that was understandable—but now he realized the real point of focus should have been elsewhere.

"Input."

Those two words were very interesting.

If there was input... was there output?

Thinking about it this way—June had gone in through one face and hadn't come out through any other face, yet she had been thrown out from the opposite face.

Could that face which had thrown her out be the corresponding "output" face?

Was it possible that the reason no one shot at him from the far side was that it was impossible to input anything into the "output face"?

If his deduction was correct, then the upward-facing side that rain fell onto should also be an "input face."

Input face, output face, cube, Wellesley.

Chase laughed softly.

"...I think I know what Artifact you have in your hands."

Yesterday I'd almost warmed back up to Chase with something like maternal affection, and then today I got stuck again—stuck until I'm bone-tired, so go ahead and scold me.

My sleep schedule has been completely turned upside down lately, I shuffle around like a zombie every day... I'll keep it shorter—after all, every word is wrung out of my life, and even an 18-year-old can't hold up forever, so let's pace ourselves.

Saturday, the Nest, the Opposition, top-secret internal meeting

Upholding the principle of never letting the Nest fall into human hands

Protecting our open, free, and independent Nest

Pledging to defend forever the golden age in which Nest Residents eat whomever they please

The Resistance Faction internal meeting is hereby convened

Meeting minutes: Zombie Typist

"Through our tireless efforts last time, I am very pleased to report to everyone that we have indeed won over a portion of the Nest hunters' sponsors."

The Dream Playwright stood up first, a document in hand. It still wore a lopsided wig, and though its blank face had no eyes, it had a pair of glasses on.

"With operating funds secured, we dispatched select comrades who can enter the human world, who quietly brought Artifacts along and made several trips into Blackmoor City."

The Dream Playwright pushed its glasses—since it had no nose to hold them up, this push was not upward but inward, into the skin.

"We made a very significant discovery! First: the sponsors who fund Nest hunters are actually the same revolving group of people, over and over again. Apparently there's a term for this: 'the sheep have been shorn bald.'"

To show their approval of its work, the assembled Residents nodded repeatedly—nodding lumps, nodding feet, nodding the empty patch of air floating above someone's shoulders.

"This gives us an enormous advantage in recruiting sponsors!" the Dream Playwright said excitedly. "So this time I've obtained a November sponsor list—we can fill in the gaps and continue our outreach."

The moment it finished speaking, three characters lit up on the meeting room's large screen:

Pang Xiaoya

"Just like the Tuna Gunsmith last time—this is a donation that deserves a bonus chapter in return." The Dream Playwright thought for a moment, a little uncertain whether it had gotten the name right. "...To give so generously all at once, she must also be a top-priority target under the hunters' close watch. If we can write bonus chapters, can the hunters not do the same?"

The taxi driver poked his head blankly out of the car window and asked, "Can they?"

Since he and the car were one entity, he had driven the car right into the meeting room.

"They... might. Some of them seem to be university graduates—we can't underestimate their literary level."

The Dream Playwright said: "The key point is, if both sides write bonus chapters for Pang Xiaoya, how do we gain the upper hand? So I've decided to send the comrades who enter Blackmoor City to quietly find her and give her passage a check-up. If she has one, we recruit her straight into the Nest to watch me write her bonus chapter in person. If she doesn't... hmm, we'll develop her through other means."

"Oh, what a great idea," the Residents below responded one after another.

Next came two names that even the Residents had grown familiar with.

Tall-Growing Fish, Staying-Up-All-Night Ducky-Ducky-Ducky-Ducky-Duck

"As for our last outreach attempt, Tall Fish was very aloof and gave us no reply."

The Dream Playwright sighed, feeling that the Slender Patient had not made a very good impression. "Besides continuing to make contact, we also need to cater to her interests. For instance—what does she like? Which Artifacts interest her? These are all things our comrades must keep investigating. We must turn her into a Nest sponsor."

As for the Night-Owl Duck, the Dream Playwright was extremely confident.

"I can guarantee that she has long since set her heart on the Nest! I sense a resonance of souls! Most of us Residents are creatures of the night—look, isn't she up late too? And besides, the moment she stays up late, her whole way of speaking changes dramatically, emotionally intense, saying it over and over, duck duck duck—she's already one of our comrades, duck duck duck!"

Everyone found this point entirely convincing.

"Next up is Atuono, alongside Non-Edible Kitten Gummies." The Dream Playwright shook its head back and forth. "...These two are tricky—I don't think we can win them over. First, they've been tipping Nest Hunters for years and probably already have someone they like. Second, their names are just no good."

How exactly were they no good? Sure enough, a Resident asked.

"They feel kind of upright and cute, respectively," the Dream Playwright said. "The other two with them—Running Cherry and Plus-Size White Priest—seem a little unfamiliar; they might be worth pursuing. Too bad... if it were Man-Eating Cherry and Plus-Size Black Priest, that would be so much better..."

The Dream Playwright was especially pleased when introducing the next one. "Messenger AtRnname is already one of ours! She's the one we successfully recruited last time!"

The conference room erupted in a cacophony of clapping, whooping, banging, buzzing, and hollering.

"But Joiiii is impossible," the Dream Playwright said, well-versed in the art of narrative twists. "She's already been completely enchanted by some guy who isn't even a Hunter—lost and not looking back. Unless Chase could become a Resident... hmm, let me jot that idea down."

"We've spotted Moon-Dust Crane Calling again! What a beautiful name—I'll find a way to have some Resident go call out to her next time and win her over. Zhao Yi Bu Yi seems to be a first-time visitor? What kind of impression does our Nest make? Do you like the Residents? And as for the owner of Hu Miaomiao, there seems to be some deeper meaning there..."

The Dream Playwright rested its chin in its hand and sank into thought. "Who is Hu Miaomiao? Can I change my name to Hu Miaomiao?"

"Aini and Diwei, Ciel Mo, Liu Jinqi—those are all regulars in Blackmoor City, the kind you often spot in comment sections across the major forums."

The Hack Playwright continued, "BaiB doesn't seem to talk much... do you all think talkative people like us more, or quiet ones?"

After all, the opposition held meetings constantly—this was not a question to be taken lightly.

The names that followed were almost all bald sheep—no, familiar faces. And a few of the names, at a glance, were clearly never going to enter the Nest as sponsors.

"Always standing on the side of the egg... sigh. We Residents, compared to anyone, are hardly the egg—though I could grow to look like one. Shandong Fugitive Excavator won't work either; that person's busy being on the run and probably can't make it."

Alongside those two, more names appeared on the large screen.

"Siyang611—good memory, can't afford to offend. Du Ziruo—always tipping in silence... Ishgard Red Puppet Tomato, the name itself is already gibberish, just like Late-Night Duck—definitely one of ours.

"A Daydream Without Sugar—no good, too idealistic, too in pursuit of beauty, not one of our comrades. Mia Ao—this one's great, let's have that cat from our Nest go find her.

"Mai Nai's Brandy... Mai Nai doesn't mean that old lady, does it? Someone that fond of her? Forget it, this one won't work either. BMZZ83... why is there a license plate number in here? Feng Ye Qian Nai, Crazy Strawberry Toast, and Ya Er are all November sponsors too—the Nest is very happy..."

Meeting minutes:

Because the Dream Playwright talked too much and kept holding meetings, by the time it finished going through the list, it found that all the Residents had left. The only one who hadn't was the taxi driver, because there was no way to drive the cab out the door. As for how it had been driven in, that needn't concern anyone.

Because I've been pulling all-nighters several nights in a row and I'm exhausted, I'm planning to sleep first and then continue writing the Silver Bonus Arc side story... It's already at 600 characters now, and I'll definitely be able to post it tonight. The Silver Bonus Arc is a real brain-burner, and right now my brain is in short supply inside this skull of mine.

Interestingly enough, under Luan Li Lao's careful analysis, she has successfully avoided the great monster in both door-openings so far. Will Luan Li Lao manage to rescue London Moon before the game clock runs out?

Please look forward to the next installment of See You, Hunter.

(Speaking of which, Little Freckles' new show is out—I knew I still like him. After finishing the first episode I couldn't bring myself to keep watching; only three episodes have been released so far.)

Chapter 205: Chase's Brief Flight

"...What he bought from me back then was a black cube, ten centimeters on each side."

It was the first time Uncle Key had spoken to Chase about the Black Cube—on a morning three hours after Wellesley's death.

"What does it do?"

Chase had only just been roused from sleep and had barely settled into his seat at the breakfast table, taking a sip of black coffee so thick and bitter it nearly stung his tongue.

He didn't know how Uncle Key had learned that Wellesley's Artifact had dispersed after his death, and so had sent him to track it down—but when Uncle Key kept things from him, he rarely pressed for answers.

"As far as I know, it's an Artifact for querying information. Input a command into one face, and the face directly opposite will display the relevant text."

Uncle Key chose his words carefully, speaking with deliberate caution.

"Query it, and text appears?" Chase raised an eyebrow. "...Like Google?"

Uncle Key made no attempt to hide the gaps in his own knowledge—he simply shook his head and said, "I was still young back then, only seven or eight years older than you are now. The Black Cube was in my hands for just four days before Wellesley bought it away... I had a vague feeling about it even then. But now I'm quite certain: what that Black Cube can do is likely far greater than I ever imagined."

He glanced around, picked up a napkin from the table, folded it roughly into a square, and held it up.

"Of the six faces of the cube, only one will receive the countdown query command—and then, from the face directly opposite, it projects the countdown date."

After Uncle Key had run through it once, Chase nodded to show he understood.

"It wasn't until after I sold the Black Cube that I started thinking: two of the six faces are used for input and output of information. So what about the other four? Do they serve any purpose? When I was testing it, the other four faces showed no response to my commands at all.

What exactly did Wellesley discover that I hadn't? By the time I wanted to know, it was already too late."

"No—there will be," Chase said, the words out of his mouth almost before Uncle Key had finished his last syllable. "I'll go find it."

This was a reflex he had developed over many years—Uncle Key's wishes were his orders.

He couldn't bear to see Uncle Key or Aunt Hai left with regrets.

Whether it stemmed from guilt, loyalty, gratitude for being raised—or something harder still to put into words, Chase had long since stopped trying to sort it out.

Whenever Uncle Key or Aunt Hai wanted Chase to do something, he would feel a faint, almost physical sense of relief; as though each request they made was one more chance for him to repay them, even just a little—however small that might be.

Even knowing he could never repay them in full.

Uncle Key nodded, unfolded the napkin, and dabbed the corner of his mouth with it. "Good."

...I found it, Uncle Key.

Chase stared at the dim, empty alley ahead of him, and thought—for a moment, he felt the urge to laugh again.

In all the times he had thought of Uncle Key and Aunt Hai before, he had never once felt like laughing.

The Black Cube had found its way to him in a form he never could have anticipated, and far sooner than he'd expected—that was worth being happy about, wasn't it?

The face marked "Person Command Input" had to exist independently from the "Information Command Input" face—it was a different face entirely—because this face only accepted humans; it hadn't even accepted Han June, so an information command was surely even less likely to work on it.

It had to correspond to an output face as well.

This wasn't a guess based purely on symmetry—after all, once a person had been dismantled and the Artifact separated out, something had to come back out, didn't it?

Things coming out through an output face: that was a reasonable enough assumption.

Which meant that of the Black Cube's six faces, the most likely arrangement was three pairs: one pair for information input and output, one pair for person input and output... and one pair remaining, whose function he still didn't know.

Chase looked up.

Whatever the top input face was, he could at least be certain it wasn't the Person Command Input face—meaning that if a person fell through it, the cube simply wouldn't accept them.

The tricky part was figuring out what would happen if it didn't.

The output face corresponding to the top was pressed very close to the alley floor; the gap between the two was enough to let rainwater through, but nowhere near enough to fit a person.

If someone fell in through the top, would they be expelled through one of the other faces—or would they be crushed between the Black Cube trap and the alley floor, squeezed to death?

Based on what he currently knew about the Black Cube, the answer was beyond question.

The Black Cube didn't care what you were—go in through the input face, come out through the output face; go in from the top, come out from the bottom. As for the spatial constraints affecting whether what emerged was a person or a puddle of a person—it was safe to say that was entirely outside the Black Cube's area of concern.

Chase had no intention of spending thirty years clawing his way through life only to end up flattened by a Black Cube Artifact into a smear of flesh with burst eyeballs and shattered skull.

...But was there any other way out?

If only there were someone who could test it for him.

Chase glanced down at the man and gave his legs two sharp tugs—unfortunately, they wouldn't budge.

He could lift the legs, shift them left, swing them right, even make them do a little dance—but he couldn't pull them free.

Besides, even if he could pull the man out, he had no way of throwing a broad-shouldered, heavyset man nearly his own height straight up into the air three meters above—he wasn't Superman.

Chase let go and dropped the man's feet; they hit the ground with two heavy thuds, one after the other—but the next instant, his whole body went rigid.

...What was that?

He thought he'd heard a third sound.

Faint and indistinct, as though it had been trying to slip itself in among the noise of the man's limbs being moved, sneaking in under cover of the sounds Chase was already making; the moment the man's feet hit the ground, the alley fell silent again.

Chase spun around and fixed his eyes on the corridor behind him.

Between the Backlights was semi-underground, its entrance connected to a short flight of steps. He was standing above those steps now, looking down into the corridor, and his line of sight only carried three or four meters before it was cut off.

Those three or four meters of corridor were empty and dim white—not a trace of any human presence.

Had he heard wrong?

Could there be a second assassin's subordinate lurking in the bar?

If the assassin had planted more than one subordinate in the bar from the start, why hadn't they sent both in together? Wouldn't that have been safer?

And if the assassin had just sent someone new—he had been standing guard at the door the whole time, so how had this person gotten in?

No. He was asking the wrong question.

The most critical issue right now wasn't puzzling over how the assassin had gotten someone into the bar—even if he couldn't figure it out, he still had to operate on the assumption of the worst case, so dwelling on it was just wasted time. The most critical issue was: who the assassin had sent in.

That question, once he thought about it for even a moment, had an obvious answer.

If he were the assassin, after a first failure, who would he send in for the second attempt—someone who could guarantee Chase would stay alive and walk docilely into the Black Cube?

Apart from his hospital gown, Chase had absolutely nothing on him.

He raised a hand and tore his shirt open with one sharp pull; a row of buttons burst free and scattered, clattering across the floor. He yanked the shirt off, bare-chested, and gripped it tight in

his fist—then said quietly, "...Han June, you can come out now."

A second or two later, what slowly materialized from the corridor was not a pair of feet.

When someone walks toward a doorway, the natural thing to see first—from Chase's vantage point—would be legs and feet; yet what was rising now from the corridor floor, emerging little by little like a full moon cresting the horizon, was a round, snow-white, bloated face.

Jet-black hair, half of it trailing along the ground, flowing like oil, spreading a dark stain across the tiles.

"Chase-gē..."

Han June—who looked as though she were lying flat on the floor with only her head stretched forward—suddenly smiled up at him, her cheeks pushing high. "How did you get your strength back so fast?"

She had no real interest in hearing the answer.

The words weren't even half out of her mouth before that Noh mask face suddenly loosened and a piece cracked away—and in that instant, Chase knew he was out of time.

He clutched the hospital gown tight, kept his eyes fixed on the small shadow hurtling straight at him, and snapped his arm out in a fierce mid-air swipe—crack—the cloth seemed to connect with something; even with his exceptional dynamic vision, the shirt had barely, barely deflected that fragment as it grazed past.

Because it wasn't a clean hit, most of the force was lost; the fragment tumbled backward a few times and steadied itself again, suspended in mid-air.

"It's not like I can only send out one piece," said Han June, her jaw now missing a chunk, in a tone of faint regret.

Again without waiting for her to finish speaking, the snow-white shards that had been hurtling at Chase suddenly became a small swarm—Chase flung the hospital gown open to shield his head and face, and at the same moment swept it outward; several fragments were instantly wrapped up in the cloth, and faintly, through the fabric, tiny leg-like shapes were writhing, as though trying to bore their way through.

He quickly snapped the shirt sideways and slammed it against the wall beside him; four or five fragments were knocked loose and sent flying.

The second attack was barely deflected, but he had no way to neutralize Han June's fragments—at this rate, it was only a matter of time before one of them pierced him, and she steered him into the Black Cube.

Fortunately, he had been watching Han June all night and had noticed something she had never mentioned—and no matter how he looked at it, it didn't seem like a coincidence.

"The fragments that break off from your face can only embed themselves in a target's face, can't they? You've never used them to pierce any other part of the body... even though targeting somewhere other than the face would make you harder to detect and far more likely to succeed."

By the time Chase deflected the fragments with the hospital gown for a third time, he could already sense that he was running on fumes. After all, it was only stimulants—he was still far from a full recovery.

There was only one path left: the alley behind him.

"So what?" Han June answered.

Before he replied, Chase glanced at the door. He estimated it was about two-point-two meters tall—add his own height to that... it would be enough.

He had no other choice.

Without a word, Chase suddenly twisted his body, pushed off the ground and leapt up, arms stretched long, catching the top of the door frame; at the same time, he braced a foot against one side of the frame, pressed up with his arms, and hoisted himself onto it—the moment both feet touched the top of the door frame, he immediately felt it swaying back and forth beneath him, as though it had suddenly come alive and was trying to throw him off.

"Chase-gē!" Han June called from inside, and she seemed to scramble to her feet immediately. "Why are you so hard to kill?"

The moment he climbed onto the door frame, he dropped out of Han June's line of sight from her position inside—but he could already hear her footsteps, rushing urgently toward the entrance. Han June had always been the kind of hunter who clamped down on her prey and never let go.

Chase crouched low and looked up at the night sky about a meter above his head.

Empty and vast, it looked as though there were nothing there at all.

It was hard to imagine that this scene—night and fine rain—might become his grave.

Not knowing whether the assassin could hear him, he smiled through his ragged breathing and said, "If I fall out from below, I'll be crushed to death."

The night wind scattered his hair; cold rain closed around him in a fine, dense curtain.

Even if a person could fly, the sky and earth were too vast—there was nowhere to escape.

Chase knew he was staking his life on a single bet.

He was betting that the assassin, before obtaining Rumor, would not dare let him die.

He was going to use the threat of his own death to force the assassin to take the Black Cube away.

I nearly got stuck halfway through writing this... I stared blankly for a good hour before I finally figured out how to finish the chapter. My sleep schedule has been completely wrecked for ages now anyway—no point even thinking about it.

That said, aside from the kind of villain characters written purely to serve as antagonists, every other character I've given any complexity to—I look at them all the way a mother looks at her child... including Brianna, who appears so rarely. But even a birth mother sometimes really wants to kill a wayward son.

Chapter 206 — Chase: How Can One Small Alley Hold So Many People

His downward fall seemed to be cushioned briefly by some kind of force.

...Was that his imagination, or had it truly happened?

But that force which had caught him for a moment—illusory as it felt—seemed to find Chase not to its taste, and vanished from beneath him in an instant, like pulling away the firewood from under a pot.

Chase plummeted straight down toward the alley floor, hurled out by the Black Cube, thrown toward that narrow gap which could crush and burst a human body.

Unexpected situations could take any number of forms.

For instance, Brianna might prefer him dead rather than let him out; or she might have blind confidence that she could find a way to extract "Rumor" from his corpse later; or perhaps she had simply sent an underdog to assassinate him, and the subordinate had not dared act on their own judgment, and Chase would have been crushed to death before anything could be decided...

But if a person doesn't dare risk anything, it's very hard to wrest anything from the world's hands.

When a person dies, they die—it was that simple, and not worth fearing.

Chase closed his eyes. He felt as though he were sinking to the bottom of deep water, as though he had fallen from a much greater height, the descent lasting far longer than he had imagined—yet also strangely short.

Short enough that before a single breath had turned over, he had already struck the icy brick floor with a heavy thud.

Even with that momentary cushion during the fall, the impact still drove all the air from his chest, and his muscles and bones seemed to buzz and go numb.

In that instant, Chase could only lie on the rough, uneven ground, his bare skin soaking in an icy puddle, unable to move; the pain of being slammed by the ground left both his vision and his chest swallowed in blackness.

Feeling the pain meant he was still alive; he had to get up immediately, get ahead of the assassin—

The thought had barely formed when a figure suddenly dropped from above, landing squarely on top of Chase, knocking out the breath he had just managed to draw back in.

Not just from above him—all around, several more shadows plummeted from mid-air, each impact shuddering the ground in turn; in that moment, it was as if someone had sprayed a cloud of insecticide into the air, and flies were raining down one after another.

...What was going on?

Rattled and disoriented from the fall, Chase gritted his teeth, grabbed the dead-weight figure on top of him, and flung him aside onto the ground—it was a man with a soft, pale, weary face, vaguely familiar, seemingly someone he had glimpsed in the bar just now—he pushed through the pain, rolled over, and got to his feet, finding himself face-to-face with the door of Between the Backlights.

Han June happened to have just poked her snow-white face out from inside the door at that very moment.

In the instant their eyes met, even Han June seemed to freeze, unsure how to react.

"Huh? Why..."

She momentarily forgot even to attack Chase, her gaze shifting instead to sweep across the alley floor.

Which was fine—Chase had no time right now to take stock of his surroundings or get tangled up with her.

Taking advantage of her momentary distraction, he raised his foot and kicked; the door slammed hard into Han June's face. She jerked backward, and in the reverberating bang of the door shutting, Chase twisted his head and lunged toward the left side of the alley.

When he had been inside the door, the assassin had been on the right; now that he had switched directions, the assassin would be on his left—or so logic dictated.

Yet Chase skidded to a sharp halt, staring at an empty alley, momentarily stunned.

...Where was everyone?

From the moment he hit the ground to getting up and lunging over here, two or three seconds at most. The alley stretched nearly a hundred meters straight ahead with no forks, building walls on both sides...how could anyone have run clear to the end and vanished without a trace in two or three seconds?

Could they be hiding behind a trash bin—

"Chase, over here!"

By the time he registered that the voice was Sydney Ginn's, Chase's body had already obeyed ahead of his mind, turning to face behind him.

Perhaps because his upper body was bare and a cold November rain was drifting down from the sky above, his skin broke out in wave after wave of goosebumps.

Sydney Ginn was still alive.

She was scrambling to her feet in a flurry, her hair soaked by the rain and clinging in strands to her cheeks, otherwise looking no different from before.

"Why did you take your shirt off?"

True to form, Sydney Ginn had noticed the least important thing first.

Chase ignored her; letting his gaze sweep down the far end of the alley, he suddenly had some idea of why Han June had paused for a moment earlier.

...Hadh't an awful lot of people fallen out of the Black Cube?

Beside Sydney, the female server from Between the Backlights was groaning as she pushed herself upright; the woman who had been selling lipstick was sharp-eyed and alert, already grabbing the man who had been knocked down twice, the two of them hastily retreating to the wall to one side, as if bracing for gunfire.

It seemed that even when someone was inside the Black Cube, the person who had activated it could choose to do nothing at all—compared to Chase's sorry state, the few people caught up in it actually looked considerably better off.

The man seemed to mumble something like "you were right, we should have left earlier," though Chase didn't quite catch it.

When he shifted and stepped aside, limping, Chase saw them.

"Don't move."

A tall, lean man he had clearly never met yet found vaguely familiar was pointing the black mouth of a gun at him. Standing beside the man was the burly figure Chase had thrown into the Black Cube earlier, who had just steadied himself, his expression caught somewhere between furious humiliation and awkward embarrassment.

"...Brianna sent you?" Chase stared at the lean man and asked.

The lean man's expression didn't shift in the slightest.

"Yes," he said. "Don't make me shoot."

Chase almost wanted to laugh.

"If killing me were an option, you wouldn't have been forced to deactivate the Artifact just now. Who are you to Brianna? No—who are you to Wellesley?"

An Artifact of the Black Cube's caliber—very likely one of the "Nest Domination Game" targets at that—was now in the hands of this seemingly obscure man after Wellesley's death. That alone was enough to show that his ties to Wellesley had been deep, and his standing far from ordinary.

After a pause, the lean, fair-skinned man said, "...To me, Wellesley was nobody."

He shifted the gun to point at Sydney Ginn by the door; by the light of the motion-sensor lamp, he looked her over.

As if he had suddenly caught sight of something deeply disagreeable, the lean man's brow furrowed involuntarily.

He swallowed, his Adam's apple rolling visibly.

"You're right that I can't make a move on you. But her—she's from Key House, isn't she? I've heard that Chase Monroe has always placed great stock in the bonds between House Faction siblings. Is that true?"

It seemed that Sydney Ginn's warning shout earlier had given him the wrong impression.

"...She's not from Key House," Chase said quietly.

"She really isn't," Sydney Ginn also panicked a little, hastening to add, "He still has an unpaid bill he owes me."

Even with a gun pointed at her, her attention still worked like a net—whatever stirred in any corner of it, she would catch and turn her gaze toward.

Among everyone in the alley, Sydney Ginn was the first to notice the door handle turning—her eyes lit up, and she immediately pointed at the bar door: "If you're looking for a Key House person, there's one—just came out!"

There was no time to rush over and block the door now.

Han June pushed the door open again and poked only her head out into the alley, Noh mask pristine and intact; she glanced left and right—small mercy, she didn't attack the moment she stepped out.

"What's the situation now?" She looked around twice and said, "Who has the upper hand? Who's left that can take me to meet the Mayor?"

...What a shameless opportunist, not even bothering to hide it.

"My offer still stands," the lean man gave a quiet laugh and said, "Chase Monroe is standing right there—let's see what you can do."

"Oh?" Han June said, and turned her face toward Chase.

The situation had somehow gotten even worse than before the Black Cube trap had vanished.

Before, the lean man apparently hadn't realized Sydney Ginn was on Chase's side, which was why he had let her out alive; now it had come to this—Chase not only still faced the risk of Han June attacking him, but Sydney Ginn had become a liability as well.

And yet he had almost no cards left to play.

Other than stalling for time, Chase couldn't come up with anything else to do.

"Han June,"

To all outward appearances, no one could have guessed that Chase was bluffing—because he had issued threats in earnest so many times before, he was long practiced at it.

He lowered his voice and said quietly, "I promise you: if you let me die, he won't live long enough to take you to see the Mayor either."

"You have a point—if you died, Key House people would come after him for revenge..." Han June seemed to have been reminded of something. "After all, it's Chase-ge."

This patchwork way of thinking—part Resident, part Han June—was genuinely unnerving to Chase.

"The most capable people in Key House are all dead. Who's left to avenge him?" the lean man said with a quiet laugh.

As it happened, before he had even finished the sentence, Chase suddenly felt his phone begin to buzz in his trouser pocket—lucky enough, the phone hadn't been knocked out during the fall.

At a juncture like this, there was only one person he could think of who would be calling him.

Was Tianxi almost here?

"What's between us doesn't need to involve people who have nothing to do with it."

Chase dropped one hand, pressing it against his pocket as if by chance, muffling the buzzing of the phone through the fabric. He had to seize every excuse he could to buy time.

"Those few people have nothing to do with any of this—you might as well let them go first—"

As Chase said this, he glanced over and only now noticed that the lipstick-selling woman, the limping man, and the server trailing close behind them had, at some point, already linked up in a line and were quietly edging along the wall toward the exit—and at his words, all three froze in place, not daring to move, as if they'd been caught in the act.

"If you hadn't said that extra sentence, we might have already slipped away by now."

The lipstick-selling woman didn't say a word, but her face spelled it out plainly enough.

And they seemed to feel the lean man—who had let them out without laying a hand on them—was a safer presence than Chase, because even as they edged toward the exit, they chose to move behind the lean man.

The lean man swept them with a sidelong glance and hesitated briefly.

...Sure enough, he was on Wellesley's side.

Hunter House Factions, whatever their individual styles, didn't often resort to bloody, life-or-death confrontations; Wellesley's side had never even managed to build a proper Hunter team, and barring rare exceptions, their way of doing things likely leaned toward solving problems with money—for the lean man to personally kill innocent people to silence them would take a real psychological effort.

Moreover, killing someone here could hand Chase a future hold over him.

Blackmoor City, after all, was not the Nest.

"If you don't want trouble—" the lean man opened his mouth, as expected.

From far away, Chase heard the sound of a car engine at the far end of the alley behind him—and then it cut off abruptly.

In the message he had sent Tianxi, he had directed him to bring people in from exactly this direction.

The squeal of tires stopping, the sound of car doors opening, accompanied by that pocket of silence where no one spoke—Chase felt as though he could sense the drizzle hanging in the dim world being disturbed by several heavy footsteps, broken apart, specks of it settling into puddles and being pressed down under leather boots.

"Sydney Ginn,"

Chase raised his head and called her name in an ordinary tone.

In the faint light of the motion-sensor lamp, she turned her head at the sound; shadow seeped deep into the blue-tinged exhaustion beneath her eyes, her skin washed pale by the rain.

"What?"

"Get down."

The gunshot from the far end of the alley rang out and echoed through the narrow space at almost the exact moment Sydney Ginn hit the ground; a stray bullet struck the motion-sensor lamp—crack—and the world went dark.

Today's laugh was brought to me by the Mayor of New York City — yes, the very one June is going to meet (not really lol).

He told reporters: "We already know the shooter's name, but we're not saying it, because we don't want to put the shooter on alert."

One: is there any chance the shooter already knows the police are after him? Two: is there any chance the shooter already knows his own name?

Honestly, pair him with a straight man and he could go perform stand-up comedy.

Chapter 207 — Chase and a Thoroughly Anticlimactic Gunfight

In the midst of a hail of gunfire, perhaps only Chase could find himself breathing a sigh of relief.

He had spent an entire night holding his breath with his hands tied—now it was finally his turn.

Chase crouched behind a trash bin, listening as Brianna's two men behind him fired shot after shot in his direction. Bullets split the air in sudden bursts of light, weaving a dense tapestry of brass-gold fire through the long, dark night of the narrow alley.

Some guns had suppressors, some didn't—the shots rang out in alternating bursts of sharp and muffled sound, a roar laced with hoarse cries, making it impossible to hear anyone else moving in the alley.

At the far end of the alley, several familiar figures had just tumbled out of a vehicle and were returning fire from behind a wall as cover; Chase let out a long whistle and called out, "Get me a weapon!"

"Chase-ge," someone responded.

Under covering fire, the person spun out from behind the corner, hunched low and hugging the wall, closing the distance to Chase in the gaps between shots. A long braided plait swayed from his shoulder in the darkness—it was Tianxi.

Chase raised a hand and caught the gun Tianxi tossed to him; the solid weight of it drew something close to a faint trembling sigh from the muscles in his arms.

The moment the gun was in his hand, he twisted at the waist, rose, and aimed—then a single shot rang out, and a dark figure dropped in the alley behind him. The body was large and heavy; it hit the ground with enough force to make the curtain of rain seem to shudder.

"Pete!"

The lanky man called out, but didn't dare rise from cover to check on his partner.

Not that it would have made any difference either way.

Seizing the moment, Chase narrowed his eyes and swept a quick look around.

Visibility in the alley was poor.

The buildings on both sides were dark; only at the far end, beyond the mouth of the alley, did the traffic lights and street lamps of Blackmoor City float in blurry reds and yellows—their colors soft and muddy, pooling in the puddles on the alley floor as if blood and fat had seeped in from the street.

...Chase sometimes had genuinely complicated feelings about his own luck.

If it had been London Moon who came tonight, he would have had no chance of diving behind the trash bin when the shooting started.

For someone unfamiliar with firearms, it might be hard to imagine that shooting a person in a controlled way—wounding them without killing them—is actually far harder and demands far more skill. And besides, Chase would sooner die with the Artifact than open his mouth and hand it over to the lanky man.

The lanky man clearly understood the situation too, which was why he hadn't rashly shot at Chase and had instead turned his gun on Sydney Ginn—in that sense, Chase's luck seemed decent enough.

But it was precisely because the lanky man had fixed his sights on Sydney Ginn that Chase had survived the initial burst of gunfire at all.

Where the lanky man had been standing was the middle of a straight alley with not even a trash bin nearby—by all rights, the odds of surviving the first volley were slim.

Yet because he had been watching Sydney Ginn the whole time and was indirectly warned, he had not only survived but managed to find cover in time—none other than the open bar door.

And how did Chase know all this?

Because at this moment, from behind the bar door, came June's characteristically lukewarm voice: "...Stop crowding me. Chase-ge isn't easy to kill."

That the man dared to squeeze in beside June—his nerve was, at least, admirable.

It wasn't only that her manner alone was enough to make anyone keep their distance; June's allegiances shifted from one moment to the next, and with her in the mix, Chase couldn't afford to act rashly.

He looked again: Sydney Ginn was on this side of the alley, while those three were on the other side, all flat on the ground, each of them sucking in their stomachs and stretching their bodies out thin and long, pressed tight against the floor and wall—at a glance, they looked for all the world like four figures in a graffiti mural.

...True Hunters, through and through—their bodies were as flexible as their minds and principles.

Chase flicked a hand behind him, and the gunfire at his back stopped at once.

"Give me the Artifact. Take me to Brianna."

He rested the barrel on the lid of the trash bin, with his field of fire covering the bar door, and said: "That's the price of your life tonight."

From behind the door, the lanky man seemed to give a quiet, contemptuous little laugh. "...What a shame. I can't do either."

"Do you really think you have any other options?"

Behind him, Tianxi heard that and let out a sudden "Hm?" through his nose, but held himself back from saying anything.

Chase continued: "There's only one door to this bar. The moment you stick your head out from behind it, I'll shoot. Don't tell me you're pinning all your hopes on June? Do you really think she'd still help you at this point?"

Tianxi, usually so steady, seemed to sense the risk of June switching sides—he shifted about as if ants were crawling over him, mouth opening and then closing again.

The lanky man did indeed appear to have placed his bets on June.

He lowered his voice and murmured urgently to her from behind the door; Chase couldn't make out the words, but he could imagine well enough.

Something along the lines of promising to bring her to see the Mayor if she subdued Chase for him, no doubt.

The duo trying to sell the lipstick, and the bar waitress, all seized the moment and quietly got to their feet, pressing against the wall and filing out one by one like crabs—Chase swept them a glance and pretended he hadn't noticed, turning his attention back to the bar door.

All Hunters; they knew the rules. Whatever had nothing to do with them, they didn't see even when they saw it, and when they left, they left.

"Chase-ge," Tianxi seemed unable to hold back any longer, "do we have people inside the bar too?"

...That question came out of nowhere.

"No," Chase gave him a look.

If they had, why would he have gone to the trouble of calling Tianxi here at all?

Tianxi looked even more restless. "Then why did you say he has no other way out?"

Chase paused—the answer seemed so obvious that he couldn't quite understand, for a moment, why Tianxi couldn't work it out and had to come ask him.

He was just about to open his mouth when, at precisely that moment, June's voice came clearly from behind the door: "...All right."

So June had been talked around by the lanky man after all?

Chase's heart seized; he instantly forgot about answering Tianxi, and every shred of his attention snapped back into place, his gun trained unwaveringly on the bar door.

But several seconds passed, and June never appeared from behind the door—instead it was Sydney Ginn, having calmed down as the situation steadied, who seized the moment and walked quickly toward the trash bin, asking as she came: "Chase, did you have people arranged inside the bar too?"

Why was everyone asking him the same question?

Chase suppressed his irritation and ignored her—he had the nagging sense that things had gone a little too quiet behind that door.

"If there's no one arranged inside the bar, he could just leave through the front entrance, couldn't he?"

Tianxi's tone was almost as if he suspected Chase had suddenly come down with dementia and was treading carefully on his behalf. He had already taken out his phone and said, "Should I have someone go block the front entrance right now?"

...Front entrance?

Chase squeezed his eyes shut, his head buzzing with a brief spell of dizziness.

What front entrance did Between the Backlights have?

Wait—hadn't he had a very similar conversation with June once before?

"Chase-ge, I'm coming out."

From behind the open bar door, June's snow-white Noh mask face finally appeared. Tianxi still hadn't gotten used to the sight of it; he was startled enough that his whole body jerked involuntarily backward.

"You've been stalling long enough, haven't you?" June said, as though nothing had happened at all. "When exactly are you going to take me to see the Mayor?"

In a sense, she was refreshingly straightforward—the moment Brianna's man was dead and June saw there was no hope left in that direction, she immediately placed her bet back on Chase.

June walked into the alley and closed the door behind her without a care in the world.

In the dark, rainy night, the alley fell into a strange, brief silence: Chase stared at June, while Tianxi and Sydney Ginn both stared at Chase.

"What are you standing there for—that man's going to run," Sydney Ginn pointed at the bar door and finally couldn't hold herself back: "Aren't you going after him?"

"I've already sent someone to block him off—" Tianxi spoke up at exactly the same moment.

Chase looked at Sydney Ginn, then at Tianxi, and even as puzzlement rose in him, he became dimly aware of a cold, creeping sense that something was wrong.

"Who ran? ...Chasing who?"

The man Brianna had sent was already lying on the ground not far away, shot by him.

Who was there left to chase?

Tianxi and Sydney Ginn both seemed to go blank—for a moment, neither of them could squeeze out a single word.

Only June suddenly lowered her head and burst out laughing.

I'm keeping this chapter short because I'm exhausted. (I know—I've said this on loop more times than I can count.)

A while back I opened the author's dashboard and happened to catch a comment flash past before I could note the username—all I remember is that soul-cutting question:

"Why has four yuan kept me going for a whole month?"

...I feel so guilty.

Chapter 208 – Chase Pursues the Blank

A fine, cold drizzle filled the air between heaven and earth, chilling his skin to a pale blue-white; as if the blood had slowed in his veins, and that flash of lucid understanding had not yet managed to reach his mind.

But after waiting a few seconds, Chase still couldn't recall anything.

"You... you weren't hit with something, were you?" Sydney Ginn hesitated before speaking. "Getting hit with something would be the better option — what if it's a stroke..."

Tianxi shot her a glance, but seemed to be infected by her worry all the same, turning to call out to Chase: "Chase-ge..."

"Hold on."

Chase wiped the rain from his face and swept his wet hair back behind his head. He stared steadily at the corpse lying on the ground in the distance and said, "Let me think."

"But..."

Chase paid no attention, only sweeping a glance at the back door of the bar, then looking over at June — the snow-white Noh mask's smile bulged high across its face, casting an almost-solid shadow within its mouthful of teeth.

...Whatever strange thing had come over him, this peculiar creature had almost certainly been watching the whole time, fully aware of what was happening.

It was too late to act now; if there had been another person behind the door just moments ago, they would have had more than enough time to reach the other end of the bar by now.

The most important thing was to first sort out his own understanding of what had happened.

Based on Tianxi and Sydney Ginn's reactions, Chase realized that his perception was likely missing two things: one, that the bar Between the Backlights had a front entrance; and two, that besides the corpse on the ground, there had been another one of Brianna's subordinates here just a moment ago.

Tianxi was a House Faction member and would not lie to him — besides, Tianxi and Sydney Ginn could not possibly have coordinated in advance to fabricate the same story.

The conclusion was inescapable: the other party possessed some means of selectively carving out a piece of his awareness.

Forgetting the front entrance meant that when he'd run into the Black Cube trap, Chase would have had no other way out; forgetting that subordinate meant he wouldn't pursue anyone — and couldn't get his hands on the Black Cube Artifact.

The person who didn't exist in his memory had walked out through a door that didn't exist in his memory, unhurried and untroubled, leaving Chase standing in the alley like a fool, believing the situation was entirely under his control.

He clenched his jaw; the muscles in his cheek tightened, then relaxed.

No — however you looked at it, that person's departure could not have been "unhurried and untroubled."

Perhaps due to the limitations of their ability, that person could only make Chase alone lose awareness of them. Which meant the window for that person to leave was extremely narrow — they would have had to get out before Tianxi and Sydney Ginn could raise any objections...

That person had seemed to be standing behind the door alongside June just moments ago.

"You covered for them while they left,"

Chase's gaze settled on June, and he said quietly, "I only lost awareness of that person — but I haven't forgotten you. Every single moment you spoke or acted just now also happened to be precisely when Tianxi was about to alert me that something was wrong."

Whenever June made a move, Chase would immediately direct his full attention toward her; and even if Tianxi ultimately managed to finish what she was saying, she would certainly have been delayed and interrupted by June's actions once or twice — all it took was buying an extra half a minute, and for that person, the difference between a successful escape and none at all was everything.

And even setting that aside — even if Chase hadn't hesitated or been confused for even a moment and had immediately charged after that person into the bar, she probably wouldn't have politely stepped aside from the doorway, would she?

June raised both hands, holding them up in the air on either side of her.

Then, both hands came together with a sharp "clap" and slowly parted again.

She seemed to be trying to applaud.

"You guessed right," June's smile remained perfectly still. "Anything else, Chase-ge?"

"You didn't make a move against me — you only covered for them while they left." Chase said coldly. "So you must be hedging your bets. You saw that the situation had shifted, decided to spare my life, and are waiting to see whether I can take you to meet the Mayor. If I can't satisfy you, you still have a backup option."

June slowly nodded.

"Then you must know their name, so you can find them afterward. If not a name, then some kind of guarantee." Chase suppressed the urge to act, and said quietly, "What is it? Tell me."

It was a shame — facing June, he had no leverage and no power to intimidate.

"No way," June said matter-of-factly. "You've already figured out I'm hedging my bets — do you really think I'd let one side go kill the other?"

"She's not June anymore," Tianxi couldn't hold back a moment before Chase, and raised her gun in a flash. "Chase-ge, better a short sharp pain than a long dull one."

Chase was silent for a few seconds, then shook his head.

June spoke as though she'd just won the first battle: "Now that's more like it — as long as you take me to—"

"Shut up."

Chase didn't spare her a single glance, grabbing June and shoving her away; as she stumbled back several steps, Chase had already turned and walked toward the corpse in the alley.

The large man who had, not long before, tried to throw Chase into the Black Cube trap had also been done in by his own bulk. At the time, he had barely dodged the first round of bullets and was looking for an opening to duck into the bar's back door as well — only to catch Chase's bullet square in the chest. The blood had spread into a pitch-black lake, trembling and on the verge of shattering under the rain.

"By the time the others looped around to the front entrance, that guy should have been long gone."

Chase said this while pulling open the large man's jacket, pressing and searching the inner pockets. Even though he understood rationally that he'd been tricked — that the bar did have a

front entrance — saying it out loud still gave him an unavoidable pang of discomfort. "Have them come clear the scene right away. Don't leave any evidence."

The gunshots just now had almost certainly prompted someone nearby to call the police; the time left to them was at most a few minutes. The one stroke of luck was that both sides of the alley were exterior building walls, and the floors above were not residential — there was no corner or opportunity for anyone to photograph or record video.

But they still had to move fast. If the police really managed to pin them down again...

"Yes," Tianxi answered and immediately pulled out her phone. "I'll call them right now."

The large man didn't have much on him — just the three things most people carry when they go out: a wallet, keys, and a phone.

The keychain was a leather fob from an auto brand, holding a single car key; Chase opened the wallet and found, as expected, the large man's driver's license.

"The two of them must have come in the same car. The one who's dead was the driver — the keys are still here." Chase tossed both items to Tianxi and said, "The one who ran can't drive the car, so he'll have to find another way out."

"So what?" Somehow, June had drifted closer again.

She was barely human at this point — being shoved didn't make her angry in the slightest. She craned her neck and said, "He can take a taxi, call a rideshare, or take the subway. Blackmoor City is huge — where are you even going to start looking for him?"

Chase paid her no mind, picked up the large man's phone, and looked up to call out: "Sydney Ginn."

Looking up, he paused for a moment. Never mind that Sydney Ginn was standing quite far away — she also appeared to be getting farther by the second, slowly inching backward.

"Where exactly are you trying to go?"

"Don't let me hold you up," Sydney Ginn waved her hand. "That, um — maybe I should just head home. I can see your strength is back, judging by how hard you shoved her just now, and the Key House people are here too, so you don't need my help anymore. The whole dead body situation doesn't really have anything to do with me — the police station is the kind of place where once you go..."

Tianxi immediately latched onto the key detail and asked, "Back? Was Chase-ge injured? And, if I may ask, you are..."

"It doesn't matter who I am," Sydney Ginn glanced at the corpse and said, "Right now it matters even less. Your Chase-ge was just — hey, can I say that?"

"Don't get into a conversation with her too easily," Chase only said this to Tianxi. "She can keep you going off-topic indefinitely."

"Ha, Chase-ge used to give me the exact same warning," June said, delighted, clapping her palms together once more.

No one paid her any attention.

"Tianxi," Chase said only the one word, and Tianxi understood immediately, circling around to the side of the corpse and hauling up the upper half of the body.

"Sydney Ginn," Chase added, "help me hold his eyelids open."

"So that's what you're doing." Sydney Ginn came over reluctantly, carefully skirting the pool of blood, then extended two index fingers and pried open the corpse's upper eyelids.

Chase did not immediately attempt to unlock the phone.

He kept his fingers off the screen, gripping only the sides, and held the camera as steady as he could to align it with the dead man's pupils.

Unlocking the phone required more than just detecting a face — it also needed to detect a pair of open eyes looking directly at the lens. Once aligned, it would unlock automatically; but if the screen was touched before proper alignment, causing the face unlock to fail, it could trigger a passcode requirement instead.

A small padlock icon appeared at the top of the phone.

Under the gaze of three pairs of living eyes and one pair of dead ones, the padlock turned and came undone.

"Chase-ge, your luck really isn't bad," Tianxi laughed, looked toward the mouth of the alley, and said, "Oh — they're here too."

Going from here around to the front entrance that had never been sealed, and then back again — it was quite a loop, so the few Key House Hunters under Tianxi's command had arrived reasonably fast all things considered.

"Just in time," Chase glanced back, beckoned to the Key House members, and asked Tianxi, "Where's your car? Have them handle the scene — we're getting in the car now."

"We" included himself, Tianxi, Sydney Ginn, and a June who couldn't stop murmuring about the Mayor — four people in total.

Sydney Ginn had no choice but to share the back seat with June, so she pressed herself tightly against one side of the car, sitting on only half the seat with her body angled forward, doing her best to stay as far from June as possible; her flushed, warm head rested against the back of the front passenger seat, and she asked, "What's the next step?"

Chase was about to answer when he was suddenly cut off by a sneeze — even Chase, after being soaked in cold rain barely above ten degrees for so long, had his bones clenched from the cold; the moment he got into the warm car, his body couldn't handle the temperature change.

"Bless you," came a voice — incredibly, from June.

Habit truly is a powerful force.

"Chase-ge, wear my jacket," Tianxi immediately shrugged off her outer layer from the driver's seat and passed it back.

Sydney Ginn made a sound that seemed to express something like regret.

...What did that mean?

Chase turned his head toward her, but her tone hadn't changed at all: "What's the next step?"

Come to think of it, tracking a target he had consistently believed didn't exist and couldn't bring to mind — this was a first in Chase's life.

From nothing but a blank void, there was naturally no way to catch up to a quarry... but the person who didn't exist in his mind did exist in other people's lives, and knowing that one thing was enough.

The other party could only make Chase forget him — they couldn't erase the traces he'd left in the world.

"...The best time to hunt is when the prey believes it has already escaped."

Chase smiled slowly, leaned back against his seat, and opened the call history on the large man's phone.

Among the most recent calls, he saw "Secretary Green."

I think I qualify as a genuine victim at this point — the streaming platform I subscribed to only releases one episode of *Jackal* per week!! Three episodes total so far!! What is this, are they holding me hostage and demanding a ransom?! Give me my little freckled one back already
ahhhhhh

That said, the show really is well-written — the dialogue is fantastic. There's this one line: "Someone has misunderstood their obligations to me" — and you can just feel the presence of a mature, complex, restrained villain coming through. Ah, I wish I could write character lines that good someday...

Chapter 209: Zebra-POV Escape and Hiding Place

"...Yes, it's in the alley behind 310 Juan Road. That's right, I heard several gunshots—it sounds like someone's been killed. Please send officers immediately."

"Sir, may I have your name—"

Brianna hung up.

After leaving Between the Backlights, she had sprinted the whole way, heart pounding, breath ragged—she'd been holding back her breathing just now so the dispatcher wouldn't get suspicious, and only after hanging up did she finally gulp down a few gasping breaths.

In the space of those few breaths, 911 called right back, just as she'd expected.

Brianna didn't even glance at it—she declined the call, then stopped in her tracks outside a glass sliding door washed white with light.

She had never noticed before that the lighting inside a Wendy's could be this bright, bright enough to make you feel there was nowhere to hide.

Through the glass door, Brianna peered inside.

The fast-food restaurant, still open at two or three in the morning, was nearly empty—only a homeless man slumped asleep over a table in the corner, and there wasn't even a staff member visible behind the order counter; the night-shift employee had probably sneaked off to rest while no one was around.

She glanced back. On the dark road behind her, there seemed to be no pursuers for the moment.

Chase had forgotten her, but the people around him hadn't.

The image of a chestnut-haired girl surfaced in her mind, and Brianna forcibly pushed it back down.

That thing called June—a Resident, probably?—was always shifting loyalties, ready to cooperate with whoever offered the better deal; Brianna had originally worried that the moment she turned her back, it would sell her out without a second thought.

If June betrayed her immediately, things would get tricky; but as it stood now, that Resident-like thing had truly bought her some time by holding Chase back.

Which meant Chase and his group were still near the crime scene—if not now, when?

She didn't know whether the police would get there in time, but she needed Chase's pursuit to be obstructed as much as possible.

Even so, June could only stall Chase for so long; he'd most likely already figured out he'd been played.

Which meant that from this moment on, Brianna needed to start thinking carefully.

The car keys were still on Pete's body—she couldn't drive away, and waiting for a car on the roadside was out of the question; the Key House people might already have spread a search net, and to slip out of this area cleanly, she would need a route the searchers wouldn't think of.

...Like a fast-food restaurant.

Brianna quietly pushed the door open just a crack, moving as silently as she could, then turned sideways and slipped inside.

She walked up to the order counter and stood there for a moment—still no employee came out to greet her, which meant she couldn't be seen from wherever the night-shift worker had gone to slack off.

Good.

Brianna planted both hands on the counter, hoisted herself up onto it, twisted around, and slid down the other side into the kitchen.

The greasy, salted scent of frying fries and the charred smell of beef patties clung thickly to the air.

It was the first time in her life she had stepped into the working area of a fast-food restaurant, and she had no idea which way led to the back door; she looked around and tried pushing open a door that she guessed might be it—but she guessed wrong, and startled a middle-aged woman who had been dozing, sending her leaping to her feet with a jolt.

"Don't be scared,"

Brianna quickly flashed her a smile and said, "I'm not dangerous—oh, actually, congratulations. You're very lucky."

"...What?"

She realized she still had her phone in her hand and immediately held it up, pointing at it. "I'm a video blogger doing a live stream. I have a show where I randomly pick someone on the street and ask them about their wishes, then give them some money."

Across that tired, puffy brown face, a glow of mingled suspicion and delight appeared.

In this day and age, all you had to do was say you were a blogger doing a recording or a live stream, and even if you stripped off someone's skin in the middle of the street, bystanders would find it perfectly reasonable.

"But... at this hour?" the employee asked.

"My followers picked the time," Brianna said with a smile. "Do you have Venmo?"

Sure enough, the woman's attention shifted instantly from the suspicious circumstances to the question of whether she was really about to get money.

What had always puzzled Brianna was that the same number, the same sum of money, seemed to carry a completely different weight for other people than it did for her.

It was only a thousand dollars, yet the employee kept looking at her phone over and over, closing the app and opening it again, as though she suspected the thousand dollars was just a fleeting trick.

"Really? For me?" She covered her mouth and said, "My daughter's due soon... there's so much to spend money on."

A thousand dollars—what good would that do?

"I'm glad you're happy—my followers will be too. But I hope you'll keep this to yourself and not tell anyone I was here. You know how it is; some followers can get pretty intense, and people will track me down by following the live stream."

Compared to excuses like a three-in-the-morning live stream or crazed fans, ordinary people seemed to find it far more unbelievable that someone would hand over money for absolutely no reason—so any excuse that came packaged with money, however absurd, carried its own persuasiveness.

When the employee nodded emphatically, Brianna asked, "Where's the back door?"

"I'll take you," the employee said right away.

But after pushing the door open and looking out at the road, Brianna was in no hurry to leave.

She hadn't gone to all this trouble just to find another way out.

The area near the fast-food restaurant's back door was about what she had estimated—a short stretch of road with shuttered storefronts, open at both ends to the main roads, with nowhere to hide.

If someone was out looking for her, one pass down this road, seeing it was empty, and they probably wouldn't come back.

So she couldn't go out.

"I'll call a car," Brianna said with a smile. "It's raining out. I'll wait here for a bit."

"No problem," the employee said cheerfully. "Are you hungry? Want me to make you a combo?"

Brianna nodded, and once the woman had left, she immediately opened her phone and looked up the contact information for Wellesley's former bodyguard team.

After Wellesley died, his widow had thrown a tremendous fit at the bodyguard team.

She had said that not only were they derelict in their duties, but the bodyguard named Ivan who had gone missing must have done something dishonorable to disappear like that—and as she said it, she broke into sobs she could barely control.

How much of it was sincere, and how much was performance, Brianna didn't know.

The security company naturally found that characterization hard to accept, and the situation had been tense for a while; as his secretary, she'd had no choice but to mediate and smooth things over, doing a great deal of unnecessary work—but her understanding and defense of the bodyguard team had always been wholehearted.

They truly hadn't done a single thing wrong.

Dad—Wellesley's death could not be laid at the bodyguard team's feet, no matter who you blamed.

Perhaps because of that one measure of goodwill, the team captain who went by "Sister Mi" agreed to Brianna's request with little hesitation.

Even faced with this sudden call at three in the morning, she simply said crisply, "Understood. I'll send Dylan to pick you up right away."

"Have him wait outside for me. This number is about to become unreachable." Brianna said.

The captain replied with only two words: "Got it."

After hanging up, Brianna peeled off her phone case, shook out a SIM ejector pin she kept stored inside, removed the SIM card, bent it until it snapped, and tossed it into the nearby trash can.

Chase would not leave Pete's phone untouched; and Pete's last call before he died should have been the one to herself.

No one truly lives on the assumption that they might die at any moment, so Pete certainly hadn't cleared his call history; she could assume her phone number was now in Chase's hands.

Hunter House Factions rarely had reason to track and locate someone by phone number, and it was likely not something the Key House could pull off just like that. Still, to be safe, Brianna could not keep carrying the SIM card—she powered the phone off as well.

Was there anything else on Pete's phone that Chase might discover?

Brianna thought back.

After the car arrived, she had gone downstairs, opened the door, and gotten in. Pete greeted her, started the car, and raised his hand to tap at his phone...

Ah. The map.

Pete had apparently been unfamiliar with Between the Backlights, so he'd used navigation—and of all things, it had seemed to be Google Maps, which recorded route history.

Her pickup location tonight had most likely been logged, and Chase might already have seen it.

The suite on the top floor of the Wellesley Group headquarters set aside for her—she couldn't go back there anymore.

"He won't go back," Chase said, leaning into his seat and looking at the Google Maps on the big man's phone, his voice low. "That location is blown. Anyone with half a brain would know we

could have an ambush waiting there."

"So do we wait for another chance later?" Tianxi asked. "Now that we know his name and identity, he can't run forever."

"No. He's carrying an Artifact I want, on him right now."

Chase thought as he spoke: "He's busy running—he probably hasn't had a chance to stash it yet. Before he has a chance to regroup... we move on him tonight."

She still had the Black Cube on her... with that dangling over things, Chase would never simply let it go.

If she just found somewhere ordinary to lay low—a hotel, say—it would be nearly impossible for Chase to fish her out of the vast expanse of Blackmoor City.

Not just hotels, either—restaurants, theaters, the subway, internet cafés... Blackmoor City had countless places open through the night; as long as she wasn't caught on the road, the places where she could hide for one night were essentially limitless.

"Have them pull up all properties connected to Wellesley, but only within this area."

Chase zoomed out on the map and pointed to the upper portion of Blackmoor City. "The lower half of the map—don't worry about that for now."

Sydney couldn't help her curiosity and voiced the question. "Why can we ignore that part of the city?"

"The Key House and Between the Backlights are both on this side, and we set out from this direction too."

Blackmoor City was divided into the main city and Central Bay Island; where they currently were happened to be in a pouch-shaped area at the bottom of the main city.

Both by instinct and logic, prey would choose to move away from where pursuers were likely to appear, as far as possible—so Green would most probably head toward the city district outside the "pouch," and going to Central Bay Island wasn't out of the question either.

"But why would he have to go to a Wellesley property?" Sydney said again. "If it were me, I'd just book a room at any hotel—you could search all morning and never find me."

Chase only said, "Mm."

"Where to?" Dylan turned his head and asked.

Brianna hesitated for just a moment.

"...Central Bay Island," she answered. "The Wellesley Group has a building there."

Why is it called the Zebra POV, you ask? Because later on the switching back and forth gets very fast, like zebra stripes—one black stripe right after another white one... well, I think the metaphor works.

Why is the illustration such a dark photo (it doesn't look dark to the eye, no idea why the photo came out like this)? Because my Photoshop subscription expired... I can't draw on the computer anymore, so I had to draw by hand—as long as you get the general idea, it's fine.

My handwriting is so ugly!

Lucky not many people are reading this, or I'd really be embarrassed!

Chapter 210: Chase Follows the Trail

A black car cutting through Blackmoor City beneath the black night seemed itself to become a drop of black rain, slipping from the hazy edges of floating lamplight, past the corners of eyes belonging to the drunk, the wandering, the post-banquet stragglers, and into the web of roads that made up the night.

No one spared it a second glance; nor could anyone have imagined it was a predator, exchanging countless signals and information in all directions.

"No good, still can't get through... it's been ten minutes already."

After a brief double-beep, Tianxi glanced at her phone screen, ended the third call, and said, "Has that person already disposed of his SIM card?"

Not long after leaving Between the Backlights, Chase had told Tianxi to use his phone to call the man named George Green, but not a single attempt had gone through.

"Wait a few minutes, then try again."

Chase had several phones resting on his thighs—his own, the dead bruiser's, and Han Ford's, which he'd temporarily commandeered; June was in no state to use a phone anyway, so it was just as well to use hers to pull up the map.

"I need to determine whether he's disposed of his SIM card or just temporarily switched off. Our course of action has to be adjusted depending on which it is."

"Understood," Tianxi replied.

Sydney Ginn glanced back and forth between the two front seats and said, "Do you Key House people have some kind of telepathy? When did you work out an action plan? Why does nobody tell me anything? Fill me in, would you?"

Chase wasn't about to take the bait.

Time was short and the situation pressing—he couldn't afford to get drawn into conversation with Sydney Ginn.

"Just sit tight and you'll see,"

he said with a brief reply, then directed his question to his own phone on his knee: "Molly, any results?"

"Got them," a woman's voice answered from the phone, accompanied by a few clicks of a mouse. "Wellesley-related results in Blackmoor City total twenty-seven."

"Remove anything held through joint ventures, controlling stakes, or subsidiary names, remove construction land and publicly operating premises, and keep only properties owned by the Wellesley parent company itself that are currently in use."

As a private secretary, Green likely couldn't commandeer Wellesley Group assets on a whim without going through corporate channels; only properties Wellesley used directly would fall within Green's reach.

Molly answered quickly: "That leaves only three."

"Send me everything you can find on them."

She wasn't technically dedicated to back-end support—most House Factions didn't need someone in that role—but Molly had always been efficient and sharp. Chase felt as though his words had barely left his mouth when the phone dinged once, alerting him to a new email.

"And what about George Green himself?" he asked, opening the email and scrolling through it quickly.

"There's almost no information on this person in Hunter circles."

Molly sounded a little troubled as she said: "Based on my investigation, he has never gone Artifact hunting, never joined a House Faction, and has never sold a single Artifact.

"His background is unremarkable—he grew up in the Midwest, graduated from a state university, and found work as a construction cost estimator in Blackmoor City. Then, two years ago, out of nowhere, he became Wellesley's secretary."

...That was strange.

An ordinary person with no apparent connection to Wellesley had suddenly leaped to become one of his closest confidants; and somehow an Artifact of the Black Cube's caliber had ended up in his hands.

"And Brianna?"

"She's the only daughter of Wellesley's first wife. After the first wife passed away and he remarried and had children with his current wife, her relationship with Wellesley seems to have grown increasingly strained. She moved out of the Wellesley estate shortly after coming of age and has lived alone ever since, apparently off a trust fund. Around five or six years ago, there were rumors that Wellesley had removed her from his will, but this was never officially confirmed."

Chase couldn't figure out the connection between the two of them. Were they a couple? Was that why Brianna had felt comfortable handing the Black Cube over to him?

"Impossible,"

He had barely voiced his uncertainty before Sydney Ginn spoke up: "Have you forgotten what he looks like? I still remember. If he's straight, I'll give you my head."

...No need for something so useless.

Since there was no answer, Chase set the question aside for now. Even if Brianna had borne Wellesley's child with Green, he didn't care in the slightest—nor did he need to.

He only needed to get the Black Cube, and kill Green and Brianna.

No one responded, yet Sydney Ginn still had to mutter to herself: "Why is there not a single person in this car who can hold a conversation?"

Chase read through the email carefully and found that of the three buildings under the Wellesley name, two were in the main city district and one was on Central Bay Island. All three used the same upscale property management and security company—worth noting was that the latter only handled building security as part of its standard commercial services, and did not provide personal protection for clients.

...In other words, if Green had gone to a Wellesley property, it wasn't because it was safer for him there.

Chase was sixty or seventy percent confident that Green's destination was one of those three buildings; but he still needed a final confirmation of exactly which one.

The fourth call to Green's phone went unanswered as well.

"Good. That means no one else can reach him either."

Chase had already formed a plan. He checked the time. Seventeen minutes had passed since Green left Between the Backlights.

"Just the right moment to make a call."

"Make a call?" Tianxi was puzzled too. "To who?"

To whoever would know where Green had gone, of course.

Chase picked up the dead man Pete's phone and dialed the property management company's after-hours number; it was three in the morning, and yet the call was picked up after only two rings.

"Hello? Hi, this is Pete, Secretary Green's driver from the Group's headquarters." Chase said.

He paused, and heard the man on the other end respond quite naturally: "Oh, right, hello—is there anything else I can help you with?"

It was as if he'd walked into the middle of a conversation already in progress...and one that wasn't his.

"The thing is, Secretary Green's phone can't be reached," Chase ventured, setting down a fragment of information.

The other party picked it up without a trace of suspicion. "Right, he mentioned that just now. The number he called from isn't in the system—if it weren't for the employee code, we wouldn't even have been able to verify his identity."

"Right, his phone's acting up. What a headache."

Chase said something casually vague and entirely uninformative. "I received instructions earlier to pick him up, but I didn't catch the address clearly—I just remember being told to contact your side if I had any questions."

"Our side?"

The property company didn't often handle headquarters staff itineraries, and the person on the phone was understandably surprised.

"Right, because he said he'd be in touch with you, so..." Chase slowed his cadence.

"Well, yes, he did contact us—I've already set up access clearance for him," the person on the line said.

Before he could continue, Chase cut in: "Wonderful. Could you give me the address? I'll go wait for him at the main entrance."

To Green and Chase, this was perhaps life-or-death information; but for the property company employee, it was just an ordinary part of the job—the secretary of the already-deceased Wellesley didn't even rank as a position that warranted heightened security attention within the Wellesley Group's hierarchy.

"Sure, the address is on Central Bay Island..."

Shortly after, Chase hung up.

The car fell quiet for a few seconds. The first to react was Tianxi—he wrenched the steering wheel hard, swinging into a right turn at an intersection where right turns were forbidden, sending the two passengers in the back seat lurching sideways.

Now that the destination was clear, naturally the only thing left to do was take the fastest route possible.

"What weapons do we have in the car?" Chase asked.

"One MP5, one .45 caliber."

"Right, the MP5 should come in handy."

Tianxi glanced back and said to Sydney Ginn: "There's a weapons bag under your feet—grab it."

"What? I've been sitting on top of a submachine gun this whole time? Whose fault would it be if it went off?"

That said, Sydney Ginn wasn't the least bit afraid—it was clear the protest was just for the sake of having something to say. She had already unzipped the bag, and of her own accord pulled out the submachine gun and passed it to Chase along with the bag.

"Let me have a little thrill," she felt the need to explain, though no one had asked: "I've never touched a submachine gun before."

Only Tianxi offered a polite "Mm" in response.

Chase looked up at the rearview mirror.

From his angle, all he could see was June's pale, round chin, stiff as a board.

Once was enough to be betrayed mid-operation by this ghoulish thing.

"June," he said in a low voice.

June's chin didn't move. No reaction at all, as if she hadn't heard.

"Shortly, I'm going to call the Mayor's secretary to warn him that someone may have intentions against the Mayor."

That sentence immediately drew a reaction from June—"Huh? That's not what we agreed on, is it? Why would you do something that hurts both sides? Tipping him off in advance just makes it harder to get to him, doesn't it?"

"...The Mayor is an important client of ours. I can't let this information go unaddressed. Allow me to look further into it, and I will report to you in person when I have more to share. In the meantime, please try to ensure that no unnecessary or unplanned individuals come into contact with the Mayor."

Chase paused. "That's what I'll say to him."

Halfway through his words, June's face had already swelled up like an overinflated, string-snapped balloon, filling the space between the two front seats to bursting.

"Chase... that's not right of you. You're pulling the rug out from under me..."

Chase turned his gun around and pressed the muzzle against her neck.

"No. I'm making you understand that after this phone call of mine, I'm the only one who can take you to the Mayor. You have no choice but to bet on me."

"But... don't you still need to acquire an Artifact? What if you drag me along and—"

"Once I have Green's Black Cube, I can take you there right away. There's no need to acquire any other Artifact."

"Really?" June's voice shot up with delight.

"Really. Now sit back," Chase said, "and give me a few more fragments."

Finally! The weekend! Is almost! Here!!

It doesn't mean much, and I'll still have to write, but I'm genuinely excited anyway... is my brain broken?

Every Saturday the bald sheep hold a meeting

Welcome to this week's Saturday night special at ten o'clock on Nest Dream TV
—"Everything's in the Dream"

Host: Dream Playwright (why is it always this one? Because it loves to work)

Co-host: Janitor (no need to be confused—this Resident never actually appeared in the main story; it was excavated from an abandoned earlier draft)

Special guest: Taylor Ford (injured, on crutches)

Highest-level security detail specially arranged to keep the Resident audience from killing Taylor Ford on the spot: the typing zombie

"...As long as I cooperate with you and get through this little TV show performance, I can go back?"

Taylor Ford sat on a stretcher, asking in a pale-faced voice.

"How come I never knew you could just enter Blackmoor City directly and abduct people into the Nest? I've been in a hospital bed—I don't remember opening any passage... How did you get me in here?"

He was flanked on either side by the two Resident hosts, while the audience seats ahead were packed with a dense mass of faces all staring fixedly at him; under the blinding studio lights, he couldn't see clearly, but he knew he had virtually no hope of escape.

"Amateurs always have such amateur questions," the Dream Playwright waved a hand dismissively. "You don't need to worry about that. Just get through the program and you can go home."

"...What kind of program is this?"

"The Nest has developed a brand-new program for its sponsors, and for those bald sheep with the potential to become sponsors—no, I mean, for its patrons."

It's more than just a program, Taylor Ford thought. It seems like even this TV station and recording studio were hastily thrown together.

"Within the program, we will provide each sponsor with a special, one-of-a-kind experience—a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity, never to come again. The content of the experience, in addition to taking the sponsors' personal preferences into account, can also be specially customized at the request of the host and guests."

"This is the first episode we're airing," the janitor said, hugging the mop handle. "We'll know how it goes after one run."

"Well said. Now, let us welcome our first guest, Joiiiiii! That last character is an exclamation mark, not an i!"

Amid the applause, Taylor Ford looked up and saw a young girl walking onto the stage from the other side—but her exact appearance seemed wrapped in a haze, impossible to make out no matter how much he squinted.

"Hot on her heels, the experience-provider guest: Chase Monroe!"

Taylor Ford nearly rolled off the stretcher.

It really is Chase—he thought, while quickly scanning in all directions for anything that could be used as a weapon. Or maybe he could try to get a Resident to side with him...

"Don't worry, what you're seeing is their dream," the Dream Playwright said. "Neither of them is physically here. The two of them have achieved a kind of shared existence within a dream."

Taylor Ford calmed down and found that it wasn't lying—because Chase was standing beside a dinner table, dressed in a waiter's uniform, gently lighting the candle on the table for her.

"Joiiiiii, we meet again."

Chase leaned down, his shadow falling over the girl, and said softly, "...Tonight seems rather special for you. Would you like some wine?"

The image paused.

"This portion takes the sponsor's preferences into account—honestly, because the preferences were so straightforward, it made our job very easy." The Dream Playwright turned its head.

"Taylor Ford, you can now add customized content. Whatever you request, Chase will do it in the dream."

If he hadn't been unable to stand, Taylor Ford would have leapt to his feet and applauded.

He had never seen such a high-quality program in his life!

...A few minutes later, the image moved again.

Joiiiiii: "Ahh... the scent on you. What men's fragrance are you wearing?"

Chase smiled.

"A special custom blend," he said gently. "Cumin stirred with rotten onion, mixed with garlic juice, marinated for ten days under the summer sun, stuffed into socks that haven't been washed in a year, and rubbed all over the body before going out. Occasionally attracts flies."

Both the Dream Playwright and the janitor looked at Taylor Ford.

"Well then... let us please welcome the next guest, Shejianng is Absent."

Since there wasn't a preference as direct and intense as the previous one, the studio had arranged a grocery-shopping experience.

The patron wandered through a spacious, bright, and clean supermarket, an empty basket hanging from their arm.

Inside the frozen desserts cabinet, Reed Hydes had been frozen blue-white in the face and was knocking frantically on the glass, hoping to be picked; on the grains and staples shelf, Mai Minghe was crouching; in the produce section, Sydney Ginn was wrapped in a sheet of cellophane, the label reading "Imported"; when passing the fresh meat section, Taylor Ford saw himself lying on the cutting board, sleeping peacefully—he was just asleep, right?

"Buy me," Taylor Ford said, not without concern. "Buy a whole one—a whole one—whatever you do, don't let them chop it up and sell it by the pound."

The next few guests appeared hand in hand.

"Please welcome Hú Qiānjiǔ, Messenger AtRnname, Yuèchén Hè míng míng, and Your Father Laughs Heartily!"

Winter. A small wooden cabin in the mountain forest. Surrounded by heavy snow, mountain ranges, and a cold moon, the cabin glowed with warm light from one of its windows.

Mai Minghe sat in a rocking chair, a thick blanket draped over her legs, a book in her hands.

In the cabin's fireplace, a log occasionally gave a soft pop; amid the smell of burning wood and the dancing firelight, four small children each cradled a cup of hot cocoa, sitting on the rug, surrounded by scattered Lego pieces.

They sipped their hot cocoa while Mai Minghe slowly told a story: "...And then, all of a sudden, a little black cat appeared at the campsite. The little black cat found the little girl and asked her a question..."

"I'd want this experience too," Taylor Ford murmured.

As she read, Mai Minghe suddenly stopped and asked, "Children, would you like some snacks?"

"Yes!" Messenger AtRnoname cheered.

"Your father also wants some," said another child.

"I baked soft cookies in the kitchen... let me check—oh, I also just bought a box of non-edible kitten gummies."

Taylor Ford glanced at the Dream Playwright.

The Dream Playwright turned and glanced at the janitor.

The janitor turned and said to the floor, "...The username was just too fitting. I couldn't help myself."

The lineup of guests after that was considerably more sprawling.

"We would also like to thank and welcome Péng Xiǎoxī, Sīyáng 611, Dù Zǐruò, Yú Mèi 33, Yìxiū Jiādé Crimson-Clothed Puppet Tomato, Atuno, Murakami's Kafka, Mia Ao, Owner of Hu Miaomiao, Moon Falls Into Cotton Candy, Sān Jiǔjiǔjiǔ, and Qī Wú!"

A large screen behind the stage lit up, and Péng Xiǎoxī walked at the front of the group, holding a flag high; the flag didn't look quite like a normal one—though it was indeed a pole, perched atop the pole was a tiny virus-shaped Resident.

Everyone behind her wore a red hat.

"Everyone stay close," Péng Xiǎoxī called out. "Sightseeing in the Nest carries a certain degree of risk! Whatever you do, don't stray from the group—"

"What happens if someone strays?" Yìxiū Jiādé Crimson-Clothed Puppet Tomato asked.

Taylor Ford thought about it. "They might turn into a tomato?"

Before he could react, it was already too late—one figure in the tour group suddenly transformed into a red tomato wearing a red hat. And it was dressed in red, after all.

"We've temporarily decided to hire a batch of Nest temporary workers, since we're a bit short on Residents," the Dream Playwright said. "This batch of temporary workers will immediately come face-to-face with the tour group..."

"Welcome, A Cup of Daydream No Sugar, Upside-Down Cauliflower, I Imagine He'd See Me Just So, Mama's Said Life Should Be Elegant, Ginger Is Sweet, Forever Stand on the Side of the Egg, and World's Third-to-Last Sea Intestine!"

Taylor Ford watched as a crowd of patrons dragged into the Nest as temporary workers came rushing headlong toward another crowd of patrons who'd been forcibly hauled in for sightseeing, and he couldn't help but rub his brow.

...Come to think of it, he must be in a dream too.

I'm genuinely surprised the thank-you chapters ended up this long!

But I've finally caught up, and I no longer owe anyone a spot on the thank-you list—hooray! The bonus chapters are a different story, though.

Chapter 211: Switching Perspectives — A History That Was Once Set in Motion

After she hung up, Dylan turned to glance at Brianna.

He wasn't close with Brianna, and even if he had something to say, it wasn't easy to say it; after turning it over in his mind for a few seconds, he finally cleared his throat: "Forgive me for saying this... but this isn't safe."

"What?" Brianna was pulled back from her thoughts.

"That property security company you just called... their information is public. A quick search and anyone can find out what properties they manage."

Dylan watched through the windshield as rain was swept away in streaks, revealing a stretch of fresh night road, only to be blurred again just as quickly by silver-white threads of rain. "If whoever is tracking you gets to them, our destination will be exposed."

"Right." Brianna murmured, "That's a real possibility."

"Not a small one," Dylan reminded her. "If I were in their shoes, even knowing the target was temporarily hiding somewhere unrelated to the Wellesley Group—say, finding a boat at the docks—I'd still sweep all Wellesley Group properties first, just to rule them out."

He was perhaps subtly hinting at how she might hide most safely right now; but it gave Brianna an idea.

"Suppose you were the one tracking me. If you truly did find out my destination from the property company, what would you think?"

"What would I think?"

Dylan hadn't expected that question. His fingers tapped lightly on the steering wheel a few times. "Given that we haven't opened up much of a time gap, I'd pursue at full speed, immediately."

He paused, then added: "And I'd come ready with firepower."

"Oh?"

"You had so many other hiding places and yet, despite the risk of being discovered, you still went to Wellesley Group property... I'd assume you had high-level security in that building. That you had backup support waiting there. And where there's backup, there's bound to be gunfire."

Brianna nodded.

...Would Chase think the same way?

Most likely.

If he believed the firefight would happen near the building...

"...Chase."

Since she'd been hit, Han June had looked like something you wouldn't want to lay eyes on—but right now, the back seat she occupied had become something like a miniature mobile haunted den.

Never mind that Sydney Ginn had already pressed her face against the car window and curled herself up to half her usual size; even Tianxi couldn't help adjusting his seat and quietly scooting forward a little, driving the whole way hunched over.

"My face hurts so much, Chase," Han June said in a drawn-out, ghostly voice.

After the window was lowered, the wind carried threads of rain that fell in flurries against Chase's face and body, like countless tiny blades of ice.

He pulled his gun back in from the window, took a deep breath, and only then turned to Han June and said: "...Give me another piece."

Han June raised her head. On her snow-white, Noh mask-like face, unevenly shaped black voids had been hollowed out; a vivid red mouth floated within a pool of deep black, while both cheeks and her chin had entirely vanished.

The upper half was a cracked and chipped frozen Noh mask; the lower half was a pitch-black abyss with a pair of red lips floating in it.

Whenever she spoke, from within that pitch-black abyss, countless tiny tendril-like things roiled and drifted upward, as though they meant to swarm out of a dark haze and crawl into the world of the living—they slithered at the edge of one's vision, and the moment you looked directly at them, they shrank back and disappeared.

"You've already taken a lot," Han June stated this calmly. "If any more of my face disappears, it can't really be called a face anymore."

"Was what you had before even a face?" The tone Sydney Ginn used sounded as though she were defending the honor of faces everywhere.

"Then it's time you took back your original face." Chase said evenly. "Is the car going too fast to catch them? Tianxi, slow down."

Han June let out a very human sigh.

"You really can squeeze a cow dry and turn her into jerky—there's nothing you can't find a use for, Chase," she complained, clearly drawing from Han June's old vocabulary. "I thought you'd be done playing around by now... Fine, just wait a moment."

Chase leaned back in his seat, gun resting on his knees again.

A few seconds later, out in the slanted, densely falling dark rain beyond the car window, a large swarm of small white fragments appeared, bobbing up and down—like stiff butterflies with countless tentacles. Tianxi glanced over and slowed the car again; the swarm of fragments moved with a liveliness that seemed like they were heading home, and in a single turn they streamed in through the car window, making straight for Han June.

"...You probably don't understand, but as a normal person, I'm truly suffering right now," Sydney Ginn murmured.

From the main city district to Central Bay Island, there was one unavoidable route: the Cross-Sea Bridge connecting the two.

She and Chase were probably both racing toward the Cross-Sea Bridge right now.

She could already see that silver-white bridge standing tall in the night—was Chase right behind her?

Brianna lowered the car window. Fine, cool threads of rain pattered against her skin, and before long had soaked her face and hair.

She squinted and reached up to wipe the rain from her face, but her palm suddenly scraped against stubble that had appeared at some point, producing a dry rasping sound—she immediately pulled her hand away, her stomach clenching involuntarily.

...No matter how much time passed, there were always these details she would never have thought of as a woman—each one pricking her like a needle.

"Opening the window isn't safe," Dylan said.

"I know," she replied. "I just needed some air."

She wanted to say that she was actually nervous—her palms were sweating.

Even though she had run through everything in her mind countless times, she was still inexplicably afraid, even quietly hoping that time would stop moving forward, that Chase wouldn't catch up—but those feelings, no matter how many times she turned them over, had no one to be told to.

There wasn't a single person left in the world who would listen to her.

"There's less traffic at night,"

Dylan still hadn't let it go. "Even if they don't know which car you're in, if the window is open, there's still a chance someone could see your face."

Past three in the morning, the flow of traffic on the road had thinned to almost nothing, yet cars still swept past them from time to time; vehicles sharing the same stretch of night sky, utterly indifferent to their presence, trailed blurred trails of red light through the misty air before vanishing into the darkness.

Brianna didn't know why, at this hour, there were still other people on the road, or where they were all rushing off to.

But fortunately, in a metropolis of tens of millions, the roads were never truly silent and empty—otherwise, when Chase caught up and found only this single car ahead and behind, even an idiot would know that George Green had to be inside.

On top of that, the head of security had been generous with her, dispatching vehicles from the fleet Wellesley had used in his lifetime; every window had been treated with blackout bulletproofing, so as long as the windows were closed, even if Chase drove right past them, he wouldn't know who was inside.

This was no time for self-pity, she thought.

You have to keep looking forward.

To free herself from this neither-human-nor-ghost predicament, to free the world from all these nightmare-like, reckless Artifacts—she had to reclaim the Rumor, seize the Key, and collect all seven targets one by one.

Only the one who ruled the Nest had the right to close it.

"Then I'll leave it open just a crack," Brianna said, gripping her trousers tightly. "I keep feeling like I can't quite breathe."

The Cross-Sea Bridge was already visible in the distance.

The car carrying Chase and his group was speeding along the coastal highway toward the Cross-Sea Bridge.

On one side of the car was the dim, drowsy city streets—graffiti, sidewalks, and tourists all gone with the daylight into the night; on the other side, beneath low rain clouds, the vast expanse of the sea spread open.

Far in the distance, against the night sky, above the straight span of the bridge, tens of thousands of steel suspension cables had been stained by the streetlamps into countless silver-white threads, like the hem of a god's skirt unfurling from mid-air.

The car window had been open the whole time, and cold wind and cool rain kept pelting Chase's face; he had only Tianxi's jacket thrown over him, and his neck and chest were speckled with drops of rain.

He wiped the rain from his face and asked: "...How much farther?"

"After crossing the bridge, just ten minutes." Tianxi thought about it, then asked anyway: "Chase, do you think he's already reached the building?"

"I don't know either." Chase swapped in a fresh magazine for his handgun. "From here all the way to our destination, he could appear anywhere along this stretch of road."

"No idea what kind of car he's in..." Tianxi clicked his tongue with a trace of regret.

Chase leaned forward, peering ahead through the gap between the windshield wipers sweeping back and forth through the rain, and ordered: "Slow down."

"Yes."

"You didn't even ask why before you agreed? You're so easy to get along with." Sydney Ginn interjected from the back seat.

Tianxi kept Chase's instructions in mind and only gave a vague "mm."

But this time, Sydney Ginn wasn't brushed off.

She leaned forward too, poking her head out between the front seats, one question after another: "Shouldn't we have caught up with him sooner? Why slow down? What if he runs up into the building and locks himself in—how are you supposed to get close to him then? And what are you looking at?"

...It was like opening a floodgate. She'd clearly been holding it all in.

Chase thought for a moment, but before he could answer, he heard her suddenly cry out: "Ah!"

She lurched forward, her entire upper body surging out between the seats, one hand planted firmly on Chase's shoulder, the other pointing at something on the road ahead, so excited she could only fling out single words: "That! There!"

"What?"

"That car!" Sydney Ginn said, smacking him several times. "Do you see it—the one that's about to get on the bridge?"

Chase followed her pointing finger and fixed his gaze on a black SUV that had just turned onto the road ahead.

Something stirred suddenly in his chest.

Even as he asked, he had already half-guessed the answer: "What about that car?"

"That SUV is Wellesley's,"

Sydney Ginn finally had her words in order: "I've seen Wellesley's motorcade—and I saw it up close, over and over again, at the Cand— and I saw it up close, many times, at very close range. Every car in that motorcade is the same model, the same look. The one up ahead is one hundred percent Wellesley's car!"

Heh heh heh, rubbing hands together—there was actually a foreshadowing planted back in the storyline with Sydney Ginn and Anthony, and I held it back for nearly 200 chapters before finally using it.

Speaking of holding things back—the Silver bonus arc is only one chapter away from being finished. Heh heh heh heh, the true form of the game scenario I designed for the scammer-attack/Silver Grandpa is about to be revealed. Heh heh heh heh, rubbing hands together furiously like a fly.

P.S.: Is the author's note chapter somehow more popular than the main text??

Chapter 212: Shift in Perspective — Dressage

"Give chase,"

Those three words were calm and light, as if Chase had only been gently nudged by a passing thought—as if the thought were of no great importance, leaving him still half-submerged in the fading haze of sleep.

The last syllable's trailing note was swallowed whole by the sudden, thunderous roar of the engine.

The car lurched as though it had gone savage, hell-bent on flinging everyone out through the rear window; Sydney Ginn was caught completely off guard, shoved hard by the momentum—had she not grabbed the front seat in time, she would have nearly toppled onto June in the back.

Her heart slammed against her spine, but sitting meekly back down was more than her curiosity could bear.

She stayed plastered to the front seat, eyes wider than usual by a full margin—before her, the car window glass was like a cinema screen, the night road rushing up and sweeping past, and through the mist-drenched lens, the red taillights of the black SUV rapidly swelled in size.

The icy, rain-laden wind rushing in through Chase's window coiled through the car like blades.

By the time the two cars had closed the gap sharply, Chase had already unbuckled his seatbelt; one hand gripping the MP5, the other braced against the seat, he thrust his entire upper body out the window.

Wait, was he planning to—

The next second, Sydney Ginn's train of thought was blasted apart by a rapid-fire succession of gunshots.

Countless muzzle flashes split the night open; on the body of the black SUV, on the road, near the tires, dazzling white sparks scattered and flickered.

A string of bullets struck the SUV's roof, sending up a sheet of scorching light that burned through the rainy night and singed the SUV into a sharp fishtail, which sent it swaying and lurching onto the Cross-Sea Bridge.

If she'd gotten the wrong car, that would be...

A hand reached out from the SUV's passenger seat.

"Watch out!" Sydney Ginn cried.

The hand held a compact pistol; the barrel swung around and fired several shots back—but Chase had already moved a beat faster, folding sharply at the waist to dodge the wind and the bullets, and unleashed another volley of fire into the side of the SUV.

...Ah, good thing she hadn't gotten it wrong, Sydney Ginn thought.

"Get down!"

The moment Dylan let out a furious shout, Brianna felt his hand drive into her shoulder and wrench her downward with brutal force: "Hold on!"

She had no idea what Dylan intended to do, but he was a trained professional bodyguard, and when it came to defensive driving, he was far more experienced than Brianna—in the final instant before she ducked, her gaze swept past the window outside.

In the rearview mirror, Chase was still very much alive, the flickering white light from the submachine gun in his hands blazing across her field of view in continuous bursts.

The few nearby cars had already lit up their red brake lights one after another, turning aside to take cover; the ones that had stopped—they'd call the police, wouldn't they?

That thought had barely surfaced when Dylan slammed his palm down on the emergency brake, and at the same moment, stamped the foot brake all the way to the floor.

If not for the seatbelt restraining her, Brianna would almost certainly have slammed headfirst into something.

The SUV was wrenched to a halt mid-road with the tires locked up, nearly lifting the rear wheels off the ground as if it might pitch forward and roll—the rainwater on the road seemed almost scorched by the friction, and a haze of white smoke rose into the air.

The car right behind them, unable to brake in time and with nowhere to swerve, struck the SUV's rear with a heavy crash, and for one brief moment Brianna's world became a boat shoved suddenly into a pitch-black lake.

She blinked hard, and after a few seconds, when her vision cleared, she found that Dylan had one hand pressed against her.

"Are you alright?" Dylan asked, restarting the car.

"I'm fine," said Brianna; her body still seemed to hold the residual shockwave of the collision, her thoughts still swaying faintly. She tried to turn her head to look back, but couldn't quite move her neck. "Why did you...?"

"I hope it worked," Dylan said, something like a sigh in his voice.

The SUV's engine turned over again, and it raced forward into the night.

Tianxi swore and stamped on the accelerator several times; the engine let out a series of futile, impotent roars.

"Is it wrecked?" Chase sat back down and asked in a low voice.

He had just been through a rear-end collision that vicious—not only had he kept his footing and not been thrown clear, he was somehow still holding the MP5 steady in his hand.

Sydney Ginn couldn't take being thrown forward and flung back over and over again; her head was starting to spin in waves, and she was genuinely beginning to regret eating so much earlier: "Wrecked doesn't seem right, but I took a really hard hit..."

"I wasn't asking you," Chase cut her off. "I was asking about the engine."

Was that any way to treat someone who'd saved his life?

"That guy thinks fast," Tianxi said, restarting the car with something close to venom, "Chase-ge, if it's done for—"

Chase turned his head and glanced at the car that had just come to an emergency stop at the roadside on the bridge.

He didn't say a single word, but Sydney Ginn's hackles rose all the same—wonderful, one night tagging along with him and she'd nearly cycled through every federal felony on the list; they might as well drive straight into a prison, at least that would save some time.

She was just about to say something when she felt the car shudder—the engine finally caught again; amid the hum, Tianxi slapped the steering wheel with a relieved exhale: "We're good!"

The engine hadn't been completely destroyed, but the hood, buckled under the impact, had twisted upward, blocking half the windshield.

Chase stared at the hood, and for some reason, paused for just a moment.

"...Give chase," he said once more, quietly.

"They're coming after us again," Brianna glanced up at the rearview mirror and said softly.

"What exactly is your plan?"

Dylan gripped the steering wheel tightly, the speedometer needle creeping steadily rightward. "If you simply didn't want them to find you, there are too many places to hide in Blackmoor City—but you didn't hide. Did you arrange for them to recognize this car as well?"

"No," Brianna shook her head, "that wasn't something I expected either. For them, this should have just been an unremarkable car on the road... Strange, how did they recognize it? I had assumed we wouldn't run into them until somewhere near the Wellesley Headquarters Tower."

Dylan's impatience and dissatisfaction were plain to see. "Even though I'm responsible for your security, that doesn't mean I have to go along with whatever reckless thing you decide to do. Do you understand?"

"I understand,"

Brianna looked back again at the car drawing closer behind them—its front half crumpled—and said: "You're right. I do have an idea that could let us shake them off for good, but I need your help."

Dylan let out a long breath.

"What do you need me to do?"

Sydney Ginn knelt on the floor of the car, both hands gripping the front seat to steady herself.

She narrowed her eyes, tilting her head back to look at the sky heavy with rain clouds, and for a moment felt strangely adrift, as though her soul had left her body.

She didn't know how she had ended up kneeling inside a half-wrecked, speeding car, watching tens of thousands of silver-white cables sweep across the night sky above the Cross-Sea Bridge;

watching the slick black road unspool like a glittering river, rolling endlessly beneath the wheels.

Her hair and lashes had long since been soaked through; she sat trembling in the wind and rain, the sea not far away.

Beside her head, Chase's large hand—pale from the rain—had just snapped a fresh magazine into the MP5 with a click.

Both cars, pursuer and pursued, had long since blown past the speed limit, tearing through the howling night wind, setting off sharp horn blares from the roadside on either side.

Scattered smaller vehicles, reading the situation, either slowed and fell behind or pulled over to the roadside in a hurry—yet ahead, a heavy truck hauling a tall shipping container was still rumbling along the road, seemingly oblivious to the gunfire and the collision from minutes ago.

It seemed equally unaware that a black SUV was now driving straight toward its rear, dead center, without any sign of slowing.

"...Hm?" Sydney Ginn couldn't help sitting up straighter. "Why aren't they changing lanes? Aren't they worried about hitting the truck?"

"Tianxi," Chase said low and level, "whatever he does next—stay on him. Don't let go."

Which meant that if the SUV didn't change lanes, they couldn't either.

The moment they dropped off the SUV's tail, it would be clearing a path of escape for the man named Green; even if it gave him only a brief window, the consequences could be worlds apart.

"Yes," Tianxi said, swallowing hard.

Sydney Ginn felt an inexplicable wave of relief. So there was someone else who was nervous besides her—at least there was someone who understood—wait, no, that wasn't right. The only nervous one was the driver?

Just as her heart lurched back up into her throat, she heard Chase call out: "June."

June, who had been silently watching the car chase the entire time, now let out another very human-sounding sigh.

"I know," she said, and the moment those words left her mouth, Sydney Ginn's instincts flared—she ducked her head fast—and sure enough, something seemed to skim past the back of her skull.

"You want my face, right?"

Sydney Ginn watched Chase's large hand open and close, catching several fragments.

From his profile, there was no telling whether he found it revolting.

The fragment-tentacles reached out from between his fingers, swaying, and he pressed them down over the barrel of the gun; the tentacles immediately wrapped around the muzzle—a streetlamp on the Cross-Sea Bridge swept past, and his jaw, the bridge of his nose, his brow bone cut through light and shadow, hard and still.

"Chase-ge," Tianxi suddenly called out low.

Sydney Ginn snapped her head up.

The SUV stomped on the accelerator again, almost as if it meant to die, hurling itself straight at the back of the truck; in the instant before they would have smashed to pieces, the front of the car wrenched sharply to the right.

On the Cross-Sea Bridge amid a thousand threads of rain, the black SUV seemed to suddenly launch into a dressage routine—the engine was revved hard, the rear wheels broke traction in an instant, the back half of the car swung out sideways in a drift, sending up a spray of white water in all directions.

Still held by one hand as it kept rotating, for one moment it was turned completely broadside between the truck and Sydney Ginn's car. The SUV was heavy above and light below, and the speed of the drift was such that it lifted half its body off the ground, tilting on one side's wheels, rocking back and forth, until it finally came back down with a thud.

The moment it landed, the SUV reversed at once, backing into the left lane right beside the truck—the lane that hugged the sea—and the truck's shipping container, no longer blocked, loomed at a crushing speed, its shadow falling over Sydney Ginn's face like a mountain collapsing.

"Change lanes!"

In that instant, Sydney Ginn thought she heard Chase bark the order.

Whether it was his warning that came first or Tianxi's hands on the wheel, she had no time to tell; she was flung sideways by the car's momentum and slammed hard into the right door, her vision going black, every thought wiped clean for a brief moment.

Before Tianxi drove off the Cross-Sea Bridge, he finally managed to wrench his head back around in time, and plunged straight toward the SUV, which was still reversing ahead of them.

The next second, Sydney Ginn suddenly felt her body go weightless—the car that had been wrapped around her disappeared from all sides.

There's an event on the Qidian author backend where you team up with another author for a timed word-count speed contest—apparently you can win all sorts of prizes if you come out on top. Lured by the promise of material rewards, I clicked in to take a look.

My opponent was a randomly drawn male-channel author, apparently a top-tier one, writing over ten thousand characters a day.

I backed out. Because I'm the kind of person who lives simply and doesn't bend for money.

PS: This chapter has quite a bit of scene description, which isn't really crowd-pleasing, but I had a lot of fun writing it myself. Ah well, I've written myself into a hobby.

Chapter 213 — Chase: Villains Don't Die from Talking Too Much

From the moment the black SUV wrenched its wheel, fishtailed, spun around, and began reversing, the entire process took less than half a minute—after all, any hesitation in any single move would have meant either crashing into the truck or plunging off the bridge.

And yet twenty seconds was more than enough for a great deal to happen.

"Chase," Tianxi called out softly.

From that moment on, time seemed to slow, stretching into a long take. The world fell silent, sinking all the way down to the deep sea beneath the bridge, until all that remained in his ears was his own breathing and heartbeat.

Gently, Chase leaned out the window and raised his submachine gun.

The rear wheels of the black SUV ahead were skidding, spinning sideways, as though an invisible hand had grabbed it and wrenched it around—the tires sent up sheets of spray, white waves rearing up to meet the dark rain, making it impossible for a moment to tell sky from sea or sea from land, everything swallowed in endless water.

Chase narrowed his eyes.

White rain beads shattered against the black barrel; several tentacles of a fragment clung to the muzzle like a tiny hand, curling and spreading at irregular intervals.

The moment the SUV's passenger-side window came into his sights, the MP5 opened fire in the rain.

When the first bullet left the chamber, the impact shook the fragment's tentacles loose from the muzzle.

In that instant, Chase almost felt he could see the bullet's nose wrapped in a headscarf with swinging "tassels," shooting off into the sky and rain alongside the fragment, its tentacles opening and closing as they tumbled through the air.

"June!" he called out, low and sharp.

"Not yet," came a murmuring, half-coherent voice from the back seat. "It hurts so much..."

Whatever she said after that had already slipped beyond the edge of Chase's awareness.

The muzzle of the submachine gun in his hand blazed white, splitting the rainy night again and again with bursts of furious light; a second shot, a third... bullet after bullet shattered the bulletproof-treated window and left a string of brilliant sparks across the SUV.

But Chase never managed to land a killing shot. The SUV successfully swung its tail around and reversed into the lane to the left of the truck—the one pressed right up against the open sea.

Behind the windshield were two blurry figures; the driver had twisted his head around and was frantically hauling the SUV backward.

Chase immediately slapped his palm against the MP5, and the fragment that had been hanging on his fingers wrapped itself around the submachine gun's muzzle right on cue—June had managed not to fail him at the critical moment.

"Change lanes!"

As soon as he said it, Chase fired another burst at the SUV's hood.

"Ah," June suddenly cried out.

At the same time, the car lurched into a violent turn, wrenched away from the trajectory that would have sent it straight into the container truck; the tires scorched the rain-slicked road and sent wisps of white smoke curling into the air.

For one instant, nothing lay ahead of the car but a vast expanse of black sea, as though Tianxi was about to drive them off the Cross-Sea Bridge entirely.

"I—" June was still calling out, as though she too sensed there was no time left; yet every single word seemed to stretch on without end. "Feel—like—"

It was time.

His left hand—the one not holding the gun—quietly pushed open the car door beside him.

Inertia flung Sydney Ginn hard to one side, and Chase heard a dull thud from the seat behind him—she slammed into the door at the same moment Chase was already being hurled high into the rainy night along with the door swinging wide open.

He remembered tumbling through the air; one moment his vision was filled with the gun gripped tight in his hand, the next with the road rushing up to meet him, the next with the vast and boundless night sky—starless, moonless, blurred with rain.

Even though Chase tucked his body in time to protect his head and face, when he slammed into the ground, there were still a few brief seconds in which his mind went completely blank—his body, overwhelmed by searing pain, would not allow him to think or feel anything else.

The truck seemed to finally realize something was wrong, bellowing a long, thunderous roar of fury in the rainy night like a roll of thunder, and that sound dragged Chase's consciousness back to the Cross-Sea Bridge.

He gasped and pushed himself upright; the stimulants had long since worn off, and adrenaline was hammering through his muscles, leaving him trembling.

The MP5 had been knocked away somewhere—he had no idea where it had landed.

One side of his jacket was soaked through—whether from rain or his own blood, he couldn't tell.

In the endless, swaying curtain of rain, some movement caught Chase's attention and made him lift his head.

He raised his eyes just in time to see the car he had jumped from thrown into the sky as if someone were playing a prank, as if it weighed nothing at all.

The car—its hood bent and twisted—flipped upside down, all four wheels tracing an arc across the night sky.

It drew a long parabola, and at the bottom of that parabola sat the black SUV, which was still in the process of slowing down. The Key House car sailed over the top of the SUV and finally came down with a thunderous crash onto the bridge surface dozens of meters away, shaking the rainy night itself.

Chase broke into a run.

The heavy truck's path forward had been half-blocked by a car that had fallen from the sky and been smashed into scrap metal, and the truck was now braking with all its cumbersome, urgent weight. Chase poured every last bit of strength into his legs, sprinting at full speed to catch up with the gradually slowing truck, and just as it came to a stop, he slid in quickly and ducked behind it, using the tires as cover.

He reached behind him and drew a second .45 caliber pistol from his waistband, gripping it tight.

In the distance there was a sudden roar—it seemed the Key House car had caught fire. Chase couldn't see it, but he could see the glow it threw up, flickering in warm orange and red across the black, rain-slicked road.

...Had the people in the car noticed he'd jumped out?

The black SUV, which had been reversing rapidly, had at last managed to stop before crashing into the burning wreckage; it had come to a halt right at the junction between the truck's cab and the container, separated from Chase by almost the full length of one container.

Chase already knew exactly what lay in that stretch of road between them.

He thought for a moment, then circled to the other side of the truck and quickly covered the length of an entire container in short, rapid strides, arriving at the front of the cab. Ahead on the road, through the countless threads of rain, the wreckage of the car burned fiercely.

As Chase rounded the front of the truck's cab, the driver inside suddenly lurched forward onto the steering wheel and stared at him wide-eyed.

...His face had been seen?

Chase instinctively wiped his eyes—as if rain had gotten in—but what he felt was slick and sticky, as though even the rain couldn't wash it away.

He looked down. His hand was drenched in red.

Good. His face hadn't been seen.

Chase raised his gun and, without sparing the driver another thought, peered around the front of the truck's cab.

In that glance he saw the rear of the black SUV and two open doors; two men had their weapons raised and were making their way forward, one step at a time, onto the empty stretch of road ahead.

"What did you do?" one of them asked. "Why did that car—"

"I told you, we needed to take care of them completely. This is my method." The other man suddenly stopped walking and said, "Stop here. Don't go any further. Keep an eye on the surroundings—there should be someone nearby."

...No, there are two people nearby, Chase thought.

Besides himself—who had jumped from the car—there was also June, who had been thrown out along with the car. The ones who had "disappeared" were Tianxi and Sydney Ginn.

The one who had spoken was undoubtedly Secretary Green... So if you don't get close, you can't see your prey caught in the trap?

Chase silently raised his gun from behind the truck, narrowed his eyes, and squeezed the trigger.

When something could be resolved in one move, dragging it out even half a second longer was senseless.

The shot rang out, and the armed bodyguard dropped straight to the ground like a puppet whose strings had been cut.

He immediately swung the muzzle toward Secretary Green, who had just reacted, and fired a second shot—but the man's reflexes were faster than Chase had anticipated; at almost the exact moment Chase pulled the trigger, Green threw himself onto the road, and Chase couldn't be certain whether he'd hit him or not.

"Everyone's still alive," a quiet, eerie voice suddenly came from behind him, nearly making Chase spin around and fire.

"The bodyguard is unconscious—seems like he's wearing body armor."

June stood not far behind him. On her Noh mask, the tentacles of several fragments were rippling, reaching toward the gaps, trying to piece her face back together.

Inside the truck's cab, the driver seemed to let out a startled cry, then vigorously rubbed his eyes; but nobody paid him any attention.

"Good timing," Chase tilted his head and said. "Your fragments will come in handy."

"My face has already done quite a lot, you know,"

As June spoke, a fragment had already shot forward, flying straight at Secretary Green, who had just picked himself up and turned his gun toward the rear.

"If my face hadn't sensed it, how could you possibly have known the instant it happened—that Mr. Green had seized that split-second opportunity and set a Black Cube trap on the road?"

From the very first word of that long-winded speech, Chase's gaze had already tracked that small patch of white through the darkness, following it as it sliced across the rainy night.

In the sound of rain, the sound of waves, and the distant wail of sirens from somewhere unknown, that small fragment sank silently into Green's cheek.

Green stood frozen in place, motionless, as though he hadn't yet understood what had just happened to him.

Chase walked toward him, one step at a time.

He didn't trust June, so he grabbed her and pulled her along with him—June didn't struggle at all, compliant to a point that was almost unsettling.

He was a pale, lean, tall man, only half a head shorter than Chase.

Chase had absolutely no recollection of him—this was, without question, the first time in his life he had seen this face.

"Give me the Black Cube," he said, not entirely sure who he was addressing. Green had lost consciousness, so it must have been June.

But June waited several seconds before going "Hmm?"

"What's wrong?"

"Strange..."

June's Noh mask drew close to Green, and she looked him over carefully—his body, his face, circling around him slowly. "Very strange... I can't move him."

"What do you mean?"

"The fragment has clearly gone into his face, and he's lost conscious control of himself. But he won't respond to my commands... What's going on?"

You're asking me? Who am I supposed to ask?

"So you can't make him hand over the Black Cube?" Chase cut off the string of "so strange, so strange" that June had started murmuring, his patience running thin.

"I can't. He can't move a single step." June paused, then added, "Actually, even if I could make him move, I don't know how to put the Black Cube away."

Chase held his irritation in check.

He turned and glanced at the empty stretch of road beside them—this was the same stretch Tianxi had driven through after turning around and giving chase.

It was true: if he hadn't wrapped June's facial fragments around the bullets—and if June hadn't sensed something when the bullet passed through the Black Cube—he would never have caught the moment to jump from the car, and he would have plunged headfirst into the Black Cube right along with Tianxi and Sydney Ginn. Only the non-human car and June would have been thrown out the other side.

Those two were still suspended inside the Black Cube right now, broken down into countless pieces.

If Green couldn't actively withdraw the Black Cube trap... from Chase's experience, there was only one remaining option.

Which was fine—it was the same outcome in the end anyway.

"...Well done." Chase walked up to Green and said quietly.

Green was like a man submerged in a lucid dream—completely unaware.

"Fast enough reflexes, bold enough nerve. Who would have thought you'd dare set another Black Cube trap while fleeing?" Chase gave a small smile and said quietly.

Green had deliberately left breadcrumb-like clues—it must have been to see whether Chase could track him down. If Chase hadn't found the clues and followed, Green would have escaped safely; if he had followed, another trap was waiting for him.

The fleeing prey was, in truth, a hunter lying in wait to lure the other hunter in.

He didn't know who Green really was, but the man was a worthy opponent.

Worthy of Chase's respect, even in death.

"Why are you complimenting him," Han June muttered, "it was my face that sensed it..."

Chase paid no attention, turned and walked over to the unconscious bodyguard, picked up his gun, then dragged Green to the gap in the bridge railing.

Chase swapped in the bodyguard's gun and pressed the muzzle against Green's temple.

The deep black sea churned and glittered beyond the bridge; threads of rain drifted down through the space between heaven and earth, falling ceaselessly against Green's cheeks, his eyelashes, sliding down his face as if weeping for him.

The muzzle flashed at his temple, and Green's body went limp.

Chase looked down and watched him fall straight into the sea, trailing a thread of blood droplets in his wake.

Well, that's the title for you—as for exactly who the villain is, that's your own Hamlet to sort out.

Earlier I noticed some people kept feeling like the Key House Faction's valuation was too low—here's the thing:

1. What I wrote at the time was that it "far exceeded" ten million;

2. Take a look—Chase made his appearance on the 18th, and by the 22nd, only four days have passed in the story, yet he's already totaled three (perfectly good) cars, hired two separate groups (mercenaries and a cleanup crew), and spent ten thousand on Sydney Ginn alone, not to mention the countless smaller expenses... I kept thinking as I wrote: how much does this guy have to be earning to spend so freely? The Key House Faction not going bankrupt is honestly impressive!

PS: Everyone unanimously assumed in the last chapter that Sydney Ginn had entered the Nest—that actually startled me; it took real effort to hold back from spoiling anything.

Chapter 214: Brianna and Her Connection to the Past

Toward the end of 2024, the thing Brianna thought about most was revenge.

Of course, calling it revenge—even she knew it was more like the wounded sulking of someone who hadn't quite shed a child's mindset: in her fantasies of successful revenge, Wellesley was always full of regret, always apologizing, always begging her forgiveness, always accepting whichever partner she chose.

Sometimes she even laughed at herself for still having such an immature side.

Enter the Nest, find a rare and powerful Artifact, then flatly refuse to sell it to Wellesley—could something as simple as that make her father wake from his dream, struck with bitter remorse?

How old was she, exactly?

Most of Brianna's still-young life had been spent in the world of the ultra-wealthy elite.

Based on her understanding of that circle, if Wellesley truly couldn't buy the Artifact he desperately wanted from Brianna, he'd more likely just hire someone to take it by force—if she didn't end up in a hospital emergency room, that alone would already count as him showing consideration for his children.

After all, to people like him, children were nothing more than the least inadequate substitute for the regret of being unable to live forever.

Children were something you could have as many of as you wanted.

After severing ties with Wellesley and being struck from his will, Brianna could still live off her trust fund—and that was entirely thanks to the status of being the "eldest daughter." When she was born, it was also Wellesley's first time being a father; back then he was still far from the top tier of the ultra-wealthy, hadn't yet shed his humanity and become a different species entirely.

But people are strange that way—reason is reason, and feelings are feelings.

She wanted to hear Wellesley say sorry to her.

It didn't matter what means, or how slim the hope.

London Moon had once said that Brianna could never help letting her emotions rule her—but she also said that Brianna, with all her warmth and intensity, was very endearing.

After discovering she had a passage of her own, Brianna entered the Nest eight times in the span of six months—a number she didn't dare tell London Moon, since half of those eight times she'd gone in secret; not counting the first time she'd stumbled in by accident, London Moon believed Brianna had only gone with her three times, and even then she thought it was too many, too reckless.

Back then, with London Moon's experience and guidance, Brianna had the illusion that she could always walk out of the Nest in one piece.

"Even though I'm a newcomer," Brianna had once protested, "I really want to grow into a proper Hunter as soon as possible. Not someone who still needs your care and teaching, but a Hunter who can fight side by side with you."

That was only half the truth; the other half—the half that wanted revenge—she was almost too embarrassed to say aloud.

"Hunters who can fight alongside me are no shortage in the House Faction," London Moon had said at the time. "But there's only one you. I'd rather you stay safe and wait for me to come back in Blackmoor City."

...To say she had no regrets about the day she died in the Nest—that was impossible.

Everything in the Nest was unthinkable, contrary to all reason; Brianna had believed she'd long since known this, but it wasn't until the day she died that she truly grasped the weight and meaning of those words.

Her death was dragged out into something extraordinarily long.

She watched with her own eyes as every cell in her body died.

She felt her lungs slowly collapse into dry husks, her heart growing slack and bloated, pressing down against her ribs; intestinal gases flowed back up into her chest cavity, mold spread over her throat and packed the passage full, and she smelled the faint gray-tinged stench seeping little by little from the pores of her skin.

Several Residents crouched beside her, one of them seemingly a small child; faces hung over hers, drool dripping down as they grinned.

"Dead, dead! When does the decomposing start? Oh, not quite dead yet? Hurry up and finish dying, how inconsiderate."

...Why could she still perceive everything even though she was dead?

But very soon her soul began to die as well—she could feel it.

The feelings she'd had in London Moon's company—those feelings humans call contentment, happiness, joy—were the first to be pressed screaming and clawing and struggling into the ground by death, breath slowly choked off one by one.

The delight of being told she was beautiful, the excitement of the first time she went skiing, the kiss her mother had pressed to her forehead when she was sick...all of it gradually withered and crumbled to dust.

What remained was not pure negative emotion, but a hollow, pitch-black churning of ink—impossible to tell what it even was.

Barring any unexpected turn, she would have lain on the floor of the Nest and slowly died, gradually decomposing, the last things she'd ever see in this world being several grotesque Residents.

And then she would cease to exist, and only the Resident born from her body would walk the Nest in her place...

And hunt London Moon.

Brianna jolted.

"What's this—you were almost there, how are you slipping back now? Hurry up and keep dying." The Residents were displeased, their tone like that of a coach.

Can't die can't die absolutely cannot die no matter what she cannot produce a Resident the Resident born from her would feel an overwhelming craving for London Moon London Moon would surely be killed by her Resident

"Ah! What—what is that? What is that?!"

At some unknown point in her long death, someone cried out in the distance, stumbling frantically and falling to the ground.

Brianna's rotting face felt the vibration through the ground.

It was a man's voice; he sounded as though fear had already squeezed tears from him, and he scrambled to his feet in a panic, shrieking: "Don't come near me! What are you—what is this place —"

Was it an ordinary person who had accidentally fallen into the Nest just now?

How unlucky, to happen to land near her corpse of all places.

Her prolonged death had already become a legend among the Residents in the surrounding area, and had gradually drawn more and more of them; by now great numbers of Residents always gathered to watch her corpse, waiting for the moment she would finally "finish dying."

The man broke into a run, but didn't get far.

Less than a hundred meters, perhaps—and then a Resident that looked like an infant pounced on him and knocked him down.

But he was far luckier than Brianna: he died almost immediately, and his death did not stretch into a prolonged ordeal—later, Brianna thought that she might have simply been especially unlucky, happening to catch the Nest in a whimsical mood.

"Dead, boring," one Resident said. "Let's see what comes out of his body. This person doesn't seem to have much in him—might not even produce a Resident. Still, that woman is more interesting."

It wasn't something she should have been able to perceive, yet within the black hollow sockets of Brianna's eyes, she somehow seemed to see the spot where the man's corpse had fallen.

And then another powerful feeling arose in her.

If she could just crawl over there, catch the moment when the man's body had opened up in decomposition but before a Resident had been born from it, and slip inside...if she slipped inside she could survive survive survive Brianna wasn't going to die she was thinking right now wasn't she if she could still think there was still hope hope hope

The Residents let out a round of loud cries—she didn't know what it meant.

It sounded like surprise, like excitement, like the sight of something novel and entertaining, but threaded through with angry roaring and sharp sounds of disapproval.

"Just let her go—she's halfway a Resident herself by now," one Resident's voice rose above the rest. "I've never seen such a stubborn dead person! Let everyone have a bit of fun."

...What?

Oh, right—she was crawling toward the man's corpse, one inch at a time.

The act of "crawling," naturally, could not be accomplished by thought alone—that went without saying.

Brianna was crawling forward using her own corpse.

She was afraid the Residents would change their minds and come block her, so she crawled as fast as she could, each movement deliberate; fortunately her arms had long since lost all feeling, and when great strips of skin were scraped away by the ground, she felt no pain.

The distance of less than a hundred meters felt, in the crawling, like crossing mountains and valleys on a long and grueling journey; she had no idea how long she crawled before she finally reached out and touched the man's hairy ankle.

"The timing is just exactly right,"

The Residents who had followed and watched the whole way kept sighing and saying: "Both of them look like they're about to decompose, but neither has yet."

"Isn't that so," one Resident turned and glanced back behind Brianna.

...About to decompose?

She couldn't say whether it was those words or something else that stirred something in Brianna's heart.

She too turned and looked back behind her.

She saw her own upper body and spine, stretching out long behind her, spread across the entire path she had crawled.

It turned out that as she crawled, her chest cavity, spine, and torso...had followed behind her head, gradually elongating, stretching to nearly a hundred meters long.

Her upper-body clothing certainly couldn't cover a hundred-meter stretch.

So when she turned her head, there was a long, unbroken expanse of bare back; the skin had gone ashen-gray, the spine slightly sunken, like the groove left by a snake dragging itself through a stretch of sand—no end in sight.

Her legs had long since become invisible.

Though they were separated from her by a hundred meters of distance, she was still connected to them.

...Everything in the Nest was unthinkable, contrary to all reason. Only now did she understand the true weight of that.

Perhaps because she had already been dead for so long, Brianna felt no surprise and no revulsion—only a desperate urge to let out a sharp, keening wail.

She turned her head back, grabbed the dead man's feet, and strained to force her way into his body—there wasn't even an opening, yet by the time she came back to herself, she had already entered the man's body.

The sensation was difficult to describe.

It wasn't her own consciousness taking control of another's body, and it wasn't entirely like putting on a suit made of flesh.

If she had to describe it, it was as though she had inserted her hands into the man's two legs and propped him up from inside like a sock puppet—only far more complex and delicate an operation.

In any case, she could finally blink again, breathe, think, speak, stand, walk...the joy of rebirth made her head swim for a moment, and she stopped caring about anything else.

So what if it was a man's body? She was still herself, wasn't she?

She fumbled around inside the man's slippery brain and wanted to know who he was, how old he was, and most importantly, what his passage was—and she found it all out, one by one.

George Green, twenty-nine years old, construction cost estimator; his passage was a scaffold striking him across the back.

No wonder her back ached a little.

Brianna reached back and pressed on her—no, George Green's—back; only then, belatedly, did she look down at the ground.

...She had to leave the Nest immediately.

Brianna seemed to have borrowed George Green's neurons along with his emotions, and for a moment she felt fear again—even sick with fright, on the verge of tears.

She had to leave the Nest immediately, and she would never come back.

During the two or three days Brianna spent searching for the scaffold, she passed through many city blocks.

No matter where she walked, whenever she turned around, she could see—just below George Green's calves, above his ankles—the connection to Brianna's two shoulder blades.

From the shoulder blades downward, her former upper body still followed faithfully behind George Green.

Her body lay face-down across every road she had walked, still stretching longer with each step, without end.

Even though the image of my upper body growing longer and longer as it dragged behind had been in my mind for a long time, it was only when I actually wrote it out that I realized—how terrible Brianna's fate is. She couldn't even die a decent death. She might just be one of the most wretched characters I've ever written.

In the eyes of characters who are able to survive, the Nest is a chaotic place of opportunity, and Residents might even seem kind of endearing at times—but at its core, it remains a cruel and terrifying place.

Brianna was truly dead long ago—London Moon wasn't lying. As for the thing now walking in the human world, I don't know what to call it either.

I often end up writing things I don't know what pronoun to use for, things whose nature I can't quite define—technically, it's quite a headache.

The crystal ball had absolutely no sympathy for my predicament.

Chapter 215: Brianna's Connection to the Present

"Just kill me,"

Brianna tilted her head back, sitting on the sofa she and London Moon had chosen together, and said this as she looked at the black muzzle London Moon had aimed at her.

"At least if you kill me, I won't be dismantled by the Nest, and I won't give birth to a Resident."

London Moon lowered the gun a second time, then raised it a third.

She was a sharpshooter known for her steadiness, composure, and precision — Brianna had never seen the gun in her hand tremble like this.

The conversation between the two of them at that time — the arguments, the weeping — had already gone on for over an hour. The future was like the sky outside the window, dark and heavy, with no trace of dawn.

"I really am Brianna," she said, lowering her head.

"...Impossible," London Moon pressed her free hand over her face and said, almost pleading: "Tell me the truth. What did you do to her?"

There were a thousand pieces of evidence she could offer to prove she was Brianna.

She could recount the experiences the two of them had shared, bring up the private details between them, or use a passcode to unlock her own phone—

Impersonating someone else would always leave gaps and slip-ups; but when it came to proving who she was, every moment of her past life was her confession, and each one could be driven like a blade into London Moon's body.

A few minutes later, London Moon aimed at the center of her forehead and pulled the trigger.

The gun was empty.

At some point while Brianna had been talking, London Moon had quietly ejected the bullets; Brianna had been so absorbed in what she was saying that she hadn't even noticed.

London Moon said it was because she knew she would pull the trigger — because she couldn't take it anymore, she had long since stopped being able to listen — yet she had also dimly sensed

that the person in front of her was truly Brianna.

She couldn't bring herself to really shoot her dead, but she was afraid she wouldn't be able to hold back the impulse, so while she still had her reason, she had removed the bullets.

"It's not just your body..." London Moon stared at the floor and said: "Even your personality and the way you talk are different."

Brianna was silent for a moment.

As if she hadn't heard it at all, she changed the subject: "I'm just holding up this man's body. Even if you put a bullet through my forehead, I wouldn't die a second time, would I... after all, I already died long ago — what the bullet would pass through is only this man's brain."

"Is that so," London Moon said quietly, her eyes rimmed red, her face drained and listless.

Red veins didn't suit those blue eyes, as though they had dirtied their clarity.

"After I came out of the Nest, when I looked down, I couldn't see the shoulder blades on my legs anymore. I don't know what happened to my body that was left behind in the Nest — it was probably still beside the scaffolding, stretched out very long—"

London Moon buried her face in both hands.

Ever since she had accepted that the man before her was Brianna, she seemed unable to look at Brianna directly — at this moment London Moon let out a sound almost like a groan and cut her off: "Please... stop talking."

Brianna gripped her trousers tight, as though she was plunging endlessly into a void; somehow she felt so disappointed she nearly wanted to cry.

She had thought that once she saw London Moon and proved her identity, everything would get better.

"If I had given rise to a Resident, it would definitely have gone to hunt you down," Brianna said in near-despair, unable to stop. "It was to keep you from danger that I fought so hard to crawl into this man's body..."

She hadn't wanted to say this out loud — she didn't want to use it to beg for mercy.

But she couldn't afford to hold back anymore. Whatever it took, whatever reason, whatever grounds — she just wanted London Moon to be gentle with her one more time.

"I'm sorry," London Moon said slowly. "I'm sorry. I should have been by your side then — if I had been, you wouldn't have ended up like this..."

That wasn't the answer she had wanted to hear, Brianna thought, in a daze.

"I'm still me — I've just changed bodies," she said, like a plea for help. "Isn't that right? You think so too, don't you?"

After half a minute, London Moon said: "...Yeah."

That wasn't her brushing it off.

To be fair, London Moon tried.

She prepared clean clothes for Brianna, ran a full bath, examined her body, and tested whether she still felt thirst or hunger — finding that her physical needs were all intact, she then went and bought Brianna's favorite food. To help her recover from the fear, London Moon sat with her through breathing exercises, listened to music with her, chatted about small things—

For a few hours, as long as she didn't look down, Brianna could almost believe she had only had a bad dream.

"The Nest is full of all manner of things — maybe one day an Artifact will appear that can restore you to your original state."

As the sky began to lighten, London Moon patted her gently on the back and said: "As long as there's a solution, I will get it for you, no matter the cost."

Brianna felt that everything truly was getting better.

Until London Moon said, gently and naturally: "Get some sleep — you've been up all night. The bedroom's yours. I'll go get a pillow and blanket and sleep on the sofa."

...She was going to sleep on the sofa?

It seemed... right that she would sleep on the sofa.

Brianna sat on the bed in the darkened bedroom, staring blankly at the wall in the darkness, without a trace of drowsiness.

She had just gone to the bathroom — she'd had quite a bit of water during the meal — she hadn't expected that to become the first difficulty and torment.

Afterward Brianna scrubbed her hands desperately, the hot water turned scalding, yet the sensation could not be washed away.

She didn't want to touch London Moon's bedding with those hands; she braced them against the bed and sat there in a stupor, not knowing what to do next.

Entirely on instinct, she followed her muscle memory and picked up her phone — people always find themselves reaching for their phone without thinking; she was no exception, even now — and the phone she picked up was not George Green's phone, but Brianna's phone.

The moment the screen lit up, she found she had received two urgent notifications, each marked with a yellow warning symbol, at some unknown point.

She turned those two notifications over and over in her mind, reading them countless times.

It turned out that shortly before her death, while she was still alive, she had been conscripted into the "Nest Domination Game" — but that moment had apparently been just before she met with disaster and died, and she had been in no state of mind to pay attention to her phone, not even hearing it.

After her death, it seemed even the Nest had come to second-guess itself.

"Are you even still human?"

The notification said, in a breezy tone: "Residents cannot be contestants, but you're not exactly a Resident either. My, my — this neither-human-nor-ghost situation of yours is really hard to define. You do love to make things difficult for people, don't you.

"How about this — we'll count you as half a contestant, what do you say? You go find another living person, form a team with them, and we'll keep your eligibility. If that living person happens to die someday, the team still exists, and it can still carry on in the team's name... Haha, isn't that just like how a company can keep going after its legal representative dies? You really know how to find loopholes, you cunning contestant Brianna."

She clutched the phone in a white-knuckled grip, finally unable to hold back — she flung it out with a swipe of her arm and slammed it hard against the wall.

"What happened?" London Moon came rushing to the doorway at once, apparently not having slept at all. "Are you alright?"

If she were made a contestant in the "Domination Game"...

Even if one connection was severed, another kind of bond could still keep her here.

After a long moment, Brianna let out a breath and said in a low voice: "...Nothing. Nothing happened."

London Moon and she made an effort to live together for two or three months after that, but it seemed as though everything had curdled.

The initial factor that caused them to drift apart was, when it came down to it, quite subtle and small — barely worth mentioning. Once, Brianna had habitually and affectionately leaned into London Moon's arm; London Moon flinched and pulled away.

By the time she caught herself and quickly reached back to take Brianna's hand, Brianna knew she shouldn't put her through it anymore.

Because she had told London Moon about not wanting the Resident to kill her, London Moon would never take the initiative to leave, no matter what; she would only faithfully stay by her side, tormented day after day by the guilt of no longer being able to love her.

Brianna couldn't wait indefinitely — waiting for some Artifact to appear out of nowhere at an unknowable time to save her from her misery.

Seizing dominion was the only hope of escaping this neither-human-nor-ghost state — whether that meant returning to her original form or dying, she would welcome either.

As for a teammate... her father was probably the most ideal and most capable candidate.

Wellesley wouldn't refuse.

Wellesley didn't refuse.

The irony was that Wellesley had once wished so badly she had been a boy. Yet when she finally appeared before him in the form of a man, Brianna found that the last trace of biological father-daughter connection between them had vanished along with it.

This male body carried none of Wellesley's genes; without the genes, the bond was severed — if any bond had remained in the first place.

During the second week after she became his secretary, Brianna's trust fund had her revoked as a beneficiary.

Wellesley said that since she was now working as his secretary, she would have a respectable salary and need not worry about living expenses; but Brianna had better not assume she could

hold on to this secretary position indefinitely if she showed no progress whatsoever in the "Domination Game."

...From that point on, nearly two years passed.

Brianna had not revisited that stretch of memory in a long time.

It seemed as though it was because George Green's brain had been scrambled into pulp by a bullet, sending her thoughts, her mind, and her memories into upheaval along with it — broken and chaotic — that she had found herself thinking of the past once more.

It wasn't only her memory and mind that had been thrown into disarray; even her control over the body, her sense of time, her experience of heat and cold — everything had been blasted to dust by Chase's bullet.

She struggled to gather the dust inside Green's body back together, to mold it into some kind of shape — like a child building a sandcastle on a beach. Gradually, she finally managed to blink, and the graffiti sprayed onto the concrete bridge pillar came into focus.

It seemed she had been carried far out by the waves — this was no longer the Cross-Sea Bridge. It looked like an overpass somewhere at the edge of Blackmoor City, close to the sea.

Brianna, who had been lying motionless on the rocky shore, took a long time to piece things together: after the waves had washed her ashore, she must have been lying here for at least a day — because she remembered that on the night she encountered Chase in battle, Blackmoor City had been pouring with rain; now the rain had long since stopped and the ground was dry.

Was it the second night now? Her phone was gone, so she had no way of checking the date.

Her wallet was still there, though, since it had been in an inside pocket.

The Black Cube...

When her consciousness had faded, the Black Cube had probably done what most Artifacts do when they lose their operator — reverted to its initial state.

Once it reverted, Chase would certainly have taken it. If her phone hadn't been washed away, she might have already received a major Nest notification.

Did that mean that without Wellesley, she was nothing—

Don't think about it.

That thought — don't go there.

Brianna dragged herself upright and touched the gunshot wound at her temple.

The snow-white shard that had been embedded in Green's face was gone too, having left at some point, leaving behind a small black hole on her face.

If she wanted to, she could slip a finger right in, and probe down and down, touching nothing at all — as though all the tissue that had once made up that part of the face had somehow vanished, leaving behind a bottomless, deep tunnel in the face.

Brianna shuddered and pulled her index finger out.

What now?

Even if she had once put makeup on Green's face before, dressed up as a woman, and even fooled Chase once — how was she supposed to use makeup to conceal a gunshot wound at the temple and a black hole in the face?

Would the flesh of the wound rot?

She probably couldn't go to see London Moon ever again.

Even if Green's face had a hole in it, she absolutely refused to let London Moon see her like this—her capacity for disgust did have its limits, after all. Especially that girl who had appeared at Chase's side; she didn't know whether London Moon recognized her, but she looked—

"...Who is that?"

A tiny, small voice cut through the blizzard of thoughts swirling through Brianna's mind.

She sat there in a daze for a few seconds, wondering if she had finally gone mad.

Come to think of it, after enduring so much, only going mad now—perhaps she was already quite strong-willed.

Because... how could this be?

"I saw... your fingers... Who are you?"

How could that small, faint woman's voice possibly be coming from the hole in her own face?

Was it that thing called June?

No—the voice sounded different.

"W-who are you?" Brianna opened her mouth and asked.

She could feel clearly how, as her facial muscles and tongue shifted, they were thrown slightly off-kilter by the friction and pressure against the black hollow tunnel running through her face, making her sound just a little slurred.

"Why are you... coming out of my eye..."

The woman seemed to have fallen into a daze. After a moment, she murmured: "I... my name is Ashley Paige. I'm a police officer."

Sometimes when I'm writing, I really want to create that cinematic quality you get in film and TV, so I make different choices in wording and imagery. But since this is still being published as a web novel, there's always this sense of disconnect—between what I'm writing and what actually gets posted... Hmm, I'm not sure that's easy to explain clearly.

Anyway, I felt so much pain writing Brianna's scenes—an author can't truly control the final product one hundred percent. When I was writing the outline, I honestly didn't anticipate that fleshing it out would turn out this cruel...

PS: You probably didn't expect this, did you—Chief Ashley shows up here! She's not just a blink-and-you'll-miss-her character!

Chapter 216: Mai Minghe's Nest Debt Has Been Paid

Being an Artifact Hunter was truly no job for a human being.

"The life you people lead — more happens to you in a single day than happens to an ordinary person in a whole year. When I think about the fact that today is only the 22nd, I feel like the Earth isn't spinning right, like it's spinning too slow."

Mai Minghe dropped down onto the wet ground without a care for all the water — her clothes had already been soaked through by the rain just moments ago.

"It's not like this every day..." Reed Hydes murmured in quiet defense of hunters everywhere.

Mai Minghe wasn't quite convinced.

"And it's not just a lot — it's dangerous, life-threateningly dangerous. What even happened? All I wanted to do was sell something, and what do I get? One me turns into a whole crowd of mes... Thank goodness the stuff didn't go missing. And where did all those bullets come from, whooshing back and forth over my head? Like we were filming a movie."

The gunfire in the distant alley had stopped, but no one — Megan included — had the nerve to go back to the bar to see what was going on or how things had turned out.

As the saying goes, a wise man doesn't stand beneath a crumbling wall; after running out, they had nowhere else to go for the moment, and were now huddled under the awning of a dessert shop by the roadside like vagrants, catching their breath after the fright.

Earlier, while Chase was facing off against the other man in the alley, the three of them had pressed their backs to the wall, slipped away on light feet, and shuffled along the base of the wall one after another like crabs — Mai Minghe had seen it perfectly clearly: as they were running, Chase had turned and glanced at them.

In that instant, the frantic thoughts swirling through her head were all along the lines of: Does the Serpent Band stop bullets? Can Artifacts be damaged? What if you get shot in the head? If she ran as fast as she could, would she be faster than a bullet?

What surprised her was that Chase had turned back around and let them go.

"Of course he'd let us go,"

Reed Hydes listened to her finish, then let out a sigh. "Three more bodies — one of them an employee of the bar — would only be a liability and a headache for him. Everyone's a Hunter, no bad blood between us; letting us go costs him nothing, and there's no way we'd ever show up in court to testify that he killed someone."

Megan refused to sit on the ground, and was crouching beside Mai Minghe on the other side, drawing a sharp breath through her teeth.

"What are you talking about," Megan said, looking at him earnestly. "I didn't see anyone die."

Huh? But that big guy just now —

"Oh, you're right," Reed Hydes nodded quickly. "I must have looked wrong — that guy tripped and fell, then got back up."

Mai Minghe caught on.

So this is what it means to be a Hunter... she thought, a little dazed.

She wanted to be a Hunter, wanted to enter the Nest, wanted to live a different life once more; and that meant she had to act according to the Hunter's way.

But accepting death as though nothing had happened — not even calling the police — and doing so with a calm and easy mind was not something she could manage at a moment's notice. She couldn't shake the feeling that she had done something wrong.

"You can't let yourself get confused,"

She had barely let a hint of her feelings show before Megan caught it immediately and said, "Conflicts and disputes within the Hunter world should stay within the Hunter world — they have nothing to do with ordinary people. Whoever kills someone, whoever steals an Artifact, there are consequences for that within the Hunter world. Whatever you see, whatever happens, that's the bottom line. If the Nest gets exposed, none of us will come out of it well — Reed Hydes, right? You should talk some sense into her."

"She's new to the trade, she's not used to it yet," Reed Hydes said, growing a little embarrassed on Mai Minghe's behalf. "She'll be fine after a while."

Megan nodded. "...Once she sells the lipstick, she'll understand."

Why?

Mai Minghe looked between the two of them, but they didn't seem inclined to explain any further.

Megan had only said one thing — "The person who wants to buy your lipstick is Chase Monroe" — but the unspoken implication behind her words seemed to be something else entirely.

Even if neither of them had ever killed anyone with their own hands, they had displayed a remarkable ability to adapt to things like gunfights and dead bodies; Mai Minghe had only sat in blank thought for a brief moment before they had already put the matter of the dead man behind them, and Reed Hydes was already worrying about her future.

"...We're in a bit of a difficult position," Reed Hydes said, tentatively. "If your bar has any contacts — anyone who knows who might be selling identities — please let her know when the time comes — actually, contact me. A full set of documents would be best, the kind that can open a bank account."

"No problem," Megan readily exchanged contact information with him. "Organizations that handle cleanup usually have that sort of thing for sale — shouldn't be hard to arrange."

That brought Mai Minghe's thoughts crashing back to earth, and to reality.

Reality was that she had no money.

The idea of reaching out to Chase again to sell him the lipstick now struck Mai Minghe as roughly equivalent to a mouse figuring out how to trade a piece of cheese with a mousetrap — forget it; what if he just took it from her?

No, she wasn't like that.

In any case, she'd wait until there was truly no other buyer before considering Chase...

When they heard the faint wail of a siren in the distance, Megan got to her feet. "Looks like things are wrapping up — I should head back."

"If there's any development, send me a message?"

Reed Hydes hurriedly called out to her retreating back; Megan only waved her hand, tossed out a "you two should head home too," and left.

The lingering fright from being caught up in an Artifact incident and a gunfight had settled down as well.

"Even though there was a bit of an unexpected incident, everything we originally set out to do has been taken care of." Reed Hydes let out a yawn and wiped away the tears it brought, recovering that weary, gentle expression of his. "Let me call a car... Oh, right — once it's light out I still need to take you to get a SIM card and show you how to use your phone."

"You really are a kind-hearted kid." Mai Minghe thought for a moment. "Thanksgiving is coming up — what are your plans? Come over for dinner? I'll make a big meal — you can bring your girlfriend, or bring Ice Cream, either is fine."

Reed Hydes looked at her as though she were an alien who had just touched down — and by the time he saw Mai Minghe home, he still hadn't said whether he'd come for Thanksgiving or not.

He said that based on past experience, he still needed to sleep for several more hours after getting home; during the time he'd be asleep, Mai Minghe was alone again, sitting in the old apartment she had lived in for decades, looking around again and again.

It was only two or three days ago that the apartment had been the only world she knew, yet now, seen through a young pair of eyes, it felt like a museum sealed away and then reopened for viewing, displaying the life of some distant, other old woman.

She gently stroked the faded cloth cover draped over the sofa, feeling the rough texture against her skin, not sure whether she should move out or not.

If she didn't move —

The thought hadn't finished before a sudden buzzing startled her; she quickly looked around for the source of the sound, and only then did it dawn on her — she was a person with a phone now, and that sound was probably the same one the phone had made when it received a message last time.

Please don't let it be another Artifact closing in on me — once was more than enough.

Thinking this, Mai Minghe fumbled to take the phone out of her jacket pocket — she had probably taken too long, because by the time she got it out, the screen had just gone dark.

Is something wrong? Is it broken?

She stared at it for a moment, then raised it high with her left hand and jabbed at it firmly with her right index finger — the screen lit up again.

According to Megan, this phone had no signal and shouldn't be receiving anything at all; that, however, did nothing to stop the Nest from finding her.

! Nest Domination Game Progress — Major Breakthrough Notification!

Congratulations to the lovely contestant Sydney Ginn for successfully obtaining the target Artifact (Black Cube icon)!

How wonderful!

What does it mean to use another's strength to your advantage, to go with the flow, to be the mantis stalking the cicada while the oriole lurks behind — this is exactly — wait.

Mai Minghe stared at the text on the screen, not quite processing it.

Sydney Ginn was the contestant who had joined the game before her, right?

The Black Cube had approached the Between the Backlights bar, but had somehow been snatched away by Sydney Ginn — that much was still understandable.

But what did "wait" mean? What was the Nest telling her to wait for?

That question was answered half a minute later by another message that set the phone buzzing again.

! Nest Domination Game Progress — Major Breakthrough Notification!

What is going on — the situation is changing far too quickly. I truly cannot bring myself to say the word "congratulations"...

At any rate, that's how it stands: the detestable contestant Chase has just obtained the target Artifact (Black Cube).

Sigh.

Cuckoo's Child, Chase Monroe, Artifacts currently held: a tongue (icon); Black Cube (icon)

Chase's current progress: 2/7

Chase's current location: Blackmoor City Cross-Sea Bridge

Chase's current status: weakened, injured

As for the rest of you contestants — are you really up to this? Letting him charge ahead unchecked like this — is that truly all right with you? Can you even sleep at night?

Even contestant Sydney Ginn doesn't look as lovely as usual right now.

You were only being held at gunpoint by Chase — did you have to give in so quickly? You found it, so it's yours — what right does he have to take it?

How do you know, without even trying, that your flesh and blood would definitely lose to a submachine gun?

To fight him for the Artifact — even if you died doing it, it would be a worthy death, a life well spent, with no regrets!

In any case, the Nest will never recognize any so-called "alliance of mutual interest" between the two of you.

Remember — in the phrase "alliance of mutual interest," the key word isn't alliance, it's interest.

When only one of you can be the final beneficiary of the Nest Domination Game, can you really hold this alliance together?

If Mai Minghe hadn't poked at the screen a few times and accidentally triggered some gesture that made the notification fully expand, she would never have been able to read the whole thing.

The Nest really did seem to dislike Chase intensely.

The tall, lean one carrying the Black Cube had apparently lost in tonight's struggle... Mai Minghe thought in a daze. That kid was after the tongue, wasn't he?

Was he dead too?

She had only caught a few brief glances, yet she had the feeling that the kid had been in a great deal of pain... There had been nothing in his outward appearance to suggest it, yet Mai Minghe couldn't shake the feeling.

Was it because of the Artifact?

It was right not to take part in the game's competition after all.

She only wanted to obtain the time Artifact and gain a second life; she had no desire to cause others pain in the fight for dominance, nor to let others bring pain to her.

Mai Minghe fiddled with the screen for a while, and without knowing what she had done, the notification disappeared; then without knowing what she had done next, the screen returned to a

greeting display, saying hello to her in various languages.

"Well, hello," Mai Minghe said hesitantly to the phone. "Um... once Reed Hydes wakes up, I'll know how to use you properly."

As she set it down on the table, the phone buzzed again, as if in response to her words.

Had Chase and Sydney Ginn already had another development?

Mai Minghe picked up the phone and leaned in to look — she saw several lines of text.

«Artifact Report»

Only those who have made a change upon the world deserve the right to move forward

Dearest contestant Mai Minghe, the following is your path to obtaining the time Artifact —

The two of them — Chase and Sydney — have quite a bit of loose ends to deal with on the Cross-Sea Bridge, but writing a whole chapter on just how they handle and clean up the aftermath felt a bit dull to me — and honestly, I've also been writing from Chase's perspective for quite a while and felt like switching to someone else.

So the true nature of their partnership is touched on indirectly in the notification.

Come to think of it, there were several earlier scenes where I didn't write Chase's cleanup process... it's not that I didn't want to, it's mostly that I couldn't fit it into the plot flow... I'll need to find opportunities to work it in wherever I can.

Official Announcement of Entry into the Sheep Ranching Industry

Across the vast grassland stretches an endless expanse of green. The thick, lush carpet of grass ripples gently in the breeze, revealing a few round, white, fluffy backs, each with an equally round, plump tail hanging from its rump, grazing with heads bowed low.

The sheep, in the calm, lake-still breeze, were quietly warmed by sunlight through their thick, curly fleece... and through the pink-white skin exposed where the fleece had been yanked away.

—

Specialty of the Nest's great plains, Wool of Love——

"Alright, thank you to our sponsors. Welcome back, everyone."

The Dream Playwright's face—or rather, the Dream Playwright's absent face—reappeared before the camera.

"Welcome to the Nest Dream Television Network's special Saturday-night-at-ten program—
Dreams Have Everything! After the first episode's pilot aired, our station received an
overwhelming response. We've even landed advertisements now—thank you all, dear Residents,
for your love, and of course, most importantly, thank you to our sponsors for your love!"

It scratched at the place where a mouth should have been, but wasn't. "Saying thank you feels
so awful... sorry, we Residents aren't very used to saying nice things."

Co-host: Baby

Special guest this episode: Sydney Ginn

Highest-level security detail to ensure Sydney Ginn enters and exits in one piece: Typing
Zombie

"Why did you pick me?"

For the first time in her life, Sydney Ginn was surrounded by this many Residents; all the
color had drained from her face, and she had become White Snow Pear. "If last time went so well,
you should have invited Taylor Ford back again."

"Shh, shh." The Dream Playwright raised one index finger. "Lovely contestant Sydney Ginn,
once you've seen our first sponsor, you'll understand. And now, please welcome——"

A line of large text appeared on the screen behind them:

Bohemian Xiang

The recording studio went quiet for several seconds.

"...Mom, I have a lot of questions," Baby said, eyes closed, grumbling as she lay sprawled in
her chair.

"I'm not your mom." The Dream Playwright said fondly. "But speaking of moms—funny
enough—the person in this sponsor's name, Bohemia, has quite a connection to that very word."

Sydney Ginn crossed her arms and said, "I don't understand."

"According to our field research, this particular patron is very special—this breed, generally
speaking, only exists in dreams, so we call them Dream Sheep for short. They tip generously, and
in large amounts, but they don't actually watch our world. We've been puzzling over how to
properly express our gratitude."

The Dream Playwright gestured broadly at the stage, as if addressing no one in particular: "The character this Dream Sheep patron loves, we have no way of inviting—apparently there's something called a 'cosmic barrier,' which I don't quite understand either. But many people say your personality is a little similar to that girl named Bohemia! Come on, contestant Sydney Ginn, put this wig on."

Sydney Ginn, in a daze, put on a long, golden-brown, wavy wig.

"Put this skirt on."

Still in a daze, she pulled on a loose, long skirt; it was trimmed with fringe and gold sequins that swayed and shimmered with every movement.

"Shoes off."

Sydney Ginn obediently slipped off her dad sneakers—Bohemian style, after all.

"Now say: 'Your mom thanks you.'"

Sydney Ginn turned around and glared at the Dream Playwright. "...That's not okay, is it?"

"It is," the Dream Playwright assured her. "Or you can say 'Xiang thanks you'—pick one."

"Your mom thanks you," Sydney Ginn said, perfectly dutifully, with a bow.

After she tugged her wig-and-long-skirt ensemble back into place and sat down again, the Dream Playwright made a grand announcement for the next sponsor.

"Welcome—having been utterly won over by the irresistible charm of our Nest, completely unable to extricate themselves, repeatedly and voluntarily shedding their wool—the Tall-Tall Sheep— no, the Tall-Tall Fish!"

"Mom, do fish have wool?" Baby asked.

"I'm not your mom." The Dream Playwright said. "Fish don't normally have wool, but once they have ahhhhhh-ahhhhhh-ai——love——"

It seemed to be allergic to the word "love" in any normal context, yet still stubbornly forced that word out of its mouth—the effort made the veins on its face bulge, its arms and legs thrashed, and its whole body twisted into the shape of a fish: "...miracles can be created."

"Don't even think about making me wear a fish skin," Sydney-Snow-Pear said.

"We won't—this one has accumulated enough to warrant a bonus chapter." The Dream Playwright applauded. "Before the bonus chapter, please welcome our most popular guest, Mai Minghe!"

Mai Minghe had prepared a table full of Thanksgiving dishes at home, and had also set up a Christmas tree in the corner of the living room. Well, it wasn't Christmas yet, but the festive atmosphere had to be done properly.

Colorful light strips hung from the ceiling, casting a warm, glowing light throughout the whole house. Cookies were baking in the kitchen, and the scented candle smelled of blueberry pie. She had specifically gone out to buy a tall little fish tank, placed the Tall-Tall Fish inside, and asked, "Is the water temperature alright? Would you like some Goldfish crackers?"

"Yes," the fish said, releasing a bubble.

"This... is the sponsor a Resident?" Sydney Ginn demanded. "Why can she go inside a fish tank? And cannibalism?"

She had forgotten that special guests could customize content—the moment the words left her mouth, the fish tank instantly transformed into two Goldfish crackers drifting through the water.

"You talk so much," the Dream Playwright said, sounding almost a little regretful. "Please, keep watching."

There was a knock at the door. Mai Minghe wiped her hands on her apron, smiled with delight, and went to open it; as she stepped across the kitchen floor, a wooden plank let out a creak.

"Next up, everyone here to celebrate Thanksgiving together," the Dream Playwright announced. "Welcome Luanli, the owner of Hu Miaomiao, Mi-A-Ao, 书友20190620111919738, Shejiangjuanzai, Mamasuo-behave-with-elegance, and Csmshksdaaa! Wow, so many people all at once—there's barely room to stand."

Everyone pitched in—pouring drinks, eating cookies; Hu Miaomiao's owner brought a (slightly chubby lately) little cat (in a photo)—because of the cosmic barrier, she explained, her cat couldn't make it in person.

That said, after a few drinks down, she had Mi-A-Ao on her lap and was already petting its fur. A kind of same-species substitution, one might say.

Luanli had recently gone vegetarian (a random trait assigned by Sydney Ginn), so Mai Minghe had specially made Italian baked eggplant lasagna for her, asking, "I understand teenage rebellion, but you're still growing—is it really okay to only eat eggplant?"

"I refuse to eat meat," Luanli said, her rebellious spirit making the words come out on their own.

Shejiangjuanzai kept trying to chat with 书友20190620111919738, but every time she turned around, she couldn't find them (him? her?)—because a string of numbers is simply too well-camouflaged, especially when they drifted near the landline phone or the wall calendar, rendering them effectively invisible.

The slogan "Mamasuo—behave with elegance" caught Sydney Ginn's interest; Shejiangjuanzai followed right along, and then Csmshksdaaa joined (unpronounceable—the only way to call her over was to tug her sleeve), and together they curled up in front of the electric heater, hugging pillows, sipping hot drinks, and discussing the art of conducting oneself with elegance.

"Am I in there too?" Sydney Ginn thought it over. "Could we really arrange it this way sometime on Thanksgiving? Who is Mai Minghe, anyway? She seems quite kind... kind and warm—how did you all find her? What does she have to do with the Nest?"

The Dream Playwright suddenly went quiet.

Baby closed her eyes and pretended to fall asleep.

A dead silence fell over the recording studio, and every Resident face turned to stare at Sydney Ginn.

"Wh-what's wrong?" Sydney Ginn started to panic a little.

"Ah, we're about out of time today, but there's still a portion of the sponsor list left—we'll have to save those for next episode." The Dream Playwright abruptly stood up and clapped its hands together—clap clap clap clap—"Another successful episode, isn't that right, friends?"

"Hold on—who is Mai Minghe?" Sydney Ginn still hadn't given up.

"Mai Minghe?" the Dream Playwright asked warmly. "What Mai Minghe? Who's that?"

I'm so exhausted today—another day of only three hours of sleep. The acknowledgments list got a little too long by accident, so part of it didn't make it in... I'm sorry, I'll definitely continue

next Saturday!

Today the Silver bonus chapter is about to reach its most critical ending; the game trap I designed is almost ready to be revealed, and I have a feeling that will run very long as well... On top of that I'm also too exhausted, energy is limited, so I could only balance out the word count between the two.

Today's thank-you chapter clocks in at 2,222 characters, which demonstrates my outstanding, word-count-hitting, pure luck.

Chapter 217: Mai Minghe's Action Point and the Mayor

«Artifact Report»

Only those who have changed the world deserve the right to move forward.

This is an exclusive report specially provided to player Mai Minghe to compensate for certain disadvantages, in pursuit of balancing the situation and strength.

Dear player Mai Minghe, the following is your path to obtaining the "time" Artifact:

You will need to complete three action points.

This report contains the first action point. No more than thirty days after you complete it, you will receive a report containing the second action point.

By the same logic, once all three action points have been completed, you will receive an Artifact Report containing information and clues pointing to the target Artifact, "time."

Using this report, you will have the opportunity to obtain the "time" Artifact before other players.

Action Point 1/3:

Please sell the "Flock Over Sky" lipstick-type Artifact to Blackmoor City Mayor Oliver Mason before December 31, 2026.

Definition of "December 31, 2026":

December 31, 2026, as measured under the Gregorian calendar era standard adopted by humanity, in which time moves linearly forward, without branching or reversal.

Definition of the "Flock Over Sky" lipstick-type Artifact:

The Artifact obtained by player Mai Minghe at the Black Heart Restaurant in the Nest—

(Image of lipstick)

Definition of "Blackmoor City Mayor Oliver Mason":

Mr. Oliver Mason (Social Security Number 113-35-570), serving as Blackmoor City Mayor as of November 22, 2026, and recognized and confirmed as Blackmoor City Mayor Oliver Mason by

all informed parties, including this nation's citizens, government members, party members, news media, and so forth.

That is all.

Dear player Mai Minghe, may you succeed at the first attempt.

Mai Minghe stared blankly at the notification on her phone, reading through it once, then again, then a third time.

The information itself was straightforward, but the questions it stirred up came crashing down on her like a flash flood, leaving her in a daze for quite a while.

Was there really a need for so many definitions? Who could possibly misread something this plainly worded? The Nest somehow knew she hadn't sold the lipstick yet — how? Why would the Nest want to help the Mayor buy something? And what if he refused to buy it?

The Nest was also the type to not release the hawk until it spotted the rabbit — it wouldn't even tell her what the Artifact looked like until she completed the action point.

But soon, all those questions receded into the background; the biggest problem rose up like a rock after the floodwaters drain, pressing heavily on her mind.

How was she supposed to meet the Mayor?

She was just an ordinary citizen — no connections, no channels.

Even getting a single meeting would be nearly impossible, and yet she somehow had to seize that meeting to pitch an Artifact to him...

Through the thick fabric of her trouser pocket, Mai Minghe instinctively pressed her fingers against that small, cylindrical object.

Lucky for her that she had been swept up in tonight's unexpected events and hadn't sold the lipstick; no matter how high a price Chase could have offered, it wouldn't have been worth more than a lead on the time Artifact — if she had truly sold it, she'd be sick with regret right now.

To be honest, Mai Minghe didn't even know who the current Mayor of Blackmoor City was.

She had spent years lying in a hospital bed with the television on constantly — local news, federal news, international news cycling through one after another all day long — yet it all felt too distant to have anything to do with her. Sometimes, the moment the TV switched off, she would forget it had ever been on.

Once daylight came, she'd go buy a newspaper and see if there was anything about the Mayor.

Having a direction to work toward was better than having none at all.

With that weight off her mind, Mai Minghe let her thoughts drift, and a creeping drowsiness began to settle over her — it seemed Reed Hydes had been right: twenty hours really wasn't enough sleep.

"...A newspaper?"

On the other end of the call, Reed Hydes went momentarily blank, as though he didn't know what a newspaper was.

It sounded like he was talking to her while simultaneously tearing his place apart looking for something — the line was full of noise: a drawer sliding open, then bedsheets and blankets being shaken out hard, then the scrape of heavy furniture being shoved across the floor.

"Right, I was just heading out to buy one,"

Mai Minghe glanced at the daylight outside the window and said, "I fell back asleep too — look at that, it's already afternoon somehow. If you hadn't called, I don't know how long I would have slept."

"You're going to look up news about the Mayor... from a newspaper?"

Reed Hydes still seemed to be struggling to grasp what she meant.

He was a smart kid; Mai Minghe didn't understand why he just couldn't follow her. It must be because he was off practically demolishing his apartment on the other end of the line, too distracted to think straight.

"What if there's nothing in it?" he asked.

"Then I'll go to the library and look through old issues."

Reed Hydes let out a long sigh. "...Your phone."

Mai Minghe blinked a few times, then it suddenly clicked. "Oh!"

"Your foot injury is lighter than mine — go wait for me at the restaurant downstairs from my building. We'll talk in person. I'll send you the address." Before he hung up, Reed Hydes muttered to himself, "...This task doesn't feel like it's going to be easy."

Reed Hydes, after a full night's sleep, did not look refreshed.

His eyes were considerably clearer; but overall, he still looked like a tired person who had tried to hide their exhaustion by dusting a thin layer of powder over their face.

Reed Hydes sipped his coffee and waved Mai Minghe off — the moment she sat down, she had eagerly thrust her phone at him. "Look at this!"

He had already heard about the Artifact Report over the phone, so he first gave her a look.

"Don't you have any guard up with me at all?"

"You're not even a player — what would I be guarding against?"

"The old lady doesn't mince words," Reed Hydes muttered, then read through the notification and nodded. "I don't think this will be that hard to deal with."

"Go on," Mai Minghe encouraged.

"To find information about the Mayor, just look it up online — if he's attending any events, there'll definitely be something about it. Hmm, you don't have a SIM card right now, so let me use my phone to walk you through it."

Reed Hydes set down his coffee cup, laced his fingers together into a bridge, and rested his head on it, lost in thought for a moment. "Where do I even start so you'll understand..."

Mai Minghe looked at his hands, leaned in closer, and looked again.

"Weren't you wearing a ring before? Or am I remembering wrong?"

"Oh, you're really observant."

Reed Hydes glanced down at his hand and frowned. "You're not wrong — I was wearing a pinky ring before. But this afternoon when I woke up, it was gone. I couldn't find it anywhere, turned the whole place upside down, checked everywhere — nothing."

No wonder he'd been demolishing his apartment over the phone.

"Maybe once you stop looking, it'll turn up on its own — that's always how it goes," Mai Minghe said consolingly. "Was it valuable?"

"Nothing worth much money... but, well. It was a gift from my ex." Reed Hydes buried his face in the steam rising from his coffee. "Maybe it's the universe telling me to let the past be the past."

This kid was surprisingly sentimental.

Before Mai Minghe could figure out what to say to comfort him, he had already set down his cup, picked up his phone, and said, "That's not important anyway. Let me teach you how to use the internet first — do you know what the 'internet' is?"

"I've heard of it!" Mai Minghe said brightly. "You use it with your phone, right? Where do you buy it?"

Reed Hydes pressed his palm hard against his face.

...A young mind truly is something remarkable.

Like sitting in class, Mai Minghe carefully jotted down a row of notes in her notebook, then followed along with Reed Hydes as he walked her through what a network signal was, what wireless internet was, what an APP was... and she came away with a vague but budding sense of what Google actually was.

All that learned in under thirty minutes!

The feeling of her mind spinning without pause — and actually being able to keep up with what Reed Hydes was saying — made her genuinely happy.

Entering the Nest felt like opening a new world; learning to use the internet was no different.

Until the moment her eyes closed for the last time, there would always be new things in this world waiting to be learned.

"...So, whatever information you want to find, you just search it on Google." Reed Hydes pushed the phone toward her. "Give it a try — search Oliver Mason on Google."

Mai Minghe tapped the rectangular box, and a keyboard floated up.

She used one index finger to peck at the letters one by one; when she finished spelling it out and nothing happened, she stared blankly for a few seconds before remembering she had to tap "go" on the keyboard.

"Oh, it came up, it really came up—"

As the page jumped and a dense row upon row of text appeared, Mai Minghe felt as though she had just cast a spell — it was that simple, type in a name and all the news about the Mayor just came spilling out?

Not just text, either — there were news articles from major outlets all gathered in one place, all published just today, each one with an attached image...

Wait.

Mai Minghe froze.

She brought the screen up close to her face, wondering for a brief moment if she had done something wrong because she didn't know how to use the phone properly.

The figure appearing in most of the photos — that wasn't the Mayor, was it?

Right, it couldn't be.

No matter how times changed, a Mayor who had been voted into office still had to look presentable — at the very least, they had to look like a person; or rather, they shouldn't be appearing at public events perpetually wearing a swollen, chalk-white mask.

From the neck down, the Mayor wore a sharply pressed black suit.

From the neck up, however, was a bloated, chalk-white round face — black eyes like air holes poked in with a finger, lips curled up bright red, as though the muscles had frozen into a high, tight smile that couldn't relax — this had to be a mask; no person's face looked like that.

Short hair as black as oil flowed down from his forehead, then stopped after a few inches, as though someone had cut many long strips out of the mask.

"What's wrong?" Reed Hydes seemed to notice her expression had shifted and asked.

"I think I searched wrong," Mai Minghe held the phone up to show him. "This definitely can't be the Mayor. What did I do wrong?"

Reed Hydes reached out to take the phone and quickly scanned through the search results.

"No, that's right," he looked up with a blank expression. "That is the Mayor."

How could the Mayor possibly look like this?

No — how could any person possibly look like this?

"You can't just say that because he isn't good-looking."

Reed Hydes gave a wry smile. "The Mayor has looked like this ever since he took office. I've gotten used to it."

I recently read the new book by a male-frequency author I used to quite like — he has a lot of female readers too — and this time he completely lost me. I won't name names.

Not even two chapters in, I was stopped cold by a misogynistic description. That particular line had a massive comment section below it. I thought people might be pushing back (since there are so many female readers), but when I looked, there wasn't a single mild rebuke — just strings of "hahaha."

You think they don't know? They do. Someone even asked out of curiosity: "Where are all the little fairies?"

I closed the book. Once the unpleasantness passed, I thought about it again and compared it to the 360-degree, surround-sound verbal beatings I've taken from every corner — I was almost ready to throw a fit.

If you can't be bothered to judge men, can you also not be bothered to judge me?

If men are a lost cause, can you treat me like a lost cause too?

If you think my asking for that is me taking advantage, then clearly everyone already knows it deep down.

Chapter 218: Why Does Mai Minghe Always Come Back to Making Money?

No matter how times changed, she simply could not accept that human faces had mutated into something like this.

Mai Minghe stared at the photo, then stared at Reed Hydes, going back and forth several times, until at last a theory took shape — she had been partially Resident-ified and had grown 0.7 of a new head; could that have produced some kind of effect on her?

Perhaps the mayor that Reed Hydes saw was a perfectly normal-looking person.

"Describe him," she said. "What does the mayor look like?"

What if the photo Reed Hydes saw looked different from what she was seeing — could her perception even be fixed?

"What's there to describe? His face is very pale, very round, puffy and bloated, like it's been soaked and swollen."

Reed Hydes took a sip of coffee and said, quite naturally, "Eyes tiny, like two little black holes. Honestly, he's just not good-looking at all... The fact that we elected him mayor maybe just goes to show that we people of Blackmoor City are especially open-minded."

Mai Minghe found the situation even harder to make sense of now.

Whether Blackmoor City people were especially open-minded, she couldn't say; especially blind, though — that seemed to be the case.

This was clearly not a human face.

"How many years has he been in office?"

"Two or three years now? Don't let his looks put you off — he's quite the political star. Rumor has it he's eyeing a run for governor. Plenty of people think his ambitions lie in the White House."

Mai Minghe truly wished that when she was lying in the hospital bed, she'd had more time to watch the news and memorize what the mayor looked like — no, wait, that wasn't right; if she'd seen it then, she might have had a heart attack.

She kept scrolling down the page (for some reason, the page never scrolled as smoothly under her fingers as it did under Reed Hydes'), and found another piece of news from a few days ago near the bottom.

As a follow-up to the capture of the "Subway Serial Killer," Mayor Oliver Mason announced that he would dispatch additional patrol officers to strengthen public safety in the subway system; she tapped to open it and found, in the photo, several unfamiliar faces.

"Who's in this photo?" Mai Minghe asked.

In a news story where the mayor was the main subject, there was no mayor in the photo?

"You're really strange," Reed Hydes glanced at the photo, then shot a suspicious look at Mai Minghe. "Are you messing with me? The one in the middle — isn't that the mayor?"

Mai Minghe was beginning to suspect this was some elaborate prank he had set up to make a fool of her.

Even if she wasn't familiar with modern technology, that was no reason to play tricks on an old woman like this.

"They look completely different!"

"They look the same," Reed Hydes said.

"How can they be the same — they're clearly not."

"They're clearly the same," Reed Hydes said, eyes going wide.

"They're clearly not—" Mai Minghe swallowed the last two words.

Going back and forth like a pair of squabbling children, they could argue until nightfall.

"Then describe for me what the mayor in this photo looks like."

Reed Hydes looked at the photo, clearly puzzled, but complied.

"Let's see — a square face, perfectly angular, dark skin. Eyes not very big, like two holes poked into the surface. Honestly, not what you'd call good-looking."

...Mai Minghe was now almost certain he was pranking her.

But even though she and Reed Hydes hadn't known each other long, they'd been through quite a few life-or-death situations together, and he didn't seem like the kind of person who'd pull something so thoughtless.

"You don't notice that your own descriptions contradict each other?"

"They don't," Reed Hydes said, looking completely blank.

Infuriating.

"Hold on a moment,"

She grabbed the phone, tossed Reed Hydes a quick word, and hurried over to the register of the small diner connected to the breakfast bar, where she asked the plump female server, "Could you take a look at these two photos for me?"

Whether to call it surprising or unsurprising, she wasn't sure — the server's descriptions of the two different photos of the mayor were identical to Reed Hydes'.

The one wearing the snow-white mask, in her eyes, simply had snow-white skin; and when she saw the mayor with his normal appearance, she knew his skin was dark.

And yet even the nearby diners who had heard and craned their necks over out of curiosity all said, in one voice, that both photos showed the same person — Mayor Oliver Mason.

Even when their contradictory descriptions were pointed out to them, not one of them showed any reaction at all.

"If you really want to push it," the server said, "the skin tone is slightly different in shade, but people's complexions naturally get a bit darker or lighter depending on whether they've been out in the sun — that's totally normal."

...This business was definitely connected to the Nest and Artifacts.

Artifacts could be anything; there was no reason there couldn't be one capable of altering a person's appearance.

If Mayor Oliver Mason, for whatever reason, wanted to change his appearance while still needing others to continue recognizing him as the mayor, then simply changing his own face wouldn't be enough — other people's perception would have to be altered as well.

But how had it been done?

And why hadn't she been affected?

Could it be that her near-Resident-ification had produced some kind of effect in her body — something like a vaccine?

Mai Minghe sat back down, her mind full of unanswered questions, and set the phone on the table.

"You went and asked around, so you know I wasn't lying to you," Reed Hydes, who had caught bits of it from a distance, now wore the expression of someone whose grievance had finally been vindicated.

"This is too strange," Mai Minghe said. "I—"

Before she could finish, she glanced down and startled; the phone screen had somehow been taken over entirely by the mayor's dark, broad face.

"How did this—"

"Oh, you probably touched it by accident and zoomed in." Reed Hydes showed her how to zoom in and out. "See, if you slide it like this, you can see details in other parts — no, use two fingers — together, together, slide them at the same time, don't lift and place them one at a time."

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes out of habit and examined the mayor's face carefully.

In both of Reed Hydes' and the others' descriptions just now, both photos had one thing in common: "the mayor's eyes are very small, like little black air holes."

But the real Oliver Mason's eyes were not large, it was true — yet not quite to the degree of air holes. On that point, Mai Minghe now had a faint inkling of understanding.

With the image zoomed in, she could barely make it out: a faint, sparse white mist was drifting in from the right side of the photo, settling softly over the mayor's eyes.

...It was almost as if something were reaching its hand into the old photographs, altering them little by little.

This guess was quickly confirmed.

Using the 22nd — today — as the baseline, the further back she went day by day, the less "masked" the mayor appeared in the photos.

The mayor from last month, even by Reed Hydes' description, had eyes that were "narrow and elongated, not particularly large or small."

But this time, Reed Hydes finally showed a trace of confusion: "Hm? He seems a little different last month somehow? I can't quite put my finger on what's off... Did he get some work done? Did he go get filler injections this month?"

What on earth.

All in all, based on this, it could reasonably be concluded that the mayor's "maskification" had occurred on the 22nd.

This change was gradually eroding past records of the mayor, altering his appearance in those records bit by bit; and as the records changed, people's perceptions were further twisted and reinforced.

No wonder the Nest handed down so many definitions, like a chatterbox that never shuts up.

The Nest didn't want her to hesitate, didn't want her to be unsure about who the mayor was.

According to the Artifact Report's definition of the mayor, she was supposed to sell the lipstick to today's snow-white face — the Nest wanted the lipstick to end up in his hands.

But why?

Mai Minghe couldn't arrive at an answer, because there was far too much information she was missing.

"No matter what he looks like, what you need to do hasn't changed."

Reed Hydes reminded her, pointing at the news page on the phone. "Look at this article... He's set to sign a welfare housing expansion project on the 28th of this month."

"Something like that he'd normally just sign in his office — it's not like we can barge in."

Reed Hydes paused. "'We'?"

"I."

She shouldn't keep dragging him along everywhere — his foot was still injured, after all.

"Generally speaking, an ordinary citizen who simply asks to meet the mayor won't be seen," Reed Hydes offered a suggestion. "But for a project like this — something to showcase his political achievements — wherever he signs it, he'll definitely invite the media in to photograph and publicize it, otherwise what's the point of signing? If you could slip in among the press personnel and go in with them, you'd be able to see him."

Not a bad idea — but how would she slip in?

It was too late to go apply for a job now.

To that, Reed Hydes gave a simple shrug and gave up cleanly: "I don't know anyone in the media, so I can't help you there. But if you want to try, 'Between the Backlights' might be able to connect you with someone — there might even be a useful Artifact."

Worth a try — but where would she get the money?

Selling the lipstick was originally supposed to bring in emergency funds; and now, she'd have to earn money first before she could even figure out how to sell it.

This adventurous new life — how did the beginning look so different from what she'd imagined, with money being a problem at every turn?

She also had no wish to ask Reed Hydes for a loan; no matter how good a person someone was, the moment money entered the relationship, things had a way of going sour.

Watching her look so worried, Reed Hydes could only throw out a blind suggestion: "You only have the one Artifact? Nothing else you can sell?"

"Nothing," Mai Minghe said. "That one trip into the Nest, I only came out with one thing — wait?"

She snapped her head up.

It was true that she'd only come out of the Nest with one lipstick Artifact; but that wasn't the only thing she'd come away with.

"'Between the Backlights' bar... do they buy information?"

Mai Minghe asked tentatively: "The Nest stuffed so much information into my head — surely some portion of it must be useful to someone. If I answered questions for Hunters, gave them leads, shared what I know, would anyone be willing to pay for that?"

Yesterday everyone gave me such a warm outpouring of comfort, I felt almost embarrassed. Can you understand that feeling? It's like when a child cries and throws a little tantrum, not really expecting anything to come of it, and then mom and dad turn around and buy them a trip to Disneyland...

Happy, and warm, and a little ashamed all at once... all this fuss over me...

P.S.: The Silver Arc bonus chapters are finally all posted! I wanted to design a scheme worthy of the Silver Arc — whether I pulled it off or not, I honestly don't know, but it's done... Feel free to go check it out, it's in the original work's related chapters volume.

Chapter 219: Mai Minghe's Thirty Subjects of the Nest and Over-Packaging

"...Running this kind of pay-to-learn scheme, how much do you really expect to make?"

Megan was not the least bit tactful.

A few minutes earlier, when she opened the bar door and saw Mai Minghe, her first words of greeting were—"You again!"

It wasn't yet opening time for the bar; she was cleaning up, getting ready for the night.

The bar was dim and quiet on all sides, the air carrying the feel of having been battered and trampled by countless people—a crumpled, weary quality—so different from when Mai Minghe had visited yesterday that it barely seemed like the same place.

Mai Minghe had assumed her proposal would catch Megan completely off guard and send her rushing to post the news—and off guard she was, sure enough—but what Megan picked up wasn't her phone. It was a mop.

"There are thousands upon thousands of pieces of Nest information, and everyone who comes back from the Nest brings a piece of it with them. The vast majority of that information gets exchanged when hunters drink and chat and compare notes... People need to communicate, after all—you can't expect to only open your mouth when you see money on the table, or nobody's going to want to deal with you. The stuff that's left over, the kind people actually want to sell—that only really falls into two categories."

She let the two people with injured feet sit in a booth, then dunked the mop into the bucket and wrung it out hard.

It was like a peculiar little lecture.

Megan, the retired hunter who worked at the bar, had watched the world turn so many times that it seemed like all you had to do was find a loose thread and give it a gentle tug, and out would unspool great tangled masses of thought and observation—a bit scattered, perhaps, but solid.

"One type is information that's been fabricated, exaggerated, or embellished for one reason or another—could be true, could be false, but it's almost always sensational, designed to hook someone's curiosity and fetch a few dollars. The other type is information that's genuinely valuable—but that value tends to have a ceiling. Generally speaking, no more than five hundred dollars."

"Only five hundred?" Mai Minghe was startled.

"A certain road in the Nest has gotten dangerous, or some new Resident has shown up somewhere... that kind of news won't even fetch five hundred—two or three hundred is about what you'd get for it. And it has to be fresh. Anything more than a month old and the price drops to nothing."

"How can that be," Mai Minghe said, indignant even if not entirely on her own behalf: "Isn't knowledge the most precious thing there is?"

Megan tilted her chin up and stared at the ceiling for a moment. "That's a really old-fashioned thing to say. I haven't heard it much since I graduated elementary school."

Reed Hydes cleared his throat and said quietly, "Times are different. We're in an era of information explosion now... an astronomical flood of information, the good mixed in with the bad—how can any of it be precious? Even within hunter circles, it seems like once the internet came along, information blew up geometrically overnight."

Mai Minghe thought back to how, when she had just searched for the Mayor, over ten thousand results had come up—in a fraction of a second.

"Information that's truly high-value will never be put up for sale."

Megan slapped the mop head down onto the floor with a loud smack and said, "Information that could be traded for an Artifact, for instance—who would sell that? Or a complete walkthrough for a trap—those do exist, but they're rare, and you can't verify them without staking your own life on them—so that kind of information is generally kept in the hands of the House Factions."

She dragged the mop across the floor as she spoke. "Oh, and there's one more situation: when someone happens to have that specific need. No matter how useless a piece of information is, the moment someone wants to know it, it immediately has value... Value is something people assign. We actually had an example here at the bar—someone sold information about the Vulture Resident mutation to the Key House Faction. Word is they got quite a lot for it."

All well and true—but did that mean Mai Minghe had no choice but to wait around for someone who happened to need the information she had?

Her window for action only ran until December 31st...

"Of course, I'm not saying I can't get the word out for you—I'm just giving you a fair warning. You suddenly show up claiming to be a 'Nest encyclopedia'—"

"Encyclopedia is a stretch. If I had to put a number on it, maybe thirty or forty subjects," Mai Minghe cut in. "I wasn't a Resident for very long, after all."

"Fine, 'thirty subjects of the Nest,'" Megan said. "Like I said, it's sensational enough—but people who are actually willing to pay, to pay a lot, and then verify the accuracy and reliability themselves afterward—there are probably far fewer of them than you think."

It seemed that no matter the era, making money was always daunting.

"If it weren't for your injured foot, I'd almost suggest going back into the Nest," Reed Hydes sighed. "The odds of coming out with an Artifact seem better than this."

If she went back into the Nest, the risks wouldn't come from the foot injury alone.

Mai Minghe could practically picture it: the moment she set foot in the Nest, word would spread through the Residents instantly; who knew how many of them, wanting to eliminate her from the Nest Domination Game, would come surging toward her like a tide.

Strange, really—she had no desire to win the Domination Game, yet the Residents were so intent on targeting her.

Mai Minghe tucked her hands in and, much like Reed Hydes, felt her energy deflate a little. "Well... regardless, go ahead and register me first."

Megan took out her phone and began editing a message with flying fingers.

"Individual who became a Resident and subsequently returned to human form... claims to possess extensive Nest information, available for paid consultation... Does that work? Our bar takes no responsibility for verifying the accuracy of any information—buyers and sellers meet in person, and all risk is assumed by the parties involved."

Mai Minghe glanced at it, said "that works," then thought of something else.

"I'm not necessarily looking only for money," she said. "If someone is willing to make a trade—getting me an audience with the Mayor would work too."

If Reed Hydes had wanted to stop her, he was already a step too late—Megan's head snapped up.

"Why do you want to see the Mayor?" A light flashed into her eyes.

Probably an occupational habit left over from her hunter days—whenever something interesting came up, she wanted to dig to the bottom of it—but Mai Minghe saw no reason whatsoever to be evasive about any of this.

Aside from the Nest Domination Game, which she shouldn't mention, everything else she could say openly; doing so would actually leave less room for people to suspect or speculate.

The best way to keep people from prying was to be forthright yourself.

"I want to sell him the lipstick."

Reed Hydes turned to look at the wall, as though her frankness left him at a loss for what to do with himself.

"Why does it have to be the Mayor specifically?" Megan pressed.

Mai Minghe thought it over. "I heard the Mayor seems to have a need for this kind of Artifact."

That was no lie—the Nest must have decided he needed it, or it wouldn't have tasked Mai Minghe with selling the lipstick to him.

"Hmm, that's actually quite possible," Megan nodded, as if she found it reasonable enough. "And he'd certainly be able to afford the price. Alright, let me add a line... There—take a look, and if it's good, I'll post it."

Since she was selling the lipstick to the Mayor, the earlier posting about the lipstick Artifact would need to be taken down as well.

"Oh, what a shame to lose that sale," Megan said with genuine regret. "The service fee we get when information changes hands is nothing compared to what we get when an Artifact does..."

The internal commission structure of the bar seemed to be its own world of complexity; the staff all seemed remarkably motivated to drum up and broker deals.

"Can you send me the earlier listing you posted about the lipstick?"

As Mai Minghe listened to herself, she noticed she was using the same vocabulary as young people—and even though she still found many of these concepts fuzzy, she felt both a fresh wonder and a sense of disbelief. "Maybe I can make use of it."

That day, she had used her "Mai Minghe" identity documents to say she was opening a contract for her grandmother, and had just obtained her very first phone number that was truly

her own—she was still pleased about it; her contacts list currently had only Reed Hydes in it, and she felt it was too lonely, so she absolutely had to exchange numbers with Megan too, to give her two numbers some company.

"Sent it to you," Megan said. "But I deleted the photos I took earlier—the ones I re-downloaded are a bit too blurry. Better if you take some new ones yourself."

Words like "download" were mostly lost on Mai Minghe; the only part she understood was that she should retake the photos.

Good—Reed Hydes had just taught her how to take pictures, and she was still excited about it, always itching to try.

Earlier she had taken quite a few photos: pigeons huddled together eating garbage, a dachshund in a cartoon character costume, a window pane shattered into a spiderweb crack yet still stubbornly holding in its frame, a row of bicycles—all blue—that she was told had to be shared and ridden by others...

Anyway, everything in the lens looked interesting; by the end of it, Reed Hydes was urging her: "Can you take something useful for once?"

Something useful—well, here was her chance.

She immediately thrust her hand into her pants pocket and grabbed the lipstick—

Every hair on her body suddenly stood on end.

That split-second alertness and chill came so suddenly that before she could process what was wrong, she had already dropped the lipstick onto the table with a thud, its weight thudding against the surface.

By lipstick standards, this Artifact was quite finely crafted—even the cap was metal...

Three pairs of eyes landed on the table, watching the lipstick cap roll in circles, then come to a stop.

...Just the cap.

I got into an argument with a reader earlier, and thinking about it now, even if I disagreed, I could have handled the comment more gently. I left a reply expressing my apology, and I'll make sure to be more mindful going forward. That said, I have a lot of work stress, my sleep schedule is

a mess, and sometimes my temper gets the better of me and I get worked up over things—if you catch me doing that, just give me a nudge and I'll get the message.

It's Christmas Eve today! Sorry this update is so late again... My update schedule is honestly just like my sleep schedule—goes around the clock. Does everyone have plans for Christmas Eve and Christmas? My Christmas plan is: writing + keeping a client's entire family company. Surely you're all doing better than me?

Merry Christmas everyone! Come open your Christmas present!

To the music of "Happy Birthday," dear readers, please open the New Year's card I've carefully prepared for you!

Tucked inside the card is a slip of paper—you open it, and oh—it's a "delayed update" excuse note.

Doesn't "delayed update" sound so much better than just taking the day off?

I call this shameless tenderness.

I've written about 800 words of the new chapter, but I didn't have time to finish it—the client's family of four is already assembled, just waiting for me to go perform my circus act (not really).

I can't wrap my head around this logic—why would you drag your whole family across the miles to spend Christmas with a company you do business with...

The déjà vu of suddenly barging into someone else's family life and settling in to celebrate the holidays and wrangle children together—what kind of karma did I accumulate to deserve this...

I am so bad with kids aaaaaaaaa what do I do aaaaaaa

I already find socializing with adults extremely strenuous, completely draining—and now you want me to deal with children, what on earth is happening aaaaaaaaa

Can I trip and fall on the way there to get out of it? If so, I just might.

I'm always complaining about how painful it is to write, but I would rather stay home and crank out ten thousand words a day for all of you (come on, I'm just saying—it's Christmas, can't I make a wish?), than go entertain a client's entire family.

An. Entire. Family.

What am I, an all-ages television program?

Maybe I should bring a book (lol).

Do you think they'd catch me reading under the table during dinner (lol).

Do you all have any tips, dear readers?

Chapter 220: Sydney Ginn, Sydney Ginn's Shell, and the Lipstick Without Its Shell

She had a very clear understanding of herself.

She was someone quick with words, emotionally expressive, and fast-paced—she could chat easily with anyone, was easy to approach, and always loved to gravitate toward people.

A personality like that, paired with her face—Sydney Ginn knew that in others' eyes, she looked like a naive, lively little creature. Just as a beauty can hardly be unaware of her own beauty, she was equally clear on the impression she made on others.

That impression was the shell she wore as she moved through the world; honestly, it had afforded her a great many conveniences.

Used well, she could even slip free of a murder suspicion.

It was a shell, yet it was also a part of her.

Only—if she were truly, completely the same inside and out, she never could have done what she did back then—

Ah, she couldn't think about that.

Here she was, with a submachine gun muzzle trained squarely on her body, and yet Sydney Ginn had drifted into a wholly ill-timed daze, her thoughts scattering like fine mist drifting through a rainy night, vanishing into some vast and unknown distance.

Perhaps there were "viewers" watching her right now, listening to her lay herself bare, quietly weighing what kind of person she was.

No matter what, she couldn't let herself think about what happened back then...

Fortunately, there was no shortage of things to distract her at the moment.

"...You lied to me?"

Chase's words came out of nowhere and snapped her back to her senses.

"Huh?"

"You said your only goal was money."

Chase stood four or five paces away, holding the gun in one hand; looking closely, the muzzle was actually trembling slightly—it seemed he was nearly spent as well.

"Did you lie to me, or did you change your mind and decide to compete with me?"

Sydney Ginn let out an "ah," understanding dawning on her somewhat, and looked down at the black cube in her hand.

It was roughly the size of a Rubik's cube, small enough to hold in one hand; her other hand was still gripping her phone.

On the screen, a message congratulating her on obtaining the target Artifact had been cut off mid-sentence by a single word—"wait"—and now the phone was silent, as if holding its breath too, waiting to see how this scene would play out.

Earlier, in the middle of the car chase, she had felt her body go inexplicably light, and then once again she was split into countless component parts; she and Tianxi together, inside the Black Cube's space, wobbling and swaying as they each dissolved into two large "clusters" of people.

Perhaps because her memories had been fragmented along with everything else, whenever she tried to recall what had happened inside the Black Cube, it was always hazy and indistinct, the details blurred; she only vaguely remembered that Chase hadn't seemed to be in there—she had no idea how he'd gotten out, or what he'd done while outside.

All she remembered was that at some point, after what felt like an unknown stretch of time, the world flipped, and some force flung her back out onto the road.

The pain of that moment sent a whole string of curses rolling through her mind.

What kind of garbage contraption was this—ever heard of handling things gently? Absolutely no manners.

The instant she was thrown out, Sydney Ginn felt like a cartoon character stuffed into a cannon barrel and fired—boom—and it was only thanks to her extensive experience with falling from the air that she managed to adjust her body in time and roll with the landing, avoiding any serious injury.

Even so, the impact still blacked out her vision for a moment, the air driven clean out of her.

Lucky...that was Sydney Ginn's first thought as she climbed to her feet.

Lucky that when she was thrown out, the height wasn't enough to send her straight into the Nest; that would have been an absolutely terrible stroke of luck.

"What happened?" she sucked in a sharp breath, steadied herself, and called out from a distance. "What's going on?"

"I'll explain in a bit," Chase said—he was a good ten-plus meters away from her at the time, holding his phone as a flashlight, sweeping it in circles across the road in search of something.

Through the thin curtain of drizzle, the Cross-Sea Bridge loomed behind him, its air thick with mist that soaked countless headlights and streetlamps into red and white smears of light, stretching away into the distance; the faraway wail of sirens, the blare of car horns, the murmur of voices, the occasional click of a phone camera shutter—the disturbed bridge and road had become a stage backdrop.

Behind her, a car burning like a bonfire flickered in and out of brightness in the rain; the cold rain evaporating into steam, billowing up thick white fog that seeped through heaven and earth, making everything feel like another world entirely, nothing like the real one.

"Tianxi,"

Not far from her, Tianxi had barely finished groaning his way upright before his boss handed him a task—"Go tie up that bodyguard on the ground and put him in the car."

Only then did Sydney Ginn notice there was someone lying in the distance on the ground.

Tianxi acknowledged the order and dragged his rain-soaked body over toward the figure; she had just formed the thought—"wonder how much Key House pays, for people to work this hard"—when she heard Chase call out to her again: "Sydney Ginn! Stay away from that truck."

She turned around and only then realized that the giant truck nearby seemed to have stopped on its own without incident; through the cab window, she could dimly make out a face pressing hard against the glass, peering at her.

Though she had no idea what role she'd ended up playing tonight, Sydney Ginn still didn't want the truck driver to remember her face, so she called back in acknowledgment and walked forward.

For some reason, she felt somewhat in a daze—it wasn't just her body moving through the rain and mist, but her mind as well, soaked through, spreading out in all directions, momentarily weightless and unmoored, without any center.

She must have hit her head when she fell.

Sydney Ginn lowered her head and rubbed the back of her skull, rotating her neck back and forth, hoping to ease some of the effects—and as she turned, her gaze was suddenly caught by something square and angular.

She paused, walked over two steps, and picked up a black cube-like square from beside the rear wheel of the truck.

...No way?

Every Hunter instinct she had buzzed to life, telling her this was an Artifact.

Whether it was from the fall or from the intensity of the feeling, she felt momentarily dizzy and lightheaded, the ringing in her ears reverberating deep into her skull—so much so that it was quite a while before she heard someone calling her name nearby.

"Sydney Ginn!"

She looked up to find Chase standing not far away, one hand reaching out toward her. The submachine gun hung from his other hand, muzzle pointed down at the road. "Hand it over."

If she had still been her usual self, she would have recognized the delicacy—and danger—of the situation at a glance.

But her foggy, unsteady attention shifted at that moment to something else entirely—she remembered that she'd heard her phone ring just now.

That usually lively, talkative shell of hers seemed to have cracked from the impact of the fall, splitting open, no longer fitting quite right; she looked at Chase, said nothing, expression blank, and lowered her head to fish her phone out of her pants pocket and glanced at it.

...The Nest was congratulating her on obtaining the target Artifact?

The Nest said, wait?

Wait for what?

By the time Sydney Ginn belatedly raised her head, she was looking straight down the barrel of a gun pointed at her.

The anger came a beat late, but it came.

"Sydney Ginn"—the "Sydney Ginn" the world knew as quick-tongued and sharp—would at this moment be doing both: backing down and flying into a rage at the same time. She absolutely would not calmly explain herself and hand over the Black Cube.

"What do you mean I lied to you?" She raised her voice, the words coming out faster than a bullet: "I zoned out for a second—how does that make me a liar?"

"...Give me the Black Cube." Chase and the gun muzzle didn't move an inch.

"Fine, I'll give it to you—like I care about your stupid thing."

Sydney Ginn raised her hand and flung the Black Cube over, watching him snap it out of the air with a sharp crack.

"You think I don't know my own situation? I have no money, I don't belong to any House Faction, and I certainly don't have a bunch of subordinates to do my bidding. I'm not a powerful competitor, and I couldn't be bothered to dominate anyone—so I thought you were a good partner, someone who could help me get the most out of this. "

Chase gripped the Black Cube and lowered the gun—both of their phones began buzzing at the same time, but neither of them looked.

He watched her, and said nothing.

"I know my position isn't as strong as yours, but you don't have to remind me of it at every turn. I happened to find it, and I handed it to you a few seconds late—so what? If I wanted to compete with you, I could have just let you die back at the hospital, couldn't I? If you think I'm going to look for a chance to trip you up at any moment, then why even work with me—go it alone! All the help I've given you up to now, and I've barely seen any benefit from it, and now you're pointing a gun at me on top of that—I owe you something?"

Chase looked almost as if he'd been stunned into silence by that torrent of words hitting him all at once.

"You're making me furious," Sydney Ginn grew angrier the more she spoke, her face flushing, and she turned on her heel and walked away. "Get out of my way! I'm going home."

"You don't have a car—"

"No car but I've still got legs, haven't I? Can't I get off the bridge and catch a cab?" She walked past Chase without looking back. "Think everyone's like you, staggering with every step?"

And it was me who held you up, no less."

Tianxi had just finished stuffing someone into the back of the SUV; he stared at her, mouth half-open, looking somewhat dumbstruck.

A few steps later, Sydney Ginn thought of the most important question.

"You have my account number. What you owe me for saving your life—that's on you to decide. However much you think your life is worth, that's how much you transfer. If you give me nothing, I won't come after it either, and I'll just go around telling everyone that Chase Monroe's life—"

She swallowed back the word "dog" and said: "—is worth not a single cent. His own words."

Sydney Ginn marched off briskly, powered along by her fury, and tossed back one last line: "I wish you and the Nest a hundred years of happiness!"

No one called after her from behind, and no one fired a shot at her.

As she walked past Tianxi, he was staring at something behind her; whatever expression was on his face, it snagged something in her, and Sydney Ginn stopped and turned to look back.

A dozen or so steps away, Chase was still standing where he'd been, watching her; through the rain, she couldn't make out his expression, only that he seemed to have been in a daze just now, lost in some unknown thought.

Their gazes met across the distance, and Chase seemed to come back to himself.

"I'm about to take June to see the mayor," he said, his voice low. "Aren't you coming?"

June—who had been lurking somewhere nearby this whole time, heaven only knew where—the moment those words were spoken, immediately surfaced from the roadside; through the dim rain and mist, a pale, wide face rose up.

"Hey," June waved at her.

Beneath the shell, a wariness rose.

Was Chase testing her?

Completing the action point of "bringing June to see the mayor" would unlock the hint for the next target Artifact.

If she had no great ambition to dominate the Nest, yet still insisted on going along and incidentally completing the action point, that would be suspicious.

This train of thought was not reflected in the "shell."

"Why would I go—is your face worth looking at, or hers, or the mayor's? I haven't seen a single cent, I've already done more than enough, I'm not going, only a fool would keep playing escort for you."

Tianxi drew in a sharp breath.

Chase didn't get angry.

"Tianxi," he simply turned and said, "let's clean up the scene around here. Time to go."

That meant she was no longer his concern, right?

Sydney Ginn crossed her arms and walked out along the bridge.

She'd gone barely half a minute when she heard Tianxi calling after her from behind, hurrying to catch up.

"What is it?" Sydney Ginn asked.

"This—is this your Artifact?" Tianxi held up something that looked like a cylindrical tube and showed it to her.

Oh, so it wasn't Chase sending money after all.

The rain and mist blurred her vision; she only glanced at it once, and felt a strange sensation—like she recognized it, yet had truly never seen it before.

"Not mine," Sydney Ginn said, with little patience for Chase's subordinate either. She liked money, but she wouldn't take things that belonged to others.

"Probably those two from just now," Tianxi said, and pocketed it. "I'll bring it back and put it in the House Faction warehouse."

Happy post-Christmas, everyone!

I'd originally thought a brief, passing mention of the scene on the Cross-Sea Bridge would suffice, but after careful consideration, I decided it wouldn't do.

I really enjoy exploring different facets and complexities of my characters—I don't like writing flat, label-ready people. Sydney Ginn is more complex than her surface suggests, and that's

something I truly love about her.

Of course, attempting to capture human complexity doesn't guarantee it will be understood or accepted—boil it down and it's still just a label... Ahem, well, whether it's Hamlet or Harry Potter, I can't control that. I'll write what I need to write.

Chapter 221 — Sydney Ginn's Daydreams and "Who Even Is This Guy"

The sleep she should have gotten after returning from the Nest—she hadn't gotten nearly enough of it, jolted awake by a man's voice in her dream.

She had followed along through an entire night of heart-stopping excitement to rescue Chase, and when Sydney Ginn finally made it home, she found it was barely four in the morning—she simply couldn't believe it. So much had happened in just a few hours?

If she hadn't gone the whole time without seeing the sun, she'd have believed anyone who told her a full day had passed.

Sydney Ginn stumbled through her front door like a zombie, collapsed onto the sofa first thing, buried her face in a pillow, and lay there dead for a while.

Only when she felt the throw pillow was nearly soaked through with her breath did she piece together what little energy she had left, resurrect herself, and get up to check on her things.

Good—everything that should be there was there; at least nothing important was lost. The custom-made hammer weapon was nestled safely in her backpack as well.

Who would have thought that the moment it was finished, she'd put it to use right away—her first real combat experience, gained right here in relatively safe Blackmoor City. Truly unexpected.

Hey, maybe her luck wasn't half bad after all?

Sydney Ginn tossed her backpack aside, changed out of her filthy, soaked clothes, scrubbed herself clean in a thorough hot shower, feeling every last crease in her body soak loose and unfurl. Afterward, she wrapped herself in a towel, steam rising off her skin, downed a huge glass of cold fruit juice in several long gulps, and burrowed back under the covers.

...Being a Hunter was absolutely exhausting—tiring inside the Nest, and tiring once you were back.

She held her phone and looked over the several new deposits in her account, tallying them one by one in her head: the payment for selling information on the Vulture, one payment for the trip to the cemetery, another for spreading the information... all the little bits added together came to nearly twenty thousand dollars.

Chase's life-money, though, was nowhere to be seen for the moment.

To pocket this much in a day or two without even needing to enter the Nest—that wasn't bad at all...

These past two days following Chase had been about as dangerous as the Nest itself, but the biggest difference was that no one could be sure they'd find an Artifact on any given trip into the Nest—bad luck could have you going a dozen times and coming back empty-handed. Seen that way, Chase was marginally better than the Nest.

She hadn't cursed him out too badly tonight, had she? The life-money was still coming, right?

Come to think of it... where had that voice in the dream come from?

It was almost like it had been specifically introducing her to money-making work... rather thoughtful of it... she wouldn't mind if it came back a few more times...

In a haze of mild contentment, Sydney Ginn let her eyes drift shut.

It wasn't until the next day that she realized she had always been, at heart, an ordinary person who had never truly come into contact with wealth.

After getting up, she reached for her phone out of habit, as she always did, and scrolled blearily for a while.

The first thing she saw was a major Nest progress notification from the night before—she had no idea why the Nest hated Chase so much; the moment it saw him claim two target Artifacts, it looked ready to send Residents burrowing into Blackmoor City just to slap him senseless and knock everything off him.

...If you dislike him that much, why invite him to join in the first place?

Aren't you afraid the final winner of the Domination Game might actually be Chase?

She'd caught a few lines directed at her from the Nest as well—something about using her body to block gunfire—and it made her blood boil just reading it.

Whether the Nest favored you or despised you, neither was a good thing.

The Nest never treated anyone well. As far as it was concerned, every human being was garbage long overdue for dismantling and recycling—raw material to be repurposed into building blocks for the Nest.

The Nest was born from people, and the thing the Nest hated most was people.

And it seemed to hate only people.

She'd heard before that someone had fallen into the Nest while holding a pet cat—the person died without question, but the cat lived on in the care of various Residents and died peacefully of old age, and by all accounts continued to live on inside the Nest even after death. It didn't sound like something that could happen; but inside the Nest, anything was possible.

Of course, that was just an urban legend among Hunters. No one would ever carry an animal inside to test it.

Sydney Ginn let out a sigh.

She wasn't an exceptionally gifted Hunter.

A large part of how gifted a Hunter was came down to what their passage was like.

The simpler and easier the passage, the better the talent—a simple passage into the Nest meant a person could maintain maximum alertness, focus, and energy; it also meant they could withdraw as quickly as possible when danger arose.

Like a snowball rolling downhill, starting from that foundation of the passage, given sufficiently capable Hunters, the advantage only grew larger and larger.

A Hunter who could enter the Nest whenever they pleased and leave just as easily would accumulate an understanding, perception, and experience of the Nest that a Hunter with a broken passage like Sydney Ginn's could simply never match.

And what about her?

Unless she drank until she was dizzy and numb, she simply couldn't work up the nerve to jump off a building; and no matter how many times she jumped, after landing she always needed a long recovery period before she could barely function normally again.

Sydney Ginn knew perfectly well that compared to Brianna, Chase, and Taylor Ford from Wellesley's team, she held no advantage whatsoever.

If she wanted to win the Domination Game, she would be the first target to be eliminated.

The risk and reward were completely out of proportion—the best strategy was to extract solid, real-world gains for herself from the competition process. Whether Chase ultimately won the game was a distant, uncertain thing; but regardless of how it ended for him, the money coming into Sydney Ginn's account right now was hard and real.

If Chase wasn't going to play fair, Brianna would do just as well.

If Brianna was out of reach, Taylor Ford would work too... though Taylor Ford was only a Director hired by the Morgan House Faction, so mobilizing resources might not be as flexible as with the other two.

Sydney Ginn had been looking after herself since before she was an adult. Sometimes, when she looked at other people—and at herself—she was a little like the Black Cube: she'd break a person down into many separate resource packages.

Which one could be traded for what, and which one would need what—she understood all of it.

Ever since she'd been drafted in, she'd gained an enormously valuable resource package in the eyes of the other contestants: "a contestant who can access another portion of the Domination Game's information."

How to maximize its use while keeping herself safe—that was the strategy she truly needed to take after entering the Domination Game.

...Strange, she thought, drifting off as she made herself lunch.

When she went out with friends, she was sincerely happy; when she saw someone meet with misfortune, she sincerely worried.

She liked people—especially good-looking ones. She liked catching the scent of a person, liked the feel of skin against skin, always wanted to know what was happening in someone else's life, what they were thinking, what they would say next. She found it all endlessly interesting.

Even Chase—Sydney Ginn liked him well enough, could chat happily with him for hours, and on top of that he was easy on the eyes. In short, all of it was sincere.

But the moment she turned away, she could forget it all.

As though none of the sincerity had ever been there.

Sydney Ginn put a few chips in her mouth, the crisp crunch briefly swallowing the sound of the TV.

Her thoughts had always been like a runaway horse—she'd be thinking about one thing and find herself somewhere else entirely without knowing how she got there. She'd been idly snacking

on chips like that for a while, and when she finally registered what she'd just heard from the TV, she spun around so sharply she nearly twisted her ankle.

"Mayor Oliver Mason is set to sign off on a forty-billion-dollar subsidized housing expansion project. The project will provide a large number of..."

Sydney Ginn stared at the TV and spaced out for a moment.

...Had Chase gone to find the mayor?

Looking at the mayor's pale, swollen, rigidly oversized face, she couldn't see any difference from before.

Ah, come to think of it—after June got hit by something in the Nest, he'd started looking a little like the mayor... that was a coincidence, right?

She wondered if they had managed to actually meet with the mayor. Probably not—the mayor hadn't changed one bit.

So what had happened to June? Had he recovered?

Aside from her wandering attention, Sydney Ginn had one other fatal flaw: curiosity.

She picked up her phone, weighed her options back and forth, and called June first—no answer.

Right, people from the Key House Faction never answered their phones.

She sent a message instead; June didn't reply to that either.

So then... should she ask Chase?

But she'd just given him a thorough scolding the day before, and the life-money still hadn't appeared—if she went back to him on her own initiative, it felt like losing face...

"Huh?"

Sydney Ginn looked at her phone and couldn't help letting out a sound.

Apparently at some point Chase had sent her a text message—short and simple, just asking her to contact a lawyer, with the lawyer's contact information attached.

"What's this about, are you suing me?" Sydney Ginn muttered under her breath. "Did I violate your reputation rights?"

She wiped the chip crumbs from around her mouth, set down her phone, and went back to making lunch. Less than five minutes later, she drifted back like a wandering ghost, hands still held out in front of her. After a restless while of turning it over and over in her mind, she finally picked up the phone.

The lawyer who answered was an unremarkable man with a flat tone of voice, who sounded like he was somewhere in his fifties.

"Hello, I've been waiting for your call, Ms. Sydney Ginn."

Waiting for me? Did you need an address to send a legal notice?

"I will be handling part of the equity transfer procedure between company founder Mr. Scott and yourself—please allow me to explain..."

What?

For a moment Sydney Ginn thought she'd dialed the wrong number. What company? What equity?

Scott—who was that?

I love the contradictory quality in Sydney—that warmth and that detachment existing side by side. This chapter really is very character-focused over plot-heavy, which is why the title could only be "Sydney's Daydreams"... and it truly is just her daydreaming...

I've mentioned before that I'm not especially gifted at crafting characters—what a master can establish in a few chapters takes me a long time to explore. I'd sensed that contradiction in Sydney a long time ago, but carving it out into something solid took a great deal more time... I find myself envying George R. R. Martin's brain on a regular basis.

My update times are getting later and later—not good.

Ahhhh, another thank-you chapter accidentally posted as a paid chapter.

Everyone please don't click it open—I can't bear to have you spend money on a thank-you post, ahhhh.

On weekends I can't reach my editor, which is genuinely infuriating. This hand of mine (18th time), why does it always forget something—losing the thread at one end while juggling the other.

I'll check on Monday when I'm back at work whether the editor can remove the paid chapter; if so, I'll post it again as a free chapter. For now, please don't click to purchase.

Ugh, honestly. This is the first time I've made this mistake with a new book—I really thought this careless habit of mine had been fixed after all those herbal remedies.

Chapter 222: A World Sydney Ginn Doesn't Quite Understand

After a long moment of stunned silence, Sydney Ginn managed to squeeze her first question into a gap in the lawyer's speech: "Which company?"

A brief silence fell on the other end of the line.

That instant of silence was practically subtitled. Sydney Ginn could see, clear as day, a line of text floating out of the phone: "Do you have so many companies actively transferring shares to you that you need to ask?"

But the lawyer was professional enough that, after a brief stumble, he simply said, as naturally as he could: "NuLife-Biotech."

She was even more confused.

A biotech company? Or was it life sciences?

She knew Key House had a nightclub—if it had been some kind of entertainment company, she might have understood; but what did Key House have to do with biotechnology?

Just from the name, it sounded very high-tech...

She did a quick search on her phone, found only a handful of results, had no time to read carefully, and just skimmed a few lines—it seemed, on the surface at least, to be very high-tech.

"Who is Scott?" she couldn't help asking. "Shouldn't it be Chase?"

The lawyer was also thrown off. "Who is Chase?"

Both parties fell silent on the line for a few seconds.

"Let me confirm—you are... Miss Sydney Ginn? Sydney as in gold, Ginn as in—"

"Yes, that's me," Sydney Ginn said, feeling like this was going to go in circles forever. "Why don't you start from the beginning—mm, starting with Scott."

"Mr. Scott told me there might be some aspects of the situation you wouldn't be entirely clear on..."

The lawyer didn't finish that sentence; he probably hadn't expected that the person about to receive a share transfer could be so thoroughly in the dark.

He cleared his throat and, sure enough, did as Sydney Ginn asked and started from the beginning.

John Scott was, unexpectedly, not a pseudonym for Chase.

He was fifty-four years old, with a resume of staggering brilliance: after graduating with dual degrees from one of the world's top medical schools, and following several years of research, he had accomplished something even harder than graduating—not only securing a tenured professorship at the same institution, but rising to become its dean. He had published groundbreaking frontier theories that spawned entire new industries, written three popular science books on the life sciences, each of which had sat on the Blackmoor Times bestseller list for over a dozen weeks—in short, he was one of the most sought-after academic luminaries in the world.

But what did any of this have to do with Hunters?

Sydney Ginn felt like she was about to be split apart by this one question that kept ballooning inside her, with nowhere to go.

"Mr. Scott founded the company four years ago," the lawyer said, apparently sensing she was lost, and switched to language a layperson could follow: "The company's preliminary valuation is currently around 300 million, and it's about to close its Series A. Prior to that, Mr. Scott has decided to release three percent of his shares and transfer them to you..."

Honestly, she didn't catch much of what came after, because the moment she heard those words, Sydney Ginn pulled up her calculator to work out what three percent of 300 million was—300 million had so many zeros to press—and when the result appeared, she stared at her phone screen in a daze for quite a while.

H-how much?

Nine million dollars? Not trying to look down on Key House, but just how many nine-million-dollar amounts could Key House even have?

Why would Chase be sending nine million dollars her way?

Did Chase think his life was worth that much?

But he was only the second-in-command—if he thought he was worth that much, did the top of Key House agree?

What if they wanted it back in a couple of days?

"Once the shares are transferred to me, can they be taken back?" She was so stunned she actually said it out loud.

The lawyer, who had been explaining things on the other end of the line, stopped for another second.

"Unless you agree..."

Well, she certainly wasn't going to agree.

"Could—could you say all that again, from the top,"

Sydney Ginn felt she needed to hear this dry, flat voice on the other end of the line repeat it a few more times, letting it become real, helping to anchor her back to the ground.

"Start from... why Scott is giving me shares."

Throughout the lawyer's explanation, not even a shadow of Key House or Chase appeared.

In his account, Sydney Ginn had become one of the core founding team members of NuLife, present from the moment Scott established the company four years ago. Before the Series A closed, core employees would receive equity according to their proportional stake—meaning she wasn't the only one getting shares; whether the others were genuine core employees or Key House members, that was anyone's guess.

If the lawyer had noticed that this identity was entirely fabricated, he gave no sign of it—never mind that he had just needed to explain to Sydney Ginn who Scott even was.

...She truly hadn't expected it: the life-money had come packaged together with a new identity.

Why arrange it this way?

"VC firms naturally need a clear picture of all current shareholders in the company..." The lawyer, hit with Sydney Ginn's reframed question, sounded a little at a loss: "This—this is obviously not a matter of Mr. Scott's personal preference; core employee equity is standard practice..."

Ah. So she'd been packaged as a core employee to get past the venture capital due diligence.

They could package her as Scott himself, for all she cared—as long as Sydney Ginn got the money—but was this real?

Could there really be such a good thing in the world, and stranger still, could it belong to her?

No, don't question good luck; when good luck comes, just catch it.

"Once I have the shares, what then? Is there a dividend?"

The lawyer went quiet for a second or two. "No—you're not an investor, so there's no dividend... but if you don't wish to hold the shares, you can request the company or the VC to buy you out."

"At—at a 300-million valuation?"

"Generally speaking, yes. But that would require negotiation with the VC."

"And if I don't sell?"

"Personally, I think it's not at all out of the question for NuLife's future valuation to multiply several times over."

Sydney Ginn didn't quite understand the world the lawyer was describing.

She understood that a higher valuation meant her shares would be worth more; but what he went on to say about VC management teams coming in, two future rounds of funding, the possibility of an IPO and an Earnout arrangement... none of that was familiar to her, and she had no idea what any of it had to do with her.

She didn't even know what NuLife actually did.

She only knew one thing: from now on, she might truly become a gold-plated Sydney.

After hanging up with the lawyer, Sydney Ginn sent Chase three messages in a row—she could hear herself that the tone was perhaps a bit too effusive—compared to the tongue-lashing she'd given him the night before, the contrast was almost too glaring—but after sitting restlessly, her palms warm, waiting for quite a while, she still hadn't received a reply.

Huh? Was he putting on airs?

Sydney Ginn thought it over and decided that face wasn't worth anything—certainly not nine million dollars—so when her first call to Chase went unanswered, she considerately waited half an hour to give him a little time, then dialed a second time.

This time the call was picked up, but the moment the other person spoke, Sydney Ginn knew something was wrong.

"Mm? Is this Tianxi?"

She glanced at her phone screen and confirmed she hadn't dialed the wrong number. "It's Sydney Ginn... right, from last night. Um... where's Chase?"

Tianxi let out a long, heavy breath.

"June's situation is a little... off," he said quietly. "It involves House Faction matters, so I can't say more—I'm sorry. I'll let Chase-ge know you called... but when he'll be able to get back to you, I don't know either."

He paused, and what he said next came out with some difficulty.

"Right now... he can't really step away."

In order to avoid as many errors as possible, I tracked down someone I know through work (who used to work in VC, and has a very impressive background) and asked a whole bunch of questions... I could practically feel the unspoken words on his end, which were probably something like, "Don't you have Google? These are such basic questions."

I added a line to the synopsis: in the Blackmoor world, the exchange rate of the universal currency to RMB is set at 1:8.

I've also seen some readers comment that 500,000 for one trip into the Nest for Taylor Ford seemed too low—I thought, seven days for 500,000 is too little?? Then I realized it was probably because I never explicitly stated the exchange rate. They were thinking 500,000 RMB; I was thinking 4,000,000 RMB.

Tomorrow I'll ask the editor whether a thank-you chapter accidentally set as a paid chapter can still be deleted... Ugh, this hand of mine, honestly.

Emergency Evacuation Notice: Massive Explosion at the Nest TV Station

(Re-posted as free version)

Several minutes had passed since the first wave of explosions—the loudest and most thunderous—yet the aftershocks still rumbled in sporadically, as if unwilling to let the ground rest. Thick black smoke, the kind that couldn't be torn apart by bare hands, continued to billow and churn, blotting out the sky and plunging everything into a murky darkness.

"Is anyone hurt?" someone called out from a distance. "Is anyone buried nearby?"

As the voice drew closer, the dense smoke drifted across the newcomer's face and scattered, leaving smudged traces like pencil ash on white paper; the figure didn't cough once, because it had no nose and no mouth.

Never mind where the voice was actually coming from—but in any case the Dream Playwright suddenly halted mid-step and called out: "Oh my! Isn't this Tianxia, our very first program sponsor scheduled to appear on this episode?"

Through the thick smoke, a young (18) girl (I'm guessing) could be seen lying on the ground, her body clean and undamaged, eyes shut tight, completely unconscious.

"This won't do—we can't have our sponsor lying on the ground," the Dream Playwright said, as if reciting a scripted line. "Whatever shall we do, how troubling, oh—that's right. Someone come here."

It was a playwright; no one had ever praised its acting.

Several Residents who had clearly been prepared in advance trotted out of the smoke in small steps, each gripping an arm or an ankle, and hoisted the person like a roasting suckling pig; the person, furious, struggled and shouted: "Let go of me!"

"Shh, shh, you're dreaming." The Dream Playwright raised one index finger and pressed it gently to Chase's lips. "Since we don't know what Tianxia (18) likes, we could only go by practicality—you're tall and solid, which makes you the ideal mattress."

While the assembled Residents busied themselves improving the sponsor's sleeping arrangements, far off among the rubble and debris, Reed Hydes shot upright, said groggily: "... Someone calling for me?"

"I was just looking for you," the Dream Playwright waved a hand. "Have you seen the second sponsor, Tangmian Ye (18)?"

"N-no, haven't seen her..."

"Good. Then let me show you."

The Dream Playwright flicked its hand, and once again several prepared Residents appeared, each holding an arm or a leg, and carried her out—not like a suckling pig—like Snow White—and set her down beside Reed Hydes.

Reed Hydes looked down at Tangmian Ye (18), then looked up at the Dream Playwright.

"Huh?"

"Please call to her tenderly, wipe the dust from her brow, and make absolutely certain that when she opens her eyes, she is bathed in your devoted care."

The Dream Playwright fished a crumpled piece of paper out of its trouser pocket. "Use this to wipe off the dust."

"I don't think she'll be happy about that..."

Reed Hydes's words passed through it like wind; the Dream Playwright paid no attention whatsoever. It continued picking its way through the rubble and shattered tiles, one foot deep, one foot shallow, when it suddenly tilted and fell, swallowed up by the ground.

"Help!" the Dream Playwright called out. "There's a huge sinkhole here! So many Residents—so many people are trapped here! Someone come save us!"

A slow, muffled voice beside it immediately picked up the thread: "But Dream Playwright, we're all trapped here ourselves—where would any hero come from to save us?"

"There is one,"

the Dream Playwright's tone shifted, brimming with delight, like an actor in a commercial who knows exactly which product will solve everyone's problems.

"I happen to know that a team of heroes is about to appear!"

Through the thick smoke, amid the clapping and cheering of the assembled Residents, a row of figures in firefighter gear and medical uniforms came walking over from afar: on closer inspection, they were 璃魑 (18), 不问花开几许 (18), 胡苗苗的主人 (18), 季山青的老奴 (18), 你爸爸爽朗地笑着说 (18), 月尘鹤鸣鸣 (18), Oceanusss (18), 流堇琪 (18), and 草上日月 (18).

The young and vigorous paramedics peered calmly down into the pit.

"I'm not sure why," said 胡苗苗的主人 (18), "but I don't feel any particular urge to rescue anyone. Besides, I'm supposed to be taking care of my health."

璃魑 (18) said, "Maybe we should just forget it and head back."

Everyone was quite calm. 草上日月 (18) was rummaging through the rubble; because 月尘鹤鸣鸣 (18) had said there might be an Artifact nearby, the rest of them all crowded over to look.

"No, no, that's not right," said the Dream Playwright, who apparently hadn't anticipated this turn in the plot. "Hmm... right! It's not just us in the pit — Mai Minghe is in here too."

At those words, the Residents all exchanged glances with one another.

Mai Minghe hadn't been called in for this explosion scene in advance, and for a moment no one quite knew what to do. After a while, someone came up with a solution: countless things that might generously be called hands jointly raised a photograph of Mai Minghe.

"You think you're fooling anyone——" said 流堇琪 (18).

"It worked! They fell for it!"

The moment the photograph of Mai Minghe was held aloft, the Dream Playwright's eyes lit up immediately — it had no eyes, but they lit up regardless, and the logic behind that need not be examined too closely — and it pointed into the distance, crying, "Look!"

The instant everyone believed Mai Minghe (the photograph) was in danger, 咪阿嫩, 非食用类小猫软糖, 树油Ya, 草我怎么莓了, 文旦驴, Joiiii, 伊修加德红衣人偶番茄, 戚梧, 捕捉一只猫猫云, 三九九九, and 新夜昼行 (all 18) wasted no time and came rushing to the scene from out of nowhere.

"Where's our Mai?" said 捕捉一只猫猫云 (18).

树油Ya (18) said, "Looks like we were tricked."

Upon hearing that Mai Minghe was fine, Joiiii (18) was drawn away by the mattress; 戚梧 (18) looked around and said, "Well, we're already here..."

"Exactly!" said the Dream Playwright, who had been sweating with anxiety, and finally let out a sigh of relief. "You're already here——"

"Anyone want to play cards," asked 戚梧 (18).

文旦驴 (18) thought this was a fine idea. And just like that, everyone dispersed — some went to look for the Artifact, some went to feel the mattress, some sat down to play cards, and some went to see where the explosion had come from.

The Dream Playwright fell silent in the pit for a moment.

"Think I've run out of moves? I am seeing this scene through to the end no matter what — so you're sponsors, so what, sponsors still follow my script — let me tell you a earth-shattering secret: I've been ready for exactly this kind of move from you all along."

"Hm?" The Resident beside it turned to look.

"There aren't only Residents in this pit!" the Dream Playwright cried. "Beneath this pit, we went ahead and dug a basement! The basement has a coffee machine, donuts, and a sofa — but as long as we haven't been rescued out of the pit, the people in the basement can't get out!"

"And the people in the basement are…?" the Residents asked cooperatively.

"R_13, 雅兒, 咕咕和呱呱, 阴暗爬行盆栽树, 月琢喜欢冒险故事, 余昧33, 世界倒数第三海肠, 木星安静的枸杞, 荀时, 杜子若, 一杯白日梦不加糖, and Cindle (all 18) — sitting there drinking coffee and waiting!"

The Dream Playwright wiped at a pair of eyes that didn't exist, and said with heavy sincerity, "You see, what would our Nest ever do without its sponsors?"

The last time I accidentally posted the paid thank-you chapter, I had the editor take it down…

Oh, this hand of mine.

What can I say — eighteen-year-olds are full of spirit and can't sit still, always rushing headlong into things without thinking. That's just how it is.

Chapter 223: Sydney Ginn Turned Away at the Door — and Those Who Got In

November 23rd — truly a memorable day worth celebrating.

There were reports that Blackmoor City was a massive noise pollution hub, its streets enveloped at all times in noise levels of up to 90 decibels — walking down the road was practically the same as having someone howl directly into your ear — and yet right now, as Sydney Ginn walked those same streets, the only sound she could hear was the music of a choir: bright, light, soaring straight up to the clouds.

She couldn't help opening her handbag and peering inside one more time.

...How many times had she looked during the walk here? Always afraid that if she opened it again, what was inside would have vanished.

But every time she opened it, Sydney Ginn could see it there, pinned against the inner lining of the bag by an umbrella and a portable charger.

And yet somehow it still didn't feel real.

Such a thin document, tucked inside such a thin document sleeve — when she shook the bag, she could barely feel any weight at all.

Such a negligible few grams of paper, and yet it was enough to carry her across a gulf that countless people wouldn't even dare dream of crossing.

Beauty, talent, ability, intelligence — whatever dazzling advantage you could name, spread across the vast ocean of eight billion human beings, it was like sand on a beach: grab a handful anywhere, and there was always more, endless and indistinguishable.

In Blackmoor City especially, exceptional, talented people were the last thing in short supply.

Brilliance, hard work, natural gift — there was so much of it that the city seemed to carry a faint undercurrent of weariness and numbness, like an invisible iron wall that smacked young dreamers from small towns right in the face the moment they arrived.

The part-time barista near her apartment had hundreds of film and costume design portfolios saved on their phone; the person receiving the coffee they handed over might have a wall full of

academic credentials back at the office; the person walking six or seven dogs for someone else might be heading to a recording studio for an audition right after — they were all just ordinary people grinding with everything they had, day after day, simply to survive.

Starting today, Sydney Ginn had left the ranks of the ordinary and been sorted into a sliver of human society that made up only a tiny fraction of the whole.

A far shore that effort, talent, or intelligence alone could hardly reach.

She still couldn't help asking herself: why?

What made her deserving?

If not for that moment of despair at nineteen — when she'd tried to end her life and fallen instead into the Nest — she never could have had any of this today...

She cut off the thought.

Joy was joy, but the questions nagging at Sydney Ginn had not diminished in the slightest.

Today she'd gone to the lawyer's office with the necessary materials, signed her name on several documents, and been told she needn't worry about anything else; from start to finish, she hadn't even caught a glimpse of Scott, let alone found anyone to answer the questions that had been gnawing at her.

On top of that, she still hadn't made up her mind whether to sell the shares immediately or wait until the market value doubled — after all, shares unsold were just a piece of paper — and she kept feeling that the whole equity matter was far less straightforward than it appeared on the surface.

No matter how she turned it over, she had to talk to Chase.

But since her brief call with Tianxi yesterday, Chase had vanished as though swallowed by the earth — no word, no message.

Perhaps she should pay a visit to Key House...

Nothing else aside, she ought to at least express her gratitude and concern in person, right? And besides, she wanted to know how June was doing.

Sydney Ginn had called several times in a row, and when she finally managed to reach Tianxi, he shut her down cleanly and without hesitation: "Don't come."

"Huh? That won't do — you don't understand, I received quite a bit in payment, I—"

"I know,"

Tianxi cut her off, then paused for a moment. "Mm, I don't know exactly how much you received, but Key House has always been generous with Hunters who contribute. We don't pay monthly salaries — beyond selling Artifacts, every time you answer a House summons and carry out your assignment, the compensation has always been substantial. That's standard practice at Key House. You don't need to make a special trip just to thank us for that."

Ah, no wonder Key House Hunters always seemed so much more enthusiastic and loyal than those from other House Factions.

Though, she wasn't coming purely to say thank you either...

"But I have some questions that only Chase can answer."

"Then when he has a free moment, he'll answer them himself. No reply means he has no time; if Chase has no time, coming here won't do you any good." Tianxi's refusal was absolute.

"What's he doing? Is he alright? Does he need my help?"

He'd been gone for over a day — not an especially long time, perhaps, but the moment she factored in the strange state June had been in, Sydney Ginn found herself genuinely worried about Chase.

Tianxi hesitated for a moment.

Whether it was because he was tight-lipped by nature or because he wasn't sure how to put it into words, he paused for several seconds before saying: "He's... he's fine. Should be fine. He should be able to handle it himself... at least I don't think you'd be able to help with anything."

The frustration of being left without an answer was like a sharp claw, nearly boring straight through the top of Sydney Ginn's skull.

What did "should be fine" mean, when she "couldn't help"?

If things were truly fine, there'd be no need for help at all — so didn't "can't help" imply the situation was serious?

She'd have to dig a little deeper.

"You don't have to worry about compensation — I mean it, this time I'll help for free," Sydney Ginn said generously. "More hands make lighter work, and as they say, three cobblers put together..."

"It's — it's not about compensation." Tianxi let out a sigh. "I appreciate your goodwill — I'll pass your thanks along to Chase for you — but it's really not necessary. Get some rest. We'll be in touch again later."

This person was like talking to a wall.

"What about June, then?" Sydney Ginn shifted direction. "Is she with Chase?"

That question seemed to strike some invisible chord. Tianxi was visibly thrown for just a moment — he swallowed back whatever he'd been about to say — and then replied: "Yes... they're together."

Over a day now — had they really been together the whole time?

"Are they both at Key House? Oh, right — where is Key House, anyway? You don't seem to have an office in the city like some of the other House Factions, so where do you all... work? Is 'work' even the right word..."

"Didn't I say not to come?" Tianxi couldn't help cutting her off.

"I'm not coming, I'm just asking."

"You really think I'd believe—"

Tianxi sounded like he was about to combust. But before he could finish the sentence, Sydney Ginn heard someone on his end call out "Tianxi," followed by the faint, indistinct murmur of something like "she's here."

Who was here?

"Got it," Tianxi said. "Let her in. It's fine — I'm not busy, this call is almost over."

"Hold on, I never said I was done with my questions," Sydney Ginn protested.

A flurry of voices and footsteps came through the phone — someone was apparently walking toward Tianxi; he had no attention to spare for Sydney Ginn and only managed a hurried "hang on a second" before apparently setting down his phone, his voice suddenly growing distant.

He said to the new arrival: "You... you're Miss Mai Minghe?"

A woman's voice replied, indistinctly, "Yes."

"Good, please have a seat."

Tianxi's voice came through clearly again — he'd evidently picked the phone back up.

He said to Sydney Ginn, with none too pleasant a tone: "I already told you — you don't need to come, you can't help, none of us can; we can only wait for Chase to handle it himself — in short, don't come. I've got things to take care of on my end, I'm about to conduct an interview, I'm hanging up now."

An interview — for a Hunter?

Before Sydney Ginn could get another word in, the call was cut.

Mm... well, that made sense, she supposed. Key House had been through a rough patch lately and had apparently lost quite a few people; wanting to bring in new blood as quickly as possible was perfectly reasonable.

The woman's voice she'd heard on the phone a moment ago had seemed faintly familiar somehow — but the other party had only said one word, and from a distance at that, so it was more likely that the sense of familiarity was just her imagination playing tricks.

The name Mai Minghe — had she heard it before?

She didn't think so.

I'll confess that the first line of this chapter was me sneaking in a personal indulgence — I'll own up to that, hands rubbing together.

This is a transitional chapter — the kind where I cover the necessary plot developments — I tried my best to make it interesting, but it's still on the shorter side... After finishing it, I thought, huh, writing short chapters is actually kind of nice?

Not writing at all would be even better (not really).

Chapter 224: The Troubles of Mai Minghe's Grandniece

She had already steelled herself for it.

When Tianxi recognized her as one of the people present during the Rain Alley shootout, Mai Minghe would produce the set of talking points she had long prepared, and do her best to convince him that she truly needed a job and had no other motive—though she couldn't say how good her chances of success actually were.

After all, she had been caught in the crossfire of a Key House gunfight the night before, and here she was, showing up for an interview one day later—a coincidence suspicious enough to raise eyebrows.

But to her surprise, when Tianxi saw her, he only paused for a brief moment before asking her to sit down.

How could he not be startled?

He looked almost as if he hadn't recognized her at all—was that even possible?

Mai Minghe watched him press the phone back to his ear, her mind spinning at full speed as she replayed the alley from that night's shootout, scene by scene.

There had been no lights in that alley; the curtain of rain had turned everything dark and murky. She had been pressed flat against the corner of a wall, lying on the ground, with a large, person-height trash can standing between her and the other two—Chase and Tianxi.

The one who had braced against the lid of the trash bin and fired was Chase; Tianxi had been a few steps behind him—which meant, now that she thought about it, that Mai Minghe hadn't gotten a clear look at Tianxi's face that night either.

The only reason she knew that this man with a long braided plait hanging down his chest had been in the same alley as her in the early hours of the 22nd was that she had heard Chase call out his name; and just before she was led into this room, the Hunter who had shown her the way told her, "Tianxi will see you shortly."

Thinking it over carefully, from start to finish, no one had ever called out the name "Mai Minghe"—

"...I'll hang up now."

Tianxi's last few words before ending the call snapped Mai Minghe's attention back to the present.

"Sorry," said Tianxi, glancing at her—and sure enough, he didn't look like someone who had recognized her, only faintly puzzled. "Have we met before?"

"I don't recall that we have," Mai Minghe said carefully.

Even without having seen each other's faces clearly, it was possible to have retained a vague impression of the other person's build or general presence. So she added: "The Hunter circle isn't large—perhaps we've crossed paths somewhere without realizing it."

From the moment she had tumbled out of the Black Cube, Mai Minghe had not said a single word, and had slipped away early alongside the other two; Tianxi had never heard her voice—that much she could be certain of.

He nodded, apparently accepting the explanation.

"Something to drink?"

Mai Minghe started. "No, thank you."

Afternoon sunlight filtered through the tall window panes, brightening the center of the room into a stage laid with thick carpet; luminous dust drifted through the light, then faded away into the shadows pooled in the room's four corners.

Mai Minghe had not expected the difference between Key House and Morgan House to be so vast.

The word "interview" had given her the illusion that what she was about to see would be something like a company or an office; but after actually laying eyes on it and walking inside, she had remained in a state of faint, dazed wonder ever since.

Tianxi noticed Mai Minghe's gaze wandering in slow circles around the room, and said from the chair three or four paces away where he was seated, with a smile: "This building was constructed in 1889—during the Queen Anne Revival period—funded by a wealthy merchant, and it took ten years to complete. I've heard the architect's design was quite bold, blending several European continental styles; in some of the details, you can still make out a hint of Victorian influence."

Apart from a few chairs, the carpet, a fireplace, the tall arched glass windows, and the decorative paintings hanging on the walls, the room—several sizes larger than an ordinary sitting room—was bare and empty.

Key House had made only the most minimal renovations to this building, which felt like a church—no, more like a noble's country manor; looking at the dark wood walls and the high ceiling, Mai Minghe almost wondered whether she had wandered into the wrong era.

"The head of our House Faction, Mr. Key, has rather old-fashioned taste."

"It truly is beautiful," Mai Minghe said sincerely. "Modern architecture no longer has details this intricate and refined."

"It's not only a matter of taste," Tianxi said, as though her words resonated deeply with him. "Key House holds to certain principles that are rarely seen anymore. For instance, we are one of the few House Factions that has never adopted a corporate structure. In our eyes, the Hunters who join us are never merely employees—they are partners worthy of trusting with your life."

He paused and raised a hand in a small gesture. "You can't hand your life over to a colleague, after all—can you?"

Mai Minghe nodded despite herself.

"Trust, however, is not something given blindly. So when we choose our future partners, we do our best to fully understand and verify a person's background and history. The more significant the responsibilities you take on, the more thorough our investigation will be. That is Key House's standard practice." Tianxi looked at her and said, "By coming for an interview today, you're indicating that you agree to our background check—correct?"

This time, Mai Minghe's nod came far more reluctantly than the last.

She hoped he hadn't noticed her unease.

Perhaps the Hunter cleanup organization had many ready-made identities available to choose from; but her biggest problem was that she had no money to buy one.

"Eighty-six-year-old Mai Minghe" was another identity that, if revealed, would only create more trouble—and given how little time she had, the best solution she could come up with was to use "eighty-six-year-old Mai Minghe" to create a new identity for herself.

She only needed a foot in the door; the new identity didn't need to hold up for very long.

"I've been in Blackmoor City for less than a year, and I've been working as a Hunter for an even shorter time—I'm afraid I don't have much of value to offer," Mai Minghe said. "I originally came to Blackmoor City to look for work, and to look after my elderly great-aunt while I was at it... Oh, her name is also Mai Minghe."

Tianxi raised an eyebrow. Plenty of people shared a name with their parents, but sharing one with a great-aunt was far less common.

"My mother was raised by her when she was little—they were very close," Mai Minghe explained with a smile.

"How old is she?"

"Eighty-six," said Mai Minghe. "If you need it, she can vouch for me and provide background information—I haven't done anything wrong. She's lived in Blackmoor City her whole life; one check and you'll know."

As she spoke, she did her best to adopt the sort of tone she imagined someone newly arrived from a small town would have.

If Key House really did call the landline at Mai Minghe's apartment, she had already figured out what to do; even if she had to temporarily unbind the Serpent Band, she would have to use her elderly voice to vouch for her younger self.

Tianxi nodded and said, "Understood. We're not the police—we don't care whether there's anything in your past history that wasn't strictly legal. In our line of work, there aren't many people who can keep their noses completely clean. You could even say it's unnecessary—better if you can't. What we care about more is what kind of person someone is, based on their background and history."

"I heard," Mai Minghe ventured, "that you're in a bit of a hurry this time?"

The word Key House had put out a few days ago only said that they needed to bring in a batch of people as quickly as possible—without going into further detail, such as what the work specifically involved or what the requirements were. The only thing circulating among Hunters was a rumor that Key House seemed to have made an enemy of someone and urgently needed to build up their strength.

...That enemy was presumably the "Wellesley Team," and Brianna?

Chase and Brianna were both contestants in the Domination Game, and with the early-morning shootout on the 22nd, the source of this conflict had clearly been established. The fact that Key House had been attacked was something Mai Minghe had learned only through gathering information; she felt it couldn't be unconnected to the Domination Game.

"Yes, the situation has been unusual lately."

Tianxi nodded. "We don't have time to complete the background checks before testing Hunter ability, so this time we're planning to take a different approach—first organize a group to enter the Nest, and then decide on the next steps based on their performance."

"Enter the Nest?" Mai Minghe was startled.

The look Tianxi gave her made her immediately regret speaking too quickly.

"Without entering the Nest, we have no way to gauge a person's aptitude, adaptability, and capability." He raised an eyebrow and asked, "You didn't know? Any House Faction, whenever they recruit, makes the final decision based on Nest performance."

When she thought about it, that made sense—without entering the Nest, how could you weigh whether someone was worth taking on?

Perhaps it was so obvious that neither Reed Hydes nor Megan had thought to mention it to her.

Mai Minghe gave a quiet, inward, rueful smile.

After discovering that the lipstick had vanished, she and Reed Hydes had spent a long while fretting and talking it over, and eventually concluded that it had something to do with the Black Cube that had dismantled everyone; and if it was connected to the Black Cube, then it was connected to Key House.

Chase Monroe's reputation was built on two things: ferocity and generosity—if he had truly picked up the lipstick, she needn't worry about him simply pocketing it for good, but there was one problem: he wanted to buy the lipstick too.

Since he wanted it and it had already fallen into his hands, the best she could probably hope for was that he'd send her a sum of money. But no amount of money held as much significance for her now as the Artifact Report.

No—to put it more precisely, it didn't matter who had it; as long as there was the slightest possibility that they wouldn't return it, Mai Minghe didn't dare approach them directly to negotiate, for fear of alerting them.

After turning it over and over in her mind, the only solution she could think of—far-fetched, yet not entirely unworkable—was to infiltrate Key House, figure out the situation, and then find an opportunity to quietly retrieve the lipstick.

Taking back something that was yours—could that really be called stealing?

In order to slip her into the group of Hunters going to the interview, Reed Hydes and Megan—who believed Mai Minghe simply wanted a job and a paycheck—had both put in considerable effort: gathering information for her, giving her an emergency crash course in basic knowledge, helping her rush through an application... With so much to do and so little time, they had all overlooked something that everyone else took for granted.

"I know that—it's just that I have a minor injury on my foot," Mai Minghe covered. "So I wasn't sure whether I'd need to enter the Nest right away..."

Tianxi glanced at his watch.

"Tomorrow morning at ten o'clock, the Hunters who pass the initial screening from this round of interviews will form a team and enter the Nest, with me leading the group. If you're unable to participate, then there's no point in continuing the screening—you can go home now. Your call."

Wait—"great-aunt" corresponds to "grandniece," doesn't it...

Last night I think I had a midlife crisis twenty-five years early (18)—suddenly I desperately wanted to quit my job, take a break from writing, hand the cats and dogs off to someone else, shed every last responsibility, pack a single suitcase, and just go wherever the wind takes me, no end in sight... That's the kind of life a true nomad is supposed to live.

This chapter kept getting longer and longer as I wrote it—go to sleep everyone, it'll definitely go up tonight.

Happy New Year, everyone!

The new chapter just kept getting longer—looks like getting it out before midnight might be a stretch, probably closer to 12:30 before I can finish. Those of you who should be sleeping, go to sleep. Don't stay up late on New Year's Day—and you'll sleep soundly the whole year through.

As for me—writing on New Year's Day means I'll be able to... write... soundly... the whole year through...

I really do have a talent for finding the bright side of a hard situation.

Chapter 225: Mai Minghe, Alone

"Are you sure?"

As she sent Mai Minghe out the door, the sight of her leaning on her cane, one foot higher than the other, made Tianxi look at her a moment longer than he otherwise would have.

Tianxi had a broad, open face with thick dark brows and hair; he showed not a trace of unnecessary expression, nor did he say unnecessary words. But he didn't need to say anything—Mai Minghe understood him all the same.

If she couldn't take care of herself, she couldn't expect anyone to pull her back from danger when it came—once you entered the Nest, your life was in the hands of fate, let alone when the people around you were strangers.

"Don't worry," Mai Minghe smiled at him, hoping he wouldn't notice how forced that smile truly was. "I know what I'm doing."

Of course she knew. She was essentially walking toward her own death.

If it were only her own death she was walking toward, that would be one thing...

"Then I'll see you tomorrow morning," Tianxi nodded. "I'm looking forward to going into the Nest with a Hunter who has managed to pull herself out of Resident-ification."

Mai Minghe understood perfectly well that, as a Hunter, she had almost no credentials to speak of.

In order to pass the initial screening, she had carefully picked through her limited experience and told him everything she could; it was only when she mentioned that she had briefly become a Resident herself that she saw one of Tianxi's thick dark brows arch upward—and in that moment, she knew she'd passed.

"...See you tomorrow morning," Mai Minghe said, with some difficulty.

Several times during the interview, she had almost told him the truth.

Tianxi didn't feel like a bad person, and that had created a kind of temptation—as though, if she simply laid out her reasoning clearly, he might give the lipstick back to her.

But Mai Minghe had lived a whole lifetime, and if she had learned one lesson, it was this: never expect someone else to do the right thing as a matter of course. People who looked like good people were no exception.

Besides, "the right thing" was different for everyone.

She had to keep moving forward with the original plan.

No matter how many years a person had lived, there were still moments like this: she didn't know which decision was right, which choice was wrong.

The thought that one's decisions today would set in motion some unknown road in the future was one that kept every human being trembling throughout their entire life—and Mai Minghe was no different.

She truly did not want to enter the Nest alongside Tianxi's group.

Not only because she herself would be in danger, but because she was the primary kill target of many Residents in the Nest—would the team traveling with her suffer for it?

Tianxi didn't know this, and Mai Minghe couldn't pretend it didn't exist.

Of course, even without her, Hunters were never short of danger—any living person was something the Nest and its Residents were eager to kill.

But what if her presence turned what would have been a five-point ordeal into an eight-point one, and someone who would have survived ended up dead? What would she do then?

But if she didn't enter the Nest, did she have any other way to get close to Key House Faction and take back the lipstick?

All of it was for the time Artifact... she still wanted to see the world nine months from now, she wasn't ready to leave yet.

Amid the tangled mess of thoughts crowding her mind, the two of them had already reached the door.

"Shaxue?"

Tianxi called out, and immediately someone poked their head out from the corridor on the right side of the first-floor lobby—the very girl who had shown Mai Minghe in earlier.

"I'm here—all done already?"

The girl called Shaxue looked to be barely past twenty, young enough that she seemed to naturally give off a kind of glow.

Her appearance and manner were both soft and calm—it might sound a little strange to put it this way, but the feeling she gave off was that of a thick blanket of snow.

So smooth and clean, because the heavy snowfall had already filled in and smoothed over all the uneven ground and cracked earth beneath.

Well—perhaps she was overthinking things again.

Sometimes it only took one glance and a few words for Mai Minghe to develop a vague, intuitive sense of a person; though most of the time, people passed her by without any deeper acquaintance, and she never had the chance to find out whether her reading of them had been right.

"Yes, would you mind showing her out?" Tianxi said. "What time is the next one coming?"

Once Shaxue appeared from the corridor, the front door was only seven or eight steps away—there was no real need for anyone to show her out.

Rather than saying Shaxue should "show her the way," it would be more accurate to say Tianxi was politely saying: take her outside, and don't let her linger.

As expected of a major Hunter House Faction—they were quite tight on that front...

Mai Minghe gently ran her hand along her cane, and an idea took shape in her mind.

If she could get the lipstick before they entered the Nest, she wouldn't have to worry about others suffering on her account, would she?

Shaxue checked her phone and answered, "The next one is scheduled for three-thirty—twenty minutes from now."

After Tianxi bid Mai Minghe farewell with a nod of thanks, he turned and left; the moment he was gone, Mai Minghe straightened her back and shifted her full weight onto both feet—in front of Shaxue, she tried to make every step as steady and normal as possible.

Shaxue walked ahead of her, turned back with a smile, and asked, "Did you drive here?"

Her driver's license had expired twenty or thirty years ago.

"I'm sorry," Mai Minghe said with an apologetic smile, stopping in her tracks. "Could I use the restroom? The thing is, I didn't feel comfortable asking Tianxi earlier..."

Shaxue understood at once.

"I'll take you," she said, pushing open a double door on the right side of the lobby and leading Mai Minghe through a side hall and into another corridor. "There's a box in the restroom—it has all the necessary feminine hygiene products. Go ahead; I'll wait for you at the door. This place is huge—I'm afraid you'd get lost."

Getting lost probably wasn't the main reason, but it was true that the place was enormous.

Mai Minghe stayed inside for a reasonable amount of time, and when she came out, Shaxue was exactly where she'd said she'd be—standing at the door, not having moved a step.

"You're entering the Nest tomorrow morning, right?" Shaxue seemed to have taken a liking to her; as they walked back, she struck up a bit of conversation. "Going in at a time like this... is that all right?"

"I'm fine, thank you." Facing her concern, Mai Minghe felt a little self-conscious. "As a Key House Faction Hunter, do you still have to work here even when you're not going into the Nest?"

For a Hunter who had just come to interview for a job, the question was perfectly natural.

"Depends on whether the House needs it. We've been a bit short-staffed lately, and I happened to be free, so I came to help keep things running—and to help Tianxi receive interview candidates on the side. Oh, he's my team leader. Key House Faction Hunters are organized by squad."

"So are you entering the Nest tomorrow as well?" Mai Minghe asked, ears perked.

Without the sound of her cane tapping against the floor, the vast and hollow building was utterly silent apart from the two of them; it was as though even the dust had settled into stillness alongside the floors and walls, undisturbed for a hundred years.

Key House was short-staffed... and indeed, there seemed to be very few people around.

"Yes," Shaxue pressed a black button on the wall beside a dark wood door, and the lock clicked open. "We try to make sure interview Hunters don't run into trouble, so we have to arrange more people to go along. Otherwise, if word got out, it'd be bad for the House's reputation."

"Then I'll be in your care tomorrow," Mai Minghe said with a smile. "I hope we'll be able to work together in the future."

After a few parting pleasantries, she walked out into the daylight beyond the manor.

The front door closed softly behind her; Mai Minghe looked up, and sure enough, there was a security camera mounted in one corner above the door.

Inside Key House manor, she hadn't spotted any security cameras. Perhaps because, ordinarily, the only people allowed inside were members of the House—even if they were cautious, they couldn't show it openly.

The front door was heavy and solid, and beside it on the wall was a keypad with an intercom. Without the code, you could only ring the bell and wait for someone inside to let you in; earlier, it had taken Mai Minghe a full half minute just to figure out how to use the intercom.

She walked quickly down the front drive and positioned herself behind a hedge, looking across the lawn at the ground-floor windows of Key House manor.

Shaxue had returned to the side room off the first-floor lobby on the right and was bent over her phone; Mai Minghe waited a few minutes without seeing anyone else moving about—it seemed Key House truly had no spare hands for patrolling the building right now.

She looked around.

In front of the manor was a private driveway; if a car came from the distance, Mai Minghe would see it at a glance.

She checked her watch: 3:15 PM.

Mai Minghe sat down beside the neatly trimmed hedge, so that Shaxue wouldn't spot her if she happened to turn and glance out the window.

After that, she waited.

The next interview Hunter was very punctual—exactly five minutes before three-thirty, an unremarkable Citroën turned into the private driveway and slowed to a stop. Mai Minghe leapt to her feet, ignoring the dull ache in her injured foot, and hurried to the front door of Key House manor before the car had even come to a complete stop, jabbing the doorbell several times in quick succession.

The Citroën pulled to a stop alongside the driveway, and someone pushed open the car door.

Footsteps sounded from behind the front door; then, through the intercom of the keypad, Mai Minghe heard Shaxue's voice. "Mr. Lisidan?"

She was in luck—the next interview candidate turned out to be a man.

The car door thudded shut behind her, and the car locks beeped twice.

"Sorry, it's me," Mai Minghe glanced back over her shoulder, speaking as the man walked toward the door. "I left my cane in the restroom."

When Shaxue opened the door, she seemed not quite sure what to make of the situation at first.

"See, my foot's just about healed up—and then when I left, I forgot I'd even brought a cane in the first place."

Mai Minghe spread her hands with an apologetic laugh. "You remember, don't you? The cane I had when I came in?"

"Oh, right, I do." Shaxue recalled it now. "Ah, I wasn't paying attention to whether you had it when you left..."

And naturally, there was a reason for that.

Mai Minghe had walked steadily in front of her and steered her attention toward the topic of the Nest precisely so that Shaxue wouldn't immediately notice that she'd left her cane in the restroom.

However, if Shaxue had told her to wait outside while she went to retrieve the cane herself, the plan would have fallen apart entirely—which was why Mai Minghe had timed it specifically to the arrival of the next interview candidate before ringing the bell. Now, hearing footsteps approaching from behind, she immediately stepped to the side and gestured for the newcomer to go ahead.

The man named Lisidan looked back and forth between the two of them with some bewilderment, then said to Shaxue, "I'm here for the interview..."

Shaxue responded on instinct: "Mr. Lisidan? Please come in."

Mai Minghe quietly cheered to herself.

Once the next interview candidate stepped through the door, Shaxue could hardly ask Lisidan to wait outside again even if she'd caught on; Mai Minghe quickly followed in the candidate's

wake, all the while saying "so sorry, I'm terribly forgetful," and slipped through the door along with him.

She was aware, of course, that she'd only managed to sneak back in because Shaxue hadn't been treating them as potential threats—the mental framing of "someone we might work with in the future" had inadvertently cleared away many obstacles for her.

"I'll go get it myself," she said to Shaxue apologetically. "You seem quite busy."

Once inside, things were easier to manage.

Whether Shaxue let Mai Minghe go get the cane on her own, or went herself and left Mai Minghe and Lisidan to wait in place—neither outcome would interfere with the next step of the plan. It was fortunate that Lisidan was a man; Shaxue could hardly bring him along to follow Mai Minghe into the women's restroom.

Shaxue's gaze moved between the two of them.

"Go quickly and come right back," she said to Mai Minghe. "I'll wait here. Don't go wandering off."

Mai Minghe quietly let out a long breath of relief and promised, "Of course. I won't."

砂雪的目光在二人之间转了转。

“你快去快回吧，”她对麦明河说，“我在这儿等你。不要乱走啊。”

麦明河暗中长松了一口气，保证道：“好，不会的。”

She endured the dull, throbbing pain in her injured foot and hurried to the restroom, grabbed the walking cane from beside the door, and immediately turned back—the whole trip taking less than half the time as before—because she had to spend the time she'd saved in the side parlor.

Fortunately, Key House was not the kind of modern building where you couldn't figure out how to open a window even if you wanted to.

Mai Minghe gently turned the window latch and left a narrow gap.

When she made her way back to the entrance hall, Shaxue and Lisidan were waiting in place, apparently forcing conversation, talking stiffly—she had returned early enough that Shaxue had not grown suspicious.

"Thank you," Mai Minghe said, lifting her cane slightly. "I got it back. I'll be off then—see you tomorrow."

The front door closed behind her for the second time.

She didn't have much time left.

Shaxue would lead the interviewee to see Tianxi and then come back—the whole round trip was probably just over a minute; within that minute, Mai Minghe had to circle around to the side of the manor and climb in through the window into the side parlor—she had to slip deeper into the manor before Shaxue returned.

Seen from outside, the bottom edge of the window was level with her chest.

Enduring the pain in her injured foot, Mai Minghe gripped the windowsill with both hands, pushed off the wall with one foot, and with great effort finally hauled herself through the window—landing with a dull thud that nearly froze her soul in place—as for whether the whole thing had been captured by some security camera, she had no time to think about that.

What now?

Her heart was slamming against her sternum hard enough to hurt. She didn't dare think about what would happen if she were caught; she had seen firsthand what became of people who crossed Key House.

Where would Key House keep Artifacts?

Had Chase taken the lipstick into the Key House manor after getting hold of it?

No—what if the lipstick had never made it into Chase's hands at all?

When she thought about it that way, there were simply too many possibilities for where the lipstick might be. If this turned out to be a wasted effort and she got caught, or lost her chance to join Key House...

Before Shaxue could return, Mai Minghe carefully slipped down a corridor.

She had to stop in her tracks and calm her pounding heart, suppressing the countless sharp waves of doubt, confusion, and lingering dread churning through her mind.

No—whatever happened, she had to search Key House first.

From what she'd gathered listening to Tianxi's phone call before the interview, Chase seemed to be tied up with something and couldn't spare the attention; if she was going to look for the lipstick, now was the best opportunity.

All right, that settled it—

Suddenly someone lightly bumped into Mai Minghe's shoulder.

It was like walking down a crowded street where people were constantly coming and going, and someone had accidentally nudged her—her shoulder jolted, then settled back to normal.

Mai Minghe's scalp prickled.

She stared at the corridor, empty in both directions, and for a good long moment could not move at all.

It's finally out! This chapter ended up being over 4,000 characters... Way too long, it wore me down to the bone.

I wonder if everyone remembers "your father said with a hearty laugh"—I'm sure you all remember it heartily, right?

Your father heartily declared he didn't need a side story, but wanted to appear as a character instead, so ta-da! Shaxue has heartily made her entrance.

Chapter 226: Before Mai Minghe's Departure

Mai Minghe pressed her back flat against the wall and drew a long, silent breath.

Cold sweat still clung to her pores, and her throat felt choked with discomfort, but after several deep breaths she finally managed to dredge her heart up from the pit of her stomach and stuff it back where it belonged.

The wall, paneled in dark brown wood, held a faint glint of reflected light frozen in the silence.

A rectangle of light fell in from the hallway entrance—thin sunlight mingled with dust, drifting in midair.

On the side table in the hallway stood a cluster of snow-white long-stemmed lilies, each bloom like a severed head split open, some tilted up and some bowed down, all staring at the empty corridor and its intruder.

There was no one anywhere; and there was no way anyone could have fled this five-or-six-meter hallway in the moment she turned her head.

But surely it hadn't been her imagination?

The light tap against her shoulder had been real and clear... and this wasn't the Nest—there shouldn't be anything like an invisible person here.

An Artifact, then?

Mai Minghe swept the area with her eyes again. Was someone using some kind of Artifact?

If a Key House member had spotted her through some Artifact, an alarm would have sounded by now; the manor wouldn't be this quiet, everything carrying on as normal.

She couldn't determine the cause.

But whatever the cause, something was there in the hallway—something that could physically touch her—and that was what unsettled her most.

Forget it, Mai Minghe exhaled and made up her mind on the spot.

If that invisible whatever suddenly decided to stick a knife in her, she couldn't stop it anyway, could she?

Whether there was a ghost, a Resident, or a Key House assassin in this manor made no essential difference to her—she still had to do what she came to do and leave as soon as possible.

Keeping one ear on Sandy's movements in the side parlor, Mai Minghe made her way slowly to a door along the hallway and gave it a push—it swung open without resistance.

She peeked inside and found a reading room fitted with several computers, apparently available for House Faction Hunters to use, with another door in the middle connecting to the next room.

She eased the door shut, took out her phone, opened the camera, and snapped a photo of the reading room—the click of the shutter rang out like a thunderclap in her ears.

Mai Minghe frantically recalled what Reed Hydes had taught her, fumbled with the phone for a while, and somehow managed to silence the shutter—thankfully, no one had heard and come to investigate.

She photographed the reading room from every angle, and it was only as she was about to open the door connecting to the next room that she noticed the books on the shelves didn't exist in the outside world.

Well, that wasn't quite the right way to put it—what she should have said was that every book on those shelves was something that couldn't be found anywhere in the human world.

Records and Documentation of Landing-Point Shifts, Expired Artifact Illustrated Catalogue (Vol. 1), Logic and Analysis of Select Trap Scenarios, Notable Historical Clearance Experiences, Resident Interviews...

Some of the books appeared to be privately printed by Key House—fresh, clean covers, multiple copies of the same title; others had clearly been gathered from the hunter community, worn to varying degrees, some handwritten, some a stack of printed A4 pages—the oldest among them was a memoir printed in 1902.

From the preface, the memoir's author seemed to be the first Artifact hunter ever to leave a historical record—but had there really been cities with populations in the millions back then?

Or had the population threshold simply risen with the growing population over time?

Come to think of it... joining Key House as a Hunter didn't sound so bad!

You'd get to learn so much about hunters and everything related to them.

Carrying that thought, along with the regret of wanting to flip through the books but not being able to, Mai Minghe quietly slipped out of the reading room.

Before pushing open each door, she would listen carefully to the surroundings; and whatever kind of room lay behind it, as long as she could get in, she photographed it from every direction.

Not just the rooms themselves—staircases, hallways, corners, the kitchen... even spots along the walls beneath the staircase where a hidden room might be concealed. Mai Minghe photographed all of it.

The place where Artifacts were stored had to be the most restricted part of the House Faction—never mind gaining entry; even locating it was likely buried so deep that getting close would be next to impossible.

The odds of finding the lipstick on this one visit alone were far too low—if she could turn up even a single clue today, that would already count as a success.

As long as she had a rough idea of where the lipstick was hidden, she wouldn't need to enter the Nest with Tianxi's group tomorrow; with Key House's people gone, the manor would be empty—that would be a far better opportunity to retrieve the lipstick.

Moving as quietly as she could past the large room where Tianxi's interview was underway, listening to the low murmur of voices behind the door, Mai Minghe climbed the stairs step by step.

Standing at the top of the staircase on the second floor, she first photographed the space in every direction, then went through the same process for the entire second floor; whenever she heard voices, she hurried to find a corner to hide in, and came back out once they faded.

Fortunately, the Key House manor was larger than she had expected, with plenty of places to conceal herself—though there were a few tense moments, she made it through without being discovered.

Half the rooms on the second floor were locked; the one at the far eastern end appeared to be the chief's office, with a nameplate reading "Roland Key" hung on the door—she didn't see Chase's office anywhere.

He probably doesn't need one, Mai Minghe thought to herself. That man always seemed to be out running around—an office would be wasted on him.

Among the remaining locked rooms, three in a row bore labels reading "Equipment Supply," one was marked "Weapons," and two others read "Evidence" and "Research" respectively—

evidence and research?

Mai Minghe was momentarily taken aback.

"Evidence"—surely that wasn't Key House's own criminal evidence?

They were a hunter House Faction. What was there to research?

Carrying all these questions, she climbed to the third floor.

Compared to the two floors below, the third floor narrowed sharply, the space including the attic divided into several half-levels, and the ceiling rose into a tall triangle.

It took Mai Minghe fewer than ten minutes to cover the entire third floor and finish taking her photos—yet she still couldn't say where the Artifacts might be stored.

The locked rooms didn't appear to be fitted with anything special or high-level in the way of security—bluntly put, a single shot could blast them open. Keeping Artifacts behind an ordinary door lock seemed rather careless, didn't it?

That said, the situation wasn't entirely surprising to Mai Minghe.

Key House would never leave their most important location in plain sight with just a lock on it, visible to anyone who walked by... she had another approach that might lead her to a clue.

In the surrounding silence, Mai Minghe made her way back to the staircase landing on the third floor.

Now, she needed to get out of the Key House manor quickly—

Out of the corner of her eye, a white shape suddenly bent toward her.

She turned her head on instinct.

In that brief, drawn-out instant, Mai Minghe stood frozen, unable to make sense of what she was seeing.

The snow-white long-stemmed lilies that had been sitting on the side table in the first-floor hallway were now blooming in midair behind her, each one bowing its head toward her in turn.

She had never noticed before how large lily blooms could be—large enough to fully engulf a person's face.

Water streamed down the lily stems and fell through the air; the glass vase followed, shattering on the floor with a sharp crack.

One by one the lilies still hung suspended in the air, still slowly widening, slowly pressing down over her face, the heart of each bloom opening to reveal a core of absolute darkness—

"Who's up there?"

A shout came from the bottom of the staircase.

Well, the update time has come full circle again, back to this hour...

To everyone who has been following along—you've really had it tough. Waiting on a story that can't update on a fixed schedule must be pretty draining, right?

Sigh, if only I could get my sleep schedule under control—I really don't want to keep you all waiting either...

Chapter 227 — Mai Minghe, No One Opens the Door

The sound of rushing footsteps and voices tumbling down from the staircase jolted Mai Minghe awake in an instant.

With that shock, the long lily petals—like curling fingers perpetually expanding in midair—finally slid away from her consciousness, letting her mind wrench free from the pitch darkness at the flower's heart. Her heart felt as though it were trying to burst out through her throat and ears all at once, and the pounding of blood in her veins left Mai Minghe unable to hear anything clearly for a brief moment.

Move. Now.

The staircase was behind her, the floating lilies before her; for a moment she could only stumble sideways a few steps, landing against the stair railing with a dull thud.

Only then did she realize that the person below seemed to have called out several times already.

Perhaps because Mai Minghe had never responded, the person stopped shouting up at her demanding she identify herself, and instead bellowed downstairs: "Get a few people up to the third floor! Let Tianxi know!"

Less than ten seconds had passed since the glass vase shattered on the floor, yet several sets of footsteps had already multiplied on the staircase; and among them, another unmistakable metallic click rang out, sharp and crisp, snapping through the air one after another.

Mai Minghe had never fired a gun, but she had watched movies; she knew that sound — it was the click of a firearm's safety being disengaged.

So when they were within the House Faction's walls, they all carried guns on them? Ready to draw at any moment?

No wonder the manor had no guards or anything of the sort — in a place where every single person was a combat member, what would they need guards for?

This was no time for musing.

Mai Minghe skirted around the lilies, turned, and rushed back into the central living room on the third floor, stealing a glance back as she went.

Those few enormous lily blossoms in midair seemed, in that moment, to suddenly remember that they were nothing more than a bunch of flowers; their petals drew in narrowly and were yanked straight down from midair onto the floor with a soft thwap.

A floor of shattered glass, water slowly spreading outward, and a few limp lily stems — it looked almost like an arrow pointing the way for the people below.

...What in the world was going on?

Was it some kind of Artifact used as a perimeter alarm?

But why only tip the vase to the floor — why not be more thorough about it? Like triggering an alarm throughout the entire house, for instance, or reporting her location immediately?

The footsteps were drawing closer. Whoever was coming only needed to round one more corner and climb the last flight of stairs to spot Mai Minghe standing in the open living room; yet her head was buzzing so loudly that she had no idea where to go.

She had just done a full sweep of the third floor moments ago — she knew perfectly well there was almost nowhere to hide up here.

The first floor of Key House was an open communal area encompassing the kitchen and dining room, a space for House Faction Hunters to use freely, with many rooms that were left unlocked and could be entered and exited at will; the second floor held important figures and supplies, and a certain level of clearance was required to open some of the doors.

But the third floor was different.

The third floor had clearly undergone renovations at some point, with several walls and doors removed; the goal was to connect half the floor into one open space and create an airy, well-lit atmosphere — which meant that just a handful of people could sweep the entire third floor completely.

Mai Minghe had no luxury of time to think.

By the time several people charged up to the third floor and stopped short before the shattered glass on the floor, she had already ducked into a corridor alongside the living room — one side of the corridor opened onto a wraparound viewing balcony, and sunlight had painted half the floor bright, making Mai Minghe feel all the more exposed.

From a few meters away, someone let out a puzzled sound.

"Is there a vase here? Where did these flowers come from?"

"I remember this being a first-floor flower arrangement," a woman's voice said hesitantly — it was Shaxue.

Did that mean even they had no idea what had happened with the lilies?

"Never mind the vase — someone was definitely here," another low, heavy voice said. "Spread out and search. The person should still be on the third floor. Shaxue, block the staircase."

Just like that, the only exit off the third floor was sealed.

In truth, manors built around the same era as the Key House estate typically had a back staircase — set aside specifically for servants to move about and carry out their work without entering the master's line of sight.

But Mai Minghe had already noticed, just moments earlier, that after more than a hundred years of changes and renovations, the back staircase had long since been converted into a freight elevator — and without a key card, the elevator door could not be opened.

Where to go?

Mai Minghe gritted through the pain in her feet, trying not to make a sound while also not daring to slow down; but even if she pushed forward as hard as she could, she knew she would eventually be cornered by the people fanning out around her — this corridor wrapped around the entire third floor, and she could already hear footsteps coming at her from the other end.

She glanced at the corridor window.

Was climbing out through the window really her only option?

She had already peered out earlier — the moment the window was pushed open, there was fifteen-odd meters of open air below; the outer wall dropped straight down, with not a single foothold, not even anything to grip onto.

Setting aside the question of how long she could hang in midair by her hands alone, the Key House Hunters weren't blind enough to miss it — a window half-open, a row of fingers clinging to the sill, that would be just as obvious at a glance.

If not for that inexplicable vase of lilies, she would probably have slipped free of Key House by now; how on earth had things suddenly come to this?

What now?

Mai Minghe was so desperate she was practically ready to scale the walls — footsteps were closing in from both ahead and behind; and along this stretch of corridor, there was only one room, its door firmly shut.

When she had passed it earlier, she had only taken a photo and not tried pushing it open.

Because anyone who glanced at the keypad lock beside the door would know there was no point; a door that locked automatically the moment it closed could not be pushed open.

"Who's there?"

From around the bend in the corridor, a stranger's woman's voice rang out. She sounded not only free of hostility but almost gentle — in a tone that was practically intimate — and said: "I know you're right there in the corridor. I can already see your shadow."

Mai Minghe jolted and swept a quick glance at the floor — a bluff, surely?

She pressed herself back against the wall beside the door, feeling a vein at her temple throbbing, throbbing, as though it were about to burst.

If she walked out and surrendered, what would the Key House do to her?

Whatever happened, she could forget about ever getting the lipstick back, right?

"Are you here to take advantage of us being shorthanded and slip in for some money?" the woman's voice remained gentle. "I'm afraid you've come to the wrong place. Put down your weapon. Don't resist — I can guarantee your firepower is nothing compared to ours."

She was stalling — because from the other end of the corridor, someone was approaching with carefully muffled footsteps.

How had she ended up cornered like this?

Should she... should she just surrender and walk out?

A soft tap — as if someone had lightly touched the door with a fingertip; the sound was so faint it nearly slipped past the edge of her awareness entirely.

Following that faint sound, Mai Minghe turned her head toward the door.

The first thing she saw was a small, green light on the keypad — suddenly lit.

For a moment she didn't even understand what that light meant — but the next instant, she saw it.

The door slid open a crack.

Mai Minghe did not see with her own eyes the moment the Key House Hunters burst out of the corridor and charged forward, sealing it off.

But she could imagine the confusion and alarm on their faces when they raised their guns and shouted "Don't move," then turned their gazes into the corridor.

There was no one left in the corridor; when the voices surged in, she was already standing inside the room, the door quietly and soundlessly closed behind her.

Mai Minghe stood facing the door, her back to the room. Aside from the fleeting glance she had cast when she slipped inside, she had not yet turned to look at the room behind her — all she knew was that when the door had slid open, there had been no one on the other side.

She could not bring herself to think about who had opened the door for her from inside the room.

There was only one thought in her mind right now, and it had frozen her whole body in place.

At the far end of the room, that human-shaped void — motionless, as though staring straight at her — what in the world was it?

I didn't get any rest on Saturday at all, and after a full day of work running on too little sleep, I realized I forgot to write the thank-you note at the end of the chapter!

I'm truly sorry, everyone — I'll make it up next Saturday along with that one.

Chapter 228: Taylor Ford's Prayer

Taylor Ford heard himself let out a low cry: "Dad..."

He could not find his own body; his soul had long since boarded a ship sailing far away. What remained of him seemed to dissolve into pitch-black waves, surging and receding one after another—unable to see the moon, yet forever driven by it.

In such a state, he could still hear Han Ford's reply.

"Mm, I'm here."

"Will you always be here?"

...So familiar.

It was as though this conversation had happened once before. For instance, he already knew that after a brief pause, Han Ford would ask—

"Do you want me to always be here?"

He also knew his own answer. Sure enough, he heard himself say:

"I don't know... I think it would be reassuring, but also painful. Sometimes I think it would be better if you were dead, yet I'm also afraid of you dying."

Silence fell again in the darkness.

Huh, that's a little strange.

Why wasn't Dad angry?

Taylor Ford drifted into a daze of puzzlement.

Hearing something like that, there was no way he wouldn't have gotten angry.

Taylor Ford remembered that the third time he came out of the Nest, he was only twelve years old, in the last summer vacation of elementary school. While his classmates went on trips to beat the heat, traveled with their families, or attended summer camps, he had finally succeeded in bringing back the first Artifact of his life.

After a series of unbelievable, curious, experimental, and euphoric events, Han Ford quickly found a buyer—he had a real gift for that sort of thing, perhaps because he had spent years selling

off belongings and had been well trained in it—the exact price it sold for, Taylor Ford never knew.

"Great news," Han Ford was ecstatic. "Haven't you always wanted a mountain bike? No problem, we'll buy one! And where was it you wanted to go? Dad will take you, I'll buy tickets right now."

They never went.

Han Ford suddenly vanished for nearly three weeks.

His best clothes, his phone, his wallet, his keys—all gone with him.

To this day, Taylor Ford could not say he had fully figured out where his father had gone during that time—he only knew that when Han Ford finally came back, he had dark circles under his eyes and looked exhausted, his body reeking of a thick, complicated odor that was deeply unpleasant—cigarettes, alcohol, sweat, and perfume all mixed together with the smell of vomit—and yet the clothes on his body were brand new.

Faced with Taylor Ford's tearful protests, Han Ford took several large strides into the kitchen, pulled out a tin of cookies, flipped off the lid, and snapped: "What's all this fuss about? Look! Didn't I leave you money? Wasn't that enough to eat on?"

The cookie tin hid three hundred and seventy-two dollars—for a child, that was perhaps a considerable sum, and one couldn't exactly say it wasn't enough to eat on for three weeks.

But for three consecutive weeks, Taylor Ford had dared to live only on water, bread, and jam, with only the occasional burger; because he didn't know when Han Ford would come back, or whether he would come back at all, and he didn't know how long he'd have to stretch those three hundred and seventy-two dollars.

One evening during that period, Taylor Ford sat alone in front of the television, licking Nutella off a spoon, thinking with near-perfect calm: handing the Artifact or the money over to Dad might have been a mistake.

"How could I possibly not come back—you're my son, could I just abandon you?"

Han Ford looked at his son's red and swollen eyes and softened his tone, one hand kneading Taylor Ford's shoulder as he said: "...Besides, if you're worried about not having enough money, you can just go into the Nest again."

He raised his head to look at Han Ford.

Before his father had even said the words aloud, Taylor Ford had already heard what Han Ford would say next.

"Oh right," Han Ford said. "Isn't it about time you went back into the Nest again?"

He said the last Artifact hadn't sold for a good price, that the money hadn't gone far, and it was already running out.

"All you know how to do is send me in—why don't you go yourself?"

During that period, Taylor Ford dreamed every night of disjointed fragments of his experiences in the Nest. Without knowing when it had started, he was crying again, his palms soaked in cold sweat, and he shouted: "Don't tell me you can't go in—even if you could, you'd definitely die the moment you got inside—"

Han Ford's slap came without warning.

"Is that what you're hoping for? Your own father dead?" Han Ford's face had gone crimson, filled with an intense fury that seemed to come from nowhere. "You'd be happy if I died? Am I such an eyesore to you while I'm alive?"

Taylor Ford froze.

He was still young then; his first instinct was to defend himself: "No, that's not what I meant..."

Taylor Ford opened his eyes. The pitch-black waves slowly receded, and no new surge came.

The light and shapes in his field of vision gradually solidified and sharpened through the haze, until he could make out a ceiling, an IV bag, white bed sheets, and a person slumped over asleep at the corner of the bed.

The person still held a phone in their hand, their back rising and falling gently, a coat draped over their shoulders.

To the steady rhythm of beep—beep—, Taylor Ford turned his head and found himself connected to a vital-signs monitor by a tangle of leads.

He had said that he sometimes wanted Han Ford to die.

Han Ford had shown no reaction whatsoever—not because Taylor Ford had been gravely injured and on the verge of losing consciousness at the time, but because that had not been Han Ford.

Taylor Ford lay quietly, staring at the ceiling.

He had been lying on the floor then, his mind clouded and his thoughts adrift, and he had said quite a lot—but it all seemed to have been directed at the "Han Ford dough figure" that hadn't actually been there.

...Which meant Han Ford probably didn't know about the "Nest Domination Game," then.

He also hadn't heard the nonsense Taylor Ford had been muttering about how everyone could be free.

For some reason, Taylor Ford felt as though he had, all at once, come back to his senses about the "Nest Domination Game."

The finish line was distant and indistinct; if everyone killed each other off before reaching it, that could hardly be called freedom.

...At what point had the person he was talking to shifted from the "Han Ford dough figure" to Han Ford himself?

He knew perfectly well that before he had fully lost consciousness, Han Ford had come back to the apartment looking for him.

Taylor Ford remembered the floor vibrating through his fading mind, jolting him back from the fog; he remembered someone gently cradling the back of his head, speaking urgently in a rapid stream—"I've called someone," "Morgan House Faction is sending people," "the ambulance is almost here."

At that moment, the "Han Ford dough figure" had disappeared... at that moment, the person beside him had been Han Ford.

Which meant...

At the very last edge of consciousness, Taylor Ford had struggled to speak the words to Han Ford.

"Kitchen... on the wall, the painting of the little cat. Keep it safe, don't let anyone find it..."

What had Han Ford's reaction been at the time?

Had he asked Taylor Ford what it was? Had he asked why it mattered so much?

Taylor Ford couldn't remember any of it.

On the bedside table next to him sat a vase of flowers, but there was no phone, and certainly no little cat painting—which was only natural; Han Ford wasn't so oblivious to priorities.

What time was it now? What was the date?

Taylor Ford slowly pushed himself upright; he couldn't even tell which part of him was injured, because his entire upper body felt as though it was about to split apart, sending waves of darkness across his vision.

He pulled the oxygen tube out of his nose, reached out with a labored stretch, and tapped the screen of the phone being held in someone's hand at the corner of the bed—the screen lit up and told him it was November 23rd, 11:15 PM.

The touch also startled Remy awake.

"Director?"

She sat up, bleary-eyed, her coat sliding off, which she quickly grabbed. She looked at the phone in her hand, then looked at Taylor Ford.

"You're finally awake? If you'd slept any longer, the doctors would have started to worry something had gone wrong."

"...Am I okay?"

Remy clicked her tongue. "Depends on your definition of 'okay'... but no vital organs have ruptured."

Then he was okay.

"Where's my dad?"

The moment it left his mouth, Taylor Ford felt a small pang of regret—he shouldn't have said "my dad," he should have said "Han Ford."

"I don't know." Remy rubbed her eyes; perhaps from sleeping slumped over, her eyeliner had smudged slightly. "After you were admitted, he disappeared. We've been trying to reach him for over a day now—his phone is off, messages have gone unanswered, and no one answers at his place either."

Taylor Ford sat on the hospital bed, staring at her blankly. "Has anyone seen him?"

"Yes—when he told me to come to the hospital, I saw him briefly." Remy wore an expression that was hard to describe, as if she couldn't decide whether to feel sympathy. "He said he was going out for a smoke, and then he left... That was past eleven o'clock on the night of the 21st. After that, no one's been able to reach him."

"Did he leave you any instructions, or give you anything to keep for him?"

Before Remy could answer, Taylor Ford had already heard what she was going to say.

"No."

Taylor Ford lowered his head and looked at his own bloodless fingers, curled weakly against the white bed sheet.

"...What about the House Faction?"

He had meant to ask whether the House Faction had seen Han Ford, and when they'd last seen him; but Remy misunderstood and immediately said: "Oh, that's a good reminder. Mr. Carter Morgan said that the moment you woke up, I was to notify him right away—he wants to ask you in person what exactly happened... something about friction with Key House Faction?"

She gave Taylor Ford a look tinged with unease and said, "This is no small matter... wait here, I'll go make a call."

Remy wasn't his person—she was Morgan House Faction's; and even though just thinking about having to deal with Carter made him tired, he had no grounds to tell Remy not to notify Carter.

Nothing to do but face what came—he'd deal with it when the time came.

Before she stood up to make the call, Taylor Ford managed to squeeze in one question: "Where are my things? Where's my phone?"

Remy pressed the phone to her ear with one hand and opened the bedside cabinet door with the other.

"We also found that black-panel Artifact of yours in the apartment—but no one dared touch it, so it's still there, we didn't bring it over. Don't worry, someone's been there keeping an eye on it these past two days. It hasn't gone anywhere."

Taylor Ford very much wanted to ask whether a little cat painting still hung on the kitchen wall, but he held himself back.

From the bedside cabinet he retrieved the backpack he'd had on when he came home, a set of clothes prepared for his discharge, and most importantly, his phone and charger.

When Taylor Ford turned on his phone, he hadn't actually thought about what he might see—he had just woken from a serious injury, every cell in his body screaming in pain, his mind a complete blank.

It was a kind of dazed instinct, a mechanical hope—he felt like he should check his messages, listen to see if there were any voicemails.

When he first caught sight of the Nest notification, Taylor Ford's immediate assumption was that it was a death notice for Chase—poisoned and fallen from a building, surely he must be dead by now?

But three Nest notifications had come in one after another, all stacked at the bottom of the screen; even with Chase's luck, he couldn't die three times in a row.

As it turned out, reality was worse than he had expected.

From the first two notifications, for reasons unknown, Chase had not only survived but had taken yet another target Artifact from a player named Sydney Ginn—his progress was now, incredibly, at 2/7.

He had found an ally in the "Nest Domination Game"?

Taylor Ford drew in a long, slow breath and tapped open the third notification.

—

Still a bit green after all, young player Taylor Ford:

My, my—how did you end up in such a state?

Almost dead at seventeen—it truly is heartbreaking, and frightening to think about.

You originally had not a single target Artifact to your name, which put you well below the criteria for conscription; the only reason you were able to enter the Nest Domination Game at all was through a "special Nest invitation."

The status of a specially invited player depends entirely on the target Artifacts in your possession!

If you keep failing to obtain target Artifacts—or obtain them only to lose them again—did you really think you could maintain your status as a specially invited player indefinitely?

Oh? Did I never mention this before?

No matter—it's not too late to say it now, and if I never said it before, that's not the Nest's fault. The Nest is never at fault.

Yes, this notification was sent to tell you exactly that, bluntly and directly.

Your contestant status has been revoked oh what a shame what a heartache tsk tsk what a truly unexpected turn of events but all things considered you're a veteran Hunter with five years of experience and you still let someone take your target Artifact from you so in the end it really does come down to your own failings doesn't it you can't blame the Nest for that anyway you're free now you don't have to collect the target Artifact anymore you're no longer part of the game bye

I just realized that Taylor Ford's last appearance was back in October 2024... well, I almost forgot there was even such a person (not really)

Speaking of which, maybe I'm a bit out of touch with the world — online novel marketing has gotten this intense? I discovered it on Xiaohongshu... book-promotion accounts, reader accounts, all kinds of accounts repeatedly posting and replying to push recommendations. After seeing it a few times I confirmed it: the recommendation posts are paid placements, the enthusiastic replies are bots, and naturally I can't name the book here.

I'd like to think the people who do this are still a minority.

Chapter 229: Taylor Ford, Perfectly Reasonable

...It would have been better if he'd never woken up.

Taylor Ford was calm in a way that surprised even himself—no, perhaps "calm" wasn't the right word.

He was more like a sheet of paper that had been crumpled and folded over and over again—every fiber of it torn apart, without enough strength to smooth itself back out, only able to spread across the hospital bed in the vague shape of a person.

He lay motionless, watching doctors and nurses come and go, checking on him and asking questions, feeling too exhausted even to open his mouth.

"Do you remember what happened before you came to the hospital?"

"Yes."

"How do you feel? Can you feel pressure on your limbs?"

"Yes."

"Is the pain severe? Do you need more pain relief—"

"It hurts," Taylor Ford said immediately. "Give me more. I need it."

After the medical staff left, he lay alone in bed with his eyes shut, trying to hypnotize his own mind into slipping back into unconsciousness. As long as he was out, the outside world had nothing to do with him, and he wouldn't have to think about anything.

But unfortunately, by the time Remy returned to the ward, he was still awake—he could feel his own eyelids trembling faintly. Since he couldn't keep pretending, he might as well open his eyes.

"Mr. Morgan is on his way," Remy said, glancing at him.

Though the age, the setting, and the circumstances were all wrong, Taylor Ford was reminded of the look that used to appear on classmates' faces when someone had gotten into trouble and been called to the principal's office.

He was in no state to deal with his boss right now.

"Do you have the energy to talk?"

Remy hesitated, then suddenly shook her head with a small smile, her deep-brown-painted lips curling upward. "Hah, even if you don't have the energy, you'll have to squeeze some out—can't be helped. Is there anything you need? I was about to go get a coffee."

Come to think of it, it had been over forty-eight hours since he'd eaten anything, but Taylor Ford didn't feel hungry.

He was about to shake his head when the word "coffee" gently grazed some nerve inside him.

"Why haven't you gone home? I'm already awake."

"Because of the friction between you and Key House Faction," Remy said with a shrug. "Just to be safe, I'm not only keeping an eye on you here—I've had people stationed at your apartment the whole time, too. That was your last order before you passed out."

She'd mentioned that just now as well...

Taylor Ford had the nagging feeling that he'd overlooked something.

But he was utterly exhausted right now, his mind a numb and empty blank—whatever he'd overlooked might as well not exist, because he had no energy to think about it.

He could only seize the idea that had just surfaced and say: "Who's guarding the apartment? Have them video call me."

"What's wrong?"

"I want to see what it looks like inside."

Remy didn't ask anything further. A few minutes later, Taylor Ford was on a video call—he had the Hunter on duty hold up their phone and walk around the apartment filming it for him. He hadn't told them where to go specifically, but as the camera swept and panned, he could already see clearly: the small cat painting on the kitchen wall was gone.

Han Ford had taken the cat painting, just as he'd instructed.

All at once, Taylor Ford wanted to piece together every detail of that night. Just like when he was twelve; back then, he'd torn the house apart searching for any trace, any clue, trying to figure out where his father had gone and how long he planned to be away.

"What time was I admitted to the hospital on the 21st?"

Remy thought for a moment. "Around ten at night? No later than ten-thirty."

Judging by the timeline, Han Ford had moved fast—the moment he returned to the apartment, he'd called an ambulance immediately, which was how Taylor Ford had been brought to the hospital in time.

"When Han Ford called for help, who did he contact?"

Remy scratched her head. "Me," she said.

"What did he say?"

"He was in a hurry. He said you'd been seriously injured at home, that he'd already called an ambulance. He said he'd taken a wound to the leg himself and was losing blood, that he'd be following the ambulance. He told me to get to the hospital right away, and to send someone to watch the apartment—he said that was your last order before you lost consciousness."

Taylor Ford didn't even remember giving that order—but thinking about it carefully, first telling Han Ford to take the cat painting, then having someone guard an apartment that no longer had anything worth guarding: that did sound like something he would do.

Apparently the ambulance arrived before the House Faction Hunters; Han Ford must have had the cat painting on him when he came to the hospital.

"After you arrived at the hospital, what did you and Han Ford say to each other?"

Remy shrugged. "After I got here, I didn't see either of you for a good while. You were in surgery, and Mr. Han Ford was having his injuries treated."

Once his injuries were dealt with, Han Ford told her to keep waiting outside the operating room for Taylor Ford, said he wanted a cigarette, and—over a nurse's objections—walked out on his crutches. No one saw him after that.

When he disappeared, the clock had just ticked past midnight, and the date had only just turned to the 22nd.

Taylor Ford closed his eyes.

His mind was a fog of exhaustion, too sluggish to turn, yet unable to simply lose consciousness cleanly.

There was no point in asking anyway; back then, he'd dug up a pile of receipts, business cards, browsing histories, and all it amounted to was sitting at home, waiting in a daze.

Taylor Ford took out his phone and stared at the notification of his removal from the list for nearly ten minutes.

...That's it?

They were treating him like a complete fool.

Give you hope and a goal, then snatch it away with one swift blow and tell you that you were never worthy of it—that its being taken away was your own fault.

Simply because Han Ford had taken the Key away—

Taylor Ford squeezed his eyes shut and cut off the thought. But more came crawling out, like weeds pushing through cracked earth.

On the morning of the 22nd, while he was still unconscious, Chase had obtained another target Artifact, and he had been removed from the list without having done a single thing—

"Director?"

Remy called out to him softly, and Taylor Ford opened his eyes.

"Mr. Morgan is here."

He pretended not to hear the footsteps coming through the door.

When Remy said "I'll step out to get coffee, you two talk," Taylor Ford kept his gaze fixed on the ceiling, took a few slow breaths, giving himself a moment—until someone sat down beside him, and then he finally, slowly, turned his head.

Carter Morgan caught his gaze and, in the silence, flashed him a toothy smile.

Taylor Ford's gut clenched.

Carter Morgan didn't care for a tan; his skin was pink and fair, and he always looked as though he'd had a good night's sleep and spent a leisurely afternoon knocking back cocktails.

Though his features were regular and his figure reasonably maintained, and there was in fact no physical resemblance to speak of, he always reminded Taylor Ford of a friendly, well-fed pig.

Taylor Ford had never seen a real pig; his deepest impression of pigs came from a book on the school reading list—George Orwell's *Animal Farm*.

Right now, Carter was smiling warmly, his eyes quietly bright.

"Taylor,"

he said pleasantly, "the doctor tells me your condition has stabilized?"

"I'm still very weak," Taylor Ford said.

Carter Morgan nodded, acknowledging this, but made no move to suggest he'd leave soon and let Taylor Ford rest.

With the pleasantries out of the way, he didn't beat around the bush.

"You're known as a genius Hunter in our circles... hunting Artifacts is a business, and I would have thought you understood that."

Carter Morgan took a careful look at the vital signs monitor.

"Though the name carries the word 'House,' we are fundamentally a modern commercial organization—one that pursues profit and efficiency. Getting into some kind of gang war with other Hunter House Factions... that was never why the board decided to hire you.

"War may be the most profitable business there is, but this kind of gang war would only erode our interests." Carter let out a small laugh, as if he thought he'd just made a rather clever joke.

Gang war?

Taylor Ford felt like he was on the verge of grasping something, but under the numbing haze of the painkillers, his brain seemed to be refusing to turn.

"Tell me," Carter sighed, with the air of someone indulging a young person's willfulness. "What exactly happened? What led things to this point?"

"It was just a misunderstanding," Taylor Ford said, the lie coming out instinctively.

Lies were one of the few things in the world that were entirely within his control—a place he could stand on solid ground.

"A misunderstanding?"

"That's right. It actually traces back to one of my runs into the Nest. He thought I'd taken a Key House—"

He didn't finish the sentence. Taylor Ford suddenly stopped.

Key House?

He turned his head and looked at Carter Morgan's quietly glowing eyes.

Every muscle in the man's face, every line of it, seemed—after years of conditioning by his environment—to be capable of fixing itself effortlessly into an expression of warmth and affability that was, underneath it all, completely blank.

Taylor Ford didn't know why he hadn't thought of this question until now.

"How did you... how did you know it was Key House Faction that had a conflict with me?"

By the time the Morgan House Faction Hunters arrived, Chase had long since left the apartment.

Based on what Remy had just told him, neither over the phone nor after arriving at the hospital had Han Ford told her that the person who had seriously injured Taylor Ford was Chase.

And besides—he did know Han Ford.

Han Ford was no fool, especially when it came to interests.

He would certainly have realized that an Artifact two people had fought to the death over must be extraordinarily valuable—and in all likelihood, it was the cat painting he had on him.

Leaking the information that "Chase" was involved would inevitably lead to questions about why the two had fought to the death; and once reasons were discussed, there was a good chance some sharp-eyed Hunter would start to notice that Han Ford had been carrying a decorative painting when he walked into the hospital.

Carter cleared his throat and smiled faintly.

"You don't know—on the night of the 21st, the gunshots and the fighting in your apartment drew a lot of attention. Some passerby recorded a video of Chase falling out the window and uploaded it online... it was precisely because we saw the video that we realized the person who had the confrontation with you that night was Key House's Chase."

So that was it.

That night, there really had been quite a crowd gathering on the street outside the window... if they hadn't called the police, Chase wouldn't have happened to land right on the crash mat.

The explanation was perfectly reasonable.

But Taylor Ford was a Hunter.

A skilled Hunter would always dig one layer deeper—and would not stop until the quarry was something truly satisfying.

"Where's that video? I'd like to see it."

Carter paused, and his face and smile both dropped at once; he reached down and brushed at a nonexistent speck of dust on his trouser leg.

My sleep schedule has gone haywire again lately—I suddenly can't fall asleep no matter how hard I try.

I fixed a small bug in yesterday's chapter: Han Ford bringing Taylor Ford to the hospital wasn't "yesterday"—it was the 21st.

Come to think of it, it's been six days in the Artifact world since Mai Minghe entered the Nest on the 17th—one month in the real world equals one day in the Artifact world!

But then again, that's not so strange, I suppose—mainly because there are so many perspectives. There are 8 billion people in the world; if you wrote about every single person's day, you couldn't finish it in ten lifetimes.

Chapter 230: The Chains Taylor Ford Cannot Hear

Taylor Ford pressed play on the video again.

He had already watched the same clip twice, and the third playthrough was naturally no different:

Amid the crowd's startled cries, a tall figure tumbled out through an apartment's floor-to-ceiling window; he barely caught hold of a window pushed open outward, hung suspended for a few seconds, then plummeted straight down into a cushioned pad on the sidewalk—the enormous goat head on his neck carving a white blur through the night.

"I swear, with my own eyes it didn't look like a goat head at all,"

The camera swung around to a young man's face. His expression was one of astonished excitement as he stressed to the lens: "I looked at the screen just now and my jaw dropped. The guy who fell—he wasn't wearing any kind of goat head. So how did a goat head end up in the video? Could it be some kind of signal interference or something—"

Taylor Ford closed the video.

From the footage alone, there was no way to tell that the person who had fallen from the building was Chase.

Carter took his phone back, his expression unchanged.

"If I didn't happen to know that Chase Monroe had an Artifact like that on him, there's no way we could have figured out immediately that the ones who had a run-in with you were the Key House Faction."

"I didn't realize you'd been keeping such close tabs on Artifact news in the community," Taylor Ford said quietly.

"Of course I have to keep tabs," Carter laughed. "My bills are paid by Artifacts—that's my bread and butter."

Was he saying that to flatter the importance of the Hunter Director?

The Morgan House Faction had made its name in the Hunter trade, but had long since grown into a cross-industry conglomerate; the reason it still maintained its Hunter branch had less to do

with profit than an unwillingness to extricate itself from the world of Artifacts.

If it was a matter of not wanting to miss out on useful Artifacts, then Carter keeping close tabs on things was perfectly reasonable...

Or rather, it couldn't be disproved.

"Is Key House trying to quietly suppress the video?"

Taylor Ford's mind was sluggish at the moment; he could only say inconsequential things to buy himself some reaction time.

"Right," Carter was equally patient. "As you know, at most they hire a few accounts to say the blogger faked the video for clicks, and within a couple of days the internet will have forgotten the whole thing. After all, the internet never runs short of strange stories and news."

"Which hospital did Chase go to?" Taylor Ford asked.

Carter smiled slightly.

"...I said, the board doesn't want to see gang warfare. Where he went for treatment—I don't know, and it's not the Morgan House Faction's business. What I want to know is why you two came to a life-and-death conflict."

So it had come back around to that question after all.

The Key House Faction operated under a traditional system resembling a criminal syndicate, and on the surface its methods and style were worlds apart from the Morgan House Faction's corporate model—yet at the end of the day, both were driven by profit.

A Hunter's profit wasn't won by seizing turf, but wrested from the treacherous and unpredictable Nest.

Unless the reward was exceptionally tempting, violent conflict between Hunter House Factions was generally rare.

The real reward, however, was something he couldn't tell Carter about; and making up some Artifact story on the spot could leave loose ends, or fail to hold up under scrutiny.

Only now did Taylor Ford realize that even though he had been eliminated from the Nest Domination Game, he still had no desire to share that information with Carter—why was that?

But now was not the time to dwell on the reason.

"...It comes down to what happened the last time I went into the Nest."

Carter had no passage, and Taylor Ford often operated alone inside the Nest; his account was equally impossible to disprove.

"He thought I'd taken an Artifact the Key House Faction was looking for, so the next time I entered the Nest, Key House Hunters came after me. But I hadn't actually taken anything—they just wouldn't believe me when I said so, and it cost me no small amount of breath. In the brief window when we were tangled up with each other, the Key House Hunters were ambushed by a Resident."

Taylor Ford had heard that Key House had suffered some losses recently—but as for exactly who had been lost and how, Chase couldn't possibly have reported each case to Carter in detail.

"You've definitely heard of Chase's reputation—the way he acts deeply loyal and treats his own people like brothers, just to keep them devoted to him. He came to my apartment to teach me a lesson, to make sure I'd never dare lay a hand on Key House people again..."

Carter's eyes floated at the center of his face, his expression perfectly still.

He said nothing at all—until Taylor Ford finished explaining, and the hospital room settled back into silence, broken only by the steady beeping of the machines.

Carter shifted in his seat; in the quiet room, his clothes rustled softly. Out in the equally silent hallway beyond the door, somewhere in a distant ward, a patient coughed once.

...It was nearly midnight. Was this really within the hospital's permitted visiting hours?

Taylor Ford suddenly found himself wondering.

But he didn't voice the thought; he simply watched Carter in silence.

As if lost in thought, Carter waited a long moment before suddenly asking, "A few months ago... the Key you were tracking—did you ever get a result?"

Taylor Ford was actually grateful for the pain and medication coursing through him—his face felt heavy and leaden, too sluggish to betray the jolt of surprise inside him.

"It's the Key that Wellesley had, isn't it?" Carter asked.

When Carter had signed Taylor Ford on, he had been perfectly clear about it: the reason he was offering such a high price was that, in addition to regular House Faction duties, he needed Taylor Ford to track down exactly what secret Wellesley held.

And so ever since taking the position, Taylor Ford had been giving him periodic progress reports—right up until November 15th, when he received the summons for the Nest Domination Game.

From that moment on, every piece of information Carter received had been nothing but smoke and mirrors.

"Unfortunately... that line of inquiry led into a dead end in the end," Taylor Ford said.

"Ah." Carter nodded as though he understood something. "So you still don't know what secret Wellesley actually holds?"

Taylor Ford didn't like his position in this conversation, but for the moment he had no answer other than to shake his head in denial.

"Which means... you're telling me that the conflict between you and Chase, and the conflict between Chase and Wellesley's people, are two completely separate incidents with no connection whatsoever?"

Taylor Ford could no longer bring himself to nod.

He had no idea about any of this—when had Chase gotten into a conflict with Wellesley's side? That person stirred up trouble around the clock; did he ever even sleep?

Wait—could it be that the second Artifact in his hands hadn't been obtained by his ally to begin with, but seized from Wellesley's side?

He dredged through his foggy mind for a while—what Artifacts had the Wellesley Team been holding before all this?

But even if Taylor Ford's brain had been washed clean by the medication, he could still hear what Carter was implying beneath his words.

Carter pulled his chair closer to the hospital bed.

He leaned both elbows on the bed, pressing down firmly on the covers over Taylor Ford; that face—the kind that could have starred in *Animal Farm*—was now uncomfortably close.

"You see," Carter explained with great patience, "your account is very plausible, but the biggest problem is that Chase Monroe is not an impulsive fool."

Taylor Ford said nothing.

"That he'd come after you on behalf of his people—that does fit his reputation, and I can't say it's impossible. But the interesting part is that on the very same night he had his clash with you, he immediately went and had another conflict with Wellesley's people right after."

He really wished that when he opened his eyes, he'd find himself lying in his apartment bedroom.

"You didn't know about this because you were still unconscious at the time. I had told the House Faction Hunters that once you woke up, they shouldn't bother you with any of this... it seems they were considerate enough, and sure enough, they didn't say a word. So this is where it gets strange. Why? Why would that Chase Monroe, with no regard for the damage it might do to Key House's interests, get into conflict after conflict with other factions?"

He narrowed his eyes. "It almost seems like... all of you are fighting over the same thing."

On the wall of Taylor Ford's apartment bedroom hung a mountain bike.

His bedroom held not a single trace that might suggest a seventeen-year-old lived there; it was so devoid of personal character that it felt more like a hotel room than a hotel.

The only exception was the mountain bike on the wall.

"See, I didn't forget."

That day, Han Ford had called him to sit down with his back to the front door, an apologetic look on his face, and after a short while Taylor Ford felt him lightly tap his shoulder.

He turned around and saw the brand-new mountain bike hanging there with a gift bow on it.

"Got you the best one they had," Han Ford said, patting it. "Unbelievably expensive—a bicycle, costing over three thousand dollars."

Taylor Ford was stunned. He looked at his father and asked, "The money..."

"It's already spent, isn't it," Han Ford said, rubbing his nose. "Is it a bit too big? I bought the adult size. No matter—you'll grow into it, just right."

Taylor Ford closed his eyes and opened them again; what he saw, of course, was not the mountain bike, but Carter's face.

He lowered his eyelids and let out a quiet sigh.

He had once watched a documentary exposing the plight of privately kept elephants in Thailand—elephants passed down through families like heirlooms, generation after generation, until they died with heavy chains clamped around their legs that they could never shake off.

Taylor Ford shifted his legs slightly beneath the covers—and of course, as always, he heard no sound of chains.

That was not because he had none.

"...Where is Han Ford?"

Without looking at Carter, he said quietly: "You must know, don't you?"

It's been a while since I've recommended any novels, because I haven't come across anything particularly good—but two days ago I finished *Pieces of Her*, and it was wonderful! A polished, intricate story that peels back layer by layer; well worth reading. It's already been adapted into a Netflix series, and there may be a Chinese edition as well.

Most of the books I've been reading based on Xiaohongshu recommendations (the ones with especially high likes and saves) have felt like a waste of time, leaving me at a loss—I can't tell whether the bloggers are paid to promote them or simply have poor taste.

But two consecutive Netflix-adapted books I read were genuinely quality reads—when you put real money on the line, the quality shows. The previous one was *Behind Her Eyes*, and by the time the truth was revealed toward the end, I broke out in a cold sweat.

Chapter 231: The Han Ford Brotherhood Club

Han Ford was good-looking, quick-tongued, and pleasant to talk to—at first contact, he gave people the impression of being very clever.

Even without a steady job, always dreaming big and always on the lookout for a way to make his fortune, he could still attract people from all walks of life who were happy to count him as a friend and companion—before Taylor Ford became an Artifact Hunter, Taylor had always felt that even when his father came home, one foot was still out the door.

"...But that was all in the past."

Taylor Ford didn't spare Carter so much as a glance, and said quietly: "After I became an Artifact Hunter, things started to change. One run into the Nest earned me more than Han Ford could make in half a lifetime... The big deals he was working outside, the grand ventures he undertook with all kinds of people—by comparison, they gradually lost their luster."

No business could match having a son who made money.

In the corner of his eye, Carter was still sitting quietly, giving no reaction to any of this.

"Even if he could get a rare Artifact out of my hands, even if he could make an unauthorized withdrawal from our joint account—don't misunderstand me, I'm not saying he wouldn't do it; if it came to that, he'd probably be capable of it. What I'm saying is, even if he did, he would never just vanish without a trace or leave me so much as a word."

Money always ran out eventually—Han Ford wasn't that foolish.

And beyond that, he wasn't without feelings for his own son.

If Han Ford had been completely cold-hearted and used Taylor as nothing more than a cash cow, that would almost be a relief—Taylor could have let out a long breath and set the weight down.

Carter seemed to have noticed this as well.

"That's a bit too cold a way to put it. Han Ford does love you," he said with an amiable smile. "Fathers can be bad at expressing it, but if you ask me, his feelings for you are far from purely transactional."

Taylor Ford didn't want to look at him at all.

"...I know."

Whether from sentiment or from self-interest, Han Ford had no motive to simply vanish into thin air; which meant that his current whereabouts being unknown was very likely not of his own choosing.

Of course, Taylor Ford had another detail to corroborate this suspicion.

If he hadn't spent two days in a coma before coming around, with his mind still thick and foggy, he might not have taken a full hour to belatedly realize this.

"Let me guess... after Han Ford fell into your hands, he held out for about three or four hours before he told you everything?"

Since entering the hospital room, the mask of warmth and friendliness Carter had been wearing finally cracked, and a flicker of genuinely human surprise showed through.

"Let me think," he said, rolling a pair of slightly clouded blue-gray eyes upward. "Yes. Three and a half hours."

It was almost as though Taylor Ford had just asked him how long it took to drive from Blackmoor City to the next state over.

"How did you know?" Carter asked, with evident curiosity.

Taylor Ford stared motionlessly at the snow-white bedding draped over him, feeling as though his entire body had turned into a single humming, vibrating nerve—one flick, and he would buckle under the tremor and crumble to dust.

He knew his father was certainly still alive, but that knowledge brought him no comfort—he reached instinctively for his trouser pocket, searching for a cigarette to take a drag from, to numb away the strange, hollow fear spreading through him.

Carter passed him a cigarette—fat at the top and tapering at the bottom, neatly rolled.

"Had someone pick it up on the way," he said, with something close to sympathy. "I thought you might need it."

Taylor Ford stared hard at the cigarette; he wanted to snatch it and throw it in Carter's face, and he also wanted to tear it apart and stuff the pieces into Carter's mouth.

After a long moment, he finally reached out and took the cigarette. It trembled faintly between his fingers; Taylor Ford leaned forward, bowed his head, and let Carter light it for him.

Anything that could numb his nerves—Taylor Ford couldn't afford the luxury of saying no.

He glanced at the smoke detector on the ceiling, knowing he wouldn't get many drags before it triggered the alarm, so he took one long, deep pull, then another, before pressing it out.

"...What happened to Han Ford?"

"Don't worry, he's fine," Carter said gently. "Apart from the leg injury he already had, not a single hair was—oh, well, that's not quite right."

He laughed again in that self-satisfied way of his, as though he thought he was being quite witty, and said: "Hair did come out, actually—quite a bit of it. The young man who yanked on it, I told him to be as gentle as he could, but there was still some pain, unavoidably."

Taylor Ford stared at him steadily.

"And it wasn't just hair," Carter said. "There was also some pub—(contents of parentheses omitted)—ic hair."

...What?

"All of it was unavoidable—things that simply had to be done. I was none too happy about it myself."

Carter shook his head, seeming to find it genuinely difficult to say.

"Saying this in front of his son is really quite ungracious. But you had to be informed, so there was no helping it... Put it this way: besides pulling out some hair, I also prepared quite a collection of er—(contents of parentheses omitted)—otic magazines for him, and told him that if he didn't produce something into a cup, he was going to be in for a rough time.

"It's not easy for a man to do that when he's in pain, frightened, and surrounded by people—but your father managed to complete the task, which was quite impressive."

Why had he pressed that cigarette out?

If it were still burning, he was confident he could jab it straight into Carter's eye.

Taylor Ford could not have said whether what he felt in that moment was anguish or humiliation—or some punishment and torment that was uniquely human, one that blended the

two and then surpassed them both.

"...Why?"

Carter shook his head and smiled.

"Have you ever heard the saying: 'Everything is fate's best arrangement'? I've lived nearly fifty years and come to feel deeply that that line was written for me specifically. God favors me, because he, too, is a white man at the apex of power. This world is his brotherhood club."

For people of Carter's class and background, they always labored under one particular delusion—that every word out of their own mouths was different, was some pearl of wisdom ordinary people had never encountered, and deserved to be listened to with chin in hand—because that was how they had been treated their entire lives.

Taylor Ford said coldly: "Get to the point."

"All right, all right. You're so capable that I keep forgetting you're actually still quite young, and don't have the patience of us adults." Carter said good-naturedly. "Let me think... roughly two days ago? A friend of mine had originally just arranged a little gathering, a bit of fun—but then something went sideways."

He glanced back toward the hospital room door.

Remy had closed it on his way out; a strip of corridor light now seeped in from beneath the door. It lay there quietly, undisturbed by the footsteps of anyone passing.

But Carter lowered his voice all the same.

"There was a woman—apparently she didn't know how to read the room, though I don't know the specifics—but in any case, she ended up dead. That kind of thing; you can call it serious or you can call it minor, it all comes down to how well you handle it. My friend knew I had experience and came to me, asked me what to do—the body was still lying there on the spot."

Taylor Ford already understood.

"It wasn't my son who caused the trouble, and honestly, I was a little reluctant to get involved. But would you believe it—right at that moment, Han Ford called me. He was vague and roundabout on the phone, but I could tell he had something remarkable on his hands.

"I was a little surprised at first. By rights, any Artifact a Morgan House Faction Hunter brings back goes through its proper channels—so why call me? But according to Han Ford, this Artifact

had nothing to do with Morgan House; it had come to him by chance. And so a major House Faction had set its sights on him, wanted to kill him and take it, and he was sounding me out, asking whether I'd be willing to pay a large sum for it.

"He said that way, the two of you—father and son—would be out of danger naturally. See, I told you Han Ford loves you. I wasn't wrong."

Han Ford had probably assumed Taylor was only carrying an Artifact of great value—one that Chase had gone so far as to fight to seize.

His logic, Taylor could practically recite for him: since it was an Artifact, sooner or later it would need to be sold for money, so what did it matter who bought it?

Carter Morgan was amiable, generous, and Taylor Ford's own employer—wasn't selling it to him far better than selling it to anyone else?

"...He didn't know you had been digging into Wellesley's secrets."

Taylor Ford stared at the blank wall and murmured: "Chase, Wellesley's people, and me—all three sides were fighting for our lives. How could you have truly thought that what was involved here was just an ordinary Artifact?"

"Exactly. Of course, Han Ford was guarded at first, talking in circles, unwilling to give me the details. But without much effort, I managed to learn two key words... 'Key House,' and 'Key.'"

Carter smiled. "Originally, I didn't want things to get this ugly."

Taylor Ford closed his eyes.

"If you could have kept your end of the deal—quietly digging into Wellesley's secrets for me, without any other ideas—you would have gone your entire life without needing to know what happened the night Han Ford disappeared.

"But I understand human greed better than most. I knew there was a good chance you wouldn't be so compliant... and as you can see, this extra measure I took has now come in useful."

Carter gave the bed a light pat. "Good—and that brings us back to the woman's body."

Taylor Ford opened his eyes.

He studied Carter's face—watching the muscles around his mouth, watching his lips form different shapes with each syllable—and in a daze, a strange feeling suddenly came over him.

Human beings are such alien creatures, he thought. As though he had never seen one before.

Carter said a woman's body had been discarded in the most chaotic and dangerous part of Blackmoor City.

Of course, it had nothing to do with him.

Naturally, someone had found the body fairly quickly and called the police.

Han Ford's saliva, bodily fluids, hair, fingerprints—they had all happened to leak out and fall, right before the body was discarded; and he had also touched things he shouldn't have touched.

"You've always been called a young prodigy—do I really need to spell it out any more plainly?"

Taylor Ford's throat was dry as sandpaper. "...Go ahead and say it."

"Between Han Ford as a free man, and Han Ford arrested, prosecuted, and sent to the electric chair as a criminal, there is only one barrier—and that barrier is me."

Carter adjusted his posture.

In an almost instructive, friendly tone, he asked: "Tell me—what is Wellesley's secret?"

Taylor Ford bowed his head; he didn't know why, but a spasm began rising from deep in his abdomen, climbing upward through his body, until it shook out of him as laughter—each wave louder than the last.

"You're too late, you pig. I've already been disqualified—and it's entirely your doing."

"What?"

Han Ford had disappeared with the kitten painting at around one in the morning.

But Taylor Ford had been struck from the roster not at one in the morning—because later, when it was nearly four, he had received notifications for both Sydney Ginn and Chase obtaining Artifacts, one after the other.

This meant that before four in the morning, Taylor Ford had still been a contestant.

When Han Ford took the kitten painting, the Nest had not counted it as a loss for Taylor Ford; this meant that by the time the Nest truly determined Taylor Ford had lost the Key, the kitten painting had already passed out of Han Ford's hands and into someone else's.

It was Carter who had cost him his eligibility.

Earlier I was chatting with someone at a workshop, and we found that the more a writer writes, the more they realize they keep telling the same story over and over—or rather, the same theme.

Back when Thousand Mountain Tea Guest (Tea Tea, hi!) said her theme was revenge, I thought about it—what's mine, then? Probably exploration and redemption.

Setting aside my first story (I didn't even know what I was writing back then, so that one doesn't count), the three I've written since—the apocalypse one, Wild Deer, and the Artifact one—all center on people seeking redemption and being redeemed.

Hm? I didn't spoil anything, did I??

Chapter 232: Taylor Ford's Exchange Game

.....How interesting, Taylor Ford thought.

Carter Morgan's face—the kind that always put one in mind of a pig—had been forced upon him far too many times; he knew it so well it filled him with disgust. Just a few minutes ago, the only thing Taylor Ford had wanted to do was grind a burning cigarette butt into those eyes.

And yet now, that face had become his greatest source of entertainment.

"Stop laughing!"

Carter was agitated, furious, and frightened all at once, a scorching light still blazing in his eyes—like a man who had gone hungry for a long time and caught the scent of a banquet in the air. For the first time, something raw and fierce surfaced on that well-tended, smooth, pinkish face.

"You heard me, I told you to stop laughing! What do you mean 'Domination Game'—explain yourself—"

Carter sucked in a sharp breath and wiped the spittle from the corners of his mouth. "Over—over what? Domination of where? The Nest? Is that real? It can't be the Nest, can it? How could humans possibly..."

Taylor Ford let his laughter fade gradually, exhaling softly, and cast Carter a glance.

".....That's exactly how it is."

The moment the six words "Nest Domination Game" had left his mouth, it was as if someone had tripped a lever, sending Carter's eyebrows flying upward; even when he forced himself to look skeptical, the flush rising across his face could not be suppressed.

"You understood correctly. The first person to collect all seven Artifacts gains dominion over the Nest."

Each piece of information Taylor Ford released from that point on was carefully measured, as though every word had become a control knob.

With each sentence he turned, Carter's face swung between being scorched red by greed and stretched wide-eyed with shock; before many words had passed, the muscles in his cheeks were already trembling steadily, and saliva had wet his lower lip.

Other than comparing him to a boar that had caught sight of its target and could no longer contain itself, Taylor Ford couldn't think of a better analogy.

".....What a pity,"

as the temperature around Carter seemed to rise, Taylor Ford said with a smile, "this has nothing to do with either of us anymore. That ship sailed long ago—and you're standing on the shore looking foolish."

Carter's face froze solid.

"Did you think you were being clever? Going after my father, taking his Artifact, using him to threaten me? And now, because the Artifact is gone, I've been disqualified."

Carter stared at him, pale-white eyelids framed by a fringe of brownish-yellow lashes.

"Listen to me," Taylor Ford smiled at him with something almost like sympathy, "you've completely buried your own chance of ever getting close to the Nest Domination Game—buried it yourself."

Nearly ten full seconds passed before Carter reacted.

"Impossible," he said, sitting up straight again and recovering a shred of composure.

"Impossible.....what proof do you have?"

It was unclear whether he wanted proof of the Nest Domination Game or proof of Taylor Ford's disqualification; by this point, the two amounted to the same thing.

Taylor Ford tossed his phone to Carter, who snatched it out of the air; he lowered his head, and his gaze immediately stuck to the last three notifications.

.....When he raised his head again, Taylor Ford almost wanted to tell him not to move—to take a photo of the expression on his face.

For someone of Carter's class, fate rarely had the opportunity to be this ironic; the look on his face right now was genuinely refreshing to behold.

"That Key—you can keep it for yourself, Mr. Morgan."

As he spoke, Taylor Ford lifted the blanket. He dragged his heavy, aching body to the edge of the bed and lowered both feet to the floor. "Don't worry—I will make sure to spread the word far and wide that you have taken my place as a participant and begun collecting the target Artifacts."

"Wait, I never became a participant at all....."

"The Nest isn't a pig farm—of course it wouldn't want you. But Chase Monroe doesn't know that." Taylor Ford suddenly asked, "By the way, have you ever met Chase Monroe in person?"

Carter startled.

"You've heard of his reputation, haven't you? You've been asking the doctors about the extent of my injuries, haven't you?" Taylor Ford said with a smile, "Someone capable of doing this to me—how long do you think you'd last in his hands? Could your bodyguards hold up against an Artifact Hunter tracking and assassinating you?"

He hadn't told Carter any of the specifics—for instance, that registered participants could view the list of participants who had joined before them, and that there were also other ways to find out who the current participants were.

Since Carter didn't know these details, he naturally had no way of judging whether Chase had a means of telling whether he was a legitimate participant.

Carter pressed his lips tightly together, his gaze fixed on Taylor Ford's phone, unable to tear itself away.

"The Domination Game no longer concerns me—but if you don't want me to notify every single participant of where the Key is—oh, I forgot to mention, there are over a dozen participants, and they're all troublesome people."

Taylor Ford got out of bed and stood beside Carter's chair, one hand still connected to the IV drip; the IV tube hung taut in the air between them, pulled straight.

He didn't like the expression on Carter's face anymore.

Carter's look was not one of "fear" or "worry"; he was still staring fixedly at the phone screen, eyes bulging roundly outward.

The emotion distorting his face was closer to "greed" and "unwillingness."

Taylor Ford understood clearly that his threat was half real and half bluff, with no immediate pressure behind it; if he couldn't make Carter afraid, how would Carter ever back down?

And yet he said anyway: "If you don't want to die, send my father home—and let me see that female corpse case broken and closed. As for the contract between us, it's naturally void as of

tonight."

Carter seemed to hear his voice for the first time, and slowly raised his head.

"Void?"

Taylor Ford looked down at him.

"No, no……that's not happening." Carter shook his head, speaking in a low voice: "It's not void—can't be voided. I almost forgot—every word out of your mouth is a trap. It's impossible……you couldn't possibly be willing to just accept disqualification like that, without making any effort, without trying to turn it around, could you?"

Taylor Ford said nothing.

"Come to think of it……I don't need to be afraid of you going out there and saying I'm a participant at all."

With each word he spoke, Carter visibly calmed down by degrees, and was nearly back to his usual self.

He tapped the phone screen and said, "When Chase got the Artifact, didn't you receive a notification? If I were a participant and I had the Key, then Chase should have received a notification too, right? I'm not a participant—he didn't receive any notification—so naturally he wouldn't believe you."

Taylor Ford did his best to keep his composure.

Carter Morgan might have won the lottery of birth, but he himself was no easy fool to manipulate.

"Besides, even if they all believed I was a participant and came to kill me—so what?"

A light blazed up in Carter's eyes.

"Domination of the Nest……this is domination of the Nest. With the Nest in hand……bringing this entire country under one's control wouldn't even be a big deal."

A smile swelled up beneath the surface of his face and wrenched his mouth open, revealing a gaping dark cavity and a full set of white, even teeth.

"Just about everything the world has to offer a person, I already have. What am I still lacking? I thought I lacked nothing—besides more money, what else was there to pursue in this

world? But that's wrong—that's not how it is at all."

Taylor Ford's phone screen had gone dark; Carter's breath fogged the screen, raising a layer of white.

"You're threatening me? You really think you can threaten me? Now that you've told me about the Nest Domination Game, I don't care whether you've been disqualified or how you were disqualified."

He sat in the chair and twisted sharply around, raising his head to face Taylor Ford.

"I don't care what method you use—if you joined once, you can join a second time. Go collect those Artifacts for me! What do you mean participant or not-participant—isn't that just an identity? Once you've got your identity back, bring me in too. I don't believe it: seven Artifacts, six of them in your hands—you wouldn't have the standing to restore your participant status? Even if you don't, go kill everyone else for me! I'd like to see how this game is supposed to go on with not a single participant left—do you really think it still won't take you back?"

Taylor Ford extended his right hand and peeled the adhesive tape off the back of his left hand.

Carter had long since worked himself into a lather, his face slick with sweat, fine flecks of spittle dotting his gums.

"Listen carefully, Taylor Ford. Your father is in my hands—if I choose, you won't catch so much as a glimpse of him before he completes the full process of being sentenced to death. The next time you see Han Ford, he'll be sitting in the electric chair. If you want Han Ford to——"

Before he could finish the sentence, Taylor Ford had already pulled the IV needle out of the vein on the back of his hand.

The upper half of his body—barely held together with painkillers as the thread—felt as though it might split open again the moment he suddenly raised his arm; a surge of acute pain blacked out Taylor Ford's vision for an instant—but it didn't matter, he had already fixed his aim on the position of Carter's trachea.

The needle tip, still beaded with blood, drove straight and true toward the spot just below Carter's throat, slightly above the center of the collarbone—beneath that thin skin lay his soft trachea.

The needle was short and fine; in most places it would cause pain, but would give Carter enough time to cry out for help.

Taylor Ford was not about to give him the chance to cry out.

He wanted to pierce Carter's trachea—and let him die in this hospital room amid the wet gurgling in his throat.

As for Han Ford—after Carter was dead, he himself would hardly escape unscathed, so Han Ford's life or death could be left to fate; he was already very tired, and he didn't want to——

Under ordinary circumstances, faced with an agitated, off-guard Carter, that needle would have slid cleanly into his trachea long ago.

He enjoyed manipulating situations with his mind—that didn't mean he was incapable of violence.

But at the last moment, the muscles across his back seemed about to tear apart, swallowing a great chunk of his strength—the needle pierced Carter's skin, but could not drive through the trachea.

"Help!" Carter flung himself backward, sending himself and the chair crashing into the vital-signs monitor, screaming desperately, "Someone come! He attacked me!"

He had stationed people outside after all.

Taylor Ford grabbed hold of some kind of wire—he didn't know what it was for—and kicked the chair aside. If he couldn't puncture the trachea, he would crush it with his hand instead.

Too bad the Nest Dissociation Syndrome symptoms aren't still here, he thought calmly.

During the two days he had lain in a stupor, there were moments when his consciousness had nearly surfaced; but the very reason it had taken him two full days to wake completely was that he had never fully shaken off the Nest Dissociation Syndrome.

Taylor Ford clearly remembered that in his half-conscious state, he had still been able to stretch his hand across the pitch-black abyss toward a distant shore, just as he had when fighting Chase. He couldn't recall what he had reached toward at the time.

Why did it have to disappear now, of all times?

If it were still there——

"Director."

Taylor Ford froze.

It wasn't because of the word "Director."

Alongside that word, Taylor Ford also heard the crisp, clean sound of a handgun's safety being released.

He turned his head and found Remy standing in the doorway, the corridor light casting a halo tinged with fine wisps of light across her dark hair.

The barrel of the gun pointing directly at him was pitch-black and deep, not unlike the spatial rifts he occasionally glimpsed during a Nest Dissociation Syndrome episode—a little like the rift he had seen in the clinic that other time; only from inside a gun barrel, naturally, no Dr. Cole heads came crawling out one after another.

"Stop," Remy said, her voice carrying something almost like an apology, "……you can't kill him. I can't let you kill him."

Taylor Ford let go of the wire in his hand.

He was still staring at Carter; between ragged breaths, he asked quietly, "Have you been watching me these past two days?"

Remy walked into the room, closed the door, and answered softly, "I'm only following orders. I don't know anything."

Taylor Ford let out a short, sharp laugh.

Carter pulled out the needle; the pain made his face contort, and he swore.

He propped himself up against the machine and stood, keeping his distance from Taylor Ford, then flashed him a grin. "Go to hell. So you can act on impulse too? Good—looks like you two really are close, father and son. Since you care so much about Daddy, do I even need to tell you what to do? Now that you know what you should be doing, I can just wait for your action report, can't I?"

How funny.

Taylor Ford had originally thought that once he seized control of the Nest, he would be free—he could finally pry Han Ford's fingers from where they were wrapped around his ankle.

That would have been fine, but if the risks were too great, he didn't have to compete; when all was said and done, the worst outcome was just returning to the status quo.

But it wasn't until he lost his qualification that he realized there was no way back—no matter what, he had to force his way back into the game—and the reason was still Han Ford.

Taylor Ford looked away, grabbed his phone, and turned to walk toward the door.

"Director," Remy called out. "Where are you going? You can't be discharged yet—"

"Move," Taylor Ford said.

Before Remy could react, Carter laughed.

"Let him go, it's fine," Carter said. "He won't get far, and he won't escape—he'll have to come back. After all, the two of us have a contract."

Remy froze for a moment, then stepped aside from the doorway.

Taylor Ford reached out and grabbed the door handle—a powerful surge of déjà vu nearly made him stumble backward—but at the same time, he had already pressed down the handle and pulled the door open.

...What was that?

Taylor Ford stared at the hospital corridor, momentarily dazed.

Reaching a hand out into the darkness, feeling for the door handle, pressing it down... and gently pulling the door open.

Why did that feel so familiar?

It was as though he had made that exact same motion not long ago. When was that? Hadn't he been unconscious the whole time?

Which door had he opened?

The confusion flickered and vanished, and Taylor Ford's thoughts returned to the present.

Not far behind him, Carter was saying, "...Trade the game for your father—don't forget that, alright?"

Sorry for the slightly late update today... Here's what happened: I wasn't sure whether to keep writing Taylor Ford's perspective this chapter, so I switched to Mai Minghe's point of view

instead. I wrote about two thousand words from his perspective, felt like it wasn't working, then turned back around and wrote Taylor Ford again...

And then, what do you know—I ended up writing four thousand words! Which means I accidentally hit my daily word-count ceiling today: six thousand!

My all-time personal record is six thousand... I'm coughing up blood, I truly am.

January 11, 2025 — The Nest Launches Its War of Aggression Against Social Media

Ever since the last special program—the one that required blowing up the Nest TV station (shack edition)—the Nest's Residents decided to rebuild a proper television-station version of the TV station; but because the project was much larger in scale, reconstruction has yet to be completed to this day.

But what about the sponsors in the meantime?

The Dream Playwright—who had exhausted every scheme, drifted ever further down the road of pleasing sponsors, and had long since completely forgotten why it had wanted to court sponsors in the first place—turned its nonexistent gaze toward a recent achievement of human technology: social media.

"Something that humans created themselves, and yet humans have become trapped by their own making, brainwashed, poisoned, and manipulated by social media in return—how truly stupid!"

The Dream Playwright stopped itself just in time.

It remembered that today's sponsors were all humans—none of them had, at least as yet, come out as Residents—and after turning the swallowed words over in its mind several times, it finally said:

"...How truly humble."

"Whether you think before you speak or not, I really can't see much difference," Sydney Ginn said.

The Dream Playwright blanked for a moment, then flew into an embarrassed rage. "People without a sponsorship don't get to criticize me."

"Anyway, why have you dragged me to the Nest again today?"

The Dream Playwright cleared its throat.

"For this installment of our program, in order to better give back to our esteemed sponsors, we have decided to present them with what humans crave and treasure most in today's society—super-popular, endlessly fresh, perpetually liked and followed—social media accounts!"

As its words fell, a round of applause echoed through the empty surroundings.

"Before we begin, allow me to explain something first."

The Dream Playwright folded its hands, sat up straight, and said, "For reasons unknown, the Nest has lately been left with almost nothing but high-value sponsors. If everyone crowds in together to receive our grateful gifts, it would be a bit of a step down—because you humans are rather vain—"

A patch of skin on its face swelled up, resembling the shape human lips make when forming the word "vain," but it paused, apparently realizing that word didn't sound great either.

Sydney Ginn leaned forward, waiting for it to continue.

"Vain—"

"Hmm?"

"...Valiant." The Dream Playwright forced out the second syllable, already breaking into a cold sweat. "Our high-value sponsors will receive our gifts in separate batches, to ensure that each person has their own time in the fluorescent light."

"That's called the spotlight," Sydney Ginn said. "Hey, not bad for a Resident—that's actually rather thoughtful of you."

The Dream Playwright paid her no mind, and simply held up an INest-brand tablet. "The first social media account we created also belongs to the first sponsor making their appearance today—welcome—"

On the tablet, an Instagram profile page was tapped open, revealing a username.

Xia Xia You Mu Ming Li

"Your account has long since been worthy of a spin-off," the Dream Playwright said, rubbing its hands together. "Please leave a comment in the blank below about whose spin-off you'd like to read, or what kind of spin-off you're after—the sweatshop assembly line starts cranking out words starting next Saturday. Now, let's continue with the account introduction."

The profile picture was simple—just a strikingly beautiful face.

738 posts

1.2M followers

225 following

"How did it reach a million followers?" Sydney Ginn was taken aback. "Is that real?"

"Of course," the Dream Playwright said smugly. "This account was carefully cultivated by our planning team. We used photos of Xia Xia herself—"

It paused, as if waiting for some reaction. Seeing none, it continued: "—and then we positioned and packaged her as a 'human lifestyle blogger.'"

"...What?"

"As a blogger who travels the world and experiences different cultures and customs, simply posting local scenery and food would be far too common—the competition is fierce. So on top of travel and food content, we incorporated a humanitarian angle. Wherever she goes, Xia Xia You Mu Ming Li actively befriends the local residents, listens to their stories, and explores the lives and inner worlds of the people who actually live there."

"That actually sounds pretty interesting," Sydney Ginn said. "Can I see the posts on the main page?"

The most recent post consisted entirely of black-and-white photos with a distinct artistic quality—though unfortunately, they were a bit hard to make out. On what appeared to be a narrow alleyway, a young woman (18) was pointing at a wall, flashing a bright, snow-white smile.

Sydney Ginn swiped to the next photo and found that the camera had zoomed in: Xia Xia You Mu Ming Li had her hands cupped loosely in front of her as if "cradling" a portrait painting on the wall, and had leaned her head in close, as though posing for a photo together with it.

In the third photo, the man in the portrait—hollow-cheeked, with deep dark circles under his eyes, as though something haunted the shell of him—turned his gaze toward her.

In the fourth photo, the man pressed one hand against the wall, lowered his head, and slowly emerged from the wall's surface, rising and pulling himself free.

In the fifth photo, the hollow-eyed man raised his right arm above his head. Xia Xia You Mu Ming Li raised her left arm above her head as well.

The two of them made a heart shape together.

Sydney Ginn stared blankly at the photos. "Huh...? This turn of events... is somehow not quite what I expected..."

The post caption read:

Today I made a long-anticipated visit to the historic walkway of the ancient Gilbert district. On Instagram, I received an invitation from a resident who has lived here for a very, very, very, very, very, very, very long time, and came as agreed to the wall where he dwells...

"Pretty great, right? Look at this post," the Dream Playwright said, tremendously excited. "It's been up for less than half a day and already has 570,000 likes! A top-tier social media account, for a top-tier you!"

The next two were also Instagram blogger accounts, and had to be introduced together.

Pang Xiaoya: profile picture of a little rubber duck, 550 posts, 890K followers, 1002 following.

Late-Night Duck Duck Duck Duck Duck Yeah: profile picture of five little rubber ducks, 550 posts, 890.1K followers, 1003 following.

"Through some incomprehensible coincidence, they have become a rare pair of twin-type bloggers."

The Dream Playwright's mouth was full of professional jargon that nobody could quite follow. "Though they live worlds apart, have never met in person, and have never even interacted online, the similarities between their accounts and content go far beyond what the numbers suggest... take a look."

With a few taps, it opened the first post on Pang Xiaoya's account.

Posted on October 9, 2024, a photo showed a fast-food restaurant tray piled high with burgers, chicken nuggets, french fries, and the like—a spread that looked simultaneously cheerful, trashy, and abundant—but there was no question that the photo told a tragic story.

"WHY!" the caption read. "Why did I go and carelessly knock over my drink! Why did this cola, of all things, have to spill ALL over my burger and fries! Everything is soaked in cola flavor now! WHY WHYWHYWHY"

"Now take a look at the other duck—no, at Late-Night Duck Duck Duck Duck Duck Yeah's post."

In a photo dated October 10, 2024, a young woman (18) was dressed in a full set of jeans and a T-shirt, drenched from head to toe, hair plastered to her forehead, with an expression that was equal parts amused and miserable.

The post caption read:

"How can something this absurd happen in the world? I was walking down the street when someone in the building above poured an entire bottle of cola straight down onto me. He said it wasn't on purpose, that he accidentally knocked it over, but that 1L bottle of cola wasted not a single drop—it all landed on me."

"Oh, that's fascinating," Sydney Ginn said, momentarily forgetting that all of this had been orchestrated by the Nest. "So these two accounts are also..."

"Yes!" The Dream Playwright slapped its thigh. "Both of your fans are constantly switching back and forth between your posts! Please enjoy the life of twin internet celebrities from now on!"

"It's just a little rough on them though..." Sydney Ginn said quietly.

"That's only that one post," the Dream Playwright explained. "Look, there are more—Late-Night Duck Duck Duck Duck Yeah had a nightmare, and then it... hmm, what's going on, this one seems a bit rough too."

Beneath these posts, one could also see accounts that the Dream Playwright and its fellow Residents had been diligently cultivating—planning to grow them up before gifting them to the next wave of sponsors.

BookFriend20241229233833599: I love the look of the man on the wall so much, I'd love to ask him to film a commercial with me.

Jupiter Quietly Having Goji Berries: A burger is fine even when wet. As long as the food remains still, it can be eaten. Everyone please be very careful of food that is pretending to be still. For details, please visit my profile.

Ya'er: I am always watching you in silence. Always.

NewNightDayWalker: Wow, the place you traveled to this time is so amazing! Please come to my hometown next! My hometown is located at the border between dawn and night eu&...

Little Sun Takes You Flying: Taking you flying, 650 per trip, DM me

MiaoAo: Giant cat in the East District searching for its lost owner, please help share and keep an eye out

(The thank-you list for tips received between 12/28 and 1/11 isn't finished yet—more will follow in the next batch. Hoping it doesn't keep snowballing···)

Almost published it as a paid chapter again—broke into a cold sweat over that one.

Even a thank-you chapter takes serious brainstorming—I am my own brain's little hamster.

PS: I watched the teaser for "Blossoms Shanghai" — the moment Li Xiaoran appeared, I couldn't stop smiling like a proud auntie (

Chapter 233: Mai Minghe's First Trial

In crime dramas, detectives always trot out the same line: "The killer often returns to the scene of the crime."

Mai Minghe couldn't remember which show she'd heard it in, but she thought: there's real truth to that.

The morning of the 24th broke into bad weather right from the start.

She took the subway, then switched to a taxi, and traveled for over an hour. By the time she reached the Key House estate, the sky was still a heavy, sodden layer of gray — like wet cotton hanging overhead, ready to drop and smother your face at any moment.

Whether it was the weather or her own guilty conscience, she couldn't say, but she kept feeling that every Key House member standing on the driveway to receive the prospective Hunter candidates had cold light in their eyes and an ashen cast to their skin.

The Key House estate stood just as it had yesterday — perched at the far end of the slope, swallowed up by a wide sprawl of lawn and shrubbery, accessible only by a single private driveway. Mai Minghe took short, quick steps, keeping her expression casual while sweeping her gaze around the grounds in a slow circle.

The Key House security was far tighter than yesterday — people posted in clusters of two and three.

Out on the driveway, Hunters were directing cars, telling the arriving candidates where to park and who to find; from the moment you set foot on the driveway, there was hardly a gap where you could go unnoticed — surely they hadn't deployed every person they had available here?

Mai Minghe hadn't come by car, so she had no choice but to hug the shrubbery along the edge of the driveway and walk. A Hunter's eyes slid over her a few times, and he called out: "Here for the interview?"

"Yes," said Mai Minghe — her voice felt hollow to her own ears.

...Had they grown suspicious?

Had the Key House figured out that she was the one who had trespassed in the estate yesterday?

"Head on in, find Shaxue," the man said, then turned and shouted toward the distance:
"Shaxue! One person per car!"

The car that glided slowly past Mai Minghe looked familiar — it seemed like it belonged to that Li — what was his name again? Oh, Lisidan's car.

Sure enough, Lisidan, whom she had met once yesterday, quickly opened the door and stepped out, greeting Shaxue with a relaxed ease.

Ah — it really was more comfortable to go about your day with nothing on your conscience.

Seeing that Shaxue had already spotted her, Mai Minghe quietly urged her wobbly legs forward and, steeling herself, walked over.

Wait — this wasn't a trap, was it?

They were deliberately pretending not to know that she was the trespasser from yesterday, luring her back under the pretense of a Nest interview, only to swarm her and pin her down?

The drumbeat in Mai Minghe's chest grew louder and louder.

Out by the shrubbery at the edge of the driveway, three to five people were already standing; by all appearances they were all candidate Hunters — when their eyes happened to meet, they gave each other a stiff nod and nothing more.

To be honest, their stone-faced demeanor really did look like a Key House trap, just waiting for her to walk right into it.

But Shaxue's expression was perfectly normal. She smiled at Mai Minghe and said, "You're all pretty punctual. Wait here for a moment — the car will be along shortly."

What car?

"We've already chosen the location where we'll open our passages," Shaxue said, seemingly aware that she had limited experience and offering an explanation. "Opening the passage from within that area is the only way we can all land at the same spot inside the Nest. We'll need to drive everyone there together."

"You didn't know that where you enter the Nest is connected to where you land inside it?"

A man asked her this out of the blue.

He was big and round, broad-shouldered and barrel-chested — wide enough to fit two Mai Minhes side by side. The question wasn't quite hostile, but it wasn't polite either; he was probably just used to talking this way. A large, physically imposing man from the dominant demographic rarely had to weigh his tone for anyone.

Mai Minghe simply smiled. "I didn't."

The others nearby all glanced at her — nobody was thrilled to find a greenhorn mixed in with the teammates about to enter the Nest with them, but no one said a word.

Two minutes later, from the other end of the driveway came the sound of tires rolling over gravel, and two black vans pulled up.

"There are five candidates entering the Nest for the trial today," —

Shaxue stood beside the first van and said, "In the first vehicle is our team leader, Tianxi, whom you've all met. Then there's Qiboli, who'll be driving the second vehicle, and myself — the three of us are responsible for accompanying, evaluating, and supervising this session."

For some reason, she didn't have everyone board the vehicles right away; instead, Tianxi and the driver of the second van both stepped out of the driver's seats and came over to greet everyone.

This was Mai Minghe's first time seeing Qiboli. He looked under thirty, with a head of tousled, slightly wavy platinum-blond hair, his eyeliner and lashes thick and dark — he looked less like a Hunter and more like a lead singer in a band.

It really was a better era now, she thought — men and women alike could dress however they pleased. Beneath his open jacket, Qiboli wore a semi-sheer white mesh tank top, and no one so much as glanced at him sideways.

Back when Mai Minghe was young, even wearing trousers would draw stares — people thought women in trousers were indecent.

She wondered if Qiboli had been among the people who'd chased her yesterday.

"Please take a moment to look at everyone here and commit each person's face and clothing to memory."

Shaxue emphasized: "Don't forget — between the Key House members and the candidates, there are eight people total."

...Why make a point of that?

"Some of you with less experience may not know why. Let me explain."

Tianxi leaned against the car door, arms crossed, and said, "The larger the group entering the Nest, the more likely it is to draw all sorts of inexplicable things. Take a good look at everyone here — once we're inside, whether you notice an extra person, a missing person, or someone whose appearance, clothing, or voice has suddenly changed, report it to me immediately."

Things like that could happen inside the Nest?

Mai Minghe lowered her gaze and swallowed back a hard lump of guilt.

She could only hope that she wouldn't bring more danger down on them because of herself...

If things took a bad turn, she would have to break from the group on her own initiative — even at the cost of failing the interview — and draw the danger away with her. She couldn't let these seven young people be dragged down because of her.

"Please take a careful look at everyone." Shaxue's words sounded almost like a pointed reminder directed at Mai Minghe.

She let out a breath, raised her eyes, and met the gazes of the four candidate Hunters around her, looking them each over in turn.

Lisidan, whom she'd met once yesterday, had a head of brown curly hair piled on top, leaving his broad forehead bare; his shirt was tucked into his trousers, the cuffs cropped to the ankle — his style was rather like an accountant from the seventies or eighties. Was that what young people called "retro fashion"?

Old-fashioned clothes like that — her wardrobe was full of them.

Their eyes met. Lisidan nodded at her and asked, "We meet again. No walking stick today?"

He really had to bring that up — Mai Minghe felt every pore on her body clench shut. She didn't dare look at Shaxue or Tianxi's expressions and could only say vaguely, "Right, it's inconvenient to bring along..."

Looking back on what she had gone through yesterday, it still felt unreal to her.

Even after she managed to get out of the Key House estate, she still didn't know how she had made it out — well, she knew how she had slipped quietly out of that particular room; the room connected to a small balcony, and she had been able to climb down from the second floor using it.

What Mai Minghe couldn't understand was why the door of that room had suddenly slid open on its own — almost as if someone had pressed down the handle from behind the door and pulled it open for her.

Why had there been a human-shaped void of blackness standing in the middle of that room?

What was that thing?

At the time, Mai Minghe had stood frozen on the spot, not daring to move, not even daring to look directly at the black void — she only kept it in her peripheral vision.

After quite a while, when she found that the human-shaped void showed no sign of moving at all, she held her breath and inched along the wall, little by little, toward the window — whatever that void was, she hadn't come to investigate mysteries; the first priority was to escape as soon as possible.

There were two reasons she hadn't moved through the center of the room:

The first was, naturally, that human-shaped black void. It was as though the space had been turned into a sheet of paper, with a void cut out in the shape of a person — head, shoulders, limbs and all. Mai Minghe was terrified that the moment she drew near, those narrow strips of darkness in the shape of arms would lift toward her.

The second reason was that in the middle of the room lay a carpet — a fleshy-pink carpet that anyone who looked at it would immediately recognize as an Artifact.

For some reason, a ring of wet, glistening marks had soaked into the floor around the carpet.

The short pile lay flat and low; the carpet itself was fleshy pink, yet the fibers were a pale, almost white color — how could the fibers be that color, and yet to the naked eye the carpet appear to be an entirely different color?

And the carpet itself wasn't keeping still — it heaved and undulated, rising and falling...

It was only a glance, a fleeting impression, yet it circled in Mai Minghe's mind for five or six seconds before something suddenly clicked, and she nearly cried out.

It was a tongue.

Or rather, something between a carpet and a tongue.

The carpet's pile was taste buds; the heaving, undulating motion was because it was a living, flexible muscle.

Once she understood, how could she dare go near it? The carpet was enormous — the only space left for her to move through was the narrow strip along the edges.

She hugged the wall, skirting around to the window. When she opened it, the wind swept through her body and rushed into the room. Mai Minghe instinctively glanced back and saw countless short, stubby taste buds standing up all at once in a dense, even row — as if they had caught a scent.

...What would happen if you touched it?

She escaped from the Key House estate without getting a single one of her questions answered.

In the end, after all that risk to sneak inside, all she had to show for it were photographs of the estate's interior.

She didn't know whether this Nest trial would get her properly hired, letting her walk into the Key House through the front door — the lipstick was almost certainly somewhere inside the Key House, and it was hers to begin with, yet getting it back was proving this difficult?

Mai Minghe had been lost in thought the whole way, and only snapped back to attention when Shaxue's voice pulled her out of her reverie — by then, she realized they were nearly at the location where they would open their passages.

Shaxue was distributing weapons to everyone; aside from the standard-issue combat supplies — handguns, blades, and flashlights — each person also received a fluorescent-orange tag that could be hung around the neck.

"Even if we all open our passages within the same area and at the same time, when we land, there's still a very good chance we'll find ourselves alone, separated from the group — or rather, there may not be a group at all."

Shaxue warned them: "The place we're about to land is the area of the Nest corresponding to Old Harbor, filled with nineteenth-century port warehouses. Once you land, move toward 'Annie Warehouse' immediately and gather at the main entrance."

Mai Minghe knew that place — in Blackmoor City today, Old Harbor had become a venue for young performing artists to try their hand at live performance, with theater troupes from around the world staging all manner of productions there year-round.

"Anyone not wearing an orange tag is to be treated as a Resident."

Shaxue said, with near-perfect calm: "Do everything in your power to keep that orange tag safe. This is your first trial to become a Key House Hunter."

I thought having two thousand words would make this chapter easier to write... Fat chance!!

Chapter 234 — Mai Minghe Mai Minghe Mai Minghe

Although it seemed no one had told Key House Faction their passage conditions, that didn't stop everyone from opening their passages in the same area at the same time — the spot where they got off was a busy district with heavy foot traffic, packed with all kinds of shops, restaurants, and office buildings.

"Everyone split up and open your passages on your own,"

Tianxi stepped out of the vehicle, and the sharp "beep" of the door locking echoed long and clear through the underground parking garage. The two vans, just emptied, sat side by side in silence; for no more than seven days hence, they would wait here in mute stillness for everyone's return.

"As long as you open your passage without leaving the zone we've marked out, your landing point should be somewhere within the Nest's Old Harbor warehouse district. If your passage is especially tricky and the conditions can't be met here, please say so now."

Everyone exchanged glances. No one said a word.

I wonder what all their passages are like? Mai Minghe couldn't help thinking.

She had heard from Reed Hydes that whether a passage was simple or not often reflected the quality of a Hunter's innate talent; if someone's passage was difficult, they certainly wouldn't want to volunteer that information to Key House Faction right now.

Mai Minghe had even less to worry about — on the road before they'd pulled into the parking garage, there had been a large shopping mall; inside and outside the mall, screens were everywhere, flashing colorful advertisements in every direction.

Huh, did that mean her talent was actually pretty good?

"Does everyone have their orange tags and supply bags?" Shaxue confirmed one last time, then gave everyone a nod: "Alright, then — see you in the Nest."

Everyone said their brief goodbyes, left the parking garage, and blended into the flowing crowds on the street.

Even with the unknown and the dangerous filling the road ahead, every time before entering the Nest, Mai Minghe still felt a quiet flutter of novelty and excitement rise in her chest — the

eighty-six years before this, and the last six days: how could they possibly belong to the same world?

She'd heard that a lot of places now had metal detectors installed, and as she walked into the mall carrying a supply bag stuffed full of guns, ammunition, and blades, her heart was practically lodged in her throat; if anyone spotted it, they'd call the police immediately — getting hauled into a police station before ever making it into the Nest would really be something.

But Mai Minghe was lucky. No alarm triggered. She walked into the ground-floor atrium of the mall as if nothing were the matter and quickly found her target.

Outside one of the shops, a screen displayed a trim, lean-muscled model in a swimsuit, skin gleaming gold like sunlight.

Mai Minghe loitered furtively outside the shop for a few minutes, her gaze sweeping the area in circles; by the time she herself began to feel conspicuous, she finally caught a gap when no one was passing by, stepped quietly back — and fell into the beach and ocean inside the screen.

When she opened her eyes again, the first thing she saw was still the sea.

Only this sea was a dull, ashen grey, as if all the air had been let out of it; it was no bigger than a palm, blurry and indistinct, with smears of grime floating across it — Mai Minghe blinked, straightened up, stepped back two paces, and realized she had been staring at a window.

The glass hadn't been wiped in what looked like a very long time; through the grime, a heavy, grey sea surface under an overcast sky filtered through — the weather inside the Nest appeared to be in sync with Blackmoor City's.

This time she hadn't fallen in. Both feet were planted firmly on the ground.

Was it because she hadn't lost her balance when she entered?

But never mind that — where was this?

Mai Minghe turned away from the window.

Mai Minghe was crouched on the floor, staring at her.

A scream slipped out of her throat before she could stop it — her heartbeat seemed to slam against her eardrums all at once; she instinctively stepped back, her spine hitting the window, the frame shuddering with a dull thud.

...What?

Why was there another her? That couldn't be a real person, could it?

The heavy sound of her own breathing, the echoes of her scream, rippled outward in waves against the surrounding silence, then slowly faded.

She herself was standing right here — whoever was in front of her certainly couldn't be real.

Mai Minghe stared hard at the Mai Minghe before her, feeling her palms soaked in sweat, and wiped them hard against her pants twice.

Then she froze.

Where was her supply bag?

She had been holding it the whole time, never let go, even when she'd fallen into the screen —

Mai Minghe instinctively glanced down.

Her hands were empty. Nothing at her feet either. The supply bag was gone.

The supply bag wasn't the only thing missing.

The fluorescent orange tag on her chest had vanished too.

Something, like a nerve no thicker than a strand of hair grazed by a breath of wind, snapped — and Mai Minghe immediately looked up again.

The Mai Minghe who had been crouching on the floor in front of her had, in the moment she'd looked down, risen to her feet and stepped one foot forward, as if about to walk toward her — then, as if caught by her gaze, had gone still again.

That face, identical to her own, held not a trace of expression, as if it had been molded from rubber.

If screaming could have helped her make sense of the situation, Mai Minghe would have screamed without a moment's hesitation; instead she bit down hard on her lip, eyes fixed ahead, all her terror seized and forced back down into her chest — she didn't dare make a sound.

This was a spacious, open red-brick warehouse — or rather, it had once been a spacious, open red-brick warehouse; it was evidently located in a small, niche performance arts district, and had since been converted into a makeshift theater.

The Mai Minghe who had been about to walk toward her was roughly three or four meters away.

And there was more than one Mai Minghe.

Rows of folding chairs were arranged below the stage; a Mai Minghe sat in one of them, her back to the other Mai Minghe.

Without even seeing her face, she could feel that it was herself — and yet she herself was clearly standing right here by the window.

In one corner of the makeshift theater was a bar counter that looked rather forlorn without its lights; behind the bar, a Mai Minghe had pushed open a side door with one hand, seemingly about to step out, and had frozen mid-motion.

The theater door was pushed open a crack, and a Mai Minghe peered through the gap with one eye, watching the other Mai Minhes.

Behind the stage curtain, at the restroom entrance, even on the scaffolding beneath the makeshift theater's ceiling — Mai Minghe after Mai Minghe stood waiting; face after face, all her own, yet each subtly different from the rest.

Some were versions of herself she had long forgotten — herself at fifteen or sixteen, cheeks round and full; some appeared to be the version of herself still inside her marriage in her forties, eyes vacant and adrift.

The Mai Minghe who knew nothing of life, the Mai Minghe just beginning to realize she was growing old, the Mai Minghe who had hesitated before going to check her fertility...

Every Mai Minghe from every stage of her past life was now standing before her.

And was she herself not simply one more Mai Minghe from one more stage?

Several times she tried to make some kind of sound.

Any sound would do — even a small one, just something to puncture this vacuum of silence; but no sound would come, just like the Mai Minhes standing before her, one by one.

Outside the window, the pale, waterlogged daylight drifted through the glass and floated in the dust.

With a sharp swoosh, a spotlight blazed to life on the theater stage — even in the murky grey of the afternoon, the white beam of light was stark and unmistakable, and it snatched Mai Minghe's attention all at once.

Mai Minghe lifted her head from the window.

Mai Minghe leaned out from behind the restroom door.

Mai Minghe turned to look at the stage.

Mai Minghe pulled aside the backstage curtain.

Beneath the white column of light sat a chair; on the chair was a supply bag that Mai Minghe recognized at a glance.

The fluorescent orange tag, caught in the light, blazed so brightly it was almost impossible to look at directly — it seemed to shimmer and lift off the supply bag.

On the backdrop wall of the stage, two lines of large characters had been painted.

"The last one standing may take what rests upon the chair."

"Kill every last one of yourself."

Oh no, I have a feeling this part is going to be a very, very difficult write...

Then again, no one's probably reading during the New Year holiday, right?

After all, everyone's busy dealing with relatives asking "How did you do on your exams," "How much do you make," "Why don't you have a partner yet"... isn't that right?

If I sneak in a day or two of rest, will anyone even notice?

Chapter 235: The Conditions for Mai Minghe's Rebirth

Mai Minghe bent down, reached under the chair, and felt along the underside of the seat—a knife was taped there with industrial adhesive. The tape came away with a long, rasping rrrrip, and Mai Minghe stood up, gripping the knife.

Mai Minghe pulled a stun baton from the supply box.

Mai Minghe snatched a bottle of liquor from the shelf behind the bar and smashed it backhand against the corner of a table. The bottle shattered with a sharp crack, and clear liquid cascaded down through the jagged, blade-like shards of glass.

Mai Minghe turned and ran.

It was perhaps a little absurd—but the moment she ducked and dodged the half-brick Mai Minghe had hurled at her, her first instinct was to reach for the Extracorporeal Telomere on her body even as she ran.

When her hand pressed against her lower abdomen and felt the coiled, slumbering long snake there, her heart—which had been suspended high in her chest—dropped back into place; the long, slightly raised Artifact was still wound tight around her body.

So she was the real Mai Minghe.

Just moments ago, she had briefly wondered whether she, too, had become one of the "Mai Minghes" the Nest had fabricated—perhaps being deceived into killing the real Mai Minghe.

The Artifact could prove her identity; since she was truly herself, where had all these other Mai Minghes come from?

Behind her, a glass window shattered with a loud clang, the glass blooming into a fleeting ice-flower in the air before scattering across the floor.

Mai Minghe twisted her body, dodging the Mai Minghe charging at her from ahead with a broken bottle half raised, and cut sharply to the side, bursting out at an angle and plunging into the rows of seats.

In just a matter of seconds, every single Mai Minghe in the dead-silent warehouse suddenly launched herself into a frenzied rush—and from the looks of it, every last one of them had her as their target.

What was she supposed to do?

The stage seemed unguarded, and the supply bag and lanyard tag had been left carelessly on a chair. Should she seize the supply bag, or escape through the exit first?

Could she even escape?

A moment's hesitation gave one of the Mai Minghes the opening she needed—she kicked a chair straight into the back of Mai Minghe's knees. Mai Minghe lurched forward without warning, no time to even hiss in pain; she stumbled and hadn't steadied herself before a shadow came flying at her from the corner of her eye.

Mai Minghe threw herself into a dive and hit the ground; the dark shape grazed past her head and slammed into another Mai Minghe's face. The dull thud of a fire extinguisher striking flesh and bone—no, a fire extinguisher striking her own flesh and bone—made Mai Minghe's scalp prickle.

"If only... it hadn't been this way."

A loud voice burst without warning from the theater's sound system, startling Mai Minghe with a jolt; she recognized it almost immediately—the voice swirling beneath the ceiling, slightly unfamiliar, was her own.

There was no one at the microphone in the corner of the stage.

Mai Minghe snatched up a half-brick and hurled it at the other Mai Minghe; even as she scrambled to roll aside, her shoulder took the hit, the pain slicing through her like a blade.

"If only I had been born into a family like Kelly's," the twelve-year-old Mai Minghe in the sound system murmured.

It was something she had never spoken aloud, though it had circled through her heart more times than she could count.

All at once she remembered—Kelly had been the prettiest girl in the class, with a head of sunshine-golden curls, and she would travel back to Copenhagen with her parents during summer break to visit relatives. Had it not been for a stroke of luck, Mai Minghe would never have had any chance of sharing a school with a child like Kelly.

Memories she had long since forgotten came flooding in from somewhere, washing over her in a daze.

Wait—was the daze from the memories, or from the brick that had clipped her temple just moments ago?

Mai Minghe pressed one hand over her temple, which was seeping blood, and staggered toward the door, weaving past the figures in her way.

The home she had grown up in was also a ground-floor shop front facing the street.

The front of the store displayed sundry goods, dried seafood, sodas, and cigarettes; during the holidays, they would set up a temporary stand selling Spring Festival couplets and firecrackers, mistletoe wreaths, and small national flags. The back half of the shop was a bedroom shared by the family of three.

One day Mai Minghe had been lying on the bed in a short skirt, reading, when the bedroom door was suddenly pushed open and a strange man walked in.

She was startled; the man also looked taken aback.

His gaze swept quickly around the room—across the bed, and over Mai Minghe's legs—before he apologized and stepped back out. After the door closed, her mother's voice rang out from beyond it: "The back is not the shop, don't just wander through there!"

Nothing had happened. It was just someone who had gone the wrong way.

But the shame, impossible to put into words, made it impossible for Mai Minghe to go on reading. She tugged her skirt down hard and locked the door.

Why hadn't she known to lock it? Why had she forgotten to lock it? Why had she been so careless?

She thought: Kelly would never encounter something like this. Kelly's bedroom must be neat and lovely—but she couldn't picture it.

"If I were a man, I wouldn't have to go through things like this, would I?"

In the sound system, the young adult Mai Minghe was saying this softly to a friend.

Ah, yes.

Mai Minghe dragged her injured foot along, thinking as she walked.

After graduating from high school, she had saved up money specifically to learn typing so she could leave the neighborhood she had grown up in—hoping to find work as a typist, even daring

to fantasize about becoming a secretary at a large company someday. It was before 1960, and there were few jobs women could do.

But the male manager sitting in that smoke-filled office hadn't cared how fast she could type.

"Legs aren't long enough. Backside isn't perky enough."

She had lingered in the restroom for a moment, and when she came out, she heard the male clerks inside talking through the door: "The most important thing is, I just can't appreciate a face like that. I still prefer blondes with blue eyes—they'd look better in the office."

Strangely, she had no idea how she'd hurt her leg—it must have happened just moments ago, yet she couldn't remember it at all; but memories from over sixty years past were, on the contrary, so clear.

"Things I shouldn't have done, ways I wished I had been different, so many parts of myself I disliked, times I was hurt and times I hurt others... there are so many things in this life that I have wished had never happened.

"No one walks through life without a scratch. I have to try to look toward the light, to walk toward the light... and that is because I have never lived in the light. Only murky, minor suffering—every single day, like a splinter snagged on the fabric of a life."

...Had all of this truly been the voice of her heart?

In the sound system, Mai Minghe let out a slow breath—it still sounded like her, only without any sense of age.

"Have you ever wondered what this place actually is? And what is the purpose of making you kill every version of yourself?"

Mai Minghe grabbed what appeared to be a coil of spare heavy-gauge electrical wire from a corner and used it as a whip, snapping it hard at the other Mai Minghe—she had no time to dodge, and the wire split the air and struck her squarely across the back.

The sound system went quiet for a moment; only after her cry of pain had died away did it continue, unhurried:

"Every version of me here is weak, ordinary, hesitant, awkward, humiliated, full of mistakes, indecisive, and falling short. Countless flaws, countless wrongs—and that is how a life was squandered.

"What does it matter that you have an Artifact? You experience a few new things, and then what? You know this better than anyone. Dragging along a self like this—a self already fixed in place by eighty-six years of living—even if the novelty brings you a few days of happiness, you still cannot step into a new life."

Mai Minghe miraculously dodged yet another Mai Minghe, threw herself desperately toward the door, and pulled it inward.

To her surprise, the door actually opened.

"Right now you cannot bring yourself to strike the killing blow—you can only flee like a coward, cry out in wounded pain. Do you know why? Because this is what the past has made you. In other words, all of this is the fault of your former selves. Kill these selves, and you will no longer be defined by the past—otherwise, giving you an Artifact is simply a waste.

"Every Mai Minghe should understand this."

Beyond the door was the sidewalk; the moment the door opened, pale, swollen daylight spilled onto the warehouse floor.

Mai Minghe stared blankly at the Mai Minghe who had been waiting outside the door all along.

She recognized that face.

A small scar on the chin, left by the heel of a crying child when she worked as a nursery caretaker. A few white hairs had begun to appear at her temples and the top of her head; her husband had said, you didn't go gray until forty—that's pretty good.

He was a gentle, mild-natured man. Mai Minghe had known back then that she had to marry; she had deliberately avoided men with strong masculine energy and chosen him instead.

The marriage had lasted eleven unremarkable years, and Mai Minghe had no particular complaints. More than a husband, he was like a friend who would not leave simply because they had started a family.

She would occasionally wonder whether this was all her life was going to be; but as the years passed, she wondered less and less.

"Kill those selves, kill that past—only then can a true rebirth come."

...Was that how it was?

Mai Minghe lowered her head, lost in a daze. Then it was already too late for her. The other Mai Minghes had gotten there first.

The knife plunged deep into her abdomen, buried to the hilt, leaving only the black handle visible.

The hand gripping the handle—Mai Minghe's hand—had no flesh over the knuckles; the tendons stood out in ridges, the joints far rougher and broader than they had been at twenty.

"The test results came back. It's throat cancer."

Mai Minghe gripped the knife tight, and said to the Mai Minghe in the doorway, in a daze: "...What am I supposed to do?"

How to put it—the way this chapter unfolded was very different from what I had in mind...

Chapter 236: Mai Minghe and So Many Things

Someone once told Mai Minghe, "You're so stupid."

A woman only gets married once in her life — she needs to find someone she can lean on, or what will she do with the rest of her years?

The person who said this seemed to be a friend, but Mai Minghe had forgotten who it was — that must have been several decades ago.

Why him? Others had also mockingly said that he had no masculine presence at all, that he spoke softly, and that if she married him, who would be the one wearing the pants in the family?

But none of them understood.

Whether it was friends or parents, they didn't know that when Mai Minghe chose to marry her husband, what she had mainly considered was not "security and support," "a better life," or "having someone to shelter her in the future"...

It was safety and dignity.

Her husband was quiet and gentle, and seemed forever apologetic about his own existence.

Even when entering his own home, if he saw Mai Minghe reading in the living room or doing needlework, he would smile with an air of apology — as though he felt that sharing a roof with her was a kind of intrusion upon her.

It was the first time Mai Minghe had ever met a man like that, especially in that era.

She felt that her eye for people was fairly sharp — as though she had been born with an antenna a little more sensitive than most.

He always dressed neatly; he wouldn't wear short sleeves to bare his arms unless the heat became unbearable. When something came up, he would sit at the far end of the small table across a desk lamp and quietly ask for her opinion.

He never ordered Mai Minghe to pour his coffee or empty his ashtray, and he never scolded her; when she mentioned that a female neighbor had been shoved by her husband and hit her head on a cabinet, her husband's face went pale with shock — just like a woman's would.

People always said that Mai Minghe was good-looking, yet after dragging things out for so long, she had ended up marrying a man with no money who was effeminate — truly too stupid.

"Ended up" — as if once she married, her life was over.

In the years after their marriage, Mai Minghe felt as though she was gradually coming to understand certain things. She had probed with a few roundabout questions, but nothing had come of it, and the doubts faded without resolution. Besides, in eleven years, no man with a particularly close relationship to him had ever appeared — but if one had? Would she have cared?

She didn't think so.

Perhaps it had nothing to do with orientation; he was simply that kind of person — someone who didn't fit society's definition of a "man."

Her husband and she were two people who had each pretended to squeeze into mainstream society, only to be crushed breathless by it. They had built a small unit together, weathering life's storms side by side — more like friends, like allies, than like husband and wife.

That was better than most marriages.

But Mai Minghe still had many unanswered questions. She wanted to hear him explain why he always carried such shame and guilt; she wanted to know whether he truly wanted a child; she wanted to know who he really was.

Only by the very end — when opening his mouth produced nothing but trembling streams of air, when even sound could no longer come out — it all seemed not to matter anymore.

She remembered how she had to bend down and press her ear against her husband's lips, carefully trying to read the shape of each breath and each pause, just to know what he wanted.

Once, he didn't want anything at all.

What he said was, "What will you do on your own after I'm gone?"

If the positions were reversed, if he were the one left behind alone, he would certainly have been terrified — that was simply the kind of person he was. And so he thought: Mai Minghe living alone in the world would be too pitiful, too frightening.

"But I have always lived on, even alone. Not only do I want to keep living — I want to live differently. I want to shed my past life like a snake sheds its skin."

Both of Mai Minghe's hands were trembling, yet she did not loosen her grip in the slightest, driving the blade deep into the other Mai Minghe's lower abdomen.

Since they were both Mai Minghe, of course she knew exactly where the Serpent Band ran on her body; the knife had been thrust in between the bands.

"Do you still remember that time?"

"I had to go to work and earn money, take him to the hospital for checkups and treatments, and come home to care for him, clean the house, and cook. Every day I was exhausted to the bone. I didn't dare think about the medical bills piling up, and I didn't dare close my eyes — because the moment I did, I could sleep straight through to the end of the world.

"By then he was already nearing the very end.

"One time, I knew perfectly well that he was calling for me. He was probably thirsty — I think I had forgotten to fill his water cup when I left for work that morning. I knew perfectly well he was calling for me. But I pretended not to hear."

The sound was so faint — little more than a thread of breath, the kind anyone might easily miss by accident — so she had pretended not to hear, and her husband would never know the truth.

She had carried that with her for the rest of her life.

"The me who carries a memory like that — the me who could pretend not to hear — I don't want to bring her into a second life. What's the point of holding on to something like that?"

The voice of Mai Minghe in her forties trembled faintly, and drops of moisture fell one by one onto the black knife handle and the back of her hand.

"The you who remembers this — the you who did such a thing — please just die. I want a clean new beginning."

By now, Mai Minghe could barely see clearly.

Blood was still seeping from her temple, blurring part of her vision; the knife in her lower abdomen seemed to have punched open a hollow channel, and her strength was draining steadily out through it.

She weakly clawed a few times at the other Mai Minghe's hand, not really knowing what she was trying to do — the knife was already in, and pulling it back out would mean nothing now.

Perhaps seeing her collapse to the floor and judging that she was not far from death, the other Mai Minghe finally released the knife, straightened up, breathing hard, and looked down at her.

Mai Minghe forced her eyes open and looked up at her forty-something self, standing tall before her against the daylight spilling in from beyond the door, forming a blurred silhouette.

Wait a moment...

She was, in truth, already eighty-six years old now — she would turn eighty-seven the coming year.

When she had been running through the makeshift theater, she had never seen an aged and decrepit Mai Minghe — it seemed as though fifty was a cutoff point. Beyond that, perhaps because the body could no longer keep up, showing up would have served no purpose anyway.

Which meant... she was the oldest of all the Mai Minghes, the one who remembered the most.

Was that why every other Mai Minghe wanted to kill her?

She glanced at her own hand lying limp on the floor.

She wasn't sure whether it was because her vision was blurred, but something seemed to cling to her fingers — something like dough, formless and indistinct.

Wait, that was...

If that was the case, didn't that mean—

Mai Minghe opened her mouth, trying to say something, but broke into a fit of coughing instead; she turned her head on the floor and saw, emerging soundlessly from the shadows in the corner, a Mai Minghe who looked no older than thirty.

Even with just one look at that young face, Mai Minghe knew exactly what past this Mai Minghe wanted to kill.

"Wait,"

She finally called out in a low voice and pressed one hand against the floor, trying hard to push herself up. Getting up from the floor requires the use of the abdominal muscles; but the moment those muscles contracted, they were blocked by the cold, hard blade — nothing came of it but a pain so searing that her vision went dark.

The Mai Minghe who had stabbed her glanced back.

"You're not dead yet? Won't be long, though."

As she spoke, she bent down and yanked the knife from her lower abdomen. As the other Mai Minghe cried out in pain, she said, "I don't want to watch you suffer either. I'll make it quick."

In the instant the other Mai Minghe raised her arm but had not yet brought down the blade, she gathered every last ounce of strength, barely managed to roll over and sit up, and threw herself forward — "threw herself" might not be quite right; she was entirely relying on the weight of her own body to bear down, and in doing so she wrapped both arms around the other Mai Minghe's legs.

Back in her forties, she had once hurt her foot tripping on a rainy night, and ever since, her ankle had always felt vaguely stiff, as though it was afraid to be pushed too hard.

The other Mai Minghe stumbled, and sure enough the old ankle injury kept her from staying upright — she went down with a thud.

Mai Minghe threw herself on top, and in the moment her arms gave out and she fell fully onto the other Mai Minghe, she felt a heavy blow land on the back of her head.

"What—"

The Mai Minghe in her forties, pinned beneath her, cried out.

Out of the corner of her eye, the other Mai Minghe seemed to have not expected her own blow to land on a Mai Minghe who was already close to death; startled, she stepped back several paces.

That Mai Minghe looked around, strode toward the audience seats, and grabbed another chair.

"What are you doing?" The Mai Minghe beneath her struggled, slapping a palm against her shoulder. "Let go of me — I can protect myself—"

"I understand now,"

The voice Mai Minghe had left in her was so faint and frail that it reminded her of her husband in his final days. "It's my fault for not doing better. Listen to me... I understand everything now."

The Mai Minghe beneath her stilled.

The one walking over with the chair seemed to pause as well.

She had no children in this life, and for half of it, she'd had no family either. Yet she had always felt that she had so much love inside her — ready at any moment, ready to ignite and be given away.

She had loved so many things in this life.

A small leather boot that was stolen, a little bird resting on the windowsill, a gecko passing by in summer, a crow she had made friends with using apples.

Every cat, dog, and goldfish she had ever kept at home, and every potted plant that died for no reason she could ever figure out.

Her parents, her husband, a younger cousin-niece, that cousin-niece's whole brood of children, the old woman next door (how old had Mai Minghe been then? She must have been only in her thirties), a fatherless and motherless boy from her evening class, the young man at the bakery who always slipped her a few extra cookies.

She still had an abundance of love left to give to the world; she wanted to embrace every person who wept, who grieved, who carried goodwill in their heart, and offer soft words of comfort.

But she had never once embraced herself.

Until today.

"Don't be afraid,"

Mai Minghe held her younger self tightly — the self from more than forty years ago — and softly said: "You want to kill me because I remember you. And then others will want to kill you, because you remember her.

"But don't be afraid. I will never let you die. I will never resent you."

She closed her eyes, because keeping them open felt too tiring.

She didn't know whether her words had truly been spoken aloud, or had only surfaced in her mind.

"Stop crying. You are only human. Humans make mistakes — but so what? You have weaknesses too, you get tired too, there are times you can't hold on any longer... and that's all right.

"I want to take you with me — every version of you that has ever been lost, that has ever suffered — and enter a new life together."

The main story has now entered territory I never anticipated beforehand...

Why am I writing this in a web novel (。

Chapter 237: The Most Obvious Thing to Mai Minghe

Where had so many Mai Minghes come from?

That question, asked just a few minutes ago, now had an answer that couldn't have been clearer or simpler—there was no need to even ask. So many Mai Minghes, of course, had all come from Mai Minghe's own life.

She had lived an ordinary life.

Perhaps it was precisely because of that ordinariness that the sharpest, most destructive aggression of her entire life had mostly been turned inward, against herself.

It might sound strange to say, but Mai Minghe had the hazy sense that being chased, surrounded, whipped, and stabbed—by herself—was not unfamiliar at all.

She had long since stopped wanting to go on like this.

When Mai Minghe opened her eyes, she found herself lying face-down on the ground, with nothing beneath her but a thin layer of dust and footprints on the floor.

The other Mai Minghe—the one in her forties—was gone, off to kill the next Mai Minghe, perhaps.

Had she fainted just now?

Mai Minghe lowered her gaze and looked at her own hands.

They were still the full, strong, clean, and supple hands of her life's prime; the blurred outline of her fingers she had glimpsed not long ago seemed, sure enough, to have been nothing more than a dizzy illusion brought on by her injuries.

Had the other Mai Minghes mistakenly assumed she was dead, and so let her—

The thought never finished. The back of her skull was struck again, savagely, by something heavy, and in that instant it felt as though her mind, her soul, and her vision were all knocked clean out of their shells.

Mai Minghe struggled to roll over, and through a haze of dizziness she could vaguely make out a young Mai Minghe standing before her.

"Wait—"

She called out in a hoarse voice, raising one hand as though that alone could stop Mai Minghe. She crawled backward and pleaded in a low voice: "I know. I know why you want to kill me. But listen to me—that thing, it wasn't your fault."

The expression that crossed Mai Minghe's face was one she had never seen before.

Yet even though she had never glimpsed it in a mirror, she immediately understood what kind of feeling it was—the kind that would make her half-lower her eyelids and twist her lips, as though barely holding back bile that could rise at any moment. After all, it had tormented her on countless sleepless nights.

"It wasn't your fault."

Mai Minghe found strength from somewhere, sat up, and grabbed the hand that wasn't holding the club.

"Being deceived when you were at your most vulnerable, most confused, when you were still so young—that was a misfortune, but it wasn't something shameful. You are not disgusting—"

Her words were cut short. A dark shape flashed at the edge of her vision, skimming just over the top of her head with a crushing weight of displaced air—a dull thud, and a fire axe buried itself deep into the floorboards, the air shattering around it like flying splinters of bone.

Mai Minghe stared blankly at the fire axe, then turned her head to glance at the Mai Minghe standing in the audience seats far away.

If the aim had been off by just a little less, she would have truly died right here...

She didn't want to strike a killing blow against her past self, but if she didn't want to die, she had to end all of this as soon as possible—but how?

Mai Minghe instinctively scrambled to her feet and stumbled in a lurching run toward the other side of the theater, every movement a decision made by her body's survival instinct on her behalf, while her mind remained in chaos.

That Mai Minghe shook off the hand Mai Minghe had grabbed and then released, as though flinging away some unpleasant sensation, and hefted the club in pursuit.

Mai Minghe kicked and swept aside the chairs blocking her path and charged at Mai Minghe from the far end of the theater.

Mai Minghe had only needed a single glance around the theater—once a converted warehouse—to see that at least four or five Mai Minghes were all lunging toward her at once; yet the one in her forties, whom she had held so tightly, was nowhere among the theater or the Mai Minghes, leaving no trace at all.

...Where had she gone?

Mai Minghe didn't dare look down at the wound on her lower abdomen. That she could still stand and flee was nothing short of a miracle.

Dizzy and unsteady in wave after wave of vertigo, she braced herself against walls and chairs and staggered forward, leaving wet, bloody handprints on the white walls and chairbacks she touched—and somehow those handprints seemed bloated, swollen larger than they should have been—

Wait.

She had already run past, but she stopped dead in her tracks and wrenched her head around. She looked at the wall, then looked at her own palm.

It wasn't a dizzy illusion from her injuries...

The right hand that had just grabbed Mai Minghe now had a distinctly blurry outline, as though two hands were imprecisely overlapping each other, making her right hand look one size larger than usual.

What was going on?

It was almost as though... as though her hand had picked up "another hand" on top of it.

Mai Minghe turned her head. The Mai Minghe carrying the club was only a few meters away.

She shifted her gaze and swept it around the theater.

The Mai Minghe in her forties was gone.

The younger Mai Minghes were lunging toward her.

The nearest one raised the club high above her head. The hand not holding the club also seemed blurry, its outline indistinct.

...So that was how it worked?

If the Nest could send past Mai Minghes dropping in one by one, could it also take them back, one by one, into "herself"?

She turned around—not to flee, not to dodge, but to move toward that young Mai Minghe instead.

If she took another hit to the head, she would likely lose the ability to move, and her end would come without question.

She knew she was crying, but she also knew her tears were not because she might die.

They were because she understood why that Mai Minghe burned so desperately to crush and erase herself.

Perhaps there existed women in this world who had never been handled or toyed with like an object, but Mai Minghe had never met one.

Why had she been so ignorant? Why so trusting? Why so stupid?

Why so disgusting?

"It wasn't your fault."

As though slipping through a miraculous crack, Mai Minghe dodged the club and grabbed Mai Minghe's hand again.

The wounds had healed, leaving raised, uneven, thick scars—like a frozen, screaming wound that, once released again, proved to hurt exactly like being beaten over and over with a club.

But it had always been part of the flesh that made her who she was: the mark of her will to survive, the proof that she had endured.

"Thank you," she murmured, again and again. "Thank you for holding on and becoming me."

By the time she heard footsteps behind her, the space before Mai Minghe's eyes was already empty.

...Just as she had thought—every Mai Minghe could be sent back to where each of them belonged.

She had no time to turn and see which period's Mai Minghe was attacking her now; Mai Minghe already had the vague shape of an idea.

Had the theater lied to her from the very beginning?

Had it buried the way out inside a trap?

Perhaps because she now had hope, her body no longer seemed to hurt as much. Mai Minghe hurried through the audience seats, dodged another Mai Minghe's attack, and charged up the side steps onto the stage two at a time.

The moment her foot touched the wooden stage floor, she looked back and saw several Mai Minghes all pressing toward the steps, scrambling over each other to climb up.

At the center of the stage, the supply bag and the orange tag were submerged in a column of white light.

When Mai Minghe lunged for the supply bag, several Mai Minghes behind her lunged onto her back at the same moment, pinning her along with the chair to the ground.

...Would she die right here?

For a moment her vision flickered between light and dark, full of nothing but shadows and limbs, as though even her mind couldn't keep up with what was happening before her eyes—Mai Minghe grabbed the supply bag, curled her body tight, pinned beneath the weight of her past lives, and shouted: "I've already taken it!"

She didn't even dare pause to see the reaction, and immediately shouted again: "I was always the last one, wasn't I?"

The attack she had braced for did not fall.

"Every one of them was once me. I went from one Mai Minghe to the next, step by step, until I reached today. Without each of them stubbornly choosing to survive, there would be no me today. So the Mai Minghe I am right now has always been 'the last one'... You lied to me. I never needed to kill my past selves at all, did I?"

After her voice fell, dead silence took over all around her—she couldn't even hear the breathing of the other Mai Minghes anymore.

She slowly opened her eyes—Mai Minghe hadn't even realized she had closed them.

The stage was empty, with only herself, the supply bag and the tag, and an overturned chair.

Where were all the Mai Minghes?

She scrambled upright and looked around in a daze.

Once she was sitting up, Mai Minghe suddenly realized her movements had been a little too agile, a little too easy; she looked down and found a slash in her clothing.

But only the fabric was torn—when she reached her hand inside to feel, she touched the intact skin of her lower abdomen between the Serpent Bands, as though she had never been stabbed at all.

The wound at her temple was gone too, and there was no swelling at the back of her skull.

The black speakers hanging beneath the ceiling slowly stretched and drooped down to the floor, then suddenly moved on all fours and came crawling toward her with a rustling scrape.

The speaker crouched in front of Mai Minghe and laughed—"pff, pff."

"Didn't need to kill—that's an understatement..."

"What?"

The speaker was working to hold its black outer panels in place and keep them from sliding off—in other words, it was maintaining its appearance as a speaker.

"How did you solve the puzzle? Tell me your reasoning. Did I let too many hints slip and let you find the way out?"

Mai Minghe stared blankly at the speaker in front of her, which was constantly using its appearance to convince itself it was a speaker.

"You were the 29th person to enter the theater, and the first to survive."

...What?

"Never mind killing all the other versions of yourself—even killing just one would have caused a fatal wound at the time, one you wouldn't be able to see or feel."

The speaker hummed, "When you inflict a wound on yourself, the wound lands on yourself— isn't that the most obvious thing in the world? Kill yourself, and you get killed. Something this self-evident, and yet the other 28 never thought of it. That's absolutely hilarious."

So that was it. She had never caused harm to a single version of herself... which was why she had come out without a scratch.

"It was a trap," Mai Minghe murmured.

"What else did you think it was?" said the speaker. "Did you think you could kill off your past selves one by one just because you didn't like them, and still walk away alive?"

"So... everyone else died?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Depends on your definition of death, hahaha."

"What do you mean?"

The speaker shifted, as though readjusting the front half of itself that was about to slip off. "If you say that as long as there's one person left alive at the end who looks exactly the same as before—able to move, able to talk—they haven't died, then there were indeed a few clever ones like that. Every game isn't completely the same, after all."

"...Looks the same?"

The speaker broke into a wide grin. "Because they... only look the same now."

Mai Minghe hung the orange tag around her neck. She was uninjured, and she knew she should get away from this thing that only looked like a speaker as quickly as possible—yet she couldn't summon the energy to move.

"Should I not have said 'the last one'? Oh dear, how should I phrase it next time..."

While the speaker muttered to itself, Mai Minghe lowered her head and slowly wiped her face.

"Maybe I should thank you."

The speaker paused. "What? Shut up."

"No, I truly should thank you... I've never felt as peaceful as I do right now, or longed so much for a new beginning."

Come to think of it, anyone who has no sense of boundaries, who likes to hold forth about other people's affairs, criticize everything in sight, constantly talk about how things were back in their day, and act like everyone owes them tribute — regardless of age or gender, I call them all old fogeys.

No matter how much a person gets praised, the moment they show any of those traits, I think they're pretty fogey-ish.

Chapter 238: Mai Minghe, Road Signs, Wooden Man, Hide-and-Seek

As she was leaving the makeshift theater, just before she shut the door, Mai Minghe caught a few stray words from the speaker:

"...Maybe I shouldn't say 'the last one'—how about 'survivor'? Hmm, 'the one who lived after killing everyone else'? ...Or maybe 'champion of the gu ritual'?"

It was wholly absorbed in refining its pitch, apparently hell-bent on making sure the next Hunter didn't make it out alive.

The traps and Residents of the Nest were vast as the sea and beyond counting.

The speaker seemed to be—wait, was it a Resident? Or was it part of some other formless, unclassifiable danger lurking within the Nest?

At any rate, the speaker didn't seem to be one of those things opposed to the "Domination Game" that were dead set on killing Mai Minghe.

Otherwise, it might not have played by the rules and let Mai Minghe walk away alive after she broke through the scenario.

The Nest held many "traps" and "scripts"—much like the Black Heart Restaurant game she'd participated in—and as long as a Hunter solved the puzzle and broke through following the rules, they could generally walk away alive. "Generally," that is.

If a Resident went back on its word and decided to kill anyway, the Nest didn't seem to stop them.

She gently pulled the door shut, sealing the speaker's words behind it. Through the door, she could only hear a muffled blur of sound, too indistinct to make out any words.

The supplies Key House had prepared for them were comprehensive—just about everything a Hunter would normally bring into the Nest could be found in the bag. She opened it, dug out a pen, and scrawled a few lines on the door. Ballpoint on a painted door left faint marks, but there was no better option.

Warning:

There is a trap inside. Many versions of yourself will appear. Once you are deceived into turning on yourself, you will die in the end.

Whatever you do, do not kill yourself! Try accepting and embracing instead.

The Resident is a speaker (?).

Would anyone actually believe a message that looked this vaguely hippie?

Mai Minghe shouldered her supply bag and walked away, but even after going quite a distance, she kept glancing back uneasily, afraid the speaker-that-pretended-to-be-a-speaker might come following after her.

The speaker hadn't followed. The streetlights, guardrails, theater troupe posters, and trash cans lining the road all looked exactly like their counterparts in Blackmoor City—nothing seemed to have been caught mid-dash, scrambling to freeze back into place the moment she spun around.

After a few minutes of walking, Mai Minghe realized her biggest headache was no longer the Residents at all, but a far more practical problem—

Where was the rendezvous point, Annie Warehouse?

This district of warehouse and depot buildings constructed in the early nineteenth century was simply enormous.

Standing at the intersection and looking around, she seemed to see red-brick warehouse structures in every direction, row after row—was she really going to have to walk up to each one and check?

Shaxue had told her that Key House Hunters would wait at the warehouse entrance for three hours, and any Hunter who hadn't arrived within those three hours would be considered to have failed the interview and could head straight home.

She hadn't wasted much time in the theater—from landing to now, barely forty-some minutes had passed—but failing because she couldn't find the place would be infuriating.

She had just been praising how thorough Key House's supplies were, yet now it seemed that wasn't entirely the case: why hadn't they included a map?

Then again, they truly couldn't have drawn a map showing the location of the rendezvous point—if someone met with an accident and the map fell into a Resident's hands, everyone waiting at the rendezvous could end up caught in one sweep.

The last time Mai Minghe had come to Old Harbor must have been decades ago; she stood at the intersection, momentarily at a loss for which direction to head first, feeling a little dazed.

Her gaze swept the surroundings—across the road, the overpass, the street signs, and a pole at the intersection hung with several directional signs.

Why were there no directional signs anywhere nearby?

Mai Minghe paced back and forth a few steps, craning her neck to peer up and down and left and right along the empty road.

This area had long since stopped serving as warehouse docking space and had become a popular venue for theater troupe performances instead—under normal circumstances it would have no shortage of tourists. At the very minimum, the corresponding location in Blackmoor City should have had plenty of signs put up for visitors.

Mai Minghe walked a dozen or so paces along the sidewalk, scanning a coffee shop, a ticket booth, and a sign pointing toward the Tourist Information Center, but she found not a single directional road sign.

...Wait.

She spun around sharply.

On the pole in front of her hung a poster for a touring African theater troupe; it was very old, rain-faded, and its surface had warped and rippled.

Perhaps because the poster hadn't fully dried—the lead actor's eyes were slowly sliding down toward either side of his chin.

She had the nagging feeling she'd just glimpsed something worth noticing...but it wasn't those eyes, barely caught by the chin.

That kind of strangeness was hardly uncommon in the Nest.

Mai Minghe looked at the sign on the pole that read "Tourist Information Center, 350 ft" and felt an irrepressible irritation—why hadn't the Nest copied over Blackmoor City's road signs along with everything else?

It didn't have to be a sign pointing to Annie Warehouse specifically—any sign at all would have given her a little confidence; yet in this vast place, there wasn't a single one.

She looked up again.

Below the sign pointing toward the Tourist Information Center, another sign hung facing the opposite direction, reading "Suicide Arts Troupe, 550 ft."

She lowered her head, unable to suppress a creeping sense of irritation.

No...something still felt off.

There seemed to be a small skip somewhere in her mind, but she couldn't put her finger on what had been skipped over.

Whatever was causing this strange feeling, it was somewhere close by—it had arisen precisely when she was searching everywhere for road signs and coming up empty.

Mai Minghe thought for a moment, then pulled her phone out of her trouser pocket.

Wasn't this a staple of horror films?

The eye sees nothing—but take a photo, look at the picture, and suddenly there's an extra ghost standing among the crowd.

The Nest was still cast in the pale grey light of an overcast day, but as Mai Minghe recalled the horror-film instinct and pressed the shutter, she couldn't honestly claim there wasn't the faintest flutter of unease in her chest.

On the photo, though, everything was just as empty and ordinary as before. The utility box, the storefronts, the trees, the road signs—except there were no road signs.

Mai Minghe let out a sigh. "Fine, I won't fight with the road signs anymore. If there aren't any, there aren't any."

She lifted her foot and picked a direction at random to walk in; after only a few steps, something stirred in her mind, and she glanced quickly back down at the phone photo—the next second, Mai Minghe wrenched around and shouted at the empty road: "I can see you!"

The road sign stood motionless right before her.

Like a lover who'd just crawled out of the wardrobe and been caught flat-footed by a sudden feint, trousers not yet on.

The feeling of that moment—even if she lived another eighty-six years—would be difficult for Mai Minghe to put into words:

The image of a road sign was clearly, unmistakably imprinted on her retinas, yet it seemed to be drawing back, fading from her mind little by little.

"I've already seen you. Stay still! It's too late to run."

If anyone had heard Mai Minghe shouting things like that at an empty road right now, they'd probably think she'd lost her mind.

The road sign finally stopped—no, that wasn't right; the road sign hadn't moved to begin with.

It was plainly in the center of her field of vision, yet it felt as though it lingered in the "peripheral" edge of her mind, ready to vanish the moment she looked away.

"What on earth," Mai Minghe was almost laughing from exasperation, "is the Nest doing with something this silly—are you playing hide-and-seek like a little kid? Let me see—what directions are you even pointing?"

Under her gaze, the road sign trembled with what seemed like anguish, like a mimosa fern on the verge of folding shut—no, that wasn't right; the road sign hadn't moved at all, so why did she keep having these hallucinations.

But Mai Minghe barked out a command anyway: "Don't move."

There were five signs on the pole in total: restroom, Suicide Arts Troupe, subway station, and ferry port—and one more besides those four, pointing southeast, which was the one that mattered most to her.

Tourist Information Center, 700 ft

Seven hundred feet, roughly a little over two hundred meters—not far.

Being a tourist information center, it should have a layout map of the surrounding buildings; that gave her a real chance of locating Annie Warehouse.

Beneath the sign there was also one small line of text.

"Please be discerning—don't be fooled by fake information centers :)"

I sometimes come across posts teaching people how to write (because I always click on them), and I've seen advice saying you shouldn't write things like "he froze" or "she looked around" and should replace them with other descriptions instead.

Well, what can I say—I've realized I actually quite like writing that way...before I read those posts, I never noticed other people considered it a flaw.

I probably still won't change in the future lol (。

2025 Themed Nest, Online Version, compatible with iOS, Android, Steam, and all major platforms

(These past couple of days I've been revisiting Theme Hospital, a game from my childhood—nostalgic and fun—so the thank-you chapters originally planned for social media have been temporarily replaced by the Themed Nest game.)

(The characters appearing in this chapter are still the tipping patrons from the 12/28 – 1/11 period. My speed at writing thank-you chapters always falls behind the times—I can never keep up with the timeline.)

"Welcome, prprprQBB, to the Themed Nest game!"

"Welcome, 划框框, 一隅逢, 信使AtRnoname, 长高高的鱼, 葵瓜, 戚梧, and 铁甲白棠, to the Themed Nest game!"

-

New Game--

Load Progress——

Tutorial——

Quit-

"Select: New Game"

"Select: Character Type"

-

Hunter (Hard Mode)——

Resident (Easy Mode)——

Unclassifiable Living Entity (Easy Mode)——

Unclassifiable Non-Living Entity (Medium Mode)--

Artifact (Medium Mode)——

Ordinary Person Who Accidentally Fell into the Nest (Ultimate Hell-Level Insane Spicy Mode)-

"Select: Random Assignment"

prprprQBB: Oh my god, what is this place? Didn't I just fall down the stairs? How did I end up here?

Dream Playwright: Hello there.

prprprQBB (looked at its blank face): AAAAAAH——wait, this is a dummy, right. That's a mask, isn't it. Don't lurk behind a mask acting all shady—who are you? What do you want?

prprprQBB took a step forward and reached out to grab the Dream Playwright's face.

信使AtRnoname slowly slid down the utility pole.

信使AtRnoname (raised a face toward the darkness): If I were you, I wouldn't touch that.

prprprQBB: AAAAAAH——what are you?! No, I need to get out of here right now. This is no place to linger.

【Objective confirmed for the above ordinary person: escape.】

信使AtRnoname: How sad I am one of the rare Residents with wicked intentions no wait good intentions but your suspicion of me has driven me to villainy so let me turn QBB into BBQ

一隅逢 followed silently. This was a fairly rare Resident type, one that excelled at blending into the environment and tailing a target, waiting for the right moment to deliver the "ultimate encounter" with a single killing blow.

划框框 drifted through the air, surveying the expanse of the Nest, searching for an opportunity. As an unclassifiable non-living entity character, it was heavily restricted, and for now could only keep spreading quietly, biding its time.

【Objectives confirmed for the above three Residents/unclassifiable non-living entity: host a Saturday BBQ and invite prprprQBB to step onto the grill.】

"Welcome, EmrysLCF and 非食用类小猫软糖, to the Themed Nest game!"

戚梧: Hmph.

铁甲白棠: What's wrong?

Qiwu: A competitor has arrived. She's a newly launched—newly recruited Hunter from the Oreo House Faction, Non-Edible Kitty Gummy Bear. We need to be careful not to let her find the Artifact before us.

Iron-Armored Baitang: Oh, your intel is sharp. But that Artifact... what was it called, the Tall-Tall Fish? Where exactly is it? It's hiding so well. Could it be in the water?

Qiwu: Don't worry. I have an old acquaintance—a Resident, but a decent one by Resident standards, anyway. We can ask around.

[The above three Hunters' mission is confirmed: find the Artifact, the Tall-Tall Fish.]

[The above one Artifact's mission is confirmed: do not be found.]

"Welcome, Hu Miaomiao's Owner and Caoyue Riyue, to the themed Nest game!"

Caoyue Riyue: Hello there, Qiwu. How's Blackmoor City been? Have you been eaten—I mean, have you eaten? If not, don't be shy—I happen to have prepared a cup of Daydream, No Sugar right here. Please, have some. Whatever you'd like to say, save it until after you've finished.

Iron-Armored Baitang: Hold on, you're actually going to drink it?

Qiwu hesitated for a moment, then finally gulped down the entire cup of Daydream, No Sugar in one go.

Caoyue Riyue: Now that's loyalty. With that, I can go back to Black— what I mean is, I can now answer your questions.

Qiwu: Please tell me—where is the Tall-Tall Fish?

Caoyue Riyue: In the place where it's least likely to appear, the place where it least ought to exist.

Iron-Armored Baitang: What a useless answer. Utterly unreliable, just as I thought.

Caoyue Riyue: I'm not offended. Not only am I not offended, I'll even point you in the right direction. Go find someone called Kuigua... hmm, an unclassifiable entity called Kuigua. Find it, and you'll be able to close the distance between yourselves and your target Artifact, the Tall-Tall Fish.

Meanwhile, the factionless lone wolf EmrysLCF was drawing on her years of Hunter experience, attempting to dig information from within the Nest. She had long since scouted the

area and done her research; now she pulled out a full cat mascot costume, slipped it on, curled her hind legs beneath her, and sat quietly by the roadside, waiting.

EmrysLCF: Meow.

Hu Miaomiao's Owner: Miaomiao! Is that you, Miaomiao? What are you doing here, Mama was worried sick about you, how dare you go wandering all over the place even inside the Nest, aren't you afraid of running into Hunters, who knows how those humans might treat you, come home with me right now—

Reportedly, Hu Miaomiao's Owner's home contained a door connecting to a so-called doomsday universe, and EmrysLCF intended to infiltrate it and investigate thoroughly.

[The above one Hunter's mission is confirmed: explore the Resident's home.]

[The above one Resident's mission is confirmed: find the real cat.]

prprprQBB: Wh-what is this place, help, is anyone there?!

Shandong Fugitive Excavator: Hey.

After the startled shriek, prprprQBB collected herself: Y-you—what are you?

Shandong Fugitive Excavator: As you can see, I am a Shandong Fugitive Excavator.

prprprQBB: What?

Shandong Fugitive Excavator: I am an unclassifiable non-living entity. My mission is simple: not only do I constantly run for my life, I also help people in trouble make their escape.

Yiyufeng spat in irritation, because it liked to encounter people who were alone. It looked up, and thought of a plan.

Huakuakuai received the message and drifted over toward the spot Yiyufeng had indicated. It slowly expanded and diffused itself, blending into the Nest's atmosphere, and silently fell into step behind prprprQBB.

Kuigua: Who's here?

Qiwu: We're here looking for Kuigua. Do you happen to know it?

Kuigua: Oh, of course I do. Walk a little further ahead—the red one is it.

Iron-Armored Baitang: Hello. Are you Kuigua?

Ixquart Red-Robed Doll Tomato: I am. What do you want with me?

Just as the Hunters and the unclassifiable entity launched into an eager conversation, Huakuakuai finally made its move.

It dispersed its body particles outward, leaving the center completely hollow, the particles forming a ring of encirclement around the perimeter; it locked onto the small figure below, and pressed down onto the ground in one swift motion—in an instant, Huakuakuai had drawn a box on the ground, enclosing the target perfectly within it.

Non-Edible Kitty Gummy Bear: What's happening?! Help! Why am I locked up?!

Yiyufeng: Dammit, it boxed the wrong person! But then again... this way, Huakuakuai can't compete with me anymore. I can keep tracking.

Shandong Fugitive Excavator: They came for you but grabbed the wrong one! Let's start running, now!

prprprQBB's heart pounded like mad, and she sprinted forward breathlessly alongside it.

Behind them, the trapped Non-Edible Kitty Gummy Bear shouted: Who did this?! Let me out!

Hu Miaomiao's Owner: Hm? There seems to be a cat here. Is that a cat? How strange—I've seen three Miaomiao's in a row now, but none of them quite seem like the real Miaomiao...

EmrysLCF: Three? Where'd three come from—I mean, meow?

Hu Miaomiao's Owner: How remarkable, I understood exactly what your meow meant. Here's the thing: before I ran into you, I also caught a cat cloud.

While it was trying to figure out which one was the real cat, Ixquart Red-Robed Doll Tomato tripped up both Hunters, and Kuigua slipped away quietly, vanishing into the darkness.

Kuigua: Ready?

Du Ziruo, Xiwei Youye: Ready.

Kuigua: Three, two, one—run.

Du Ziruo, Xiwei Youye: Help, there's a Resident chasing us, it's terrifying, run!

Kuigua: Stop right there—be good and let me eat you. Aren't you my food delivery? How dare the delivery run away?

Du Ziruo, Xiwei Youye: Don't look back, it's so scary, keep running... oh, excuse me, young lady, are you running for your life too?

prprprQBB: What a coincidence—you two as well?

Du Ziruo, Xiwei Youye: Yeah, run together, run together! We'll lead the way.

The group of four (loosely called people) ran for their lives together; but without any warning, iron spikes suddenly shot up through the ground one after another, sending prprprQBB sprawling.

The Artifact, Tall-Tall Fish, tumbled off her.

prprprQBB: This... what is this?

Messenger AtRnname: Hahaha, welcome to my grill! I've been waiting for you!

—

— Game Paused —

The Dream Playwright sighed, took off their glasses, and gave them a wipe.

"Honestly, I'm clearly an NPC, and not a single sponsor-player came to talk to me. Whatever—let them keep playing on their own. It's Saturday anyway. I'm taking a break."

The thank-you chapter is finally done! It's Saturday anyway, so I'm taking a break.

Going to play one more round of Theme Hospital.

Chapter 239: The Poster Nobody Noticed

Walking in broad daylight did nothing to ease even a thread of tension or unease.

It might not make sense to say so, but Mai Minghe felt that the daylight of the Nest somehow made her sense of insecurity worse—there were too many things on the road that she would rather not see.

Human eyes only face forward, which is truly inconvenient. The sides, the back, the sky, the ground beneath her feet—all blind spots that no light could reach.

When Mai Minghe turned her head to the left, a finger from the right gently slipped into the hair at the back of her head.

She jolted, quickly leaped away and twisted her body to the right—in her peripheral vision she caught a shadow slowly retreating behind her—but when she turned around, the street was completely empty.

Though "completely empty" wasn't quite right, either.

About a hundred meters away, a completely naked figure was crouching behind a trash can, only a stretch of flesh-colored back and buttocks exposed; the spine rose high out of the back, each vertebra jutting out in a long, prominent ridge.

From a distance, it looked as though a massive, flesh-colored, wart-covered hooked nose had poked its way out from behind the trash can.

No matter how far she walked, how long she walked, or how many circles she made, that bare back always crouched behind the same trash can at the same distance, never more and never less than a hundred meters away.

She couldn't get closer to it, and the thing made no move to close the gap.

...This was the Nest.

Mai Minghe gripped tightly the handgun that Key House Faction had issued her, aware of its uselessness, while also thinking that for someone who had never touched a gun in her life, the only target a handgun could threaten might very well be herself.

These movements—illusory, unsettling, the kind that made you paranoid—weren't even the most annoying part.

Ever since she had "caught" a road sign once, the sidewalks and streets ahead of her were packed full of them.

Road signs crammed together, one pressed up against the next, desperately shoving their way into her field of vision and the space around her, breathing hot breath onto her face and ears, clawing at everything she tried to look at.

Every road sign tried to seize her gaze, then grip it and lead her somewhere—which sounded exactly like something a lunatic would say, but Mai Minghe had, in fact, nearly been led by road signs into side streets several times.

She quickly realized: don't look. Don't look carefully at the road signs.

The moment she read the words on a sign, her feet would unconsciously follow the direction it pointed; it was only when the next sign successfully hijacked her attention and wrenched her steps onto a different path that she would snap back to her senses, realizing she had wandered far off course again.

A stretch of road barely two hundred meters long took Mai Minghe half an hour to get halfway through in the right direction—or at least the direction she had originally decided was right.

The forest of road signs vanished all at once, as though an invisible giant hand had yanked them all out of the ground—gone without a single warning; when the space ahead of her suddenly opened up again, Mai Minghe stopped mid-step and blinked hard several times.

A woman turned away from a glass window and glanced at her.

Beneath a sky weighed down by heavy, overcast clouds, the fluorescent orange lanyard hanging from the woman's chest was the only spot of color in the entire surroundings.

Mai Minghe reflexively touched her own chest—her own orange lanyard, recovered only after great difficulty, answered the color across from her.

"You found your way here too," the woman said, giving her a nod.

Thank goodness Shaxue had forced them all to look at each person's appearance and clothing several times over and memorize it.

They had introduced themselves to each other before setting out, including the woman now in front of her—a woman named Aimeli.

Aimeli wore her hair pulled back in a tight ponytail, pressed so firmly against her skull that it looked like it might rip away from her hairline; she was nothing like what her name suggested—her face was narrow and long, her brow ridge strong, and her thin lips always pressed together—no matter how old she got, she would never have to worry about developing smile lines.

Exactly as she remembered, and with the lanyard, too—this should be her in person, right?

"I thought I was the only one who didn't know where Annie Warehouse was,"

Mai Minghe said, glancing a few times at the door beside Aimeli that read "Information."
"See, we had the same idea. Is this the Tourist Information Center? They should have the location of Annie Warehouse inside—"

"Don't come any closer," Aimeli said.

Mai Minghe stopped in her tracks.

Like her, Aimeli had drawn her gun, but rather than holding it in her hand, she had tucked it into her waistband. Unlike Mai Minghe, Aimeli seemed entirely comfortable and familiar with firearms.

"I'm not a Resident..."

The words left her mouth, and then she felt foolish; a Resident wouldn't admit to it either.

"I know you're not," Aimeli said. "But the thing standing behind you is."

Before Aimeli finished her last word, Mai Minghe had already spun around; she turned so fast that her vision seemed unable to keep up with her head, smearing into a blurred, dizzy streak.

There was nothing behind her.

About a hundred meters away, the same trash can still sat in its spot; but the massive "nose" formed by the naked back and buttocks was receding behind the trash can—and right there under Mai Minghe's unblinking stare, it vanished.

What had Aimeli seen just now?

The moment that thought surfaced, Mai Minghe froze in place, as though encased in ice.

Any desire to ask Aimeli what was going on vanished entirely; she already knew the answer.

She had no idea how she had walked all the way here without noticing such a vivid, conspicuous poster.

It wasn't a theater advertisement, nor a product promotion—it was a warning poster put up by the Old Harbor police precinct.

A reminder from the Nest Police:

Criminal incidents targeting visitors have been occurring frequently in the area. To ensure your personal safety and the security of your property, please keep the following rules in mind:

1. Do not go anywhere with people you know or recognize.

Be especially careful around family members and friends!

These two groups are notoriously dangerous. According to the precinct's case summary, harm from acquaintances is frequent—as many as 85.4% of all injuries come from these two groups. When a friend who stayed back home suddenly appears and asks you to go to the harbor to take photos for them, when parents who have already eaten suggest trying out a certain restaurant, please stay alert and take care to discern what hidden motives they might have!

Stay away from family and acquaintances. Keep yourself safe.

2. Resist the temptation of the "Tourist Information Center."

Stay calm and firmly say no to the "Tourist Information Center."

Do not accept any program listings it hands you. Do not look at any program listings it hands you. Do not follow its directions. No matter what it promises about giving you a wonderful memory, do not purchase any souvenir merchandise. Do not carefully compare the differences between each "Tourist Information Center." Do not go inside. Do not turn your back to its door.

The lower half of the poster had been torn away.

But that last line was enough to make every pore on Mai Minghe's body clench shut; her sense of her whole body seemed to go dim, except for her back, which felt especially vivid—hot and burning—as blood rushed in a prickling, tingling surge against the skin of her back.

"...Why are you trying to hurt me?"

She forced those words out of her dry throat. "What happens next?"

Today's chapter is a bit short, because I've been too stuck. I have an idea for the future plot, but it's still too vague—I need to explore it properly... In other words, the outline is used up!

To think there's something in this world even less durable than money!

Chapter 240: Mai Minghe's Roaming — The Tourist Information Center

Aside from a piece that had been torn away, the yellow warning poster was so new it looked utterly out of place with its surroundings.

It was stuck on a roadside electrical box, far below eye level — if you weren't actively scanning low, your gaze would easily slide right over the top of the box. Perhaps that was exactly why she hadn't noticed it on the way here?

Inside Mai Minghe's head, her thoughts tangled themselves into a knotted mess of yarn, and for a moment her mind was nothing but questions:

Wasn't it against the rules to hide a rule somewhere inconspicuous? Her stored knowledge of the Nest clearly stated that rules were supposed to be as obvious and legible as possible, giving humans a fair playing field.

Now that she'd broken a rule, what would happen?

"What did you say?" Aimeli's voice sounded again from behind her. "Are you talking to me?"

Mai Minghe's heart lurched — she sounded considerably closer, as though she were walking this way.

But why? If Aimeli was walking toward her, didn't that mean Aimeli would first have to turn around, putting her back to the Tourist Information Center's door?

When she turned her head, she found that was exactly the case: Aimeli had already turned her back to the Tourist Information Center door and was walking over; she had crossed the narrow road and was only a few steps away from Mai Minghe.

Watching her draw closer and closer, Mai Minghe felt confused.

Surely she wasn't planning to hurt someone else before taking herself out? She certainly didn't look it.

Aimeli's face was utterly still, her strong bone structure casting deep hollows and ridges, and without any expression she looked almost like a rock sculpture.

The only reaction when her gaze landed on the poster was the faintest lift of her lashes; after that, her face didn't stir at all. She stared at the poster for a long moment, then gave a nod.

...Could it be that she was also seeing this poster for the first time?

Mai Minghe formed a guess that seemed almost unreasonably convenient.

"So that's how it is... I wasn't lying. There truly was a Resident behind you just now, but the moment you turned around, it vanished somewhere." Aimeli said, "This rule poster — I'm also seeing it for the first time. Even though we turned our backs to the door, you don't need to worry. I have a rough idea of what's going on."

Mai Minghe stared at her blankly. "What's going on?"

Aimeli gestured toward the Tourist Information Center on the other side of the road.

"I believe the one behind us is not the real 'Tourist Information Center' — it's simply one of the Nest's unclassifiable non-living entities, disguised as a Tourist Information Center. That's why, after we turned our backs to it, we appeared to violate the rule, yet nothing happened..."

As she spoke, Aimeli's brow furrowed. "That was close."

The words "non-living entity" snagged Mai Minghe's attention, and the corresponding Nest data immediately surfaced in her mind.

Beyond Residents, traps, scripts, Artifacts, and the other things that could barely be categorized and recognized by Hunters, the Nest was also filled with a vast number of chaotic and dangerous things that resisted definition — like the road signs that had followed Mai Minghe in dense clusters all the way here.

"Living" and "non-living" were merely crude distinctions drawn from their outward appearances.

But whether living or not, all of them were capable of producing thought and reaction; all of them would adjust and adapt in response to a Hunter's actions, weaving a net that drew tighter and tighter.

"How did you know?" Mai Minghe asked, with a lingering trace of fear. "The consequences of breaking a rule don't have to happen immediately, do they?"

Across the narrow road, the Tourist Information Center looked convincingly real. In the display window beside the door stood a few frames of theater troupe advertisements and several informational brochures; the door even listed the center's open hours for all seven days of the week.

At the very least, one thing was now certain: Aimeli hadn't just been trying to set her up, or she wouldn't have ended up breaking the rule right alongside her.

Strangely, that realization brought Mai Minghe more comfort than anything else.

"True, I can't rule out the possibility that we'll run into trouble a little later — but I think the odds are low."

Aimeli said, her voice still calm, "You may not know this, but along the several hundred meters behind us, the entire street is practically wall-to-wall Tourist Information Centers. I came from the other end, and they were lined up one after another the whole way — nothing but."

Mai Minghe startled, and immediately thought of something else.

"I came this way because of a road sign. At the time it said the Tourist Information Center was seven hundred meters away, and warned me not to be fooled by fake centers. I've only walked half the distance, and I've already spotted one... Which means it really is suspect. At the very least, it's not the same information center the sign was pointing to."

Aimeli nodded. "Walk a little way in that direction and you'll see — that street is full of them."

She paused, and her gaze returned to the poster. "Lucky the rule was broken outside the rule zone itself. But even so, this is deeply unfair. The rule is posted somewhere this inconspicuous, and on top of that it's nowhere near the Tourist Information Center — the very place the rule applies to... What difference does it make whether the rule is stated or not?"

Even in her dissatisfaction, her tone remained calm. One probably couldn't become a Hunter without some kind of exceptional quality.

"Did you pick one and go inside to have a look?"

Aimeli shook her head. "If there were only one or two, I would have gone in for a look. But with an entire street of them, every single one with 'Tourist Information Center' written on the door, I couldn't bring myself to commit to entering any of them. Too many choices, and the result is not wanting to choose any of them. I decided to keep walking and see where it ended — and then I ran into you."

Mai Minghe could relate to that feeling.

It was fortunate Aimeli hadn't gone in, or she very likely would have broken a rule without even knowing the rule existed — when put that way, it really was deeply unfair.

"This information center should be the last one. I came from the opposite direction, and I've also covered the nearby area — didn't see a single information center on the way." Mai Minghe said, pointing back the way she had come.

"In that case, there are seventeen Tourist Information Centers in total." Aimeli said immediately.

...How many?

"You counted?"

"I counted," Aimeli nodded. "Not only that, but each one also has a small numeric ID on the door. The one nearest to us is numbered 17 — and it's the seventeenth Tourist Information Center I counted."

Mai Minghe almost wanted to let out a sigh — was there really nothing that could go smoothly?

She and Aimeli had to find the Annie Warehouse within one hour and forty minutes, or the interview would be considered a failure. But with seventeen Tourist Information Centers, even if they spent only five minutes checking and identifying each one, all their time would be used up — there would be nothing left to get to the meeting point.

Before she could say a word, Aimeli seemed to have already guessed what she was about to say.

"I've also considered whether I should abandon this area entirely and find the Annie Warehouse some other way..." she said, arms folded. "But since touching down, I've spent an hour searching the nearby area and looked through no end of red-brick buildings, and still haven't found the Annie Warehouse. So I'm wondering — could Key House Faction have anticipated this situation all along?"

Mai Minghe thought it over.

"You mean, 'finding the Annie Warehouse' is part of Key House Faction's test for us, and the Tourist Information Centers are very likely the test's checkpoint?"

"Exactly."

Aimeli snapped her fingers, her expression still flat, no emotion showing. "Key House Faction specifically chose the Old Harbor area as the drop zone, which means they're clearly familiar with the challenges in this part of the Nest. They know what kinds of problems we'll run into, and they want to see how we handle and overcome them. Otherwise, why would they go out of their way to keep the location of the Annie Warehouse from us?"

Mai Minghe was silent for a moment.

"...Find the real Tourist Information Center, get the location of the Annie Warehouse from it, then go rendezvous with Key House Faction — is that right?"

She let out a sigh. "If that's the case... this is more than just a headache. We've put ourselves in a bit of an awkward spot, haven't we."

Aimeli tilted her head, glanced at her, then glanced at the poster — as though she had understood what she meant.

"The very first rule states it plainly: don't walk with anyone you know."

With a vague, inexplicable embarrassment, Mai Minghe said carefully, "How about we just stay far apart from each other? Keep enough distance, and that should count as being quite 'wary' of acquaintances — not a violation, right? As long as we can see each other, we can at least watch out for one another."

"I don't need anyone watching out for me," Aimeli said, as composed as ever. "And I won't watch out for anyone else. In the Nest, conserving energy is critical — looking after yourself is enough. That said, I agree with your suggestion. We can each walk on one side of the road, try to stay parallel, and not talk unless it's necessary."

They couldn't walk one in front of the other — otherwise, the person behind would become someone "following an acquaintance."

Aimeli was every bit the experienced Hunter: before leaving, she took out her phone and photographed the rule poster; jolted by the reminder, Mai Minghe quickly took a photo as well.

She always found it oddly fascinating that a single press of the shutter could make a clear image appear on a screen, so after taking the photo she stared at it for a few extra moments, as she always did.

By the time she put her phone away, a vague, shapeless, cloud-like feeling of unease had risen in Mai Minghe's chest.

...She couldn't quite say what exactly it was about.

"Let's go," said Aimeli. "We're probably both heading to the same place."

Those who make it as Hunters are never fools.

The first place to check was naturally the Tourist Information Center roughly three hundred and fifty meters from where Mai Minghe stood — it was the only location the road signs had pointed to, and deserved to be their first priority.

Though, based on Aimeli's description, the spot three hundred and fifty meters away likely had several information centers crowded together. How they'd tell them apart — well, she'd figure that out when she got there; she hadn't seen it with her own eyes yet, so what conclusions could she draw?

Mai Minghe walked past Tourist Information Center No. 17, thinking as she went.

Aimeli walked on the other side of the road, keeping pace with her.

Her pale, faint shadow fell softly against the display window glass, momentarily dimming the performance advertisement behind it.

Before rounding the corner and stepping onto the street lined with Tourist Information Centers, Mai Minghe unconsciously swept a glance through the window.

Three advertisements stood side by side in the display window, all gazing back at her: a woman dressed in medieval European clothing, cradling a wooden basin; a small figure holding a yellow slip of paper aloft, surrounded by a crowd; and a pair of enormous eyes, subtly distorted behind a magnifying glass.

When Mai Minghe turned her head, she found she had fallen two steps behind, and quickly quickened her pace to catch up with Aimeli.

The two of them kept parallel and walked into the street beyond the corner.

Mai Minghe raised her eyes.

In that instant, she felt as though someone had chewed up every Tourist Information Center in the world, swallowed them all haphazardly, and then vomited them back out; the half-digested mess had flowed down the length of the street, pooling into a road of Tourist Information Centers.

At just that one glance, her mind nearly dissolved into the same formless disorder as the vomit-like Tourist Information Centers lining both sides of the street —

Tourist Information Center tourist tourist center information information center tourist
tourist center tourist tourist information center information

Information center tourist center information tourist information tourist center center center
tourist information center

This chapter nearly killed me — another day just gone like that. I'm so desperately looking forward to having two days off over the New Year holiday...

Writing web novels—you truly can't afford to miss a single day. I took Saturday off and only posted a thank-you chapter, and already it feels like I've committed some grave transgression...

Chapter 241 — In Every Tourist Information Center Along Mai Minghe's Street

Aimeli had never described this street in any detail, and now that Mai Minghe thought about it, perhaps Aimeli simply hadn't known how.

Human language, when placed inside the Nest, often proved woefully inadequate.

As Mai Minghe stood and stared, what gradually rose up within her was not adjectives, metaphors, or plain description — but wave after wave of dizziness and nausea.

The whole street was no more than a few dozen meters long — calling it a "street" was already being generous — yet it was crammed with sixteen and a half Tourist Information Centers, the reason for the "half" being that the rear portion of Tourist Information Center No. 17 also occupied the same street.

It was like a car that had been rear-ended, its back end smashed in by another great tangled, competing mass of Tourist Information Centers.

At roughly the three-hundred-and-fifty-meter mark where the street came to an end, Mai Minghe and Aimeli both stopped at the same moment.

The street was short, and they had now reached its end; ahead was an intersection, and beyond the intersection everything settled back into calm and composure — not a single twisted, clamorous, crash-warped Tourist Information Center remained in sight.

The two of them exchanged a glance across the narrow road.

Aimeli checked her phone first — probably reviewing the rules on the warning poster to avoid making a mistake — and then pointed to the half-tilted door beside her, indicating she would check the Tourist Information Centers on her side.

Mai Minghe nodded to indicate she would begin searching for clues from her side as well.

She stepped forward first, skirting clear of the doorway across the road, then turned to face the Tourist Information Center on her right — turning carefully the whole time to make sure her back stayed out of range of any door.

The wall peeled back in layers, and the display window sank so far into the wall it was like looking down a tunnel.

She shifted her gaze; Aimeli was standing just inside the information center doorway, watching her.

Mai Minghe sucked in a sharp breath and nearly cried out; she stepped back half a pace before she registered what she was actually seeing.

The door frame was barely holding itself upright, yet under the press of the many Tourist Information Centers crowded around it, it had managed to maintain the shape of a door.

But the door panel was gone; in its place was a massive theatrical performance poster, plastered across the entire doorway from the inside as though standing in for the door itself — there was even a "No. 1" written in the corner.

Mai Minghe had no idea what had been there before her eyes landed on the poster.

By the time she saw it, Aimeli was already printed on it — the latter stood behind a row of iron bars, half her face pressed through the gap between them, still expressionless, one calm eye fixed on Mai Minghe.

A thin poster, a flat Aimeli — of course it wasn't a real person, just a 2D image.

At the bottom of the poster, a line of text read: The Imprisoned Woman

Performance Date: 2026.11.24

Today's date.

Mai Minghe immediately glanced back — across the road, her back was not lined up with any door, nor was any door quietly sliding toward her.

Aimeli was even more cautious than she was; she hadn't turned around at all, keeping her body angled sideways toward the Tourist Information Centers.

She was craning her neck, crouching down, peering into the gap between two stacked Tourist Information Center display windows; Mai Minghe could only see the back of her head and her long hair spread across her shoulders — Aimeli's front was still facing the intersection ahead, with nothing but the sidewalk behind her.

Only then did Mai Minghe exhale.

There was no need to specifically tell Aimeli that her likeness had appeared on a poster — no point in making her anxious for nothing, even if the girl had a calm disposition and didn't seem the type to unsettle easily.

Mai Minghe's gaze returned to the poster.

Had this poster been here when they walked past earlier?

Even if it had been, it certainly hadn't been showing Aimeli's image — otherwise Aimeli would have noticed long ago. Humans were very sensitive to being watched, even by the gaze of a mere image.

Let alone one that was life-sized.

The Aimeli behind the iron bars reached one hand through the gap, as if directing Mai Minghe to look at the phone screen she was holding.

The screen was divided into two sections: the upper two-thirds was a white background with a green message bubble floating on it; the lower third was a keyboard.

Mai Minghe recognized this interface — she had seen it when Reed Hydes taught her how to send text messages.

As for the specific text in the message, she couldn't make it out clearly.

...Since it wasn't a "program list," it should be fine to look at?

Mai Minghe reviewed the rules once more, then let her eyes drift toward the phone screen on the poster with studied casualness — though who exactly she was trying to fool with the performance, she herself didn't know.

I've been locked up by a Tourist Information Center, please help me

Tap RELEASE on the keyboard letter by letter

And you can let me out

Mai Minghe snapped upright and took a large step back, nearly stepping into the road.

She turned to look across the street. Aimeli had noticed nothing of what had just happened on this side — she was still crouching in place, neck twisted, peering into the gap between two windows jammed up against each other. Between the windows there was no wall, no window frame, only a deep black fissure.

...What was she looking at in that fissure?

Mai Minghe did not call out to her, nor did she reach out to touch the keyboard on the poster's phone.

She turned halfway around, her back to the intersection not far behind her, and walked on toward the next Tourist Information Center — all the buildings, really, were like shattered, chaotic Picasso abstractions, fragments haphazardly piled and crammed and pressed together; if not for the fact that each Tourist Information Center still barely retained a door on the street side, each door numbered, it would have been impossible to tell one from another.

For instance, as she passed one particular wall, she noticed a narrow horizontal crack running across its middle, and wedged inside the crack was a display window lying on its side.

Not a window frame, or a pane of glass, but a real window connected to a room; when Mai Minghe tilted her head and peered inside, she could even see through the display window the performance advertisements within, and the corner of the room beyond — or rather, below — the window.

The entire room seemed to have been flipped upside down and buried inside the wall.

"...Where's the door?"

Almost as if in response to her gaze, the moment Mai Minghe made out the room below the window, she heard a thin voice sound from beside it.

It seemed as though someone was hiding just behind the window — no, the voice was too close, as if it were concealed inside the wall itself.

It was unmistakably a man's voice, but he was pinching it high and thin, imitating a woman's: "Isn't this ironic? I came in to find an Old Harbor map, I found the map, and now I've gone and gotten lost inside the Tourist Information Center and can't find the door. Where's the door? I want to leave. Here's the thing — you keep walking ahead, and as long as you glance at the door, I'll know where it is, and I can open it and get out myself."

...An Old Harbor map?

Mai Minghe's heartbeat seemed to break into a quick trot. If there was a district map of Old Harbor, the location of Annie Warehouse should be on it, right?

Of course, she had absolutely no intention of letting that thing out — but simply knowing that an "Old Harbor map" might exist filled her with considerable hope.

Mai Minghe had no idea which numbered Tourist Information Center that room belonged to, so she kept her eyes fixed on the pavement tiles, not daring to glance at any of the doors along the road, and silently walked past what seemed like three or four doorways before she finally felt it was safe to look up again.

The door she was about to pass was a glass door — clean and intact, lit from within into a bright luminous rectangle, utterly out of place on this distorted, jumbled street.

"...Mai Minghe?" A muffled voice came through the glass.

Mai Minghe spun her head around.

Behind the glass door, Lisidan had raised one hand, seemingly about to knock on the glass to get her attention — Mai Minghe's eyes immediately swept to his chest.

Lisidan had a lanyard around his neck, but where the fluorescent orange badge should have been, it was blocked by a brass plate fixed to the glass door.

No. 07 Tourist Information Center

"You made it here too? Looks like nobody knows where Annie Warehouse is after all."

Lisidan said, his voice blurred through the glass. Seeing a familiar face, he looked genuinely pleased. "Do you want to come in?"

Rules aside, Mai Minghe would not have pushed that door open with any confidence. She hesitated, lifted her own badge by the lanyard, then tilted her chin toward him.

Lisidan understood.

He lowered his head, pulled up the lanyard, and held up a fluorescent orange badge.

Through the glass door, his appearance and clothing were exactly the same as before; on his arm hung the same supply bag issued by Key House Faction.

Mai Minghe relaxed slightly, then tensed again at once — "Come out!" she said quietly. "We can't just walk in there — it might be dangerous."

But Lisidan shook his head.

"I can't leave yet. Beside the door of this information center, there's an electronic display screen — the kind that cycles through photos continuously, you know the type? When I first came in, I thought I caught a glimpse of a building with 'Annie' in the name... I'm waiting for that photo to come back around. Why can't I come in? I've been in here several minutes already and nothing's happened."

As he spoke, he kept glancing to the side every so often, staring at something blocked by the wall that Mai Minghe couldn't see — that must be the electronic screen.

So it meant... Tourist Information Center No. 07 wasn't a real one either, which was why Lisidan was fine?

"Aimeli and I found a rules poster," Mai Minghe said. "It says we're not allowed to walk into a real 'Tourist Information Center'... I took a photo. I can show you."

Lisidan, as expected of a Hunter, recovered from his brief flash of surprise quickly.

"So this isn't a real 'Tourist Information Center,' and that's why I'm okay?"

That vague, shapeless, wordless feeling of wrongness drifted up again, hazy and indistinct.

Mai Minghe truly had no idea where that feeling was coming from; she nodded.

Lisidan's gaze was drawn again to something beyond the wall that she couldn't see.

"Take your time," said Mai Minghe, already beginning to lift her foot — she had thought of rule number one, which was not to follow someone familiar. "If you find anything—"

The eyes Lisidan had trained on the corner suddenly lit up, and he drew a quick breath.

"There it is! That's the one — so this is what Annie Warehouse looks like," he said, still staring at the electronic screen, beckoning rapidly toward the door. "Come in and take a look, quick — have you seen this building before?"

A spark of excitement lit up in Mai Minghe — wonderful, there was finally a chance of finding Annie Warehouse — and she had just placed her hand on the door, about to push it open, when she stopped.

...Looking closely now, Lisidan's expression was anything but relaxed.

The hair at his temples was slightly damp with sweat; at the corner of his forehead, a faint blue vein pulsed steadily, betraying the pace of his heartbeat.

Through the glass door, she couldn't hear subtle sounds, but she clearly saw his throat bob as he swallowed.

Another question surfaced.

Why didn't Lisidan just open the door himself?

Was it the same as everything else she'd encountered along the way — impossible to open from inside?

When Mai Minghe quickly stepped back from the glass door and put several paces between herself and Tourist Information Center No. 07, a long wailing scream erupted from behind the glass.

"Don't go! Don't go don't go don't go! Open the door for me! Open the door!"

I've been reading three wonderful novels in a row lately, and I feel absolutely delighted!

Ah, though I shouldn't say "in a row" — there was one sandwiched in the middle that had a writing style that drove me crazy. I read thirty-something percent of it, and absolutely nothing was willing to happen. Life is short, so I looked up the spoilers and quit, saving myself at least two days.

But anyway, finding three good ones and one decent one is genuinely great luck. Reality is too painful — the virtual world is still where it's at.

Chapter 242: Mai Minghe Now Has Two Targets

Muffled by the glass, the dull howling lasted nearly half a minute before it finally died down behind the door.

Mai Minghe stood on the sidewalk, three or four steps from the Tourist Information Center door marked number 07, staring at it without looking away.

The glass door flashed one moment with a half-flattened face pressed against it, the next with Lisidan's shoulder ramming up from below; a flesh-colored fist flickered in and out of view against the glass, over and over, surely making a tremendous racket—yet the glass door remained perfectly calm, as though the two sides of the glass belonged to two entirely different worlds, and neither vibration nor sound could pass between them.

Apart from Lisidan's muffled howling, Mai Minghe could hear no vibration at all—even when round after round of rapid gunfire struck the glass, it was the same.

For half a minute, she could barely move her feet; not because she was afraid.

Nest Residents could perhaps disguise themselves to look human—the information the Nest had poured into her mind included a type of Resident called the Vulture, which could seamlessly take on human appearances—but Nest Residents had great difficulty replicating industrial products: a phone, a fluorescent-orange lanyard badge, a handgun that could actually fire bullets.

So the person inside was probably Lisidan himself, not a Nest Resident in disguise...

Probably because he had broken the rules, entered the Tourist Information Center, and then could no longer get out.

He was still so young—he looked no older than thirty.

Was there still a way to save him? Mai Minghe didn't know.

Everything on this street was subtly urging her to open the door; if she truly opened it, whether Lisidan could be rescued was uncertain, but she herself would almost certainly be lost in the process.

"You... if you're still alive, hold on a little longer. Wait for me," Mai Minghe said in a low, breathy voice. "Wait until I figure out what opening the door will mean... there might be a loophole."

There might be a way.

She took a deep breath and tried to sort through her thoughts.

The rules poster said not to enter the "Tourist Information Center"—what it likely meant was not to enter the *real* Tourist Information Center, just like the rule about not turning your back to the Tourist Information Center door.

If the door you were turning your back on wasn't the real information center's door, nothing would happen—she and Aimeli had both personally confirmed this just moments ago.

Lisidan had entered the number 07 information center and something had gone wrong... could this, in reverse, indicate that the number 07 information center was the real one?

No—there was another possibility.

The number 07 Tourist Information Center might equally not be the real one, yet it had still trapped Lisidan—or perhaps already killed him—precisely to make others mistake it for the real one, and thereby open its door.

After all, the rules only said you couldn't go in; they said nothing about not opening the door. Never mind rescuing someone—even if you were only looking for clues inside a Tourist Information Center, opening the door versus not opening it made a world of difference, even if you didn't step inside.

Every door on this street was doing everything it could to make people open it.

What would happen after these doors were opened? What might come out?

Mai Minghe couldn't sort out a clear answer, yet that nameless, inexplicable sense of wrongness kept floating up, impossible to press back down.

Perhaps it was precisely because her mind was in such a tangle that it wasn't until several minutes later that Mai Minghe suddenly realized the street had grown far too quiet... quiet in a way that felt off.

Something that should have happened hadn't happened.

She slowly raised her head. At the far end of the street, Aimeli was still crouched in place, neck twisted, motionless, staring at the same crack.

If anything was different, it was that Aimeli had pushed one arm into the crack—the dark fissure had swallowed her all the way up to the shoulder.

She hadn't stood up just now, hadn't asked any questions, let alone walked over to check—and the street wasn't even long; yet Lisidan's howling seemed not to have reached her ears at all.

Aimeli's hair hung loose over her blue hoodie, the black lengths rippling and winding their way across the fabric and the hood, tumbling down her back.

...Something was different.

Something was wrong.

Mai Minghe stood in place and thought for a few seconds, then walked as quietly as she could back toward the far end of the street—toward the intersection.

Lisidan had his back against the glass door of number 07, the back of his head knocking against the glass again and again, muttering incoherently to himself: "What do I do? There's no back door here, no ventilation ducts, not a single window that can be smashed open. I want to get out so badly... let me think... oh, if only I could turn myself into liquid, I could flow out through the gap under the door—and actually, I've always thought the structure of the human body is unreasonable, so maybe that's the way to go—wait."

Mai Minghe didn't dare even breathe loudly; she only stole a quiet glance at his back.

At least for now, the back of him still looked like a person.

"Wait... what am I saying... humans can't turn into liquid... my name is Lisidan, I am a human, a Hunter, I live in Quinn District, Blackmoor City..."

Mai Minghe quickened her pace and walked past the number 07 Tourist Information Center.

She had to figure out what was going on with the "Tourist Information Centers" on this street—before it was all too late.

She passed the wall crack again, with its entire room flipped upside down inside (the sound was gone), passed the poster with Aimeli on it, and walked all the way to the intersection, where she carefully crossed to the middle of the road, craning her neck to get as good a look at Aimeli as she could.

The next second, Aimeli suddenly turned her head toward Mai Minghe.

Mai Minghe instinctively jumped back a step.

"What's wrong with you?" Aimeli raised one eyebrow; beyond that, her face was as expressionless as ever. "Were you looking at me?"

Her features, her voice, her tone and expression—all exactly the same as before.

...Including the ponytail pulled tightly against her scalp; the light-brown hair lay smooth and flat against her head, not a single strand out of place.

"I... I wanted to see what you'd found." Mai Minghe's throat was dry.

Aimeli slowly drew her hand back out of the deep black crack, inch by inch—for a moment, Mai Minghe almost expected her to keep pulling and pulling, her arm endless, her wrist never coming into view.

Fortunately, that turned out to be her own paranoia.

Aimeli withdrew her hand; in it was a phone. She glanced at the screen before looking up. "I wanted to see what's going on inside."

"You just... just stuck your hand in there?"

"The rules didn't say you can't put your hand in, did they?" Aimeli shrugged. "I felt like there was some movement inside the crack, but I couldn't see clearly, so I put my phone in and recorded a video."

...Wait, the phone could record video?

Reed Hydes had been thorough about nearly everything, but she hadn't taught Mai Minghe how to record video—wait, that wasn't the point.

Three questions—"What did you record," "Didn't you hear Lisidan screaming," and "What's going on with your back"—all jostled to climb out of Mai Minghe's throat at once, and ended up jamming each other in her windpipe, not one of them making it out.

Aimeli lit up the phone screen. "Look."

Mai Minghe was still standing in the middle of the road, still far away; she paused, gathered her nerve, and stepped closer—stopping when she was still four or five paces from Aimeli.

The screen was pitch-dark, but she could just barely make out that both walls of the crack were very smooth. Deep in the dimness, some shadow rustled and shifted suddenly.

"Who—who's there?"

A small voice came from deep within the crack, captured by the phone and played back out. The voice was completely unfamiliar, saturated with terror.

Aimeli seemed startled too. "Huh? When I was recording, I didn't hear a thing."

"When you were recording, you didn't hear *anything*? Not just this voice—on this street—"

Before Mai Minghe could finish, that small voice sounded from the phone again.

"I'm a Hunter. The Nest got me. Where am I? Can anyone save me? I need to keep looking for the rules, I need to keep looking for the rules... but the rules on this street are just not fair at all, so strange—"

The next moment, Aimeli's voice came out of the phone: "What's wrong with you? Were you looking at me?"

Immediately after, the dimness on the screen swayed and gradually brightened—the phone was being pulled out of the crack.

"It mentioned the rules, didn't it?"

Aimeli glanced at Mai Minghe, then tapped the phone. "I'll keep recording and see what else it says. If I'd known the recording picked up sound, I wouldn't have taken the phone out." She pressed record again.

It almost seemed like a mild reproach that Mai Minghe had come at the wrong moment.

...She seemed completely normal. Surely she hadn't just been seeing things?

Mai Minghe wasn't sure what she'd said herself—she seemed to have murmured something about going to check on something else, and drifted away from Aimeli's side—after all, the first rule was that you couldn't travel with someone you knew, and she didn't dare stay too close to Aimeli.

Once she was back on the other side of the road, she turned for another look.

Aimeli's black hair had grown longer, winding and curling down her back like vines.

...She couldn't shake the feeling that the longer time went on, the more things would spiral into something irreversible.

Whether it was the location of Annie Warehouse or the lives of these two young people—Mai Minghe wanted both, wanted to hold onto both. Was she being too greedy?

This time, her steps were urgent and her gaze swept quickly in wide circles—not only over the warped and distorted "Tourist Information Centers," but across the road, the sky, and the power

lines too—though she couldn't quite have said, even to herself, what exactly she was looking for.

It was only when she found it that she realized this had been her target all along.

A yellow rules poster, its top half torn away, had been crumpled into a ball and stuffed carelessly on top of an already overflowing trash can; the character "𠃊" peeking out from one corner snagged Mai Minghe's attention at once.

When spread flat again, the torn edge of the poster aligned exactly with the half-poster in the phone photo—however, the very bottom portion of the crumpled poster had also been torn away.

So a single rules poster had been torn into at least three pieces, scattered and hidden separately?

No wonder that voice had said it wasn't fair.

3. If you see someone you recognize appear in a theatrical performance (or on a show poster)—no, you do not recognize him/her/it.

4. You may sometimes receive a distress call from within a Tourist Information Center.

Do not act on your own. Ask him/her/it: "Have you called the police?"

If the other party answers, "I've already called the police," leave immediately.

If the other party gives any answer other than "I've already called the police," do not trust that the next action he/she/it asks you to take is harmless.

5. Always follow the rules on this warning poster. Do not trust any other code of conduct.

Mai Minghe had been about to take this rules poster to show Aimeli, then ask Lisidan whether he had called the police—she felt this might be a way to test whether he was still alive—but she didn't move.

That feeling of wrongness was growing stronger and stronger, more and more impossible to ignore... especially after seeing this second piece of the poster.

If she didn't get to the bottom of it quickly, she was liable to make a very serious mistake.

I've decided to take New Year's Eve off, and I haven't made up my mind yet about New Year's Day—it depends on how tired I am the day before.

Taking advantage of the holiday, I'm planning to make a huuuuuuuge pile of dumplings and try to eat my way through to September lol.

Everyone is welcome to share your New Year's Eve dinner—I absolutely will not be looking at it.

Chapter 243: Mai Minghe Splits the Rules Poster

If anyone had glanced down the street toward the Tourist Information Center at that moment, they probably would have thought that all three Hunters out there were just about done for.

The silhouette visible through the glass door still appeared calm, still looked human—you'd have to lean in close to catch that thin, murmuring voice: "...My name is Li Lilililili, Lisidan Lisili humans are in the second row from the right, top shelf of the lockers, I live inside the cavity in the second molar on the right side of Miss Smithers' mouth, the history teacher at Rose Hill High School in Blackmoor City's Quinn District..."

Aimeli remained with her head twisted to the side, facing the wall and the cracks in it, the back of her skull turned toward the street. Her black hair slowly crept downward, spilling across the pavement; beneath the black hair were two bare legs curled against the ground, the skin dry and cracked, toenails yellowed and thick and long, twisted, hooked against the surface.

One hand still gripping her phone had sunk deep into the black crevice, all the way up to the shoulder; as though numbed into emptiness, Aimeli did not move at all—as long as no one disturbed her, it seemed she could stay crouched there forever.

Mai Minghe had been still for a good while now as well. Head bowed, one hand holding the yellow warning poster, the other holding the photo of it, she had become a standing statue.

The strange, jarring sense of incongruity—without question—came from somewhere between these rules.

Mai Minghe's gaze returned to the photo on her phone.

2. Resist the temptation of the "Tourist Information Center."

You must calmly say no to the "Tourist Information Center."

Do not accept the program list it offers you, do not look at the program list it offers you, do not let it direct you, no matter what beautiful memories it promises—do not purchase souvenirs, do not carefully compare the differences between each "Tourist Information Center," do not walk inside, do not turn your back to its door—

...Wait.

Mai Minghe stared at that passage, unsure how she could have been so slow to notice—only now did she catch the contradiction between these words and her actual experience.

The contradiction had been right in front of her the whole time, plain as day...why was there such a tremendous gap between the rules and reality?

In that case, Rule Five—"Always follow the rules on this warning poster; do not trust any other guidelines"—clearly implied the existence of other rules nearby. Where were they? Why hadn't she seen any?

The more Mai Minghe thought about it, the more it seemed her suspicion was heading in the right direction; but it was still only a guess, and to confirm it, she would have to find the third torn-away poster.

She raised her head and first checked the sky.

The sky remained a heavy, leaden gray—like the face of someone utterly exhausted.

Mai Minghe looked around.

Not long ago, when she had first encountered Aimeli, the first thing she'd spotted was the fluorescent orange lanyard tag on Aimeli's chest; she could still remember the feeling in that moment—as though, across the entire world, that single bright spot of color was all there was.

Looking more carefully now...it hadn't been her imagination.

Everything around her was just as dim and weary as the sky. Even where there was color—the red brick, the brass plaques, the green trash bins, the posters in the windows—it was as if a thick layer of grime had settled over it all, requiring careful scrutiny before you could tell what color it was supposed to be.

But the warning poster with the rules printed on it was an exception.

Because the warning poster was brand new—the half still stuck to the power distribution box was perfectly flat, untouched by a single trace of weather. Even the crumpled piece in her hand, though wadded into a ball, was still a vivid, bright yellow...

On the dim, gray street, she had seen that vivid yellow three times.

The half-poster on the distribution box, the crumpled poster she'd pulled from the trash bin, and one more time—she had seen that yellow one more time—

Where was it?

When Mai Minghe snapped her head up, she could have sworn she heard her own neck vertebrae crack.

She remembered.

Mai Minghe spun around and charged back the way she had come, leaving both Lisidan and Aimeli behind; she strode at a run to the intersection, rounded the corner sharply, and stopped dead.

In front of Tourist Information Center number 17, an old woman swathed in a tattered cloth robe and hunched into a crouch was squatting on the ground, both hands pressed hard over her mouth to smother her laughter, shoulders still heaving in spasms; beneath the sparse salt-and-pepper eyebrows, her eyes were two curved black slits.

"...Contestant Mai Minghe,"

From beneath those hands—skin loose and wrinkled and covered in liver spots—came a muffled voice. With each word, the old woman shuffled one step closer to Mai Minghe, until at last a laugh escaped.

"Long wait, long wait long wait long wait thank goodness they kept you here so long it finally let me find you come come come we old sisters need to talk talk talk talk talk—"

With every syllable, it shuffled forward one step; as the words began to spray out in a torrent, the old woman's crouched legs and feet spun so fast they blurred into a smear, like some enormous spider, and in the blink of an eye it had lunged close to Mai Minghe.

Before she turned and fled, Mai Minghe still did not forget to sweep one glance through the display window of Tourist Information Center number 17.

Of the three theater posters standing side by side, the one in the middle showed a tiny figure surrounded by a crowd, holding a yellow slip of paper high overhead.

The third rules poster was hidden inside the poster.

But she had no time to read the text on that last poster—how was she supposed to fire this thing? Was this how the safety was released? Then you just aimed and pulled the trigger?

Mai Minghe ran while fumbling with the handgun, panicked and frantic, nearly dropping it on the ground.

The old woman moved in a squat along the ground, yet was far faster than she was; before Mai Minghe had worked out how to fire, it had already shot past her and cut off her path ahead.

The old woman crouched in the road ahead, and her hands slowly drew apart from her face.

"Now that we know each other know each other know each other keeping my hands over my mouth would just be rude so let me show you my face"

The first bullet she fired seemed to have a deep respect for the old woman's personal space—it didn't so much as graze her, sailing wide over her head and into empty air.

Mai Minghe hadn't expected it: for such a seemingly small handgun, the recoil was not to be underestimated—it was as if someone had suddenly slammed a hammer into her shoulder, nearly knocking the gun clean out of her hand.

Her hand was shaking badly, but she didn't dare slow down for a moment; she re-aimed at the old woman's head and fired several shots in rapid succession—bang, bang, bang.

The moment the old woman's hands finally came fully apart from her face, one bullet struck squarely in the center of its forehead.

At that range, the bullet hit with tremendous force, snapping its head backward and folding its neck and body into a ninety-degree angle.

...She hadn't seen it. She hadn't seen it.

For a moment, that was the only thought left in Mai Minghe's mind.

She hadn't seen the old woman's face—and since it wanted her to look, she absolutely could not see the old woman's face—

Residents cannot be killed by bullets.

When the old woman's neck slowly straightened back up from its ninety-degree angle, Mai Minghe grabbed her supply bag, which had, miraculously, remained hanging on her shoulder.

She yanked the zipper open, not bothering with the things that tumbled out, and with one swing of her arm she threw the entire supply bag over the old woman's head like a hood, then turned and ran, charging back toward Tourist Information Center number 17.

It wasn't like it had no hands—wouldn't it just brush the bag off its head in an instant?

Mai Minghe cursed herself silently for having no better plan while praying that the old woman would be delayed for as long as possible; she screeched to a halt in front of the display window and, though she had no idea how much time she had, immediately pressed herself against the glass and squinted—the poster-within-a-poster had ragged edges, and sure enough, it looked to fit together with the second rules poster perfectly.

What did it say?

She cupped a hand beside her eye to block out the sky's light and strained her vision to its limit; at last she could just make out the text on the poster.

Effective date of this police advisory:

Starting December 1, 2026

Every curse word Mai Minghe had ever learned in her life flashed through her mind.

Today was November 24, 2026—meaning every single rule she had found so far hadn't even taken effect yet?

What kind of hellish joke was this?

To avoid breaking the rules, she and Aimeli had walked far apart from each other, had refrained from going directly into the Tourist Information Center to search for a map—if she'd known the rules weren't in effect, would Aimeli have still been caught? Would they have wasted so much time in the area?

If not for Mai Minghe being there, the others might never have had to go through any of this at all.

No wonder it contradicted their real experience...where were the true rules?

Perhaps, as that old woman had said, there was something else nearby doing everything it could to muddy the waters—

The old woman.

When Mai Minghe straightened up from the glass, the reflection in it was no longer hers alone.

The old woman, hands still pressed to her mouth, crawled around the corner in her squat—could you still call it walking, squatting like that? Should it be called crawling?—it made its way to

the display window and stopped a step or two behind Mai Minghe; then its legs began to slowly unbend, rising, straightening, as it gradually stood upright.

"Turn. Around."

The old woman's arms had long since dropped from its face, hanging to the ground like lengths of electrical cord, spread into a half-circle that had enclosed Mai Minghe neatly at the center.

"Let's. Talk."

Knowing full well she must not look, Mai Minghe still felt an indescribable urge rising in her to lift her eyes and look at the old woman's face in the reflection—perhaps the way a person standing at the edge of a cliff feels a dark undercurrent of impulse, wanting to jump even when they have no wish to die.

She suppressed the urge by force and fixed her gaze on another corner of the display window.

The old woman drew closer—one step, another step, and another.

It stood behind Mai Minghe, right up against her.

"Let me help you twist your head one hundred and eighty degrees. Then we old sisters can have a good long chat chat chat chat chat chat."

When its hands closed around Mai Minghe's neck, whether from the actual pressure or from terror, her voice came out pressed thin, squeezed through a narrow crack.

"Placard Worker!" she called, eyes shut, her voice trembling: "The rules here are broken—Placard Worker, come out!"

It's not quite the holidays yet, but with the new year approaching I've got no heart for work / writing, and today I just want to play games... I'm taking January 28th off for Spring Festival! Apparently there's no New Year's Eve this year! When that day comes I can post a Resident get-together chatting chapter, everyone come hang out (。

Some of you asked what good books I've been reading lately—the best novel I've read so far in January is called *My Best Friend's Exorcism*. How to put it—the whole story is right there in the title, but it's truly a great read: a warm and touching coming-of-age story about girlhood friendship. It's not scary at all; the author writes the feelings and emotional journey of a girl growing up with remarkable delicacy, and the friendship between the girls is deeply moving—I

found myself marveling again and again that only a woman writer could do this, it just feels so right.

After I finished it (I shed a few tears), I turned, still wanting more, to look at the author bio...

Male author!? A man?!

Chapter 244: Mai Minghe Follows the Map to Find the Nest's Secrets

The Nest's adherence to common sense is like that thing hiding in the darkness of your wardrobe, pretending to be human.

Even though both you and it know it isn't human—no person would crouch in the shadowed corner of a wardrobe, slowly dropping their jaw as the black holes on its face stretched longer and longer—yet the moment your eyes meet, it still mimics human habit and greets you: "Good evening. Off work already?"

In other words, the Nest's adherence to common sense is exactly that: persistent, yet inexplicable.

Take the Placard Worker, for instance.

According to the Nest knowledge stored in Mai Minghe's mind, the Nest clearly considered the existence of this type of Resident to be a matter of course:

Of course there have to be Placard Workers!

In traps or scenarios without a Resident overseeing things, don't the rules have to be written out, printed, posted on walls, projected on screens, broadcast on monitors... so that those nauseating, self-righteous humans—who'd be better off dead—can see them?

So naturally there must be Residents who go ahead of time to post the rules, or swap out the old ones, clean up the dismembered remains and blood left behind by previous players, wipe away the hints they left, optimize the traps, reduce the odds of escape... isn't that just obvious?

So of course there are Caretaker Residents—also called Placard Workers.

As for how the paper rules get printed in the first place?

That's simple enough too.

Residents can't manufacture printers themselves, but when the Nest is born, expands, and updates, certain buildings inside naturally come equipped with printers.

Think of it this way: we're like the snake and the apple born into the Garden of Eden—everything within the garden is there to be used. Easier to understand now, isn't it?

Mai Minghe did not find that analogy easier to understand at all.

But the most critical piece of information had finally surfaced in her mind just now, as she desperately read poster after poster.

Placard Workers—also called Caretaker Residents—could be summoned.

Particularly where paper rules were concerned: paper could suffer all manner of accidents or damage, and under the premise that the Nest "endeavored" to guarantee fairness, Hunters had the right to know what the true rules governing them actually were.

Not that, in the real world, many places could claim the same.

In short, under such circumstances, a Hunter could summon a Placard Worker to provide them with the correct rules again—though of course, if the Hunter in question had no idea that "Caretaker Residents" even existed, that was hardly the Nest's fault.

Another consideration rooted equally in fairness: when a Placard Worker was reorganizing and providing the rules, the Hunter should not continue to be attacked.

Even if someone were half-swallowed by quicksand, as long as the Placard Worker was required to "tidy up the premises," the Hunter had to stop sinking—though whether that default protection still applied to Mai Minghe, the primary kill target of who-knew-how-many Residents, was another question entirely.

"Pla..."

Mai Minghe could barely get the word out.

She had just twisted her arm around and emptied the last bullets in her gun into the old woman's body, but the crushing grip at her throat hadn't loosened in the slightest—let alone left any room for escape.

Why hadn't the Placard Worker appeared yet?

Should she call for the Caretaker Resident instead?

Red shadows had begun to pulse at the edges of her vision, like capillaries bursting one by one, slowly staining her eyes with blood.

Mai Minghe could barely still see her own reflection in the glass: her neck was squeezed grotesquely thin, the part protruding from the old woman's grip no wider than a bubble tea straw.

Her windpipe, trachea, and neck bones should have shattered long ago... yet she was still alive, her neck still intact.

The old woman's method of killing didn't seem to involve destroying the target's body—instead, by twisting and warping a person's physiology and psychology together, the person would be as good as dead even without dying.

"Care... Caretaker..." Mai Minghe's voice was barely breath shaped into words: "Come out... the rules are wrong..."

"Hah."

An unfamiliar voice suddenly rang out from the sidewalk around the corner.

It was the Caretaker Resident—without a doubt.

The moment you heard its voice, you immediately thought of a real-world "caretaker"—its voice sounded like a heavy ring of keys hanging at someone's hip, jangling and knocking together with every step.

"What do you want with me?"

Threaded through its words you could even hear the wet slap of a mop sweeping across a tile floor; its breathing was the low hum of electrical current running through a light bulb.

"These rules you saw—they haven't taken effect yet, but they do have an effective date written on them. You didn't see it. How can you call that unfair?"

The Caretaker Resident had clearly appeared, yet the old woman still hadn't released her grip.

"There's... there's no... real... rules..."

"Who says?" The Caretaker Resident let out a snort through its nose—like a hammer striking a nail squarely on the head. "The real set of rules is right nearby. You've probably walked past it several times already."

What was it talking about? What other written explanation could be nearby?

Could it be not in writing—something like a broadcast instead?

But there was nothing like that either—why wasn't the old woman letting go???

"As long as the 'true rules' exist and their content is accurate, calling for me does nothing—I have nothing else I can do, and I don't want to do anything anyway."

???????

Meaning there actually were things it could still do, but as a Resident on the other side, the Caretaker wanted to kill Mai Minghe—no, wanted to kill me???

"You can't even find the true rules and yet you're called the most promising candidate for the Domination Game that's hilarious you've become this unstable already I can see all the question marks piling up in your head being unstable won't help you there's nothing I can do about the other Resi—"

The voice from around the corner cut off abruptly.

The Caretaker Resident vanished mid-sentence.

What happened???? What did it mean it can't do anything about the other Residents!!!! Wait wait wait, I think I understand!!!! Is it—aaaaaargh suffocating, I want to kill the old woman why is it forbidden to kill Residents aaaaah!!! No, no, back to what it just said—

The voice that belonged to Mai Minghe had become like a wild beast hurling itself against a cage—the slightest stimulus sent it into a frenzy inside her skull.

She forced herself not to think about how much time she had left as her body slowly warped.

It must be other Residents who tampered with things!!

Mai Minghe forced herself to stay calm—it had to be other Residents who tampered with things.

There were other Residents nearby, but why hadn't that Resident come at Mai Minghe directly—why instead "hold" her in place, waiting for the old woman to arrive?

Residents didn't necessarily have killing ability... some could mimic humans and shapeshift, some were skilled at feeding false information, some could transform an entire area into a trap.

The Resident that had concealed the true rules: one, was right nearby; two, had no ability to attack directly.

Mai Minghe's consciousness was approaching blankness.

Not on the verge of passing out—more like the old woman was drilling into her skull.

By the time she finally noticed that something was very wrong with her reflection in the glass, her hands were pressed tightly over her face, and in her ears came her own "pfft-pfft-pfft" laughter.

Mai Minghe slammed her hands down hard and choked back the laugh.

Think carefully... think carefully... the one time a Resident had truly appeared when she was nearby—

Aimeli's voice surfaced in her mind without warning.

"...I wasn't lying. There really was a Resident behind you just now, but the moment you turned around, it vanished somewhere."

When she had turned back, the street behind her had been completely empty.

Wait—behind her—behind her—

Mai Minghe laughed "pfft-pfft" to herself while desperately reaching behind her back with both hands and clawing around wildly, but grabbed nothing.

No, that couldn't be right—if that Resident had been on her back, Aimeli would have seen it when she turned around; Aimeli wasn't blind—wait.

The laughter in Mai Minghe's mouth stopped.

The Nest knowledge poured into her mind was a bit like the search engine Reed Hydes had shown her: without a keyword to trigger it, her thoughts could only drift aimlessly through a sea of information; but once a keyword appeared, the corresponding Nest knowledge would surface.

Before setting out, when everyone had looked each other over carefully, the focus had been on the front—the natural, instinctive bias of human thinking.

Even now, if Mai Minghe tried to recall the backs of heads and the backs of the other candidate Hunters, she couldn't be confident she'd remember them with full accuracy.

In other words, when she had turned around, what Aimeli saw as "Mai Minghe's back" was very possibly not her back at all.

Aimeli had assumed the Resident had "vanished somewhere"—but the answer was simple: it was still on Mai Minghe's back. Like a dead-leaf butterfly mimicking a dead leaf, this was a Resident that could disguise itself as a human's back—and Mai Minghe had seen it not long ago.

It had two habits:

One: it pressed flat against a person's back and flawlessly mimicked the back of the head, behind the ears, the neck, the shoulders, the back... all the way down to the heels.

Of course, it could also choose to reveal its true appearance—letting vine-like black hair slowly cascade down along the street, letting thick yellowed toenails twist and extend outward—or it could disguise only part of itself.

After all, Residents were flexible things.

Two: it could jump from one person to another. As long as B saw the "Back-Drifter" on A's back, it would naturally transfer itself onto B's back.

The Back-Drifter had already jumped onto Aimeli.

It had chosen not to disguise itself, so that once Mai Minghe saw it, she hadn't dared take a single step closer to Aimeli... but why?

Was it because the true rules had been on Aimeli's back all along?

If that were the case...

Mai Minghe listened to her own laughter smothered beneath her palm and thought—had she figured it out too late???

Vacation is almost here, yay yay yay yay

Who's a happy Resident, I'm a happy Resident

Saturday night gathering: Nest Poker Night

(As more and more Residents appear in the main story, the thank-you chapters have more and more supporting characters too—today we have enough for a full poker table.)

(As for why Hunter characters have gradually faded out of the thank-you chapters, it might be a case of bad money driving out good...)

(Today's thank-you list covers the generous patrons who tipped between 1/11 – 1/25. I've caught up again, hahaha.)

"New Year's coming," the Dream Playwright said the moment he opened the door: "Could you at least look a little festive?"

The Caretaker Resident stood at the doorway, carrying a wildly struggling and cursing Sydney Ginn, and paused for a moment.

"Didn't January first pass ages ago?"

"That's the Gregorian New Year—I'm talking about the Lunar New Year," the Dream Playwright's blank face was full of displeasure. "Have you forgotten which country our sponsors come from?"

"Oh, right. Strange, why didn't they sponsor the BJ Nest? BJ meets the conditions for a Nest too, doesn't it?"

"Who knows, maybe the BJ Nest couldn't pass review and got shut down."

"So how am I supposed to look more festive?" The Caretaker Resident's eyes turned toward the Dream Playwright's outfit. "Why are you dressed so eye-wateringly?"

"What do you know—for New Year's you have to wear red, that's what festive means."

"Such fuss," it tossed Sydney Ginn into the room and said, "I'll be back in a moment."

Sydney Ginn cried out in pain while scrambling up from the floor in a disheveled heap; the Dream Playwright was about to close the door when a sudden flash of inspiration struck him, and he barked furiously: "Get back here! Don't go off and get yourself covered in human blood! That is not festive!"

The Resident said "oh" and came back inside: "Sheesh, why didn't you just say so."

"You kidnap me every Saturday!" Sydney Ginn glared at them both. "The sponsors were all poached by your Nest—if you've got the nerve, go thank them yourselves. Why do you always drag me into it?"

The Dream Playwright pulled out a chair for her: "Cards. Drinks, alcohol, and snacks on the house."

She was quiet for a moment.

"...Ahem, why didn't you say so earlier."

Sydney Ginn slid smoothly into the chair. "I actually enjoy playing cards... What are we playing? What are the stakes? No thank-you?"

"Today's deck is a bit special," the Dream Playwright smiled — no mouth, but it could still smile, don't worry about how — "It's called Granny Cards. We're playing Dou Di Zhu with Granny Cards today."

"Granny Cards..."

"Let me give you a quick introduction first. The specifics, you'll pick up as you play."

Big Joker: Under-the-West-Wood-Named-Chestnut (the back of the card is blank — Granny, please fill in whose bonus chapter you'd like to see in the blank space: ____)

Little Joker: Added Leisure (the bearer need not go to work, blessed with abundant free time; unanimously recommended by all cards to be Little Joker)

Below the Little Joker: Iron-Armored Baitang (clad head-to-toe in iron armor, hurts whoever she hits, rose to power by force)

Next up: prprprQBB (inexplicably carries the scent of grilled meat; a magical attack capable of distracting other cards)

Then: I-Am-Ayun's-Doll-Wuwuwuwuwu and The-Duck-Duck-Duck-Duck-Duck-Pulling-An-All-Nighter

(Pay attention! These two cards are peculiar, because they both stutter — no wait, because they both have repeated characters, they can be paired together, and when paired, they form a Bomb.)

When played as singles: if cards are played at night, All-Nighter Duck has home-field advantage and beats Cloud Doll. During the day, Cloud Doll beats All-Nighter Duck — unless there are dolls nearby, or clouds visible through a window. When either of these conditions is met, Cloud Doll will be overwhelmed by its own weeping and become the lowest card in the deck.)

The next tier of cards: Chrysvielle

Then: Non-Edible Kitty Gummies

At this point, the Resident's patience ran out.

"Just remember, all the remaining cards rank below everything introduced above. Let's just play — honestly, even if I explain more, you won't remember it. First round is the tutorial; you'll get the hang of it as you go, thanks to the mystical power of the Nest."

The shuffling and dealing wrapped up quickly. On the question of who would be the Landlord, two pairs of eyes and one blank face regarded each other for a moment, before it was finally decided that the Dream Playwright would take the role.

"The two of you need to work together to beat me — don't let me empty my hand first." The Dream Playwright studied its cards for a moment, then cautiously played a single numbered card:

"Reader20231210205514636."

What a remarkable numbered card — the moment it hit the table, it turned invisible, and you couldn't tell at all who it was anymore.

"What card beats yours?" Sydney Ginn's eyes swept over the cards.

"Four digits equal one character, so Reader20231210205514636 counts as 6 characters plus 6, meaning you need to play a card with at least 7 characters."

Sydney Ginn looked at her hand, then suddenly let out a "ha," and played a card: "That Girl Is Called Xiaomei! Exactly seven characters."

The Caretaker Resident froze for a moment: "Who's called Xiaomei? What girl — oh, right, it's a card."

"So there really is one," said the Dream Playwright without a trace of fear, seemingly holding something in reserve. "Caretaker's turn."

The Caretaker Resident grinned smugly and, without a word, gently set down a card: Always Stand on the Side of the Egg.

"Nine characters," it said with concern. "Can you handle that?"

"The principles and spirit of this card make my whole body uncomfortable," the Dream Playwright muttered. "Hmm, maybe I should dress up as an egg next time..."

"Come on, hurry up," Sydney Ginn urged.

The Dream Playwright, full of confidence, slammed a card onto the table: Ishgard-Red-Robe-Doll-Tomato.

"Ten characters?" Sydney Ginn sighed. "Long names are free now, are they?"

"Anyone want some?" the Dream Playwright looked around.

"Non-Edible Kitty Gummies!" Sydney Ginn played fast. "This card beats everything that wasn't introduced earlier, right? What a shame — I was kind of hoping to keep it and take a little nibble."

The Caretaker Resident nodded and quietly played a Chrysvielle.

That was already the 7th-ranked single card. The table fell quiet for a moment. The Dream Playwright steeled itself, determined to take back control, and played with grim resolve: "Iron-

Armored Baitang!"

"Ooh, brutal — the third most powerful card, and it's in your hand. Not bad." Sydney Ginn and the Caretaker Resident both shook their heads. "Pass. We'll wait and see."

The Dream Playwright let out a smug laugh and this time laid down five cards in a row: "Mia-Ao, Catch-a-Kitty-Cloud, Kittycutee! Three consecutive cat cards! Who can beat three cat cards? Three-with-two — and I'm adding a pair: Jupiter's-Quiet-Wolfberries and The-World's-Third-to-Last-Sea-Cucumber, a pair of food cards!"

Three cat cards with a pair of food cards wiped the smiles off Sydney Ginn and the Caretaker Resident's faces — and significantly thinned the Dream Playwright's hand.

Riding high, the Dream Playwright played just a single card this time: "Xun Shi."

It had only two cards left in its hand.

"What does this card even mean?" Sydney Ginn was baffled. "What beats it?"

"How would I know what it means? It's a Granny Card either way. More characters means higher rank."

Sydney Ginn hesitated, then played: "Sun-and-Moon-on-the-Grass."

"Oh, what a waste," said the Caretaker Resident, leaning over to peek, then pressing down a card. "I'll play Hu Miaomiao's Owner. See, these two cards of ours could actually form a pair of Acquaintance Cards — what a shame, they're split up."

The Dream Playwright, smiling, played prprprQBB — the fourth-highest card.

With that, the Landlord Dream Playwright had only one card left in its hand.

Sydney Ginn started to panic: "Bomb!"

I-Am-Ayun's-Doll-Wuwuwuwuwu and The-Duck-Duck-Duck-Duck-Duck-Pulling-An-All-Nighter fell onto the table, and the Dream Playwright's expression shifted — it could shift, don't worry about how.

The Caretaker Resident looked at Sydney Ginn with hopeful eyes. "We can't let the Landlord escape — it's got one card left. Play a pair."

Sydney Ginn took a deep breath. "Xiewudie, XingJiTui — this is a pair... a pair of..."

She thought hard for a long time, then said: "A pair of verb cards."

"Bullshit verb cards!" the Dream Playwright immediately protested. "Take them back! If you can't explain why they make a pair, they're singles!"

The Caretaker Resident let out a wail.

At this point: the Dream Playwright had one card, Sydney Ginn had two, and the Caretaker Resident had three.

Sydney Ginn asked, very reluctantly: "Can I forfeit my turn to play?"

"Of course not, are you kidding."

Sydney Ginn silently played the cryptic XingJiTui as a single.

The Caretaker Resident, expression heavy with grief, played the highest card in its hand: the Little Joker, Added Leisure.

The Dream Playwright let out a whoop, leapt up from its chair, and danced wildly around the table, like a dancing Xiewudie.

"Big Joker! Under-the-West-Wood-Named-Chestnut!"

It placed Under-the-West-Wood-Named-Chestnut reverently at the very center of the table, held up two empty hands and showed them back and forth, and laughed: "I got out! I win! Caretaker, what cards do you have left?"

The Caretaker Resident sighed. "I have one pair left... Ciel-Mo, wes — a pair of English-letter pair cards."

Granny Cards Dou Di Zhu Tutorial Round Complete

Those wishing to purchase a Granny Cards deck to bring home and enjoy with family and friends during the New Year, please click the purchase link below:

[NestTreasure] Fake ones get penalized with four Residents X "Tipping deadline 1.25 Granny Cards hahaha I've caught up again"

Writing this made me want to play a round of Dou Di Zhu myself! Currently short two players, and also short a deck of cards — in other words, I've got nothing.

Chapter 245: The Nest That Mai Minghe Loves

No one can save you, the old woman said.

Mai Minghe was sharing a narrow room with it.

The room had no doors or windows, and felt more like a solid, pitch-black hollow block of iron; how she had gotten inside, she had already forgotten.

The room was only tall enough for a crouching person; she crouched on the ground with the ceiling pressing heavily down on her head, leaving no space to straighten her neck.

The old woman pressed tightly against her, crouching at her side, behind her, in front of her. Mai Minghe was squeezed in the middle, forced to curl herself into the smallest possible bundle, arms wrapped around her shins.

No one can save you, the old woman said.

Besides Mai Minghe, the other two Hunter candidates had each been seized by a Resident and could not break free. Without even noticing, Aimeli had managed to attract two Residents targeting her at once—that was because Nest Residents were drawn to confident people.

Mai Minghe didn't know how she knew, but she knew:

Lisidan was struggling to keep his mind intact, yet his grip on his own mental faculties was crumbling further and further, growing harder and harder to maintain.

Every time he lost control, a corresponding body part would go haywire; if someone were to crouch down and peer into his ear at that moment, they would find an eyeball rolling about in frantic confusion deep inside the ear canal.

"I think I'm about done for... Maybe coming to the Key House Faction interview was a mistake."

Lisidan was muttering to himself in another world twenty meters away: "If I die in the Nest... someone has to write a description of what I look like before I die so I can crawl into it crawl into that description I can be resurrected from those words can I someone heard that someone saw that you have to write it down oh——"

Aimeli, from another perspective, might end up dying in a rather fortunate way.

She hadn't noticed that anything was wrong at all.

As far as she was aware, she had only just slipped her phone back into the gap moments ago, trying to record the voices coming from within; to avoid turning her back on the Tourist Information Center's entrance, she had cautiously only tilted her head to the side.

She believed she was still maintaining a high level of vigilance—the moment anything moved nearby, she would detect it immediately.

But nothing nearby moved.

The street was quiet and calm, with no anomalies, no danger.

And so Aimeli just kept on crouching and crouching and crouching and crouching, recording and recording and recording and recording.

All it would have taken was a single bullet to knock the Back-Drifter Resident off and snap Aimeli back to her senses—but there was no one nearby capable of doing it.

I heard that the other two Hunter candidates were lucky—they landed far enough away from you that they weren't dragged down by your situation, found clues early, and have both already headed to Annie Warehouse.

The old woman covered her eyes with both hands, revealing a mouth that could not be looked at.

From every angle at once, it spoke to Mai Minghe: only these two had the bad luck of running into you. Now all the others have gathered elsewhere, and there is not a single Hunter nearby who could save anyone.

Give up, the old woman said.

Let go of the hands clasped around your shins, and everything can end—it's going to end sooner or later anyway, let go of the hands clasped around your shins, so why endure a little longer, why suffer a little more, why keep holding onto your shins?

It's just like life—let go of the hands clasped around your shins, live for a few dozen years, and you'll die in the end no matter what, and 99% of people will be tormented by illness, dying in agony, let go of the hands clasped around your shins. So why force yourself through it? Give up sooner, and become a Resident in the Nest, let go of the hands clasped around your shins, free to

do whatever you please, at ease in your own body—what's wrong with that, let go of the hands clasped around your shins.

Mai Minghe held her shins in a death grip.

The only thing she seemed to feel with any clarity anymore was her own legs and feet.

A thousand-ton ceiling of cement pressed down on her head, forcing her neck down, her body coiled tight into the shape of a shrimp—yet even those sensations were not quite sharp; she couldn't feel her back muscles spasming, and her neck didn't ache.

Only her legs and feet, as though bearing an unimaginable weight, trembling, unsteady, still straining with everything they had——

Straining... straining to do what?

Mai Minghe jolted, and remembered.

She was walking along the road packed with Tourist Information Centers.

She didn't know when she had been thrown into this narrow stone cage; the moment she realized there was a Resident clinging to Aimeli's back, she also realized she had no way of freeing herself from the old woman.

It had locked onto Mai Minghe's throat, drilling bit by bit into her skull, and she was powerless against it—she couldn't even cry out for help or raise the alarm.

If she couldn't shake the old woman off, there was only one option left, wasn't there?

The most foolish option.

If she couldn't shake it off, she would just have to drag it along with her and move while she still could.

At the edge of her fading consciousness, Mai Minghe struggled forward, taking one step past the corner.

Then another.

Every step was long and grueling, as though she were reliving eighty-six years in the span of it.

The old woman had only seized her by the throat—her feet were still free, and even though each step cost her like it was eating away at her life, even though she felt as if she were hauling a

thousand-pound weight forward on her hands and knees, she could still move her feet—which meant there was still a sliver of possibility.

Ah, right—it seemed it was just as she finally rounded the corner that Mai Minghe found herself crouching inside the stone room.

The old woman pressed in on Mai Minghe from everywhere at once, and the stone room was thick with the smell of its open mouth.

Mai Minghe had thought it was saying "let go of the hands clasped around your shins," but listening carefully, she realized that beneath the surface sounds and words, another layer of language was concealed:

Give up. So tired... so tired you can't even keep your eyes open.

A person has to listen to their own heart, listen to their own body, at least once. You've already been gritting your teeth and fighting against life for so many years... so tired, you're truly exhausted to the bone...

The old woman's presence, the old woman's voice, the stone room pressing in around her—it all seemed to emanate from inside her own skull. It had already bored its way in; yet at the same time, it was still behind her, clamping Mai Minghe's throat in an iron grip.

Mai Minghe took another step.

Most people would probably have given up long ago, wouldn't they? She wanted so badly to give up too.

She truly didn't know what she was fighting so desperately for: to pass the interview and join Key House Faction? To steal back the lipstick and sell it to the Mayor? Then get the clue to the time Artifact and start her life over?

Such a long road, one step after another, no end in sight. How easy it would be to give up.

No—I don't want to reach the end either, Mai Minghe thought. I just need to take one more step.

Just one step, and then give up immediately.

She took one step forward.

One more step, just one, and then she could give up, and everything would be easier.

"Didn't I tell you to give up?"

The old woman's wail suddenly rang out, sharp and real, right beside her ear—this time it was no longer an echo in the skull-stone-room: "Haven't you just drifted along through your whole life? Have you forgotten? Eighty-six years wasted in a fog, and now you want to chase a goal? On what grounds? Because you're special?"

Mai Minghe opened her mouth, her lips parting and closing several times, but with her throat seized so tightly that not even a breath of air could pass, no sound came out—the fact that she could still walk forward at all was already a miracle.

"What?" the old woman's voice suddenly stopped short, and it asked.

...Hm?

Come to think of it, Residents had a way of making one realize, at the most unexpected moments, that they were things that had come from people—something left over in them that belonged to humanity, and compared to people, it seemed even more intense.

For instance: curiosity.

Mai Minghe's lips parted and closed twice more.

"What?" the old woman cried out as expected. "What could you possibly have to say at this point, what do you want to say, what, what, what, what, what—it's not like I'll change my mind, I won't strangle you if I'm curious—but what do you want to say, what is it?"

Aimeli was not far ahead now... Mai Minghe, as if in urgent haste, let her lips flutter rapidly several times.

"Are you begging for mercy? Pleading? Trying to negotiate?"

Mai Minghe, with enormous effort, forced a sound of denial out through her nose.

The old woman fell silent for a moment, during which she took another step.

"I'll loosen up just the tiniest little bit, all right—don't think I'm letting go. Go on then, what do you want to say? Let me hear it, so I can properly mock you."

Air and sound stirred back to life, slightly, from her throat and chest.

The old woman's curiosity had not granted Mai Minghe any chance of breaking free; she was still being crushed by the stone room, her consciousness still trapped within the old woman's

breath—the only difference was that she could now barely force out the faintest hoarse thread of voice, like the dying breath of a husband in the last days of throat cancer.

"Do you know why... I love... the Nest?"

The old woman was quiet for a few seconds. "You love the Nest? Even now? Even when you're being tormented half to death?"

"Mm... I do."

Mai Minghe said in a rasp, and took another step. The muscles and bones in her legs felt as though they might shatter and scatter at any moment, rolling off in all directions across the floor.

"The world... looks vast, but it's so cramped. So many invisible... walls. No—what look like walls... are actually people. What blocks you, what ties your hands and feet... it's people, and the tools people create. The paths left open... are very narrow, very narrow..."

She had already walked up behind Aimeli.

The old woman seemed capable of only targeting one part of the body at a time—if it switched from gripping her throat to gripping her legs in order to stop her from walking, then the deformation Mai Minghe had produced so far would all have been for nothing. You see, when someone drills their way into your mind, it isn't only that they come to influence you—you also come to understand them.

"So I had no choice but to drift along..."

"But... the Nest is different. The Nest has so many rules, so many Residents... yet what I do, what I can do... that's for me to decide... Fighting you is interesting too. More than before, it feels like actually living. I'd rather fight a hundred of you than be crushed half to death in the middle of the night by a mountain of... debt, crying..."

Mai Minghe drew the already-emptied pistol from her waist.

People born in her era were, generally speaking, more frugal and careful with their belongings.

Even an emptied pistol, she would never casually toss aside—that heavy, solid metal, that fine craftsmanship; how could you treat it like trash just because it had run out of bullets and throw it away?

Mai Minghe raised the pistol high and brought it down on the back of Aimeli's motionless head.

Because both hands were clamped around her throat, she couldn't even lower her head to look, and could only feel her way through it, striking again and again; whether the Back-Drifter Resident had jumped off, whether the real rule had fallen away, Mai Minghe couldn't see any of it.

Before the old woman tightened its grip again, she forced out one desperate shout: "Aimeli, tear up the rule, call a Placard Worker!"

Lately I've been on a lucky streak of finding one great horror novel after another!

This new one I just started is really interesting too—especially the way the author writes the protagonist, it's brilliant: that dishonesty, arrogance, self-obsession, chaos, and disregard for others makes you want to reach through the page and slap him.

But don't worry about getting too frustrated, because right from the opening of the book, you already know the protagonist ends up dead.

Chapter 246 — A Sliver of Hope Amid the Chaos of Mai Minghe

The Back-Drifter Resident's cry of pain rang out sharp and shrill, rebounding urgently through the stone chamber in Mai Minghe's mind and making her eardrums ache—"Back!"

"I want a back!"

With that shriek, a hurried shadow slid down Aimeli's back and lunged toward the blurry corner of Mai Minghe's vision, like an insect scrambling for its life the moment someone enters a room and flips on the light.

"Back back back back when I was little my dad carried me on his back the sunlight was warm and gentle on my back lying on a back you could see so far you could see a safe and steady life stretching out ahead back back I want—"

That string of words was like a chain of neurons detonating inside a brain; as the bioelectric sparks extinguished one by one, the voice vanished along with the Back-Drifter Resident in an instant, without a trace.

Rules... rules... Aimeli...

Mai Minghe was clearly standing on the sidewalk with an old woman clinging to her throat from behind, yet at the same time she felt as though she were crouching inside the stone chamber, the stone ceiling pressing down so low she couldn't lift her head, her body reduced to nothing but sensation in her legs and feet.

So even though her head was physically held high up in the air, she still felt as if she had to strain to roll her eyes upward, looking up, just to barely make out the lower half of Aimeli's body.

"Hurry..."

The old woman bore down harder again, squeezing Mai Minghe's voice back into a ghost's whisper. "Tear it up... the true rules..."

"Wha—what's going on?"

Aimeli was murmuring incoherently, "Did I get hit...? The true rules... where are they?"

Right there on the ground, wasn't it? When the Back-Drifter Resident fled, it had dropped a folded piece of paper, already crumpled and creased—

"I can't see anymore—why can't I see? I can't feel my face—"

Her voice was frantic and helpless, and so was her hand—but only one hand, her right hand, groping blindly behind her.

...Where was her left hand?

Mai Minghe was in no state to think or reason clearly right now, and yet she still had to wrestle against the old woman's grip, fighting for the last scraps of her dwindling consciousness.

Could it be that Aimeli's left hand was still clutching the phone, wedged deep in the gap between the windows?

The old woman had indeed said that Aimeli had attracted two Residents.

Her back was back to normal now, yet she was still crouched on the ground.

As she looked left and right, her light-brown ponytail swung sharply a few times behind her head, but she never turned around—Aimeli's right hand was still groping and flailing along the ground in reverse: "Right, if I find the true rules, maybe I have a chance of getting back to normal..."

...She seemed to have not heard a word of Mai Minghe's instruction to tear up the rules.

Mai Minghe blanked for a moment before realizing that Aimeli hadn't heard her—which was entirely understandable.

Because her own mouth was producing two sounds at once.

One was the faint, barely-there instruction that Mai Minghe had forced out with every ounce of effort; the other was the old woman's loud, uncontrollable, fitful laughter.

If anything, the remarkable thing was that Aimeli, beneath all that laughter, had managed to catch the four words "true rules" at all.

In other words, she couldn't count on Aimeli.

When Aimeli's fingertips brushed across the scrap of paper several times and finally caught one corner of it, Mai Minghe clenched her teeth and forced herself to lurch one more step forward—she brought her foot down squarely on the paper just as Aimeli grabbed it and yanked, and with a tearing sound, the paper split apart.

"Caretaker..."

"What a nuisance," said a voice, cold and sudden, like a ring of keys clanging together.

"You've only torn it in two—it's still readable. Can't you just line the pieces back up yourselves?"

"What?" Aimeli startled. "Who are you?"

Mai Minghe shifted her full body weight onto the scrap of paper and ground it in circles with her heel, shredding both the paper and the printed ink, pressing the fragments down into the grime packed between the sidewalk bricks.

No one would ever be able to read that true rules again.

A few seconds of silence. The Placard Worker let out a sigh.

"Fine, ease up a little." It said, reluctantly. "Can't be helped—until I've posted a fresh set of rules, you can't keep killing her."

The old woman spat out a string of sharp, filthy curses—so foul and creative they almost commanded a reluctant admiration.

"I'll be back in no time," the Placard Worker promised. "Two minutes—no, sixty seconds. Sixty seconds and I'll be back with the rules, posted and ready."

...Only sixty seconds?

Half her life spent, and all she'd bought was one minute?

With that promise given, the old woman gradually retreated from Mai Minghe's mind, and the stone-ceiling it had conjured slowly rose; though it still loomed overhead and though the old woman's hands were still around her throat, Mai Minghe finally breathed in a thread of air and finally felt her own body again.

Mai Minghe's first instinct was to tear at the old woman's hands with all her strength—but they were locked steadily around her throat, not tightening any further, yet nearly impossible to push away.

...At least, not with her own physical strength alone.

She blinked.

The Placard Worker was already gone.

Aimeli sat with her back to her in the middle of the road ahead, one hand sunk into the gap, the other raised as if she were about to touch her own face.

"Aimeli," she called, keeping her voice as calm and steady as she could manage. "I need your gun right now. Give me the gun—I'll find a way to get us out of this."

Aimeli paused.

She seemed to be struggling to pull herself together: "What happened?"

As she spoke, with one hand still trapped in the wall, she twisted her body with effort toward Mai Minghe behind her and said: "Why can't I feel my face anymore?"

Where her face should have been, there was now only a wide expanse of smooth, flat skin, trembling faintly as she turned, as though her head were a block of meat jelly with a third of it sliced away.

Mai Minghe instinctively looked away, then forced her eyes back.

The front third of Aimeli's skull was gone; her neck and body were still intact. The handgun was still tucked into the holster at her front waistband.

"I'm working on it, but a Resident has me pinned—I can't bend down. I need you to hand me the gun right now. Time is short. You have to trust me."

Aimeli lifted that piece of flesh—where a face should have been, now sliced smooth and flat as a slab of jelly—and was silent for an agonizingly long two seconds.

Long enough that Mai Minghe wanted to moan, to plead, to curse—but Aimeli finally drew the gun and held it out into the air with no particular aim.

"Please..." Aimeli murmured.

With no nose, it was impossible to tell whether there was any tremor or tears in her voice.

"What are you doing?" The old woman seemed to grow suspicious. "Bullets won't—"

Before it could finish, Mai Minghe had already flipped the gun around and pressed the muzzle against the inside of its arm, aimed at the joint, and pressed the trigger down hard.

The first bullet was like a leaf falling onto the surface of a lake—only the faintest ripple, barely perceptible.

But Mai Minghe didn't let go of the trigger; one bullet after another, all aimed at the same spot, fired and hammered out in rapid succession, shaking the old woman's arm again and again—

and at some point, on some bullet she lost count of, the old woman's arm snapped like a rope suddenly cut loose, sent flying high up into the air.

An enraged howl echoed across the sky.

The same move that had been useless before now worked: because the Placard Worker's appearance required a semblance of "fairness," the old woman could no longer keep bearing down harder to resist the bullets this time.

Mai Minghe ducked low—and only now, at last, broke free from the old woman's grasp.

Though her mind and strength hadn't fully steadied themselves, she ran anyway, stumbling through waves of dizziness, and lurched across the road.

"Where are you going?" Aimeli shouted from behind: "Weren't you going to save me?"

There was no time to answer. Rounding the street corner, Mai Minghe had already spotted the Placard Worker—it was wearing a brown work jacket, and the face set deep into its head called to mind a long corridor with a dying light bulb: dim, shadowy, impossible to make out clearly.

It carried a bucket of paste in one hand and a poster in the other.

Mai Minghe raised the handgun. Without looking back, she knew the old woman had crouched back down on the ground and was crawling rapidly toward her, already halfway across the road; she aimed at the poster in the Placard Worker's hand and fired, releasing a rapid burst of shots.

"Hey, what do you think you're doing!"

The Placard Worker let out an enraged shout, as if the bullet had actually stung it, and flailed its hand furiously: "You've ruined the poster again! Look at this—is this even usable anymore? I'm telling you, if you keep this up you're going to be punished—"

Mai Minghe had already sprinted away, leaving its angry shouts behind.

As long as the new rules hadn't been posted again, nothing nearby could continue attacking any of the three of them—and this would be their only lifeline.

Mai Minghe shouted "Move!" at the door of Tourist Information Center number 07 and immediately shouldered the glass door open; Lisidan, stumbling and unable to get out of the way

in time, was knocked head over heels, his long slender esophagus swinging an arc across his cheek, and he hit the ground with a thud.

"Don't be scared," Mai Minghe said, turning back to the humanoid thing on the floor. "The Residents nearby can't keep attacking anyone right now—everything—everything worsening and transforming has paused."

She was actually more frightened than he was when she finally got a clear look at Lisidan, and her words almost stumbled over each other.

If it weren't for the threads of clothing color tangled through that mass of flesh—a trace of fluorescent orange—and the supply bag sitting beside it, she wouldn't have recognized this as Lisidan at all.

Already come to this...even if they got out, could he recover?

"You... go brace the door. Don't let that old woman in. Do you hear me? Can you still hear me? Say something back."

In Lisidan's current state, it was anyone's guess which part of him could reach out to brace the door.

"Got it..." he said, muffled and indistinct. "Map... be careful..."

Mai Minghe turned her head and swept her gaze around the Tourist Information Center.

Earlier, something that had tried to trick her into letting it out had also mentioned that there was an Old Harbor map inside the Tourist Information Center—that turned out not to have been a lie after all.

Along the wall of the reception hall sat a row of shelves, and in the most prominent spot was an Old Harbor map—or rather, something whose outward appearance happened to be an Old Harbor map, standing there with a straight face, perfectly still, pretending it had no awareness of its own.

The old woman slammed into the glass door with a bang, startling Mai Minghe.

She looked back, made up her mind, and grabbed the "Old Harbor map," wrapping it in her hand.

The map suppressed a smile.

"Get ready,"

Mai Minghe said to Lisidan on the floor, "we're taking Aimeli with us and breaking out of here together."

My physical energy has been completely drained these past few days—yesterday I thought, the new year is almost here, let me tidy up the apartment. And sure enough, I managed to excavate a mountain of trash and five tons of dog fur...

The next two days won't be any calmer either—I have to run around to several places, and just thinking about it is exhausting... Isn't the new year supposed to be a time for rest?! What a lie!

Nest Residents Welcome Early Spring — Forcing Small Talk Amid the Sound of Firecrackers

Welcome to the Nest Chat Group

Group members (\$@hh people?)

Group Admin Dream Playwright: The chaotic force that's been pressing down on the Nest all day has finally lifted — we can now directly interact with non-Hunter humans

Group Admin Dream Playwright: Everyone take note — you still cannot drop your disguises. The time hasn't come yet. Continue letting humans believe we are kind and adorable.

Baby: Do they actually have that impression of us

Group Admin Dream Playwright: Of course

Group Admin Dream Playwright: If you understand, reply with "Happy New Year"

Taxi Driver: Ne.....

w.....

Year.....

Group Admin Dream Playwright: Shut up.

Caretaker Resident: Are there any humans coming in now? What are we supposed to talk to them about?

Restaurant Husband: If someone asks me to swallow her head, how should I respond to seem kinder and cuter?

Restaurant Wife: Happy New Year

Group Admin Dream Playwright: No idea if anyone will show up—we'll worry about it when they do

Group Admin Dream Playwright: Ready? I'm opening the door. Three, two, one

Wishing everyone a Happy 2025 Lunar New Year!

Chapter 247: Mai Minghe's Last Few Seconds

Even Mai Minghe had something animal in her blood.

In a daze, she recalled how back at the Black Heart Restaurant, she had grabbed a chair and swept it through the air in a blurred, brown-wood arc; driven by a fury that erupted from her muscles, carried on a torrent of violence, she had brought it crashing down on a person's head and sent it splintering in all directions.

In a daze, she realized she had already kicked the glass door open, and with the old woman's arms spreading wide, just as its mouth was about to be revealed, she pressed the gun muzzle against its forehead and let out a ring of bright white fire.

The old woman's head was knocked back again, both arms swaying in the air as if trying to grab hold of her balance.

Before it could steady itself and raise its head again, Mai Minghe swept out a kick and knocked it to the ground.

Adrenaline dissolved every thought, every anxiety, every fear, washing away everything extraneous, leaving her with only the most pure and animal instinct — to fight for survival.

"Go, now!" she barked.

At the edge of her peripheral vision, Lisidan came scrambling half-crawling, half-running out through the doorway, somehow still clutching the supply bag, fleeing in a hurry toward the intersection, leaving behind a trail of wet squelching sounds, like walking in rain-soaked shoes on a rainy day.

Mai Minghe knew she could not look at the old woman's mouth.

By some small merciful miracle, she had not truly seen the lower half of the old woman's face until now; perhaps that was also why she was still alive — even having her neck squeezed into a straw was less dangerous than looking directly at the old woman's full face.

The old woman's head was half-pinned beneath its own shoulder, and right now only one ear and one side of its face were visible.

Its face was scraping against the road surface, pulling itself free fast; Mai Minghe quickly turned her head away, fixing her gaze only on Lisidan's retreating figure in the distance, while

pressing the "Old Harbor Map" in her hand haphazardly down onto the old woman's face.

Through the writhing, struggling map, her fingers suddenly sank downward, as if falling off a cliff; she quickly lifted her hand, grabbed the map, and shoved it forcefully into the darkness below the old woman's nose — the part she had never seen, the part she suspected contained nothing at all.

The "Old Harbor Map" could not produce a human voice, nor could it howl; but in that instant, Mai Minghe seemed to hear the sharp, tearing crack of paper fibers being ripped apart, amplified a dozen times over.

Residents devouring Residents — it must be agonizing for both sides.

From within the old woman's face, a heavy, throbbing hangover headache resounded — not sound, mind you, but a real, skull-splitting ache of someone who had drunk themselves sick, which hammered itself suddenly and forcefully into Mai Minghe's head.

She dared not linger any longer, and bearing the pain, stumbled and staggered toward the intersection.

The Placard Worker had disappeared, but it would likely receive a second copy of the rule introduction soon enough; once that happened, it would no longer return here — at least, not to Mai Minghe's side, giving her another chance to destroy the rules.

The time left for them to escape was under a minute.

"Did you get them out?"

By the time Mai Minghe came sprinting to the entrance of Tourist Information Center number 01, she already knew the shout was pointless — only Lisidan was at the door; his fingers, barely recognizable as fingers, had not so much as touched the theater troupe poster by the entrance.

...Hadn't she already told him exactly what to do?

On the theater troupe poster, Aimeli was still squeezed behind the iron bars, one hand extended outward gripping a phone.

But the message on the phone had changed.

That's right, you guessed it — my face was cut off and locked inside the poster.

Ever since we set foot on this street, I've been caught — my face has been trapped the whole time.

Just press RELEASE on the keyboard.

My face will come back to my head.

Hurry — there's not much time left.

"It's a trap, a trap," Lisidan's voice shook along with the rest of him. "That's not the real person — this is obviously a trap... I know this well, whatever comes out won't be Aimeli."

Even as he said it, he kept crawling forward.

"I — I won't release whatever is in the poster. That's not Aimeli anymore. I'm experienced, I know... she's beyond saving. It's not my fault..."

Mai Minghe quickly glanced across the road.

Aimeli was still crouched on the sidewalk exactly as before, one arm reaching into the gap, showing only the back of her head; unlike before, that silhouette — the one that truly belonged to Aimeli — was now trembling.

From far away, her voice could still be heard, scattered fine as spittle through the air: "Why am I stuck? Why can't I move? Where's my face? Weren't you supposed to save me? Where did you go?"

Behind her on the road, the old woman was swaying to her feet, its limbs seemingly not yet coordinated on which direction to turn; one hand propped up in reverse, cradling the head hanging down from its back, one foot pointing toward the two-o'clock position, one foot heel-first forward.

From its mouth, the "Old Harbor Map" protruded halfway, trembling in the air.

Mai Minghe turned back around — she had been wrong; she didn't even have a full minute.

Before the old woman staggered close enough to catch her — how long did she have? Ten seconds? Five? — Mai Minghe had to make a decision: whether or not to release the Aimeli in the poster.

In other words, was the one in the poster truly Aimeli or not?

"Ever since we set foot on this street, I've been caught — my face has been trapped the whole time"?

That wasn't how it happened, was it?

Mai Minghe remembered that after she first spotted the poster of Aimeli asking for help, she had turned back once and crossed to the other side of the road. At that time, Aimeli had noticed her, spoken to her, and shown her the recording on her phone.

At that moment, two faces belonging to Aimeli had existed on this street at the same time.

One growing perfectly on her head, the other printed behind the iron bars of the poster.

How could that be?

Which face had been Aimeli's own at the time?

Mai Minghe turned to look again — in just those few seconds, the old woman's limbs had already coordinated themselves, every arm and leg now pointing in the right direction — straight toward Mai Minghe.

Even if she wanted to fire a few more shots to buy a little more time before it recovered, it was no longer possible; she had already emptied every bullet in Aimeli's handgun once more, just a moment ago.

She turned back and found that the text on the phone screen in the poster had changed again.

What are you still hesitating for?

If you don't release me now, we'll both die here.

Hurry — press RELEASE on the keyboard.

There's no time left — save me.

Indeed, any more hesitation and it would be too late. Although the old woman's head was still folded backward, it was resolute despite its broken state, and had already taken a step forward.

Mai Minghe tore her gaze away and forced herself to stare back at the poster.

...The Nest always insisted on reason and logic in the most inexplicable places. Even if its reason and logic looked like a chopstick placed in a bowl of water — appearing twisted and bent.

By common sense, the face growing on Aimeli's head should naturally be her own face, right?

Then by that logic, the face that had appeared on the poster at the time was naturally not Aimeli's face.

So where had Aimeli's true face gone right now?

Mai Minghe stared at the phone screen and watched the message text change again — but it was still more pleas for help, persuasion, and reminders to click the keyboard.

Not far away at the intersection, Lisidan twisted around and glanced back at her.

"Move, now!"

His voice was growing steadier, seeming to gradually approach something resembling human. "Even if you saved me, I won't stay here reminding you forever. This is the last time — don't release what's in the poster—"

His final word dissolved into a cry of alarm as Mai Minghe pressed her hand against the poster's phone.

Lisidan turned and bolted.

Mai Minghe could hardly make out his retreating figure in her peripheral vision either, because cold sweat was stinging her eyes. She forced herself desperately not to turn and look at the old woman advancing toward her one shambling step at a time, her finger pressing on the blue back-arrow in the upper-left corner of the poster's phone screen.

She decided to take a gamble.

...The Nest was reasonable in the most inexplicable places.

If pressing the letters RELEASE on a printed image of a phone keyboard could interact with the phone... then could she press somewhere else?

As it turned out, the Nest was reasonable after all — even if its reason was twisted.

It was clearly a phone screen printed on a poster, yet the moment Mai Minghe tapped it, it exited the messaging interface and became a row of message threads from many different contacts.

Mai Minghe was deeply relieved that she had learned how to operate a smartphone before entering the Nest this time.

She tapped the back arrow once more, returning to the phone's app interface; then she quickly opened the photo album.

As for exactly why she thought to open the photo album, there was no particularly logical reason — the last time she had seen Aimeli's face looking normal, Aimeli had been about to record another video.

The most recent icon in the photo album of the printed phone, when tapped, turned out to be a video only three or four seconds long.

The old woman's shadow fell over the road a few steps to Mai Minghe's right.

The phone screen went black first, and then Aimeli appeared; the camera shaking, she seemed to pause in surprise and brought the phone up closer to her face.

Then, from the printed phone, her voice came through — "...Hm? Why did it switch to the front-facing camera?"

She suddenly lifted her face and pressed it right up against the camera lens, and for one instant, smeared the entire screen into a blur of skin-toned flesh.

In the moment after Aimeli pulled the phone away, as the flesh tone faded and the lens shifted before cutting back to the road surface, Mai Minghe saw it.

Aimeli, now that she had lowered the phone, no longer had a face.

Her head was like a block of meat jelly with a third sliced away, leaving behind a smooth, flat surface.

...As if that one press against the camera had caused her face to fall into the phone and become trapped in the recording — yet Aimeli herself had not noticed at all.

But could that logic really hold up?

Was this truly the way to save her?

Mai Minghe's finger hovered over the tiny trash-can icon, hesitating for just a moment.

If she deleted this video, and as a result Aimeli could never come back out—

The old woman's face pressed itself against Mai Minghe.

Surprise! I updated on the first day of the Lunar New Year! That means in this new year, I'm going to... keep being... a word-grinding dog...

Chapter 248: The People at the Mai Minghe Rendezvous Point

The moment the old woman reached out her hand, somewhere in a nearby corner, the true rules must have just been reposted, going "online" once more.

In that instant, it seemed as though even the air stirred with a faint excitement; as if flickering sparks of electricity lurked beneath cognition, crackling to life in the depths of sensory perception. But if one tried to look directly—

Mai Minghe could not look directly.

Her eyes were clamped shut right now, her head wrenched to the side, yet she could still feel the old woman's completely unobstructed face casting a shadow across her own.

The old woman's fingers sank deep into Mai Minghe's cheeks—deep, deep, deep, deep, deep—the ten fingers converging inside half of Mai Minghe's skull, left cheek pressing against right cheek, teeth squeezed into a crumbling cluster in the middle.

"You caught me off guard just now. That won't happen again."

The old woman said it in a singsong voice. "You see, we Residents have to learn on the job too—practice makes progress."

With a single twist of its hand, Mai Minghe's head was wrenched involuntarily toward it—if the old woman had let go and she found that her skull and neck had long since been snapped from their connection, and her head went rolling across the ground, Mai Minghe wouldn't have been surprised in the least.

"Open your eyes," the old woman was still singing. "Open your eyes and look at my face, and all your troubles will vanish without a trace."

Several fingers lifted from deep within her cheeks and began crawling toward her eyes.

From several seconds ago—from the moment she realized the old woman was reaching out to grab her—Mai Minghe had been holding herself back, not moving a single step; no, beyond turning her head and squeezing her eyes shut, every muscle in her body had contracted and seized up, locked in stillness, beginning to ache with a dull, cramp-like throb.

Only by staying completely still could she ensure that wherever her fingers had tapped down so quickly, she could still make contact with the trash can icon—and so she had been caught by

the old woman fair and square.

She must have already deleted the footage by now—but what had happened?

Or rather, had nothing happened at all?

Maybe she hadn't managed to save Aimeli, and had only thrown away her own life in the bargain—

A male voice announced loudly: "After a spirited competition among the company's full roster of gardeners, the Holy Trinity of Three has decided to promote Johnny Johnson to Maze Market Department Manager! Because Mi Gao has demonstrated outstanding performance over the past fifty thousand years of evolutionary history, completing multiple undercover disguise-retribution-raid team operations among humanity, all his hard work has gone to make a wedding dress for Johnny..."

...What?

The bewilderment had barely taken shape when a gunshot rang out, nearly shattering both the air and Mai Minghe's eardrums—the source of the shot seemed to be only two or three steps away, and her ears were immediately flooded with a fierce ringing that almost drowned out the shout beyond the ringing: "Run!"

It was Aimeli.

The grip crushing her cheeks loosened at once, and she immediately wrenched her head back around, feeling both cheeks spring back into place, teeth and jawbone and tongue all snapping back to where they belonged—she didn't dare glance toward the old woman's direction, and turned and ran.

Out on the road a few steps away, Aimeli sprinted to catch up, firing back over her shoulder as she ran—her face had finally come back to her, and so had her field of vision.

"Don't look at its face!" Mai Minghe shouted.

"I know," Aimeli answered between gunshots.

"What was that thing just now?"

"A recording I had on my phone," Aimeli shouted. "Random, incoherent, nonsensical speech—it can make a Resident briefly confused, make it forget what it's supposed to be doing. That's one of my trade secrets."

Her marksmanship was far better than Mai Minghe's: she fired only once every few seconds, yet managed to hold the old woman at bay for quite a while; it wasn't until the two of them reached the intersection that Mai Minghe finally found a moment to glance back.

True to her reputation as an experienced Hunter.

Every one of Aimeli's bullets had landed with precision on the same kneecap of the old woman—the right leg's knee joint had long since been bent sharply backward at a high angle; every time it tried to give chase and took a step forward, it lurched violently, losing its balance.

"Which way do we go?" Aimeli paused at the intersection and asked.

"This way," Mai Minghe pointed to the road on the left and charged ahead first.

"Wait, there's something on that road—"

Mai Minghe looked up and spotted Lisidan's figure in the distance, fleeing at full tilt; compared to before, he looked slightly more human-shaped now—it seemed that after breaking free of the trap, he was indeed gradually recovering.

"Don't worry, that's Lisidan."

Whatever questions Aimeli had, she didn't ask a single one—after all, now was not a good time for questions.

Two people with perfectly functional legs—well, Mai Minghe's foot couldn't exactly be called functional—and bodies otherwise unharmed ran far faster than Lisidan, and in no more than a dozen seconds they had already caught up to him.

"I am Lisidan,"

The shape ahead of them—tangled and chaotic, as if every bone and organ in its body couldn't decide which way to go—was still muttering to itself as they drew near: "I am a Hunter. Today is November 24th, 2026. I entered the Nest to attend the Key House Hunter interview... Ah!"

He turned around—let's call that twisted-over portion a "head," for now—and seemed to startle, nearly rolling off his own ankle bone: "Wh—when did you—"

"This thing is really Lisidan?" Aimeli said, already raising her handgun as she ran. "What kind of person can stay human looking like that? You've been tricked by it!"

"You actually let it out of the poster?" At the same moment, Lisidan was shouting too: "I told you—whatever was on that poster was not human Aimeli—"

"Both of you, listen to me,"

Mai Minghe was caught between the two of them, practically having words pumped into both ears at once, giving her a splitting headache. "I guarantee you, you're both real people. However real you are, the other one is just as real. I'm the one who pulled both of you out, and I know that better than anyone."

Both of them fell silent.

It was as though someone had just said something they had never heard before in their lives—nothing in their combined experience offered them a fitting response.

For a moment, all that drifted through the air around them were hurried footfalls, ragged breathing, and the sound of Lisidan's lungs expanding and contracting.

Without leaving the Nest, there was only one way to truly shake the old woman—to enter another Rule Domain, another sub-scenario, or the territory of another Resident.

It was, in a sense, drinking poison to quench one's thirst.

But Mai Minghe could only deal with the immediate crisis first; as for what to do about the next lethal thing waiting for her—well, she'd cross that bridge when she came to it. No, actually, she didn't even know how to stumble into the next danger zone right now; if she did know, it would almost be easier to handle.

"Where are we running to?" Aimeli couldn't help but ask.

"Annie Warehouse," said Lisidan.

"You know where Annie Warehouse is?" Mai Minghe startled, unsure whether to feel relieved or cautious.

"I found an Old Harbor map in the 'Tourist Information Center.' It disguised itself as something harmless at first and let me see the location of Annie Warehouse. It was only when I was about to leave that I fell into the trap."

Aimeli immediately asked: "How do you know for certain that's the real, accurate Annie Warehouse?"

As Lisidan's recovery accelerated, his speech quickened along with it. "I don't know for certain—but do you have a better idea?"

Aimeli let out a puff of air through her nose and said nothing more.

"But there's something chasing us from behind," Mai Minghe worried. "If we lead it to where everyone else is... won't the others be in danger?"

The other two Hunters said nothing.

After running in silence for a few seconds, Aimeli said out of nowhere: "I believe you."

"What?"

"I fully believe now that it was you who pulled me out of that faceless state. I don't mind being honest with you—there was actually still a small part of me that wondered if it was some accidental coincidence that got me free... because we have no real connection to each other, and we're even competitors, so you had no reason to look out for me. But I know now. You're just the kind of person who saves people."

Lisidan paused for a moment.

"I told her to leave, because whatever came out of a poster couldn't possibly be a real person—but she still wouldn't leave. Even as that Resident was about to catch up to her, she was still tapping and poking away at that poster..."

He turned his face toward them—in under half a minute, Lisidan had grown a face again, glasses and all, perched back on the bridge of his nose.

As they ran, his height had also been gradually returning; now at a glance, every part of him appeared to be more or less where it belonged—at least not so alarming that someone would shoot at him on sight from a distance.

"Don't worry,"

he said to Mai Minghe. "There are five Hunters gathered at Annie Warehouse. With us added, driving out one Resident together should be no great difficulty. And besides, the Key House Hunters have almost certainly prepared another challenge for us... If Annie Warehouse itself is also a sub-scenario, the old woman chasing us will have an even harder time getting close."

That did make sense... but the moment she thought about how she had nearly lost half her life and the Key House interview still hadn't truly begun, Mai Minghe couldn't help but feel a wave

of throbbing headaches.

She had even lost her supply bag, leaving her with nothing but a fluorescent-orange tag around her neck and an empty gun at her hip—she had no idea how she was going to get through the next round.

After running a while longer, Aimeli used one hand to cover her upper eyelid to avoid accidentally catching a full view of the old woman, and quickly stole a glance back—then reported: "The Resident's gone!"

"Really?"

Aimeli swept her gaze across the ground behind them several more times, scanning a much wider area this time. "Really. I haven't spotted it for quite a while now. It seems like we've shaken it off... or maybe it gave up on its own."

"Wait, does that mean..." Mai Minghe hesitated.

If there wasn't another trap waiting ahead, it was hard to imagine the old woman willingly giving up on her.

Almost as if in response to that thought, the moment Lisidan led the two of them around a corner and onto the next street, a group of Hunters in front of a large red-brick building turned their heads toward them.

Tianxi let out a long, leisurely whistle and raised one hand into the air.

...They had finally reached the rendezvous point.

The long breath Mai Minghe had been about to release suddenly froze as she drew near, lodging itself in her chest so stubbornly that it even began to ache faintly.

Tianxi, Shaxue, and Qiboli—three Key House Hunters who appeared to have been waiting for quite some time—were already there; the other two trial Hunters had also arrived early and were sitting on the curb, chatting idly.

The hulking man even let out a mocking laugh. "Took you long enough? There's still half an hour before the gathering time closes—I was starting to think you were all going to be eliminated."

...That was right. There were five people in total.

But there were six faces.

Mai Minghe's arc ended up going on this long—I'm honestly surprised too... Speaking of which, basically no one reads during the Spring Festival holiday, and I'm not even sure why I'm still this dedicated, maybe it's because I want to finish the story sooner (lol)

Chapter 249: Mai Minghe's Real Trial

"...Not particularly pleasant."

When the other Hunters—especially the Key House Hunters—asked about her experiences after landing, this was the only answer Mai Minghe could come up with.

Half of it was because she wasn't used to complaining to people.

For instance, the burns on her feet had never had a chance to heal; whenever she thought things were about to calm down, Mai Minghe would have to throw her full body weight onto them, striking the ground one step after another as she ran for her life.

Fortunately, she'd had the foresight to pad the inside of her shoe with a sanitary pad before entering the Nest today, to absorb the pus and seeping blood from the wound; it also added an extra layer of cushioning, which was somewhat more comfortable than before—at least more bearable.

The other half of the reason was that she couldn't focus.

She kept warning herself not to look at the sixth face—no, now that the three of them had joined, she should be calling it the ninth face—yet she couldn't help stealing glances toward it. When the Key House Hunters questioned her about her experiences as though conducting an interview, Mai Minghe could only give distracted, vague answers to brush them off.

...Was she the only one who could see that face?

Calling it a face wasn't quite accurate: it was more as though someone were hiding behind the air itself, tucked deep within the space, extending only a head, propping up the outline of a face.

In empty space, only when the light happened to hit at just the right angle could you faintly make out the shift where the space had been pushed up—the semi-transparent crease; but when the "face" drifted behind a building wall or between leaves, what had been solid and three-dimensional seemed to turn into a thin sheet of cloth, bulging outward in the shape of a face's features.

Mai Minghe covertly studied the face for a moment and couldn't make out anything beyond the fact that its nose and brow ridge were tall and sharp—beneath the firm, pronounced contours, the eye sockets had become two deep, dark hollows.

"...Right, we escaped together just now," Lisidan—fully restored to normal—was saying to the Key House Hunters.

The moment he'd spotted them, his footsteps had faltered slightly, as if he were reluctant to let the others see him still in his state of physical disarray.

But by the time the group had inevitably converged, he showed almost no trace of having been affected—except for the belly button on the back of his neck, which was still slowly sliding down toward his collar, searching for a more appropriate place to settle.

It wasn't a big deal; after a look from Mai Minghe, Lisidan pressed one hand over the back of his neck as though stretching his shoulder and neck muscles, and concealed it just fine.

"She looked after us quite a bit," Aimeli nodded and said. "She's a Hunter worthy of respect."

As for what exactly Mai Minghe had done, the two of them kept their accounts vague and understated.

After all, this was still an interview.

Telling an interviewer that you'd nearly died, and that you'd only made it to their presence alive thanks to your competitor, was not exactly a winning interview strategy.

"You lost all your supply bags?" Tianxi had noticed Mai Minghe's empty hands.

Mai Minghe looked down at her own hands. "Uh... the situation got a bit urgent, so I ended up using my supply bag as a weapon..."

Tianxi considered for a few seconds.

"Well, unexpected situations are unavoidable... Our requirement was to hold onto the orange tag, and you managed that, so you pass. Once we're out, you can explain the details properly."

The Nest, in truth, had no interest in her tag; the Nest was far more interested in her life.

"When do we leave?"

Even knowing it wouldn't end so simply, Mai Minghe couldn't help but feel a flicker of hope.

Just as no one else could see that face, the face also seemed unable to see them clearly.

But it kept drifting from side to side, sniffing and probing, as if searching for something—and she was fairly sure it wasn't her imagination: whenever she spoke, the face seemed to drift a little closer toward her.

To avoid being touched by the face, Mai Minghe endured the pain in her foot and pretended to be stretching her legs, and had already paced in circles several times.

"Everyone rest for thirty minutes, then we enter the Annie Warehouse."

Tianxi had clearly heard about the ordeal the group had been through before making this impromptu decision. "Once you successfully clear this stage, you can head back to Blackmoor City."

As expected... inside the Annie Warehouse was the real trial the Key House had prepared for the applicant Hunters.

Mai Minghe let out a quiet sigh inside.

The goal of successfully infiltrating the Key House to retrieve the lipstick seemed to grow further and further away the harder she tried—every step she took, the road stretched by three more, until it was so distant it left a gnawing unease in her chest.

She could only bring her attention back to the present and focus on—

Mai Minghe lurched backward as if shocked, jerking her head to one side so hard her neck let out a sharp crack.

Everyone around her turned to look.

"What's wrong?"

Through the air in front of her—faintly warped, a face pressing through its surface—Aimeli's figure was distorted too, but the alertness in her expression came through clear as ever. "What did you see?"

Mai Minghe steadied her breathing and took a step back, putting a little more distance between herself and the face lurking behind the space.

"Nothing... a bug suddenly landed on my face," she said, at the risk of seeming like she'd overreacted, patting herself down. "I already knocked it off."

"This is the Nest," the burly man named Robert grumbled. "Don't go jumping at every little thing."

But not everyone accepted her explanation—besides the three Key House Hunters, the other female Hunter was still studying the air in front of Mai Minghe, as though trying to see through its disguise.

She was around thirty, with the top half of her hair tied into a bun and the bottom half shaved close to the scalp—a rather odd style; Mai Minghe truly couldn't make heads or tails of some of the trends among young people these days.

Suobeihua had a sharp chin and a lean, spare face; her gaze was habitually soft, yet that softness seemed deliberately layered on, like gauze wrapped around a hard diamond to conceal what lay beneath.

They had waited at the entrance for nearly half an hour without noticing the face in the air, and now that Suobeihua looked more carefully, she naturally saw nothing either.

This was, in fact, one of the reasons Mai Minghe had hesitated and then decided not to mention the "transparent face."

Not only could none of the five at the entrance see the transparent face, they had coexisted peacefully with it for this long—which meant it was very likely targeting Mai Minghe specifically, with no interest in the others. If she told everyone there was a transparent face here, they would certainly take action against it, and that might very well cause the transparent face to treat them as enemies too.

Well, forget it—let the battlefield stay limited to just herself, Mai Minghe thought, looking away from the transparent face.

The current situation fit the classic old saying perfectly: "What you don't know can't hurt you."

"While everyone rests, Qiboli will give a brief introduction to the traps inside the warehouse."

Tianxi clapped once to draw everyone's attention, then gave a nod to the platinum-haired young male Hunter—Qiboli stepped forward and flashed a crooked smile.

"I'm the one who discovered this trap. Our House Faction has used it to test and screen quite a few Hunters already."

The young man's face was somewhat asymmetrical; his smile always tilted to one side, and one blue eye was slightly narrower and longer than the other green one—though one couldn't say the look had no charm.

"The first thing to remember is that when you step into the trap, you'll find your form has changed. There's no need to panic—we all change.

"Your ordinary human appearance will briefly disappear, and what manifests within the trap's space is the Nest's summary of you."

Qiboli glanced at the door, then swept his gaze across the group.

"Before someone joins the Key House, we must know clearly what kind of person they are, what principles and beliefs they hold—or don't hold; and what goals they carry."

I'm spent—there's been a lot going on at home these past few days, and I've been run ragged. Even though it's the Spring Festival holiday, I've had basically no time off and no rest. On top of that, my period hit, and I'm practically about to pass out. Since tomorrow is Saturday (though I suppose that doesn't mean much during the New Year period), I've decided to take one more day to rest.

The God of Wealth says today's update will go out a bit later.

I actually had no holiday for the New Year, so on top of my regular workload I basically forced myself through the whole festival, and all the extra effort nearly flattened me... Yesterday I thought I'd finally get a day off, but then I ended up spending the whole day tidying the house, buying things, and cleaning, and I even forgot to write the thank-you chapter.

Today's update will probably go past midnight. The God of Wealth says today is the day he pays his visits—very important—and everyone must not neglect welcoming him just to read the update.

So that everyone can welcome the God of Wealth with full devotion, the update will go out a little later.

See? I'm so considerate.

(Too guilty to even bring myself to add punctuation.)

Chapter 250: Chase Osmosis

"...June?"

He had never been so careful in his entire life.

He remembered crossing the boundary with the lightest of steps, leaving his feet behind him, left outside in that darkness. He didn't know what he used to slowly walk forward.

But that didn't matter—people without legs could still get around, couldn't they? That wasn't so unusual.

In the pitch black, there was no light, and no answer.

Chase stood still and waited for a moment.

He thought he should try calling June's name at least once.

After all, since he'd walked in, he hadn't tried that most basic method of finding someone.

"June?" Chase called out softly. "Can you hear me? Where are you?"

While waiting for a response, he kept walking deeper into the darkness.

He had never been so careful in his entire life.

He remembered crossing the boundary with the lightest of steps, leaving his feet behind him, left outside in the darkness.

Chase thought he should try calling June's name at least once.

After all, since he'd followed June inside, he hadn't called out to her yet.

"June?"

Perhaps sound could travel through the darkness too. Perhaps June could hear him.

He should call out to her, give it a try. After all, for the past several minutes, he hadn't made a sound...

Wait—how long had he been in here?

Chase couldn't remember, but he felt it couldn't have been very long. He remembered that he had a keen sense of time, that he could keep track of it with perfect precision...

That was a little strange.

It was clearly something about himself, yet thinking of it now felt like recalling a movie character's defining trait—distant, as if it had been written for him by some screenwriter.

Never mind. That didn't matter.

More precisely, he could no longer summon the tension that normally came with finding something important.

In any case, Chase had a sharp sense of time. If he felt it hadn't been long, then he must have just arrived.

Looking down was pointless anyway—in this endless darkness, he couldn't see the watch on his wrist.

Though he couldn't see the watch on his wrist, Chase could occasionally make out people in the darkness behind him.

Those silhouettes flickered past in an instant—sometimes people he recognized, sometimes not. Every now and then, they'd drag a fragment of their surrounding background or environment with them, drifting up through the darkness in a hazy blur.

Whenever that happened, Chase would quicken his pace toward them, carefully studying each face and each environment in turn.

Once, he spotted an unfamiliar little restaurant—a heavysset man sitting in a booth, eyes vacant and glassy, his mind clearly somewhere far away.

Chase had slowly walked toward him, intending to reach the man's side first, then enter the restaurant from there to search for June—because the man's table was at the very front, and the restaurant seemed to begin from him, existing only as his backdrop.

It wasn't until Chase drew close to the table that he suddenly realized there was a mirror mounted on the wall beside the booth.

The heavysset man happened to turn his head, his eyes landing on the mirror, and his gaze collided with Chase's.

His face went pale in an instant; he sucked in a sharp breath, lurched to his feet—his belly knocking the plates, forks, and coffee cups on the table into rattling, clanging chaos—and opened

his mouth as if about to cry out. But then everything around him seemed to be yanked away in an instant, and in the blink of an eye it all plunged back into darkness.

...Why was he so afraid of him?

Chase stood blankly in the darkness, unable for a moment to figure out where the heavyset man and the little restaurant had gone.

If he remembered correctly, a person could stand up and move somewhere else—that was right. But a building couldn't... couldn't it?

Right, buildings couldn't just up and leave, couldn't just retreat into the darkness like that... could they.

But never mind—none of that mattered.

What mattered was finding June.

June was somewhere nearby... he couldn't let go of any thread of hope that might lead him to her.

Though Chase didn't know what "here" was, he was certain June was in this place. After all, he had followed her in.

The only continuous thought Chase could hold onto seemed to be "find June"—and rather than a thought, it had become an obsession. Driven by that obsession, Chase moved forward step by step, walking deeper and deeper into the darkness.

Everything else—his other thoughts, his reasoning—was like particles dissolving into liquid, diffusing and scattering, drifting further and further away from him.

The memory of the heavyset man and the little restaurant softened as if waterlogged, gently peeling away from him, floating off and fading into the depths of the darkness.

Chase remembered that, besides the heavyset man and the little restaurant, he seemed to have seen others too—had entered somewhere very familiar, had walked for a long time... was it the Key House manor?

He couldn't quite recall, but in any case, that building—the one that resembled the Key House manor—had ultimately stood up, fixed its gaze on him, and shuffled backward in tiny steps until it disappeared into the darkness.

What remained in the end was only the darkness that seemed to hold nothing, yet was in fact saturated with countless thoughts.

But just as diffusing particles drift and float in all directions, every so often a memory or thought belonging to Chase would drift back to him, light as a feather, brushing against him a few times like a fish, as if wondering whether he might open a gap and let it come home.

...He should call out to June. Perhaps she could hear him if he did.

After all, since he'd come in, he hadn't called her name even once.

"June—"

This time, Chase suddenly stopped.

He halted—which was of course only a manner of speaking; he didn't remember bringing his feet in with him, so he probably hadn't—and stared fixedly into the darkness ahead.

Beyond layer upon layer of churning, tangled, writhing darkness, someone was crouching.

He couldn't see them, but he could feel them.

"...June?" Chase could only call out the one name left in his mind. "Is that you?"

Though she was only on the other side of the darkness, it felt as though she were somewhere impossibly far away. She was quiet for a moment, then answered, "...It's me."

Chase wanted to reach into his memory for June's voice and compare it to the one he was hearing now, but he failed. The memory containing June's voice had long since drifted away like a speck of dust in water, gone to who knew where.

He remembered that June was a woman, and the voice that had answered him was a woman's—that seemed like a good sign.

"What are you doing here?" Chase ventured. "Are you all right?"

"...That's exactly what I wanted to ask you. Where did you come from?"

Chase considered for a moment.

Right—where had he come from? He still remembered that he had followed June inside; that part of his memory hadn't scattered yet. But before coming in...

"Blackmoor City," Chase said. "I can't remember exactly where, but it was definitely Blackmoor City."

The person in the darkness drew a small, quiet breath—for some reason, it sounded almost like admiration.

"You've come quite a long way, then."

Had he? Chase wasn't entirely sure how far he'd walked, but it didn't seem like much time had passed.

Chase's sense of time was precise.

If he felt it hadn't been long, then he must have just arrived.

"Put your hands down," he said. "You've been covering your face the whole time—I can't make out who you are."

The word "make out" was of course imprecise; everything he perceived at this moment—including the image of the other person crouching on the ground with both hands over their face—also drifted like a particle, slowly floating into the darkness, seeping from the darkness into his mind.

But human language had always fallen short when faced with things it had never encountered before, and one could only make do with old words.

The person in the darkness laughed and said, "Then I'll let you see my eyes. My mouth is off-limits."

He felt he should probably ask why she wouldn't let him see her mouth—but in the same instant, Chase realized that even seeing her mouth wouldn't mean anything.

...What did June's eyes look like, anyway?

Were her eyelids heavy and thick, layered fold upon fold, drooping over half of her clouded irises?

He couldn't remember.

"Chase... Chase Monroe." The person in the darkness suddenly called out his name.

Right. That was his name.

Since she knew his name... did that mean she really was June?

Because in this darkness—where the world seemed to have stopped existing—who else but June could possibly know him?

Whatever the case, the first priority was to bring her out.

"Come with me," Chase said. "I'll take you home. Don't worry—the one that had taken over your body, that... that..."

Whatever had taken over her body had also become a small scrap of white, drifting further and further away, dissolving into the darkness until it was no longer visible.

"Anyway, it's gone now. You're safe," Chase murmured, barely above a whisper. "I'm sorry... I'm glad you held on until now."

The person in the darkness covered her mouth with her hands, crouched on the ground, and let out a soft giggle.

"I can't go with you," she said.

"Why not?"

"Weren't you just watching over Key House?"

Was that right? How did she know? Chase himself could only remember things when those memories and thoughts drifted back to him and nudged him.

"Do you still want to keep watching over Key House?"

Of course he did.

That was the one task he carried through this world, bearing the weight of his sins.

"Clear out the threat... I'll take you there, and we'll clear out the greatest threat to Key House... the moment you see it, everything will come back to you. Trust me."

June crouched on the ground and giggled again.

The God of Wealth has departed, but has left everyone his Ma Yinglong bank account number and withdrawal password—go look for it at home (lol).

Updates have shifted to after midnight again. My update schedule just orbits the clock along with my sleep cycle—thank you all for sticking with me.

Chapter 251: The Consequences of Chase's Choice

Strangely, no matter how far he walked into the depths of the darkness, he could never get close to June.

"Why can't I get over to you?" Chase asked.

Being unable to grab June's arm with his own hands left him uneasy.

Would she get lost? All around was nothing but endless black. Without being able to hold her hand, could she still follow him back safely?

"Why can't I cross over to your side?" Chase asked.

Even as she walked, June remained crouched low to the ground, her legs turning round and round like wheels, rolling her forward; hearing Chase's question, she mumbled something in reply. She kept her hands pressed over her mouth, and when her voice dropped too low, her words were impossible to make out.

"What did you say?"

June raised her voice. "I said, you've already asked that question a dozen times, and I've answered it just as many, and then you go and ask again — you're driving me absolutely crazy."

Chase was taken aback. Was that so?

It must be that the same doubt — why he couldn't reach her side — kept drifting back through the darkness, colliding with him again and again; each time it hit him, he would ask the same question once more.

But the memory of June's answers never drifted back to him.

"Is that right," he said blankly, "...I'm sorry."

June let out a snort. "Aren't you just — in every way, you've truly wronged me. You'd better keep that in mind, don't you dare forget that you owe me."

"...All right, I won't."

The guilt he felt toward June had stayed with him all along, never drifting away from him, never dissolving into the dark.

Taking another step forward, Chase murmured, "Why can't I reach your side?"

Deep within the darkness, June suddenly shot to her feet.

"So annoying so annoying so annoying asking over and over without end is that doubt really so important to you if you'd just stop fixating on it it wouldn't keep swimming back to you over and over so annoying"

She spun around, hands still pressed over her face, and came charging toward Chase in long strides.

Though countless things had already peeled away from Chase and drifted off, his animal instinct for survival remained — dulled and sluggish as it had become. Just as he startled and tensed, on the verge of defending himself, he realized at the same moment that June's target wasn't him.

June had one hand stretched across her own face, blocking its center.

Her other hand spun and swung above her shoulder like a windmill, as though she were furiously beating back and scattering the invisible thoughts drifting through the dark.

Still separated from Chase by a distance that seemed impossible to cross, she shrieked at the top of her voice: "Get lost! You've already fallen off him — now get out get out get out get out get out, come back again and I won't be so nice about it, just dissociate quietly, dissociate dissociate break apart scatter dissociate, I couldn't care less whether you eventually dissolve away together with your host!"

June's way of speaking had a truly distinctive quality — like a great gush of pus bursting out after a cyst was punctured underfoot.

Chase genuinely wished he could remember whether June had always talked this way.

When June finally lowered her hands, she stood motionless in the darkness for a moment, hands still covering her face.

What was wrong?

"Hmm... I just realized, these things that have broken away from you — annoying as they are, they do have their uses..."

She turned away, presenting the back of her head to Chase, then lowered both hands.

If he could only walk over there, he could see her face — and know whether she really was June — ah, but he had forgotten: June's appearance had long since drifted away into the darkness as well.

"Think about guarding Key House — really think about it — think about your resolve to protect Key House... Yes, that memory is nearby, I just caught a glimpse of it... Focus on it and it'll come back to you..."

Chase drew a sharp breath.

Right...

After he had followed June into the darkness, at first they hadn't been separated at all.

Chase remembered running in great strides through the dark, chasing relentlessly after that shadow that kept retreating, kept shrinking — where exactly he had charged into didn't matter; why he could still sense June's direction even though he could see nothing but black, didn't matter either.

Wherever this place was, whatever was happening here, he was going to bring June back out.

June alone was the only thing that meant anything in this endless dark.

At that point Chase still hadn't realized: the more violently he moved, the more things peeled away from him and drifted off.

He was like a biscuit soaking in water — if the biscuit stirred itself into a frenzy, its crumbs dissolved away all the faster, while the water seeped deeper in.

As the darkness and Chase spread into each other, permeating one another, he ran and ran — and then, suddenly, forgot what June looked like. The memory containing her face had happened to break loose in the course of his running, and drifted away.

But that did nothing to slow his pace.

What made him jerk his head sharply around and stop dead in his tracks was the darkness in another direction — layered, tangled, chaotic — and behind that mass of dark, he "saw" a place he knew better than anywhere else.

In the darkness he had come across many people, some familiar, some not; every time, they appeared trailing fragments of their worldly surroundings with them like a backdrop.

Even appearing only as a backdrop, Chase recognized the Key House manor at a glance.

Inside the Key House manor was a young woman — he felt he had seen her somewhere before, but the memory of where and who she was had long since drifted away into the darkness.

He could only be certain that she was no Key House Hunter.

The woman moved with light, careful steps, slipping into an empty corridor, cocking her ear to listen for a moment — she seemed to be watching out for the people of Key House. How had she even gotten inside?

What was she here to do?

Chase's shout was pure muscle memory, pure instinct — "Someone get to the first-floor library corridor — we've got an intruder!"

But the words fell into the darkness and seemed to become just another set of drifting thoughts and memories, stirring no response; naturally, no Key House Hunter came charging into the corridor to catch anyone.

The woman remained furtive, moving with light, careful steps. She pulled out a phone and photographed the corridor from every angle — front, back, left, right — not even sparing the ceiling.

...Was she trying to map out the interior layout of the Key House manor?

In an instant, several guesses flashed through Chase's mind — planting a bomb, assassination, ambush, robbery — one or two of them, no sooner born than they slipped away, tumbling into the boundless dark. But what remained was more than enough to set his nerves jumping.

Completely on instinct, he stepped toward the young woman and reached out to grab her phone — but it was as though Chase were nothing more than an image made of countless loose particles; he passed straight through her shoulder without catching the phone, only making her shoulder sway slightly.

He stared blankly at his empty hand.

If his usual touch registered at a hundred percent, then right now it had been diluted down to a single percent.

With so faint an influence, how was he supposed to stop the woman? What exactly was this place, and where had June brought him —

June.

Chase's head snapped up. Far away in the depths of the darkness, he could just barely make out June's retreating silhouette. He hadn't lost too much time — if he went after her now, he could still catch up.

But...

He turned and looked at the young woman beside him — the one who had slipped into the Key House manor with unknown intentions.

She seemed unable to figure out why, in an empty corridor where there was no one around, someone had somehow managed to brush her shoulder. She stood there pale-faced and frozen.

Chase looked again at June, growing smaller in the distance.

The darkness was boundless, and seemed almost to think.

There were no signposts in the dark, no sense of direction; the moment he looked away, he feared he would never find his way back to the path he was supposed to be on.

The young woman stepped deeper into the Key House manor corridor. June receded further into the darkness, growing smaller and smaller.

"...You remember now, don't you? You see — for the sake of protecting Key House, you abandoned even me. If you hadn't been lucky, you never would have found me again."

June laughed quietly and clicked her tongue a few times. "You definitely have to pay back what you owe me. So whatever I tell you to do, you do it — understood? No need to overthink it. Ah, but then, you can't overthink things anyway — there's barely a core left to you."

...So losing June had also been his own failure.

Chase took a long, deep breath and said, "All right."

"Besides, what I'm asking you to do is good for you too. That memory fragment that just drifted back — you saw it too, didn't you? A woman broke into your Key House. Am I right? I know who she is, and I know where she is now. Come with me."

June turned and gestured for Chase to follow.

No matter how much he quickened his pace, he could never close the distance. Without being able to hold her hand — could she make it back on her own?

He was just about to ask why he couldn't get through to her when June stopped first.

She lowered one hand from her face and pointed toward a hazy red-brick building deep in the darkness.

"You see it, right? She's there — about to meet up with your Key House people and start the Hunter interview. How can that be allowed to stand? She has to be killed, doesn't she, doesn't she! I can teach you how to strike when she's caught in the warehouse trap, oh oh oh oh oh oh oh oh"

I! Am going! To wear out! My Resident! Face!

From now on I can post selfies to my heart's content — anyone who sees this exhausted ghost face of mine will fall into the Nest and never find their way back.

Chapter 252: Mai Minghe, and Mai Minghe in the Mirror

When Mai Minghe raised her head, she found herself facing a hallway with peeling walls and dim, sickly lighting.

The fluorescent lights were failing at their job—like a mouthful of cavities from eating too much sugar—every few steps, one of the tubes had gone dark, leaving nothing but a rotted black void.

Even the remaining dim lights were unreliable; every now and then, a tube would flicker with a sharp snap, driving a split second of darkness straight into one's eyes.

.....What floor was she on?

It certainly didn't look anything like the entrance behind the ground-floor street-facing door; at the far end of the hallway was a narrow little window, through which she could faintly make out the rooftops of nearby buildings.

Mai Minghe listened carefully—aside from the fluorescent tubes' low drone, the hallway was utterly silent.

There was no one else nearby; the other four, along with that semi-translucent face, had all been scattered to some unknown corner of the building.

Maybe that semi-translucent face had stayed outside together with the Key House Hunters?

"This month, the production being staged at the Annie Warehouse theater is a contemporary piece—the story is set in a toy company struggling to stay afloat, not far from closure."

While giving his introduction at the entrance, Qiboli paused at that point and glanced at Mai Minghe, seeming to remember that she was short on experience and seniority, then added a clarifying note:

"These theaters in the Old Harbor of the Nest also have productions running—the shows rotate every so often. To us, they're deadly traps, but to the Residents, these 'plays' are their cultural entertainment...after all, there's no production they enjoy more than watching humans die."

He said this and let out a small laugh: "Honestly, I can't say I don't understand the appeal."

"Boli," Tianxi glanced at him.

Shaxue didn't react at all.

"Alright, alright. I just meant that if I died in the Nest, I'd definitely produce the most powerful Resident out there."

Qiboli reached up and idly ran a hand through his platinum hair, then returned to the matter at hand: "Under the influence of that month's production, the interior environment and scenery of the warehouse will change accordingly. Once we go in, we'll find that the entire building has transformed into that failing toy company."

It seemed the company had been quite successful at one point—the scale was not small, spanning more than one floor—even if the interior didn't look that large.

"...Once you enter, you'll find yourself placed randomly on one of the floors. The requirement to pass the interview is to return to the first floor within one hour and exit through the main door. Don't worry—the main door is not locked. As long as you can make it back to the first floor and find the main door, you'll be able to leave without any trouble."

She had listened to Qiboli's introduction word by word, carefully.

"Let me point out one thing first—something special about this particular theater. The first thing you should do after entering is to determine what your appearance has been changed into. Before you see your own appearance with your own eyes, it will remain a shifting, unfixed chaos—which means the theater can style and shape it however it pleases.

"Like the observer effect in physics—the moment you see your own appearance, it will truly become fixed and settle into one form. Once your appearance is fixed, the theater can no longer freely reshape what you look like.

"Remember: you must determine your appearance first, before taking any next steps."

He also said that within five minutes of entering, you had to find a way to see your own appearance with your own eyes; failing to confirm it within five minutes was as good as failing halfway already.

He never explained exactly why, though.

Despite the fact that he was briefing them on imminent dangers, he had smoothly skirted around every part that held any real peril.

Qiboli had, however, made one thing clear: after one hour, anyone who had not passed the trap would be considered completely failed.

At that point, the three Key House Hunters waiting outside Annie Warehouse would enter the building to carry out whatever rescue they could for any trapped interview candidates—provided, of course, there was still anyone left to rescue.

None of the Key House people had said outright just how dangerous the interior of this theater was; but judging from their tone and the way they spoke, it seemed likely that more than a few who'd gone in had never come back out.

Why would anyone risk so much just to join a House Faction?

Mai Minghe looked back—behind her was only a single door, connecting to a fire escape stairwell.

...A restroom. There had to be a restroom somewhere along this hallway.

She made her way along the corridor, step by careful step, moving quietly forward; her hand rested on the gun at her hip.

The gun had been given to her by Aimeli—the supply bag issued by Key House had contained more than one firearm. Lisidan had also given her some bullets, paper, and a pen; between the two of them, they had managed to piece together enough that Mai Minghe didn't walk in empty-handed.

While Aimeli was divvying up supplies for her, Mai Minghe had tried to probe, in a roundabout way, whether she thought the interview risks were too great.

"Taking this risk now is precisely so that once we're in a House Faction, we won't have to face dangers like this alone and completely unprepared anymore."

Aimeli had shaken her head at the time, continuing to dig through the supply bag, and said: "Life-threatening things happen in the Nest all the time, everywhere—no matter how much you guard against it, you'll still get dragged in. There's no defending against it completely. Since you're taking risks either way, you might as well take one that earns you House Faction backing. I've had enough of going solo."

Or rather, the real question ought to be: if it was so dangerous, why become a Hunter at all?

But Mai Minghe had a feeling that even if she asked, no one would be able to give her a satisfying answer.

Even she herself didn't know how to answer—but there was one thing she was perfectly clear on.

No matter how dangerous the Nest was, she still wanted to be a Hunter.

All along the hallway, Mai Minghe kept a wary eye on the doors on both sides—especially when passing glass doors, she would first stand off to the side and observe and wait a moment before taking a quick stride past—the hallway wasn't long, yet it still took her a minute or two before she reached the far end.

Fortunately, the interior of the company seemed relatively normal, fairly logical; the restroom was easy enough to find, right next to the break room at the end of the hallway.

Of course—what kind of company would make its employees navigate a maze just to use the bathroom?

That was all well and good, but when Mai Minghe stood at the entrance of the women's restroom, she couldn't help but feel a creeping sense of suspicion.

In Qiboli's briefing, he had left out every danger and trap that might possibly arise.

"...What we test a Hunter on, beyond their goals and character, is above all their ability. Whether they can detect the source of danger, whether they can recognize what is actually dangerous—that, too, is part of what's being tested. I obviously can't give away all the answers right from the start, can I?"

Which meant that the fact he had specifically emphasized the need to confirm one's appearance first—was it not only because this step was genuinely unusual and something no one would think of unprompted, but also perhaps because this very part concealed a hidden danger?

If all it took was walking into a restroom and taking a look in a mirror to complete an important step—wasn't that a little too simple...?

Mai Minghe first tilted her head and listened; the restroom was silent.

She pushed the door open a crack—for a moment, she half-expected to see the back of a long-haired woman in the corner again; but this restroom was empty, with no figure in sight.

The walls and floor were tiled in long, narrow ceramic tiles; there were three toilet stalls in total, facing two sinks.

Above each sink, a mirror had been mounted on the wall.

Before looking at the mirrors, Mai Minghe first bent down and checked the floor of every stall—she saw only the bases of the toilets, no feet.

...Things in the Nest—she wasn't sure whether they were required to have feet.

Mai Minghe ran through her memory and felt that every Resident she'd encountered so far had, at minimum, possessed feet; that was at least some consolation.

In the cold air thick with the smell of chemical cleaning agents, she carefully approached the first mirror.

Qiboli had said that after entering, one's appearance would change.

He had also said that the change in appearance was a crucial clue to solving the level.

...What had she been turned into?

Mai Minghe stood before the mirror, raised her head, and looked at the reflection staring back at her.

Her mind went completely blank; in what was almost a reflex of muscle memory, she raised one hand and opened the door.

Mai Minghe had no idea how to make sense of what she was seeing.

In all of 2024, I only went out to have fun once (music festivals don't count—they were too short); looking back now, it was all work, socializing, and dealing with nonsense. The whole year felt dim.

But 2025 is different! I caught a lucky break at the start of the year, and I can finally share it with everyone now (also for future reference when I need to take time off).

There's a cousin of mine who broke up with his girlfriend (no need to feel sorry for him—he brought it on himself). He'd originally planned a trip with her to Kenya to see the Great Migration, but that fell through, so he put out an open invitation in the family group chat... Kenya! The Great Migration! Take a guess whether I'm one of the people going!

Getting vaccinated this month, departing in March—just thinking about it gets me excited, ahhhh!

Sorry about that—the donkey ran off, but it won't go far.

I might have worn myself out lately and my immune system is down—today I seem to be coming down with a cold, feeling terrible, dizzy, weak, and breaking out in cold sweats. I pushed through and wrote 1,400 characters but I just can't hold on any longer. Taking a day off...

I won't take Saturday off—I'll make up today's missed update then. These days, even the donkey has earned comp time...

Chapter 253: The Lead Mai Minghe Cannot Escape

When she touched her face with her hands, everything still felt normal: skin, nose, eyebrows... all present and accounted for.

But when Mai Minghe opened her eyes and looked into the mirror, the young face that had returned to her life after more than sixty years was nowhere to be found.

The reflection still had a human body—right up to the neck, it was still the original Mai Minghe.

...Only the head and face were gone, replaced by a wooden carved door the size of a human head.

Was this a toy, or a decoration?

The doorframe formed a pointed arch; where the eyes had been were now brass filigree carvings; the ears had vanished, replaced by two black ornamental door columns. Occupying two-thirds of the face was a pair of double doors inlaid with ivory, complete with two thumb-sized door handles.

As if sleepwalking, Mai Minghe raised her hand toward the mirror, and following the reflection's movements, found a round door handle that had never existed on her face before.

Between her fingers there was nothing but air; yet in the mirror, her thumb and index finger had already closed gently around the round handle.

What followed was almost natural—she gave a pull, and one side of the mirrored door swung open.

...Mai Minghe had opened one side of the door on her face.

Was this even something that could happen to a person?

As that thought flashed through her mind, the small door she had pulled open revealed a mirror inside.

Both sides of the door on her face could be opened, and once they were, two-thirds of her face became mirror.

Mirror facing mirror, forming a long corridor of reflections—countless identical slices linked end to end—and countless Mai Minghes, each topped with a wooden-door mirror, stared back into the bathroom mirror.

...Her face had turned into a wooden carved door toy with a mirror inside. What was that supposed to mean?

Mai Minghe stared for a few moments, then truly could not bring herself to look at the mirror any longer.

The reflection held no head of hers—only countless wooden doors, and mirrors within mirrors within mirrors—a few extra glances were all it took to drag her into a sensation of weightless dislocation, as though she had lost all grip on her own body; she nearly stumbled and crashed into the bathroom counter.

Get out first and figure it out from there... Since she needed to go downstairs, finding the staircase was the obvious first step.

Suppressing a swirling dizziness, Mai Minghe closed "the door on her face" again; she walked out of the bathroom and drew a deep breath—and as she exhaled, the image that surfaced in her mind was a mirror slowly fogging over with white mist.

The feeling of having a toy-like wooden double door balanced on her neck was deeply strange, and looking for the staircase turned out to be a decent way to redirect her attention.

It took Mai Minghe two or three minutes to make a full circuit of the entire floor; when she finished, she stood still for a moment, dazed.

...That couldn't be right.

Mai Minghe set off again—a second circuit, a third, each one slower and more thorough than the last.

By the time she began her fourth search, it had become a true sweep: she found a utility knife in one of the offices, cut open and pulled up every strip of carpet in the workspace, and amid great billowing clouds of dust and debris—coughing, covering a mouth that existed only in the mirror—felt her way across every inch of the bare floor beneath.

Nothing.

This entire floor seemed to have been sealed shut with concrete: no elevator, no staircase, no hidden door, no passage of any kind leading downward.

What she had assumed was the door to the fire escape opened onto a solid wall.

...What about the windows? Could she leave through a window?

Not pausing to think about the dust coating her, Mai Minghe rushed toward the end of the corridor where she had first entered—anxiety rising, her footsteps quickened, stirring a draft around her; the draft struck the window at the corridor's far end and made whatever lay beyond flutter slightly.

Hm?

She stopped short, staring blankly, not quite trusting her own eyes.

Mai Minghe reached out and peeled up one corner of the "window."

The window—along with the sky and rooftop outside—turned out to be a photograph printed on a sheet of paper; because it had been made to the exact dimensions of a real window, it looked completely identical to one from any distance.

The photo had just started coming unstuck, and a gust of wind had lifted one corner, revealing the thick white wall behind it—not even a crack in it.

When she returned to the office and, with a lingering shred of hope, lifted the blinds, she found only more photographs pasted behind them, one after another—some showing the parking lot below, others showing the street beyond the perimeter wall.

With the blinds lowered, looking through the slats, it was utterly impossible to imagine that every view outside was fake.

Ventilation ducts... were there ventilation ducts?

Two minutes later, standing on a desk with a ventilation panel removed, Mai Minghe stared at the same solid block of concrete behind it and felt she really had no right to be surprised or disappointed anymore.

If there was anything she had gained from this search, it was just one thing: the room numbers all started with 3, running from 301 to 303—two large open-plan offices and one private office. That meant she was on the third floor.

The third floor.

If every floor was a sealed concrete block, even if she hammered her way down level by level, the time it would take to break through the floor and drop into the first floor would far exceed an hour—and even if she could break through reinforced concrete, where would a toy company office get a hammer?

Toy samples, though, there were plenty of those.

A few plush stuffed animals, puzzles, snap-together dolls, remote-control cars, and an assortment of other sample toys crowded a long table against the wall, watching Mai Minghe with their plastic eyes in perfect silence, as if waiting patiently to see whether the quiet unease growing inside her would blossom into full-blown claustrophobia.

She had been sealed inside a concrete block... worst case, if she couldn't get out, the air should at least last her an hour.

But even when that hour was up and the Key House people launched a rescue, where would they even enter from?

Wait—since this was a trial floor chosen by Key House, it couldn't possibly be a dead end with no way out...

Could it be that the carved wooden door and the mirror held some significance for getting downstairs?

Was her own appearance some kind of clue—was that why Qiboli had made a point of emphasizing it?

But Mai Minghe truly did not want to go back into that bathroom and face the mirror again.

Standing before it, the slightest tilt of her head was enough to set the mirror-within-mirror reflections spinning like a kaleidoscope—each Mai Minghe smaller than the last, each wooden door hiding another wooden door within it; the deeper she looked, the more her eyeballs seemed to swell, as though they might tumble out of her skull and roll end over end down that deep corridor of infinite wooden doors inside the mirror.

Mai Minghe was afraid that when she turned away from the mirror to leave, she herself would have already fallen into some unreachable depth—and the one walking out of the bathroom would only be "a Mai Minghe."

Of course, this fear was irrational and baseless—after all, there was no clue at the moment suggesting she was in any danger of falling into the mirror.

Oh?

Since her phone could take photos, surely it could take photos of herself too?

She just had to flip the phone around, point the rear camera at herself, and find the shutter button on the screen with her finger—wouldn't that let her capture what she looked like?

She vaguely remembered seeing tourists on the street take photos of themselves that way; that was probably how they did it.

Even in a moment like this, a small, ill-timed flicker of pride rose in Mai Minghe: Reed Hydes had never taught her this, and she had figured it out on her own.

Holding the phone behind her, locating the shutter button on the screen by feel was not easy; after two or three tries, she finally heard a click and quickly flipped the phone back around—in the photo, a carved wooden door faced the lens, its double panels shut tight, the mirror invisible.

...She had forgotten to open the door.

Mai Minghe's fingers hovered in the air above her cheek, close enough that even her fine hairs could sense the faint warmth of her fingertips.

She could not feel the door's handle, so she went by memory alone—guessing at the handle's position and making a rough "opening the door" gesture somewhere on her face—then tried to take a selfie again. After several rounds of this, she finally managed to take a clear photo: the door open, the mirror showing.

A photo of yourself with a wooden-door mirror balanced on your neck was admittedly unsettling to look at, but it was still far better than standing in front of an actual mirror; that sensation of being about to fall in, of weightlessness, was completely absent when viewing a photograph.

Mai Minghe enlarged the photo and examined the wooden door and mirror on her neck carefully.

She did not neglect the reflection in the mirror either—the back of the phone, the camera lens, the arm holding the phone, all were captured in it; but beyond the things she had already seen and expected to see, she found no clues at all.

...What now?

At a complete loss, Mai Minghe walked into the large open-plan office once more and collapsed with a thud into an office chair.

Only after sitting down did she feel it—her exhausted muscles were as heavy as if filled with concrete, and the wound on her foot burned in throbbing waves.

Rest for a few minutes first. The deeper the trouble, the more important it was to keep herself in good shape; panicking around like a headless fly was how you made mistakes, wasn't it?

Mai Minghe gave herself a reason to stay seated a little longer; her gaze drifted aimlessly around the office.

The carpet had been ruined by her cutting—pulled up in chunks and piled in heaps. Other than that, everything looked like a normally functioning office—or perhaps a little too normal.

Normal to the point where it felt as if the employees had been in the middle of their workday and simply vanished all at once.

Beside the computer in front of her sat a cup of coffee, long since unfinished and dried down to a hard shell of sediment; Mai Minghe accidentally nudged the mouse, and the screen lit up, asking for a password she didn't know.

...So the Nest had computers too? They must have been generated along with the building, right?

She had decided to rest, yet without realizing it, she had already risen to her feet.

Some chairs still had coats and bags draped over them; she found half a packet of biscuits in one of the drawers; on one desk sat a photo of a child who looked—Mai Minghe thought, well, she shouldn't say anything unkind.

The real find came when Mai Minghe passed by the printer and, on a sudden impulse, bent down to look.

She reached in and picked up the stack of papers that, since the day they were printed, had never been touched by anyone.

February 2025, Week One Work Summary Minutes (for use at the weekly meeting)

This week's meeting topic: Where exactly is Miss Jones hiding?

(And: how much time do we have left to find Miss Jones? If we can't find her, who will be next? Etc.—thirty minutes reserved for open discussion.)

Thank you all for your concern—I was truly feeling unwell yesterday and didn't reply to any of you... I feel quite guilty about it. I'm a bit better today; it doesn't seem like a cold, but I'm not sure what's wrong with me. Anyway, I finished writing the second half of the chapter.

Chapter 254: Where Is Miss Jones?

The toy company's conference room was easy to find—just behind the second large open workspace, a perfectly ordinary rectangle of a room.

Mai Minghe peered through the glass door and immediately knew she had come to the right place.

The conference table was scattered with countless faintly yellowing slips of paper and documents; several thick binders lay open; the whiteboard bore lingering pen marks, diagrams, and several bright-red "???"s left by a marker—and on the opposite wall of the conference room, a full wall of employee headshots had been posted.

Four rows of photos in total, five photos per row; each one roughly the size of an A4 sheet, like the kind of photos actors use for auditions.

At least a dozen of the photos had large red X's slashed across the faces.

As Mai Minghe quietly pushed the door open, she instinctively held her breath—as if not breathing might somehow spare her from the misfortune the conference room seemed to portend.

Five chairs, corresponding to a total of three notebooks and two laptops on the table—suggesting that five people had attended the meeting.

A company with at least twenty office employees, and only five people left to attend the weekly meeting...

The writing remaining on the whiteboard was hurried and erratic, mentally unstable—as though the letters might crash into one another at any moment, leaving a mess of scattered limbs behind.

1. The last person to see Miss Jones

(Location, time, what she was doing, what she said, where Miss Jones might be hiding??

The closing parenthesis was never written; the person writing had simply stopped mid-sentence, the final question mark arcing wildly toward the edge of the whiteboard as if trying to fly off it entirely.

Had the same handwriting not reappeared a short distance away in smaller script—"Doesn't seem like Jones is in the conference room! Conference room = safe?"—Mai Minghe might truly have assumed something had happened to the writer.

She figured the person must have finished writing that line and only then suddenly remembered to check the conference room... wait.

Shouldn't she check as well?

Mai Minghe quickly swept her gaze around the room, then pulled out a chair, bent down, and peered into the dim shadowy space beneath the conference table.

She let out a breath of relief.

She'd been overthinking it—there was no one under the table. Only a small child crouching there.

Mai Minghe had just straightened up when her scalp suddenly erupted in a burst of alarm; she stumbled backward, her back slamming against the conference room door with a thud, and half a shriek floated off her lips and dropped into the hushed and still air, falling to the floor.

She stood there breathing rapidly, staring at the dark stretch of carpet under the table, and after a few seconds, leaned in for another look—it was not a child.

It was only a child-shaped doll, its limbs twisted and arranged into a crouching pose, the raised corners of its mouth fixed into a blank, wooden smile.

Mai Minghe had no desire to touch it, and equally no desire to share a room with it; she wavered for a few seconds, and ultimately the latter feeling won out—if she wanted to read the writing on the whiteboard, she would have to turn her back to the conference table. The mental image of that child-like doll slowly crawling out from beneath the table was far worse than anything else she could think of; she steeled herself, grabbed the doll with one hand, and hurled it out of the conference room.

2. How many employees were actually in this company's third-floor office to begin with, and who were they?

Who among the employees can still appear here, alive?

Can all of them be found in the HR roster?

Patricia

Aoshu

Liremon

Eugene

Jie

Laura

Six names in total? On reflection, it made sense.

Five people had been sitting at the conference table, with one more serving as the facilitator—though "facilitating a meeting" was perhaps less accurate than "running an emergency war council."

The checkmarks meant these six people could all be found in the employee roster? But why did they need to confirm this?

Wasn't their problem that employees were disappearing one by one?

Mai Minghe quickly realized that her initial guess had been correct; because on the table lay a printed sheet that was exactly what she thought—the company's employee list.

The list had twenty names in total; she skimmed through it quickly and was about to set it down when her hand suddenly paused.

The six names on the whiteboard were indeed all on the employee list—all people who had been with the company for at least two or three years—and had checkmarks beside them. When they held their meeting, they must have taken particular care to confirm that every person present was someone who was supposed to be there at that time and place.

And yet Mai Minghe couldn't shake the feeling that there was a problem with this list.

She stood there in a daze for a moment, her gaze drifting back to the whiteboard, and then a sudden jolt of understanding ran through her.

..."Jones" was not on the employee list.

It probably wasn't a case of someone removing Jones's name after she disappeared; because aside from the six people on the whiteboard, the names of all the other missing colleagues were still there.

So... who was Jones?

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes and leaned close to the whiteboard.

The writing after "3." had been wiped away, leaving only a ghost-like faint smear; whether it was her imagination filling in the blanks or not, Mai Minghe felt that what had been written after the 3 was probably those same four words—"Who is Jones?"

...Could it be that the six people who had once held their weekly meeting in this very conference room had made the same discovery as Mai Minghe?

Shouldn't they have known better than anyone who their own colleagues were?

She couldn't make sense of it; and she had no idea what any of this had to do with her escaping the third floor—but Mai Minghe had only this one thread to follow, so she kept pulling at it.

4. What products does the company make?

Including products from the company's past history

Below 4 was blank—nothing written at all; likely because there wasn't enough room on the whiteboard for that section—the illustrated binders Mai Minghe had spotted on the table turned out to be product catalogs from the toy company's recent years, and in the margins, someone had filled every bit of white space with the names of products they could remember, written in a handwriting that bordered on frenzied.

Strange...

These people seemed neither certain that everyone present was truly a colleague, nor able to recall whether there had been a colleague named Jones among them, nor did they know where "Jones" was. Most of their colleagues had apparently gone missing, yet here they were, methodically going through every product the company had ever released?

Mai Minghe's head was so full of "why" that the questions inside her skull were nearly pushing her eyes out of their sockets.

She skipped straight past the laptops on the table—long since dead—and opened the most recent notebook, flipping to the last section with writing in it.

1. Jie

Around 2:30 this afternoon, the break room

Jones: "I'm going to find somewhere to hide on the third floor, and you're all going to come find me."

Jie: "What are you talking about?"

Jones: "I won't cheat—I'll stay on the third floor. The stairwell, outside the windows, or the ventilation ducts don't count as the third floor, so I won't be hiding in any of those places. You can rule those out."

Jie: "Hold on, what do you mean? Do you know why the stairs disappeared? Do you know how to get out? Where did everyone else go?"

Jones: "Don't you all have your weekly meeting this afternoon? Work out a strategy together first, then come find me—that's fine too. Or you can each look for me one by one. Whatever you prefer."

Jie: "I told you, I don't understand what you're saying!"

(Note: throughout this conversation, Jie did not recognize Jones's identity at all!!)

The sentence inside the parentheses had two exclamation marks, with three heavy underlines beneath it.

Jones: "Before this, Little Carter and the others never found me. I hope you all have better luck than they did—after all, hide-and-seek does have a time limit."

Jie: "Wait, you know where Little Carter and the others went? Did you make them play find-you too?"

Jones: "It's starting."

(Jones left the break room; Jie ran out after her, but there was no one outside the door.)

Mai Minghe furrowed her brow.

It was fortunate that someone had written down the discussion from the meeting in such detail.

So then... the toy company employees—or rather, the "toy company employees" the Nest had created—had already gone through what she was currently experiencing: the third floor becoming a sealed concrete block with no way out.

Among the toy company employees, there was a "Jones" whom no one could identify; they were forced to play hide-and-seek with Jones, searching the third floor for where she was hiding.

What the benefit of finding her was, no one knew yet; but failing to find her clearly meant disappearing one by one—until a twenty-person office was reduced to six.

Mai Minghe turned to the next page of the notebook.

The content on the next page struck her retinas like a sudden shove, briefly jolting her thoughts out of alignment.

2. Six people in total attended the weekly meeting.

We printed out photos of all employees and posted them on the wall. Those who have gone missing get a red X.

Because no one can remember what Jones looks like, we had no choice but to use a process of elimination.

Mai Minghe read through this passage, then turned her head and stared at the photos on the wall for a long moment.

Four rows, five photos each, twenty people in total.

But fifteen of those photos had red X's on them.

I've been vegetarian for quite a while this time—over a year now, I think? But because I'm too lazy to plan my meals properly and I can't stand spinach, I seriously suspect I'm iron-deficient...? Anyway, it's been three days—I feel weak and my hands are shaking, and I'm in rough shape overall. If taking iron supplements tomorrow doesn't help, I'll go see a doctor.

Speaking of vegetarianism... I didn't know the brand Ma Liuji before—saw it on sale and just grabbed three packs on a whim.

Now I know it all too well... When I think about the fact that I contributed twelve yuan to that mother and son duo, I feel so uncomfortable and bitter!! It feels like I've wronged Da S and my childhood.

Chapter 255: Mai Minghe Searches for the Jones Level

Could Jones actually be one of the six people at the meeting?

Had no one else noticed?

Mai Minghe stood there in a daze for a moment, then strode around the conference table, grabbed the other two notebooks, and flipped through them quickly—in the second notebook, a single line was written with heavy pressure: "Action Plan," the pen tip nearly punching through to the back of the page, with several circles drawn around it.

Jones: adult, possibly female—at least Jie believes the other party is female

Height approximately 5.5 feet (167 cm)

Places that could hide an adult woman???

We should not split up

Divide the third floor into sections, conduct searches together, move together, cannot split up

Think about horror movies

Break room

Room 301 (including sample cabinet)

Room 302 (including conference room)

Manager's office

Men's restroom

Women's restroom

Electrical room

Is it supernatural??? Is it a haunting??? Then "Jones" might also appear in a form we can't comprehend, right?

Should we check every humanoid object in the company???

Haha, why don't we just shout into every corner: "I found you"—see if that thing comes out

Going crazy, going crazy, I want to go home so badly

Mai Minghe closed the notebook.

The person recording had slashed the pen across the page hard enough to tear it at the very last stroke—after "want to go home," not a single word more was written.

...Things crossed out with a pen meant they'd already been searched but turned up nothing, right?

Through the glass door of the conference room, she swept a glance across the office with its rows of work cubicles. Outside was utterly silent; the fluorescent lights seemed to have been frozen alongside the computer desks, the coats draped over chairs, the trash cans under the desks, and the water dispenser in the corner—all suspended in a pocket of time.

The third-floor office, seemingly untouched by any outsider ever since the "search for Jones" began, made one thing unmistakably clear: within the span of a single day, everyone had vanished—not a single survivor remained.

No one had found Jones—did that also mean Jones was still hidden somewhere in a corner of the third floor?

Was that why every means of reaching the outside world had remained absent?

It seemed the interview level Key House had prepared for Hunters was this one; it was precisely because there was no passage out that their definition of clearing the level was to return to the front door on the first floor...

The Hunters sent to other floors probably each had their own different levels.

Although she didn't know what significance the wooden-door mirror around her neck held, at least every clue so far pointed to one thing: Mai Minghe had to keep "searching for Jones."

...Of the six people at the meeting, who was Jones?

Mai Minghe looked at the names on the whiteboard again.

Patricia

Aoshu

Liremon

Eugene

Jie

Laura

Neither of the first two notebooks had recorded the owner's name, so the only person who could currently be ruled out as Jones was "Jie."

Aoshu, Liremon, and Eugene all appeared to be male names, making it slightly less likely—though not impossible—that any of them was "Jones"...

Amid her jumbled thoughts, Mai Minghe opened the third notebook—and almost immediately realized that this one was likely her greatest hope for cracking the Jones mystery.

The reason was simple: the notebook's owner, Eugene, had not only written his name inside, but had also recorded the entire situation in exhaustive detail, almost like a diary entry, right up until the moment he himself disappeared.

5:15 PM

(Time to get off work, yet none of us can go home.)

(I vow to write down everything. If Jones can distort our perception, then written records are the only reliable source of truth.)

Following Aoshu's suggestion, we thoroughly searched the office several more times. We checked inside every cabinet, under every desk, behind every sofa, even inside the refrigerator.

Aoshu said that if it was a haunting, we should also check every humanoid object—and when you think carefully about how many humanoid objects there are in a toy company, it's enough to make you deeply uneasy.

Even though Jie kept insisting that the other party was in the form of an adult and couldn't hide inside a toy, we still squeezed and cut open every humanoid doll.

Mai Minghe quietly made a mental note: so the second notebook belonged to Aoshu.

That meant Jie, Eugene, and Aoshu—all three of them could be ruled out, couldn't they?

Just now in the office, Mai Minghe hadn't gone to look at the toy samples; but looking back, if she had, she probably would have found the traces the missing employees had left behind—the guts of those toys split open.

She turned the page.

*

After checking the humanoid toys, we returned to the conference room.

Everyone is desperate... Aoshu is furious, kicking the wall and cursing "Jones" with a string of profanities. Since coming back, Jie has been sitting there blankly.

Laura cried softly for a long time, on and off. Patricia consoled her for a few words at first and is now pretending not to hear. Honestly, I also find the sound of her crying deeply unsettling.

Liremon has been trying to analyze the situation, laying out multiple possibilities; in the end he said he thinks we're experiencing a collective hallucination—thank goodness he said "collective." If he thought the rest of us were products of his own hallucination, there's no telling what he might do to us.

I've already thrown up twice. When the pressure gets to be too much, I just...

No Jones in the toilet, at least.

*

Mai Minghe furrowed her brow and counted the names in these few paragraphs.

Wait—including Eugene, the one doing the writing, wasn't that already six people?

Though it didn't seem all that strange, really...

"Jones" apparently could scramble people's perception—face to face, no one would know that the person in front of them was something they had never met before, something that might not even be human.

So when Eugene recorded each person's behavior, he would naturally treat that person as a real colleague—if it were obvious from a glance that something was wrong, they would have found Jones long ago.

But given that, could Mai Minghe still find any clues?

*

6:02 PM

To keep up our strength, everyone reluctantly ate a little from the refrigerator. Judging by the times the other colleagues disappeared, we probably have about two more hours—if we don't find Jones, will we meet the same fate and vanish too???

I can't bear to think about it.

Just thinking about it turns my stomach; I don't want to make another run to the restroom.

Patricia brought up something terrifying.

"Were there always this many samples in the company?" she asked.

She's the product designer with the most seniority, yet she said she suddenly noticed that many of the samples displayed around the company were ones she seemed to have never seen before today.

Could the colleagues who disappeared have...?

The thought was too absurd for anyone to say aloud, yet everyone must have arrived at the same conclusion. Laura kept praying softly.

We quickly decided to find the company's product catalog and compare it against the existing samples.

We don't know where to look for Jones anyway, and sitting around doing nothing is still sitting around.

The samples were left in a mess after we'd been through them, so we had to reorganize them first, then compare them against the product catalog one by one. For older models not in the catalog, Patricia wrote down the ones she could remember.

*

Mai Minghe turned her head and glanced out through the door.

The small child doll she had thrown out earlier was still in the position it had landed in—limbs scattered, heaped on the floor; its head lolled sideways from its shoulder, staring fixedly at the conference room door.

...It hadn't moved, had it?

The faint, fragmented reflection on the glass door dimly showed part of the carved wooden door; Mai Minghe's gaze swept past her own reflection and fell back onto the notebook.

*

The results are in.

I don't know how to make sense of this... I was overthinking it after all.

The dozen or so colleagues who disappeared did not join the ranks of the toys. Everyone had recalled there being roughly ten to twenty samples in the office; after checking, there were exactly twenty—no more, no less.

With that many samples, it's perfectly normal for Patricia not to remember some, or to misremember—even Patricia herself has started to doubt her own memory.

When we first discovered the sample count was correct, Aoshu was very displeased and complained that Patricia had wasted precious time.

(P.S.: He also said my keeping records is a waste of time. But I think the real reason he doesn't like me recording is that he dislikes the feeling of leaving behind something like a death message.)

But we quickly discovered that not a single one of the twenty samples was a toy the company had produced.

Sorry, updates have been really short lately—I haven't been feeling well. I've been taking iron supplements for a couple of days with some improvement, but very little; lifting my phone is still a struggle.

It's that feeling of holding your hand up in midair for a long, long time before letting it drop—fingertips hollow, like there's no blood in them, let alone any strength.

I've been writing the update in fits and starts, not daring to miss a post, yet worried that my condition will make the writing worse...

I may need to see a doctor on Monday.

Chapter 256: Mai Minghe and Jones's Hiding Scheme

Most of the notes in Eugene's notebook were written in shorthand.

Although he had already been writing faster, the strokes in the sections that followed grew increasingly hurried and sloppy—sometimes a whole word was dashed off as a single squiggling line, making it quite difficult for Mai Minghe to decipher.

*

Things got a bit chaotic after that. I'll try to record them in order.

While we were examining those twenty unfamiliar toys, someone—I'm not sure who—said, "Twenty employees, twenty toys."

That line has been weighing on my mind ever since, and I think the others felt the same. At the very least, Jie had definitely made the connection between the two...

Everyone was inspecting the toys one by one while secretly sizing each other up, trying to match a person to a toy.

But we wasted at least ten or more minutes for nothing, and still couldn't figure out what those twenty unfamiliar toys had to do with any of us.

Jie said the little girl on the cover of a coloring book looked a bit like her.

The skin tone and eye color were indeed the same...

But Liremon argued that didn't prove anything—it was just a poorly drawn cartoon girl, and Jie had brown eyes, which were common. (I personally thought the girl looked more like a loaf of bread than anything.)

No one else found a toy that seemed to represent them.

The idea that "if we don't find Jones, we'll turn into toys" seemed truly too absurd—if anything, it felt even more absurd than the stairs and windows suddenly vanishing.

Besides, if the people who disappeared had become toys, the number of toys here should be fourteen, not twenty—the six of us hadn't disappeared yet.

In the end we split into two camps: one believed the unfamiliar toys had appeared alongside Jones and that there must be a connection worth analyzing carefully.

The other camp believed the toys might just be a "red herring"—a false clue designed to divert our attention and throw us off—and that the toys had appeared purely to waste our time.

I sat on the fence: whichever side started making their case, I'd find myself agreeing with them.

When we put the next course of action to a vote, both sides turned on me at once.

...Strange. Who was it that said those words in the first place?

*

Reading this far, Mai Minghe turned her head and glanced at the children's doll outside the door.

It hadn't moved, still frozen in its original pose.

She thought for a moment, then carried the notebook out with her and nudged the doll a few times with the tip of her foot—it was made of hard plastic and couldn't be cut open; but the moment she pried apart its outer clothing with her toe, she could see it was riddled with several scissor punctures, clearly left behind by Eugene's group when they had searched it for Jones.

So the toys had never been swapped out—they were still the same batch.

Mai Minghe took the opportunity to check all the toy samples in the office once more and confirmed that the total was indeed twenty items; among them was one coloring book with a little girl drawn on the cover.

But what connection could these toys possibly have with the employees?

*

If you ask me what the one silver lining in this nightmare is, all I can say is that the manager disappeared along with everyone else—what a relief.

Though the moment I think that I might end up sharing his fate—

*

Eugene had perhaps tried to write something lighthearted to lift his spirits, but the effort had clearly failed.

Below that abruptly broken sentence, he had added: "Ugh, I can't keep thinking about what happened to them—I almost threw up on my own lap just now."

Those children... they must have been terrified in their final moments, mustn't they?

Mai Minghe reminded herself that this was the Nest, and they might not have been living people at all.

Yet precisely because this was the Nest—unpredictable as it was—she couldn't be certain whether they had ever truly been alive or not. What if they had?

She let out a quiet sigh and swept her gaze across the page.

Since everything was written on paper with the same pen, it was hard to tell—without Eugene using a phrase like "just now"—that there had in fact been a gap of some time between one sentence and the next.

...Hm?

Something about that felt important.

Mai Minghe turned the thought over slowly in her mind several times and committed it to memory, then murmured softly to herself: "This seems important... I'll think more about why later. I can't work it out right now."

Since entering the third-floor office, this was the first time she had made a sound—her own voice, unmistakably hers, yet dropping without warning into the hushed, still air, floating before a wall full of red-crossed photographs, slightly tight, slightly dry, and somehow like a stranger's voice entirely.

Mai Minghe held her breath and waited a few seconds—thankfully, no other voice suddenly rang out to answer her.

She really was quite good at frightening herself.

*

We had no other options, so we searched every corner of the third floor all over again.

The results were no different from last time.

There aren't many places an adult could hide... It's past seven now, and aside from the scratch of my pen, no one in the conference room has spoken for quite a while.

More than once, I thought they had all disappeared and my heart nearly leapt out of my chest; but every time I looked up, everyone was still there—just too despairing and dejected to say

a word.

*

Somehow, we ended up arguing about what "Jones" actually is.

Liremon refused to take part in the discussion; he went off to check the break room and the pipes outside, hoping to find the "toxic gas" that had caused our collective hallucination. Aoshu told him not to act on his own—he didn't listen at all.

Patricia believed that "Jones" was the monster lurking in each of our hearts—a primal fear of Neanderthals buried in the collective unconscious of Homo sapiens, a remnant of our evolutionary history.

Aoshu mocked her for still spouting the kind of high-minded nonsense only a psychiatrist would say, even at a time like this.

I think Jones might be something supernatural that happens to take human form—perhaps some kind of ghost or curse, something out of a horror film.

Jie agreed with me; but Aoshu refused to accept that any force beyond the reach of science could exist.

Anyone could see that Aoshu was very frightened.

That line must never fall under his eyes.

*

Mai Minghe turned the page, and when she saw the next sentence, her blood seemed to stop for a moment.

*

I flipped back several pages—Laura was definitely among us at the start

*

...What did that mean?

Laura had suddenly vanished?

Even Mai Minghe couldn't help flipping back several pages and hurriedly reading through the notes again; sure enough, though not many times, Eugene had mentioned Laura a few times.

But in the two most recent sections, everyone had appeared—yet only Laura had disappeared from the notes... When had she gone missing?

Laura didn't look to have left on her own. Could she have vanished soundlessly while surrounded by the others?

*

Had the time limit run out?

Why did it start with Laura disappearing? Wasn't Jie the first one among us that Jones had called upon to find her?

And we'd waited for several minutes without disappearing either.

Even Liremon, who had gone out alone, came back just fine when he heard our crying and shouting.

In the end, it was Patricia who dried her tears and put forward an idea that temporarily calmed everyone down.

"Laura must have belonged to one of the earlier groups sent to find Jones—she wasn't part of our wave."

We asked her why.

She pulled out the employee roster and said that Laura's name was in the first ten, while the five of us remaining were all in the last section.

The order in which Jones called employees to play hide-and-seek with her appeared to follow the employee roster.

The reason Laura hadn't disappeared along with the previous wave but had instead stayed with us for several hours was that Laura had recently been helping her sister look after a child, hadn't slept well the night before, and had snuck into the conference room during lunch that day to catch up on sleep—Patricia had known about it at the time and had even covered for her in front of the manager when he came looking.

"I remember glancing around the office and wondering why it felt so empty that day. Looking back now, the first batch of colleagues who were supposed to go find Jones but treated the whole thing as a joke had already disappeared by then. As for whether the stairs were sealed before or after that, I really don't know."

In other words, Laura should originally have been one of the people in the previous wave to go find Jones.

But because she was asleep at the time (it's unclear whether she had already received the request to go find Jones before falling asleep—looking back now, it seems very likely she had, only she hadn't taken it seriously), the time she spent sleeping had been temporarily "frozen"—and when she woke up, she was pushed into our wave instead.

None of us knew whether this reasoning was actually correct, but I think the others, like me, were desperately hoping to believe it.

After all, it would mean that as long as we fell asleep right now... our own inevitable disappearance could be pushed back—couldn't it?

Maybe by the time the sun rose tomorrow, everything would be back to normal.

We're going to try to sleep.

*

Mai Minghe immediately reached out and grabbed the employee roster.

"JL Toy Company Employee Roster"

Sales and Marketing Department:

Leikoni, Little Carter, Melina, Bailey, Julilan

Administration and Customer Service Department:

David

Finance and Accounting Department:

Gabler, Angelina, Laura

Human Resources Department:

Flores, Hayman.

Production Department:

Felix, Trisha, Aiden, Scott, Eugene.

Design and Development Department:

Patricia, Jie, Aoshu, Liremon.

Patricia was right—Laura was indeed listed on her own up at the front, under the Finance and Accounting Department, while the other five were all at the very end.

Mai Minghe set down the roster and sat in a brief daze, then looked back at the wall full of red-crossed photographs.

...Something seemed a little off.

She picked up Eugene's notebook again.

She had actually noticed just moments ago that after the group decided to sleep, Eugene had not written another word; but unwilling to accept it, she had flipped through once more before finally setting the notebook down with a sullen reluctance.

Even if Eugene had truly managed to fall asleep in those circumstances, he couldn't have escaped the final outcome through sleep alone; so without a doubt, because no one had found Jones, everyone had disappeared together in the end.

Mai Minghe sat motionless in the chair for quite a while, not making a sound.

...She thought she might have guessed where Jones was hiding.

I'm worried my physical issues might be diet-related, so I've scheduled an appointment to see a doctor.

But after booking it, I discovered that the appointment falls on the exact same day as my vaccine shot! And the vaccine can't be rescheduled—I need to leave about a month for it to take effect, and March 12th is when I'm leaving, so this is the last possible chance to get it.

Not a single way out left for me... Even healthy people feel awful for a day or two after a vaccine shot—and I'm going to get one in the state I'm in...

Chapter 257: Mai Minghe Found You, Jones

Mai Minghe grabbed a pen from the table. Three notebooks, the employee roster, and several blank sheets of A4 paper were spread out before her.

Trying to call out "I found you" in hopes of flushing Jones out—the JL Toy Company employees must have already tried that trick.

In their long, desperate, fruitless search, they had probably tried every method they could think of—Mai Minghe had even found, on one of the sheets of paper, a short prayer written in someone's hand.

...Probably Laura? She seemed to be the only one who was religious.

And she was the first to disappear.

This meant that unless the person searching for Jones was one hundred percent certain—unless they were staring directly at "Jones" with their own eyes and declaring that they had found it—"Jones" would not show itself.

"...So the first step to drawing you out is to tell you exactly how I know where you're hiding. Only by following a chain of thought and analysis to its one and only conclusion will you be convinced that I have truly found you—rather than just trying to bluff you."

Mai Minghe listened to her own voice fall and dissolve into the silence, and even though she knew no one would answer, she added: "Right?"

She opened the first notebook and said, "Then let's begin. I want to start with the trap you set."

The conference room was dead silent; beyond the door, a small doll tilted its head, staring vacantly into the room.

"Your hiding place is already far beyond what anyone could imagine—incredibly difficult to find—and yet you still left a misleading red herring, hoping to trap those who came after in the same snare, so they would fail one after another.

"That trap was this: 'Jones is hiding among the last six people.'"

The reason she had been misled in the first place was something very simple.

The first notebook read as follows:

2. There were six participants in the weekly meeting in total.

We printed out photos of all the employees and posted them on the wall. Those who went missing got a red X.

Since nobody can remember what Jones actually looks like, we had no choice but to use the process of elimination.

But when Mai Minghe turned around, she found that fifteen of the photos on the wall had been marked with red Xs.

"Twenty employees in total, fifteen missing, and yet six people still remain for the weekly meeting? Given that Jones can alter people's perception—so thoroughly that you can't tell face-to-face whether someone is your colleague or not—it seems highly likely that one of the last six is Jones. That reasoning is perfectly logical, isn't it?

"What's more, the last group of employees turned the third floor upside down and couldn't find Jones anywhere, which seems to further suggest that Jones had slipped in among them."

Mai Minghe let out a sigh.

"To be honest, at first I was also trying to figure out which of the six was Jones—even attempting to narrow it down based on what the notebooks said."

But when she was reading Eugene's notebook, she suddenly realized that when a later reader sees only words written on paper, they have no way of telling how much time passed between one entry and the next.

...Wasn't it the same with the red Xs drawn on the photos?

"Where is the evidence that all fifteen red Xs were drawn at the same time? Given that Laura disappeared afterward, the most likely scenario is actually this—only fourteen photos had red Xs at first. Someone added the X on Laura's photo only after she vanished.

"In other words, Jones is not hiding among the last six people. Spending all that time trying to figure out which one of them is Jones was falling right into the trap—moving further from the truth."

She thought for a moment, tapping her fingers a few times on Aoshu's notebook.

"The theory that 'Jones is one of the six' is a bit like a conspiracy theory. All it takes is one small initial fact—say, an inconsistency between the number of unmarked photos and the number of remaining people—and once you accept that one small fact, you automatically start finding all kinds of 'supporting evidence' to complete the narrative."

For instance, Aoshu had clearly written in his notebook that he was worried the office was haunted, and yet once night fell and Laura disappeared, he refused to accept that supernatural forces existed in the world—didn't that seem like two completely different people?

But in reality, when people face fear and confusion that they cannot comprehend or name, as despair deepens, they may instead fall into denial: the deeper the despair, the more they want to close their eyes and not look.

Or, for that matter—had Laura ever truly existed?

"So situations like these, which can be explained in multiple ways, cannot be treated as ironclad proof—they shouldn't even be dwelt on, to avoid being led astray. As for genuinely solid evidence, I've found two pieces so far."

First: the remaining six employees had all experienced a degree of blurring in their sense of their colleagues' identities.

It wasn't only their perception of "Jones" that was blurred—when the remaining six held their final weekly meeting, they sat face to face looking at one another and still could not be certain that the person across from them was truly their colleague.

"This was a clue written plainly on the whiteboard, and yet somehow, as I read through the notebook records, it gradually receded and retreated to a corner of my mind."

On the whiteboard were three questions written one after another: How many employees were originally in this third-floor office, and who were they? Which employees are still alive and able to appear in person? Can all of them be found in the HR roster?

Mai Minghe swept her gaze across the whiteboard, then immediately turned back.

"Let's look at the employee roster again. Besides Eugene and Laura, the remaining four are all from the same department. They didn't trust their own memories or perceptions—even for colleagues in the same department, they couldn't say for certain that person had ever existed.

"They may have remembered certain moments they'd shared, had some impression of the others, but they were also afraid that all of it was perception that had been manipulated and

altered.

"So the method the six of them adopted was this: each person had to announce their name one by one, and then that name had to be found and checked off on the employee roster before anyone could confirm that this person had originally been a company employee—and not Jones."

Even for people sitting right there in front of them, alive and in the flesh, they couldn't be sure—they had to rely on the employee roster to verify identities.

So what about the people who had vanished?

Mai Minghe's pen circled a sentence in the first notebook.

"...Since nobody can remember what Jones actually looks like, we had no choice but to use the process of elimination," she read aloud softly.

"The first time I read this, I didn't think much of it and passed right over it. But after I'd gone through all the clues, this sentence became far more meaningful."

Mai Minghe pushed the notebook aside and glanced at the photos covering the wall.

"These six people couldn't even be certain about the colleagues sitting right in front of them. Would they really have had a clear memory of each and every person who had disappeared—clear enough to apply a process of elimination?"

Not only was this implausible, there was also no evidence that they remembered the missing people clearly at all.

"So what did they actually use for the process of elimination? If their perception was already unreliable, how could they eliminate anyone?"

Mai Minghe swept her gaze across the conference table, as if trying to see the six desperate people who had once sat there. "The answer is obvious. They used themselves as the basis for elimination."

In other words, their reference point was themselves.

Anyone in the photos who was not currently sitting in that conference room attending the weekly meeting could be identified as a missing colleague.

"That is the first solid and reliable piece of evidence," Mai Minghe concluded. "The second is —"

Second: something wrong with the employee roster.

"The roster lists twenty people in total, organized by department, but there is no manager."

Mai Minghe gestured toward the wall—rows of faces pinned beneath red Xs, each wearing a slight smile as they gazed back at her.

"...That's a little strange, but not entirely inexplicable."

Technically, a manager is also an "employee," but the roster seemed to count only ordinary staff, without including management positions.

"And that is your sleight of hand."

Mai Minghe glanced back at the small doll lying on the floor outside the door.

"Throughout this entire game of hide-and-seek—'find Jones'—it is constantly emphasized that JL Toy Company has twenty people in total...twenty names on the roster, twenty photos on the wall. But the truly brilliant stroke is that one line."

Mai Minghe gestured toward the door. "Twenty employees, twenty toys."

The twenty unfamiliar toys were indeed a red herring, but not for the purpose of making people waste time guessing at the connection between the toys and the employees—though of course, if it happened to waste time along the way, so much the better.

Their purpose was to make everyone believe the JL Toy Company employee roster was accurate—after all, even the strange and eerie supernatural force had matched each person to a toy one by one; surely JL Toy Company had exactly twenty employees, didn't it?

"You wanted everyone to fix the number '20' firmly in their minds. As long as the total came to 20, it would automatically feel right—no one would think to question the number..."

"I fell for it too, which is why it took me quite a while to realize that the photos on the wall should number twenty-one.

"Even if the employee roster doesn't include management, there is no reason to exclude the manager from the photos of the missing—is there? The most important evidence is right there in Eugene's notebook, where it is clearly written that the manager was also among the missing.

"This means the employee roster is incorrect. There is one extra name on it that shouldn't be there, occupying the manager's slot.

"It is entirely possible that the six of them—Eugene and the others—never noticed the extra name, because when they were cross-referencing the roster, their focus wasn't on identifying who had gone missing—given how blurred their perception was, they might not have recognized those names anyway—they were only looking for themselves on the list.

"At this point, whether the manager's photo is on the wall, or which specific name is the extra one, no longer matters...what matters is the message it conveys."

Mai Minghe rapped her knuckles on the employee roster on the table.

In a Nest level, clues to the solution must be left for the Hunters, in order to guarantee a certain degree of fairness.

The manager's "absence" was a clue that a Hunter could notice—one that indirectly ensured fairness.

If the discrepancy on the roster had involved only an ordinary employee in an ordinary department, how could an outsider—someone who had no idea who worked at JL Toy Company—ever have spotted the irregularity?

"Excluding management, the roster should have contained only nineteen names—yet there is one extra. Which name is the extra one, I don't know, but the extra name belongs to someone who is, in theory, among the disappeared.

"And that is the most important hint.

"Jones is not hiding among 'those who remain'—Jones is hiding among 'those who have already disappeared.'

"At first I thought I had reasoned myself into a dead end...most people had already vanished, so how could Jones be hiding among people who no longer exist? Then I remembered—the people who disappeared are all still here. They simply exist in another form."

She stood up and walked slowly to the far end of the conference room, coming to a stop before the wall covered in photos bearing red Xs.

"Aren't the missing people all right here on the wall?"

Mai Minghe drew a slow, deep breath.

The target she had been searching for in this game of hide-and-seek had been beside her all along, watching her without making a sound.

"Jones. I found you."

Because I've been under the weather these past few days, my mind has been running slow as well. In this chapter I did my best to lay out the reasoning and logic as clearly as possible, but if any of you still have questions, leave a comment and I'll take another look to see whether the main text needs further explanation or revisions. If it's not something that has to go into the main text, I can also reply in the comments.

Chapter 258: Mai Minghe, the Mirror Corridor, and the Wooden-Door Mirror

The moment the words left her mouth, she felt unmistakably like Mai · Holmes · he; she waited quietly for a minute, then was forced to revert back to Mai Minghe.

By the time the third minute passed, the conference room was still utterly silent—the walls, photos, and furniture all seemed to be holding back laughter, dedicated extras who refused to look her way; left standing alone in the room was a single Mai · Completely-At-A-Loss · he.

.....Had she guessed wrong?

Jones wasn't in the photos on the wall?

And here she'd just been brimming with confidence—thank goodness no one had seen that.

There were plenty of eyes around, but people—counting Jones for the sake of argument—not a single one.

How could Jones not be here?

Mai Minghe turned her reasoning over in her mind again, even playing the part of a villain inside her head, trying to poke holes in her own logic and argue against herself—but no matter how she thought about it, she couldn't figure out where she'd gone wrong.

Could it be... that she had to identify which specific photo was Jones?

That was asking a bit much.

She was an outsider—how could she possibly know which photo corresponded to which employee? She couldn't even be sure about the last six employees.

Faced with twenty strangers, what did Mai Minghe have to go on in determining which one was Jones?

Could some of the Nest Residents be deliberately skewing the fairness of this against her, just to corner her?

Mai Minghe went through them one by one, but every A4-sized photo showed the same frozen, smiling face.

Even knowing full well it probably wouldn't work, she still tried calling out at a photo:
"Found you!"

After calling out like that four or five times, it didn't feel like she was drawing closer to solving anything—it felt more like she was losing her mind alone in a conference room—and Mai Minghe stopped before the toys outside the door could laugh at her.

She furrowed her brow, instinctively propping her chin against the web of her thumb and forefinger; the moment she did, it reminded her of something else.

Qiboli had said that the new form was very important for solving the level... could the final step in picking Jones out from the photos rest with the wooden-door mirror on her face?

Seemed worth a try.

That said, Mai Minghe had no idea how to try it.

She pinched at the air in front of her cheek, found where the "handle" ought to be, pulled the "door" open, and then held her face up against each photo—the portrait on each photo happened to be about the size of a real human face—but as she went through them one by one, nothing happened except the feeling that she looked ridiculous.

Then, what about looking at how the photos appeared reflected in the mirror?

For the convenience of taking the shots herself, Mai Minghe lifted each photo off the wall and spread them all out across the conference table; what surprised and worried her a little was that every single one came off the wall without any trouble.

.....She'd had a nagging thought this whole time: that Jones's body was standing inside the wall, with only its head poking through into the photo, smiling broadly as it watched everyone in the conference room try to find it.

But the photos had all been taken down... did that mean Jones had no body?

Or had she truly guessed wrong?

Mai Minghe held up her phone in one hand and a photo in the other. She held the photo directly in front of her face and raised the phone slightly higher—click, one shot.

Twenty faces passed in succession through the wooden-door mirror around her neck; fifteen of them were crossed out in red. She looked back and forth between the phone and the photos, comparing them repeatedly, yet still came away with nothing.

Mai Minghe was starting to feel genuinely frustrated.

"If you don't come out, I'll tear all the photos up," she tried as a threat.

Still no response from the conference room.

"I'm going to tear them?"

But Mai Minghe didn't dare actually do it. What if tearing up the photos counted as failing the task, and she'd be trapped there to die, ending up disappeared like the toy company employees?

She clutched the stack of photos, momentarily out of ideas and at a complete loss; she stood there blankly for a moment, then felt a sudden spark in her mind and turned to walk out.

Things had already gotten this far—what could trying one more method possibly make worse?

There was one other way to examine what the wooden-door mirror reflected.

Cradling the stack of photos, Mai Minghe walked quickly into the restroom and stopped in front of the sink. She raised her eyes slightly—and sure enough, in the reflection within the mirror, another mirror appeared, connected into what seemed like an endless corridor of nested reflections, one ring inside another.

So that she wouldn't block her own line of sight when she held up a photo, she stepped back a good distance this time; her eyes landed just above the wooden-door mirror, in the perfect position to look over the raised photo and all the way down into the mirror above the sink.

Mai Minghe set down one photo she'd just looked at and picked up a new one; set down another finished one and picked up yet another... it became almost mechanical, like an assembly line, and she sometimes had to remind herself what exactly she was looking for.

Somewhere around the tenth-something photo, Mai Minghe found it.

She had nearly missed it entirely.

In the reflection within the mirror, it was still a standard-issue smiling workplace photo—the face on it was unremarkable and forgettable, divided into four quadrants by two crossing red-pen marks.

Even though that face was the kind you couldn't remember, Mai Minghe had grown familiar with it after putting it through every method she'd tried—just as she was about to set the photo

down and move to the next one, the mirror's angle shifted slightly, and the corner of her eye caught a sliver of navy blue.

.....A sliver of navy blue that hadn't been there before.

Mai Minghe went still. Two seconds passed, then she adjusted the angle of the photo and her face against the mirror, and for the first time she finally saw Jones clearly.

In that corridor of nested mirror images—where mirror connected to mirror, reflection folded into reflection—something appeared that had no business being there.

.....How to describe it?

It turned out she hadn't guessed wrong: Jones had indeed poked its head through the photo.

The smiling face in the photo was Jones's face—and that face was still connected to a neck, connected to a body; the body was dressed in a navy-blue casual suit.

But Jones's body was not standing upright and hidden inside the wall the way Mai Minghe had imagined.

The photo was like a picture frame; Jones had put its head through it, was lying face-down on the ground with all four limbs splayed out, its body forming a horizontal line with the face in the photo.

In other words, Jones was sprawled across the mirror corridor like a giant gecko, the photo hanging around its neck.

Mai Minghe's gaze met the gaze inside the photo within the reflection, and Jones suddenly let out a "pfft" of laughter.

The mouth beneath the red crosses opened and closed: "Found me, did you? That was no small feat—how did you even manage to find me like that? The photo is flat because I'm hiding in the reflection, and reflections are flat, doesn't that all sound perfectly reasonable, isn't it extremely logical that you found me in the reflection-ec-tion-ec-tion-ec-tion-ec-tion-ec-tion? Actually I was just improvising hahahahaha I was supposed to be hiding in the wall—hey!"

That last word burst out of the air without warning, reverberating off the restroom walls, startling Mai Minghe.

It didn't quite sound like the way a Resident's severed artery would spray out words; Jones seemed to be... seemed to be calling out to someone.

"I've already done what you asked the mirror's aligned why aren't you crawling out already kill her kill her kill her?"

What?

Mai Minghe jolted and suddenly realized she was still holding Jones's photo; she quickly flung her hand and sent the photo flying away—out of her hand, out of the mirror's view.

Once the image of Jones sprawled face-down on all fours vanished, Mai Minghe suppressed the dizziness and looked into the corridor formed by the nested mirror reflections.

Deep in the corridor—the corridor connected through the reflection cast by the wooden-door mirror that her face had become—

The semi-transparent human face that only she had noticed not long ago suddenly rose up and came rushing toward her at speed, as if it meant to use Mai Minghe's face as a door and break free through it.

I can't believe I've kept up with updates—it's starting to feel like I'm completing a challenge...

Today (yesterday, I should say) I went to the doctor in the morning and had blood drawn (I'm practically braised tofu—they couldn't get the blood out, the nurse had to press down on my vein and squeeze, and one arm wasn't enough, so they switched to the other one), now I'm waiting for the results...

Without stopping to rest, I went and got three vaccines in the afternoon... I'm basically a pincushion. Stronger than the covid vaccine, not as painful, but they warned me I might start running a fever as early as tomorrow.

I've decided to take tomorrow off, and it works out perfectly since this stretch of the story has reached a good stopping point anyway.

Chapter 259: Mai Minghe's Cement Waterfall

Perhaps from some point onward, she had already gone quietly mad—burning through one bout of delirious, hallucinatory fever after another inside the Nest's grotesque reality. Otherwise, why would Mai Minghe feel as though something deep inside her skull had "fallen out"?

How could the depths of one's skull—one's consciousness—"fall out" of the body?

Mai Minghe had no explanation.

If a person could be divided into a "surface" and a "depth," then the moment she caught sight of the face in the mirror, her "depth" had vanished in an instant—like a passenger sucked out into the sky when an aircraft door is suddenly ripped away.

It was as though only a "surface" remained of her, and even that "surface" had become a rustling, trembling sheet of plastic film on the verge of collapse; the transparent face hurtling toward her at full speed was slamming straight into it.

Mai Minghe spun around and ran.

She felt as though she had become a paper cutout, every point where her arms and legs made contact with space narrowed to a thin, paper-thin edge.

One stumbling step after another, she cut through the icy air of the restroom and drifted down the corridor—the exit to the lower floors had disappeared because she was required to play hide-and-seek with Jones; but now that she had found Jones, would the exit reappear?

The fire door she had pulled open earlier was still wide open, leaning against the wall; Mai Minghe rushed to the doorway and looked—and saw a semi-transparent face floating above a staircase that had just appeared.

No, wait—she hadn't "seen" it.

"Seeing" meant light reflecting off something in front of you, passing through the cornea and into the eye; but that semi-transparent face was not "in front of" her—it was behind her retina.

For reasons she couldn't explain, wherever it resided seemed to be connected to Mai Minghe's retina and her brain.

The transparent face was surging from behind her retina, again and again, toward her eyeball, her skin, her nerves, her bones, her eyes—everything was swelling with pain, as if it were about to burst.

Even if she fled down the stairs, there was no escaping what lurked behind her own retina—but Mai Minghe threw herself down the staircase anyway, moving so fast, with such reckless momentum, that it would have been no surprise if she'd tumbled and snapped her neck.

Key House Faction.

Those two words rose unbidden from the depths of her mind, trailing a shadow the color of blood and black.

If she had to die, Mai Minghe would rather break her neck in a fall on the stairs than let another face shatter hers and squeeze itself out through the ruins of her facial bones.

She plunged down the stairs, rounded a landing, threw herself toward the next flight, and rounded another landing.

She didn't know whether it was just her imagination, but it seemed that the longer she ran and the deeper she descended, the less the throbbing pain behind her eyeball—could it be that the point where that transparent face had connected with her was on the third floor?

It seemed that as Mai Minghe kept running down flight after flight without stopping, the face grew farther and farther away.

But...

Weren't the stairs a bit too long?

How many floors did this building have?

One flight after another, and at every landing there was always another flight stretching downward.

Looking up, the staircase spiraled endlessly upward and dissolved into a leaden gray expanse of concrete; looking down, it descended step by step, plunging into blurry depths.

No matter which direction she looked, there was nothing but the same leaden gray concrete and leaden gray iron railings—Mai Minghe felt as though she were running inside a monotonous, endlessly cascading cement waterfall, and as she ran and ran, even time grew blurry; she had no idea how long she had been running.

Gasping for breath, she stepped off the last stair and stopped on a landing, dropping to the floor with a thud.

The semi-transparent face seemed to have vanished—or perhaps it simply couldn't reach her for the moment.

She had escaped the third floor, but it seemed she had fallen into an even worse situation... even if there were no semi-transparent face on the third floor, she probably couldn't get back there anyway.

Mai Minghe tilted her head back and stared up at the infinite concrete above her, no longer even sure where "the third floor" was—no matter how she looked or in which direction, she had long since passed any place where the third floor could possibly be.

There should be doors leading to other floors in a stairwell...

Mai Minghe rested for a few minutes, then dragged her legs—which were filling with cement as fast as the staircase—and knocked along the walls for a while. Fine, no hidden door. Nor on the next level.

She didn't know how many more floors she had walked when she pulled out her phone and glanced at the time.

Only ten minutes left before mission failure.

One obstacle after another—the Nest's Residents had completely stripped away any pretense of "fairness." Now she didn't even know if there was any hope of getting out alive, let alone joining the Key House Faction.

If she failed the interview, she couldn't get the lipstick back; without the lipstick, she couldn't get the Artifact Report—one bad outcome cascading into the next, an avalanche crashing down on her.

Mai Minghe buried her face in both hands and gave herself one minute—let all her anxiety, worry, fear, self-reproach, and regret surge up at once, let her tear ducts open on their own—but only one minute.

In this life, no one can escape being frightened and tormented by the unknown, but you can give it one minute at most.

Otherwise, it will think you're welcoming it, and sit down and never leave.

One minute later, she wiped her face dry again and stood up.

Mai Minghe walked downward step by step, this time not letting any corner or detail slip past her.

Each flight had exactly twelve steps, followed by a landing; one full turn, then another twelve steps.

There were no floor numbers marked anywhere. White fluorescent lights existed only on the landing ceilings; aside from those, there was a green illuminated sign bearing the silhouette of a running figure and an arrow, with the words "Emergency Exit."

Since the sign was flush against the wall, the arrow also pointed at the opposite wall—could the exit be inside the wall?

Mai Minghe slammed her shoulder against it twice as hard as she could; the wall didn't budge an inch—but she herself had used too much force, and her shoulder bone ached sharply, and she let out a low involuntary cry.

"...Did you hear that?"

From somewhere below the staircase, a vague half-sentence of human speech floated lazily upward.

Mai Minghe jolted, immediately lunged to the railing and looked down; she was about to call out, then stopped herself just in time.

Whoever had spoken wasn't by the railing—she couldn't see them. Who knew whether it was a Resident?

"Sounds like a woman..." A second voice rose, this one much clearer, even faintly familiar.

"Shouldn't be a Resident," said the first voice—a woman's voice, who seemed to be walking up the stairs as she spoke, since her voice was steadily growing clearer: "Hold on, in your condition, the less you move the better. I'll go see what's going on."

Mai Minghe quickly stepped down several stairs and leaned out to look—sure enough, she saw the top of someone's head.

The woman's upper half of hair was gathered into a bun, the lower half shaved short; she was one of the other Hunters who had come in to interview—what was her name again?

"Suo... Suobeihua!" Mai Minghe called out loudly. "Is that you?"

Suobeihua looked up at the sound, revealing a narrow, sharp-featured face; in the endlessly spiraling stairwell, their eyes met.

"Who are you?"

Suobeihua startled, and in a single motion drew a gun from her hip and leveled it at Mai Minghe—so fast she nearly left a blur behind her. "Don't move. Are you a Resident?"

Suobeihua's memory was terrible—

The thought hadn't finished forming before Mai Minghe suddenly understood.

She didn't know why it had taken her until now to actually look at Suobeihua's lower half—the other woman wasn't climbing the stairs step by step; she was "swimming" up.

From the waist down, Suobeihua's legs were gone, replaced by a long, thick, rounded serpent's tail of blue-green, trailing all the way down and around the next landing.

Right—once you entered, your form would be altered...

It just hadn't occurred to Mai Minghe that when people faced each other with the naked eye, what they saw was also each other's Nest-altered forms.

Which meant that what Suobeihua saw was a person with a wooden door mirror balanced on top of their neck—no wonder her first instinct had been to draw a gun.

"Wait, I'm not a Resident," she immediately raised both hands and said: "I'm Mai Minghe—I came in to interview with you. Look at my orange badge—and I also have a gun at my waist."

Suobeihua narrowed her eyes to look, then slowly, hesitantly, lowered her gun.

"You haven't gotten out either?"

It was nothing more than running into someone who had come in for the same interview—not even a companion, and freedom was still far away—yet Mai Minghe felt something like relief wash over her, as if she had been rescued.

"I thought I was the only one trapped in this stairwell, and I had no idea what to do," she couldn't help the rush of feeling, and hurried down the stairs, asking: "Do you know what's going on with this stairwell? How long have you been trapped here?"

Up close, Suobeihua's serpent tail was even more striking—she looked almost like a mythological creature, or a demoness from folklore.

If she stood up on the tip of that tail, Suobeihua would be at least three meters tall, wouldn't she?

They had both had their forms altered, yet how did the other person's form manage to look so imposing?

"I finished the second-floor challenge and came in here about seven or eight minutes ago. I imagine you had the same experience as me—kept walking downward but could never see the bottom." Suobeihua tilted her sharp chin toward the lower stairs. "Besides me, Robert is also trapped here."

So that male voice had been Robert.

"Is he injured?" Mai Minghe asked.

A very peculiar expression crossed Suobeihua's face—as though she wanted to say something but held it back.

"...No."

More than Robert's staying put, what puzzled Mai Minghe was that expression. "I heard you tell him to stay where he was and not move..."

Suobeihua seemed to be wrestling with a thought, fighting to keep it from slipping out of her mouth.

"Right, I said the less he moves the better."

Was there a difference?

"Go down and see for yourself. Come on."

Suobeihua turned around, and her serpent tail moved as if it had a life of its own, curling into a loop on the staircase with a soft *shush-shush*, scales shimmering with a fine, dense green luster. "This works out well—we can figure out how to get out of here."

"Oh, right," Suobeihua suddenly turned her head and said softly in a low murmur: "When you see Robert, don't stare, and don't laugh. Whatever you do, don't laugh—or he'll lose it on the spot."

...Why would she laugh?

Yesterday my blood test results came back—guess what, the blood sample was damaged (no explanation of exactly how), and in any case the iron couldn't be measured. All other indicators came back normal, but the one thing I most needed to know—iron—couldn't be measured. Went in again today for another draw, and both arms are bruised now.

Though all the other markers related to iron were normal, so the likelihood of iron deficiency seems smaller now... so do I have the Lin Daiyu disease, or the romance-novel-heroine disease? Except which romance-novel heroine spends her days this limp, flopped in a chair like a deflated bag of skin, too weak to even hold her own in a push-and-pull with the male lead.

This is an ancient-setting transmigration story, truly.

As 九五 (hereafter referred to as Jiuwu) slowly came to, what gradually sharpened into clarity from the blur was a soft gauze curtain.

A satin quilt covered her; she turned over and found her neck especially stiff—she looked, and her five-star hotel silent down pillow was gone, replaced by a porcelain pillow.

...The headache—was it from the hard surface?

The moment she stirred, someone outside the curtain immediately said in a pinched voice: "Miss, you're finally awake!"

At the sound of that pinched voice, the fragmented memories of this body's original owner floated into her mind. So she had transmigrated, she thought calmly.

After all, it was a common enough thing—which modern person doesn't transmigrate seven or eight times in their lifetime? As long as she identified the key objectives of her situation and executed a core strategy, she would make it home.

"Xiaomeng?" Jiuwu asked. "...What happened to me?"

The maidservant Xiaomeng lifted the bed curtain, lowering a pale, featureless face—blank where the eyes, nose, and mouth should have been.

Hmm, something seemed a little off, but 95 decided not to dwell on it for now.

"It's all that little demon from the great-aunt's family! Miss, you fell into the lake by accident—but if it weren't for her, you never would have run such a fever for days. The First Mistress has been worried sick."

It said this while primly straightening the lopsided brown wig atop its head. As expected of a maidservant from a great household, its manner was very... very... well, let's call it elegant.

"I can't quite remember, Xiaomeng. What exactly happened?"

"Well, who else but Miss Csmshksdaaa?" Xiaomeng deftly produced a name from its mouth that was utterly impossible to pronounce.

It forestalled 95's attempt to repeat it.

"Oh my, Miss, you mustn't try. That name cannot be spoken by you. Have you forgotten? When Miss Csmshksdaaa was young, a wandering herbalist came to their home, and she asked him to prepare a remedy. After she drank it, non-Residents—that is, ordinary people—lost the ability to correctly pronounce her name. They simply cannot say it."

That seemed rather outside the usual scope of medicine... but then again, who could say—what if the herbalist had been a miracle healer?

"Why would anyone want their name to be unpronounceable?"

"The benefits are many! If she does something wicked, witnesses can't name her. Military conscription can't call her up. At private school, when her mind wanders, the teacher can never call on her by name. And anyone who insists on trying will have their tongue tied in knots for three days—three days of not being able to eat."

How practical!

"What did Miss Unpronounceable do?"

Xiaomeng flicked its handkerchief—a touch too forcefully—and smacked it against the blank expanse of its face where the eye socket should have been. "Don't even get me started! She simply had to compete with you over the 'Ji Shanqing' nameplate."

...What did that mean? Who was Ji Shanqing?

"Ji Shanqing is a name," Xiaomeng said, stating the obvious. "Whoever obtains the nameplate bearing this name will automatically earn the loyalty of a retired imperial bodyguard, who will willingly become the nameplate holder's shadow guard."

It thought for a moment, then said, "That shadow guard never announces her name either. All we know is that she calls herself the old servant of Ji Shanqing."

What blind devotion—all it took was holding the Ji Shanqing nameplate?

"And my relationship with Miss Unpronounceable is..."

"How could you forget even this, Miss? Miss Csmshksdaaa is your cousin on your mother's side. The two of you are usually quite the pair of frenemies."

As the elder sister, letting her younger sister have the shadow guard of the self-proclaimed old servant of Ji Shanqing didn't seem like such a big deal—so how had things escalated to the point of falling into a lake?

"It's a long story."

Xiaomeng plopped itself down on the bed, sending the gauze curtain askew, and with a ripping tear the curtain peeled halfway off its Velcro fastening.

...95 couldn't shake the feeling that something about this ancient era wasn't quite so ancient—but perhaps it was a fictional world, 95 thought.

"Surely you remember Miss Tianxia from the Minister's household?"

95 had been about to say no, but suddenly felt a flush rise to her face and said, "...Yes, I remember."

Here came the core mission.

"See, I knew it. Miss Tianxia is grace and elegance personified—one glimpse of her adds leisure to the day. Everyone in the capital, from high ministers down to the lowliest souls, longs to... hmm, how to put it, what's the phrase—same-city speed-dating?"

Remarkable—she had transmigrated into an ancient-setting romance, 95 thought to herself. Though the maidservant's vocabulary did seem a bit peculiar.

"Your greatest rival, Miss Qiwu," Xiaomeng said, "took advantage of Lord Minister's absence on a river crossing, disguised herself as a rare-goods merchant, slipped into the Minister's estate, and met with Miss Tianxia. Not only that, she presented her with an ancient treasure as a token of her feelings."

"What treasure?"

"Non-edible kitty gummies."

"...Hm?"

"Though labeled non-edible, the moment you place one in your mouth it dissolves instantly—soft, sweet, and coated in a layer of sugar shaped like cat fur. With one in your mouth, you can produce a perfectly authentic meow and engage a cat in philosophical debate."

...She wanted one so badly! Truly an ancient treasure!

"Infuriating—Qiwu is far too cunning," 95 said through gritted teeth.

"Lord Minister was away crossing the river and not at the estate, but upon learning of the situation through a magic crystal ball, his favorable impression of Miss Qiwu actually rose. This is quite the crisis for you."

Through what? Hadn't Xiaomeng just said it was a homing-pigeon letter?

"And how far have things progressed between me and Miss Tianxia?" 95 asked.

Xiaomeng hesitated for a few seconds. "After you fell into the water, Miss Tianxia finally became aware that someone like you exists."

"Then I can hardly call Qiwu my greatest rival! Don't rivals have to be on roughly the same level to count as rivals? And what does any of this have to do with me falling into the water?"

"Allow me to explain," Xiaomeng said, unhurried. "You, sharp as a whip, immediately sensed trouble. So you quickly invited Lady YQ Aqing from the general's estate for tea, to help you come up with a plan. Lady YQ Aqing also brought her daughter, Miss Liu Jinqi—because, they say, Miss Liu Jinqi always responds to plot developments with remarks that are either amusing or constructive, making her a most valuable voice of reason."

In short, at the scheming tea gathering, Miss Csmshksdaaa accidentally knocked over Miss Liu Jinqi, who was on her way to the washroom. Miss Liu Jinqi, gentle and magnanimous, thought nothing of it, gave a wave of her hand, and walked on.

Miss Csmshksdaaa stared after her retreating figure in a daze, then suddenly snapped to her senses, hurried to catch up, and said, "Which household's young miss are you? Might we be introduced? My name is—ah!"

"Having lived eighteen years, Miss Csmshksdaaa realized for the first time that an unpronounceable name had such a terrible disadvantage."

Xiaomeng said gravely and mournfully, "So she followed Miss Liu Jinqi to the tea gathering, eavesdropped outside the window for a while, and overheard Lady YQ Aqing suggest that you

invite all the ladies of standing in the capital to a flower-viewing party—and use the occasion to play the hero and rescue Miss Tianxia."

At this point, 95 had two questions lodged in her throat, demanding to be asked.

One: was this ancient romance world an L-world?

Two: what did any of this have to do with her falling into the water?

"I don't know why the sponsors... I mean, I don't know why every person in the capital is a young woman, and all of them are eighteen years old," Xiaomeng said. "For instance, Lady YQ Aqing and Miss Liu Jinqi are mother and daughter, yet both are eighteen. Also, Lord Minister did not cross over into the ranks of the nineteen-year-olds—he too falls among the eighteen-year-olds."

All that effort, just to work in the phrase "did not."

"You're welcome," Xiaomeng said. "I love repeating syllables—the more I can repeat-repeat-repeat-repeat them in one unbroken breath, the better, Miss."

"...So how exactly am I supposed to play the hero?" 95 sighed and asked.

A legend had long circulated throughout the capital—the legend of the peerless assassin, Shark Pepper 9.

They said that when she first began her career as an assassin, she had been Shark Pepper 1. Each time she failed a mission, her name would change, adding one to the number. A truly once-in-a-generation genius—

"Hasn't she failed eight times!" 95 said furiously. "She's eighteen too, isn't she! Eighteen years old, and she's already failed eight assassinations! What kind of genius is that!"

"W-well... that just shows how kind-hearted she is..."

"Then why did she become an assassin in the first place!"

In any case, Shark Pepper 9 had accepted the mission to assassinate Miss Tianxia.

The mission went as follows:

At the flower-viewing party, if Qiwu was not nearby, approach Tianxia immediately.

Ask Tianxia what she thought of 95. If the answer was favorable, do not proceed to the next step—turn and leave at once.

If the answer was anything other than "favorable," prepare to proceed to the next step, and lead her to the lakeside.

Key point: ensure that 95 was also at the lakeside when the mission was carried out!

"I think I understand..." 95 said. "I jumped in to save Miss Tianxia and fell in myself."

Xiaomeng said, "That's not it."

Miss Csmshksdaaa, in order to make Miss Liu Jinqi learn her name and to win Lady YQ Aqing's favor, had gone to great lengths and prepared her own flower-viewing party plan.

When the party was underway, everyone discovered that the lake surface, which had been calm before, was now crowded with a great flock of ducks-ducks-ducks-ducks-ducks that had apparently been pulling an all-nighter.

The ducks-ducks-ducks-ducks-ducks slowly paddled through the water, arranging themselves into the shape of Miss Csmshksdaaa's name.

But because the lake was only a garden pond, the name was very long, and there were far too many ducks-ducks-ducks-ducks-ducks—they packed the lake surface so densely that Shark Pepper 10 (provisional) couldn't even find a gap through which to push Miss Tianxia in.

At precisely this moment, the villain Qiwu produced yet another treasure—a love letter, W0ZV—and presented it to Miss Tianxia. No need to ask what it did; the name said it all. Quite perfect for producing on the fourteenth of February.

Seeing that she was about to lose her ducks and gain nothing, 95 immediately cut off the villain and invited everyone to come view a rare plant that had recently been introduced to the estate: the Jupiter-Calm Wolfberry.

"It comes from Jupiter. Very calm. It is a wolfberry." 95 had apparently been so flustered she could only manage this introduction.

"I would rather everyone go back and enjoy the lake view," Miss Csmshksdaaa said, displeased.

Just as Shark Pepper 10 (provisional) was circling about in search of an opportunity, a high-ranking police inspector among the ladies at the flower-viewing party, Gu Xizhou, suddenly recognized the infamous assassin at a glance.

"Everyone find cover immediately!" Gu Xizhou called out. "Guards, come quickly!"

The garden flower-viewing party instantly descended into chaos: the two guard captains, Xiwei Youye and Caoshang Riyue, rushed into the garden in one swift motion, trailed by two fierce beasts they were pursuing, a cat named Mao Yunyun and another named Mi A'ao; Shark Pepper 10 (provisional) wasn't frightened in the slightest—she immediately altered her appearance and blended into the crowd of ladies and food numerals, making it impossible to tell who the assassin was.

"Wait—what do you mean she blended into the food numerals?"

"It means she could have been in human form, or she could have been a food item, or possibly a number."

Ancient worlds are truly remarkable places, 95 thought.

"Under the command of the two guard captains, Xiwei Youye and Caoshang Riyue, guards Duziruo and Xunshi carried out a thorough inspection of everything in the garden."

Everyone had been eating wontons that day, and upon inspection, the crowd discovered that the wontons contained a small wonton—but it turned out to be just a neighbor's child who had snuck in for the excitement, not the assassin at all.

A plate of the world's third-to-last sea cucumbers and a small dish of Ishgard Red-Robed Figurine Tomatoes on the table—neither contained the assassin.

Miss lol115 and Lady R_13 (whose face cannot be looked upon directly by anyone under thirteen) also had no connection to the assassin.

Lady _E_Stella_ suddenly said, "No need to be afraid, everyone. Shark Pepper has come here with a specific target in mind. I happen to have a Ji Shanqing nameplate—whoever wears it will automatically gain a shadow guard, the old servant of Ji Shanqing..."

Xiaomeng let out a sigh.

"Miss Csmshksdaaa knew that the assassin you hired would not pose any real danger to Miss Tianxia's life. So she hoped to seize the nameplate and present it to Miss Liu Jinqi, to make a good impression."

In the struggle between the two of them, 95's former self lost her footing and tumbled into the lake—

"Wait, what about all those ducks?"

"Naturally they were all pulled ashore for inspection too," Xiaomeng said, as if this were obvious. "What if the assassin had disguised herself as a duck?"

...That was a fair point.

"And so you fell into an empty lake." Xiaomeng said, somewhat hesitantly. "It was only at that moment... that Shark Pepper 10 (provisional) suddenly leapt out from the crowd and tried to stop you, letting out a great shout."

"Don't fall in!" Shark Pepper 10 (provisional) cried out. "I planted one hundred thousand volts of i in that lake!"

95 listened to the end in a daze, and understood.

Was the original host electrocuted to death by a hundred thousand volts?!

How did this ancient romance suddenly seem to get very dangerous all of a sudden?

She had originally planned to complete the core mission and slip home without a word. Now it seemed she had no choice but to ask Xiaomeng for help — if she stayed any longer, things might get very dangerous.

"Wait, I'm not your young mistress. If I want to go home, what should I do?"

Xiaomeng let out an "Ah." "So you're a transmigrator too! Seeing it in person is something else entirely. I understand now... While you were unconscious, a lady came and left word that if you woke up wanting to go home, you only need to silently recite her name three times."

"What name?"

"Home lies in the sunlight."

(The above is the patron appreciation list for the period of 1.25 – 1.31. Though I call it an appreciation list, I only realized after writing it that there isn't a single word of thanks in the whole thing. Well, that's... hm...)

Chapter 260: The Four Forms of Mai Minghe and the Infinite Floors

Fortunately, to everyone else, what hung around Mai Minghe's neck was simply a wooden carved door inlaid with a mirror.

No matter what expression she made, as long as she didn't make a sound, Robert wouldn't notice her expression or attitude—which, all things considered, saved quite a bit of awkwardness and embarrassed indignation.

Mai Minghe bit hard on the inside of her cheek, lips pressed tightly together, keeping her head level, and only occasionally let her eyelids droop for a stolen glance.

She couldn't help but look—nobody could have helped it.

How on earth was she supposed to describe how she felt right now? She'd lived a whole lifetime and had never encountered a situation like this before...

When she followed Suobeihua downstairs and caught her first glimpse of Robert sitting on the stair landing, Mai Minghe had simply been startled.

All the skin Robert had exposed outside his clothes had turned into flesh-colored plastic, looking exactly like a Barbie doll's boyfriend—what was his name again?—his limbs and cheeks appeared stiff and sluggish; it was a little unsettling, but not to the point of being laughable.

It wasn't until he finally stood up with some hesitation that Mai Minghe hurriedly swallowed back the "ah" that had nearly escaped her throat.

Robert's trouser zipper was undone—because he had no choice but to leave it undone.

From the open zipper, a silver metal rotating handle protruded, shaped like a large key; Mai Minghe recognized it at once—it was a wind-up key.

What the wind-up key had replaced was practically screaming to be said out loud.

...What did that mean?

Why would there be a wind-up key there?

Just now, Suobeihua had told him to move as little as possible—and that was because... wait, surely not?

Robert opened his mouth—the mouth was a separate, movable part; when he opened it, a square black slit split open across the plastic face, the plastic lips rising and falling, opening and closing.

"Well, another one stuck. How do we get out? Any ideas?" Robert asked. He seemed to want to pretend the wind-up key didn't exist.

"Actually, seeing Mai Minghe just gave me an idea."

Suobeihua glanced at her phone. "We only have six or seven minutes left. To be realistic, I think we've all failed this interview. Can everyone accept that? With so little time left, a miraculous sudden breakthrough is almost impossible—better to conserve our strength and make sure we stay safe."

Robert gave a displeased grunt.

Suobeihua glanced at Mai Minghe, as if waiting for her to weigh in.

"...No. There are still six or seven minutes left, and I think I should keep trying for those six or seven minutes," Mai Minghe said quietly. "Waiting until time runs out to confirm failure before thinking about what comes next isn't a bad idea either, is it? It's only a difference of six or seven minutes."

If she gave up the moment things looked bad, what was the point of having a second life at all?

She had done enough of that in her first eighty-six years—sometimes forced by circumstance, sometimes surrendering of her own accord.

Looking back afterward, there was always that unpleasant, deflated sense of dejection, the kind that made her want to avoid the memory entirely. If she could hold on until the very last second with everything she had, she thought she might not mind remembering a straightforward failure...

"You're very likely right," Mai Minghe said to Suobeihua, almost reassuringly. "I don't have any unrealistic illusions either. But wherever I can push to, I still want to push."

Suobeihua was silent for a few seconds, and seemed to give her a look—though all that was visible was a wooden-door mirror.

"My original thought was that we should stay put and try to get help from the Key House people. For instance," she pointed at her phone and said something cryptic: "I just searched—there's no communication signal inside the Nest, but there are at least four Bluetooth signals nearby. Even if we rule out yours and his, one of them might belong to a Key House member. Maybe I could pair with it and ask for help."

...Every word individually was familiar; put together, it was harder to understand than a Resident.

"Then try it already," Robert glanced at Mai Minghe, his gaze dropping from the wooden-door mirror to her chest before he looked away. "As for her, if she wants to keep looking for a way out, let her—we each do our own thing, simple. Whichever side makes progress first... wait... wait."

Mai Minghe stared at him in disbelief.

Robert slowly reached his hand down, and Suobeihua immediately averted her eyes.

He grabbed the wind-up key protruding from his trouser zipper and began turning it around and around, bit by bit; the key slowly wound up a distinct series of clicks—"clack, clack, clack"—from somewhere deep within.

...So that was indeed how the wind-up key worked.

He had to keep winding the key at his groin in order to have the energy to stand, walk, talk, and do anything at all.

This... the form each person took on couldn't possibly have been tailored to each person's individual traits, could it?

"Is the frequency with which you need to wind yourself up getting higher?" Suobeihua asked flatly.

Robert ignored her and straightened his plastic body back up.

"Go look," he said to Mai Minghe, in a tone that was almost a command. "There wasn't much time to begin with—if the interview can—"

"Who's up there?"

A shout that rang out without warning startled everyone.

"...Lisidan?"

Mai Minghe was the first to recognize the voice. She leaned over the railing and looked down, calling out, "Is that you? I'm Mai Minghe—all three of us are here."

"It's me—you haven't gotten out yet either? I'm with Aimeli." Lisidan called back up. "You haven't found the exit either?"

"Well then, not a single one of us passed the interview." Suobeihua muttered under her breath.

When all five of them—especially after the transformations, with Suobeihua dragging a serpent tail more than two meters long—crammed together into the narrow concrete stairwell, it was hard not to worry that one wrong move would send someone tumbling over the railing and plunging into the fathomless darkness below.

Lisidan was covered head to toe in antennae.

He was a man, so at least he hadn't gotten a wind-up key as well—that alone was probably something to be grateful for.

Honestly, he looked rather like a humanoid porcupine that had just been subjected to torture; countless silver-white antennae pierced out from his skin, dense and clustered, all reaching into the air—whenever anyone spoke or moved, any number of antennae would sway and drift like underwater plants, as if searching for the source of the disturbance.

Even his features were obscured—short antennae bristled from both lips—and one glance was enough to make one's scalp prickle and feel a phantom ache on his behalf.

Lisidan, far from feeling any pain, even offered his own analysis: "Ah, I guess my alertness to danger must be especially high?"

As for Aimeli—if no one told you it was Aimeli, no one would have been able to tell it was a person.

"...Have you ever played Plants vs. Zombies?"

Lisidan patted what was probably Aimeli's... shoulder. Shoulder, let's say. It was impossible to tell what part of her body it was.

"Never? Really? Hmm, that game is a bit old, I suppose. Anyway, there's this very tough nut in it that zombies can't chew through. Just like that. Exactly like that."

Mai Minghe felt that, sometimes, the world of young people was even more confusing than the Nest.

Aimeli-the-nut emitted a "tch" through what might have been her nose, though no one could tell whether it was a reaction to Lisidan or because she had spotted Robert—that large, impassive, hard-shelled macadamia nut (or walnut?), which had shifted slightly to one side to make room, its nutshell scraping rasping against the concrete wall.

Suobeihua took a long, deep breath and rubbed her face hard.

"Four Bluetooth signals... looks like they were all here?" She tapped her phone screen and said, "No wonder I couldn't reach the Key House Hunters outside. Calling for help is out of the question now—until they come in to rescue us and find us, we have no choice but to keep looking for a way out."

Since they had to keep looking for a way out, they needed to gather as much information as possible.

"When did you two enter the stairwell?" Robert demanded. "How come we never heard the door open?"

"Just now." Lisidan similarly pretended the wind-up key didn't exist and said, "I solved the puzzle on the second floor—"

"Second floor?" Suobeihua was taken aback. "I was on the second floor earlier too."

A brief silence passed among them.

"...I came from the third floor," Mai Minghe volunteered.

The moment her words landed, Robert and Aimeli said, without any coordination, "So did I."

They all looked at one another, and for a moment, none of them seemed to quite know what that information meant.

Mai Minghe was certain that the third floor—at least the third floor she had been on—had only her in it.

In her search for a way out, she had carefully checked every inch of it, even pressing her ear against the walls and the floor... if there had been any movement on the other side of the wall, she should have noticed.

When she herself was neither speaking nor moving, she had felt as though she'd been sealed inside a concrete coffin and buried underground. That deathly, desperate silence could not possibly have been because whoever was next door was moving quietly.

"The only way we can tell which floor we're on is by the number on the door."

Suobeihua's brow furrowed, and she said in a low voice, "...If the floor numbers on the doors have nothing to do with what floor you're actually on, then we could have each come from any floor among these Infinite Floors. Which means this place is filled with countless third floors and second floors."

My blood test results came back—no iron deficiency, everything normal—so my fatigue has nothing to do with being vegetarian. I also asked the doctor: if it's not iron deficiency, what else could cause weakness? She said the second most common cause is that I unknowingly caught a virus.

My ferritin in the blood test was on the lower end of normal, which is indeed fairly common after a viral infection... thinking about it now, I did have a sore throat a while back and felt like I was coming down with something, but it cleared up the next day.

In other words, my body fought off a virus, got me through all the New Year's hustle, and survived my period... I am a woman warrior!

I'll take it easy and recover from here. Thank you all for looking out for me and always urging me to take a break...

Chapter 261: The Blind Spot in Mai Minghe's Clearance

After Aimeli turned into a walnut, although she felt as though she was still walking on two legs, her speed was still somewhat affected.

According to her, after leaving the "Third-Floor Checkpoint," it took her two or three minutes to descend just one floor before she ran into Lisidan.

"Of course, that's also because I was observing my surroundings as I went down," Aimeli added, her voice carrying a thin layer of cold wariness.

...She's probably the type who's terrified of being seen as weak, Mai Minghe thought.

Lisidan remembered that she herself had gone down two floors before she heard Aimeli's footsteps behind her—even though the walnut appeared to have no feet.

Lisidan's second floor

Aimeli's third floor

The floor where Lisidan and Aimeli met

"That's the order, right?" Mai Minghe said, mulling it over. "Strange—when Lisidan descended to Aimeli's floor, she didn't run into her... Did they just happen to miss each other?"

"It's also possible that the floor order doesn't mean anything, and after each person clears the checkpoint, they're randomly placed on a floor when they push the door open." Suobeihua let out a sigh, muttering as if to herself: "Why is it this hard... it shouldn't be."

Setting aside the fact that everyone here had come to the Key House Faction interview with confidence in themselves—being a Hunter, and a continuously living one at that, already proved that they were either capable or lucky, and no one here was ordinary.

And yet all five of them had been trapped in the checkpoint and failed the mission together—the more Mai Minghe thought about it, the more a flicker of guilt stirred inside her.

Could it be that this warehouse had become a one-way trip because of her?

And as for failing the interview, and getting the lipstick back...

Mai Minghe closed her eyes and cut off the thought.

First, get out of here. No need to torture herself with future problems just yet.

"Let's not waste time—find an exit. Are we going to talk one into existence just by standing here chatting?" Robert suddenly drew a handgun from the back of his waistband and barked at the group: "Move."

"What are you doing?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Ever heard of a Möbius strip? The floors above and below could all be illusions—we might just be cycling through the same few floors over and over. To find out whether there really is an Infinite Floors here, we have to test it."

Before he finished speaking, he fired several shots in quick succession at a railing post below the handrail; though everyone scrambled up the steps in time and not a single person was hit by a stray bullet—which was a small stroke of luck in itself—the gunshots cracked and reverberated, then were swallowed just as quickly by the monotonous concrete-gray walls.

Robert snapped off the shattered railing post and, with a swing of his arm, hurled it down into the seemingly bottomless stairwell below.

Everyone held their breath and waited quietly for a moment.

Not a sound.

The iron railing spun in circles through the void, slicing the air again and again as it fell endlessly, like dropping into a bottomless abyss—its silhouette vanished from sight. It wasn't until a minute or two later that Suobeihua was the first to straighten up, saying softly, "...We're not going to hear it, are we."

It had fallen that long and still no sound of impact—even if the stairwell had a bottom, it was probably deep enough that any sound would be too faint to hear.

"Looks like the Infinite Floors isn't an illusion."

Lisidan lowered her voice as well, as if afraid that if the railing happened to hit the ground right then, her words would drown it out. "Even if it's not truly infinite, there must be a lot of floors."

"The fact that bullets can damage the stairwell is a significant discovery in itself."

Robert held the gun in one hand and absently wound his wind-up key a few turns with the other; he looked around, as if searching for the next thing to shoot.

His gaze settled on the landing wall between two flights of stairs.

"...Can the wall be broken?" he asked.

Of course, even a green Hunter rookie like Mai Minghe wouldn't think they could brute-force their way through a Nest trap—but whether the wall could be broken, how it could be broken, and what would happen if it were all counted as "information."

And if there was one thing this monotonous, endlessly repeating concrete stairwell lacked most, it was "information."

Suobeihua shrugged. "We don't have a better idea right now anyway. Let's try."

Construction is no easy feat for anyone, but destruction seems to be a talent buried deep inside every human being.

Following Robert's lead, they each knocked down a few railing posts; then they used bullets to punch several holes in the stair treads. After that, everyone used the iron posts to chip and widen the cracks, prying loose several large chunks of concrete from the steps by sheer force—the whole process went so fast it almost felt like it shouldn't—and before long, they had something to smash the wall with.

Mai Minghe's ears were still ringing from the gunshots when she took hold of a large chunk of broken concrete stair and blankly asked a silly question: "...Bullets can crack concrete?"

All the antennae on Lisidan's face swayed for a moment—it was hard to say what that meant.

The wall had been riddled with bullet holes as well; everyone held their concrete chunks and focused on the cracked, load-free spots, hammering at just two points—though Aimeli looked like a limbless walnut, chunks of concrete still rose and fell through the air around her head, crashing into the wall one after another, as if she were some kind of movie special effect.

"We broke through!"

Aimeli suddenly cried out, "The sky—I can see the sky!"

If they had hammered for half an hour and still couldn't get through the wall, or if the wall's thickness had turned out to be as infinite as everything else, Mai Minghe wouldn't have been surprised—yet when a shaft of daylight truly did spill through the crack in the wall, she was caught off guard.

Everyone crowded in around the walnut.

The crack was tiny—not even half the size of a palm; "hole" was probably a more accurate word for it. Even pressing face to face, they had to take turns looking, and for a while the stairwell was filled with things like "my turn," "stop shoving," and "move your antennae."

When Mai Minghe finally got a clear look at the outside world, she drew a soft breath.

Beyond the wall was the very same road where they had gathered. From the gathering point's perspective, this endless stairwell appeared to be situated several dozen meters to the right of the main entrance—and standing by the gathering point right now was a single person, head bowed, checking their watch.

The one-hour interview window had long since passed. The other two weren't here—did that mean they had already come inside to help?

"Tianxi!" Mai Minghe couldn't help calling out. "Can you hear me, Tianxi!"

"There's no way they can hear us," Lisidan muttered.

And yet the very next second, Tianxi looked up.

He didn't seem quite sure where the voice was coming from; he followed the sound toward them, looked around in all directions, and finally tilted his head back—locking eyes with Mai Minghe, who was two or three floors above.

"How did you..." He stared for a moment. "Who's up there with you? What are you all doing?"

Encouraged, everyone picked up the pace and chipped the hole a few rounds larger; now it was like a small window, wide enough for several people to look out of at once.

"What happened to you all?"

Tianxi called up: "If you could knock a hole and call out to me, why can't any of you come out?"

That wasn't an easy question to answer.

They passed the explanation back and forth between them, piecing together the story of being trapped in the stairwell as clearly as they could; Tianxi stood with his arms folded and listened for a long while, then seemed to understand and nodded.

"From the inside it looks like an endlessly extending stairwell, but from out here it's only about ten or so meters tall. The way I see it, rather than trying to break out from within, you'd be better off just trying to climb down the outer wall... Hmm, let me call those two back and see what's the best way to get you all down."

"Is that really all?" Lisidan seemed just as astonished. "It's that simple to get out?"

From a distance, they could faintly make out Tianxi letting out a sigh.

"What else? It's the shortest path right in front of you. Before anyone comes out, throw something down first to test it."

That was easy enough—they had plenty of iron posts and concrete chunks on hand.

Unlike the first railing, everything they threw down this time landed squarely on the sidewalk outside; Mai Minghe squinted to look carefully, and could even see that some of the paving bricks had been chipped by the impact.

"I'll find a way to climb higher and toss a rope up—see if you can grab it. Once you've got it, come down one at a time. Be careful," Tianxi instructed.

The difficulty had ended so suddenly and so easily that everyone was at once disbelieving and unable to hold back their relief.

No—it hadn't exactly resolved easily out of nowhere; they had, after all, put in enormous effort, chipping through the wall blow by blow—Mai Minghe's palms were rubbed raw.

"Some traps are cleared with brains and quick thinking, so it's not surprising that some can be cleared with pure force," Robert said, winding his wind-up key as he spoke. "Maybe that's the blind spot of the stairwell trap."

Even if they'd failed the interview, at least everyone would make it home safely—as the tension eased and their spirits lifted, it was as if even the surrounding concrete had lost its gloomy gray cast.

"...I'm not going out."

Suobeihua said suddenly, quietly.

Honestly, when I'm not feeling well, keeping up with updates isn't the hardest part—the hardest part is still updating when I'm stuck on the writing... I'd rather be under the weather and not be stuck...

The reason I bring this up is because I have a feeling it might be starting to happen...

And lately my lucky streak of "stumbling onto great novels one after another" has broken, my fatigue still isn't getting better, and, well—I'm not in a great place. The moment I get stuck, the whole world feels dim, and everything is just gloom.

Chapter 262: Mai Minghe's Braid

Mai Minghe was suddenly struck by a profound realization—so the difference between Hunters and ordinary people sometimes hid in gaps this subtle and fleeting, gone in a flash.

No matter how much they believed that brute force was the way to break through a situation, Hunters would never give up using their heads.

After Suobeihua's words "I'm not going out" fell, not a single person in the stairwell was the first to blurt out that most obvious, most effortless and lazy response—why?

In that instant, Mai Minghe could almost hear the faint rushing sound of everyone's thoughts spinning at full speed.

Given that the interview had already been confirmed a failure, the most natural reason for Suobeihua not going out was only one: she felt it wasn't safe outside. That much didn't need to be asked—there was no point wasting breath on it.

The truly crucial question was: what had tipped her off that something was wrong?

If she said nothing, could they find the problem themselves?

Would rashly asking her reason influence their own judgment?

If something outside really was off, how could they explain what was in front of them right now—especially Tianxi standing by the roadside?

When the Hunters spoke, they were almost painstakingly careful.

"I was just thinking about it too...the Key House people seem to use this warehouse as an interview gauntlet pretty often,"

Lisidan said slowly, weighing each word: "It was the Key House Hunters themselves who warned us that physical transformations would occur. So it's perfectly normal that Tianxi wasn't the least bit surprised to see us looking so strange...they should even have some means of surveillance to observe our performance, so it's even less surprising that they know who each of us is."

He added: "Ah, that—I'm not saying I'm necessarily right. That's just what I was thinking just now."

"Tianxi isn't inside the gauntlet, so his perception may not be affected by this building. If you're worried about that, we can probe him with some sideways questions." Mai Minghe thought for a moment and added her own point.

Hey, hadn't she been using her head this whole time too? Was she starting to look more and more like a Hunter?

Suobeihua stood with her eyes downcast, lost in thought.

"What exactly did you notice?"

Aimeli finally asked.

"Although crawling out through a hole we hack open does sound too simple, from another angle—if the Nest just laid the real exit right in front of us like this, making us suspicious and anxious so we trap ourselves, wouldn't that also be exactly the kind of thing the Nest would do?"

Mai Minghe didn't have much firsthand experience with that point yet; but both Lisidan and Robert nodded several times in agreement.

"...You all think this hole is the way out?" Suobeihua finally spoke.

"No," Aimeli answered immediately, "I'm only laying out my thinking and judgment. I could still be persuaded by your view—but you have to start talking."

Suobeihua pressed her lips together without a word and swept another glance outside through the crack. Tianxi seemed to have gone looking for a climbing point so he could toss the rope up to them.

"...Even if you all laugh at me, there's nothing I can do about it." She took a deep breath and said, as if she had made up her mind: "Tianxi's braid switched sides."

The stairwell went quiet for a few seconds; Robert was the first to let out a "Huh?"

"That's it?" He sounded somewhat incredulous. "With hair that long, you just reach up and brush it from one shoulder to the other— isn't that completely normal? You'd call that a red flag? And how would you even know that you...you...didn't..."

As he bent his head again to wind up his key, Lisidan filled in what he hadn't finished saying: "You remember which side his braid was on? Even if you're certain you're not misremembering, this is..."

"Neither of you has ever had long hair," Suobeihua said with a stiffness to her voice. "His braid doesn't start from the center back of his head. To make the braid fall over one side of his chest, he starts braiding from behind his right ear—that way the braid always hangs down in front of his right shoulder. From our perspective, the braid is on our left."

"I really haven't had long hair...but what does starting behind the ear have to do with it?" Lisidan asked.

"If you start the braid behind the right ear and then push it over to the left, the hair fights back and won't cooperate—and it pulls the braid loose," Mai Minghe explained. "I used to work as a childcare worker when I was younger and braided plenty of little girls' hair."

"The way you talk sounds so old—never mind. If his braid came loose, couldn't he just redo it on the other side? They've been waiting outside for over an hour; casually re-doing your hair is pretty normal, isn't it?"

Lisidan paused, then said in a conciliatory tone: "It's not that I don't believe you—it's just that this braid...really can't count as evidence. Sometimes a Hunter's instinct can't be explained. Is it possible you've just got an inexplicable gut feeling?"

Suobeihua opened her mouth—in that instant, she clearly wanted to push back, but she caught herself in time and changed direction: "Mm...right. It's probably just my instinct."

Even if it couldn't quite be called a red flag, one person's gut feeling that something was wrong was enough to make the others uneasy as well.

The group glanced back and forth at each other's strangely altered faces, and for a moment none of them was quite sure what they should do next.

"Who wants to be the first to poke their head out and test the waters?" Lisidan said, half as if he were joking.

Many sincere thoughts are always spoken in the guise of jokes. No one paid him any mind.

"Or we could put him through some questions," Aimeli said, standing at the edge of the crack. Behind her walnut-shell exterior it was impossible to tell, but she seemed to have been staring down at Tianxi the whole time as he tried to figure out how to rescue them. "See whether his answers line up with what we experienced."

"Ask what?" Robert said absently, turning his wind-up key.

It seemed that from some point earlier, his hand had barely left the wind-up key; the stairwell had been filled throughout with the creaking sound of the key being wound tight. Whenever Mai Minghe thought the key was wound enough and would surely hold for a while, within just a few minutes Robert would start winding it again.

Everyone fell quiet for a moment, and Mai Minghe looked over at the position of the crack.

The opening was set quite high; at her height, it lined up only just about with her face. "Let's ask him what color the badges Key House handed out are," she said, the idea coming to her out of nowhere. "He shouldn't be able to see the badges on our chests."

When they tossed that question down to him, Tianxi looked like he found it both funny and a little exasperating.

"Orange—fluorescent orange." He stood with one hand on his hip and said: "So all this time I've been down here trying to figure out how to rescue you, you've been up there getting paranoid. Any other questions? I don't mind."

"Did your braid switch sides?" Aimeli asked, cutting straight to the point.

Tianxi froze for a moment and instinctively touched his hair.

"No—you're absolutely misremembering. My braid has always been on the left. When I was little, I went hunting with my father and brothers once and slid down a hillside, cutting a gash in the right side of my neck. Boys being boys, I thought having a scar was something to be proud of, so I deliberately kept my braid on the left to show off the scar on the right. As I got older the scar faded and you can barely see it now, but the habit stuck."

Everyone couldn't help turning to look at Suobeihua.

She simply stood motionless, staring out through the hole at the road and at Tianxi; when Mai Minghe looked over, she found that the expression creeping across Suobeihua's profile was something close to anguish—as if she both desperately wanted to believe she had misremembered, and was truly terrified that she hadn't.

It was just a braid...was she really this confident in her own memory?

"Do you see us as we normally look?" Aimeli asked again.

"Yes. Can't you all see each other normally too right now? Didn't you just say you'd left the gauntlet?"

"Then am I..."

"Aimeli," Tianxi cut her off before she could finish, raised one hand, and pointed at each of them one by one as if calling roll, matching every name to every face. "By the way, you all failed the interview—you know that, right?"

If he had said that going out right now still left room to negotiate entry into Key House, that would have been quite suspicious; but Tianxi didn't seem the least bit eager to pressure them into climbing out.

The group also picked a few questions about their individual interview experiences and posed them to Tianxi—and by all appearances, he got every one of them right without any mistakes.

"What do we do? Does anyone still have doubts? No one?" Lisidan stepped back and said quietly, "I'm also starting to feel like there really isn't a problem. So...who wants to go out first?"

Mai Minghe looked over at Suobeihua again.

The hand hanging beside her serpent tail was clenched into a tight fist, her knuckles bleached white and nearly straining through the skin.

"It's fine if you don't want to come out," Tianxi called up. "Didn't I say? The two of them already went in for the rescue a while ago. I was originally going to have them come back out, but I can also have them turn around and find you from inside the building. Let them take the lead climbing out first—surely that works."

It was plain to see that everyone let out a breath of relief; several backs and shoulders softened and relaxed.

"Alright then," Lisidan said, the antennae trembling and swaying all over his body gradually settling down. "We'll wait."

Even though the staircase was infinite, the people the floors spat out always seemed to end up near one another; finding them in the endless stairwell was not beyond the realm of possibility.

...So for now, they could only wait for rescue?

Mai Minghe looked out at the small figures on the road below and thought, feeling somewhat at a loss.

Tianxi pulled out a wireless walkie-talkie—or something that looked like a wireless walkie-talkie; what technology it actually used to function inside the Nest, Mai Minghe had no idea.

"...Can you hear me?"

Faintly, she heard Tianxi's voice carried over by a gust of wind. "...Right, keep going...yes, they won't come out...okay, be careful yourselves when you and Connie go in for the rescue."

Mai Minghe froze.

The person coming to rescue them...who was it?

My physical condition still hasn't recovered these past couple of days, and trying to guarantee both quality and consistent updates is quite a strain...if these chapters aren't written well, please don't tell me, okay!

Chapter 263 — Mai Minghe, 2019

"...Who were the Key House hunters that went into the Nest this time?"

Mai Minghe turned around, and from the temporarily trapped companions around her, received the same answer as her own memory—"Tianxi, Qiboli, Shaxue."

She lowered her head and threw the same question down to Tianxi, who sighed and called upstairs in a tone that said "when is this going to end": "It's me, Qiboli, and Connie."

Lisidan drew a quiet, sharp breath.

Robert immediately stepped forward, blocking the crack with his back, and said in a low voice: "...Did he get caught? Or was it the one called Shaxue?"

If what lay outside was a trap carefully set by the Nest, it seemed unlikely it would leave such an obvious entry and exit—let alone mention it so casually. Tianxi's own perception being the problem seemed more plausible.

"Right, that must be it," Suobeihua looked up, as though the answer had clicked into place all at once. Her expression darkened. "Something happened to Tianxi and the others."

"He got hit without even knowing it—so who's going to come rescue us?" Lisidan said, keeping his voice down. If he hadn't been afraid Tianxi would hear, he might have shouted it.

"Let me ask him a few more questions," Suobeihua lifted her chin, gesturing for Robert to move away from the crack, and said: "We need to figure out what happened to them—"

She added: "It might help us find a way out."

Aimeli said: "Go ahead and ask."

While Suobeihua called down and the others listened in silence, Mai Minghe found her thoughts drifting somewhere else entirely—to be precise, drifting upward.

Tianxi had said something a moment ago that had stayed with her, and she couldn't quite decide whether it was reassuring or unsettling: "From inside it looks like an infinitely extending stairwell, but from the outside, it's only about ten or so meters tall."

...Why hadn't she thought more about that just now?

Looking down from their current height, they were roughly at the second floor—less than ten meters from the ground; when they talked, they didn't even need to raise their voices much, just a slight lift in pitch was enough.

If from the outside the warehouse was only ten-some meters tall, then suppose Mai Minghe climbed all the way up—climbed ten floors and chiseled a hole—how far from the ground would she be? What about fifty floors, five hundred floors?

Would the opening always come out on the second or third floor, no matter what?

Whether second or third floor, both were heights you could safely climb down from... so her confusion circled back to the same question: what was the point of the Infinite Floors?

And what did the answer to that question have to do with whatever had happened to Tianxi's group?

"It took us nearly an hour to clear the challenges and reach the stairwell."

Without realizing it, Mai Minghe had turned her thoughts into words and spoken them aloud: "So even if Qiboli and... Qiboli and Connie are familiar with the traps inside, it would take them at least thirty minutes or more to reach the stairwell—that assumption isn't too far off, is it?"

Even though her voice was low and Suobeihua was busy calling down below, Aimeli beside her still caught it; Lisidan's antennae swiveled around and he turned toward her as well.

"Mm?" Aimeli prompted her to continue with a single nasal sound.

"...Are there any concrete chunks left?" Mai Minghe said, already bending to pick up a metal railing from the floor. "I'm going up one floor to chisel another hole. Want to come help?"

"I don't really feel like moving." Aimeli's speech was slow; after a few seconds, she added: "...Tired."

...Tired?

Mai Minghe glanced at her—but behind that enormous nutshell, there was nothing to read.

"Why? You can't be worried about this hole, surely?" Lisidan said with a laugh. "You might as well go down a few floors—maybe the hole you chisel there will be closer to the ground, and you won't even need a rope to get out."

Mai Minghe wasn't quite sure whether he was joking.

Going up or going down made no essential difference to her—she was full of unanswered questions either way—but she chose to go up.

"Hey!"

Suobeihua spun around and hissed without warning, stopping Mai Minghe in her tracks. She turned, and found Suobeihua staring at her with bright, intent eyes. "Where are you going?"

Mai Minghe lifted her arm to show her the concrete chunk she was carrying. "Up. To chisel another hole."

"Why?"

Mai Minghe had no answer, and could only turn it back: "Why not?"

Suobeihua thought for a few seconds.

"The floors seem to spit us out at random. I'm worried that if you leave, the stairwell will shuffle like a deck of cards and slot you into some random floor that no one can predict. If we get separated in the Infinite Floors, we might never find each other again—not until we die."

That was a risk she hadn't considered...

"Wait a moment," Suobeihua said, apparently afraid that Mai Minghe would turn and disappear on her own. "Let me ask Tianxi a few more questions, then we'll all go up together. If everyone helps you smash the wall, it'll go faster, won't it?"

Robert had no objection—but Mai Minghe couldn't help thinking he was probably glad to have something to do. Sitting in one place without exerting himself made it hard to keep winding his wind-up key.

Lisidan grumbled at length, didn't object, but still had plenty to say; Aimeli, by contrast, said nothing and didn't move.

Suobeihua lowered herself a few dozen centimeters, brought her face back in line with the crack, and hesitated, seemingly unsure what to ask next. Her string of questions earlier hadn't seemed to pull up much meaningful information.

She met Lisidan's eyes, and, as though grasping for something to say, called down: "...Tianxi, what time is it right now?"

The sound of Tianxi's sigh drifted up two floors.

"Four eleven in the afternoon," he said, checking his watch. "You went in just before three. Anything else? By the way, today is Sunday, November twenty-fourth."

The stairwell fell silent for two seconds.

"No, it's not Sunday," Suobeihua said. "What are you talking about? You're misremembering—look at your phone. Today is Tuesday."

Tianxi let out another sigh.

He seemed to take the suggestion in stride and did pull out his phone; after a second or two, Tianxi called out: "No. I'm looking at it right now—the screen says, plain as day: Sunday, November 24, 2019."

...2019?

Everyone looked at one another. For a moment, all that remained in the stairwell was the sound of their breathing.

"Is he joking?" Lisidan murmured.

"I'm going to chisel the hole," Mai Minghe suddenly made up her mind, turned, and started up the stairs. "If you want to follow, move fast."

Suobeihua rose from her serpentine coil, said "I'm coming" in a rush, and glided up the stairs right after her—even a little faster than Mai Minghe on foot.

Lisidan and Robert followed one after the other, with Aimeli bringing up the rear; it wasn't until everyone had already hammered shallow craters into the wall that she finally appeared at the corner landing, slow as ever.

"...Tired,"

When Mai Minghe found a moment to ask, Aimeli's answer was the same as before. "Heavy."

With the experience from before, chiseling through the wall went faster this time; in no time at all, the group had forced a crack through the thick wall wide enough to see through.

Suobeihua was the first to press forward, pressing one eye to the crack; after a few seconds, she glided away without a word and gave up her spot to the next person.

Mai Minghe quickly understood that it wasn't because everything outside was normal and there was nothing to say—that was not why Suobeihua had gone quiet.

When a person is plunged into profound bewilderment, sometimes they don't even know what question to ask—at least, that was how Mai Minghe felt for a full half a minute.

Their height above the ground had not changed, as though they hadn't climbed a floor at all; outside was the same street, with the same Tianxi standing there.

Only—just now, Tianxi had been standing directly below, pressed against the wall, calling upward; now Tianxi stood far off, dozens of meters away by the entrance, across the street, hands in his pockets, not glancing toward the building at all—as if he had completely forgotten about the hunters he was interviewing upstairs.

...His braids were hanging in a different direction.

"I think we need to go up one more floor and chisel another hole," Suobeihua said, her voice dry and hoarse.

This time, even Lisidan seemed to have run out of things to say. To the sound of a wind-up key turning tighter and tighter, the group climbed another floor, repeated the process, and forced open another crack.

Out on the same street, Tianxi, Qiboli, and Shaxue stood together, murmuring about something; Mai Minghe couldn't make it out, but Lisidan could.

His antenna stretched out long through the crack, swaying in the air; after a moment, he turned back and reported:

"...They're saying there are only ten minutes left before the interview ends—how come not a single person has come out?"

My editor asked me to write a bonus story for Wild Deer, because it looks like Wild Deer might be getting a print release (I don't know the details either), and they're planning to include the bonus story in the book. It's just that given my current state... ugh, my body and brain are both dead—can I even pull it off?

Chapter 264: Mai Minghe's Rescue Arrives Beyond All Expectation

If the floor from 2019 were designated "Floor 0," then going up: Floor 1 was "Tianxi with her braid on the left," Floor 2 was "ten minutes left in the interview"—and it seemed that from this point on, everyone simultaneously realized that the dull, grueling labor had only just begun.

Outside the walls of Floor 3 was a deep night howling with wind and rain, as though the entire neighborhood had long since been abandoned by the world—not a single shadow of a Key House Hunter anywhere.

The Tianxi outside the walls of Floor 4 was a woman. Her features still retained traces of Tianxi, and she even wore a long braid combed to the left; Robert looked at her a few extra times.

The timing of the breach on Floor 5 was uncannily precise—they happened to see five interview Hunters leaving Annie Warehouse alongside three Key House Hunters, setting off on their way home. They could only make out a cluster of small, distant figures, and after arguing for several minutes, could not determine whether those five were themselves or not.

But whether they were or not seemed not to matter anymore. In any case, they absolutely could not go out.

After the wall of Floor 6 cracked open, what lay beyond was a series of flat scenery panels standing beneath a gray, overcast sky.

Building panels, tree panels, Tianxi panels.

The moment the Tianxi panel caught sight of them, it immediately slid toward the hole in the wall as though hidden rails were concealed beneath the floor; the smile printed on its face grew larger and larger, more and more earnest, the closer the panel came.

As the five of them stumbled backward, Mai Minghe nearly fell into the stairwell—after the railing had been smashed off and removed, the handrail was no longer secure, and when her back struck it, the handrail gave way and plunged into the void below, taking one of her legs with it.

...If Suobeihua hadn't grabbed her by reflex, she would still be falling endlessly downward right now, wouldn't she?

The group had broken through nine walls in a row; the blisters on their hands had already burst, and both their ammunition and stamina had been heavily depleted—yet they had not

caught so much as a glimpse of any hope of rescue. Driven by sheer blind desperation, with nothing left to try but anything at all, they turned back to Floor 0 and began chiseling downward through the walls.

-

The Tianxi on Floor 1 urged them to stay put, saying she had already sent two Residents in to help.

"Don't worry, those two are among the rare harmless Residents of the Nest. Our Key House has a working arrangement with them—when we run into a particularly tricky trap, we ask them for assistance," said the Tianxi on Floor -1 gently. "But you absolutely must stop running around, understood? ...Qiboli? Sandy? Our House Faction has no one by those names."

-

The scenery and date on Floor 2 were entirely normal, but the Tianxi on Floor -2 insisted that Suobeihua was not one of the interview Hunters.

-

The moment a crack opened in the wall of Floor 3, Lisidan was just leaning in to look when a long, flesh-red phantom shadow flashed through the gap without warning and swept violently across the countless antennae covering his head and face—at least several dozen antennae were crushed and snapped off on the spot, and Lisidan's screams of pain seemed just as endless as the stairwell itself.

What was even more unsettling was that Aimeli seemed to have gone quiet for a long time.

Every time Mai Minghe prompted her to say something, she only let out a low "mm" from her throat. She moved slowly, and at one point she seemed to lose her footing and slam into the wall, leaving a shallow dent—which was helpful enough for breaking through walls, yet Mai Minghe could never understand why Aimeli, who was still fundamentally flesh and blood, could dent a wall like that.

Then there was Suobeihua, who kept shifting between standing high and standing low, as though she truly could balance on a serpent's tail.

Robert went without saying—when breaking through walls, he could only use his left hand. And weren't Lisidan's antennae supposed to be illusions? Yet when they were snapped off, he howled in pain for so long...

And herself?

What changes were happening to her?

If there were changes, she was the same as the others—there was nothing she could do to stop them... It even seemed like she didn't know where to begin with self-examination.

"Enough. Stop wasting energy."

The words no one had been willing to say aloud, Suobeihua said first. "Every floor seems to lead to a different reality. Infinite floors, infinite realities—we... we're probably never going to find our way back, are we."

"Are you planning to spend the rest of your life in a stairwell?" Robert immediately let out a cold snort. "Or do you intend to just pick a random reality and walk out into it?"

"Stop talking nonsense," Suobeihua said, as if she meant to throw every word like a throwing knife. "Right now, all we can do is wait for Key House's rescue."

Mai Minghe had no such intention, yet the image of a "stairwell life" rose unbidden in her mind—because from a certain angle, it was something that could entirely come to pass.

Infinite floors, infinite Tianxis, and among them there were surely many, many Tianxis willing to supply them with necessities: food, water, sleeping bags, axes, bullets... Just a moment ago, one Tianxi had even asked if they needed a power bank.

Anything dropped into the endless stairwell would never hit the ground, so there would never be any need to worry about waste falling and breeding stench or disease; only that, when it came to the larger business, one would probably need a fair bit of aim and balance.

Even the rule that a person could only spend seven days in the Nest didn't seem entirely impossible to work around—so long as they found a floor where what lay beyond the wall was not the Nest but Blackmoor City, they could lean their body out and pull it back in, and there was a reasonable chance of avoiding the worst outcome.

No, that idea was absurd. Who would want to spend their last nine months here?

Mai Minghe shook her head hard, flinging those uninvited, unwelcome thoughts back out—but that shake of her head drew a sideways glance from Suobeihua.

"The door on your face can open... what's with the mirror behind it?" Suobeihua descended slowly from the ceiling and asked her.

Only then did Mai Minghe realize—when she had fled from the transparent figure in the mirror, she had slapped the wooden door on her face shut; and after finding the others, there had been no reason to open it again deliberately, and she had even forgotten to mention it. That shake of her head had swung it open without her meaning to.

"I don't know either,"

Mai Minghe thought for a moment, then asked the group: "Does what the mirror on my face reflects look the same to you as what you see directly?"

Lisidan, slumped on the floor, immediately grasped the implication, scrambled to his feet, and positioned himself between the mirror and the wall—without needing to turn his head back and forth, as though his antennae were already picking up the visual signal for him.

"Same," he said, deflated, and dropped heavily back onto the floor. Fortunately, there were no antennae on his backside. "Hah... your imagination runs pretty wild. Got me worked up for nothing."

As expected, she had overestimated her own luck... Mai Minghe closed the door again.

The few of them, already thoroughly exhausted, aching and heavy, all sank onto the stairs without discussion, some lying down, some sitting. Even while sitting spread across two floors, they didn't seem to get tossed to some random other floor by the infinite stairwell, so Suobeihua dragged her long serpent tail and drifted down to the stairs of Floor -6, settling beside Mai Minghe.

Earlier, to escape the phantom shadow that had reached into Floor -3, they had run three floors down in one breath, yet no one suggested breaking through the wall again.

"...What do you think?" Suobeihua sat in silence for a while before asking in a low voice.

"Me?" Mai Minghe was a little surprised.

Suobeihua nodded. "You're the most steady and composed among us, and you were the first one to suggest going back upstairs and breaking through more walls. If there's anyone whose judgment I trust the most... it would be you."

Mai Minghe gave a bitter smile and patted her hand in a consoling way.

"Once we've rested a bit, we can take down that Emergency Exit Sign and have a look at it. Then go back upstairs... and use my mirror to shine into the cracks in the wall. Beyond that, I

really don't have any other ideas... While we wait for rescue, sitting here is still waiting, and doing something is still waiting too, right?"

Suobeihua leaned sideways against the wall and let out a breath.

"If I'd known, I never would have come to this interview. A trap in the Nest with absolutely no way out—I'd only ever heard of something like that, never run into one... how could I be the one to stumble into a dead end?"

As a player in the "Nest Domination Game" that the Nest's Residents most wanted dead, Mai Minghe might well be the primary reason this warehouse trap had suddenly twisted and turned monstrous—yet now that things had come to this point, she could no longer say that suspicion aloud.

"Even if Key House is capable, can they truly find us?" Suobeihua gave a cold, thin smile. "And even if they can find us, how are they supposed to get out? The ones who'd come in would still be Hunters acting on House Faction resources—in essence, how much better off than us would they really be..."

Hunters acting on House Faction resources...

Those words stirred a vague, foggy unease in Mai Minghe.

Was she afraid that in the end, even the rescue could not be counted on?

Mai Minghe sat in a blank daze for long enough that when Suobeihua called her name a few times, she startled back to herself: "...What?"

"Are you all right?" Suobeihua gave her a probing look. "I was just asking why you came to this interview. Newcomers don't usually try to get into Key House right out of the gate."

Now that the interview had failed, retrieving the lipstick had drifted further and further away like a receding dream... Mai Minghe sat there blankly, no longer certain whether the deep exhaustion in her body came from breaking through walls or from something else entirely.

It seemed not to matter anymore.

"I had a reason for wanting to join Key House," Mai Minghe said, unwilling to lie but unwilling to tell the truth, settling for something vague.

Suobeihua did not press her.

"It's out of reach now anyway," she only said with a sigh. "All we can do is hope they manage to get us out."

Mai Minghe nearly felt unsettled in her seat—those words inexplicably sent a faint chill through her.

Why?

"Hm?"

Lisidan suddenly lifted his head. In the momentary silence of the stairwell, every antenna on his body reached downward, nearly lying flat.

"Footsteps," he said, scrambling to his feet. "About twenty-some floors below, there are footsteps—more than one person's footsteps. It must be the rescue, right? It has to be the rescue, right?"

Though none of the others could hear anything, they were all stirred into excitement all the same, leaning over the railing to look down, and Robert even shouted several times in a fury: "Is anyone down there? Who's coming?"

After a few seconds, small, indistinct figures replied from deep within the stairwell.

"Are you the ones from the interview?"

The voice was a man's—it should be Qiboli. But the sound bounced back and forth through the stairwell, losing its edges layer by layer as it scattered and blended, and the distinctive quality of Qiboli's voice could no longer be made out. "We're here for the rescue, I'm Qiboli!"

Lisidan let out a muffled sob from his throat, and even Suobeihua couldn't help exhaling.

It was at this very moment—as the others exhaled in relief—that Mai Minghe suddenly understood the source of her unease.

She stepped back from the railing, swept her gaze across the group, and asked in a low voice: "...Which floor did the rescue come from?"

The other four seemed to have their throats gripped by the same invisible hand at once.

Robert snapped his head around with a sharp crack, his wind-up key forgotten, and asked: "What do you mean?"

"If what lies outside each floor is not an illusion," Mai Minghe said, "then the Key House Hunters on every floor who believe our interview has failed would all send in a 'rescue.' So which floor's Qiboli is the one coming now? In other words, if we follow them out, which floor's reality would we be entering?"

Robert laughed.

"Are you an idiot," he said, perfectly at ease. "Do you really think each floor leads to a separate reality? There are no parallel realities in this world—they're obviously all illusions, meant to trick us into going out."

Tricks?

If they were tricks, why not create an illusion indistinguishable from reality? Or make the world beyond every floor look exactly the same?

It was precisely **because** the world outside each wall was different that they dared not go out—wasn't it?

"Obviously because the Nest needs to maintain fairness," Robert had an answer for this too.

...Where exactly was there even a shred of fairness left in this stairwell?

Mai Minghe turned her gaze, and it met Suobeihua's. The two looked at each other for a second, then Suobeihua bent down and called toward the floor below: "Qiboli, who did you come in with?"

"Connie, of course,"

Those few words rose like an ascending spiral, coiling up the staircase ring by ring, spilling into everyone's ears.

How good I've been to Mai Minghe—I originally only planned one rescue, but I gave you countless rescues. Ah, that's what a real mom does.

Alright, I'm going to go reply to last chapter's comments now. I've been in poor condition lately—after finishing writing I just collapse and rest, and haven't gotten around to replying to you all yet.

Chapter 265: Mai Minghe's Colorful Reality and the Undercover Snake

The longing everyone had felt forty minutes ago for Key House rescue had now been satisfied by the Nest a thousand—more precisely, an infinite—fold.

The real problem wasn't that every rescue team came from a different reality; the real problem was that rescue wasn't all that had arrived.

Very quickly, the group discovered that within the endless expanse of parallel realities, there also existed endless reasons for all manner of things—indescribable, barely classifiable things (or were they people?)—to enter the stairwell with endless motives, all aimed at a single target: Mai Minghe and her companions.

The first rescue team, Qiboli and Connie, were relatively easy to deal with: they seemed to have come in with sincere intentions to save people.

"...You're not leaving?"

Qiboli was already climbing into view from the stairs below as he spoke. His appearance, clothing, and manner of speaking were identical to the Qiboli Mai Minghe had seen before entering—perhaps the Key House people knew how to bypass the checkpoints, because he hadn't transformed at all, and the surprise and confusion on his face were plain as day.

"You're voluntarily choosing to stay trapped in this stairwell forever?"

The woman beside Qiboli, named Connie, asked Suobeihua again in disbelief to confirm.

She was a complete stranger—not Shaxue under a different name. But Connie still appeared to be nothing more than a healthy, mature human woman; both of them spoke and behaved rationally and normally, even in a manner entirely consistent with how Key House Hunters ought to act.

"Did something get to you? What's your reason for not leaving?" Connie was quite displeased. "If you all die in here, no one will believe you stayed of your own free will—and in the end, it's our Key House reputation that suffers."

In that instant, a vague but sweet thought seemed to flow like water from one person's mind to the next.

Mai Minghe hadn't confirmed it with anyone, but she had the sense that everyone must have felt that same unspoken suggestion.

...These two were from Floor 0.

The group of five had asked Floor 0's Tianxi the most questions; from what they currently knew, the reality Floor 0 occupied was no different from their own, except that the year and time didn't match.

If everything was normal, wouldn't going back with these two to the reality still in 2019 be better than staying trapped in the stairwell forever?

But no one said it aloud.

Floor 0 was just above them, not far; if it truly came down to having no other choice, they still had a chance to crawl out through Floor 0...probably.

After being refused repeatedly by Suobeihua, who kept insisting they leave, Qiboli and Connie stopped pressing—Qiboli shrugged, turned around, and headed back down the stairs, saying, "Fine by me. Whether you've been gotten to or not, I'm not the kind of person who forces rescues on people. Hey, Connie, let's go."

Connie was silent for a few seconds, took one last look at the five of them, then turned and followed. Under everyone's fixed gaze, the two grew smaller and smaller until they disappeared—the group let out a collective breath and straightened up.

Connie's furious, horrified scream shot straight up the stairwell at that very moment: "Qiboli? Qiboli! Qiboli! Where are you? Where did you—"

Her vocal cords abruptly ceased their vibration, sending no further sound, leaving only a dying echo that circled and circled through the stairwell, sinking gradually into silence.

Mai Minghe was certain she wasn't the only one whose back had gone rigid and whose palms had broken into a sweat.

The first rescue team—Qiboli and Connie—seemed to have vanished from the stairs the moment they were sent away.

None of them suggested going down to check, not because the five were of one mind and all being cautious, but because at that very moment, from the floor above, someone seemed to cover their mouth with one hand and let out a muffled snicker through their nose—it was Qiboli.

"Don't be afraid—I didn't disappear, I'm playing hide-and-seek."

He stood at the top of another staircase going upward, just around the corner, speaking in a hushed breath. When the group looked up, they could only see his trouser legs and feet. "Don't tell them I'm here, okay?"

...This was a Qiboli sent from another reality—not the one from Floor 0. That much was obvious.

"Oh, I forgot. Once we're inside the Nest, we don't need to play hide-and-seek anymore...old habits die hard. I actually blanked for a moment just now, thinking—you five were clearly found by me, so how come none of you have turned into ghosts yet?"

"What are you talking about?" Robert demanded angrily. Even the anger seemed forced.

"When someone gets found, they become a ghost," this Qiboli said vaguely. "The most important rule of Blackmoor City—you must not be found..."

Down in the depths below, something seemed to lurk that had silently swallowed the first rescue team; and on the floor above stood a Qiboli, slowly recounting the history of hide-and-seek in Blackmoor City.

Everyone had to play hide-and-seek, everyone had to stay hidden, everyone had to conceal their identity—in that Blackmoor City, people who liked posting on social media had died off long ago, wiped out after the "hide-and-seek" catastrophe descended.

Suobeihua glanced at Mai Minghe and mouthed silently: Go down?

Mai Minghe swept a glance downward.

She shook her head urgently, jabbing her finger hard toward the stairs below, drawing the attention of the others nearby, who all bowed their heads to look.

Two Residents were climbing up the staircase—the reason they could be identified as Residents at a glance was that one of their hooded sweatshirts was printed with "居" and the other with "民."

Beyond that, their faces caved deeply inward toward the center, like dough that had collapsed and folded shut after being punched—which was, in its own way, an honest form of identification.

The two of them tilted their faces upward, seeming to meet the group's eyes through the sunken cleft, and immediately began to speak in a call-and-response rhythm, perfectly in sync.

"We," said the Resident on the left.

"Are, are, truly are," said the Resident on the right.

"Harmless," sang the one on the left.

"Residents!" the right one chimed in. "Harmless, pleasant, and eco-friendly,"

The left one said: "A rare find!"

Robert swore.

"There are only four or five floors left before they reach us," Lisidan panicked. "They're climbing too fast—"

"Don't be afraid," the Resident on the right soothed.

"Come with us," said the left one.

"Don't shout no, no, no—" The Resident on the right mimicked the screaming and struggling of human resistance with uncanny precision.

"Saying no just means yes!" the left one declared, as though concluding a verse.

Every face still capable of showing an expression had drained of color.

Suobeihua bit down hard on her lower lip, snapped her head up, and said to Qiboli's feet above: "You have to play hide-and-seek here too—did you know that?"

"Hm?"

"Go hide now. We're coming to find you in just a moment!"

Mai Minghe understood her meaning at once—but would it actually work on him?

"The rules don't work like that..." Qiboli said.

Suobeihua glanced down at the two Residents rapidly closing in on them. "The rule in this stairwell is that the larger group searches for the smaller group—the exact opposite of Blackmoor City."

She seemed to have taken in at least part of what he'd said earlier; it was unclear whether Qiboli had truly been convinced or had his own plan, but he let out a short laugh, and those feet pivoted direction, pattering up the stairs.

The moment those feet disappeared, Suobeihua immediately dropped her voice and barked "Run up—now!", then was the first to surge up the steps.

No one wanted to stay behind and find out whether those two Residents were truly harmless.

The first three waves of "rescue teams," though they had arrived one after another in quick succession, were not the most difficult or deadly of the lot—Qiboli had vanished somewhere in the blink of an eye, and the Residents, though fast on their feet, had their attention drawn away mid-chase by other humans they encountered along the way.

No one knew what—or who—they had seen.

Mai Minghe, and her several makeshift companions who likewise dared not breathe too loudly, pressed themselves against the railing, listening as the two Residents stopped in their tracks and called out in their alternating singsong:

"Little one,"

"All alone?"

"The two of us,"

"Are good people."

It was most likely another Hunter sent in from a different reality...whether they had come to rescue, who they were, and what became of them afterward—the five of them had no idea.

After the voices of the two Residents faded, the stairwell seemed to return to stillness.

During their flight, they had long since passed Floor 0, running all the way up to Floor 6 in one breath; the muscles in Mai Minghe's limbs felt as if their fibers had snapped—exhausted and hollowed out, trembling faintly, with nothing left to squeeze from them.

"Let's...rest...a...moment," Robert said, and started winding up his key again. That sound of metal coiling and grinding—Mai Minghe had grown thoroughly sick of hearing it.

Lisidan's antennae all swayed back and forth, picking up movement from above and below in the stairwell; Aimeli drifted to the rear last of all, leaning against the wall in silence.

Suobeihua buried her face in her hands.

"You know," she said out of nowhere, "I didn't have to come to this interview at all."

Mai Minghe blanked for two seconds before realizing she was being spoken to.

Lisidan had surely heard; a few of his antennae turned ever so slightly, but he didn't look around, as though pretending not to have noticed. Given the state Robert and Aimeli were in right now, it was hard to imagine they still had the energy to spare for Suobeihua's barely audible murmuring.

"I'm not a solo operator Hunter at all." Suobeihua lowered her hands and looked at the coiled serpentine tail beneath her, giving a self-deprecating laugh. "I have a House Faction."

Shh.

Mai Minghe watched her tail slowly coiling and suddenly understood: "You—you were trying to infiltrate Key House? That's why you're in the form of a snake?"

Snake wasn't a flattering word; so whenever she had seen Suobeihua's serpent tail, she had always avoided probing too deeply into its significance—now, at last, she had her answer.

"Pathetic, isn't it," Suobeihua murmured, her face ashen. "I only wanted to look into Chase Monroe's movements...I knew it was a dangerous assignment, but I never expected the danger to come from outside Key House. To think I'd crash and burn at an interview checkpoint like this."

Shh.

"It's just not worth it...it's just not worth it."

Suobeihua laughed softly. "For the sake of gathering information on Key House...it's just not worth it. We have no hope of getting out anymore, unless we pick some random 'reality' and crawl through it, only to be played with by the Nest until we die. Or we stay, and slowly become something neither human nor ghost."

She turned to look at Mai Minghe, but her eyes seemed to register nothing at all.

Whether the person sitting before her was Mai Minghe or a cat or a dog apparently no longer mattered to her in the slightest.

Shh.

Suobeihua stilled the hand that had been stroking her serpent tail, her expression vacant, her voice dropping to barely a whisper. "What about you? Do you regret it? Just wanting to find yourself some support, some backing..."

"I wasn't actually looking for Key House just to join a House Faction either..."

Mai Minghe let the sentence drop.

Not because she feared this conversation might reach Key House ears; her wariness and worry about Key House had by now become something distant, something shadowy and faint as mist.

It was like how, after a mother's terminal cancer diagnosis, you suddenly stop repeatedly checking whether the gas stove was turned off, stop going back again and again to make sure the front door is locked—that kind of anxiety over physical safety is a luxury reserved for those who know they will go on living.

She stopped speaking because she suddenly noticed that Suobeihua had stopped stroking the scales of her serpent tail. Amid the rhythmic sound of the wind-up key, she could still hear...

Shh.

Mai Minghe turned her head.

From a crack in the wall, a thin, human-shaped flat piece of scenery had already pushed half its body through.

Friends, tomorrow is Saturday, but I'm going to be a bad child about it — sorry to let down all you generous tippers. I plan to use the time off from updating to write the Wild Deer Convenience Store side story, and I'll make up the thank-you chapter next Saturday!

Honestly, I don't even know if Wild Deer can pass the censors. Supernatural weirdness — will they let it get published...

Chapter 266: Mai Minghe and the Three Lizard-Skin Quacks' Discovery

"Robert!"

Mai Minghe was the first to snap back to her senses, leaping to her feet and shouting, "Get out of the way!"

The person leaning against the wall, sitting right below the crack, was Robert—who had been winding himself up this whole time.

He had been completely absorbed in it, as though climbing upward through a sensation that built with each revolution of the key, and it took Mai Minghe calling out twice before he finally snorted a breath through his nose and came back to himself: "...What? What are you yelling about?"

Before Mai Minghe could say anything, he seemed to sense something was wrong on his own.

Robert tilted back that flushed plastic face of his.

The face on the Tianxi cardboard backdrop met his gaze directly, casting a shadow of a beaming smile across his features.

Robert's body jolted; half a cry slipped from his throat, and he immediately let go of the key. He still had enough presence of mind not to leap straight up on instinct—otherwise he would have thrown himself right into the Tianxi cardboard's arms—and instead lurched sideways in a panic, crashing into Lisidan and sending him stumbling into the wall.

Antennae snapped and broke; amid Lisidan's cries of pain, Robert yanked out the pistol at his waist and fired at the crack—bang, bang, bang.

But the backdrop was at most three to five centimeters thick, and the bullets grazed past the Tianxi cardboard and struck the wall, ricocheting back as wild, scattering shots; for a moment everyone scrambled to throw themselves flat and take cover, shouting and screaming, the stairwell plunged into chaos.

Lisidan kept crying out, "Push it back! Push it back out!"

"If you want to touch it, go ahead," Robert snarled, then barked an order down at Aimeli on the stairs below: "What are you just sitting there for? Run—get out of the way!"

Suobeihua was also shouting, "Come back, we can't scatter!"

By then, Mai Minghe had already wheeled around and charged up the stairs; from higher up the flight, looking down, she finally got a clear view of the Tianxi cardboard in its entirety.

"Cardboard backdrop" didn't seem quite right as a description.

Both sides of the human-shaped thick cardboard were printed with Tianxi—one side showing her face, the other the back of her head—the image so sharp and lifelike it looked as though a living person had been flattened into cardboard.

Even as cardboard, it didn't seem to hinder its movement in the slightest; within seconds, it had slid further into the stairwell, more than half its body already through.

Mai Minghe raised one aching, trembling hand, squinted one eye, barely trained her gun on the human-shaped cardboard below, and shouted, "Everyone clear out—I'm opening fire!"

The two arms printed on the human-shaped cardboard suddenly split away from the shoulders and came apart.

The "Tianxi cardboard" used its two long, flat cardboard arms to shove hard against the wall, then fell to the floor with a smack—it came to rest against the wall upside-down, head below and feet above; for a moment it looked like a prop someone had temporarily set aside.

At the same instant, Mai Minghe's bullets poured down onto the Tianxi cardboard's back.

The gunshots slammed through the stairwell like rolling waves of thunder, swallowing every cry of panic. In the slowly fading echo, everyone's breathing was audible—all waiting for whatever came next.

The cardboard lay perfectly still, its back riddled with holes, bent and crumpled where it had been struck.

With a smack, a small piece of new cardboard fell from somewhere and landed on the floor.

Lisidan steeled himself and peered carefully; Mai Minghe, looking down from above, also got a clear look.

The cardboard was circular with a pointed tail pulled out at the bottom—like a speech bubble from a comic strip.

"That hurt,"

it read on the cardboard. "I came to rescue you, and this is how you repay me? Ah, I understand now—you're not the real interviewees. You're all fakes. You're Residents. That must be why you look a little strange, as if you're especially swollen, bloated with too much fluid..."

The second speech-bubble cardboard that fell read: "Ha! Since you're all Residents, I won't need to hold back."

"Move, now!"

Robert had also read the text on the cardboard; he spun around on the stair landing and kicked out at Aimeli, who was blocking the stairs. "Stop blocking—"

The words died in his throat, replaced by a sharp cry of pain. Robert staggered backward, one foot hovering in the air: "My toes—my toes—"

Aimeli still hadn't moved an inch, her body not even swaying.

"Everyone get down,"

From not far from Mai Minghe, Suobeihua, who had been coiled on the corner landing, suddenly called out, "Hold on tight—don't get swept off by me!"

Whether the others heard and understood, whether they had time to react—Mai Minghe paid no attention to any of it.

Because in that moment, her gaze was seized by the thick, powerful snake tail beneath Suobeihua, as though she had sunk into a rippling green tide formed by countless fine scales and could not pull free—a deep-green river, gleaming with wet light, sinuous and unfurling, drifting slowly through midair.

The Tianxi cardboard, which had just picked itself back up, was caught squarely in its path; the snake tail coiled around it and kept surging forward, and when it swung out over the open shaft of the stairwell, the tail released—the cardboard Tianxi plummeted straight down into the infinite void below.

Countless small circular pieces of cardboard burst into the air at once, each one printed with the same words, stringing out a trail through the air:

"Ah"

"Ah"

"Ah"

The little cardboard pieces vanished in an instant, chasing their owner into the depths below.

...Truly impossible to say whether it was more absurd, funny, or terrifying.

"Are you all right?"

After a few seconds, Mai Minghe came back to herself, her gaze moving back and forth between Suobeihua's face and her snake tail. "You used... used the snake-tail illusion to touch it?"

"...Is it still an illusion?" Suobeihua looked down at her own snake tail and murmured softly.

Mai Minghe had no answer for that.

Was her head also slowly solidifying—becoming a mirror?

"That's great," Lisidan said, letting out a breath of relief, apparently not the least bit bothered by the antennae covering his body. "Your snake tail is really useful, isn't it? I handle detection, you handle sweeping anyone who attacks us into the stairwell—if we work together like that, wouldn't we have nothing to fear?"

Robert hissed through his teeth, hopped back to the spot beside the crack, and bent down to pick something up off the floor.

"That's not guaranteed. There are bound to be some who can slip past detection and aren't afraid of falling into the stairwell... What would you do about those?"

The stairwell fell silent for a second or two.

Mai Minghe had just reached up to touch her own face, and when her fingers found an unmistakable "door handle" there, her heart sank—she hadn't caught a word of what Lisidan said.

Suobeihua was looking at Lisidan, her lips pressed tightly shut.

Robert had been bent over picking something up just now; Aimeli hadn't said a word in a long time, let alone strung together a sentence that long in one breath.

...So who had just responded to Lisidan?

Every single antenna on Lisidan's body slowly swiveled, all of them pointing toward the stairwell in front of him.

Mai Minghe looked down at the railing beside her feet.

From the edge of the stairs beside Aimeli, from beneath the railing in front of her, and from inside the stairwell directly facing Lisidan, three heads gradually rose into view at the same time.

Three people—no one knew when they had climbed up along the stairwell shaft to reach them.

"Fortunately, you no longer need to worry or be afraid." The round head near Mai Minghe's feet opened its mouth toward her. "We've come to rescue you."

"Even though you didn't pass the interview," said another—one who vaguely resembled Tianxi but far more closely resembled a lizard (a person?)—"we still have to take you out of the Nest."

"Otherwise, who would dare come to our kah-kah-kah-kah-kah—house to interview in the future?" The last one spoke up, its voice faintly resembling a woman's.

Whether it was incapable of pronouncing "Key House," or whether in that lizard-person reality the House Faction was simply called "kah-kah-kah-kah-kah House," was impossible to say.

Within just three or four seconds, everyone knew that bullets were useless.

Some bullets were swallowed whole; others sank gently and slightly into the lizard skin, then bounced back out playfully, like small flying insects toying with the lizards—the atmosphere was almost lively and cheerful for a moment, at least from the lizards' perspective.

"Sweep them already," Lisidan shouted, "with your tail!"

"Stop talking nonsense," Suobeihua snapped.

"Oh, what are you doing here?" one lizard said.

Another lizard fell into thought: "Why are you shooting at us? Don't you want to be saved? Come to think of it, how is it you haven't kept even a trace of lizard form? Rather suspicious."

"Run," Mai Minghe called out, "head upstairs first!"

A snake tail that thick and long—the moment it wrapped around anything, the lizard-people would latch onto it immediately and climb right up—no wonder Suobeihua was unwilling to extend it.

Nearly everyone was scrambling up the stairs in a desperate rush—so what if it was only a stopgap? Every moment of escape was worth taking.

But not everyone thought that way.

Aimeli stood on the corner landing and said, "I'm not afraid."

Mai Minghe stopped dead in her tracks, nearly letting Robert slam into her from behind—being hit by that wind-up key of his would have been deeply unpleasant.

"Aimeli," she leaned out over the railing and shouted down, "get up here!"

"I'm not weak," Aimeli said.

Something that was vaguely like Qiboli, but shaped like a lizard, slowly rose up on two legs behind her.

Judging by the way Aimeli's shell was growing thicker and harder by the second, convincing her in a matter of seconds was probably impossible; Mai Minghe turned around, grabbed Suobeihua's hand beside her, and said with a pleading look, "...Please."

Suobeihua understood what she meant, and glanced quickly downward—the other two lizard-human hybrids were also climbing straight up the stairwell shaft and would soon be on them again.

"Why?" Suobeihua asked. "Is she with you?"

"No," Mai Minghe said quietly, "but she's a human life."

Suobeihua hesitated for just a moment; the muscles along her jaw rose and fell against her cheek, and then the snake tail unfurled from beneath her again—Aimeli, being a large solid nut, had no time to resist before she was coiled around and hauled up the stairs.

"Come on," Mai Minghe reached out to grab the nut—there was nothing to actually grab onto, so it was less like grabbing Aimeli and more like nudging her along.

"If you value human life, why are you doing this kind of work?"

Suobeihua pushed Aimeli from behind, the three of them together chasing after Robert and Lisidan ahead.

Mai Minghe had no time to answer her, and could only manage a wry smile: "Just run!"

But they could only climb the stairs one step at a time with two legs—Suobeihua aside—while the lizards could shoot straight up on all fours. How could they possibly outrun lizards?

Mai Minghe began to suspect: it seemed like the lizards could have pounced on them long ago, yet hadn't.

The three lizard-like figures even gradually appeared to slow down; once or twice, when she looked back, she found them gripping the railing, crouched at the edge of the stairs, observing something she couldn't make out.

...That question was answered very soon.

"Have you noticed," the Tianxi-lizard said, "the Emergency Exit Sign..."

"Yes, I noticed it from the floor below—the little figure has stopped running," the Qiboli-lizard said.

What little figure had stopped running?

Mai Minghe and Suobeihua exchanged a glance; even if it was a trap, neither had any will to resist, and they looked toward the Emergency Exit Sign without a word of coordination.

The little figure had truly stopped running.

The little figure that had originally been drawn on the sign striding forward in a wide step was now standing motionless on the sign, legs together. It didn't look like it belonged on an emergency exit sign at all—it looked more like the symbol on a men's restroom door.

Not only had its pose changed, but its size had changed too.

Originally its head and limbs had all fit within the sign's frame, but now it seemed to no longer fit; the little figure's legs were no longer visible.

"It's gradually getting bigger, floor by floor..." the Shaxue-lizard said, "No, wait, that doesn't seem right."

The Qiboli-lizard suddenly understood: "Oh—the little figure is gradually drawing closer to us! One floor closer with each floor we climb. One or two more floors, and it should be crawling right out of the sign."

As if in response, a startled scream from Lisidan suddenly rang out from the floor above.

The bonus chapter is coming along very slowly—I've only written a little over a thousand words so far... Emotionally, going back to dig up a story that already feels finished and write a bonus chapter seems to take a lot of mental energy... I don't know if that makes sense to everyone, because I'm not entirely sure I understand it myself (。

Chapter 267: Mai Minghe's Long-Overdue Message

Lisidan had probably been a cautious, quick-witted man who valued his life—always keeping his ears pricked to the sounds around him, always watching for the nearest way out.

After the lizard emerged, he was the fastest runner among them all.

He had pulled two full floors ahead of Robert behind him; at that distance, no one had seen how he died.

In truth, Mai Minghe couldn't even be certain he was truly dead.

They stopped on the floor below where Lisidan had last cried out for help, and carefully craned their necks to peer upward—after the screaming ceased, pale light and gray concrete pressed down over everyone's field of vision, utterly indifferent.

From the edge of the staircase steps, a few scattered silver-white antennae poked out, faintly catching the light.

When they had rushed up to this floor just moments ago, the Emergency Exit Sign had already lost its green—only a wash of white remained, as though the little figure had pressed itself flat against the surface of the casing and was about to crawl out, its white body swallowing the sign whole.

But now, after Lisidan's screams had gone silent, the little figure was gone too; all that remained on the sign was an empty expanse of green and the four letters "EXIT."

"...We'll have to go up and check sooner or later," Suobeihua said between gasps, thoroughly spent.

Aimeli seemed unable to walk on her own anymore; the entire way, Suobeihua's serpent tail had been dragging and hauling her along, barely keeping her with the group.

Mai Minghe could see it too—Aimeli's condition was deteriorating: the nutshell was losing its plant-like texture little by little, gradually hardening and petrifying, growing heavier and heavier, so heavy that she didn't dare push Aimeli up the stairs from below—she was afraid that if her arms trembled for even a moment, or if Suobeihua's serpent tail slipped, Aimeli would tumble and crash down, sending her plunging into pitch darkness.

"Use your serpent tail to prop yourself up and take a look."

Robert glanced at Suobeihua and issued the order.

Suobeihua almost certainly hated being ordered around by him; but a few minutes ago, the situation had shifted—or rather, the balance of power had shifted, and she could no longer brush off Robert's words.

The five interview Hunters had always existed in a relationship of more or less equal partnership. Suobeihua had carried a little more weight in discussions because of her serpent tail, but on the whole, no one had the standing to give orders.

Thinking about it now, that was because all five of them had originally had guns.

The root of power is violence.

Not long after encountering the lizard, the five of them had exhausted all their bullets.

With no one having a gun, that could have been a new kind of equilibrium—yet in the final drawn-out, terror-filled screech Lisidan let out, Robert had raised his gun at the lizards who were also cocking their heads to listen to the sounds above.

Not the handgun issued by Key House Faction.

What Robert held was small and inconspicuous, so much so that when he suddenly raised his hand, no one could tell he was holding anything at all—besides, the stairwell had been in complete chaos at the time, and no one had paid any attention to that brief motion of his hand.

In that moment, Lisidan's cries for help and Mai Minghe's useless shouts were humming and reverberating between the concrete walls; Suobeihua was calling out "What happened?" over and over, receiving no answer.

But even if all the chaos and shouting were stripped away and the stairwell restored to dead silence, no one would have heard a single gunshot.

When Robert fired, there wasn't a sound throughout the entire process.

By the time everyone—including the two lizards—suddenly registered that something was wrong, the lizard resembling Tianxi had already released the railing it had been gripping and dropped straight down into the stairwell shaft.

It fell fast, but Mai Minghe and the others still caught a glimpse in their peripheral vision: it was no longer a creature of flesh and blood shaped like a lizard-person—it was a flat piece of

cardboard, spread wide on all four limbs in the shape of a lizard, split down the center by a crack, just like the cracks they had chiseled into the walls.

"What's hap—"

The lizard resembling Qiboli didn't finish its sentence before it too turned to cardboard and fell.

The last one, the half-lizard that still retained a woman's shape, seemed only now to realize that the danger was coming from the five people in front of it.

It twisted its head and leapt downward immediately; Robert lunged forward a step, raised his hand toward its back—and only then did Mai Minghe finally get a clear look at his weapon.

...A cardboard gun. A paper-thin trigger.

"What are you standing there for?" Robert said to Suobeihua now. "You're the only one who can rise straight up and take a look."

Suobeihua bit her lower lip and slowly moved toward the staircase, gradually straightening her body upright on her serpent tail.

Robert kept his eyes fixed on the thick, dark-green serpent tail below her, unblinking, his hand closing around the wind-up key again.

...If things kept going on like this, he would probably be incapable of doing anything other than winding. No—in truth, that he could still occasionally stop winding even now was already surprising enough.

"Be careful," Mai Minghe said, knowing the words were useless, yet unable to stop herself from saying them to Suobeihua.

It had been two or three minutes since the last wave of "rescuers" had appeared in the stairwell; but judging by the number of parallel realities, that brief window could close at any moment.

Their ability to escape so far had been almost entirely down to luck; what would happen when that luck finally ran out?

Lisidan's luck had run out one step ahead of theirs.

"Can you see him?" Mai Minghe asked, her tone almost tentative.

"...No."

Suobeihua stood tall in midair, craning her neck to survey the landing above. She said quietly, "I don't see a body, but he must have..."

She didn't finish the sentence. She didn't need to.

All that Lisidan had left behind were extensive, unmistakable signs of struggle.

Shattered, snapped antennae glittered like countless silver hairs as they rolled and scattered across the stairwell; the broken antennae had become blunt needles, cutting or piercing—it was impossible to tell which—puncturing Lisidan's skin and leaving spatters of blood in their wake.

The blood trail traced the path along which Lisidan had struggled and been dragged in his final moments.

The frantic signs of a desperate fight began midway up the staircase, continued across the surface of the landing, climbed up the wall, and finally disappeared into the Emergency Exit Sign.

The casing of the Emergency Exit Sign had been smashed open, exposing an irregular, deep black hole.

Lisidan had most likely vanished into that black hole.

Around the Emergency Exit Sign, blood had splattered across the walls and ceiling in large swaths; it hadn't yet thickened and congealed—still vivid red, dripping to the floor. Occasionally a drop carried a fragment of torn skin and landed with a wet smack.

...The smell was dense enough to feel solid, dense enough to cloud the eyes.

Suobeihua pressed one hand tightly over her mouth, seemingly struggling desperately to suppress whatever was roiling in her stomach; Robert went blank for a moment, his hand loosening involuntarily for a beat.

Aimeli stood rigid on the staircase, her expression unreadable.

"...That little figure drawn on the sign," Suobeihua said in a low voice, "climbed out of the sign and then...then dragged Lisidan inside alive?"

"Looks that way,"

Robert squeezed past her and up the stairs, his shoe soles crunching on the snapped antennae with each step, sharp and hard. "Suobeihua, come up and check—does the sign on the next floor

still have that little figure?"

Suobeihua swallowed her reluctance and held her tongue. She swept aside the broken antennae, slowly moved to the halfway point of the staircase, and propped herself up on her serpent tail again. "No."

"The Emergency Exit sign is empty?"

"Yes," Suobeihua confirmed, looking up. "Just a green sign—no little figure. Strange..."

She turned and glanced back at the Emergency Exit sign behind her, the one beneath the ceiling with the black hole gaping from it.

"What's behind it?"

"What do you mean?" Robert turned to look more carefully at it, thrown off by her question.

"Where did that little figure drag Lisidan?" Suobeihua said, pointing at the sign. "That sign is a light box—broken open from the inside. It should be exposing wiring, the casing, or the wall behind it. But right now there's only darkness... can you see the end of it?"

She hadn't even intended to wait for Robert to answer; as she spoke, she had already pulled out her phone, opened the flashlight, and directed a beam of white light inside.

Mai Minghe stood motionless on the staircase as if in a dream, watching that beam of light fall into the darkness. It struggled forward a few steps, whitening the denser, more crowded darkness ahead, before its strength finally gave out and the darkness swallowed it whole.

She had thought of it.

Nest information that refused to surface unless triggered by the right keyword always seemed to arrive one beat too late—as if it wanted her ignorance to linger a little longer, to see if it could create a few more chances for her to die.

...Though what Mai Minghe had just recalled would do nothing to help her out of this predicament, the information was still taking its time arriving.

"What's wrong with you?" Suobeihua called out to her. "Did you get frightened?"

Mai Minghe shook her head, her gaze falling away from the black hole.

She raised one hand and touched the cold, hard mirror surface on her face, behind the door.

"...I think I recognize it."

Suobeihua startled, her expression caught between belief and doubt. "You mean the black hole? What is it?"

"We need to leave here immediately first," Mai Minghe said, gesturing upward. "We go up...I have an idea that might lead us back to the floor where our original reality is."

How has Mai Minghe taken this long to write aaaaaaa

When I was planning it out, I knew I'd be writing her continuously for a while, but I didn't expect it to go on this long...

I mean, writing a single POV is definitely a lot easier, but isn't this story supposed to be an ensemble?

Chapter 268: Mai Minghe's Fleeting Glimpse of Home

.....Is it really up there?

Every breath Mai Minghe dragged into her lungs felt like inhaling wet cement—no matter how hard she strained, the air seemed unable to flow into her body.

Since being trapped, she had lost count of how many flights of stairs she had run; her lungs felt as though a roaring fire had been kindled inside them, and the air she managed to force in only fed the flames, making them fiercer and more painful.

Whether it was because she had climbed too many floors, or because the mouth and nose she breathed through were gradually turning into mirrors—that question, Mai Minghe no longer wanted to think about.

"How much longer?"

Breathless and gasping, every word Suobeihua spoke came out as a sharp hiss, more like a snake than a person. "Is—is it up there?"

After leading the group in a long run with near-attacks several times along the way, the four words "I don't know" were very hard for Mai Minghe to say.

After all this time, had they long since passed that floor? What if her guess was wrong?

What if the floor she had appeared on had been pulled out and randomly inserted somewhere else?

The farther they ran, the less certain Mai Minghe felt.

"I—I ran down from above," she said, enduring the pain inside her as though her body had been doused in fuel oil. "If we keep running upward...we should be able to get back to the floor I came in on."

"How would you recognize it?" Robert challenged her from the side. "Do you know how many cardboard bullets you've made me waste, running up here like this without a care?"

He had asked a few times already, and this time Mai Minghe felt it would be hard to brush off again.

After passing through Lisidan's death floor, they had encountered life-threatening danger several times in under ten minutes; if Mai Minghe hadn't sworn with absolute certainty that she could lead everyone back to the floor she had entered from—and that they absolutely had to go together—Robert probably would never have opened fire to drive off enemies for the others.

She pushed Aimeli, who was coiled in a snake's tail, upward with both hands, and forced another hard breath.

"It has...it has something to do with my mirror..."

This wasn't an outright lie, but it was only her guess.

"What does it have to do with it?"

...My mirror has probably been tampered with by the Nest.

That thought had been sitting heavy in her stomach the whole time.

For a good while, Mai Minghe had wondered whether she was making the mistake of seeing a thief in every shadow—once a person forms a preset idea in their mind, everything starts to look like evidence, and even unrelated details begin to seem suspicious.

But she couldn't refute herself, and she couldn't ignore the one key piece of evidence she'd had from the very beginning.

Her mirror...rather than reflecting some characteristic of Mai Minghe herself, it provided the Nest with a "function." The way it changed was fundamentally different from how other people's changes manifested.

The Nest hadn't even bothered to conceal this.

From the very start, even before the physical transformations had begun to materialize, her mirror had already provided a corridor through its reflection for "Jones" and the "transparent face"—hadn't it?

"Jones" could hide inside the corridor; the "transparent face" could come bursting out of it.

"Hey!" Robert suddenly bellowed, grabbing her arm. "Do you have any idea what you're doing or not? Have you lost your mind?"

Mai Minghe stumbled, quickly bracing herself against the step above, and managed to steady herself—just barely keeping herself from tumbling down the staircase from the sudden yank.

"Let go of me,"

Even with Mai Minghe's mild temper, she couldn't help wrenching her arm away hard. "I told you, I—"

A sudden pain shot through the back of her eyes, and she doubled over, the rest of her sentence dissolving into a groan.

"What's wrong?" Suobeihua turned her head from the landing above. "Are you hurt?"

Mai Minghe couldn't speak.

She stumbled down a few steps, and only when Robert moved to follow did she wave him off, forcing out a sentence through gritted teeth: "No...don't move. The floor I came in on is right above...Suobeihua just has to go up a little farther on the stairs."

Aside from the motionless Aimeli, the other two both tilted their heads to look—the floor above looked no different from any other.

"How do you know?"

How was she supposed to answer that?

If she told the truth right now—that there was a semi-transparent face that had just surfaced from deep behind her own eyes, imprinted in reverse on her retina, hovering there and waiting for a chance to come bursting out through her face...

Robert would truly think she had gone mad, wouldn't he?

She should have realized it sooner, actually: the fact that she had kept running downstairs and escaped that transparent face proved that it couldn't give chase—it was fixed in one place, which was the floor where Mai Minghe had first been caught in the "find Jones" stage—in other words, the reality she and the others had come from.

In that sense, the "transparent face" had become a landmark.

Find it, and they would find the floor they had entered from.

Now that this had been confirmed, Mai Minghe found she couldn't feel glad about it.

For her, this stairwell was a dead end with no way out; she could no longer tell whether it was the Nest's design or sheer coincidence.

What good was finding the floor they'd come from?

She couldn't go up there at all.

The semi-transparent face was still some distance away, and couldn't yet batter her retina and facial bones the way it had before.

But the moment Mai Minghe moved upward, she would be back in the same situation as before—even now, with two flights of stairs between them, every time she glanced around, a faint half-shadow always drifted at the edge of her vision, like an inescapable floater in her eye, waiting for her to draw near.

And after she had nearly escaped only to be driven back, the semi-transparent face seemed to press its attack harder, more relentlessly—just now, from a single blow struck from deep within her eye, Mai Minghe's vision had gone dark for several seconds.

"What's the matter with you, just standing there gasping and not saying a word?"

Getting no answer from her, Robert ran out of patience and abruptly turned to stride up the stairs, calling out: "This floor—right?"

Suobeihua tensed and asked, "What are you going to do?"

"Don't you want to get out?" Robert smiled. "She says the reality we came from is right behind the wall on this floor, doesn't she? So let's tear down the wall and see what's behind it."

His whole body was powered by a wind-up key, and when it was wound tight, he could get his mind turning. Robert seemed to have already figured out a plan—when Mai Minghe carefully craned her head upward, she saw him standing at the top of the staircase, raising his cardboard gun toward the wall across from him.

His finger pressed, then released the trigger.

The cement-gray wall was perfectly still, showing no change at all.

Robert walked up to it step by step, placed one hand on the wall, and gave it a sudden shove.

The wall—which had taken the combined force of five people hammering at it for a long time before even a crack would appear—lost its weight in that instant, peeling away from both sides almost smoothly, exposing the hollow interior of thick cardboard. It fell backward out of the stairwell, opening up an entire slab of sky.

Daylight and a rush of cool fresh air flooded into the stairwell, and Mai Minghe shivered.

Robert peered out for a moment; from where Mai Minghe stood, she couldn't see what lay beyond the wall.

He came back down the stairs.

"Are you sure this floor is the reality we came from?" Robert asked.

"...Yes."

He looked left and right, and his gaze suddenly settled on Aimeli.

Mai Minghe's heart sank.

"Letting you go first is out of the question, I'm sure," Robert said. "How about we throw Aimeli down first to check the situation, then we go. What do you say?"

He hadn't really planned to wait for anyone's opinion—even as he spoke, he had already spread his arms wide, grabbed Aimeli around the middle, and with one heave, began dragging her bodily up a step.

"Wait," Mai Minghe startled. "You're planning to throw her from the third floor?"

"With a shell that thick, she won't shatter from the fall—it's basically built for exactly this." Robert glanced at her, still dragging Aimeli along. "If not her, then who? Are you willing to go down first?"

"No, that's wrong, stop." Mai Minghe frantically sorted through her thoughts. "When I came in, I entered from inside the third floor—but after you tore down the wall, it opens to the outside of the building..."

"Didn't you say the floor was right? As long as it's the same floor, the same reality, what does it matter if it's inside or outside?"

Suobeihua was standing in a corner of the landing, her brow furrowed hard; probably wary of the cardboard gun, her expression was grim, but she made no move to physically intervene.

"Let go of her,"

In her desperation, Mai Minghe rushed up several steps—but before she could even reach the landing at the turn, the semi-transparent face surged up like a massive creature rising from the ocean floor, swallowing her field of vision whole in an instant. Even knowing that turning her head wouldn't shake it loose, she twisted her head away on instinct and pressed down half a cry of pain.

She had already steelled herself for it, but the second impact never came.

...The semi-transparent face had suddenly stopped.

It hovered behind her retina like a floater composed of a human face, imprinted on her eye, completely still.

Mai Minghe blinked, catching her breath.

Suobeihua followed her gaze and turned toward her. "What's wrong with you?"

Mai Minghe raised a hand and touched her own face—since opening the "door" last time, she had never closed it.

She was now standing partway up the staircase looking upward, which meant...the mirror behind the door was reflecting Suobeihua's face right back at it.

So that was it.

"Do you see it?" Mai Minghe said, her voice hoarse. "...You saw her, didn't you? Why did you stop?"

Robert, still holding Aimeli, paused and gave her a suspicious look. "What? Are you talking to me?"

Mai Minghe shook her head. "No, but wait a few minutes."

Without giving Robert a chance to respond, she looked up at Suobeihua and said: "Today is November 24th."

"...Right, so what?"

"On the night of November 22nd, I saw Chase Monroe once at Between the Backlights."

Mai Minghe studied her reaction and said in a low voice: "He seemed a bit under the weather at the time, but well enough to get into a gunfight with someone in the back alley. The whole bar probably knew about it. The interview was yesterday, November 23rd—Chase wasn't at Key House for some reason and didn't handle the interview. We entered the Nest today at ten in the morning."

"What exactly are you trying to say?" Suobeihua raised one eyebrow.

"You said you wanted to infiltrate Key House to look into Chase's whereabouts." Mai Minghe took a breath. "...Why?"

"I don't understand what you mean."

"From an outsider's perspective, Chase had only been missing for one day at most—the 23rd—and for all we know he was home sleeping. After all, his general whereabouts were perfectly clear. There's no real need to infiltrate Key House just to find out what he was doing on the 22nd, and it doesn't make sense to take such a big risk over a single day's gap on the 23rd."

Suobeihua said nothing, only watching her steadily.

Those eyes, as deep and green as her serpent's tail, seemed to carry a sharp, blade-edged quality even in their gaze.

Robert looked back and forth between the two, seemingly completely lost.

"You told me you were doing it to find out about his whereabouts because you knew—and you assumed I also knew—that something had happened to him."

Mai Minghe let out a soft sigh.

"You said you wanted to go undercover in Key House Faction... That's actually a rather clever angle, because it explains why you're so familiar with Tianxi—why you even remember which way his braids were facing. After all, he's a Key House person, one of your 'targets.' Being familiar with him isn't unreasonable. Of course, it's not the most airtight explanation, but it's enough to pass."

The translucent face floating in her field of vision still hung in midair, seemingly staring fixedly at Suobeihua.

He wasn't sure if it was an illusion, but Mai Minghe always felt that the expression on that face seemed... seemed somewhat dazed and flustered, at a loss.

As if he retained only a vague impression of Suobeihua; as if, after many years, catching a glimpse of a town flashing past outside a train window, he didn't dare confirm for a moment whether that was truly his hometown from childhood.

"The intelligence the House Factions hold, you naturally wouldn't know—we have our own reasons."

Suobeihua shook her head and suddenly smiled. "The one-day blank you brought up isn't the reason I infiltrated this place. The word 'movements' covers a lot of possibilities—you can't

assume, just from that one word, that I only wanted to know Chase's location. Maybe they had some kind of plan, and I wanted to learn the inside story?"

Mai Minghe had a strange feeling.

...Rather than saying she was denying it, it was more like she wanted to hear what Mai Minghe would say next.

"Fair enough—just that one point truly isn't enough to prove anything." Mai Minghe held up two fingers and said, "But I've also found two other things."

"Oh?"

"First: you once said something—that this Infinite Floors is packed with countless second floors and countless third floors. But the Key House people never told us this building only has three stories. Looking at it from outside, the building itself is easily over ten meters tall, far beyond the height of a typical third floor—that was one of the pieces of information Tianxi told us. For a building over ten meters high, why did you assume it only had a second and third floor, with no fourth?"

Suobeihua paused. "And the second?"

"...Second: Chase just recognized you."

Suobeihua froze—and in the next instant, her expression shifted sharply, her voice going taut: "What do you mean by that?"

"You're a Key House Hunter, aren't you?"

Mai Minghe asked quietly.

Writing is like falling into a river.

My condition was especially bad today—groggy and out of it—so I thought I'd write a short one, post early, and get some rest early.

But once you fall into a rushing river, wherever the current drags you, you have no resistance at all. You go wherever it takes you, and you can only climb out when it finally slows down... I finally dragged myself ashore, looked back, and—four thousand characters!

Half my life expectancy, gone just like that.

Chapter 269: Mai Minghe — Between the Nest and the World of the Living

"You're with Key House Faction?"

The moment Mai Minghe finished speaking, it was Robert who reacted the most strongly.

He shoved Aimeli against the wall and crossed to Suobeihua in two strides, demanding: "Is what she said true? Did you people know about this stairwell? Since you're in the same faction, you can contact the people outside, can't you? Have them let me out!"

Suobeihua closed her eyes and drew a long, slow breath.

"The stairwell was an accident. I can't reach them. For now we can only find a way out ourselves — but before that, there's something I need to get clear."

She had obviously forced her fury down, and only gave Robert those few grudging words out of respect for the cardboard gun — the moment she finished, every bit of her attention snapped back to Mai Minghe: "You said Chase recognized me. What did you mean by that?"

That name she used... did it mean she was admitting it?

Mai Minghe rubbed her face hard several times.

In the brief moment she closed her eyes, that half-transparent face still floated behind her eyelids; in the darkness, it looked slightly clearer than before.

Now that she had guessed who he was, looking again at that face — as though kneaded from the folds of space itself — she found it strange: his features were so distinct, so sharply defined, yet how had she failed to recognize it as Chase's face at first?

"Don't be in such a hurry to come bursting out of my face... my face is attached to my neck anyway, it's not going anywhere."

Mai Minghe murmured, not knowing whether he could hear her. "You may as well listen to what we have to say first."

A light flashed in Suobeihua's eyes. "Who are you talking to?"

Before she could answer, Mai Minghe's body gave out like a collapsed frame and she dropped onto the steps — she was utterly exhausted.

When all was said and done, it was because she wanted to resist the final law that governs all living things, because she wanted something that kings and emperors throughout all of human history had schemed desperately for and never obtained.

Measured against a goal so greedy, so immense, perhaps the ordeals she was suffering at this moment amounted to nothing at all.

...And might even fall far short of what was needed.

Sitting where she was, Mai Minghe counted seven or eight distinct kinds of pain in her body. But compared to the very end of life, the pain she felt now was vital and alive — and perhaps even worth cherishing.

"I thought I escaped in time yesterday, but it seems you figured out that the person who broke into the estate was me after all?"

Suobeihua gave a small nod.

"To be precise, we hadn't confirmed it was you. We don't install cameras inside the estate, only at the entrances and exits, and you happened to avoid the camera coverage. We narrowed our list of suspects to people who had come for interviews that day, and you were the most suspicious — because you were the only one who had gone back to the estate a second time."

No wonder they hadn't pinned her down the moment they met today...

"Inside the Key House estate, aside from a few stationed Hunters and some weapons and furniture, there's nothing at all. After much deliberation, we concluded that your primary target for breaking in could only have been one thing — Chase."

Suobeihua's expression remained composed throughout, but whenever she mentioned Chase, her voice was like a blade sliding from its sheath — a thin, cold, sharp edge exposed.

...Nothing at all?

Key House Faction didn't keep Artifacts in the estate?

Then where was her lipstick?

"The appearance of the stairwell was completely beyond my expectations. Originally, I was meant to join as your 'fellow new hire' — entering Key House Faction alongside you to monitor your movements and find out your purpose."

Suobeihua drew a deep breath and smiled.

"But as things stand now, it saves me quite a bit of trouble. Speak then — what was your purpose in looking for Chase? How do you know about him — how much do you know about his current condition?"

Robert stared wide-eyed, knowing full well this had nothing to do with him, yet unable to stop himself from listening.

Suobeihua glanced up at the wall he had just torn apart.

"If you think you still have room to be uncooperative, then let me assure you — the one thrown down the stairs as a test subject will not be Aimeli."

Mai Minghe waved a hand — the other party's hostility was perfectly understandable, yet she still wasn't used to it; she wasn't famous, had no money, and had lived her whole life without ever being hated by anyone.

"Even if I tell you the truth, will you believe me?"

"You're welcome to try telling it first."

For a moment, Mai Minghe truly didn't know where to begin. The Nest information that had surfaced, the scene she'd witnessed in the Key House estate, the Domination Game and her analysis and guesses about it... things she could say and things she couldn't, things she was certain of and things she wasn't, all tangled together. She thought for a while before finally deciding to take a chance.

"I broke into Key House Faction's estate not because of Chase, but it does involve him."

She sat on the steps, looking at the whole stretch of sky visible above, and said: "By accident, he took away an Artifact that was very important to me. I entered the estate only to get back what was mine —"

Suobeihua let out a sharp "ha," clearly not believing a word of it; before she could say anything more, Mai Minghe cut in ahead of her: "It wasn't until just a moment ago that I suddenly understood what kind of situation Chase has fallen into."

After she closed her eyes, the half-transparent face in the darkness seemed to tilt slightly upward at those words, as though faintly surprised.

...Did he know what kind of situation he was in right now?

"Do you know what 'Nest Dissociation Syndrome' is?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Of course."

"Then do you know where a Hunter goes when 'Nest Dissociation Syndrome' reaches an advanced stage?"

Suobeihua seemed to chew over those words twice without grasping her meaning. "That's a psychological condition — they don't go anywhere —"

Mai Minghe shook her head.

"No. When it reaches an advanced stage, the Hunter's physical body also begins to show dissociation symptoms. I don't mean that a person's body falls to pieces... what I mean is that the boundary between flesh and reality begins to blur. Hmm, let me think of an analogy that might help you understand."

She tilted her head and thought for a moment, then said: "Take a watercolor painting. When it's properly dry, the watercolor exists clearly on the paper, doesn't it? Our physical bodies are like the watercolor, and the paper is the world of the living where we spend our lives. Under normal circumstances, we all live clearly and completely in the world of the living.

"But when dissociation syndrome grows severe, or when a person's human essence comes under some kind of attack, it's as if someone has poured water over the watercolor painting — we begin to become unstable as human beings.

"...The watercolor dissolves again; its edges blur and slowly soak through the paper. If you then slip another sheet of paper beneath the painting, you'll see some of the color has passed through the first sheet and bled onto the one below — our bodies are like that watercolor, dissolving and blurring, with a part of ourselves seeping through the world of the living and into somewhere else."

The analogy wasn't entirely precise, but it was the most fitting one Mai Minghe could come up with.

Once watercolor soaks through the paper, the pigment that is lost cannot be recovered; but a person's Nest Dissociation Syndrome can still be reversed, and the physical body can still become clear and stable again.

Suobeihua still didn't believe her, but she cooperated well enough: "Seeped into where?"

"...The 'Black Abyss Zone.'"

Mai Minghe explained: "That name is one I gave it myself — whether it has any actual name, the Nest information — I mean, I don't know either. It's a pitch-dark space with no directions, no matter, like a labyrinth with no exit, separating the world of the living from the Nest.

"A Hunter's 'passage' works like a wormhole — it bypasses the barrier of the Black Abyss Zone, allowing a person to travel from the human world into the Nest. Residents in the Nest have no passage and can't get around the Black Abyss Zone, which is why they can't enter the world of the living."

The half-transparent face suddenly turned, as though tugging on some nerve, giving Mai Minghe a brief flash of pain — for some reason Chase seemed to have reacted to her last sentence.

"The black abyss you're describing... a space of complete darkness..." Suobeihua started, her lips trembling a few times before she stopped, as though she didn't know what the rest of the sentence should be.

"You must have seen it."

Mai Minghe looked at her and said: "I've seen it too. Only when I saw it, I didn't think for a moment about what it actually was... because from the outside, it was nothing more than a human-shaped black void, standing in the air, bottomless."

Suobeihua sucked in a sharp, cold breath.

At the time, Mai Minghe had been trapped in a corner of the third floor of the Key House estate, caught in a pincer attack with no way out.

When the door at her back was, for some reason, quietly pulled open from inside, Mai Minghe had no other choice — she darted in at once and slipped into that room, the one that had been secured with a combination lock.

In the center of the room stood a human-shaped void, motionless.

"At that moment I realized the rug in the center of the room was a tongue-shaped Artifact, so I didn't dare go near it at all — I pressed myself to the corner along the wall, inching my way toward the window, and climbed out from there down to the balcony below to escape. The whole time, I neither dared to look too closely at that human-shaped void, nor dared to stop watching it."

She had been on edge the entire time, always afraid that the moment she turned her head, the human-shaped void would be standing right behind her — so she kept catching glimpses of it out

of the corner of her eye, unable to help herself.

It was precisely when Mai Minghe climbed out the window and cast one last sweeping glance back into the room that she suddenly noticed there had been another person in there all along.

From three directions inside the room, that person was invisible; only after climbing out the window could she barely make out a silhouette from the side, because that person was positioned right behind the human-shaped void —

No, "behind" wasn't quite right.

Who that person was, she couldn't tell.

In that fleeting instant of a glance, all Mai Minghe registered was the impression that it was likely a man, of what seemed to be a tall and large build. The human-shaped void was around 170 centimeters tall, yet this man had to bend down, leaning most of his upper body into the void.

He leaned into the void — and then disappeared.

From the time Mai Minghe entered the room until she escaped through the window — several minutes in total — that man, half-disappeared, had been completely unaware of her, frozen and still, as though he had already slipped through the fingers of the living world.

She couldn't make out who he was, but she could guess; what she never knew was where the upper half of him, the half that had disappeared, had gone.

It wasn't until Mai Minghe saw the shattered Emergency Exit Sign, saw the deep, dark void that Lisidan had been dragged into, that the Nest information that had been poured into her mind finally surfaced with a reluctant, grudging sort of emergence — and Mai Minghe understood all at once: that tall man who might have been Chase had also disappeared into the Black Abyss Zone.

But why had a tear suddenly appeared in the "reality" of the room in the Key House estate, exposing the Black Abyss Zone?

Suobeihua suddenly lowered her head and pressed the back of her hand hard against her nose.

"Chase... that human-shaped void you saw — it's not a void. She is a person. She has a name." She said it with her eyes closed. "Her name is June."

Per your request, the following is the content generated for you:

Financial freedom financial freedom financial freedom financial freedom financial freedom
financial freedom

Thank you for using Nest AI.

Chapter 270: Mai Minghe's One-Way Communication

"At first, she looked like she was simply in a deep sleep."

June's face had returned to normal.

Her complexion was a little pale, but her breathing was steady, and her blood pressure, heartbeat, pupillary response, and neurological reactions were all normal; at the time, everyone believed that as long as she kept resting, she would eventually wake up on her own.

Chase had even wondered whether he had been too demanding, and that was why June had risked herself to record a video that was only ever meant as a precaution—when she woke up, should he scold her? Advise her? Thank her? Or should he look inward himself?

"...Chase seemed to be quite troubled about it, and even went to talk it over with Tianxi. The two of them had a serious conversation, then called me in with straight faces and asked me, 'To carry out Chase's orders, how much risk would you be willing to take?'"

Suobeihua let out a quiet laugh.

"I thought they had some high-difficulty mission to assign me, so I was full of myself—I exaggerated everything, going on about how fearless I was, how willing I was to take risks, how there was nothing I wouldn't dare do... The more I talked, the worse Chase's expression got, and Tianxi rushed to shove me out the door."

With June's recovery looking promising, a sense of lightness and ease settled over the Key House mansion.

That atmosphere lasted less than ten hours.

"I don't know who was the first to notice."

Suobeihua lifted her eyes and studied Mai Minghe carefully—not looking at Mai Minghe herself, but at her mirror, as though trying to determine whether what Mai Minghe was saying was the truth, and whether Chase was truly visible in the reflection.

"All I know is that by the time we registered what was happening, June's body... had begun to cave inward."

It was a sight that was extremely difficult to describe.

The body lying on the bed seemed to have become a human-shaped frame; the flesh, bones, and organs were slowly sinking down within their own framework—just from the description alone, Mai Minghe couldn't picture what that must have looked like.

"The outer silhouette formed by the bones was the last to cave in. I went to see her once, and found that the gap between the outermost ring of bone and her slowly hollowing face was deep enough to stand half a palm upright. She had been such a beautiful person... I... I was very frightened at the time, and I even thought to myself that maybe it would be better if she had just died."

Suobeihua shook her head and said, "I'm ashamed of myself for thinking that."

She glanced up at Robert on the floor above.

Since the matter concerned Key House's private affairs, she had just firmly but politely asked him to wait upstairs and "keep an eye on the situation outside"—but the stairwell wasn't large, and if he held his breath and listened, there was no telling how much he might have caught.

As for Aimeli, nobody paid her much mind; her condition was such that it always seemed like it wouldn't matter whether she heard or not.

Suobeihua lowered her voice again.

"...Chase didn't say anything, but I imagine he must feel deeply guilty."

Mai Minghe thought to herself: it must be a surging, overwhelming guilt.

Otherwise, after June had finally collapsed entirely into a human-shaped black hole, there would have been very few people in the world with the courage to slowly push their head and body into it.

"He tried several times. The first time, he immediately pulled back out and told Tianxi and the rest of us hunters that there was nothing inside but pure darkness—he couldn't see a thing. At that point we all told him to stop going in—listen to me, 'going in,' like she was some kind of door."

Suobeihua covered her face with her hands and paused for a few seconds.

Mai Minghe had the urge to gently touch her arm to calm her down, but the moment she moved, Suobeihua immediately lowered her hands and fixed her gaze back on her.

Even though Mai Minghe had told her about "Chase in the mirror" and expressed her willingness to find a way to bring Chase back to the real world, Suobeihua still regarded her with wariness—which was, in fairness, understandable: everything was simply too far-fetched, and the existence of the "Black Abyss Zone" was something she had never even heard of.

And the way Mai Minghe had gotten tangled up in all of this was, in itself, genuinely suspicious.

"He didn't listen to your advice," Mai Minghe said.

"...Right. He's always looked out for us, but this time even I found myself wondering—wasn't this going too far? Even out of guilt, there was no need to..."

Suobeihua shook her head and left the thought unfinished, then changed the subject.

"The second time, he stayed in the darkness for a few minutes before coming back out. The third time he pushed his body in even deeper, and was about to step one foot inside... Fortunately, Tianxi grabbed hold of his leg. We told him to pull back right away, but he didn't seem to hear us. It was a long while before he moved even slightly. And by the time we sensed something was wrong and tried to pull him out, we found we couldn't."

Chase was like a small insect trapped in setting concrete—frozen and immobile.

None of them dared to pull hard; all they could do was call out to him while gently keeping hold, preventing him from sinking any deeper into the black hole.

"After that... everything went still. He remained lodged in the black hole, and more than a day passed with no sign that he could free himself."

Suobeihua swept a glance at Mai Minghe.

"Then you slipped into the mansion, and somehow managed to open the door to the room where Chase and June were. You say the door opened on its own—I won't believe that. The Key House locking system is not so shoddy that it can't even perform the basic function of a lock. But that point can wait until we're out of here."

Mai Minghe gave a wry smile.

No matter how hard she thought, she couldn't figure out how that door had opened, and she had no answer that could satisfy Suobeihua.

"You said you wanted to understand the situation, and I've told you everything from beginning to end—even though I still feel I shouldn't have. It's just that we're completely at a loss right now, and even if you're lying to me, I have to try. All right, now it's your turn to tell me how we're going to bring Chase back to the world of the living."

She made no mention of June; someone who had already turned into a hole was, in all likelihood, beyond saving.

"I... I only have a guess."

Mai Minghe looked up at the sky and light pouring in through the floor above, where an entire wall had been removed. "I don't know what situation Chase is in right now, but I believe he can see me clearly. Is that right?"

That last question was one she boldly directed at Chase; he seemed able to not only see her, but hear her as well.

The semi-transparent face behind the eyeball hesitated, then gave a faint nod.

"If he's been following close behind me all this time, then haven't I become his landmark and guide? If I return to Blackmoor City and stand beside his body, then when he walks toward me, won't he be able to return to the rift formed by June, and find his way back into his own body?"

"That sounds very reasonable," Suobeihua said coolly, "and it also happens to work very much in your favor."

"Regardless, it's worth trying. And if we stay standing in this stairwell with no way out, no one can be saved..."

Mai Minghe paused.

Come to think of it, this stretch of uninterrupted quiet had lasted far longer than expected... Was it because they were nearly back in their own reality?

So the people from the other realities had stopped coming after them?

Suobeihua seemed to have thought of the same thing; she swam forward a few steps and called up toward the staircase: "Robert? Do you see anything?"

The semi-transparent Chase suddenly turned his head from behind the eyeball—at first, Mai Minghe assumed he had picked up on some movement in the stairwell, and instinctively followed his gaze, turning her head in the same direction.

But all she saw was a stretch of bare concrete wall.

Chase, however, seemed to be looking at something.

He looked as though he were listening to someone speak, occasionally opening his mouth and silently responding.

Chase was looking at someone inside the Black Abyss Zone…?

But that couldn't be right—in a darkness where nothing existed, there shouldn't be anyone at all.

Who was he talking to? June?

Mai Minghe really wished she could read lips; but Chase was only a semi-transparent outline, and even if she could read lips, she couldn't make out the shape of his mouth.

"…Robert?"

In the brief half-minute that Chase had distracted her, Suobeihua's voice suddenly sharpened.

Mai Minghe's heart clenched; she immediately climbed the stairs in long strides—a sky, a street, and a Nest as wide as an entire wall lay just within arm's reach; one stretch of the hand, and freedom could be grasped.

…Robert was gone.

"Aimeli, did you see where he went?" Mai Minghe quickly turned and asked.

The enormous walnut was silent, motionless.

Just when she thought Aimeli might have lost the ability to respond, the voice came slowly, barely above a whisper: "…Nothing to do with me…"

Suobeihua climbed back up the stairs and looked around the upper floor, but it too appeared to be empty.

Chase seemed to grow faintly agitated—a shadow of a crease sank between his brows; he shook his head at that person Mai Minghe couldn't see, the one who shouldn't have been there.

"Did he go out ahead of us?" Suobeihua looked hesitantly toward the opening in the wall.

The street outside was empty—not only was Robert absent, but so was Tianxi, who should have been waiting outside.

Tianxi might have come in with the other two to help, so his absence didn't necessarily mean anything. But Robert's whereabouts were baffling: there was no way he would go ahead and scout on someone else's behalf, being the first one down.

"Did you see him leave?" Suobeihua asked Aimeli—but no matter how many times she asked, there was no response.

Mai Minghe lay flat at the edge of the floor, not daring to lean her body out, and after a moment suddenly said, "Wait, don't talk for a second... do you hear that?"

Suobeihua walked over to her side and listened quietly for a moment.

"Is that... a wind-up key sound? No, wait, that's not right—winding a key doesn't go that fast."

The rapid, dense clicking of metal gears turning was tight and unrelenting, without a moment's pause; the speed was extraordinary—if this were someone winding a key, the mechanism would have long since worn down and started smoking.

"It's coming from below the building," Suobeihua said.

The sound was pressed right up against the base of the building's outer wall, in a blind spot that neither of them could see without leaning their heads out.

"I'm not about to risk myself for him," Suobeihua said, standing up. "If he fell out and still has a wind-up key on him, that means the outside of the building isn't reality. Let him be—we'll find another way out."

Behind the eyeball, Chase suddenly startled—his face and expression had been imprinted on Mai Minghe's retina all this time, and his abrupt jolt made her involuntarily flinch as well, drawing a glance from Suobeihua.

Chase turned his head and fixed his gaze on Mai Minghe, his hazy semi-transparent face with his mouth moving rapidly, as if speaking to her.

No—not speaking.

He was warning her.

Alright, I can feel the block setting in...

That's why today's update is late...

Things haven't been going well for me lately—lots of setbacks and hassles, I've been frazzled all day every day. I originally thought going to Africa with my relatives would be an easy ride on their coattails, but then there were plane tickets to book, medicine to buy, visas to sort out—and after all that, I found out that the hotel my relatives booked was actually the smallest expense of the whole thing...

Since I'm the one footing the bill, what's even the point of rushing to go during this chaotic stretch when I have so much to deal with ahhhhhh